



Information

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Vainqueur the Dragon

Author: [Void Herald](#)

RANK 348

4.9

154

Chapters

351K

Views

2.98K

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Status

Categories

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- [Comedy](#)
- [Fantasy](#)
- [Action](#)

Vainqueur the Dragon novel is a popular light novel covering Adventure, Comedy, and Fantasy genres. Written by the Author Void Herald. 154 chapters have been translated and translation of all chapters was completed.

Summary

Vainqueur Knightsbane is your average dragon: a giant, fire-breathing lizard who loves to take naps on his golden hoard, kidnap princesses for fun, and make the life of adventurers miserable. Vainqueur's only pleasure in life is to watch his treasure get bigger, one coin at a time.

So when a would-be thief turned unwilling minion tells him about «classes,» «levels,» and «quests,» Vainqueur wonders if maybe, just maybe, he should consider a career change.

After all, why bother hunting monsters for free when you can get paid for it?

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Tags

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- 1
Zephhhyr
Reader
1mo

The stars have aligned ! The festival is nigh ! General Zephhueur, mightiest Dragon of Nexus, awaits you ! Join Life of Fantasy, Shadow Magister and Dex the shitling in journey of reading about 2nd Mightiest Dragon around ! This novel is superb and you wont regret !

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3 0

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23d

what is this guy doing here

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Vaudas

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F*ck*ng stop calling me a shitling you old b*st*rd

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ShadowMagister

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Heh  May the mighty dragon guide us in our journey  

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Belpy

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Peak.

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anatre106

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Any romance here? I know there are no romance tags but some novels do have a little romance despite no romance tags.

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SupremeLotusCapybara

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3mo

One of the best novels out there, only a stupid minion would give less than 5 shiny stars to vainqueur the best dragon.

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KiYoShIhErMaN

Reader

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this has a webtoon in case you don't know

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8 0

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Sheeza

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3mo

I actually had no idea

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- 6

TrainingFrance

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5mo

POGGIES!!!

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1 0

- 22

bread

Reader

7mo

ill try it eventually but no dragon can ever be better than invisible dragon

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31 2

- 1
LOSTFROMfated
reads
Reader
1mo

I really hate you. Once I was tricked by one of your cult members on TikTok to read it and I really thought it was a good novel. In the end, it wasn't a novel at all! No, it was.. Honestly, I don't know how to say it, but you get my point.

Reply

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- 13
Polle
reads
Reader
1mo

no dragon can be worse either. there is only one dragon and he's invisible

Reply

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oNoone
reads
Reader
1mo

Invismid dragon

Reply

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- 7
Seolw
[bread](#)s
Reader
4mo

Are we talking about toothless 🙄

Edited: 4mo

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2 1

- 4
GrayELuna
[bread](#)s
Reader
4mo

LMAO 🤔 What a classic Lol

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1 0

- 1
IndeedItIsOrIsIt
[bread](#)s
Reader
6mo

What is the name of the novel?

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1 0

- 1
ADudeThatsReading

reads

Reader

6mo

What dragon you talking bout

Reply

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■ 22

reads

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5mo

Invisible Dragon, its a peak novel

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■ 18

AnimeOverlord856

reads

Reader

4mo

Is it on this site

Reply

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■ 22

reads

[AnimeOverlord856](#)

Reader

4mo

i dont think so

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1 0

■ 18

AnimeOverlord856

[bread](#)

Reader

4mo

Yeah it isn't also its apparently the king of troll novels

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0 0

■ 22

bread

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Reader

4mo

nonsense invisible dragon is a peak novel

[Reply](#)

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■ 18

AnimeOverlord856

[bread](#)

Reader

4mo

Peak middle school

[Reply](#)

1 0

- 22
breads
[AnimeOverlord856](#)
Reader
4mo

lmao fr

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1 0

- 14
Dwonk269
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Reader
5mo

I got curious, and I looked it up. Superaswame

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Sheaa
Reader
8mo

Looks like a short and sweet novel, lets dig in

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1 0

- 2
SilentTox
Reader

10mo

Full love to this novel, I am on 105... if you want the same amount of just insanity Florida Man's General Store. That is right.

[Reply](#)

11 0

◦ 1

LOSTFROMfated

[SilentTox](#)

Reader

1mo

I was going to read it but now that I've read your comment I don't think it's a good idea.

[Reply](#)

0 0

• 25

[A_certain_reader](#)

Reader

11mo

[A certain reader ended up here after reading 'The Perfect Run' from the same author, instantly fell in love with that one and found the only other story written so far by Void Herald, this one] [A certain reader has high expectations]

[Reply](#)

77 0

◦ 11

Boots

[A_certain_reader](#)

Reader

8mo

I am the same, The Perfect Run is amazing, the author has other novels tho: 1- This one 2- The Perfect Run, and a side story. 3- Kairos 4- Underland Sadly only the first two are here.

[Reply](#)

9 0

▪ 6

ImmortalReaderMan

[Boots](#)

Reader

5mo

Blood & fur now too, not finished but holy f*ck*ng kaboomzki...is it worth

[Reply](#)

0 0

◦ 3

B00MER

[A_certain_reader](#)

Reader

10mo

the author has many other novels but not on this website, or only available for purchase

[Reply](#)

15 0

◦ 1

gabrielreads

[A_certain_reader](#)

Reader

11mo

Haha been seeing you in the comments for the Perfect run, now im here for the same reason as you, although i've not finished yet

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12

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Chapter 1: Vainqueur the Dragon

Vainqueur the Dragon, great calamity of his age, stirred as he awakened from his sleep.

This sixty-foot long beast of legends, with scales more radiant than molten rubies and great jet black wings, yawned as he stretched his body, pushing away some of the gold and jewels of his hard-won hoard. *How good*, he thought, his golden eyes opening and acclimating to the darkness of his cave, to rest on the wages of victory after a feast. He could spend another half a century here if he didn't feel the urge to eat some cattle this morning.

Vainqueur slowly stretched his mighty neck until his crown of horns scraped against the stone ceiling. He surveyed his cave deep within the southern mountains of Albain, marveling at the beauty of his shining conquests. A bed of rubies, diamonds and gold coins, looted from beastkins, mermaids, the retinue of an elven princess, and the corpses of armored manlings foolish enough to challenge him. A good hoard, but a small one; one he promised himself to double in size before going back to hibernation.

Maybe he should raid the dwarves next? He had heard they collected enough gems to fill underground vaults.

And here, on his left, one of his trusty, dutiful goblin minions cleaned up a silver rapier, one of the finest items of his treasures. It was a tall goblin, with smooth skin, a dirtied hood and a terrified expression as Vainqueur watched him...

Wait.

That was no goblin, but a human. A *manling*.

Vainqueur suddenly blinked in realization, and so did the manling who just realized he had woken up a dragon.

“A thief!” Moved to action by a flash of fury, Vainqueur roared and attempted to crush the manling with his upper arm, the terrified rogue jumping to the side with the rapier before he could make a dash to the exit. Vainqueur kept attempting to stomp the manling like a fruit, but the cloaked one had good reflexes.

No matter, the cave was too small, and the exit on the other side. The dragon quickly cornered the robber, trapping him between a wall and himself. The manling held the rapier as a desperate weapon, but only the threat of melting his treasure prevented Vainqueur from burning that treacherous animal to cinders.

Vainqueur quickly scanned his hoard with a glance, sighing in relief upon finding no missing piece. He had caught the thief right in the act.

“I swear it,” Vainqueur cursed in dragonian. “You take a quick nap for fifty years—*fifty years*—and everyone forgets the food chain.”

Even setting up his lair in the tallest mountain known to western dragonkind hadn’t discouraged thieves.

And where were these damn goblins he had allowed to live in exchange for keeping watch? Did they run? Or did the thief kill them? Why was it so hard to find good help nowadays?

No matter. He would eat this fool and then raid the nearby villages for cattle; that would teach the manlings not to bother him again. “My sweet food,” he told the thief in the manling’s tongue, “What is your name?”

The manling’s hideously small eyes bulged beneath the hood. “You can speak?”

“Yes, yes, sometimes I talk to my breakfast.” Or to maidens he abducted back in his younger years. “Answer me manling, before I lose patience.”

“I, uh...” The human trembled at Vainqueur’s amazing majesty. “Victor, sir...”

“Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of his Name, Great Calamity of this Age and King of the Albain Mountains. But you may call me Your Majesty.”

“Your majesty—”

“With a capital M,” Vainqueur corrected his insolent food. “I can tell the difference.”

“Your Majesty, I swear this is a mistake!”

“I do not think so, manling. Now, tell me, because I truly want to know. What made you think trying to steal from *me* was *ever* a good idea?”

The manling narrowed his eyes in recognition of his stupidity. Vainqueur knew little of manlings, but this one sounded young, barely an adult. “I swear,” he said. “I didn’t know this mountain was yours. Someone hired me to recover that rapier, and that was all! It was thought lost, not yours.”

“Liar!” Vainqueur roared, his voice causing the ceiling to tremble, “You must have fought past an army of goblins to get there!”

“There... there’s been no goblin activity in the mountains for decades, Your Majesty. They fled Barsino’s great march through the Albain mountains twenty years ago.”

What? Vainqueur hummed deeply, trying to smell goblin stench. His sharp senses didn’t pick up any, not even the faintest hint. The manling was right, no goblin had guarded his lair for ten years at least.

“Those moronic cowards, fleeing the very second I take a nap?” Vainqueur cursed in dragonian, the manling unable to understand the brilliant elder tongue. The dragon deigned to return to the creature’s primitive language. “Do you have minions, manling Victor?”

“Minions?” Understanding the dragon would let him live so long as he answered, manling Victor spoke. “I had a party once, but it didn’t work out.

Like I was the only professional with ambition beyond petty theft.”

“Finding good help is hard everywhere,” Vainqueur ranted to his audience. “I advise you never to hire goblins, even if you will not live long enough to. I will spare you this mistake.”

“Wait, wait!” The manling panicked. “They will send someone else, even if you kill me! No one knows Your Majesty lives in these mountains!”

“They will, once I burn the countryside to cinders,” Vainqueur replied, although the manling indeed piqued his curiosity. “But I am curious, who sent you? I will eat them after you.”

“I don’t know! It was an anonymous request in the guildhall of a town nearby,” manling Victor said, “The reward was one thousand gold coins.”

“A nice sum for such a dirty deed,” Vainqueur condemned him, vowing to search for these coins once he had tracked down the mastermind as payback.

“Yes, but I mostly took it for the challenge,” the manling admitted. “I thought I would gain a few levels out of it. Maybe even a special Perk from the climbing.”

“Levels?” What was that, some kind of cattle food? That interested Vainqueur. “What is that?”

“You, you don’t...” The manling shut his mouth. “How to explain... levels are powers you gain in a class, like Knight or Wizard or Outlaw, and which grant you extra power called Perks. You gain levels through work, experience, or killing stuff. I thought I would gain at least one or two.”

What rubbish was that? “You cannot even begin to *fathom* the number of thieves I slew, manling Victor, and I never received any of these, ‘levels’.”

“Maybe you just didn’t know,” the manling pleaded for his miserable life.

That was stupid. Class? Like what, a thief? He was a great red dragon, the king of the mountains, the apex of creation! Surely the mighty dragonkind

would have unlocked such a power long ago if it existed!

Congratulations!

What? Vainqueur thought, as words appeared right before his eyes.

Through your sheer ego and noble dragon bloodline, you gained a level in the [**Noble**] class!

+30 HP, +10SP, +1 STR, +1 AGI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You gained the [**Old Money**] class perk!

What was this witchery? Math magic? The sight puzzled Vainqueur. “Old Money?” he said out loud, much to manling Victor’s confusion.

[**Old Money**]: double the chances of monsters dropping treasure after death.

Ah. Nice. “Manling Victor,” the dragon asked his food. “Do you self-identify as a monster?”

“Of course not!” the manling replied, and it didn’t sound like a bluff, “Monsters are goblins or trolls or... or...”

“Or dragons?” Vainqueur finished the sentence, amused. Well, if that ‘perk’ worked on that damn, arrogant frost dragon Icefang in the northern lands, he might just triple the size of his hoard. The dragon narrowed his head until it was within an inch of the thief, who tried to present a strong face. “Take off your hood and cloak, manling, slowly. Look me in the eye.”

The manling did so, revealing his face. As Vainqueur had guessed, this was a young adult manling, with disgusting short black hair instead of mighty horns; how these animals could live with them Vainqueur would never understand. Still, the dragon liked the fear and the hint of low cunning in these small, amber eyes. The would-be thief also carried two metal toothpicks around his belt, not worth adding to his hoard.

That manling was no goblin, but it would make a nice substitute. “Manling Victor.”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“Put the rapier back where you found it. You will lead me straight to this ‘Guildhall’ so I may see this request for myself. Since I am short on goblins right now, you will be my new minion until you pay back your life debt to me.”

The manling couldn’t believe the great honor bestowed upon him and thought himself undeserving of it. “I am wholly unsuited for this role, Your Majesty.”

“I am a dragon,” Vainqueur reminded the manling of this timeless wisdom. “You are now my minion.”

The manling said nothing for a short while, before gracefully accepting his new role, “It is a great honor, Your Majesty.”

“Very good. There is a great reward in doing as I wish. Namely, living. Any other dragon would have eaten you for your sinful crime and would never have taken a manling in their service, but I am forgiving and merciful.”

“This is very generous of you, Your Majesty.”

“I know, manling. Now, tell me more about these Perks...”

Chapter 2: V&V

Victor had no idea what he had gotten himself into.

For the first time in his life, he flew outside the confines of a plane. Namely, the dragon carried him in palm—because his back was too good for Victor—as he flew north of the mountain, towards the Valbin village where he took that damn request. Victor hated the experience; not only did he take the icy wind head on in the face, the dragon held him tight and could crush him any moment.

Victor had had a terrible luck streak lately, and no amount of Luck stat increase changed it. Dying on Earth to end up in this fantasy world, falling in with brigands to make ends' meets, barely avoiding death half a dozen times, and then getting caught by a giant dragon on his very first adventurer quest.

This world sucked!

“Your Majesty!” Victor shouted, as the duo left the snowy mountain for the grasslands, the sight of the village coming to life under the morning sun. “I should go alone! The guard will sound the alarm at your coming!”

The dragon would have none of it. “Minion, a king sometimes must show his face to his subjects, so they may remember who rules them. Also, I do not trust you yet not to have lied to me, especially about this ‘class system’.”

In hindsight, Victor wondered if informing a giant red dragon about it had been his brightest idea.

How could he have known? Every civilized person on this goddamn planet knew about it! They even had Class Scholars!

As expected, as they reached the village's wooden ramparts, Victor heard the song of bells, the city watch sounding the alarm upon seeing the dragon. Not that it would help. Victor had heard a single dragon could devastate a country single-handedly, and Vainqueur seemed huge even by reptilian standards.

A few archers and wizards on the ground launched arrows and lightning bolts at the legendary beast; they bounced off Vainqueur's scales, who didn't even notice. "Minion, where is this guildhall?" the dragon demanded, as he circled the village, the inhabitants closing their windows at the sight of his dreaded shadow.

"The stone building with the bells, between the bell tower and the marketplace, Your Majesty."

Finding his target, the dragon landed on his hind legs in the middle of the marketplace, the flapping of his wings and his sheer mass blowing away most stands. Panic set among humans, beastkin, and elf merchants, as they hurriedly fled screaming, most of them not even grabbing their wares with them.

Vainqueur briefly glanced at the animal-like beastkins with what looked like hunger in his eyes, before focusing on the guildhall and its human-sized, closed doors. Without a care in the world, the dragon headbutted the entrance, smashing down the walls and most of the ceiling, so he could move inside.

Victor found himself in front of two dozen adventurers armed to the teeth, forming a wall between the dragon and Charlene, the pretty, plump receptionist Victor had hoped to take out on a date after his first quest. The mission board which caused this whole fiasco stood behind her back; Victor immediately noticed that damn request among them.

A powerfully built spearman led the adventurers, swinging his spear like a show-off. "My fellows!" he shouted, his white teeth shining as he flashed a smile, "Are you afraid of a flying lizard? Well, I am not! I am not afraid of an oversized drake, and I will prove it this second!"

That asshole braggart, Alain... Victor couldn't stand him, but that smug bastard was the highest level adventurer in town at twenty-five. He had killed a lot of drakes, even a giant. Maybe he had a shot at killing the dragon.

With a mighty roar, Alain charged with his spear, his sheer moxie inspiring the rest of the adventurers to follow suit.

With a gaze full of condescension, Vainqueur lazily moved his free hand in front of the incoming spearman, and flicked his fingers.

Alain went flying and crashed against a stone wall with a loud, morbidly amusing sound. He turned into a puddle of blood, brains and bones on impact, like a squashed mosquito.

... they were all doomed.

The adventurers immediately screamed as one. They dropped their weapons and fled by crashing through the windows and the staff backdoor, much to Vainqueur's smug amusement. Only poor Charlene stood behind her desk, too shocked to move, her poor colleagues probably hiding beneath it.

Finally, the dragon released Victor, letting him walk again. "Minion Victor, do the thing," the dragon ordered, Charlene briefly blinking at hearing him speak in common.

The poor rogue briefly glanced at the broken windows, realized they were too far off to escape, and cleared his throat. "Charlene," the terrified receptionist's eyes moved from the dragon to him, "I present you King Vainqueur the First of his Name, my new boss. Long may he live."

Her eyes widened in stark, raving terror. "Vainqueur? Vainqueur *Knightsbane*?! The Red Terror of Midgard?!" She clenched her fists in a mix of horror and fury, while Vainqueur looked proud that people remembered him. "You brought an ancient red dragon to our village! Are you insane?!"

“Yes, yes, of course I had a choice in the matter,” Victor deadpanned, pointing at the giant behemoth right behind him.

“Minion Victor, who is this female manling and why do we need her?”

“She’s the chief of staff and receptionist of this guildhall, Your Majesty,” Victor explained, making discreet signs to Charlene to play along.

“Charlene, please tell the giant angry dragon what you do.”

The woman glanced up at the dragon, then wisely decided to play along. She dusted her robes, then adopted the same professional look she used with every would be adventurer, albeit while still noticeably trembling in fear. “I manage the paperwork and requests on behalf of the Gardemagne Adventurer Guild. I receive requests from clients and distribute them, and the rewards to adventurers and mercenaries willing to take them on.”

“Minion Victor, ask manling Charlene to find and read the request that led you to my domain out loud.”

Of course, the dragon couldn’t read the language, even if he could speak it. Even Victor had taken a few months of intense study to learn it. “Your Majesty does not talk to other humans?” Victor asked the giant beast, curious.

“No, talking to animals is what a minion is for,” Vainqueur replied. “Minion Victor, ask manling Charlene to read your request out loud.”

“Charlene, would you kindly…” The secretary had already grabbed one of the paper sheets on the board behind her, clearly in no hurry to test the dragon’s patience.

The woman cleared her throat. “Louise, Marquise de Carabas, offers a generous one thousand gold pieces reward for the return of her family’s prized Silver Rapier, last reported in the hands of goblins in the Albain mountains. There is a drawing of the sword with it.”

Since most goblins had fled the mountains years ago, Victor thought it would be easy money. That, and bringing the rapier back would give him

the opportunity to scout the Carabas estate in case something caught his fancy.

A pity the locals had forgotten to mention the dragon's presence.

"It appears you spoke the truth, minion Victor. You shall be spared. You too, manling Charlene, if you tell where I may visit this Marquise and eat her cattle."

"Charlene, where is—"

"I heard," the angry receptionist cut him off. "Victor, give me your map."

The rogue hurriedly grabbed the old sheet of paper he kept around his belt, Charlene taking it from his hands, grabbing a feather pen, and marking a spot in the south-east of the Gardemagne countryside.

Vainqueur squinted, as he observed the board where Charlene took Louise de Carabas' request. "Minion, explain to me how it works."

"People, mostly nobles, merchants, or groups of peasants, send requests to the adventurer guild alongside promised rewards," Victor explained, "With the end of the Century War two years ago, many of them involve dealing with roving monsters or brigands."

"There were many lucrative requests and bounties to take Your Majesty down, decades ago," Charlene said, "until you were declared dead."

"Oh? And all this time I thought your kind had a collective deathwish, like sending your sick and your wounded to die honorably at my—" Vainqueur suddenly stopped mid sentence, as the words hit him. "Declared dead?"

Charlene winced as the dragon glared at her. "A-a group of Barinian adventurers brought back a red dragon skull twenty years ago after Barsino's march through the mountains, declaring it belonged to Vainqueur... and since no red dragon showed up for years afterward..."

"This, this is an indignity!" The news had infuriated the beast almost as much as Victor's attempted robbery, smoke steaming from his nostrils.

“Minion, order manling Charlene to inform your primitive, credulous species that I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, am not dead!”

“I am sure the news will travel fast after Your Majesty’s mighty show of force,” Victor deadpanned, the dragon thankfully too incensed to notice the sarcasm.

“They better do!” Vainqueur calmed himself, his eyes fixed on the board. “What kind of requests does this manling get?”

“Charlene, can you read a few quests for His Majesty’s benefit?”

A bit more confident due to being in her element, Charlene grabbed a paper sheet and read it out loud. “A clan of trolls calling themselves the Branded Barks has sacked the lands of the Count of Provencal and currently hide in the Woods of Gevaudan, east of his domain. The Count offers a great reward for the extermination of this vermin.”

“You get ‘experience’ and ‘levels’ for this deed?” Vainqueur asked, before clarifying his true intention. “*I could get levels?*”

“You know about levels?” Charlene blinked, without waiting for Victor’s ‘animal translation.’

“His Majesty Vainqueur apparently leveled up in the Noble class,” Victor told her. It was fitting for a large, bellyful parasite living off the gold he ‘taxed’ from people weaker than him.

“A dragon can level up in a class?” Whatever colors left on Charlene’s face suddenly drained, as she realized the implications. “Oh, by the twelve gods, dragons can get class levels.”

“Yes, my minion recently informed me of the existence of this class system.” If glares could kill, Charlene would have murdered Victor twice over. “How much do you manlings get paid for this request?”

“Six thousand gold coins.”

“Six thousand gold coins, to eat trolls?”

“This is considered a difficult quest, Your Majesty,” Victor said. These were war trolls, brought by Prydain during the great war, crafty and strong.

“Trolls? You are afraid of *trolls*?” The dragon’s bellowing hiss of a laugh made the walls tremble. “You manlings are so weak!”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Victor deadpanned, angered by his patronizing. “Maybe you should consider a career as an adventurer and show us the ropes? I’m sure you would do great.”

He said this as a joke, but much to his horror, the dragon seemed to consider his words seriously. “Six thousand coins for a feast of trolls...” he mumbled. “Is this the most well-paid request available?”

“No, Your Majesty,” Victor replied. “I think it was the kraken hunting bounty, right?”

Charlene nodded abruptly. “Killing the Kraken of Massaline is worth the equivalent of sixty-four thousand gold coins in emeralds.”

The fires of greed lit up in the dragon’s eyes. “Sixty-four thousand? That is almost as much as my entire—” He stopped himself, probably realizing that he had already said too much.

As much as my entire hoard, Victor guessed. Perhaps more. The rogue estimated quite a few of the items the dragon had collected had lost their luster over time.

Victor could almost see the gears turning in the dragon’s head, and the exact train of thought his mind followed. And it terrified him.

Oh no. Oh please no.

“Minion Victor, I intended to burn this village to the ground for you manlings’ crimes against my royal person,” Vainqueur declared. “But I suddenly realize my usual method of building my hoard may be slightly outdated. All of this wealth sleeping without a good dragon to claim them is a sin, and if this Old Money perk does not lie...”

Oh by the gods, please no...

“I, Vainqueur the Dragon, will gladly answer requests and solve your inferior species’ problems for your coins!”

Charlene, too, wondered if the dragon was serious. When it became clear that yes, he was, she didn’t know what to do. “Your Majesty, Vainqueur, I am not sure a dragon can become an adventurer.”

“Of course, I am overqualified,” Vainqueur declared proudly.

“Your Majesty, this is not—”

“I am a dragon. I am, now, an adventurer. And you are starting to sound like food. Minion, is manling Charlene food?”

“Charlene, are you dragon food?”

Charlene, understanding the implied threat, searched under the desk for a huge pile of paperwork, putting it on the desk. “I will register you two as a new adventurer company. We will need both your signatures, and the paperwork done.”

Vainqueur glanced at the pile of paper, then at Victor, who saw what came next coming from a mile away. “Minion Victor.”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“I officially promote you to my minion chief of staff and living signature. You shall be responsible for managing this ‘paperwork’ thing on my behalf. This is a great and important responsibility, but you will do fine.”

Victor guessed he wouldn’t be paid for it, but wisely kept that to himself.

Congratulations! By becoming the chief enforcer of a mighty dragon, you gained a level in the **Monster Squire** Class!

Victor blinked at the notification. Monster Squire? He had never heard of that class.

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You gained the [**Monster Kin**] Class Perk!

[**Monster Kin**: you can now talk to and understand any monster, and gain a +20 charisma bonus when interacting with them!]

Wow, he never received such a massive stat boost before. That Class must have incredible growth potential.

Victor glanced at the name Charlene registered the adventurer company as, and froze.

V&V?

“Is this a prank?” he asked out loud.

Charlene glared at him, then at the dragon, then at the destroyed ceiling, then back at him.

Okay, maybe he deserved it. He supposed that also meant she wouldn't go out for a drink with him. Bugger.

“What is it, minion Victor?”

“Nothing, Your Majesty,” Victor sighed as he completed and signed the documents on both his and the dragon's behalf, “Nothing.”

“I would wish for you to go to hell, Victor,” the receptionist said. “But I think you're already there.”

Chapter 3: First Quest

They gave him a lead plate tag with his name on it. *Him*. Like he was some *mammal*.

“This is degrading!” Vainqueur complained to his loyal lackey Victor, as they flew above the farmlands of Carabas. The news had put him in a foul mood. “Lead? *Lead!*”

“Every adventurer starts with a lead plate,” Victor explained, the wind in his face causing his lips to move in ways Vainqueur found distracting. “That’s the ranks. Lead, copper, iron, bronze, silver, gold, and starmetal. I’m a lead adventurer too, Your Majesty.”

“But you are a *manling!*” Also, why the adventurer guild put that greenish unshiny starmetal higher than brilliant gold, Vainqueur would never understand. “I am a *dragon*. Can you manlings fly? Can you breathe fire that melts stone? Can you live forever? No, so why is that not enough for gold?”

“You are a unique case, Your Majesty,” minion Victor tried to assuage his wounded pride. “Forgive my poor species, who does not know how to deal with you.”

“Just this once!” Vainqueur said, flying over a vast forest, smelling the presence of trolls, slimes, and other beasts below. Birds and harpies flew away in fear at his arrival. “Are these the troll woods?”

“Yes, Your Majesty. Trolls usually live in caves, if we look for one—”

“Minion, I will not sully my peerless scales with some troll’s dung. I am a dragon, remember?” Vainqueur took a long, deep breath, and then dove

towards the woods. The forge in his stomach lit up, the infernal power within turning the air into flames.

The great calamity unleashed his mighty dragonfire upon the forest, a torrent of bright, nearly white flames incinerating trees, animals, everything; Vainqueur flew in a straight line around the forest, intending to make a full ring of fire and trap the trolls – and whatever creatures unlucky enough to live with them – within.

Victor screamed in surprise, held close to Vainqueur's own maw. "Your Majesty, what are you doing?!"

"Fulfilling your kind's request," Vainqueur replied, after taking back some breath and preparing for a second round. Thanks to the wind, the inferno spread through the forest far north, turning trees to candles and grass to embers.

Vainqueur dove again through a cloud of smoke, much to his minion's terror, smelling trolls below. A bunch of these savage, green-skinned giants attempted to flee the coming flames, only for the dragon to bombard them, spitting his fire in the shape of fireballs instead of a continuous stream. The projectiles exploded on contact with the ground, vaporizing the beasts, blasting the dirt and forming craters.

Congratulations! You gained a level in [**Noble**]!

+30 HP, +1 INT, +1 LCK!

Vainqueur awaited the declaration of a new Perk, but nothing came up. Maybe he hadn't burned the place enough. The forest bordered several hills forming a natural frontier, and so Vainqueur bombarded this area too, intent on devastating the entire forest instead of just the troll's lair.

After a few minutes of firebombing the land, Vainqueur finished remaking the Woods of Gevaudan into a nice, smoking hellscape. "There, troll problem solved!" Vainqueur said, happy with himself. "All we need is to claim the reward now!"

“Your Majesty, can I...” Victor pleaded, the ash-filled wind making him scoff, “Your Majesty, flight is terrible when you hold me in your palm. Especially when you breathe dragonfire down my neck.”

“This must be your lack of scales,” Vainqueur said. “I empathize with your situation, I truly do, but what can I do about this birth defect?”

“Can I... can I... can I ride on your back instead?”

Vainqueur looked down on his insolent lackey. “Minion, what kind of ungrateful demand is that? Have I not given you an honest occupation? When I found you this morning you were but a mere thief, purposeless, adrift. Now you are chief of staff. *My* chief of staff. Do not demand too much.”

Victor sighed at his master’s scolding. “I guess at least I got a level out of this.”

“You did?” Was that not payment enough?

“Yeah, I got a level in Monster Squire when you made me your ‘chief of staff,’ and now I got another. I didn’t even know this class existed.”

“What is a squire? A manling term?”

“It’s, uh, the apprentice of a knight or a noble. They help them get ready for battle, do menial chores for their boss, learn the tricks of the trade...”

“Ah, yes. A minion.”

“Yes, it pays just as much.”

Of course, the manlings would copy this honorable dragon institution. They learned from the best. “I did not get a perk this time, which I find confounding.”

“It’s only one per two levels, Your Majesty.”

“Who decides that?”

“The gods, I think. Or maybe the Fomors.”

“These good for nothing upstarts? They always claim they made the world when *everyone* knows dragons did it first. Tell me where I can find and reprimand them.”

Victor gave him a strange, incredulous look. “Reprimand the... I don’t know Your Majesty, I’m not a religious guy. Maybe we could ask a bishop.”

“We will after you climb down and recover what is mine.”

“After I *what*?”

“According to this Old Money Perk , the trolls below should drop treasures when they die. You do not expect me to get down and sully myself with ashes?”

Victor glanced down at the fiery crater below them, then back at his master. “Your Majesty, I am not immune to fire.”

Not immune to—ah yes, he had forgotten. By the elder wyrm, how could the manlings avoid extinction so far? “We will delay my gratification until after the fires die down,” Vainqueur said, “after we obtain restitution for your previous employer’s crime.”

“Sure, sure, if we could just land somewhere safe so I could look at the map...”

No wonder that Marquise lowered herself to hire thieves. Vainqueur too would be bitter at living in a palace with only one tower.

And one on such a small hill at that. The female manling would seethe in jealousy upon seeing Vainqueur’s own lair, made of the world’s tallest mountains. That castle had little stone walls, overseeing villages from above its mound, and manned with manlings equipped with bows and arrows. They had fired a few of these toothpicks as Vainqueur and his minion landed on their front door, with the dragon retaliating by tossing a few of

the primates on the ground with his tail. After they stopped, Vainqueur had patiently waited for them to bring their master for a civilized chat.

The castle overflowed with the smell of cats and felines, including lions, tigers, and even a sphinx, according to Vainqueur's nose. A flag representing a cat with boots stood at the summit of the tower, much to the dragon's amusement.

Maybe they had good knights? It had been a while since Vainqueur had lived up to his name.

"I have been wondering, minion, what does Marquise mean in your language?"

The minion finished stretching his legs, happy to be back on his feet. "That means she's a noble lady. Don't ask me where she ranks in the kingdom's hierarchy, I just know she's above the count that put the request for the trolls."

A noble lady? Vainqueur's head perked up, his Princess Sense stirring. "Is she a princess?"

"A princess? I don't think so, no. Why?"

Disappointing. "Old habits."

The manling's tiny eyes blinked. "Does Your Majesty kidnap princesses?"

"Sometimes, mostly elves," Vainqueur said, fondly remembering that particular hunting season he snatched the only elven princess of the current generation before his rivals. He had bragged to his fellow dragons for centuries afterward. "This is a very popular sport among dragonkind, since the black dragon Grandrake ransomed the manling Princess Genevieve a thousand years ago. Maybe I will take you minion on a hunting season someday."

"Do you..." His minion hesitated, as if afraid of the answer, "Do you eat them?"

“Of course not, do you take me for a savage? I release them back in the wild when I get bored of their whining.” Or when he ran out of the food he had stored to keep them alive.

As if hearing their conversation, a chubby, two-legged cat the size of a manling joined the soldiers on the walls, wearing emerald and gold jewelry that Vainqueur immediately thought would look great atop his hoard; so would her golden fur. Two pretty manling maidens attended the cat, looking fearfully at Vainqueur.

Apparently, the owner wasn't a manling, but a catkin. “What business have you here, threatening my castle, dragon tamer?” the cat, Marquise Louise, asked the minion.

Vainqueur couldn't help but laugh. Humans, taming dragons? “I think you got our relationship backward!” Victor shouted back with modesty.

“*I tamed him,*” Vainqueur made a face. Even if that talking cat was probably the Marquise, she didn't smell like a princess. She didn't even smell like a virgin! Not worth adding to his hoard. Still, since she was noble blood, Vainqueur deigned answer directly. “I am Vainqueur Knightsbane, King of the Albain Mountains, great calamity of this age! You sent ruffians after my silver rapier treasure, interrupting my long nap. I thereby demand half your cattle as restitution for the trouble caused, alongside the one thousand gold coins you offered for my possession.”

“Half the cattle in my marquise?” the catkin asked with her shrill, insolent voice. “This is preposterous!”

“I had to fly two hours to get here,” Vainqueur emphasized his pain, “Two. *Hours*. I burned pounds of fat and smelled the dung of your peasants coming to this place.”

“Also, Your Majesty burned the local woods coming here!” minion Victor shouted to the Marquise. “On request of the Count of Provencal!”

“Who owes me six thousand golden coins for this service!” Vainqueur pointed at the lead tag around his neck with his claw. “See this tag? I am an

adventurer! The greatest your puny race has ever known!”

“Certainly, Your Majesty,” Victor said. “Certainly.”

The marquise let out a hiss as she squinted at the lead tag, then turned to whisper at one of her manling knights. “Bring me Count Gilbert for an explanation,” Vainqueur heard her say thanks to his good ears, before she turned to the dragon. “If I give you what you want, you will leave my lands at once?”

“That depends, do you have more quests for me?” Vainqueur asked, eager for more gold.

“No, no, we do not,” the marquise declared with haste.

“Also, if you have a Bishop on hands, Your Majesty has theological questions!” Victor added. “Important questions!”

“Good thinking, minion,” Vainqueur said.

“Our chaplain is away on a diplomatic mission.” The marquise then turned to whisper to the same knight as before. “Tell our cooks to prepare a feast for King Vainqueur. The ‘troublesome guest’ kind, with the special ingredient.”

“I will tell the cooks to put the maximum dose,” the knight added.

“We will provide you with a feast, and the reward for your noble deed!” the marquise told Vainqueur. “I hope you shall forgive us for our lack of courtesy!”

“Only if your cattle is good!” Vainqueur replied.

“You will find it most exquisite,” the catkin noble replied with a strange tone, before leaving with her knight.

“She’s...” Victor struggled to find his words. “Damn, she’s a catkin. And here I thought she would be hot.”

“Not as hot as me,” Vainqueur rolled his eyes at his chief of staff’s naivety. “You are too easily impressed, minion. My breath burns brighter than the sun. You have seen it. Of course, she would be lukewarm in comparison.”

“Yeah, at least most of the staff is human. I wonder if one of the ladies-in-waiting is single.”

“Of course they are not ‘single’, your noblewomen are rare in the wild, but not as much as princesses.” Clearly, Vainqueur would have to finish the poor minion’s education.

As the sun began to set, armorless manlings came out of the castle, bringing Vainqueur fat, cooked sheep, pigs, and cows on carriages. A fat, obese manling wearing brighter, cleaner clothes than the servants led the way, carrying purses and sweating. “Minion, is that manling part of the feast?” Vainqueur asked Victor.

“I’m not sure, Your Majesty...”

“No, no,” the fat man sweated. “I am Gilbert, Count of Provencal.”

“Ah, the one who issued the troll request?” Vainqueur’s head perked up. The purses must contain his rewards.

“Yes, yes, I was petitioning the marquise for help getting rid of them before Your... Your Majesty solved the problem.” The count gulped as he looked at the smoke rising on the horizon. “You were very zealous...”

“I am taking my duty as an adventurer seriously,” Vainqueur agreed, swallowing a cow whole and spitting out some meat that got stuck between his sharp fangs. “You can eat the leftovers, minion. Let it never be said that Vainqueur starves his staff.”

The minion glanced at the feast, then at the count, noticing sweat over his forehead. “No, no, I cannot share Your Majesty’s meal,” Victor replied. “It’s all yours.”

Such a dutiful manling. Why did Vainqueur ever bother with goblins? “You have come to deliver my reward?”

“Alongside the marquise’s gift of apology,” the sweating manling said. “She said this was my duty as her vassal.”

“Indeed, what a good minion you are,” Vainqueur said, feasting on sheep covered with a strange sauce. “Minion Victor, count the coins. And do not dare steal them!”

“Oh, very far from my mind, Your Majesty,” Victor replied, taking the purses and doing as asked.

Congratulations! By stomaching the poison in the food like a champ, you gained the **[Lesser Poison Immunity]** Perk!

“Poison? What was this? Manling seasoning?” The count smiled, although it strangely did not reach his ears, and sweated so much Vainqueur wondered if he would die of it on the spot. Was he ill?

“Yes, Your Majesty,” minion Victor said. “It’s a very bitter spice for special occasions.”

“I did not feel the taste, bring more of it!” Vainqueur complained, the count hurriedly running to the castle and attend to his needs.

Maybe he would get a stronger Perk at the end of the feast?

Chapter 4: Chief of Staff

When the marquise had invited Victor to a private breakfast in her apartments, Victor had expected everything *but* an actual breakfast. Maybe a poisoned meal, or being made into the breakfast, or maybe fed to a lion. Not an actual, pleasant breakfast with the lady of the house and the Count of Provencal.

Of course, she had four knights ready to chop his head off at any moment, alongside a few catkin butlers, but he was thankful for the meal all the same. It had been a while since he last ate beef and cooked vegetables with a fork.

Thankfully, he didn't taste any poison in the meal. He guessed yesterday's fiasco taught them a lesson.

"This is humiliating," the marquise said, lounging in a mink chair while petting a winged lion in one hand and sipping a glass of wine with the other. Victor guessed she had taken more than a few drinks. "A red dragon empties our pantry and then decides to take a nap at my front door. Why did the gods send this calamity? Is he still there?"

"Yes, my lady," an armored knight in full plate armor replied, glancing through the window. "He is resting on his back, with a hand on his belly. The poison should have killed him thrice over by now."

"Why did you have so much poison on hand in the first place?" Victor asked, too curious for his own good.

"Intense war politics," the marquise replied without giving more of an explanation, shifting uncomfortably in her chair. "I cannot take this anymore! Someone groom me!"

One of the catkin attendants, a thin, frail, humanoid cat wearing butler clothes, groomed the back of the marquise's ears with a paw, soothing her. "Victor, is it?" she asked him suddenly. "What is your level?"

"I'm level seven, madam." Five levels in Outlaw, two in Monster Squire.

"A level seven taming a dragon?" She sneered at him with resentment. "I do not believe you."

"Do I look like a dragon tamer to you?" Victor replied with a sneer of his own.

"He listens to you," the Count of Provencal said, having removed his sweat with a now wet handkerchief. "You saved my life."

"Listens is a bit exaggerated. That creature is a goddamn wrecking ball, all I can do is try to steer him in one direction and hope he doesn't burn too many houses."

"We could mount a surprise attack while he sleeps," a guard proposed.

"Yeah right, try to kill the invincible dragon who ignores arrows and thinks your best poison is pepper. Maybe you will give him a better perk this time." As he drew glares from the nobles and their guards, Victor cursed his tongue. When he had noticed Vainqueur didn't understand sarcasm, the adventurer could no longer help himself. It helped relieve the stress of dealing with the wyrm.

"Use another tone with your better, ruffian!" one of the guards spoke up, barely restraining himself from hitting him in the face with his iron gauntlet. His mistress interrupted him with a mere gaze.

"Where do you come from?" the marquise asked Victor. "Your accent is not Gardemagnian. It sounds vaguely Prydanian."

Her tone told Victor this wasn't a good thing to flaunt. The Fomors of Prydain had shed much blood in their attempted conquest of Gardemagne,

and their Wild Hunt still attacked ships approaching their island. “I come from America,” Vic admitted, before adding, “Earth.”

“A Claimed,” the marquise nodded. “Show me.”

Victor pulled back the sleeve on his left arm, revealing a crimson, shining tattoo representing a twenty-faced dice. “The mark of Dice,” the Marquise recognized. “I should have known only a chosen of the luck god could befriend a dragon.”

Some luck. This world *sucked*. It was full of brigands, man-eating monsters, *dragons*, oh, and stuck in the Middle Ages! He hadn’t been able to take a hot bath for months! All because he saved some girl he had a crush on from getting mugged, only to be stabbed and left to bleed in an alley. And if *death* hadn’t hurt enough, getting forced to join a band of outlaws to survive right afterward had been just as harrowing.

But he understood where that comment came from. People from Earth reincarnating in Outremonde after being branded by the local gods were a known occurrence, and most sported unique perks allowing them to make a life for themselves. The phenomenon even caused the rise of a new religion, the Esoteric Order of the New World.

But Victor didn’t care about becoming a hero or a local curiosity. He just wanted to survive, get laid, and return home.

Also, *befriend*? Victor would have run away if he could. Unfortunately, the dragon would probably track him down in no time, that beast had keen senses. “Look, lady, I’ll try to lure him off your lands, but I don’t promise anything. Just don’t try to steal his stuff again, okay?”

“My lady, why did you ask for this rapier in the first place?” the Count of Provencal asked.

“This is a family heirloom,” the marquise replied. “My ancestor, according to legends, befriended a manling adventurer and tricked a King of Gardemagne into giving the boy his daughter’s hand. As a reward, the

manling gave my ancestor his prized rapier and the marquise of Carabas. Catkins ruled Carabas ever since.”

Ah, that explained all the felines running around.

“Looters stole that rapier from my great grandfather’s corpse during the Century War, but I had no idea it ended in the claws of a red dragon,” the marquise said, a maid refilling her glass. “I did not know one befouled the country, let alone Vainqueur Knightsbane.”

“He’s got a reputation?” Victor asked, eager to know more about the wyrm.

“He was the bane of Midgard for centuries, before vanishing fifty years ago,” the Count of Provencal said. “Legends say he fought a Wild Hunt party single-handedly and traded blows with a level sixty-seven elf knight.”

From what Victor had heard, only the now legendary Shining Knight approached that level. Which meant the dragon might as well be invincible. “Yeah, and now he has taken two levels in Noble.”

The marquise and the count exchanged worried glances. After all, like most aristocrats, they probably had levels in that class too. “A red dragon should not have access to a Rogue Class,” the marquise stated. “How did this happen?”

Victor wisely decided not to mention his own responsibility. “No idea. He was already like that when I found him. Now he’s set on becoming an adventurer because it pays well, and it’s *easy* for him. Look at the forest.”

“The monsters of Gevaudan plagued the regions for ages, especially with the chaos of the Century War,” one of the knights said. “To destroy the entire area in minutes...”

Louise de Carabas nodded. “While the loss of my pantry is devastating, the economic gains do outweigh it. We might as well make use of the dragon’s current fancy. If he wants to be an adventurer, we could send him on a fool’s errand.”

“My lady, you cannot be serious!” the count protested. “A dragon adventurer? What else, a troll prince?”

“The creature is toying with us,” a guard agreed, clenching his fists. “How long until its natural instincts reassert themselves?”

“We could offer him a doomed request, like attacking the Fomors of Prydain or the demon lord Brandon Maure,” the marquise ignored her advisers, her butlers moving to groom her back. “Either he will succeed and do the world a favor, or fail and get killed.”

“Er, the lizard won’t move unless there’s a significant reward,” Victor said, although the idea had merits. If the dragon was willing to fight other monsters for a price, then maybe he could steer him towards a better purpose. “You better be ready to deliver if he succeeds.”

The marquise frowned, probably lacking the funds to assuage Vainqueur. “No matter,” the marquise said. “My court’s Wizard sent messages to His Majesty King Charles Gardemagne and the Shining Knight, who will dispatch their best warriors after him. After the news spread, this dragon’s days are numbered. ”

Victor doubted they would amount to much. Vainqueur’s family name was *Knightsbane* after all.

But what should he do? Lure Vainqueur to his death, hoping an adventurer would get lucky? His gut told him it wouldn’t work. No, Victor was stuck with the dragon for now, and from what he had seen he would better work with or around him than *against*.

The adventurer decided the best option was to make use of the dragon’s fancy, as the marquise suggested. Even with the war’s end, the kingdom of Gardemagne remained plagued by troublemakers, who killed people right now, instead of retreating to an island far away like the Fomors.

He might also make a nice profit out of this mess. He had gotten two levels in less than one day, after struggling for months to level up in his Outlaw class. Being around a dragon killing strong opponents he himself couldn’t

take on helped him level up faster. If he reached a high enough level while guiding and studying the dragon up close, maybe Victor could escape his grasp one day.

“Are there any troublemakers that need death by dragonfire?” Victor asked, drawing gazes at him, “This is a gamble, but if I aim him at dangerous enemies, maybe one will get lucky and kill him.”

That greedy Vainqueur would never let him keep anything shiny, but if he managed to grab a noble title or magical items while at it...

“The main threats to Gardemagne’s peace are the Scorchers, roving bandits and mercenary bands ravaging the countryside since the end of the Century War,” the Count said. “Bands led by the kind of Ogron the Ogre, Gustave La Muraille, and François Vilmain are causing trouble in the south-west. Duchess Aelinor issued bounties on their heads.”

“They are no match for a dragon, Gilbert,” the marquise said. “Even Ogron is only level thirty-five or so, and while the duchess put a bounty on the Scorchers’ leaders, they are low. Will they motivate a dragon?”

“Do you have the bounties on hands?” Victor guessed he would just guide Vainqueur towards that kraken. Considering the reward, he would have no trouble convincing the dragon. But it wouldn’t hurt to take a look at the other options.

“Minion?” Victor winced, as Vainqueur’s voice made the walls tremble. “Minion?! MINION!”

Vic sighed. Duty called. “Do you happen to have a large bag?” he asked the nobles. “And maybe a potion of fire resistance?”

“Have you not asked enough already?!” a knight lambasted him, the winged lion growling at his outburst.

“Otherwise, I tell him you have a hidden pantry under your tower,” Victor replied, annoyed. “Your choice.”

The marquise waved a hand in annoyance. “Fetch him what he wants, so long as they leave.”

Victor figured babysitting a dragon had its perks.

Chapter 5: Food Chain

“Are we there yet?” Vainqueur asked for the hundredth time, as they flew over yet another stinking human village.

“Nope, sorry,” manling Victor replied, his eyes set on the map he struggled to keep pace with the wind. “Ogron was last seen near Haudemer, and this is Pointin.”

“How do you know?” Vainqueur lambasted his minion guide. They had flown all the way across the land, almost reaching the western sea; yet missed the target. “All of your dirty villages look the same!”

“Oh, Your Majesty, I believe the next one will be the right one.”

“And how so?”

“Because of the fires, Your Majesty.”

Indeed, a column of fire rose from the west, on the coast. Vainqueur squinted, noticing a small city under assault by a large group of manlings.

Vainqueur approached the city and circled it from above to take a good view of it and the nearby beaches. It was larger than the villages they had visited, with stone houses and a wooden extension leading into the sea itself; a port welcomed a dozen floating buildings the manlings called ships. Quite a few of the inhabitants hastily tried to board them.

A large group of manlings, around eighty, attacked the city from the north, axemen slaughtering people like pigs while bowmen set the roofs of nearby buildings on fire. Dozens of corpses littered the stony ground, while defenders used carts as improved barricades to slow down the invaders' progress.

A monstrous, fifteen-foot tall cyclops led the manling attackers, swinging a large two-handed axe which cut soldiers in half with each blow. Arrows and spears bounced off his thick green skin, as he tossed carts away with every step.

Incensed at them not stopping to marvel at his arrival, Vainqueur let out a mighty roar from above, and it did the trick. Everyone looked up at him, freezing at his crimson majesty, their faces draining of colors.

“A dragon!” one of the defenders shouted on the ground. “Ogron has a dragon!”

“Ogron? Aha, finally!” Vainqueur chuckled. “Minion, on whom do I land?”

“The attackers, Your Majesty.”

Vainqueur descended in the streets below, the manlings fleeing at his sight; but not fast enough. His landing blew away nearby houses and crushed half a dozen latecomers.

Only the cyclops hadn't run, glaring at his men with its single eye. “Cowards! Dragons aren't scary!” he shouted at them.

“Of course not, they are amazing,” Vainqueur replied, releasing his minion on the ground. The defenders cowered behind the barricades, unsure how to take this turn of events. “Which of you is Ogron the Ogre?”

The cyclops struck the ground with his axe, pulverizing stones and making the street tremble. “I am!”

Vainqueur looked at the cyclops, then burst out laughing, the one-eyed meat responding with a glare. “No seriously, which of you is Ogron?”

“Your Majesty, this is Ogron,” the minion said.

“Minion, this is a cyclops, not an ogre. Ogres have two eyes.”

“Yeah, I know, but that's Ogron the Ogre anyway. I've seen his poster.”

“You goddamn righ’,” the one-eyed ogre said with rising frustration. “Ain’t no other Ogron! I traveled to this country to figh’ and make war for Gardemagne! I bled dry, and instead of gold, the king gave me a dirt poor farm! Ogron ain’t no farmer, he is a warrior! Ogron will not stop until—”

Vainqueur zoned out at that point, too confused by the eye paradox. All he could notice were isolated blabbering, “Ogron, Ogron, Ogron, pirate! Blah blah, flee the country! Ogrongron, knights!”

“—and that is why Ogron will sail these boats!”

“Minion, if he is a cyclops and not an ogre, why is he called Ogron the Ogre?” Vainqueur ignored the one-eyed ogre. “It doesn’t make sense!”

“Ogron is called Ogron the ogre because...” the cyclops said with a low growl, swinging his axe with impatience and showing his bloodied teeth. “Ogron eats people.”

“You too?” Vainqueur looked at the cyclops with a new, fresh gaze. He was just fat enough around the angles, with plenty of meat...

The cyclops let out a roar, raising his axe to swing it at Vainqueur. “You die —”

Chomp!

Vainqueur took a bit out of the giant’s upper torso, swallowing a third of the corpse in one go. He sprayed blood all over his mouth, too ravenous to care. Everyone looked at Vainqueur as he digested the cyclops’ eye and head, the manlings having all turned pale for some reason.

“Minhion, shyclopsh tashte like shalty pihg!” Vainqueur chewed on the giant’s flesh, finding the taste too sweet to stop with one bite. “Sho good! I wansh more!”

“What about some human bandit snack to go with the taste?” Manling Victor suggested, pointing a finger at the cyclops’ pale followers.

They looked a bit too sick now, but Vainqueur approached his muzzle to smell them closer; at least one of the archers had soiled himself, so the dragon made a face. The bandits panicked at his approach, running away from him screaming.

Vainqueur wondered if he should pursue them, then decided he would rather eat the rest of the cyclops than run. He absentmindedly grabbed a large chunk of a house's stone wall, and tossed it at the fleeing manlings, crushing many of them like insects. The others sped up even faster after that, and Vainqueur returned to his meal.

He ate the rest of the one-eyed ogre with two more bites and let out a belch.

You gained a level in [**Noble**]! You earned the Class Perk: [**Snobbery**]!

+1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

[**Snobbery**]: your attacks inflict five percent more damage on non-noble targets, and you receive five percent less damage from non-noble assailants.

“Minion, I leveled up!”

“Sweet, how many stat points did you win?”

“Four, minion,” Vainqueur replied proudly, before realizing he had no idea what that meant. “Minion, where do stat points go?”

“You can check your class and stats by saying ‘Menu’ out loud.”

“Really?”

“Your Majesty didn’t notice?”

...

“Of course I noticed,” Vainqueur spared the minion’s feelings. “I *always* noticed. I was just testing your knowledge. And you have passed.”

“Truly an honor,” the minion replied with gratitude.

“Menu!” Vainqueur said, the word making hungrier than the ogre. A series of words appeared out of nowhere in front of him.

Vainqueur Knightsbane

Level: 3 (Noble 3)

Type: Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points 5,315 Special Points 1,290 Strength 95 Vitality 88 Skill 11
Agility 39 Intelligence 9 Charisma 71 Luck 39

Personal PerksClass Perks Dragonfire Breath Old Money Fire Immunity
Snobbery Red Dragon Lifeforce Dragon Arrogance Dragonscale Super
Senses Virgin Princess Radar Lesser Poison Resistance

V&V? Double Vainqueur!

A heavy silence had fallen on the area, and Vainqueur realized the manlings defenders looked at him with open eyes.

“Minion, the ambiance feels too heavy,” the dragon said. “Sing my praise to cheer it up.”

Manling Victor immediately raised a fist. “Vainqueur, best dragon!” He turned to the silent manlings behind the barricades, raising his other hand to encourage them, “Vainqueur, best dragon!”

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” a urine-smelling man said. Eventually, the other manlings joined in.

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” “Vainqueur, best dragon!” “Vainqueur, best dragon!”

Much better. “Thank you, thank you, I deserved it,” Vainqueur said, licking the blood on his lips. “I, Vainqueur, am an adventurer coming to rescue you! See the plate? See the lead plate? Now bring me your cattle!”

They fed him only a cow and two pigs, which disappointed Vainqueur slightly, but he was too full from the cyclops to complain.

Vainqueur had made his nest on the beach next to the city, resting on the warm sand as he digested his meal. Even if he had saved the city, he noticed quite a few ships leaving it regardless, fleeing as far away from him as possible. The dragon ignored them and toyed with this ‘menu’ power.

“Menu,” he said, the words appearing, before saying it again. “Menu.” The words disappeared. He did again, finding the process strangely addictive.

After five minutes of playing, Vainqueur noticed the minion returning with two other manlings, one female—not a princess—and the other male. The former was an adult with large mammaries, long blonde hair and that strange clothing the manlings called a dress; the other was an old, frail male with a grey beard and a hat, but otherwise perfectly plain.

Vainqueur still had trouble telling one monkey from another. They all looked the same at first glance.

“Your Majesty,” minion Victor said. “This is the mayor of Haudemer, and its innkeeper, Miss Lynette, and the village’s Class Scholar, Henry Bright. I briefed them on your career choice.”

“Your Majesty Vainqueur, on behalf of Haudemer,” the female manling said, bowing deeply, “As thanks for saving the city, allow me to grant you the city’s highest honors, the keys to—”

“Where is my money?” Vainqueur cut her off.

“Already covered, Your Majesty,” Victor replied, while the female remained speechless from the blunt rebuke. “The local guildhall reported your deed to the Duchess, who will send men at arms to deliver the reward soon.”

The mayor coughed. “Please allow me to offer you free lodging at my inn for a week, free of charge. It would be a pleasure to have you around.”

“Is there a lava bath?” Vainqueur asked.

“A lava...” the female frowned. “No, Your Majesty, no, we do not have a lava bath.”

No lava bath as a basic accommodation? They truly were backward peasants. “I will sleep on your hot sand, but my minion probably does not have my quality standards.”

The female made a strange face, while the minion concurred, “Certainly not, Your Majesty. I will be sure to enjoy a good, warm bed.”

Vainqueur brushed the matter off, focusing on that Class Scholar, who began to speak up. “Great Vainqueur, your friend Victor told me your majesty needed advice on the class system—”

“Majesty, with a capital M,” Vainqueur corrected him. “Also, what is a friend? Some kind of minion?”

Henry blinked. “How can you... does Your Majesty have the [Super Senses] perk?”

Vainqueur checked his menu, noticing it among his ‘personal perks.’ “Ah, yes, I do. How do you know?”

“It’s a Perk common among highly perceptive species, such as beastkins.”

“Henry is our city’s class expert, advising us on how to develop our career, stats, and perks,” Lynette told the dragon. “Although I didn’t know a dragon could get one.”

“Me neither!” Henry exclaimed, “This a new discovery! I couldn’t wait to discuss with Your Majesty about it!”

“Me too,” Vainqueur nodded. “Now, what is this system exactly?”

“It’s a powerful supernatural system unlocked by the god Dice during his first rolling spree, back when it was still a sentient dice artifact,” Henry explained, already losing Vainqueur’s attention. “Classes represent powerful roles, which grant us immense powers when we tap into them.”

“Are you sure dragons did not create it?” Vainqueur pointed the obvious hole in his logic.

“Your Majesty, historical research show the class system appeared with Dice, who is the very first recorded instance of an intelligent being gaining a level in a class. Even if Dice never claimed to have created it, evidence shows that it activated it first.”

“So you have no proof dragons did not create the system first,” Vainqueur replied.

“Er, yes, maybe, but this would go against every research we ever did, all species combined.”

“So this is a dragon-created system to grow stronger and richer, I get it,” Vainqueur said, minion Victor putting his hand on his face for some reason. “Now, manling Henry, I want to get more levels in Noble.”

“Are you sure?” the manling sounded confused, “The noble class is a hit or miss, with either situational ones like [Aristoradar], which help sense true or false nobles, or strong ones, such as [Stipend], which grants money every month.”

“Free money?” Vainqueur’s head perked up, the sudden gesture startling the manling trio, “When?!”

“Noble level nine!” the scholar cowered.

“And then? I gain diamonds at eleven? Tell me!”

“None of the other perks of the noble class increase money gains,” Henry continued, trembling under the dragon’s gaze, before adding hurriedly. “But

there are very good perks, like [Privilege], which allows you to ignore one attack a day.”

“Why would I need it? I already ignore your attacks all the time!”

“That is true indeed,” the minion said.

“What else can make me *richer*?”

“Merchant,” Victor said with a laugh. “Or Banker.”

“But merchant is a minion’s work!” Vainqueur protested.

“Crafter classes tend to get better material rewards, compared to other classes,” Henry said. “But maybe it would be better if I started from the beginning, please?”

Vainqueur sighed, already bored by the professorial tone. “Go on...”

“Classes are divided into five categories. Fighters, the best at direct combat and warfare; Spellcasters, who gain strong magical abilities; Rogues, who focus on tricks and social perks; Crafters, who create items or empower existing effects; and the rare Monster classes, which are only available through deals with monsters. If Your Majesty wants to get richer, Crafter classes like Alchemist or Merchant would indeed work better.”

“A dragon does not hold a shop,” Vainqueur replied proudly. “What else? How many classes can I get?”

“As many as possible, although one cannot get farther than level 100 in total, everything combined. When a person reaches level 100, they level up into the God class, becoming true deities, but no longer able to grow further. Also, the higher your total level, the harder it is to gain new levels, even if a class’s entry conditions are low. You will need ever greater challenges to reach a new level. I see with my Class Screen perk that you have three levels in Noble, so you could probably level quickly to level nine with a good training regiment.”

“The Scorchers are pressured by knights of the Shining Crusade, adventurers out for their bounty, and men of the King,” Lynette said. “Ogron’s band attacked us to board ships to escape the country, and Haudemer is less defended than other ports. Which means they may return.”

“Good, free experience,” Vainqueur replied. “That way I won’t have to burn fat to chase them.”

“Oh, by the way, I gained a level in Monster Squire when King Vainqueur made me his chief of staff,” Victor butted in the conversation. “Ever heard of it? It might come in handy.”

“Monster Squire?” Henry frowned. “No, I never heard of this class. What kind of perks does it have?”

“Monster Kin, which makes me buddy-buddy with monsters.”

“This may be a monster class,” Henry said. “Monster classes are classes which are usually only available through deals with intelligent monsters or fiends. Somehow, your promotion fulfilled the class’ entry condition. Amazing.”

“Yes, yes, all my minions bask in my brilliance,” Vainqueur said, impatient. “Now, what class can make me rich in a good, dragon way?”

Henry frowned, thinking. “Gamblers have good, balanced stat growth for an unpromoted class,” he finally said. “C in Health Points, C in Special Points, D in strength, D in vitality, A in skill, C in agility, A in intelligence, B in charisma, and, the best for last, S in luck. A jack of all trades with a strong focus on luck, and several useful perks to farm gold.”

“What is this gibberish?” Vainqueur started having a headache. “Unpromoted?”

“Every time Your Majesty gains a level in a class, your stats have a chance to increase according to that class’ stat growth,” the manling continued. “D is a one in four chance, C one in two, B three in four, and with A, you always win a point. S means you always get two points instead of one, and

E means you never gain anything. Promoted classes are classes only available if you reach sufficient level in another class, so Gamblers open the path to—”

Boring! “Minion Victor, you are now my official class manager,” Vainqueur said when he couldn’t take it anymore, “This is a very important job, the most important you will ever receive. You deal with this.”

“Me?” manling Victor frowned. “Didn’t you want to learn everything about the system yourself, Your Majesty?”

“I, as a dragon, have too much on my hands to learn every single detail... that is why we dragons have minion laborers do it.”

Lynette and Henry exchanged glances, with Vainqueur tiring of their presence. “Leave,” he said, resting in the sand. “Minion, stay a bit longer.”

The two monkeys left hurriedly, leaving the dragon alone with his favorite audience. “Merchant,” Vainqueur complained. “I am not paid enough for this, minion.”

“What? But it went so well!” the minion tried to cheer him up, “Free lodging, Your Majesty! I even got an anonymous letter from an admirer! With so many single maids in town, maybe I have a shot.”

The manling sighed at Vainqueur’s puzzled look. “A shot at getting laid, Your Majesty.”

“Getting laid?” After some deep thinking, Vainqueur guessed the meaning. “Ah, ah, you want to *breed*! To put your eggs in a female manling!”

The minion said nothing, then gave him a strange, empty stare. “You had to say it like this,” he complained. “Your Majesty’s phrasing ruined it for me.”

“No, no, minion, the problem lays elsewhere,” Vainqueur corrected him, “You will never succeed unless you take a bath.”

“A bath, Your Majesty?”

“Minion, I wanted to spare your feelings before your fellow monkeys, but you stink like beetle dung! You will never breed with that smell!” Manling Victor lowered his head in shame, his master deciding to cheer him up.

“Minion, I swear to you as your master, I will do everything in my power to ensure you breed and perpetuate your species.”

The minion’s head sprung up so fast, Vainqueur thought he would snap his neck. “Wait, what, really?”

“Of course I will! That way I can renew my stock of minions within the year.” The minion didn’t get it, so Vainqueur detailed his logic. “If you breed well and your females lay their eggs before winter, then I should have a new tribe of minions available by next summer. No more goblins, all manlings. I will even let you use my cave for a nest if you need it.”

“We humans don’t grow as fast as—Wait, goblins lay eggs?”

“All the time,” Vainqueur nodded. “Manling, I, Vainqueur, order you to take a full bath, for your own good. These peasants have no lava bath, but there’s the sea right next to us.”

“I will settle on a hot bath at the inn, Your Majesty.”

“Then go breed, and sin no more!”

Chapter 6: Gather the Minions

Victor let out a moan of pleasure, as he sank in the warm, hot bath. So good!

Lynette's inn was a top-notch establishment, a stone mansion renovated into a resort for adventurers and merchants; he had his own room with a king-sized bed and full access to a private bath in the back.

Victor had left his clothes and weapons nearby, just in case. He had had a nasty experience with a naked ambush in the past, and it didn't hurt to be paranoid.

Victor glanced at the copper plate around his neck. Following Ogron's 'last meal,' the adventurer guild had upgraded him and Vainqueur to copper-rank adventurers. Of course, from what he had gathered, the guild itself still had no idea how to handle the dragon and simply decided to follow due process until King Gardemagne or the Shining Crusade 'settled' the matter.

Victor had no idea what to make of the dead cyclops' axe however. It didn't have any magical powers, and it was too heavy for anything but a giant to use. He figured he would let Vainqueur toy with it, then sell it behind the dragon's back.

The former outlaw had a more important problem to deal with. Namely, the love letters, and the maiden blushing at him when he walked through the street. Now Vainqueur had agreed to settle in Haudemer for a few days after Victor conned him into fighting the Scorchers, he could fool around again. Lynette was also quite easy on the eyes...

The bath's door opened behind him, Victor's hand moving to grab his daggers on impulse. Was it Lynette, bold enough to join him in the bath?

Damn, this just kept getting better and better.

Except it wasn't a maiden, but a disheveled Henry, and fully clothed at that. "Sir Victor!" he smiled at him with enthusiasm, ignoring or uncaring about Victor's weapon. "Here you are!"

"Henry, why are you in my bath?" Victor asked the obvious question. Especially since he must have gone through the bedroom to get here.

"I couldn't wait! I've been studying your case since yesterday, and it has been bugging me since—"

The Class Scholar suddenly noticed the black sword tattoo on Victor's left shoulder and paled. "That's the mark of the Nightblades." He knew what the mark meant, and the organization which issued them.

Damn, the outlaw thought. He would rather keep that little secret to himself.

"Let's call them legitimate repossessioners of private goods, and I left them when I became an adventurer." A lie. No one ever truly left the Nightblades. "And if you're smart you will hold your tongue about it."

Henry wisely dropped the matter, more interested in class discussions anyway. "I'm sorry, but it has been bothering me for a while," he said. "Why not Crusader?"

"Crusa—what?"

"The class! With his immense strength, the dragon would reap the best benefits of its stats' growth, and the self-healing would make him nigh impossible to put down! Think of the optimization potential!"

"You're seriously considering making that dragon impossible to kill," Victor said.

"Y-Yes, isn't it your job?"

Yes, but he wasn't going to do it *well*! "Look, all he cares about is money," Victor replied. "He's probably strong enough to handle anything short of

legendary adventurers, so unless you propose a class that can farm gold without doing ‘minion work’, I’m not interested.”

Congratulations! For being perfectly in tune with your master’s desires, you gained a level in [**Monster Squire**]! +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 LCK!

You gained the [**Minion Trainer**] Class Perk!

Minion Trainer: you and your minions gain fifty percent more experience when fighting side by side.

“How is it that I just leveled up in Monster Squire?”

“Ah, you probably gain experience doing tasks for the dragon,” Henry guessed. “You gained your class by serving him right? So, of course, the system will reward you if you protect his interests.”

Great, Victor got levels by being a good, loyal henchman. Somebody up above laughed at him. Minion Trainer though? Did the Class expect him to go befriend more dragons? One was already enough trouble!

“That just proves my point,” Victor said. “The way I see it, Vainqueur will level in the Noble class until he gets that stipend perk, and then he will delve into a new class better for moneymaking.” One which hopefully will not make him even more invincible.

“Gambler then. They have an excellent luck growth to complement the [Old Money] perk, and multiple abilities that can multiply money gained from bets.”

“I just can’t imagine Vainqueur ever betting anything though,” Victor said. “He’s a dragon, a miser.”

Henry thought about it, before having a eureka moment. “The Gladiator fighter class then! They gain lots of Perks that can provide tangible rewards if they impress crowds. Dragons have high strength and charisma, perfect to make full use of that class.”

Victor guessed it would appeal to that dragon show-off. “Do you have documents on it?”

“Yes, of course! Do I have your permission to take notes on its evolution? I have no idea how it will synergize with a dragon.” Henry lost himself in calculations. “You yourself have the [Claimed by Dice] perk, right? That means you get ten percent more chance to increase your intelligence and luck. You would make a good Spellcaster.”

“I would rather not spend all my time reading scrolls and grimoires,” Victor replied. “Don’t get me wrong, I won’t mind shooting lightning bolts, but I prefer to stick to daggers. All kinds of them, if you catch my drift.”

Henry didn’t get the dirty joke, making Victor sigh in disappointment. “Why not Gambler, then?”

He would have tried, if Vainqueur paid him. “Henry...”

“Yes, Sir?”

“That’s a bit dirty, but... is there a class that helps getting laid?”

“For men or women? Most are gender-exclusive, except the Red Mage class.”

That wasn’t the answer Victor had expected. “There’s more than one?” he asked, puzzled.

“Of course, there are dozens of seduction-oriented classes, and many of them have useful perks for it, like the Dark Knight’s [Sinful Aura]. It’s a very common question.”

Damn, Henry made it sound like a respectable academic subject. And here Victor thought it was a stupid question! “I have a friend who has been... inactive... for a while, and he wants to step up his game. Level ten, mostly rogue-like classes.”

“He? Ah, too bad, the best class for seduction is the female-only Black Widow. Does he have a high charisma score?”

“As good as mine.”

“Average then,” Henry said, Victor sulking. “Then I would suggest the Fiendish Rake class, discovered by Ludvic Van. It has very high entry conditions though, including charisma, vitality, and agility scores of fifty each, and surviving a special demonic ritual. If he doesn’t that score yet, he should build his charisma and grab a few perks in the Red Mage class. I can give you a book on it if you want.”

Was everybody in this world a munchkin?

For studiously learning about the Class System and how to improve your dating life, you receive the [**Observer**] personal perk.

Observer: you can instantly divine the class levels of someone you look at, as long as they are the same total level as you or lower. If the target is higher leveled than you, you can only see the total class level.

Yes, even Victor himself. “Henry?”

“Yes, Sir?” he asked, his eyes full of hope.

“Thank you,” Victor said. “Now get out of my bathroom, please.”

The unfortunate implications of their current situation suddenly dawned on Henry, who hurriedly left while apologizing all the way to the door.

Victor sank back in the bath, leaving his dagger aside, and letting himself drown in pleasure.

His moment of respite lasted one minute before someone knocked.

“What?!” Victor complained as the person opened the door without his authorization.

Lynette walked in, wearing a summer, golden dress showcasing her assets. Victor instantly sank deeper in the water, only his head rising above the waters.

The innkeeper laughed at the sight. “Such modesty,” she said. “Am I interrupting, Sir Victor?”

“Not at all,” Victor replied, having a very nice view with the current sight angle. “What can I do for you?”

“I have a very pressing problem in my basement, which I think only you alone could solve.”

Alone in the basement...

Ah.

Ahah! Finally! “I’m all ears,” Victor grinned with a smile, Lynette smiling in response.

Victor sighed, as he walked into the inn’s dark basement, a torch in hands. It smelled of cheese, meat, and brewery, and the bitter scent of disappointment.

Instead of a basement tryst, Lynette had sent him on a giant rat extermination mission.

Seriously? He knew he had technically just started his career, but this was adventurer hazing number one! And unpaid labor at that! The things he did for dragons and pretty faces...

Yet, Victor had been scouring the underground without finding any rat and started to wonder if Lynette had overreacted. She said food had been missing lately, but it could have been the cook or a staff member stealing...

“Remember, everything is in the heart!” a high-pitched voice said, coming from behind a crate, “We need to say it with the heart, the heart! And practice the pose!”

Or maybe not. Grabbing a dagger with his free hand and holding the torch with the other, Victor looked behind the crate and found himself facing five pairs of eyes.

There *were* monsters in the basement! Except they weren't rats. They were...

Kobolds.

Small, lizard-like humanoids the size of human children, and just as smart, kobolds had sharp claws, stunted horns, and long, slithering tails. Victor counted five of them, each with scales of different colors, namely red, blue, yellow, black, and pink. Quite the rainbow.

Victor noticed a small tunnel, dug in a wall nearby. The creatures must have dug all the way from the countryside to steal the basement's food.

"Oh my gosh, a human!" the pink kobold said upon seeing him, cowering at the sight of the much bigger Victor.

"Everyone, time for the choreography!" said the red one, bigger than the rest and seemingly the leader, "Remember, say it with the heart! He will cower before us!"

Much to Victor's amazement, each kobolds adopted a strange, ridiculous pose.

"We fight for injustice!" the red Kobold started.

"We live for mayhem!" the black one continued.

"We strike at night!" the blue added.

"We strive in discord!" the pink one shouted.

"We are..." the yellow reptile finished, before shouting in unison with his gang, "The Kobold Rangers!"

Victor stood there, too confused to respond.

"Yeah, we finally mastered the choreography," the red one chuckled happily, congratulating his team. "We floored him!"

“I still think we should add ‘chaos’ somewhere in the motto,” the pink pointed out, “I mean, it has such a zing!”

What the hell was Victor watching right now? “I felt that blue’s timing was off,” the adventurer admitted. “Also, if you want to go all the way, you need a team pet, like a white alligator.”

“What?” the blue kobold glared at him, “How dare you insult my talent! A human can’t understand true art!”

“I never understood abstract art, no,” Victor replied, not that impressed. Kobolds were no more dangerous than rats, and these ones looked like a bunch of utter idiots.

“Foolish mammal, the Apple of Knowledge showed us the truth!” the yellow one added.

“Wait,” the red one said, giving a blank look at Victor, “How did he...”

“You humans are out of style!” the black one snarled, showing his tiny claws and leaping at him. “It’s killin’ time!”

Kobolds being as small as human children, Victor stopped him by wordlessly putting his foot on the creature’s face. The monster struggled, its tiny hands unable to reach him, before calling to his teammates, “Help!”

“Wait!” the red kobold said, preventing the others from joining the ‘battle’ by moving in between the two groups. “He understood!”

“He understands?” the blue one repeated. “Absurd!”

“Yes, I understand what you said,” Victor shrugged, before realizing that he probably shouldn’t. The [Monster Kin] perk worked!

“And the smell,” the red said. “Do you smell his scent?”

The black one stopped trying to reach Victor and backed down, sniffing the human’s boot. “He smells like a reptile! A super reptile!”

“Ultra Reptile!” the yellow one exclaimed, sniffing Victor with such intensity the adventurer felt deeply embarrassed.

Even after a warm bath, spending days with Vainqueur had rubbed his awful smell off on him. And the dragon had complained his chief of staff stunk?

Victor instantly cursed himself for internalizing that stupid job. But then again, maybe he could make use of it... “Listen to me, kobolds,” the human declared with a broad gesture, “I am His Majesty King Vainqueur the Dragon’s chief of staff, guide, and class manager! Cower before me!”

“A dragon’s chief of staff!” Much to the human’s amazement, they seemed to recognize its meaning. “A real minion chief of staff!”

“Such raw charisma...” ‘Pink’—Victor decided to mentally nickname them after their scale color—had tears in her eyes. “I can almost feel it!”

“We have no choice!” Blue said, “We must sue for peace!”

“Peace!” Red repeated.

“Then, bring me this Apple of Knowledge, and I shall let you go,” Victor ordered them, although he suddenly felt guilty for some reason. Like he was bullying guillible children.

“Quick!” Red ordered, the others running into the tunnels, and quickly coming back with a black and white tablet computer with a familiar logo on its back. Victor lowered himself slightly to look closer, as they showed it to him.

An Ipad?

Sweet! He could never afford one! Victor had heard items from Earth sometimes found their way to Outremonde, mostly brought by people abducted there. Where did the critters find it?

The adventurer lit the Ipad up, the screen loading with a delay, maybe due to aging. A quick glance at the desktop told him the previous owner had

been one huge fan of downloading ebooks and videos; while most were hidden behind passwords, a few could be freely accessed.

Victor loaded one of the videos, showing old, silent footage of one of these ridiculous Japanese Super Sentai series. It was cheesy enough to make him cringe, but the kobolds watched with rapturous interest.

“He knows how to unleash the Apple’s power,” Blue muttered.

“Take us!” Pink implored Victor.

“Wait, what?” Victor asked, “Where?”

“Oh mighty chief of staff, please accept us as minions,” Red asked, bowing to Victor and soon imitated by the others. “We do not have the experience, and it would be our very first minion work, but... but we are hardworking and polyvalent and... please!”

The human found them strangely cute, monstrous critters aside. After seeing their big, adorable eyes looking at him with candid hope, the adventurer couldn’t help himself. “I’m willing to take you as interns,” Victor said. “Unpaid interns.”

Urgh, Vainqueur had rubbed off him.

“Interns! We’re interns!” the black one jumped on place, before stopping in confusion, “What’s an intern?”

“It’s a great opportunity towards potential future career advancements,” Victor deadpanned, repeating the words from his first summer internship.

“Such responsibility,” the blue one said with big bright eyes, much less cynical than Victor had been in his place.

For recruiting your first group of expendable minions, you have gained **two** levels in [**Monster Squire**]! +10 SP, +1 STR, +2 VIT, + 2 SKI, +2 AGI, +1 INT!

You gained the [**Monster Student**] Class Perk!

Monster Student: you can now learn monster-exclusive Perks after you are taught or targeted by them. You also count as a monster for the purpose of class access criterias.

Now, how would Victor word *that* to Lynette?

Chapter 7: Interlude:

Murderhobos

Henry knocked on the door with impatience, a book under his arm.

He wondered who owned the house. Located in the outskirts of Haudemer, many thought it abandoned, its owner absent, and his host had indicated she only rented it for a while. Thorns and weeds had taken roots in the garden and the stone walls, while the shutters remained firmly closed. No matter the outside spookiness, he had run towards the place as soon as he read the invitation.

“Professor Henry.” A charming young woman welcomed him, as she opened the door with a squeak. She was no rare beauty, keeping her long raven-hair tied with a white rose, but her dark eyes shone with a keen intellect. Most importantly, she wore the black and gold wizard robes of the Royal University of Gardemagne. “How kind of you to visit me.”

“When you informed me you visited our beloved Haudemer, I couldn’t pass up the opportunity,” the scholar replied. “It is an honor to meet you in person, Miss Lavere.”

“Please call me Lucie,” she replied politely. “I may represent the Royal University, but I never forgot my humble roots.”

Indeed, it made her academic success all the more striking. She had published two papers, one on the effects of the Red Death plague on base stats, and another about spellcasting classes synergies. A brilliant young mind, she was apprenticed to the famous royal headmaster Nostredame, a wizard of great renown.

Henry examined her class with his Class Specialist Perk.

[Lucie Lavere; **Scholar 15/Unknown Spellcaster Classes 22**]

Unknown classes meant she had an item preventing him from clearly identifying her levels. A Perk would have hidden the information entirely. “Why hide your spellcaster classes?”

“University politics,” Lucie replied calmly. “I study new fields of spellcasting yet unrecognized by the University, and I might get in trouble before I publish my thesis. Many covet my apprenticeship under Nostredame and would ruin my reputation to take it.”

“To be level thirty-seven at your age... most adventurers retire at it. You are very good, miss Lavere.”

“I am an apt pupil, and I learn from the best,” the young woman replied with great courtesy, before inviting him inside, “Please come in.”

Henry did so, finding the house’s inside much more welcoming than the outside. The two stepped inside a long hallway, covered with a red carpet and lit up by fire elementals kept in glass containers above their heads. While the place lacked in decoration or a personal touch of any kind, the owner took care to maintain it in pristine condition.

The inside also looked far bigger than the outside. “A space altering spell?” Henry asked, impressed. He had never seen one.

“The true owner’s doing, I must say,” Lucie replied, closing the door behind them.

It must have been a spellcaster of great power. “I wonder what a scholar of your caliber is doing in Haudemer, especially in these dark times.”

“Learning,” Lucie replied. “One of my mentors asked me to follow her on a business trip, which of course must remain between us. She is a very private person. ”

“I didn’t tell anyone,” Henry replied. He understood scholars of her caliber wished for anonymity, especially since Scorchers might target them for ransom. “I thought you would be interested.”

He handed her his notes, which the woman began to read at a quick pace, almost a page a second. “Monster Squire,” she noted. “I never heard of that class before.”

“It has good, equilibrated growth for an unpromoted class, and very interesting Perks,” Henry said, eager to impress the other scholar. This may be his chance to get his research published, and for him to finally obtain some recognition. “A whole unknown monster class. And the dragon, Vainqueur, gained levels.”

“I saw this dragon, Vainqueur, laying in the sand outside the town. He is not the first case of an intelligent monster gaining levels, but this is certainly the first case for a dragon. Even the fabled Jade Dragon of the East never gained a class of his own.”

“I wish I could study him further,” Henry said. “Mayor Lynette told me the Shining Crusade would send a squadron of knights to kill him as soon as possible.”

As he told her of the recent events, Lucie chuckled, amused by the passage on Vainqueur’s demand of a lava bath. “I would not count on your crusaders for this task,” she said, before stopping before a wooden door. “We can discuss it in my study. I believe your research has great potential.”

“Thank you, hearing you say so warms my heart,” Henry said, as he opened the door and walked inside the dark study.

Finally, after spending years researching classes, he was on the verge of a breakthrough. If Lucie validated his findings, the Royal University would publish his researches; he would get credited as the discoverer of a new array of Monster Classes and Perks, and his name would live on.

At first, he couldn’t see everything, although strong odors assaulted his nose. The study didn’t smell like paper and ink.

It smelled like rotten meat.

Then the room suddenly lit up, and Henry screamed.

It wasn't a study, it was a dungeon; a cold, dark room smelling of death, full of wooden operation tables and shelves covered with surgical tools. Two zombies hung in the middle, suspended to the ceiling by chains. Henry recognized the faces as a couple of fishermen, whom he had often seen while strolling around the docks.

The door closed behind him.

Henry turned around, expecting to face Lucie.

Instead, a knight two heads taller than Henry barred the entrance, pointing a sword at his throat. The titan of metal facing the scholar had shoulders that would rival a bull, and his heavy plate armor exuded a strong sense of menace. His horned helmet, which covered his face, made him look like a gatekeeper from Hell.

Henry instantly recognized him from a wanted poster, even before his Perk activated.

[Gustave La Muraille; **Knight 20/Heavy Knight 4**]

A Scorching leader.

“Ah, Lucie brought us a friend,” another voice, pleasant, called from behind the chained zombie.

A man walked into Henry's line of sight, an elegant, black-haired man of Harmonian descent, with a pleasant face and beautiful amber eyes. He wore the white and gold garments of a priest of Mithras but proudly displayed the sinister crow symbol of the murderous god Deathjester on the upper left. He wielded a rapier around his belt, although he hadn't unsheathed it.

[François Vilmain; **Fell Bishop 13/Outlaw 3/Sellsword 7**]

“Hello, my dear guest. My name is François, François Vilmain,” the fallen priest said with a mirthful smirk. “I am a captain of what you call the Scorchers, alongside my comrade Gustave. I’m sure you’ve heard a lot of horrible tales about us, all of them true.”

“What have you done to Miss Lavere?!” Henry asked, Gustave grabbing his shoulder with his free hand and maintaining right in place. Lacking any combat ability, Henry had no chance of fending off these two.

“Lucie?” Vilmain chuckled, “Her master owns the house and agreed to let us hide there, so long as we helped with her student’s, shall we say, empirical research.”

A necromancer. The headmaster laid in bed with Scorchers and necromancers? Henry froze, aghast, before realizing they said ‘her’ student, and the archmage Nostredame was a man.

“Please, take a seat, Henry,” Vilmain offered, waving his hand at a wooden stool right next to the restrained zombie. Before Henry could respond, Gustave forcefully grabbed him with his free hand and forced him to sit with inhuman strength. “Let’s have a chat.”

“People will notice my disappearance,” Henry pleaded, trying to buy time.

“Oh, don’t worry about us, we have your case covered,” Gustave replied.

Vilmain cleared his throat. “Contrary to what you may believe, Henry, neither me nor Gustave, or even Ogron, started as bandits. In fact, we fought for Gardemagne during most of the Century War; back then, the king granted adventurers and mercenaries a writ, allowing us to raid enemy towns in his name. Unfortunately, with the end of the war, our respectable occupation of massacring people and torching their villages is no longer politically correct.”

“We were asked to retire, farm like peasants, or move on to much more dangerous monster-hunting jobs,” Gustave said with disgust.

“Fortunately,” Vilmain said with a light grin, “His Dark Majesty, Brandon Maure of Ishfania, offered us a very nice retirement sum and asylum, so long as we torched the countryside of Euskal to the ground and kept the crusaders busy while he retakes his fortress of Rochefronde. Which unfortunately for you, Henry, includes Haudemer. Do you understand?”

The poor scholar nodded, pissing himself. Vilmain glanced down at the soiled pants with a sneer, before continuing his story.

“But you see, we have a very big problem. Apparently, you have a dragon guarding the city, and he ate our men for breakfast. When we sent men to check on these men, he killed more of our men. Finally, the royal army is breathing down our necks, and for important reasons, we cannot skip Haudemer’s destruction. The situation is not good for our financial future.”

“So we caught these two,” Gustave pointed at the zombies. “Who said the dragon had a master.”

“Of course we had to rough them up before they gave names, namely, that this master, ‘Victor,’ often met with you.”

“That is wrong,” Gustave replied. “That we roughed them up. One of them talked when he saw you zombified the other.”

“Ah, yes, but you had your Outlaw knife him dead afterward if I remember.”

“It was to help him level up. I take care of my men.”

“He got a level out of this commoner? Lucky beginners, they don’t have to burn the midnight oil the way we do.”

It was relatively easy to break into the two-digit range by killing low-level people, even up to level twenty for dedicated killers. Afterward, the increased experience requirements made it necessary to fight people who could fight back on even terms.

After this awful interlude, Vilmain focused back on Henry. “So, my friend, I am sure we can find a solution we all agree on.”

“You’re going to kill me anyway,” Henry said. “Why would I tell you anything?”

“Of course we are going to kill you,” Vilmain replied with a disturbing kind of serenity. “The only question is, do we have to rough you up first? Unlike my fellow Gustave here, I would rather make it quick and painless. I am not a savage, Henry.”

“Says the priest of Deathjester,” his comrade replied with a taunting tone.

“I am the holiest man there is,” Vilmain protested. “I worship the god of crime, and he likes my work.”

“Whatever,” Gustave replied, swinging his weapon. “Do you talk, scholar, or do I cut a leg?”

“No, no, Gustave, wait,” Vilmain raised a hand to appease his fellow criminal, while Henry shook in pure, unadulterated fear, “I tell you, I’m not a savage. While you are most certainly going to die so word of our presence does not spread, I’m sure we can honor last requests. If you tell us the truth, the full truth, the entire truth.”

Knowing his life was done for, Henry figured out he might as well try to bargain for something. “Will you spare someone, if I speak?”

“Depends on whom,” Vilmain replied. “We are going to kill that Victor fellow whatever happens. I am sorry. Professional pride.”

“No, Mayor Lynette.” He had had a crush on her for years, even if he never dared make a move. “Also, please do not burn my house. The research inside... they’re my life’s work.”

“You demand much,” Vilmain replied mirthfully, “Lynette, that’s the innkeeper right? I heard she’s very beautiful. Smart woman too. Do you like her?”

“Y-yes, I do.”

“Ah, very well. If you speak, we will spare her life, and we will try to leave your home unscathed if you give us its location. No promise on that one, fires spread in wild directions sometimes. Maybe I will find a way to sell your papers to an Ishfanian scholar if they are truly so precious. Now, tell us everything.”

And so, Henry spoke.

He gave them a rundown of his discussions with the dragon, including his general personality and levels; then, much to his shame, he sold out Victor, his class levels, his Perks, everything he could gather.

He would have lied if he could but Bishops like Vilmain could detect lies. “A Nightblade?” the priest of Deathjester raised an eyebrow. “Interesting.”

“The Nightblades can control dragons?” Gustave asked, worried.

“Of course not,” Vilmain replied. “I do wonder what a career criminal is doing protecting a village.”

“He said he left them,” Henry said.

“You never leave the Nightblades. Well, no, technically, you can leave them, but life leaves you first. No matter. Is he greedy, like this Vainqueur?”

“I don’t think so...”

“He must have a weakness. Honor, fame, women...”

“Mayor Lynette had him do jobs for her,” Henry remembered. “I noticed him glancing at her, and not at her eyes.”

“Ah, yes, of course, no man can resist a chest, any kind of chest.” Vilmain chuckled at his own sexist joke, while Gustave didn’t. “What else?”

“I... I have no idea. He is a nice person who wants to help.”

“A good man, with a kind heart? Ah, now this is interesting. Gustave, what do you think?”

The cruel knight’s fingers twitched on his sword’s pommel. “There is absolutely no way we can beat that dragon in a fight.”

“Yeah, I didn’t think so either.”

“But he is dim.”

“But he is dim,” Vilmain nodded. “We will have to distract him before we burn this town down, recover the Apple, and flee on stolen ships afterward. As for that Victor, we can handle him easily enough. We’re both over twice his level, and a kind heart is easily misled. Is that all, Henry, my friend?”

“I told you everything,” the scholar replied, crying in shame at his own cowardice.

“Did he lie?” Gustave asked his partner.

“No, he is an honest man, albeit not a brave one.” Vilmain shook his hand, before flashing a comforting smile at his prisoner. “You must not know it, but my friend Gustave here has three levels in Turncoat. That class’s first Perk, [Falseness], hides Turncoat levels from scanning Perks, such as yours. The second is called [Traitor’s Joy]. I’m sure a scholar like you knows what it does.”

Henry clenched his fists in impotent shame. “You get an experience boost every time you betray a promise.”

“I told you he was a savage,” Vilmain said, sounding falsely sorry. “Poor Lynette.”

“You said it, not me,” Gustave replied, raising his sword.

“Wait,” again, Vilmain raised a hand to stop his ally, “Not yet.”

“What?” Gustave complained, “He’s of no use to us.”

“We could make use of him as an hostage, for now. Just knock him out. I swear you will have his head in time, my friend.”

Gustave grumbled and struck Henry from behind with the pommel, the poor scholar's world fading to black.

Chapter 8: Level Grinding

Instead of breeding, Manling Victor had adopted a full litter of new minions.

And already they proved useful. “Master Vainqueur, Master Vainqueur!” Yellow, the kobold with the best nose, pointed a claw at a bush, the dragon smelling a Scorcher manling hiding there. “I found another!”

Vainqueur let out a roar, raising the giant axe Ogron the one-eyed ogre had kindly given him...

Or rather, struggling, as he couldn't keep the axe properly aligned even while wielding it with all his clawed fingers. How did the manlings do it?

Like a rabbit, the manling ran out of the bushes, only for Black, the biggest of the new recruits, to chase after him with a spear. Vainqueur followed, causing trees to fall as he moved through the woods; he constantly struggled against the urge to run back on all four, as a good dragon should.

How did that cyclops do it? Raise the axe up, and then down.

Vainqueur tried, the upward swing sending a pine tree fly, and he struggled to aim right at the escaping food-in-waiting. “Minion!” Vainqueur shouted. “MINION!”

“Yes, yes, I'm here!” Manling Victor emerged from the woods with his dagger toothpicks, barring the escaping prey's way and forcing it to flee in another direction.

“This axe is not working!”

“Just swing it down when we have him immobilized! And remember, you meet the class criteria, but you have to impress your fans with a melee weapon strike, Your Majesty! Kill him with style, or you won’t access the new class!”

Style? Like a crushing display of superiority? “Dear mammals,” Vainqueur asked Dead Manling Running. “Do you know what dragons call pain?”

Kobold Red jumped from a bush, trapping the prey and forcing him to stop running. The mammal briefly turned his head behind, crying at the sight of Vainqueur’s majesty.

“A birth defect!”

And then Vainqueur swept the scorcher with the axe, smashing him into a crater of blood and broken bones.

“Argh!” The aftershock sent his entrails splatter on Red’s face, the poor kobold having to remove brain matter off his eyes. “I have human blood in my eyes!”

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” Black and Yellow cheered him up, as expected. “Vainqueur, best dragon!”

By impressing a crowd of fans with your weapon prowess and moxie, you gained a level in the [**Gladiator**] Class! You gained the [**Arena Warrior**] Perk!

+30 HP, +2 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

[**Arena Warrior**]: instantly gain medium proficiency in all melee weapons.]

“Ouch,” minion Victor said. “Ouch, that joke hurt.”

“Joke?” Vainqueur asked, finding the axe suddenly light in his hand. He played with it, but he still had troubles wielding the weapon without his claws getting in the way. His hands were made to run on all four or rip the prey to shreds, not carry a bladed stick!

“Wait, dragons really consider pain a birth defect?” his chief of staff asked him.

“Why, yes, only lesser beings feel it,” Vainqueur replied plainly, before standing proud. “But not as much as I felt this new Gladiator class!”

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” Red added, late to the party. “Your Majesty is the greatest in the world!”

“Yes, yes, thank you,” Vainqueur replied, pleased, “Still, Minion Victor, do I still need to use the axe to gain levels in that class? I find it impractical.”

“No, just to impress fans with your battle prowesses.”

Vainqueur gave the stick one last chance, grabbing the axe with his mouth and swinging it this way. “Hosh do I loosh?” he asked, trying to adopt a dominant pose, only to hit a tree with the back of the blade and nearly lose equilibrium.

The minions exchanged glances, too aware of their master’s sensitivity to speak their mind. Obviously, he should stick to his dragon weapons.

He was too good for manling weapons anyway.

“Your axe sticks suck,” Vainqueur said, as he spat out the weapon, which landed in the bushes nearby with a loud crash. “Now, Minion Victor, I keep slaughtering these Scorchers ruffians and yet [Old Money] does not activate with your kind.”

“Yeah, I guess it is to prevent nobles from slaughtering their peasants for items. It should work with monsters though.”

Vainqueur glanced at the kobolds with greed, before deciding no good dragon slaughtered their minions for items. For treachery and theft, always, but good, loyal minions were too valuable to get rid of casually.

The world already abounded with victims.

“At least he had some standard loot on him,” Victor said, as he inspected the remains. “Iron daggers, and nice boots.”

“Not good enough for my hoard,” Vainqueur replied. A good dragon had wealth standards. “Next!”

“I don’t smell another,” Yellow said, smelling the air with his fellow kobolds. “Your Majesty got them all!”

“Aw... “ Vainqueur sighed in disappointment. “So no more levels and no gold today?”

“We can always sell his belongings,” Victor suggested. “I know you don’t want to become a Merchant, but we don’t need a class to sell these items. I could even use the gains to invest in better stuff.”

“Invest?” Vainqueur didn’t know the word.

“Yeah, you give away some gold in exchange for something else with more value.”

Vainqueur’s brain stopped working. “Giving away gold.”

“Your Majesty,” Victor cleared his throat. “For something else which has *more value*.”

“Giving away gold,” Vainqueur repeated, his noble mind unable to progress past that line.

“Yes, but you gain more afterward, so you don’t really give it away. It’s a disguised loan.”

“Giving away gold,” Vainqueur repeated these cursed words for the third time. “Manling Victor are you well? Are you sick? I did not know the lack of breeding could have such dangerous effects on your mental health.”

The minion finally understood he had gone too far into sin. “Your Majesty cannot even *imagine* it.”

“What kind of sane mind would?” Vainqueur retorted, before shuddering at the mere word. “*Giving*.”

“Yes, I suddenly realize that may have been too much for Your Majesty.”

“Master Vainqueur, the chief of staff only tried to help you,” Yellow pleaded. “Please forgive him.”

“Buttkisser, buttkisser!” Black taunted his fellow, Red punching both of them in the shoulders. “Ouch!”

“No argument before the chief of staff!” Red said. “Remember protocol!”

“The protocol?” Manling Victor asked.

“The minion protocol,” Vainqueur clarified, before realizing he never drilled his chief of staff on proper minion management.

“The chief of staff is the highest echelon of the minion pecking order, the ultimate honor a monster lord can bestow!” tiny Red explained to manling Victor. “It is the ultimate minion killing machine, the most ferocious enforcer of the most dreaded of masters! Fifty percent strength, fifty percent cunning, two hundred percent loyalty!”

“Now you’re exaggerating on that last bit...” manling Victor replied with his trademark humility.

“You underestimate your importance in the food chain,” Vainqueur cheered him up, “You are only beneath me in the preciousness hierarchy. You are even above princesses!”

“Nice to hear Your Majesty values me between himself and pretty faces,” the minion thanked his generous master.

“Of course, princesses are precious, but you are almost an honorary part of my hoard, manling Victor. If we are to starve, we will make a sacrifice and eat the minions together.”

“Your Majesty, I understood your first sentence, but you lost me with the second.”

“The preciousness rating also represents your place in the food chain,” Vainqueur taught him. “Each member of the chain can eat those below if they are hungry. If you and I are hungry without food available, we can eat minions as emergency rations.”

“It would be an honor to feed Your Majesty!” small Yellow said.

“Wait, wait,” manling Victor panicked. “Does that mean you count me as a potential meal?”

“Not unless we have no food or minions available,” Vainqueur reassured him. “That will never happen. The world is full of dragon food.”

Manling Victor probably understood he should focus more on recruitment from now on. He knew his previous chief of staff had hired a lot of goblins after they had that conversation. Minion Ressource was a full-time, difficult job, after all.

Speaking of minion management... “Where are the sweet Pink and Blue?” Vainqueur asked, having grown slightly paranoid since his last goblins abandoned him in his sleep.

“I sent them to deal with the local blacksmith on my behalf,” Victor said. “I think the Scorchers aren’t at Haudemer to flee the country. Or at least, not only. I believe they are looking for something, and so I want to be prepared.”

“Something? Is it a treasure?”

“I dunno... maybe?”

“If it is not good for my hoard, it is good for nothing. Manling, explain.”

“Haudemer’s region is south of Euskal and north of the city of Rochefronde, which is held by crusaders but besieged by the Ishfanian and

summoned fiends. By torching the countryside, the Scorchers cut the supply lines between Euskal and Rochefrond. Do you follow me so far?"

As it always happened with too many uninteresting words, Vainqueur zoned out, pretending to politely listen to what his minion had to say.

"Interesting," the dragon lied.

"Blah blah... no strategic value... Brandon Maure... scorcher scorched... blah bla..."

"Interesting."

"-And Your Majesty is really listening?"

"Interesting," the dragon repeated.

"Interesting," Red the Kobold and his fellows nodded in agreement, before clenching his tiny fist. "The chief of staff trusted us with such an important mission, we will not fail him!"

"See?" Vainqueur said, "Minions solve every problem, when you raise them right. As expected from my prized chief of staff."

"One day too, I will be chief of staff," Black said.

"Me first!" Red butted head with his fellow, Vainqueur so proud of them fighting for the job already.

That would keep Victor sharp. He could already see the seeds of spirited competition germinate in the sharp glint of his treasured minion's eyes. That fear of losing one's position to an underling, Vainqueur found it so entertaining.

"Your Majesty."

"Yes, Minion Victor?"

"I earned a Perk which makes it possible for me to learn monsters' Perks, either if they teach me or if I experience them."

“Ah, so if I try incinerating you, you will breathe fire too?” Vainqueur asked, curious. “Is that what you want?”

The minion looked up at his beloved dragon master and the smoke coming out of his nostrils, then paled. “You know, Your Majesty, on second thought, I may have been too hasty,” he said. “Let’s forget we ever had this conversation.”

“Your loss,” Vainqueur shrugged. Why would anybody not want to breathe fire? “Maybe one day, should you prove the best chief of staff I ever had, I will teach you the ultimate technique of dragonfire breathing. It is the perfect weapon to kill manlings.”

There, that should motivate him to work hard for Vainqueur’s personal gain.

“I would rather avoid killing people myself,” minion Victor declared. “If I kill a fellow human, I will meet all the criteria for a specific class, and probably level up in it. I don’t want to.”

“Oh? Which class?” Maybe it could apply to Vainqueur.

“Assassin. I really wouldn’t feel proud of this one, even if the Scorchers are assholes who deserve to die.”

“Minion, I have eaten enough of your kind to get sick of it, and I never received a level in that class,” Vainqueur pointed out.

“I never did either!” Black complained.

“When did you ever kill a human?” Red asked.

“In my heart...”

“You need to fulfill a few more criteria,” Victor shrugged. “And you need to kill members of your own species willingly, which I doubt you have yet.”

“Well, minion, it’s not as if you will need to defend me from your puny kind. Stick to my class planning and I will take care of the food.”

“Your generosity truly knows no bounds, Your Majesty.”

“I know,” Vainqueur said, feeling on a goodness spree. “About this ruffian’s belongings, Minion Victor, you are now—”

“Your treasurer and hoard manager?”

“Never!” Vainqueur roared, taking the manling aback as his golden eyes shone with wrath. “No touching my hoard!”

The kobold minions cowered behind their chief of staff, who had lost all the color on his skin. By now, Vainqueur had guessed manlings reacted this way when reminded of dragon superiority.

The greatest calamity of this age calmed himself. “No, manling Victor. I said yesterday selling is a minion’s work, and that is exactly what you and the kobolds are going to do.”

“So you want me to open a shop away from the frontlines?” Victor asked, slightly more enthusiastic than Vainqueur had expected.

“You already have the name,” Vainqueur said, “V&V! That way, we get rid of the junk not shiny enough for my hoard, except gold and jewels, which are!”

“Your attempt to corner the value chain is truly brilliant, Your Majesty,” the obsequious Manling Victor congratulated him.

“And, *and*, to keep you motivated, I will allow you to keep one,” Vainqueur raised a claw once he had the minions’ full attention, “One-tenth of the profits you will earn!”

“We... we are going to be paid?” Yellow almost had tears in his eyes. “Paid...”

“Indeed, you are way more generous than the King himself,” said Victor.

The mere mention of this ruffian angered the dragon. “I swear to you, manling Victor,” Vainqueur declared, “V&V shall never pay taxes to this

criminal, ever.”

“I will send royal constables to you, Your Majesty. I am sure they will agree to a tax exemption.”

“No giving away money,” Vainqueur insisted, shuddering at the words. “No investing. The glorious name of V&V cannot be associated with this madness. Also, sell the corpses. I am sick of eating manlings all the time.”

"Selling corpses, Your Majesty?"

"Doesn't your kind hunt monsters to collect their corpses and sell their parts?" Vainqueur had seen many would-be 'dragonslayers' - he sneered inwardly at the word - wield weapons and items made of other creatures.

"Well, yes, but *monster* parts. Adventurers don't harvest bandit corpses."

"Then what do you do with them?"

Victor scratched the back of his tiny head. "We just leave them laying around for animals to eat..."

"No more *giving*, minion. You will now find a way to make money out of this waste of skin."

While Vainqueur removed some meat in between his fangs with his claw, Victor kept nodding to himself in short succession. Vainqueur wondered if he had broken his neck. “So Your Majesty wants me to open a shop where I sell junk and monster parts and corpses. Wonderful. Anything else?”

“This is a lot of work, but you are my chief of staff,” Vainqueur reassured him, “You will find the time in between preparing my class progression and training the Kobolds in those you deem appropriate.”

Manling Victor said no word, as he struggled under the weight of his duties. “Teach classes to the kobolds...”

“You fail to grasp my grandiose vision for V&V, Minion Victor. An adventurer party of minions, trained from the egg and working to the death

to fulfill quests; shopkeepers selling junk and meat in every single one of your backward villages, filling chests with gold. Everyone working together to build the greatest hoard that shall ever be! A mountain of gold which will make your tallest castle crumble in shame at its shiny glory!”

Vainqueur narrowed his head, so his silent minions could see the fire in his eyes.

“My hoard!”

Victor made a strange smile, which Vainqueur assumed as one of absolute joy.

Chapter 9: Gods and Zombies

Located on a creek near the docks, Haudemer's temple was a rather large stony church by manling standards. According to Manling Victor, due to Haudemer being a small town, the twelve 'gods'—Vainqueur couldn't help but chuckle at the word—the manlings worshipped had to share the same temple.

From what he had understood, puny species worshipped these stronger creatures the same way minions obeyed their dragon masters, with the bonus of being promised a place at their side after death. That part confused the dragon, he expected to live forever.

Vainqueur guessed the prospect of an afterlife could only appeal to races fragile enough to, well, *die*.

The inhabitants had deserted the temple's surroundings once they caught sight of Vainqueur. While he perfectly understood their inferiority complex when basking in his presence, a little awe and worship would have been nice. If they had enough of it to worship twelve non-dragons, then certainly they could spare him some adoration.

Only one manling hadn't fled, and harassed his chief of staff instead.

"Do you want salvation in a new world?" That manling looked even more ridiculous than the rest of his kind, with his black robe and a badly painted map of seas and land masses on his chest and forehead. "Wait, I can feel your Isekai levels, medium!"

"I'm a Claimed," Vainqueur's chief of staff protested, showing his dice tattoo. "And you mixed up North and South America on your map!"

“Ohoh, perfect!” Instead of being discouraged, the harasser grabbed the minion’s arm. “If you sign up to the Esoteric Order of the New World, you are *guaranteed* to reincarnate on the mythical island of Japan, where every girl is a virgin!”

“Scram!” Victor tried to push the manling away away. “Get him off me!”

“Minions,” Vainqueur ordered, as he was too important to deal with it. “Do the thing.”

“Defend the chief of staff!” Red commanded the kobolds, the five critters jumping on the deluded cultist at once and clawing at his face.

“Argh, kobolds!” the manling cultist protested, as he tried to throw the critters off his back. “Get them off me!”

“Don’t kill him, just restrain him!” Victor pleaded as the Kobolds restrained the poor fool on the ground. Vainqueur watched the scene with quiet amusement.

Those five were too adorable to end up as emergency rations. Vainqueur hoped Victor would recruit less funny minions whom he could eat without regret.

The scene did confuse the dragon though. “What was that, manling Victor?”

“It’s a money scam,” Victor complained. “I’ve lived on Earth, and it’s *nothing* like he just said!”

“Why are we even here? Minion, while I understand your lesser species’ need to pay homage to a higher power, but if you want to pray to someone, you should pray to me. I even answer sometimes.”

“Your Majesty wanted to get rid selling off corpses and monster parts,” his chief of staff pointed at the carriage behind them. “The church deals with them.”

Ah, yes. In total, Vainqueur had ‘collected’ six manling thieves, and one manticore he accidentally cut down during his masterful practice with his

axe. They also encountered goblins, fleeing on sight from him; the dragon had simply glared them down as if they weren't good enough for him, which they were.

What was he thinking back then, recruiting those cowards as minions? Manling Victor had made the right call, kobolds solved everything.

Manling Victor left the cultist to the minions, walking past the temple's opened gates and inside the whitened, majestic hall within. Vainqueur followed him soon afterward, head and neck first, carrying himself with pure draconic majesty.

Then, he failed to fit his wings through.

With a grunt, Vainqueur attempted to squeeze himself inside, but too fat after feasting, he couldn't fit. His shoulders hitting the walls made the temple tremble, but unlike the puny guildhall, the walls were strong and thick.

Manling Victor watched the sight with a blank expression, taking a sip of a water canteen while politely waiting for his master to finish his dramatic entrance. Vainqueur noticed a few other manlings inside the building watching with expectation.

"Minion Victor!" the dragon complained to his sidekick, "Tell the architects to build a bigger door!"

"Sure, Your Majesty," the chief of staff replied. "But could you avoid causing the place to fall on us poor mortals?"

As he finally realized he wouldn't get inside without collapsing the entire temple on his lackey first, Vainqueur settled on only letting his neck and head inside with a groan.

Why did the manlings have to be so small?

The temple of Haudemer was mainly composed of a great white hall, and two small wings on both sides. Each of the twelve gods of the puny races

had a statue and altar inside, although not with the same degree of respect.

The dragon's share of the spotlight went to the same creature Vainqueur had acquired a statuette of, Mithras, the sun god of law and justice. It was a manling king wearing a golden crown of fire and wielding a blazing sword, whose giant marble statue had the largest altar. At his side was a statue of a blonde female manling knight with large mammaries, whom the puny races called Leone, goddess of art and nobility.

According to Manling Victor, these two ascended manlings were the titular deities of Gardemagne, and thus positioned at the center. "The architect placed the more ambiguous deities, such as the Dread Three, Sablar and Shesha, on the left," Manling Victor told his master, his tone so low Vainqueur could barely hear it, "And the 'politically correct' deities, the Moon Man, Seng, Cybele, Isengrim, and Dice on the right."

The manling glared at that Dice's statue with hatred. From what Vainqueur had gathered from the last prayers of the adventurers foolish to attack him in the past, the 'Dice Who Rolled,' was the deity of magic, weather, and luck. As per its name, it was a dice with an eye at the center of each of its twenty faces.

"Manling Victor, you do not like dice?" Unlike Victor's subdued tone, Vainqueur didn't care about respecting a quiet atmosphere, his voice booming through the hall. Nobody dared complain.

He would have eaten any who did.

"That dim creature summoned me to Outremonde without asking," the lackey replied. "And unfortunately since it first unlocked the class system, everyone worships it. It is almost as popular as Mithras."

Pff... *right*. As if dragons didn't level up first. Vainqueur refused to believe he was the first of his kind to do so.

Dice's altar looked more like a gambling table than a religious site, with a catkin priest busy playing a board game with what the dragon assumed to

be two minions. Even Vainqueur's wonderful arrival hadn't made them raise their eyes off the game.

So Vainqueur loudly cleared his throat, and they briefly glanced up at his head long enough to satisfy him.

Most of the altars had at least one tiny priest nearby, with three exceptions. One tentacled squid whom the dragon recognized as the Moon Man, an ancient creature his kind fought off in the distant past; a humanoid crow wearing a harlequin costume and carrying a sharp scythe, drenched in blood; and a huge worm like those infesting the caves below Vainqueur's own lair. The manlings had utterly savaged the last statue.

"That's Sablar, the monstrous worm god of earth, time, and destruction," explained Manling Victor. Vainqueur was silently pleased he didn't have to voice his ignorance out loud. "No one worships it in Gardemagne, since it supports their enemies. People pray *against* it."

"And the others?" Vainqueur listened, just in case there was profit to be made.

"Bah, the Moon Man doesn't remember he has followers half the time, and Deathjester is the god of *crime*. Nobody worships him openly."

"How much levels is that Sablar worth?" Vainqueur asked, eager to get that stipend and free money. "We could hunt him down if there is a reward on his head."

"I don't think picking a fight with a god is a good idea, even for Your Majesty."

"Why? If it exists, I can kill it. I am a dragon, remember? I eat his wormy kind whenever they enter my cave."

"Yes, but that one is level one hundred and turned the southern continent into a desert. Also, nobody puts a bounty on a god's head."

Saddening.

Vainqueur briefly noticed Manling Lynette discussing with a priest nearby, but Victor focused on the matter at hand first, approaching the altar of Mithras.

“Greetings, faithful,” the Bishop behind it said, a nice-smelling priestess of Leone at his side; unlike the unflappable priest, the woman observed Vainqueur with the appropriate degree of fear and apprehension. “Have you come to make an offering?”

“An offering?” Vainqueur asked, amused by the puny races’ strange customs.

“You offer money to the Church as an offer to the god, in place of fealty,” Victor explained to him the concept.

Vainqueur immediately saw an opportunity. “Minion Victor—”

“Your Majesty can’t be a god,” his lackey said hastily, the quickest sentence he ever uttered, “Unless he reaches level 100.”

Vainqueur sulked in disappointment. When he reached that level and became a god, he would ask his minions to build him a larger temple and a bigger statue than this Mithras. No way he would share it with other gods either.

“We have six human corpses outside, and that of a Manticore,” Victor told the priest. “Will the church take them?”

“We will purify the corpses so they do not rise as spontaneous undead, then burn them free of charges,” said the priest of Mithras. “If you prefer another method, the priests of Isengrim and Cybele will bury them in the forest, so they can return to nature.”

“For free?” Vainqueur glared down at the priest. “You will not pay me for the transportation service?”

“Why would we pay you for a public service?”

“Because we inquired *significant* expenses in the course of their deadification.”

“This isn’t a real word, Your Majesty,” Victor said.

“Of course it is, since I said it,” Vainqueur insisted.

“We do not pay people to gather corpses,” the Bishop of Mithras replied, glaring back at the dragon. “If you want to be paid instead of doing the moral thing, I suggest you turn to the church of Shesha instead.”

“Where?” the dragon asked immediately, his greed stronger than his anger at the animal’s insolence.

Victor pointing a finger on the left-wing, at the altar of a serpentlike humanoid with the upper body of a winged woman and the lower half of a snake. As befitting of a creature that looked the most like a dragon, her statue was the most outrageous of all, made from solid gold.

“Hi there, Lynette,” Manling Victor said as he approached that altar. Vainqueur greedily looked at the statue, leaving his lackey to his poor attempt at pre-breeding. “Of course you would worship the goddess of commerce.”

“Yes and no, Victor,” she replied. “It’s more of a business deal.”

“Unlike the other gods, who are fickle in their gifts, Lady Shesha trades for her miracles according to the rules of the market,” said the goddess’ priestess, a bellyful dwarven woman. “For an appropriate monetary gift, she provides.”

“She improves the prosperity of my inn for a fee,” Lynette explained.

“Really?” Manling Victor sounded strangely hopeful. “How much to be transported back to my homeworld of Earth?”

“Let me ask the goddess.” The priest underwent a brief trance, feverishly waving his hands until a golden number made of light briefly flashed into sight.

...

...

Vainqueur had never seen so many zeros. “That’s robbery!” Victor voiced his master’s contempt.

“You get a twenty percent reduction if you take the Shesha worshipper annual subscription,” the priestess tried to sucker Manling Victor, the number altered to reflect the deduction. “Thirty percent if you become a Bishop or Vestal. Donations to the Church of Shesha are also tax-deductible, so if you have time we can discuss your financial future.”

“The minion has no intention of leaving his current, fulfilling job,” Vainqueur answered for Victor, although he noted that being a god sounded almost as profitable as being an adventurer.

“Yeah,” Victor replied with a strangely less than enthusiastic tone. “We came to get rid of seven corpses outside, six Scorchers and one manticore.”

“We can buy the corpses to make fertilizer, and use the manticore’s parts for leather and potions. Taking into account the value, I would give one gold piece per human corpse, and one hundred for the manticore’s pelt.”

“One hundred and six?” the dragon said upon adding the numbers, “I say double.”

“One hundred and six,” the priestess replied, eyes shining with the steely determination of the true negotiator.

So Vainqueur upped his price. “Triple!”

“Your Majesty, you are supposed to go lower in a negotiation.”

“Lower is only for unassertive manlings,” Vainqueur replied. “I am a dragon, I know what I am worth. As my representative, I expect you to show dominance as well, minion Victor.”

“Dragon or not, the market is absolute,” the priestess replied, her greed so *pure*, so *dragon-worthy* Vainqueur couldn’t hold it against her. “One hundred and six.”

Manling Lynette observed the scene in silence, while a hooded figure wearing heavy, hooded crimson robes, approached the group as the argument heated up.

“Excuse me, I heard your argument,” a figure said with a raspy voice. Even if he couldn’t see his face beneath the hood, Vainqueur noticed his corpselike white hands and the familiar smell of rot underneath. A ghoul. “Are you looking to sell fresh corpses?”

Vainqueur glanced at the undead, then at his lackey. “That’s a worshiper of Camilla,” the minion said, pointing at the mosquito crest on the newcomer’s robes. “The Marquise of Blood, goddess of death, pestilence, and darkness. One of the Dread Three.”

“The three what?”

“The Dread Three. Camilla, goddess of death, Deathjester, the god of crime, and Veran, goddess of fire and tyranny. A trio of evil adventurers who became gods together, and stayed friends since; they oppose Mithras, but people are too scared of them to ban their worship.”

“I resent that evil label,” the ghoul replied. “Our goddess is simply misunderstood.”

“Didn’t she unleash the Red Death plague that turned many people into bloodthirsty vampires?” Manling Victor asked.

“Only to prevent overpopulation, and the vampires played a critical role in defeating the Fomor during the Century War. As I said, misunderstood.” The figure coughed. “Anyway, have you heard of the undead labor trade?”

“Here we go again,” the priestess of Shesha said with a sigh.

“No, never,” Vainqueur said.

“I did,” Victor said. “They buy corpses from living relatives, turn them into mindless zombies, then put them to labor work, from mining to farming. Isn’t it illegal, though?”

“The undead labor trade is a perfectly legal new industry, albeit currently limited to very few cities allowing it in their charters,” the hooded figure replied. “Very few of them do, but in time, when they see the benefits of enslaving the dead for the betterment of the living, we hope more towns adopt it. Imagine, zombies laboring the fields in every town, from Midgard to Ishfania, or fearless skeletons saving helpless orphans from forest fires.”

“Oh, where can I get one?” Vainqueur asked, now positively giddy.

“Your Majesty loves the dead?” Victor asked. “I never thought you would be that kind of dragon.”

“Minion Victor, having undead as minions is a status symbol among dragons,” Vainqueur told his chief of staff. “And they are so useful. They never run away, they do not eat, they are not tempted by a hoard, they live almost as long as dragons...”

Vainqueur’s own rival, that arrogant Icefang, couldn’t stop boasting about his army of dead manlings protecting his treasure when he didn’t brag about his crown.

“From what I heard, Victor,” the necromancer priest of Camilla told the lackey, “You fit the criteria to unlock the Necromancer class. You could make good money.”

“Really?” Vainqueur glanced down at his lackey, who lowered his head. “You can raise the dead? That is wonderful!”

“I meet the criteria to take levels in that class,” the lackey admitted. “But I’m not proud of it.”

“Minion, you have to take levels in that class,” Vainqueur insisted. “For my own good.”

“I must warn you,” said the priestess of Shesha. “That our goddess herself is currently unsure whether the potential long-term consequences of mass necromancy make up for the added market value.”

“I assure you our use of undead labor is perfectly safe, and no matter what these bourgeois noble imperialists trying to crack down free undead enterprise will tell you, there is no proof necromantic energy negatively affects the environment.” That necromancer couldn’t help going on a tirade. “Sincerely, the use of mindless labor is more ethical than the animal slavery still practiced by our nation. Animals have feelings, animated corpses don’t.”

“Corpseling,” Vainqueur interrupting, caring more about a quick buck than local politics. “How much?”

“If you sign a binding contract authorizing us to turn them into undead, we can provide fifty gold pieces per corpse and five hundred for the Manticore. Eight hundred in total.”

“Deal!” Vainqueur said before Minion Victor could open his mouth.

“I will need to inspect the corpses first,” the priest of Camilla said.

The necromancer left to examine the ‘wares,’ Manling Lynette put a hand on Victor’s arm. “Victor, Your Majesty, can we talk for a second?”

Victor nodded, clearly eager to earn the female’s favor. “What’s the matter?”

“Henry is missing,” she told them, before giving Victor a letter. “Someone ransacked his home last night, stole his researches, and left this inside.”

Henry. Vainqueur struggled to remember that name, while Victor read the letter.

“One very pompous *Captain François Vilmain of Harmonia*,” said the minion, “Politely offers to discuss the release of ‘our common friend Henry’ and an ‘offering of gold’ with ‘His Glorious Majesty King Vainqueur

Knightsbane' in exchange for the use of Haudemer's ships." Vainqueur silently appreciated that at least one manling knew the proper way to address him. "Vilmain also offered coordinates for the meeting point and an hour this evening, and not at all sinisterly signed with blood."

"Our apothecary confirmed it to be Henry's," said Manling Lynette, who sounded worried, "Since we do not have any spellcaster powerful enough to locate him, I thought to ask the goddess Shesha, but the price she asks is great."

"If they want to buy my forgiveness and a ship, who am I to judge?" Vainqueur replied, still not remembering who this Henry was.

"Your Majesty, the meeting place is conveniently very far from Haudemer. This is clearly a trap."

"I know, minion, but what can they do? Not die?"

"Clearly not, but they could sack the city in Your Majesty's absence and escape," the manling pointed out. "If they haven't lied and killed Henry already by bleeding him dry."

Manling Lynette made a blank face, then left without a word. "W-wait, I didn't mean it!" Minion Victor called her, "That was just the worst-case scenario!"

Vainqueur figured his lackey wouldn't reproduce anytime soon.

In the end, after the corpseseling found the wares to his liking, Vainqueur had Victor sign a very long contract with the church of Camilla. Basically, as the legal 'living relative' he swore on the gods he agreed to surrender the corpses to necromantic transformation.

"I just sold corpses to a necromancer for postmortem slave labor," Manling Victor complained. "That feels dirty."

"Why? There is no greater pleasure in life than watching my hoard grow!" Vainqueur decided to cheer his lackey up with his promised fee.

“Corpseling, please give my chief of staff his fee of eight gold coins.”

“Eight coins?” Manling Victor blinked. “I thought it was one-tenth of the sales?”

“One one-tenth,” Vainqueur clarified.

Manling Victor looked up at his master, apparently not very good with math. “Like one-tenth of a tenth?”

“Yes,” Vainqueur replied, “One one-tenth, as I promised. What, you want less?”

“No, I’m good,” the minion said wisely. “This is already too generous from you.”

“We will have the corpses reanimated and sent to the cities of Ferpuit and Minecreuse for immediate mining labor,” said the necromancer, true name ‘Jules Rapace’ according to the contract. “Thank you for supporting our country’s modernization.”

Congratulations! For ruthlessly selling your enemies’ corpses to the church of Camilla, making the world a deader place, you earned the [**Deadfriend**] Personal Perk!

[**Deadfriend**]: mindless undead mistake you for one of their own and do not attack you, unless attacked first; +5 charisma when interacting with the undead or worshippers of Camilla.

“Sweet, minion, I have a new Perk! You too?”

“Never before have I been more ashamed of one.”

Chapter 10: The Battle for Haudemer

That disloyal minion! “You thankless traitor!” Vainqueur lambasted Minion Victor in front of the terrified kobolds, the sheer power of his voice making him fall down on the sand. “You, you... you *goblin*, how could you do this to me?!” “I swear, Your Majesty, this is not what it looks like!” “It is exactly what it looks like!” Vainqueur replied. “I turn my back on you for five minutes, five minutes, and you cheat on me with another dragon! And a wyvern at that!” A horse-sized wyvern with lustrous black scales, and shiny ruby eyes that would lead any minion astray - and did - stood next to Victor. The pony to Vainqueur’s pegasus, all pretty looks and nothing else. Wyverns were as dim as cattle, and couldn’t even breathe fire! Vainqueur had caught his minion riding that shameless creature’s back, caressing the scales behind her horns. He felt disgusted just by remembering it. And worse, the minion had brought an iron necklace adjusted to that flying rat’s neck! The minion had intended to replace Vainqueur and then dress her up! Of course, the treacherous minion tried to play dumb, “I was just testing the [Horn of Wyvern Summoning], I swear!” Vainqueur was too pissed to care, “You fool, she is all pretty scales and nothing else! What, she let you ride on her back? Was it worth it?!” “Your Majesty, I don’t—” “No Majesty, you maggot! I spend all my time being the best dragon master for you, and this is how you repay my kindness? I thought we had committed to a special, fulfilling master-minion relationship!” “I swear this is not what it looks like,” Minion Victor repeated, even if Vainqueur had caught him in the act. The wyvern looked at Vainqueur with a dumb, smug look. Vainqueur would have eaten that filthy creature if it hadn’t been cannibalism. “And you cheat on me after I gave you custody of our first minions!” Vainqueur pointed a claw at their kobolds. “After I *promoted* you!” “Master, chief, please stop fighting,” sweet Pink cried. “Your Majesty, I really, really don’t like the wording of this conversation.” Victor found the strength to rise back up,

dusting sand off his cloak. “And I climbed on her back just once!” “I know your species has a shameful fixation on dragon riding, but climbing on my back is a very special privilege. You know I can never give you that, minion. But it does not matter. What *matters*,” Vainqueur stressed that word, “Is that you are a dirty, shameless master-chaser trying to replace me with a wyvern!” “Wait, no, of course not! It’s part of a plot to trick the Scorchers and get you richer, I swear!” “Then what about this necklace?!” “It’s not a necklace, it’s a ring! For you!” Vainqueur froze in surprise. “Truly?” he asked, his greed getting the better of him. Indeed, that necklace did look like the rings he often saw on princesses’ fingers... “I hope I’m not going to regret it, but...” Victor sighed. “Here’s a dragon-sized [Ring of Invisibility]. Just say ‘blink’ while wearing it, and you will become invisible. Remember when I sent the Kobolds on an errand? I asked the local blacksmith to craft that ring, and he was glad enough for your protection not to ask for a payment.” His... his first, dragon-sized magical item? No, wait, that was a trick to get back in his good graces! “Why would I become invisible, when I am perfect the way I look?” “It’s a trick to use on the Scorchers, Your Majesty,” the minion replied, “So you can take them by surprise.” Ah. Ah... “Like when kidnapping a princess by swooping in in front of knights?” Vainqueur asked, well-versed in that timeless strategy. “Like princesses with knights,” Victor replied with his usual strange, pitiful tone. At long last everything made sense, much to Vainqueur’s satisfaction. “I cannot believe I doubted my own chief of staff’s loyalty. Why did you make me doubt you? I could have eaten you for it.” Vainqueur grumbled at his manling’s mishandling of the matter. “I will forgive you for this misunderstanding.” “I am forever in Your Majesty’s debt.” “Of course, since I own you,” Vainqueur stated the obvious. “Now, give me that ring before I change my mind.” And so, under the twilight sun, Vainqueur accepted the minion’s gift of reconciliation. Manling Victor put the ring on his master's left fourth finger, while the minions clapped in happiness and the wyvern sulked in a corner. His very first magic item!

Congratulations! For making up with your trusted vassal and strengthening your relationship, you have gained two levels in [**Noble**]! You gained the [**Noblesse Oblige**] Perk!

+60 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +2 INT, +1 CHA, +2 LCK!

[Noblesse Oblige]: You gain a temporary stat boost to all your statistics when you defend your vassals from outsiders.

“Your Majesty just needs to say blink, and—”

“Blink!” Vainqueur’s scales turned transparent. “I cannot see myself.” “Yes, Your Majesty, you have become invisible,” Victor said, the kobolds petting the wyvern in the background. “Yes, but it is one thing to imagine the world without me, and another to 'see' it,” Vainqueur complained. He, after all, denied everyone the pleasure of watching him. “Now, minion, when do I get that [Stipend] Perk?” “Soon, Your Majesty, soon...” minion Victor marked a short pause, his eyes set on the city nearby. “Mmm?” “What is it, minion?” Vainqueur glanced at Haudemer’s direction, noticing a thick white mist spreading to engulf the city whole. The dragon couldn’t smell, nor hear anything within it. Strange. “An evening fog?” “Spreading so quickly at this hour?” Victor shook his head. “No. The Scorchers returned, Sir. The town is under attack.” “The rangers are ready to strike, chief!” Red said, the kobolds adopting a brilliant fighting pose, while the wyvern croaked behind them. “Can Your Majesty blow the fog away with his wings?” Victor asked his invisible master. “Of course.” Nothing easier for a dragon. “Okay then, rangers, follow me, we’ll scout ahead.” Victor wandered into the fog, followed by the minions. Vainqueur prepared to take flight and show the weather who was the master around here, but struggled somewhat to do so. As he flapped his wings, he ended up overdoing it and landing back on the sand within seconds. Since he couldn’t see his wings anymore, he had trouble orienting himself. The dragon had never flown ‘blind’ in his life. “Minion, how do I turn it off?” Vainqueur asked, but manling Victor had already vanished into the fog, “Minion? MINION!”

Victor somehow lost his way so badly, he ended up right where he wanted. He guessed these new luck points had worked out for him. While struggling to see within this dense mist, he had spent enough time at Lynette’s inn to recognize its shape. Victor guessed the mayor gathered the townsfolk here when the fog began to spread, for their own protection. A very good decision, for the inn was under siege. A dozen men armed to the teeth with bows, swords, and axes surrounded the place while led by an armored knight and a priest. Victor instantly recognized them as Vilmain and

Gustave; much to his horror, he also noticed Henry Bright, gagged and chained to a horse near Vilmain. The scholar had sword scars all over his body, and lost a lot of weight. Thankfully, the Scorchers hadn't noticed Victor yet. "Rangers?" Victor's voice lost itself in the fog. Damn, he had lost the kobolds. He hoped they were fine; monstrous critters or not, he couldn't let them get killed by bandits. Victor noticed Lynette and others through the inn's windows. The townsfolk had barricaded themselves inside, watching the encroaching bandit band with apprehension. "Hello, friends," the priest announced himself. "I am Vilmain, François Vilmain. We come in peace. If you open the door and let us ransack the inn, we will let you leave unharmed!" Victor hoped Lynette wasn't dumb enough to believe him. After a minute of waiting, without the door unlocking, it turned out she wasn't. "I will break the door," Gustave said, carrying a heavy claymore with one hand and a large shield with the other. "No, no need for that hassle, my friend," Vilmain replied. "Since they have barricaded themselves in, I will set the place on fire with a [Fireball] and cook them alive. You and your men can kill those who try to escape." "Not fair, you will get all the experience." "I want my next Bowman Perk, sir," one of the archers complained to Vilmain. "I will never miss anymore with it!" "Yes, I understand, but it will be quick, and we have to move before the dragon finds his way in." The priest turned towards Victor, apparently seeing him fine within the unnatural weather. "Well, would you look at that?" Victor sighed, as a dozen Scorchers looked at him. He might as well try to buy time until Vainqueur could blow the fog away. "That's the [Disorienting Fog] spell, isn't it? Pretty high level spell. I didn't expect a level thirteen Bishop to have access it. The last spellcaster I saw use it was in his mid-twenties." "Familiar spell? I would expect a *Nightblade* to know of it." Vilmain insisted on the mention of the criminal syndicate. "My class, Fell Bishop, allows me to cast powerful spells by sacrificing people to my dark god. So we nabbed a peasant on our way here. " Disgusting. "That's your fault by the way," Vilmain said, "We hoped you would leave the town to rescue poor Henry from us, but you didn't, you shameless, honorless fiend. Abandoning a civilian to his death? How unheroic." "Yeah, trying to lure the brave knight away from the town you want to loot. That's Outlaw trick number one. I was almost sure you already killed him." "Henry? No, it is always good to have an emergency sacrifice on hands, just in case. Don't give me that glare, he sold you out first." That didn't make it right. So that

was their plan? [Disorienting Fog] reduced sound within its radius and caused people to get lost within it. They thought they could use the weather to prevent the dragon from burning the place down from above without friendly fire. Simple, but effective. Why did they insist on sacking Haudemer instead of sensibly fleeing Vainqueur though? Victor guessed they had another motive than pillaging. “Why the hell are you even sieging that inn instead of boarding ships and escaping the country?” “In time,” Vilmain smirked, “But our employer, Brandon Maure of Ishfania, asked us to recover a certain magical apple buried under Haudemer. Once we have secured it, we will leave.” The iPad? They were after the iPad? Victor thought about handing it to them, but realized they would still kill everyone afterward. These guys killed as much for easy levels as gold. Vilmain coughed, “So, if you’re a thief yourself, why not join us then? There’s more money to make by joining in the pillaging than fighting us, and a man taming a dragon is one I want on my team. Also, you will live.” Yes, joining a group whose leaders had levels in *Turncoat* and *Vile* in their *name* was a brilliant idea. No way it could go wrong. That left fighting as the only option. Point for him: thanks to Vainqueur, he had powerful equipment, and the dragon would be here any second now... Point for these two monsters: they were twice his level, and they had minions of their own. Minions of their own? Damn, he was turning into Vainqueur. Mmm... a wise man once said criminals were a cowardly, superstitious lot. “Allow me to make you a counteroffer.” Victor revealed his [Horn of Wyvern Summoning]. “Surrender now, and I won’t use this horn of dragon summoning to bring Vainqueur on your front door.” Vilmain laughed. “I have the [Eye for Treasure Perk], my friend. That is a simple trinket for wyverns, nothing that can bind a great red dragon.” “That’s what the false description would lead you to believe,” Victor lied. “And it worked that way until I unlocked its secret powers. How do you think I bound that dragon to my will in the first place?” “Nonsense,” Gustave said, losing patience. “Enough talk. Join or die.” While Vilmain and Gustave were too cunning to fall for it, Victor could see their minio—their men hesitate. He hoped their fear of Vainqueur outweighed their trust in their leaders. “Your loss. Vainqueur, I summon thee!” Victor sounded the horn. “Archers!” Gustave called, bowmen readying their weapons and preparing to shoot Victor. Meanwhile, Vilmain began to intone a spell. “At my signal—” “Wait, above!” one of the men interrupted him. The shadow of a winged dragon appeared above their

heads, its features obscured by the fog. “The dragon is here!” a bowman shouted, before immediately lowering his weapon in abject fear. The wyvern let out a screech through the fog. Immediately, one of the outlaws turned tail, and the rest lost their nerve. “Wait, fall back into rank, cowards!” Gustave raised his blade, but his men had already started running away. Even Vilmain’s horse fled at the wyvern’s sight, dragging Henry with it. “I will have your head for this!” “Fine!” Vilmain declared, the two criminals left to their fate. “[Summon Lesser Demo—]” With a surge of speed he didn’t know he could achieve, Victor interrupted Vilmain with daggers in both hands. Reacting with lightning fast reflexes, the Fell Bishop parried one with a rapier, while Victor’s other weapon slipped past his guard and stabbed him below the shoulder. Victor sensed he may have a chance in close combat against Vilmain. The priest had more levels, but in a spellcasting, healer class. Unfortunately, this was a two on one fight. Gustave rushed to his ally’s side, tackling Victor with his shield. Victor’s [Sun Bracers] activated, empowering him with newfound strength and vitality. The blow almost tossed him to his back, but the Monster Squire managed to stay on his feet. Without giving him a respite, Gustave swung his sword to try and bisect Victor, who dodged the strike. The Monster Squire, unable to harm his foe through his heavy armor, tried to work around him to get at Vilmain, but the cunning Gustave always blocked his path. “[Skill Up]!” An unholy red glow surrounded Vilmain as he cast a spell, his free hand searching under his cloak. Victor guessed he looked for a potion to heal his wound. Instead, he brought out a flintlock pistol and aimed at Victor. Bringing a firearm to a sword fight? That cheater! Victor touched the [Firebomb Necklace] around his neck before Vilmain could pull the trigger. He had only three charges, so he better make them count. “Firebomb!” The enchanted necklace activated, unleashing a sphere of fire with a crimson spark. The projectile hit Vilmain and interrupted him, but the flames didn’t spread to his clothes. The criminal must have cast a fire-resistance spell of some kind, in case Vainqueur broke past the fog. Vilmain fired his flintlock like a maniac, clearly not caring about hitting his ally. Victor dived to the ground, a bullet killing an unlucky watcher by flying through a window. Gustave, ever the pragmatist, tried to strike Victor before he could rise to his feet, with the Monster Squire retaliating with another charge of his necklace. The Scorcher hid behind his shield, tanking the projectile like a champ. Yeah, the chief of staff couldn’t beat that knight on

his own. “No!” Victor cursed out loud over internalizing his new job, rising back to his feet and dashing at Vilmain. He managed to get past his accomplice's defense, moving between both Scorchers. Gustave tried to intercept him, but the wyvern, which had been circling them from above, fell upon him like a hawk. Her claws and fangs struck his armor without piercing it. Unable to reload fast enough, Vilmain threw away his pistol and struck with his rapier. Victor deflected the blade before it could pierce his heart, but the sword hit his left flank and drew blood. Damn, what was that greedy dragon doing? Ignoring his reservations against killing humans, Victor stabbed the bishop back. His dagger pierced him through the left eye, splattering the criminal's face with blood. It didn't kill Vilmain, but it angered him. And behind Victor, Gustave had cut one of the wyvern's wings with his sword, pinned her to the ground with his shield, and prepared to finish the beast off.

Vilmain incanted a spell, moving his free hand against Victor's torso. Cackles of dark energy built around his fingers... And then five Kobolds jumped out of the fog from behind, grabbing Vilmain's arms, legs, and head. “For His Majesty!” they shouted at once, biting the priest's flesh and interrupting his spell.

Congratulations! By ambushing a stronger enemy in the middle of a fight, your Kobolds have each gained a level in the [Outlaw] Class! “The power!” Red said, stabbing Vilmain in the other eye with his tiny claws. “I can feel the power!” “My eyes!” Vilmain screamed in agony as he struggled to get the kobolds off him. As the criminal lost his hold over his rapier, Victor dropped one of his daggers and stole the sword. He then stabbed the bishop back in the chest with his own weapon. The Fell Bishop fell on his back with a painful gasp, the kobolds still biting and clawing at him. “Vilmain, you weakling!” Having killed the wyvern with a swing of his sword, Gustave charged at Victor to save his ally. Distracted by the pain in his chest, the Monster Squire couldn't dodge in time and Gustave hit him with his shield. Crack! The blow propelled Victor against the inn's walls, his left shoulder going numb after a brief moment of sharp pain. “Chief!” Yellow attempted to defend Victor, only for Gustave to cut him in half with his sword. With another merciless swing, he struck down Blue. The other kobolds immediately attempted to fight back, but they were no match for

the knight. Gustave kicked Pink right in the face like a puppy, knocked out Red with his shield, and backhanded Black when he tried to flank him. The confrontation had lasted mere seconds. “Can you heal yourself?” Gustave asked Vilmain, who crawled on the ground, struggling to get back up while covered up in his own blood. “I exhausted... my special points with all the... interrupted spells.” Vilmain coughed. “I will need help... to walk.” “Pity.” Without remorse, Gustave struck his own ally in the back with his blade, killing him in one blow. “Sorry, *friend*, I wanted that new level more than I liked you.” An unholy aura surrounded the treacherous knight, empowering Gustave further. Victor used the last firebomb, the necklace disintegrating with its last charge exhausted. The projectile slipped past Gustave’s guard and hit him in the chest. The knight didn’t even flinch at the resulting blast. A rumbling sound echoed through the fog. Had the citizens of the city decided to fight back against the Scorchers? Victor couldn’t know, and wouldn’t live long enough to. With his chest wound and a limp shoulder, he couldn’t hope to dodge Gustave’s sword. “[Attack Stance],” Gustave tossed away his shield to wield his sword with both hands. The murderous aura around him increased in strength, the sheer pressure paralyzing Victor. “And now, I will take my sweet time cutting you —” Splat! Gustave collapsed into a puddle of blood, crushed by an invisible behemoth. “Minions? MINIONS! Where are you?” The knight’s blood splattered Vainqueur’s invisible scales. “Minion, there you are!” For a split second, Victor couldn’t find his words. “I cannot see where I go, and I cannot turn it off! How do I turn the invisibility off?” “You must say ‘blink’ again, Your Majesty...” Vainqueur marked a short pause, then said, “Blink!” The invisibility veil suddenly lifting off the dragon. The beast took a few seconds to look at his own scales, without any hint of narcissism whatsoever. “Much better.” The great dragon expanded his wings, unleashing a powerful gust by flapping them. The wind lifted the fog and unveiled a trail of destroyed houses which Vainqueur left behind. The invisible dragon had damaged the city more than the Scorchers themselves.

At least no civilians had died. “Ah, clear as day,” Vainqueur said. “I can at long last hunt the thieves.” Victor glanced at Gustave’s remains, stuck under Vainqueur’s left foot. The dragon hadn’t even noticed. “That won’t be necessary, Your Majesty,” he said, as Lynette and the townsfolk exited the inn, the danger now gone. “Except stragglers, most fled at your coming.” “I

will have my stipend!” Vainqueur complained, before hunting for Scorchers, leaving blood behind with each step. “Sweet manlings, where are you? Come out, I do not bite... not always...” “Victor, are you alright?” Lynette rushed to the Squire’s side, forcing a green potion to his lips before he could answer. As Victor drank it, finding the taste sweet, he felt the pain vanish, and his shoulder could move again. Unfortunately, the kobolds hadn’t been as lucky as him, mourning their fallen comrades. “What do we do?” Black said, tears in his eyes. “Yellow... Yellow was the best minion out of us all... I should have died...” “We sell them,” Red cried. “That was what they would have wanted.” ... “Come again?” Victor asked, blinking. “We sell them to make Master Vainqueur’s hoard bigger,” Pink said, Black and Red nodding with sorrow. “That way they will be part of it forever...” Victor figured out he had experienced a strong culture clash.

Congratulations! For fearlessly leading monsters to victory against superior opponents, you earned seven levels in [**Monster Squire**]!

+120 HP, +70 SP, + 5 STR, + 4 VIT, + 4 SKI, +5 AGI, +6 INT, +6 CHA, +7 LCK!

You earned the [**Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)**], [**Monster Rider**], and [**Monster Insight**] Perks!

[**Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)**]: the blood of your dragon liege flows in your veins. You gain the additional creature Type: Dragon, which is both a blessing and a curse. You gain immunity to Drain, Paralysis, Fatigue, Insta-death, Disease, and resistance to Fire and Aging. You gain vulnerability to Frost, Fairy, and Dragonslayer.

[**Monster Rider**]: You can now ride monsters with medium proficiency. If the target is a minion, your proficiency increases to good.

[**Monster Insight**]: When you observe a monster, you gain a vision of their strengths, weaknesses, and tidbits of information.

Seven levels at once? It almost made up for the deaths and the blood loss. A glance at the rapier he pilfered from Vilmain told him he had also gained some interesting loot out of it. “I have no idea how to reward you, Victor,”

said Lynette. “You were very brave out there.” Reward? Oh, and hell, why not. He had nothing to lose, except his dignity. “Do you want to breed?” he asked Lynette.

Chapter 11: Multiclassing

As dawn rose on Haudemer, Vainqueur allowed himself to rest on his back in front of the city's entrance.

He had spent the night hunting down the last of his walking punching bags, shoring up all the experience he could. His stomach hurt from the manling indigestion.

Congratulations! For crushing the Scorchers and stylishly stomping on the enemy leader before an adoring crowd, you earned four [**Gladiator**] levels! +120 HP, + 8 STR, + 1 VIT, + 4 SKI, +4 AGI, +4 CH, +3 LCK!

You gained the [**Crowd Favorite**] and [**Supercrit**] class Perks!

[**Crowd Favorite**]: You gain a temporary, random boost to one of your statistics when you impress a crowd, alongside the small chance of gaining an item.

[**Supercrit**]: Double the chances of your physical attacks inflicting critical hits.

Small chance to get an item if he impressed his fans? Sweet! He should find his minions and try it out.

However, what did they mean by stomping on the enemy leader? Vainqueur looked under his left foot, noticing a lump of flesh stuck between two of his claws. "Strange," he commented, licking his claws to taste the sweet meat.

The dragon decided to turn invisible, so he could see if other manling parts had stuck somewhere else. "Blink." He was gone.

"Blink!" And now he wasn't! "Blink, blink, blinkblink!"

Vainqueur found turning his invisibility on and off strangely amusing. He could spend all day doing it.

However, the ruckus of horses stampeding interrupted his game. Vainqueur wondered if the bandits had come for another round of '*honorable demise by dragon*.' That would confirm his theory about manlings having a collective deathwish.

Instead, two hundred riders, clad in the finest armor and wearing the shiniest weapons, rushed towards him. Most of them wore a sun emblem emblazoned on their armor, but a few of them carried flags representing a golden lion on a red background.

Knights. Lots of manling and beastkin knights.

Maybe they had a princess he could add to his hoard?

The knights stopped in a line facing Vainqueur, who didn't even bother rising up. It wasn't like they *could* do anything to him, and he was full enough to just burn them to oblivion if they tried.

Their leader, a female manling riding a white unicorn, stood in front of the line to address him. She had these long, fashionable golden hair, the same color of Vainqueur's own beautiful eyes, and tiny blue spots for a gaze. She wore a purple hermine. "So it is true," she said with a shrieking voice whom the dragon immediately disliked. "Haudemer has been occupied by a great red dragon."

"Indeed I am," Vainqueur answered that waste of skin. "Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of his Name, Great Calamity of this Age and King of the Albain Mountains. But you may call me Your Majesty."

"There is no king of the mountains," the upstart manling replied, before answering with her own presentation. "I am duchess Aelinor of Euskal, second removed cousin of King Gard—"

"Not a princess," Vainqueur interrupted her, annoyed at her forgetting the 'Your Majesty' part.

The petulant woman glared back at him. “I beg your pardon?”

“Not a princess,” Vainqueur repeated with contempt since the food was slow-minded. She didn’t smell like a princess, and instead had the scent of *disappointment*. Also, he was too good to speak directly to that creature. “Minion? Minion?! MINION, GET BACK HERE! The food is talking back!”

Where was his official animal translator when Vainqueur needed him?

The manling’s face turned red for some reason. “Vainqueur Knightsbane,” Somehow she made his noble name sound like an insult. “Our forces and the Shining Crusade have defeated the last of the Scorchers and retaken the citadel of Rochefronde from Ishfania. Only François Vilmain and Gustave la Muraille escaped judgment, and I intend to bring them justice and flames.”

Vainqueur knew nothing about Rochefronde, but according to the minion, they killed both of those manlings somewhere. “Done,” the dragon replied. “Also, your flames are weaker than mine, so no need to humiliate yourself.”

“Inspect the city for confirmation after we are done with him,” the manling told one of the knights, before turning her attention back on the dragon, “Vainqueur Knightsbane, you are wanted for the uncalled destruction of the Woods of Gevaudan, property damage, and the devastation of the local Euskalian countryside. A century-old bounty of one hundred twenty thousand gold coins on your head has been issued again!”

Finally, the false news about his demise had been invalidated! However... “One hundred twenty thousand?” Vainqueur asked for a confirmation, disappointed, “That is all? I order you rescind it.”

“Order me?” her face got even redder, almost as much as Vainqueur’s own scales. “Do you deny the charges against you?”

“No, but I am worth more,” Vainqueur replied, getting annoyed by the lack of a translator. Miscommunications, especially about their respective places in the order of things, clearly piled up somewhere. “I am at least worth one

million gold coins, and I am being *incredibly* modest here. Tell your mammal king to correct my net worth.”

“Are you insulting the god-chosen king of Gardemagne?” One of the knights raised his spear. “You vile creature, the Shining Crusade stands before you! You will burn in the fires of Lord Mithras for your pride!”

An aura of dread permeates the area, as the weight of the gods’ judgment falls upon you. [Terror] ailment—

“Apologize to *me at once*,” Vainqueur countered, his patience wearing thin.

But it failed miserably! [Terror] canceled by [**Dragon Arrogance**]!

“Apologize to you?” The noble manling’s eyes snapped open in uncalled defiance. “What for?”

“This is my world. I do not remember giving any of you my royal permission to live in it. Also, you should apologize for your weakness, because I have no idea how you can live with yourself.”

The manling leader twitched, and so did the knights.

Congratulations! For browbeating the upstart food with words alone, you gained the [**Taunt**] Personal Perk.

[**Taunt**]: Your soul-crushing, humiliating taunts have a small chance of inflicting the [Berserk] status on their targets. You monster.

Taunt? He was just stating the obvious.

“You are an arrogant creature,” the manling lady rasped like a snake, amazed at being in the presence of a true dragon.

“I am Vainqueur Knightbane, King of the Albain Mountains, the greatest adventurer in the world!” Vainqueur boasted, showing off the adventurer plate around his neck. “I am a *god*! No, wait, I am better. I am a *dragon*! Your puny gods answer to me! They pay me to kill your kind!”

“Blasphemy!” One of the knights snarled back, Vainqueur ignoring the animal’s yapping.

“Since I removed the trees around your land and protected this town from hostile manlings, I expect you to properly pay me for the service. I demand a wage of sixty-four thousand gold coins. Under the table, according to your manling reward ritual.”

“You... you are asking a duchess for a bribe in front of the holiest of knights?! Have you no shame?!”

“A dragon will never pay taxes!” the dragon roared proudly.

Congratulations! For defending your noble, unjust privileges, you gained two levels in [**Noble**]!

+30 HP, +20 SP, +2 STR, +2 SKI, +2 AGI, +2 INT, +1 CHA, +2 LCK!

You gained the [**Aristoradar**] Class Perk!

[**Aristoradar**]: You immediately notice other nobles, even undercover and false ones. No more bourgeois.

“I have had enough of this,” the noble lady said, raising her tiny hand. “Knights! Slay this stupid dragon!”

“You dare refuse to pay your due to your true King?” Now well and truly angered, Vainqueur rose back on his feet, the knights charging at him. He considered blowing them up with his breath, but decided to test his new Perks instead.

Raising his left, clawed finger, Vainqueur poked the first rider to reach him, crushing him and his horse at once and with enough force to cause the ground to shake beneath them. The knights stopped in horrified surprise.

Critical hit! [**Crowd Favorite**] activated!

Vainqueur’s eyes widened in joy, as a golden nugget materialized in a flash of light right in the middle of the knight’s remains.

Ah.

“Aha, yes! Finally!” Vainqueur glanced at his left finger. That was the secret to gain new items! He just had to poke these upstarts one by one! The dragon rejoiced, as the brave knights rushed at him, eager to make the dragon live up to his name.

Good.

He would poke them all.

Victor still couldn't believe it.

It *worked*!

That pickup line actually worked!

“Excalibur?” Lynette asked, her hands reaching to draw most of her bed's sheet to herself.

“Don't ask,” Victor replied, resting on the left side of the bed. All the stress and tension of following an insane dragon had vanished.

That world rocked!

Congratulations! For finally getting laid and experiencing the thrill of a short-lived fling, you gained the Perk [**Romantic**]!

You gain a +5 Charisma Bonus when interacting with the opposite sex!

“Very nice,” Victor said, “Sorry for being so... upfront about it.”

“Oh, no, actually, I'm very happy about it,” Lynette replied, her body resting against his. “For a second, I thought you would ask gold of me.”

Why did Victor had the sudden feeling he had just been shortchanged? “So, it's...”

“Just a transaction, nothing more.”

Victor should have expected that from a worshipper of the goddess of commerce. “At least I got a Perk out of it.”

“[Romantic]?”

Victor squinted at her. “How do you know?”

“I have the higher rank of that Perk, [Seducer]. You have to sleep with twenty different people to get it, and one hundred for the upgraded version. I am still dozens away from that one.”

“D-did you sleep with me for a Perk?”

“Just a transaction,” she smiled, “Nothing more.”

Yeah, he had been BEEPED in more ways than one. Capitalism struck again.

As he left his ‘damsel in distress’ to rest and got dressed, Victor took it back. That world sucked.

Closing the bedroom door behind him, Victor found the three kobolds waiting for him outside, alongside Jules the Necromancer. By now, the inn’s clients had gotten used to him bringing monsters around whenever he went.

“Chief, chief!” Red said, he and Black carrying the corpses of their fallen comrades on their back. “Sorry to interrupt your murder attempt.”

Murder? Ah. These poor children. They had looked through the keyhole. Victor was too relaxed to scold them. “Hi, Jules. You’re here for business?”

“Yes, yes, I need your signature for the new raw material Lord Vainqueur gathered. Your servants also informed me you were open to the idea of selling their dead companions; I commend you for your dedication to recycling.”

“Since Yellow and Blue are gone, we are two members short for the choreography,” Red complained. “We cannot serve His Majesty Vainqueur without one. We must look for recruits, stylish and colored...”

“Oh, could we look for a green and a white this time?” Black asked his leader. “We need brand new colors.”

“And a sixth with shining silver scales,” Pink squirmed. “A young, virile male.”

“No yellow or blue will ever replace our fallen comrades,” Red said gravely. “We shall look for new colors, and create a rainbow so we may showcase the great Vainqueur’s luster!”

“About that, Jules, is there a way to bring them back to life?” Victor asked the necromancer. “Not as mindless undead, but true revival.”

“True resurrection is a power far beyond my level, and that of anyone alive today,” Jules replied, much to Victor’s disappointment. “You may turn to the goddess Shesha, but she charges a harsh price for it. However... are you under level twenty?”

“I’ve just reached seventeen yesterday.”

“Then it should be easy to take a level in the [Necromancer] Class, and use its starting Perk, [Animate Dead], to revive your servants as undead. After you reach level twenty, the experience penalties will make it significantly harder, so it may be now or never.”

“Can’t you do it yourself? I can pay if you accept magical items.”

“I only raise non-intelligent undead for ethical reasons. [Animate Dead] will bring the lucky fellows back as intelligent ones, including the original soul, if you sacrifice coins or some of your items.”

“Chief, no!” Red protested. “They gladly gave their life for you!”

“You saved my life,” Victor replied. “I owe you that.”

They had also gained class levels out of it, which complicated matters; while convincing monsters to fight more monsters sounded appealing on paper, his experience with Vainqueur made him fear the consequences. Neither did he want the critters to end up as Vainqueur’s emergency rations.

Maybe he would better send them on a non-dangerous errand for their safety?

While he didn't like taking a level in a dark class, Victor decided the kobolds, monsters or other, had earned a raise.

Congratulations! For working with a necromancer to enter the death market, you gained a level in the [**Necromancer**] class!

+10 SP, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You gained the [**Animate Dead**] Class Perk!

[**Animate Dead**]: You can revive corpses as undead with a touch. By sacrificing money or items, you can revive a living being as an intelligent undead, retaining both the original soul and class levels. The funds needed to revive someone depends on the soul's value, whom you intuitively understand.

With a glance, Victor instantly guessed the two kobolds were worth a few hundred coins each; more than he owned. He removed his sun bracers, each worth as much, and activated the Perk.

An unholy, purple glow filled the room, turning the bracers to dust. The dark aura then moved to the broken remains of the two dead kobolds, binding them back together, and consuming the flesh.

Much to Victor's silent disturbance, the two skeletons rose back on their own, their bones having changed color to yellow and blue respectively. An unholy glow shone in their eye sockets.

Your Kobold minions have been revived as Kobones!

"Blue, Yellow?" Red asked as the undead turned at him. "Are you... alright?"

"**Flesh...**" Blue's voice had turned into a cavernous, terrible voice.
"**Flesh...**"

What? “Has the Perk failed?” Victor frowned.

“Nah, I’m kidding chief,” the Blue skeleton replied, regaining his original voice and letting out a strange chuckle. How the skeleton managed to do that without lungs was beyond Victor. “Still the same old me, except now I can see my clavicle.”

“This new voice is awesome! Let me try!” Yellow chirped, his voice turning from his original one to the same cavernous echo. **“I am Ranger Yellow, and you have met your doooooooooom... doooooooooom...”**

“Red, I am your father,” Blue said with the same voice in a pretty good interpretation of Earl Jones. “Neat!”

“Doooooooooom...”

They took their transformation into undead skeletons pretty well. “Blue, Yellow!” Red embraced the reborn minions. “You are back!”

“Yes, and I don’t feel my stomach ulcer anymore,” Yellow said, returning to his normal voice. “Being undead is marvelous!”

Victor smiled at the scene. While annoying as hell, Vainqueur and the Kobolds did save his life and the city. Maybe he had been wrong to distrust them. Maybe they could do good, all of them.

Maybe he could get used to this new life...

Then a knight flew through one of the inn’s windows and crashed against a wall, dashing Victor’s hopes.

Victor glanced at the broken man, and took a long, deep breath. “Minions, help Jules with his business,” he told the kobolds while his fingers went for his trusty canteen and he took a sip of alcohol.

When another knight flew through a second window, and a third hit the wall outside, the adventurer decided not to stop at a sip. “Well, well, well,” Jules rejoiced, clapping his hands. “This association keeps getting better and better...”

“Minion?” An unpleasant voice came from outside the inn. “MINION!”

Sighing and out of alcohol to drown his sorrow, Victor calmly exited the inn, his hand on the new rapier around his belt. He had also taken Vilmain’s flintlock with him as a trophy but didn’t think he would make much use of it.

As expected, he found Vainqueur waiting for him right in front of the building. A good two dozen knights laid broken and defeated around town, the sight fitting the aftermath of a deadly drunken brawl. They bore the insignia of the Shining Crusade.

There died his hopes of getting rescued by a knight in shining armor.

Surprisingly though, the dragon had come back with a pile of treasures in his hands. “Minion, look at what they *gave* me!” Vainqueur proudly showed his new shinies, from gold purses to magic items.

“What happened?” Victor asked.

“I poked them,” Vainqueur replied, licking his left finger.

“All of them?” Why did Victor sound so bored? The disaster had numbed him to the dragon’s insanity.

“This is the critical hit finger, minion.” Vainqueur showed him his left hand’s index claw. “Every time I kill a manling with it before your brethren, they reward me for it!”

Yeah right. While at it, Victor decided to try his new [Monster Insight] Perk on his ‘master.’

Vainqueur Knightsbane.

Elder Red Dragon (Dragon)

Vulnerable to: Frost, Fairy, and Dragonslayer.

Strong against: everything else.

Self-proclaimed 'best dragon', a great red wyrm who is more than a match for the strongest of adventurers. His immense strength is matched only by his arrogance and lack of common sense. Kind of greedy, vain, and self-absorbed, but secretly insecure about his minions leaving him.

Gee, you think? What a useless Perk. "Your Majesty, Duchess Aelinor of Euskal was supposed to lead this band of knights to Haudemer. Maybe we should check on her for the reward."

"Done," Vainqueur replied happily, "We can finally move on from this stinking town. I miss bathing in my hoard."

"Ah?" Victor raised an eyebrow, curious. "What happened, you poked her too?"

The dragon scrapped his teeth with a claw. "I ate her."

Victor's mind stopped working. "You what?"

"I ate her. Although I think she would have tasted better with that sweet poison sauce."

"You ate the quest giver." And a high-ranking noble in the kingdom.

"Do not worry for the gold, I recovered the reward first," Vainqueur 'reassured' him, before belching.

"W-why?" Victor choked. "Why did Your Majesty do that?"

"Because she was annoying, would not pay me, and wasn't a princess," Vainqueur replied angrily. "Also, she tasted like pork."

Victor looked at the dragon, words dying in his throat.

"Minion, do not look at me like that. There are more enough beastkins lying around for a barbecue if you are hungry."

Chapter 12: Looking for Dungeons

How good to bathe in a bigger hoard!

Vainqueur had done far more than what he had set out to do. He hadn't doubled his treasure's size, but more than quadrupled it. While he once struggled to fully shower himself with coins, the dragon could now roll happily in gold and jewels.

All of this in less than a moon. At this rate, his cave wouldn't be enough to contain his full hoard.

"Guys, go away!" Minion Victor called outside, Vainqueur paying it no mind. "Haven't you seen the signposts? You will get killed if you get closer!"

"Is that the dragon's lair?" a shrilling voice answered, Vainqueur trying to block out the sounds.

"Yes, but you really, really don't stand a chance—" A zapping sound like that of lightning echoed in the distance. "Alright, that's it! Shoot them, minions!"

The sound of an explosion and tremors interrupted Vainqueur's joyful bath. The dragon turned to the cave's entrance, where his minions had barricaded themselves. "Manling Victor, what is happening?"

"Dragonslayers, again!" his chief of staff shouted back, another tremor causing an icicle to fall at the cave's entrance, nearly impaling one of the kobolds. "Blue, snipe the wizard!"

"I am trying, chief!" The undead minion fired an arrow with his bow of cattle bone. "I got him!"

Vainqueur was very proud of Victor's choice of learning necromancy. Not only did undead minions add to Vainqueur's prestige, but he could also now eat minions, spit out the bones, and still make use of them.

"Nailed him right between the legs!" Red gloated after firing his own arrow, before snarling. "They have a healer!"

Vainqueur grumbled, rising from his hoard to join the siege.

Since they achieved a level in [Outlaw]—which amused Vainqueur, who considered laws a manling absurdity—Victor had given each of the Kobold Rangers bows and taught them how to use them. A good idea, since this was the seventh adventurer party they sniped this week.

At first, it had been amusing and profitable, but Vainqueur had grown tired of the constant interruptions.

The dragon's head exited the cave's entrance, casting his minions in his shadow and glancing down at their targets. A foolish band of manlings, dwarves, and elves, mostly armed with these sticks Manling Victor called arquebuses or wands. Vainqueur counted fifteen of them.

Aw, they came back with greater numbers this time, as if it would help. *Adorable.*

Unfortunately, they didn't bring any pegasus riders, unlike the previous group, so no horse food tonight. Vainqueur would have loved nothing more than poke them, but his finger had grown sore from overuse.

"They are very persistent." As a magical projectile bounced off his head, the dragon considered learning magic himself. The way some sorcerers often threw lightning at him always fascinated Vainqueur. Not that it ever *worked*, but it amused him. "I thought they would give up after the first three pokings."

"The bounty on Your Majesty's head is very high," Victor replied. "And your lair's location is well-known now."

Yes, yes, such were the downsides of fame and celebrity.

The dragon let out a powerful roar, causing an avalanche; the snow rolled down the mountain, flooding the screaming manlings while leaving the cave unscathed. He knew choosing this location would prove helpful.

Congratulations! For defending your territory and minions with the power of your noble roar alone, you have gained a level in the [Noble] class!

+30 HP, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

Finally! Vainqueur had started to wonder if he would gain any experience out of this, and he was one level short of that sweet stipend. “There, problem solved,” the dragon said. “Recover their treasure, while I return to my bath.”

“Your Majesty, this can’t continue,” Victor said, black marks under his eyes. “They just keep coming, even at night. They ignore all warnings.”

“We cannot repeat our new motto,” Red complained. “And Yellow keeps ruining it when we find the time too!”

“I just say we should add ‘doom’ somewhere,” the yellow skeleton replied, before switching to that deep voice he had grown awfully fond of.

“Dooooooooom.”

The echo caused a lesser avalanche, finishing off the few manlings who managed to crawl out of the snow. Vainqueur ignored them as he retreated inside his cave. “Minions, I am just as annoyed as you, but what can I do about it? I cannot forbid manlings from committing assisted suicide.”

“Yeah, I have become comfortable killing idiots attacking us first as part of natural selection, but we should relocate.” Manling Victor shuddered, freezing even while wearing a goatskin coat. “To a warmer mountain where adventurers won’t keep finding us.”

Abandon his cave? A dragon did not run! “Are you not happy to have a roof?” Vainqueur browbeat his minions. “You have food aplenty, the best

sight of the continent...”

“We lack space, and I’m sick of eating mountain goats all the time,” manling Victor complained, having grown bolder and angrier due to the lack of sleep. “Also, one cave soon will not be enough to hold your treasure, Your Majesty.”

Vainqueur pondered the suggestion, his eyes settling on his hoard. Indeed, his cave would soon become too small, and a thief might get lucky stealing his gold while he hunted outside. While he trusted his minions, they could not handle so many robbers at once.

That, and ever since they cooked that squid, they haven't had received any requests. Maybe they should use the time off to find a new place to live.

“I still do not understand why your guildhalls become deserted every time we go there,” Vainqueur grumbled.

“Your Majesty,” his chief of staff coughed. “The problem with eating a quest giver is that no more people will give you quests, because they are afraid you will eat them too.”

“But she refused to pay me first!” Vainqueur protested. “Before witnesses!”

“Yeah, well, she was also a high-ranking noble with lots of connections. I did send a complaint to the adventurer guild, and I heard the duchess’ sister is secretly happy we hastened her inheritance, but we aren’t getting work for a while.”

“I cannot believe it, is that what your puny race do in this situation? Complain and laze off?”

“Your picture of my species is very flattering, Your Majesty,” Victor said with his usual obsequiousness. “Usually we just clean a dungeon, kill monsters, and take their treasure.”

Vainqueur’s head perked up at the mention of treasures, hitting the ceiling. “Treasure?” he repeated, the kobolds cowering behind him to avoid falling

icicles, “Minion, tell me everything.”

The chief of staff scratched the back of his head, probably wondering where to begin. “Dungeons are dangerous areas, overflowing with monsters and holding treasures,” he explained to his master. “Adventurers clearing the place can take everything they get their hands on, and even claim the dungeon if they kill all the monsters within. However, dungeons usually have a super-strong creature, a boss, keeping them.”

“A monster lord,” Vainqueur guessed.

“You have a term for it?”

“Monster lords are the top of the food chain,” Pink chirped. “They are the strongest of the strongest, to whom minions owe obedience!”

“Dragons are always at the top,” Vainqueur clarified. “Where can we find such a dungeon?”

“Most in Gardemagne have been emptied by older adventurers, but I heard of a few too dangerous for most, especially alongside the border with Ishfania. I guess Your Majesty could handle them.”

“Are these dungeons large enough to hold my ever-growing hoard?” The minion nodded. Mmm... it might also be the occasion to rebuild his minion base since Manling Victor clearly couldn’t breed for the life of him. “What kind of dungeons have you heard of?”

“There is the underwater city of Meropis—”

“Next!” Vainqueur immediately interrupted, having enough of watery adventures already. “Somewhere warm and on land. No wetness.”

“No marsh, then? I had a pretty nice one in a marsh.”

“No marshes, no swamp, no forest, no lake, no mud, no dirty, dung-smelling manling city.”

His chief of staff kept nodding. “And no frost, for our sake. What about a nice, dry desert then?”

“Oh, oh, I heard of one!” Yellow butted in the conversation. “I heard of an antlion nest in the southern desert, beyond the mountains! It is very deep and very warm!”

Black shuddered. “The cacti shoot you with needles there. I still feel the pain in my butt.”

“Ah yes, I remember that time we tried to practice in the sand,” Blue said. “Now is the time I am happy not to feel pain anymore.”

“Antlions don’t carry treasure besides the remains of their victims,” Manling Victor pointed out. “At best we will only get a few trinkets and what we can take by killing the beasts. The place would be big enough for the hoard, though.”

Vainqueur would rather eat two cows with one bite. “Next.”

“Great, great, then what about a castle in the middle of a volcano?” Manling Victor suggested. “Since Your Majesty *enjoys* lava baths as much as golden ones...”

Indeed he did. “I am listening,” Vainqueur said. “How much lava are we talking about?”

“I dunno, I’ve never been there. But the place, the Castle of Murmurin, has a spooky reputation. From what I gathered, it was once an officer training facility for the continent’s elite and the headquarter of the Ishfanian Inquisition. At the start of the Century War, Brandon Maure sent his general, the Lich Furibon, to claim the castle, turning it into a haven for fiends and waking up the volcano they had built the fortress on. The Ishfanian Inquisition did its best to fight off demons but—”

"Twenty words," Vainqueur interrupted his minion.

Victor marked a short pause. "Excuse me, Your Majesty?"

"I start zoning out after twenty uninteresting words," Vainqueur said. "I know you manlings love to blatter meaningless words, but a dragon has better things to do than listen. Twenty words, twenty-five if you push it, and gold, treasure, and money do not count."

Manling Victor let out a strange sound. "Lich occupying the castle, *bad*. Killing it, *good*. *Great* reward."

Vainqueur suddenly realized the manling may have used big words to hide his true lack of intelligence. That poor human. The dragon had probably saved his life while taking him under his wing. "What reward?"

"I heard the Ishfanian Inquisition kept most of their fortune in vast vaults underneath the castle, including unique relics. In fact, Maure ordered the attack so they couldn't be used against him. Also, Gardemagne promised that whoever cleaned up the Castle could claim the surrounding lands as their own, which doesn't mean much since they have long been deserted."

"Not really, chief," Red countered. "I think I know the place, and many kobold warrens made their home there."

"Deserted by the civilized races," Minion Victor corrected himself, before frowning. "Wait, you lived there?"

"Our original warren still does," Red nodded. "When resources grew too scarce to feed all of us, the five of us left to find a monster lord of our own. The minion job market is crowded there."

Blue nodded. "The mountain is full of demons, undead, and nasties, except for that one human village."

"There is still a village there?" Victor asked, only caring about his puny kind while Vainqueur imagined the legions of kobolds who would soon cater to his every wish. "How did it survive?"

"No idea, chief," Red replied. "The elders said that the village is 'bad moon mojo,' and everybody avoids it. We ate all the other adventurers for miles."

Which meant no more attempted robberies. “Nice, you have sold me,” Vainqueur said. “Pack your belongings, minions, castles are the new caves.”

“I must warn Your Majesty that the lich Furibon still occupies the castle and has wiped out every adventurer party trying to dislodge him. Gold-ranked adventurers even.”

A lich... “Minion Victor, a lich is a kind of undead, right?”

“Yes—”

“I knew it!”

“They are the strongest of all undead, spellcasters who turned to the dark arts in order to prolong their life. And Furibon was a level fifty magician when he conquered the castle one hundred years ago. He is probably stronger now, he has armies of minions, and he himself is a general of Brandon Maure.”

“Brandon whom?” The name sounded vaguely familiar.

“The demon king who usurped control of Ishfania one hundred years ago. Also, the employer of the Scorchers; since we caused them to disband, Gardemagne was able to retake the fortress of Rochefronde from his forces, so he’s probably pissed off at us.”

“I fail to see why I should care,” Vainqueur replied, who feared no one. “I will poke him as I did with your puny kind.”

“I’m just saying a demon king and a lich who killed just about every hero sent after them for one hundred years might present a bigger hurdle than a bunch of bandits.”

Great, that would mean more treasures to grow his hoard with, and more levels. “I, Vainqueur, relish the challenge,” the dragon replied, unmoved. “Pack your belongings and my hoard.”

His chief of staff glanced at Vainqueur’s treasure, marveling at the size. “Your Majesty,” he said. “How do we transport all the gold?”

The dragon squinted, before realizing the problem.

Ah, indeed. Vainqueur's hoard had grown so much, the dragon could no longer carry it in his hands, and what his minions had in wit, they made up with a lack of brawn. They couldn't transport the entire hoard in one go.

"We could leave it behind," Manling Victor suggested. "Collapse the entrance. It would take days for adventurers to dig it out if they even try."

The idea of leaving his hoard unattended for days while robbers kept making their way to the mountaintop horrified Vainqueur. What if he came back to find some of the gold lost? After he struggled so much to grow his treasure! "Minion Victor."

"Yes, Your Majesty?"

"Find a bag. A big bag."

"A big bag? For the entire hoard?"

"A very big bag," Vainqueur clarified when his chief of staff looked at him with his big, ugly eyes. "And smaller, tiny bags for the other minions."

"Your Majesty, there is no bag big enough for your hoard."

Vainqueur took it as flattery. "Then do you have a better idea, minion? Gold does not fly."

The manling opened his mouth to say something stupid, then closed it, then looked inside his coat and brought a strange, white metal plate from underneath. The other minions whistled in awe, much to Vainqueur's confusion.

"Actually," Manling Victor said. "I think it can..."

Chapter 13: The Event

The Castle of Murmurin looked better than anything Vainqueur could have imagined.

An *immense*, foreboding structure of black stone, the dungeon stood on a rock in the middle of a crater full of hot lava, the black smoke surrounding the place giving it a spooky look. The remains of a half-destroyed stone bridge linked the volcano's edge to the castle's entrance, a stone doorway more than large enough to fit Vainqueur through - unlike that stupid temple.

A ring of stone bound the castle's numerous towers and fortifications, overseen by magnificent dragon statues. The structure had one pointed tower larger than all others at the center, Vainqueur catching glimpses of shadowy forms through stained glass windows. Clouds of carrion birds and crows flocked to the roofs, hungry for manling blood, while giant worms roamed the magma below.

It had lava. It had a food reserve. It had towers.

In short, it was the perfect lair where to stash his hoard!

The land outside the castle was considerably less impressive than the building itself though. The volcano was suitably big and bordered the western sea, but the countryside was an unsightly patch of badlands and arroyos. The soil was brown, flowers and plants scarce, while under the southern horizon, Vainqueur could see the beginning of an immense red sand desert. The remaining manlings had built a small village at the foot of the mountain, while the dragon noticed a few primitive encampments near the desert's border.

Vainqueur would have preferred more than one village to supply him with cattle, but the castle made up for the poor neighborhood. “Strange,” he mused to himself, with his minions providing the audience, “I can remember flying over this region two centuries ago, and it looked much greener.”

Not that the great dragon cared. He was already in a good mood, and a mere glance at his flying hoard cheered him up.

Manling Victor and the minions had created an ingenious device: a flying ship.

By exhaling without igniting his breath, Vainqueur provided hot gas to fill a giant bag made of silk, paper, and other stuff; merchants from around the Albain Mountains gave them up when the dragon asked kindly. Somehow, when powered by his marvelous breath, the enormous balloon could lift even a ship.

Working together - continuously in the case of the kobones, who never slept - the minions created a wood ship, much smaller than the balloon, and which could carry the hoard. The kobones powered wooden helixes with pedal, allowing the ship to change direction thanks to a wheel operated by Manling Victor. Vainqueur had asked that the ship's bridge be open, so he could see his hoard inside and catch any treasure flying overboard.

It had taken the minions a good week to finish the ship and sew the balloon while Vainqueur watched, but in the end, it worked out.

While Manling Victor had worked on the ship's design, the Kobolds had discussed other methods to fly the hoard, which included: using stuff called 'magnets'; strapping bird wings to chests; putting everything on throwing discs and then launching them above the mountains; and finding a magical bag which would make the hoard tiny. Vainqueur had shot down that suggestion immediately.

While the dragon had liked the winged chest idea the most, he was satisfied with the final result. No longer did he need to carry his gold the old-

fashioned way! He only had to fly next to it and occasionally provide hot air.

“Good job, minion Victor,” Vainqueur congratulated his chief of staff, as he flew next to the ship. “I am proud of being your master.”

“Yeah, I noticed the iPad’s files held schematics for planes, so I thought maybe they had information on aircrafts; and I guessed a dragon's breath had to work on some sort of gas to catch fire. We aren't going to cross the Atlantic with that airship, but it will do for short distances.”

“Only our chief of staff could access the true power of the Apple of Knowledge!” Red chirped. “And it worked on its first try!”

“It flew on its first try after we crashed the eight prototypes,” Manling Victor pointed out. “You know, I wouldn't have been able to design anything like this while back on Earth. The eleven Intelligence points I gained since really showed there.”

Vainqueur didn’t understand half of what they said, too happy to care. “Minion, you will land my hoard there after we are done with the introductions,” the dragon pointed at a small, isolated valley, “Away from thieves.”

“Sure,” minion Victor said, glancing at the castle while keeping the ship above the crater's edge. “I’m pretty certain the owner must have seen us coming.”

“Good,” Vainqueur replied, hovering above the volcano’s edge. “What is his name again?”

“Furibon.”

“Minion, announce my presence to that Furibon.”

“Is Your Majesty really, *really* sure they want to do that?” Manling Victor took a deep breath, then shouted towards the crater, his booming voice causing the crows to flee, “FURIBON! King Vainqueur Knightsbane, King

of the Albain Mountains and greatest adventurer to ever live, wants to have a talk!”

“Minion, do not forget ‘Great Calamity of this Age,’” Vainqueur chided his lackey. “I worked hard on earning that one.” So many princesses abducted... the dragon promised himself he would grab one after moving in.

Unfortunately, the current owner teleported outside the castle before the minion could correct his mistake.

Furibon the lich was a skeleton, larger than that of most of the puny races, with a long serpentine neck and a manling-like skull. His bones seemed made of gold, the teeth of jewels, while the empty eye sockets shone with a bright, purple light. The creature wore expensive, red and purple robes like living wizards, but while it had long, thin arms, it lacked legs. Magic alone allowed it to fly.

And it had a nice crown, whom Vainqueur immediately wanted for himself. “I wonder what is his level... let's use [Observe]...” Manling Victor’s eyes widened. “Fifty-eight?!”

The undead flew upward towards the dragon and his flying hoard with a speed that rivaled Vainqueur’s. The lich stopped right in front of the ship's bridge. “Greetings, mortals,” the lich said with a deep, frosty voice. Vainqueur noticed the air chilled out around him. “His Majesty King Vainqueur Knightsbane, and Victor Dalton, I assume?”

“Indeed, I am King Vainqueur,” Vainqueur replied proudly, happy at being shown proper respect. This day just couldn’t get better.

“You face Furibon, archmage of Ishfania,” the undead replied, “Welcome to my humble abode. It has been so long since I have had living visitors. My creations are so... *eager* to fight.”

“You know our names?” Manling Victor spoke up. “You were *expecting* us?”

“My lord and master, King Brandon Maure, warned me that you helped Gardemagne retake the fortress of Rochefronde by destroying his chosen agents, and stole the Apple of Knowledge." The creature's 'eyes' moved to examine the ship. "I see that you already peered in its forbidden knowledge."

They did what with Rochefronde? Vainqueur hadn't paid attention back then.

"Have you come to return the artifact to its rightful owner?" the lich asked, "I hope not. I would have to spare you in that case."

“As if anyone could take what belongs to me,” the dragon taunted the lich with disdain.

The creature let out a deep sound which Vainqueur thought to be a laugh. “Why not play a game for it, then? You are adventurers eager to challenge my castle, are you not? The lack of victims bores me so very much; your feeble minds cannot fathom the number of trap designs I went through over the last half a century. When you are immortal and tasked with holding a crumbling ruin, you have to occupy your time somehow.”

“By making death traps?” Minion Victor asked with a strange tone. "To each their hobby."

“A sarcastic mortal,” the lich replied with the exact same tone, except it somehow sounded more scathing. “How original. [Black Curse].”

A black aura surrounded Manling Victor, instantly draining all colors from his skin and bringing him to his knees.

The sound the minion made though... Vainqueur had never heard such a ridiculous sound in his life, and neither did Furibon, who let out a chuckle. "Still standing? Then, let us try again. [Black Curse].”

Victor collapsed to his chest this time, almost falling overboard. “Chief!” the kobolds and kobones immediately rushed to his help.

“Why did it not make an amusing sound this time?” the lich wondered.

“Because I already... learned your monster Perk... wanna see?” Manling Victor raised a feeble hand at the lich. “[Black Curse]...”

A black aura surrounded the lich, who shrugged it off. “A [Monster Squire]. How amusing, trying to fight me with my own Perk. Maybe I should cut the greetings short and cast down this ship from the skies, and you with it.”

“Stop bullying my minions,” Vainqueur warned the creature, moving between the flying ship and the lich. “He is my chief of staff. To attack him without my permission is to show *me* disrespect and commit suicide by dragon.”

“Oh? You wish to fight? I admit I would rather test my creations on you first, but if you wish to skip directly to a fight, I will take back the Appl—”

Bored with the conversation and eager to claim his new castle before dinner, Vainqueur fingerpoked the lich in the chest.

The blow sent him flying towards the castle, but the creature’s flight stabilized before it could hit the walls. “You...” the lich fumed with cold anger. “You lizard, how dare you touch me? I will mount your head on a spike in my library!”

He survived the poke.

The lich survived the poke.

“How dare you survive the poke!” Vainqueur complained, raising two fingers. “Now I will have to use half my hand to destroy you!”

“Your Majesty, powerful undead are immune to critical hits...” Minion Victor warned, regaining enough strength to speak up normally. “Use your breath!”

“[Magic Up],” the lich rasped, shining with a crimson aura. “[Greater Fire Res—”

Vainqueur just blasted him with a quick fireball, vaporizing him at once.

He instantly regretted it.

The crown!

Congratulations! For taking a powerful lich by surprise and temporarily destroying it before your fans, you have earned a level in [**Gladiator**]!

+30 HP, +2 STR, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” his minions congratulated him. “Vainqueur, Vainqueur, Vainqueur!”

“Where is the treasure?” Vainqueur asked, once the smoke settled to reveal nothing but dust. “He should have dropped a treasure.”

“That’s because he’s not dead, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor said, as he rose back to his feet.

“Of course he is. He is an undead, he was dead before I killed him.”

“Your Majesty, first, Furibon is a lich. Their souls are held by a container which will allow them to revive within a few days if not destroyed.”

Before Vainqueur could argue further, the lich materialized right back in front of them, powerful sorcery surrounding him. “[Greater Fire Resistance], [Magic Ward], [Stone Ward], [Accelerate], [Greater Evasion].”

"Already?" Victor squinted at the sight. "Shouldn't it take you days to recover?"

"I have a special Perk which accelerates the process. As for you, Vainqueur, I will teach you why your kind is—" The lich dodged Vainqueur’s attempt to poke him by flying out of the way. “Stop this at onc—” Again, he avoided a poke. “Stop this! [Crimson Barrier].”

A shining sphere of red magical surrounded the lich, blocking Vainqueur’s frustrated attempts at poking him with two fingers. “Better. King Vainqueur,

I thought you would be an entertaining victim, but now I cannot wait to make a bag out of your skin.”

“As if,” Vainqueur replied with smug disdain. “A dragon has no weakness!”

“Is that so?” The lich flew to get a direct line of sight of Vainqueur's gold, on the ship's bridge. “Is that your hoard, King Vainqueur?”

No... “Do you not dare throw my hoard in the lava!”

“Throw that wealth in the lava?” The lich chuckled. “Do you take me for an animal, Vainqueur Knightsbane? What kind of wasteful monster would throw such a hard-won hoard into magma?”

Ah. Ah, thank the elder wyrm, that undead was a civilized fellow.

“I have a better idea in mind,” the lich said, raising both hands and calling upon purple sparks of lightning.

“[Transmute Gold to Lead]!”

Before Vainqueur’s mind caught on, his entire hoard turned from beautiful gold to unshiny lead with a bright flash of dark magic.

For a long, agonizing moment, the great wyrm was too shocked to compute the situation, his brain freezing inside his skull.

...

“Boss? King Vainqueur?”

...

“Your Majesty?”

...

"Ohoh, I 'lived' for centuries, and I never knew dragons could make that face."

...

“Minions, turn the balloon away. Let’s get the hell out of here *now*.”

“But chief—”

“Turn the damn balloon away!”

...

“Well, King Vainqueur, now that I have taken what you value most, why not make a deal? Return the Apple to me at once, and I will change your gold bac—”

Vainqueur’s sight turned bloody red.

**Attack Up! Attack Up! ATTACK UP! Fire Power Up!Warning:
[Berserk] ailment!**

“RAAAAAAARGH!”

Vainqueur instantly blasted a giant fireball at the lich, a projectile big enough that the few manlings who witnessed the attack in the past mistook it for a meteor. “[Teleportation].” The lich blinked out of the way before the fires could destroy him, the projectile hitting the crater’s edge and causing a large span of it to fall into the magma.

The lich reappeared nearby, observing the destruction with ominous silence. "In hindsight," he muttered to himself, "Maybe that was a mistake..."

In the ropes of berserk rage, Vainqueur blasted the entire area, castle and lich included, with fiery death. This time, Furibon was hit directly by a fireball, shattering his crimson shield and sending him flying through one of the castle's wall. One of the smaller towers collapsed on him.

Too angry to think, Vainqueur kept firing at the dungeon, melting the stone and blasting another tower into the magma. Immediately afterward a bright, yellow magical barrier surrounded the castle, shielding it from the dragon's repeated bombardment. The monsters in the magma cowered in fear.

Vainqueur furiously roared to the heavens, and the mountain trembled.

Chapter 14: Just your average Hometown

Holy hell... Victor thought as he watched the fireworks from the foot of the mountain. The crater above appeared in the middle of a fiery eruption, fireballs and clouds of rancid smoke flying out while the earth trembled.

While not religious at all, the adventurer prayed to the twelve gods that Vainqueur didn't start an actual eruption while rampaging. "Guys..."

"Chief..." Red and the other kobolds cowered at the sight, hiding behind the hill of lead Vainqueur's hoard had turned into.

"I think it would be best never to mention the *event* ever again around Vainqueur." The critters all nodded at once. "He will calm down *eventually*, but when he does, we will show our beloved dragon ruler full emotional support, and carefully avoid the word 'lead' until we die. This is for everyone's own good."

Victor glanced at the mess around him; he had managed to make a semi-respectable emergency landing without Vainqueur's support in the badlands, stashing the hoard there. Not that he thought anybody wanted to steal it now.

Maybe they should consider becoming plumber adventurers? It worked out for Mario.

"Chief, what do we do?" Blue asked him, terrified and looking for guidance.

“Right now... well, you have family here, right?” The critters nodded. “Go visit them, or practice your choreography. Take some time off.”

“But chief,” Pink protested, “We can’t abandon Master Vainqueur when he needs help!”

The ground trembled with another fiery detonation. Victor looked back at the mountain, noticing huge monsters fleeing the volcano. It appeared the local horrors had wisely decided to bolt the hell out of the region. One giant worm flew over the crater's edge, probably tossed out by Vainqueur.

How long did dragons rampage? Days? Or would he calm down if he managed to kill Furibon?

“Right,” Victor said. “Look, ‘Master Vainqueur’ is too furious to act rational, and he isn’t calming down anytime soon. Consider this a vacation. You earned it after all your good work so far.”

As the kobolds and kobones kept exchanging glances, Victor suddenly realized these professional minions had no concept of a vacation. They literally lived to serve bigger creatures and didn't understand life outside it.

“Okay, look, minions, I am giving you a secret mission. Do you remember Vainqueur’s glorious vision about V&V?” Merely mentioning the name gave him cancer. “You said the local minion job market is crowded, and His Majesty has a shortage of them. So, fetch us more minions.”

“Chief, are...” They looked about to cry, even the undead ones. “Are you replacing us?”

“No, in fact, you are now no longer interns, nor even new minions, but *minion lieutenants*,” Victor improvised. “You will be the admins serving under me, but above new minions. The *elite* of our adventurer guild.”

“We... we’ve been promoted!” The tears quickly turned to joy, with Red outright jumping on place. “Promoted!”

“So go find more interns.” Victor made a dramatic gesture. “They will be your responsibility though, so accept only the best.”

“Yes, chief!” They bolted off so fast, Victor’s eyes could barely follow them.

Truth to be told, Victor actually started to enjoy leading minions around. He mostly blamed it on Stockholm Syndrome and Vainqueur rubbing off on him the wrong way, but it felt nice to be obeyed, rather than obeying.

Damn, he was turning into a dragon.

That, and after that stunt with the duchess, Victor was all but trapped with Vainqueur. Without the dragon's protection, he would no longer be able to set foot in Gardemagne without being executed. More minions meant less people likely to pick a fight with him.

Now alone, Victor decided to visit the one village around, in case he could buy supplies. He was aware of the minions’ warnings about the place, but he could probably handle it on his own if he was careful.

From afar, it appeared the town had less than two hundred people living there. It was a small farming community, with Victor recognizing olive, citrus, and stranger fruits orchards, even a vineyard. The large stone houses could accommodate entire extended families, reminding Victor of American ranches.

Also, he noticed that they had a lot more sheep than they should need.

Besides these details and the pervasive scent of dogs, even if he couldn't see any, the village seemed relatively normal. Victor approached it warily, and two locals immediately came to greet him.

The two looked like a couple of ranch hillbillies, one male in his late twenties and a girl a bit younger than Victor himself. Both were brown-skinned, with eyes of the same color, and similar enough that Victor assumed they must have been part of the same family.

"Hi there, traveler," the man spoke up. Powerfully built, with a mane of black hair and dirty, rancher clothes, he looked straight out of a Clint Eastwood Western. "I'm Croissant and this is my sister, Chocolatine. Welcome to Murmurin."

"Hello, handsome," said the girl, a pretty creature with semi-long coffee hair and dressed like Little Red Riding Hood, "You're an adventurer coming to hunt the dragon, right? Right?"

Victor had the strange feeling a lot of eyes were observing him. "Hunt the dragon?"

Croissant pointed a finger at the volcano. "A dragon just made its lair in our mountain and is frightening the livestock. If you could kill it, that would help us a lot."

"No, I'm a lead merchant," Victor deadpanned.

"Lead?" Croissant repeated, confused.

"Lead. I love lead. Are you all vampires?"

"What? Of course not! Vampires are vile, tasteless things! Nobody likes them!" Tasteless... odd choice of words. "Why the sudden accusations, stranger?"

"My Kobolds interns told me of bad moon mojo around here, and you're a creepy village in the middle of nowhere. I've watched movies, and I can defend myself."

Victor suddenly realized that wording made no sense, but the duo seemed to understand. More and more suspicious, the adventurer decided to use [Monster Insight] on them, just in case.

Croissant

Werewolf (Humanoid/Beast)

Strong against Moon, Beast, Madness and Fairy effects.

Weak against Silver, Manslayer, and Beastslayer effects.

Older brother of Chocolatine, and a werewolf; can turn into a giant wolf-hybrid at will, but goes berserk during the full moon. Kind of rough around the edges, especially if you mention Gevaudan. Oh man, you are so BEEPED if you mention Gevaudan. Almost as BEEPED as if you BEEP his sister.

Chocolatine

Werewolf (Humanoid/Beast)

Strong against Moon, Beast, Madness and Fairy effects.

Weak against Silver, Manslayer, and Beastslayer effects.

Pretty little riding hood, foe to all grandmothers everywhere, and sister of Croissant. A priestess of the beast god Isengrim, she looks sweet and innocent while being anything but. Finds you very appetizing due to your big charisma boost, and wonders whether she should cook you with a stew or with pepper sauce.

“Ah, werewolves! Bad moon, of course you would be werewolves.”

“Wait, are you...” Croissant trailed, before turning to his sister. “Is he one of us?”

Chocolate said a few words, apparently casting a spell on Victor. She smiled happily at once. “It’s okay, brother, he’s a monster, too! A Humanoid/Dragon Type!”

“Oh by the Moon Man, for a second I thought you were a homeless person nobody would miss,” said Croissant, horrified. “We avoided a terrible mistake. I’m so sorry.”

What the— “You were going to kill me?”

“Not *us*,” Croissant shrugged. “Some of the villagers often feed strangers to the Moon Man’s eldritch children, and they think the dragon is punishment

for being late with the current sacrifice. I do not condone it, but we are an open-minded community, you know? I hope you can forgive us for the misunderstanding.”

Of course! It made Victor feel so much better!

“Guys, it’s okay!” Croissant shouted in the settlement's direction. “He’s a monster, too! You can drop the disguises!”

Victor heard sighs of relief, and watched, astonished, as the locals exited their houses.

Half of them looked human enough, although [Monster Insight] informed him most of them were werewolves or shapeshifters, like Doppelgangers; the other half, not so much. Victor noticed a large family of pallid ghouls, a squid-human hybrid with a calmar-like head, a rusty steel golem, and two dozen other creatures straight out of a bestiary.

The entire village was populated with humanoid-looking monsters.

Victor blinked, as he recognized a familiar figure among them, a tall Lizardkin with sandy scales, sharp fangs, and long claws. The humanoid lizard had short back swept horns and a barbed tail, but kept most of her powerfully built body beneath brown and green traveler robes. As usual, she carried a sash full of potions and various spices, and had the Nightblades’ black sword tattoo on the left side of her face. “Savoureuse?” Victor called her. “Sav, is that you?”

“Vic?” The beast took a few steps out of the crowd to get a better view of him. Besides having tanned a little, she was exactly the same as in his memories, with those warm, green reptilian eyes. “Hey, Vic!”

“Hey, Sav!” Victor waved at her. She had briefly been his friend during his brief tenure as a professional thief, showing him the tricks of the trade.

“Long time to no see! What are you doing here?”

“Business.” She winked at him. “We’re discussing with the locals to set up a warehouse there, so the Nightblades’ guildmasters sent me.”

“Nice, sounds like a good vacation.”

“Aha, it’s good to take a break from waste collecting sometimes. Shame you left us, Vic, you were an excellent reposessor.”

Ah, the old naming conventions. ‘Repossession’ instead of theft, ‘waste-collecting’ for assassination, and ‘community contribution’ for extortion. No wonder Victor left the criminal syndicate the second he could get away with it.

“By the way Vic, why didn’t you tell me you were a dragon monster in disguise? I’m almost insulted you managed to hide it from me.”

“It’s a pretty recent change,” Victor replied. “So what is this, a secret humanoid monster community?”

“Yes and no, we disguise as humans to avoid inquisitors and adventurers who often wander in the region,” Croissant explained. “They always try to wipe us out otherwise.”

“So we kill them in their sleep first,” Chocolatine chirped with a sweet, happy smile that sent shivers down Victor’s spine.

“We also have something of a school for mimics and other shapeshifters, so they can learn to blend in within a safe, family-friendly environment,” said Croissant, before he moved to firmly shake Victor’s hand. “Victor, is that it? Nice to meet you, what kind of monster are you?”

“I’m a dragon’s chief of staff,” Victor explained, a few of the locals whistling.

“*That* dragon’s?” Croissant glanced at the volcano.

“Yeah. We came to take over the castle, but the current owner pulled a prank on my ‘master,’ who didn’t take it well.”

“Owner? Furibon? Even with no flesh anymore, he’s a giant dick.” Victor couldn’t help but laugh at Croissant’s stupid joke. The werewolf’s tone implied this wasn’t the first time the lich caused them trouble. “I heard he

was so annoying a fomor transformed him into a cave troll, before he turned himself into a lich. He leaves us mostly alone, so we do not bother him either, but he's very open to us supplying adventurers trying to challenge him."

"I think he's bored and lonely in his castle," Chocolatine said with a conspiratorial tone.

"So, Vic, it was true what I heard?" asked Savoureuse. "You fed the Duchess of Euskal to a dragon?"

"Did you?" Chocolatine had stars in her eyes.

"I..." Well... technically he *did* bullshit Vainqueur into hunting down the Scorchers instead of the Kraken, which indirectly led to that disaster. "You could say that..."

Croissant frowned. "That's a bit over the top, no?"

"I don't understand, Vic, have you left us, or have you not left us?" asked Savoureuse. "Because feeding a noble to a dragon is very Nightbladish to me."

"I guess my current job isn't that different from the old one," Victor admitted.

"Anyway," Croissant butted in. "We're happy to welcome you to our community. How long will you stay?"

"I dunno, as long as the dragon stays here. Maybe longer." If Vainqueur did kill Furibon and managed to claim the promised reward, then they might settle in the region. "Why that question?"

"Eh, they're a small community, and they want more people to avoid inbreeding," Savoureuse replied. "They have a nice open door policy for newcomers. Isn't that right, Croissant?"

"Yeah, we're recent settlers, too. We used to live in the Woods of Gevaudan, in Gardemagne. Ah, times were good. Best hunting grounds we

ever had, so much food around.”

The woods of...

“But that was before some dumbass human and their pet red dragon burned it to the ground while hunting trol—”

Croissant stopped mid-sentence, then glared suspiciously at Victor.

Uh oh.

Chapter 15: Cult Management

This world sucked!

The locals had bound Victor to an olive tree with heavy chains under the faint moonlight. Around twenty werewolves had gathered to observe the sacrifice, while a squid-like humanoid held the ceremony, chittering incantations while wielding a scepter. Victor guessed the Moon Man worshippers were a relative minority in the community.

Unfortunately, the majority had given Victor the silent treatment.

“Brother, is that smart?” Chocolatine asked her brother, one of the few who did argue against the adventurer’s capture. “He is the dragon’s chief of staff, and that one is angry already...”

“He burnt our previous home, sis,” Croissant pointed out. Unlike his sister, he had shapeshifted in a monstrous, car-sized black wolf, glaring at Victor with seething hatred.

“Yes, which is why I don’t want him to burn our current one.”

“I’m sure Victor was just following orders,” Savoureuse tried to argue with the cultists, although that wasn’t the passionate defense Victor had hoped for. “Do not blame the follower, blame the leader.”

Croissant sneered back. “I asked the adventurer guild after the dragon devastated our home, and they confirmed the ‘human partner’ led the dragon in the first place.”

“But Vainqueur burned the forest on his own!” Victor protested.

“You still led him there!” Croissant snapped back.

“He burned my house!” another werewolf complained in the crowd.

“I watched all my livestock die!”

Savoureuse gave Victor a sympathetic gaze. “I’m sorry, Vic. I tried. I would have fought to release you if my life wasn't in danger.”

Victor shrugged. It was more than he expected.

The Moon Man’s priest finished the incantation, and a beam of light descended from the skies. With a brilliant flash, a horrible insult against nature manifested in front of Victor, a bus-sized hybrid of a dragon and a squid, with no eyes and only squirmy skin. Its countless tentacles thrashed around, tossing away some of the werewolf cultists.

The mere sight of the creature gave Victor a headache.

Charisma check successful! [**Madness**] negated!

The creature sounded no more happy to be here than Victor himself. “You *again!*” it shrieked with a shrilling, inhuman voice. “Why will you not *stop?*”

“Great Moon Beast!” the lead priest called, the other cultists bowing before the creature. Only Croissant, Chocolatine and Savoureuse remained still. “Your rancid glory honors us! Please, accept this sacrifice in atonement!”

The monster didn’t feel grateful. At all. “I do not understand the movements of your squishy tongue, skinbag, but I swear on the Moon Man, one day I will lose my self-control, and I will drip my pseudopods in the hole you use for excrement.”

“Mmm... sir,” Victor told the creature. “I would like to say that I am not complicit in this.”

The titan froze. “You speak r'lyehian, skinbag?”

R'lyehian? Victor figured his Perk had translated the words in the creature’s native tongue. “Well, yes I can understand you just fine.” The adventurer

blinked. “They can’t?”

“He can understand the Moon Beast without going mad?” the squid priest turned to Croissant, who shrugged his shoulders in confusion.

Victor guessed they lacked the Perk needed to discuss with the interstellar abomination. “Since you can also understand me,” the human told the creature. “Words can’t convey how unappetizing I am.”

“Why would I eat you? You don’t even have pseudopods. Eurgh... you moving gametes disgust me... your face is terrible, and you look like a cancer with these big, bulbous, disgusting... *eyes*...”

How did it even know Victor had eyes since it had none itself? “Yeah, having eyes is terrible, almost as much as being tied to a tree while being threatened with death.”

“I will tell you what is terrible, gamete creature. You are minding your own business, enjoying your once in an eon vacation, before the stars are right and you must go back to work, and you are *this*,” the abomination raised two tentacles, “*this* close to eating that tasty telepathic spider. Then, without warning, someone teleports you right as you have your food in your tendrils, then throws a screaming human whelp at you. And they do that. Every. Single. *Moon*! Wouldn’t *you* vent a little?”

When seeing things this way... That would explain why tentacled creatures always destroyed the world when summoned.

“Yes, but...” Victor trailed, glancing at the cultists and Croissant in particular, who couldn’t understand the Moon Beast’s half of the conversation. “Why at *me*, and not at *them*?”

The creature sighed. “The Moon Man is... absent-minded, so we have to take care of his cults. He already has so few of them, and while *stupid*, this one is devout. I wish they could just stop summon me all the time, though. I do not know where they got the idea that the Moon Man needs live sacrifices, but the idea spread everywhere.”

“I think they do that because they do not understand what you say, unlike me,” Victor replied. “I can clarify your needs to them, and make them stop.”

“You can make it stop?” The titan's tentacles wriggled and let out a sound that sounded dirty. “Oh, yes! *Yes!*”

“You’ve got to spare and free me first, though.”

“Yes, yes, anything it takes.” The titan’s tentacles surged towards the chains, breaking them without effort. Victor walked away from the tree, enjoying his newfound freedom, much to the amazement of the cultists, and Croissant’s frustration.

None were more than the leading priest. “He... the newcomer has been chosen by the Moon Beast as its mouthpiece!”

“It says...” Victor trailed, before frowning at the Moon Beast. “Actually, what is your name?”

“Thul-Gathar, gamete skinbag.”

“Thul-Gathar says moonly sacrifices are not needed to show your devotion to its progenitor.”

The cultists exchanged hushed whispers. “Then how can we serve the Moon Man?” asked the chief priest.

“They’re asking what they should replace the sacrifices with,” Victor translated.

“Tell them they must moonwalk until they collapse of exhaustion every full moon, then to eat their own fecal matter.”

“Seriously?”

“No, but that would have been funny,” the Moon Beast replied. “Tell them to pray to the Moon Man for insight, then to hold a quiet, private orgy under

the moonlight every full moon; narcotics are encouraged, but not necessary. Order them to stop summoning me, as I have other cults to guide.”

“Thul-Gathar says that you must pray the Moon Man for insight, while...” The cult listened to him with religious, rapturous attention, making Victor uneasy. “Having a drugged orgy every full moon.”

“Also, no more incest,” the Moon Beast clarified. “It is very important Father’s cults remain healthy and fertile. We allowed inbreeding long ago, and cults keep dying out because of it today.”

“Thul-Gathar explicitly forbids incest, which is an affront to the Moon Man.”

“Even cousins?” the priest asked.

“Are cousins allowed?” Victor transmitted the message.

The Moon Beast hesitated for a good minute, before coming with an answer. “Cousins are reluctantly forbidden, but in-laws are allowed in return.”

“Cousins are not allowed, but since blood is the only barrier to love, thou can lay with your in-laws. Finally, your repeated summonings prevent Thul-Gathar from guiding other civilizations to glory. It says that you have reached sufficient enlightenment to manage yourselves.”

“Ch'yar ul'nyar shaggornyth,” the cultists said all at once.

“Yes, yes, inbred gamete people,” Thul-Gathar answered dismissively, his flock unable to understand him. “Are we done?”

“Yes, I think they will behave from now on.”

“Then thank you, skinbag. Show me your hand, so that I may reward you for giving me peace.”

The Moon Beast touched Victor’s left arm with a tentacle, the moist contact sending shivers down his spine. The shining, white mark of a full moon, the

Moon Man's symbol, appeared on his skin.

Congratulations! You were granted a blessing by a star spawn of the Moon Man! You earned the [**Claimed by the Moon Man**] Personal Perk!

[**Claimed by the Moon Man**]: when you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance of gaining a Charisma point. You gain Immunity to Madness and Moon effects unless those caused by the Moon Man and his servants.

Nice! Finally, things turned around in his favor for once!

"Tell me, gamete animal, would you like a job?" the Moon Beast offered. "You can make a good mouthpiece to address the Moon Man's flock, and I have been looking for a chief of staff to lead my minions."

A chief of staff? Here we go again. "I am already taken, sir."

"You are?" The creature hummed at Victor. "A dragon's scent? You serve a dragon?"

"Unfortunately, yes."

"Look, carbon-based mammal, dragons are prestigious, but they underpay their minions." Like it wouldn't believe. "If you serve me, you will be swimming in pearls and seashells by the next moon. As my chief of staff, you will also have unrestricted breeding privileges, including ignoring the incest restriction. You can keep your tendrils in your family."

It was official, the creature was officially trying to bribe him. Victor pondered the offer, the idea of managing a fertility cult appealing to him.

But considering how Vainqueur had reacted when he thought Victor had left him for a wyvern, and that he would be in a cranky mood for a while... "I am very flattered," said Victor. "But my dragon is very insecure about me leaving him, too, so I am not tempting his wrath. I also kind of like the other minions."

“Your funeral,” the Moon Beast replied. “If you change your mind, visit me on the moon.”

“But thank you, I am honored by your proposal,” Victor said politely, in case the creature could hold a grudge. He turned to the cultists. “Also... what am I to do with them?”

“BEEP them.” The Moon Beast vanished in another flash of light, clearly in a hurry to leave the place behind.

Congratulations! For resisting the temptation to cheat on your dragon master with a Moon Beast, proving your faithfulness, and for serving as a bridge between monster lords and their flock, you have earned **two** levels in **[Monster Squire]!**

+60 HP, +10SP, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You earned the **[Rally Minions]** Class Perk!

[Rally Minions]: By uttering a strong authority statement, such as “*Die to them, or die to me,*” you can increase all the stats of your minions for a short duration.

“Nice work,” Savoureuse congratulated Victor, “I didn’t understand half of what it said, but you handled it like a champ.”

Victor shrugged. He had the feeling he had done the best he...

Wait.

Wait, wait! Victor hadn’t asked the creature if it could send him back to Earth!

“I guess I will have to eat him myself,” Croissant said, showing his fangs, only for the priest of the Moon Man to block his path with his scepter.

“You will not lay a fang on a prophet of our god, Croissant!” The priest turned back to Victor. “Please, chosen Victor, what was the final revelation? What are you to do with us?”

... do not abuse your power, Victor. Do not abuse your power, don't abuse the power.

Abuse the power. "Thul-Gathar asked me to—"

Before Victor could make his unreasonable demand, a powerful shadow obscured the moonlight, followed by a familiar sound.

"MINION!"

Everyone trembled, as Vainqueur landed in the field with a loud crash, his landing blowing off dust. "Minion! There you are! Stop daydreaming, and tell me where is my hoard! Is it safe? Is it cured?"

Victor sighed, his vacation was very short-lived. He already regretted not taking the Moon Beast's offer. "I put it where you wanted, Your Majesty, but no, it is not *'cured.'*"

"As I feared," Vainqueur fumed, his golden eyes falling upon the gathered villagers, the fire in his gaze making them step back. "What are they, new minions?"

"They're survivors from the Woods of Gevaudan, which Your Majesty burned."

"Yes, we are." To his credit, Croissant had enough courage to stand up to Vainqueur. "You burned our home."

"Then you will apologize to me at once, wolfling."

Croissant glared back at the dragon, aghast. "Why would we apologize to *you*?"

"If you had not survived, I would have gained more treasure," Vainqueur replied. "So your survival cost me. You will *all* apologize by becoming my new minions. Now, there is a great reward for doing as I wish. Namely, living. Any other dragon would have eaten you all for your sinful crime, and would never have taken werewolves in their service, but I am forgiving and merciful."

Victor had terrible flashbacks at the wording, which he blamed on Post Vainqueur Stress Disorder. The more Croissant listened, the more incredulous he looked. "You cannot expect—"

"I am a dragon. A dragon who never ate a wolf before, and you are starting to sound like food. Minion Victor, is that wolf food?"

"That depends," Victor looked at Croissant dead in the eyes. "Are you dragon food, Croissant?"

The wolf looked at Victor, then at Vainqueur, realized that he was twenty times smaller, then glared at Victor again. "I am starting to realize that the 'just following orders' excuse may be valid," he grumbled.

"You're goddamn right," Victor replied, a bit too happy to rub it in the wolf's face.

Croissant looked at the rest of the villagers, none of them willing to take a stand. And then, proving himself far smarter than every noble in Gardemagne, he decided to cut his losses after a glance at his sister. "I apologize to both of you," the werewolf said, forcing himself to say every word. "Just don't eat us."

"Not unless you run out of sheep," Vainqueur replied, the villagers looking at one another. The dragon lost interest in the wolf pack, turning to Victor. "Minion, I must become a wizard."

"A wizard, Your Majesty?"

"The lich does not stay dead when I kill him, and now hides in his castle like a coward. You said he hides his soul in an item, which makes it immortal."

"His phylactery, which is probably hidden in the castle, yes." Victor started realizing where the dragon was going.

"I cannot break the magical barrier protecting it nor cure my hoard, so I must become a wizard to do so," Vainqueur explained. "We must destroy

the great evil that is Furibon, Minion Victor. This is no longer about wealth, minion. This is about all dragons, all hoards, present, and future. Furibon is the greatest threat to the dragon way of life since the Gold-Eating Insects.”

“There are insects that eat gold?” Victor asked, wondered how that even worked.

“There *were*,” Vainqueur said with an ominous tone. “I was overconfident, thinking being an adventurer was all about increasing the size of my hoard. I now realize that I was blind to the danger ahead. There are threats to all hoards hiding in the darkest corners of the world, and I must destroy them.”

Victor said nothing, astonished by Vainqueur’s passionate speech.

“Furibon is evil incarnate, a cruel, heartless monster who delights in taking all that brings worth to the world and turning it to *lead*. Imagine if he spreads that spell outside of this castle? Imagine a world without gold?” Vainqueur marked a short, rhetorical pause. “You cannot, manling, and neither can I! Because only a twisted monster like Furibon could imagine it! He is evil, and he has to be *stopped*. So we will break the magical barrier, clear that dungeon and destroy the lich for good. Even if it takes us a thousand years!”

They were all doomed.

Vainqueur had started behaving like a true adventurer.

Chapter 16: Vainqueur's Private War

Sitting amidst an orchard and a pen whom he had emptied of its sheep, Vainqueur glared at Murmurin's volcano, a dark, fuming place even under the bright sunlight.

What kind of atrocity the lich was planning deep in his dungeon? How long before he spread knowledge of this dark, horrifying spell to the outside world? Vainqueur seethed at the thought, simmering with anger.

Although he heard Manling Victor and the new werewolves minions approach, Vainqueur didn't even bother glancing at him, entirely focused on the mountain. "Your Majesty?" minion Victor called. "Your Majesty, are you alright?"

"Where are the kobolds?" Vainqueur asked.

"I sent them to recruit new minions."

Good. More fodder to throw at the lich. "Minion Victor, you are now my military advisor," Vainqueur told him, "I would have promoted you to general, but command of this operation is too important to delegate. I will oversee the war against Furibon myself."

"The war, Your Majesty?"

"Yes, minion, *war*. This is war, against an enemy willing to cross any line into depravity. So you will gather all information about this dungeon, every trap, and every defender, every way to break this magical barrier, every way to return my hoard to normal, and then you will give me strategies to

validate. You will also research ways for me to become a wizard stronger than Furibon, who is evil and must be destroyed.”

“Dragons can be wizards?” Croissant asked.

“Dragons can be *anything*,” Vainqueur clarified.

“I can’t believe I’m saying this…” Manling Victor hesitated. “But Your Majesty’s choice of taking levels in the [Wizard] class will be very suboptimal. Let alone the fact it will take you at least fifty years of study to become anywhere near Furibon’s level.”

“Fifty years is the length of a nap to me,” Vainqueur clarified, resolute in his choice. “I told you, minion, that I would destroy that lich, even if it takes me centuries.”

“Yes, but wouldn’t it be faster and easier to just recruit a professional wizard? I already asked Savoureuse for her contacts, and that way I would live long enough to see the lich defeated.”

“Your Lizardkin ally Savoureuse may be of use, and look reptilian enough to please me,” Vainqueur agreed, happy the minion shared his resolve. “But I can smell she serves another monster lord, and I will not rely on another’s minion to win this battle.”

“You remember her?” The minion seemed shocked. “Holy… Your Majesty is *not* fine.”

“A dragon is not poor, Manling Victor,” Vainqueur told his chief of staff. “My gold is sick, and so I am. Only gold and revenge against Furibon, who is evil and must be destroyed, can cure me.”

“Technically sir, only your gold is ‘sick,’ the silver, jewels, and magical items are fine. So the hoard is not totally gone, most of your assets are just… frozen.”

“A dragon’s hoard must have gold in it!” Vainqueur replied angrily. “Or it is not shiny enough!”

Having no hoard worth bragging about was a fate worse than death to Vainqueur, and he refused to suffer through it.

“I’m just... you’re being so intense and serious about it, Your Majesty, it’s scaring me a little.”

“Furibon took everything that was precious to me!” Vainqueur ranted, the strength of his booming words making Victor fall on his ass. “I am the great calamity of this age! I am the apex creature! No one mocks me and lives! My reputation will be in tatters if word of his cruelty spreads! So if I cannot blast his fortress the proper dragon way, then I will do whatever it takes to *destroy* him!”

Furibon had made Vainqueur feel like a *pauper*, and for that, he had to die. Or become deader.

Vainqueur would also learn how to break that curse of lead, in case another Furibon rose up after he had destroyed the current one.

“Your Majesty, I have thought about the problem, and if I may, I think there is an easier solution than working years on becoming a wizard.” Manling Victor rose back up. “There is a spellcaster-class called [Witch Hunter], which specializes in killing spellcasters and demon worshippers, and they learn exorcisms highly effective against both. With enough levels in it and Charisma points, you should be able to break the barrier.”

While Vainqueur stubbornly sought to cover his rear with magic, the idea of a class dedicated to destroying Furibon’s kind appealed to him. “What has my natural charisma to do with canceling a barrier?”

“The potency of [Witch Hunter] Perks is based on Charisma, and from what I gathered Dragons have lots of it. Must be the scaly charm.”

It suddenly occurred to Vainqueur that he never cared about what those points did. He stopped looking at the mountain, focusing intently on Victor.

As expected of his chief of staff, Minion Victor explained without Vainqueur having to ask. “Health Points represent your life force, health,

and longevity. The more of them, the longer you live and the slower you age. Special Points power magical abilities. Strength is strength, Vitality increases your constitution and endurance. Skill handles your dexterity and skillfulness; Agility represents speed and reflexes. Intelligence is intelligence. Charisma influences willpower and charm. The more you have it, the more you get laid. Finally, the more Luck, the more randomness favors you.”

“So the higher the Charisma, the more willpower I have?”

“It also improves the use of certain spells and abilities. Since it represents willpower, [Witch Hunters] can use their Charisma to dispel magic or rain holy judgment on their enemies.”

Vainqueur checked his current stats. “Menu.”

Vainqueur Knightsbane

Level: 14 (Noble 8/Gladiator 6)

Type: Dragon.

Party: V&V.

Health Points

5,615

Special Points 1320 Strength 109 Vitality 89 Skill 20 Agility 47 Intelligence 14 Charisma 79 Luck 48

Personal PerksClass Perks Dragonfire Breath Old Money Fire Immunity Snobbery Red Dragon Lifeforce Nobless Oblige Dragon Arrogance Aristoradar Dragonscale Crowd Favorite Super Senses Supercrit Virgin Princess Radar Lesser Poison Resistance Deadfriend Taunt

“My Charisma is seventy-nine, Minion.”

“Seventy-nine?” Croissant almost choked.

So did Manling Victor. “That’s three times more than me!”

“Yes, yes, minions, everybody loves me,” Vainqueur replied dismissively. “It should be more than enough to break the barrier, then.”

“Well, you must burn an arcane spellcaster to get the class, like a witch or another lich. Demons also work.”

“I have the burning part covered,” Vainqueur replied. “Fetch me a witch. Any witch. It is not enough that I destroy Furibon, who is pure evil and has to be destroyed. Anything that looks like that cursed creature will burn in the fires of my wrath!”

“Furibon Delenda Est,” Minion Victor spoke a foreign language as if it made him sound more intelligent. “But we don’t have many liches or spellcasters available.”

“That’s not true, we have a dryad drui-” Croissant put his hand on sweet Chocolatine’s mouth before she could finish.

“It is easy to take levels in class before reaching level twenty, from what you manlings told me,” Vainqueur said, formulating a plan at once. “I awakened the proud [Noble] class simply by learning I could take levels. Gaining access to [Witch Hunter] should be quick, even without a witch on hands to burn.”

Minion Victor stayed silent for a moment, before making a face and asking, “Your Majesty, what is your intelligence stat?”

“Fourteen, and I started at nine!” Vainqueur said proudly, assuming the Manling started at one.

“I’m just scared of what Your Majesty will achieve with more points.”

“Oh, I have a great idea!” said Chocolatine with a gleeful smile, after pushing her brother’s hand away. “Why not summon demons as practice dummies?”

“Summon demons?” Victor turned to her, appalled.

“Yes! Since there is no witch nearby, we just summon demons! Demon witches, and you *murder* them, and we harvest the body parts.”

“Chocolatine, I already told you no,” Croissant told his sister. “We’re not sacrificing sheep to summon demons and then kill them. This is too dangerous, even if we summon only lesser fiends.”

“But we would get more meat that way! And Rolo said he wanted fertilizer for the farms...”

Vainqueur listened with attention, smelling an opportunity. “Minion Victor, could I gain [Witch Hunter] levels out of this?”

“You can gain [Witch Hunter] levels by burning demons, or people possessed by demons, yes,” Victor said, scratching the back of his head in embarrassment. “You would think they had some kind of fire resistance, though, seeing where they come from.”

“To your puny fire maybe, but not my dragonfire!” Vainqueur boasted.

“Some are immune to it, but we can summon those who aren’t,” said Chocolatine.

“Yes, but... summon demons just to kill them?” Victor grumbled, too pessimistic to see the golden opportunity. “I dunno, it sounds like prank calling Hell. No way it’s not going to backfire somehow, right?”

“Minion Victor, how can you not see the potential?” Vainqueur chastised his lackey. “That way, we can both gain quick levels, minion. I kill the demons, then you revive them as undead, and then I kill them again. This will double my experience, and I gain treasure both times!”

“Your Majesty wants me to turn demons into undead so he can kill them *all over again*?”

“You will also let the demons use their Perks on you whenever possible, in case you can learn them.”

Minion Victor’s skin turned pale. “I would rather not—”

“That’s a great idea!” Croissant complimented Vainqueur’s choice, Manling Victor sending him a fierce glare. The werewolf answered with a smirk.

“It’s okay, Victor, I can cure you,” said Chocolatine with a cheery smile. “So long as you are not dead, I cast a spell and zap, you’re fine again!”

“Is your god even okay with this scheme?” Victor asked Chocolatine. “I thought Isengrim was one of the nicest deities.”

“Of course he is! Commandment Seven: *you shall respect the hunt. Hunt to feed, or to thin the herd, but never for profit or pleasure, and never to extinction. Except demons and undead. Demons and undead can be hunted for pleasure, for profit, and to be made extinct.*”

“As far as divine declarations go, it's pretty direct.”

“Minion, while I never felt it, I understand that pain hurts for your kind,” Vainqueur reassured his lackey, “But this is *war*. War calls for sacrifices, and sweat, and tears. For the sake of my hoard, you cannot fail, and so you will do whatever it takes to become the best chief of staff you can be.”

Minion Victor said nothing, lowered his eyes, then raised them back. Vainqueur noticed a change in his gaze, a gleam that wasn’t there before.

The spark of a dragon’s greed.

“Alright, Your Majesty, but, can I ask you a request? Can I keep the undead instead of having you destroying them again? I’m not sure you will gain experience, and I could use them as minions.”

“Oh, and you can always sell them afterward for me,” Vainqueur caught on. “Good idea minion.”

“That’s the spirit,” Minion Victor said with an ominous tone.

And so, for the first time in his immortal life, Vainqueur began to train seriously.

Using a knife, Chocolatine sacrificed a lamb, then drew a circle of blood around the cattle outside the village. She began to recite incantations, the circle shining bright with unholy light. "[Summon Lesser Demon!]"

As she finished her prayer, a creature manifested inside the circle, a manling-sized goat with wings and wielding a fork. "Hell's Witch Customer Service, what can I do for you? Is it to sell your soul for magical powers, or some other..." The fiend stopped, looking up to Vainqueur. "What the Heaven is—"

Vainqueur lightly blasted him with a fireball.

The explosion tore the fiend in half, sending the remains fly a few meters away from the impact; the sacrificed sheep was entirely vaporized.

Argh, he had wasted the food! Vainqueur decided to breath lighter next time, since demons looked very fragile.

Congratulations! Through your sheer hatred of a spellcaster, burning of a foul fiend at the stakes, and your inclination to solve every problem with fire, you earned a level in the **[Witch Hunter]** class!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 VIT, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You earned the **[Spell Purge]** Class Perk!

[Spell Purge]: By exhausting one SP per second, you can radiate a field of antimagic energy which automatically cancel any spell in its range, including yours; your Charisma must be higher than the spell's effective level (Spell Tier + Main Stat Value of the Spellcaster at the time of casting) to cancel it. You can activate and deactivate Spell Purge at will.

Vainqueur's mood improved when two treasures appeared on the spot where the fiend had fallen. [Crowd Favorite] and [Old Money] had both activated!

At this rate, he could rebuild his hoard within the month.

“I am so going to hell for this...” Victor said, as he put back both halves of the fiend together and raised it as a soulless zombie. “But it’s going to be worth it.”

Vainqueur suddenly realized they forgot to train his minion first. “Manling Victor, next time, you stand in the middle of the circle. Do not forget to let them use their abilities first, then get out of the way so I can burn them. Chocolatine, bring another sheep.”

“Can you leave a bit more meat next time, Your Majesty?” Chocolatine asked, disappointed by the experiment’s result. “I really want to cook a demon’s heart with beans.”

Chapter 17: Job Interviews

“Wait, wait, don’t kill me, don’t kil—”

Vainqueur poked his hundredth demon in a row, a monstrous rat the size of a manling, crushing it between his claw and the ground below. Like an insect, the creature died without making a sound.

Nothing. No level, and no treasure.

With a growl of disappointment, Vainqueur tossed the corpse on the pile of demon meat which had yet to be turned into undead. “I am out of sheep, Your Majesty,” Chocolatine informed him, who stood next to a second, bigger pile of slain cattle. “Do we move to pigs or children?”

“No,” Vainqueur replied, bored to death. Even his chief of staff had asked for a break after the eightieth, and the dragon started to understand why. He couldn't take the tediousness of the process anymore.

Level grinding was no fun at all.

As if reading his master’s mind, Manling Victor joined them, carrying papers under his arm. “Is Your Majesty done bullying Satan?”

“Minion, I cannot get that eleventh level of [Witch Hunter]!” Vainqueur complained while Chocolatine left to feed some demon corpses to her remaining cattle. “Is the system broken?”

“Your Majesty, I told you, the greater your level, the more you receive an experience penalty to gain a new one. Repeating the same activity over and over by killing weaker opponents is good before level twenty, but afterward, the system rewards fighting opponents who can fight back.”

“So I am stuck at level ten in [Witch Hunter] until I destroy Furibon, who is evil and must be destroyed.”

“Pretty much.” His class manager read the documents Manling Henry had once given him on class progression. “Okay let see your new Perks so far... [Spell Purge]... [Witch Burning], your fire attacks bypass magical resistance and inflict additional holy damage, so your breath should be doubly effective against undead like Furibon. [Lesser Magic Resistance], meaning you can shrug off weaker spells. [Exorcism I] allows you to learn and cast Tier I exorcisms, and [Hunter’s Resolve] gives you a bonus against attempts to control your mind.”

“The Exorcism Perk does nothing,” Vainqueur complained.

“Spells or spell-like effects are organized into tiers of power, from one to ten. You do not gain access to them automatically, though; the Perk only allows the owner to learn and cast them. At this point, Your Majesty is the ultimate anti-magic tank.”

“What is a tank?” It sounded awesome.

“It means nobody hits harder than Your Majesty,” Manling Victor flattered him, before whistling at the pile of treasures Vainqueur obtained from his training. “So the next item on your war agenda is the recruitment of new minions. Is Your Majesty sure they want to deal with it personally? You sounded okay with me recruiting the kobolds on my own.”

“This is different, Minion Victor. We are not hunting weaklings, but Furibon, who is evil and must be destroyed.”

“Is Your Majesty going to repeat that every time they mention him?”

“Yes, minion, because this is *war* and everyone must know!” Vainqueur sat and observed the line of applicants waiting outside the orchard, mostly kobolds, but also other unique monsters.

“In total,” said Victor, “We have one hundred kobolds applicants. I also ordered Croissant to send us inhabitants with class levels above twenty,

which include a troll, a dryad, and a golem. Does that cause His Majesty problems?”

“Minion, I do not discriminate. All creatures are equally inferior to me. I will always fight for the right of everyone to become my emergency food.”

“Your Majesty is truly ahead of their time.”

“Of course, since I am a dragon.” Vainqueur turned to the applicants, clearing his throat to make an announcement. “V&V is more than an adventurer company! You are part of my treasures! Do you shine enough to be part of my hoard? Do you have what it takes to become a true minion?”

“He’s looking at us!” One of the kobolds chirped to the rest of its warren, led by Red.

“Quick, lower your spine in obedience!” Red forced the animal down. “Please excuse my cousin, Your Majesty.”

Ah, yes, *minion nepotism*. An insidious slippery slope leading to complete lack of discipline. However, since kobolds had been helpful and zealous so far, Vainqueur decided to examine them first. “You will be interviewed as a set,” Vainqueur said, who couldn’t be bothered to check every one of them individually.

“Rangers!” Red called, the Kobold rangers adopting a pose. “After the chief promoted us as minion lieutenants, we gathered every able-bodied kobold we could find!”

“Minion Victor, you promoted them on your own?”

“Uh, yes, I did. Is that a problem?”

“No, no, I am proud of your initiative. You acted like a true chief of staff.” Vainqueur had so many offices to assign. “When I remember the day you begged me to become my minion, back when you were but a purposeless thief adrift, I am amazed by your growth.”

The minion glanced at him with his big eyes. “Your Majesty, that is not how I remember our meeting.”

“Then you know to trust my version, which is now the official one,” Vainqueur focused on the new recruits. “V&V only recruits the best of the best. Are these kobolds battle-tested?”

“Not yet, Your Majesty, so we made them interns,” Blue said. “Unpaid interns.”

“I am so proud,” Manling Victor said.

“Then they will be on probation, and the responsibility of the Kobold Rangers,” Vainqueur agreed. “While they will be too weak to fight Furibon, they can help carry the treasures we find.”

“You heard that?” Black turned to the other kobolds. “You are all interns!”

The kobolds cried in joy, some hugged one another, and one collapsed due to a heart attack. Vainqueur dismissed them. “Next.”

“Next is the dryad and the steel golem. Apparently, they come as a set.”

“No,” Vainqueur decided immediately. “Steel golems are not minion material.”

“What? Your Majesty, why not? They’re super strong!”

“Minion Victor, have you considered the logistic?” Vainqueur chastised his chief of staff. “We cannot eat it if we are out of food.”

“But he could hunt it for us, then!”

Vainqueur frowned. “Only if the dryad is fat enough for two, then.”

The two candidates walked towards Vainqueur. The golem looked like an armored knight two heads taller than the average manling. Its steel armor had rusted, and it wore an old straw hat and a bag of grains. The dryad was like the rest of her kind: a tasty, green-skinned humanoid looking exactly

like a manling, with fully black eyes and long black hair. She hid her legs beneath a robe of flowers and vines while leaving the top exposed. Vainqueur found her a bit too thin, but she seemed appetizing.

“You’re olive-skinned,” said the minion, distracted by the female’s mammaries. “Like an actual olive.”

The tasty dryad glared at him. “Do you have something against colored people?”

“No, no, of course not! Some of my best friends have colored scales! It’s just... it’s a fantasy land, I haven’t seen any non-white, non-furry humanoid since I left the United States.”

“United States?” The dryad’s eyes widened in recognition. “Where? New York?”

Minion Victor’s eyes widened. “You too were reincarnated—”

“—in that other world?” she finished the sentence at the same time, both smiling at the other. “Although not as a human. Can’t complain though, this body is way better. I lucked out.”

“Yeah, I heard an unlucky claimed became a slime.” Since the minion seemed familiar with the creature, Vainqueur let him take over the interview. “Where do you come from?”

“Morocco, but I’m half-Spanish on my mom’s side. You’re a ‘Murrican, aren’t ya?”

“Chicago boy all the way.” Minion Victor showed up his sleeve, revealing dice and moon tattoos on his skin. The dryad responded by pointing a mark on the back of her neck, representing a spiral-shaped flower. “Oh, that’s the brand of Cybele right? The sex and fertility goddess?”

“Ah, yes, because that’s the *only* thing people pay attention to with her. She also the goddess of forest and knowledge, you know? She’s very wise and ancient.”

“Sorry, I’m not too religious. Especially since people here worship a human abducting dice or a tentacled horror. Still, you sound pretty happy with your own claimer.”

“I am. I was gonna die a very dumb death, and this marvelous goddess appears to me and says, ‘Allison, would you like to live again and restore the land?’ How could I refuse?”

“She appeared to you directly instead of just branding and throwing you aside?”

“I’m here to help Rolo with his farming project.” The dryad gave the golem a pat on the back, “He had been praying to Cybele for someone to maintain him while he continues farming, and I was an auto-engineer on Earth. Golems aren’t like cars, but I manage. No more nine to five desk job. Anyway, I renamed myself Lys here, because it sounds cool, but my true name is Allison. You can just call me Al.”

That made too many names. Vainqueur subtracted her some points.

“Enchanted, I’m Victor,” the minion replied while showing his bright teeth to the female. Unfortunately, his desire to breed led him astray. “I thought golems weren’t self-aware?”

“One percent of them wake up with free-will. Rolo is one of those. Since he has a soul, he even has class levels. Sixty-seven, all [Farmer].”

“Really?” Victor blinked. “That’s the highest level [Farmer] I’ve ever met. He has more levels than the Shining Knight!”

“Rolo refuses to take levels in anything but [Farmer],” the dryad clarified. “At least until his goal is realized.”

“I, Rolo, have a dream!” the golem farmer pumped a fist. “To see the red desert green again!”

“So I remembered right, the area used to be greener,” Vainqueur rejoiced.

“It was, before the Sablaris dried out the region,” the golem said, its voice brimming with anger.

“The Sablawhat?” Vainqueur repeated.

“The Sablaris were a dark elf empire ruling most of the southern continent, Ishfania, and Barin,” Alison said. “Cultists of Sablar the destroyer eventually took it over, hence the name; to hasten their patron’s goal of universal entropy, they caused a magical cataclysm that turned their entire empire into a red desert. Brandon Maure, the bastard of a demon lord and a dark elf, then took over the ruins of Ishfania with summoned monsters.”

Vainqueur noticed he could listen to long monologues without being bored now. Was it the result of new intelligence points? “Since you’re from Earth too,” Allison continued. “Did DiCaprio win an academy award at last?”

“Yes, but not for the Wolf of Wall Street.” The dryad seemed disappointed. “I know, I think they gave him a consolation prize after that movie.”

“Maybe I should move to that world’s North America and open a better Hollywood then. That’s *unjust*.”

“That world’s North America?” the minion picked up.

“You haven’t looked at a full map of the Mistral continent?”

"Only that of Gardemagne's southern regions."

Noticing Manling Victor’s embarrassment, tasty Allison cast a spell, vines growing out of the ground and forming a map with names whom Vainqueur didn’t recognize.

“That looks like a rough map of Europe with the countries’ frontiers all wroooooong...” the minion suddenly left the word hanging, as if reaching a realization. “No way...”

“Outremonde is a magical mirror of Earth,” said Alison, “With pretty big differences. I mean, they have an Atlantis-like island in the Atlantic Ocean, Malta is flying, and the—”

“Minion,” Vainqueur put back the interview on track, “We are here to discuss their future as meat shields, not friendly chit-chat.”

“Yes, yes, Your Majesty. What is your level, Allison?”

“Twenty-four, mostly [Druid] and [Vestal].”

“Nice. You can serve as a healer while we storm the dungeon.”

“Storm the dungeon?” the tasty creature frowned. “As a dryad, I cannot physically leave a mile away from my orchard without dying.”

So she couldn’t leave the village. That settled it. “You are both fired,” Vainqueur immediately ‘congratulated’ the golem-dryad duo.

“You did not employ us,” Alison countered.

“You are still fired. You are no longer emergency food. Now you are just food.”

The two wisely decided not to linger any longer. “Before you go,” Victor asked sweet Alison. “Do you want to have a drink somewhere?”

“Only if it's on you,” she replied while showing her teeth, the vine map vanishing behind her.

The minion watched the two leave while looking at the female’s behind. “Minion,” Vainqueur sighed. “You should ask her to breed and get on with it.”

The minion’s face turned red. “It worked last time, but I think it’s a bit too early there.”

“Minion, if you want to put your eggs in a female, you need to impress her with the size of your hoard. Show her your shiny gold before asking them to breed. Females also do the same to entice males but be sure to check the size of their treasure. You do not want to let paupers take care of your eggs.”

“Does Your Majesty only reproduces with the wealthy?”

“Of course not. Why would I put my eggs in another dragon? More dragons meant more competitions for my hoard later. No, minion, breeding is for creatures like you, who die all the time and must perpetuate their species before it goes extinct.”

Come to think of it, since other dragons meant no more competition for hoards, and he may be paid for killing his kind... Vainqueur pondered the moral problem of hunting his own kind for money, before deciding it would wait for the destruction of Furibon.

“Also, Manling Victor, no breeding harassment between minions, that causes tensions and minion wars.”

“That is why I waited until after you fired her before making a move,” Manling Victor replied, before the next candidate showed up, a tall, lanky green troll with green hide and a tusked, piglike face. “This is Barnabas.”

“A troll?” Vainqueur squinted. “I burned a lot of them recently.”

“I noticed,” the troll replied. “You killed everyone I knew when you destroyed the Woods of Gevaudan. The good thing is, I hated everyone I knew.”

“What is your level, Barnabas?” Manling Victor interrogated him after clearing his throat.

“Twenty-one, [Blacksmith], [Merchant], and [Alchemist]. Mostly [Blacksmith]. I make weapons, don’t wield them.”

“You’re hired,” Vainqueur said immediately. “I promote you to my official armorer. You will work on dragon-sized items at once.”

“Sure, if I can I get new raw materials.” Victor pointed at the pile of items which dropped during Vainqueur’s training. “That will do.”

And so ended the recruitment. “That was fast,” said Victor, as Barnabas immediately went to work.

“That was effective,” replied Vainqueur. “Next?”

“Chocolatine and Croissant, whom you already ‘recruited,’ both have class levels that could help for the dungeon. Chocolatine because we need a healer, and Croissant, because we need a meat shield for the traps and I hate him. I wish we had a decent level spellcaster with us for the raid, but we’ll have to make do with what we have.”

“It will do, minion. It will do.”

Congratulations! For recruiting a vast adventurer company meant to cater to your noble desires, you gained a level in **[Noble]**!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 VIT, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You earned the **[Stipend]** class perk!

[Stipend]: You gain a monthly stipend of four hundred gold coins multiplied by your total level.

Vainqueur’s eyes widened in pure, unbridled joy, as a huge pile of gold materialized right in front of him with a bright flash of light.

Finally!

By the elder wurm, he had waited so long for this moment! Four hundred per level? Once Vainqueur reached level one hundred, that meant forty thousand coins a month, half a million the year! He would swim in a vast ocean of shiny gold and—

“**[Transmute Gold to Lead]**.”

The coins turned to lead with a flash of black magic, causing Vainqueur’s heart to skip a beat. He immediately glanced at the source of the disaster, sitting atop the pile of demon corpses.

Furibon! His bony finger still cackled with his foul sorcery!

“That was for blowing up my library, you dimwit lizard,” said the lich, before adopting a taunting tone at Vainqueur's silent hatred, “It is true what they say... silence is *golden*.”

Furibon insisted so much on the word, Vainqueur was paralyzed by fury.

“Your Majesty,” Victor butted in. “Use [Spell Pur—”

Snarling with rage and reacting before his minion could finish, Vainqueur attempted to smash the lich the dragon way, but the undead teleported away while cackling. Instead, Vainqueur's hand smashed onto the pile of demons, creating a crater and causing a small quake.

“Holy Hell, Your Majesty's strength points are showing,” Minion Victor complimented his master, as if it could cheer him up.

“No more waiting, Minion Victor,” Vainqueur declared, his heart set on vengeance. “We raid the dungeon tomorrow!”

He already imagined the treasure that Furibon would drop.

Chapter 18: Uninvited Guests

Due to his role in their new dragon overlord's administration, the locals had wisely 'gifted' Victor a large mansion overseeing the rest of Murmurin. Finally, the human's life as a homeless adventurer had reached its end, at least until they claimed Furibon's dungeon tomorrow.

And what a place it was! With three floors, a basement, and a roof, it was huge enough to welcome a lord's entire retinue. Unlike the early medieval architecture of Gardemagne's manors, the place had been built in a later time's style, with wide rooms, black wood flooring, and a central velvet stair leading to the upper floors.

Victor had heard it once belonged to a dark wizard doing experiments in the basement though, and considering the dust around, the inhabitants hadn't touched it in years. He better watch his back inside.

Victor entered the grand foyer with Savoureuse and twenty mindless, demonic skeletons in tows. "Go clean the place," he ordered his servants, "No dust must remain."

The automatons spread around as ordered. "And now I officially live in a ghost mansion," Victor told Savoureuse, as they moved to explore the ground floor while the earth trembled. "Do you think Vainqueur smashed a succubus this time?"

"I don't think Chocolatine can summon on—" Savoureuse suddenly chuckled. "Ah, I get it, smash a succubus!"

"You can't imagine how much I missed someone laughing at my lame jokes," Victor said, finding a large cozy room with an old fireplace and armchairs. "We had good times."

“It’s not quite the same since you left, Vic. We’re taking a wrong turn since that Lavere woman arrived.”

“Wrong turn? The Nightblades are an outlaw ring. That’s pretty redundant.”

“Yes, but we respected the government,” Savoureuse said, Victor giving her a blank stare. “Okay, sometimes we put nobles through death traps, but who doesn’t? We didn’t take up arms against the King, because it was bad for business. But last time I was at our headquarter in Noblecoeur, there were talks of supplying Ishfania and the Scorchers with weapons.”

Well, Vainqueur shot that plan down.

Victor sat in one of the armchairs, finding it extraordinarily comfortable. “[Channel Hellfire]!” His finger fired a ray of ghastly blue flames at the fireplace, lighting up the leftover black wood.

That was the only Monster Perk he got out of this grueling training, and he earned it. He should have listened to the priests’ warning of fire and brimstone in his childhood.

“Do you want an omelet?” Savoureuse asked him.

“Sure.” The proposal couldn’t make Victor happier since she had many levels in the Cook class. Other Nightblades had fought to the death over her meals.

The reptile sat on the ground like a chicken. “Do you want me to go to another room?” Victor asked, embarrassed.

“No, it’s okay. I do it everywhere.”

Victor turned his eyes away from the sight still, finding a treasure chest in a corner of the room, overflowing with gold.

Yeah, right. Just a chest.

“Treasure!” the disguised mimic barked. “Treasure!”

As if Victor would fall for it. “You know, most adventurers are wary of chests nowadays,” the Monster Squire told the creature. “You should take the shape of a magic weapon, like a shiny sword, and you mustn’t make a sound.”

The chest apparently understood, for it repeated, “Shiny sword? Treasure?”

“Trust me, no adventurer can’t resist the appeal of a big shiny sword, especially if set in a stone.”

“You can understand mimics?” Savoureuse asked him, rising up to reveal a large, ostrich-like egg under her clothes. “It is very difficult to make them behave.”

“I think there are frying pans in the kitchen, and yes I can,” said Victor, before shouting, “Minions! Minions!”

A skeleton immediately rushed inside the room. The M-word had never felt so pleasurable. “Go get us kitchen tools,” Victor ordered, the undead immediately obeying.

The squire took it back. Mindless undead slaves made his life way easier than before.

“Sword treasure!” By now, the chest had morphed into a huge, outrageous two-handed sword made of pure gold and jewels. “Sword treasure!”

“Better, but too much,” Victor told it, who suddenly wondered how the mimic could talk without a mouth, “Try having a black metal edge and an elegant pommel. Don’t overdo it.”

“Sword treasure.” The mimic followed his instructions, becoming the perfect picture of a magical sword.

“Excellent. Now you shouldn’t have trouble getting food. Just don’t kill anything in the village, alright?”

“Sword treasure!” The sword purred and hopped out of the room like an animal, just as the skeletal servant came back with four frying pans. “Sword

Treasure.”

Victor now had a pet.

On a whim, he called it Vainqueur Junior.

Congratulations! Through your teaching, Vainqueur Junior has gained a level in [**Fencer**]!

Really? Like that? Victor guessed [Minion Trainer] made it easy for monsters to gain class levels when following his directions. “Is this place the mimic school I heard of?”

“Yes, and I would avoid the beds if I were you.”

Victor suddenly wondered if disappearances in inns were caused by disguised mimics.

“Nothing better than a warm meal after a good day of training,” said Savoureuse, breaking her egg on the frying pan, before adding spice to her omelet. The skeleton stood there waiting, so Victor sent him away looking for plates and cutlery.

In total, Victor had gained six levels in Necromancer before hitting a Level glass ceiling like Vainqueur. The dragon still asked Chocolatine to summon more demons to calm himself after Furibon’s last visit.

Victor still couldn’t believe an ancient lich had nothing better to do with his time outside of pranking a dragon. He must be really, *really* bored in his dungeon.

“You little—” Victor heard Croissant’s voice from outside the room. The werewolf soon joined them, in human shape and with a bloody hand.

“Croissant, are you alright?” asked Savoureuse in worry. “What happened?”

“I found a sword laying on the ground, and it bit my hand when I tried to grab it! Then it ran off!”

Vainqueur Junior grew up so fast. “Sad,” Victor lied since he found some twisted pleasure in that jerk’s pain. “Why are you here?”

“I asked Vainqueur what we should run ourselves, now that we are all his minions and that we are going to run out of sheep. He answered, textually, ‘A dragon has no time for sub-minion management; I have a war to prepare for, so go to my chief of staff for directions.’ Then, he had my sister summon another demon and punched it.”

“So I’m basically your village’s mayor now. Wonderful.”

“Looks like it, pal. Also, the Moon Man’s followers are at the door, waiting for your ‘final revelation.’”

Victor let out a sigh. They had kept pestering him every time he wasn’t with Vainqueur, who scared them to death. “I will be their prophet later.”

“No hard feeling for that perk stuff, right? You brought Vainqueur here, so you kinda deserved it.”

“No, no hard feelings, since you will serve as our scout tomorrow.”

The werewolf blinked. “I’m what?”

“We are raiding the dungeon tomorrow. Your sister is coming too, but she’s going to be fine in the rear. As a rogue class, you will scout ahead for traps.”

“But I’m a [Ranger], not a trap finder! I hunt beasts, I do not disarm traps!”

“I know. I meant you will scout out traps by *triggering* them. Maybe next time, you won’t try to sacrifice your future commanding officer to a cult. Just saying.”

“You... you petty snake...”

“As a wise woman told me,” Victor smirked at him. “I wish you would go to hell, Croissant, but I think you are already there.”

Clenching his fists and fangs, the werewolf exited the room with fury in his eyes. “Merciful Isengrim, damn that dragon, damn his staff, damn them all...”

“That was very immature, Victor,” Savoureuse chided him, “Even if he deserved it.”

“Ah, it’s fine,” Victor replied. “We’ve both blown off steam, now we’re cool.”

“You look like you need a warm meal to ease you up,” said Savoureuse, who finished the omelet. “Here.”

“Thanks,” Victor replied, as he sat back in the armchair. “What else in on the menu—”

Of course, his stats appeared when he said that word.

Victor "Minion" Dalton

Level: 26 (Outlaw 5/Monster Squire 14/Necromancer 7)

Type: Humanoid/Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points

645

Special Points 240 Strength 24 Vitality 23 Skill 32 Agility 31 Intelligence 30 Charisma 30 Luck 29

Personal PerksClass Perks Claimed by Dice Lockpick Observer Eye for Treasure Deadfriend Knife Master Romantic Monster Kin Claimed by the Moon Man Minion Trainer Black Curse Monster Student Channel Hellfire (Minor) Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon) Monster Rider Monster Insight Rally Minion Animate Dead Necromancy I Dead Divination Lifespell

Minion? Even his goddamn menu had started calling him that!

Still, very good stat growth so far, although he never tested the new Necromancer Perks. He was now around the same level as the late Gustave and Vilmain.

Congratulations! Due to meeting entry requirements through your [**Monster Student**] Perk and [**Necromancer**] levels, you can convert some of your levels into promoted Monster Classes! Stats will not be affected, but Perks will.

You can either combine [**Monster Squire**] and [**Necromancer**] into [**Death Knight**], or [**Outlaw**] and [**Necromancer**] into [**Reaper**].

The change will be permanent and cannot be undone; you will no longer be able to progress in the converted classes if you choose to combine them.

Interesting, Victor thought as he took a bite out of that delicious omelet. Savoureuse partook in the feast in a weird act of self-cannibalism. What were these classes?

[**Death Knight**]: An undying warlord, commanding armies of the undead to rid the land of life itself. Specialties: All Weapons, Necromancy, and Riding. Major growths in Strength, Vitality, Skill and Agility. Perks affected: Monster Kin, Monster Student, Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon), Necromancy I, Lifespell.

[**Reaper**]: A thief and stealer of souls who does terrible things in their quest for power. Specialties: Scythes, Necromancy, and Dark Magic. Major growths in Skill, Intelligence, Charisma, and Luck. Perks affected: Lockpick, Knife Master, Dead Divination, Lifespell.

Charming. So [**Death Knight**] was a pure combat class with some dash of magic thrown in, while [**Reaper**] was a mix of rogue and spellcaster.

It didn't take long for Victor to make a choice. He doubted he would progress further in the [**Outlaw**] class, making it redundant, and his

[Monster Squire] class was too good to trade. Besides, Vainqueur had the pure combat niche covered.

He could definitely see the effect of the new intelligence points.

“Ever heard of the [Reaper] class?” he asked Savoureuse.

“It is usually reserved to dark fairies or psychopomps who steal souls,” she explained, sitting back again to lay another egg. “I heard rumors that the god Deathjester was one, and that he killed so many people with a scythe, it turned into an artifact.”

Then it was official. Time to *reap* these levels.

Choice registered! Your [**Outlaw**] and [**Necromancer**] levels have been transformed into [**Reaper**] levels. [**Outlaw**] and [**Necromancer**] are no longer accessible.

[**Lockpick**] replaced with [**Skeleton Key**]. [**Skeleton Key**]: you can unlock any lock on a successful Skill check, even magical ones. You always count as ‘invited’ to any location magically protected.

[**Knife Master**] replaced with [**Scythe Lord**]. [**Scythe Lord**]: you gain perfect proficiency with scythes; scythes now count as staves for the purpose of spellcasting.

[**Dead Divination**] replaced with [**Helheim**]. [**Helheim**]: if you kill someone with a scythe, you can trap their soul in your weapon, increasing the weapon’s statistics. The victim cannot be revived, reanimated, or reincarnated as long as they are trapped in the scythe. You can talk with the trapped souls and release them at will.

[**Lifespell**] replaced with [**Steal Life**]. [**Steal Life**]: when you inflict damage with a scythe, you recover HP equal to half the damage inflicted.

Victor briefly grabbed the daggers around his belt, finding that he had lost all familiarity with it. With [Knife Master] gone, he could no longer draw in the class’ pool of knowledge.

“What are you going to do with all these undead servants, by the way?” Savoureuse asked him in between bites, as he used the dagger as cutlery. “I thought you found them disturbing?”

“I recently asked the goddess Shesha the price to return home, and it’s terrifyingly high. I noticed you could make a killing in the undead trade,” Sav chuckled at the phrasing. “So I thought I could save money to pay her the service.”

“How high?” Victor told her the price, and Savoureuse almost choked on her omelet. “Vic, that is insane! Even if you take over the continent, you won’t have enough gold to pay that price!”

“Yeah, but I miss my family and friends on Earth.” Victor had been growing homesick long before he met Vainqueur, and the discussion with Allison only increased that.

“I know you keep saying this world sucks and you miss your old one, but you’re making a life for yourself here. If you’re missing on your family and friends, you can make new ones here. You also have a lot of opportunities. You are working with a dragon, and gaining levels so very fast. Who else is that lucky?”

He wouldn’t call it luck, but yeah... even if the fiasco with Euskal had killed every other avenue for work. No way he could set foot in the country again without Vainqueur’s protection.

Against his better judgment, his thoughts turned to Vainqueur’s ‘advice.’ “Hey, Sav. Would you find a male with a very big hoard of gold attractive?”

“Of course. Who doesn’t like someone with a lot of money they can repossess?” Unfortunately, the crafty creature immediately guessed his trail of thoughts. “So that was true? You asked Allison to breed?”

“N-no, nothing that direct,” Victor defended himself. “There are steps in between. Like a drink.”

“You are too good for her,” said Savoureuse with a motherly tone. “I would not try to breed with her if I were you. You do not know where she has been.”

“What is that supposed to mean?”

“She is a priestess of Cybele. She must have laid with half the town and called it religious service.”

That... that meant...

“I knew it!”

“Victor, what you need is a well-bred, nice woman with strong family values,” said the reptilian assassin for hire, without any hint of hypocrisy whatsoever. “Like Chocolatine. Not a dryad of loose morality like Allison.”

Chocolatine? That psycho? She had fed some of the demons' flesh to pigs hoping they would grow fatter on it!

“My religion does not allow love triangles.” Someone knocked on the room's window, Victor glancing to notice the calmar priest right behind. With a sigh, he rose from his chair and opened the window. “Yes?”

“Oh, prophet of the Moon Man!” The priest had gathered the entire congregation outside. “Please deliver unto us the final revelation!”

... don't ask them to bring you virgins, don't ask them to bring you virgins. “Bring—” Victor stopped himself, realizing that he had a unique occasion to tame a dangerous cult. Even if their master forbade human sacrifices, they might interpret his command with violence and zealousness.

“Bring?” the priest picked up.

“Bring love and friendship to all, for we are all the children of the Moon Man.” That sounded less cheesy in his mind. “There. You have the final revelation.”

The cultists exchanged glances. “Did Thul-Gathar meant to bring love in the figurative sense?” one werewolf asked the calmar priest.

“I believe it must have been literal. As in, you must love your neighbor as you would love your wife.”

“Or maybe it meant—”

“Guys,” Victor interrupted their theological debate, “On your way out, can you ask Barnabas to forge me a scythe for battle? A really cool scythe, but not a scary one. No skulls motif.”

“We shall, prophet! Now, I was saying, I think it meant we must open the Full Moon Orgy to everyone—”

Victor closed the windows, leaving them to their religious debate and sliding back in his chair.

He hoped it would work well. Now that he had some free time and a belly almost full, he brought out the iPad, intent on exploring its content while eating. Savoureuse observed the Apple product with envy. “Is that...”

“You recognize it?”

“The Nightblades’ leadership was looking for it.” Victor glared back at her. “I wasn’t sent here for it, so I’m not going to steal your stuff, Vic.”

Better. While she was a friend, he had already seen it wouldn’t matter if her life was at risk. Victor looked into the various file folders, finding schematics for various kinds of planes. Nothing extraordinary, but valuable in an early Renaissance world. The previous owner must have worked in aeronautics.

The name of the most encrypted, restricted folder though?

‘Lockheed Martin Corporation.’

... Yeah, Victor now knew why so many people wanted it. How did it end in Haudemer, though? Could it be that since Outremonde and Earth were

mirror worlds, items and people often traveled from one to the other on their own?

Come to think of it, he was centuries ahead of his time here. Valuable knowledge. Perhaps he could help improve that world and make a profit out of it, gain money by doing good.

The sound of the entry bell echoed in the room. That must have been Allison... “Better that someone alive opens the door,” Victor thought out loud, rising up with the iPad under his arm. “Sav, do I smell good?”

“Better than her, Vic,” the reptile hummed, “Much better than her.”

The adventurer smirked as he opened the mansion’s door.

“Good evening, young man.” Furibon smirked back with a dark glow in his empty eyes. “You have something that belongs to my master, or so I heard.”

Chapter 19: The War of the Hoard

- Chronicles of the War of the Hoard, final chapter: "Furibon must die."

In a magical land, far, far away...

Murmurin is at war! In a stunning move, the foul Furibon has kidnapped Lord Victor, first among all minions. The lich's evil has swept across the land, corrupting all that is shiny. But hope remains.

Deep in his fiery forge, the great smith Barnabas forged a dragon-sized [Ring of Elemental Resistance] and a [Killer Scythe]. In them, he poured stat boosts, magical protections, and his frustration at working overtime.

A last alliance of kobolds and werewolves march against Furibon's armies, and on the slopes of a fiery mountain, they fight for the great hoard. Wielding the master ring, the good King Vainqueur leads a desperate charge, determined to end the lich once and for all.

For Furibon must die!

That was it, Vainqueur thought when he hummed the smoke and listened to the drums of war. The final battle for the dragon's way of life.

His heroic minion armies, led by the Kobold Rangers, used mobile wood bridges to reach the castle, fighting imps, and undead. Kobolds, werewolves, and undead minions fought together as one, under Vainqueur's watchful eye.

The dragon statues protecting the castle fired rays of light at Vainqueur, who circled around the castle, blasting the defenders with his breath. The dragon majestically avoided them, taking the opportunity to show off.

“Brother, I’m flying!” said Chocolatine, being held in one of Vainqueur’s hands. As a good and loyal minion, she carried the scythe Barnabas crafted for Vainqueur’s chief of staff.

“I’m going to throw up...” Croissant the meat shield complained in Vainqueur’s other hand.

“[Spell Purge!]” Vainqueur’s Perk activated, and the great dragon radiated a dark aura, causing the magical barrier around Castle Murmurin to blink out of existence. With the defenses now exposed, Vainqueur crash-landed on the statues, blowing them apart and causing the castle to shake.

He tossed the fiends defending the entrance into the lava, then released his two werewolf minions in front of the entrance. The doors were open, the darkness unwelcoming. “Croissant, go inside and trigger all the traps while I finish off the defenders,” Vainqueur ordered. “Die if you must.”

“Can we skip the last part?”

“Die if you must!” Vainqueur ordered, the werewolf going in while whining. This Croissant was only good as a meat shield, as his chief of staff had warned.

The mere thought filled Vainqueur with fury. That abominable lich, it wasn’t enough to curse his hoard, he went the extra mile and stole his most precious henchman. He imagined Furibon heinously forcing poor Victor into minion recruitment sessions, or to bring him gold coins he could sicken.

Victor was part of Vainqueur’s hoard, the best chief of staff the dragon ever had. The Manling *belonged* to him, and no one else.

But Vainqueur had come equipped. On his right left finger, his new [Ring of Elemental Resistance] would shield him against the worst of the lich’s magic. This time, the evil Furibon would not escape him.

Vainqueur unleashed his breath against flying gargoyles and vicious creatures attempting to protect the entrance, his flames now shining with a

bright, golden afterglow. All were vaporized instantly.

“[Fire Amp],” Chocolatine said, who cast spells on her King as he fought.
“[Regen], [Strength Up]!”

Your fire attacks now inflict twenty percent more damage!

Strength increased for ten minutes!

You recover one percent HP every ten seconds for five minute!

As he vaporized the last of the defenders, his minions climbing the castle’s walls and taking them over, Vainqueur turned to the entrance, running through it with Chocolatine in tow.

Vainqueur soon found himself in a great stone hall, with two doors on each side. One had been opened, with bloodied spikes and acid arrows littering the ground. “I think my brother went this way,” said Chocolatine. “Do we follow him?”

“No, Chocolatine,” decided Vainqueur, who could smell his chief of staff’s scent. He disabled his Spell Purge, so he could save it for later. “That would be the manling way, and playing by Furibon’s rules. We will find my chief of staff the dragon way. Blink.”

Vainqueur turned invisible, prepped himself up, and then solved the door problem the dragon way.

He charged the wall in front of him, powering through. The stones were no match for his strength, and parts of the ceiling collapsed behind him; roaring proudly, Vainqueur kept going, destroying wall after wall, stamping on fiends and skeletal warriors, and redesigning his future castle.

Finally, after a long charge, Vainqueur smashed his way inside a large, dark throne room, illuminated by ghostly candelabras. Six steel statues of armored manlings held next to ancient, ruined tapestries. His loyal chief of staff, bound and held hanging by chains from the barely holding ceiling, rejoiced at the sight of the wall collapsing. “Your Majesty!”

The evil Furibon waited on his sinister throne on the opposite end of the room, a paragon of evil and madness. In his dark eye sockets, Vainqueur saw no mercy, no hint of civilized intellect; only the bitterness of a pauper determined to ruin the rich and the wealthy.

“You realize I can hear you, Vainqueur Knightsbane?” the lich taunted Vainqueur, obviously lying. “You made a big hole in my wall, so you are not very discreet.”

Vainqueur knew it was a trap to imbalance him, and try to make him reveal his position. Chocolatine, who had ran after her master, walked into the room while panting. She used Manling Victor’s scythe as a pole against which to breath.

“I am saddened you skipped most of my traps, but at least we can have a proper confrontation.” The lich dramatically extended his arms. “You have done it, King Vainqueur. After all your sacrifices and your losses, you have reached your beloved lackey.”

“I can’t believe I’m the damsel in distress,” Manling Victor complained, ashamed of his weakness.

“At long last, I can unleash my greatest creation.” As Furibon spoke, a circle of dark energy lit up in the middle of the room. “Cower before the strongest undead I have ever created, from the far reaches of Hell! The Black Beast of Murmurin!”

An undead abomination manifested in the middle of the circle; a monstrous, grotesque, hound-shaped amalgam of white, fossilized flesh stitched together. Black stone coated the upper part of the body like a cuirass, and while far smaller than Vainqueur, the creature was big enough to challenge him without looking ridiculous. The titan wriggled with unholy strength, opening its eyeless mouth and revealing ranges of venomous teeth.

“And now, both of you, fight for my entertainment!” Furibon ordered.

The undead abomination did not move. Not even an inch.

The invisibility worked!

“I said, fight for my entertainment.” The lich twitched as the monster refused to move. “Is it broken? [Magic Scan].”

Words of purple light materialized in front of Furibon eyes, as he ‘glanced’ at his creation, and then around the room. “The [Deadfriend] Perk? You *all* have it?”

“Chocolatine, you have it too?” asked Minion Victor.

“Why, yes, how do you think I dispose of the bodies? It helps create strong bonds between the churches of Isengrim and Camilla.”

“That is highly disappointing,” the lich said, his empty, soulless eye sockets burning with fires that turned gold to lead. “Such a waste of good flesh. In that case, I will have ‘Your Majesty’ attack it first to trigger its rage. [Enthrall Monster].”

[**Enthrall**] ailment negated by [**Hunter’s Resolve**]!

“A dragon’s will is greater than yours, Furibon!” Vainqueur replied proudly, slowly tiptoeing around the corpse titan and toward the lich for a sneak attack. “I trained three days for this! *Three days!*”

“Maybe, but I too had time to prepare. [Za Warudo]!” To Vainqueur’s senses, time seemed to stop for a brief instant, and when it flowed again, Furibon had covered himself with multiple colored layers of magical energy. “I see you came well-equipped, dragon, but I have more spells than you have years.”

“Only a dragon will never know defeat!”

“Then let us dance like the damned.” Furibon rose from his throne, his hands shining with foul sorcery, “But know that you are too late to stop us. The Apple of Knowledge already belongs to my master, Brandon Maure.”

“Why would I care about a vegetable?” Vainqueur replied with arrogance. “I only eat meat!”

“Soon, you and all of Outremonde shall know iron and blood! [Ancient Met —” The dark lich stopped still. “You do not know about my master's plan?”

“I know of your plan,” Vainqueur replied, furious at the depraved plot. “To infect all the world’s gold with lead sickness, ending the dragon way of life forever!”

The lich tried to deny his culpability, “No, I do not... that would be amusing, but ridiculous.”

“Also, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor butted in. “Gold being turned to lead is not lead poisoning.”

What had that poison sauce have to do with this? The lich seemed as confused as Vainqueur. “If you did not come to Murmurin to stop my liege's from laying waste to Gardemagne, then why are you here?”

“To stop your sickening scheme!” Vainqueur replied, proud to fight for the future of his hoard.

“This...” the lich let out a deep, bellowing sound. “Why did you come here in the first place? The seal below? How did you learn about it? Did that dark woman send you?”

“We know about the treasure of the Ishfanian Inquisition you keep in your vaults,” Victor said. “That was part of the reason we came here. What? Aren’t you keeping it?”

“You believe an ancient lich wizard would spend a hundred years holing up in a crumbling ruin to keep a stash of hidden gold?” The lich disdained the dragon way of life, firmly cementing himself as completely irredeemable. “Do you even know what is down there, waiting?”

Manling Victor fell mute.

“You do not.” Furibon the Evil twitched. “Then, and this time you will answer or die, why did you come here?”

“We needed a castle where to stash His Majesty’s hoard,” Manling Victor answered with a pitiful tone. “Because the previous cave was too small.”

As the lich’s skull slowly turned to Victor, Vainqueur realized his lackey was distracting the lich for his master to deliver a sneak attack. Brilliant!

“Stash his hoard?” The undead’s neck cracked. “You attacked me, tried to take my home, and killed hundreds of demons, because you needed a place where to *stash your gold?*”

“A dragon does not go to the bank!” Vainqueur boasted, having circumvented the undead titan and now with a clear line of fire. “Only a dragon can be trusted with his gold!”

“Why did you not just bury it in your *backyard?*!” the lich snarled. “But, but... what about the demons? Why did you keep summoning them, except to thin the ranks of my master’s forces? Why did you create an undead army?”

“I kinda intended to sell the undead corpses for money,” Victor admitted.

“With a ninety-nine one-tenth going to my hoard,” Vainqueur reminded his chief of staff.

Furibon shook on his throne in envy and hatred of Vainqueur’s wealth. “I spent one hundred years keeping watch over this crumbling ruin, weakening the seal, preparing traps and monsters while praying Dice that a powerful adventurer would finally challenge my monotony... and the one who does, wants a bigger cave to *stash his hoard?*”

“The biggest hoard in the world!” Vainqueur boasted as he breathed long and deep.

“You... you...” The lich scratched his skull with his bony fingers with fury. “Argh!”

[**Taunt**] successful! You successfully applied the [**Berserk**] status to Furibon! The lich is too pissed to spellcast!

And so, while his nemesis was distracted, Vainqueur unleashed a great fireball with a defiant roar. “Surprise attack!”

An immense, fiery projectile hit Furibon, the power of the blast destroying the throne and most of the wall behind it. The lich’s robes were incinerated, his bones blown apart in two halves, with his torso flying and crashing against one of the steel statues.

Your [**Witch Burning**] Perk was super-effective!

Vainqueur looked at the broken bones of his defeated enemy with smug satisfaction. “Blink,” the dragon revealed himself back in his full glory, freeing his chief of staff by biting the chains holding him. “Minion Victor, are you safe?”

“Yes, yes, Your Majesty, I’m fine,” the lackey replied, stretching. “Thanks for saving me.”

“Of course, Minion. You are the crown jewel of my hoard.” The minion glanced up at Vainqueur with happy eyes, warming the dragon’s heart. “You are my most precious asset and most loyal servant. I will never let you go. Ever.”

The minion blinked several times in a row, overwhelmed with emotion. “Oh gods,” he finally said. “You are never letting me go.”

“That was quick,” Chocolatine grumbled in disappointment.

“It is not over,” Minion Victor said wisely.

Indeed, in the blink of an eye, the evil Furibon teleported right next to his former corpse. His body radiated dark magic, as he pointed his palm at Vainqueur. “[Ancient Meteor!]”

Before Vainqueur could react, a huge, fiery stone hit him right in the eye before exploding.

Vainqueur learned a new sensation he never experienced before, which he didn’t like it at all.

You have taken damage!

Vainqueur had no idea what that sensation was, but it felt itchy and *wrong*. Like an indigestion.

“Stash your gold!” Furibon glared at Vainqueur with seething hatred, the same the dragon felt for the lich. “I could have *understood* if you attacked me on principle because I am a lich, but to *stash your gold*? I will not be expelled from this castle by home invaders!”

“Then you will die disappointed once more!” Vainqueur replied by blasting his foe with his fiery breath.

“[Za Warudo],” the lich cast. In a blink, he had teleported out of the way of the flames, and spike of ice appeared out of nowhere to fly at Vainqueur. They bounced back off his scales harmlessly. “[Elemental Resistance]? Then I will weaken your flesh, and then blast you to death! [Black Curse], [Accelerated Superflare]!”

A dark aura covered Vainqueur, who suddenly didn’t feel so well, and then an explosion detonated in front of him. Once again, that strange itching, uncomfortable sensation filled his scales.

All enhancements removed! All stats diminished by one stage! You can no longer recover HP while [**Black Curse**] is active!

Sweet Chocolatine, who had immediately taken cover behind her invincible master, tried to support Vainqueur with spells. “[Curse Breake—]”

“[Accelerated Silence],” the lich cast, robbing sweet Chocolatine of the ability to speak before she could finish, “Out of my way, mortal! [Hasten]!”

Furibon began to move at greater speed, dodging a fireball by running around, while firing green, jagged beams of light at Vainqueur; the dragon retaliated by firing fireball after fireball, blasting walls and statues.

“Guys, stop, you’re going to collapse the castle!” Manling Victor shouted, as the explosions caused debris to fall from above and Vainqueur’s flames

spread to the tapestries.

“Minion, do not distract me while landscaping!” Vainqueur replied, as he fruitlessly tried to smash the lich, who kept teleporting around before the dragon could put him in range of his [Spell Purge].

“Fine!” Furibon snarled, his mouth moving so fast Vainqueur could barely understand the words. “I would rather turn that castle into a crater than surrender it to that dragon!”

“Your gold-destroying plan will be stopped, Furibon!”

“I do not... you wyvern imbecile, gold is nothing compared to arcane secrets!”

Vainqueur’s eyes flared with rage. The lich had gone mad. Not only did he use the cursed *W-word* to demean a true dragon, he also spouted insane nonsense.

Vainqueur decided to fight seriously, and destroy this lich with extreme prejudice. “[Spell Purge.]” The dragon activated his Perk again, extinguishing one of the explosions as it entered his antimagic field’s range.

Charisma check successful! [**Black Curse**] lifted by: [**Spell Purge**]!

“You will run out of SP for that Perk before I exhaust mine, wyvern!” Furibon snarled.

It didn’t matter. The lich may be a wizard with shiny spells, he would become a powerless skeleton once Vainqueur caught him in range of his [Spell Purge]; while *he* would stay an invincible dragon. He just had to catch him.

Vainqueur lunged at the lich.

The undead teleported out of the way before Vainqueur could get him in range.

The dragon roared furiously as he kept trying to trample and bite Furibon, who dodged each of his attempts. The more he did, the more Vainqueur grew furious. It was like playing catch with a frustrating goblin.

“Foolish!” Furibon taunted him, his hands cackling with unholy power. “Your brute strength is no match for my mastery of magic, Vainqueur! I have peered into the abyss of time, overcome death, and become power incarn—”

Then his own undead abomination caught the lich in its jaws from behind.

Vainqueur, who had been entirely focused on the evil Furibon, noticed his scythe-wielding lackey riding the abomination’s back with Chocolatine.

“Who is a good undead dog? Who earned a bone?” Manling Victor told the abomination, who kept shaking Furibon in its jaws like a dog with a mouse, “Who earned a treat? That’s you! That’s you! There, throw it to your friend.”

The undead hound tossed the angry lich at Vainqueur. “[Telepor—]”

Vainqueur caught the foul lich in his hand before he could cast his spell, negating it at once.

The dragon glanced down at his captive with smug satisfaction. “Good job minion,” he congratulated his lackey, who earned it.

“I knew [Monster Rider] would come in handy,” Minion Victor said, his monstrous mount scratching under him.

“[Teleportation]!” Furibon cursed, but nothing happened.

“Manling Victor,” Vainqueur said. “You are now promoted to my royal executioner. I know you must still be reeling from the torture the lich inflicted on you, but you will pass judgment on him at once!”

“He didn’t torture me. Actually he was quite chatty, in a creepy undead way. I think he *really* needed somebody to talk to after a century alone making traps, like a middle unlife crisis.”

Poor minion. The pain had broken his mind, forcing him to sympathize with his abuser. Vainqueur would make sure to give him the caring needed to recover.

“Kill me,” Furibon let out a furious hiss, like the wounded snake he was. “This day cannot get any worse.”

"After we find your phylactery," said Manling Victor.

The lich let out a chuckle. "Do you take me for a fool? I moved it to a hidden crypt on another continent when the dragon threatened to destroy my castle. I will return, and when I do, no more games. I will rain spell after spell until you are all dead.”

“You know, I somewhat sympathized with you until that last part.” Minion Victor glared at Furibon with the same disdain as Vainqueur, before swinging his scythe. “If I understand it, your soul returns to its phylactery when your body is destroyed, allowing you to create a new one.”

"Yes, this is called immortality," Furibon replied with a patronizing tone.

"Which means that your soul inhabits your body right now. Otherwise, if your current vessel was an animated puppet, I don't see why you wouldn't abandon it right now instead of waiting for us to destroy it. Ever heard of the [Helheim] Perk?"

The lich fell silent, then finally said, “It will not work.”

“Let's find out, shall we?"

“[Enhanced Teleportation]! [Teleportation]!"

Minion Victor swung the blade, cutting off the lich's skeletal head.

The lich's bones crumbled instantly, a specter of black energy escaping from them; it silently tried to flee out of the room, only for a dark force to drag him inside the scythe. Right afterward, the blade reflected Furibon's screaming face within.

“Poor choice of last words,” said Manling Victor, as he swung his scythe again, Furibon’s ghost silently snarling inside the blade. Chocolatine looked at the scene with gleeful eyes. “His silent screams are so sweet.”

“You sealed him, minion?” Vainqueur asked, his lackey confirming with a nod.

"I think his soul will return to his phylactery if the scythe is destroyed, but for now, yes, he's sealed."

“Finally, his evil will never befoul my wealth again.”

Congratulations! For sealing the evil Furibon in your minion’s weapon, and claiming the Castle of Murmurin as your dungeon, you earned a level in the ultra prestigious [**Kaiser**] class!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You earned the [**Dungeon Owner (Castle of Murmurin)**] class Perk!

[**Dungeon Owner (Castle of Murmurin)**]: you are magically tuned to your dungeon. You can instantly teleport in any place within the confines of the Castle of Murmurin at will, and you can navigate inside with perfect awareness of your path.

Vainqueur didn’t pay it much attention, his eyes instead set on the new treasure that appeared in his palm, amidst Furibon’s remaining bones. A magnificent, jeweled golden crown, the most beautiful headpiece Vainqueur had ever seen.

But it was manling-sized.

“Minion Victor, you will have Barnabas forge me a dragon-sized crown, after we find a way to cure my gold.”

“Actually, I think I have a solution,” Victor said. “Your Majesty negated the lich’s spells with [Spell Purge], so you should cancel—”

“I can cure lead sickness!” Vainqueur interrupted his lackey, overjoyed.

At long last, the hoard was saved.

And so Furibon, enemy of all that was good, was destroyed by the same obsession that fueled his bottomless evil: his hatred of gold. Once again, the forces of greed prevailed, and the dragon way of life endured.

Through the blessing of King Vainqueur’s [Spell Purge], his wealth was returned to him, and so was his faithful minion. Croissant the useless, who survived every trap only to find the battle done, was mocked, and wept. A great feast was ordered. Sheep were eaten. Using their entrails, demons were summoned. They, too, were eaten.

And so peace returned to Murmurin. In the depths of his castle, King Vainqueur gathered a great hoard, one hoard to bind them all. Lord Victor alone, to atone for his capture, carried the burden of keeping the pauper Furibon sealed.

I, Pink Ranger, was tasked by King Vainqueur to write the glorious chronicles of the Great War against Furibon, who was evil and had to be destroyed. I swear my words are the truth, the official truth, from the mouth of King Vainqueur himself. May his glory shine through the ages to come.

And so, remember, always, that in the darkest times, even in face of the most sinister of evil...

The wealthy always win!

Chapter 20: Emperor Vainqueur

The vaults of the castle overflowed with treasure.

Deep in the depths of the dungeon, Manling Victor had found strong, metal doors so thick and huge, five dragons could have gone through them at once. After some fiery landscaping, Vainqueur and his minions had forced their way inside, only to be welcomed with the most beautiful sight in the world: an immense underground metal vault, overflowing with hills of gold and silver coins.

Vainqueur immediately jumped into his new treasure, swimming in the gold like a shark in the water. So many baby coins imprisoned below ground by that lich, and without a good dragon to take care of them!

“Minions!” Vainqueur shouted, while vicariously showering his belly with coins. “Grow my new hoard by adding the old one to it!”

“Sure, but... what the hell is *that*?”

Vainqueur, who focused on his new shinies alone, hadn’t noticed a second door on the other end of the vault. This one was made of ancient stone and sealed shut by heavy chains covered with ancient runes.

Was there a bigger vault behind it? This kept getting better and better!

“Oh, that’s written in old Ishfanian.” Sweet Chocolatine moved to examine inscriptions written on the stone. ““Beyond these doors, closed by the blessed Inquisition of Mithras the Eversun, is the demesne of the Archdevil Isabelle, Mistress of Blades. May these bindings never break, or Ishfania shall know Hell Unending.””

“Of course the Ishfanian Inquisition would build a fortress over a gate to Hell,” Minion Victor said. “The castle was meant to protect it from invaders coming from *inside*.”

“Isabelle is Brandon Maure’s mother,” Croissant the Useless said. He still hadn’t recovered from the traps Vainqueur sent him to scout through, with slashes and paint all over his body. “Furibon must have worked to open these doors over the century and supply his master with demonic armies to throw at Gardemagne.”

“What about the seal?” Manling Victor asked. “Will it hold?”

“The bindings have weakened from lack of maintenance, but I can repair them with Squid’s help...” Chocolatine’s face beamed. “Oh, oh, why don’t we open them ourselves? That way we can slaughter demons as they come out. More money, more meat.”

Vainqueur’s chief of staff didn’t share her enthusiasm. “I really don’t like the undertones of tricking an entire species into getting killed one at the time by entering a closed room, even demons.”

“But organized slaughter is okay if it is done to fiends!” Chocolatine protested.

“No, it’s not! And does Your Majesty really want to give an army of would-be robbers direct access to their hoard?”

No. That would be like the mountain, except with winged goats rather than manlings. “Wolfling Chocolatine, you will keep these doors closed,” Vainqueur ordered. “You can still use sheep to lure them in your backward peasant village.”

The werewolf pouted in disappointment, while minion Victor rejoiced. “Wolflings, you go fetch that squid and reinforce these doors,” Vainqueur ordered. “I will not have my vault open to the paupers any longer than necessary. Kobold Rangers, go ask Troll Barnabas if my crown is ready. Manling Victor, you stay here to discuss my class planning.”

The minions left with haste to attend his needs, leaving Vainqueur alone with his most beloved treasures: his hoard, and his chief of staff. “Now that the evil Furibon has been destroyed, we can focus on what truly matters to me,” the dragon said, burying himself in gold until only his head was above it. “That sweet [Stipend] provides me with more gold the higher my level. Find a way to increase that amount.”

“The obvious way would be to level up further, Your Majesty,” Victor stated the simple solution. “Maybe a magic item or specific Perk can increase the money you receive, though.”

“I leave you to find the proper solution, Manling Victor. You are my class advisor.”

“Your Majesty, about magic items.” His chief of staff cleared his throat. “I suggest you let the minions keep and use your non-dragon sized magical items, as you allowed me.”

“Minion, Furibon is sealed forever, and the castle is mine.” He had already put the crown recovered from Furibon around his finger, like a ring. “There is no need to spread my wealth around. And speaking of loaned treasure, where are the sun bracers and the fireball pendant I gave you?”

The minion fell silent for a second, embarrassed. “Well, Furibon caught me by surprise before I could equip myself...”

“You should be more wary next time, and wear my items proudly,” Vainqueur chided his lackey. “It pleases me to always have my treasures in sight. It reassures and looks good on me.”

“Yeah, I get it. I’m just saying, now our adventurer company is in charge of the barony, we may need a good police force, and minions with magical items will be more effective.”

Vainqueur squinted at his minion. “The barony?”

“I told Your Majesty before, Gardemagne promised that whoever destroyed Furibon could lay claim to the surrounding lands, which is called a barony. I

had Savoureuse send a message through a homing pigeon, so you should officially be named Baron of Murmurin once the adventurer guild is notified. And if they refuse, well, It's not like they can do anything about who owns the place. Murmurin is so far away from Gardemagne, so full of monsters, and so close to Maure's territory that not even suicidal adventurers will dare dislodge us."

"The Barking of Murmurin," Vainqueur corrected, before explaining his logic to his confused lackey. "Baron King Vainqueur. Barking Vainqueur."

The minion gave him an empty stare.

Vainqueur suddenly realized the problem with the name. "Kingron? Kingaron?" Nothing fit! "Is there a title that could include both? King of the Albain Mountains and Baron of Murmurin does not sound melodious."

"I think Emperor is above King, Your Majesty, since empires are bigger than kingdoms. So it should cover everything."

Really? And all this time he just called himself a king because he thought there was nothing above it! "Minion, I shall henceforth be known as His Majesty Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of his Name, Great Calamity of this Age, and *Emperor* of Murmurin and the Albain Mountains."

"As you wish, Your Majesty *Emperor* Vainqueur."

Vainqueur realized that never before had he loved a new word so much.

"It displeases me to spread my hoard around and out of my sight," said the dragon, "Ask Barnabas to create the minions weapons; until then, I agree to loan the kobolds weapons, so the beauty of my hoard encourages them to work, but only for a time. You alone are worthy to wield my sacred treasures in battle, Minion Victor. You are the only one I can fully trust not to lose them."

"Thank you, Your Majesty," the minion said, without any pitiful tone this time. Come to think of it, Vainqueur didn't remember him ever using such a warm voice before.

“As a celebration for my promotion to Emperor, I declare today to be the Vainqueur Day. Every year, we will rejoice over the defeat of Furibon, who was evil and had to be destroyed. A great feast of cattle will be held, and I will burn a wood puppet of Furibon before an adoring crowd while they cheer me.” Maybe he would get a treasure out of it. “Also, the minions will build a statue of me in that werewolf village, so my subjects can be in awe of my emperor person. I want a bigger statue than the gods in your temples.”

“Your Majesty, holidays and public works are good, but what about actual laws? I think Murmurin's inhabitants want to know how they will govern themselves now that you are the top dragon in town.”

Vainqueur thought about it, and the first direction became obvious. “Minion Victor, this experience, and the cruelty of your manling king made me realize that there is no greater crime than separating a dragon from his hard-won hoard. In my magnanimity, I declare my first commandment to be: no taxes, ever.”

“No taxes, ever?”

“No treasure tax of any kind will ever be levied in my empire. Taxes are evil. Instead, I will take a daily tribute of cattle in reward of my enlightened dragon leadership.”

“I think Your Majesty invented tax havens way ahead of their time. What about reducing the tax on my one one-tenth fee then?”

“That is different,” Vainqueur replied, incensed by the Minion’s base greed. “That is not a tax since you are selling my non-shiny possessions on my behalf. The one one-tenth is a *reward*. If you want to get rich and impress females to breed with you, build yourself a hoard by working hard.”

Manling Victor let out a sigh. “I guess levies and mindless undead labor will cover for public service.”

“My second commandment will be: no lead. Lead is the work of Furibon and forbidden until the end of time. Everyone found smuggling lead in the

lands of Emperor Vainqueur shall be eaten. Unless the lead is sickened gold, in that case, it shall be cured and added to my hoard for eternal safekeeping.”

“Copper for plumbery then.”

“My third commandment is,” Vainqueur stared at his minion dead in the eyes, “Minion Victor, do the thing.”

His lackey blinked, the honor overwhelming him. “Do the thing?”

“The non-dragon thing,” Vainqueur clarified. “I have better things to do than manage the life of wolves, minions, and manlings, like counting my new coins or killing liches. I am a dragon, I do not care how minions run their lives so long as they do as I say when I demand it. So, Manling Victor, I now promote you to my Grand Dragon Vizier, and Doer of the Thing.”

“So, I keep doing what I always did, doing the boring stuff while you enjoy the rewards.”

“Do not abuse your privilege.”

Congratulations! By self-promoting yourself to Emperor, establishing your ‘imperial authority’ over the Murmurin region, and possessing enormous personal power worthy of such a title, not only did you earn a level in **[Noble]**, but your Noble Class has evolved into the **[Emperor]** Class!

Warning: you will lose the benefits of the **[Emperor]** Class’ Perks if you cannot defend your title from challengers and doubters; you will regain these benefits only if you fend off naysayers.

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

Your **[Old Money]**, **[Snobbery]**, and **[Aristoradar]** Perks have changed!

[Old Money] changed to **[Born in the Purple]**: Your chances of gaining treasures after killing monsters are tripled.

[**Snobbery**] changed to [**For the Emperor**]: When you lead them in battle, your soldiers and vassals gain a stat and moral bonus proportional to your Charisma.

[**Aristoradar**] changed to [**Dynasty**]: You can grant a [Noble] level to others at will. You can only grant one level per person after which, they must level up the class on their own.

Vainqueur thought it nice that the system recognized his authority, but now that he had his sweet stipend, that class interested him less. At least the level and that [Born in the Purple] Perk would increase his monthly gains.

Thinking of gains... “Manling Victor, has this misunderstanding with your duchess’ untimely demise been cleared with your species?”

“I dunno.” The minion shrugged. “It should resolve itself once the news of Furibon’s demise reaches them, or else it never will for anything. Your Majesty wants to go on an adventure again?”

“One with a princess,” Vainqueur said. “Bragging Day will arrive soon, and I need a princess to parade as the crown jewel of my hoard.”

“Your Majesty already brags all the time,” Minion Victor replied. “Every day is Bragging Day.”

“Yes, but not to dragons,” Vainqueur said, his minion frowning when he mentioned his amazing species. “This is Bragging Day. Now that my hoard is cured of lead sickness, it has grown big enough to brag about to the rest of my kind; but a true hoard is not complete without a princess caught in the wild to showcase. I want to hold a Bragging Day here in two moons, so find me a well-paid quest with a princess.”

“Is Your Majesty going to eat the princess?” the minion asked worryingly. “I know you said you wouldn’t, but... if this is a special occasion...”

“Minion, I am not a savage. I will keep it until the end of the Bragging Day, then I release her so she grows into a queen, and makes more princesses. So

will continue the cycle of life. I am a dragon mindful of preserving the wildlife.”

“Okay good.” His minion breathed in relief. “How many dragons are we talking about? No offense, but Your Majesty is already a lot for us mortals to handle.”

Vainqueur thought about it long and deep. He would invite every member of his kind whom he had remained in contact with, so he could showcase his wealth in a great show of dominance.

“No more than two hundred,” Vainqueur said, the minion losing all colors on his skin. “You should prepare the cattle already. It would be very miserly of me not to show my wealth by welcoming them with a great feast.”

“Two... two hundred...”

“I know, so few, but we dragons enjoy our alone time too much to stay in touch,” Vainqueur explained. “Most of my kindred are hunting princesses in the north, in lands so cold I freeze thinking of them.”

The minions returned with both that strange squid who worshipped the ground Manling Victor walked on and Minion Barnabas. The troll struggled to carry a crown, helped by the kobolds.

The second he saw it, Vainqueur immediately fell in love with the trinket.

It was the most beautiful crown he had ever set his eyes on; a golden, dragon-sized diadem with three miniature copies of Vainqueur rising from the front of the circlet, surrounding an enormous ruby. Four ivory horns were mounted on the edges, giving it a strong, yet elegant look; it would mesh so well with his own natural horns.

“This is a [Crown of Dragon Authority], Yer Majesty,” Barnabas said. “+10 Charisma, and a whole host of benefits.”

“Mine!” Vainqueur’s hands greedily reached for it, putting it on his head at once. The crown fit right around his black horns, and the dragon

immediately looked at his reflection in his hoard's coins.

Pure perfection!

Which was him!

“I am Emperor Vainqueur Knightsbane, owner of all I see!” Vainqueur boasted, the minions falling to their knees. “Praise me! Cheer me up!”

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” "Vainqueur, best dragon!" "Vainqueur, best dragon!"

Chapter 21: Interlude: The Shining Knight

- **1291 After Mithras, Mithras' heavenly realm.**

Death *sucked*. Not as much as she thought, though.

Kia had never been religious, and so, she expected a dark void and then nothing. Apparently though, religions were onto something.

The afterlife existed, and it looked like a greek temple made of marble, golden clouds and shining light. Whichever god ruled this place had given her a comfortable chair on which to sit, in front of a bright pyre.

“Kia Bekele.”

She raised her eyes, finding that what she thought to be pillars were in fact the legs of two immense figures.

The first was a great man with marble-like skin, like a statue chiseled from the stone. The entity wore a crown of flames and carried a blazing sword, hidden below a royal mantle. It was the archetypal king, with two suns for eyes glancing down at Kia with kind benevolence. “I am Mithras, god of the sun, law, healing, and justice,” he presented himself with a warm, booming voice.

“And I am Leone, goddess of glory, nobility, art, and strength.” The second was a true knight in shining armor, a woman with blonde hair, glowing blue eyes, and clad in golden armor. She carried a great sword anchored in the ground with both hands on the pommel, and radiated an aura of bravery.

“We are two of the twelve gods of Outremonde.”

Outremonde?

“A coin has two faces, Kia,” Mithras said. “Earth is but one world among many, and it has a twin. Outremonde. A world similar to yours in shape, but with dragons instead of planes, magic instead of science. A world threatened by a great blight, and in dire need of heroes.”

“You died an early death on Earth before you could fulfill your destiny,” Leone continued, Kia wondering if they were married or very close friends to synchronize so well. “But death is a door. It can lead you to whatever afterlife awaits, or to a new chance in Outremonde.”

“Like reincarnation?” Like the novels she read online?

“If you wish,” Mithras explained her options. “We can return you to Outremonde as you are now, with all that you carry. Or we can reincarnate you into the body of a man, an elf, a dwarf, or even a cat. As long as it is neither a fomor nor a dragon, you can become anything, or anyone.”

“That’s... oddly specific,” Kia pointed out.

“Fomors have no soul and thus you cannot incarnate as one. Dragons...” Leone made a face of absolute disgust, before regaining her composure. “Dragons are forbidden. You will be granted divine blessings, and great boons, so you may forge yourself a new destiny. But great power comes with a certain obligation.”

Of course, there would be a catch. Kia hadn’t done anything extraordinary in life. She moved from Ethiopia to Europe with her parents, only to die a school student when her stupid boyfriend drove their car into another. Beyond some charity work in her free time, she had nothing heroic to present. “You have a mission for me.”

Leone nodded. “The people of Outremonde are threatened by an ancient foe, the fairy lords of the fomor.”

“They are not the little fairies of your movies. The fomors are soulless abominations, wicked witches, eaters of children, and cruel giants. They

treat humans as toys or food, and create life only to enslave it. They uplifted the beastkin by giving animals the gift of intelligence, only to hunt them for sport. They are foul tyrants who once ruled Outremonde with an iron fist alongside their dragon rivals, before our fellow deity Dice came along.”

“Through our support and the power of Classes, humans and other species have slowly pushed them back in the dark corner of Outremonde. But almost a century ago, one of them decided to fight back.”

Mithras raise a hand, and miniature phantom pictures appeared in front of Kia, like holograms.

The scene represented a medieval city inhabited by humans and assaulted by monsters. Trolls, ogres, winged harpies and other horrors had breached fortified walls, setting the city on fire while fighting a collapsing defense of knights and magicians. It would have looked awesome if the battle wasn’t horribly one-sided in the horde’s favor.

A monstrous rider the size of skyscrapers rampaged around the city, crushing houses with every step. The creature, a humanoid, rode a giant lizard with spikes on its back as if it was a horse.

Was that a D&D tarrasque? Or Godzilla? And something was *riding* it?

The giant riding it looked like a monstrous, headless knight, carrying an enormous axe of flesh and bone with one hand. A floating eye of blue flames hovered where the head should have been, glaring down with malice at the small people the monster cut mercilessly.

“King Balaur, strongest and foulest of the fomors, has raised a terrible army and wages war against the Mistral continent,” Mithras explained with a grim voice. “Countries have fallen to him, and now Gardemagne, the stronghold of mankind, is threatened with destruction. If he succeeds, Balaur will soak the continent with the blood of all mortals, so they may never rise again to challenge the fomors.”

“Why do you not help the mortals directly?” It always bugged her why deities never seem to do so in stories, and that creature seemed like a threat

big enough to warrant it. “That thing looks *nasty*.”

“We would like to, and once I did,” Mithras said, surprising her. “But we are not all-powerful. We are closer to your Olympians, or your Aesir. We are powerful and we cannot die, but we have our limits.”

“A millennia ago, we gods agreed not to fight on Outremonde itself,” Leone said. “For when we did, we caused more harm than good, with no clear winner. Another god, Sablar the World Eater, supports the fomors in his quest for universal decimation, and thus prevents us from intervening. So for now, all we can do is guide and empower mortals. We can reincarnate people from Earth, by ‘claiming’ their souls, and making them our champions.”

“So, if I agree to fight this Balaur, I will be granted a new life and amazing powers?”

“This will be a dangerous journey, and you may very well die,” Mithras said. “But know that if you die in the line of duty, you will be granted a place in our divine realm. Neither will you be alone.”

“We reincarnated many other humans from your world, who had the potential to become true heroes,” Leone confirmed Kia’s own thoughts, “Together, you will form a great crusade and fight as one against Balaur.”

They were bribing her with heaven?

Now that she knew it existed, how could she resist?

“Can I get a better body?” she asked, a bit embarrassed. Kia was black, with a nerdy look and glasses; the kind of girl who spent their time in the library without seeing the light of day. She had always had some sort of body issue over it, and so seized the chance. “I want to stay human and close to what am I, just... better-looking.”

“That can be arranged,” Leone said, who didn’t sound surprised.

“Yes. I don’t want too much change, just to be in better health, not need glasses, and have a beautiful face. I know that sounds stupid, but...”

“This is not stupid, Kia,” Mithras reassured her with kindness, “In fact, you are more mature and humble than the others.”

“Ah? How so?”

“Most of them ask for bigger... implements... and I shall not sully myself by giving lurid details.”

“You can get a bigger chest? Is that on the table?”

The gods’ stare became cold and unbearable.

“I was kidding,” Kia said, who wasn’t sure herself. The offer was good, and she was in no hurry to find whatever ‘normal’ afterlife awaited her. “I’m in.”

“Thank you, Kia,” said Mithras. “Shall we, Leone?”

“Beforehand, though, can I ask you a question?” The gods nodded at Kia’s demand. “Why me, among all the others? What made me special?”

The deities exchanged a glance in uncomfortable silence. After long, agonizing seconds, Kia grew very nervous.

“I do not have the heart to tell her,” Leone told Mithras.

The god sighed in response, glancing down at Kia. “Kia. I am the god of justice. Truth and honesty are under my purview, which means I am physically unable to lie, no matter how much I would like to spare someone's feelings. My words will be the objective truth, so please, do not take anything I say personally.”

Kia prepared herself for impact.

“You are bland, and forgettable.”

Kia sank deeper in her chair.

“You were largely irrelevant in your previous life, and while you died with good karma, it was more because of an absence of evil deeds than any worthwhile quality. You are, for a lack of a better word, *mediocre*, but *passable*.”

Never before did Kia thought words could hurt so much.

“We have already reincarnated all the people whom you could call true hero material, but the fomors either killed them, or they are not enough on their own. We are, to use your local expressions, scraping the bottom of the barrel, and accepting anyone with remotely good karma. We hope that where quality failed, quantity will succeed. The situation is that terrible. Even if we do not expect it, you have the potential, with some boons and luck, to become a hero. It is *unlikely* but *possible*.”

By now, Kia’s self-esteem had been torn to shreds, and she couldn’t find her words.

“But no pressure,” Leone tried to reassure her, with a forced smile.

No, not at all.

"You can still become a hero, and seize the chance to grow into a legend," Mithras said, kinder than before. "Even if you fail, I will welcome you in my realm, where you could enjoy a bountiful afterlife. The choice is yours."

She liked the idea a lot less than before, but it was still better than the alternative.

Both deities raised a hand at her, and two symbols materialized on the back of each of Kia’s palm as tattoos: a shining, golden sun, and a shield with a stylized pen symbol.

Congratulations! You were granted a level in the prestigious [**Paladin**]
Class!

+1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

You earned the [**Holy Champion**] Class Perk, and the [**Claimed by Mithras**] and [**Claimed by Leone**] Personal Perks!

[Holy Champion]: You gain advanced proficiency with Swords and Spears, all attacks you make with any weapon will inflict additional Holy Damage.

[Claimed by Mithras]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Charisma or Strength point. You are also immune to all Fire and Holy effects, except those caused by Mithras or his servants.

[Claimed by Leone]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Vitality or Skill point. You gain a 30 percent experience bonus whenever you finish a quest or slay a monster.

Mediocre and passable?

Kia promised herself that she would show them they were wrong.

She would show them all.

- **1301 After Mithras, three days after Emperor Vainqueur's self-coronation.**

“KIA! KIA! Get your ass out here!”

Kia awoke from her slumber with a heavy headache, the bottle of wine she drank last night on the side of her king-sized bed. The morning sun bothered her through the windows, making her groan and draw the bedsheet to herself.

She heard her butler reason with the guest on the other side of the door. “Sir Nostredame, the Shining Knight does not wish to be bothered... she doesn't feel well...”

“I'm her teammate, I've seen her in the most humiliating positions imaginable. A bad morning is tame.”

Recognizing the man's voice, Kia let out a frustrated moan. “Let the sucker in...”

The door opened with a kick, and a tall, charming dark elf with dark skin and short white hair stepped in. He wore shadowy blue and gold robes brimming with magical power, alongside a host of powerful artifacts, from rings to a silver diadem. His purple eyes set on her with heavy disapproval. “Kia, what the hell, it’s one in the afternoon!”

Her hands reached for the stuff laying below her bed. She grabbed her legendary sword Arondight, forged to kill the mightiest of dragons, and used it as a cane to stand out of bed. “What’s the matter...”

“Kia, my gods, are you *drunk*?” He closed the door behind before opening the window with telekinesis, letting fresh air inside.

“No, I just had... a little too much wine last night... gimme a sec...” She put a hand on her chest. “[Cure].”

The hangover ended with an aura of green light, and Kia could think properly again. “Better,” she said, standing straight and smirking at her old teammate, “Hi, Kevin.”

“It’s Nostredame!” her friend lambasted her. “How many times did I tell you to use my hero name?”

Kia remembered, but still teased him. Like many other Claimed, Kevin had chosen a new, fantasy-sounding name upon arriving in Outremonde. Since they were thick as thieves, he let her get away with it for the same reason she was comfortable letting him in her room while she only wore white lingerie.

Kia moved towards her bedroom’s two-meters high mirror, adjusting her hair. When the gods reincarnated her, they altered her appearance to the point she forgot her old one. Her new body in that strange world resembled the model Liya Kebede, with shoulder-long black hair, lustrous dark skin, and piercing eyes. She had lost some muscle and gained fat since she started living in the vineyard, but she still looked more like an amazon than a fragile flower.

Most lusted at her on sight, to the point of making her uncomfortable, but Kevin didn't. That nerd only loved magic and math, to the point that he asked to become a dark elf because it would make his Intelligence growth better. "The butler told me you drank all the time," Kevin scolded her. "I know we had epic, messy parties back in the day, but drinking alone isn't like you."

"I don't have anything better to do," Kia admitted.

Two years ago, two hundred experienced adventurers in the sixty level range and above fought King Balaur at the Golden Fields, Kia among them, in an epic battle for the continent's future. Each of them had the best equipment, including artifacts, preparation time, and a well-oiled strategy.

By the time Kia landed the final blow, they were down to eleven.

But at long last, with their leader dead, the fomors fell into infighting, their horde scattering, and the stragglers easy picking for adventurers. While generals like Mag Mell successfully retreated to their homeland of Prydain, the war was over. Mortal life would endure.

Kia, as one of the greatest heroines of Gardemagne, was granted the title of Shining Knight and noble lands. Including a vineyard estate where she spent most of her free time nowadays. Kevin, meanwhile, had become the headmaster of Gardemagne's royal academy and an advisor to the king.

And it bored her to death.

Kia had now reached beyond level sixty, and almost nothing could threaten her anymore. Well, some powerful monsters could, but after that legendary battle with King Balaur, everything felt like a let-down. Instead of going on epic quests, she spent her days making speeches or courted by nobles wishing to marry the Heroine of the Golden Fields. Even one of Gardemagne's princes had gotten to it.

'Back in the day,' as Kevin said. Kia felt like these cranky old people ranting about the 'good old times,' and she *hated* it.

Her eyes trailed to her bright, green starmetal armor and shields standing in a corner. Maybe she could go back on the road as a solo hero, fighting the fomors in Prydain, or exploring the western continent?

“Do you want a drink?” Kia offered her friend, as he snapped his fingers, causing a table covered with paper to appear, alongside chairs.

“No thanks,” he said, sitting and inviting her to do the same. “I came for business, actually.”

He did? Kia was suddenly all ears since business usually involved the fomors or Brandon Maure. “The King finally decided to invade Ishfania?”

“Not yet, and we have a new fox in the hen house. A great red dragon appeared in the south and caused a lot of turmoil there. He has been identified as Vainqueur Knightsbane, an elder red wyrm who terrorized Midgard before it was destroyed by Balaur and then assimilated by Gardemagne. He was presumed dead during the Century War, but so far, reports and divinations agree that this is the real deal.”

An elder red wyrm. Like a fomor, one would need a party in the fifties to kill it. Kia could probably take it down solo, so bringing the entire party was overkill. “How dangerous?” she asked, her hopeful tone surprising her. “The name sounds familiar. I think I heard stories about him.”

“He’s pretty much the archetypal dragon in Outremonde, at least in the southern lands. He was considered the greatest calamity of the age, before King Balaur came along, and earned the Knightsbane nickname because he killed every hero who challenged him.”

“I figured. The king wants me to deal with it?” It would change her mind and distract her for a bit.

“Actually, it’s... it’s more complicated than that. I don’t know how to say it with a straight face but... He has a human partner, and they...” Kia frowned, as her friend struggled to find his words. He eventually gave her a short letter. “Just read.”

Kia proceeded to, and the more she read, the more confused she was.
“*Emperor Vainqueur Knightsbane? V&V adventurer company?*”

“The dragon wants to be paid with lands and gold for destroying one of Maure’s generals, the lich Furibon.”

“What do you mean, the dragon wants to be *paid*?” She quickly figured it out. “Don’t tell me...”

“The adventurer guild recognized Vainqueur Knightsbane and his human partner as an adventurer company, plates included. With Furibon’s destruction, they should be upgraded to gold-rank, but after the Euskal fiasco, they will probably settle on the politically safer iron or bronze.”

The Euskal fiasco? What did she miss last night? “A dragon. A dragon adventurer.”

“With class levels.”

Dragons could get class levels? She thought they were like the fomors, soulless, and thus unable to access the system, even after being informed of its existence. “How did this happen? Start from the beginning.”

“The human partner is Victor Dalton. He is a Claimed of Dice, who ended up joining the Nightblades shortly after arriving in Outremonde. He took levels in the [Outlaw] class and had a short—”

“Dalton,” Kia interrupted him. “His family name is *Dalton*, and he started as an *Outlaw*?”

“Yes, he was predisposed for evil. Imagine if his name had been Dick Dalton.” Kia couldn’t help but chuckle. “Anyway, he worked for the Nightblades syndicate in Noblecoeur before leaving to become an adventurer. He was hired by the Marquise of Carabas through the Albain chapter of the adventurer guild to recover a rapier, which led him to Vainqueur’s lair. We do not know what happened there, but three things were certain afterward: Vainqueur returned, Dalton had become his

accomplice, and they forced the local guild to declare them an official adventurer company.”

“Is Dalton—”

“He doesn’t control the dragon as far as I can tell, but my apprentice, whom I sent to investigate, told me he accessed a Monster Class called [Monster Squire]. I suspect he sold his soul to the dragon in exchange for power.” The archwizard presented her two piles of paper. “I have two radically different versions of the events that followed, both plausible and with nothing in between. I do not know what to make of them.”

“Tell me,” Kia asked. “The more information we have, the better we can deal with them.”

“The first version is mostly based on the testimony of the nobles and their retinues,” Kevin warned. “Dalton and Vainqueur first moved to Carabas to wreak ‘revenge’ on the marquise, burning her lands and threatening her into surrendering a tribute of gold and food. The marquise tried to have the dragon poisoned, but he shrugged it off, and Dalton blackmailed them for items.”

Well, that escalated quickly. Kia guessed that dragons and outlaws remained monsters, no matter what they called themselves.

“The two then occupied the town of Haudemer, on the west coast. Our spies tell us they sought to recover an artifact hidden by a Claimed who escaped Brandon Maure’s clutches, the Apple of Knowledge. After the duo devastated the countryside, recruiting savage monsters along the way, the Scorchers fought them over the artifact and were massacred. After the carnage, Dalton...” Her friend paused. “Do you really want me to give you the ugly details?”

Kia nodded, a dark look on her face.

“He... Dalton ordered one of the women to *breed* with him.”

Kia tightened her hold over her sword, thinking how she would castrate that criminal with it.

“Duchess Aelinor arrived with knights and crusaders to free Haudemer, but Vainqueur crushed them. Then, when she refused to pay him a tribute of gold, he ate the duchess alive. Dalton, who had already sold corpses to necromancers, began to raise monsters from the dead as undead slaves, and together they slew a dozen adventurer groups sent after them. They then moved to Murmurin, conquering it for themselves.”

So these two were a duo of villains, the likes of which Gardemagne hadn't seen since the end of the war. A human criminal and a savage dragon, who somehow managed to draw the worst out of the other.

Kia knew these were bad news, and that she shouldn't feel joy over it, but she once again brimmed at the call of a righteous quest. “What about the other version?”

“Well... I interrogated the local guild manager, especially about her experience with Victor, and she said: *'he is an idiot, and I wish him to suffer for bringing that dragon to my guildhall, but he is no villain. Just an idiot.'* The Count of Provencal said the arson was the result of a monster-extermination request that the dragon interpreted a bit too zealously, and that Victor saved his life by covering up the poisoning incident. As for Haudemer, they left a mixed memory to the locals, who say they saved them from the Scorchers at the cost of unnecessary property damage.”

“But what about the woman Dalton forced himself on?” Kia asked, appalled. “What about the undead business? The duchess' murder?”

“The victim of the *breeding* insists this was consensual and that, I quote, ‘eight out of ten, not the best I had, but I would gladly do it again.’ The undead deal was apparently a completely legal operation under the new Undead Labor Laws. While Dalton handled the paperwork, the dragon was the main pusher according to witnesses, for purely venal reasons. Finally, Dalton explained through letters that the duchess refused to pay Vainqueur for the Scorchers' demise, and it escalated into a fight. Aelinor's successor,

Justine De Sade, officially recognized that version and didn't press charges."

Kia digested the news in silence. Indeed, there was little middle ground between the two versions. "So they are either fiendish villains or destructive idiots."

"Or both."

"Show me a map of that 'empire of Murmurin'." Her friend showed a spot between Gardemagne and Ishfania's western frontier, bordering the sea. He circled a small area, making Kia laugh. "They call *that* an empire? You can't even fit Delaware inside!"

"What do you have against Delaware?" Kevin protested, since he came from there. "It's a dragon, Kia. Common sense doesn't apply to them. Remember that Black Wyrn in the swamps?"

Kia still shuddered at it. That dragon had abducted a dozen of noble ladies so it could 'raise princesses in captivity.' "Would that not help Gardemagne?" she asked her more politically-minded friend. "The dragon is right between the kingdom and Ishfania, and already declared war on Maure by taking over that area."

"In theory it does help us, but a dragon with class levels is something to watch out for. Dragons warred with the fomors for control of Outremonde until the fairies bribed them with gold. So far that wyrn asked to be paid in return for services rendered, but imagine if he realizes he can bully towns into giving him gold? And while a controversial figure, Victor worked with the Nightblades. He's a criminal."

Kia pondered the problem. Her gut told her these two were closer to amoral mercenaries than dangerous calamities, but she couldn't know before checking up first. "You said they claimed that region. They did it as an adventurer state?"

Her friend confirmed with a nod. Since Outremonde's lands were more than sixty percent unexplored, monster-ruled wilderness, Gardemagne allowed

adventurer companies to claim areas which they conquered. In theory, they worked as tributary states, but in practice, the company ruled their territory as its leaders saw fit. Gardemagne's ancestor, the Mithraic Empire, started as one such state.

Eventually, the kingdom fully absorbed these areas by making adventurers official nobles, but no adventurer state ever had a dragon at its head. Especially one calling himself emperor. Rebellious adventurers were usually crushed, but they weren't castle-destroying behemoths. "What does the King say about it?"

"His current stance is to ignore the dragon. Since duchess De Sade declined to press charges for her sister's death, and the beast destroyed Furibon, King Roland froze the bounty on Vainqueur's head. Better to let the wyrm play noble, he says, so long as he follows the guild's procedures and limits his aggression to the kingdom's enemies. Since everyone who picked a fight with Vainqueur died, and Murmurin is a monster-infested desert nobody wants, that seems reasonable."

"But you don't share his opinion."

"I'm wary of letting power get to a dragon's head since they are egomaniacs at best. Lucie already proposed to move to Murmurin to check on them, alongside a representative of the adventurer guild." Kia knew that by that, he truly meant a long-term spy of the kingdom. "Since you are looking for excitement..."

"I could check up on them, and take them down if needed."

Within an hour, Kia took her armor out of storage, and her gryphon out of his stable.

Chapter 22: The Meat is Life

“You call that a castle?” Vainqueur complained as he bathed in the lava around his new lair, “I demand at least seven towers! Work harder!”

“Yes, Emperor Vainqueur!” the kobolds shouted back, while Vainqueur briefly closed his eyes in satisfaction at the name. The minions had built a large bridge to carry raw material from the mountain to the castle, rebuilding the towers the dragon had destroyed during the War of the Hoard.

The hyena-like humanoid called gnolls carried most of the black stones making up the castle, the males doing most of the work under the supervision of their females. Vainqueur found their spotted fur and their clothes funny to look at.

As it turned out, the encampments south belonged to gnoll tribes who lived in fear of the dread Furibon, who allowed them to live and keep their gold so long as they obeyed him. Most had fled the region when Vainqueur warred against the lich, but the few who didn’t came to Murmurin looking for work. After condemning them for knowingly serving that cruel undead, Vainqueur forgave them and accepted them in his service.

The gnolls had proven lazy and cowardly though, unlike the zealous kobolds; they stopped working when Vainqueur wasn’t looking or picked fights with the other minions. The dragon had to eat twenty troublemakers before they started behaving.

“Also, the highest tower must have a crown!” Vainqueur ordered the minions. “A stone crown!” If it could give him more charisma, then surely, it would make his castle more beautiful.

“Your Majesty?” Vainqueur turned towards the bridge, seeing manling Victor riding that undead beast, with the corpseling and necromancer Jules Rapace on the back. Barnabas had dressed his chief of staff strangely, granting him a cowled, tattered mantle and dark boots. “I see you’re enjoying the new accommodations.”

“The temperature is just right, minion,” Vainqueur said, although he was careful not to let his crown too close lest it melt. The dragon felt some sympathy for his chief of staff, whose lack of immunity to fire prevented him from partaking in the bath.

“Emperor Vainqueur,” Jules the corpseling saluted the dragon with great deference. “How good to see you again. Words cannot properly express my gratitude.”

“A dragon does not turn away good minions,” Vainqueur said. Especially those he could digest, unlike that steel golem. “You should have asked to join V&V back in that backward village, instead of waiting so long. I know a true dragon may intimidate your kind, but I am an equal opportunity master.”

“I didn’t know Your Majesty would go this far back then. How could I resist the call of a country lacking Gardemagne’s heavy taxation on undead labor, and open to the idea of mass zombification? I feel a great corpse boom will soon start, and that the Empire of Murmurin may kickstart the undeathstrial revolution I dream of.”

“Interesting,” Vainqueur replied, trying to calculate how much funds they could gain from that business. “Now, for the important matter. My hoard was treacherously attacked by Furibon, who was evil enough to attack innocent, defenseless gold. It almost died of sickness.”

“I had him read the book, Your Majesty,” said manling Victor. “We used mimics to print it en mass.”

“It is a national best-seller,” Vainqueur boasted. Everyone should learn of his great deeds, and how he saved the world’s gold from the lich. “My

hoard must learn to defend itself, especially if I am on an adventure and not present to protect it. Minion Victor said you could help.”

“I can indeed imbue your hoard with the ability for self-defense,” Jules the corpseling said.

“Then show me.”

Manling Victor and Jules climbed down from the mount, with the chief of staff giving a purse full of gold to his corpseling minion. Vainqueur watched the scene closely.

Spilling gold on the bridge, corpseling Jules cast a spell on it. “[Animate Golem].”

To Vainqueur’s marvel, the coins combined into a vaguely humanoid shape, a tiny, shiny engine of destruction. “This is the miniature version, but Jules can make golems the size of Your Majesty,” Manling Victor said.

“They will obey Your Majesty’s orders, and attack anyone trying to pilfer your treasure without authorization,” Jules said. “I may add alarm spells to the underground vault, to warn you of intruders no matter the distance.”

“You shall do so, Corpseling, and you shall be rewarded for your good deed. You shall be moved between Manling Victor and the other minions in my emergency ration priority list. You are now equal to the Kobold Rangers in the food chain.”

“Your Majesty’s generosity honors me,” the corpseling replied with a deep bow.

“Minion Victor informed me I would not be able to gain levels beyond thirty,” Vainqueur asked. “Why is that?”

“The ‘why’ is a mystery, but people need to use items called Crests to gain additional levels. This may be the system’s way to test if users are ready for greater challenges beyond mere experience progression.”

Vainqueur promised himself to have a word with the dragons who created this system when he found them. “Where can they be found?”

“Crests are heavily regulated by adventurer guilds and governments,” Jules explained. “The Gardemagnian Guild confiscate all Crests they can and issue them only with the King’s authorization. This allows them to control the levels of people, and reduce the number of dangerous criminals.”

“I sent a request, but I doubt it will lead anywhere,” Victor said.

“Otherwise, I believe Your Majesty will have to find one by conquering dungeons, fulfilling quests, or buy one on the black market.”

Vainqueur frowned. “Corpseling, repeat the last sentence.”

“Since Crests often find their ways through the government’s grasp, Your Majesty could buy one the Black Market for a sizeable sum.”

Yes, that was indeed the word he used. *Buying*. Even thinking of it made Vainqueur sick. “So I must destroy more Furibons to earn a Crest,” he said, refusing to entertain the other possibilities.

“Your Majesty may also contact the fomors if they are desperate,” Jules said. “The fomor Mag Mell created artificial items called Dark Crests, which break the level ceiling, but come with dangerous side-effects.”

The fomors? Those upstart fairies who pretended they had created the world when obviously dragons did it first? Vainqueur despised them as much as he did the lich. “Could a quest with a princess yield a Crest?”

“I’m afraid I cannot say. Crests are generated by the system without warning.”

“Minion Victor, we will try to fetch a Crest while hunting princesses.”

“Princesses?” Manling Victor picked up. “With an s?”

“I need three princesses now,” Vainqueur confirmed with a serious tone.

“What?” Manling Victor once again proved terrible at math. “Three princesses? Why?”

“Because my hated rival Icefang has caught twins,” Vainqueur said, the mere thought of that frost dragon outdoing him driving him mad. “I will not be overshadowed at my own Bragging Day, so I will have *three* princesses to parade.”

Manling Victor put a hand on his face for some reason, before sighing, “Unfortunately, Brandon Maure has no daughter, so we can’t kidnap her.”

“Minion, it is not kidnapping, it is capture. A true dragon has enough class not to kidnap baby princesses.” Also, Vainqueur heard they cried all the time.

“Your Majesty, quests with one princess are rare, let alone three of them.”

“Minion, you are my grand dragon vizier, my second-in-command, and the warden of Furibon,” the dragon reminded his minion. “I push you hard because I know you will rise to the occasion.”

Manling Victor stared blankly at his beloved master, awed by the positive reinforcement. “Hm, thanks, Your Majesty.”

“You are welcome, minion,” Vainqueur replied, “If needed, we will capture these princesses separately instead of as a set. Also, we have a quest specialist in town. Ask her.”

After his coronation, the adventurer guild had finally cleared that mess with Vainqueur’s last noble meal, with a guildhall manager settling in Murmurin and granting them iron plates to replace the copper.

The manlings had sent Manling Charlene, whose skin was constantly red, and her mood always foul.

Vainqueur didn't know the reason, but this should make her more open to breeding with Manling Victor, which was why he encouraged his minion to spend time with her. The dragon was losing patience with his chief minion’s

inability to sire a new litter of minions, the only black spot on his otherwise perfect record.

“Charlene is never in a good mood when she sees me,” Manling Victor said. “Also, while I am all for chasing princesses, we have a much more urgent matter to deal with. Namely, the *food*.”

“Have you not already started solving this problem?” Vainqueur climbed out of the lava, peeking over the crater’s edge with his head. “Look at how greener it is!”

While the lands right next to the volcano were somewhat fertile, the region was too dry to feed Vainqueur’s guests for Bragging Day. So Minion Victor, ever the perfect Doer of the Thing, organized a great greening project with the added minion workforce. Gnolls dug canals from the sea and towards Murmurin, while kobolds gathered trees which provided shade for grass; Rolo the steel golem had taught them how to use devices called spades, which could also be used to mine gold.

Vainqueur almost regretted firing him.

“Rolo and Allison plant trees, while the minions build irrigation canals or pits to draw water from the mountain’s underground sources,” Manling Victor said. “According to Rolo, we need magical plants which thrive on sandy soil and will remove the salt from saltwater. We also experimented with seawater greenhouses for agriculture—”

“Minion,” Vainqueur interrupted him. “Twenty-five is not fifty. Try to make shorter sentences.”

The manling blinked. “How did you count them? Anyway, what I mean to say is, based on Your Majesty’s average diet, and accounting for excesses, we need at least *two hundred and fifty tons of meat* for Bragging Day, and that is a conservative estimation.”

Corpseling Jules counted in his head. “So, roughly two thousand and five hundred well-fed sheep, or four hundred cows, per day.”

“Sheeps, with a s,” Vainqueur corrected him.

The corpseling didn’t understand Vainqueur, which reminded the dragon why he needed a translator with animals. “Your Majesty, the plural of sheep is sheep.”

“Of course not,” Vainqueur replied, educating the minion. “How else could you tell one sheep from many? This would be confusing.”

“Your Majesty, I insist—”

“I am a dragon. You will say sheeps, or you will be sheep.”

Jules said nothing, with Manling Victor putting a hand on his back and shaking his head. “Still, Your Majesty,” the chief of staff said. “We don’t have the means to feed our own minion population, let alone so many dragons.”

“Minions, you fail to notice the perfectly good rations building my castle,” Vainqueur said, eying the gnolls and the werewolves. Only the kobolds, he couldn’t bear to sacrifice and would have to hide from his kindred. “Also, that way, it means less mouths to feed.”

“I would rather not,” Manling Victor said.

“Then summon fiends. They are plentiful if rancid and bitter.”

“At this rate, I think we will depopulate Hell faster than Heaven ever did. Your Majesty, we need more resources, more food, than we can provide right now. I’m using everything we have, even having Jules scour the countryside to revive decades old corpses as undead labor, and two moons is still too short a time window.”

“Well, Victor, since you use seawater greenhousing, you must accumulate a lot of salt, do you not?” corpseling Jules said, “It is highly sought after, especially to slow down zombie degradation. I can use my contacts with Gardemagne to exchange them for fresh meat.”

“And you shall be granted a one one-tenth commission,” Vainqueur encouraged the corpseling.

“I’ve also been toying with other activities to build funds,” Manling Victor crossed his arms, “Since Your Majesty forbids taxes, and keeps the underground vaults, they could keep deposits safe from thieves for a cut.”

Vainqueur glanced at his minion with a knowing look. “No manling in their right mind would try to steal from a dragon, is that what you imply?”

“I didn’t know Your Majesty was alive!” the minion protested.

Vainqueur considered the proposition. Protecting the hoards of the world appealed to him, but on the other hand, it went against his dragon instinct to keep those of others without seizing them as his own. It sounded a lot like being a banker, which was a manling absurdity. “Are we that desperate for meat?” he asked his chief of staff.

“Yes. Yes, we *are*.”

Vainqueur didn’t believe it. They were desperate for meat to feed both his guests and the minions. If they sacrificed the latter, they would satisfy the former.

However, he could see that Manling Victor was desperate to save as many of them as possible; and Vainqueur had grown attached to a few of them, especially the Kobold Rangers.

After the torture he suffered from Furibon and his hard work, Vainqueur decided to indulge his chief of staff. He would make a sacrifice for Bragging Day. “Then no hoard shall be left defenseless in my empire. Minions and hoarders may send me their treasures if they fear for their safety, and I shall protect them from the Furibons of the world.”

Congratulations! For showing a sliver of true nobility and understanding a true leader often puts his minions’ well-being first, you have gained a level in [**Kaiser**].

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 SKI, +1 VIT, +1 INT, +1 CHA!

A sliver of nobility?

“Well, now we are officially dragon Switzerland,” Manling Victor said, although Vainqueur didn’t understand the last word.

“I also declare that all creatures dying within my service will be reanimated to work as sentient undead, as were the Kobold Rangers,” Vainqueur decided. “No need for death to end their fulfilling jobs. They shall serve me in death, as well as in life.”

“I do not raise thinking undead for ethical reasons, and Your Majesty will need size—”

“I will take care of that,” Manling Victor said, putting a hand on Jules’ shoulder. “But can I get an exception, Your Majesty?”

“Minion, you will not die on my watch unless we run out of other minions and I starve,” Vainqueur said, before remembering the fragile manlings could die of old age.

“While I will not do the deed, I can ask a less ethical colleague to bring you back as a thinking undead, Victor,” corpseling Jules proposed, although his chief of staff didn’t seem so keen on the idea, “A vampire, or a ghoul? Perhaps even a lich, if you are ready to make a live sacrifice to Camil—”

“No lich!” Vainqueur snarled, making the crater tremble. “Minion, I forbid you from becoming a lich!”

“I would rather live longer as a living creature, than forever as an undead,” said Victor.

But come to think of it, Manling Victor was indeed mortal and fragile. Vainqueur had already almost lost him to Furibon. They would need to solve that problem as soon as possible before he suffered a tragic minion death. “Manling Victor, how long do Manlings live?”

“I dunno, eighty years?” Vainqueur laughed at the paltry number, the minion frowning. “Some of us reach one hundred!”

“You can calculate your longevity with your Health Point, Victor,” said Jules, “Take your maximum Health Points, then divide it by six; if you have aging resistance, you can double it, as you age two times slower. Other elements increase longevity or outright grant immunity to aging, such as the ‘Claimed by Sablar’ perk or the Undead Type.”

The minion did the calculation, as did Vainqueur. “Two hundred forty-five?” was the number his chief of staff came up with. “I can live up to two hundred forty-five?”

“And I shall live to two thousand years,” Vainqueur boasted, before realizing the problem. “A dragon *can* die of old age?”

“There is little chance for anyone to die of old age,” said the corpseling. “According to my research, you have a fifty to sixty percent chance of dying by violence in Outremonde, either in battle or from depredation, and twenty percent to sickness.”

“That will not be a problem for us,” Vainqueur replied with confidence, but he found the number worrying. Two hundred and a half was very short. “Minion.”

“Yes?”

“Find a way to become immortal. You still have too much work to do.”

Chapter 23: The Regent

“Hi, Charlene.” Victor waved at the poor office manager, as he rode through the town square while on top of his new mount, the Black Beast of Murmurin. “What’s up?”

The guild manager glared back at him. Her ‘office’ was composed of a board, a desk, and a chair in the middle of the town’s square, gnolls and kobolds often checking the few requests available.

Murmurin had grown thrice-fold since the ‘War of the Hoard’, with minions building more houses or tents to accommodate newcomers. A giant stone statue of Vainqueur stood in the middle of the town, with Vainqueur Junior buried underground right next to it, ready to ambush anyone trying to pull the false sword.

They had been forced to equip the locals with axes and spears, or otherwise, Junior became jealous and tried to eliminate the competition. Even Victor’s rapier had suffered his envious wrath.

Since he reaped most benefits by wielding a scythe, Victor gave Red Ranger the musket which he stole from Vilmain. The raptor had proven himself an incredibly deadly shot, gaining [Gunslinger] levels at a pace that surprised even the chief of staff. The Kobold Rangers had become the official sheriffs of Murmurin, keeping the monsters in line. In fact, they had even started taking requests from Charlene as official members of V&V, chasing rogue monsters who didn’t submit to the ‘Emperor’s’ authority.

They had a pretty effective strategy too. The weaker rangers ganged up on and exhausted the troublemaker, and then Red swooped in to deliver a finishing blow.

Kobolds being kobolds, they surrendered their gains to Vainqueur all the time.

“I hate you,” Charlene told him, clearly not happy to be here. Since she was the most familiar with V&V, having named them, the higher-ups had transferred her to Murmurin instead of someone else. “I hate you and that dragon so much.”

“No need to be snappy,” Victor replied. “I’m still sore about that iron plate. Our company destroyed an ancient lich who killed gold-plated adventurers, and we’re not even bronze?”

“They took the politically safe path with your company. I wonder *why*.”

Since civilized species feared Vainqueur, only other monsters and unsavory characters had started moving into Murmurin. Which meant only monsters or close enough creatures like Jules the ghoul made up the company, and with his new Perk, even Victor counted as one now.

They were the first fully-inclusive monster adventurer company.

“Also, just feel thankful I let you keep your adventurer fee behind Vainqueur’s back,” he told Charlene. “No tax, so spoke the Emperor.”

“I wouldn’t even be here if you hadn’t told that dragon about classes and levels.”

“If it had been anyone else getting that rapier, Vainqueur would have destroyed the nearby villages in his fury,” Victor pointed out, before glancing at the board. “We’re looking for princess-oriented quests. With three princesses, and which would make Brandon Maure’s life miserable if possible. Do you have any?”

She gave him the ‘are you serious’ look, then twitched upon realizing he wasn’t. She stared at him blankly, then turned around, seized an isolated request on the board, then gave it to him.

‘The Demon King’s Captive

Rank: Gold.

Giver: King Roland Gardemagne.

Brandon Maure is a fiend infamous for collecting foreign beauties as trophies. Imperial princesses from the fallen Sablaris empire, noble ladies from the Harmonian League... and the king's own niece, Princess Merveille, abducted as a child during the war and kept as a political hostage. The King offers a boon to the rescuer of Merveille, so long as it is within the bounds of reason.'

“A harem? Maure kidnaps women as brides?”

“No, of course not. He sacrifices them to demons for power.” Yeah, somehow that made it sound better. “Maure has captive princesses kept in his capital of Mauria, so if you want to die to the demon king, please consider picking it up.”

Like the salt of the earth, Croissant joined them, aiming for Victor, but his eyes getting sidetracked upon catching sight of Charlene. “Oh,” Croissant looked at the office manager like an appetizing meal. “Vic, you didn’t tell me you knew such a pretty woman.”

The guild manager smiled, slightly charmed. “Thank you.”

“I love mature women with lots of meat on them.” Victor shuddered at the wording, while Croissant put an arm on the guild’s counter. “What’s your name, pretty one?”

“Charlene.”

“I’m Croissant. I run this town.”

“He *did*,” Victor clarified, the werewolf glaring at him. This just encouraged the adventurer. “Now he’s run *over*.”

“Did they ruin your life too?” Charlene asked Croissant, giving him a sympathetic look.

“Like you wouldn’t believe.” The werewolf returned to his flirting. “Why don’t I give you a tour of the place, especially the spots the dragon doesn’t know about yet?”

Charlene’s mood improved tremendously. “This town may not be so bad after all.”

Yep, they would end up together. Although Victor still wondered if Croissant intended to eat her or flirt; maybe even both. “Before I vomit on Charlene’s counter, why are you here Croissant?”

“Savoureuse has brought a newcomer and is waiting for you at the town’s entrance, and Sis and Allison have a problem with a summoned demon who won’t let himself get killed at the temple. This’ gonna sound strange, but that woman outside creeps me out more than the demon.”

Victor would have loved to say this was the weirdest problem he had to deal with in Murmurin, but it wasn’t. At all. He sighed, then had his monster walk to the town’s entrance.

He found Savoureuse talking with a woman his age whose raven hair was tied with a white flower; she wore some kind of university uniform, and felt, for lack of a better word, off-putting.

“Hey, Vic!” Savoureuse waved at him. “How are you? I hope work isn’t stressful.”

“Not as stressful as getting kidnapped by a lich while you watched,” Victor replied with heavy sarcasm.

“Yes, but my life was in danger,” Savoureuse said. “I could not help.”

Yeah, right. Why was he friends with her again? For the food, he decided. And maybe the Crests, if she could smuggle one as he asked her to. If only Furibon had left one behind, but he had sent all of those found in the region to Brandon Maure to empowering his soldiers.

His eyes settled on the newcomer. “And who might you be?”

“Remember the woman I told you about?” Savoureuse asked, slightly embarrassed. “This is her.”

“My name is Lucie Lavere, of the Royal University of Gardemagne,” the newcomer said with a formal, professional posture. “I heard a lot about you and your master, Lord Victor.”

“Oh? From whom?” According to Savoureuse, this woman belonged to the Nightblades, and so she was bad news.

“Many, but especially my new friend Henry. Since the debacle with the Scorchers, I keep an eye on him so he does not get into trouble.”

Somehow, her tone implied something sinister... which it probably was. “Are you here to keep an eye on us too?” Victor asked, suspicious.

“Depends. Are you going to meddle with the wrong crowd?”

The conversation had taken a sharp turn towards the tense. He could play the game too. “Not unless you do it first.”

“I will not.” She smiled at him, but behind the smirk, there were sharp teeth. “I choose my friends carefully, and I think you may be a trustworthy, reliable fellow.”

He immediately used [Monster Insight] on her.

Lucie Sinistra Lavere

Alchemical Vampire (Undead/Humanoid)

Strong against Sunlight, Moon, Alchemy, Darkness, Unholy, Blood, Frost, Necromancy, Drain, Insta-Death, Mind-Control, Disease, Poison, Fatigue, Sleep, and Beast (Boss Undead, huh?).

Weak against Holy, Fire, Life, Berserk, Manslayer, and Deadslayer.

The archmage Nostredame’s prized student and top spy. Secretly a deadly monster lord and the criminal mastermind behind the Nightblades

syndicate. She's Evil with a capital E, MUCH stronger than anyone in Murmurin except Vainqueur, and currently reading your thoughts with creepy undead mind-reading. She knows you know.

In short, thou art BLEEPed.

"Interesting Perk that you have," the woman said, amused.

"How the hell can you walk under the sun?" Victor asked, his hand reaching for his scythe while Savoureuse watched, disturbed.

"Fairy flowers, gifted from one of my teachers," she replied, caressing the flower in her hair with her fingers. "I am repaying the favor by carrying some politically-minded tasks."

"Savoireuse told me you asked the Nightblades to support the Scorchers," Victor put the two and two together, growing more and more uneasy. "You are the one who handed Henry to Gustave and Vilmain. Are you working for Ishfania?"

"Sometimes. Sometimes, I work for Gardemagne. Nostredame asked me to report on your new 'empire.'" The name amused her as much as it did Vic. "But do not worry, I have no intention of bothering you. Unlike that lich in your scythe, I am not stupid enough to pick a fight with a dragon."

'In hindsight, I would not recommend it, no,' Furibon whispered from in the scythe, annoyed.

"I have come for Nightblade business alone. We are looking for a warehouse that could serve as a relay for our black market endeavors. If you agree to leave us alone, so will I. I will even turn a blind eye to your desertion. You know the usual punishment."

"Are you threatening me?" Victor wasn't amused. "No repossession here, or waste disposal, or Vainqueur will have you killed."

"Certainly," Lavere said. "Who in their right mind would try stealing from a dragon?"

Victor glanced away.

“You were.” The vampire chuckled. “Oh my, how far you have gone since then. You have even learned necromancy. Perhaps I could even give you... private lessons.”

Was she flirting or threatening him? Victor couldn't tell and didn't want to. In any case, she was creeping him out like nobody else ever did.

“As a token of good faith, I will tell you a secret,” Lavere said. “After you took out Furibon, Brandon Maure has decided to get off his throne and come for you personally. Expect an ambush in the near future.”

Well, that made attacking him in his capital a preemptive counterattack then. “Sav, give her the official history of Murmurin, ‘The War of the Hoard.’ It has been transcribed from our emperor's mouth to paper by our scribe, Pink Ranger, and then duplicated by mimic printing presses.”

Creatures capable of transforming in nearly any items had turned out surprisingly useful, once Victor could provide them directions. He would order one of them to keep an eye on that woman while she stayed in town.

“It won't work,” Lavere replied, reading his mind, before taking her leave with Savoureuse. “See you soon, *Vic*.”

Victor rode to the village's main temple a lot less confident than before.

The temple the gods Isengrim and Cybele shared wasn't a temple as much as a druidic circle, ten olive trees circling two statues of the deities. Isengrim was represented as a white deer whose horns ended in blades, with the goddess Cybele was an incredibly beautiful woman, with flowers for hair, vines for a dress, and horns of wood.

Victor climbed down his undead ride, who Allison had forbidden inside the area, and walked inside the circle. He found his fellow earthling and Chocolatine keeping watch over a huge prisoner.

The priests had trapped a demon in a circle of runes, a huge, bipedal, insectoid monster with ice plates for an exoskeleton and sapphires for eyes. The creature looked big and nasty enough to tear Victor in half with its two pincers. He immediately used [Monster Insight] on the fiend.

Malfaisant

Bug Demon (Demon/Insect)

Strong against Unholy, Frost, Water, Physical, Disease, Poison, Critical Hits, Petrify, Bug, and Swarms.

Weak against Fire, Holy, Demonslayer, and Bugslayer.

An ice demon with unconventional ideas and a greedy streak that rivals dragons. Local manager of one of Hell's corporations, Infercorp, which is a completely legitimate business mindful of post-mortem customer safety. Has come to investigate the 'demon slaughterhouse.'

"Vic, there you are." Allison glared at Chocolatine. "She summoned that thing in the temple, and now I cannot give offerings to my goddess properly."

"It was an accident!" the young werewolf retorted. "I intended to summon an imp like always, but a major demon came through instead!"

"Three hundred lesser fiends went missing after using your summoning line, and my superiors sent me to investigate," the demon rasped with a smarmy voice, glancing at Victor. "Are you the legitimate authority? The Grand Dragon Vizier Victor Dalton?"

"Lord Victor for short." He was sick of his full, pompous title. "Malfaisant, is it? Your kindred had... how to say it, dragon accidents, and then were recycled."

"I do not follow."

Victor pointed at animated demon skeletons building up a house next to the druidic circle, the bug fiend looking at them, then at Victor, then back at the

undead. “You killed my kind, to raise them as mindless slaves?”

Victor cringed at the wording but nodded, as the demon’s cold eyes peered into his soul. “You mortals say Hell is other people, but they are wrong. Hell is people like *you*.”

The fact it came from a goddamn demon made it all the more shameful.

“Which is to say, Hell *needs* people like you.” The demon’s tone turned admiring, much to Victor’s confusion. “People who *care* about the *bottom line*. About profit. Mortals who are ready to sully their hand for *their* greater good.”

“Wait, you’re not mad?”

“Please, Lord Victor, call me Malfy,” the demon replied with a charming voice. “No, I am not mad. In fact, I misjudged you. I feared that you were cunning demon hunters, but you have the trappings of a good business partner. Let’s make a deal.”

“So I can keep summoning demons for more food?” Chocolatine asked, hopeful.

“Not in the temple!” Allison chided her. “And no!”

“But we have more carnivores than meat! We cannot sustain our ecological niche without sacrifices!”

Her argument surprised Victor, who found it rather well-thought out. Not that the demon cared. “I will reroute the summoning channel to send you victims of corporate downsizing and violent layoffs. By having you deal with the severance package, we can cut corners on our execution costs and you get free labor. Everybody wins.”

Victor wanted to be horrified at the sheer callousness, before realizing he should have expected something like that from a hellspawn.

“Lord Victor, since you seem interested in economically developing your region, I have *fantastic* opportunities for you. Succubus brothels,

casinos...”

“You are seriously asking me for *Hell’s* permission to invest there?” Victor asked, dumbfounded.

“Taking over the mortal world by force? Treacherously twisting the terms of Faustian bargains? It damages our PR, and Angels have a killer marketing department. If we want to improve our shareholders’ soul dividends, we must offer clear deals where mortals are so happy with our customer service, that they convince their friends and families to sell their souls too. ‘Buying souls by doing good business.’ That’s my motto.”

Victor had more urgent matters to deal with than vague corporate promises. Also, *Hell*. "We picked a fight with the local Demon King's forces."

"Brandon Maure? His mother runs a demon corporation different from ours. We often cooperate on joint-ventures on Outremonde, but there is no love lost between us."

That made it better, but just barely. “If you want to come, you have to bring food, do whatever labor we ask of you, and respect the law, which includes no lead. In return, you won’t pay taxes.”

“No taxes?” The demon’s head perked up. “This is way better than I thought. I will gladly use my control swarm ability to assist with food production. Part of the revenue from our ventures will also find their way to your pockets, alongside VIP privileges.”

“Are you bribing me in public?”

"No, of course not, I donate to the community."

Yes, a bribe. Victor would keep one one-tenth for himself and send the rest to Vainqueur, to avoid trouble.

“I would expect a demon to stay in Ishfania,” Allison said, doubtful.

“‘King’ Maure imposed a heavy tax in order to fund ‘the inevitable war of annihilation against Gardemagne.’ Now, human sacrifices and slave

gladiator combats, I can get behind. But losing two-thirds of my hard-won savings? Never!”

Charming. “Is he telling the truth?” Victor asked Chocolatine.

“It’s a circle of demon binding, he is forced to,” the werewolf said, before joining her hands. “Please, please, say yes.”

Victor rolled his eyes, before considering it. They needed food and money that much, and he had already stepped as low as selling corpses for money. On the other hand, he was wary to give a demon a permanent residency in Murmurin, even one promising to behave.

“Okay, at least for the demon downsizing,” he decided, Malfy letting out a happy sound and Chocolatine smirking with cruelty. “But summon demons outside the town next time. For the... investments... I need to consider it more thoughtfully.”

“I will return to Hell and come back with a proposal from management. Thank you for your trust.” Malfy vanished in a cloud of white smoke, the circle following afterward.

“Thank you, Vic,” Allison congratulated him. “I don’t know what I would do without you. You just ooze authority now.”

“I’m still trying to get the Earl Jones tone right,” Victor joked, “Like ‘You have failed me for the last time.’”

“You sound like Tim Curry, more creepy than awesome.”

“Okay, I’ll try again. ‘The emperor is not as forgiving as I am.’” Which was true.

“No, seriously,” she laughed at his performance. “Stop, it sounds ridiculous.”

Victor had quite a fun time hanging out with Allison, talking about Earth, about their respective experiences, and life in general. She wasn’t that different from him; she died a stupid death by causing an explosion while

tinkering with a car's fuel reserve and adapted to the new world in spite of being surrounded by monsters.

She liked gardening and was very passionate about making the desert green again. Her partner, Rolo, couldn't be bothered to do anything but gathering seeds and disdained everything else. Much like a certain other creature...

He could definitely feel a connection brewing. "Hey, Allison..." Victor plucked up his courage. "Would you like to have that drink tonight?"

"I'm kind of fully booked with the orgy, but we can try tomorrow. Is tomorrow okay?"

That wasn't the answer Victor expected. "You are *breeding* with other people?"

"What? No." She looked at him strangely. "I am a vestal of the goddess of pleasure, and the Moon Man cult is organizing an orgy. Since our cults are friendly, I have been asked to help with protective spells."

"And you... you participate?"

"Vic, this is an orgy for *werewolves*. During the *full moon*."

His brain betrayed him and provided him with a mental picture. It felt like an ice shower. "I'm sorry, I need to go out," he blurted out, struggling to breathe. "I need air."

"We are outside Vic... Vic?" Allison called him, as he fled the druidic ring. "Vic, what's up?"

Victor's mind blocked out her words, as the picture wouldn't leave his mind. Goddammit, now he would need to drown himself in work to forget! He climbed on the back of his ride, ready to return to the castle when he noticed Chocolatine following him outside. "Yes?"

"So, mm, Victor, about that orgy..." Chocolatine gave him a cheery smile.

"Do you want to breed?"

Victor gave her a blank, empty stare that should have made her drop dead. She took it as encouragement. “It’s okay, I’m on the pill. No full moon transformation. We can put that Monster Rider Perk to goooooood use.”

Okay, that was too many details, too soon. She skipped a *lot* of steps. “I didn’t know you saw me that way...” said the adventurer, unsure how to answer without her slicing his throat in his sleep.

“I didn’t either until you killed that lich with your scythe,” she swooned, putting her hands on her cheeks, “The way you rode that undead beast and trapped his soul for eternal torment... and the way you showed that demon who was the boss...”

Victor suddenly realized that his monster-oriented Perks combined with his increased charisma meant monsters may see him as quite the catch. All that time he had failed at pursuing human women when he should have asked out werewolves instead.

On one hand, she was cute, and somewhat nice when demons and undead weren’t involved; but on the other hand, she was *Chocolatine*. And the crazy gleam in her eyes...

...

No. *Definitely* not. “I’m sorry, but, I don’t want to ruin our friendship,” Victor lied, leaving her crestfallen.

No way he would BLEEP her except to save the human race.

Even Victor had standards.

Chapter 24: Dragon Profiling

Sand. Sand. Sand.

Walking cactus!

Oh, it was dead.

Sand. Sand. Sand...

Vainqueur forced himself not to fall asleep out of boredom in the middle of the flight. He was sick of this endless desert, carrying his chief of staff in one hand, and a big, goatskin bag for princesses in the other. “Why am I flying invisible again?” the dragon asked his minion, who had insisted Vainqueur use his ‘Blinkblink’ ring. “And why didn't we bring the other minions?”

“Because otherwise Brandon Maure will have us shot on sight, and my [Cowl of the Reaper] grants me some camouflage.” The minion sounded tired, and just as bored as his master. “It’s better to travel light.”

“Minion, I meant why I should care if that fiend notices?”

“Because we are on a princess rescue mission, which means we need to be discreet. Otherwise, Maure will evacuate them elsewhere, and we may not know where this time.”

At long last, Vainqueur finally noticed their destination when he squinted his eyes at the horizon.

A rock the size of the Albain mountains’ tallest peak floated above the desert, a fortress-city built from red, bloody bricks; greenish stones below the flying structure released a whirlwind of swirling sandstorms keeping the

city afloat. Vainqueur noticed a few flying creatures patrolling the skies near it, each of whom would make for passable snacks.

Instead of rejoicing at finally reaching their destination, Manling Victor let out a heavy, crushed sigh.

“Minion, why are you so down?” Manling Victor also sounded a lot less enthusiastic about this adventure than Vainqueur thought he would. Come to think of it, he hadn’t argued about Vainqueur bringing a princess bag, while the minion usually worried about everything. “Have you bred yet?”

“No. I tried.” The minion sighed, crestfallen. “But as it turns out, Allison likes girls...”

The dryad? “Minion, I am not that strict about minion harassment. You have my imperial permission to bestow your eggs on Manling Charlene, for example.”

“I’m pretty sure Croissant got there first.”

“Then eat him.” Vainqueur would have sworn the minion looked up at his master in confusion, but he couldn’t tell with the cowl. “You are a chief of staff, he is below you in the food chain. If he bothers you, eat him. I have never devoured a werewolf before, but they must taste like a cerberus, strong and thick.”

“Your Majesty has eaten cerberi?”

“When I fought the fomors as a young wyrm with the rest of dragonkind. They kept sending monsters like cerberi to die to me back in those days.” Eventually, the fairy lords paid Vainqueur and his kin a large tribute of gold as an apology for falsely claiming to have created the world first.

Speaking of food, what was that scent in the wind? “I can sense we are being followed.” Vainqueur hummed the air. “It smells like a big bird, with a manling on its back.”

“Huh? We should be wary, it could be one of Maure’s men—”

“[Solar Judgment!]”

A beam of light hit Vainqueur in the back by surprise, the blast making him crash into the dry sand below.

[**Solar Judgment**] bypassed your [**Fire Immunity**]! You have taken heavy damage!

Once again, he felt that itchy sensation... “Minion, I do not feel well in my back,” Vainqueur said, opening his palm to find his chief of staff safe and sound. “What is this?”

“I think that it is pain, Your Majesty!”

Pain? Of course not, only mammals suffered from it.

Vainqueur glanced up at the one responsible for his back itches, a manling knight in heavy green armor. The treacherous creature rode the back of a golden lion, with the head, wings, and talons of an eagle.

A griffon! And an adult, meaty one at that!

“I doubted your guilt until I scanned your classes, Victor. [Monster Squire] and [Reaper]!” The knight pointed a shining blade at Vainqueur, who could tell it was a cursed fairy work meant to kill dragons. According to the voice, the knight was a female manling. “The unholy scion of a thief of souls and a necromancer, with a dash of scum! And your perks! [Helheim], [Channel Hellfire]! You reek of evil!”

“That armor...” the minion trailed, as the dust settled. “Holy shit, level sixty-six?”

“I am Kia Bekele, the Shining Knight of Gardemagne! Prepare to die, miscreants!”

Annoyed at the greenish knight not announcing his imperial name next, Vainqueur just blasted the bird out the skies with a fireball.

“[Bravewind!]” Much to the dragon’s surprise, the bird and its rider flew out of the way of his flames, carried by strong winds. They dived down as Vainqueur kept trying to blast them, moving at speeds that even the dragon had a hard time following. Before he knew what hit him, the knight slashed at Vainqueur between the neck and the shoulder, cutting a scale.

[**Arondight**] inflicted doubly effective [Fairy] [Dragonslayer] damage!

Like that damn lich, the knight and her flying cattle retreated before the dragon could poke them. Manling Victor tried to assist his master by blasting bluish hellfire at their foe, but she flew out of range and made a circle in the skies. Vainqueur suddenly wondered how she could notice him while invisible, with a glance telling him the sand on his body revealed his position.

Above, the knight moved to dive back, shining under the sunlight.

That female manling was eager to make Vainqueur live up to his name. “Minion, stay there,” Vainqueur ordered his manling, putting him on the ground with the princess bag. “I will take flight and deal with this flying snack personally.”

“Your Majesty, she’s the strongest adventurer in Mistral, and the slayer of King Balaur! Don’t underestimate her!”

“Balaur?” For once, this made Vainqueur pause. “The fomor?”

A mere manling riding a flying cow took down *Balaur*, the *second* greatest calamity of this age? When?

“[Spell Purge]!” Vainqueur snarled, revealing himself in his full draconic glory as his Perk negated his ring’s invisibility. “Fear my wrath, manling knight! You face Emperor Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of his name, Great Calamity of this Age, Emperor of Murmurin and the Albain Mountains, and Slayer of Furibon!”

“I know about the lich,” the knight said, raising her blade. “I would say thanks since we never got around to killing him before, but—”

“You knew about Furibon?” Vainqueur glared at the knight, suddenly outraged. “And you did *nothing*? Do you know what he was doing in that dungeon? Do you *know*?”

The knight paused, halting her descent. “Excuse me?”

“I am sure he must have sacrificed hundreds of baby princesses to prepare that dread, foul, evil spell! He was about to release it on the world before *I* stopped him! Do you know what he made me suffer through? The bloody war I had to fight? The sacrifices I had to make? Do you *know*?”

“Uh, no, I—”

“You would, if you were cultured enough to read *The War of the Hoard*!” Vainqueur kept ranting. “My minion was abducted and tortured by Furibon! The lich stole his vegetable and forced him to eat baby coins!”

“Your Majesty, maybe you are exaggerating there...”

“My minion risked his life to seal that foul lich’s soul away!” Vainqueur ignored his chief of staff and kept shaming the knight, who had lowered her sword. “We had to fight a horde of three hundred demons until he could become strong enough to imprison that depraved monster!”

“I, I...” The knight struggled to find her words when faced with her obvious incompetence. “I’m... I’m sorry, I didn’t know...”

“I am sick and tired of you manlings’ speciesism!” Vainqueur vented off. “I am being the best dragon adventurer to your backward species, and you deny me my rightful payments when I solve your problems! You even send thieves after my hoard, even after I worked hard to save the one true way of life from Furibon!”

“Your Majesty always says all species are equally inferior to dragons,” Manling Victor reminded his master.

“Which is a *fact*, not a silly superstition!” Vainqueur replied, the knight now silent as her griffon looked up at her in confusion. “And your species’

attitude has done nothing to change my opinion! *I* saved everything good in the world from Furibon!”

“Also, attacking us after using a magical scan, just because I have monster classes and Vainqueur is a dragon?” Minion Victor shouted at the knight. “It’s called racial profiling!”

“It’s... it’s not!” the knight protested feebly. “Two secs. [Enhanced Karma Scan].”

“You are doing it again!” Victor accused her, as light words appearing in front of her helmet while she looked at both Vainqueur and his lackey.

“No, I’m not!” she protested, the words quickly vanishing. “Okay, I have checked your karma, with both of you being neutral, with the dragon very much oriented towards chaotic and Dalton tending towards good.”

“Dalton?” Vainqueur squinted at his minion.

“That’s my family name,” the manling said, Vainqueur realizing he never even considered his lackey may have one. “Also, neutral... isn’t that a polite name for bland?”

“Enough talk!” Vainqueur extended his wings. “I will kill you, Knight Kia, and eat your flying cattle for your treacherous attack.”

“I, uh... I don’t think it will be necessary for us to fight, I jumped the gun,” the knight said, casting a spell. “Sorry, [Rain of Healing].”

A shower of golden powder fell on Vainqueur and his lackey, with the dragon attempting to grab the gold on instinct; the powder vanished on touch but made his back stop itching.

You have recovered all your HP!

“I deeply apologize,” the knight said, although she stayed at a respectable distance. “I mistook you for villains, instead of the goodish mercenary type. I can’t believe I never imagined you would be that kind of heroes.”

“It happens all the time,” Manling Victor said with surprising warmth.

“Minion, you will reproduce with someone else,” Vainqueur lambasted him for his skewed priorities, the minion lowering his head in shame while the knight recoiled. “She attacked me, and she will pay me a tribute as apology. I demand no less than five griffins as reparation.”

“Your Majesty, I do not think that is a good idea. She must be almost as strong as you, and we have princesses to save.”

“Minion, a true dragon has no equal,” Vainqueur replied, unwilling to let it slide. Even if she had killed Balaur, he was only the second greatest calamity behind the dragon. Vainqueur had *earned* that title.

“Princesses to save?” The knight interrupted. “Princess Merveille? You intended to go to Mauria and rescue Princess Merveille?”

“Her and all the other princesses Maure captured,” Manling Victor spoke up.

“And you... and you will keep them for yourself?” asked the Shining Knight, her hold over her sword wavering.

“Of course not, do you take me for one of these horrible humanophiles?” Vainqueur shuddered in disgust. “I will release them back in the wild once I am done, and your Manling King has granted me the promised boon for their rescue.”

“About it, Your Majesty hasn’t told me how much they intended to ask for,” Manling Victor pointed out.

That was because Vainqueur had an idea for a special gift. If that manling king proved unable to deliver, then the dragon wouldn’t ask anything less than one million coins or a hundred thousand jewels, to add to his current hoard.

“Okay, we are on the same page.” The knight had her griffon land on the ground in front of Vainqueur. “I deeply apologize for my uncalled attack,

but I'm not giving up my griffon. However, if you agree, I could make it up by helping you in your quest."

Vainqueur squinted at the griffon, who glared back at him. "I am listening," he said, in case that knight could be helpful in carrying his princesses to Murmurin.

"First, I have to ask, do you intend to fight Maure yourselves? Because I can't support it."

"Why? Because it would be dangerous?" Minion Victor asked.

"What? No, it would be *amazing*, and I insist on coming along." The manling sounded positively giddy. "I've been trying to convince my party for months to kick that foppish demon bastard's ass, and they always delay. Same with the lich. If we had known he worked a foul magic which threatened the world..."

"Your feeble mind cannot imagine the depth of Furibon's depravity," Vainqueur said grimly. "He was pure evil, the kind that existed for itself. He was unliving *lead*."

"For a dragon to say that... I'm not going to ask for the gory details. Is that his soul in the scythe?" The knight looked up at the Manling Victor's weapon, "I see... you took that cursed Reaper class because it was the only way to defeat the lich. It must have been a difficult choice."

"You could say that..."

The green knight removed her helmet, and Vainqueur squinted, for it was the first time he saw a manling with skin so dark and hair that did not look ugly. Manling Victor stood in place speechless, while his master wasn't impressed. She didn't smell like a princess.

"I'm Kia. Kia Bekele. Sorry to have shot you out of the sky." She put a hand through her hair. "You both have a terrible reputation."

“Canihaveyourautograph?” Manling Victor spoke so fast that even Vainqueur’s imperial ears had trouble understanding him. The female manling laughed warmly, amused. “You’re the Shining Knight, the greatest paladin in the world! Are you really a Claimed?”

“I am. Came from Ethiopia, although I stayed some time in the United Kingdom.” The knight seemed to struggle to find her words, obviously as poor as Manling Victor at pre-breeding conversations. “And you, Victor, where do you come from? Can I call you Victor?”

“Sure! I’m Ame—”

“Manling,” Vainqueur let out smoke by his nostrils, annoyed at the knight ignoring him. “How will you make up for the crime of striking the Emperor of Murmurin and the Albain Mountains?”

The knight sheathed her blade and opened her empty palm, a blue, shining, egg-shaped stone materializing within it. “It’s an [Agarthan Warp Stone], a one-use item that can teleport you and anyone close back to any place you visited. It even bypasses protections against teleportation effects, such as the barriers protecting the city of Mauria.”

“My [Eye for Treasure] tells me this is the genuine article, Your Majesty,” said the minion.

“I always carry two of them, just in case,” the knight said. “You can use one to transport everyone back to a safer place, safe from Maure.”

Oh, and that way Vainqueur wouldn’t have to burn fat flying back home! Perfect. “As Emperor of Murmurin and the Albain Mountains, I accept this tribute, and forgive you for your sinful offense against my person. Any other dragon would have killed you for your insolence, but I am generous and magnanimous.”

The two manlings exchanged glances. “Dragons,” they both said at once before Victor frowned. “You met another?”

“I fought one with my old party. Blightswamp, I think that was her name.”

“That pauper living in the boonies?” Vainqueur sneered. “She doesn’t even have a cave in her swamp!”

“She had a tar pit before we dislodged her. I don’t know where she fled afterward.”

She ran from manlings? *Manlings*? And to think he invited her to his own Bragging Day, what was Vainqueur thinking?

It made his celebration all the more important. As far as Vainqueur knew, he was the only one protecting the honor of dragonkind against hordes of liches and peasants. He had to put pride back in the heart of his kin.

“Also, Nostredame’s intel woman told me you had lost the Apple of Knowledge to Brandon Maure,” the knight asked Minion Victor. “From what I understood, it’s an iPad?”

“From a Lockheed Martin engineer,” the minion said, the knight frowning. “With schematics to match.”

“Alright, it is indeed time to kick Maure’s ass. Do not underestimate him. He is eccentric, but nobody survived a duel with him, and he possesses one of the most optimized Fighter Class combinations in the world.”

Vainqueur shrugged with contempt. “He is an elf. Elves are cattle, they eat *grass*. I will devour him and then get the princesses.”

“Still, don’t underestimate him.” She turned to the flying rock. “Shall we go?”

Chapter 25: The Demon King

Vainqueur had to give it to the elves. Unlike the manlings, they kept their lairs clean.

Their flying city was a treat for the eyes, with shiny white stone and marble statues which Vainqueur thought would look great on his hoard. He promised himself to return for groceries after recovering his princesses.

Gargoyles with forks patrolled the city's ramparts, unable to see Vainqueur nor the cattle-riding knight. She too had turned transparent, although the dragon could smell her just fine. "The invisibility will trick lesser fiends, but neither Maure nor his elite guard," Kia the knight whispered. "I wonder why the city is so lightly defended, though. It's usually so full of demons our spies can't even approach it."

"I can smell many fiends nearby," Vainqueur said, humming and looking for his meal. The flight had made him hungry, and he had gotten used to demon flesh. He flew toward the source of the scent, some kind of flying port, with a great metal bird nesting in the middle.

...

That was a big, *big* metal bird.

Many, many times bigger than Vainqueur himself, with great iron wings and iron spikes under them. Demons manned strange devices on its back, which looked like bigger versions of the musket weapon Red the Kobold carried with him. The bird had only one eye made of glass, with fiends and elves hitting it with hammers.

As usual for his puny race, his chief of staff was deeply intimidated by the animal's size. "Holy hell, they broke the iPad's passwords. They built a

bombardier.”

“It’s not a bombardier, it’s a flying fortress,” the knight said, just as terrified. “It’s bigger than the *Titanic*! Do you think it’s functional? It looks rough and archaic.”

“Dunno, but we’ve got to destroy it before it takes off.”

Only manlings could worry about a bird. Vainqueur would burn and cook the fiends inside, the same way he prepared his training diet. He lazily opened his mouth to rain death on the big fat bird...

Then his [Virgin Princess Radar] activated.

Vainqueur immediately turned his head towards the source of the signal, in the middle of the city. “A princess!” His eyes widened in giddiness. “A princess maiden!”

“Your Majesty, what the—”

Vainqueur, overtaken by his dragon instincts, ignored the metal bird and flew straight towards the princess’ location, knocking both the knight’s griffon and gargoyles out of the skies. The fiends noticed him as he caused a building to fall after hitting it, immediately sounding horns and bells.

“Knightsbane?” Kia the Manling called Vainqueur from the sky port, who heard but didn’t listen. “Knightsbane, Dalton, where are you going?”

“Princess!” the dragon shouted back.

He flew over the elven city, with his wings blowing off houses and fiends off until he found what he was looking for: a massive, circular arena of red brick in the very center of the flying city. Hundreds of elves and fiends had gathered in the stands with food and drinks.

The dragon immediately recognized the princess, chained to a marble pillar in the middle of the sandy ground of the arena.

That creature was the most beautiful pet Vainqueur had ever set his eyes on, a cute animal with pretty green hair fur which would compliment his gold perfectly. Her skin was so pure it reminded Vainqueur of cow's milk, and the fiends had dressed her like a present.

There were other two princesses bound next to her, two elves, but Vainqueur didn't care half as much; they didn't smell like virginal maidens. The one at the center, though, that was the one he wanted, the crown jewel of his Bragging Day! The others would complement her, as he put them on display atop a mountain of gold.

"Today, fiends and elves, we gathered for the ritual of the demon corrida!" A tall, bulky red fiend shouted from atop the stands, the crowd cheering at his words, "In order to gain Hell's favor in the destruction of Gardemagne, three, yes, *three* noble ladies shall be sacrificed today before the fights! The ghastly deed shall be done by our esteemed king's guest, the beautiful, the poisonous... Melodieuse!"

The elves and fiends cheered, as a purple-haired manling materialized in front of the princesses. A pretty creature with long, deep purple hair arranged in a tress, with bloody, red-rimmed eyes; she wore a queenly black dress, made of the fur of warbeasts and fiends both. The woman's sight bothered Vainqueur, although the dragon couldn't tell why.

"Witness the sacrifices!" the speaker continued. "Princess Merveille, niece of our hated nemesis, King Roland Gardemagne! The oracle of Appol—"

"MINE!" Vainqueur landed in the arena with a loud sound, blowing off a large cloud of dust around himself. "MINE, MINE, MINE!"

While the audience fell silent, and the purple-haired manling looked up at his face, Vainqueur turned to the captive princesses, showing them his princess bag.

"Get in the bag!" The princess maidens looked around them in fear and confusion. "I said, get in the princess bag!"

"Your Majesty, you are invisible, and they are chained!"

“[Null Magic].”

Vainqueur’s invisibility vanished, and he could feel the power of his other trinkets negated as well. The crowd panicked at his sight, while the princesses shuddered in fear. The dragon ignored all of them, glancing at the source of the attack.

“[Crystal Prison.]” At the strange manling’s command, barriers of purple crystal grew around the princesses, trapping them within like bugs in amber. The dragon instantly recognized the substance as cursed fairywork. “Knightsbane, you have come to delay our ambitions?”

The thing looked like a noble princess but smelled anything but. She smelled like the deadly flowers of the Dark Forest, of death, and putrid miasma.

Not a manling.

A fomor.

Vainqueur exchanged a glance with the fairy, and her soulless eyes confirmed his suspicions. A tense, hateful silence fell between them, neither willing to make the first move; the dragon dropped the princess bag and his chief of staff, ready to smash that abomination at the first sign of hostility. Their species may have made peace, but her mere presence infuriated the dragon.

“Your Majesty?” His chief of staff, unaware of the woman’s nature, looked back and forth between them. “Who is she? I can’t read her with any of my Perks, and she feels *wrong*.”

“Minion, hide behind me,” Vainqueur said, extending his claws and preparing to fight to that creature's death if needed. “Fairkind hunts manlings for their fur.”

“Ohoh, viewers, a surprise challenger stormed in! Vainqueur Knightsbane, ‘Emperor’,” the fiend commentator laughed, and so did the crowd, much to

Vainqueur's confusion, "of Murmurin and the Albain Mountains, self-proclaimed great calamity of the age!"

"Self-proclaimed nothing!" Vainqueur contested the lie.

"In the other corner, the demonic superstar, the invincible champion, the undefeated king of Ishfania... the fabulous Brandon Maure!"

An elf stepped into the arena through a door built into the stone wall itself, as thin and fragile as the rest of his kind. His skin was light purple, almost greyish, with silver eyes and short hair of the same color. He wore a gold-plated, shiny cloth that covered his whole body except for his exposed chest, and a horned, silvery diadem around his head. The dead meat walking carried a blade with one hand and a red cloth with the other.

The crowd cheered at the elf's coming, who raised his red cloth at them. Openings in the arena's walls unleashed streams of fire and white smoke above. "Maure, best demon!" The cattle audience chanted. "Maure, best demon! Maure, best demon!"

The elf, who smelled like brimstone, smirked at Manling Victor. "Ah, the mere sight of Brandon Maure's perfect body has made you fall for him. Brandon Maure gets this reaction all the time."

"Actually, I was just very surprised by the *traje de luces* outfit—"

"There is no need to deny your lustful feelings for Brandon Maure's sublime body," the demon king cut off the chief of staff with a smug look which Vainqueur immediately despised. "None can resist Brandon Maure, and he welcomes all admirers. For beauty has a lover, and it is Brandon Maure."

Elves. Always the arrogant cattle.

That fomer however... Vainqueur kept his eyes focused on the fairy, in case she went for a sneak attack. He didn't even move to smash the arrogant cattle, unwilling to give that sworn foe of dragonkind any opening.

“You, V&V, have slighted Maure for months,” the elf said while walking to the fomor’s side. “You slew his human minions, stole his precious apple, destroyed his court magician, and ruined a century of demon summoning work. Now you want to take his hard-won sacrifices from him? Brandon Maure truly wants to know: what has he done to you to deserve this?”

“You exist in my world,” Vainqueur replied as a matter of fact, his eyes still on the witch. “I am Emperor. I do as I want.”

“You, Vainqueur, are no Emperor. Murmurin is a daughter of Ishfania, and Ishfania has only one king. The king who stands before you!”

Warning: your [**Emperor**] title is contested by Brandon Maure!

If you do not assert your rightful authority, your [**Emperor**] class perks will be nulled!

“Contest? What is there to contest?” Vainqueur snarled. He should not even have to defend his title, since its validity was obvious!

“What do you intend to do with that bombardier?” Manling Victor asked, still more preoccupied with the metal bird than the challenge to his master’s authority. “How did you even build it so fast?”

“Maure had the Iron Eagle built months ago, but his minions lacked the knowledge for the finishing touches. As for what he will do with it, earthlings have a word for it, if Brandon Maure remembers. Something with carpets.”

“Carpet bombing,” the fomor said, her voice without warmth.

“Yes, carpet bombing. Brandon Maure will carpet bomb the monkey farms of Gardemagne until only rubble and dead apes remain. He will also make a short detour to raze these stinking Haudemer and Murmurin villages.”

“W-why?” Manling Victor asked. “What is the point?”

“To starve my guests by destroying the cattle,” Vainqueur explained.

“Because Brandon Maure has many qualities. Beautiful. Perfect. Generous. But *forgiving*, is not among them.”

Vainqueur’s chief of staff readied his scythe. “Not on my watch,” he said, prepared to defend his master’s honor and food supply.

“Maure cares nothing for monkey props.” The arrogant elf turned to look at the minion’s scythe. “And if you wish to survive with all your ears attached to your body, you shall release Maure's lich servant at once.”

Furibon? That monstrous elf wanted to break the seal keeping Furibon prisoner! “I will not let you release that evil on the world, fiend!” Vainqueur declared, preparing to blast these two with fire and flames, fomor-dragon peace or not.

“Maure's will shall be fulfilled.” The fiendish elf turned to the fomor witch. “Melodieuse, please do Brandon Maure a favor, and clear his arena of peons.”

“As you wish, princeling.”

Vainqueur immediately blasted the spot where the fomor stood with a fireball, but she teleported out of the path the same way the frustrating Furibon did.

"[Hellzone]." Before he could react, she raised a hand, and the very fabric of space collapsed around Vainqueur and Victor; a rift showcasing a world of fire and brimstones superposing over the arena. The mirage lasted only an instant, but his chief of staff vanished with it.

Luck check successful, but your minion has been banished to Hell.

“My chief of staff!” Vainqueur wrathfully extended his wings, to showcase his dominance to the fomor. “Bring him back at once! I am not clearing a dungeon again!”

“Only a true winner makes demands, dragon!” Brandon Maure replied while a beam of light fell straight from the heavens, hitting the area where

the iron bird was nested. The elf looked in this direction with an angry snarl. “The Iron Eagle! They have brought reinforcements!”

“Not for long.” The fomor witch glanced at the source of the light, then vanished in a veil of darkness, leaving nothing behind.

“I will show you your place, grass-eater!” Vainqueur snarled, intending to eat that walking cattle, put the princesses in the bag, and then force that witch to release his chief of staff. He would find the time to rampage somewhere in the middle. “Your feeble spells will do nothing to me!”

“Only the weak rely on magic to win their fights! A true warrior just needs his muleta and his espada! You, Vainqueur, Brandon Maure challenges you! One on one, champion against dragon!”

“Vainqueur Knightsbane does not back away from a fight!”

You accepted Maure's [**Demon Corrida**] challenge!

The audience will empower or weaken the fighters depending on their performance!

“Then, Vainqueur, Brandon Maure swears it on his honor as a [Matador]...”
The elf swung his blade. “Today, you shall learn the bitter taste of defeat!”

Chapter 26: First Blood

As it turned out, Charlene had been right. Victor did end up in Hell after all.

It was a horrible place, but not for the reasons Victor had expected.

Hell was a fiery, brimstone cave, like the religions of Earth foretold; but they had moved away from burning souls and into new, more inventive forms of punishment. On one side, Victor noticed row after row of captive humans bound to chairs in front of a large mirror, forced to watch some kind of horribly acted, medieval reality TV show. On the other side, other damned souls fashioned tiny, hand-held mirrors reminding the adventurer of mobile phones' screens, while being whipped by imps.

Victor would have loved nothing more than free those poor souls from their eternal torment, had he not been surrounded by insectoid fiends. Three dozen of the creatures looking like thinner, moth-like cousins of Malfy pointed sharp, poisoned spears at him.

One figure, however, differed from the others and looked at Victor with pupilless blue eyes. A hybrid creature between a woman and an insect with greyish skin, she had two large, golden moth wings with a skull motif growing out of her back. A black, skintight dress covered her entire body, except for sharp claws where the fingers ended, and a mink-jacket like ring of white fur around the neck. She was eerily beautiful and elegant, in a creepy ice queen sort of way. Only two horn-like antennae growing out of her long, silver hair betrayed her demonic nature.

Her face looked a bit too much like Brandon Maure's to Victor's liking, though.

“A new sacrifice.” Much to Victor’s amazement, the female demon sounded remarkably soft-spoken. “You are not a virgin maiden.”

“Neither have I been mistaken for one,” the adventurer replied, tightening his hold on his scythe with one hand and looking under his cowl for the Agarthan Warp Stone with the other. He had no idea if it could teleport him out of Hell, but he saw no other escape route.

The bug fiends raised their blades against his chin and his hands, stopping him dead in his tracks.

However, the demoness leader raised an eyebrow at him, more confused than anything. “You can understand High Infernal?”

He wasn’t supposed to? Thank the twelve gods for that Perk, maybe he could talk his way out the way he did with the Moon Beast. Victor immediately used Monster Insight on the fiends’ leader, desperate for a morsel of information.

Isabelle Maure

Archdevil of Vanity and Mindless Entertainment (Demon/Insect)

Strong against: Light, Darkness, Drain, Mind-Control effects, Insta-death, all negative status effects, Frost, Lightning, Unholy, Fire, Acid, Screens.

Weak against: Holy, Wind, Demonslayer, and Bugslayer.

The mistress of blades, and one of Hell’s corporate overlords. The fiendish mind who invented procrastination, gladiator fights, and Outremonde’s equivalent of reality TV. Owns many businesses dedicated to enslaving souls through the power of screens, such as Infernal Cable and Helltube, but secretly regrets sacrificing her golden years for her career.

Uh oh. “You smell of dragon, and is that a soul I see trapped in your scythe?” The demoness asked, her eyes set on Victor’s scythe. “Furibon? Is that you?”

“Kill him, Your Highness!” Furibon shouted from inside the scythe, Victor doing his best to keep his poker face. *“This is an enemy of King Maure!”*

“What is he trying to say?” the demoness asked. “I can see his teeth move on the scythe’s edge, but I cannot hear a word of it.”

“He is complaining about his old master executing him for screwing up opening a Hellgate,” Victor lied through his teeth.

“Ah, so this is what happened. I was wondering why the portal had been reinforced without warning. I had an army of thirty thousand fiends waiting behind it.”

“And you are...?” Victor trailed off, although he already knew and Furibon kept screaming without being heard.

“Archdevil Isabelle Maure, Mistress of Blades, Chief Demonic Executive of Maure Hellcorporated.”

“The mother of Brandon?”

“Oh, you know my Braniño?” Her delicate face showed some worry. “How is he? Has he conquered Gardemagne yet? The gate was supposed to open from his side but never did, I worried so much.”

“Wait, he didn’t inform you?” Victor sweated internally, thankful for Maure’s carelessness.

“He never visits and only calls when he needs something. ‘Mother, Brandon wants a new demon horse’, or ‘Mother, Brandon needs more infernal power!’ I know I birthed him in the first place so I could expand into the overplane, but a little affection would not hurt. I am not a cold-hearted hellspawn all the time.”

“Parenting is a thankless job,” Victor replied, half trying to be nice and half trying to talk his way out of an early grave. “What about his dad? Maybe you could ask him for support.”

“Oh, I drained him of life while we conceived Brandon,” she said, sending shivers down the adventurer’s spine. “He wanted a child to perpetuate his inbred, infertile bloodline, and I wanted an agent on Outremonde. A win-win. Unfortunately, elves are frail with few health points, so he died halfway through. A shame. Braniño inherited his good looks. Have you had children, Mister...”

“Victor,” Victor blurted out, but thankfully the name didn’t ring a bell to the woman. Brandon Maure *really* didn’t call his mother often. “A werewolf chick asked me to breed, but I had to refuse. She was crazy.”

“Werewolves,” Isabelle Maure sneered with elitist disgust. “You did well, they have fleas. So, Victor, you are my son’s new executioner? How did you end up in Hell, Mr. Victor?”

“I’m a chief of staff, actually. That Melodieuse woman sent me here with a spell.” Technically true, and so far the charade had kept him alive. If Victor survived this, he promised himself to take levels in a Charisma-oriented class.

“I told Braniño he shouldn’t listen to that woman,” the demoness said with a frown as if Victor confirmed a previous opinion. “Nothing good can come out of dealing with fairies, I told him. What we fiends do for business, they do for pleasure.”

Victor guessed what this Melodieuse was, and decided to avoid her at all costs. He was thankful she sent him there instead of killing him on the spot.

“I will correct this mistake,” Isabelle said, the bugs lowering their weapons.

“I am most thankful, ma’am. My master is waiting for me though, so I shouldn’t be away for too long.”

“My ungrateful son will wait,” she replied with a tone that brooked no disobedience. “Thank me by indulging me over imp brewed coffee. I want you to tell me everything Braniño has been up to. Then you will be killed.”

“With pleasure...” The last words suddenly registered. “What?”

“Then you will be killed,” she repeated flatly. “I will be correcting Melodieuse’s mistake and make sure you die this time.”

“But... but...”

“I can understand what the lich says, Victor Dalton. I was playing dumb partly because I wanted to see if you were trustworthy, and partly because I enjoy playing with my dinner.” She smirked at him, and behind the lips, there were sharp teeth. “If you tell me everything about Braniño, I *may* make it painless. Since you ruined a century of efforts on that gate, you better be entertaining.”

“Oh, I will have a hell of a time watching this,” Furibon rejoiced.

Victor’s hands moved to grab the Agarthan Warp Stone, but two bug soldiers caught his arm and restrained him, SWAT-style. “Take him to the tea room, and prepare the spice for the seasoning,” Isabelle asked.

“Halt!” A new voice came up. “This is a violation of our rights.”

Malfy? Victor recognized the voice, as the fiendish manager walked into sight, backed by two similar, thinner bugs clad in suit and ties.

“Infercorp?” Isabelle Maure didn’t hide her surprise, as her soldiers pointed their weapons at the newcomers. “What the Heaven are you doing here?”

“Protecting our client.” The bug in a suit handed a huge paper file to a surprised Isabelle. “As per our procedures, Victor Dalton here present is protected by our Faustian Associate Protection Program. He is a true mortal partner of Infercorp on Outremonde, and thus protected by our non-competition clause.”

“Give me that.” Isabelle grabbed the file and read it, her frown deepening. “Murmurin? But it is part of my market!”

“It *was*, now it’s *ours*,” Malfy replied, before turning to Victor. “Mr. Victor, fancy meeting seeing you here. You’ve come under a lot earlier than I thought.”

“Hi, Malfy,” Victor replied, still sore as the demon soldiers kept him restrained. “What’s up?”

“It’s Vice-President of Mortal Market Development Malfaisant now. The shareholders loved the new Murmurin project so much, they promoted me after they chocolatined my predecessor. You can still call me Malfy though, Mr. Victor.”

“Any violence against our client will be seen as an act of corporate warfare, and we will have to send the imp ninjas,” the bug in a suit, clearly a lawyer of some kind, argued to a livid Isabelle Maure. “We ask that, for the sake of our mutual investments, you will abandon all pursuits against Mr. Dalton.”

“Of course, since you now understand the benefits of having friends in low places, I expect you to approve our construction project in return,” Malfy whispered to Victor.

“Which project?”

“The one you will find on your desk tomorrow morning.”

Congratulations! For pulling off a Houdini on Isabelle Maure and getting a crash course on corporate impunity, you have earned the [**Get out of Hell Card**] personal Perk!

[**Get out of Hell Card**]: As long as you maintain favor with infernal powers, true Demon-Types affiliated with Hell cannot use direct violence against you, although they may still scheme or use proxies. If you use violence against a Demon-Type affiliated with Hell, you will lose this Perk.

“Is this a common thing?” Victor asked, curious, as the bugs reluctantly released him.

“Yes,” Malfy told Victor. “We have made sure that rich people get away with *everything* since you mortals invented capitalism.”

Vainqueur opened the battle with his secret weapon.

The poke!

Furiously raising his index finger, Vainqueur attempted to poke the elf in the face. Moving with incredible speed for his feeble kind, Brandon Maure dodged the strike by leaping above the hand and landing on his arm.

Before Vainqueur knew what hit him, Brandon Maure dashed on the arm, jumped, and struck him in the neck with his blade. “[Estocade]!” he shouted as his blade grazed Vainqueur’s neck, unable to pierce the scales.

Insta-death negated by [**Dragonscale**]!

Vainqueur roared and threw the grass-eater off of him, raising his hands to crush the creature. Maure landed on the ground, and the fiend dodged the dragon’s attempts at squashing him like a bug. “You shall not land a single hit on Maure’s perfect skin, Vainqueur! [Death or Glory!]” Brandon Maure’s Agility, Skill and Strength have increased, but his Vitality has drastically decreased!

The elf began to move with greater speed, faster than a fly or even the evil Furibon. He danced around Vainqueur’s limbs, nailing the dragon’s ankles with his blade. The dragon felt some itches on his legs, growing more and more annoyed with every second the grass-eater stayed alive.

“Come back here!” Vainqueur attempted to smash the elf, who leaped atop the fairy crystals holding the princesses. The dragon carefully aimed, humming and preparing to unleash a stream of fire at the elf without harming his new treasures.

“[Faena Muleta!]” Brandon Maure rose his strange red cloth in front of Vainqueur. The dragon’s eyes fixated on the red cloth, finding it strangely mesmerizing. For a reason that escaped him, his flames died in his throat.

Intelligence check failed!

Your strength has increased, but you can only use physical attacks against Brandon Maure!

What? Vainqueur hummed again, but he could only unleash hot air out of his mouth. The elf had cast a spell on him! “[Spell Purge!]”

“This is no magic trick, Vainqueur!” Maure raised his blade and red cloth piece in a stylish pause. “This is all Brandon Maure!” The crowd cheered at his words, singing his name the same way the kobolds usually cheered Vainqueur.

The love of his fans has empowered Brandon Maure! His blade will now deal [**Dragonslayer**] damage!

“[Airblade!]” The very winds swirled around Maure’s sword. And quick like the wind, he leaped off the crystal and struck Vainqueur between the eyes.

This time, the sword didn’t make his scales itch.

This time, it felt *much* worse.

Vainqueur let out a frustrated growl, moving his hands to scratch the elf off his head. The damn insect backflipped before the dragon’s claws tore him apart. Brandon Maure sliced the air in the middle of his fall, unleashing cutting blades of wind at the great calamity. Each strike hitting his scales made his body itch worse and worse.

Vainqueur tried to blast the upstart with fire, but yet again, it didn’t work. Neither could he take his eyes off that cursed piece of cloth. It infuriated him so much, all he could think was to charge at it like a bull.

And so he did, his horns and crown first while snarling. They smashed the arena’s walls, collapsing them alongside a good chunk of the stands, with the audience fleeing towards higher areas. Yet, his majestic attack failed to even hit Brandon Maure, who raced below Vainqueur, slashing him on his soft belly.

As if the terrible itching wasn’t humiliating enough, the elf kept taunting him. “You are a bull, Vainqueur! All strength, no skill! You are no emperor, but a beast who should have stayed in its cave!”

Argh, this creature was as frustrating as Furibon! But like the lich, the dragon only had to hit him once. Vainqueur just needed to take the grass-

eater by surprise to catch it.

“Blink!” Much to his displeasure, the dragon did not turn invisible. That fairy’s attack had broken his magical items.

“Magic? I should have expected that from a feeble dragon!” The insect taunted him, standing within the reach of Vainqueur’s hand and yet unharmed. “While you savage beasts ate cows in your caves, we elves ruled the greatest empire in the world!”

“We made the world first!” Vainqueur snarled back. “I had more power as an egg than your entire inbred species!”

“You crass beast, while in diapers, Brandon Maure was stranglings manling monkeys with his mere han—”

While the elf was busy ranting, Vainqueur grabbed some of the arena’s sand and threw it at him.

Surprised, the elf took the sand right in the eyes, while the crowd fell silent. “Maure’s eyes!” The elf started crying, as his kind usually did, while Vainqueur opened his mouth. “Maure has sand in his eyes!”

Chomp!

Vainqueur swallowed Brandon Maure whole like a snack and gulped. Finally, he had caught the frustrating cattle.

The audience came out of its silence to boo at him.

The crowd condemns your dirty fighting! All stats decreased!

Vainqueur didn’t care. He had won. Now, he would enjoy his reward, put the princesses in the princess bag, and then find his chief of staff...

Wait. His stomach started to feel... feel sick...

A sharp, horrible feeling made him throw up Brandon Maure at a wall like a projectile, raising a cloud of dust.

You have lost a quarter of your HP.

What... what was this feeling? It was beyond itching, beyond...

Beyond painful.

For the first time in his thousand year long life, Vainqueur realized dragons *could* feel pain.

The elf rose out of the dust, but he was no longer an elf. The walking cattle had transformed into a white and golden humanoid moth, with jet black wings and a mouthless face. A red wing grew below his left arm, replacing the cloth, and the sword now shone like the sun. With a swirling movement, he cast Vainqueur's saliva off of him, sparkles on his skin.

"A true Matador's pride is unbreakable!" the bug buzzed, with the demons' cheers becoming deafening.

The crowd's electric enthusiasm raised all of Brandon Maure's stats!

"[All or Nothing!]" As the moth raised his sword of light for a new strike, Vainqueur let out a defiant roar, rose on his two back legs, and prepared to firebomb this bug once and for all.

His eyes set on the crimson wing, and his fiery breath turned to hot air.

Faster than Vainqueur's eyes could follow, the moth dashed at him and sliced the dragon's chest. The emperor's world briefly turned white from the pain, and he collapsed on his back with a loud sound, blowing off dust all over the arena.

Massive damage!

You have lost half your HP!

What... what happened? Vainqueur tried to get back up, but his chest hurt worse than anything he had ever imagined. The crowd turned uproarious, cheering the demon king's name.

He... he was being *matched*? By an *elf*?

They eat *grass*!

“You are no emperor, Vainqueur! Thou art a beast, fit only to have your horns cut!” The moth raised his blade, as the crowd acclaimed him. Items and jewels materialized around the dirty creature, with a furious Vainqueur realizing that the fiend had activated his own [Crowd Favorite] Perk.

“Brandon Maure rules supreme!”

“Brandon, best demon! Brandon, best demon! Brandon, best demon!”

Vainqueur raised his head, feeling something warm on his belly. A shining, beautiful golden liquid flowed on his scales from the place where the bug had cut him.

It looked like dragon blood.

His blood.

Vainqueur could bleed?

A text notification added insult to injury.

Warning: You failed to properly defend your [**Emperor**] title by steamrolling Brandon Maure.

All of the [**Emperor**] class perks are ineffective until you regain your honor.

“And now, Vainqueur, know that Brandon Maure will slaughter all your fans after you are done,” the moth declared. “Then, he shall claim all your treasures as his own!”

...

No!

Vainqueur had to win.

For the *hoard*.

Giving up when faced with a true challenge was what a *manling* would do. Vainqueur was a *dragon*. The apex species, a supreme beast of legends, the greatest calamity of this age! Dragons never gave up, because, in the end, they always win!

[Dragon Arrogance] triggered! All debuffs removed!

Roused by his pride and his pure love for his treasure, the great calamity forced himself back up on all four, much to Brandon Maure's surprise.

"I will not fall!" Vainqueur roared with defiance. "For my hoard!"

"You, Vainqueur, are a worthy, well-bred, noble beast!" the moth said, adopting a wary fighting stance. "Your guts honors this arena! It will be an honor for Maure to kill you!"

Charisma check successful!

By impressing the cruel crowds of Ishfania with your fighting spirit, you earned the **[Bravo Bull]** personal Perk!

[Bravo Bull]: When your health is critical, your strength is greatly raised.

The elf thought the dragon a beast who couldn't think, and maybe Vainqueur couldn't win with strength alone. But he had *fourteen* in intelligence, and even Manling Victor started at *one*. If he couldn't crush his prey with strength alone, he would outsmart it.

Vainqueur couldn't take off his eyes from the moth's red wing as he paraded; he couldn't even close his eyes. So long as he couldn't breathe fire, he was at a disadvantage. He couldn't hit that Maure cattle with physical attacks, but he could only use them against him.

Vainqueur suddenly realized the key flaw in that [Faena Muleta] Perk.

He extended his wings and unleashed a strong gust of wind at Brandon Maure. The demon elf protected his face with his crimson wing, vanishing

from the dragon's sight behind a veil of sand.

Vainqueur couldn't target the *moth elf* with his fire.

The Perk didn't say anything about incinerating the *stage*.

And so did the dragon unleashed fireballs all over the arena, unable to see that cursed crimson wing nor its owner; he carefully avoided the crystallized princesses, but blasted the rest of the battlefield into ashes. Hopefully, he hit the grasshopper.

Your flames are inflicting heavy Holy damage to Brandon Maure!

While the moth couldn't use that cursed Perk on him, Vainqueur turned to the true source of the bug's power.

His minions.

Without giving the spectators a warning, Vainqueur chomped at the stands, eating a good dozen dark elves and fiends by surprise. The cattle's cheers turned to screams, and they ran off in panic as Vainqueur kept on chewing more of them.

These fiends tasted like spice!

Within seconds, the crowd dispersed, fiends flying away, dark elves stepping on one another, others jumping over the stands' ledge...

You interrupted the [**Demon Corrida**!] All stat changes have been canceled!

By feasting on the spicy thralls of Brandon Maure, you recovered some HP!

“[Sandstorm]!” The winds swirled around the arena, a rising sandstorm extinguishing the flames while the moth elf walked into sight. It looked furious, and much to Vainqueur's delight, bleeding and burned at the wings. “Maure's fans! What kind of beast attacks an audience of loving demon supporters?!”

“The dragon kind!” Vainqueur boasted, proud of his tactic’s success. “No more minions to support you, grasshopper!”

“You only delay your inevitable defeat, Vainqueur! Cheering fans or not, Maure will triumph!”

Vainqueur roared to the heavens, extending his wings and facing the moth elf in a show of dominance. The moth raised both his sword and crimson wing, ready to finish the fight.

Then Manling Victor teleported between them with a cloud of rancid smoke.

“Huh? That’s less damage than I imagined.” In stark contrast with both fighters, Vainqueur’s chief of staff looked unharmed. “Your Majesty? Damn, you look savaged!”

“Minion, you are back!” Vainqueur rejoiced, although he kept his focus on that cursed moth elf.

“Dalton?” the moth elf raised a blade at Vainqueur’s lackey. “Thou have escaped Hell?”

“As expected of my chief of staff!” Vainqueur boasted. “I trained him well.”

“Braniño?” Minion Victor waved a hand at the moth while holding his scythe with the other. The annoyed visage of Furibon reflected on the blade’s polished surface. “I almost didn’t recognize you for a second.”

The demon king of Ishfania made a short pause. “How do you know that nickname?”

“That’s what your mother called you. Why, is it forbidden?”

Much to Vainqueur’s displeasure, the moth lost interest in the fight and pointed his blade at Manling Victor. However, before the dragon could blast him with flames, the bug also paraded his red wing in his foe’s direction. “What have you done to my mother, ruffian?”

“Nothing. My infernal lawyers saved my hide, and apparently I have full immunity from fiends. Your mother did insist on sending me back there herself for some reason.”

The bug’s eyes narrowed dangerously. “Brandon Maure knows why. He’s half-fiend, and he loves piñata.”

The minion blinked, before adopting a defensive stance. “Wait, wait—”

Vainqueur attempted to squash the bug with his hand before he could attack, but even slowed down from the loss of his stat boosts, the creature moved faster than the dragon.

In the blink of an eye, the moth elf closed the gap between his minion and himself, before stabbing Manling Victor through the chest.

Vainqueur's vision turned red.

Chapter 27: Heaven's Door

“The pain...” Vainqueur’s chief of staff complained as Brandon Maure gored him through the chest with his blade, before smirking. “Thanks.”

The Demon King raised his head. “Indeed, there is no greater pleasure than dying by the blade of Brandon—”

“No, thanks for getting close...” The minion grabbed Maure with his free hand. “Black Curse!”

A black aura surrounded Brandon Maure, instantly draining him of his vibrancy and strength.

All of Brandon Maure’s enhancements have been removed, and all his stats reduced by one stage!

Brandon Maure can no longer recover HP while [**Black Curse**] remains active!

“What have you done?” Brandon Maure stumbled with his sword, while Manling Victor collapsed on his knees with a gaping chest wound. “Maure no longer feels amazing...”

Enraged, and only able to use physical attacks, Vainqueur raised a fist and lunged to hit Brandon Maure with a roar. The moth moved to dodge but reacted slower than before; he couldn’t run away this time.

"NO TOUCHING MY HOARD!"

And so Vainqueur punched him.

The dragon's enormous fist hit Brandon Maure with such furious strength, that it made the arena tremble and caused a blast of wind on impact. The sheer might of the blow shattered the bones in the fiend's body, and sent him flying. Maure went through the flames, the arena's wall, and then through the stands without stopping.

An entire part of the arena collapsed after the blow, Manling Victor watching on with a terrified look.

Vainqueur, meanwhile, managed to calm himself upon realizing what happened.

“I hit him!” the dragon gloated. “I finally hit the moth!”

You punched Brandon in the face! By punching a major demon lord into temporarily ‘*retreating*’, you gained a level in [**Gladiator**] and a level in [**Kaiser**]!

+60 HP, +3 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +2 CHA, +2 LCK

You earned the [**Victory Fist**] and [**Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)**] class Perks.

[**Victory Fist**]: You gain advanced proficiency in unarmed combat; your physical attacks can now harm even intangible opponents as if they were tangible.

[**Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)**]: At will, you can summon your monster herald and trusty chief of staff Victor to your side; this is a teleportation effect. If an effect should prevent teleportation, you can ignore it with a successful Charisma Check.

Warning: You have reached the level 30 class ceiling. You will no longer be able to gain additional levels until you use a [Crest]. You can still gain perks through special deeds, but your experience gains are set to zero.

“I wasn’t sure if that perk could work on him... but I’m glad it did...” His beloved minion coughed up blood. “I need a healing potion...”

“Later, minion.” The notification said, ‘temporary retreating,’ and he hadn’t regained his rightful Emperor title. “The moth yet lives!”

“Yeah, I figured it wouldn’t be easy...” Victor glanced around the arena, a hand on his bleeding chest and using the scythe to stand up straight, his eyes settling on the crystals. “The princesses...”

“These fairy crystals curse on touch with their magic,” Vainqueur explained, the fomors having fashioned that damn spell to annoy the dragon race. He grabbed back his princess bag and activated his now favorite perk. “[Spell Purge].”

Charisma Check partially successful! [**Fairy Crystal**] weakened by [**Spell Purge**]!

Vainqueur grabbed the crystallized princesses, the touch of the crystal freezing slightly on touch, and put them in his grocery bag. “Now, minion, let us find the elf moth.” With luck, he would drop a Crest for Vainqueur to use.

He smelled Knight Kia and her flying cattle coming, circling the arena. Her griffin was burned around the wings. “You have Merveille?” the knight asked. “Good, let’s use the Agarthan Warp Stone and get away, quick!”

Get away? From whom? “Not without my Crest, the moth's head, and a tribute of cattle, Knight Kia.”

“Have you destroyed the plane?” Victor asked her.

“I damaged a wing, but that woman... she’s an archmage of some sort and she packs a punch. Then Brandon Maure teleported there and ordered the plane launched! They staffed it with an army!” Noticing Manling Victor’s wound, she cast a spell on him at once, “[Greater Healing].”

A golden light enveloped his chief of staff, the chest wound closing. Victor let out a sigh of relief, and so did his master; he had worried his chief of staff would die from the blood loss like his fragile kind usually did.

Still furious, Vainqueur prepared to take flight and hunt the moth when the stench of fairykind filled his nostrils. Flying through sorcery like Furibon, that woman, Melodieuse, descended from the skies, glaring down at them.

“I tire of you, Claimed,” the fomor said to the manlings, before turning her attention to Vainqueur. “Leave, dragon. You have no business interfering. Take your slaves with you, and I will order the princeling to let you rule Murmurin unchallenged.”

The dragon finally recognized the smell. The fomor Mag Mell’s. Was she that fairy in disguise, or another of its spawns? No matter. “I fear no one, and especially not a grass-eater! Go back to your forest, fairy!”

“Then perish. [Call the Hunt].” A torrent of purple smoke surrounded the fairy, and four monstrous, elephant-sized black hounds made of dark shadows materialized around her. The creatures let out roars as they landed among the arena’s ruins, charging at the dragon and Manling Victor.

Fairy hounds. Warbeasts the fomors once created to fight dragons, and whom Vainqueur slew by the dozens in his younger days.

The first of them lunged at the dragon, who backhanded it away against the very last of the arena’s walls with his free hand, collapsing it on the abomination. Much to Vainqueur’s astonishment, his body reacted on its own, finding more entertaining, better ways to punch and poke the beasts as they came into range.

One of the beasts attacked Manling Victor, who blocked the jaws with his scythe before they could snap him in half. Knight Kia immediately rushed to help him, summoning her Solar Judgment on the creature; a beam of light hit the fairy hound in the back, vaporizing half of its body.

The fomor engaged Knight Kia in an aerial battle, raining down fiery stones and sharp spears of ice while the flyer dodged every one of them. The knight quickly closed the gap between them and tried to slash the creature in half, only for Melodieuse to quickly catch the sword with her hand, not bulging.

“[Darkest Fe—]” Melodieuse summoned a spell, only for Knight Kia to punch her in the face with her free hand. It didn’t harm the fairy, but it did distract her enough for the knight to free her sword and put back distance between them.

“She is delaying us!” Knight Kia shouted, before invoking Solar Judgment on the fomor, blasting her with light. Vainqueur heard a deep, powerful sound approaching. “Use the stone!”

Retreating?

Never! A true dragon does not run, because he cannot die!

Vainqueur ignored her, as one of the hounds he poked to death collapsed into smoke, leaving behind a pile of gold. The dragon immediately pulverized a second one with a fireball, eager for more treasure. “Minion!” he called to Manling Victor, who had managed to fend off his own opponent with his scythe. “Quick, grab my gold!”

“Your Majesty, I think we should listen to Kia!”

“Minion, a true Emperor does not run!” Vainqueur replied as he finished off the last of the fairy hounds with a stomp, and a cloud’s shadow began to cover the area. “What should I fear?”

Manling Victor raised a finger at the skies, Vainqueur following it.

The giant metal bird flew high above the arena, casting it in its immense shadow. Strange, spear-shaped iron talons pointed at them, while the left wing let out some smoke. “Vainqueur!” The voice of the moth elf came from the iron bird, the dragon noticing him through the beast’s window eye. “You have slighted Brandon Maure long enough!”

Sweet, the moth had come back to die. “I will slight you as long as you do not recognize me by my title!” the dragon roared, extending his wings proudly...

Then a magical circle appeared beneath Vainqueur's feet. "What is this?" he wondered, glaring at the fomor witch in case she intended to attack with it.

"Death," the fomor witch replied, dusting off her burnt robes before vanishing with a veil of darkness. One of the spear talons fell from the bird, then flew straight at Vainqueur, propelled by strong winds.

"Vainqueur, Victor, flee!" Knight Kia immediately grabbed a stone from under her armor with her free hand, vanishing alongside the griffon.

"Holy sh—" Manling Victor immediately ducked behind his master, who also put the princess bag behind him for safekeeping.

Before Vainqueur could react, the spear hit him in the face, detonating on contact with a blast of sharp, blinding light; the explosion unleashed a blast of compressed wind in all directions, blowing off stones, dusting the flames, and making the dragon collapse to the side.

His *entire body* itched.

You have taken *massive* damage from the Wind Spear! Critical health, [Dizzy] ailment!

You are below a **fourth** of your health!

[Bravo Bull] activated!

Vainqueur rose back up, a surge of strength helping him do so, but he had trouble standing straight. His head hurt, and the world blurred. "Minion, I do not feel well," Vainqueur admitted, feeling like throwing up his dinner. "I feel sick..."

"He *survived*?" The moth sounded very angry above. "How the Heaven did he survive a weapon made for *castles*?!"

"I am..." Vainqueur forgot his next words, stumbling on his boast, "Unforgettable..."

"Carpet him!"

Four, maybe five more magical circles appeared below Vainqueur, and more spear talons fell from the iron eagle.

“Okay, we’re done!” Manling Victor said, whom Vainqueur’s body had shielded alongside the princess bag. “Hoard, hoard, hoard!”

As the spears flew towards them, the world changed; in the blink of an eye, Vainqueur was back in his hoard, surrounded by his precious jewels and coins.

“It worked.” Victor collapsed on the gold, and for once, Vainqueur did not complain about him touching his hoard. He was too exhausted to chastise him. The Agarthan Warp Stone in his chief of staff’s hand turned to dust. “By the gods, that was close...”

“I’m not feeling well...” Vainqueur collapsed on his hoard, the warmth of the gold soothing him. His eyes moved to the princess bag, damaged but the content intact, his eyelids falling... “I’m not... I’m not well...”

“We almost died, your Majesty,” Manling Victor said something stupid. “I would settle on feeling *not well* rather than *dead*.”

“Nonsense, death is... death is a birth defect... only mammals suffer from it, like pain...”

But he did feel pain. If Vainqueur could suffer, then... maybe he could die too?

No. No, it was impossible. Vainqueur was the biggest and strongest of his kind. He could not suffer from a disability, unless every other dragon had it.

Unless... unless...

The horrible truth dawned upon Vainqueur, like a revelation from the Elder Wyrm itself. The darkest possible conspiracy theory among dragonkind, proven!

Death...

Death was *not* a disability!

Congratulations! For figuring out that yes, dragons are mortal, you earned +1 INT point.

“My entire culture is built on a lie!” As if the day could not get worse, Vainqueur realized his chief of staff had only his scythe on him. “Minion, have you grabbed my gold?”

His chief of staff glanced back in silence, and Vainqueur twitched.

Victor collapsed on his bed with his clothes on, more tired than ever. That plan did not work. At all.

They almost *died*!

Vainqueur almost died. *Vainqueur*! Brandon Maure was alive and vengeful, his magitech plane functional. If they hadn't pissed him enough to develop a grudge, then taking his princesses and punching him did.

He had to prepare Murmurin for war because his gut told him Maure would make that promised detour to bomb the region, and very soon. He had ordered the Kobold Rangers and Jules to sound the alarm at the first sign of a giant bird in the skies, and he hoped Kia would warn Gardemagne.

“No one can save you,” Furibon taunted him from within his weapon. *“You can no longer take levels, and my master commands the most powerful weapon in the world. You shall all die, so very soon.”*

As his mind worked furiously on methods to protect his charges, Furibon's words made Victor turn to the lich's soul. “You can help.”

“What?”

“Even if we can't level up without Crests, I can learn Necromancy spells, and Vainqueur can learn Exorcisms,” Victor pointed out. “You're an archmage, you must know many of them.” He would also ask Jules for training tips.

“Teaching you and that dragon magic? Never!”

Annoyed, Victor shook the scythe like a dog with a treat, Furibon’s soul hitting the blade’s limits while he did, much to his annoyance. *“This will not—”* The adventurer swung harder. *“Okay, okay, stop swinging me! Only you! I do not know any Exorcisms, and I do not want to be around that dragon!”*

Good. Victor gave the lich a respite. “We begin tomorrow,” he said, his eyelids heavy.

Before he could sleep, a bright, soothing light lit up in the room. Victor immediately raised his head, worrying Maure had teleported an assassin to him.

Instead, he found an angel at his bedside.

“Mister Dalton,” the heavenly beauty said, her voice soothing him. The creature took the shape of a blonde, eerily beautiful woman, with shining green eyes, large silver wings, and a magnificent white dress. “I am the angel Miel. I have come to save your soul.”

“Am... am I dying?” Victor asked, horrified. Was Maure’s blade wound cursed?

“No, but you almost did,” the angel replied. “Every year, hundreds of thousands of neutral-aligned, unclaimed mortal souls end up in Hell by accident. You escaped once, but you may not be so lucky next time.”

“Are you saying I will go to Hell if I die now?” The angel nodded. Victor would have loved to say he was surprised, but after everything he did, it didn’t. “But I’ve been Claimed by two gods, shouldn’t I go to them after death?”

Not that he wanted to go to Dice, but he could settle for the Moon Man.

“You do not worship them, and those deities are chaotic,” the angel replied. “You will find no salvation with them. No, Mister Dalton. The only way to

avoid damnation is to take the proper Karma Insurance. It is not too late for you.”

...

Oh, come on.

“By insuring your karma, giving us some of your Special Points every month and all of them when you die, you can avoid eternal torment,” the angel continued her sales pitch. “Please consider taking our ‘Hellfire Protection Plan’, or else you will be tortured forever when you die. We angels *care* about your safety.”

“Or at least you care about my SP.” Victor squinted at her.

“We use them to send guardian angels to orphans and heal the sick,” the angel defended herself. “If you do not give us SP, you are committing a *sin*.”

Was she trying to *guilt-trip* him? Victor started to understand what Malfy had said by angels having killer marketing. Then again... “What are your insurance plans?”

The angel blinked. “You are interested?”

“What, wasn’t it the point to sell them to me?”

“You are my first client, and the higher-ups said you were a very difficult case.” She smiled at him, like a telemarketer. “They think Redemption Chasing is a dirty job, and that you would never see the light.”

Had he such a terrible reputation upstairs? “Look, I already have very pushy offers from below, so give me a rundown.”

“Yes. First, we have the ‘Halo Health Insur—”

“MINION!”

In a blink, Victor landed in Vainqueur's vault, his back against the gold and the angel nowhere to be found.

"Ah, minion." Vainqueur glanced down at the surprised Victor. The dragon pointed at the crystalized princesses, whom he had put atop his hoard like candles. "First, I cannot break these crystals no matter how hard I punch them. Find a way to free my princesses."

"H-how did you teleport me there?"

"I summoned you," Vainqueur replied as if the answer was obvious.

"You can do that? *How?*"

"I call 'Minion' and you show up," the dragon replied, as a matter of fact. "Now, anytime I need you, I no longer have to find you. You can fulfill my requests without wasting time."

As the implications dawned on him, Victor wanted to scream, but his voice died in his throat.

"Secondly, after much thinking, I have come to accept that," Vainqueur seemed to practically force himself to speak the next words, "that death is *not* a birth defect."

"Yes, Your Majesty, death comes to all of us," Victor replied to Vainqueur, unsure what to make of the dragon's reaction. He had said it with the solemnity of someone discovering the Earth hadn't been flat all along. "Except maybe the gods."

'They can,' Furibon replied from within the scythe. *'They just do not stay dead. How do you think someone had the idea of lichdom?'*

Better not mention that idea. A dracolich would solve the meat problem, but also cause new, bigger problems.

"Which makes reaching level 100 all the more important," Vainqueur declared. "You will find two Crests, so that I may blow up that giant bird, eat that grasshopper, and never die."

“*Two Crests?*” Victor frowned.

“Yes, for the two of us,” Vainqueur clarified, his tone similar to one talking to a stupid child. “Minion Victor, I told you to become immortal. Do not make me repeat myself.”

Victor would still take the angel insurance.

Just in case.

Chapter 28: Interlude: The Chocolatine Factory

It was offering day, and so Chocolatine decided to bake three cakes: one for her god, one for her crush, and one for her brother.

Humming to herself as she dressed, Chocolatine explored her and her brother's farm looking for the pantry. She kept a lot of demon flesh salted and fresh, and an imp in an iron birdcage. The demon looked at her with his big eyes. "Kill me," the fiend pleaded. "Send me back to Hell, you crazy wolf."

"Maybe later," Chocolatine replied cheerfully, looking inside the cage. "I need eggs." Savoureuse had given her one of her own, but it wasn't enough for three cakes.

The imp looked inside the straw that worked as his nest, giving her four black eggs. "Only four?" Chocolatine complained, putting the eggs in a basket. "That's twice less than last week!"

"I'm hungry," the imp complained.

"But I give you meat all the time!"

"Demon meat! I would rather starve than eat my kindred!"

Chocolatine rolled her eyes. Damning souls and working for a lich was fine, but *cannibalism* wasn't? What was the logic behind that? "I will give you a homeless inquisitor if I find one, but they are getting rarer. Or a gnoll. Do you imps eat gnolls?"

The imp nodded with energy, Chocolatine making a mental note to ask Jules for leftovers. She put the sugar, baking powder, and some of the strawberries Rolo gave her last week into her basket, then moved to the pens outside her ranch to milk her cow, Raisin, harvesting three bottles. She took a second to oversee the pigs' pen; unlike that prickly imp, they gladly accepted demon meat, growing fatter and gaining tiny horns. With further animal husbandry, she would create a new breed of demon pigs who could sustain the village.

People thought her odd, but that was because she cared. As a priestess of Isengrim, it was her role to maintain the balance of nature, and a village full of carnivorous monsters presented unique problems she had to solve. One day, she would find a way to make the community sustainable, even if she had to keep importing food from Hell.

The vestal then went to the kitchen to bake, finding blood-splatters everywhere, even the oven. "I forgot to clean?" she asked herself out loud. Bah, she would do it tonight. Nothing better than the smell of sheep blood to get pumped while cooking.

After an hour of steady work, she finished the three strawberry cakes, the most beautiful she had ever made. Each of them, she shaped like a heart; the symbol, not the organ. She tried once, it didn't take.

Congratulations! For creating delicious cakes with love while using morally dubious ingredients, you gained a new level in [**Monster Patissier**]!

+30 HP, +1 AGI, +1 SKI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

Another level in that class? At this rate, she would hit level thirty in no time!

Croissant entered the kitchen just as she finished, lured by the lovely smell. "Good morning, sis."

"Good morning, brother." Chocolatine gave him his present inside a lunch bag. "Here is Charlene's cake, with extra flavor."

“Thank you, sis. You are sure there will be no secondary effects? The last cake bit me.”

“I told you, it was a Birthday Mimic, not my cake!” Since her Victor mass-promoted every monster he could find in order to prepare Murmurin for war, Chocolatine had no end of trouble with those shapeshifters. “None of my desserts killed anyone yet!”

Croissant gave her ‘the stare,’ but took the cake anyway. “Why three of them?” he asked, noticing the other two lunch bags she prepared, “One is for Isengrim, but the other?”

“It’s for my crush,” Chocolatine replied, without mentioning the name. She knew her brother couldn’t stand her Victor since he politically emasculated him.

“When are you going to tell me who it is?”

“So you make him run away like the last one?”

“I didn’t chase him, I ate him,” Croissant defended himself. “According to the taste, you were too good for him.”

“You’re not eating my new crush, brother.” Of course, she knew her Victor would laugh it off, but her brother’s overprotectiveness annoyed her. “How would you react if I ate Charlene?”

“Touché,” Croissant admitted. “At least promise me it’s not a gnoll this time.”

“No, he’s way cleaner,” Chocolatine chirped happily, taking the two lunch bags and leaving the house with her brother. “He is strong, charming, and forceful.”

“Eh, you can present him to me once you’ve caught him.” Croissant shrugged, as they separated, him going to Charlene’s office and her to the temple. “Maybe we’ll get along.”

She doubted it.

Chocolatine cheerfully reached the temple she shared with Allison, finding the dryad praying her goddess with Rolo. The golem had brought a sheep, asking Cybele to bless it. “[Multiply Cattle].” Rolo touched the sheep and activated his Perk, the animal dividing into two, then four, then eight.

Chocolatine waved at the two, then attended her deity’s needs. She placed the cake in front of Isengrim’s deer statue, knelt, and spoke the prayer. “God of the Hunt, Lord of the Beasts, I offer you my sacrifice. I ask you for your blessing. You are the great white deer who roams the summer woods, the bringer of spring. Oh, Isengrim, please accept my gift.”

With the prayer, she sent a few of her SP to her god, and the cake vanished from the altar. Her lord had accepted the offering.

“Chocolatine, my favorite vestal, your cake tastes delicious!” The deer statue’s eyes shone, the god Isengrim speaking through with his youthful, cheerful voice. *“You have done well maintaining the natural equilibrium in Murmurin, ousting the lich Furibon from power, and hastening the extinction of demonkind. I am proud of you, keep up the good work!”*

“Thank you, my lord,” Chocolatine nodded. “Can I ask for your guidance, oh Isengrim?”

“Of course. What is troubling you, my child?”

“There is a boy I want to breed with, but he will not. How do I breed with him?”

“Is that that Victor whose name you keep repeating in your prayers?” Chocolatine nodded ardently. *“Is he married?”*

“No.” If that was the problem, Chocolatine would have solved it long ago. She had lots of poison in her pantry. “He is single, although he does not like it.”

“Have you offered to lay with him during the mating season?”

“Yes, I did, but he said he didn’t want to break our friendship.”

“While I am the god of the hunt, that kind eludes me. I will ask my friend Cybele, goddess of love, on advice on your behalf. Otherwise, try perfume. The sweeter the smell, the greater your chances of catching your prey unaware.”

“Thank you, great Isengrim!”

“Good luck, Chocolatine!”

The priestess ended her prayers, the light leaving out the statue’s eyes. She found out that Allison and Rolo had finished her own prayers. “Choc, are you available this evening?” the dryad asked her. “We need anti-vermin spells to help protect the culture from depredation.”

“With pleasure.” She owed the dryad one. When her Victor tried to make a move on her, proving that the ‘friendship’ could be overcome, Allison had said that she liked girls—which was true, but she liked boys just as much—to fend him off. The sisterhood resisted! “Do you think we could feed a big city, after the dragons are gone?”

“Ten thousand, if we finish the irrigation canals,” Rolo replied. “With judicious use of my, and Allison’s [Grow Plant] Perks, we could hasten the landscaping.”

“You wish to invite more settlers,” Allison guessed.

“Cousins from other tribes,” Chocolatine nodded, pumped by Rolo’s answer. “I thought about it while in Gevaudan: why do civilized species hate us werewolves, monsters, and predators?”

“Because you eat them,” Rolo replied.

“Because we eat them, and we eat them because we lack enough meat; to retaliate, the humans and their kin chase us away from the cities which could sustain our hunger, and the cycle continues! Mimics, vampires, and others adapted by infiltrating civilization, but that is not enough! We need trade, import! By creating a city of monsters which can sustain itself, we

can inspire our kindred to imitate us, and ‘civilized’ species that we can feed in harmony! Maybe even trade!”

“You meant live,” Allison picked up. “Live in harmony, not feed.”

“Yes, same thing,” Chocolatine replied cheerfully, as the two worshippers of Cybele exchanged a glance.

Her service done, the vestal carried the last cake with her to the new building in the north part of Murmurin. Bug fiends under Malfy’s direction had constructed a large, ivory-draped, six-floor building there, the tallest next to Emperor Vainqueur’s own statue. Chocolatine didn’t particularly like the rounded architecture—which the fiends called ‘modern and trendy,’ but the place stood out.

She found a crowd of monsters gathered in front of it, including the Kobold Rangers, and Malfy himself. A ribbon kept the doors closed, her Victor ready to cut it with his scythe while riding the Black Beast of Murmurin.

The voice of Malfy, enhanced by a spell, resonated, the monsters focusing on him. “Welcome to the grand opening Nethermart, the first fiendish magic item shop in all of Outremonde, open to all monsters and mortals! If you cannot pay with coins, you can keep a tab with us for the low, low price of your soul as collateral! And to celebrate the coming war with Maure, we offer a thirty percent sale on weapons! An axe in every home!”

The crowd of undead, kobolds, gnolls and other monsters cheered as one.

“The Emperor couldn’t bear to watch his minions buying stuff with the money he pays them, so he sent me to inaugurate it in his stead!” Victor said, raising his scythe. “In his name, I declare the Nethermart open!”

He narrowed his weapon and cut the ribbon. The monsters immediately rushed to the gates, with Malfy the fiend barely having the time to move out of the way.

Only Chocolatine, Malfy, and Victor remained outside. She immediately worked on her crush. “Vic!” She approached him with a leap. “What a

coincidence, I was looking for you!”

“Oh, really?” He didn’t sound half as enthusiastic as her. Had she overdone it? “What for?”

“I know you are super exhausted with preparing the Bragging Day, so I prepared you lunch.” She offered him the cake, but his free hand didn’t reach for it. Instead, the Doer of the Thing appraised the gift with wariness.

“Is it poisoned?” Victor asked.

“Of course not!” Chocolatine replied, offended. “If I wanted to kill, I would eat you, and eating poisoned food is unhealthy.”

“That is reassuring,” Victor replied, before taking the lunch. “Thanks, Chocolatine.”

Her crush started opening the lunchbox, whistling upon seeing the cake. It was working, it was working, it was working...

Then Victor popped out of existence with the cake before he could take a bite, leaving his undead mount behind.

“Unfortunately, that is happening more and more,” said Malfy, moving to shake ‘hands’ with the astonished priestess. “Chocolatine, how beautiful you are today. Thanks for coming to our opening day.”

“You’re welcome, Malfy. You are my best import source.” The werewolf shook the fiend’s pincer, regaining her cheery disposition once the bitter disappointment and shock had passed. Unlike other followers of Isengrim, she didn’t hate fiends and undead; they were just easy, bountiful prey whose hunt her god condoned. “You look so happy, too!”

“Nethermart’s share value is through the roof on Soulwell Street. Thanks to the goodwill gained from our current partnership, we will make a killing on the soul stock exchange.”

“Nice,” Chocolatine said, although she had no idea what he meant. She glanced around, in case someone was listening, asked him for advice. “You

sell everything?”

“Almost. Following the mysterious mass disappearance of swords in the region, we no longer sell those.”

Junior strikes again. “Do you have love potions?”

The bug looked at her with what Chocolatine took for disapproval. “We no longer sell love potions. They are unethical, and the equivalent of slipping someone a roofie. We respect our clients’ free-will, which is the cornerstone of our bottom-line.”

Chocolatine pouted. “But you come from Hell! Shouldn’t you offer that kind of solution?”

“We are no longer called Hell,” Malfy replied. “After decades of benchmarking studies, our Corporate Overlords identified the name as no longer politically-correct. We have now been rebranded as *Happyland*.”

“Happyland?” Chocolatine raised an eyebrow. “It sounds like a fair.”

“Exactly the reaction our marketing department looks for. We expect mortals to assimilate the new branding within fifty years, correlating with an increase in soul revenue. I insist that, in spite of what the name would imply, *Happyland* does not sell mind-control devices.”

Why couldn’t she find an easy solution? “May I ask who is the victim?” Malfy asked, curious.

“Vic.”

“Ah, Mr. Victor? I understand the cake part better.” The bug let out a sound of interest. “You would be such a good influence on his ethics. Can I offer you my help?”

“You will?” The bug nodded. “Great! Any idea on how to catch him?”

“I believe the quickest solution would be assassinating your rivals for Mr. Victor’s affection.”

“I can’t kill half the world’s population!” Chocolatine protested. “It is impractical, and against my religion.”

The fiend summoned a pen and a paper, while the first clients exited the Nethermart with weapons, potions, and other items. “Let me ask you, what relationship status are you hoping for? Shotgun wedding? Deadly mantis coupling? Cat and mouse relationship? The more details the better tailored my solution.”

“No wedding.” Chocolatine hadn’t thought that far ahead. “I just want him to break into my temple, tie me up with ropes to my god’s statue, then say ‘time to *desecrate* this holy place,’ and—”

“I do not imagine Mr. Victor in that kind of situation without severe use of mind-control,” Malfy interrupted her, scribbling notes. “Which I cannot endorse.”

“I just want him to use his [Monster Rider] Perk on me at least once a week.” Her brother’s overprotectiveness had left her frustrated and starved.

“That Perk can apply to this kind of situation? Thank you for the information, I will tell the Succubus Department.” Malfy took notes. “So no marriage? What you want is a purely physical relationship?”

“I would like some foreplay, tension, excitement...”

“Yes, but no tying down. Good. As a demon, I cannot, in good conscience, support marriage.” The bug considered the matter. “We at Nethermart sell magical items which can increase your charisma, but Mr. Victor may lose interest upon reaching the naked part of the process. A more rewarding, longer-lasting method would be refashioning you.”

“Refashioning?”

“Before I became manager, I was a damnation coach for the Succubus Pickup Scene. We had fall from grace down to a science. Thankfully, Mr. Victor is, what we call in Happyland, a ‘good-hearted lecher,’ one of the easiest marks. We have many protocols for him.”

“Protocols?” Chocolatine frowned. “You were planning to seduce him?”

“We fiends have been subject to libel-filled PR campaigns from angels since our arrival in Outremonde. Unfortunately, Mr. Victor has been influenced by this heavenly propaganda, which slows down our progress in Murmurin; I even discovered he agreed to a Karma insurance plan with them, which means Heaven tries to enter *our* market.” The fiend shook with anger, before calming himself. “We will launch a holistic lobbying campaign aimed at nudging Mr. Victor, and through him, the Emperor, towards a complete paradigm shift on the subject of Happyland.”

Chocolatine did not understand half of the fiend’s buzzwords, but she got the gist of it. “You have a plan.”

“Yes, I recommend opening the seduction with Redemption Signaling.”

Chocolatine listened in with rapturous attention, the fiend explaining himself with a professional tone.

“It is a technique where you send mixed messages to the mortal target about the possibility of redemption. The idea is to qualify yourself as a PRT, or ‘potential redemption target,’ and then his heroic instincts will kick in. Mortals are suckers for broken birds. Now, you have to maintain a careful balance, like *‘I steal, but I fight worse people,’ ‘I’m not bad, I just don’t follow the rules,’* or *‘it is not my fault I am like this, blame society.’*”

“And it *works*?”

“All the time. It would have been even better if we could make a ‘cat burglar’ motif work with you. The core of the strategy is to make the target believe they can change you, that you could ‘go straight’ with a special person’s love, which they will believe to be themselves. Play hard to get so the mortal believes he has to work for it, and they will fall into the trap.”

“It sounds very manipulative though,” Chocolatine pointed out.

“Do you want him or not? Then show him signs of the wounded heart beneath your... predatory... exterior, look vulnerable when he thinks you

do not know he is watching, and over time, he will get attached.” The fiend handed her over the paper note. “Here is a script for you to follow.”

Chocolatine read it with great attention, her eyes widening as she went on. He even had a tree chart for each possible answer.

Could she really be desperate enough to follow his advice?

...

“And what happens if you are nice for real?” Chocolatine asked, finding that option nowhere in the chart. “Not pretending.”

“I do not understand,” Malfy replied. “You mean a double-layer trap? I would not recommend it, only an expert can pull that off.”

She would give it a go.

Chapter 29: Dragon Guests

“You are certain, Manling Victor?” Vainqueur asked, upon looking at the strawberry cake, which his lackey had moved in front of the fairy crystals. “This seems like a waste of good food.”

“Positive,” his Doer of the Thing said. “Come on, try.”

“[Lesser Demonbane]!” Vainqueur cast the exorcism spell with his finger, a ray of light hitting the cake. While the food remained unharmed, a dark, crimson aura escaped it, letting out a terrible scream.

You have exorcised: Demon Strawberry Cake.

“It worked, Manling Victor!” His very first spell! “I am a wizard!”

The dragon had spent days in his cave, practicing the spells that Corpseling Jules taught him. Since Vainqueur never bothered to learn how to read manling language, he had the corpseling teach him how to read scrolls and grimoires.

The dragon picked it up very quickly. Vainqueur could have sworn it took him years to learn to speak his minions’ primitive tongue, centuries ago.

“It should work well against Brandon Maure,” his lackey said. “His enhancements make him dangerous, but if Your Majesty hits his demonslayer weakness with exorcisms, they should dispel them.”

“Then I eat him,” Vainqueur nodded in agreement.

“My turn then...” The minion raised his scythe like a staff. “[Death Candle].”

A tiny spirit made of bluish, ghostly flames appeared above the cake, like a candle. It stared at Manling Victor with two yellow spots of eyes without a word. “Nice. I can use the scythe to spellcast. Must be that [Scythe Lord] perk.”

“Minion, my guests cannot eat ghosts,” Vainqueur pointed out, the flame spirit looking at him next. “You should learn to summon demons, like tasty Malfy.”

“One tier at a time, Your Majesty.”

“Have you found a way to break the fairy crystal curse?” Vainqueur asked, looking at his beautiful trapped maidens. “While they make for great decoration, we dragons prefer talking, singing princesses to stuffed ones.”

“Unfortunately, nobody in Murmurin has powerful enough magic to shatter them. Malfy said his company may have the necessary tools, but he must ask his executives. Charlene also informed me King Roland Gardemagne will come personally to, I quote, *‘Recover his niece, meet with the self-proclaimed Emperor of Murmurin, and grant unto him a boon for his service.’* I think he will bring stronger sorcerers with him, maybe Kia.”

“Self-proclaimed nothing!” Vainqueur contested angrily. “I am Emperor!”

Your [**Emperor**] Class is no longer recognized.

“Of course it is!”

Your [**Emperor**] Class will be unrecognized until you defeat: Brandon Maure.

“Minion, when is that moth supposed to attack us?” Vainqueur narrowed his eyes, eager for payback.

“He already should have,” Manling Victor replied. “Kia must have damaged his flying fortress enough to delay him. I promoted every able-bodied minion I could find, asked everyone to prepare for a siege, bought weapons from Malfy—”

“Bought?” Vainqueur glared at his minion, horrified. His lackey couldn’t be desperate enough to embezzle his treasure!

“With my own money,” Victor reassured his master, although it still shocked the dragon. “All of this to say, I wouldn’t worry about Maure coming. The only question is, *when*, and with how many soldiers.”

“How many steaks,” the dragon corrected him. Vainqueur almost wished for that moth to come on his Bragging Day, so he could stylishly smash him before his brethren. Almost.

Someone frantically struck the vault’s doorbell, causing Vainqueur and Victor to look at the gate. “Open!” The spells set by his spellcaster minions causing the vault’s door to widen and reveal the Kobold Rangers.

“Birds, Your Majesty!” Red the Kobold said, panicked. “Big birds in the sky!”

“Birds?” Manling Victor panicked. “Maure has a *fleet*?”

“More than one!” Blue panicked as well. “Half a dozen with great wings and breathing smoke!”

“Minion, those are not iron birds,” Vainqueur clarified, energized. “*They* are here! Prepare the appetizers!”

Manling Victor started to panic. “But, but, but they should have arrived tomorrow!”

“Ah, yes, I forgot to inform you that, unlike your kind, dragons are smart enough to be early when a feast is involved, so they can eat the best parts ahead of the competition.”

“Is Your Majesty subtly implying my kind is mentally challenged?” Manling Victor tried to defend his kind’s nonexistent honor. “We humans have ten intelligence on average, more than most species.”

Pfft, no way, Vainqueur started at nine.

...

Nine.

The average manling started at ten?

...

“Menu,” Vainqueur spoke up, his voice ice cold. “Show me my original intelligence score, before I gained the Class system.”

Pre-class INT score: 8.

...

“Your Majesty? Why are you twitching? You’re scaring me.”

“Menu,” Vainqueur repeated, this time his voice more ominous. “What is my *correct* score?”

Pre-class INT score: 8.

“No, it is not! What is my true score?” Pre-class INT score: Square Root 64.

“Better,” Vainqueur said, happy with the higher number. “We will welcome the first guests at once, so that I may smugly showcase my superior might and unrivaled intellect. Kobolds!”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“Tell the other minions to prepare the snacks. Hurry!” The kobolds scampered off, Vainqueur closing the door’s vault behind them. “Minion Victor, remember what I told you. You shall second all of my boasts, not speak unless addressed by a dragon first, and you will repeat that I am good, smart, and wealthy every time I am mentioned.”

“Your Majesty, I have been meaning to ask, could we please avoid mentioning classes and levels?”

“Minion, I have rediscovered this ancient dragon system,” Vainqueur reminded his Doer of the Thing. “Why *wouldn’t* I brag about it?”

“Because other dragons will compete with you over treasure if they learn to access it.”

Oh, he was worried about his master’s safety and long-term dominance. Adorable. “Good, that will keep me sharp,” Vainqueur replied, embracing the challenge. “It would do no good for my reputation if I was the strongest of my kind because they are all weak; does anyone boasts about being the best manling? Or the best troll? No, because nobody wants to be the best manling. Everyone wants to be the best *dragon* because dragons are *awesome*.”

“But your greed—”

“Minion, while there is nothing greater than my hoard, I will brag fairly. Silence invites accusations of fraud, and I shall prove that I earned my wealth. Finally, without this system, I would not have had the power to cure the curse of the evil Furibon, who had to be destroyed. Other dragons must know in case the lich is ever released from his seal.”

Manling Victor put his hand on his face. “I knew this day would come...”

“Of course, I told you,” Vainqueur replied, before making use of that [Dungeon Owner] Perk of his. With a thought, he teleported atop the highest of his castle’s tower, under the bright sun.

Vainqueur glanced at his territory, finding that his minions had finished refurbishing the castle as he commanded, even adding a stone crown to the tallest tower. Perfect.

“MINION!” Vainqueur summoned his chief of staff at his side, before giving a majestic roar as his manling almost fell from the tower.

Above, six dragons answered with roars of their own, the flock descending to nest on the various towers’ roofs; the minions staffing the castle stopped briefly to look at them through the windows, and Vainqueur didn’t chastise

them for it. Being in his company was already an honor, more of his kind was an overdose to their senses.

His first guests were, as he expected, his close family, among them his favorite cousin, the brown wind dragon Genialissime. A clutch of three dragonlings the size of poneys followed him, the children he had gained custody of after mating with Blightswamp. Each of them was black like their mother, but Vainqueur hoped they had inherited the father's intellect. He also noticed his niece, the red dragon Jolie, all grown up.

Unfortunately, there was one exception: a white, frost dragon with icicle spikes growing out of his back, smugly staring at Vainqueur with smug blue eyes. "Icefang," Vainqueur said in the old dragon tongue, glaring at his hated rival. That smug lizard had grown almost as big as the great red dragon. "Still unable to breed?"

"Vainqueur, still poor?" Icefang replied with a jab of his own, flying above the castle without bothering to land, a very foppish manoeuver. "And it is *Great King* Icefang now!"

"I was never poor!"

"Compared to me, you are!"

"Your hoard is made of silver!" Vainqueur contested, refusing to be upstaged on his big day. "It does not count! It does not shine enough!"

"Wealth knows no limits!" Icefang shouted back. "I hope for you that you can back up your boasts, for I will count every coin!"

"Then you will count until the end of time!"

Besides the natural rivalry between red and frost dragons—since the reds were obviously bigger and wealthier—Icefang had made it his life's purpose to upstage Vainqueur as the greatest of all dragons, spending all his time while awake gathering a bigger hoard, beautiful princesses, and the finest of minions. He always failed, and a fifty-years nap had only worsened his bitterness.

Vainqueur would show him the true meaning of rich.

“Uncle Vainqueur!” Vainqueur’s niece Jolie landed on a tower near his own. She had grown into a small but elegant red dragon, bigger than an elephant. “Happy Bragging Day!”

“Jolie, you have grown bigger!” Vainqueur saluted his niece, as he did his cousin. “Good to see you too, Genialissime!”

“How could I miss my dear cousin’s Bragging Day?” the wind dragon replied happily, his clutch of dragonlings landing on their father’s back. “Children, I present you your first cousin once removed, Vainqueur Knightsbane. Vainqueur, this is Courageux, Sage, and Fort.”

“Money?” one of the dragonlings, Courageux, asked, with his father’s big eyes.

“How much?” replied his sister Sage, while the third tried to speak the word ‘gold.’

“Oh, they are saying their first words!” Vainqueur rejoiced, Genialissime nodding with paternal pride. “They have your eyes.”

“Thank you, but we must discuss an important subject.” Genialissime scowled. “A great enemy is in our midst.”

“The evil Furibon,” Vainqueur replied grimly.

“Your minion messengers told us of the Goldslayer Furibon, and his insane scheme to turn the world's gold to lead,” Icefang said. “Where is he?”

“I defeated Furibon, and my lackey, Victor,” Vainqueur put his hand behind the shy Manling Victor’s back, pushing him at the forefront, “sealed his twisted soul inside his scythe. Manling Victor, show them!”

Manling Victor, anxious at so many dragons looking up at him, raised his weapon, showcasing the dark soul kept within. “Manling Victor does a great service to dragonkind, keeping this depraved lead-lover sealed,”

Genialissime declared. "I propose that no dragon eats Manling Victor until he dies fulfilling his sacred duty."

"For as long as the Evil Furibon remains sealed, I welcome this motion," Icefang said.

"Uh, thanks..." the manling said, taking a step back as the dragons' eyes turned intense.

Genialissime whistled. "Vainqueur, your chief of staff can speak and understand dragon?"

"I taught him well," Vainqueur boasted. He knew Manling Victor would reflect well on him!

"That is because Your Majesty is good, smart, and wealthy," his lackey confirmed. "Not necessarily in that order."

"Anyone can teach draconic," Icefang replied. "Nothing to brag about. The dragon language is pure and simple, even the lesser species can learn it!"

"Are you implying that dragon speech is on the same level as the manlings' backward language, Icefang?" Genialissime replied, offended. "Teaching a member of the lesser races our complex and noble language demands extraordinary effort, and that primitive humanoid speaks like a native!"

"While I am proud that my *unparalleled* genius spilled onto my chief of staff, how do you find that less bragworthy than defeating the evil Furibon?" Vainqueur asked, incensed they did not cheer his great victory.

"You cannot boast about it," Icefang replied. "Since according to your own *War of the Hoard*, which my own chief of staff found poorly written, by the way, Manling Victor delivered the final blow and sealed the evil Furibon. You could not have destroyed the lich for good on your own, so it does not count."

"I agree, unfortunately," said Genialissime. "The boast goes to Manling Victor alone."

“But he is my minion!” Vainqueur protested. “I chose him, prepared him! When I found him he was but a homeless thief! I made him the best chief of staff in the world!”

“You can boast about your great choice of minion, which is bragworthy, but it would not be fair to claim the death of Furibon as your own, Vainqueur,” Genialissime said. “I am sorry, cousin, I cannot give you full points for this boast.”

“This is an indignity!” Vainqueur replied angrily. “I will not stand by this! Look at the castle I claimed from the lich! See the towers? See the lava?”

“Mmm... seven towers.” Icefang hesitated, even he admiring the architecture. “Good. It is a very good castle.”

“It is the greatest castle in the world, brimming with my dragon majesty! Hundreds of undead minions built it!”

“But can it *fly*?” Icefang nitpicked, ignored by the others.

“Uncle Vainqueur, you have undead minions?” Jolie blinked in awe.

“Hundreds of them!” Vainqueur boasted, the dragons amazed by this status symbol. “Those I do not eat, I raise!”

“Uh, you still eat minion meat?” Jolie complained, less enthusiastic than before. “Should you brag about it?”

“My niece is a cattletarian,” Vainqueur told his confused chief of staff with a sigh. “She only eats non-speaking animals and cattle.”

He found that dragon movement ridiculous since every creature had the fundamental right to be eaten by him. Discriminating made them no better than manlings.

Also, he had heard that she let her minions ride on her back, which he found socially offending. He hoped that her teenage rebellion phase wouldn’t last another century.

“Manlings and other sentient beings have souls, like us,” Jolie said, most of the other dragons rolling their eyes or snickering. “Yes, eating them and abducting their princesses is morally wrong.”

“Except elves,” Vainqueur told his chief of staff. “Elves are fine.”

“While I applaud your stand on not eating my kind, why not extend that mercy to elves?” Manling Victor asked. “They’re people too.”

“Your chief of staff is badly trained, Vainqueur,” Icefang said. “He speaks out of turn.”

“No, it is fine, I will explain cattletarianism to him, too!” Jolie replied, before turning to Manling Victor and speaking with a teacher-like tone. “Manling Victor, elves are not people. They are *elves*. They eat grass like cows, and they make the best princesses.”

“Have you released the one I caught for your first Bragging Day back into the wild?” Vainqueur asked his niece, who dutifully nodded. “Good. Every dragon must be mindful of preserving the wildlife.”

“Princesses are an endangered species in the north due to wanton dragon overhunting,” Icefang lamented. “I wish more of my kind was environment-conscious.”

“Blightswamp has been trying to find a way to preserve them by raising them in captivity,” Genialissime said. “However, she has yet to find the way noble ladies evolve into princesses. She thinks they need knights to undergo the metamorphosis.”

“Princessness only happens in the wild,” Icefang replied with contempt. “Also, where is the sport in raising princesses at home? The hunt is half the pleasure.”

While he despised Icefang, Vainqueur could not agree more. He had considered using his [Dynasty] Perk to create nobles and then princesses, before realizing it would dilute the value of wild maidens.

Sensing the spotlight getting away from where it belonged—on Vainqueur—the Emperor of Murmurin made a bold move. “While tomorrow shall be my true Bragging Day, before all my other guests, as a reward for your quick arrival, I shall present you a sneak peek of my magnificent hoard!”

“Ohoh, that should be amusing,” Icefang said. “I’m sure you can’t even bathe in it!”

Chapter 30: Demon Feast

Much to Vainqueur's satisfaction, when Icefang looked upon his magnificent hoard, the frost dragon's eyes widened as if he had suffered from a stroke.

"So huge and deep!" Jolie walked on the hoard, amazed by its depth, its warmth, its texture... its shininess. As a kingly gesture, Vainqueur let his family touch his treasure, so they could *feel* his wealth.

"It's so warm and golden!" Genialissime added. "It's... it's the biggest hoard I have ever seen!"

"Indeed!" Vainqueur boasted with a quiet, smug voice. "Can you feel the warmth? The richness? The perfect mesh of jewels, gold, and princesses?"

"How did *you* accumulate that much gold?" Icefang asked, ever resentful. "Your treasure could barely fill a cave one hundred years ago!"

"It is because I discovered a great, ancient secret," Vainqueur kept boasting. "A system designed to make dragons even richer! By dragons, for dragons!"

"Twelve gods, please forgive me..." Manling Victor muttered to himself in a corner, while the dragons examined every inch of Vainqueur's hoard, looking for a fake setup. "I tried. I'm so sorry..."

"An ancient secret?" Jolie turned to her uncle with stars in her eyes, and so did his small first cousins once removed.

"A great sorcery, if somewhat faulty." Vainqueur decided not to mention the intelligence score errors nor his problems with the Emperor Class, before

raising his index finger. “Which allows me to summon treasure by poking manlings to death!”

“This is gibberish,” Icefang contested, and even Genialissime seemed puzzled. “What next, the moon is not a planet, and death is not a birth defect?”

Vainqueur realized that too many revelations at once may be too much to stomach for his kind, and so reluctantly, kept the dark secret of dragon mortality to himself. The world was not ready yet. “It is the truth,” Vainqueur defended his greatest discovery. “By taking levels in the amazing Noble Class, I now earn a stipend of shiny gold every month!”

“What?!” All the dragons’ eyes turned at him.

“I knew I was right to take that insurance plan...” Manling Victor muttered. “Thank the gods I did.”

His dragon master ignored him and proudly showed his guests the iron plate around his neck, and began to boast eagerly, “I, Vainqueur, am the greatest adventurer in the world! The manlings worship the ground I walk on when I do not fly! They pay me to kill their kind, and so do their gods!”

“This plate made you rich?” Icefang looked at it with greed.

“Oh, look, princesses!” Jolie noticed the trapped maidens in the fairy crystals, suddenly more interested in them than the secret of gold farming. “Two elves, so beautiful... and a human. Uncle Vainqueur, that one is not ethical.”

“They are stuffed!” Icefang complained. “They cannot dance nor sing! It is *indragon!*”

“Yes, feel jealous of my wealth and treasures,” Vainqueur taunted his rival. He opened his mouth to gloat further when his castle trembled, and a shrieking sound erupted.

“The magical alarm,” Manling Victor said, panicked. “Maure!”

“No, that is my vault’s alarm!” Vainqueur glanced and smelled around, looking for an uninvited guest, and found none. He immediately glared at Icefang. “A thief! A thief in my hoard!”

“Vainqueur, I respect myself too much to steal your gold on your own Bragging Day,” Icefang sneered back. “And silver is better, purer.”

“No, it is not,” Vainqueur replied to that heretic.

“Mayhaps this caused the sound?” Genialissime asked, pointing a claw at the second set of doors in the vault. Vainqueur squinted at them.

Indeed, the gate to Hell did shine strangely.

At once, without much warning, the chains holding the doorway closed broke. As the gates opened, a burst of sulfuric smoke entered the vault, alongside dozens of imps, fiends, and bug-like monsters. All of them carried weapons and wore armor, walking as an ordered regiment on Vainqueur’s hoard.

“The seals broke?” Manling Victor raised his scythe. “But Choc and the others reinforced them! Unless...”

“Vainqueur, your illegal occupation of King Maure’s property ends here!” A huge, tasty fiend that looked like a mix between a cow, a bat, and a humanoid stepped through the gates. “We, Maure Hellcorporated, shall take back our market share!”

The sight of these paupers desecrating his treasure room briefly paralyzed Vainqueur with fury, before he understood the situation. “Ah, good thinking, Manling Victor,” the dragon told his confused chief of staff. “Excellent idea to bring appetizers for the early guests.”

“Is that the buffet?” Genialissime said with a cheerful expression, humming at the sulfuric smell. “Nice, they smell spicy.”

The fiendish leader suddenly realized that he faced seven hungry dragons of various sizes, and his troops took a step back.

“I thought you, Vainqueur, would be stingy on the food, but I am pleasantly surprised,” Icefang said, glimpsing at the humanoid cattle with hunger. “He’s a bit skinny around the edges, but it will make for a passable snack.”

“A talking cow?” Jolie looked at the fiendish captain with interested eyes. “A new kind of cattle? It’s grey enough not to count for my regime! Dibs on the cattle!”

The fiend’s eyes widened in panic. “Retreat!” the cattle shouted to its troops. “It’s a trap! IT’S A TRAP!”

The gold coins below the fiend moved on their own, taking the shape of a manling-like creature, which immediately restrained it from behind. Vainqueur knew he was right to give his hoard self-defense classes.

And then...

Chomp!

Jolie swallowed the cattle fiend whole, and the other adult dragons rushed for the gate with hunger. The fiends tried to run away back to Hell through the gate, only for them to get frozen by Icefang’s chilling breath or stopped by the hoard as Genialissime closed in.

And so the feast began.

Vainqueur watched with quiet joy as he saw his niece and cousins catch the food and devour it with ravenous energy. Genialissime’s children, too young to hunt alone, worked together to bite a screaming demon’s legs and drag him to a corner; even his bitter rival enjoyed the appetizer, showing classy table manners by snapping fiends in half before eating them like sticks.

“Holy Hell...” Victor stared at the scene, horrified, putting a hand on his mouth. “It’s... it’s... savage...”

“Manling Victor, you’ve seen me feast for months,” Vainqueur replied, delighting at the scene. His guests were fed, and the thieves punished. Win-

win!

“There are more behind that door!” Jolie shouted, her mouth drenched in fiendish blood, as she put her neck through the gate. “Spicy!”

“Safari time!” Genialissime rejoiced, moving through the gate with the others in tow.

Vainqueur was slightly bothered that they would ignore his wealth for the food, but couldn’t blame them. They had flown for miles and burned a lot of fat to come here. “Good work, minion. Your quick thinking showcased the true depth of my wealth and the bountifulness of my domain.”

“Your Majesty, this wasn’t my doing,” the manling replied. “I believe the seals were sabotaged from our side, which means Maure not only has agents in Murmurin. This may be the opening salvo of a full invasion.”

Vainqueur’s eyes flared with fury. “The moth attacks us on my big day?!”

The castle trembled, and all magical alarms went off with strident sounds. The enraged Vainqueur immediately activated his [Dungeon Owner] Perk and teleported outside, on the roof.

The dragon found his castle under siege by a flock of gargoyles and spearmen riding wyverns, who fought his kobold and undead minions on the fortifications. That damn metal eagle flew high above the southern desert, followed by a large flock of flying beasts.

On the ground, a black mass, the moth’s land army, spread out of the sandy lands and into his dominion. That was a *lot* of fiends and elf cattle, more than Vainqueur had ever seen gathered in one place. They were crossing the canals his minions had built, and rushed towards Murmurin with pillage on their minds.

“You will not ruin my big day!” Vainqueur incinerated the nearest gargoyles and wyvern-riders with his holy breath, their corpses falling into the lava below. His mere presence emboldened the minions, who shot arrows and

spears at the invaders. The dragon took flight, hunting down the panicked air force with claws and flame.

Two circles of light materialized on the castle's ramparts, and Vainqueur instantly realized what that meant. "Not my castle!" the dragon snarled, flying above the crater, as the distant iron eagle fired two projectiles at his lair.

Vainqueur hit one with a fireball, causing it to detonate harmlessly above the crater, but the other slipped past his guard and reached his lair.

A magical barrier, the very same which Furibon had hidden behind during the War of the Hoard, stopped the weapon before it could hit the castle. A powerful burst of compressed wind blasted both minions and invaders in all directions, making the crater tremble; yet the barrier resisted.

Manling Victor rushed out of the castle's gates, riding the Black Beast of Murmurin and followed by a group of undead led by Corpseling Jules. "I had Jules activate Furibon's old defenses," Manling Victor explained as he glanced up at his master. "How many enemies?"

"All of the food in this backward desert," Vainqueur replied, unable to count.

"The entire Ishfanian army is attacking us?" Manling Victor panicked. "Your Majesty made Maure mad when you punched him."

"The foolish moth knows my emperorness is the greatest threat to his authority," Vainqueur replied.

Your [**Emperor**] Class is not recognized.

"Yes, it is!" Vainqueur insisted.

"They're going to Murmurin?"

"The moth is trying to take back my hard-won empire, break the seal keeping Furibon imprisoned, and ruin my big day!" Vainqueur snarled, imparting on his lackey the seriousness of the situation.

“I think he wants to wipe us out then continue to invade Gardemagne, as he planned. He must be stopped right there.”

“Yes!” The dragon cared about one thing and one thing only. “We will defend my hoard and my castle, even if we have to burn every single elf out there. The coins must be protected.”

“If that magical barrier can resist one of their ‘wind spears,’ then their air force shouldn’t have what it takes to break it,” Manling Victor pointed out, before turning to Jules. “You can hold the castle by yourself?”

“If I can maintain the magical protections and raise the dead as they fall, I believe we will have enough forces to,” Jules said. “But if they take the village and climb the mountain, their mages may either disable the barrier or, more likely, wake up the volcano to sink the castle.”

Vainqueur froze. That would destroy his hoard!

“We must stop their troops at Murmurin,” said Manling Victor, showing his worth as a military advisor. “Your Majesty, the other minions and I can defend the castle and the town, but none of us can fly nor defeat Maure himself. He’s probably commanding the attack from the eagle’s bridge. If we take him down, the army will fall back.”

“Minion, that is an iron bird, not a bridge,” Vainqueur replied, before glaring at the iron fortress. Everyone counted on him to save the world. It was his moment in the spotlight. “Minion, will I gain a Crest if I kill that moth?”

“If not, I don’t know what it will take.”

Vainqueur nodded, extending his wings. “Minion Victor, I promote you from my military advisor to Minion General. You will win this minion war against the moth in time before my guests arrive, and you shall protect my hoard with your life.”

“I will try—”

“No, you will,” Vainqueur coached him. “Manling Victor, you found me when you tried to steal from my hoard, do you remember?”

“Every day of my life.”

“Then you must understand how much I trust you to entrust its safety to you,” Vainqueur continued, the manling’s eyes widening at the honor. “I do this because I trust you. You are my prized chief of staff, and this is my big day. You *cannot* fail.”

His lackey said nothing, then returned Vainqueur’s words with a sharp, thankful nod. “Alright, Your Majesty, I will. We all count on you to win this.”

“Of course,” he replied, as Jules cast a spell and briefly disabled the barrier, allowing them out. “Dragons always win.”

And with those wise words, Vainqueur flew out of the crater, invigorated by both his minions’ cheers and his own burning desire for payback. Manling Victor rode with kobones towards Murmurin, while Jules set the barrier up again before invaders could slip through.

Five wyvern riders attempted to intercept Vainqueur as he rushed towards the iron eagle, but he shot them down with fireballs without slowing down. The moth may have challenged him on the ground through trickery, but Vainqueur ruled the skies.

Flying at greater speed than he ever did before, which he attributed to his stat gains, Vainqueur reached the iron eagle, blasting through the air force protecting it. The strange musket-like weapons on the fortress’ back turned towards him.

“Vainqueur!” Brandon Maure, transformed into his demonic moth form and wielding his blade, flew out of the iron eagle alongside a flock of demons. “You have slighted Brandon Maure long enough! Today you die!”

“One of us will!” Vainqueur roared and engaged the flying fortress in battle.

Chapter 31: The Monsters of Murmurin

When Victor reached Murmurin, he found the village under siege. The Ishfanian scouts had reached it first.

Thankfully, all the training and drilling had borne fruit. Everyone in the V&V Adventurer Company was armed, and the citizens had set barricades south of the village, where the bulk of the army came from. Allison and Rolo had summoned a thick, dense barrier of thorns and blackberries around the village to delay the invaders, entangling soldiers with plants.

Rushing on the back of the Black Beast from the north, Victor rode to the town square, where the minions fought off dozens of invaders around Vainqueur's statue. Most of the enemies were armored elf soldiers with tridents or cursed bows while huge gargoyles served as their heavy hitters.

Thanks to the weapons crafted by Barnabas or bought from Malfy—both of whom participated in the battle—the gnolls, kobolds, and undead held their own against their opponents, swarming them at the numbers of three against one. The werewolves, fully transformed and led by Croissant, handled the stronger gargoyles.

Vainqueur Junior, too, had joined the melee, grabbing elves with his hands and swallowing them whole. Other mimics, shaped like chests, swords, and cakes, followed its lead, feasting on the elves like wolves among sheep.

The sight of everyone working together warmed Victor's heart a little.

The strangest of the attackers were ethereal, demon-shaped living shadows; they cast lightning spells at gnolls and kobolds, killing one with each strike.

Red and the Rangers attempted to shoot them with arrows and musket bullets, but they phased through them. Only Chocolatine, who kept her human form, and the priest of the Moon Man managed to hit them with light spells.

“Chief!” Red rejoiced at Victor’s arrival. “Our weapons can’t hit the shadows!”

But Chocolatine’s spells could. As incorporeal beings, they were probably only vulnerable to magic... or to specific abilities. Victor used his [Monster Insight] on the closest shadow monster.

Sombreux

Shadow Fiend (Demon)

Strong against: Unholy, Darkness, Frost, Physical, all status effects.

Weak against: Demonslayer, Holy, Light, Necromancy, Magical effects.

A veteran of three downsizings. Immune to physical attacks as a bodyless soul; doesn’t know you eat them for breakfast or would have fled. Hopes killing everyone in Murmurin will earn him a promotion to Financial Affairs.

“You must be the Infercorp representative,” the shadow fiend hissed at Victor. “Genocide Choc!”

“You’re half-right,” Victor replied. “No fiend from Hell can hit me, from what I heard.”

“But we aren’t from Hell,” the demon said with a smug, amused tone. “We’re from Happyland.”

Your [**Get out of Hell Card**] Perk has been canceled, because, duh, *demons*.

Son of a... Trusting his [Monster Insight], Victor charged at the shadow fiend, and cut it with his weapon. The shadowy monster laughed it off, only

to find itself dragged into the scythe by surprise.

Critical hit! [**Helheim**] and [**Steal Life**] activated!

Aha! His Helheim perk worked well against incorporeal beings!

Victor felt the life force of the creature move into him, reducing his fatigue, while the fiend's soul joined Furibon's in the scythe. "*A roommate,*" the lich said, with a tone that sounded both irritated, and strangely happy.

"Finally, some company to talk to."

By the end, he would have a *lot* of it. "I'm always here," Victor pointed out.

"Good company."

Victor, like a mounted grim reaper, struck down any soldier or fiend he could, receiving notifications of critical hits with half of his strikes. Months before, he doubted he could kill so many enemies so casually; hell, he would have probably fled while using the chaos of the battle. Surviving Vainqueur's antics had made him braver.

A fearsome monster looking like a fiend covered in bone spikes engaged Victor in combat, parrying his scythe with a shield and trying to drag him off his mount with a spine-whip. His Black Beast mount attempted to crush the attacker, but the agile fiend leaped backward. Victor prepared to target him with a necromancy spell, while his foe swung his whip threateningly.

Then the monster gargled blood, as a reptilian hand pierced his back and went through the chest. The corpse collapsed, revealing Savoureuse in full assassin mode, her claws sharp and bloodied. "Sav!" The sight rejoiced Victor. "You haven't run away?"

"I couldn't!" she replied, causing him to facepalm with his free hand. "Fairy beasts coming from the north cut my retreat!"

Fairy beasts? "Melodieuse," Victor cursed, as he cut down a gargoyle's head before it could drag him off his mount. If she came from the north, then the entire village was now surrounded.

Rolo and Allison joined the fray as well, with the iron golem hitting a gargoyle with a shovel. “[Sheepinize].”

With the word, the giant gargoyle turned into a black sheep, which Rolo kindly moved out of his way. “Farmers can do that?” Victor asked, astonished.

“At level fifty-one,” Rolo replied, raising his shovel threateningly at fiends. “You will all become Rolo’s sheep!”

“Sheeps, Rolo,” Allison replied, summoning giant flytraps to catch the gargoyles. “Here, it’s *sheeps*.”

Victor suddenly realized he didn’t want to learn where most of the sheep in Murmurin came from. Pink, who unlike the other rangers didn’t fire projectiles at the fiends, began to sing, “*Arise, children of the dragon, the day of glory has arrived!*”

[**Bardic Song**] has raised your Strength by one stage.

“Bardic Song?” Victor blinked, as he cut down an elf bowman before he could shoot him off his mount. “Pink, you took levels in [Bard]?!”

“Since I wrote *The War of the Hoard!*” Pink shouted back, before returning to her singing. “*To arms, minions! Form your battalions, let's march, let's march! Let cattle blood fertilize our crops!*”

Encouraged by Pink’s bloodthirsty anthem, Victor and the other minions backed the remaining scouts against a house’s walls and slaughtered them, with only the shadow demons managing to scamper off from the slaughter.

“Meat treasure!” Vainqueur Junior gargled, as he spat out the remains of a half-digested elf.

“What is the situation?” Victor asked Red, looking at their forces. Most of the minions had survived, but they had lost dozens to the initial strike, their corpses littering on the ground. Hundreds more minions and citizens gathered at the town square, waiting for instructions. His [Mook Promotion]

Perk told him many could be promoted, having gained experience from the battle.

“We pushed back the scouts, but a lot more will come!” Red said, his claws shaking as he held his musket close. “Thousands!”

“Too many!” Croissant said, Charlene by his side. She looked *very* bothered by her boyfriend’s wolfish appearance but stood with him wielding a spear. “We’ve got to evacuate!”

“They’ve already encircled us!” Savoureuse replied.

“And they have cavalry,” Allison, who herself couldn’t leave the village, pointed out with a cool head. “They will catch up to us if we try to flee.”

“Charlene,” Victor turned to the one human in the group. “Have you informed Gardemagne?” Since the King was due to visit them soon with his retinue, they could warn him in time to mobilize an army and stop Maure’s.

“I sent messenger pigeons, but archers shot most of them,” she replied, clearly fearing for her life. “I have no idea if any of them got through, and it will take them hours to send an army.”

They were on their own.

As everyone looked at him, Victor realized it fell on him to organize the defense. “We can’t win a prolonged battle against their overwhelming numbers,” he admitted. Especially since those were just the scouts, and the bulk of the army was running at them. “All we can do is delay until Vainqueur takes down the flying fortress and causes the army’s rout.”

“The Emperor has taken the field?” Blue raised his undead skull at the skies, ablaze with flames.

“To lead us to victory!” Victor raised his scythe, bringing hope back in the minions’ heart. “The Emperor is fighting for the great hoard as we speak! Which is his *gold*, but also *us*! If these paupers take the village, they will steal our lives, our sheep, and our coins! Will we run away, tails between

our legs? No! We will send them back to the nowhere from which they came! Remember how we won the *War of the Hoard*? We bested them once, and we will do it again! For we are *V&V*! We are mighty! We are the hoard!”

That was complete, desperate improvisation based on cartoon speeches he watched on Earth, but it worked. “We are the hoard!” the minions cheered, while the sanest citizens such as Allison or Charlene tentatively raising their hands in support. “We are the hoard!”

“They will meet their doooooooooom!” Yellow the Kobone couldn’t help himself.

“For my local monopoly!” Malfy added his own battle cry.

“Follow my command, and we shall prevail!” Victor shouted. “For the hoard!”

[**Rally Minion**] activated! All minions’ stats raised by one stage!

Victor immediately singled out the minions whom he could promote, namely ten gnolls and all the Kobold Rangers save for Red himself. “Come here,” he said, before touching and causing them to evolve in quick succession. “You are hereby given a pay raise!”

As they evolved, the gnolls grew from tiny to a three meters tall, monstrous, and emaciated gnoll humanoids, with a skull-like face and ashen skin. Their eyes turned red, simmering with bestial fury.

Pink and Black, the living half of the Kobold Rangers, turned into pink and black colored copies of Red, albeit with Pink having a more effeminate figure. Blue and Yellow changed into skeletal versions of their kindred, with a black, beating heart in their chests; Blue’s bones turned deep blue, and Yellow’s golden.

Your Gnolls evolved into Tomb Gnolls.

Kobold Pink Ranger and Kobold Black Ranger evolved into Raptor Rangers.

Kobone Blue Ranger and Kobone Yellow Ranger evolved into Kobloods.

“We are all grown, and color assorted!” Blue rejoiced.

Victor immediately began to distribute orders. “Allison, keep entangling the enemy. Rangers, set the thorns on fire once enough soldiers are trapped. Shoot anyone who breaks through with arrows and bullets. Malfy, cover the skies with insects, so they can’t shoot arrows at us. We must create such chaos, that they will not be able to avoid friendly fire. Pink, keep singing. You, the squid priest, and Chocolatine—”

“Yeeees?” The werewolf’s head perked up at her name being called, which made him shiver.

“You focus on buffing the werewolves and ashen gnolls with spells or healing the wounded unless confronted by shadow fiends, in which case you toast them.” She seemed to enjoy the wording a bit too much. “Rolo, Junior, Sav, we will fortify the north with the new troops. Everyone else hit and run; ambush, isolate, swarm, then retreat behind flames and thorns. Bleed them dry for every inch of ground.”

“What new troops, Vic?” Savoureuse asked, anxious.

“These ones: [Animate Dead],” Victor activated his Perk, raising the dead from both sides as zombies. Since he didn’t sacrifice any gold, he only created non-sentient monsters, but they would make for nice meat shields and supplement the heavy hitters.

As Malfy summoned an enormous swarm of hungry locusts and Allison began to grow thorn trenches, Victor turned to Red the Kobold. “You are in charge. Remember, ambush and retreat, like in Haudemer.”

“Yes, chief!” The rangers made a pose. “We will protect the hoard with our lives!”

Congratulations! For showing your valor leading an army of minions against overwhelming odds in the name of your dragon master, your [**Monster Squire**] Class has been promoted to [**Monster Knight (Red Dragon)**]!

Your [**Rally Minion**] and [**Mook Promotion**] Class Perks have been strengthened!

Huh? Nice...

Or so he thought until his whole body began to itch and burn. Within *seconds*, jet black wings almost identical to Vainqueur's own grew out of Victor's back and through his cloak, while a crimson, reptilian tail sprung out of his pants.

Victor remained immobile on his mount for several seconds, uncomfortable with both the new sensations and the stares he received from the other minions. Furibon laughed like a maniac from inside his scythe.

"Shut up!" the wielder complained. He could swing his new tail as if he had grown up with it, but...

Goddamnit, he was turning into a mini-Vainqueur! How gross!

No matter. He would worry about it later. He ordered his mount to dash north, followed by his undead thralls and the other minions.

...

As it turned out, riding a beast while having a tail was *incredibly* uncomfortable.

The makeshift group quickly reached the sheep pens north of the village, where five fairy hounds like those which they had fought in Ishfania had broken in, stepping on the food they gathered for the dragon guests. Melodieuse, riding the back of a horned, black pegasus, oversaw them from above, alongside three giant, monstrous crows and an escort of wyvern riders.

“My flock!” Rolo went berserk at the sight of his sheep trampled down, his rusted body heating up; moving faster than Victor’s own mount, the golem broke past the fence like an unstoppable juggernaut. Following him, the Reaper cut a fairy hound’s flesh as it attempted to lunge at him, both the beast and the squire’s own ride circling one another. Savoureuse hid among the panicked sheep, waiting for her chance for a sneak attack.

The fairy birds dived on them like birds of prey, one of them catching Savoureuse by surprise and trying to drag her up. Junior grabbed some of the sheep trying to flee the battle, then launched them at the crow as improvised projectiles, forcing the crow to release its captive. Then the mimic grabbed the sword working as its lure and used it to slice the neck of a fairy hound reaching for him. “Sword!” Junior snarled, showing surprising swordsmanship.

Above them, Melodieuse began to sing a spell. Victor, still struggling against butt pain, attempted to blast her by channeling a blast of Hellfire from his fingertips, but she immediately summoned a purple barrier around herself and her mount.

Her wyvern-rider bodyguards began to bombard them with a volley of arrows, with Victor incinerating the projectiles before they could hit him. Rolo just shrugged them off, busy manhandling a fairy hound and beating the hell out of it with his shovel. The arrows hit Junior, making it moan in pain, while Savoureuse dodged everything.

“[Death Candle],” Victor spellcast, summoning small will-o’ wisps from the remains of the sheep. He sent them to swarm the wyvern riders, halting the attack. Meanwhile, the undead he had created finally joined the fight, swarming a fairy hound like the horde of zombies they were. The beast collapsed under the weight of dozens of walking corpses.

Well, that was going way better than expected! Maybe they could handle—

“[Crimson Lightning].”

As Melodieuse uttered these words, a powerful red bolt of lightning hit Victor and his mount. The black beast of Murmurin was felled in one blow,

while its rider ejected from its back and crashed on the dirt, losing his grip over his scythe along the way.

You have taken massive damage! Critical health!

“Ohoh,” Furibon cackled inside his scythe, as Victor struggled to get up.
“Will your luck finally run out?”

Victor raised his head from the dust, finding a fairy hound opening its jaws in hunger, ready to devour him. A shadowy giant bird descended to feast on him as well.

No.

It was way, way bigger than the birds, or a wyvern rider.

The fairy hound barely had the time to look up at incoming death, before the giant flyer landed on it, its sheer strength scattering a cloud of dust and sheep in all directions.

When Victor regained his sight, he found himself staring into the yellow eyes of a green dragon almost as big as Vainqueur, albeit more crocodilian than lizard-like.

“You smell like a chief of staff, and you look dragon enough to be halfway civilized,” the green dragon said with a foppish, arrogant tone. The surprise sight of the ancient reptile caused the beasts and wyvern-riders to halt their assault. “Tell me, minion of Vainqueur, is this the welcome buffet? I was told there would a sweet poison sauce, which tastes good with cows and pigs, for the fashionably early.”

“Yes!” Victor replied, realizing the opportunity offered to him. He pointed a finger at the fairy beasts. “But the fomors are trying to spoil the food!”

“The fairies feel acting mischievous again? Haven’t they learned the food chain the first time we ate their cattle?” The dragon turned to the skies and roared. “Vainqueur brought us elves and tasty birds for snacks!”

“Dibs on the elves!” A red dragon smaller than Vainqueur roared back as it descended from above, picking a wyvern rider like a hawk attacking a dove. Melodieuse immediately cast a spell, strengthening her barrier, but her escort wasn’t so lucky.

Soon, an entire flock of dragons descended from the heavens, most going south to pick on Ishfania’s army, but four dived to prey on the wyverns and the fairy birds. The green dragon left Victor to feast on the fairy hounds and the sheep without discrimination, turning the battle into a one-sided feasting slaughter.

Melodieuse looked down on the disaster, leaving her escort to die while slipping closer to Victor with a hateful gaze. “The hellgate has fallen,” she said. “My plans for Gardemagne wasted. You ruined *everything*.”

“It was you all along,” Victor realized, as his hands reached for his scythe. “The Apple, the Scorchers, Maure’s invasion... you set it all up!”

“None of this would have happened without you,” Melodieuse glared back at him. “You taught Vainqueur the secrets of this cursed class system, and now our rightful quest to take back Outremonde will become harder than ever before.”

“Taught? You’re exaggerating there.”

“It does not matter. More of the lizards will follow his lead. But you will not live long enough to see it. [Darkest Fear].”

A dark aura swallowed Victor before he could retaliate, draining him of his life and vitality. An irrational fear of death seized him, as he looked at it from above.

HP and SP reduced to one! [**Terror**] ailment! [**Necrophobia**] ailment!

“Any last words?” Melodieuse asked Victor with fake politeness. He noticed Savoureuse make a dash to rescue him, but she was too far away to make a difference.

Victor used [Monster Insight], trying to decipher any weakness that woman may have.

???

Damn! “Can’t we... talk it out?”

Charisma check...

Failed!

“We just did, manling,” Melodieuse raised her hand. “[Death Spike].”

As sharp, pointy ice spears rose from below Victor, he realized that *maybe* he should have taken a better insurance plan.

Chapter 32: The Bitter Day of Brandon Maure

Like he did back in that flying elf farm, Brandon Maure showed Vainqueur his cursed red wing, while his flying troops swarmed the dragon. “[Faena Muleta].”

Intelligence Check successful!

Vainqueur answered the moth’s pitiful display with a stream of holy flames.

See? He was smart!

The demon king, while surprised by the failure of his previous tactic, successfully flew out of the way. His slower lackeys, the dragon incinerated. Their ashes fell in a gray rain.

The Iron Eagle approached while Vainqueur pursued the moth in the skies, the musket-like weapons on its back, firing harpoons at him. The dragon dodged them artfully, only for Brandon Maure to intercept him with his sword in the middle of his manoeuver, grazing his scales with the tip of his blade.

[Dragonslayer] effect bypassed your defense!

“Let see if you are strong without your enhancements!” Vainqueur prepared his secret weapon. “Lesser Demonbane!” His spell hit Brandon Maure in the face, much to the dragon’s delight.

Charisma check successful! Your exorcism weakened Brandon Maure!

“My charm is greater than yours, grasshopper!” Vainqueur boasted.

“But Maure remembers how you denied him the joy of single combat last time!” Maure snarled, his movements more sluggish and less confident than before. “MINION! Come defend your king! [Summon Torero Fiend]!”

A powerful devil nearly as big as Vainqueur himself, with simmering, burning ash for skin, popped up next to the demon king. The spicy monster’s dragonlike wings extended, and it flew at the dragon with its sharp claws extended. He shot a shadowy ball of energy at Vainqueur while moving to engage him in close combat.

“[Spell Purge!]” As Vainqueur activated his perk, the spell vanished upon reaching his marvelous scales. The monstrous devil reached him a second afterward, Vainqueur catching his fists with his hands.

While the creature was strong, the dragon was better and pushed him back, still holding the demon’s hands captive. He attempted to bite the tasty fiend’s face off, but it lowered its head before Vainqueur’s jaws could close in on him.

The moth, ever the cowardly elf, retreated. He landed on the Eagle’s back and activated a Perk of his own, pointing his blade at Vainqueur. “[Picador]!”

Skill check failed! Evasion drastically decreased!

While his speed didn’t diminish, Vainqueur felt his reaction time slow down, his attention reduced. It was as if he had gotten drunk on eating dwarves again.

Focusing on the moth’s minion first, Vainqueur breathed holy flames right in the face of the giant devil; the fiend let out a snarl of rage as he proved as weak to dragonfire as anything else. Vainqueur rotated on himself, throwing the demon towards the clouds below before chasing after the Iron Eagle.

“Harpoons!” Maure ordered to a fiend operating one of the bird’s muskets; the weapon instantly fired pointed, chained spears at the dragon. While he couldn’t evade the harpoon in time due to that cursed [Picador] Perk, Vainqueur did something better.

He caught the harpoon with both hands.

Then he pulled it towards him, tearing the musket off the Eagle's back and its fiendish operator with it.

Empowered by the knowledge granted by the Class System, Vainqueur swung the chain like a flail and threw it at the flying fortress. The musket's wreckage impacted on the metal bird, but Brandon Maure managed to dodge the attack.

"Coward!" Vainqueur accused the moth, targeting the eagle's back with fireballs. His flames blasted off metal plates and destroyed the demon-operated muskets, but failed to hit his true target, who raced towards the front part of the metal bird. "Stop running and fight!"

"Maure no longer plays!" the demon king replied, before barking orders to the metal bird. "Launch the Wind Spear! Blow him off!"

The iron bird launched three projectiles at Vainqueur, the explosive needles making circles in the skies as magical circles appeared on the dragon's scales.

Unable to dodge, Vainqueur destroyed one with his fiery breath, then a second; the explosions made the Iron Eagle flinch, and spread the smoke in all directions.

Before he could destroy the third one though, Maure's summoned devil rose back from above the clouds, then rammed Vainqueur from behind, grabbing his throat with his strong arms. "Get off me, you cattl—"

"[Mando Bull]!" Brandon Maure said, pointing his blade at Vainqueur from a safe distance.

Skill check failed! Strength and Agility reduced by one stage each!

The fiend on the dragon's back choked him, preventing Vainqueur from destroying the third wind spear as it approached. With a surge of skill, the

dragon moved to use the fiend on his back as a shield, the projectile hitting that frustrating minion first.

The massive explosion that resulted killed the fiend and made Vainqueur's entire body itch, one wing in even worse shape than the other. The sheer power of the detonation sent the dragon falling straight through the clouds, struggling to fly.

You have fallen below twenty percent HP! **Critical Health!**

[**Bravo Bull**] activated! You regained your lost strength!

Reenergized, Vainqueur managed to stabilize in the middle of a cloud, somewhat. One of his wings had gotten weaker than the other, he couldn't fly straight, and the moth's Perks still weakened him.

The dragon considered his options. Brute strength hadn't worked, but the dragon was more than fire breath and physical force.

He was *smart*.

Vainqueur deactivated Spell Purge, then used his blinkblink ring to become invisible while the cloud still shrouded him. Struggling against the itching and the pain, Vainqueur managed to catch up to the Iron Eagle, flying discreetly above its back. The moth glanced overboard, looking for Vainqueur's corpse.

"Is he dead?" Maure rejoiced, as he began to bark more orders. "Carpet the ground to be sure, and that ugly village with it!"

"SURPRISE ATTACK!" Vainqueur shouted as he blasted the moth with a fireball. The explosion destroyed a large part of the flying fortress' back and sent the Demon King to crash on the left wing of the bird. Half his body had been burnt to a crisp.

Your sneak attack was super effective!

Vainqueur landed on the wing while dispelling his invisibility, as Brandon Maure rose back up. "You... you... how dare you attack Maure while

invisible!”

“I am smart enough not to give you a chance to run around this time!” Vainqueur said, slightly insecure about his intelligence score and eager to showcase it. The tactic had worked on Furibon, and it proved its effectiveness again. “Not so strong when you cannot hide behind your minions, are you, moth?”

Cornered and unable to fly away with a burned wing, Brandon Maure swung his sword and prepared to stand his ground. “[Airblad-]”

But the dragon was faster, and didn’t give his foe any respite.

“[Lesser Demonbane]!” Vainqueur cast his spell, the exorcism weakening the fiend before it could finish enhancing himself.

The dragon then breathed his mighty dragonfire at Maure, and weakened by the previous attack, the moth couldn’t dodge. Vainqueur’s flames melted his flesh and the metal underneath both, causing an explosion below the wing.

The demon king stood out of the flames as an emaciated, burnt husk. “If it is any consolation,” Vainqueur taunted the furious elf. “You never stood a chance against me, grass-eater. You were doomed the moment you threatened my minions.”

A voice came out of the Iron Eagle, enhanced by a spell. “Your Highness, the dragon damaged the engine! We have to make an emergency landing!”

“Crash the Iron Eagle in the volcano’s crater!” Maure ordered, forced to use his sword to stand. “Destroy the dragon’s castle and his hoard with it!”

The voice coming from the iron bird sounded as horrified as Vainqueur himself. “My liege, with all the wind spears onboard, Mount Murmurin will erupt! The entire region will be wiped out!”

“Yes!” Brandon Maure replied. “Rochefronde, Vainqueur, Murmurin, annihilate them all!”

“But our troops—”

“I DON’T CARE!” the demon king snarled, dropping speaking in the third person for the first time. “I WANT ALL OF THEM DEAD!”

Warning! [**Berserk**] status applied.

“It is not over, Vainqueur!” the elf ranted, showing off his blade. “Brandon Maure still has resources, and friends in low places! He will come back—”

Furious, and now faster than ever, Vainqueur poked the moth mid-rant, squashing him like the bug he was.

His mighty hand made the metal bird shake as it hit.

When he raised his finger again, he could only see a bloody smear on the metal.

Congratulations! You regained your [**Emperor**] title with style! Your Perks have been restored!

The dragon let out a furious roar, and breathed a torrent of flames towards the skies, ready to rampage across the land in celebration.

Or he would have, had the Iron Eagle not been diving straight toward his volcano.

“My hoard!” Fear for the survival of his coins stripped him of his anger, his mind now fully focused on saving his gold.

Vainqueur flew under the Iron Eagle’s wing and pushed with both hands against its underside. Grabbing the flying fortress by its underside, the dragon used all his strength to push it up and redirect the bird away from his volcano. He struggled against his wounds from the Wind Spear, against the pain in his wing, against the heaviness of the metal bird.

Vainqueur was a dragon. The strongest! He could do it!

He thought of the coins in his hoard, waiting for his return, of the princesses he would expose, of all his minions cheering him up on the ground. They gave him strength.

Using all of his bottomless might, Vainqueur managed to force the fortress up, making it miss the crater by mere inches; then, he pushed it towards the badlands and arroyos away from the mountain.

The dragon, finally out of strength, finally let the bird go, struggling for breath.

The bird kept going and then crashed in a remote valley; the same one where Manling Victor stashed his hoard when Furibon sickened it.

The collision unleashed an incredibly powerful blast of wind which blew dust all over the region. A cloud of sand expanded in all directions.

“I won!” Vainqueur rejoiced, exhausted and his wounded wing starting to let him down. “I won!”

Then the cloud of dust reached him, covering him in dust and sending sand in his eyes. “Argh!” The dragon let out a snarl of frustration as he scratched his eyelids to remove it.

Flawless victory!

For defeating Brandon Maure and ending the threat of the Iron Eagle, you earned a **[Crest]**.

A light fell from the heavens in front of Vainqueur, a golden, shield-like item descending from the skies and floating right in front of him. It was one of the most beautiful devices he had ever seen, covered with colored gemstones; something worthy of his hoard.

Vainqueur let out single a tear at the scene; whether because of its beauty or the sand in his eyes, he didn’t know.

Use **[Crest]** to break the Class ceiling?

“Yes!” No sooner did the dragon speak, the item and the light surrounding it vanished at once.

Crest used! You can now progress up to level 60!

For using a [**Crest**], you gained the [**Crested**] Personal Perk.

[**Crested**]: You moved up from ordinary adventurer to folktale hero. You can now access more prestigious classes.

Sweet! All was well in the world.

Vainqueur, exhausted, struggled to fly back to Murmurin to burn the remaining minions of the moth. Instead, he found his early guests hunting down the fleeing elves and fiends in a good old safari hunt.

The dragon was briefly worried his big day was ruined, but his kindred looked very happy with the free food. Vainqueur let out a sigh of relief, his pride safe.

Such an easy battle. Nothing like the War of the Hoard; and his Bragging Day was safe. Truly this couldn't get better.

“Minion, where are you? I have been crested!”

But no one answered.

“MINION!”

His lackey didn't teleport to his side.

“Minion?” Vainqueur repeated, now worryingly, but yet no one answered.
“Minion?”

The seed of doubt worming itself in his mind, Vainqueur searched for his prized lackey. He watched his minions, led by the Kobold Rangers, fight off stragglers while Sweet Chocolatine captured imps in fishnets. The minions cheered Vainqueur as he flew over them, as they should. He didn't land to ask them, for, with his damaged wing, he knew he couldn't fly again after landing.

The dragon went north, towards the sheeps' pens, finding his dragon guests feasting on his pantry. Corpseling Jules and Rolo the golem tended to his chief of staff, laying in the dirt and surrounded by other crying minions,

from Malfy the fiend to that reptilian Savoureuse. Vainqueur graciously landed nearby, covering the minions with dust.

“Ah... ah... ah minion, here you are,” Vainqueur said while catching his breath. He immediately noticed that his lackey had grown wings and a tail, just like his master! What a faithful chief of staff. Vainqueur didn’t have the heart to chastise him for failing to win the minion war before his guests arrived.

“Your Majesty?” Jules the Necromancer looked up at him, and at his weak wing. “Is Brandon Maure—”

“The moth is dead!” Vainqueur boasted. “I smashed him, his bird, and his pride! I received a crest from it, just as you said, Manling Victor!”

His chief of staff didn’t answer. Malfy the fiend exchanged a glance with the other minions, with Victor’s pet mimic letting out a sad moan, then spoke up, “Your Majesty, I am afraid Lord Victor cannot answer.”

“Of course he can, I trained him to,” Vainqueur replied, looking down to wake his minion from his nap. “Manling Victor now is not the time to sleep! My guests have arrived...”

Then Vainqueur noticed the ice spike through his lackey’s chest and his empty white eyes.

Manling Victor was...

...

He was *dead*?

The dragon saw red. “Who *dared* do this?!” Vainqueur roared, his mere voice making the minions tremble in fear.

“The killer, that fairy, teleported away after I tried eating her.” A green dragon resting on his back, his belly full, let out a belch. “Vainqueur, your sheeps taste delicious, so soft...”

Vainqueur would have thanked him if he wasn't *livid*.

"Minion, I ordered you to become immortal!" Vainqueur chastised his dead lackey, before turning to that pile of scrap of a golem. "You, tinman, you are my minion now. Fetch me Chocolatine, a healer, even that dryad if needed!"

"Nobody can cure death, Yer Majesty," Rolo the Golem replied.

"You can!" Vainqueur said, turning to Corpseling Jules. "Raise him like the kobolds!"

"I would like to, but we cannot reanimate him, Your Majesty," Jules replied. "His killer applied the [Necrophobia] status to Victor before murdering him. He cannot be reanimated, not even as an undead until it is dispelled."

"I cannot even claim his soul and incarnate him as a fiend," Malfy said.

"Then get away, bugling," Vainqueur said, as he put his hand on Manling Victor's remains and activated his favorite Perk. "[Spell Purge]!"

Charisma check failed!

You could not dispel the [Necrophobia] status.

Charisma check failed? How could it be? Vainqueur was the most charismatic dragon in the world, the destroyer of Furibon! How could he fail a check?!

Yet... yet he had only weakened the crystal curse that fairy placed on his princesses. Not dispelled, weakened. Her sorcery was beyond even the evil Furibon's. Vainqueur glanced around at the thought, thankfully finding the scythe near Manling Victor. That witch didn't have time to break the seal keeping that evil contained.

The reality of the situation slowly dawned on Vainqueur.

Manling Victor, his most prized, loyal chief of staff, class advisor, Vizier, and Doer of the Thing, was gone.

The dragon remained still, trying to process what to do next, while his minions tried to cheer him up. “Your Majesty—”

“I refuse to accept this!” Vainqueur cut him off brashly. “Find a way to raise him!”

“Why the rush, Vainqueur?” his dragon guest asked, more surprised than anything. “It’s just a manling. A dragon-shaped, well-trained manling, but a manling all the same.”

“Manling Victor is worth more than any minion,” Vainqueur replied. He could find any new minion, but he could never find a second Manling Victor. “He is the crown jewel of my hoard. My Bragging Day cannot be complete without him.”

“Your Majesty,” Jules began. “There is a... a last option to raise him, but... you will need to make a great sacrifice.”

“Anything to save my favorite minion,” Vainqueur said, glancing down at the corpse with genuine sadness. “Anything for my manling.”

Chapter 33: BFF

“I’m sorry, but you can’t get into Heaven right now.”

Sitting on a chair in the middle of an endless, white expanse, Victor glared at Miel. The angel winced behind her ivory desk, the enormous pile of paper representing his case sitting on it. “But you said I would get in Heaven if I died in the line of duty against the forces of Hell!”

“That would be if you had taken the Heaven+ Plan, instead of the Standard Karma Insurance.”

“I didn’t know I would die in *weeks!*”

Also, death hurt like Hell.

At least Brandon Maure died, from what Miel told him. Vainqueur’s guests, proving almost as dangerous as him, had eaten their way to victory both on Outremonde and Hell.

“Unfortunately, you *also* died protecting a village of monsters where demons buy souls openly and most citizens have an evil or chaotic karma,” the angel replied, embarrassed. “I will do everything I can so we accept you into Heaven on merit since you were instrumental in the bankruptcy of Maure Hellcorporated, but you may have to wait months in limbo. The fact you died a virgin on Earth might help convince my superiors of your hidden saintliness.”

Could it? Because he did his best on Outremonde to catch up on that front.

Months sitting in a chair? Victor *loathed* bureaucracy. “What about the lower place?”

Miel made a frustrated face, but searched in the papers and gave them to him. “As my client, I will tell you the other offer, but I strongly advise against it,” she said, Victor reading the document. “Infercorp made a request that you be reincarnated as a demon mortal consultant... however, since they lack the power to dispel the [Necrophobia] status your murderer put you under, they cannot reincarnate you into a new shape. Your soul will end in Hell as it is now: helpless.”

“Like those Isabelle Maure tortured last time I visited?”

“I do not recommend it.”

Curse that fairy. Victor understood why Vainqueur couldn't stand the fomors. “Have I no other option?”

“Two deities have a claim to your soul, namely Dice and the Moon Man.” The angel hesitated to speak again. “We also received a surprise third afterlife proposal from Camilla, the goddess of death, for, I quote, *‘exemplary service to the undeathstrial revolution and continued friendliness towards the church’*.”

At this point, Victor might as well entertain the various offers. He hated Dice for abducting him to Outremonde, but Camilla was a goddess with a dangerous reputation. He would rather try the chaotic deities first. “Okay, what do the first two offer?”

“I will send a request for a meeting.” Miel wrote on a parchment with a feather, the paper vanishing at once. “Thankfully, the Moon Man should be in one of his ‘good’ phases. No rampage.”

No sooner did she say that, that an entity materialized next to them with a rumbling noise. Victor had to look up to see the full, titanic creature.

The other creature was an enormous version of Thul-Gathar, a monstrous moon beast over sixty feet-tall; a titan far bigger than even Vainqueur. It wore old, tattered yellow robes over its body, leaving only the tentacled, squid-like head and hands exposed. It also used a sorcerous, pine-sized cane to walk.

“Is this an appointment? Did I forget it?” Much to Victor’s surprise, the Moon Man sounded more like his elderly grandfather than an abomination from outer space. More worryingly, it spoke in the human’s head through telepathy, rather than through words.

“Hello, Mr. Moon Man,” Miel said with a cheeky smile. “I am Miel, a junior angel insurance counselor. My client here, Victor Dalton, is the prophet of your Murmurin cult; your spawn Thul-Gathar claimed him on your behalf.”

“I have a prophet?” The Moon Man sounded confused. “I have a *religion*?”

When Thul-Gathar complained about his patron deity being absent-minded, he wasn’t kidding. “Don’t you hear the prayers of your followers?” Victor asked.

“I hear voices often, but prayers?” The ancient abomination shook its head. “Cats and dogs rule your Earth. You think they are enemies, but they have a secret pact. The pets in presidents’ houses? They *are* the presidents. Kennedy’s dog Charlie ordered him assassinated when he threatened to reveal the truth.”

Victor blinked. “Excuse me?”

“Mmm?” The giant squid replied. “Yes?”

“What did you say about dogs and cats?”

“That you should eat them after cuddling?” The deity touched its tentacles with its hand as if it were a beard. “I am getting old, so my memory is not all there.”

“He is the god of madness,” Miel whispered to Victor. “*He*’s not all there.”

“Sometimes I feel like I am becoming a star, with a burning core and ionized breath,” the Moon Man continued. “Can you feel my gravity?”

The more he heard, the more Victor doubted that god could even provide him an afterlife at all.

Something fell on Miel's desk with a weak sound, causing Victor to look at it.

He found himself facing a twenty-faced dice, surging with magical power. Each of its faces had living, multi-colored eyes located inside or next to the numbers. All of them watched back at Victor with expectation.

"Roll me," the dice asked with a kid's voice.

...

"Roll me!" the god Dice insisted like a child. "For your afterlife! Roll me!"

Victor stared blankly at the dice, while the Moon Man looked at it with curiosity. Miel winced, embarrassed by the scene.

That... that *thing* was a god?

The one who brought him to Outremonde at that!

Eventually, with nothing better to do, Victor grabbed Dice and rolled it. The dice eventually landed on its 'tenth' face. "Ten!" said the god of magic.

"Average afterlife! Reincarnated as a part-timer in Japan!"

"That doesn't make any sense!" Victor complained.

"I am a god!" the dice boasted back. "I don't have to make sense!"

"Chaotic deities," Miel said with a forced laugh, clearly uncomfortable with the situation.

Victor knew he should have worshipped Allison's pleasure goddess, Cybele.

Reincarnation in Japan tempted him; even if it sounded somewhat terrible, he could probably find his way back to the United States and his family in time. Would they recognize him though? For all he knew, he could be reincarnated as an entirely new person.

Another look at Dice trying to roll by itself on the desk made him change his mind. He wanted to rant at that creature for bringing him to Outremonde, but he couldn't muster the energy at the sight of its stupidity.

"I think I will wait for Heav—"

A new figure popped up with a golden glow next to him before he could finish his sentence.

The newcomer had the upper body of a golden-scaled, graceful winged woman, and the lower half of a green serpent. Snakes made up her hair, and she carried a bag full of paper scrolls on her back. Her slithering eyes sized up Victor like a ruthless merchant examining a product.

The human instantly recognized the goddess.

"Oh, Miss Shesha!" The angel sounded giddy at the goddess' sight. "What a surprise!"

"Miel, good to see you again." The goddess of commerce immediately turned to Victor, clearly all-business and much saner than her competition. "Victor Dalton, this is your lucky day."

"You're betting on my soul too?" Damn, Victor had become more popular in death than he ever was in life. At least she looked like an actual, dignified deity.

"Better. Mortals paid me a generous 'church donation' for your revival on Outremonde."

The human blinked. Didn't she charge a huge amount of money for that service? Who could have paid for it? Victor briefly thought of Vainqueur, before realizing that the dragon would never part ways with any coin. No, the villagers of Murmurin had probably pooled their funds to revive him.

"Wait, what about the [Necrophobia] status?" Victor asked.

"I am a goddess. While the caster's level approaches the divine, overcoming it is trivial." The goddess gave him a cunning smirk. "Now, my

services are expensive. Since I have a result obligation, I will not cash my reward in if you refuse to return. Between us, if you do accept, I will grant you a free Perk.”

“Are you bribing me in front of witnesses?”

“No, no, I am sweetening a deal. It has been a while since someone could afford a resurrection.”

Victor was sure he had been there before.

“As the goddess of commerce, I am very interested in what you and your dragon associate are doing on Outremonde. While I am... conflicted... about your undead and demonic ventures, a tax-free commercial zone appeals to me. Hopefully, we will discuss investment terms after your return to the living.”

Classic merchant, wording the request by implying he already accepted.

Victor hesitated. The other options weren't all that good, but returning to Outremonde meant continuing his life as a minion, with all that it entailed.

But...

Victor thought back about what Savoureuse told him, before the fight with Furibon. That he had the opportunity to make a good life in that new world instead of trying to chase after the past.

Victor would never admit it out loud, but he had grown attached to Outremonde, and the people he met there. Even that crazy dragon.

Especially that dragon.

“Will I still get into Heaven if I return?” he asked Miel.

“You will have to take a new insurance plan,” Miel flashed a smile at him, which he didn't find innocent at all. “A better one this time.”

That settled it.

“Excellent choice,” Shesha said, happy with the transaction. She touched his left arm with her cold fingers, a tattoo representing a coin with a snake symbol on it materializing on his skin.

Congratulations! You earned the [**Claimed by Shesha**] Personal Perk.

[**Claimed by Shesha**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Charisma or Intelligence point. Merchants, bankers, and entrepreneurs always see you as a trustworthy partner and will give you a 20 percent discount.

“As dragons dance, so do Earth and Outremonde,” the Moon Man said. “The golden path is paved with fairy blood.”

“What?” Victor asked.

“I said, return home, and do your prophet work,” the Moon Man replied, as confused as Victor himself. “I think...”

Shesha snapped her fingers, a luxurious private jet materializing out of the nothingness right next to the Moon Man. “I am the goddess of commerce,” Shesha told an astonished Victor. “Trains are out of fashion, and I have *taste*.”

The door of the private afterlife jet opened, and Victor walked inside. Miel waved at him. “Come back soon!” the angel said.

Yeah, right.

While death had been painful, resurrection felt like waking up from a happy sleep.

No sooner did Victor open his eyes, that he found Chocolatine’s visage approaching to kiss him up close.

“Argh!” Victor jumped in surprise, the startled priestess backing away. It was a trap!

“You see, Chocolatine, I told you he wouldn’t need CPR,” said Allison. Victor realizing most of the minions and Murmurin’s important inhabitants, from Charlene to Croissant, had gathered around him in a circle. Malfy carried his scythe. “Welcome back, buddy.”

“Chief!” Pink Ranger cried at the scene. “You are alive!”

As his eyes acclimated to the light, Victor realized he had been revived deep inside the vault. The gate to Hell was closed, with Vainqueur’s guests sitting in front of it, bellies full, shocked, and silent.

“You pooled your money to fund my revival?” Victor guessed.

“We all did—” Croissant began.

“No, *we* did, even Savoureuse,” Allison replied, glaring at the werewolf. “Vainqueur forced *you* to.”

“But it was nowhere near enough to satisfy the goddess’ greed, Victor,” Jules Rapace admitted. “She demanded a price too high.”

Then who paid for the difference?

“How could a dragon...” Icefang said, his gaze empty and distant. “Why would *any* dragon?”

Victor slowly rose up and glanced around.

Most of Vainqueur’s hoard had gone missing, with a large, empty hole in the middle. Only a few thousand gold pieces, random magic items, and the crystallized princesses remained. Vainqueur himself was whining in a corner, more saddened than Victor had ever seen him.

...

Holy hell.

“My hoard,” Vainqueur whined his hands on his eyes. “My sweet hoard...”

Victor struggled to find his words, staring blankly at the hole, then back at his dragon master.

“I think we should leave you two alone,” Allison said, glancing at the others. Malfy handed Victor the scythe, and the chief of staff absentmindedly took it, his mind working on autopilot. Even the dragons followed their example, leaving the old duo alone in the emptied vault.

“Why?” Victor finally asked, Vainqueur looking at his chief of staff with *destroyed* eyes. He only had that word on his mind. “Why? This is your Bragging Day!”

“You are the crown jewel of my hoard...” Vainqueur regained some of his composure, forcing himself to adopt a proud dragon face in spite of being clearly shaken. “If it hadn’t been for you, I would never have gathered it in the first place. You were worth more. With you gone, what was there to brag about?”

That very instant, Victor realized he would never leave Vainqueur, no matter what.

He no longer wanted to.

“You know...” Victor trailed off. “You have become a lot more than a ‘master,’ Your Majesty. You have become a friend.”

“What is a friend, some kind of minion?”

“That means I will stick to you no matter what, even if I’m released from service.”

“You better, Minion Victor, because I forbid you from sleeping until you have reimbursed your debt to me, which is...” Vainqueur took a long breath. “*Twelve million, five hundred forty-five thousand, one hundred thirty-three* gold coins! Which is added to the life debt you owe me for raising you as my prized chief of staff!”

Twelve million in debt? Damn, it was his student loan all over again. “Okay,” Victor replied, strangely at peace with it. “I will find a way, Your Majesty.”

“Then you will work until we both become gods, and order this greedy goddess to reimburse me in full for this vastly overpriced service!”

“Sure,” Victor replied, as Vainqueur kept ranting and venting off, the dragon regaining his previous proud demeanor. He could settle on becoming god of minions everywhere.

It paid well, and from what he had gathered, he wouldn’t be worse off than the others.

After he finished cursing Shesha, the gods, and merchants in general, Vainqueur calmed himself. “Minion Victor.”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“As you wish, I promote you to my first and only ‘friend’,” Vainqueur declared, in his own, greedy way. “You better prove yourself worthy of that honor.”

“I hope so,” Victor replied, before correcting himself. “I will.”

“I want to puke,” Furibon finally spoke up from inside his scythe.
“Watching you gave me diabetes.”

Chapter 34: Bragging Day

It was a starry night, and Vainqueur would soon make his bragging speech.

His gluttonous guests had gathered in Murmurin's town square for the main feast, after yesterday's elf appetizers. Dragons rested and talked, either on the ground or on nests made of the minions' houses, as Vainqueur's lackeys supplied them with a near-limitless supply of sheep, cattle, and cooked fiends.

Without a hoard to show—the thought alone broke Vainqueur's heart, although he was too dignified to cry—the Emperor of Murmurin had ordered half his minions to serve the meals to distract the dragons, and the other half to recover *anything* that could pass for treasure.

Thankfully, the moth's army had left gifts behind after dying or retreating, including inside the wreckage of their metal bird. Shiny weapons, glittering armor, and the cattle money the moth's minions had been paid with...

There was a startling lack of swords, though. Vainqueur had expected the mimic retriever to bring at least one of them.

His remaining minions, those who had survived the battle, had done their best, gathering a large pile of treasure right next to his statue. It was a good hoard, but nothing like the perfect, golden marvel he sacrificed to that greedy goddess. He could brag about it, but it wouldn't cement his status as the greatest dragon of all.

Thankfully, he had kept the crystallized princesses on top. They somewhat made up for the rest, and Icefang was livid at his twin princess record being upstaged.

“That was all we could find, Your Majesty,” his flying Grand Vizier said, throwing his scythe and every magical item on top of the hoard as a token of fealty. The other minions had done the same, returning all their magical items to the great hoard, as the cycle of life demanded.

“Where are the items I lent to you?” Vainqueur asked, finding a few of them missing.

“I, uh.” Victor scratched the back of his head. “To be honest, I kinda lost them.”

Vainqueur immediately guessed what happened. “That fairy thief!” the dragon enraged. “Not only did she rob you of your life, but she also looted your corpse afterward!”

“No, no, I—”

“Only I am allowed to profit from my minions’ remains!” Vainqueur ranted. “By robbing you, she robbed me! I vow it on your head, Manling Victor, one day I shall cook that fairy and eat her for dinner!”

“Why are you vowing on my head?” Manling Victor complained. “I already lost it once.”

“Exactly, since you will never lose it ever again,” Vainqueur gave his favorite minion a knowing look. “This guarantees my prophecy shall come to pass.”

“This is your Bragging Day. I am not contesting your logic.”

“Yes, that is why it is called *logic*,” Vainqueur replied.

“Also, King Roland, Kia, and Gardemagne’s royal retinue have arrived to recover Princess Merveille,” Manling Victor explained. “They kinda panicked when they noticed the dragons feasting and the dead demons littering the road, but then they calmed down after Charlene told them you killed Maure. The king wasn’t even surprised, from what she told me.”

Clearly, that manling King was an intelligent fellow. “I shall deign to treat them as my guests, in time for my bragging speech,” Vainqueur said, magnanimous, as his kobold minions brought him a cart of cooked beef with creamy poison sauce.

A group of thirty manling knights on horses made their way to him, led by Manling Charlene. It reminded Vainqueur of that time he ate the duchess of Euskal, except these manlings seemed civilized enough not to attack.

“His Majesty, King Roland Gardemagne,” one of the knights exclaimed, a tall, meaty old bearded manling riding on a white horse at the forefront. This manling went shirtless, with a long ermine cloak whom Vainqueur had to admit would look good on his hoard; he wore a diamond crown on his head and a two-handed golden axe on his back. Knight Kia rode her griffon on his right, and some kind of black elf flew by his own magic on his left.

Knight Kia glanced the piled up weapons, the destroyed houses, and the smoking remains of the Iron Eagle with a dejected look. “I missed the big battle,” she said, sounding incredibly disappointed. “I *missed* the *big battle*.”

“Yeah, it really would have helped if you had shown up,” said Manling Victor, as he landed clumsily on the ground. Since his pet’s destruction, he had been forced to learn to fly to get around and hadn’t quite mastered this great dragon skill.

“Vic?” Kia recognized his chief of staff. “What the hell happened to you? Is that a tail coming out of your pants?”

“Puberty,” Manling Victor replied, the dark elf letting out a laugh and Knight Kia having a chuckle. “Also, it’s ‘what the Happyland’ now.”

“It has lost its zing,” the dark elf replied.

“My Grand Vizier has been Vainqueurized,” Vainqueur said, sighing as gazes turned to him. Did he have to teach them everything? “It is a verb which means to become awesome. I Vainqueurized that village, we

Vainqueurized the world, it was Vainqueurizing, this meal was Vainqueurlicious... it goes with everything, as my name should.”

“Is Vainqueurspeech going to be our national language?” Manling Victor asked with his usual strange tone. By now, his master had grown used to it.

“I am considering it, but the road toward civilizing your kind is long and paved with ordeals,” Vainqueur replied.

The manling King, who had been carefully observing the scene, finally spoke up. “Emperor Vainqueur,” he said, the way he sized Vainqueur up reminding the dragon of a lion sizing up a rival. “I have been hearing about you for a while, and you do not disappoint. You are exactly as I imagined you.”

“Yes, the most powerful of emperors stand before you,” Vainqueur asserted his title, in case the Class System once again bothered him. “The Emperor of Murmurin, and the Albain Mountains.”

“And Ishfania, from what I understand,” Manling King Roland replied. “You have done a great service to Gardemagne in felling the Demon King before he could bomb our cities. This act of friendship shall not go unrewarded.”

“Fifteen million,” Vainqueur replied, the manlings frowning in confusion. “The bounty you put on my head does not represent my net worth, which I find insulting. Thus I ask that you increase it to reflect it.”

“That isn’t the number Your Majesty gave me yesterday,” his Grand Vizier pointed out.

“Shush, Manling Victor,” Vainqueur hushed his chief of staff.

“Were you not informed?” Manling Roland asked. “I froze your bounty a month ago. I asked that no adventurer of Gardemagne go after your head.”

“Aw, but that was free experience and treasures!” Vainqueur complained.

“Your Majesty, we left the previous hideout because they kept bothering us,” Manling Victor reminded him. “Also, I’m pretty sure we’ve made many enemies who will love to go after our heads.”

Manling King Roland cleared out his throat. “Bounties are for enemies, and I would like to come as a friend.”

“Only Manling Victor earned that title,” Vainqueur chastised the upstart, the statement taking back the various manlings.

“Then, as a good neighbor,” King Roland replied. “I have no quarrel with you, so long as you return my niece to me.”

“I, Vainqueur, unlike you robbers, do not tax or infringe on my minions’ private property,” Vainqueur replied smugly. “I shall release your princess back into the wild after tonight. But you better grant me my promised boon.”

“Of course,” King Roland replied, proving himself a civilized fellow, unlike that tasteless duchess. “What do you want? Lands, honors, knighthood—”

“NO TAXES!”

Vainqueur’s roar made some of the guests raise their eyes from their meals to look at him. “No taxes?” King Roland frowned.

“I will not pay a dime of the treasure I burned fat to earn!” Vainqueur declared. “I want all my quests to be robbery-exempted! No guild fee, no tax, no nothing! Ever!”

“Deal,” the king immediately agreed, as if expecting the dragon to change his mind if he didn’t seize the opportunity. “V&V will be forever exempt from all fees usually applied to adventurer companies.”

“But, but...” Manling Charlene made a face. “How will I sustain the local chapter?”

“The Kingdom will fund it,” King Roland replied dismissively. “It is paramount that we keep good relationships with the new Ishfanian

government.”

“The new government?” Manling Victor picked up.

“With its army destroyed and Maure dead, Ishfania is gone as a nation. While a demon-infested desert, it possesses resources. Enough of them that nations like the Eversun Empire, Barin, or even Prydain may try to claim it. I would rather avoid a new Century War and fill the vacuum as soon as possible.”

“But *I* squashed that moth!” Vainqueur protested. “*I* saved the great hoard from him!”

“Exactly and thus I propose a treaty,” the King said. “Gardemagne will recognize your claim as Emperor of Ishfania, making it an official adventurer state; you will still enjoy all the benefits of the Adventurer Guild and rule your territory as you wish. In exchange, I ask for a solemn vow that our countries never to take arms against the other and fight united against outside threats. A mutual protection pact.”

“Oh, and I will never lose access to my Emperor class!” Vainqueur realized. “Brilliant! I accept this tribute!”

The manling king nodded with dignity, then turning to his archmage. “Nostredame, a map of the continent, and a pen.”

The dark elf conjured the tools with a snap of his fingers, the manling king tracing a line across it. “This is the Albain Mountains. They shall serve as the frontier between your dominion, and Gardemagne.”

“But the mountains are mine,” Vainqueur insisted. “Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains.”

The king looked up at the dragon, then at the ruins of the Iron Eagle, then back at Vainqueur. “So long as we keep ownership of the powerstone mines we opened already.”

“I, Vainqueur, am too wealthy to lower myself to claiming your hoards for myself,” the dragon tried to sound generous.

“Then I assent to your request,” the King replied, circling a large swath of land on the map. “All of this is yours.”

“Vainqueur Knightsbane,” the dragon began to voice his new title out loud and rejoiced. “First of His Name, Great Calamity of the Age, Defender of the Hoard, *and* Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains.”

“Your Majesty,” Knight Kia began.

“Yes?” both Vainqueur and King Roland said at once, the dragon being disappointed when the knight turned to her fellow Manling.

“I immediately ask to be transferred as the ambassador to the Empire of Murmurin.”

“What?” For the first time, the Manling King seemed shocked. “Lady Kia, what is the meaning of this?”

“Kia, what the hell?” the dark elf echoed the king’s sentiment, as the various knights present exchanged whispers.

“There are still remnants of Maure’s army out there,” Kia replied. “And Melodieuse escaped justice.”

“But Kia...”

“I *missed* the *big battle*!” Knight Kia cut her ally off. “No more!”

The King examined her, before nodding. “Very well,” he replied. “You are the hero of the Golden Fields. If you believe you can defend Gardemagne from abroad, I shall not stop you.”

“Thank you my liege,” the knight nodded, before turning to Vainqueur. “That is if the Emperor accepts me.”

“I must consult my chief of staff.” Vainqueur narrowed his head towards his favorite lackey, speaking to him very, very lowly, “Manling Victor?”

“Yes?” his manling whispered.

“Have you bred yet?”

His manling’s face told him that, no, he hadn’t. The dragon realized his hopeless lackey would *never* reproduce without help, and so took the matter into his own claws.

“I agree, Knight Kia,” Vainqueur said out loud. “Since my Empire’s capital village is under renovations, you shall be granted a room in Manling Victor’s quarters. Our chiefs of staff will thus practice close minion diplomacy, Manling Roland.”

“Yes!” Knight Kia pumped her fist. “Thanks, I won’t let you down.”

“I assume we are done,” King Roland said, turning to his elf wizard. “Can you free my niece from that prison?”

“The caster’s level surpasses mine, but with my artifacts and my optimized Perks, this will be trivial, Your Majesty.”

“You shall release my princesses after the celebration,” Vainqueur said, before extending a hand towards the buffet. “Now, eat! My minions shall see that you have your share of sheep!”

“With pleasure, Emperor Vainqueur,” Manling King Roland said, as he and his retinue unhorsed, kobolds leading them to their future meals.

Wait.

If Vainqueur had waited for that cattle wizard to dispel Manling Victor’s [Necrophobia] status, then Corpseling Jules or tasty Malfy could have revived him for a cheaper price.

By arriving late, that uneducated King cost him money!

For the sake of his audience, Vainqueur managed to keep a straight face but raged inwardly.

“Did you just set me up with Kia?” Manling Victor asked Vainqueur once the guests out of earshot, unaware of the great injury done to his master.

“Minion husbandry is a long-honored dragon tradition,” Vainqueur replied, hoping Manling Victor’s offspring would inherit his wings and tail. “If only he had come early, I might have called your robber king halfway civilized.”

“He kinda short-changed us,” Manling Victor said, ever the pessimist. “He dumped the responsibility of cleaning up a demon-infested country on you, secured a dragon ally, and kept all the benefits of the Albain Mountains without having to spare troops to defend them from Maure anymore. Also, I’m sure Charlene will keep an eye on us on his behalf, if she wasn’t before.”

“But no more taxes,” Vainqueur pointed out the truly important matter.

“But no more taxes,” Manling Victor replied with a sigh.

Anyway, it was time.

Vainqueur glanced at his guests and minions, and upon seeing all of them present, let out a mighty roar. All eyes turned to him, and the great dragon cleared his throat. Manling Victor, ever faithful, supported his master with a nod.

“Brothers and sisters, manlings and minions,” Vainqueur began. “It is with great pride that I gathered you, so that you may marvel at the tasty bounties of my domain, my immeasurable wealth, and my three, yes, *three* princesses.”

“The princesses aren’t dancing,” Icefang immediately replied. “Six out of ten!”

“I say eight,” Genialissime countered. “Because Vainqueur has two spares, which is bragworthy.”

“Three princesses in one place magnify their princessness,” the black wyrm, Blightswamp, agreed with a scientific tone. “Also, the fact Vainqueur caught three from different species proves my theory that princessness is a contagious condition.”

“But they aren’t triplets!” Icefang nitpicked. “And the food is the only thing to brag about! Look at his paltry hoard!”

Vainqueur ignored his rival, although he noticed the dragons weren’t very impressed by his treasure.

Here goes nothing.

“Certainly, you must have heard rumors that I gathered a greater, golden hoard,” Vainqueur continued, waving a hand at Manling Victor. “And that I sacrificed it all to revive my greatest treasure, my prized, dragonized chief of staff.”

The dragons whispered between them, as Victor knelt in gratefulness. “Vainqueur best dragon!” the minions cheered. “Vainqueur best dragon!”

Although pleased, Vainqueur silenced them with a look. He waited for his audience to calm down, then spoke up again.

“The rumors are true.”

When in doubt, be awesome.

“Yes, you heard that right! I, Vainqueur, have grown a hoard so big, that I can afford to *spend* it!”

His radical declaration drew gasps from the audience, as he proceeded to turn this disaster into a triumph.

“That’s how rich I am!” Vainqueur kept boasting. “I am so wealthy, that I could spend *twelve million gold coins* on reviving *one* minion!”

“Heresy!” Icefang screamed, the other guests speechless at his brazen words. “A dragon does not spend his hoard!”

“That is a poor dragon’s response!” Vainqueur retorted, his rival fuming at the insult. “A truly wealthy dragon should be so rich, that twelve million coins are no more precious than one!”

“Then where is the rest?” One of the dragon guests asked.

“Look around you!” Vainqueur extended a hand towards his marvelous lands. “This is my hoard! I, Vainqueur, have founded an empire on the enlightened dragon principles! A country where no minions ever leave my service, even in death, where demons can trade souls without paying taxes to manlings! An empire where greed is law!”

“You use mass undead labor?” Knight Kia blinked, before noticing Malfy and turning red. “You trade souls with *demons*?!”

“It’s... not as bad as you think...” Manling Victor winced, while Knight Kia’s jaw clenched.

Vainqueur ignored them, showcasing the audience the iron plate around his neck. “I have become an adventurer! The weak and fragile manlings, afraid of trolls and fairies, have paid me tributes of gold, and given me their hoards to defend!”

“Vainqueur, you have become a banker?” Genialissime was aghast. “But that is minion work!”

“I am no banker,” Vainqueur replied. “I am the Defender of the Hoard! Of all hoards! I slew the dread Furibon during the First War of the Hoard, and then the Moth King during the Second! I uncovered the ancient dragon system, gaining the power to protect the dragon way of life from those who would turn it to lead!”

“Ridiculous!” Icefang rolled his eyes. “A ‘system’ which grants you power and money? If it is easy enough for you to access it, why haven’t I? Because it doesn’t exist, and I will prove it right now!”

“No, no!” Manling Nostredame began to panic, Vainqueur worrying if new moths had come to ruin his moment again. “The only requirement to take

the first level is awareness of the system, and meeting the stat criteria for beginner classes! The only reason they haven't—"

"Vainqueur, if this 'system' exists, then may it appear before me this instant!"

Icefang stopped ranting, seemingly glancing at an invisible text in front of him.

Everyone fell silent at his reaction, Vainqueur smugly smirking in triumph.

"I... I have seen a message..." The frost dragon squinted.

"*'Congratulations! Through your bitter resentment and dragon ego, you gained a level in 'Noble.' Noble? I am a king!'*"

"Oh? So if I say that I can become a wizard, I will be?" Genialissime blinked, apparently receiving a message of his own. He pointed a claw at a house, unleashing a bolt at it, much to everyone's amazement.

"It worked." Genialissime rejoiced. "It worked!"

"Me too!" a red dragon spoke up, unleashing a feeble spell with a word. "I am a wizard!"

"Oh, this is fun!" another guest said, the skin of the non-dragon guests turning white for a reason Vainqueur couldn't grasp. "I need to improve my cooking, so I want to be a cook!"

"Can it make me a better minion manager?" Jolie asked. "Mine keep escaping!"

"Sage," Blightswamp told one of her dragonlings. "You can become a princess! A dragon princess!"

"Princess!" her daughter replied.

Almost immediately, Vainqueur's guests took to the game and began to declare themselves sorcerers, knights, and nobles. Only that idiot

Blightswamp failed to replicate true princessness, which was beyond even the system's power.

"This... this is all true!" Icefang's eyes widened, as he turned to Manling Roland. "Manling King!"

"Yes?" The King of Gardemagne had watched the display with far more stoicism than the rest of his fearful kind.

"Hand me a plate!" Icefang ordered with a haughty tone. "It is a great honor for you, that a dragon of my caliber deigns to answer your species' requests, but I will gladly do it for your gold and silver!"

"Silver!" Vainqueur chuckled.

"Silver is shiny enough for a hoard!" Icefang replied angrily, before brazenly stealing his rival's catchphrase. "I am a dragon, and I am now, an adventurer!"

"Me too!" Jolie added, "I want to go on an adventure and find a minion that I can love as much as Uncle!"

"I wonder if the manlings can pay me for the privilege of me not attacking them," a dragon said. "That way, I get richer without effort. Passive revenues!"

"Oh, great idea, but I like getting rewarded for eating food better!"

The manling King said nothing while his minions paled and panicked. Instead, he simply turned to Manling Charlene. "You there."

"Y-yes, Your Majesty?"

"You deal with this," the king ordered. "Do as the dragons say. If they want to create their own adventurer companies under the auspices of Gardemagne, the guild shall oblige. We have enough would-be Maures and unclaimed rewards in the world; dragons willing to take care of them are welcome, so long as they do not eat quest givers."

At Manling Charlene's stony face, Friend Victor exploded into laughter, held his chest, and then rolled on the ground.

"Indeed, Manling Victor!" Vainqueur rejoiced as much as his chief of staff, as the feast was drowned in buzzing, animate discussions. "Like Grandrake invented princess hunting, I, Vainqueur, inspired a new era of dragon adventuring!"

He would brag about his visionary thinking until the end of times!

"We are doomed," Manling Victor replied, crying in the middle of his laugh. "So *doomed*, it becomes art!"

Chapter 35: Season Finale

“Bye Vainqueur!” one of his last dragon guests said, flying away under the midday sun. “Amazing Bragging Day!”

“Of course, it was mine!” Vainqueur replied, which left his close family as the only remaining dragons. “Aww, you’re leaving?”

“I do not want to leave my hoard unattended for long,” Genialissime replied, his mate Blightswamp at his side. “You know how many greedy ratlings live near my place. You avoid eating them for a year, and then they forget the food chain.”

“Uncle Vainqueur, Uncle Vainqueur!” Jolie could scarcely stay in place. “Can I make my lair nearby? I want to become a great adventurer just like you!”

“Jolie, there is a big flying city full of tasty elves and demons which now belongs to me,” Vainqueur replied, happy to have company. “I will gladly let you settle there!”

“Great!” Jolie squealed in happiness. “I will bring my hoard there!”

“It was the best Bragging Day of the century,” Genialissime congratulated Vainqueur. “I cannot wait to test my new magical powers on my cattle!”

“Just wait for my new one next century!” Vainqueur said although he wouldn’t stop boasting about his great discoveries anytime soon.

“This system’s discovery means so much for my princess studies!” Blightswamp said, carrying Genialissime’s offspring on her back. “If nobles can evolve into emperors, then this may be the process that allows noble ladies to become princesses! If I can figure out how it works...”

“Honey, I think some of nature’s mysteries are best left unanswered,” Genialissime replied, apparently in a philosophical mood.

The loss of his three princesses had left Vainqueur in a sad mood in contrast. After the elf wizard released them from their crystals, they had screamed at the sight of two hundred dragons. It had taken twenty minutes for Manling King Roland to calm them down. Vainqueur had offered the manlings to take one of his princess bags to carry them home, but they instead used horses to carry them away. The dragon blamed it on a culture clash.

Vainqueur suddenly wondered if his [Dynasty] perk could allow him to create and raise a princess collection.

...

No, that would be too easy.

He would just go to the elves for groceries.

Vainqueur waved a hand at his family, as they flew towards the skies, officially ending his party on a satisfying note.

Congratulations! For being recognized as Emperor by a powerful head of state, achieving full dominion over Ishfania's monsters, and inspiring newfound respect as a Monster Lord, you earned a level in [**Emperor**] and two levels in [**Kaiser**]!

You gained the [**Imperial Authority**] and [**Malefic Secrecy**] Class Perk!

+60 HP, +10 SP, +3 STR, +3 VIT, +2 SKI, +2 AGI, +2 INT, +3 CHA, +2 LCK!

[**Imperial Authority**]: reduce enemy’s evasion by twenty percent.

[**Malefic Secrecy**]: divination spells and Perk trying to ascertain information about you automatically fail, unless they succeed on an opposed Charisma check.

Vainqueur rejoiced at the news. The [Crest] had worked!

Of course, like after every Bragging Day, the entire area looked like the aftermath of a volcanic disaster. There wasn't a house unturned, or a sheep left alive. "Minions!" Vainqueur ordered, the Kobold Rangers, gnolls, mimics and other servants rushing to his side. "The party is over!"

"Your Majesty," Kobold Red bowed, imitated by the others. "How can we serve?"

"Where is Manling Victor?" Vainqueur asked, ready to summon his trusty sidekick to his side.

"I think I saw the chief with a girl," Bony Blue replied. "But all humanoids look the same, so I cannot tell which one."

Ah! Finally!

Vainqueur resisted the urge to summon his minion, at least until he had bestowed his eggs upon a worthy stock. This would be his only day off this year. "Then you, Kobold Rangers, shall be in charge of leading the minions for the following missions."

"The Kobold Rangers live to serve, Your Dragon Majesty!" The rangers adopted a pose, Junior the Mimic letting out a happy bark behind them.

Vainqueur immediately began to distribute orders. "Ranger Red, fetch me Manling Charlene and ask her for quests! The holiday is over, now it is time for work! My vaults must overflow with gold again! Ranger Pink, you shall write a new chronicle of the 'War of the Hoard', narrating the defeat of the Moth King Maure. It shall be called '*The Return of the Dragon*,' and it shall be distributed to every home, so everyone can learn of my great deeds."

"No work of mine will ever do justice to Your Majesty's deeds, but I will do my best!"

"Ranger Black, fetch me Corpseling Jules and have him raise every minion fallen in the line of duty. If death will not end Manling Victor's service,

then I shall not deny this pleasure to my other lackeys. The rest of you...”

Vainqueur pointed a claw at the ravaged village. “Clean this up!”

“Yes, Your Majesty!” they sang together, before immediately scampering to work.

Vainqueur observed his minions do their merry work, dragging away corpses and repairing the houses. His eyes turned to his volcano, then to the desert which now belonged to him. How much treasure slumbered beneath the sands? How many coins cried alone, hoping for him to carry them away to his vault? His adventures made him realize he had always thought small, before meeting Manling Victor. Now, he had to see big.

Soon, the entire country would be his golden hoard. Everyone would know his name, and the false news of his death would be at long last forgotten!

Come to think of it, Vainqueur had never punished the thieves who dared lie about killing him. With his Bragging Day done, he could finally focus on finding them.

Then he would eat them, and take their cattle.

“Ugh...” Victor woke up, his eyelids were heavy. His sworn enemy, natural light, assaulted him relentlessly. “My head...”

He had tried his best to drink himself into oblivion after last night’s disaster. Due to his Red Dragon Life force, he had needed a lot of alcohol for it to stick, but he had managed to overcome it.

Victor managed to open his eyes, his mind foggy. His back and neck hurt like hell, and his eyes struggled to become accustomed to the lighting.

What happened? He remembered the dragons’ mass discovery of the system, Kia getting angry at him for the whole ‘Soul Nethermart’ thing, teaching Beer Pong to Sav and Jules, asking Allison how he could convert to Cybele, the gnoll bum fight, comforting Charlene after Croissant drunkenly admitted that he fed her cakes to fatten her for dinner...

Victor's eyes snapped open.

His eyes acclimated to the light, and Victor realized he was in an unknown, dirty bedroom, sharing a bed with someone else. The owner didn't keep the room clean, and he could see fleas hopping on the ground.

Werewolves had fleas.

The seed of doubt worming itself in his heart, Victor slowly raised the blanket to peek at who slept underneath.

Please gods, anyone but Chocolatine. Kia, Allison, Isabelle Maure, even Pink Ranger; *anyone* but *her*.

Thankfully, it wasn't Chocolatine.

"My head..." Apparently, Charlene had drunk as much as he did. "Urgh..."

Victor sighed in relief, before realizing that he comforted her in more ways than one.

He glanced at the bedside, finding a fully clothed Croissant snoring on the ground with a bottle in one hand, and Victor's scythe in the other. *"He used me to scratch his back,"* Furibon complained, sounding broken. *"To scratch his back..."*

Victor blinked at the sight; his eyes moved to Charlene, then back to Croissant, and finally back to Charlene, who returned his gaze.

"That's awkward," Victor said.

Charlene glanced at Croissant with an angry sneer. "He tried to fatten me for dinner," she said, "Serves him right."

He had forgotten how petty she could be when revengeful. "So, um..."

"I still don't like you." Charlene thought over it. "You're *good*, but I still don't like you."

Figure. "Then why?"

"You screwed me over with the dragons."

"No, but yes?"

"So I screwed you."

...

Okay.

His life was weird.

Someone knocked on the door, with Charlene immediately hiding beneath the blanket and faking sleep; the chief of staff putting on some pants just as an impatient Allison entered the room. "Ah, Vic, you are done," Allison said, upon glimpsing at the sleeping form in the bed. "First, let me say that I am so very happy you took my lessons about the worship of Cybele to heart."

"Yeah, I figured out I should worry about my afterlife as soon as possible."

"Second, I..." She paused upon noticing Croissant sleeping on the ground, and fell silent.

"Not even remotely what it looks like," Victor insisted.

Allison said nothing, and then showed him a casket. "I brought you ice and healing potions for the breeding line outside. I hope we have enough."

"The breeding line?" Had he heard right? His head was heavy.

"Yes, the line outside the house."

What the Happyland did he do last night? Still in the throes of the hangover, Victor looked through the bedroom's window. A line of people, mostly women of all ages, waited in front of the house.

More than a hundred! “How did this happen?”

“Yes, you kinda made it loud that you wanted to breed last night, the village is depopulated, and you are the second most powerful person in the ‘empire,’” Allison rolled her eyes at the word. “You do the math.”

No way. It was too good to be true, so it wasn't. There had to be a trap.

He examined the line in detail, and it confirmed his fear.

Most were werewolves in human form, but half of them weren't human-looking at all. Furry gnolls, kobolds, mimics, festering ghouls... “How many?” Victor asked, worried.

“Since you told them you met their god, who made you his prophet and ordered the banishment of household pets, the entire cult of the Moon Man wants a piece of your genes. Add some gnolls and kobolds, the fact that the mimics seem obsessed with seeing your ‘*sword treasure*’...”

At that moment, Victor realized that there could be ‘too much of a good thing.’

A terrible idea crossed his mind. “Who is the first in line?” he asked.

Allison’s smile didn’t reach her eyes.

No.

Oh please gods, no...

“Viiiiiiiiic...” *her* voice came from behind the door.

Victor immediately attempted to jump through the window and escape.

Much like Vainqueur in Haudemer, his new dragon wings prevented him from passing through.

“This world sucks!” he complained, desperately struggling to squeeze through.

"In your case," Allison said, before pushing on his back to help him escape, "Maybe in more ways than one."

"You foolish fiend!" Kia pointed her sword at that cursed building. "Why should I not bring down this place?"

"This is a free trade area, and Happyland has invested with the full support of the Emperor," the bug fiend Malfaisant replied, he and other demons protecting the Nethermart. "Our presence here is perfectly legal!"

"It is unethical!" the knight complained, disgusted. "I am not cleaning Ishfania of Maure's fiends just to let others take it over!"

"Miss Kia, this is the perfectly normal result of a free-market economy," the fiend replied with a hint of smugness. "Nature abhors a vacuum. We are only answering the market's needs."

"So will we." A pillar of light fell from the heavens, a golden-haired angel materializing next to Kia herself.

"Miel?" Kia recognized that angel, from the time she ended up in Heaven back when she had just started her adventurer career. "Hi Miel, have you finished your internship?"

"Good morning, Miss Kia. Indeed, I am now a full-fledged heaven counselor. I must inform you that you should upgrade your subscription to Heaven+. For your sake."

Angels. Meaning well, but pushy.

"Look at that," the bug fiend's tone turned venomous. "A redemption chaser. Let me guess, your subscriptions are down again, and you have come to learn from the *better* multiplanar company?"

"Those are donations, and they are up!" Miel replied, the mere sight of the fiend angering her. "In fact, I have come to prospect new cli—new believers!"

“Prospect?! This is our market! We took it from Maure Hellcorporated, now it’s our turn to establish a monopoly!”

“Since it is a ‘free market economy’, as you slimy sales demon said, the higher-ups want to invest there,” Miel replied, showing the fiend a contract. “I have received the authorization of the Grand Vizier himself!”

“You... You will not steal our market share!” Malfaisant protested, much to Kia’s joy.

“The goddess, Shesha, also voiced her intention to invest in the new Ishfania, as did the Church of the Dread Three,” the angel replied. “If you fear our competition, then wait until *they* arrive.”

Malfaisant turned to his fiend bodyguards. “Inform the shareholders,” he ordered. “And cut our prices the way the Emperor cuts his foes!”

“Is this what I think it is?” Kia asked, seeing the big picture rearing its ugly head.

“A land ruled by, and for, greedy monsters, with no taxes, no regulations, and total freedom of religion.” Miel nodded. “Ishfania will become a haven for chaotic mortals and non-humans in a very short time. Now that Mr. Dalton has opened the market after breaking Maure’s monopoly, we in Heaven can finally bring light to all.”

Having seen Heaven and its practices, Kia rolled her eyes when Miel didn’t look. They were better than the alternative, but...

“Since I cannot harm that fiend the paladin way without voiding my diplomatic immunity, I’m going to Mauria,” the knight decided. “Maure still has followers who need to be kicked out downstairs.”

“You have the ear of the Emperor and his Grand Vizier, so we hope that you will convince them to take the right path.” Miel gave Kia a wink similar to those in advertising. “Everyone needs a shoulder angel.”

Urgh, politics again.

Not that Kia complained since she had a feeling things would turn out to be very interesting...

“All of the dragons present developed a class of their own.”

The temperature dropped heavily at her words. The red-eyed, carnivorous trees of the Dark Forest observed her with hunger, ready to tear her limb from limb at their master’s command.

Lucie Lavere, leader of the Nightblades and vampire criminal mastermind, kept her cool and continued her report.

“I destroyed the bindings of the Hellgate as you asked, but the dragons tore through Maure’s army, leaving it in shambles. Vainqueur has claimed Ishfania as his own, with Gardemagne’s support. Most of his guests followed his example, and decided to become adventurers.”

“Why did you not assassinate the dragon’s main minions before the attack?” her mistress pointed out, her voice betraying a hint of anger. The situation had gotten far out of hand.

“You didn’t ask,” Lucie replied. “You ordered me to destroy the seals. No more no less. Besides, it did not stick.”

In the end, Lucie was a mercenary, and she had some laundered gold stashed at Vainqueur’s castle. You do not mess with your bank.

Lucie’s mistress, the fomor Mell Odieuse—who went by the name Melodieuse when falsely claiming humanity—rested on her throne of black, cursed wood, her face one of stone. Her eyes stared through Lucie, while her fingers tightened on the Apple of Knowledge. Not *at*, but *through*, as if she was a ghost.

Eyes were the windows of the soul. But Mell Odieuse had none. Her eyes promised neither pity nor praise; they promised only annihilation. Lucie believed that if pure, distilled evil existed in the world, then it must have looked exactly like that woman.

Lucie worked for the dark woman so she could walk under the sun and learn her ancient magic, but had no reason to be overzealous. She knew that the fomors hated all other life, and the criminal wasn't stupid enough to think she would somehow be spared once her usefulness had ended.

The fairy joined her fingers, thoughtful. "This has gone too far," she said. "I wanted to avoid involving the dragons, but it can no longer be helped."

Lucie said nothing, waiting for her mistress to elaborate. As usual, she didn't, keeping her cards close to her chest.

"You are dismissed," Mell Odieuse declared. "Keep an eye on Vainqueur and Gardemagne, until I have further need of your... other services."

That was how Mell Odieuse worked, fostering chaos in the shadows without involving herself directly. She had empowered Maure with knowledge, hoping he and Gardemagne would slaughter one another, leaving only the fomor victorious. In a way, she had solved the Ishfania problem, by making a bigger one.

"My teacher," Lucie nodded and began to recite a teleport spell. Before vanishing, she caught a glimpse of Mell Odieuse glancing at the immense, stone gate behind her throne, the greatest, most secret treasure of the fomors.

The gate to that strange world called Earth...

Chapter ss1: Side story: The Great Calamity

- 1198 After Mithras, One hundred years before Manling Victor's ill-attempted robbery; the day Vainqueur Knightsbane became known as the Red Terror of Midgard.

Colognenburg, biggest western city of the Midgard Republic.

Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of His Name and Great Calamity of the Age, woke up with a terrible headache amidst ruins, fire, and devastation.

The great dragon didn't feel so well, his eyelids so heavy he could barely open them. Moving was a struggle, and he forced himself to stand up on his legs. His eyes slowly acclimated to the smoke, until he could see his surroundings.

Vainqueur was in the middle of a vast crater, amidst what appeared to be the ruins of a large manling city. Flames, most probably his, had ravaged its districts and reduced most of them to cinders. A large castle was still ablaze in the middle of the destruction, its towers turned into candles. The dragon was alone with the sound of wood burning, the area empty of life.

Where was he? He didn't recognize this place. Had he destroyed it? Why?

Ugh, and he felt sick in the stomach...

Ugh...

Vainqueur spat out something caught in his throat and examined it.

It looked like half-digested knight's armor, with a broken sword of some kind.

Huh? He didn't remember eating a knight since last year.

Come to think of it, what had he done last night? A fog obscured his memories, and his head hurt just trying to remember. What had he eaten to suffer like this?

Finding no food among the ruins to enlighten him, Vainqueur widened his wings and took flight, struggling to raise himself up. He was slowly getting better, especially after breathing some fresh air, but he had rarely felt so terrible.

As he flew over the city's ramparts, Vainqueur realized he hadn't destroyed one city. He had set the entire countryside ablaze in a straight line for miles. Over time, he recognized the area as a coastal region far, far west of his lair, which he only rarely visited.

The sheer scale of the chaos he left behind surprised the dragon. He usually only rampaged like this when he caught a thief stealing from his—

His hoard!

Suddenly reinvigorated, Vainqueur flew straight towards his lair, the furious movement of his wings causing trees to fall beneath him as he went. Within one hour, he reached his home, hoping his precious were safe.

The dragon had made his lair in a cave under a grass hill, in the middle of a valley the manlings had given him when he ordered them to. His goblin minions had built a small village of their own around the area, with wood and mud. They bred almost as fast as Vainqueur ate them when he ran out of cattle, feeding off the vegetables the dragon disdained.

Vainqueur landed in front of his cave, finding three greenish, childlike goblins sleeping on the job. The mere sight of these slackers infuriated him, and he landed right in front of them, the aftershock sending them flying

against the cave's walls. "Minions!" he roared, making the area tremble. "My hoard!"

"Y-Your Majesty?" One of the goblins urinated on himself at the sight. "What is the matter?"

"Where is my hoard?! Is it safe?" Vainqueur moved his head inside his cave, afraid for his gold's safety.

Thankfully, he found his hoard inside, as perfect and shining as ever. The sight relieved him.

"Your M-Majesty?" one of the goblins struggled to find his words, as Vainqueur removed his head from the cave and looked down on him. "W-What is it?"

"Minion, has a thief tried to steal from me recently?"

"Y-Yes, but—"

That was it! "Minion, I do not remember what I did last night," Vainqueur said. "Tell me what happened."

"What I last remember?"

"Yes, before the last thing you remember is my stomach."

"N-No need to go that far, Your Majesty... What I remember..."

- The day before, Red Dragon Hill...

Vainqueur Knightsbane woke up to the tune of goblins whispering in the dark, and of coins falling down from his hoard.

"I say we should run away... he ate half of us last month when he ran out of cows..."

"But if we run, he will track and eat *all* of us."

“Then we wait for the long winter, yes, when he hibernates, and then—”

“Minions, what are you blabbering about?” Vainqueur said, moaning as he woke up, his eyes acclimated to the darkness. His goblin minions were discussing at the entrance of his cave. From the light, it was morning, and he was hungry.

“N-nothing, Your Majesty!” the goblin replied, the others cowering behind him. Each of them looked the same, tiny, greenish humanoids who could barely serve as snacks. “We caught a thief for you, that is all!”

They did? Such good, loyal guards he had. “Is he fat?”

“No, he’s a ratling, thin and nimble.”

Pity. Vainqueur would have loved a fat and meaty breakfast, like a dwarf. The dragon roused himself, walking towards his minions and causing the cave to tremble with every step. “Where is my chief of staff?”

“I, I am Your Majesty,” one of the goblins said.

He was? Vainqueur squinted at the minion, who looked like every other goblin under the sun. The dragon needed a way to identify him from among the others, like a red cloak or iron teeth. “Minion.”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“First, become more remarkable. I might get confused about your place in the food chain otherwise.” The chief of staff had already recruited a lot of goblins when Vainqueur informed him of the concept. “Next, bring me that thief, and my grocery bag. I am hungry.”

“The grocery bag?”

“The big bag,” Vainqueur elaborated, annoyed by the minion’s incompetence. “You have not forgotten to sew it back, have you? Because I am hungry, and if I cannot do my groceries, I will eat at home.”

Understanding the message, the goblins bolted out of the cave, with Vainqueur simply moving his head outside. The goblins soon climbed the hill towards his cave, keeping the thief restrained with ropes, and carrying a big, dragon-sized cowskin bag. The thief was a ratling, a strange hybrid between a rat and manling, with the ugliness of both and the tastiness of neither.

The animal did show Vainqueur the respect the dragon expected upon seeing him, groveling in front of him. “Great Vainqueur Knightbane! How majestic you are!”

“It is Knightsbane, not Knightbane!” Vainqueur roared, the goblins kneeling in obedience at his reaction. “I can tell the difference!”

“F-Forgive my mistake, my king.” The ratling lowered his spine so much, Vainqueur half expected him to eat grass like a sheep. “I, I am but a humble traveler...”

“Is that what your kind call thieves now?” Vainqueur accused him.

“I did not come to steal from you, oh great Vainqueur Knightsbane... I came to gaze upon the size of your hoard, and of your magnificence... to see if you were—”

“As big as the tales said,” Vainqueur finished, the thief blinked. “I heard that one before. Three times. Find a new one.”

The ratling gulped. “The tales of Your Majesty do you little justice, Your Majesty... your claws are sharp as spears, your breath a hurricane...”

The dragon’s eyelids narrowed in disappointment.

“Five times I have heard this,” Vainqueur said. “Now you will see the inside of my bowels, which should be a first for you.”

“W-wait!”

Vainqueur chomped the thief and swallowed him whole. Like every ratling, it tasted like dung and garbage, so much that the dragon almost vomited.

Sometimes, Vainqueur wondered why the lesser species thought trying to steal from him was a good idea. The matter bugged him so much, he promised himself he would ask the next one trying, unless the food wised up.

“That was all?” Vainqueur asked, puzzled. While he would have been annoyed at a thief, the fact they had caught him before he touched his hoard made the incident a mere afterthought. Nothing to rampage over. “What happened next?”

“Then you left for groceries, Your Majesty... w-with the big bag... and you didn’t come back.”

By now, Vainqueur was confused. He wasn’t hungry, so he had found the food he sought back then. What could have angered him so much? Also, he didn’t have the grocery bag with him when he woke up.

More and more puzzled, Vainqueur flew away without a word, the wind from his wings throwing the goblin on his back. He decided to check his usual grocery places, in case it jogged his memory.

The dragon quickly reached his favorite farmlands, finding the remains of barns and pens. Some sheep eating grass fled at his coming, and Vainqueur noticed his own footprint in the middle of a broken fence.

Clearly he had done his groceries before being interrupted. By what? Vainqueur circled above the area, observing every detail, smelling the air...

Suddenly, among the smell of manlings and cattle, he noticed the stinking, horrible scent of a fairy.

Yes, he remembered.

“Little Wyrn has lost her sheep, And can't tell where to find them, Leave them alone, and they'll come home...”

Vainqueur sung to himself, as he ripped off the roof of a barn, manling whelps screaming and running away on horses. He found cows, pigs, and

sheep inside, making sounds at his arrival.

Let the shopping spree begin.

With one hand, the dragon cheerfully seized a cow, then put it in the bag. Then he seized two pigs and wondered if he should take the sheep with him. He would burn some fat returning home, and he wouldn't mind a snack in the middle of the road.

"Vainqueur Knightsbane..." His ears picked up his name spoken in elder draconic, and his nose the smell of a fairy. Vainqueur instantly turned towards the source, hate and disdain in his eyes.

Springing from the dirt behind him, a fomor stared back.

This abominable, sworn foe of dragonkind was two times smaller than Vainqueur; a deformed centaur with the lower body of a spider, and the upper half was humanoid. The torso was disproportionately larger than the lower half, covered with an insect-like armor; the left arm was a centipede with sharp blades for mandibles, the left one a crimson hand. Eight multicolored eyes looked at Vainqueur from the creature's head, with a row of pointed teeth underneath.

"I am Mag Mell," the fairy presented himself with a chittering voice, although Vainqueur already knew the creature. That fairy had created half the beasts the fairy lords sent against dragons during the war, from trolls to werewolves. "Father of monsters."

"I am Vainqueur Knightsbane," he replied. "I can do everything you do, but better."

The fomor hissed at the dragon's rebuke, a chilling cold filling the air.

"Have you come to glare at me?" Vainqueur said at the creature with disdain. "Or to die?"

"Others will die," the fomor replied, his voice low and heavy. "All the New Folk who pollute our lands will die. Such is the word of our champion,

Mighty King Balaur.”

“Balaur?” That overmighty dullahan? Vainqueur snorted. “I could eat him whole in one bite.”

“That was long ago, and this is now. He has grown, and so has his hatred. He is the strongest of all fomors.”

“Not as strong as me,” Vainqueur replied with pride. “The strongest of your kind would still be no match for the weakest of dragonkind!”

“Yet many of you we killed, in the dark days.”

“They suffered from birth defects!” Vainqueur defended his kind’s honor. “It doesn’t count.”

“Only us fomors are forever,” Mag Mell replied, having no answer to Vainqueur’s implacable logic. “You are the greatest of dragonkind. The great calamity of this age, or so you pretend.”

“I pretend nothing. I *am*.”

“Then, my King has an offer for you. Fight at his side, and paint this green land red.”

“Why would a fomor ask for a dragon’s help?”

“Soon, we shall wage a great war. A great Wild Hunt we gather, a horde of millions. We will spill the blood of the mortals until we have slain the last of them. Then, we shall take our war to their nest, that world they call Earth. Outremonde shall be ours again, as it was during the old days. A quiet land, where the Old Folk rules.”

“I have always ruled, and I still do,” Vainqueur replied, looking down on the fairy with condescension. “It is your kind who has grown weak enough to get defeated by manlings.”

“Other dragons have died to them too.”

“Handicapped dragons!”

“The mortal are vermin, and the magic they use a disease. Diseases are cured, and the vermin which carry it, silenced. We will hunt them into their houses, and cradle their children to sleep until Outremonde is pure again. There will be a great reward for joining in this carnage, Vainqueur. A tribute of fairy gold and mortal flesh.”

“Why would I exterminate my favorite food? If I kill all the puny races, where will I find coins and princesses? Have you thought of the logistics, fairy? Do you think?”

“We can raise gold from the air, and shape slaves from the dirt. With one hand, we create life; with the other, we take it.”

“I would rather eat coins than trust a fomor!” The dragon extended his wings. “Begone, fairy, before I devour you. Vainqueur Knightsbane is no one’s pet.”

“Then, on this day of the solstice, mark the words of Mag Mell. In time, the New Folk, too, will come for you and your kind.”

The abominable fairy cursed in its archaic language, becoming one with the earth and vanishing from Vainqueur’s sight. The dragon delighted then returned to his shopping—

Wait, solstice?

“The solstice is today?” Vainqueur panicked. “I forgot!”

Quick, he needed a princess! Any princess!

Vainqueur tried to remember what was so important about the solstice, but his memory remained foggy.

Had the fomor cast a spell on him? Why would he need a princess? Not that he wouldn’t mind getting one, but his own Bragging Day and the Princess Hunting Season were far, far away.

Vainqueur left his shopping barn to try and retrace his way, finding the ruins of isolated elfling castles nearby. The dragon could recognize the melted stone he left behind anywhere, and the more he saw, the more his memory slowly came back...

When he reached a half-collapsed castle with three towers, Vainqueur had a new flashback.

Finally!

He had to destroy three castles, but he found an elfling princess with golden hair. Just the way *she* would love it.

Having barged inside their throne room by collapsing the castle's walls, Vainqueur seized the screaming princess and prepared to put her in the grocery bag with the cows. Guards and maids had run away at his coming... with one exception.

An elfling wearing crimson armor and a cloak pointed a rusty toothpick at him. "Vainqueur!" Much to Vainqueur's surprise, this elfling spoke in draconic with a somewhat good accent. "At long last, we meet again!"

"Elfling, while it pleases me that your kind is starting to learn the one true language," Vainqueur replied in his own tongue. "I am too busy today to help you commit suicide. Fall on your sword on your own."

"You will not ignore me, villain. I'm fifty-seven!" Pfft, Vainqueur was already bigger than their puny houses at that age. Not impressed. "I am Oersted, of Colognenburg!"

Colowhat? "Whom?"

"Oersted."

"Yes, whom?" Vainqueur repeated to the stupid animal.

"Oersted!" The elfling insisted, apparently too dim to understand Vainqueur's words even in his own tongue. And here people wondered why dragons needed minion translators. "You burned my city fifteen years ago!"

He did? Vainqueur observed the elfling closely, trying to identify him, but... nope. "Which one?"

The elfling shook. "You do not remember."

"Elfling, if you are here to bore me to death, stop right there. I am immortal, but my patience is not. Either get to the heart of the matter or get lost."

"In the west, near the sea! There is a white, chalk cliff nearby."

A chalk cliff? Ah! "Yes, I remember!" Vainqueur said, the elfling's head perking up. "That is the city with the big clock?"

"We don't have a clocktower. Our water clock was destroyed fifty years ago to put out a fire caused by a drag—" The elfling froze, before glaring at Vainqueur. "You burned our city *twice*?!"

"Your villages all look the same," Vainqueur replied. "How do you expect me to remember every place I visited for groceries? After a time they all start blurring together."

"G-groceries?"

"You think I overturn your villages because I like it? Frankly, it would be much easier if you left your cattle and princesses on display for me to take. I have better things to do than rip off your fragile roofs or collapse your towers; which I deeply regret every time I do." Towers were beautiful, like mountains.

"You... you monster! Why? Why can't you leave us in peace?"

"I allow you people to live in my world, is that not enough? I am good and generous, but do not ask too much."

"You... you..." The elfling knight finished shaking, putting both hands on the rusty pommel of his blade. "This is the thousand years old Sword of Leone! I spent years looking for it, investing all my skills in swordsmanship until I could find and master this blade! By it, you shall meet your fate."

Huh? That toothpick looked very old and fragile. “What is that supposed to do?”

“To kill you!”

With a surge of speed whom Vainqueur had to admit surprised him, the knight charged at him and hit him in the chest with his tiny blade.

The sword broke against Vainqueur’s scales.

The elfling knight looked at his broken blade, almost as disappointed as the dragon himself.

“But... but, this is the thousand years old sword of Leone! It shouldn’t break!” Vainqueur rolled his eyes at the sight of this crying animal. *Elves*. Sometimes, he wondered what was up with humanoids and their obsession with old, outdated swords.

After all, if they were *that* precious and powerful, why would *anyone* leave them in some cave in the middle of nowhere?

Still, understanding he wouldn’t be free until he helped the suicidal elf, the dragon ate him whole in one bite while he was still crying over his broken weapon.

He put the screaming princess in the grocery bag and flew away towards the great river region.

The great river region?

Ah, he was visiting family. Why bring a princess though? To brag?

Vainqueur flew towards the great river crossing through the immense continent, witnessing river serpents and turtle monsters swimming in the current below. As he approached his cousins’ territories, he ended up finding one in a compromising situation, right on the riverbank.

His favorite cousin, Genialissime, was a wind dragon, a beautiful beast with silvery feathers over his scales; like most of dragonkind, he was much

smaller than Vainqueur but still big enough to eat manlings whole.

The black wyrm, Blightswamp, laid next to him, with Genialissime having put a paw on her belly. While Vainqueur's cousin seemed awake, she was in a deep, restful sleep. Still, an outsider couldn't mistake the sight for what it was.

... they had *bred*?

"Vainqueur?" Genialissime raised his head to look at him, sounding tired. "You sobered up?"

Sobered up? "You bred with Blightswamp," Vainqueur said, disgusted. He knew Genialissime liked breeding, but the elder wyrm knew where she had been. She lived in a *marsh*! "Blightswamp."

"It... wasn't as bad as you think. Also, this is your fault."

Vainqueur glared back. "How is it my fault that you cannot keep your eggs home?"

"You hurt her self-esteem, I had to give her a wing to cry on."

What? "Look, Genialissime, I do not remember anything from yesterday," he admitted. "You seem to, however."

"It does not surprise me. You were in a *terrible* mood yesterday." His cousin shuddered, making Vainqueur worry about what he had done. "Do you remember what day it is?"

"The day after the solstice?"

Genialissime sighed, frustrating Vainqueur. "And who was to have her Bragging Day on the solstice?"

Bragging Day... Solstice...

"Ah, yes I remember," Vainqueur said, his memory coming back to him. "It was Jolie's first Bragging Day!"

“Uncle Vainqueur, Uncle Vainqueur!” His adorable, tiny spitfire of a niece squealed at seeing him land in front of her cave, near the riverbank. Much to Vainqueur’s annoyance, he noticed half a dozen dragons had arrived before him. “You came!”

“How could I miss my sweet niece’s first Bragging Day!” Vainqueur nuzzled his adorable kin. She was a red dragon barely the size of a big horse, who had learned to fly very recently. “I brought you a present!”

“A present?” She looked up at him with big, cute eyes. “Is it a minion? Uncle Grognon gave me my first minion too, a catkin kitten! Is it another?”

“No, even better!” Vainqueur searched inside his grocery bag, ignoring the pigs and bringing out his elfling captive, who kept whining and shivering. “A princess!”

“A princess!” Jolie began to cry in joy, as he looked at her present. “My first princess?!”

“She makes a whining sound when you squeeze her,” Vainqueur told his niece how to use the princess doll. “Be wary of knights trying to steal her away.”

“Oh, can I dress her up? Can I dress her up?”

“Any way you want, my sweet firedrake.”

Vainqueur put the princess doll on Jolie’s hoard, inside the cave. It was a tiny hoard, of copper coins and treasures she had managed to scrape together as a young wyrm, but every dragon present would give her positive reinforcement for her first Bragging Day. She would have all the time to work hard for her fame when she was all grown up.

“I will feed her fishes!” Jolie said, grabbing the princess by the robe with her mouth and lifting her up. “Totheriver!”

Ah, this reminded Vainqueur of his first Bragging Day, after he paid back the gold debt he owed to his parent for bringing him into the world. He

watched his niece fondly, hoping she would grow almost as big as him in a few centuries.

“Hey, Vainqueur!” The red dragon turned his immense head towards the newcomer, Genialissime. “Long time no see!”

“Genialissime!” Vainqueur saluted his cousin. “How are you?”

“Great! I think I will organize a Bragging Day in ten years or so, after the new Princess Hunt Season.” He glanced at Jolie’s hoard. “I am so proud of her, gathering a hoard at her age...”

“Yes, especially since her father had a birth disability.” Vainqueur’s brother had been killed by elflings, whom the red dragon had helped commit assisted suicide afterward. “I hope she hasn’t inherited it.”

“Yeah, being killable sucks as an illness. I can’t believe so many of us developed it the last ten centuries. It’s like a plague the puny races carry with them.” Genialissime glanced at the various invites, especially a black female wyrm. “Hey, Vainqueur, there is a new dwarf city nearby. Blightswamp and I discussed it, and we think we will crash the place after Jolie is done bragging about her hoard.”

“The Bragging Day hasn’t even begun, and you are already preparing the afterday feast?”

“That is a good question. A better question is, will you follow us?”

Mmmm... “I always get drunk when I eat dwarves, even if they are fat and tasty. I never find the way back to my lair afterward.”

“Come on, just eat a few. I will stop your excessive consumption, as your afterday handler.”

... why not? He hadn’t eaten dwarves in a long while.

How bad could it be?

“I became drunk on eating dwarves?”

“You ate three dwarves, and then you couldn’t stop! You became crazy violent, you burned everything!” Genialissime frowned. “And when Blightswamp and I tried to restrain you, you called her by the W-word.”

The dragon looked at his cousin, horrified. “I called her a *wyvern*?”

“Yes, yes, you did. She was mad, but thankfully I’m fertile.” Genialissime shook his head. “You have a serious dwarf intolerance, Vainqueur.”

“Oh, by the elder wurm, I am so sorry,” Vainqueur said, horrified he had called a true dragon, even one who lived in a swamp, a *wyvern*. ”And Jolie? Did she have a good Bragging Day?”

“Ah? Ah, yes, she had a fun first Bragging Day, regaling us with the tales of her adventures hunting copper coins in the wild. I think she really likes the princess you brought her. She kept parading her by the robe to everyone. It’s a very shy princess though, she kept crying all the time.”

Vainqueur would have loved to find a better princess, but he had been running out of time. Still, he was happy his niece had enjoyed his present. “Do you know where I left my grocery bag?” the red dragon asked. That was the last unresolved mystery.

“I think you burned it during your rampage.”

Argh, he would have to order his goblin minions to sew him another! Vainqueur disliked eating the food surrounded by manling peasants’ dung.

Come to think of it, seeing the deserted region after his rampage, Vainqueur had probably scared the food away for miles. He would have to fly for hours to find a manling shopping barn now, and maybe days to catch a princess.

Vainqueur decided that he would migrate south, to a more populated area with food close. He had heard the Albain Mountains were nice. Frosty, but tall enough for him; the climb would also discourage thieves, with no ratling to try to take his treasures from him.

Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of his Name, Great Calamity of this Age, and King of the Albain Mountain. It sounded great.

He promised himself never to eat dwarves again though.

Chapter 36: Interlude: Tales of the Kobold Rangers

“Your Majesty?” Victor asked, his body slippery and sultry from the gold shower.

“You know what I want, Minion,” After watching him swim in his golden hoard, he could barely restrain himself. “You are the shining jewel of my hoard...”

Victor blushed, his white skin glittering like silver in response. Truth to be told, he had never dared voice his feelings for his great, wealthy master.

“Bragging Day is tomorrow, and I need to... treat myself,” Vainqueur’s voice was heavy with desire. “Lay on the gold.”

“Pink, what are you writing?”

Writing in Nethermart’s cozy drink shop, Pink jumped out of her seat; she accidentally dropped her beer cup on the ground, much to the imp barista's annoyance.

The other Rangers looked at her in confusion. “Pink, you’re late for the training, and Red is getting mad,” Black said, frowning at her as she whistled. “Now you’re acting suspiciously.”

“She’s hiding the text behind her back!” Yellow said, trying to circle her.

“No!” Pink turned to face Yellow, only for Blue to use the opportunity to grab her scroll from behind. “Give it back!”

“Is this the sequel of the *War of the Hoard*?” Blue immediately opened the scroll. “Sweet!”

“No, don’t read it!” Pink attempted to reclaim the paper, but Yellow and Black restrained her. “It’s not meant for publication!”

Her comrade didn’t listen and suffered for it. The more the kobone read, the more he shook, the crimson light in his empty eye sockets faltering. “Oh, gods...” Blue dropped the document in horror. “I feel fear. I am undead, and I feel fear!”

“Pink, what have you done?” Black released the bard, who immediately recovered her scroll.

“I... I just had a plot lizard that wouldn’t leave,” Pink said, sheepish and ashamed. She never expected anyone but her to read it.

“What do lizards have to do with... with *this*?” Although usually the most aloof member of the group, Blue kept shaking in dread. “How could you write the Emperor and Lord Victor like that?”

“But they are obviously made to be together!” Pink complained. “Emperor Vainqueur, Lord Victor, and the Hoard!”

She couldn’t help it since she had started taking levels in [Bard] after writing the *War of the Hoard*. The signs were there! Chocolatine, Allison, Lynette, they were all false leads which the good Emperor Vainqueur had to eat to win his minion’s heart! Why couldn’t anyone else see it?

“Ugh, one of your V&V ‘fanfics’ again?” Black rolled his eyes. “How many has it been? You haven’t even finished your ‘*Bad to the Bone*’ Vainqueur and Furibon story.”

"I'm ChocoVic all the way," Blue said.

"And I'm a VainquHoard!" Yellow declared, fist bumping Blue over compatible fan followings, "And now I want to read Pink's story out of morbid curiosity."

“No!” Pink kept the scroll behind her back. “No reading my unfinished works! Please!”

“Guys, stop bullying Pink!” The voice of Red Ranger made the kobolds and kobones behave, their tall, powerful leader walking into sight with the musket and rapier Lord Victor provided him. “Why are you taking so long?”

“It’s nothing, Red!” Pink lied.

“Pink was getting drunk writing a fanfic again!” Yellow mercilessly betrayed her, Pink kicking him in the leg’s bone. It hurt her more than him. “Ahah! I don’t feel pain anymore!”

“Traitor!”

Red sighed. “Pink, you can write what you want, and I am proud that you can.” Few kobolds could even read or write. “But drinking beer before our rehearsal? What am I supposed to think?”

“I need to get alcohol to proceed with my writing sometimes,” Pink admitted. Some of her ideas were so dark, so deep, so *artistic*, that she couldn’t bring them out without help. “When Emperor Vainqueur asked me to write about the... the *lead event*, I had to get drunk before I could commit it to paper.”

“We all know how traumatizing the *Event* was,” Red said with sympathy. “That is why we must train hard. So this kind of senseless atrocity can never happen again on our watch. Remember what Lord Victor said. We are the *elite* of the minions!”

“Minion lieutenants!” Black pumped a fist.

“We are His Majesty’s shield!” Red reminded them, his words brimming with charisma. “The Hoard’s last line of defense! The last line to hold! We... are the Kobold Rangers!”

“Kobold Rangers!” the group shouted, the imp barista ignoring them as he served a drink to Barnabas the troll.

Pink remembered that fateful day, when they stole the Apple of Knowledge from that human. The second they had laid their eyes upon the ancient techniques of the Tokusatsu clan held within, of these brave warriors fighting paupers with style, the Kobolds had understood what they had missed in life.

On their own, Kobolds were weak, small, and unremarkable. Most died before they hit ten winters. But by learning the ancient techniques held within the Apple, and reviving the Tokusatsu clan’s traditions, Red had argued that they could become more than mere Kobolds: they could become legends whom their kind would celebrate in tales for centuries! They may die anytime, but their legacy would live on forever!

And so they became the Kobold Rangers, the elite warriors of the Murmurin Empire.

“His glorious Majesty, Emperor Vainqueur’s Bragging Day will happen soon!” Red reminded them. “For the sake of the Emperor, we cannot embarrass him. Our dancing and motto must be perfectly executed. And... and...”

“And?” Pink frowned, sensing her leader’s troubled mind. “What is stressing you out so much?”

“Rolo has a quest for us,” Red continued. “A very dangerous quest. A monster is feasting on the vegetables. If this continues, the livestock will starve, and His Majesty’s Bragging Day Feast will be ruined!”

“Who would dare launch such a treacherous attack?” Black spat on the ground. “The elves?”

“Worse,” Red replied ominously. “A *rabbit*.”

A rabbit. The ancestral nemesis of koboldkind; they fought those mammal vermin over burrows since the dawn of time. The brave fathers of the

Rangers' warren had managed to fend off one of their invasions before Pink was born.

Now, it was her turn to defend the burrow of Murmurin against those hungry monsters.

"And not any rabbit," Red added, turning away with a dark look on his face. "A Black Rabbit."

The Rangers gasped and exchanged worried looks.

A Black Rabbit. A rabbit who gained magical powers by becoming a dark prince among its filthy, verminous kind. It could summon armies of rodents, grow to enormous sizes, and cast spells from its horn.

Black Rabbits were blights upon the land, devastating all in their path. Countless kobold martyrs had fallen to them.

"If we do not kill him, entire cultures will fall to its hunger," Red said. "Rolo is convinced he will attack by twilight."

"Can we... can we defeat him?" Yellow joined his hands in a silent prayer. "One of them killed my father with its horn."

"For His Majesty, I am not afraid to die again!" Blue replied with empty bravado, his voice breaking.

"If it comes to it, and we cannot defeat the Black Rabbit on our own..." Red trailed off, turning to Pink. "We will have to summon the Mimiczord with your song."

"But she cannot control it!" Black protested. "Once called, there will be blood!"

Red slapped some sense into him. "Get a hold of yourself, you coward! There is no greater honor than dying, so that His Majesty may be fed!"

"I..." Black scratched his cheek. "I am sorry, I... I let fear control me."

“It is okay to be afraid in the face of such evil,” Red consoled his friend. “But so long as we are together, you can rely on us. That is what being a Kobold Ranger is all about.”

Black nodded firmly, imitated by the others. “Let’s repeat the motto,” Red said, happy with the group’s resolve. “We fight for the hoard!”

“We are made of gold!” Black continued.

“We strike from the shadows!” Blue added.

“We strive for His Majesty!” Pink shouted, the drink shop’s clients glaring at their magnificent display.

“Prepare to meet your doom!” Yellow said, going off-script with his deep, undead voice.

“Yes, that is rig—Yellow!” Red stopped in the middle of the motto, everyone else groaning, “You’ve gone off-script again!”

“I’m sorry, it’s too hard to resist!” Yellow replied. “I... I will say it right next time!”

Red sighed. “Second attempt!”

The beast arrived under the twilight sun.

Never before had Pink seen such a monstrous being. The incarnation of Hell had fur that was as black as night, with big vicious eyes; his enormous ears reminded the Bard of twin pillars of darkness. While as tall as any other rabbit, the ground shook under the immense power of its back legs. A single, golden horn shone in the middle of the monster’s forehead, surging with magical power.

The Kobold Rangers established a defensive perimeter, Rolo’s fields of carrots and lettuces behind them. Yellow and Pink carried bows, while Black and Blue had switched to spears. Red remained at the forefront, musket, and rapier in hand.

Pink knew this would be a dangerous fight. All of them had levels in [Outlaw], but only Pink and Red had delved into other, combat-oriented classes. And this... this... this was a legendary beast, far more terrifying than Gustave the Scorcher, who killed Blue and Yellow in the past.

“Food?” the black beast uttered with a guttural, dark voice.

Pink’s [Bard] mind filled out the words left unsaid, translating the monster’s black speech into true epic dialogue.

“Kobolds?” (You dare stand between me and my sweet pleasure, kobolds?)

“Yes, we Kobolds Rangers shall defend His Majesty’s pantry from you!” Red shouted back. “You shall not pass!”

“Hungry!” (Do not get in my way! All those who do will be eaten!)

“You. Shall. Not. PASS!” Red repeated.

“Rabbits!” (Then only death will remain! Come to me, my loyal soldiers! **[Summon Rabbit Horde]!**)

The Black Rabbit let out a vivid screech, a cloud of dust surrounding him. A swarm of white rabbits crawled out of the earth, an army summoned from the farthest reaches of Hell itself. At their master’s command, the rodents charged as one with a great rumble.

“Defend the fence!” Red commanded, firing with his musket at the incoming swarm, imitated by Yellow. A rain of bullets and arrows felled the first wave of rabbits, while Blue and Black readied their weapons to kill those who managed to break past them. “Pink, sing!”

Pink did so, singing the praise of the good Emperor Vainqueur during the War of the Hoard. *“Minions, remember Furibon! Take your swords, and rise, and fight! Fight for the Hoard! The wicked will perish in the king’s flames!”*

[Bardic Song] raised all of your teammates’ strength!]

Empowered by her words, the Rangers held the line, Black and Blue impaling every rabbit that threatened to get past them. More kept coming from the burrows, waves, and waves of hungry beasts; Red and Yellow ran out of projectiles and joined the melee, the kobone fighting with its bare claws.

The Black Rabbit oversaw the slaughter with his cold dark eyes, before raising his horn to the heavens. Electricity surged from it, as he pointed it at the Rangers while the weaker rodents distracted them. “Black!” Pink warned her ally, as the horn pointed at him, firing a thunderbolt. “Watch out!”

But even the Black Ranger couldn’t outrun lightning. He barely had the time to look at the monster, before the bolt hit him in the chest and sent him crashing against the fence, defeated.

“You beast!” Yellow snarled, breaking the formation and rushing at the Black Rabbit.

“Wait!” Red shouted his rapier red with rabbit blood. “This is what he wants!”

The last of his dread servants defeated, the Black Rabbit’s horn shone bright, the monster’s size increasing. Within seconds, he had become as big as a cart, walking on his back legs.

The mammalian titan let out a roar and impaled Yellow Ranger with his horn, like a bull with a manling. The kobone was propelled to the side, his spine breaking in half upon crashing. The dread mammal then stepped towards the remaining rangers, his greedy, malevolent eyes set on the vegetables.

Panicking, Pink kept singing while she raised her bow, firing an arrow at the monster. The projectiles bounced off his fur.

Blue let out a maddened war shout as he charged with Red, weapons raised. The Black Rabbit easily kicked Blue aside with one of his enormous legs, but Red managed to graze his skin with his rapier. He barely dodged a

lightning strike from the beast's horn, needling the beast's ankles with his weapon.

"Fight for the hoard!" the bard kept cheering her friend, as he managed to halt the beast's progress. *"You can win! You can do it!"*

But the Black Rabbit, infuriated by their resistance, turned to Pink, his horn surging with the power of thunder.

"Pink!" Red jumped in the way, the lightning bolt hitting him instead of his teammate. He collapsed on the ground, trying to rise back up, only for the Black Rabbit to stomp on him. Crushed under the beast's weight, the leader of the Kobold Rangers stayed down.

"Summon... it..." Yellow, struggling to put back his bones together, implored Pink. The Black Rabbit left the defeated Red behind, ignoring the last of the Rangers as he walked towards the fence. "Summon the Mimiczord!"

Here goes nothing.

"Behold! What a shiny sword!" Pink sung, as loud as she could. *"What a shining blade this is, trapped in stone!"*

The Black Rabbit stepped on the fence, crushing it beneath his leg. He prepared to feast on the vegetables, when a shriek interrupted him.

The dreaded Excalitrap, Vainqueur Junior, rushed into sight, its bloodthirst roused by Pink's words. The mimic rivaled the attacker in size.

"Sword?" the mimic said, Pink's mind translating the word into a full dialogue. (I am the only true sword treasure! Where are the challengers?)

"Him!" Pink pointed a finger at the Black Rabbit's horn.

As she hoped, Junior mistook him for a sword, furiously leaping between the garden and the evil beast. One of the mimic's many hands grabbed the sword lure on its back, swinging it like a true swordsman.

“Sword death!” (You will suffer the agony of a thousand deaths by my sword!)

“Rabbit!” the monster replied. (A rabbit prince fears nothing! A rabbit is fear!)

The Black Rabbit attempted to impale Junior the same way he did with the Rangers, but the mimic parried with his blade. Then, with a push, it forced the beast behind the fence.

Pink watched on, amazed, as Junior fought the monster evenly. Sword met horn in a dance of damnation. Every time the monstrous mammal attempted to cast lightning upon his foe, the mimic interrupted him with a well-placed thrust.

“Strong,” the Black Rabbit screeched. (I did not expect to fight such a powerful foe. How delightful.)

“Sword strike!” (It shall take but a single stroke of my sword to put you down!)

“Horn!” (My horn will bathe in your unworthy blood!)

With a brutal swing, Junior pushed the beast back, both enemies facing each other under the sun. The mimic proudly raised its blade, swirling flames surrounding it. “[**Elemental Saber: Fire**]!”

Junior’s Sword will now inflict additional Fire Damage!

One of the fabled [Fencer] Perks... Pink had never seen it in action. Would it prevail against the beast, though?

“[**Holy Horn**]!” the Black Rabbit replied, its horn growing longer, until its length matched that of Junior’s blade.

The Black Rabbit's horn will now inflict additional Holy Damage!

Both foes glared at one another, then charged with a roar.

In a blink, moving so fast Pink's eyes could barely follow, both fighters exchanged a blow and kept going, having switched places. For a short, tense moment, they stood in place, two silhouettes under the sunlight.

Then, blood flew from the Black Rabbit's head.

"Food..." the beast said while whimpering. (So this is how I die? Food we all are... and food we shall remain...)

The monster collapsed on his left side, vanquished. Junior let out a victorious roar, as the rabbit regained his original, tiny size. The mimic grabbed the corpse with one hand and immediately swallowed it whole.

Pink couldn't believe it.

They won! Junior won!

The mimic, though, wouldn't leave without exacting a price. 'Sheathing' back its sword on its back, Lord Victor's pet turned to the defeated Red, who had forced himself back on his knees. "Sword." (Give me your sword.)

Red hesitated, for his rapier had been granted to him by Lord Victor for his deeds against the Scorchers. He knew *exactly* what the Mimiczord did to every sword it could get its hands on.

"Sword!" the mimic insisted, its voice turning dangerous.

As a tribute for its service, Red gave Junior his rapier, his eyes turning away. He couldn't bear to look at what he knew would follow.

But Pink, for the sake of true historical accuracy, didn't flinch at the execution. The mimic cruelly broke the rapier in half with its bare hands, threw the remains on the ground, and buried it under the dirt with a gleeful smirk. Junior then left without a sound, satisfied at proving its superiority.

Pink immediately rushed to Red's side, helping him back on his feet and preventing him from collapsing. "It's over," she said, looking at the fence. "It's over."

Congratulations! For defeating a Black Rabbit, you have taken two levels in **[Bard]**! You earned the **[Extended Song]** Personal Perk.

+60 HP, +20 SP, +1 AGI, +2 INT, +2 CHA, +1 LCK!

[Extended Song]: Your [Performances]' enhancements last twice as long.

“Yes...” Red glanced at the rest of his team. Blue had recovered, while Yellow struggled to put back his bones in place. “Are you alright, Rangers?”

“Can’t... move...” Black groaned, paralyzed by the lightning. He would need to be patched up by Chocolatine.

“Blue, help him,” Red commanded, the kobone rushing to his living brethren’s side. “Are the vegetables...”

“Safe and sound,” Pink nodded.

“Then... congrats everyone. We have done it. We’ve won. The Bragging Day Feast is saved.” Red chuckled. “Pink, you better write a song about it.”

She would. She already had a name for it.

‘The Night of the Black Rabbit.’

It would wait until she finished *My Immortal Dragon* though.

Black Rabbit

Type: Beast.

Recommended party level: 5.

Following the golden tradition set by giant rats, bandits, and goblins, Black Rabbits are among the most popular targets of low-level quests. Every adventurer group has a story of hunting one of these pests on behalf of farmers at the start of their career. No matter how many of them are cooked with prunes and mustard, more always come.

Thankfully, they never run fast enough.

Chapter 37: Meet the Dwarves

Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of His Name, Great Calamity of the Age, Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains, and Protector of all Hoards, had waited so long for this moment.

He hadn't allowed anything else to distract him; for a whole *month*, he had waited in his great vault, sitting on his ever-growing hoard. He had counted every single one of these thirty days of patience, meditation, and focus; every hour between him and this golden moment of pure *bliss*.

As the minutes separating him from his greatest pleasure turned into seconds, the pressure became almost unbearable. The echo of his tense breathing filled the underground vault, as his eyes widened in greed.

Then, it finally happened.

A large pile of gold, as shiny as the sun itself, materialized in front of Vainqueur, perfection made metal.

“YES!” Vainqueur roared out in relief, as he hugged the coin pile tenderly like a father with his child. After a whole month of separation, he couldn't put a word on the joy he felt. “It is fine, everything is okay, you are safe! I will never let you go again... *Never*.”

The dragon enjoyed the warm comfort of his wealth returned to him, of his favorite Perk working again. At long last, everything had returned to normal.

He had to brag.

“MINION!” His prized chief of staff materialized at his side, stumbling on his master's gold with his pants down. He seemed to have been sitting

before Vainqueur called him. “Look! My [Stipend] returned! Manling Victor, you...”

Argh, what was that smell coming from his minion?

“Manling Victor, you stink like your kind's peasants!” Vainqueur complained, his lackey rising and putting back his pants on. His minion had also traded his black cowl for crimson robes and a hood, which meshed better with his wings and tail. “What did I tell you about taking a bath?”

“Your Majesty summoned me while on the toilet, what did you expect?! The smell of roses?”

“Yes, that is true that you manlings suffer from that problem,” Vainqueur said with condescension. “I hoped that your dragon transformation would solve this, but I guess you were better off with a magnificent tail. I suggest that you get rid of your manling half as soon as possible.”

“As if you’re better...” Manling Victor frowned when he realized that, yes, his master *was* better. “Wait, you’ve never... you’ve never actually... uh.”

“Yes, which is another proof of dragon superiority.”

“But where goes...” Poor Manling Victor couldn’t grasp the perfection of dragon biology, observing his master with his big, confused eyes. “Well, *everything*?”

“Here,” Vainqueur put a hand on his belly. He suddenly realized he had grown fatter due to the lack of exercise. “Nothing is wasted. But, this is unimportant. What is important is that the moth elf has, at long last, well and truly been defeated!”

“Your Majesty killed him a month ago,” Manling Victor replied, unaware of the true significance of the event. “You had Pink write a book about it.”

“Yes, but now the last stain on my honor is gone! The [Stipend] Perk works again!” Vainqueur had worried the Perk had been broken, since no gold appeared after he rightfully regained his [Emperor] Class. The shock had

been enough to delay his questing, until he was sure he had fully recovered. “My patience has paid off.”

“Wait, so all this time you shut yourself in your vault, asking not to be bothered except to get food or gold for the hoard, you did nothing but wait for the money to fall on your lap?” Manling Victor put a hand on his face, which he often did for reasons that eluded his master. “Your Majesty has become a true landowner.”

“I have not waited, Manling Victor, I have *rested*,” Vainqueur replied, adding his new pile of gold to his ever-growing hoard. Destroying Brandon Maure, ending his scheme to destroy his hoard, and organizing the most revolutionary Bragging Day known to dragonkind had exhausted him. “That was a wonderful vacation.”

“Doing nothing for thirty days?”

“Thirty days watching my hoard,” Vainqueur clarified. “Now that my Perk works, all we need is to find you a Crest, so that I may bestow [Noble] levels on you through my [Dynasty] Perk. You will need that sweet [Stipend] if you are to reimburse your debt to me, which is...”

The dragon recalculated the debt, removing the funds his minion had delivered to him the last month. “Twelve million, two hundred twenty-seven thousand, five hundred and twelve gold coins.”

“I’m just glad I managed to scrape three hundred thousand together in one month,” Manling Victor congratulated himself.

“At this rate, it will take you four years to reimburse me, which is too slow,” Vainqueur chastised his minion. “As an adventurer, I earned twelve million coins in much less time. While I do not expect you to surpass me, I want higher reimbursements.”

“Yes, but I’ve also been working full time to keep Your Majesty’s empire stable,” Manling Victor pointed out. “I swear more money will come soon. It will definitely take less than four years... I hope.”

“We shall see,” Vainqueur said. Friend Victor may have been his trusted chief of staff, but his master wouldn’t let him off the hook until he had reimbursed his life debt. “I hope you used my vacation time well, to grow my empire and breed.”

“Yeah, I... I did both. More than I would have liked. It’s exhausting.”

The dragon hummed the air, instantly recognizing a new scent on his lackey. “You smell of dwarves,” Vainqueur frowned in disapproval. “You have not bred with dwarves, have you? They are not minion material.”

“No, we’ve welcomed new ambassadors from the underground realm of Agartha,” Manling Victor replied. “I was actually preparing for a meeting with them before you summoned me.”

“Dwarves are not minion material,” Vainqueur repeated. They were meaty and tasty, but since they always made him drunk when he ate more than three, they made for poor emergency rations.

“I still think Your Majesty should see them,” Manling Victor insisted. “Also, I finally identified the scammers who took credit for your death.”

Vainqueur’s head immediately perked up in interest. “Where?” he asked, gleeful at the idea of settling the score.

“Charlene studied the guild’s archives, and identified them as a disbanded Silver-Ranked adventurer company from the merchant republic of Barin, the *Blue Rose Legion*. They were a classic four-person party specialized in big game, monster-hunting work.”

“Disbanded? They are dead?” Disappointing. Vainqueur would have Jules raise these criminals from the dead as skeletons, so he could kill them properly.

“I’m not sure, the papers said that they separated in Barin twenty years ago, dissolving the group. I think that after claiming the reward for Your Majesty’s head, they earned enough money to retire.” The mere idea infuriated Vainqueur, who had already taken their slander personally.

“Thankfully, Charlene found a quest in Barin which could help us investigate. I could even get a Crest out of it.”

Excellent. “Then we leave tomorrow for that quest, Manling Victor.”

“What?” Manling Victor panicked. “Like that?”

“I shall not be denied in my rightful revenge,” Vainqueur replied. “I shall take a tribute of cattle for staining my reputation, and seize the gold they received for my demise. Then we shall return to fulfilling quests and growing my hoard further. Must I remind you that V&V now has competition from my kindred?”

“Oh, I almost forgot, we received a promotion last week.” Manling Victor searched in his pockets, bringing out two bronze plates. “Here.”

“*Bronze*,” the dragon squinted, unimpressed.

“Bronze.” His minion sounded as annoyed as his master.

“How can it be that I am not gold yet?!” Vainqueur complained angrily. “I saved your robber king’s princess, slew the evil Furibon, and put the demon grasshopper in his place!”

“The adventurer guild is having a tough time reorganizing their rankings, with all the new dragon adventurers registering. Icefang even created the first dragon only *Silver Dragon Adventurer Company*.”

“Silver?” Vainqueur recoiled in disgust. How could Icefang live with himself? “V&V cannot fall behind these poor excuses for dragons, Manling Victor. I swear it, we shall wear gold-plates before the end of the year.”

“Can we talk about the V&V Empire’s situation first, though? I’ve got a lot on my plate—”

“Minion, you are my Grand Dragon Vizier and Doer of the Thing. Dealing with minion administration is *your* job.” And as long as he was in crippling debt to his dragon master, Vainqueur would not allow him to rest on his laurels.

“I get it, and I’m starting to like it,” Manling Victor trailed off, Vainqueur frowning. Had he not enjoyed it before? “But we’re getting a lot of newcomers, especially representatives from other states or ‘overplanar investors’, and they want to meet the Emperor. Some even say you are dead and your minions are keeping up a charade.”

“What?” Vainqueur’s booming voice made the vault tremble. “Who would be stupid enough to think I can die?”

Had the secret of dragon mortality spread to the paupers? Who else knew?

“Lots of people, apparently.” Manling Victor scratched the back of his head. “It would be good if you could show up, to dispel the rumors.”

The dragon sighed. He could not truly blame them; of course, everyone wanted to see His Majesty in the flesh at least once in their empty life. “Fine, fine,” the dragon replied. “What do they want? To touch my scales, hoping it will cure their sick?”

Come to think of it, Vainqueur could charge the manlings for this service.

Food for thought.

“Well, Your Majesty, the country is now fully yours.”

“Minion, it *always* was.”

“Yes, but now that the Empire has crushed the elven resistance... which I always wanted to say... we now control all of Ishfania, including the old capital of Mauria. It’s closer to a demon-infested dungeon than anything, which your niece and Kia are busy cleaning up, but Ishfania is more or less pacified.”

The news that his niece had adopted the family business of getting paid for eating smaller creatures warmed Vainqueur’s heart, but he didn’t understand his chief of staff’s point. “And?” Vainqueur replied, losing interest.

“Ishfania may be a desert, it has a lot of potential and many people want a piece of it; there’s also the matter of the Iron Eagle’s remains to deal with. I

can make decisions in Your Majesty's name, but it would be better if you were to grace the doubters with your imperial presence."

Oh well.

Who was Vainqueur to deny lesser creatures the pleasure of his sight?
"Bring them here, so they may marvel at my wealth and greatness."

His minion returned with a group of dwarves, whose appearance confused Vainqueur.

Unlike the dwarves he used to eat in the past, their skin was as grayish as ash. They clearly hadn't seen the light of day for ages. Each of them wore black steel armor and fine robes, with the leader having a slightly more elaborate dress with golden linings; each carried strange, glass-like protection over their eyes.

However, Vainqueur noticed something even stranger.

They *didn't* smell of alcohol.

"Your Majesty, I present you Marbré, the ambassador of Agarthia," Manling Victor announced, the dwarves bowing at Vainqueur. The dragon welcomed them while sitting on his hoard like a throne.

"Your Imperial Majesty, it is a great honor to meet you," the ambassador said, the dragon puffing up his chest at the praise. "The tales of your revolt against the elven bourgeoisie reached even our own Supreme Leader's ears."

"Yes, I squashed the cattle Brandon Maure with my hand," Vainqueur boasted. "Which I found extremely gratifying."

"Indeed," Marbré agreed, as he stopped bowing and clenched his fists. "I remember my visceral feeling of contentment when our Supreme Leader cut the heads of the dark elf oppressors, seized their means of production, and established an Averagist, dwarf-made utopia. Served these smug pointy ears right!"

“I know,” Vainqueur nodded, understanding where this feeling came from. “Elves are so arrogant, as if *they* were the apex species everyone looked up to. Even if they are cattle who eat grass and breed with trees.”

“Exactly, elves were always looking down on us because they were tall, beautiful, and had higher Intelligence scores,” Marbré went on a tirade. “They oppressed and mocked the Agarthans, forcing them to mine jewels underground while monopolizing the profits.”

Pfft, they had copied dragons again? Had the grasshoppers ever had an idea of their own? “Truly, if they didn’t make the best princesses, there would be nothing to salvage from elves,” Vainqueur agreed. “No matter how many times we dragons put them in their place, at the bottom of the food chain, they never learn.”

“We Agarthans delighted when we learned how you cast down one of their outdated feudal states.”

“Wait, are you dwarves, or Agarthans?” Manling Victor asked, confused. “You keep using those words interchangeably.”

“We are Agarthans by our nation and Duergars by our species, but we call ourselves dwarves as a political statement, for we are all equally small.” Too many names. Vainqueur subtracted them a point in the potential minion ranking. “Most of the dwarves on the surface are traitors to the revolution or helpless drunks that we expelled.”

“Interesting,” Vainqueur replied. If these dwarves expelled their drunks, then he could perhaps eat them safely.

“Emperor Vainqueur, let me first congratulate you on your nation’s first step towards achieving Averagism,” Marbré said. “You are among the first people of the surface to have taken this step towards a true post-feudalism world.”

“Minion, translate for me,” Vainqueur ordered his chief of staff, unable to understand the lesser creature’s language.

“He’s impressed that you overthrew the local elf nobility to replace it with absolute authority, which is close to what they have.”

“We have fully finished our own revolution,” Marbré explained his thinking. “By overthrowing the elven bourgeois, and shortening the heads of anyone taller than our current Supreme Leader, we Agarthans have achieved perfect equality of height. That is Averagism: everyone is equally average.”

“But what about children and younger people?” Manling Victor asked.

“We use heeled boots,” Marbré replied, pointing at his shoes. “Everyone is as tall as our Supreme Leader. No exceptions.”

Vainqueur didn’t understand. What was the point of ruling lesser species if they weren’t smaller than him?

“Though you moved away from feudalism and abolished the elven bourgeoisie, you are stuck at the Hoardist Imperialism stage of economic development,” Marbré continued to speak nonsense. “Thankfully, Hoardist Imperialism is but a step towards true Averagism. Your Majesty just has to seize the means of production to better safeguard them, as did our Supreme Leader.”

“We’re kinda trying a free-market zone experiment there,” Victor said, confusing Vainqueur even more.

“But you have nationalized the land, mining, and farming, have you not?”

“Everything belongs to me,” Vainqueur said, understanding that part. “Except lead, which is banished until the end of time.”

“In time, you will realize free-market carries the seed of its own inevitable destruction,” Marbré said, losing the dragon’s attention again. “We Agarthans offer to establish an embassy here on the surface, so we can properly assist in your political revolution and trade. We would also like to study the ruins of the elven Iron Eagle if you allow us.”

“The metal bird?” Vainqueur could have sworn he had wrecked it utterly.
“What about it?”

“We are interested in it for our patriotic war against the sun,” Marbré replied flatly.

Manling Victor glanced at Vainqueur, who was as puzzled as him. The tiny dwarf noticed, and cleared his throat.

“When we Agarthans first made forays toward the surface to export the revolution, we were treacherously attacked by that fiery aster,” Marbré said with contempt, raising the black glasses on his nose to reveal milky eyes. “It burned the eyes of our ancestors, forcing us to wear these ‘sunglasses’. Ever since, we Agarthans have declared war on the Sun and its apostate god, Mithras. The Sun cowardly stayed too far away for us to reach, but the ‘Wind Spears’ might be the key to bring the fight to it.”

“I cannot condone it,” Vainqueur replied firmly. “The sun was made by dragons to fight cold. I will not allow dwarves to harm it.”

“We do not want to destroy the Sun, just to force it to stop burning our eyes,” Marbré tried to reassure him. “We want to coexist with the sky, but on our terms. In any case, we would like to exchange technology, and maybe buy some of your Powerstone supply.”

“Minion,” Vainqueur whispered to his lackey, low enough that the dwarves wouldn’t hear. “Are they serious?”

“I think so,” his chief of staff replied with a sigh.

“I do not think they share my values,” Vainqueur said. “They are ridiculous.”

“What does Your Majesty want me to do about it?”

“Cook them, obviously.”

“Okay they’re eccentric, but they can offer us a lot. Does Your Majesty remember the teleport stone we used to escape—” Manling Victor corrected

himself when his master squinted at him, “tactically retreat from Maure? It was called an [Agarthan Warp Stone].”

Vainqueur guessed what the name implied. “It was dwarf-made?”

“I think we would benefit from a technology exchange.”

“They get the bird, we get the stones?” As his vizier answered with a nod, Vainqueur turned back to Marbré, suddenly interested. “What are these Powerstones that you want?” The Robber King of Gardemagne also spoke of them.

Marbré snapped his fingers, a member of his retinue opening a small box.

Vainqueur peeked at the content, a dozen glowing stones of different colors, from the purest blue to fiery red. Unlike his beloved gems, they appeared raw and fragile, like glass. Yet, he could sense the red one radiating heat, a white one cold, and the clearest releasing a faint stream of air around itself.

“These are Powerstones, a magical mineral imbued with elemental power,” Marbré explained. “We Agarthans need them for our forges, and we are ready to share our gold and perfectly safe magical items in exchange for a steady supply.”

“Wind Powerstones are what allow Maure’s old capital to fly, and the Eagle’s bombs to work,” Victor added. “The Albain Mountains have a lot of deposits, as does the Ishfanian desert.”

Vainqueur examined the stones closely, before voicing his judgment.

“Not shiny enough for my hoard,” Vainqueur said. “My minion will see that my treasure benefits from the sales. As I solved the manlings’ problems for their coins, I too will accept a tribute of gold in exchange for this junk.”

“Your Majesty is truly a true friend of the revolution.” Marbré bowed deeply. “I will see your vizier for the fine print. We will deliver you our newest creations, which have been tested, tested, and tested.”

“You said tested thrice,” Manling Victor pointed out.

“Yes, to assert the fact our magic item prototypes are perfectly safe to use since we tested them before sending them to you.”

“Now return to me with gold, or do not return,” Vainqueur sent them away, the dwarves bowing and leaving the vault.

Congratulations! For showcasing your imperial majesty to foreign diplomats, you earned a level in [**Emperor**]!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA!

Once the dwarves had left though, the dragon looked at his chief of staff with a heavy gaze. “They are odd. *Too* odd to be minions.”

Manling Victor looked up at his master. “*This* is where Your Majesty draws the line?”

“I believe everyone has the potential to make for a good minion, if properly trained,” Vainqueur replied. “But I have quality standards, and they do not meet them.”

“And that tested comment makes me wonder if I just made a big mistake granting them access to the Iron Eagle.” Manling Victor sighed. “But so long as the Apple of Knowledge remains unaccounted for, we need their expertise.”

Vainqueur frowned. “What does your vegetable have to do with this?”

Chapter 38: Minion Deathcare

Murmurin had grown bigger.

A month after Maure's army and Vainqueur's guests devastated it, leaving no stone unturned, the village had grown unrecognizable.

Murmurin had not only risen from its ashes but grown into a decent, if chaotic city. With tribes of monsters moving in for the promise of steady food, overplanar visitors setting shop, and undead looking for a place where they could 'live' undisturbed, the population had reached eight thousand. The fields and sheep pens, originally created to accommodate Vainqueur's guests, could now sustain a large population; and Maure's fall had only encouraged locals to get closer to the new ruler of Ishfania.

As he flew over the city with his great wings, Victor could only marvel at the difficulties this population boom caused. Everywhere he could see new buildings and houses under construction, with kobolds, gnolls, goblins, and other creatures cooperating to build them. Angels and fiends had each claimed a district next to the other, and he caught sight of two of these rival species harass a gnoll to sell him an '*afterlife service*'. The Kobold Rangers had to break three of these rivalries which turned violent this week.

Neither did the newcomers always get along. Gnolls and goblins kept picking fights, and the newest settlers, a tribe of orc, kept causing acts of petty vandalism.

In short, Murmurin had become an island of chaos in a feudal world.

Victor had done his best to steer this evolution into a positive direction, but there wasn't a day without a new issue or problem to solve; and he had his

debt to Vainqueur to reimburse. Even with his Class' resistance to fatigue, the constant stress had started getting to the chief of staff.

Victor landed in front of his mansion to find a line of monsters waiting for him, surrounded by kobold minions. "Okay, who is here for business?" the grand vizier asked, with quite a few hands raised up. "Who is here for breeding?"

Fewer hands raised up, although some visitors had raised their hands twice. Weeks of turning them down had weeded out his number of admirers.

"No breeding today," he announced, the people in the line complaining.

Victor remembered all these harem animes, where he had fondly dreamed of the constant attention of female company. That was until he experienced it himself; constant sexual harassment and outright stalking didn't feel nice, it was tiresome and outright disturbing. Some even broke into his mansion to steal his hair!

Eventually, he just kept turning down almost everyone and having the Kobold Rangers restrain the ones who didn't get the memo. It wasn't that Victor disdained female attention, and he even indulged a bit, but being treated as a breeding stallion annoyed him.

Thankfully, most of his harassers eventually lost interest... with a few exceptions.

"Chocolatine..." Victor frowned upon finding her in the line with a big smile.

"I'm not here for breeding!" she said. "I'm here for the new temple."

Victor frowned, before remembering that matter. Still, he doubted she had changed her mind about him. "After I'm done with other urgent matters," he said with a sigh, the werewolf pumping her fist.

The chief of staff walked inside his home, with Charlene waiting for him, a pile of papers in hands. Someone else had gotten to her first, much to her

dismay. “But honey...” Croissant begged on his knees for her to come back again. “I swear I love you.”

“Croissant, I do not know in how many languages I have to say it,” Charlene replied. “We’re *done*. I have a busy day, so unless you are here for business...”

“Honey, I have thought over it for weeks,” Croissant insisted. “I am so sorry...”

“You lied to me, hiding that you were a werewolf!” Charlene complained. “And all the cakes you gave me... I thought it was sweet, but you fattened me up for dinner!”

“Okay, yes, maybe our relationship started as animal husbandry, but I care!” Croissant said. “It’s... it’s like a pig you have fed for years to make ham, only to find you couldn’t go through with it.”

Real smooth, Croissant, Victor thought, as Charlene reddened at the pig comment. It didn’t help that she had lost weight since she broke up with him. “A pig? Is that what I am to you?”

“Yes,” Croissant replied, mistaking her anger for blushing. “You are my cute piglet...”

Victor struggled to keep a straight face, as Charlene turned into a tomato. “Enough!” she said, turning to undead guards. “Take him off government property!”

“But Charlene—” Croissant found himself surrounded by skeletons and was forcefully dragged out, crestfallen.

Victor shook his head at the sight. “That was therapeutic,” Charlene replied, adjusting her hair with a hand. “But he’s annoying.”

“I can issue a restraining order if you wish. The Kobold Rangers hate him, so they will love the job.”

“No,” she replied, dusting off her clothes. “He will give up eventually.”

If he was anything like his sister, no, he wouldn't.

“What will it be this morning?” he asked, as Charlene handed him a pile of paper bigger than yesterday's one.

“The Universal Minion Deathcare project, the new shared temple project, legalizing murder—”

“Legalizing murder?” Victor almost choked.

“Or waste disposal, if you want to sound politically correct,” Charlene replied, taking this with more stoicism than him. “With the angel-demon price war, Savoureuse sensed an opportunity and lobbies to open an official assassin guild.”

“I do not sleep enough to deal with this madness,” Victor replied with a sigh.

“I know,” she replied with a knowing smile. “Next, there is the quest you wanted to tackle in Barin. Kia also sent a message saying that Mauria is more or less pacified, and Barnabas has been introduced to the new Agarthan smiths. He said they will deliver new magical items next week.”

“Put the temple last on the agenda,” Victor decided since Chocolatine would attend. “Vainqueur wants to leave tomorrow, so let's deal with the quest first.”

She pointed at a paper in her pile, Victor reading it. It detailed the quest and a map of the southern continent. “The quest comes from Barin's leader, the legendary tactician and merchant Barsino,” Charlene explained. “He wants to recover an ancient artifact, the *Bottle of Mot*, kept within the desert's most dangerous dungeon: the Tower of Sablar. Barsino informed me he would gladly reveal the location of the Blue Rose Legion's members in exchange for the artifact.”

The Tower of Sablar? The place where the ancient ritual that turned Ishfania and the southern continent into a desert took place? It was a superdungeon

that frightened everyone; however, the tales of the riches held within encouraged tomb raiders to try their hand at conquering it.

So far, few returned alive.

“It is a very dangerous quest; the Tower of Sablar is considered a challenge for adventurers in their high fifties. Barsino believes that, I quote, ‘a dragon emperor of Vainqueur’s caliber should prove powerful enough to triumph.’”

And it would certainly contain Crests for Victor. “I will ask Kia if she wants to tag along,” he decided. The paladin would certainly enjoy the adventure, and they would need the extra muscle.

“We begin with the universal deathcare then?”

Victor nodded, entering the dining hall of the mansion, which he had more often than not turned into a reunion room. Ghostly will o’wisp provided additional light, and skeleton servants polished a large, rounded table with handkerchiefs. The chief of staff sat, and observed as Charlene invited Malfy, Miel, and Jules into the room.

Since she couldn’t rely on the usual guild fee, Charlene had to more or less depend on both Gardemagne and V&V’s donations to maintain her chapter. Eventually, confronted with the challenge of building an administration for the city, Victor settled on employing her part-time as an assistant.

His own chief of staff.

Instead of stressing out, being put in charge of the city’s administration improved her mood a *lot*. Victor guessed she had stagnated at Valbain, and being promoted to city administrator helped with her self-esteem. She was actually a nice person to hang out with, when not stressed out and annoyed.

Of course, Victor also worked on her in other ways...

“Dead and fiendish gentlemen, angel lady,” Victor welcomed the group, as they sat around the table. “I gathered you to officiate the new Minion Deathcare project.”

“Before we begin, I want to say that I love the name, Victor,” Jules said, the most enthusiastic of the three about the idea. He had even offered a large share in his new undead start-up to the vizier, which would help a lot with the debt.

“Death sucks. Trust me, I’ve been there twice, it *sucks*. It’s painful, and you have to wait months before going to a decent afterlife.” Which Victor wasn’t even sure was *that* good... “So I’ve been thinking... we can make sentient undead cheaply. Since many minions of V&V die in the line of duty, I think our guild should owe them something for their service. Hence my idea: V&V minions can have their own undeath pension plan, allowing them to be raised as undead after death.”

“I was against the idea of creating sentient undead for labor, but the idea of making necromancy a societal institution won me and the church of Camilla over,” Jules added. “The minion’s individual contribution will determine what kind of undead we can raise them as.”

“I suggest lichdom for the most deserving,” Furibon said from within Victor’s scythe, startling the chief of staff. He had almost forgotten the lich, since the undead spent his time talking with the other sealed souls rather than his jailer. *“You will need a virgin sacrifice, but it is worth it.”*

“Undeads are a plague,” Miel stated, drawing a glare from both Jules and some of the skeletons. “Instead, you should make Heaven Insurance mandatory. This is the only way to ensure a good, safe afterlife for all.”

“This is a free-market economy, redemption chaser,” Malfy butted in, before turning to Victor. “I say that Infercorp gets a priority claim on the souls first. We have been pillars of the Empire since its conception, and we are all about customer service.”

“Hence why minions can choose between three retirement plans,” Victor said. “Undeath, Heaven Insurance, or whatever Hell—”

“Happyland,” Malfy corrected.

“Whatever Happyland proposes.”

“But one of the options is *amoral* and the other *immoral*,” Miel complained.

“If you want people to sign with you, offer them an afterlife they want without a month long delay.”

“You were a particular case!” Miel defended her poor customer service.

“Certainly if Heaven is as good as an afterlife as it advertises itself, people will flock to your outdated overplanar company,” Malfy taunted her. “Also, Mr. Victor, you have heard Infercorp opened its succubus brothel in Murmurin. It would be great if you could, as the vizier, sample the wares. For safety reasons.”

Sample the wares? Victor’s head perked up, while Charlene rolled her eyes. “Is it always open?”

“Always, for a friend.”

“Mr. Victor, I have great news for you!” Miel immediately went on the offensive, “Thanks to your service to the cause of universal heavenly insurance, my higher-ups have decided to offer you a free guardian angel, who will do everything you want. *Everything*.”

“Oh, Mr. Victor, it seems that a large public donation has slipped from my hand,” Malfy put a large purse full of money on the table. “It would be a shame if nobody picked it up...”

“Okay, thank you, but this deal isn’t negotiable,” Victor stopped them as Charlene distributed them pieces of paper. “Take it or leave it.”

The three examined the documents and eventually signed; Victor noticed Malfy and Miel exchange a heavy, tense gaze as they handed out the papers. He could almost see the lightning between their eyes.

Why did he have the feeling he had started a war?

Twenty minutes later, the three had switched places with a very enthusiastic Savoureuse, who carried a basket. “Hey, Vic! How has it been?!”

“I’m fine, Sav,” Victor replied. “Work is tiring, but we manage.”

“Manage? Vic, you’ve done great! I leave the village for three weeks, and I find a city on my way back! Oh, and I have a gift for you...” Savoureuse opened the basket, revealing an array of cheese within. “I brought you this from the north.”

“Oh, sweet!” Victor couldn’t resist taking a goat cheese, although Charlene declined due to her diet. “So, Sav, Charlene told me you wanted to... legalize waste disposal?”

“It’s a bit more complicated. The Nightblades’ leadership thinks your city has grown enough to deserve its own chapter operating here. At first, they wanted to open a thieves’ guild, but I told them *‘a thief guild in a country ruled by a dragon? How can that end well?’*”

“You don’t say,” the chief of staff deadpanned.

“So instead, I suggested they open an assassin guild,” Savoureuse explained happily. “It will be good for the economy, Vic.”

Victor gave her a blank stare.

“It will create jobs!” Savoureuse defended her profession. “Like my nephew, Potiron. He couldn’t find work with his law degree, so he reinvented himself as a respected hired killer. Vic, as long as there are three people on the planet, there will be a victim, an assassin, and a silent partner. If you do not regulate it, the Nightblades will still carry out contracts, except we will do it in seedy back alleys instead of offices with government oversight.”

“What kind of argument is that?” Victor contested. “You will legalize every crime under the sun with it!”

“Of course not. Waste disposal is a community service, taking care of troublemakers. What is the difference with mercenary work, besides the fact we cleanly kill our targets in their home instead of on a battlefield?”

“There’s a difference between killing a soldier and assassinating someone’s business rival,” Victor replied. “Sav, I have spent enough time among the Nightblades to know they aren’t picky about who they stab, so long as they get paid for it. I’m not going to openly condone that kind of trade, especially since people here are amoral enough to make use of it.”

“So, it’s a no?”

“If I may,” Charlene butted in before Victor could brush his friend off. “I can see a compromise.”

“Charlene, do you *want* an assassin group operating here?”

“No, but as she said, they will carry out contracts anyways and cracking down on them will be a drain on our very tight budget. There is another, cheaper solution, which worked well in Noblecoeur.”

Noblecoeur? The stronghold of the Nightblades syndicate? Victor saw where this led before Charlene made her case. “Nobody leaves the Nightblades,” the guild manager said, Savoureuse nodding. “Since Victor was part of the syndicate, he could be made the head of the local chapter.”

“Yes,” Savoureuse agreeing. “I was going to suggest it. As the Crime Lord of the local chapter, Vic, you will have a finger in every pie, and you will be the one to approve the hits or not. The perfect union of crime and government.”

Was Victor the only one seeing a problem with this? “So, you will want me to legalize an assassin guild, by making me its head?”

“Vic, what kind of empire does not have a shadowy assassin arm to complement its monstrous army?”

When she put it this way... Victor decided to stall for time. “I will consider it, but I’m not making a decision today.”

“That isn’t a no,” Savoureuse rejoiced. “I cannot wait to show you the tricks of the trade. It will be just like old times.”

Victor sighed and sent her out of the room. “Charlene, how many jobs do I have?” he asked his own chief of staff, before realizing Savoureuse had stolen Malfy's bribe without anyone noticing.

“Taking into account Vainqueur’s titles, I count at least twenty.”

Why was the reward for good work *more work*? “You can’t seriously expect me to take this one,” Victor said. “Even if cracking down on them will drain the budget, it’s better than letting a criminal syndicate operate undisturbed.”

“But by running the organization you will be in the perfect position to dismantle it, if the situation calls for it,” Charlene replied.

Like she did here for Gardemagne? Victor was pretty sure she kept watch of Vainqueur for the Kingdom. “How did we end up working so closely together?” The vizier couldn’t help but make a joke about their situation. “Didn’t you hate my guts before the invasion?”

“I disliked you,” she admitted. “But as you said, that was before the invasion. After seeing you leading the defense of this town against Maure’s army and saving my life, it would have been very petty of me not to reevaluate my opinion. What are you doing tonight?”

“I’m leaving tomorrow, so I need sleep,” Victor replied, as Allison and Chocolatine walked in. he couldn't suppress a question which haunted him for a while. “Hey Allison, I need your point of view on something. Rolo turned some enemy elves into sheep.”

“Sheeps,” Allison ‘corrected’ him. “Yes, what about it?”

“If I eat a sheep that used to be a humanoid, does it count as cannibalism?” Victor asked, worried.

“That kind of question is why I am a vegan. No meat, no questions.”

Victor couldn’t live without meat—in fact, his transformation into a half-dragon had only worsened his appetite for it. He would have to secure a safe, non-dubious source of food.

Chocolatine must have read his mind. “Vic, it is only cannibalism if you and the food are equal,” she chirped, trying to reassure him. “This is why Isengrim condones hunting demons.”

“I’m a bit worried by your experiments, Choc,” Allison admitted. “Some of the new tomatoes you watered with demon blood have teeth.”

“But they can grow in the desert, was it not what you wanted?”

“Ladies,” Victor interrupted them before they engaged in another debate. “The church of Shesha is coming to invest in our little city, and they offered to fully fund a new temple for the twelve gods.”

Since the Agarthans worshiped Veran, Jules Camilla, and the Nightblades Deathjester, the triad of evil deities known as the Dread Three had gained a following in the city and requested a temple of their own. Outside of Isengrim, Murmurin had become a haven for ill-reputed or chaotic cults.

Strangely, neither Mithras nor more lawful gods had followed them.

“It would be good to increase the size of our temple,” Allison nodded. “Since Choc invited other werewolf tribes into Murmurin, we no longer have enough space to hold congregations. But Shesha being Shesha, she never does anything for free. I am not going to pay rent to worship my own goddess.”

“I haven’t seen anything of that kind in their proposal,” Victor said, Charlene shaking her head. “I think she just wants publicity and goodwill by funding that public work.”

“As long as there is no fine print,” Allison shrugged. “Does that mean you’re going to stay a polytheist, Vic?”

He nodded in response. He had discussed with her about the worship of her goddess Cybele since his current afterlives weren’t so appealing. Of course, Chocolatine, upon hearing of it, had immediately tried to convert him to Isengrim, and even Jules had preached to him the benefits of worshipping Camilla. Since he had been marked by three gods already, with one of the

cults treating him as a prophet, and to stop everyone's nagging, Victor had settled on shunning everyone equally.

The more the chief of staff considered the matter, the more he came to agree with Vainqueur that becoming a god might be his best bet.

After another boring meeting discussing the temple's architecture and location, Allison and Chocolatine agreed to share the new building with the other cults; the Moon Man's followers had already given full power to Victor to decide on that case.

"Vic," Chocolatine asked, after the meeting ended, "Can I talk to you alone for a minute?"

"Charlene, do I have another meeting soon?" Victor begged his assistant.

"You still have six scheduled, but the first begins in ten minutes."

Victor slammed his head against the table in tiredness. "Okay, one minute..."

"Yes," Chocolatine pumped her fist, as Allison and Charlene exchanged a glance and quietly left. "You know Malfy is opening a new casino?"

"Yes." Although the fiend hadn't tried to pitch it to him as hard as the succubus brothel. "What about it?"

"I have two, two VIP invitations for the luxury lounge..."

Of course she hadn't given up. "Chocolatine..."

"But you have bred with seven people this month, Charlene included!"

"Yes, but... you're special Chocolatine..." Victor suddenly realized that wasn't the phrasing he should have used, at all. "Wait, how do you know? You stalked me?"

"No, I smelled you." Victor recoiled. "Just one date. One date! And if it doesn't work, I give up!"

Victor's eyes widened. "Really?"

"Yes!" She said, putting a hand on her chest. "I swear on my god Isengrim. If it doesn't work, I'll stop bothering you."

"Deal!" Victor jumped on the opportunity before she changed her mind. Finally, an exit was in sight. Just one date, and it would be over. "Just a date, no breeding, after I'm done with the newest quest, but deal, deal, deal!"

"Yes!" Chocolatine replied, just as overjoyed. "You're not going to regret it!"

It wasn't like it could end anything but badly, but he would live with it.

Chapter 39: The Ballad of Jolie Dragon

“Uncle Vainqueur!” Jolie rejoiced, as the Emperor of All landed in her open lair with his chief of staff. “You’ve come!”

“Jolie, how beautiful you are today!” Vainqueur scratched his niece between the horns as he did back when she was a dragonling, making her wriggle in pleasure. She had grown fatter on demon meat, just like him. “Who is my favorite dragon, after me? You are!”

Vainqueur remembered promising himself to rampage in Maure’s flying demon farm, back when he had confronted that grasshopper for the first time. He had been recalled to his hoard before he could properly crush the moth and ravage his land, so Jolie had beaten him to it.

His niece, her minions, and Knight Kia had cleaned up the city the same way Vainqueur’s guests had with Murmurin, destroying most of the houses and leaving beautiful, flat ruins laying everywhere. Jolie had decided to celebrate by hosting a sitting party of her own, drinking a strange green liquid from an amphora.

“Hello again, Victor.” Knight Kia drank her own tiny cup next to her griffon, giving one to Manling Victor. “You look like you need a vacation.”

“And you look like you just came back from one,” the Vizier replied. “You stormed out angrily last time I saw you.”

“I still do not agree with half the things you guys allow in your country, but it was damn satisfying to put an end to Maure’s regime for good,” Kia said with a happy smile. “I leveled up after we finished cleaning up this city of

its last demons. Do you know how long it has been since I did? More than *years*.”

“You didn’t gain a new level since defeating King Balaur?” Victor asked. “How many demons did it take?”

“Plenty,” she chuckled. “The rest of the elves accepted to become Jolie’s minions in exchange for being spared.”

“I gave them ribbons!” Jolie said. “Elf kittens are adorable with ribbons.”

Vainqueur never understood the appeal of those grasshoppers among his kind. But he was interested in the strange, green liquid his niece consumed. “What is this?”

“It’s green herbal tea from the Jade Empire, further east,” Kia explained. “I heard rumors their emperor sought guidance from a wise dragon.”

“Of course, who but a dragon could properly lead a country?” Vainqueur said although he wondered why his kindred hadn’t become emperor himself. He must have been too occupied growing his hoard. Jolie gave her uncle a large bowl, allowing him to taste—and spit out—the drink. “Argh, it tastes like grass!”

“Tea is made with herbs, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor said.

“Do you have cow milk?” Vainqueur asked his niece, who shook her head. “Sheep blood then? Any meat juice?”

“Have you found the Apple?” Manling Victor asked his kindred while Vainqueur complained about the lack of edible drink, who shook her head. “So Melodieuse still has it. That spells trouble.”

“Unfortunately, she could be anywhere in the world. Unlike most fomors, she can pass for a human easily enough even without magic.”

“She smells like the rest of her fairy kind, no matter how she looks,” Vainqueur replied. “I will eat her after this Blue Rose Legion. I will avenge slights in order of personal importance.”

“Thank you, my liege,” Victor replied with obsequiousness. “I’m glad to hear you put my actual death right behind your fake one.”

“That is because I care,” Vainqueur replied with a satisfied nod.

“Since she’s obviously planning against Gardemagne, and now your country, Melodieuse will probably make the first move,” Kia said. “Nostredame told me her magical might surpassed his own, so she is not to be underestimated.”

Vainqueur snorted. That fairy had hidden behind her minions, the same way Maure had. He was not impressed.

“I will protect you, Kia,” Jolie promised the knight, apparently having grown fond of her as much as Vainqueur liked his chief of staff. “I will not let a fairy touch your strange head hair!”

“Thank you, Jolie. Likewise, I shall be your sword and shield.” Kia turned to Victor. “So you’re going to challenge the Tower of Sablar? Not without me.”

“Yeah, I would welcome extra muscle,” Victor said, “The place is too dangerous for the other minions.”

“It was the magical superweapon the cult of Sablar used to turn the old elf empire into a monster-infested desert,” Kia nodded. “It is full of powerful elementals, magical entities, golems, undead—”

“No liches,” Vainqueur said.

“Mummies. My old party and I considered challenging it before the final battle with Balaur since it contains ancient, powerful artifacts, but we never got around to it.”

“Uncle Vainqueur, can I come?” Jolie looked at her uncle with her big teary eyes. “Pleaaase?”

“Of course, Jolie,” Vainqueur nodded, eager to impress his niece with his adventurer know-how.

“Thanks!” Jolie said, approaching her head from Knight Kia. “Kia, you are so beautiful and strong and kind. Do you want to become my chief of staff? Pleaaaaase!”

Vainqueur gasped, as Manling Kia *hesitated*. She looked at Friend Victor for guidance, the Doer of the Thing madly waving one finger to encourage her. “Jolie, I am very honored,” Knight Kia said, “but I cannot accept.”

“But I will put golden ribbons in your hair, and cuddle you!” Jolie pleaded. “We will be as close as uncle and Manling Victor! We’ll go on great adventures and rescue princesses together!”

“How dare you refuse my niece’s offer?” Vainqueur angrily browbeat Manling Kia, “Look at her. Look at her! She is the second most beautiful dragon in the world after me! Her scales are like rubies, and her eyes shine like gold!”

“I am very honored,” Knight Kia remained obstinate in her mistake, “But I am a knight and your friend, not an assistant. Sorry, Victor.”

“Manling Victor! Defend your profession’s honor!” Vainqueur ordered his minion.

“It has its perks when you get used to it,” his lackey said, which wasn’t the passionate speech his master had hoped for.

In fact, it didn’t convince Knight Kia. “It’s nothing against you, Jolie. I consider you a friend, but I value my independence and dignity more.”

“Your *dignity*? What greater honor can a dragon bestow upon a manling, besides making them their prized chief of staff?” Vainqueur complained. “My niece is too good for you, Knight Kia. You disappoint me *so* much.”

“I will let you ride on my back!” Jolie insisted, making Vainqueur freeze in shock. “Like you do with your griffon!”

The Knight’s jaw dropped, as did Manling Victor’s. “Ride your back?” Kia and Vainqueur choked both at once.

“Yes! You will swing your sword while on my back, and I will roar ‘RAWR’ as I fly! Please, accept!”

“Riding... a true dragon’s back...” Knight Kia said nothing, glancing at her griffon, who glared back with jealousy. “I... I...”

“Jolie, no!” Vainqueur pleaded with his niece. He knew she was in a teenage rebellion phase, but this went too far! “You will confuse the minions about the food chain if you allow them to ride you!”

“Uncle, that is a backward mentality!” Jolie replied. “Allowing a minion to sit on your back is the true progressive attitude!”

“No, the proper way to socialize with a manling is to constantly remind them of their place; this ensures that they grow into responsible minions. Look at Manling Victor! Thanks to my proper guidance, he went from a purposeless thief to a half-dragon!”

“Oh, Kia can become half-dragon too?” This only encouraged Jolie. “A dragon riding a dragon would be *awesome!*”

“I... I am tempted but...” Knight Kia shivered at both her mount and Vainqueur’s glare, but her species shameful obsession with dragon riding prevailed. “Under one condition.”

“Yes!” Jolie answered.

“NO!” Vainqueur roared.

“I do not want to be subservient to someone else, so... I will become your chief of staff if you become my squire... and let me ride on your back.” Knight Kia’s griffon let out an angry roar at the betrayal. “I’m not abandoning you, Twilight! I will still ride you, I swear!”

Squire? Vainqueur remembered where he had heard that word, back in his first adventure with Manling Victor. “A squire is a kind of minion!”

“So, you will become my minion, if I become your minion too?” Much to Vainqueur’s horror, Jolie actually considered the terrible, insane offer.

“That way, our relationship shall be that of equals,” Kia said. “We become partners, instead of master and servant.”

“And by becoming a squire, she could take levels in a Knight class,” Minion Victor said, making his master aghast.

“Minion Victor, do not encourage her!”

“What? Now that the cat is out of the bag, at least she should choose a good class.”

“No niece of mine will ever become a minion!” Vainqueur insisted. “Jolie, if you let this... perversion of our ancient dragon institution happen, I will stop gifting you princesses for your Bragging Days!”

“But, but...” Jolie began to cry. “But Uncle...”

“No uncle, young dragonling,” Vainqueur resisted this attempt at playing on his feelings. She would thank him for this when she grew up and matured. “The minion, or the princesses.”

Jolie tearfully looked at her uncle, then at Knight Kia, and finally back at her uncle.

Hopefully, she had seen reason.

“She lets her ride on her back,” Vainqueur said, crestfallen. “On her *back*, Manling Victor. Like a *wyvern*.”

He watched Knight Kia ride his niece like a horse, as the two dragons flew through that damn desert searching for the dungeon. The sight of Jolie wriggling as Knight Kia raised her blade under the sun, reveling in her perversity, disgusted him.

“My niece...” Vainqueur kept complaining. “My niece, ridden by a manling...”

“Which you never allowed me to do,” Manling Victor complained, following his master.

“And never will!” Vainqueur roared back. “See, this only encourages that kind of unreasonable comment!”

“Your niece is truly the Rosa Parks of dragonkind,” Friend Victor replied, although Vainqueur did not understand the reference.

“The world must not know,” Vainqueur ordered his minion. “You will keep this... this... *this*, quiet, until I can convince my niece to see reason. I trust you not to reveal this secret, alongside that of dragon mortality.”

His chief of staff shrugged, as a great structure came into sight; Vainqueur briefly mistook it for a hill before approaching it further. Half buried into the sand, a twisted pyramid of black stone loomed over the dunes, dwarfing the Castle of Murmurin in size. A crimson crystal, which Vainqueur recognized as fairy work, shone at the tip of the structure.

The dragon may have considered this place as a nice lair, if it didn’t smell of fairies, dead elves, and ghosts.

“Here is it,” said Manling Victor, paling at the sight. “The Tower of Sablar.”

“Manling Victor, this is not a tower,” Vainqueur replied. “This is a pyramid. I can tell the difference.”

“Maybe the builders had a different name for it, I cannot say,” his chief of staff replied, while Jolie and Knight Kia circled the pyramid looking for an entrance. “I heard it reached the stars at its height.”

Another manling lie. That pyramid did not even reach the clouds.

As he watched his lackey fly, a thought crossed Vainqueur’s mind.

“Manling Victor, since you have wings and a tail, can you now breathe fire?”

“I never could figure out how,” Manling Victor replied. “I think I may need more levels in [Monster Knight] before I can achieve it.”

“Guys!” Knight Kia shouted at them, Jolie having stopped flying in front of the pyramid’s left side. “Look!”

Vainqueur followed, and squinted. His niece faced a huge, dragon-sized hole in the pyramid. “I’m pretty sure this is recent,” Knight Kia said.

“This is concerning,” Manling Victor said. “A monster escaped from within? No, the stones point to something getting in.”

“See, Jolie,” Vainqueur taught his niece. “This is how I conquered the castle of the evil Furibon; by making a path instead of playing by the lich’s rules.”

“My minion read me your book!” Jolie said happily. “The wealthy always win!”

“Indeed we always do,” Vainqueur replied, flying into the hole to enter the pyramid.

Whoever had gotten there had done it the dragon way; crushing anything its path, smashing through walls, tossing marble elf statues to the ground, leaving only ruins in its path. Mosaics representing scenes of slaughter and mass manling sacrifices had been defaced, pillars overturned...

As he landed on the dusty ground and observed the chaos, Vainqueur couldn’t help but frown. The one responsible had demolished the decorations like a savage beast, even those which would complement his hoard. Reptilian and corpse-like creatures, whom the dragon assumed had been the minion keepers of the area, had been frozen in blocks of ice and stuffed on display.

“Wow,” Manling Victor said, as Kia climbed down from Jolie to join them. “I think we’re late to the party.”

“It must have happened yesterday,” Kia replied after examining the scene closely, frowning. “Wait, have I missed a big battle *again*?”

Frozen minions... a beast with absolutely no artistic taste...

Vainqueur’s eyes widened as he realized who caused this. “No!” he shouted, rushing through the destroyed pathway while ignoring the others. “NO!”

Within seconds, he reached a large, rounded vault, which must have been the treasure room. The invaders had stripped it of everything of value, of every last coin; leaving only dust, a bandaged corpse, and a message painted on a wall in old dragonian.

‘Guess who got here first and grabbed all the gold?’

‘With love,

Your social better,

Icefang.’

Chapter 40: Tomb Trouble

“This means war!”

The pyramid trembled, as Vainqueur’s roar echoed through the treasure chamber. In his fury, his tail hit a wall and caused it to shake.

“Your Majesty, calm down!” Victor pleaded before he could collapse the place on them.

“Ah, that takes me back,” Furibon said from within his scythe. *“I should not rejoice at the sight... but I do.”*

“You, shut up,” Victor replied, while Jolie attempted to calm her uncle.

“Uncle, we can still find new treasure—”

“This is not about the treasure!” Vainqueur roared back, his niece cowering at his outburst. “This is a personal insult and challenge to my authority as the first, and greatest, dragon adventurer!”

As Vainqueur loudly declared the Third War of the Hoard on Icefang and ranted about his grievances to his niece, Victor noticed that Kia remained eerily calm. She was busy examining the mummy left behind by icefang, ignoring the dust falling from the ceiling.

“The mummy hasn’t risen,” Kia said, after finishing. “They plundered the pyramid’s treasure room, but no mummy rose.”

“So what?” Victor asked, before catching on. “Oh, I get it. If it was a dungeon’s true treasure room, then the corpse would have attacked or cursed the invaders.”

“The Tower of Sablar was said to reach the skies, and this pyramid is smaller than other dungeons I visited,” Kia replied. “The bulk of the structure is probably below us, with the room serving as a decoy to deter foolish intruders.”

Icefang must have called it quits after grabbing the first batch of gold he could find; meaning there could still be treasure left behind. How did he know Vainqueur would loot it soon afterward though? Something didn't feel right. “So there may be a secret passage, either in this room or the next.”

Kia nodded, examining the walls Vainqueur hadn't smashed. Strange hieroglyphs covered the murals, representing scenes of elves prostrating before a giant worm as it moved to eat the sun. Victor recognized the iconography as the symbols of Sablar, the worm god of time, destruction, and earth.

Allison had told him Sablar's worshippers took over the elven empire which ruled the continent, before drying it out. The magical cataclysm they caused wiped out their entire civilization.

Could the pyramid be only the tower's tip, with the rest buried under the sand?

A picture, so small that almost no one would notice, caught Victor's attention. A skeletal beast surrounded by icy, chilling winds, whispered words to a pharaonic figure. An immense, pointed tower overshadowed them, the creature looking at it with a malicious grin.

“Vic, can you read the pictures?” Kia's fingers trailed on dust-covered runes. “I don't know the elf language.”

“That is not elven,” Furibon said from within the scythe. *“That is R'lyehan.”*

The tongue which the Moon Beast used? In that case, Victor tried his hand at reading it, translating the words out loud thanks to his Perk. “The password is: Wormlike Apple.”

The second he ended his sentence, Victor was swallowed by a flash of violet light. He had left the treasure room for... somewhere else. A place filled with such thick darkness, that he couldn't even see his own hands.

"[Death Candle]," Victor cast, a ghostly will' o wisp materializing in front of him, and illuminating the room.

A dark, closed room crawling with animated corpses.

Victor immediately raised his scythe to find himself surrounded by eight undead knights three times as tall as Kia herself; monsters wearing heavy armor thick enough to resist artillery fire, and massive swords which could easily cut horses like cheese. These monstrous beings glanced down at him, their crimson eyes shining in the darkness.

"A trap room," Furibon guessed, taking pleasure in his 'owner's' impending trouble. *"I had one but your dragon master smashed through it."*

"Guys?" As no one answered, Victor readied his scythe, ready to defend his life. "You want a piece of me? Come at me!"

But they did nothing.

The knights stood there threateningly, observing him as if he were a prop.

"Hello? You aren't going to kill me." No answer; the knights didn't even move an inch. "Hello? Can you understand me?"

No answer. Either they didn't care, or more likely, couldn't.

They weren't sentient. Fearsome automatons, but vulnerable to his [Deadfriend] Perk nonetheless.

"Okay..." Victor didn't question his luck, glancing around in case the stone room had murals with other trick passwords; it didn't. "Why didn't Kia and the others follow? I blurted out the code out loud."

“You must say it in their native tongue,” Furibon said. “Your Perk translated your words into R’lyehan, but your friends will not have the same privilege.”

Come to think of it, why hadn’t Vainqueur summoned him back to his side? This being a trick room, maybe it blocked teleportation effects?

He would have to find his way out. Bugger. Victor walked out of the room through the only gate, the dead warriors leaving him be.

Victor found himself in an underground maze of stone stairs and corridors, kept in much better shape than the levels above. His will o wisp familiar provided him with much-needed light, guiding him around.

Rusted, steel golems dusted off the various rooms like workers, while undead warriors patrolled the area. Victor guessed that no sentient creature would stick around keeping a silent tomb after the first century, leaving only mindless automatons to defend it.

Unfortunately for the owner, time hadn’t been kind to the guards. Most of the golems had fallen into a state of disrepair, enough that some had collapsed and now crawled with their arms. Their design reminded the visitor of Rolo, and he figured the golem may have come from this stock.

While the defenses could have easily taken down any invader in their early days, Victor’s group could probably force their way through.

“Hey, can you point me towards the exit?” Victor asked one of the undead guardians, which ignored him. “Furibon, is there a necromancy spell which could take them over?”

“I would teach it to you if you had the tier level needed to cast it. These are Tomb Defenders, among the most powerful kind of undead to exist. A group of them could swarm and overwhelm a dragon.”

Victor doubted they could take down Vainqueur unless in large numbers, but decided not to linger long, in case their programming could overcome his Perk.

After twenty minutes of wandering around the tomb though, he realized this would be easier said than done. The dungeon had many rooms, all of them identical and lacking in anything other than walls and space. He began to cut marks in the stone to note his path, and quickly realized he had walked in circles.

“Where is the treasure?” Victor wondered. “Hell, where are the decorations? Who would build a tomb containing nothing but stone?”

“You think the tomb of a cult worshipping entropy would care about post-mortem materialism?” Furibon taunted him. *“Followers of Sablar do not value anything that does not come from the earth.”*

“Wait, you knew this tomb might have no treasure? And you said nothing?”

“I hoped that you and that dragon would die for nothing, is that too much to ask? Also, have you tried the second room on your left?”

Victor glanced in that direction, finding a room he hadn’t marked yet. He stepped inside, finding it to be slightly different from the others.

For one thing, a black sarcophagus laid in the center, covered with worm symbols and purple gemstones. Murals similar to those of the fake treasure room adorned the walls, alongside decorations such as canopic jars on pillars and scimitars.

One of the decorations contrasted starkly with the others by its brightness: a golden shield covered with gemstones, attached to the wall in front of the sarcophagus. Victor’s [Eye for Treasure] immediately identified it as a [Crest].

“Trap?”

“Trap,” Furibon replied.

Victor first glanced at the sarcophagus, in case it was a mimic or some other dangerous device. He warily knocked at the surface with his scythe, remaining at a respectable distance.

When no mummy rose to kill him, Victor turned to look at the crest, poking it with his scythe. Instead of causing the roof to collapse or the like, he received a notification.

Use [**Crest**] to break the Class ceiling?

“Uh, sure?” Victor said, expecting the item to break his level cap. Instead, the shield vanished with a flash of light, making him tense.

Crest used! You can now progress up to level 60!

For using a [**Crest**], you gained the [**Crested**] Personal Perk.

[**Crested**]: You moved up from ordinary adventurer to folktale hero. You can now access more prestigious classes.

No sooner did the Crest vanish, than a stone door closed the exit, trapping him inside.

Victor panicked, as the sarcophagus began to open from within, with a loud, squeaky sound. A chilling wind filled the room, bony, bandaged fingers seizing the edge of the coffin.

His scythe acting as his only protection, Victor found himself staring back at the most terrifying mummy he had ever seen. A monstrous creature clad in old, dusty green robes, with bones made of black obsidian. The bandages holding them together were scrolls covered with hieroglyphs; a funerary mask hid its skull save for two glowing lights in place of the eyes. The entity radiated malice and sorcerous power, the invisible pressure it released dwarfing even Melodieuse's.

Victor immediately activated his Monster Insight Perk, to find the creature's weakness. He was already fighting in an enclosed space, so he needed any advantage.

Akhenapep

Black Pharaoh (Undead/Eldritch)

Weak against Spirit, Life, and Holy.

Strong against pretty much everything else.

The great calamity of a previous age, and one of the superbosses of Outremonde. The Prophet of Sablar who ruled the southern continent from behind the scenes, before destroying it with a magical superweapon. Can cause sandstorms and quakes, raise armies of the dead, and kill you with a mean look.

Recommended party level to take him on: mid-80s.

Run, Forrest, run!

Mid-eighties? That was more than fifteen levels above Kia's, let alone Vainqueur and him!

"Trespasser," the powerful being spoke with heavy words, the magic in his words making the room tremble. "Is it time to end the world?"

"No!" Victor blurted out in panic.

"Oh?" The ancient mummy sounded... confused, the power in his voice gone. Before Victor knew it, his confusion turned to annoyance. "Then scram, fleshbag."

The ancient terror laid on his back and closed his sarcophagus.

Victor stood there, astonished by the absurdity of the situation before Furibon drew him out of his trance. "*Run, you idiot!*" the lich said, panicking. "*Before he changes his mind and destroys us both!*"

Following the wise advice, Victor immediately attempted to bolt the hell out of the room, but the stone door hadn't risen back up. He examined the hieroglyphs, searching frantically for any password which could teleport him out.

Unfortunately, before he could find a switch, the sarcophagus opened up again, Akhenapep rising back from it; a lot less dramatically this time. The

mummy's glowing eyes peered at Victor with a hawk's focus.

"Wait, fleshbag," the mummy spoke, all the gravitas of his previous tone replaced with curiosity. "If this is not the end of the world, why are you there?"

That was a very interesting question... Victor's mind worked furiously to find an excuse, the Black Pharaoh was clearly not very patient.

"Speak, fleshbag."

"I was... checking up if everything was fine!" Victor lied through his teeth. "See if you were still there and ready for the big day!"

"Ah." The mummy pondered his words, seemingly believing him. Victor thanked the gods for his Perks and their charisma bonus' against monsters. "It is true that I have not woken up for centuries, but as you can see, I am perfectly fine."

"Yes, indeed," Victor nodded. "Since you are indeed perfectly and dangerously unalive, I will take my leave."

Charisma check...

Failed!

"Why the rush, fleshbag? Have you not faced many traps and guardians to reach me in the first place? Unless you have come for..." The mummy suddenly noticed the empty spot where the Crest used to be, "*other* reasons?"

Victor could have sworn the pressure had grown tenfold.

The Black Pharaoh quickly raised a hand, casting a spell faster than the chief of staff's brain could compute. "[Epic Magic Scan]."

It took every ounce of willpower for Victor to keep a straight face, as phantom text appeared in front of the mummy. The pharaoh began to mutter something to himself, draining information from him at an accelerated pace.

“Victor Dalton. A strongly chaotic shade of neutral.” It seemed legalizing necromancy and the Nightblades pushed his karma from goodish to chaotic. “A Red Dragon Monster Knight... Reaper, very good... and... Grand Vizier of the V&V Empire, and prophet of the Moon Man?”

Victor kept his mouth shut, as did Furibon, while the mummy finished reading his scan, the words vanishing. “Fleshbag, why is the Grand Vizier of some remote empire visiting my tomb?” the monster cast a quick spell to punctuate the danger, “[Greater Detect Lies].”

Okay, so... no trickery.

Maybe half-truths could work. He didn’t have to say the full truth, just avoid lying.

“I have come to search for the mythical artifact called the Bottle of Mot,” Victor admitted.

The mummy nodded to himself, unsurprised. “I see how it is,” the superboss said. “Necromancer, why did you not tell me your real reasons for waking me up?”

Play along, play along, play along! “Because you’re intimidating, and I thought you would think me for a thief. I had a terrible time last time this happened.”

“I may be intimidating, but you will never usurp your emperor with this attitude. Nor do I recommend it yet. You may be just starting, or I assume you are considering your low level, but your mindset leaves much to be desired. I do not share my advice with every would-be cultist who knocks at my door.”

...

Come again?

“It is not enough to wear robes, manipulate an emperor from behind the scenes, and steal souls to become a true Grand Vizier,” the mummy

continued. “You need a special mindset. You cannot imagine the number of advisors cut down by pesky paladins because they wanted to be emperor in place of the emperor; instead, you should make your emperor a powerless figurehead, so your enemies will blame him instead of you. Thus you can justify claiming power by removing an ‘evil ruler’.”

The mummy sounded very *patronizing*, like talking to a child, but Victor didn’t dispel his misconception.

“Patience is the mother of victory. Your time will come. What matters is not to appear in charge, but to be. Step by step. I assumed your soul familiar would have taught you that.”

“Victor has much to learn,” Furibon said with an obsequious, servile tone, eager not to contradict the almighty mummy. *“But he is rash and rarely listens.”*

“The student’s faults lie with the teacher, and I detect a lie in your sentence,” the pharaoh rebuked the lich. “How many countries have you conquered yet, fleshbag Victor?”

“One,” Victor quickly replied, the mummy clearly *unimpressed*. “But we’re just getting started!”

“Then clearly you need guidance. This should be the moment where self-righteous gods like Mithras or Seng empower a group of knights and peasants to cast you down. They have done so for centuries, and so they are very good at it. So you must be better, starting with the basics. Do your empire’s legions have face-concealing helmets?”

“Uh, no?”

“Good. Does your lair have air vents a gnome could crawl through?”

“No,” Furibon replied, before pausing. *“Do secret passages count?”*

“There are secret passages in the castle?” Victor asked. “Why didn’t you tell me?”

“Because I h—” Furibon caught himself. *“Because it wasn’t the time.”*

“You must do away with secret passages, except for escape routes,” the mummy said. “This is the second stratagem. Next is the third stratagem, *‘Become an only child.’*”

Victor wisely decided not to interrupt the creature, as it went on to deliver a full tirade about killing holy knights whenever possible, and the best methods to do so. The chief of staff hoped he could stall long enough for Vainqueur and the others to rescue him.

How long would it take?

Two hours later...

“Stratagem thirteen, *‘the rule of fire.’* If you kill someone, especially a cunning rogue, shoot the corpse with a volley of arrows to be sure, then cremate it. Finally, disperse the ashes to the winds. That way, they will not rise to bother you again, as an undead or second born.”

“Huh?” Victor asked, his curiosity getting the better of him. “Even if deities intervene? Asking for a friend.”

“The more savaged the vessel, the harder the task, even for gods. Undead are cheap to make with the corpse intact; dispersed ashes are harder. Now, stratagem fourteen, *‘the law of no last request.’*”

Seven hours later...

“Stratagem fifty-two, *‘No secret passages.’* Have architects check your lair for any secret passage you do not know about, then collapse them.”

“But...”

“No secret passages,” the pharaoh cut off Furibon. “One closely guarded route for emergency escape, and nothing else. A secret passage *will* be found and used by enemies to infiltrate your lair. Collapse or booby trap them, or both.”

“Both?” Victor asked, scribbling notes on a scroll the mummy provided from his bandages.

“Have the passage collapse on the intruder when they reach the end. Then unbury the corpses, shoot them, then cremation. If one fleshbag is missing, assume it escaped.”

“That is brilliant,” Furibon said, impressed. *“Why did I never think of it?”*

Twelve hours later, after a passionate lecture about political intrigue, conquest, managing minions, public relationship, magical research, and architecture...

“And so, that is why the fleshbags must be provided with an endless stream of mindless entertainment, so they stay docile. Cats are good. Cats are distracting. When the helpless masses realize you intend to conquer and then destroy the world, it will be too late.”

“Amazing,” Victor admitted, so enthralled by the lecture he no longer had to struggle against tiredness. So many ideas! “What about assassin rings?”

“As said in stratagem forty-four, only employ those who fight for money, so long as you can outbid the competition. Those who fight for fun give the enemy sporting chances or turn on you when they can no longer rein in their murderous impulses.”

“But what if, hypothetically, the treasure is guarded by an immense dragon and cannot be used?”

The mummy pondered the question like a philosopher pondering a complex problem. “Offer them nobility titles. Do not ask them to work the land. Killers do not want to farm, they want to kill. A dog is a dog, not an ox. Each fleshbag in their place.”

“Like what Gardemagne should have done with the Scorchers,” Furibon added his viewpoint.

“The lesson is to avoid mercenaries and make them vassals instead. Make them work for more than money.” The mummy nodded to himself, satisfied with the seminar. “This covers the ‘One Hundred Stratagems of the Grand Vizier’.”

Congratulations! For following a retired evil overlord’s seminar, you received the **[Vizier Education]** Personal Perk!

[Vizier Education]: You gain a +8 Bonus to your INT when dealing with manipulation, strategy, statecraft, magical research, or plotting against your liege.

“I got a Perk,” Victor said. “[Vizier Education]?”

“Good. You have listened.”

“Were you a vizier?” Furibon couldn’t help but ask, the mummy nodding. *“I thought you were the last elf pharaoh?”*

“I was. How do you think I *became* a pharaoh? I wormed my cult into the upper echelons of the empire’s structure, corrupted it from within, then created this great tower to dry out the land in Sablar’s name.” The mummy cackled with malice. “I still remember my ‘master’s’ face when he realized the truth too late.”

Yeah, the centuries in his tomb hadn’t dulled out his evil. But Victor was aware he lacked the power to confront that monster yet, and so kept his mouth shut. “So, um... thanks for the lesson?”

“You are welcome. Seeing you, all eager to plunder magical artifacts for power, reminds me of my lost youth.” Akhenapep searched inside his sarcophagus, before handing Victor a beautiful, blue ceramic bottle covered with dust. “Here is the Bottle you were looking for. My minion is still inside.”

Victor blinked. “Your minion?”

“Yes, Mot, my minion. The key to keeping him in check is to constantly remind him of his lowly status, in every conversation you have with him. Or else he becomes rebellious. I have no longer any need for his services, so I bequeath him unto you. If you are smart, you will never grant him his freedom. Now go.”

“How?” Victor asked, pointing at the closed door.

The mummy looked at him as if he were an idiot. “Ask Mot,” the undead replied, before grabbing the edge of the sarcophagus, “Now, fleshbag Victor, I wish you good luck, as one vizier to another. Tell the other cultists that I am fine, and that I will rise on apocalypse o’clock.”

“Uh, sure, I will.”

“Anyone else interrupting my nap ahead of time, I shall kill.”

“Definitively will.”

The mummy closed the sarcophagus, and Victor could have sworn he heard snoring noises coming from within.

Congratulations! For befriending and tricking an ancient dark lord back to sleep before he could cause havoc, you earned two levels in [**Monster Knight**]! You gained the [**Slayer of Men**] Class Perk!

+60 HP, +20 SP, +2 STR, +1 VIT, +2 SKI, +1 AGI, +2 INT, +2 CHA!

[**Slayer of Men**]: Your armed attack always count as [Manslayer] and inflict double damage to creatures of the Humanoid type.

“Does that bottle contain what I think it does?” Furibon asked.

Only one way to find out. Victor pulled out the bottle cap, a stream of black smoke erupting from it.

A small, tiny creature popped out; a bluish, miniature horned goblin with golden eyes.

“AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAGHH!”

The small genie let out a horrifying wail, making Victor step back. “What the—What the *Happyland*?”

“Hundreds of years trapped in a BEEPing *bottle*!” The genie replied, as his screams turned to tears of relief. “I’m out. I’m finally out. It’s over... I have space now... space... oh, gods... hundreds of years...”

Well, things just became a lot more complicated.

Chapter 41: The Djinn in the Bottle

“SURPRISE ATTACK!”

Invisible thanks to his blinkblink ring, Vainqueur unleashed a mighty poke at a golem, turning it into scrap. His finger felt sore, having felled dozens of these puppets since he began searching for his missing minion.

So he switched hands, crushing an undead minotaur with his right index finger claw.

The tunnels had grown smaller and tighter the further underground Vainqueur smashed through, eventually leading them to an underground, crumbling mausoleum. The number of suicidal monsters eager to die to him, however, had only increased. Bandaged mummies, skeletal fighters, and clay golems had emerged from hidden chambers to swarm them.

Vainqueur would have loved nothing more than burning them with his breath but lacked the space to do so without harming his niece or take flight. What was it with architects refusing to make areas sized for his kind?

At least each of these warmups left a treasure behind, from gems to golden rings. Vainqueur’s [Born in Purple] Perk had returned to him, much to his joy.

Knight Kia, who had finally let go of her dragon-riding obsession to fight on foot, cut through hordes of ancient undead warriors like butter. Her sword shone like the sun, empowered by a glowing aura. Meanwhile, Jolie swallowed a bandaged elf corpse with her mouth, letting out a belch.

At long last, Vainqueur finished smashing the last of the golems, the mausoleum turning silent.

Congratulations! You earned a level in [**Gladiator**].

+30 HP, +2 STR, +1 VIT, +1 AGI, + 1 CHA, +1 LCK.

“It’s getting harder as we go down,” Knight Kia said, sheathing her sword.

Harder? No, tiresome, especially since he only got a level out of it. Vainqueur looked at the exit, finding it smaller than the previous. He could barely slip his neck through!

“They get tastier,” Jolie said, her belly full of dusty undead meat. “Dry food is the best food!”

“I am not squeezing through a dusty tunnel again!” Vainqueur complained; he already had sand sullyng his claws. “I will make a bigger one!”

“Your Majesty will collapse the whole floor on us if you do that,” Knight Kia protested.

Vainqueur grumbled. While he would undoubtedly survive it and didn’t care if Knight Kia didn’t, he wanted to protect his niece.

“MINION!” Vainqueur shouted. “MINION! Get back here! I am not digging further down!”

Charisma check failed. You could not overcome the anti-teleportation effect.

“No one is more charming than I am!” Vainqueur replied. “Revise your poor judgment! Minion! MINION!”

His chief of staff popped up among his new treasures, a bottle in hand and with a new goblin minion.

“Ah, minion, here you are!” Vainqueur rejoiced, the system having finally recognized its mistake.

Both his minion and the goblin looked around, Vainqueur realizing that he hadn’t negated his invisibility. “Blink,” he said, revealing himself in his full

glory, the blue critter speechless at the sight.

“Vic, good to see you alive!” Knight Kia rejoiced almost as much as the dragon, before noticing the bottle the half-dragon carried. “You have found the artifact?”

“Yep, and here is Mot,” Friend Victor pointed at the goblin following him. Seeing a dragon for the first time had floored the critter, who glanced up at Vainqueur in silence. “I see you didn’t waste time.”

“When you teleported away, Vainqueur broke the ground which revealed pathways down,” the knight told him. “We have gone down seven floors since.”

“There’s a dangerous mummy waiting at the bottom, Akhenapep,” Friend Victor said. “He’s *very* tough. In the eighty level league, according to my Monster Insight. I managed to talk him out of killing me, but the next one to wake him up will not share that mercy.”

“This mummy is just as dangerous as King Balaur.” Knight Kia sounded excited at the thought. “I knew there was something worth fighting down there. I will bring my whole party to finish him off.”

“King Balaur?” the blue goblin, Mot, asked. “The first dullahan? He is still around?”

“Kia killed him,” Manling Victor said, the goblin’s eyes widening in surprise.

“Pff, he was only the second calamity of this age,” Vainqueur replied, puffing his chest. “Neither can this mummy compare to me.”

“Oh, it is an elf mummy, right?” Jolie asked, salivating at the thought. “Where does it make its nest? Does it have friends?”

“At the bottom of the dungeon, in a hidden crypt,” Manling Victor said. “Since Mot wished me up, maybe he can help us skip the floors.”

“No I cannot,” the blue goblin said. “No wish can negatively affect the creator of my bottle, Akhenapep. I cannot wish him away, teleport armies to his doorstep, or cause the tower to collapse. You will have to fight your way through.”

“Also the tunnels are too small for dragons,” Friend Victor said. “Unless we polymorph Your Majesty and his niece into smaller shapes somehow.”

“Like what, a manling?” Vainqueur asked.

“Yes?”

...

...

...

Vainqueur erupted into laughter until he struggled to breathe, making Manling Victor frown. “Good... good one, minion. Seriously, I am not clearing out a hundred floors again. We have the bottle, the quest is finished, and we need to get my new shinies back to my hoard. Time to claim my reward.”

“About that,” Manling Victor frowned. “The quest giver forgot to mention the *content* of the bottle.”

“You said Mot wished you up?” Knight Kia asked. “Is it a genie in a bottle?”

“Yes, phenomenal cosmic powers and all, although not limitless.”

“What kind of goblin is this?” Vainqueur asked, smelling the creature. The scent seemed disgustingly familiar but too faint for him to remember why.

“I am a djinn,” the goblin replied, “I grant my master’s wishes.”

“Like a chief of staff?” Vainqueur asked.

“Yes, except this one is blue,” Victor replied with his strange flat tone.

“I can grant any wish from the owner of the bottle, within limits,” said Mot.

“Like only three wishes?” Victor asked.

“You can make as many wishes you want, Master Victor, but I can only fulfill yours.”

“A minion’s minion?” Jolie asked, looking at the goblin with her big, curious eyes, much to his discomfort.

“If someone wants to become my master, Master Victor has to transfer ownership of the bottle or be killed for it. Now that I think of it, if my master gets killed and then revived, maybe it would count as ownership transfer...”

“I am not paying millions to raise Manling Victor again,” Vainqueur brushed the creature off. “What wish can you grant, chief of staff of my chief of staff?”

“You don’t want me to transfer ownership to you?” Friend Victor asked, ever eager to please his master.

“I am too good to claim my indebted minion’s hoard for myself.”

“What wish can I grant?” Mot repeated. “Good question. But a better question would be, what wish can I *not* grant? My powers are great, but they cannot overcome those of the gods or powers which rival my own. Neither can I affect the entire world. A city I can manage, but nothing bigger.”

“Can you turn a city into gold?” Vainqueur asked, suddenly very interested.

“Certainly, but no take-backsies. I cannot wish a previous wish away. I can make a wish which can counteract the effects of a previous wish though if you word it nicely. Finally, I cannot kill anyone directly, and no time-travel.”

“Okay, let’s make a deal right there,” Manling Victor said. “I’ve read the stories of your kind, and it would be better for everyone if you didn’t twist the meaning of our wishes.”

“I would never do that, Master Victor,” the goblin replied with a grin. “But what do you propose?”

“If you grant the wishes without nefarious side-effects, I will let you out of the bottle all the time, and I will consider wishing for your freedom.”

“I’m not comfortable with the *considering*, Vic,” Kia said with a frown, while the genie listened with a stone-cold face. “He’s a *slave* trapped in a bottle.”

“Knight Kia, he is no slave, but my minion’s minion,” Vainqueur replied. “It is the second most pleasurable experience his kind can ever know, after being my direct minion. He is free to do as I wish.”

“I accept your kind offer, Master Victor,” the genie said, showing his teeth. “In fact, I will gladly continue to fulfill your wishes after you free me, out of the kindness of my heart.”

“Yeah... no offense, but I don’t really trust you right now,” Victor said. “I’m not releasing you until after probation. Also, the quest giver Barsino wants the bottle.”

“Yes, only the bottle,” Knight Kia pointed out. “We can give it to him after releasing the genie first.”

“I’m pretty sure he wanted the full wish-granting package.”

“Master, what can this quest giver provide that I cannot top with a wish?” the genie asked, eager to stay with the better team.

“Exactly!” Vainqueur said. Minion subcontracting at its finest! “Tell me where these cursed adventurers are, now!”

The genie looked up at Vainqueur, then turned to Manling Victor for a translation. “Mot, I wish to learn the location of the members of the Blue

Rose Legion, a disbanded adventurer company from Barin.”

Mot snapped his fingers, a scroll magically appearing in his hand. He opened it, revealing a map of the continent and other landmasses that Vainqueur did not recognize. Four red crosses formed on the paper, dispersed across the world, a name picture above them.

“Each cross is one of them,” Mot said. “I took the liberty to have them move on their own with the target, master.”

Manling Victor grabbed the map, frowning as he examined it. “They’re pretty far apart.”

“That one, Dextra, is in the Gardemagnian city of Noblecoeur,” Kia said after glancing at it. “But the others are in other countries. The fallen Harmonian League to the east, the Winter Kingdoms to the north, and the vampire kingdom of the Nightlands.”

The Winter Kingdoms. Icefang’s dominion. “Minion, summon them to this room,” Vainqueur ordered. “So that I may eat them.”

“They are too far away, and most too well-protected magically, for me to forcefully teleport them here,” Mot said. “I cannot teleport someone from across the world against their will.”

“What about teleporting us to them?” Manling Victor asked.

“Oh, good idea,” Vainqueur nodded. “Can you teleport us back to my hoard as well? I do not want to burn fat by flying on the return trip.”

“That wish I can grant, but I cannot teleport an entire army to their doorstep.”

“I recognize one of the names,” said Knight Kia, after examining the map more closely. “Garland Renoir, a high-level Scorcher. He and his mercenaries managed to escape to the east before the Shining Crusade could catch him. He still has a hefty bounty on his head.”

Good. Vainqueur would get paid doing something he would have done for free. But first... “Manling Victor, can your chief of staff wish for a Crest?”

“I already found one down there, but good question,” Manling Victor turned to his goblin, “Can you create a crest? Maybe a legendary one?”

“Trust me, Master Victor, while I so dearly wish I *could*,” the genie said, grinding his teeth. “I cannot affect the Class System in any way. No free Crests, nor level, nor magical stat boost.”

“Then can you—”

“A powerful divine magic protects Crests from being located through supernatural means,” the genie interrupted Manling Victor, frustrated with the subject. “I am sure that part was intentionally meant to screw my kind over.”

“You are disappointing, minion of my minion,” Vainqueur told the djinn.

“Your Majesty, please don’t mock my debt-solving plan,” Manling Victor replied. “Mot, you can create gold from nothing, right?”

“Ah. Ah, yes, wealth is easy. Magical items too.”

“I can erase my debt!” Manling Victor said, before frowning. “You can create magical items?”

“Vic, this may be the reason Barsino wanted it in the first place,” Knight Kia said, although she frowned suspiciously at the genie. “While not all that powerful, Mot’s powers have great military applications.”

“Not all that powerful?” The genie glared back at the paladin. “Half of my limitations are because of this damn bottle! If you want real power, you will have to free me first.”

“Can you summon princesses?” Jolie asked.

“Jolie, there is no bragging in having a princess delivered to your lairstep,” Vainqueur reprimanded his niece. “You have to work to catch them!”

“But I want to have a princess tea party! I will put ribbons in their hair, I will wear a hat, and then we will laugh while putting our claws on our mouth!”

“In any case, genie or not, V&V is already unstoppable,” Vainqueur replied. “Who won the two Wars of the Hoard? All I hear is that Friend Victor is now ready to start paying back his debt. Come to me, my chief of staff.”

Manling Victor approached, Vainqueur putting a finger on his tiny head. “I, Vainqueur the Great, Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains,” the dragon declared, “bestow upon you the everlasting blessings of my golden Dynasty!”

“This doesn’t make any sense—” Manling Victor shut up, as a light surrounded him.

Through your [**Dynasty**] Perk, you granted a [Noble] level to your chief of staff.

Due to your minion’s status, his [Noble] class evolved into [**Grand Vizier**].

“Now, Manling Victor, ask your minion to bring us home. I shall issue my first wishes atop my ever-growing hoard.”

“So what will it be first?” Manling Victor asked. “Turning Icefang’s treasures to snow?”

Vainqueur gasped in horror at his chief of staff’s ruthless suggestion, as did Jolie. “Minion Victor, I cannot do something so horrible to a dragon, even my hated rival. He shall be humiliated, but I will first use my wishes responsibly. I shall start by destroying one of the greatest threats to dragonkind everywhere.”

“Fairies?” Jolie’s head perked up, as did the genie.

“No,” Vainqueur shook his head. “A foe more terrible, more insidious, more nefarious.”

The dragon marked a dramatic pause, as all eyes looked up to him, before raising a fist to the ceiling.

“I, Vainqueur, will wish for the extinction of *lead*, until the end of time!”

Chapter 42: Interlude: God Game Night

The Crossroads.

Such was the nickname of Outremonde across the cosmos, for Earth's twin was exactly that: a crossroads between various planes of existence. Heaven, Hell, the Elemental Planes... each had at least one gate leading to that world, hidden somewhere.

Ever since they had agreed not to make war on Outremonde directly, the twelve gods had each created a plane of their own and retreated there. Sometimes, they even shared one, such as Mithras and Leone's abode in Heaven.

Among the most feared deities of Outremonde were the Dread Three, the godly triad of death, crime, and war. The collective nemesis of the shining Mithras, whom they opposed as mortals, the trio ascended together and remained friends even after divinity. When they gathered, blood was shed, wars started, plagues unleashed...

"Strike! It's a strike!"

But more often than not, they just played games.

Camilla, goddess of death, vermin, darkness, and plagues, teleported into the Game Room to find other deities entertaining themselves without her. "You have started without me, traitors?"

An open space under a starry night sky, with the 'ground' made of clouds whom the gods could shape at will, the Game Room was the place where

the Dread Three had fun, whether together or with guests. Her teammates hadn't waited for her and started playing Shooting Star with the Moon Man and Dice.

The rules were simple: throwing comets at the heavens above and trying to hit something. Planets counted as more points than suns, since they were harder to hit.

"First strike!" A humanoid crow, the god Deathjester never left his home without his crimson harlequin costume—it helped hide the blood. Countless souls wailed from inside his scythe. "Which world did I hit?"

"Karcosa," Veran said. The dwarven goddess of flames, war, and machines hid herself beneath heavy, tank-like battle armor of her own design. Stilts allowed her to stand shoulder to shoulder with her comrade. "Jesty, don't get your hopes high. We're playing with uninhabited planets."

"Oh, phooey," Deathjester said, disappointed, before turning to welcome Camilla while the Moon Man narrowly missed a sun. "Hey, Cam! You're finally here!"

The goddess crossed her arms and glared at her old teammate. A dark elf vampire with skin black as night in life, crimson eyes, and white wavy hair, Camilla dressed in a form-fitting black dress with a low backside, which enhanced her voluptuous figure. She always had fashionista tendencies while a mortal, making up for Deathjester and Veran's lack of style, and the trend continued as a deity.

"Come on, don't give me that face, we're just starting," Deathjester replied, before returning to the game. "Why were you so late anyway? You finally introduced AIDS to Outremonde?"

"For the thousandth time, I will not." Camilla rolled her eyes. She liked her mortal lovers too much for that, and she preferred supernatural diseases like vampirism. "And that was private business."

"I've been thinking all day," Deathjester continued to vex her. "If a vampire makes love to a living mortal, does it count as necrophilia?"

“You’re in an awfully disruptive mood today, Jesty,” Veran replied, forming a meteor in her palm and throwing it at some solar system. Her comet missed the star by a huge margin, making Deathjester laugh. “Damn you, sun!”

“Of course I feel happy,” the harlequin replied. “There hasn’t been this much chaos on Outremonde since the Century War! So many laughs!”

“Indeed.” The last guest, the goddess Shesha, made herself known by teleporting in the room. “So many new opportunities.”

Everyone already knew what, and who would be the talk of the night.

“Shesha, good to see you. Have you finally considered sponsoring the Undead Labor Trade?” Camilla asked, ever the politician eager to advance the cause of undead rights. “With the new policies of the V&V Empire, the Undeathstrial Revolution can no longer be stopped.”

“I am still on the fence, considering the nefarious long-term side-effects of necromancy,” the greedy reptile replied. “I decided that I will neither support nor condemn the trade. I leave to my worshipers to make the choice themselves.”

“So each of your churches will decide on their own?” Camilla pushed, knowing she could convince a few to work with her.

“I don’t micromanage,” Shesha confirmed. “It decreases productivity.”

“Work, work, work,” Deathjester complained, as the game ended in a decisive victory for him; none of the other deities had an aim worth a damn. Especially Dice, who didn’t have arms. “Relax, it’s game night!”

“Are we waiting for someone else?” Shesha asked.

“Nope,” Deathjester replied. “I sent Mithras an invitation card with ‘Nightlands’ written on it. He didn’t answer.”

Camilla laughed alongside her friend. As the deity of the sun, Mithras had never accepted that a vampire nation bordered his cherished Gardemagne. It

didn't help that the monarch, Orlock, had... peculiar beliefs as far as the sun god was concerned.

"Seven or so chapters to wait," the Moon Man said, eyes turning towards him. "Mmm? What did I say?"

Deathjester shrugged, before crafting a table and chairs from the clouds. As the game master for the night, he invited the deities to sit.

As usual, only half the Pantheon attended the game. The more self-righteous gods, Mithras, Leone, Isengrim, and Cybele, preferred to play among themselves; and Mithras and the Dread Three couldn't stand being in the same room anyway. Seng, the goddess of the sea, freedom, dreams, and alcoholism, usually got drunk with mortals while incognito.

And nobody in their right mind invited the destructive Sablar to that kind of game, *ever*.

Camilla sat between Veran and Deathjester, while Shesha sat between Veran and the Moon Man. While the same height, the gods would have appeared as giants to any mortal walking into the room, hills sitting around a plateau. Only Dice had elected to ignore the chair and hop on the table itself.

Camilla greatly enjoyed these opportunities to meet with her fellow deities. As the goddess of undeath, she did everything in her power so that her followers never passed on, allowing them to remain as ghosts, ghouls, or vampires. She thus had very little company in her realm, and usually resorted to hanging out with mortals in disguise.

"Okay," Deathjester began, summoning a vividly precise, animated board map of all of Outremonde on the table. The design on the board took a life of its own; mountains of stone rose from the paper, the oceans of ink began to flow, and the names of the various cities of the world shone above key points. "Tonight folks, we play Outremonde Civilization."

"Wartime edition?" Veran pushed. "Haven't had a good one since the Century War, and I was too late for the Murmurin-Ishfania conflict. I want to test my new war golem on the field."

“It will be for the next game,” the Moon Man said, before rambling. “When the four are one.”

“No prophecies!” Veran shouted, but the ancient star abomination couldn’t help himself.

“Steel boots will trample marble ground, as purple roses show their thorns. Blades in the night, shields of darkness, and bloodstained roots.”

“Great, just great,” Veran sighed. “I guess I will figure out what you meant in a year or so.”

“Aw, my friend, trying to figure it out is half the fun,” Deathjester replied, ever the optimist. “The other half, screwing destiny over.”

“No war,” Shesha said. “War is bad for global trade.”

A true warmonger, Veran insisted further. “But there are still fomors all over the world. Just a crusade, to finish them off. Or a border conflict. I can settle on one.”

“Veran, don’t be greedy,” Camilla told her teammate. “You introduced gunpowder and artillery through your Claimed champions last campaign.”

“I want to try new stuff!” Dice said.

“You dominated the Century War Campaign,” Deathjester added. “Learn to share, Smally.”

“Pfft, you say that because you have a field day with all the bandits and political assassinations that followed the war.”

“As Shesha usually says,” Deathjester cackled, “business is booming.”

“Look, the fomors are dead set on exterminating the mortals, and they don’t have souls to feel regrets,” Veran stubbornly clung to her position. While a warlike deity, she wanted her worshipers to rule a populated world, and not a silent grave. “I say we will never be safe until we wipe out every last one

of ‘em. That Mell Odieuse is the new King Balaur, with teats. The best crowd control is death.”

“She is protected by Sablar,” Shesha pointed out. “The fomors are in no position to try anything big for at least another century, and the nations of the world are exhausted. It would be better for mortals to use the respite to build.”

"Yes, and Vainqueur Knightsbane will probably confront her," Deathjester added, "Which my intuition tells me will be a very entertaining conflict."

“Who is up for a more peaceful campaign this time?” Camilla raised her hand, everyone but Veran doing the same. Well, Dice hopped, which still counted as a yes. “Sorry my friend, you are outvoted.”

The dwarf crossed her arms while pouting.

The rules of Outremonde Civilization were simple. Each god could affect that world through three methods: guiding their followers, from priests to inquisitors; summoning Claimed champions or through their sphere of influence. While the gods could visit the mortal world, they held to a strict non-intervention policy after the last war between them... although everyone cheated when they could get away with it.

During War Editions, they usually set their worshipers against the others. The Century War had turned into one when the vile Sablar sponsored the fomors in their destructive rampage across Mistral, forcing the deities to settle on summoning and guiding champions to turn back the tide. Veran had had a field day using the war as an excuse to introduce new technology to the Mistral continent.

Overall, though, it had been a tense, brutal campaign. The mortals of Mistral had had a real chance of being wiped out, and only streams of summoned Claimed had turned the tide against King Balaur.

“First, before we begin, I want to address the flying elephant in the room,” Deathjester said. “*Dragons*. As you all know, thanks to Vainqueur Knightsbane, long may he live, dragons have started to take levels, which is

awesome and spices the game up, but also opened a whole can of worms. I think I know everyone's opinion on it, but I got to ask: do we lift the ban on dragon reincarnation for this session?"

"No!" everyone said almost at once.

"Dragons are forbidden—" Dice added.

"Until the end of times, yes," Deathjester shuddered, alongside the rest of the deities. Camilla knew the god of crime had violated every single divine rule at one point, *except* that one.

"Thankfully, raw power alone won't be enough to reach Valhalla," Shesha shuddered. "Nobody wants another... *Incident*..."

"Jesty laughed over it," Veran said.

"Yes, like at a joke so bad, so tasteless, it circled right back to good," the crow prince of crime replied. "Agreed then, no dragon Claimed allowed. Dragons priests are allowed though, alongside the usual divinely empowered classes."

"There are dragon priests?" Camilla asked, jealous she didn't have one yet.

"Yes, one dragon, Icefang I think, tried to worship himself to access the class. Obviously, it didn't work, but I wouldn't rule out a dragon paladin showing up." Deathjester closed his eyes while fantasizing about it. "I hope one shows up. Mithras would be so mad about it."

"I suggest we play an Age of Discovery campaign," Shesha came forward with an idea, the gods listening, "Sea monsters have made it impossible for mortals to cross the oceans... until now. Some civilizations, like the Teikoku, Barin, and the Thaoten Empire, have developed archaic flight; Maure created one functioning aircraft; and *dragons*. If last campaign's focus was a worldwide war, I suggest the next one be an age of adventure and exploration."

"Good idea!" Deathjester nodded. "I was getting sick of the Middle Ages!"

“I thought we were already moving out after the Century War,” Veran pointed out. “With the introduction of artillery, undead labor, and the new classes the system created in their wake.”

“Yes, but now we can enter the magitech renaissance,” Shesha said. “I trademarked the name. A new age of entrepreneurship, treasure hunting, and global trade!”

“And then culture clash will lead to more conflicts down the line,” Veran nodded. “I’m sold.”

“How much?” Shesha asked.

The Moon Man, who usually went along with everything when he didn’t rant, nodded happily at the suggestion. “I want to play discovery.”

“I agree too,” Camilla said with a sly smile. As the Thaoten were an undead empire worshiping her, she and her church had a considerable head-start in the campaign. She could spread her cult and the joy of undeath across the globe in no time.

“Roll me!” Dice insisted. “Roll me for new additions!”

“Alright, alright, democracy has spoken, this century’s theme will be the Age of Discovery,” Deathjester said. “We start with the Mistral continent, and Dice will take the first turn.”

The dice hopped happily, while the other deities exchanged glances. As magic and luck incarnate, Dice’s rolling sprees always drastically changed Outremonde. Deathjester had taken to letting him go first, so the other gods could plan around or after the fallout rather than before.

“Here is the state of the world...” Deathjester cleared his throat, before taking a deep, narrator voice. He always had a gift for theatrics. “The Century War has ended, leaving the Mistral Continent forever changed. The dread fomors, under the protection of Sablar, retreated to Prydain and the Dark Forest to plot further destruction. The Harmonian League and the Midgard Republic fell, absorbed by the almighty kingdom of Gardemagne,

the merchant empire of Barin, or the vampire theocracy of the Nightlands. To the north, the warlords of the Winter Kingdoms fight both dragons and each other for dominance. The wyrm emperor Vainqueur Knightsbane has conquered the land of Ishfania, renaming it the V&V Empire. While the war has ended, chaos and confusion reign. What do you do?"

"Roll for new magical weather conditions!"

"For each country?" Camilla winced in fear, as did Shesha. Both favored a specific country, the Nightlands, and Barin, respectively.

"Moon Man, since you have no favorite country, please roll the dice," Deathjester asked. The ancient moon beast grabbed Dice with a tentacle and threw it on the map.

Then the slaughter began.

"Barin, one! Global warming! Dry weather and fiery winds! Winter Kingdoms, four, cool weather and strong hail!"

With each roll, Dice introduced new effects on the map. A fiery sirocco moved towards Barin's dominions in the south, much to Shesha's frustration, while ice shards shredded the north of the map.

"Gardemagne, ten and seventeen! Nice summer to the south, acid rains to the north!" Deathjester cackled at the result; soon, clouds began to unleash green ink on some areas of Mithras' beloved kingdom.

"Nightlands," Camilla winced, as Dice landed one its fifteenth face. "Fifteen, rains of blood!"

The vampire goddess sighed in relief, as crimson rain drenched her beloved vampire country. Luck smiled on her.

Which left only one country...

"V&V Empire, twenty!" Dice sounded overjoyed at the result, introducing an unknown weather pattern to Outremonde. "Rain of slime!"

Tiny green clouds formed above the former Ishfanian territories, raining slime creatures like water. Camilla hoped Vainqueur and his troops were hungry, because they would have a jelly feast for a meal.

“None of these are natural weather patterns!” Shesha protested. “You cannot rain jelly!”

“I’m a god, I don’t have to make sense!” Dice replied. “I say rain of slime!”

By the end of the turn, all of the continent’s weather had been altered for the season, Dice leaving the permanency of the changes to chance.

“Who wants to go next?” Moon Man raised a tentacle at Deathjester’s question. “The lord of madness has it. For fairness, we will play in a clockwise turn, and I will close the Mistral round. Moon Man, what do you do?”

“To confirm, I heard I had a prophet,” the Moon Man said. “Does this mean I have a cult?”

“Yes, for the thousandth time, you have followers,” Camilla replied, annoyed. The Moon Man forgot he had a religion almost every session, to the point he had the smallest pool of worshipers.

Sablar had more. When you were less popular than the *god of destruction*, you had to ask yourself questions.

“In that case, I order all of my followers to travel to the Moon.”

A short silence followed the declaration. “Come again?” Deathjester asked.

“We’re playing Age of Exploration,” the Moon Man replied calmly. “I ask my followers to brave the one true frontier, space. They will join my children on the Moon so that we can shake tentacles in harmony.”

“Wow, you’re skipping a *lot* of intermediary steps there.”

“This is great!” Veran had taken the declaration in stride. “I can introduce magical missiles in fifty years top!”

Deathjester sighed. “Will that be all?”

“My one true prophet shall lead my flock to the stars,” the alien deity added. “I have spoken.”

“Hasn’t Dice claimed that one first?” Veran asked. “You too, Shesha?”

“He’s *easy*,” Shesha replied, who had claimed him too. Somehow, the way she worded it implied another thing entirely.

“Shesha, you go next,” the crow prince of crime said. “Even if it will be hard to top the Race to the Moon, what do you do?”

“I order my church to invest in overseas travel,” Shesha said. The most calculating and practical of the deities, she favored logistics over flashy displays of power. “To bolster the age of exploration, I increase the reward for exploring undiscovered areas. Since the monster-hunting market is overcrowded by the new dragon competition, exploration will become more lucrative.”

“Boring, but nice,” Deathjester commented.

“Then, I introduce paper currency to bolster the economy, starting with—”

“Already done.”

Shesha made a short pause. “What do you mean, already done?”

“Manling Victor, Grand Vizier of Murmurin, is already plotting to introduce paper clips as the official currency of the V&V Empire,” Deathjester replied. “It hasn’t been made official, but they started using mimics to print it. Emperor Vainqueur gave it the go, since he thought it would make less gold for manlings and more for him.”

“How do you know that, Jesty?” Camilla asked, Shesha considering the news. “Have you been infiltrating that country?”

“Please,” Deathjester pleaded guilty. “I have eyes everywhere.”

“I knew that place would be interesting,” Shesha said. “I increase all of my church’s investments in the V&V Empire, and I end my turn.”

The next player was Veran, who, as usual, began her turn by ordering her worshipers to destroy the sun and Mithras. A would-be warlord trying to conquer the surface while a mortal, the Dread Three began when she hired Camilla and Deathjester, then freelance necromancer and assassin respectively, to assist. While the invasion failed, they had bonded over killing knights and stuck together as adventurers afterward.

“Next, I introduce a new kind of monster to Outremonde: the Lava Golem.” As Veran spoke, a miniature of the monster, a monstrous titan of magma, manifested at the edge of the map, “Expected level to take on: fifty. Then, I special summon a Claimed with knowledge of making AK-47’s in the Winter Kingdoms.”

A small, dwarf-shaped wooden piece appeared on the north of the map.

“Why are you summoning a person who can create this weapon in the country with the least resources to build it?” Shesha frowned.

“Because they are the most likely to use it,” Deathjester replied. “They have a big dragon problem.”

“About that, since dragons are now getting stronger, I think it’s unfair for everyone else,” Veran added. “So I create and distribute new Dragonslaying loot items all over the world, and I inspire my clergy with the knowledge of how to forge more. I end my turn.”

“As if it will do them any good,” Camilla said with a knowing smirk, as her own turn began.

“Cam, will you introduce new undead again?” Deathjester asked, hopeful. “I suggest the dracolich. Please, take the dracolich.”

“Lich is a class, Jesty, not a spontaneous condition,” Camilla reminded her ally. Not that it worried her. Considering how fast dragons leveled up, it was only a matter of time before one succeeded.

What could she do though? Unlike Deathjester, who reveled in his terrible publicity, Camilla didn't consider herself evil; she thought the world would be much better when everyone could enjoy mortal pleasures as an undead, instead of passing on. She had pushed for the legalization of necromancy, and after centuries, her wish had finally been granted. At this point, she only had to encourage and preserve the trend.

"Everything is already going well for me this session," she admitted.

"You're not skipping your turn, are you?"

"Of course not, Jesty. I have my church officially recognize the V&V Empire; support their undeathstrial minion pension plan; and generalize it among my followers. Everyone will now gain the possibility to rise as a sentient undead, against a donation."

"Would you be open to multi-religion bundles?" Shesha proposed.

"Of course, but undeath will remain a fundamental right for everyone, as the key to happiness," Camilla replied with political-mindedness. "I will not budge on this."

"Cam, Cam, you're mistaken," Deathjester said. "The secret of happiness is to kill everyone who makes you unhappy, and then one day you will be dead for good too."

Camilla smiled back at him. In spite of failing constantly, the assassin always maintained a positive attitude; he had never given up on his dream to kill Mithras, even after failing dozens of times. "Believe what you want, Jesty. I end my turn."

"Which leaves me," Deathjester hung back in his chair. His friend knew that the cunning rogue had arranged to go last, so he could see the others' strategy first.

Which the trickster immediately moved to disrupt.

“I command the winds, to redirect the brunt of the weather changes towards Gardemagne,” Deathjester said. “Can’t have my new favorite country suffer from slime depredation for too long. Then, for karma’s sake, I order my followers among the Nightblades to claim any dragonslaying weapon they can and distribute them to bandits across the world. Finally, I activate my trap.”

Another piece of wood, this time human-shaped, appeared right next to Veran's own.

"I special summon a Claimed of my own in the Winter Kingdoms, and I order him to murder yours, Veran.”

“What?” The goddess jumped on her seat. “Why?”

“Because of too many guns. And on these wise words, I end my turn.”

And that was only the first continent.

They had seven more to go.

Chapter 43: Fool's Gold

It was raining jelly this morning.

Victor knew that there were moments in the life of a man, where the world didn't seem to make sense. His life had stopped making sense long ago, so he only bothered with raising an eyebrow at the sight.

He had been busy mimic-walking Vainqueur Junior around town with a chain leash when it started. Colored clouds appeared out of nowhere, before raining green, blue, red, and white jelly monsters. Puddle-sized creatures of colored goo landed on the houses and the ground, each looking like a blob with two vitreous eyes. Victor used his [Monster Insight] Perk on a blue one, which released some residual electricity around itself.

Thunder Jelly

Type: Slime

Strong against Physical, Water, Acid, and Electric.

Weak against Earth and Magic.

A young slime with the ability to generate bio-electricity. While incredibly weak and vulnerable to most spells, their body makes them immune to physical attacks. Often used as dungeon cleaners or pets by bigger monsters.

The other slimes seemed to have different elemental affinities; the bodies of the red ones seemed perpetually on fire, the green ones dissolved matter on contact like acid, and a chilly frost followed the whites.

“Interesting, a new magical weather,” Furibon said from within the scythe; by now Victor always carried it around for safety reasons. *“Is it the start of a slime season?”*

The slime let out screeching sounds which Victor translated as crying.

“Babies?” Vainqueur Junior said, with a hint of concern and affection. Oh, yes. Victor had forgotten Mimics were Slime-types. These creatures were Junior’s distant cousins.

Victor figured that in *any* other city, a rain of monsters would have been cause for alarm, but the citizens of Murmurin took it in stride. “Free food!” a gnoll merchant rejoiced, immediately moving to capture the slimes in bottles.

“Sweet, fire-starters!” a werewolf transformed into monster form to grab a fire jelly, probably to use it in his chimney.

Instead of the defense of a village against a monster army, the event quickly turned into a slime hunting party. Even Victor participated, albeit reluctantly, as his pet strained against its chains and forced him to move around.

“Babies!” Junior shouted as it grabbed the crying jellies with its hands, putting them on its back. The scene reminded an amused Victor of a mother hen putting chicks on its back for safety.

It was a pretty fun moment, if stressful, as Junior seemed intent on rescuing more slimes than the other citizens could capture. How long would that rain last—

“MINION!”

Victor found himself teleported to the temple district, leaving his chained pet behind to meet his master. Unlike the rest of the city, this area, located closer to the mountain, didn’t suffer from the rain yet.

“Minion!” Vainqueur angrily pointed a claw at the new Temple of the Twelve Gods under construction. The Church of Shesha, careful of the local population, had brought mostly beastkin workers from abroad to build the place, overseen by dwarf engineers. Built on a hill next to the volcano, the final design would put Haudemer’s cathedral to shame.

“It’s the new temple,” Victor replied. The place was nowhere near finished, with only the main walls raised. “Why, you want it gone?”

“It looks taller than my statue in central square!” Vainqueur complained, incensed. A crowd of monsters and workers gathered nearby to look at the giant dragon. “No way this merchant con’s statue can overshadow mine! Fetch me Mot!”

Here we go again, Victor thought with a sigh, grabbing the bottle around his belt with his free hand which carried Junior’s chain beforehand. “Mot, come out.”

The genie appeared in a puff of white smoke, his expression sorrowful upon seeing Vainqueur. “Oh.”

“Minion of my minion, make the biggest statue of me that you can!”

“*Another* statue?” Victor could see the light in Mot’s eyes slowly dying out with each new wish, replaced by the familiar, empty gaze of a jaded veteran of Vainqueur’s antics.

“But one made of rubies this time,” Vainqueur clarified. “So it looks crimson like my scales. Make it taller than that temple.”

“Mot, please create a pure ruby statue of His Majesty,” Victor said, sympathizing with the creature. So far, Vainqueur had mostly used the djinn for whimsical demands.

The genie let out a heavy sigh and snapped his fingers. A giant representation of Vainqueur slightly smaller than the Statue of Liberty, made of the purest rubies, stood in front of the new temple. It would have

been an amazing, impressive sight... if Mot hadn't represented the dragon ready to take flight with an arm extended like Superman's.

Obviously, Vainqueur was too enamored by his own image to find the subtle ridiculousness in the sight; and the crowds were too amazed by the impressive display of magic to laugh at it.

"Make a smaller statue of my chief of staff next to it," Vainqueur added. "Onyx for the clothes, and lapis-lazuli for the skin."

"Do you have *any* use of my phenomenal cosmic powers outside of landscaping and making money?" Mot asked, increasingly frustrated.

"No," Vainqueur replied bluntly.

The genie made an exhausted face. While he had taken reimbursing Victor's debt in stride, Vainqueur's demands had slowly eaten away at his enthusiasm.

"A dragon does not rule a city full of dung," the Emperor declared. He had gone on a wishing rampage after visiting Murmurin for the first time since his month of seclusion, due to finding the place sub-par. "His land must be as shiny as his hoard!"

Victor had to admit that Vainqueur may have a hidden talent for architecture. After wishing away all lead in his dominion—Mot turning it to gold—Vainqueur had used the genie almost exclusively for landscaping: creating extravagant marble-paved roads, adding golden dragon statues on every street corner, and overall transforming Murmurin into an impressive capital worthy of a dragon emperor.

"I wish to rule a city of gems," Vainqueur ordered. "The shiniest place in the world!"

"Is that an actual wish?" Mot asked with a frown, Victor nodding. The genie let out a heavy sigh; like a condemned criminal resigning himself to his death. "I will grant it."

“I will leave you both to your landscaping,” Victor said. “I have to catch Junior before it does something stupid, and then meet with Kia at Allison’s place.”

“Minion, I changed my mind,” Vainqueur said with a serious voice tone. “I do not want you to breed with Knight Kia. She is a terrible influence on my niece, and she will be one on you too.”

“It’s fine, I’m taking someone else out to dinner tonight. Hopefully for the last time.”

“Good, we shall go return the bottle to the quest giver tomorrow,” Vainqueur declared, surprising both Victor and the djinn.

“You will?” Mot’s head perked up in joy. “You truly will?”

“A dragon does not go back on his word,” Vainqueur replied with pride. “I said I would return the bottle to its owner, and I will. He shall get the bottle, and we shall keep you, Minion Mot. You shall never stop working for V&V, I swear it!”

If there was a picture for ‘absolute despair’ in the dictionary, Mot’s face would have had to be the top pick. Victor absentmindedly used [Monster Insight] on him, in case his species had some tricks up its sleeve.

???

The same result as Melodieuse. Maybe his Perk only worked on lower level monsters?

But then why could it work on Vainqueur himself?

Mmm...

After returning Junior and its newly adopted slime litter to the castle, Victor flew to Allison’s place. As Rolo’s mechanic, she shared a house with the golem and recently agreed to let Barnabas settle in her workshop. From outside, their workshop looked like a mad scientist’s haven, with robot parts littering the ground alongside gears, reservoirs of oil, and forging tools.

He found Kia waiting for him in front of an open garage, Allison, and Barnabas the troll tinkering with Rolo's gears. "Sorry I'm late," he told the knight. "Got a few problems with the rain. I think we caught most of the slimes."

"I know," Kia nodded at a glass lamp above the garage's entrance. A sleeping red slime provided the light. "They're strangely cute for blobs of goo."

"Do you think we could produce an electric current with enough of them?" Victor asked, unsure if other countries had tried to tame them.

"You would need a lot of them, and they remain wild monsters," Kia pointed out. "A few alchemists tried to domesticate them, but most turned to powerstone study after the initial failures."

Then again, most civilized species lacked Perks useful for dealing with monsters, such as Victor's [Monster Student]. If he had managed to tame something as alien as Junior, Victor thought he could still make use of the creatures.

"I haven't found anything on djinns," Kia said, as Allison and Barnabas finished their check-up of Rolo, the golem flexing his arms. "You would think a species capable of granting wishes would have more lore about it."

"Yeah, I wanted to do more research on his kind before wishing for stuff, but Vainqueur hated lead too much to listen." At least he convinced the dragon not to wish anything too spectacular or sensitive for the moment. "I don't trust him. Vainqueur wants to return the bottle to Barsino, and that would help us fact-check that map."

"I cannot say if it would be wise to give the djinn to Barsino or not," Kia admitted.

"Isn't he a hero of the Century War?"

"Yes, but he only supported Gardemagne because he saw an opportunity to claim territory for his country. I met him once, and he struck me as cunning

and charming, but also as an opportunist.”

Still better than Melodieuse. Thinking of her... “By the way, I asked Mot to locate Melodieuse, and he came up short.”

“So she is either using a pseudonym or blocking his power?” The paladin sighed. “Of course that would be too easy.”

“Thanks, Barney!” Allison thanked Barnabas, as they finished working on Rolo.

“Been thinking about testing these new Agarthan gears for a while,” the troll grumbled. “Advanced design, but shoddy work.”

“I feel as good as new,” the golem replied, before bumping a fist to the heavens. “Nothing can stop Rolo now!”

“Hi, Vic, Kia!” Allison welcomed them with a bright smile, cleaning her oil-stained hands with a towel. “What’s up?”

“I’m looking for love,” Victor joked.

“In my garage?” she deadpanned back, Kia chuckling at the scene.

“Well, I gotta start somewhere,” he replied, before turning to Rolo, “I visited a tower full of golems recently.”

“The Tower of Sablar? That takes me back.” So indeed, the golem Farmer had come from that place. “I received my first Crest when I managed to fight my way out of it. Is the vile Akhenapep still sleeping at the bottom?”

“I’m looking for supplies to help kick his ass,” Kia confirmed, glancing at Barnabas. “Do you have any item effective against ancient mummies? Like rings protecting against Earth-based attacks?”

“I can forge an [Amulet of the Sandstorms],” the troll replied, eager to create new magic items. “High resistance to the Earth and Wind elements, immunity to the [Sandstorm] weather and its debuffs, and immunity to Curses.”

“The Pharaoh enjoys the benediction of Sablar, for his crimes against nature,” Rolo warned Kia, Allison frowning at his words. The poor state of Ishfania and the rise of Brandon Maure had been a direct result of Akhenapep’s magic. “Time effects do not affect him, and magical protections never resist him for long.”

“I’m not attacking that monster until I have the team assembled and the perfect set-up,” the experienced knight reassured him.

“Do you have information on his abilities?” Allison asked her golem friend. “You worked for him before achieving sentience.”

While Rolo, Allison, and Kia discussed Akhenapep’s abilities, Victor turned to Barnabas. “I’m also looking towards upgrading my arsenal. Items which could help me heal Vainqueur in a fight.”

Vainqueur had the physical part covered, but had no means of regenerating health. Since Victor could never match his master in sheer firepower, he thought he would better learn how to support him; and thanks to his new Perk, he should get a nice discount.

“Money first,” the troll said. “You’re indebted.”

“I was,” Victor replied, before presenting him his purse, full thanks to Mot’s wish. “Here’s more than enough to satisfy you.”

The troll blacksmith glanced at the coins but refused them. “Nah, I don’t accept fairy gold.”

Victor blinked at the same time as Kia and the others, at the mention of fairies. “Come again?” the vizier asked.

“I don’t take fairy gold,” Barnabas replied. “It is either cursed, fake, or blood money.”

...

Uh oh.

Victor connected the dots. [Monster Insight] did work on dangerous monsters.

The Perk just didn't recognize *one* specific kind.

"Vic," Kia quickly unsheathed the sword. "Mot is *not* a djinn."

Because djinns didn't exist in Outremonde. They were another name for...

"Damn!" Victor immediately rushed outside, Kia, Allison, and Rolo following him. With all the wishes he granted for Vainqueur, it was only a matter of time before—

"AAAAAAAAAAAAAAAAARGHH!"

Before Mot snapped.

His frustrated scream echoed through the city and with it a foul purple light. "[Greater Blessing]!" Kia immediately cast on herself, surrounding herself with a golden aura...

But the purple blast canceled the spell at once, instantly turning her and Allison into gemstone statues. Only Victor and Rolo remained unaffected.

Of course, Mot would take out the woman who defeated Balaur first.

"Allison!" Rolo paused in fury, before rushing towards the source of the scream.

The bottle's protective magic had protected Vic from the wish, and Rolo was an artificial creature with natural resistance to magic, but no one else was as lucky. As the two raced through Murmurin, they passed by citizens transformed into gemstone statues.

They found Mot in a devastated townsquare, busy materializing tons of gemstones atop Vainqueur and burying him underneath. The genie had already pinned the great dragon under a large pile of them, his Spell Purge unable to counter the effect.

"You like gems? You like gems?!" Mot snarled, with a twisted, maddened look on his face. The great wyrm would have easily crushed the 'djinn' in a fair fight, but he had been taken by surprise.

"MINION! Minion, stop—" Vainqueur shouted from under the enormous mountain of gems, more falling to drown his head. Even the almighty dragon didn't have the strength to lift so many precious stones at once; the tip of his tail waved outside the pile, showcasing the emperor's fruitless struggle to escape.

Mot glared at Victor and Rolo with contempt. "Ah, my 'master' and a traitorous golem. What a wonderful pair."

"Mot, what have you done?" Victor glared at the 'goblin.'

"Vainqueur wanted a city of gems," Mot said, with cruel glee in his empty eyes. "Now he has it. No more new statues!"

"Can't believe you lasted only a few days," Victor taunted him. "I maintained my sanity for months!"

"Yes, when bound to that bottle, I may look like you, a lowly slave... but deep down in my frozen heart, I know who I am." His voice turned deeper, echoing with the sound of freezing winds. **"An eater of men, the shaytan of legends..."**

The goblin grew and changed until Mot wasn't little anymore. His enormous shape, bigger than a mighty troll, overshadowed his 'master.' The creature seemed made of bones of ice, a skeletal eater of children with goat horns; the spine moved to attach itself to the bottle around Victor's belt as if only half the body was allowed out. Two blue stars shining with malice replaced its eyes, as it glared at the vizier.

"A fairy lord of the fomors."

"The destroyer of the land," Rolo grumbled with a hint of terror.

"You're the creature on the tower's murals," Victor recognized it.

“The Tower magnified my powers until Akhenapep could wish the land of the elves dry dead,” Mot said with a vicious kind of pride. **“When you have wished for my freedom, when I can strangle the mortal children myself, I shall lay waste to the land and finish what Balaur could not.”**

“Yeah, smart to tell me that, never going to happen now,” Victor deadpanned. “You should have played the long game. I would have released you if you had been on good behavior.”

“I intended to, but found something *worse* than being trapped in a BEEPing bottle and providing gifts to mortals against my will,” Mot said, glaring at the buried Vainqueur. **“Serving that dragon!”**

“I can wish for those turned to gem to become flesh again,” Victor pointed out.

“I will make flesh out of your statues, so they become alive and eat you,” Mot replied. **“Or I shall make everything flesh, from bones to brain. Any wish you shall make I will twist, no matter how you word it. Unless I am set free.”**

Yeah, no way in Happyland. But if Vainqueur’s own [Spell Purge] could not suppress Mot’s ancient magic, then only another wish could counteract the chaos. The genie must have had a weakness of some kind. “You can’t kill people.”

The monstrous fairy chuckled. **“You would be surprised by what I can make you live through. So? Deal, or agony?”**

An idea crossed Victor’s mind. “Okay. Let’s make a contract.”

“Yes, wish for my freedom, and I shall—”

“No, I mean a *written* contract.” Overseen by the few evil creatures as good at twisting words as a genie. “I’m calling my lawyers!”

Chapter 44: Lawfu Fight!

“Good morning, Mr. Victor, Your Majesty.” Malfy saluted the rulers of Murmurin, backed by two bug-like fiends in suits. The demon didn’t seem perturbed by the people turned to gemstones all around them.

“Hi, Malfy!” Victor waved back, inviting them to sit around a table Mot had conjured in the central square. The fomor glared at them with malice from the other end, his bottle in between them.

“Minion, I admit I have mixed feelings about the situation,” Vainqueur complained, his whole body buried under a mountain of precious stones next to the table. Only his head and waving tail jutting out of it. “I hate fairy tricks, but my current situation is even comfier than my hoard.”

“Why don’t you escape?” Victor asked. Since Mot couldn’t kill, Vainqueur could probably escape, if he tried to. Or so he hoped. Considering the genie’s malicious actions, the vizier had sent Rolo to attend to the trapped citizens around town, in case the wish had put them into threatening situations.

“That fairy being the greatest evil to grace my sight since Furibon, I cannot do so without melting or trampling the gems,” Vainqueur replied, knowing his priorities. “This is the perfect trap for a dragon.”

“As per our lobbying campaign, we will handle this on the empire’s behalf,” Malfy said, presenting his lawyers. “This is Mr. Nick, and his partner Mr. Scratch. They have defended innocents as respectable as the Wicked Witch of the West, Dracula, and Fantômas. They famously obtained a *dismissal in absentia* during the Jesus vs Judas case.”

“Self-defense,” one of the lawyers said. “The key is always self-defense.”

“Okay, so to explain the situation again, Mot here,” Victor pointed at the fomor, “can grant wishes but twists them no matter how hard I try to word them well. He caused all the chaos around here and wants me to explicitly wish for his freedom in exchange for returning Murmurin to normal. However, if set free he will be allowed to kill with his wishes, and of course, he intends to double-cross us.”

“Ah, I see,” the first lawyer, Mr. Nick said. “You want to draft an agreement where you keep all the benefits of the previous wishes, remove the negative effects, and ensure that there will be no repercussions.”

“I want to keep all of my statues,” Vainqueur specified.

“Standard Faustian case law,” the other lawyer replied, Victor not understanding their jargon. The fiend opened a briefcase full of documents. “We already prepared a first draft, according to your specifications.”

“Can I trust you not to screw us over with the wording of the wish?” Victor asked, just in case. He had already set up his strategy with Malfy before arranging the meeting, but they remained fiends.

“Mr. Victor, I take this unlawful fairy competition in our core business very seriously,” Malfy replied. “Mr. Mot also disrupted our plans and bottom line by petrifying Chocolatine. This is corporate war.”

Victor almost considered reneging on the deal to keep Chocolatine off his back but brushed off those thoughts.

“If I cannot take revenge on this country, I will settle for the death of every first-born,” Mot declared with mock kindness.

“First, we insist that you sign a non-disclosure agreement before beginning the negotiations.” The demon handed a document to Mot.

“He turned everyone for miles into gems, and you want a secrecy agreement?” Victor frowned.

“Dear client, I assure you that this is part of our perfectly calculated strategy,” the lawyer replied, Mot conjuring a feather and signing the NDA with frozen blood. “We will handle it.”

“Can it be done before this evening?” Victor asked. “I have a very important date then.”

“You consider me less important than a beastly woman?” Mot hissed, his pride wounded. **“Perhaps I should turn you into a monster at nightfall, so you can never find rest.”**

“I’m sorry, but I’ve died twice, once after being impaled by an even more psychotic fairy than you,” Victor replied. “After that, every threat feels like a letdown. Also, the joke is on you here.”

“I will not raise Friend Victor again,” Vainqueur repeated. “I almost died from a stroke last time.”

“The matter will be settled in time for your date with Lady Chocolatine,” Malfy promised, ever obsequious.

“I specify that ‘liberated from the bottle’ shall not be constructed as ‘liberated from living,’ as clause thirteen-five implies,” Mot said, pointing a frozen finger at the second paragraph of page eighty-seven. **“I want an addendum saying that I shall not be transferred into another container right after I fulfill the wish.”**

“Minion, I do not understand,” Vainqueur complained, as the fiends edited the text in response. “Are we winning?”

“I dunno,” Victor replied, but the lawyers’ frustration didn’t seem good to him. “How are things going?”

“His law-fu is powerful,” the first lawyer admitted, speaking low so Mot wouldn’t listen. “Very powerful. But we can do better.”

“I am about to do what mortals call a *pro-lawyer* move,” his fiendish partner said, dramatically cutting off a word and writing another.

“I change the introduction line from ‘*wish that you do*’ by ‘*wish that you shall*. ”

“But this changes the entire meaning of the text!” Mot protested.

“You have the right to keep silent,” the lawyer replied, the fiends at the table exploding into diabolical laughter. Victor merrily winced at their terrible sense of humor.

“And this agreement shall not allow, under any circumstance, the designated Mot, henceforth called ‘the wish granter,’ to torture, negatively impact, kill...”

“MINION!”

Vitality check successful! [Sleep] ailment negated.

“Ah!” Victor’s eyes snapped open before he could fall asleep.

“Stop lazing around!” Vainqueur said. “We are almost done!”

“We are?” The fierce battle of law, wits, editing, and contractual wordplay had lasted for hours until the sun had lowered in the sky; while Victor struggled to stay awake, the dragon had the willpower to follow the negotiations.

“We have agreed on a satisfactory four hundred pages compromise,” one of the lawyers said, presenting Victor with a massive pile of papers. Mot was reading a copy. “We are currently reviewing its terms.”

“The gist of it is this, the negative effects of the wishes will be removed, and the positives, such as your newfound full treasury and the emperor’s statues, will remain,” Malfy explained. “Mot shall be set free, but will not be allowed to do anything harmful to V&V’s members, allies, and subjects for the next fifty years.”

“You may live, but your kind will know death and suffering.”

“But I can still kill the fairy?” Vainqueur asked, eager for payback.

“Doing so will void the agreement,” the lawyer warned, while Vainqueur and Mot hissed at one another. “I would recommend that you make peace and forget this failed joint venture. Win-win.”

“I don’t call letting him kill the rest of the world while sparing us a fair deal,” Victor falsely protested, for the sake of his plan.

“It is not?” Malfy asked, genuinely confused.

“I would have preferred to kill you as well, manling,” Mot said. “But this is the best you will get. I am not budging on anything else.”

“I agree with my chief of staff, an outcome where I do not kill the fairy does not satisfy me,” Vainqueur said angrily. “I am a dragon. My kind won the dragon-fairy war, I must defend my honor.”

“What did you say?” Mot’s empty eyes turned into fiery stars. “You dragons did not win, we gave you gold so you would stop bothering us!”

“You granted us a gold tribute after your shameful defeat!” Vainqueur replied angrily, he and the fairy started to argue which version was the truest.

“Can you add an addendum where His Majesty and the fairy can duel each other without voiding the entire agreement?” Victor suggested to the lawyers, before turning to Vainqueur. If everything went according to his design, then it wouldn’t be necessary, but better safe than sorry. “Would that be alright?”

“Yes!” the dragon nodded. “Once the gems are safe and out of the way, nothing will stop me from feasting on his bones!”

“Fine!” Mot snarled back, as the lawyers edited the contract. “If you wish to join the cohorts of the dead, Vainqueur, I shall oblige!”

“There,” Malfy said, handing out the final versions of the agreement to both Victor and Mot. “If that is satisfactory, Mr. Victor, can you make your

wish?”

Victor faked reading out the front page, focusing on the empty space in between the sentences. “That sounds good,” the vizier said, while Mot nodded. “Vainqueur is going to kick your ass, djinn.”

“As if,” the djinn replied. **“Fifty years is the blink of an eye for a fomor, Victor. Your time will come.”**

“Then, Mot,” Victor read the first sentence of the contract. “I wish that you fulfill this contract in full, to the letter.”

“Finally, I waited so long!” Mot couldn’t restrain his glee, as he raised a hand to snap his fingers for the last time. **“Your wish, and my freedom, is granted!”**

With his finger-snap, Mot released a wave of magic which covered all of Murmurin; an energy pulse far mightier than the first one. Victor watched on with amazement, as the chaos around them ended as suddenly as it started; the petrified citizens turned back into flesh and bone, and the gem mountain keeping Vainqueur trapped split in two, as Moses did with the sea.

Much more worryingly, Mot’s spine escaped from the bottle, trailing a lower half with it. The skeletal fairy lord stood on two legs, dancing on his feet. **“Free, free!”** the creature rejoiced, unaware of Victor’s trap. **“Free at last!”**

“You will be free to see the insides of my bowels!” Vainqueur replied, the red dragon to extending his wings with a fearsome roar.

“If you like gold so much, dragon, gold you will be!” Mot snapped his fingers.

...

And nothing happened.

Vainqueur looked down at his claws, in case the transformation was gradual, before raising his head with smugness. “Hah! Puny fairy, I did not

even need a stat check to ignore your attack!”

“I said gold you would be!” Mot snapped his fingers a second time, then a third. **“Why is it not working?”**

“Because your magic is no match for me,” Vainqueur replied arrogantly.

“Actually, this is Mr. Victor’s doing,” Malfy replied, the lawyers nodding.

“You?” The chief of staff couldn’t suppress a sly smirk, as Mot glared at him. **“How? I checked the text for every loophole!”**

“I know,” Victor replied, Vainqueur having halted his threats to observe the scene, “While I hoped our lawyers might succeed, there was no way to trick someone as experienced as you with the wording alone. At best, they would bind you to a compromise we could have lived with. But I knew that as a cunning, paranoid genie, you would obsess on finding the complex loopholes in the text and miss the trap right on the front page. Letting you believe you could solve the aftermath with a fight wasn’t planned... but would have made for a nice back-up.”

The genie immediately grabbed his copy of the contract, checking the fine print of the first page for a loophole.

“I noticed something, back in the tomb,” Victor explained, as the genie failed to notice. “You couldn’t see Vainqueur due to his invisibility ring. That made me wonder if, in spite of your enormous power, you had limits. Since fairies are always bound by obscure rules in tales, I suspected fomors were no different. You had to end up trapped in a bottle *somehow*.”

“Your point being?” Mot asked, annoyed.

“You can’t see the invisible words.”

To punctuate his declaration, Malfy cast a spell on the contract.

“[Invisibility Purge].”

Words appeared in-between the sentences, a hidden wish addendum which the fairy had unwittingly fulfilled. **“After granting the wish detailed in**

this contract, the wish granter will lose *all* use of his powers,” the genie read out loud, shaking with anger, **“unless invoking the penalty clauses.”**

For a few delectable seconds, Mot remained mute in his shock and fury... and Vainqueur began to laugh.

“But... but...” the fomor let out a scream of frustration.

“Vizier stratagem fifty-four,” Victor said. “You will not double-cross a being stronger than you are. Instead, you will set up things so they screw themselves on their own.”

“I did not consent to this!”

“I wished that you fulfill the contract in full to the letter. It's not our fault if you didn't contest the invisible fine print. And as you said yourself... no take-backsies.”

“Oh, don't worry, we have been slipping fine print in our contracts since Happyland achieved independence from Heaven,” one of the lawyers said with smug contempt. “You lost to the very best.”

“This is fraud! This is fraud!”

“I guess we will have to ask the authorities to investigate your claim,” Malfy gloated, as he turned to the chief of staff. “Am I right, Mr. Victor?”

“Case dismissed,” the vizier shrugged. “We're the government. It's not fraud if *we* do it.”

“Tricked by my manling!” Vainqueur taunted the fomor, too amused to attack. “As expected of my Vainqueurized chief of staff!”

Mot screamed angrily, tossing the table aside and attempting to murder Victor with his bare hands. Vainqueur, showing surprising speed, raised a hand to squash the fairy, but he didn't need to.

Bound by his own magic's letter, Mot ended up sucked back into his bottle. He vanished inside before a second passed, for good this time. “Oh, the

hidden penalty clause,” the first lawyer commented. “I did not think he would invoke it so soon.”

“He should have read the fine print,” Victor said, as he picked up the bottle back, “Now he’s never getting out again.”

As he had suspected, Mot was bound by the rules of his own power.

“I am surprised that it worked,” Furibon said from within the scythe, having observed the plan from start to finish. *“I thought the fairy would not be bound by words it didn't notice.”*

“And I’m surprised you didn’t rat us out in exchange for freedom,” his holder admitted.

“Trusting a fairy seemed as smart as turning a dragon’s hoard to lead.”

“I’m glad you learned.”

“Good job, Manling Victor,” Vainqueur congratulated him earnestly. “Now we can send that bottle away from my sight and keep the gems.”

Kia would be the most unhappy. She had missed another battle.

Congratulations! For skillfully tricking a fomor on behalf of your dragon master, you earned two levels in [**Monster Knight (Red Dragon)**]! You earned the [**Master’s Shield**] Class Perk.

[**Master’s Shield**]: as long as you are within fifty-feet of your master, Vainqueur Knightsbane will enjoy the benefits of the [Regen] Status.

60 HP, +20 SP, +2 STR, +2 VIT, + 2 SKI, +1 AGI, +2 INT, +2 CHA, +2 LCK!

By reaching level twenty in [**Monster Knight (Red Dragon)**], you maxed out the class! You can no longer take levels in it, but you gained the capstone ability [**Fright Knight**].

[Fright Knight]: Technique, 50 SP. You exude a sinister aura for five minutes, forcing anyone perceiving you to succeed on a moderate difficulty Charisma check, or be afflicted with the [Terror] ailment and have their Strength and Charisma decreased by one stage. A successful save only negates the [Terror] ailment.

Well. Now they had defeated this enemy, Victor had to face a much more terrifying foe.

Chocolatine was waiting.

Chapter 45: The Dragon Wingmate

Vainqueur Knightsbane, greatest of all dragon adventurers, checked his travel bag, in case he had forgotten anything.

The map, to find his targets.

Three sheeps, for breakfast.

Enough coins to build a makeshift bed, on which he could sleep.

There would be enough space within to gather treasures he collected, alongside princesses, if he caught one on his journey. From his spot near the Devil District, the dragon glanced at his beautiful city, which his minions were busy restoring after the damage the fairy caused; it irked him to leave it and his hoard behind, even for a few days.

The thought of that cursed Icefang getting the lead on him infuriated him more, however. What if that silver lover caught the Blue Rose Legion before Vainqueur did? He wouldn't stand another humiliation, especially not after the fairy fiasco.

But he would leave tomorrow. Tonight, he would be busy commanding his elite minions for a sensitive operation, the most important since the War of the Hoard. He observed the small crowd gathered in front of him, each aware that their life would be forfeited should they fail Vainqueur today.

“Scrap golem?” Vainqueur began to check his lackeys.

“The feast is ready,” Rolo the golem nodded, having put on a white chef hat. “I have brought out my most precious vegetable and wine from storage, Savoureuse supplied us with the best cheese this side of Outremonde, and I can finally cook that Black Rabbit.”

“I spared no expense,” Savoureuse boasted. “My adorable Victor needs to settle down with the right, caring girl.”

“I still think we should have gone with a vegetarian dinner, or at least stick to fish,” Allison the dryad said, who had assisted the chef with the presentation.

“You cannot have dinner without meat,” Vainqueur replied, incensed by the woman’s lack of culture. “Even if my minion is obsessed with that apple vegetable, his dragon half will demand raw sheep meat. Where is Chocolatine?”

“Already inside,” Allison replied. “Malfy is coaching her on the proper script.”

Vainqueur suddenly realized he should have done the same with his chief of staff. Too late.

As a reward for reimbursing his debt to his dragon master, and dealing with that damn fairy, Vainqueur had decided to *personally* make sure the minion’s mating ritual would go well. Manling Victor had proven helpless at reproducing on his own, but the dragon had been an excellent goblin breeder in his youth. He knew how a minion’s mind worked.

Sometimes, it hadn't worked out so well, resulting in minion wars and Vainqueur's policy against minion harassment. However, Manling Victor had proven himself the best minion he ever had. The dragon knew his friend would be responsible; and if helping him breed with Chocolatine was the only way his lackey to pass on his genes, then so be it.

“Kobold Rangers, are you all ready?” the dragon asked his favorite servants; even though they no longer counted as Kobolds, the name stuck.

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Red Ranger nodded, a banjo in his hands; each of the five carrying a different musical instrument. “Pink made us practice the songs.”

“She wasn’t very enthusiastic about it though,” Yellow said.

“Because... because...” Pink seemed to hesitate with the plan, much to Vainqueur’s confusion. “Because Lord Victor belongs with the Emperor!”

“Of course he does, he is my chief of staff,” Vainqueur replied, confused by the ambient embarrassment among the Rangers.

“Don’t listen to her, Your Majesty,” Ranger Black said, putting his foot on Pink’s. “She didn’t mean it that way!”

“I can’t silence the truth...” Pink struggled to find her words. “I... I even... I even wrote a book about it!”

She brought out a scroll, too fast for the other Rangers to steal from her hands. “Pink, you lied to us!” Red glared at her. “You said you would burn it!”

“I couldn’t! His Majesty must know!”

“I must know what?” Vainqueur wondered angrily. “Are you hiding things from me, minions?”

“Your Majesty, please do not read this!” Red panicked, as everyone looked at the scene in confusion. “This is... this is a cursed work, that should never have been committed to paper...”

“Minion Red, I am Emperor of all I see. I can handle any hard truth of my territories. Pink, tell me of this book, but be short. My minion will arrive soon.”

“Yes, Your Majesty,” Pink Ranger opened the scroll, while the other rangers recoiled. “*My Immortal Dragon, Chapter One: The Minion’s Wish.*”

From the first sentence on, Vainqueur started to feel odd. The world began to chill like the frozen heart of winter, and he sensed a sinister force crawling on his back with every paragraph detailing Manling Victor’s forbidden love for his master. The other minions shivered in dread, perhaps none more than Allison the dryad.

Charisma check successful! [**Terror**] and [**Madness**] negated!

“Oh gods, I...” Allison put her hands on her mouth. “I feel nauseous...”

“Is this how Manling Victor feels?” Vainqueur asked, even more terrified than the other minions.

“I know in my heart, that he does!” Pink Ranger replied.

That poor chief of staff... Vainqueur would have to let him down gently. “I will deal with this myself. Until then, follow my grand strategy.”

Speaking of the devil, Vainqueur could smell his chief of staff coming. “Quick, in position!” the dragon ordered, the minions dispersing, while Vainqueur moved towards the entrance of Malfy’s newest casino, a den of iniquity and wastefulness.

Such a vile establishment... Vainqueur couldn’t understand why minions would risk wasting their hoard for nothing. Did they not appreciate their gold, the way a dragon did? If so then the Emperor would work tirelessly so quest givers would give him their coins to safeguard.

“Manling Victor,” Vainqueur welcomed his chief of staff, as his servant landed in front of the entrance; two demonic bouncers nodded at them.

His friend had made an effort to dress brighter for the night. “Your Majesty, have you come for my deathbed confession?”

“Pink Ranger informed me of how you feel towards me,” Vainqueur replied. “Which... I understand. Look at me. I am *me*. Everyone loves me on sight because I am good, smart and wealthy.”

“What is Your Majesty saying?” the poor minion denied his feelings. “I do not understand.”

“Minion, I cannot reciprocate your feelings for me. I know this hurts, but it is true. I owe this honesty instead of stringing you along.”

“What the Happyland are you implying here?” Manling Victor remained in denial.

Are you sure you want to friendzone: **Victor Dalton**?

Yes. It broke Vainqueur's heart, but he had to.

“Minion, while you are my most valuable lackey and friend, but my one true love shall remain my hoard and myself. I am too important to share.”

Charisma check successful! Victor Dalton now suffers from the [**Confused**] status!

You have successfully friendzoned: **Victor Dalton**.

“Okay...” His minion seemed devastated.

“But rejoice, tomorrow we go on an adventure together,” Vainqueur cheered him up. “We will finally clear my name!”

“Yeah... I guess the next hour will suck, but it will be worth my peace of mind afterward.” His chief of staff excused himself, walking into the casino with a heavy heart.

Poor minion.

Vainqueur activated his blinkblink ring and peeked at the summit of the casino, where the luxury lounge was located. The place had been emptied of everyone but Chocolatine, the staff, and the minions; Malfy had set a table where Sweet Chocolatine waited, having traded her usual clothes for a cow-leather dress. The Kobold Rangers had already started playing slow music, to put the minions in the mood.

When Malfy guided Manling Victor to the roof, he almost didn't recognize the werewolf waiting for him. “Choc?”

“Hi, Vic!” She waved happily at him, before frowning at his lack of reaction. “Is something the matter?”

“Aw, I... I never saw you in a dress, that's all.” He sat at the table, as Malfy handed them the menu. Hidden from Manling Victor, the fiend slipped a detailed script in Chocolatine's card.

“You know, Vic,” Chocolatine began by reading the script, “It is so nice to have a date without background prejudiced comments.”

“You’ve suffered from discrimination?” Manling Victor frowned.

“Yes, because I am a half-breed,” she kept reading, “I’m half-monster, and half-monster.”

“Uh... I... I didn’t know.”

It hurt to watch, so the dragon decided to coach his minion.

“Psst...” Vainqueur put his head over the roof and whispered to Manling Victor. “Psst... minion...”

His lackey looked in his general direction. “Your Majesty?” he whispered back. “Are you invisible?”

“Show her your hoard...” Vainqueur advised. “Impress her with your hoard... show her your gold... she is poor, she will love it...”

Manling Victor’s face turned red. “Can Your Majesty not watch my execution? This is embarrassing.”

“Yes, yes...” Of course, Vainqueur didn’t stop watching, but he moved his head away to let them talk privately. Malfy the Fiend, who could see the Emperor while invisible, joined him near the edge of the roof to watch.

“She’s opening with the half-breed discrimination feint,” the fiend said, “I’m so proud.”

When Savoureuse and fiend servants arrived to serve the first dishes, Chocolatine had closed the menu; but much to Tasty Malfy’s horror didn’t keep it at her side. In spite of the distance, Vainqueur’s picky ears allowed him to listen still.

“I’m sorry if I’m embarrassing to be around,” Chocolatine said with a sheepish smile, “When I see someone I like I lose my way.”

“You’ve never dated before?” Victor raised an eyebrow.

“Yes, but my brother always cut it short,” she replied with a sigh, “I guess I latched on to you because you were the only one he wouldn’t chase away or eat. Besides your other qualities of course!”

“I’m not good at this either, to be honest,” Victor admitted, “I didn’t have any close relationship back at home, outside of my family.”

Her exchange with Manling Victor clearly wasn’t part of her coach’s plan. “She isn’t following the script,” Malfy muttered to his invisible Emperor. “Why isn’t she following the script?”

“It seems to work anyway,” Vainqueur replied, as Manling Victor’s dreadful expression slowly morphed into kind interest, as he and Chocolatine exchanged childhood tales.

“She is... actually being heartfelt?” Tasty Malfy didn’t understand the scene at all. “Or pulling a double-layer trap? I told her this was too risky.”

Savoureuse slipped towards him with a scowl. “We have a problem. Kia is coming this way from the north.”

“Heaven,” Malfy guessed. “They are trying to screw over my lobbying campaign by sending Kia Bekele to disrupt the closing.”

“I will not allow her to lead my chief of staff astray the way she did with my niece,” Vainqueur replied, stealthily moving away to intercept the paladin.

He didn’t have to fly long. Much to his annoyance, Vainqueur found her riding his niece towards the establishment; Jolie had even taken to wearing armor matching that of Knight Kia over her perfect crimson scales! It took every ounce of his bottomless willpower not to go on a rant at the sight.

“Blink,” Vainqueur declared, revealing himself in his full glory.

“Uncle Vainqueur!” Jolie rejoiced at the sight of him, which was almost enough to ease his anger.

“Miel told me Vic was facing an emergency,” Knight Kia said, seemingly very eager to ruin everything.

“My minion is undergoing a pre-breeding ritual, and considering his poor track record, I shall not suffer interruptions,” Vainqueur said. “It is *handled*.”

“Pre-breeding? I thought he was the kind of guy to skip straight to the fun part...”

“Kia, do you plan to breed someday?” Jolie asked, making the knight wince. “I can show you my cutest minions!”

“I... thank you, but I will pass—”

“No!” Vainqueur shouted, unable to restrain himself. “You are not keeping Knight Kia as your minion! She is not chief of staff material!”

“Uncle, I take whoever I want as a minion!”

“I am right here, and I take issues with that discussion,” Knight Kia pointed out, but the dragons ignored her. She sighed in disappointment. “Here I hoped for an emergency.”

“Kia, you wanted to fight?” Jolie looked up at her minion.

“I missed a big battle,” Knight Kia complained, disappointed. Manling Victor had given her the fairy bottle for safekeeping so she would hold up. “How is it that I missed a big battle *again*?”

“Because you are useless, and corrupt the youth,” Vainqueur snarled at the manling, as he glared at his niece.

“Stop being mean to Kia, Uncle! She’s nice and kind!”

Vainqueur couldn’t believe that Jolie would talk back to her uncle. Clearly, he and Genialissime had spoiled her too much. “Jolie, you leave me no choice but to use my parental authority,” he declared. “For letting a manling

ride on your back and refusing to listen to your uncle, you are grounded! I am confiscating your minions and all of your elf dolls!”

“What? No!” Jolie’s eyes widened in horror since it was the first time Vainqueur ever punished her. “Uncle, you cannot ground me! I am a hundred and fifty!”

“As long as you share my lair and haven’t reached two hundred, you will do as I say!” It wounded Vainqueur deeply to discipline his niece, but this was for her own good. “So long as you allow Knight Kia to ride on your back, my punishment shall stand!”

Jolie began to cry, breaking Vainqueur’s heart... but he held true in face of her tantrum. When she grew older, she would understand.

“Look, what about we go on a quest?” Knight Kia tried to reassure Jolie. “We’ll go deliver the bottle to Barsino, and we secure the reward.”

“A... reward of gold?” Jolie’s head perked up.

“You better have a bigger hoard to show for that bottle when I return from my own,” Vainqueur grumbled, “I will allow you to finish that quest, but afterward Jolie, you shall not go out unless you see reason.”

“Is it wise to trust Mot’s map though, considering its source?” Knight Kia pointed out.

“My chief of staff saw that any negative effects of this fairy’s meddling were erased,” Vainqueur replied. “The map remained behind.”

“So the information inside is truthful?” Knight Kia frowned. “Very thoughtful.”

Of course. Vainqueur had started with sixty-four points in intelligence. Figuring this out was mere child’s play to him.

Kia convinced Jolie to stop crying and go on to deliver the Bottle of Mot back to the quest giver, with Vainqueur hoping this experience would teach his niece the value of upholding the food chain.

He returned to the casino under an invisibility veil to observe the ritual, and the results were decidedly mixed.

Manling Victor and Sweet Chocolate exchanged words, in between consuming a marvelous buffet of sheeps, demon tomatoes, fishes, and solidified cow milk. The discussion grew slightly livelier over time, and Manling Victor even laughed at one point.

In the end, after they finished the meal, Manling Victor accompanied Chocolate outside the casino, under the silent stares of the other minions present. As they reached the main entrance, they waved hands at each other and separated.

“So?” Vainqueur whispered to his minion, as Chocolate left to return home.

“Well, we agreed to have a second date where everybody is *not* watching us. But it was nice. Nicer than I expected.”

While his minion clearly wouldn’t reproduce anytime soon, the mating ritual would continue. Vainqueur considered it a success.

Congratulations! For sparking some shade of interest between two monsters, you have gained a level in [**Dungeon Breeder**]**!** You earned the [**Monster Empathy**] Class Perk!

+30 HP, +1 STR, +1 SKI, +1 CHA.

[**Monster Empathy**]: you can make a Charisma Check to improve the attitude of monsters toward you, making them friendlier. This ability works even on wild monsters such as Beast types. Monsters who hate you for a personal reason or mindless automatons such as golems will ignore the Perk.

“Minion?”

“Yes?”

“Pack your belongings, we go on the hunt at dawn.”

Chapter 46: Quest Competition

It had been a long time since Vainqueur had visited the lands far east of the Albain Mountains.

The manlings called it the Harmonian League, or so his chief of staff told him. To him, they were just hunting grounds he had briefly visited before his hibernation. After the mountains and the nearby lakes, the landscape could be resumed as green, grassy plains, crossed by long manling stone roads or farmer fields. Groups of manlings and beastkin, whom Vainqueur assumed to be merchants, cowered at the sight of the dragon flying above them.

“Minion, where is this Garland hiding?” Vainqueur asked, growing bored with the lack of change in scenery. They had planned to tackle a few easy quests on the way, namely hunting the Badalisc Beast, eating bandits, and escorting a merchant caravan.

He had to make this revenge trip profitable. He wouldn’t let avenging his reputation get in the way of a nice reward.

“According to the map, he’s hiding at Lagon, one of the biggest of the fallen city-states.” Unlike his master, he seemed to enjoy the landscape. “The League used to be a loose alliance of them until they betrayed Gardemagne for King Balaur during the Century War. Gardemagne and Barin ended up conquering their lands and splitting them in two.”

That served the fools right. *Never* trust a fairy. “I can smell cooked manling in the air,” Vainqueur said.

“The region is still unstable. While Lagon and the northern cities swore fealty to Gardemagne, they’re still quarrelsome. And since the local nobles

make heavy use of mercenaries to harass their rivals' lands, people like the Scorchers flocked there to find work and protection."

"Minion, I mean *cooked* manlings, with spice; not a burned village." Vainqueur recognized the scent, flying towards its source. He had an inkling to who was responsible, and it justified a detour.

As he expected, Vainqueur found his favorite cousin cooking meat around a large campfire, while a little manling ate a chicken nearby. "Genialissime!"

"Vainqueur, Manling Victor!" the other dragon rejoiced, as the Emperor of Murmurin landed next to the campfire. Much to Vainqueur's confusion, he had started wearing a pointed, dragon-sized blue hat over his horns, like his cousin's crown. "Good to see you! Have you come to visit?"

"No, but this is a welcome surprise," Vainqueur replied, before looking at the breakfast.

"I'm cooking bandits!" Genialissime replied, before offering Vainqueur a stick covered with juicy meat. "Do you want some? It's claw lickin' good."

"No, thank you, I have sheeps in my travel bag." Genialissime may have been a talented cook among dragonkind, but Vainqueur found manlings bland, even with seasoning.

"I guess our bandit hunting quest is toast, then." His own chief of staff covered his nose to protect himself from the smell of his cooked kindred, before landing near the other manling nearby. Both exchanged a frown as if they recognized one another.

"Henry?" Manling Victor said. The name jogged Vainqueur's memory enough to remember the bespectacled Class Scholar from the stinking city of Haudemer. "Henry, is that you? You're alive?"

"Victor? Is that you? Are those real wings?"

"Yeah, I had a, shall we call it, a class accident."

“Fascinating...” Manling Henry muttered. “I knew some Monster Classes could change the user’s type, but I didn’t imagine [Monster Squire] would...”

“Oh, you know my class planner, Manling Victor?” Genialissime nodded in appreciation. “I have taken twelve levels in [Wizard] thanks to his guidance. He even found me this [Hat of the Aqua Mage] to bolster my spells!”

“You have a class planner too?” Vainqueur asked while bringing out his sheeps for breakfast.

“Yes, I figured that I needed a minion like your Victor, who could help me become the best dragon I could be. So I searched the cities whom you visited, dear cousin, and I asked them if they had a chief of staff in between jobs. Manling Henry immediately jumped at the occasion to serve me until the end of times.”

“I... I made, through no fault of my own, a powerful enemy,” Henry admitted. “I figured no one would dare attack a dragon, even someone with her reach. It also allowed me to pursue my research on dragon classes.”

“As long as I am here, Minion Henry, none shall touch you,” Genialissime reassured his chief of staff. “And if anything happens, I will go to a minion repairman to patch you up.”

“Corpseling Jules,” Vainqueur told his minion, who clearly didn’t understand the term. “A minion who can repair other minions if they break.”

“You mean when they die?”

“Yes, when they break.”

“Do you want some, Manling Victor?” Genialissime offered him a meat stick.

Manling Victor glanced at the stick with revulsion, clearly not a full dragon yet. “I have chicken,” Henry said.

“Thank the gods,” Victor muttered.

“My cooking is so good, nobody dares taste it,” Genialissime replied with pride, swallowing the stick whole.

“Victor, I, uh...” Henry bit his lips. “I would like to apologize.”

“For ratting me out to the Scorchers?” Manling Victor shrugged. “It’s fine. I got more than five levels out of it, and considering how they treated you afterward, I guess that makes us even.”

Manling Henry did that? While the debacle with the duchess remained clear in his mind, Vainqueur had long forgotten how they dealt with those Scorchers. “So, Genialissime, which classes have you progressed in?” Vainqueur asked, eager to learn if one had made him richer.

“I have tried to take levels in [Crusader] on Minion Henry’s suggestion,” Genialissime said. “So I could heal in battle. Since I am a dragon, and obviously unable to die, I brushed him off. Instead, my class planner ensured that I could progress as a [Wizard], increasing my intelligence.”

“What was your starting score?” Vainqueur prodded, brushing away the shameful secret of dragon mortality.

“Square root forty-nine!” Genialissime said proudly.

Vainqueur breathed in relief. Lower than his own.

“I was actually considering Your Majesty’s newest options,” Manling Victor said, as he bit in a cooked chicken. “Our last ‘battle’ made me realize that Your Majesty is optimized for combat and authority, but may need more utility Perks. I was thinking about a magical class like [Wizard].”

“I would say [Crusader] or [Priest] could supplement a dragon’s natural abilities,” Manling Henry suggested. “But the person must worship a god.”

Vainqueur scoffed, before pondering the matter. “Can I worship myself?” He did intend to become a god one day if only to get his money back; if he worked his way up with his own church...

“No,” Manling Victor replied quickly.

“But I am worth it!” Vainqueur complained.

“Oh, can we worship our hoard?” Genialissime asked cunningly. “If they are shiny enough?”

“Worshiping money?” Manling Henry frowned. “I do not think it will work. In fact, the ability to tap into divine classes is what proves the deity’s divinity. If you cannot gain power by worshiping them, then they are not divine.”

Mmm. A true hoard was too good for the heavens anyway. Besides, wasn’t [Crusader] Knight Kia’s class? Vainqueur would rather take any class that the corrupter of the youth hadn’t touched first.

“Why not [Geomancer]?” Manling Henry suggested.

“[Geomancer]?” Manling Victor and Vainqueur asked at the same time.

“[Geomancer]. It is a Spellcaster Class that allows the caster control over the land, but its Perks need an *enormous* amount of SP. A dragon has so much in store it won’t be a problem. Genialissime told me you were ruling a country?”

“Yes, without taxes,” Vainqueur replied proudly.

“[Geomancer] would be extremely useful then,” Manling Henry nodded. “It can help with landscaping, agriculture...”

Vainqueur considered the matter. Casting spells wasn’t indragon, unlike being a merchant. “Can it make me richer?” the dragon asked the only important question.

“I definitely see a few ways it can,” Manling Victor said, satisfying his master. “How can you access it?”

“How about we discuss it, while you tell me everything about your class’ evolution?”

“Deal,” Manling Victor said.

While their chiefs of staff exchanged class tips, Genialissime turned to his cousin. “Vain, Jolie has set up lair with you, has she?”

“Yes, but I have her grounded,” Vainqueur replied. “She is in a rebellious phase.”

“Youngsters.” Genialissime chuckled. “There have been worrying incidents recently, and I’m worried about her.”

“Incidents?”

“A few younger dragons have gone missing while going on their first quests,” Genialissime said, shaking his head at Vainqueur’s frown. “They probably had hidden disabilities, but Blightswamp won’t let our kids out of her sight now.”

“Did you imply my niece can *die*?” Vainqueur replied.

“No, of course not. No corpses were found, so this may be something else. But with the number of disappearances, you have to wonder.”

“I will keep an eye on Jolie.” The Emperor shrugged, before worrying slightly. He had never imagined that his niece could die, and the thought suddenly filled him with dread.

No. He was worrying too much. She could handle herself, and while he disliked her, Knight Kia was powerful. Jolie was in safe hands.

What happened to these young dragons, though?

- *Sometimes later, in the city of Milani...*

“What do you mean, protecting the caravan is no longer a problem?” Vainqueur complained.

“We already have a dragon protector, Magnifique the Great,” the manling showered a green dragon with praise, whom Vainqueur recognized as one of

his guests.

“They offered to pay me *forever* as their ‘Don’ if I protected their city,” the dragon rejoiced. “I can watch my hoard grow without doing *anything!*”

“I did that with my empire, they reward my benevolent leadership with cattle,” Vainqueur replied, torn between happiness that he had inspired others to follow in his footsteps, and annoyance at being denied another quest.

“I am thinking about innovating in minion management,” the dragon continued. “There is that law of silence I would like to try...”

- *Later in the morning, the village of Lombardia...*

“The Badalisc? Oh, thanks, but the monster has already been slain by one of your scaled kindred, and...” The village’s mayor showed his teeth, sweat falling from his forehead. “Uh, how to say it...”

“You don’t need more help?” Manling Victor asked as Vainqueur noticed that some of the houses had been set ablaze. It reminded him of that time he had burnt a forest hunting trolls.

“Not *that* kind of help.”

“Minion,” Vainqueur said, as they flew along the eastern coast. “Informing my kindred of the Class System may have had some unforeseen side-effects...”

“*Unforeseen*, Your Majesty?” Manling Victor replied with a flat tone.

“I expected my kind to be competent, but not this much!” Vainqueur complained. They had gone through five manling villages, only to find other dragons had solved every quest available there!

“Yeah, that’s the thing with adventuring, it’s an open market and it often dries up,” Manling Victor shrugged. “And by now, I think going on quests might actually be counterproductive. We already have an unstable country to handle, and more than enough resources to exploit.”

“Handling this, while I do the dragon thing of getting paid for tasting lesser creatures, is *your* job, minion.”

“Yes, but that is work I’m not doing while adventuring with Your Majesty.”

“Your presence is essential for my class progression.” Besides, the one time he left his chief of staff without supervision during a battle, he had ended up dead. “Especially since I developed this [Dungeon Breeder] class.”

“Your Majesty is *not* whoring me out. I have paid my debt already.”

Vainqueur frowned at his chief of staff. “You can get paid for breeding?”

Before his minion could answer, a sharp spike of ice fell on them from the clouds.

“Minion!” Vainqueur warned his chief of staff, but the projectile was aimed at him alone. He quickly dodged it, glaring at the cloud it came from.

A detestable, familiar voice called out, as a winged white dragon appeared from the heavens above. “My social better, huh, Vainqueur?! My *social better*?!”

“Icefang!” Vainqueur snarled.

“You are not stealing my quest this time!” Icefang roared, claws extended. “Out of my way!”

Chapter 47: The Smartest Bandit in the World

As usual, both dragons opened their duel with their elemental breaths, Icefang unleashing ice, and Vainqueur a torrent of flames.

Of course, fire won.

Vainqueur's flames pushed Icefang's breath back, but the frost dragon skillfully dodged. The red dragon pursued him across the skies, knowing his rival wouldn't stand a direct hit; he did notice that Icefang had grown faster and sleeker since their last duel, centuries ago.

"You may have become an [Emperor], Vainqueur, but I have leveled into the best classes this system offers!" Icefang raised his hands, manifesting star-shaped blocks of ice between his claws. "[Ice Shuriken]!"

He launched them at his rival, the projectiles moving in angles which Vainqueur himself couldn't predict. The dragon disintegrated a few but had to fly around to dodge the others.

"[Otaku no Shunshin]!" Icefang joined his claws into a series of strange hand signs, his very body blurring.

Icefang's evasion has increased by three stages!

"[Spell Purge]!" Vainqueur activated his own trump card, moving to catch Icefang in close combat and dispel his protections. However, his attempts to claw at Icefang proved fruitless; the slippery ice dragon danced around his blows like an eel.

"No magic, Vainqueur!" Icefang boasted. "All talent!"

“Stop!” Manling Victor shouted. “Please, stop!”

Vainqueur brushed off his chief of staff and prepared to blast Icefang from the skies with his breath, but his friend moved between the two rivals.

“Minion! Get out of my firing line!”

“Your chief of staff is wise to surrender!” Icefang declared, interrupting his assault to gloat. “*I* am the wronged party there! Even your minion can see that!”

“Wronged party?” Vainqueur sneered. “What is my crime, being *better than you*? If so I confess!”

“Your taunts! You think I could forgive your insults to my social position?”

“What insults?” Manling Victor asked, constantly positioning himself so Vainqueur couldn’t attack without hurting him, much to his annoyance.

“His messages! Five times! Five times this month I try to complete a quest, only to find *you*,” Icefang pointed an accusing claw at his rival, “stole the glory from me and taunted me about it! All of this because you couldn’t handle the *immense* overnight success of my adventurer company!”

The admission was enough to make Vainqueur stop... if only to laugh.

“Success?” Vainqueur couldn’t believe the *nerve* of this poser. “You named it after the *second* most precious metal!”

“Silver is good enough to make up most of a hoard!”

“That’s impossible,” Manling Victor interrupted. “His Majesty has been resting on his hoard for a month, and he completed only one quest last week.”

“Resting on your hoard for a month? How could any dragon waste that much time?” Icefang sneered, proving to Vainqueur that he had absolutely no taste.

“That is a rich dragon thing, you cannot understand,” the Emperor of Murmurin mocked his rival.

“Do you dare repeat this—”

“Your Majesty, High King Icefang, if I may—”

“It is High King *President* Icefang now, manling, with a capital H, K, and P,” the frost dragon interrupted Manling Victor. “I can tell the difference.”

“High King President Icefang, what was the content of the taunting messages?”

The frost dragon spat a block of ice to the ground below. “*‘Guess who grabbed all the silver first? With love, your social better, Vainqueur!’*”

Vainqueur frowned. “That was the same wording which you left in that pyramid.”

“What is a pyramid, a place for paupers?” Icefang asked.

“You have not been to the dungeon in the desert?” Vainqueur asked for confirmation, more and more puzzled.

“Why would I go to a desert? It is full of sand, it dirties my perfect scales.”

...

...

“Someone tricked *you*,” Vainqueur taunted Icefang. “Shame on you.”

“Well, Your Majesty, someone tricked both of y—”

“I *knew* it was a set-up, minion,” Vainqueur reassured his chief of staff. “No dragon could be vile enough to deface an artistic mural, not even Icefang. Obviously, someone tried to disguise their crime against dragonkind by lying, poorly.”

His rival scoffed. “You think I will believe *this*, Vainqueur?”

“Icefang, I swear on my minion’s head that I did not lower myself to insulting you.” He was already ridiculous without the red wyrm having to do anything. “And I will never let him die again, so be assured that Vainqueur Knightsbane’s honor is goldclad.”

“You, Slayer of Furibon,” Icefang turned to Manling Victor. “Do you swear on your head that he is telling the truth?”

Vainqueur’s chief of staff looked at his master with intimidated eyes, before nodding at the frost dragon. “I swear. We don’t have anything to do with this, and in fact, I suspect the one responsible pulled a similar stunt on us.”

“Mmm...” Icefang, while having poor taste, at least had the sense to recognize the truth. “Then whom could have slighted me? The messages were written in old dragonian.”

“A fairy,” Vainqueur guessed. “This would not be the first time they tried to divide dragonkind, and one attempted to ruin my Bragging Day.”

“Melodieuse would be the obvious suspect, but something has been bothering me,” Manling Victor said. “How can the responsible know Your Majesty would raid the Tower of Sablar?”

“Minion, that was no tower, but a pyramid,” Vainqueur insisted. “I will not allow improper grammar in my chief of staff.”

“High King President Icefang.” Manling Victor marked a short pause at the name. “Why did you attack us now?”

“The manling adventurer guild informed me of an unclaimed bounty in this stinking city,” Icefang replied. “That I could get paid by eating a certain Manling Garland.”

“I will not let you, Icefang!” Vainqueur roared. “He is mine! He slighted me personally!”

“I reached this city first!” his rival roared back, claws extended. “Find another quest! The money is mine!”

“Please, great noble dragons!” Manling Victor put himself between them. “How about we settle this with a compromise? We get Garland, and in exchange, V&V swears off any quest in the old Harmonian League.”

“What? Minion, you cannot suggest...” Vainqueur stopped himself, before pondering the matter thoughtfully. “Ah, I understand. Us fighting is exactly what the fairies want.”

“Yeah, they probably set you up hoping one would kill the other, or that they could finish off the wounded winner.”

If so, they had drastically underestimated Vainqueur, if they thought Icefang had a chance. “It is my duty as the noblest of dragons to take the high road,” the Emperor of Murmurin declared. “So I will deign to accept this wise peace settlement until I can eat the true miscreant.”

The frost dragon smelled a trap, but also an opportunity. “Mmm... I will deign accept this show of apology.”

“This is no apology,” Vainqueur glared at his one true nemesis. “I can get richer than you without questing in this land!”

“My company’s hoard has grown bigger than yours ever was!” Icefang *lied* brazenly.

“Laughable!” Vainqueur replied, his pride unable to let that slide. “And I will prove it! By the end of the harvest season, on the eve of Halloween, our adventurer companies shall compare their hoards, and mine’s shininess shall prevail over yours! The loser will recognize the winner as the greatest dragon in the world!”

“I relish the challenge!” Icefang accepted, before storming off. “You shall bow before my hoard, Vainqueur!”

Vainqueur seethed at his rival, watching him disappear beyond the clouds. “Manling Victor, I am proud of your plan,” he told his minion, once Icefang out of earshot, “This is the perfect win-win scenario.”

“Really?” his chief of staff raised an eyebrow. “I thought you would be mad.”

“Of course not. If I cannot find quests, then this land is worthless to me. I will get my revenge, *and* that idiot gets nothing! I won *twice*!”

Congratulations! For using your head and not falling into your enemies’ insidious trap, you have earned two levels in [**Kaiser**]! You earned the [**Charged Attack (Dragon Breath)**] Class Perk!

+60 HP, +2 STR, +2 VIT, +2 SKI, +2 AGI, +1 INT, +2 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Charged Attack (Dragon Breath)**]: You can now charge your fiery breath, building up its power in your belly, before releasing a more potent version of it.

And that was just the cow on top of the sheep cake.

The manling city of Lagon was most uncommon. The manlings had built it on the water.

From what Vainqueur could see, the city had once been a hundred or so small islands, before the manlings linked them together with stone bridges. They further expanded into the sea by building stone platforms standing on wooden pillars buried underwater and even refashioned ships in disrepair into improvised buildings. While the dragon couldn’t for the life of him fathom why anyone would live with so much water nearby, he had to praise their design.

However, it took *three* tries before Vainqueur found a floating house that wouldn’t sink when he landed on the roof. The manlings should find better architects.

Thankfully, the citizens of this city seemed civilized enough to treat Vainqueur as the emperor he was and immediately agreed to give him both his target and a feast. They didn’t breed good livestock, but they had spicy tamed krakens.

His chief of staff, as usual, handled the translation with the locals while his master gorged himself on squids; citizens on gondolas regularly circled his own current ‘throne’ to look at him, with Vainqueur doing his best to look magnificent to impress them.

“Your Majesty.” Manling Victor eventually came back leading a gondola carrying a mighty manling. This tanned, barbarian man towered above his chief of staff, and carried a cloak, a bag, and a heavy helmet. “I present you Garland Renoir, former member of the Blue Rose Legion, retired Scorcher, and currently a mercenary captain in service to the city of Lagon.”

The condemned manling looked up at Vainqueur with sorrowful green eyes, while the dragon let out a belch after finishing his kraken. He hadn’t tried to run away—not that it would have helped—which saved Vainqueur the trouble of hunting him further. “I knew this day would come,” he spoke with a grave voice, “Is it too late to say I’m sorry?”

“Yes,” Vainqueur glared at this worm. “Your sin against me is unforgivable!”

The man winced, cowering at the dragon’s divine judgment. “How much then?”

“How much?” Vainqueur repeated while squinting.

“How much *not* to eat me?” the manling offered, proving himself the smartest bandit in the world.

Vainqueur scoffed at the manling. “You believe you can buy *me* to forget your vile deed? *Me*? You think a dragon’s pride is for sale?”

“Twenty thousand gold coins?”

“That does not even cover the cost of my flight, not to mention my hono—”

“Thirty thousand.”

...

Vainqueur marked a short pause, before turning to his chief of staff. “How much is his head worth?”

“Thirty-*five* thousand,” Manling Victor replied.

“Okay, what about *fifty-five* thousand?” the criminal proposed. “That covers my bounty and the money I got from my old lie. Pretty good deal, huh?”

The dragon pondered the question. His pride was second only to his lust for gold...

“Sixty thousand, twenty cattle, and you will have to make a formal, *public* apology to me in front of witnesses,” Vainqueur replied. “That is my first offer. The second is a trip to my bowels.”

“Okay,” Manling Garland immediately accepted. “I’ll take a bit of my company’s reserve fund, but I can scrap the money.”

“Your Majesty, he is a Scorchers,” Manling Victor pointed out. “He’s a wanted man before he murdered a baron and burnt his castle. Just saying nobody will miss him if you decide to eat him anyway.”

“Look, pal, you think I *wanted* to become a bandit?” the other manling replied angrily. “You think *anyone* wants to become a bandit? You think I went to some school and said to the teacher, ‘*when I grow up, I wanna be the best thief there ever was*’?”

“You don’t have to be snappy about it,” Manling Victor pouted.

“Times were hard, and my last employer didn’t pay me after I risked my life killing monsters for him. So I torched his place for the sake of my pride and took his stuff. Was that really ignominious?”

“I too have eaten a quest giver who would not pay me,” Vainqueur said, sympathizing with a fellow victim of manling ungratefulness.

“I’m doing honest sea monster hunting work there, enough that the city’s people didn’t turn me in to the royal authorities,” Garland continued. “I’m

paying my debt to society. And I'm willing to pay the one I owe Yer dragon Majesty if you let me live long enough to do so."

"Since you offered reparation, I shall find in my heart the mercy you lacked," Vainqueur declared. "Because I am forgiving and merciful."

"Yes, but are you really going to let him go?" Manling Victor seemed to struggle with his master's decision. "Don't get me wrong, I am all about the diplomatic solution, but this sounds unlike Your Majesty."

"Last time I forgave a thief and criminal, he became the best chief of staff in the world," Vainqueur replied. "If this one is truly sorry for the vile crime he committed against my imperial person and offers a tribute in reparation, then I shall grant him a chance to turn his life around. Killing would be the petty manling thing, and I am a noble dragon. I am *forgiving* and *merciful*."

"Oh, believe me, I've lived in fear since I heard you were back," the former bandit said. "I feared that either you or my old employer would track me down for my lie."

"I know the adventurer guild can be ruthless towards those who try to con them, but that was twenty years ago," Manling Victor replied. "They had completely forgotten about you until we researched your identity."

"Not the guild," Garland shook his head. "We claimed the bounty they put on Yer Majesty's head, but that wasn't why we went after you. Somebody hired us to first."

This caught Vainqueur's full attention. "Explain," he ordered the manling.

"You want the full story? Guess I owe you that." Garland cleared his throat. "Two decades ago, I was an adventurer with my pals in Barin, one of the countries in the south; we were very good monster hunters. When our country Barsino joined Gardemagne in the Century War, the army hired us to help out against the fomors' war beasts. The fairies and Brandon Maure fielded some nightmarish creatures, and they needed experts like us—"

“Manling, stop loving yourself,” Vainqueur interrupted. “I know it’s your kind’s favorite occupation, but I lose patience at more than twenty-five words.”

“Barsino crushed Maure’s forces and then marched through the Albain Mountains. We stayed in the area to kill monsters which could threaten the supply lines. That’s when someone approached us. Some freaky bard called Hamelin. The scary things he could do with his pipe... *anyway*, he had a job for us, with a big prize.”

Garland marked a short pause, before going on further. “He told us a red dragon called Vainqueur Knightsbane hibernated somewhere in the mountains, but he couldn’t find his lair. He wanted us to find the wyrm, kill him, and then bring back his bones as trophy.”

Friend Victor looked up at his master, who trembled with silent fury. Manling Garland hesitated to continue, but Vainqueur restrained himself for now.

“We managed to find your lair, but when we saw you sleeping... and just how *enormous* you were... we... we... how to say that...”

“You chickened out?” Manling Victor suggested, the wording making Vainqueur hungrier.

“We *tactically retreated*,” Manling Garland denied his cowardice, while Friend Victor put a hand on his forehead. “We didn’t even touch the hoard for fear Yer Majesty would wake up.”

If they had, Vainqueur would have eaten him on the spot. He gave this manling a point for showing the willpower not to touch his hoard; a temptation that even Manling Victor couldn’t resist.

“We couldn’t go back empty-handed, so our [Astrologer] located old dragon fossils in the mountains. We dug them up, falsified them, and then we pretended they were yours. We tricked the guild and Hamelin, seized the reward, and then scattered to the winds in case anyone caught on.”

“How could you sully *my* name for money?” Vainqueur growled.

“The bard didn’t pay us with gold. He gave us top of the line magical items... such as this one.”

The manling mercenary opened his bag, bringing out a strange weapon which seemed vaguely familiar to Vainqueur: a long, heavy iron stick with a barrel at the end.

Manling Victor seemed to recognize the item, his eyes widening. “Holy hell, that’s—”

“The legendary weapon [**Kalashnikov**],” Manling Garland boasted. “Neat weapon, huh?”

Chapter 48: Ghostbusters

The Nightlands were just as Victor had imagined them to be: dark.

Ever since the powerful vampire Orlock had cast a dark ritual over the land, the entire country had been trapped under a veil of eternal twilight. While it was noon, dark clouds obscured the skies and dimmed the sunlight. The flora on the ground looked twisted enough to survive in this kind of environment, from forests of black thorns to roses with eyes.

They had noticed a lot of giant bats and wolves on the roads below, as the duo flew further north; they didn't seem to attack anyone though, making Victor wonder if they were vampires in disguise.

Every crossroad also had a small shrine dedicated to Mithras, and all villages had a statue of the deity. From what Victor had gathered, King Orlock believed the light god would grant vampires a reprieve from the sun if he made his country pious enough and stamped out all the 'heretics' he could find. The deity never answered the vampires' prayers, but Orlock never got the memo.

Their inability to find a quest, and the revelation that someone tried to kill him in his sleep, had soured Vainqueur's mood for the trip, making him crankier than usual. "Minion, are we there yet?" the dragon complained, as they flew over a castle straight out of Dracula's Remake. He carried the bag full of Renoir's coins and cows in one hand. "This place stinks of meat, blood, and garlic."

"The map says the next member of the legion is..." Victor stopped above a graveyard, between the castle and a nearby village. "There."

The chief of staff landed among gravestones, his dragon partner crashing loudly nearby; and unfortunately, their arrival immediately awakened the citizens of the graveyard.

An army of ghosts and wailing specters emerged from the gravestones in a nightmarish procession, swarming the dragon first with hate in their empty eyes.

Vainqueur slapped them.

Victor's eyes widened, and so did most of the ghosts', as the dragon backhanded the closest specters as if they were mosquitos. "Your Majesty can slap *ghosts*?" the vizier asked, astonished.

"I have a Gladiator Perk for that," Vainqueur replied. "I am Vainqueur Knightsbane. I can poke *everything*."

The specters *immediately* collapsed into white smoke.

"Come back!" Vainqueur ordered, disappointed. "Give me treasure!"

Victor doubted ghosts would have dropped anything, instead checking Mot's map. The document led him right in front of a random marble, gravestone.

Ming the Gnome.

1253 AM - 1296 AM.

Adventurer. Blood Dealer. Heaven+ Premium Customer.

"Your Majesty, I think our target is very, *very* dead."

"Then raise him, so I can punish him myself."

"I don't think I can raise someone who has been dead that long," Victor said, as he read the tombstone. "He's been buried for half a decade, and more to the point, he was *insured*."

“Minion, this place stinks of undead!” Vainqueur roared angrily. “Are you telling me we have found the only manling who didn’t have the sense to rise up after his inevitable demise?”

“A gnome.” It didn’t calm Vainqueur at all. “So, what are we doing, Your Majesty? We return home?”

“Why would we?” Vainqueur replied, both frustrated and confused. “I lost *twenty* kilos flying all the way to this place, and except for my rightful settlement and new levels increasing my sweet stipend, we have no treasure to show for it! I will not come back empty-handed!”

“This trip informed us Your Majesty has a dangerous enemy after their head,” Victor pointed out. “Renoir’s weapon was an AK-47, but my [Eye for Treasure] Perk told me it has been magically modified to never run out of bullets.”

“Akawhat?” Vainqueur repeated, confused.

“A weapon from my world,” Manling Victor continued, confusing Vainqueur even more. The vizier forgot his partner had never cared about Earth at all. “Like Maure’s Iron Eagle. What is the likelihood these incidents aren’t connected?”

“Of course someone is after me, minion. I am the greatest dragon in the world. Someone is *always* after me. Which is good, since it means free food is delivered to my doorstep.” Victor could tell that in spite of his bravado, the attempt to kill the dragon in his sleep had infuriated him. “The question is *who*? The fairies?”

“The more I look at it, the more I believe the fomors may have indeed planned this,” Victor nodded. “They’re the main creatures with a vested interest in seeing Your Majesty gone, even before you gained levels, and Melodieuse gave Maure weapons from my world. That is the same MO as this Hamelin.”

Of course, Vainqueur had no idea what a MO meant, but he was too proud to admit it openly. Victor had learned to notice when he wanted his partner

to explain him things without asking directly.

“In both cases, the method was the same: giving advanced weapons to intermediates and let them dirty their hands.” Victor had a few ideas about how they obtained those weapons but had nothing concrete yet. “I also think the Adventurer Guild may be implicated, or at least infiltrated. They’re the only organization which knew we would raid the Tower of Sablar—”

“*Pyramid*, Manling Victor.”

“They’re the only organization which knew that we would raid the Pyramid of Sablar and that we would attempt quests in the Harmonian League.”

“Manling Charlene betrayed me?” Vainqueur growled.

“I don’t think so, but I wouldn’t rule out that someone intercepts her letters.” Especially since she sent reports to Gardemagne and has asked around to get information on the Blue Rose Legion. “But their ability to anticipate us suggests they’re watching us closely.”

Vainqueur didn’t like the implications at all. “Friend Victor, are you suggesting that the fairies have infiltrated my minions?”

“It’s a possibility.”

The thought filled Vainqueur with anger. “How can anyone be ungrateful enough to betray me, like goblins? After I allowed them to live?”

“It’s just a supposition,” Victor replied. “But this is why I suggest we should go back. It’s getting harder to find quests the usual way, and while I left a semi-functional administration to handle things in our absence, the longer we stay away from Murmurin, the more we invite an attack.”

Vainqueur thought about it long and hard. “No, Manling Victor. We are not turning back,” the dragon replied, before explaining himself, “The Winter Kingdoms, where the next villain on my list lives, is also home to Icefang’s lair. While it is cold and dreary there, we will eat two cows with one bite.”

Victor immediately caught on. “You want to investigate the local adventurer guild there, and find out who sent Icefang after us.”

That... That was surprisingly well-thought. Sometimes he forgot Vainqueur’s intelligence score had steadily increased since they first met.

“And claim the settlement owed to me. It is not about revenge, Manling Victor, but something far more important. *Money*.” The great dragon let out a yawn, as he put his travel bag on the ground. “We will go tomorrow. I am tired, hungry, and want to sleep.”

“Here?” Victor would have preferred to sleep anywhere but in a graveyard in the middle of nowhere.

“You can sleep against my hot scales if you are afraid. I will keep you warm and safe like my gold.”

“No, I’m f—” Victor stopped, as Vainqueur gave him *the stare*. “Okay, fine.”

As usual, Vainqueur snored too loudly for Victor to get a good night's sleep. All he could do was close his eyes and straddle the line between sleep and drowsiness, his head against his partner’s belly.

Sleeping against Vainqueur felt strangely comfortable though. His scales radiated warmth, like a chimney, and it helped shake off the frosty night. Victor had realized he had become more sensitive to cool temperatures since he leveled in the [Monster Knight] Class, and taken to wear thicker blankets in his bed.

Thankfully, no one was stupid enough to approach Vainqueur, not even the dead.

“Hey. Hey. Psst.”

Apparently not. Victor opened his eyes, finding a cowed, white-skinned man standing near him. The dragon’s presence hadn’t deterred him.

“Hey,” the man repeated, showing his fangs. “You got blood?”

“Blood?” Victor repeated, drowsy.

“I need my fix, quick. The gov’ got my supplier after he spliced his blood with fairy dust. You can’t get away with nuthin’ nowadays.”

Why did Victor always attract weirdos? It must have been the robes. “I don’t have blood,” the vizier lied.

“You aren’t a dealer?” the vampire looked confused. “Cause you look the part.”

Definitively the robes. “I’m not a dealer. I just want to sleep.”

“You sure? ‘Cause I can pay good money for a sip—”

“I can’t sell my blood, it’s against my religion,” Victor deadpanned. “Now scram please.”

The vampire junkie cursed but scurried off.

Unable to sleep, Victor busied himself by checking his stats.

Victor "Minion" Dalton

Level: 35 (Monster Knight: Red Dragon 20/Reaper 14/Grand Vizier 1)

Type: Humanoid/Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points

855

Special Points 300 Strength 30 Vitality 31 Skill 41 Agility 38 Intelligence 38 Charisma 38 Luck 35 **Personal Perks** **Class Perks** Claimed by Dice Skeleton Key Observer Eye for Treasure Deadfriend Scythe Lord Romantic Monster Kin Claimed by the Moon Man Minion Trainer Black Curse Monster Student Channel Hellfire (Minor) Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)

Claimed by Shesha Monster Rider Crested Monster Insight Vizier
Education Animate Dead Necromancy II Helheim Steal Life Mook
Promotion Slayer of Men Is-No-Good Master's Shield Fright Knight Rally
Minion

His Skill was his highest base stat? And here he thought his Luck had
dipped in the negatives, but it was nothing to sneeze at.

He checked Vainqueur's stats next. Instead of [Old Money], the starting
Perk [Grand Vizier], [Is-No-Good], didn't increase drops, but allowed him
to constantly check his liege's location and stats.

Why did the very essence of the class assumed he obsessed over his
superior?

Vainqueur "Best Dragon" Knightsbane

Level: 38 (Emperor 12/Gladiator 8/Witch Hunter 10/Kaiser 7/Dungeon
Breeder 1)

Type: Dragon.

Party: V&V.

Health Points

6,155

Special Points 1460 Strength 125 Vitality 100 Skill 35 Agility 61
Intelligence 29 Charisma 101 (+10) Luck 61 **Personal Perks****Class Perks**
Dragonfire Breath Born in the Purple Fire Immunity For the Emperor Red
Dragon Lifeforce Nobless Oblige Dragon Arrogance Dynasty Dragonscale
Crowd Favorite Super Senses Supercrit Virgin Princess Radar Spell Purge
Lesser Poison Resistance Witch Burning Deadfriend Lesser Magic
Resistance Taunt Exorcism I Crested Hunter's Resolve Stipend Dungeon
Owner (Castle of Murmurin) Victory Fist Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)
Imperial Authority Malefic Secrecy Monster Empathy Charged Attack
(Dragon Breath)

No wonder Vainqueur started to plan ahead; his intelligence had begun to catch up with Victor's own. Maybe the [Geomancer] Class would help him increase it and gain more common sense?

The vizier felt slightly jealous when seeing the gap between their abilities; while he knew he would never rival Vainqueur in sheer strength, the sheer gap in charm made him insecure. He should definitely follow Henry's old advice and level in a Charisma-oriented class; twice Victor had met someone he couldn't talk down, and in one case it ended in his death.

But there was a moment for all things, and for now Victor needed to sleep. He closed his eyes, trying to block out Vainqueur's snores...

"Gamete Prophet... Gamete Prophet..."

"WHAT?" Victor snarled, as he opened his eyes again... only to find himself facing an enormous, tentacled abomination against nature.

"What is this insult to biology?" Furibon asked, waking up from inside the scythe. *"I do not understand a word of what it says."*

"Hello Gamete," the creature said, taking Victor's reaction in stride. "We met a few solar cycles ago."

"Thul-Gathar?" The vizier recognized the Moon Beast whom he met in Murmurin. "Hey, what's up?"

"I am good, Gamete. Now that I am no longer summoned by skinbags, I could finally eat that telepathic spider and write my own fantasy novel. It is so good, your kindred go mad and remove their eyes when they read it."

"It's a common problem." He already received a few complaints about Pink Rangers' works. "You want me to proofread it? Or something else?"

"It is time to meet your destiny, Gamete Prophet," Thul-Gathar said. "Father has chosen you for a divine mission."

A divine... a divine mission? "I must fulfill a prophecy?"

“Yes. You are the chosen one.”

Victor’s heart skipped a beat, and he held his breath. Then he squealed like a schoolgirl. “Yes, yes!” He immediately leaped back to his feet. “What kind of prophecy? Saving the world from the fomors?”

He knew on some level that with his luck, there had to be a catch somewhere, but the idea of a traditional adventure appealed to him so much...

“No,” Thul-Gathar replied, disappointing the vizier slightly. “You are to usher in an age of exploration, by leading the Moon Man’s people to the Promised Land.”

Huh, so Victor was the new Moses? “I won’t have to stay in a desert for forty years, right?”

“No. You will lead Father’s flock to the *Moouoooooon*.” The Moon Beast trailed the word as if to make it sound more dramatic.

“A place called Moon for some reason, or the actual Moon?”

“Not the ‘Moon’, Gamete,” Thul-Gathar replied, waving a tentacle at the darkened sky, “The *Moouoooooon*!”

...

“Can I do it the American way and fake the moon landing?” Victor asked with heavy sarcasm.

“No, Gamete Prophet. That is not an option.”

“Then what is?” Victor snapped back, his enthusiasm gone. “Build a medieval rocket and send everyone upstairs? Use a teleportation spell?”

The Moon Beast sighed. “Listen, this is not my idea, Mammal Prophet. This is Father’s divine demand. The Moon Man wants his flock together in friendship on the *Moouoooooon*, and he chose you as his shepherd. I am to visit

every carbon-based mammal priest of his and tell them you shall lead the way to the stars.”

Could he give back his ‘Claimed by the Moon Man’ Perk? Victor sighed. The things he did for stat growths... “Do I have a deadline?”

The creature considered the question. “Father did not mention one.”

“Awesome, then I will deal with that after I am back from my current quest.”

“There will be a great reward for your deed.” Victor raised an eyebrow, while Thul-Gathar’s tentacles moved in a distractingly dirty way. “Yes. A great, great reward.”

At this point, Victor doubted it would be worth the hassle. “Any pointers?”

“Use [Protection against Madness] when you reach the *Moooooon*,” Thul-Gathar advised. “Your flock will need it when they see the dark side’s tentacles. The truth will shatter the weaker minds.”

The racket had disturbed Vainqueur’s sleep. “Minion...” the dragon growled, as he glanced at Victor and the squid abomination. “What is it? Why are you talking to squid food?”

“We will meet again, Gamete Person. Remember your destiny.” Thul-Gathar vanished before Vainqueur tried to squash him for a treasure.

“Your Majesty, it seems that I must go to the moon,” Victor said, refusing to say it the way Thul-Gathar did.

“The planet?”

“The moon is not a planet, Your Majesty.”

“Of course it is. It is round and up in the sky.” Vainqueur’s head perked up. “Minion, is there gold on the moon?”

“I... I dunno, Your Majesty.” Since there were creatures on Outremonde’s Moon, there should probably be dungeons or treasure located there. “Maybe? Probably?”

“Aww, but there are no dragons on the Moon, right?” Vainqueur raised his head at the skies, squinting at the faint moonlight piercing through the dark clouds. “There are no quest-stealing dragons on the Moon...”

Something in his tone chilled Victor to the bone, while the dragon’s eyes widened with glee.

Oh no... oh please no...

“Manling Victor, you are a genius!”

Chapter 49: Those who hunt dragons

Vainqueur hated frost.

He had taken residence in the southern Albain Mountains because he thought that it would deter thieves, but the chilly air of his beloved mountains couldn't compare to that of the so-called Winter Kingdoms. Located north of the Nightlands, this vast expanse seemed entirely covered in snow; even now, in the middle of the day, a weak hail kept bothering his flight.

"It's cold..." Manling Victor shook like a tree while flying at his master's side. Even his heavy clothes didn't protect him. "It's horribly cold!"

"We will leave as soon as I get my gold," Vainqueur reassured him.

He couldn't wait to go to the Moon.

That was possibly Manling Victor's greatest idea since he decided to lovingly serve Vainqueur forever. If the Emperor couldn't complete quests or monsters on this planet, he would move on to *another*, without competition! The Moon would become *his* hunting ground, V&V's newest conquest!

What could possibly go wrong with this plan?

"According to the map, the third name on Your Majesty's list, Cornelia Stormwind, should be nearby," his minion said. "I wonder if she will pay Your Majesty too."

Vainqueur hoped so as well, as the dragon and his minion flew above a frozen lake and then a snowy forest of spruce and pines; the dragon had left his bag behind so they could explore the area to his leisure without him fearing for his new gold.

The red wyrm noticed a flying shape whose white color meshed well with the snow approaching them. “Hello, Vainqueur!” A small ice dragoness saluted him, while they crossed paths in the skies. “Strange to see you there!”

“Snowsweep.” Vainqueur recognized her from his feast. “I am looking for a lesser creature called...”

“Cornelia Stormwind,” Manling Victor provided the name,

“Cornelia Stormwind.”

“That good for nothing elf?” The dragoness shrugged. “She has taken control of this forest after I caught its ruling princess. I guess you will find her breeding with a pine tree nearby. Why are you looking for her? She is no princess material.”

“She has insulted me,” Vainqueur replied. “She owes me a tribute of gold and cattle.”

“Good luck catching her then,” the dragoness replied. “But, if you are snooping around, can you tell my little brother Windi to come home? He has not returned from his latest quest, and I am starting to worry for his safety.”

“I will,” Vainqueur promised, nodding at the other dragon while she left to search further south.

“That’s the fourth dragon we’ve met so far,” Manling Victor said, as he and his master circled the forest from above.

“Most of my kind prefer the cold of the north than the south’s warmth.” Why frost dragons outnumbered their *better* cousins was beyond Vainqueur;

and that climate reminded him why he preferred heat. While his [Ring of Elemental Resistance] may shield him from the discomfort of the cold, he still felt it.

Vainqueur sniffed the air, trying to locate the elf grasshopper. He noticed multiple scents spread around the forest, dozens of manlings, elves, beastkin, and even...

“Manling Victor, stay close to me,” Vainqueur ordered, suddenly on edge.

“What?”

“I smell a disgusting fairy on the ground,” the Emperor said, trying to pinpoint its location; failing that, he would burn the entire forest, to be sure.

“Look there!” Manling Victor pointed his scythe at shapes emerging from the clouds and flying straight at them. One looked like a dragon from afar, and Vainqueur identified the other as a gryphon rider.

Was that Manling Kia and Jolie?

No. The “dragon” was a silvery, winged serpent, a frost drake; and one carrying a manling knight on its back at that! A lightly-clad elf woman with bluish skin and white hair rode the gryphon, wielding a metal machine similar to Renoir’s [Kalachnikov]; and he noticed a third form, that of a manling brunette in a strange furred dress, flying through magic between them.

Each of them had a strange ring of light floating above their heads.

“Your Majesty, watch out!” Manling Victor warned, “She has a hunting rifle ___”

The woman on the gryphon pointed her metal stick at Vainqueur and fired a strange lead, rounded arrow at his belly.

The projectile bounced off his scales.

“Lead!” Vainqueur exclaimed with mock pain, a hand on the point of impact. “My only weakness!”

“Really?” the woman on the gryphon asked, as she and the others closed in.

“No,” Vainqueur replied, retaliating with a fireball while she was distracted. “Weaknesses are for manlings!”

The projectiles did make his scales itch a bit, but the dragon ignored the feeling.

The trio dispersed to dodge the fireball, showing annoying quickness at it. While Friend Victor almost cut the drake’s head with his scythe, forcing the beast on the defensive, Vainqueur tried to eat the tasty gryphon with one bite.

Other projectiles flew at them from the forest itself, a massive lightning bolt and a shining arrow. His beautiful ring helped him shrug off the spell like the lead projectile, but the arrow...

Vainqueur felt *excruciating* pain when it hit him in the belly, blowing up a scale.

[Arrow of Dragonslaying] inflicted double damage!

The red dragon snarled in anger, even as his scale immediately started growing back.

[Master’s Shield] activated! You gained the **[Regen]** Status.

“[Battlefield Voice].” A booming, womanly voice echoed through the forest below, although Vainqueur couldn’t pinpoint its source. “Knightsbane, Dalton! My name is Cornelia Stormwind! Lay down your weapons, you are surrounded!”

“Surrounded by dead manlings? I am not impressed!” Still, the dragon guessed that she wouldn’t pay him his due. “Come out of your forest and fight, grasshopper!”

“I will! You have been looking for me, Vainqueur Knightsbane? I’ve been waiting for your coming for *months*! [Defensive Gambit]!”

All of Cornelia’s troops gained the [**Physical Ward**] Status. Physical damage will be reduced by fifty percent for five minutes.

A thin layer of golden light covered each of their attackers, but it didn’t matter to Vainqueur. He would eat all of her minions if he had to.

“Minion, take care of the flyers, while I smoke out the insects below!” the dragon ordered, diving down while his ‘wingmate’ targeted the flyers with hellfire.

Opening his maw, the great calamity unleashed a torrent of flames below, turning the snow to steam and incinerating everything else to ashes in its path. The dragon flew in a straight line, killing anything there, and causing animals and manlings to flee the flames and smoke.

“[Impending Doom]!” Cornelia shouted on the ground, disappointing Vainqueur.

A random attack will hit you in the near-future. Your Luck will determine its severity.

Vainqueur inhaled, deciding to create a circle of fire around the forest and trap his foes on the ground inside it.

“[Ice Shards]!” the drake rider shouted, as he broke past Manling Victor’s defense. He pointed his fingers at Vainqueur, firing icicles at him. The dragon didn’t even bother dodging, the projectiles bouncing off his mighty body.

The drake rider grunted, before turning to the flying manling in a dress. “Krona, The dragon has protection against elemental attacks!”

“[Curse of Winter]!” the woman replied, blue dust trailing after her fingers.

Charisma check successful! You ignored the curse!

“A [Witch],” Manling Victor recognized the type of caster, busy keeping the gryphon rider at bay with hellfire. “Your Majesty, we must take her down first! She’s a debuffer!”

“A debuwhat?” Vainqueur growled back, distracted from burning the forest.

“She makes her enemies weaker and inflicts status effects! In short, she’s distilled *pain*!”

“[Curse of Weakness]!” the witch replied, targeting Vainqueur with hand movements.

Vitality check successful! You laughed at her puny power!

“My spells can’t affect the dragon!” the witch shouted. “His stats are through the roof!”

“Manling toddler, you do not understand,” Vainqueur mocked her. “I am not fighting *you*. You are fighting *me*!”

“You... argh!” The witch’s face turned red with fury.

[**Taunt**] successful! You successfully applied the [**Berserk**] status to Krona! The witch is too pissed to spellcast!

The manling immediately flew straight at Vainqueur, too blinded by her rage to see the madness in her action. “Krona!” The gryphon rider immediately moved to try and intercept her ally, but the Emperor reacted faster.

He blasted *both* of them with a massive fireball, incinerating them.

But when the smoke cleared, both the witch and the elf reappeared, albeit grievously injured, and without either their magical barrier or halos. The gryphon didn’t revive either, causing the rider to fall with a scream.

“[Gravity—]!” the witch cast a spell on the gryphon rider, slowing down the fall harmlessly.

“Dalton can heal the dragon by flying near it!” Insect Cornelia snarled, her words reverberating through the forest. “Separate them!”

“On it!” The witch cast a spell at Manling Victor, who charged straight at her with his scythe. “You’re going down! [Gravity+]!”

Before either member of V&V could react, an invisible force pulled Friend Victor to the ground.

[**Master’s Shield**] canceled! You have lost the [**Regen**] Status.

“Minion!” Vainqueur shouted in worry, as his minion landed in the forest.

“Hah!” The witch gloated, before freezing as the furious Emperor glared at her. “Uh oh.”

As fast as lightning, Vainqueur punched her. The blow sent her flying and crashed as a bloody smear on the ground below.

“Krona!” the drake rider shouted, while the vengeful Vainqueur turned to him next. “Cornelia, Krona’s dead!”

He tried to wound the dragon with ice shards, but Vainqueur retaliated with his dragonfire. His flames turned the ice to steam, but the annoying insect glided around the attack. Another projectile came at him from the forest, yet it missed by a wide distance and exploded above the clouds.

“Bring the fight to the ground, while we activate the golem and summon reinforcements!” his master replied, before casting a spell. “[Predict Bad Weather]!”

The drake rider immediately flew back to the forest, while the hail grew in intensity. The ice turning hard as stone and itching Vainqueur’s scales on contact.

The weather worsened! [**Hail**] became [**Hailing Storm**]! You will take residual damage while exposed to it!

Cursing as the hail hammered his wings, Vainqueur flew towards the ground, but not to pursue the drake.

His minion needed him.

“Blink,” Vainqueur said, turning invisible, and ready to eat every last one of them.

Strength check partially successful! You can move normally on the ground, but you cannot fly.

Victor grunted as he rose up from the snow. He had managed to make a semi-respectable landing after the law of gravity came calling, but it hurt like Happyland!

He barely had the time to get up, then he heard a detonation near his location. A big, fire-propelled projectile flew above the woods and towards Vainqueur. His scythe ready, Victor immediately moved towards the source, while the projectile exploded harmlessly.

He found a small group hiding beneath strong, tall trees, allowing them to weather the increasingly violent hail. One elf woman in a bear coat, carrying a bone bow which his [Eye for Treasure] Perk immediately identified as a [Bow of Dragonslaying]; a figure covered by a white cowl and cloak, hanging back; and a fellow human with red hair, a bag of rockets, and a big, big rocket launcher.

...

A rocket launcher.

They had a *rocket launcher*.

Victor immediately used [Observer] on the trio and try to guess their level.

Emile Lavere, level 30 (Outlaw 15/??? 15)

Vladimir “Gunman” Finnickson, level 33 (Artificier 15/Alchemist 7/Ballistician 6/Gunner 5)

Judith Mazel, level 34 (Archer 20/Huntress 8/Sniper 6)

Lavere? Like the Nightblades' leader? Could it be...

"You missed?" the elf archer mocked his ally.

"I missed?" the human with the rocket launcher gasped.

"How could you miss?" the elf archer reprimanded him. "How could you miss a *giant dragon* with a *bazooka*?!"

"I don't know! Stop shaming me, and fire! Knightsbane's getting closer!"

"Each of them except the cowled one have the [Halo] effect, in addition to their magical shield." Furibon noticed the white ring of light above their heads. *"They will revive with one HP once if killed."*

Not if he trapped their souls first. Victor noted that they must have had at least one healer, though; and a high-level one at that.

The cowled fighters suddenly glanced in Victor's direction, revealing the lifeless white skin and crimson eyes beneath. "The lackey's here," he whispered with a low, raspy voice.

Okay, Victor really, *really* didn't want to go through with that part, but it was Vainqueur or them...

The vizier threw his scythe at the gunner, his weapon hitting him in the back before he could pull the trigger. The scythe pierced through the magical barrier, and cut through the flesh.

Critical Hit! [**Slayer of Men**] inflicted super effective damage!

His body collapsed on the snow, blood dripping from the wound. Victor thought he should have felt bad about killing a fellow human being; while he had helped, he never carried out the finishing blow himself.

Instead, Victor felt... nothing special.

Congratulations! Through your fleeting membership of a criminal syndicate and one-shotting a fellow human in a vicious, dishonorable way, you earned a level in [**Assassin**]!

You earned the [**Lethal**] Class Perk!

+30 HP, +2 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK

[**Lethal**]: Your armed attacks have a chance to inflict Insta-Death (Luck divided by two).

The gunman's soul was drawn into Victor's scythe, the halo vanishing. His [Helheim] bypassed their protections!

The archer hastily turned in his direction, while the cowed figure revealed two daggers dripping with poison. "I hated Legolas!" Victor shouted as a war cry, before blasting both of his foes with hellfire.

The cowed fighter turned into white mist before the flames could hit him, furthering Victor's suspicions, but his teammate couldn't dodge. She took a blast of infernal flames to the face, stumbling back. She launched her arrow, the projectile hitting a pine tree's bark.

"Hilda, Dalton ambushed Emile's team," Cornelia's voice echoed from afar. "Do your job and hit him hard!"

Damn! How did she know?

Victor suddenly remembered that one of the Blue Rose members had levels in [Astrologer], thus someone specialized in divination. She probably scried the vizier from afar, while guiding her team.

The vizier quickly rushed to recover his scythe, then mercilessly cut down the burning archer before she could recover. Once again, his Perk combination bypassed the enemy's buffs.

Critical Hit! [**Slayer of Men**] inflicted super effective damage!

While he sensed his victim's lifeforce heal his bruises, Victor dodged a sneak attack from the cowled rogue. The strange figure had materialized right behind him.

"Hellfire," the cowled rogue rasped, dodging Victor's scythe. "And here we only came with standard [Rings of Fire Resistance]."

Smart, but not enough to stop Vainqueur's breath or the unholy effects of hellfire. Victor used [Monster Insight] to confirm his theory.

Emile Lavere

Alchemical Vampire Spawn (Undead/Humanoid)

Strong against Moon, Darkness, Unholy, Blood, Frost, Drain, Insta-Death, Disease, Poison, Fatigue, Sleep, and Beast.

Weak against Necromancy, Holy, Fire, Life, Berserk, Manslayer, and Deadslayer.

A Nightblade infiltrator and vampire assassin sent to distribute dragonslayer weapons among disgruntled adventurers; also tricked Icefang by leaving messages in dungeons which others cleared first. Uses a cloak and the weather to avoid death by sunlight, and never forgets his vampire mommy's birthday.

A vampire. He was right. "Hey, I know your boss! She has money stashed in our vaults!"

The undead assassin responded by trying to slice his neck with his daggers. Both engaged in a deadly dance of blades, unable to hit the other, while a rumbling noise began to echo through the trees.

Something was approaching. Something big.

A piper song began to echo through the woods, Victor instantly recognizing the melody as the *Ride of the Valkyries*. A gloomy, piper remix of the song, but the famous song all the same.

???’s war melody raised his pawns’ Strength and Vitality by one stage!

And Cornelia kept issuing commands from her hiding place, “[Fabian Strategy].”

Cornelia’s troops can now better avoid attacks!

Damn! The support members empowered the party from the cover of the forest, and according to the smoke rising in the sky, they had intercepted Vainqueur before the two partners could rejoin. Victor had to finish off this rogue before reinforcements arrived, and go help his partner.

A fiery rift through space opened to his left, dashing his hopes.

Victor parried a blue spear with his scythe, as a cavalier in heavy armor emerged from the rift. He, or she, rode a massive black stallion, with a mane and hooves made of fire. The knight attempted to feint him with a second, crimson spear, forcing Victor to retreat to avoid impalement.

Sigismund “Sigi” Twinspear, level 36 (Cavalier 20/Spearsman 11/Chaos Rider 5)

His [Eye for Treasure] Perk also identified the effects of his weapons. One spear inflicted Frost Damage, the other Fire. Victor could ignore the latter, but the former would hit him really hard.

While the vampire rogue tried to flank Victor, the nightmare horse let out a wail, a fiery portal opening right in front of the cavalier. The rider and his mount crossed it, the tear closing right behind him.

Worse, he noticed three new shapes braving the hailstorm, and rushing at his location. He and Vainqueur were fighting an entire Adventurer Company!

No. These guys fought in small groups of three to four. V&V faced *several* parties working together. All above level thirty, and some of them sporting Earth weaponry.

It was a full *raid*!

“Wait, are *we* the raid bosses?” Victor choked, as the dark rider reappeared and tried to trample him. It became harder and harder to dodge attacks from both opponents at once. “Hey! Why? What did we ever do to you?”

“You *stole* our jobs, you BEEP!”

The vizier blinked. “I beg your pardon?”

“You told the dragons how to do quests, and now we can’t get any!” the cavalier, Sigi, glared at him. “They kill monsters and clear dungeons faster than anyone else can! Our Adventurer Company was ruined because of *you!*”

That was their reason? “Hey, shouldn’t you be happy we made the world a safer place?” Victor argued back.

“Not if it leaves us jobless!”

Okay, maybe he and Vainqueur increased the adventurer unemployment rate, like every government in the world, but that was no reason to murder them!

Unfortunately, the other three arrived and helped surround Victor. A tanned, strongly built woman with short blonde hair carrying an enormous warhammer on her back and a whip in hand, seemed to be the leader. She was backed up by a tiger-like humanoid wearing only crimson pants, and a two-handed swordsman in heavy plate armor.

“*Five on one,*” Furibon noted. “*I guess this is the end for you. Again.*”

Victor hated to agree with him, but his odds didn’t look good. And meanwhile, the rumbling noise kept getting closer and stronger... “If I die there, I have something to tell you.”

“*Oh? Do tell.*”

“You’re a giant, bitter pain,” Victor declared bluntly, before softening the blow. “But I’m going to miss you a bit. We had fun.”

“Just go die already.”

Victor used [Observer] on the newcomers, trying to find the weak link in their formation.

Hilda Brightside, level 36 (Warmaster 20/Warrior 12/Reaver 3/Whip Master 1)

Tiger Jajang, Level 39 (???)

Sven Ironguard, Level 35 (Crusader 30/Heavy Knight 5)

“A Crusader? What the Happyland is a Crusader fighting me, and five-on-one at that?”

“You steal souls, raise undead for a living, and register as slightly evil to my [Karma Scan], Victor Dalton!” the holy knight replied. *“While we fight for truth, justice, and the adventurer way!”*

Oh come on, Victor received a label because he followed *one* evil overlord’s seminar?! *“Evil? You’re fighting with a vampire assassin!”*

“You dragon racist,” the vampire deadpanned, waiting for an opening to strike again.

“He’s a thug, your dragon master is a conqueror!”

“Anyway, let’s just kill him,” the Warmaster cut the discussion short, her voice strangely soft and meek. *“Jajang, please.”*

“Yeah,” the tiger replied, joining his hands so fast Victor could barely follow. *“[Accelerated Flame Pillar].”*

Before he knew what hit him, a pillar of fire erupted beneath his feet.

It didn’t inflict much damage, but it distracted Victor at a key moment. The Warmaster’s whip coiled around his scythe and pulled it back towards its wielder, disarming the vizier.

Victor cursed under his breath, but the other adventurers didn't give him any time to retaliate. The horseman vanished through a fiery rift, while vampire assassin immediately moved to strike at Victor, his dagger piercing through his clothes and cutting flesh at the left shoulder.

Vitality check failed! You have been [**Poisoned**]!

"Nice scythe," the Warmaster said with a cheeky smile upon seizing it. "[Sunder Weapon]!"

Seizing the scythe with both of her hands and bringing down on her knee, the Warmaster broke Victor's weapon in half.

Instantly, the dozens of souls contained within escaped at once, Furibon's cackling specter at the forefront. Victor's eyes widened in panic, while the Warmaster threw the weapon's remains on the ground and switched her whip for the warhammer. "[Lightning Smash]!"

Victor just *narrowly* avoided having a hammer bash his skull by side-stepping, the Warmaster shattering the pine tree right behind him like a kitkat bar.

Realizing he was hopelessly outmatched, not to mention surrounded, Victor summoned will'o wisps with [Death Candle]. While they barely slowed the opposition, it allowed him to reach the corpses of his two victims. "[Animate Dead]!"

As the corpses rose, Victor activated his new Perk, praying whoever insane god listened to for victory. "[Fright Knight]!"

A dark aura surrounded him, the atmosphere growing oppressive as his zombies faced the opposition. "Even if I die," Victor promised, trying to channel his inner edgelord, "I am dragging you with me down to Hell!"

Your enemies' Strength and Charisma decreased by one stage!

You inflicted [**Terror**] on: Tiger Jajang and Emile Lavere.

Both the vampire and tiger froze in dread, before instantly retreating; the undead by turning into mist, and the other by straight-up running away.

“Cowards!” The crusader shouted, a powerful light surrounding his blade, while the warmaster cracked her neck.

Victor prepared to blast them with magic when a pine tree fell nearby. By now, the rumbling had become overwhelming, for the thing responsible walked nearby.

The vizier barely caught a glimpse of the *enormous* creature crushing everything on its path, of its metal frame shining with magic... of this twisted parody of a knight, which looked like Rolo’s big, *big* evil brother.

His [Monster Insight] activated on its own.

Talos Mark III

Talos Golem Prototype (Artificial/Fairy)

Strong against Dragon, Fire, Physical, Magic, Status Ailments, Spirit, Mind-Control, and Frost.

Weak against Water, Lightning, and Fairy.

The Mell clan’s newest weapon against mortalkind. A golem made of Earth technology animated by fomorian magic, meant to slay dragons and humans alike. A relentless automaton, it inflicts [Dragonslayer] damage with its sword, possesses a mounted cannon in its shield, and breathes virulent poison.

But hey, it’s flawed goods! Your boss can take it!

Holy hell...

Chapter 50: Class Struggle

The forest smelled of dung and paupers.

Vainqueur always knew this day would come. The day when pitchfork-wielding peasants, fairies, and minion strikers, envious of his well-deserved wealth, would gather in a great rabble host and try to bring him down. The emperor of all knew that in this time of need, he would be called to serve as the final bulwark of dragon civilization against the forces of the rebellion.

“Do you see him?” a pauper leading a small group of three manlings knights with swords asked; Vainqueur immediately recognized her as the pegasus rider. The weather impaired them as much as it did the dragon himself, forcing his preys to advance against the snow. Each of them carried that strange ring of light above their heads. “I can’t distinguish anything with this hailstorm, but I saw him crash nearby.”

These lawless savages had treacherously stolen his minion, isolating him from his master; and now they moved to encircle him.

Time to show them which species won the class struggle.

“SURPRISE ATTACK!” Vainqueur declared as he squashed a knight into a bloody smear. Thanks to his blinkblink ring, he had managed to mesh with the snow, moving with the stealth of a cat between the trees. The magical shields Cornelia Stormwind had summoned made the manling much harder to chew than usual, but the dragon was hungry enough to make the effort.

“We’re under attack!” the pegasus rider shouted a warning while firing her lead weapon at random, only for Vainqueur to bite her in half.

“How... invisible!” One of the few remaining manlings cursed, unable to distinguish Vainqueur, “He’s invisible!”

“Dragons don’t run invisible ambushes!” the other replied. “They’re dumb as bricks!”

Vainqueur twitched in anger. “I have sixty-four in intelligence!” he corrected them, before tossing the manlings against trees with his tail, causing the plants to collapse on their back.

Much to his frustration, the four annoyances popped back after death, albeit wounded; while they immediately attempted to retreat, Vainqueur blasted them with a fireball. His flames resisted the hail and spread to the trees.

“Vainqueur demolished Erik’s team in the north!” Cornelia’s voice echoed through the trees and causing snow to fall from the leaves. “The golem will be there soon. Green Boy, Drake, Wizi, ensnare him!”

Vainqueur snorted at those words, before noticing the ice drake rider flying above him, having traded his weapon for strange crimson rods whom he set alight. Unlike the dragon, his winged serpent didn’t seem impaired by the hail.

Vainqueur opened his mouth to blast him from below, but the rider dodged the attack. “Here!” the cavalier shouted.

The forest shook, as the roots of the trees sprung out of the ground and snow. These tendrils immediately attempted to ensnare Vainqueur, who burned them with his fiery breath.

The drake rider above tossed his crimson rods to the ground near Vainqueur’s location; each detonating as soon as they hit the ground or the dragon’s flames. One of the blasts hit the dragon to the left, making his scales feel itchy.

You have taken weak damage.

It reminded him of the grasshoppers’ wind spear, except much weaker.

Worse, a magical circle appeared near Vainqueur on the ground, an enormous black sphere falling on it from above and causing a crater where

it stuck. The paupers sniped him from afar!

As the root attacks and bombardment grew more intense, Vainqueur let out a roar and charged through the forest to find a better battlefield, tossing trees to the ground and stepping on any manling unlucky enough to be on his path.

Within minutes, Vainqueur exited the forest to reach the shores of a frozen lake, sliding on the ice surface before regaining his footing. The hail battered his scales and wings in the open field.

You are taking passive damage from the [Hailstorm].

Vainqueur glanced around his location, rejoicing at the sight of his flames consuming the forest and turning the horizon black from the smoke.

“To the lake!” Grasshopper Cornelia ordered, and soon enough, her pack emerged from the fiery forest to face Vainqueur on the battlefield.

In total, thirteen creatures came after him, the drake rider included; Vainqueur recognized mages, rogues, and knights among them, a true pack of adventurers united to die by his hand. Most were manlings, but they included elves, one dwarf, a beastling, and even a green-skinned, meaty orc.

At the far end of the rear, Vainqueur noticed an elf woman with pale skin and blue hair riding a unicorn; wearing a heavy, bear-fur mantle and an icy crown, she looked like the leader.

And at her side... was a fairy in disguise.

While he had taken the shape of a white-bearded manling wearing a crimson cloak and hat, Vainqueur recognized the frail-looking insect for a fomor. The creature gave him a crooked smile, playing a song with its pipe made of bone.

“Mell Lin!” Vainqueur recognized that abominable trickster. He should have known he was behind this rabble revolt. “Have you come to see the back of my hand again, pied piper?”

“[Dispel Magic]!” A mage wearing symbol-covered robes pointed a finger at Vainqueur’s direction, removing his invisibility. Many in the adventurer army gasped at the sight of his crimson scales.

“He’s *huge*!” one of the mages, who dressed like a bedsheet ghost, gasped in awe of the dragon’s majesty.

“Odie, don’t stand there, summon an eidolon,” the mounted elf ordered, revealing herself as Grasshopper Cornelia.

“Y-yes!” the bedsheet ghost made strange movements, but Vainqueur reacted first. The dragon opened his mouth and attempted to burn the entire adventurer pack with fiery doom.

“[Enhanced Rune Barrier],” the symbol wizard reacted, creating a yellow, symbol-covered shield around the army. Although it cracked, the protection deflected Vainqueur’s breath, much to his annoyance. The flames started melting the snow and ice nearby, albeit not enough to destroy the lake’s surface.

“[Summon Snow Dancer]!” The bedsheet ghost finished his ridiculous dance, a white magical circle forming next to him. A lithe statue of ice with hair made of mist materialized within it. Superficially looking like an elf, the creature had blue crystal blades attached to her arms, and a white mask hiding her face. Thin strings linked her limbs to the bedsheet mage, like a puppet.

“Minion!” Vainqueur shouted, eager to be reunited with his chief of staff; if they summoned reinforcements, so would the Emperor. “MINION! Get back here!”

“He’s calling Dalton!” Cornelia warned as the barrier dispelled, allowing her warriors and the ice creature to charge at Vainqueur.

“[Ninjutsu: Seal Perk]!” A manling whose every patch of skin was covered in a black bodysuit made hand signs, and the dragon instantly felt weakened.

Your [**Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)**] has been sealed by Ninja Weeb!

You will not be able to use that Perk as long as Ninja Weeb stays on the field!

“Everyone, adopt the Azincourt formation! The Runemaster stays behind and protects the buffers!” Cornelia barked orders. “Cardinal, heal our tanks and damage dealers! Follow my strategy and we shall win!”

Her minions let out a shout of enthusiasm, while Vainqueur scoffed. He had crushed insect armies in the past, and he would do so again; even if he had to kill them twice.

The adventurers divided into various groups to encircle Vainqueur. At the front, the dragon faced the Snow Dancer, a buff manling behemoth with a huge hammer, a knight whose bronze armor was covered with runes, and a dwarf dressed as a priest. The drake rider joined them, providing aerial support.

Ninja Weeb and a piglike orc smelling of herbs and dung moved to his left; while an elf Bowman riding a horse flanked him to his right.

Elfling Cornelia stayed at the rear, alongside Mell Lin the Pied Piper, the Runemaster, a scantily-clad catkin, the Summoner, and a mage wearing a black cloak and a wizard hat.

“Spell Purge!” Vainqueur activated his favorite Perk and charged at Cornelia, ready to trample anyone in his path. The scantily-clad catkin began to dance, the fairy played a song, and the runemaster raised a barrier to protect the rearguard.

Dancer Felix’s [**Witchcat Tango**] raised the magical power of the enemy mages!

The front team intercepted Vainqueur, the hammer-wielding manling jumping at the dragon with his weapon raised. The dragon poked him out of the way, but surprisingly, the monkey survived the blow, crashing on the ice and quickly moving back to his feet. The Snow Dancer, sliding on the ice

with incredible speed, sliced at Vainqueur's ankle and quickly avoided a counterattack.

[Frostblade] inflicted a super effective hit! You have taken medium frost damage!

“[Waifu no Raiton]!” Ninja Weeb joined his hands to make a strange sign, firing a lightning bolt at Vainqueur, while the orc breathed a storm of petals. The dragon's scales deflected both attacks, the emperor instead backhanding the bronze knight. “Can't pierce the dragon's defense!”

“Sneak attack, the druid will switch to support,” Cornelia directed, turning to the black wizard at her side. “Wizi, use your strongest spells; all-out offense!”

“[Lesser Demonbane]!” Vainqueur cast at the Snow Dancer as she moved to attack again, hitting her. Both the creature and its summoner stumbled, making Vainqueur wonder if the latter possessed his minion. Before he could move to finish it off, the bowman rider fired an arrow at him from the side, while the drake rider prepared to throw more bombs. The archer fired first, Vainqueur raising an arm in the way and grunting on impact.

[Arrow of Dragonslaying] inflicted double damage!

Moving with exceptional speed, Vainqueur seized the horse before it could dash away, the archer with it, and threw both at the drake rider. The surprised cavalier couldn't evade the improvised projectile, the fighters crashing on the frozen lake.

Their bombs detonated, blasting them apart and causing part of the frozen surface to collapse; the orc mage was caught in the blast and then fell into the icy water.

The archer and the drake rider both reappeared wounded on the lake's icy surface, next to the hammer-wielder; the ring of light above their heads gone. “[Multi-Heal]!” The dwarf priest extended his hands, unleashing a pulse of golden energy around himself. The wounds of the warriors near him closed instantaneously.

Realizing that their magical protections shielded them from his physical attacks, Vainqueur switched to his breath, and cooked everyone in sight. His breath incinerated the drake rider, the archer, and the barbarian, killing the first two and causing the third to run around screaming in pain. The dwarf managed to dodge, while the Snow Dancer and the bronze knight hammered at his legs with their needling attacks. Enlightened, Vainqueur tossed the bronze knight into the open crack in the lake, watching him struggle to stay afloat before sinking.

Wizi the Black Wizard finished casting a spell, throwing a sinister sphere of black energy over the protective barrier, the projectile hitting Vainqueur in the back. His whole body had begun to feel itchy, but not as much as it did when he fought Maure.

You have taken medium Unholy damage!

You have lost twenty-five percent of your HP!

“The druid and the rune knight haven’t resurfaced, boss,” the catkin dancer panicked. “He’s tearing us apart!”

“We’re down half the team!” the Summoner panicked, while Vainqueur kept trying to incinerate his icy minion. “And what is Hilda doing? She should have killed the lackey already!”

“Knightsbane has lost more than one thousand HP and cannot regenerate!” Cornelia shouted, as if it was something to boast about; only the fairy didn’t panic, happily playing his pipe amidst the chaos. “Keep whittling him down! It’s life or death!”

“Yours!” Vainqueur taunted them back, in between two fiery attacks. Ninja Weeb, who had slipped past his notice, reappeared to leap at the dragon, sword in hand.

“Sayonara, reptile!” The blade connected with Vainqueur’s head...

And shattered.

The manling barely had the time to choke at his incompetence, before Vainqueur bit him in half.

He reappeared a few feet away, but Vainqueur didn't mind. He tasted like fish food, and couldn't wait to eat him again. "Invincible!" the dragon boasted, cheering himself up. "Vainqueur, Vainqueur, *Vainqueur!*"

Then the ground shook, as a new challenger stepped out of the forest. Vainqueur turned to face the new suicidal adventurer and found himself facing a golem instead.

A *huge* golem, almost as big as the dragon himself. A mechanical titan in heavy, knightlike plate armor, the automaton wielded a long sword as long as his own tail and a rounded shield with a strange hole at its center. Its face was a skull-shaped helmet, meant to intimidate manlings, and it stank of fairywork.

"That is the best challenge you fairies can provide?" Vainqueur scoffed. He hoped he would get a good treasure out of killing this walking tin can.

The golem ignored his words and charged at him, its shield raised. The dragon responded by humming and then blasting it with dragonfire...

... and it kept going.

Vainqueur's eyes widened in shock, as he increased his output; yet the golem kept charging, the shield deflecting the flames.

A mighty thunderbolt hit Vainqueur from behind, making him stumble and interrupting his attack.

You have been hit by [**Impending Doom**]!

Vainqueur barely had the time to regain his footing, before the golem reached him and slashed at his chest, cutting through his scales and shedding blood.

[**Dragonslayer Claymore**] inflicted heavy damage!

How could it be?

His flames burned brighter than the *sun*!

Meanwhile, Victor was fighting for his life; against his foes *and* poison.

You have taken passive [Poison] damage!

You have lost half your HP!

The vizier ignored the message, focused on anticipating the furious strikes of the Warmaster. He dodged, but couldn't avoid the crusader's weapon aiming for his chest. A sixth wound opened below his nipple, and he barely avoided the horseman's spear aiming for his head. The rider opened another rift before Victor could retaliate, vanishing once more.

He had managed to kill the crusader once with the help of the summoned undead, only for that tincan to return from death and heal. That warrior wasn't dangerous as much as resilient, flanking him to make the Warmaster's job at hitting his chest easier.

And *any* of her hits would kill him.

Only his [Fright Knight] technique had saved his life, weakening his foes enough to allow him to resist so far. *So far*.

“[Crit Up]!” the Warmaster buffed herself up, each of her stray strikes smashing a tree. Victor summoned another will'o wisp as a buffer, the crusader destroying it almost instantly.

Warning: you will soon run out of SP!

“I know!” Victor shouted, finally finding an opening in the crusader's defense and blasting his face with hellfire. This time, the warrior cooked in his armor and fell dead on the back.

Vitality check successful! You shed off your [**Poisoned**] Status.

Okay, that left only the Warmaster and the Rider. He could do this! Victor unleashed another fireball at his foe, but the woman jumped out of the way; he prepared to fire a second and—

You ran out of SP.

...

Out of mana!

Without any other chance at survival, Victor made a final dash to reach the corpses of the other adventurers he killed.

Most precisely, the bazooka.

Unfortunately, the atrocious sensation of an ice spear piercing his back dashed his hope, making him collapse in the snow.

Super Effective hit!

Warning: **critical health!**

You have fallen below twenty-five percent HP!

“Finally!” the nightmare horseman declared, he and his beast standing in front of Victor with both spears raised. “I thought he would never go down!”

“He got Sven,” the Warmaster replied sadly. “We’ve got to kill him and help the others. I can still hear the battle from afar.”

“Yeah, yeah,” the horseman replied, preparing to trample down Victor with his horse. “See you in Happyland, ass—”

“[Za Warudo]!”

In a blink, the rider had been turned to dust, his twin spears falling on the snow, and his horse stopped in confusion.

Victor's eyes widened, as a dark lich had popped into existence between the Warmaster and her prey. "Mine!" the undead snarled, before casually killing the hammer warrior with a crimson ray of light, "Mine, mine, *mine*!"

"Furibon?" Victor couldn't believe it. "You saved me?"

"Mine," the lich replied, as he zapped the Warmaster and the Horseman dead a second time when they returned from the dead. Unfortunately, he sounded more *pissed* rather than friendly, "[Enhanced Binding Cold]!"

As the lich spoke, chains made of ice appeared around Victor, binding him like a ham on the snow.

"Now, I can kill you *myself*."

Of course, he wouldn't save him. The vizier cursed under his breath, trying to melt the chains with hellfire.

You ran out of SP.

Damn it!

The Lich repaired Victor's scythe with a spell, grabbed it, and then raised the weapon above its previous holder's head, "It will be *just* like old times... except *I* will be the one to carry you around making your eternal existence unbearable."

"Joke is on you," Victor pointed out. "The soul trap only works if I carry out the final blow."

"Oh." The lich sounded disappointed but quickly recovered. "I guess I will settle on killing you the old fashioned way, then."

"Wait!" Victor insisted, "Don't I get a last request?"

Charisma check...

Failed!

"This would be a violation of stratagem fourteen."

Oh, come on!

Furibon lowered the scythe and preparing to behead his former captor. Victor's awaited the end... but the blade stopped within an inch of his neck. "You are not screaming?" the undead asked.

"Oh, you know, it's my third time," Victor shrugged. "It still sucks but you get used to it."

"Make an effort," Furibon ordered. "I did not save you for our relationship to end like this."

Why was the lich dragging his demise? Unless... unless...

Unless he secretly didn't *want* to go through with it.

"You have Stockholm Syndrome," Victor realized.

"... No..."

"You have Stockholm Syndrome!" Victor rejoiced, as the lich couldn't go through with the execution. "I knew it was contagious!"

"Shut up!" Furibon snarled, trembling but unable to go through with the kill. "I do not care! I do not... I am not sick!"

"I wanted to die too when I caught it," Victor reassured him. "You get used to it after a while."

"That is it!" The lich cursed in an ancient language, well and truly furious at his inability to kill Victor for good. "I am so *done* with you and that giant wyvern! I hope the fomors turn you both to lead!"

And with that final curse, Furibon teleported away in a flash of light, taking Victor's scythe with him.

The chains binding Victor soon dispelled, leaving him disarmed in the snow, and facing the now riderless nightmare horse. The vizier glanced at the corpses of the adventurers—mostly their equipment—and then the beast.

No, that... that would be ridiculous...

...

He couldn't resist.

Chapter 51: The Greatest Gladiator

For the first time since *forever*, Vainqueur found himself on the defensive.

Nothing worked!

The golem brushed off his claws, fangs, spells, and dragonfire! *Dragonfire!* The mightiest, warmest gift of dragonkind didn't work on a, a... a *farming machine!*

The golem kept fighting him at close range, and every stab of its sword *stung*. When Vainqueur attempted to put distance between them, the creature pointed its shield at him and fired lead spheres that hurt almost as much. The monkey's fighters also didn't stop hitting his ankles, especially that cursed snow creature and the hammer warrior. It didn't hurt much, but it made it harder to dodge the much more dangerous golem's strikes.

Another sword slash hit him in the chest, right next to the previous one.

You have taken heavy damage!

You have fallen below half your HP!

Now pushed, Vainqueur attempted to fly and get the high ground, hailstorm be damned.

The golem, seeing it coming, pointed its shield at the dragon and fired a cannonball; although Vainqueur dodged, the adventurers used the opportunity to target him with spells. "[Aura]!" the dwarf priest said, firing a beam of light at Vainqueur's wing and blowing a hole through it.

The great wyrm let out a grunt of pain, before landing on the ice—and crushing the dwarf priest underfoot while at it. The ice cracked beneath his and the golem’s feet, although it didn’t collapse.

The piper’s melody changed to a more oppressive tone, and the golem’s behavior changed to match it. The machine exhaled a cloud of miasma from its skull face, and although it itched to breathe it, Vainqueur resisted the attack.

[Mustard Gas Cloud] negated by **[Lesser Poison Resistance]**!

The manlings weren’t so tough though.

“My eyes!” The hammer warrior cried like a cow, dropping his hammer to scratch his bleeding eyes; the revived dwarf priest reappeared in the middle of the poisonous cloud and soon dropped dead. Only Ninja Weeb avoided the attack by leaping away, while the Snow Dancer ignored the attack like Vainqueur did.

“Hey!” one of the adventurers hiding at the rear turned to the fairy. “You’re hitting our own!”

The fairy responded by changing his melody from gloomy to violently aggressive, and the golem began to swing its blade with maniacal fury. Vainqueur barely had the time to leap to the side, the machine’s claymore smashing the hammer manling into a bloody puddle.

The adventurers understood the message and shut up. The Snow Dancer and Ninja Weeb put distance between the golem and them, giving breathing room to Vainqueur.

Since the fairy obviously controlled his puppet with his pipe, the dragon turned to the dreadful musician’s direction and shot a fireball at him. Once again, the Runemaster shielded him and the other annoyances with a barrier.

He knew he should have become a wizard!

...

That was it.

That scrap creature had been built to fight dragons... so Vainqueur shouldn't fight it like a dragon.

He should fight like a *witch hunter emperor gladiator*.

The dragons had created this system to become stronger and richer. *There* lied the key to his victory! Energized, Vainqueur stopped walking on his four limbs and instead stood on his back legs, his claws tightened into fists.

“What the—?” Insect Cornelia was at a loss of words before Vainqueur's fabulous fighting pose. “Is that a *boxing stance*?!”

“[Victory Fist],” Vainqueur said, feeling the system's knowledge empower his body.

The golem took a step attempted to skewer the dragon.

Vainqueur, acting entirely on instinct, dodged the sword, and punched the golem in a cross-counter. His fist bypassed the titan's defense and smashed it right in its metal face, the icy ground shaking under the power of the blow.

Critical hit!

The scrap pile stumbled back, just in time for Vainqueur to hit it again with a jab. The blow sent bolts flying, and the emperor felt his dragon blood rising up. He should pick a name for his technique, such as the Poke...

The scrap machine attempted to retaliate, but each time, Vainqueur wasted it with counterattacks. Deflecting the blade with his palm, moving his punches in hook-like motions, using his superior agility to run circles around his punching bag...

Each blow tore off part of the machine's armor, revealing nuts, bolts, and shining symbols beneath the armor.

“He’s beating the tar out of the golem. He’s punching the golem to death.” Insect Cornelia began to panic as Vainqueur punched the golem further back, while even the fairy began to look doubtful. “Don’t just stand there and watch! Stop him!”

“Oh, right!” the bedsheet ghost replied, sending the Snow Dancer after Vainqueur, while Wizi the Wizard began to cast another spell from behind the barrier.

“[Husbando Bushin]!” Ninja Weeb said, creating two clones of himself and trying to flank the dragon; with the golem temporarily stunned, the emperor turned towards the new challengers.

Vainqueur could smell they were only illusions and was not fooled. With casual contempt, he slapped the true rogue with the back of his hand, crushing his bones and sending him to fly across the sky and into the fiery forest.

Ninja Weeb has left the field. Your Perk has been unsealed!

“Minion!” Vainqueur called his chief of staff, the Snow Dancer avoiding one of his mighty jabs. “MINION! I am not raising you again!”

Answering his command, space ripped in half, and his chief of staff rode through on a flaming horse’s back. He hid something beneath his robes, and while bleeding profusely grinned at seeing his master again.

[**Master’s Shield**] activated! You gained the [**Regen**] status.

“Hilda failed?!” Insect Cornelia cursed, the puny adventurers losing hope as Vainqueur’s wounds began to close.

“Minion! You finally came!” Vainqueur rejoiced, briefly turning around to punch back the golem in the face, before pushing back the relentless summoned creature with his tail.

“And here I thought I would save Your Majesty,” Manling Victor said. “But you’re handily winning this!”

“You will help,” Vainqueur declared. “By cheering me up!”

“Vainqueur, best dragon!” his chief of staff began to sing, drowning out the fairy’s melody. “Vainqueur, best dragon!”

“Nothing can stop me now!” the dragon boasted, turning back towards the golem. “I am unforgettable!”

“Well, well, well,” the fomor briefly interrupted his wicked song. “It was fun while it lasted.” And then he ran away into the forest, abandoning his minions while humming a playful melody.

[**Despair**] spread through your enemies’ ranks! All their stats are decreased by two stages!

“Everyone support Wizi!” Insect Cornelia ordered, her catkin dancer making moves to empower the wizard. “[Final Gambit]!”

Wizi the Dark Magician’s offensive power drastically increased, but his defenses dropped!

“Oh no, you don’t!” Manling Victor charged at the barrier with his horse. Vainqueur trusted him and focused on finishing off the golem instead. The bedsheet summoner moved the Snow Dancer to intercept his chief of staff; a rift in space appeared before the horse, and the rider crossed it.

Vainqueur’s minion reappeared behind the protective barrier, trapping them between their own shield and himself.

“And it is with great joy that I say this...” Manling Victor revealed a strange cannon, which he had previously hidden beneath his robes. “Say hello to my little friend!”

“[Enhanced Earthqua—]” But Wizi the Wizard wasn’t fast enough. Manling Victor fired a projectile right in the midst of the fairy’s minions.

An enormous explosion tore the group apart, the barrier collapsing almost instantly; the strings controlling the Snow Dancer were severed, the

summoned creature immediately skidding away. When the dust settled, only blood and corpses remained, his minion chasing a survivor into the forest.

One-hit polykill! [**Astrologer/Tactician**] Cornelia has been killed!

Cornelia's [**Gambits**] and [**Hailstorm**] have been canceled!

As the golem, the last opponent standing, put its shield up to protect himself, Vainqueur moved in to finish it off. The dragon kicked it in the leg and made its defense collapse; while his fist moved into an uppercut, a title finally came to Vainqueur's mind.

“Feel the weight of my wealth!” the Emperor declared. “Hoard Punch!”

Uppercutting the golem with such force to throw it on its back; the ice cracked beneath it. The machine didn't get up.

Grabbing the golem with both hands, Vainqueur forcefully lifted the machine above his head, then inhaled. Time to test his new Perk.

“[Charged Attack]!”

Vainqueur opened his mouth, and instead of unleashing flames, his breath turned into a blinding beam of golden light.

The ice shook under the sheer weight of his powerful attack, the ray hitting the golem in the chest. Vainqueur's attack melted the fairywork metal, pierced the creature's chest, and came out on the other end; his light splintered the heavens and dispersed the hail clouds.

The ray eventually shattered the golem in half and kept going, clearing the skies and going up into the dark depths of space. At long last, Vainqueur closed his mouth, and tossed the broken remains of the golem at his feet.

A long, crimson and golden cape appeared out of the golem's remains, a royal mantle for Vainqueur to wear.

Flawless victory!

Congratulations, that was BEEPing awesome.

For prevailing in this epic battle, you earned eight levels in [**Kaiser**], and three levels in [**Gladiator**]! You earned the [**Victory Roar**], [**Mirror Scale**], [**Fire Crown**], [**Immovable**], [**Show-off**], and [**Gold Shower**] Class Perks!

330 HP, +60 SP, +14 STR, +8 VIT, +8 SKI, +8 AGI, +5 INT, +11 CHA, +9 LCK.

[**Victory Roar**]: Technique, 30 SP. You can unleash a mighty roar lowering the Strength of every enemy within earshot by one stage.

[**Mirror Scale**]: If a spell fails to pierce through your magical defenses, it is automatically reflected back to the sender.

[**Fire Crown**]: Technique, 100 SP. You can temporarily surround yourself with a mantle of burning flames for fifteen minutes, which will inflict medium Fire and Dragon Type damage to anyone caught in its range. Your weakness to Frost turns into a resistance as long as [Fire Crown] is active.

[**Immovable**]: You cannot be Teleported or Banished against your will.

[**Show-off**]: You receive +20 evasion and +20 precision when you do not wear armor.

[**Gold Shower**]: When you defeat an elite enemy, you have a chance of being showered with gold. The percentage of triggering this Perk is equal to your Luck stat.

By gaining enough levels in your various classes and your [**Crested**] Perk, you can now combine some of your classes into stronger—

Vainqueur didn't read any longer, mesmerized by a surreal sight.

It was raining gold.

The dragon extended his arms, abandoning himself to the blissful feeling of coins raining down his scales.

Riding the Nightmare Horse, Victor pursued the last adventurer through the woods. It was easy enough, he just had to follow the bloody footsteps in the snow.

He eventually tracked the survivor to a hidden grotto under a small hillock, which must have served as a camp for the adventurers. They had mostly stocked a huge amount of weapons there, both old and modern; bows, spears, grenades...

Also, *dragons*.

Victor counted at least seven small dragonlings no bigger than black bears, heavily chained in steel cages. They had found the missing dragons.

“Help!” one of the small dragons, white as snow, rejoiced at the sight of Victor. “We’re saved!”

“Manlings can’t be saviors,” another wyrmling replied. “They don’t have souls!”

Victor ignored the slur, pointing his weapon at the only other human in the cave.

Wizi the Wizard was bleeding profusely, desperately searching for an item among the stockpile of weapons, turning around when he heard Victor. He carried a Crest painted black in his hands.

“You’re awfully resilient for a mage,” Victor said. His boss and compatriots died easily enough, but that guy survived the blast with his defenses down *and* had enough strength to keep running.

Still, he was clearly clinging to life only by a narrow margin.

“[Dark Magicians] have S in HP growth,” ‘Wizi’ replied, brandishing the blackened crest, “Now back off, or I... I *will* use *this*!”

Victor’s [Eye for Treasure] instantly identified the item.

[**Black Crest**]: An artificial Crest created by the fomor Mag Mell. Allows the user to break past both class ceilings, but forcefully grant them ten levels in a sinister Monster Class.

“I’m not bluffing!”

“Sure, go ahead. What will be quicker? Your Crest...” Victor pointed his rocket launcher at the wizard, “or my bazooka?”

“You won’t shoot in an enclosed space.”

“Are you betting your life on it?”

The mage hesitated, his eyes moving between both items, and then succeeded on his Intelligence check.

He lowered the crest and put his hands behind his head.

“Wise choice,” Victor replied, before turning to the dragonlings. “It’s okay, I’m here to help.”

“When I am grown, I will make you my chief of staff!” one of the female dragonlings said.

“I am already taken, but thank you,” Victor replied, before glaring at the wizard. “You caught and beat up children?”

“I am eighty!” a dragonling protested.

“Have you looked at the adults?” Wizi grunted back. “That coward Hamelin and that vampire just wanted blood samples from dragons with class levels. They gave us weapons in return, and promised they would take care of the dragon problem.”

“And you *believed* them?”

“What other choice did we have?”

“Okay, they may have tricked some adult dragons into fighting each other, but what was your plan afterward? Blackmail the parents by threatening the kids? Dispose of them? How did you think kidnapping young dragons would end in anything *but* a disaster?”

“We... okay, after a point, we were making stuff as we went on.” Victor narrowed his eyes. “Hey, we didn’t think we would actually catch any of them!”

Victor blinked, then sighed at the sheer stupidity.

Congratulations! For your prowess in this battle, you earned three levels in [**Reaper**] and two levels in [**Assassin**]. Thanks to your chaotic alignments, [**Crested**], and [**Monster Student**], you have also taken a level in the elite [**Chaos Rider**] monster class!

You earned the [**Hades Blast**], [**Necromancy III**], [**Blade Stinger**], and [**Black Horseman**] class perks!

60 HP, +20 SP, +3 STR, +2 VIT, +8 SKI, +6 AGI, +6 INT, +6 CHA, +4 LCK

[**Hades Blast**]: Spell effect, HP cost. You sacrifice part of your lifeforce to unleash a powerful blast of Spirit energy at your foe; the more HP you sacrifice, the stronger the blast. Alternatively, you can force an ally within twenty feet to pay the price for you on a successful Charisma check.

[**Necromancy III**]: You can now learn and use Necromancy spells up to tier three. This replaces Necromancy II.

[**Blade Stinger**]: You can apply the [**Poisoned**] quality to your bladed weapons. This poison will inflict weak passive damage, but the victim has a chance of curing themselves on a successful vitality check every minute.

[**Black Horseman**]: You gain perfect proficiency in riding, but only with monstrous mounts. At will, you can mark a willing monster as your steed, which you can then summon to you at any time. You can only have one steed marked at once.

“Do you have gold, manling?” one of the wyrmlings asked.

“Uh, yes, why?”

“G-give it to me. Give me your money.”

His amazing cape floating to the howling wind, Vainqueur glanced at the skies, his manling at his side. His kindred had been set free, the last adventurer chained for trial, and the enemy routed. Yet, he couldn't rejoice.

“Overall, while this isn't a perfect victory, I say Your Majesty came out of this adventure with more good than harm,” Manling Victor said, always seeing the positive even in the darkest of times. “We got a huge amount of loot. More than if we had fulfilled a quest.”

“You call this a victory, minion?” Vainqueur couldn't shake his overwhelming sense of dread filling the air. A dark cloud, once banished, had swept back unto the land, bringing an end to his happy days. “The enemy is out there.”

“It's true that the fomor escaped, but we have a prisoner and the golem's remains—”

“Who cares about the fairy?!” Vainqueur turned to his manling, fire in his eyes. How could his chief of staff not understand the *gravity* of the *situation*? The sinister consequences of this day for dragonkind, no, the world at large? “I am talking about the *true* enemy of dragonkind, no, life itself!”

A great darkness, once barely kept at bay, had *returned*. The seal was broken.

“Minion, the vile Furibon has escaped!”

Manling Victor fell silent, crushed by his shame. Finally, he understood that in failing to keep the monstrous lich imprisoned, all the countless *atrocities* the goldslayer would commit shall be on his head.

Nothing would be the same anymore.

“There shall be a new War of the Hoard,” Vainqueur said with the grimness of an old warrior, glancing at the horizon as if he could glimpse the pitch blackness of the era ahead. “And the world will know the terror of lead, once again...”

Chapter 52: To the Moooooon!

“I’m surprised Your Majesty wanted to join me on this one,” Manling Victor said, guiding his master to a valley near Murmurin. “I thought you considered ruling minion work.”

“The vile Furibon has returned, Friend Victor,” Vainqueur reminded his trusty sidekick. “My empire is no longer safe. We must remain vigilant, and prepare for the dark times ahead.”

There was still one of those conmanlings to deal with, but with Furibon’s escape, Vainqueur had decided to put his revenge on hold. The dark lich, whose imprisonment had only made crueler and bitter, would doubtlessly take revenge for his shameful defeat.

And the Emperor would be ready to defend his hoard once again. “While I trusted you to *Do the Thing*, I shall now take a personal interest in managing my Empire and build its defenses against invaders. I shall also order the minions build me an arena.”

“An arena?”

“A great, shining arena where my subjects can shower me with gold every week!”

The dragon and his lackey oversaw the valley, or rather, the crater created by the Iron Eagle when Vainqueur threw it there. The dwarves had taken over the area and turned it into an open scrapyard, scavenging the ship’s remains while building forges and workshops nearby. They had also created strange metallic constructs that the dragon couldn’t identify.

More surprising, his eccentric guests had started rebuilding the Eagle itself, pulling back its wings and polishing its cannons.

Marbré, the dwarf's leader, waited for them next to it alongside two bodyguards. "Emperor Vainqueur, Grand Vizier Victor!" he saluted them, as they landed on his side. "Welcome! You come back to us triumphant!"

"Hi, Marbré," Victor replied on both his and his master's behalf.

"First, let me congratulate you on exporting the revolution across borders," the dwarf said, Vainqueur puffing his chest. "Twice, you have killed an elf imperialist, *and* crushed a fairy-sponsored counter-revolution."

"Yes, yes, you are too kind," Vainqueur replied. "But now is not the time for praise. Now is the time for action! We are at war!"

"Have you given a look to the golem's head?" Manling Victor asked, annoying his master by underestimating the threat of Furibon in favor of that tin can.

Manling Victor had insisted that they bring back the golem for the dwarves to oversee, but carrying it and the looting bag had proven too tiresome for Vainqueur. The dragon had settled on taking the head and some gears, before dumping the rest in the ocean.

"It is one of the most fascinating pieces of technology I have seen yet," the dwarf replied. "I recognize the form Mag Mell's handiwork, but the core mechanisms look similar to those of the Eagle. Our engineers have only barely begun studying that machine, and it will take us weeks to disassemble it."

"Clearly, the fairies elaborated this entire operation to free the vile Furibon from his seal," Vainqueur said. "We must prepare ourselves for his return, and this means strengthening our military."

"Your Majesty, I believe these events are unconnected—"

"Manling Victor, you are my adviser, but I won all the wars," Vainqueur cut him off. "Do you not see the great conspiracy trying to take me down? How it all fits?"

“Your enemies are the enemies of the Averagist Revolution, and you can count on us to support you.” Marbré nodded, the dwarf seeing the bigger picture. “We will lend you our strength and expertise.”

“Then show me.”

The dwarf ambassador waved a hand at the Iron Eagle. “As you can see, we have analyzed this elf weapon, and in two weeks, it will work again. It shall, without a doubt, become the backbone of your country’s military, and allow you to cross the ocean to export the revolution across the world.”

Vainqueur remembered something. “Minion, the vile Furibon, who is evil and must be destroyed again, said his phylactery was hidden on another continent. If sealing could not keep him imprisoned, we have to find his soul, and destroy him for good.”

“Yes, Your Majesty, but there are eight continents since Atlantis is still a thing on Outremonde. Do you really intend to explore all of them?”

“I will spare no effort to see the lich destroyed,” Vainqueur ordered with a firm nod. “I want this machine painted gold and staffed with minions. It shall no longer be called the *Iron Eagle*, but the *Piggy Bank*.”

His piggy bank.

“Your Majesty, I do not want to be the one to say it, but...” Manling Victor struggled to find his words, while the dwarves remained stone-faced. “The name is not... not very good.”

“I am a dragon,” Vainqueur replied. “It shall be known as the Piggy Bank.”

Friend Victor let out a strange sound. “Why not Flying Gold?”

“That sounds too imperialistic,” Marbré contested.

“See?” Vainqueur replied. “Manling Victor, leave the names to me and focus on our class progression. Doubtlessly, our enemy has learned his lesson, and the tricks we used to put him down shall not work again. I expect you to research further ways to increase our strength.”

Speaking of classes... while Marbré gave them a tour of the weapon forges, Vainqueur let his minion handle the discussions for a moment to check on his new features.

Congratulations! Due to meeting entry requirements through your **[Crested]** Perk and **[Gladiator]** levels, you can convert some of your levels into promoted Classes! Stats will not be affected, but Perks will.

You can combine **[Gladiator]** with **[Emperor]** into **[Augustus]**, or **[Gladiator]** and **[Witch Hunter]** into **[Godhand]**.

[Augustus]: a glamorous emperor ruling through fabulous charm, bread, and circus. Specialties: Unarmed, All Melee Weapons, and Leadership. Major growths in Strength, Skill, Charisma, and Luck. Perks affected: Noblesse Oblige.

[Godhand]: A melee-fighter empowering his fists with magical effects to take down mages. Specialties: Unarmed, Anti-magic, Status Ailments, and Self-Buffs. Major growths in Strength, Skill, Vitality, and Agility. Perks affected: Witch Burning, Hunter's Resolve, Exorcism.

"Augustus!" Vainqueur immediately decided. **[Witch Hunter]** had served him well against the evil Furibon in the past, and certainly combining his two favorite classes could only end well.

Choice registered! Your **[Gladiator]** and **[Emperor]** levels have been transformed into **[Augustus]** levels. **[Gladiator]** and **[Emperor]** are no longer accessible.

[Noblesse Oblige] replaced with **[King of Games]**.

[King of Games]: Whenever you face a check in a game or game-like situation, you gain a stat bonus equal to your Charisma divided by four.

Pffft, of course he would always win any game he participated in. The fact his limitless charm was recognized made his day, though.

“We have already started smelting weapons for your armed forces, in partnership with your troll smith,” the dwarf declared, bringing Vainqueur back to reality.

“We should be ready for any outside attack, but I can’t say the same for infiltration,” Manling Victor said, before turning to his master. “Is your Majesty happy with the dwarf’s work?”

“Almost,” Vainqueur replied. “Dwarf Marbré, my kind has once again proved its superiority over all of life, completing quests and leaving me without honest, richly rewarded work. For the sake of my hoard, I must now turn my eyes to a new frontier, and the gold mine up in the skies.”

“The Moooooooooon?”

“The Moon, yes.”

“Thanks the gods, Your Majesty says it the right way,” Manling Victor flattered his master. “Also, this is a *literal* mission from god.”

“Gods are the drug dealers of the people,” Marbré replied with a stone face. “You will outgrow them.”

“I could fly up to the Moon, but I would burn so much fat I would become skinny and ravenous,” Vainqueur said. “I would have to eat every cow in sight and hibernate, which would leave my hoard unattended. Henceforth, Dwarf Marbré, find a way to send me to the Moon without any effort from my part.”

“How could Your Majesty fly to the Moon without breathing air?” Manling Victor asked a silly question.

“Manling Victor, I breathe fire, not air.” Vainqueur rolled his eyes at this idiocy. “How could you forget that after all that we have shared?”

“True, that was a stupid remark,” Manling Victor replied with a flat tone.

“Indeed, which is very unlike you.”

“Grand Vizier, if I may, what makes you say there is no air in space?”
Marbré the dwarf asked.

“Because there isn’t,” Manling Victor replied. “My kind... or rather, those of my homeworld of Earth, already managed to send people to space. It’s a big, dark, empty void.”

“That...” Marbré considered the question. “That makes our war against the sun much more difficult than expected.”

“And there isn’t air on the moon... I think.” Manling Victor marked a short pause. “Come to think of it, maybe I should ask Thul-Gathar. But I am ninety-nine percent sure there is neither air nor gravity in space.”

“I should have known the cowardly sun would build a fortress between justice and him,” the dwarf replied. “Moon Beasts favored by the Moon Man have interplanetary teleportation as a special Perk, but they cannot bring anyone with them. But thankfully, we may have a solution. A rocket.”

“A rocket?” Vainqueur and Victor asked at once.

In response, Marbré led them to a bigger, half-built version of the Wind Spear which Maure tried to kill Vainqueur with.

“Marbré.”

“Yes, Grand Vizier Victor?”

“That’s a primitive missile, not a rocket.”

“What difference does it make?” Vainqueur asked, curious.

“This is a bigger replica of the Wind Spear Maure used against us! It’s a weapon, not a transporter!”

“Our Sunslayer was built purely for non-threatening purposes,” the dwarf replied with a flat tone. “We have absolutely no intention of attacking anyone with it.”

“There are *bombs* on this thing!” Manling Victor protested. “I can smell the gunpowder from there!”

“Bombs are people too, Lord Victor. They react to imperialist aggression by blowing themselves up, true, but who is to say they should be barred from boarding a rocket—”

“A missile.”

“Certainly travel should be allowed to everyone, even bombs. *And* I can assure you that our rocket never exploded in the past.”

“Wait... I received complains of quakes while we were away,” Manling Victor said. “That was *your* doing?”

“Our rocket never blew up. It was sabotaged by elf bourgeois infiltrators before the flight because they feared the revolution.”

“Furibon,” Vainqueur guessed. “He is already at work among us!”

“Right,” Manling Victor said with a strange tone.

“And as you pointed out if we manage to send someone up, it must survive in a vacuum,” Marbré insisted. “Bombs are small and do not breathe.”

“What does size have to do with this?” Vainqueur asked with a worried frown.

“Our device needs gravity powerstones, which are extremely rare, to propel itself past the clouds,” Marbré replied. “The more weight, the more stones needed. We cannot afford to waste any of our supply, so the prototype should be able to fly small passengers before we create a model sized for Your Majesty. And unfortunately, none of our test pilots survived the tests so far. This slows down progress.”

“Yeah, speed hurts,” Victor said, “There were a few victims in the space race at home, and while we don't have magic, we are way ahead of this world in matters of technology.”

"It will take us years, if not decades, to create a rocket capable of reaching the Moooooon, but it would be much faster if we had pilots who could survive test flights," Marbré said, "We need a test subject who is highly resistant to physical damage, does not need to breathe, and small enough to fit in a very narrow space. Such creatures aren't raining—"

Vainqueur's eyes widened. "Minions, they do!"

"Babies?"

"To send to the Moon," Victor replied to his pet. That exchange sounded a *lot* better in his mind.

After the whole jelly rain fiasco, Victor had turned one of the farms into an improvised shelter, which Junior had turned into its new lair. While Akhenapep had advised to distribute cats to control the population, Murmurin's citizens had instead latched onto jellies. Slimes had become popular pets, and those eager to adopt one had to first gain Junior's trust before they could return home with it. Victor counted thousands of the tiny creatures looking at Vainqueur in awe from behind a fence.

"Moon sky?" Junior pointed a finger at the clouds.

"Yes, the planet," Vainqueur invited himself in the conversation.

"No!" Junior hissed in response, moving between Vainqueur and the fence. "Children!"

"Okay, I will not lie, the dwarf's device looks shoddy," Victor admitted. "But I will have Barnabas help. We will make sure our tester is as safe as possible."

"Minion, stop arguing with your pet, this is ridiculous," Vainqueur cut in, the dragon turning to Junior. "I understand that you wish to protect your progeny, but this is for my own good."

Strangely, Junior seemed to hesitate at Vainqueur's words, but still didn't bulge. "Danger!"

While Vainqueur glanced down at the mimic with annoyance, Victor's mind furiously worked on finding a peaceful solution before the dragon ate his own pet for the defiance. Fortunately, the sound of a large crowd stepping towards them interrupted the argument.

The second he recognized the newcomers, Victor suppressed a sigh of agony.

"Prophet, we have heard of your divine mission, and have come to offer our help!" The cult of the Moon Man had gathered, from its squid priest to its lowest member. Worse, they had grown in numbers, followers of the deity from all across the Mistral Continent having traveled to Murmurin to follow in their prophet's footsteps. "We shall all give our hands for the creation of the glorious ark!"

"Guys, thanks, but this is a very delicate matter," Victor said, trying to let them down gently. They had become relatively harmless since he laid down rules for them to follow, but their zealousness frightened him a bit. "We are just figuring out a way to—"

"I offer my child!" A squid-like humanoid presented Victor with a viscous tadpole. "He is moist and ready for the sacrifice!"

"Sacrifices are forbidden!" another cultist replied. "Learn the proper doctrine!"

"I will gladly offer my jelly pet Finky as the chosen slime!" A werewolf presented Victor with a pink slime, slipping through his fingers. "Please, bless him!"

"Take my life if needed!" A werewolf all but threw herself at his feet. "I am ready to be martyred, so my children can reach the Promised Land!"

"Me first!" The cultists all but began to shove one another out of the way.

"Friend Victor, how great that you have found such zealous minions," Vainqueur spoke up with appreciation, "I am so proud."

Victor closed his eyes and sighed. He was starting to wonder if he should go Old Testament on them; a lot of prophets didn't show as much patience as he did with this insanity.

No seriously, how could this madness end well?

"Moon!"

A cute, kitten-like voice made itself heard, Victor glancing at its source; the cultists fell silent to imitate him.

A blue jelly with two big, yellow eyes, had jumped on the fence. "Moon!" it said, before hopping at Victor's feet. "Moon!"

"Danger!" Junior shouted back at the jelly with a disapproving voice.

"Adventure!"

"Young!"

"Stars! Dream!"

"Family!"

Victor watched Junior and the jelly have a heated one-word argument, unable to fully understand the gist of it. From afar, it did look like the discussion he once had with his parents about abandoning his stupid dreams about becoming a professional Youtuber to go to university.

"Moon moon!" The slime was a lot better at arguing back than Victor ever was though. "Sword rocket!"

"Sword rocket?" This argument took Junior aback, the chest turning to Victor. "Sword rocket?"

What? What did he miss? "It's, uh, it's pointy yes." Wait, how did it know? Did the slime watch the tests?

"Sword rocket..." Junior turned back towards its adopted child, "Moon?"

“Moon,” the jelly replied with steely determination in its cute, tiny eyes.

“Back,” Junior pleaded. “Alive.”

“Sword live,” the jelly replied with a kind, affectionate tone. Junior patted it on the head, the creature turning to Victor next, “Moon?”

“Uh...” At this point, Victor had abandoned all hope of making sense out of it. “Yes, you will go to the Moon. One day. Maybe.”

It would probably take years, if not decades, for their ‘space program’ to reach it even with magic, but with Vainqueur and a deity dead-set on the idea... they had to succeed *eventually*.

“Moon!”

“The chosen jelly will lead us to the Mooooon!” the cultists cheered the jelly and began to utter prayers to their god. “*Lä Moon Man cf’ayak’vulgtmm, vugtlagln vulgtmm!*”

Congratulations! Thanks to your encouragement, Buzz Jelly gained a level in [**Stuntman**]!

“Mooooon...” The blue slime gazed at the skies with longing.

Chapter 53: Interlude: The Fairy Lords

The fomor Hamelin loved human weapons.

“This is the legendary weapon [**Magnum**],” he told the manling while presenting him the silver-plated gun. “It was used by Knight Lee Oswald to kill King Lincoln at the battle of Pearl Harbor. It is like a bow that can pierce even the toughest hide.”

The manling, some self-righteous bounty hunter, looked at the weapon with fascination. “King Lincoln?”

“The King of America, the world beyond the sea,” Hamelin lied. “It is a land of weapons, where dragons called dinosaurs existed.”

“Existed?”

Hamelin responded with a crooked grin.

One of his rats made noise while jumping on one of the back-alley’s trash piles. The manling turned around, trying to see in the darkness of the night; he had been on edge since the meeting started, wary of Barin’s watch interrupting them.

“Don’t worry,” Hamelin reassured the animal. His rats surveyed the area, keeping watch of the perimeter from the roofs. He continued the presentation as if nothing happened, although the manling remained uneasy. “Point, and pull the trigger. So easy, even children can use it.”

The piper approached his lips to the manling’s ears.

“They did.”

That was why he adored firearms. They were deadly and so easy to use, that an untrained peasant could kill a trained knight with it. The perfect spark for wars, revolts, and slaughters.

The more the manling listened, the more he looked like a bear having found a honeypot. He feared the bees, but the prize tasted so sweet. “Can it kill dragons?”

“Only the younger ones, and the eggs. It will hurt the bigger ones, but not kill.”

“The eggs?”

“The best way to deal with dragons is to smash their eggs and kill their young before they grow big and unmanageable. Just put [**Magnum**] in between their eyes, and pull the trigger.”

“Killing... kill their young?” The manling recoiled at his words. Why did the mortals always turn self-righteous when children were mentioned?

Still, the piper sensed this one just needed a little push to come around his way of thinking. “They don’t have feelings, my friend. They’re predators and thieves the moment they are born. Have you seen any dragon hesitate about burning houses with screaming innocents inside? Of course not. That’s why we have got to kill them every last one of ‘em. It’s a *knightly* duty.”

That line always worked. No matter how hard they tried to portray themselves as mercenaries, adventurers always wanted to be looked up to deep down.

“Yeah...” Hamelin said nothing, letting the manling convince himself.

“Yeah, you’re right. They’re literally monsters.”

“Greedy monsters. Once they just stole gold, now they even take jobs. They don’t care about you. It’s a tough world, and you have to defend your

livelihood, right?”

“But what about the adults? If I-”

“We have the weapons to kill adults too, and we will handle them,” Hamelin reassured the manling, “But everyone has to do their part. Will you do yours? Will you rise up and seize the day?”

The bounty hunter nodded, taking the weapon. “You said you had others?”

“Plenty.” Although his stockpile shrank a lot faster than he thought. “I keep the best for myself and my friends. Maybe you will become part of the inner circle too, one day.”

“How much do you want?”

“I’m doing it for the cause,” Hamelin replied, giving him a letter. “But if you want more and better stuff, you have to prove your dedication. Capture young dragons with class levels, alive, and give them to our care.”

The manling took the paper, read it, then incinerated the contents with a spell to leave no trace. “It’s as good as done.”

“I only believe in what I see,” Hamelin replied. “Get results, and I will contact you again.”

The hunter responded with a sharp nod and offered his hand. Although the physical contact privately disgusted him, the fomor took it with a smirk.

Mell Lin, who preferred the nickname of the Pied Piper of Hamelin after his most infamous crime, watched the manling leave with the weapon hidden beneath his cloak. That deal went well, and hopefully, this one would succeed at slaying a dragon, where many of his kind failed.

If he didn’t, that meant one less manling to kill down the line.

Claimed were harder to bait. They had grown up with firearms, and while they recognized their potential, they lacked the quasi-religious respect their

descendants had for guns and rifles. They always asked too many questions about where he got the weapons from, and he often had to silence them.

Most fomors were cold as ice, but Hamelin was different. Where his kind held nothing but apathy for mortals and considered killing them a chore, the piper had come to enjoy the good work.

He had toyed with mortals for centuries, in one form or another. Once, long before they learned the power of classes, he had come across a manling village infested with rats. On a whim, he took on a human shape and offered the villagers to take care of the problem, leading the rats with his pipe to drown in a river.

The manlings refused to pay him.

So Hamelin sang another song, and they paid the price with blood.

The fond memory made the fairy chuckle. Those were the old days when the Old Folk ruled over lesser creatures, and none but the dragons could challenge them. Then the mortals learned the power of Classes, and the natural order crumbled.

The fomors still had strongholds across Outremonde. They ruled Prydain, and held sway in the Dark Forest covering most of the world. King Wotan and Baba Yaga also ruled vast expanses north of the Winter Kingdoms, but they were too soft toward mortals. They let them *live*.

But these shallow kingdoms shrank every century, a decline which Balaur halted, but could not stop.

Would Mell Odieuse do better? So far, he liked his sister's style, subtle and devious like his own.

One of his rat familiars crawled to him, Hamelin lowering his head to listen to his report. The piper had granted a mind to that beast, and unlike the bigger ratkin, the rodent remembered his *place*. "The paladin and the dragonling returned the bottle to Barsino," the rat told his master. "He greeted them with a feast."

“What about Mot?”

“V&V sealed him within his own bottle with a wish and ordered that he never get out again.”

That idiot. They would need magic greater than Mot’s to unseal him, and only Baba Yaga’s sorcery fit that criteria. Unfortunately, she *despised* the djinn.

Should they ask Sablar? The fomors had a loose alliance with that mercurial deity, but it was his high priest who caught Mot in the first place. “Can you steal the bottle?”

“No,” the rat shook his head. “Even if I could, we would surely be seen.”

Not a fair trade. Hamelin’s slaves had proven their value time and time again, while Mot had been stupid enough to get caught by mortals *twice*. He would have his rodents keep an eye on the bottle in case an opportunity to snatch it presented itself, but the fomor wouldn’t take any risk. “At least the tactician will not make any wish.”

“He was surprisingly happy with the result.” Hamelin’s eyes squinted at these words. “The paladin reacted the same way, so Barsino told her he had wanted to study the bottle’s design and then bury it in a place where it would never be found. He knew Mot would twist any wish he made.”

“The design, you say?” Hamelin quickly caught on. An artifact that could trap even the strongest of the fairies... of course, the famed tactician would want to study a powerful weapon against the fomors. He had survived more assassination attempts from them than that ‘Fidel Castro’ did on Earth.

Fairies had a long memory, and they never forgot a slight. Barsino had played a large role in Balaur’s defeat, and Mell Odieuse had marked him for death, like that paladin.

Especially the paladin. “What of Kia Bekele and Knightsbane’s niece?”

“Barsino welcomed the human with a feast and showered the dragonling with diamonds. She declared him her new best friend, and they laughed. The tactician said great games would be organized in their honor.”

This would strand them in Barin for weeks. Hamelin considered the situation, an idea for mischief crossing his mind.

“Plague.”

A green glow briefly surrounded his thrall, as Hamelin’s vile spell infused him with a curse. “Your fangs now carry a dangerous disease,” the piper said. “Spread it to the mortals of this city. To their merchants and dignitaries, so they carry my gift across borders.

“Ugh, I hate the taste of elflings and manlings,” the rat complained. “But you can count on me.”

“You and your brothers keep an eye on all three of our sworn enemies, the bottle, and my catspaws.”

“Cat?” the rat glanced around, making Hamelin chuckle. “Master, please don’t scare me like that!”

“Do the work, and I will make you grow bigger than a dog,” the piper lied. He had learned the lesson from the beastkin; to never make his slaves too strong nor too smart, lest they get *ideas*. “Now go.”

His thrall fled the alley, carrying Hamelin’s gift with him.

His work done, the fomor brought out his dragonbone pipe from under his cloak and summoned a fairy ring with a song. A dark green portal opened before him, and vanished after the fairy lord crossed it.

As he landed back home, in his father’s workshop, Hamelin dropped his human guise.

His skin turned from flesh to rotten wood, crimson eyes opening all over it; on his shoulders, his chest, and his ‘hat’. His clothes revealed their true nature as parts of his body, his beard turned into tentacled roots, and his

fingers became branches. Hamelin was an old nightmare, one of the horrors that made mortals fear to tread the woods at night.

When he arrived, the smell of oil and gunpowder greeted the piper. Giants and ogres worked metal under a twisted dark wood ceiling, fashioning steel armor, carefully breaking down earthling weapons into tiny pieces, or assembled the head of a new golem.

Hamelin's forefather, the insectoid fomor Mag Mell, oversaw his thralls' work with a craftsman's attention. "Another layer," he ordered his servants, each of whom he created in his lab. "A thicker armor with less impurities."

"Thrice thicker, father," Hamelin suggested. "Vainqueur blasted the chest apart."

"Did you see it from your hiding spot, my son?" Mag Mell responded without sparing his child a glance. "I wonder."

"Oh, I had the most beautiful view of your toy getting punched into scrap." It had been like one of those 'movies' the Earth's manlings loved so much. "I cannot wait to see how the next one fares."

Each fomor was a lord on its own, with their own fief and servants, answering to no one. Only a mighty, charismatic leader such as King Balaur could shape these proud lords into a cohesive army, and only so long as he lived. The fairies felt no love toward one another, except a kinship as the supreme overlords of creation; even bloodline held little sway.

The downsides of lacking a soul. Love, humor, kindness... Hamelin could not understand these strange things the mortals prized.

"I too expect better results."

Like a snake in the grass, Mell Odieuse had sneaked up on her kindred without even Hamelin noticing. The piper showed no hint of fear, greeting his sister with a tip of his hat, but couldn't quite shake the dread she inspired.

As usual, she wore her human guise, infuriating her progenitor.

“Daughter, you displease me with this face,” Mag Mell said with disgust. Every mortal reminded him of the System he loathed with a passion. After all, he partly created it.

All fomors could create life, or grant intelligence to objects and animals. Mag Mell once crafted a magical dice, in an attempt to create an artifact that could tap into new forms of sorcery. On a whim, he also granted it a mind.

So Dice was born, and with a roll, brought the System to Outremonde.

To say Mag Mell had regretted that incident ever since would be an *understatement*.

For indirectly bringing the cursed System into the world and giving mortals an edge against them, the fairy lords shunned Mag Mell. Ever since then, the mad fomor had dedicated his immortal life to regaining his kind’s favor and bringing down the System.

None had studied the cursed Classes as extensively as Mag Mell, and his work yielded results over the centuries. The spell [Darkest Fear], meant to make sure mortals slept in the dirt forever; the Black Crests, traps that would twist men and women into abominations when they yearned for power; and countless monsters engineered to kill heroes.

When King Balaur approached him with a chance to regain his honor by assisting in his crusade, Mag Mell eagerly supported him. He fed Balaur potions to make the dullahan grow, grow, and grow until none could defeat him. They had become *so* close to taking back Outremonde last century...

Yet Balaur died, and Mag Mell fled in disgrace to fight another day.

But the fairies *learned*. Where brute force had failed with King Balaur, Mell Odieuse chose strife, division, and hate. Make the mortals fight one another, encourage a state of war unending, and then decimate the winners when they least expected it.

Hamelin preferred that approach to the old one. His kind called him a coward because he preyed on those who couldn't fight back and ran when needed, but he called it intelligence. Good old Hamelin had bested many heroes in the past centuries, and he was still around.

Hamelin knew nothing awaited him after death. Having no soul, his body would dissolve into the soil from which it sprang, and all would go dark. That fear had motivated the piper for centuries, drove him to kill others before they could do the same to him.

Mell Odieuse ignored her father and cut straight to business. "Lin, report."

"I distributed the weapons as you asked," Hamelin replied. "Pulled a small prank on Barin too, but Mot is out for good."

Mell Odieuse's frown deepened as he gave her more details, while Mag let out a bitter hiss when he mentioned Kia Bekele. "What next, my sister?" Hamelin asked once he finished. "Do you need more weapons?"

"I will open the doors again on Samhain when my powers reach their peak," the dark witch confirmed. It took a lot of mana to open the Earthgate, and so the fomors only used it for short trips. Not to mention the *'magical problems'* on the other side. "But you will fetch me more than guns this time."

"Your obsession with the Earthlings' technology will be your undoing, my daughter," said Mag Mell, who feared it. Enough that he never dare launch a raid on Earth since the manlings invented firearms. "Magic will be our salvation, you shall see."

Mell Odieuse's eyes turned disdainful. "Finish your so-called 'masterpiece' first, and then I will believe you."

"Lin gave me the samples I needed," Mag Mell replied. "Where *you* were found lacking, my new creation will succeed."

Hamelin would have sold his pipe to read his sister's thoughts, behind that cold face of her.

Mag Mell made Mell Odieuse from his own blood, but he fed her that of dragons all her youth. He even infused her with the bones of ‘Vainqueur’ that the adventurers brought them, hoping to create a powerful champion for the fomors.

He made Mell Odieuse powerful, alright, and cunning too. But she was no King Balaur.

The piper may have to blame his choice of agents for that. When Hamelin learned Knightsbane had returned, his fury at being tricked knew no bounds; and doubly so when he learned dragons gained levels. At least he finally got around to stealing Vainqueur’s blood, and that Cornelia died as a sweet bonus.

“In the meantime, you will finish the new iteration of the Talos Golem, until I agree with the final design.”

“My talents are wasted on this pointless task.” A consummate artist, the fomor would rather have moved on with another project after the failure of the first golem, but his daughter had forced him to create more while working out the flaws.

Mell Odieuse glanced at her father with cold dead eyes. “Is this defiance then, father?”

An uncomfortable, threatening silence filled the workshop, Hamelin noticing that even Mag’s thralls had frozen. The patriarch said nothing for several seconds, before finally answering, “No.”

“Then get back to work.”

“What about Knightsbane?” Hamelin asked as Mag Mell turned to oversee his thralls. “He knows.”

“I will not allow a dragon to become a god,” Mell Odieuse said. “Especially not Knightsbane. We have to destabilize his ‘empire’ before it becomes a new Gardemagne or gives the dragons ideas. I already sent Lucie to take care of them, and you will assist her.”

“We would not be in this mess if she hadn’t lied to Good Ol’ Hamelin back then,” the piper pointed out. His sister’s protection was the only reason that treacherous vampire still *‘lived.’*

“So long as she is of use, you shall wait,” his sister replied, although Hamelin caught the not-so-subtle message. If the vampire failed... “Until then, you shall follow my strategy.”

The piper was nothing if not patient. His time for revenge would come.

Hamelin summoned another fairy ring, this time to the Nightblades’ stronghold of Noblecoeur, briefly glancing at his father chafing at his task.

Mag Mell feared the Earthlings and their weapons, but his daughter loved them even more than Hamelin. He thought his sister had the right idea, to combine their sorcery and the technology from Earth to gain an edge.

In time, when they had retaken Outremonde, they would cleanse that mortal nest. Cut their supply of heroes at the source.

No more saviors from another world.

“Lin,” Mell Odieuse interrupted her brother before he could cross the portal.

“Yes?”

“You said Barsino wanted to study the bottle to trap us?”

“I do not see another reason,” he replied, “Why?”

“I have an idea,” the fairy replied ominously, a heartless, cruel smile forming on her face.

Even for a hardened killer, the sight chilled Hamelin to the core.

Chapter 54: Dark Side of the Gold

“What do you mean, my Karma Credit Score is in the red?!”

“Due to ‘chaotic behavior,’ ‘dishonorable combat maneuvers’ and ‘remorseless killing of thine own kind,’ your karma has moved towards a weak shade of chaotic evil,” Miel read him a report with a frown on her face. “Your new classes also do *not* inspire confidence.”

“That's ridiculous! I earned them saving baby dragons from raiders!”

“Adventurers whose job loss is indirectly your doing, and most of these dragons being dangerously destructive themselves. Opposing a fomor plot gave you a bonus, but not enough to offset the downward spiral. We will have to increase your subscription rate if you want to keep the benefits of your current insurance.”

Victor slammed his head against his mansion's table. These thieves already took half of his SP at the end of each month!

“I'm sorry,” Miel tried to reassure him. “I am defending your case the best I can, but I have a lot of pressure from my higher-ups.”

“They're blaming my score downgrade on you?”

Miel sighed, apparently as annoyed as him. “It is a hard job, regulations are strict, and my higher-ups want to avoid too many people undeserving of Heaven dodging their due karmic retribution. I would like the rules to relax a bit, but I do not make them.”

“Why don't you strike on your own?” Victor suggested, massaging his forehead. “Free enterprise and all.”

“Like an infernal corporation?” Miel shivered. “That is not how Heaven works, and I would certainly fall.”

While he contested the evil part of his alignments, the more Victor heard, the more he thought chaos fit him a lot better than the alternative. “Heaven sounds like a huge, sticky bureaucracy.”

“It is.” Miel let out a sigh. “I wish I would spend more time relaxing than managing celestial red tape.”

“Maybe I could help you with the relaxing part. Maybe we can have a drink?”

“Dear client, are you making a pass at me?”

“I’m just saying, I’m high-level, rich...” As he said that, the ground shook, probably due to another one of Marbré’s rockets blowing up. The jelly tester had survived two of them so far. “And *available*.”

Charisma check...

Partial success!

Finally! Vainqueur was right, that rich line worked!

“This would be *very* unprofessional,” Miel replied, although she did sound like she was considering the offer. “Besides, you are already dating someone, are you not?”

“I haven’t committed to anything outside of a second date yet,” Victor pointed out.

“I must warn you that harems have a negative effect on your Karma Score, albeit not as much as a committed monogamous relationship with Chocolatine. My projections say your Karma will take a hard, *hard* dive downward if you go there. I cannot stress how much I discourage this course of action.”

“What *can* I get away with?”

“If you somehow convince Chocolatine to turn around towards good, you will get what we call the ‘RedemFinder Bonus,’ which is *very* appreciated up there. However, I highly suggest that you marry someone with a more positive alignment, such as Miss Bekele.”

“Okay, I’m drawing a line in the sand there, I’m not letting insurance dictate my love life,” Victor replied. “I already risk my life as it is.”

The angel let out a sigh. “For your offer, I would consider it if your karma moved to good. I do not want a fling with an evil mortal jeopardizing my career, and while my superiors are ambivalent about chaos, they are not about that part. Alas, you are drenched in sin...”

“Are you trying to guilt-trip me?”

“Heaven patented this approach,” she replied with a kind smile. “We will save your soul, no matter what.”

Yeah, right. Victor had the feeling she needed to loosen up a bit and tone down the holier-than-thou spiel but kept his mouth shut. At least she meant well, instead of filling her pockets, like Malfy. “How are sales going?”

“Excellent!” she replied too fast and with a grin too big for it to be true.

“Miel...”

“I don’t understand!” Her facade quickly cracked. “We cut the prices by seventy percent during our Feather Friday promotion, and clie—our lambs flocked to our rivals anyway!”

“Really?” Victor raised an eyebrow, although this didn’t surprise him all that much. “Maybe I should take a loo—”

“No, please!” she begged him, her sharp change of demeanor making him jump off his seat. “You are our star client! I will be fired if you cancel. I-I will be homeless, and I will die in the snow all alone!”

“We are in a desert, it never snows,” Victor pointed out.

Miel responded by looking at him with big, tearful eyes.

Another guilt-tripping attempt... but it worked. The things he did for pretty faces. “Look, I don’t promise anything,” the vizier said. “But I can look into it later. Maybe you just need to revise your marketing.”

After five minutes of reassuring the angel until her face dried up, Victor sent her on her way to focus on other matters.

A ghoul walked in to replace her. “Hi, Jules,” the vizier greeted the necromancer, who had now grown into a friend.

“Good morning, Victor,” the necromancer replied before taking a seat. “I hope you recovered from your last fight.”

“Don’t tell me.” Overall though, the adventure had ended much better than it could have. The survivor was kept in the castle’s dungeon and interrogated, but had little to say. Most of the items found at the adventurers’ base, including the Black Crest, had been confiscated and sealed in the vault. While Furibon’s escape was a mess, they had gained excellent loot out of the adventure, and even a new mount. “I was actually looking forward to discussing class progression with you. I like to talk my way out, but I have a recurring charisma problem.”

“That does not surprise me,” the necromancer replied. “[Monster Knight] and [Reaper] strike me as well-rounded classes without a particular focus. What other classes have you leveled in recently?”

“[Grand Vizier].”

“Oh, then you should be fine. The Vizier variant of [Noble] has a strong growth in charisma.”

Victor raised an eyebrow. “Really?”

“You need a lot of charm to convince rulers to keep you employed in spite of obvious treacherous tendencies.”

Fair point.

“I heard they have very useful Perks, but Viziers are rare and poorly researched. I know for sure that they can hide most of their abilities and karma at a certain level, but otherwise, users of the class keep their cards close to the chest.”

Huh? Hiding your Karma?

Food for thought. “I also have levels in [Chaos Rider], and I’m not proud of saying it, [Assassin].”

“Mmm... [Chaos Rider] is a combat class with strong physical stats, but poor charisma. However, [Assassin] usually combines with the Noble-line class at some point, usually into rare combinations such as [Caligula], or [Kingmaker]. It is not guaranteed however.”

Not good enough for Victor. “Any class specialized in diplomacy?”

“If you do not mind more negative karma, I would suggest [Politician].”

“Mine is already in the red, and I have my dignity.” Well, at least he now knew rulers had stat bonuses toward lying to the population. That explained a lot.

“Summoning classes then,” Jules said, “Most possess an S-rank growth in charisma and considering your current deals with the outer planes, you should meet most requirements. But otherwise, I simply suggest focusing on leveling your [Grand Vizier]. If a class can lie its way out of trouble, it would be that one.”

“Yes, but would I have to betray Vainqueur for it? Because that will never happen.”

“I do not think so. You should be fine if you stick to managing government affairs and listen to your natural deviousness.” Did he really have such a terrible reputation? “However, if I may ask, what is your current total level?”

“Forty-two, and Vainqueur is one level short of fifty.”

“Mmm... this is unfortunate, because you both have reached the forty level experience plateau. I doubt you will gain more levels except through yearly practice of a class like Rolo did, or rare exploits. While you have a gift for putting yourself in dangerous situations and coming out of them alive, I would not count on gaining new levels to solve your problem in the short-term.”

“So that leaves what, equipment boosting my charisma?”

“Alongside spells, and buffs,” Jules suggested. “What is your current necromancy tier?”

“Three.”

The ghoul rejoiced at the news. “Excellent. You should be able to learn useful buffs for both yourself and his Majesty. I will gladly assist you in the path of the Necromancer.”

Maybe it is time for Victor and Vainqueur to explore the abilities they already had, instead of counting on gaining new ones.

Charlene walked into the room without knocking. “We have a problem!” Victor’s secretary announced with a stressed face, a pile of paper in hands and her skin white as snow. “A big, *big* problem.”

“We are under attack?” the vizier frowned.

“Yes, yes, we are!” Charlene replied, throwing the paper pile. “Our economy is under assault!”

“What, Gardemagne is closing its borders?”

“Worse! According to my book-keeping, we have a *huge* inflation rate. The prices are rising very fast due to the constant influx of gold!”

Victor blinked. “Vainqueur’s stipend? Mot’s creations?”

“That, and the magical items, foreign investments, and dirty money keep coming in constantly!”

“Noble classes are heavily restricted to avoid that kind of scenario,” Jules said.

“How much inflation do we expect for the year?” Victor asked, Charlene providing him with a single sheet of paper sheet. He started reading and... and...

Oh, *gods*... he felt his heart skip a beat for a second at the dreadful sight.

Vitality check successful! [**Insta-Death**] negated!

“Your ‘*space program*’ is also putting our already small public budget in the red,” Charlene continued. “At this rate, we will have to borrow money from Gardemagne, call the Church of Shesha, or establish new sources of income.”

“You mean taxes,” Victor guessed.

“Yes! There’s so much money coming in from abroad, and we don’t get any shares!”

Which Vainqueur would never allow. How do you manage an economy when your leader thought taxes were evil, and that coins going inside the treasury could never leave it?

“This is a serious problem,” Victor agreed. “Skyrocketing inflation will destroy the value of our gold reserves, exports, and eventually cause the local wages to lag behind the prices.”

Charlene raised an eyebrow. “I studied economics,” the vizier replied, although he never quite understood the lessons before his Intelligence stat began to increase. “All of this to say, we have a recipe for civil war.”

“Are you two not panicking too quickly?” Jules asked. “Your minions are loyal to Vainqueur even if he does not pay them. While Murmurin welcomes new inhabitants every day, the bulk of the infrastructures worship the ground that His Majesty walks on.”

“You underestimate the power of the dark side of the economy,” Victor said. “Especially if we get financial bubbles and panics. We have to regulate the money coming in and out. Are the paper clips ready?”

“I will say it again, this is a stupid idea,” Charlene frowned, having opposed the project since the very first day. “Paper money will never catch on. It’s clips against gold.”

“That is not an answer.” His assistant let out a resigned sigh, confirming that they had printed enough. “Good. We will introduce this new exchange money, the *Vainqueur Dollar*, and create the national Bank of Murmurin by the same occasion.”

By encouraging citizens to put their gold safely in Vainqueur’s castle as reserves, and use the paper clips instead, this should allow Victor to control the money going in and out.

“And where will we find the money for our budget and this initiative?” Charlene pointed out. “We have near-limitless labor forces, but little resources which we can avoid importing.”

“V&V owns the mines, the undead workers, and the land,” Jules said. “Most of the latter is not exploited. The treasury can easily generate money by redirecting the workforce there.”

“Of course we cannot exploit the lands, we are in the middle of a desert,” Charlene replied. “And from what I gathered, the only reason there is even a patch of land to exploit there is because one golem Farmer worked on it day and night for centuries. We do not have enough casters such as [Astrologers] or [Meteomancers] who could help with that.”

“I have perhaps one solution,” Victor said. “A dragon one.”

It was time to introduce Vainqueur to Geomancer, as Henry advised, and see if it would work as well as advertised. However, if his friend was right and his dragon friend had reached an exp plateau, then this will turn out more difficult than expected...

“My friends, you are not seeing the true problem at hand,” Jules said.
“Namely, who will tell His Majesty that *too much gold is bad*?”

A tense, heavy silence fell between them.

“That’s your mess.” Charlene immediately dumped the responsibility on Victor. “You do it.”

“I am afraid you are the most qualified,” Jules agreed, patting the Vizier in the back and abandoning him to his demise.

Someone knocked on his door before he could protest. Allison opened the door without waiting for authorization, seeming worried. “Vic, can I borrow you for a minute? Maybe for one hour?”

Had his office turned into a revolving door? “We are in the middle of an urgent crisis there!”

“It is about Vainqueur,” the dryad said, Victor immediately squinting at her. “He has somehow learned about *gold farming*, and has started practicing in Rolo’s fields with Choc’s help.”

Of course, it would happen now, of all times. Wonderful. “Has he called monsters or summoned demons again?”

“No, he is *literally* farming gold. Planting coins in the ground.”

Chapter 55: Perk Practice

Vainqueur had never understood the appeal of agriculture.

How could anyone spend their life wading through dung, manhandling cows, or laboring in the fields, when they could look for gold instead? Peasantry was the very definition of minion work.

But as he opened his coin seed bag, imagining them growing into shining piles which he could then harvest, the dragon realized that he had been wrong. Watching his gold grow from the earth would make for honest dragon work.

Especially since he mostly watched his servants do the heavy lifting for him, as a true ruler should.

“Kobold Rangers!” Vainqueur ordered, as his minions dug trenches in the farm’s soil. “More holes with feathers at the bottom! My coins deserve the best accommodations!”

“Yes, Your Majesty!” His reptilian lackeys happily obeyed him, while Chocolatine cast spells to help with the harvest.

“How many more fields do you want to seed?” Rolo the golem asked, his arms crossed. “Rolo must harvest his tomatoes.”

“I want a field of gold, a garden of silver, and a greenhouse of gems! Each of them as safely guarded as my vault!”

Vainqueur opened his bag, carefully taking a sweet little coin, and then put it in a hole. That was the most important part of the process, the one he would not delegate.

Like the sheep on top of the cow cake, his chief of staff ran straight to the field, followed by Tasty Allison, Corpseling Jules, and Manling Charlene.

“Hi, Vic!” Sweet Chocolatine waved at her fellow minion.

“Hi, Chocolatine.” His favored minion greeted her back, before turning to Vainqueur. “Your Majesty, we need to talk.”

“Choc, what did I tell you about the fields?” Tasty Allison told Sweet Chocolatine with a frown. “No more experiments!”

“But the tomatoes grow faster since I fed the soil with demon blood! I’m sure coins will become alive too!”

“Which will allow them to defend themselves against the vile Furibon when he inevitably returns,” Vainqueur told his minion. “A dragon must think ahead.”

“Your Majesty, that is not how coins are made,” Manling Victor argued.

“I know, minion. Your kind takes the gold from the earth and then mints it into coins.”

“You know?” His friend gave his master a strange gaze. “Then... why?”

“I thought this class system was rubbish when you begged me to become my minion, so I decided to keep an open mind. If the System can create amazing royal capes for me out of thin air, who am I to question how to farm gold?”

Manling Victor stayed silent for a second, before massaging his forehead. “I hate it when things that don’t make sense make sense.”

“Yes, minion, once again, I triumph with logic.”

“Farming gold is not planting coins in the ground to harvest golden trees later!” Victor protested. “Usually, it’s simply killing monsters who drop a huge amount of money when slain!”

... oh?

That was even better! “There are monsters who give more gold than others?”

His chief of staff frowned. “That’s a good question,” he said while glancing at Corpseking Jules. “Are there monsters who drop more loot than usual on Outremonde?”

“Golden Gooses and Jackpot Golems drop an enormous amount of wealth if defeated,” the necromancer said, but quickly dashed Vainqueur’s hopes. “However, they have been hunted to near-extinction by adventurers and are extraordinarily rare.”

“The most lucrative monsters to kill nowadays are Fairy Rafflesias, Sea Serpents, and Phoenixes since their corpses can be harvested for high-quality material,” Allison said. “But good luck finding one, let alone killing it.”

“For manlings maybe, but a dragon never backs down before a challenge. We shall find these creatures and poke them at once.”

“Your Majesty, we have enough gold already,” Manling Victor said a stupid thing.

Vainqueur glared at his chief of staff. “Manling Victor, I will not allow you to act lazy while my bet with Icefang is ongoing. My hoard needs to dwarf his own, for the sake of all dragonkind. I cannot allow this *poser* to become the richest of them all.”

Manling Victor exchanged glances with the other minions before taking a long, hard breath. “Your Majesty,” he began. “We have too much gold in Murmurin. We are overflowing with it.”

“There is no such thing as too much gold,” Vainqueur replied, confused. “Minion, are you well? Has the fairy bewitched you?”

“No! I mean it!” His chief of staff’s words made the dragon blink. “The more you have of a commodity, the more it loses value! By harvesting so much gold, we are causing it to lose value nationwide!”

Intelligence vs Charisma check... Failed!

You could not understand the broad economic implications of the dragon way of life!

Realizing what was happening, Vainqueur immediately targeted his chief of staff with his fearsome magic. “[Lesser Demonbane]!”

The spell hit his servant head-on, causing him to stumble, but couldn’t banish the demon which took him over. “Minions, Furibon targeted Manling Victor with a foul spell!” Vainqueur panicked. “I cannot lift the enchantment!”

“Your Majesty, I am not—”

“Chief is possessed!” the Kobold Rangers panicked, Red first among them. “We have to restrain him!”

“We can’t fight a chief of staff, it’s against everything I believe in!”
Yellow complained.

“Your Majesty, Victor is sound of mind,” Corpseling Jules defended the chief of staff, before saying nonsense as well. “As much as it pains you, he speaks the truth. Your gold is losing value as we speak.”

“Furibon turned my gold to lead again while I was away?!” Vainqueur growled, incensed. That explained it. The sight must have led his minions to fall to madness after breaking their spirit!

“No, no! This is natural!” Manling Victor confused his master even more. “If we bring too much money from abroad in such a small place as Murmurin, inevitably it will lose value and cause prices to increase!”

“Gold shines intrinsically!” Vainqueur insisted. “It cannot lose value, because it is by nature the shiniest metal in the world!”

“This has nothing to do with shining, Your Majesty! Currencies have a fluctuating value and the more we have of it, the less it is worth!”

What was this hysteria? *Gold* losing value? His *hoard* losing its net worth? “My hoard is the greatest in the world!” Vainqueur defended his prized fortune. “Hoarding gold increases its value, the end. To say otherwise would invalidate the dragon way of life, which unlike your insane ‘theory’ is the absolute *Truth*.”

“But Your Majesty, think about it,” Manling Victor insisted, having fallen too far and too deep into nonsense. “If everyone has gold, then it is not special. And with your Majesty’s actions, gold is now freely accessible to everyone in Murmurin. It’s no longer special!”

Intelligence check partly successful!

“Oh, I understand!” Vainqueur finally caught on. “I understand what you mean to tell me, minion. You could have said it with simpler terms.”

Manling Victor frowned. “You do understand?”

“If my hoard is only made of gold, it will seem less impressive than if I collected other shining metals to complement it! Since even my minions have become rich thanks to my enlightened leadership, I must increase my standards and broaden my horizons! I must rejuvenate my hoard with newer, more avant-garde material like platinum!”

What a great idea Vainqueur had today! Once again, the dragon surprised himself with his forward, visionary thinking.

His chief of staff exchanged a glance with Tasty Allison. “Vic, that’s the best you will get.”

Manling Victor sighed. “Good enough.”

“Not good enough, minion!” Vainqueur cheered up his minion, “Good enough is for those who settle for less than excellence! We will go beyond for my hoard!”

“So Your Majesty agrees to stop farming gold and look for new sources to decorate his treasure?”

“About that, minion, I promote you to my Minister of *Hoard Research and Development*,” Vainqueur said. “This is a very important responsibility since quests are becoming rarer, but I trust your innovative spirit will serve me well.”

“Well, if Your Majesty was okay with gold farming, then maybe you will agree to help work the land?” Manling Victor suggested, already at work. “Most of your empire is a desert whose underground resources we cannot exploit without serious landscaping.”

“I will try this [Geomancer] class Manling Henry told us about,” Vainqueur declared, eager to become a wizard like his cousin.

“[Geomancer]?” Tasty Allison sounded pleasantly surprised. “I was considering taking levels in that class as well; I have all the grimoires and magical weed needed in my shack.”

“Magical weed?” Manling Victor frowned at the dryad, who smiled innocently.

“I must warn Your Majesty that due to their high level, it will take time before you earn that Class,” Corpseking Jules said.

“I am a dragon,” Vainqueur replied proudly. “I will now become a wizard.”

“Oh, oh, about magic.” Sweet Chocolatine smiled at Manling Victor, who took a step back. “Vic, can you mark me?”

“Mark you?”

“You can mark any monster to teleport them to you right? Maybe it works on more than horses!”

“Oh, like I summon Manling Victor whenever I need him?” Vainqueur nodded happily. “That would be very useful.” By summoning his manling,

who would then summon the other minions, the dragon could have his servants work for him at any time. Brilliant.

“Exactly!” Chocolatine recognized his genius. “It would be super-useful! For battle. For *battle!*”

“It’s... that’s... that could actually...” Manling Victor considered the offer before his curiosity and loyalty overwhelmed him. “[Black Horseman].”

A dark glow surrounded Chocolatine for a brief moment, before dissipating. “Did it work?” she asked eagerly.

“I don’t think so,” Manling Victor replied, Chocolatine sighing in disappointment.

“Are you done?” the scrap golem asked. “Rolo needs to work on his yard.”

“I will get the grimoires,” Allison promised.

At long last, Vainqueur would become a true wizard.

With night having fallen on Murmurin, Victor Dalton laid in his king-sized bed, trying to chase away a *dangerous* thought.

He had lied.

You have one mount marked: Chocolatine de Gevaudan.

He *did* successfully mark Chocolatine with the [Black Horseman] Perk. He received a notification to prove it. Meaning he could probably summon her right now.

If he could mark a monster woman and summon her at any time... That would be useful.

For battle.

For *battle!*

He could summon reinforcements if ambushed in his bedroom! Especially if he could mark more than one if he leveled further in that class!

No, Vic, that would be a gross misuse of the elite [Chaos Rider] class. A gross misuse of the power granted to you by the heavens to fight off against the fomors. For all you know, you won't summon Chocolatine in your bedroom even if you try. And if you do, nothing would happen. Nothing at all!

...

Vic, don't do it.

Remember what your shoulder angel Miel said. Think about your karma. Think about the angels. Think about living with moderation and morality so you can safely retire in red tape-ridden heaven and do nothing exciting for your entire afterlife.

No, that didn't work at strengthening his resolve. That reasoning didn't work at all!

Victor jumped out of bed, making circles in the room while trying to convince himself not to make a *huge* mistake.

He had to think about mankind.

To think about his vow! To not BEEP that except to save the human race!

If he failed that test of mental fortitude, Victor condemned his entire species to destruction! That would be tantamount to cross the line, treacherously abandon his last embers of morality, and fully commit to monsterhood!

With all the perks of power, wealth, longevity, and getting laid all the time!

Victor realized that arguing with his subconscious was a lot harder than expected. It was as if he had an inner shoulder devil, but the angel had left in disgust.

Maybe he could just try to summon Chocolatine only to test the Perk. Even if he summoned that girl to his bedroom, he could resist the temptation to do anything he would regret. He had the will power.

That would be a test run to see if he could mark, say, Miel! Nothing to worry about!

“S-su...” His heart began to pound in his chest like a locomotive, his curiosity overwhelming his common sense, “S-summon Chocolatine...”

As he uttered the cursed words, a flash of bright light overcame the room, proving that yes, the Perk did work that way.

What materialized... what materialized...

It was *terrifying*!

Chocolatine appeared as advertised, except that she was wearing the most scandalous demon fur nightgown he had ever seen, which left absolutely *nothing* to imagination.

Unfortunately, she must have skinned the creatures needed for the dress only hours ago, because he could see, and *smell*, the blood on it. She wore a makeshift hood with a black rabbit's ears on her untied hair... but *also* carried the skinned animal in her left hand, and the hunting knife she used to do it in the other.

“Ta-da!” she said, extending her arms and smirking in a way that was both endearing and frightening, due to the blood on her cheek. “So? How do I look? How do I *look*?”

Victor answered with a scream of terror.

She screamed back, looking like a maniac while doing so.

His undead guards standing watch over his bedroom's door opened it, ready for battle. “It's okay!” Victor shouted before they could attack Chocolatine. “It's okay, false alarm!”

The mindless automatons said nothing, before closing the door behind them. “What the BEEP?” Victor asked while Chocolatine’s shoulders crumbled sheepishly. “Why are you dressed like that?”

“I...” She sounded as ashamed as he was disturbed. “I kinda hoped you would call me somehow, so I worked all evening on the dress. I was almost done too!”

“And the... the rabbit? Why are you wearing a dead rabbit’s skin?”

“Don’t male humans like girls dressed as bunnies? Because they want to eat them?” Chocolatine seemed devastated, the rabbit ears folding somehow. “You don’t like it? I blew it?”

She looked so cute and vulnerable when she said that, it made up for the horror.

That instant, Victor realized that one could feel terrified by *and* attracted to someone all at once. “Look,” he finally said. “What about you take a shower to remove the blood, get rid of the rabbit, and drop the knife somewhere?”

“And... and then I go home?”

“Then we try again, but do it right.”

Chocolatine beamed like the sun.

...

...

...

...

...

Well.

Mankind wasn't the only thing Victor screwed that night.

Chapter 56: On Relationsheeps

Congratulations! For repeatedly surviving a werewolf's bite, you earned the **[Silverfang]** Personal Perk!

[Silverfang]: When biting a mono-type Humanoid, you can infect them with the Curse of Lycanthropy if they fail a moderate Vitality check. On the next full moon, unless the curse is dispelled, their species permanently change to werewolf (Humanoid/Beast).

As he laid in his bed, with biting and scratch marks everywhere on his body, Victor Dalton came to a sudden realization. All his life, the adventurer thought he was a man with standards, when it came to those he would sleep with.

But when pushed, it turned out he had none.

Considering his life path, consorting with demons, helping a dragon take over a country, indulging a bit with the flock of the Moon Man, and becoming half-monster himself, he should have seen it coming.

"I *knew* that Perk would work that way!" Chocolatine gloated next to him.

The worst thing was, that night had been the best Victor ever had. Screwing the human race had never felt so pleasurable.

"My Karma score is going to take a huge dump for this," the vizier said. Miel would be *so* mad.

"Just falsify it!" Chocolatine happily suggested, like a grown-up shoulder devil. "I'm sure it can be done with the right spells. Malfy can help with it."

Bad influence *indeed*. “So, uh... where do we go from here?” Victor asked. “Your brother will show up and wed us at gunpoint?”

“Silly, Croissant would kill you if he learned. Or he would try, and fail.”

“I figured, but that doesn’t answer my question.” In truth, while Victor had grown rather fond of her—a lot more than he thought he would—he didn’t want to settle down with anyone right now, and liked his bachelor lifestyle. On the other hand, he didn’t want to hurt her feelings either.

Chocolatine drew the blanket towards herself. “No tying down.”

“No tying down?” Victor raised an eyebrow in surprise.

“Except with ropes! I want foreplay, tension, excitement!” she began to rant with a disturbing, crazed face. “You breaking into my temple with a whip at night with a mad gleam in your eyes! Strolling on your horse and abducting me to the desert to have your way with me on the sand!”

As she described her weirdest and truly *disturbing* fantasies, Victor backed away until he had reached the end of the mattress. Her formerly cute face morphed into the purest expression of psychotic obsession.

“No, no, I have a better idea to spice it up further. We will need chains, a sacrificial altar, an electric slime, a sheep, and a *knife*!”

...

In hindsight, this may have been a mistake.

A *huge* mistake.

“But, but you start by using that Perk on me once a week until the end of the mating season.” She moved to bite his shoulder, Vic stopping her with a hand.

“I’m going to drink a healing potion downstairs first.” She took out a *fifth* of his HP, and the raid battle had taught him the importance of remaining in top shape at all times. Also, he needed some breathing room.

Victor put on a dressing gown and escaped the room while Chocolatine cheerfully hummed to herself, letting out a breath of relief after closing the door behind him.

...

...

He BLEEPed up.

Victor *knew* he shouldn't have bred with the crazy, but he still did.

He needed to skip town. No, the entire *country*. He had to escape!

Charlene informed him many churches had started encouraging adventurers to discover new lands, even starting to build exploration fleets. He had to take the first boat and run, run, *run*!

America? Antarctica? Anywhere!

No, no, Vainqueur would summon him if he vanished without warning! He was trapped!

Think, Victor, think!

Buy time. Drink a potion, satisfy the wolf-fiend's appetite, and then find a way to get out of this mess alive.

The fearful Grand Vizier moved downstairs to his dining room, where his undead servants always kept a stockpile of healing potions on the table. He found Allison waiting for him there, alongside a cadre of skeleton butlers. "Al?" Victor raised an eyebrow. "What are you doing in my house in the middle of the night?"

"I was done helping Vainqueur with his [Geomancer] training, and came to visit," the dryad replied. "He grew angry when I told him he had to make seeds grow with magic instead of something more 'bragworthy.' He called it *minion work*."

“But he still did it?”

“He tried, but I had to promise he would unearth a precious metal mine with this new class first,” Allison replied. “Since Ishfania is an alternate Iberia, I’m sure we can unearth some in the south.”

There was more money to make from developing a country than going quest hunting. Halloween and the confrontation with Icefang was less than six months away, and while Vainqueur disdained undragon-like activities, his hatred of his rival and desire to outshine him outweighed his pride.

Once they had stabilized Vainqueur’s new empire, Victor guessed they could turn their eyes outward.

If he lived that long.

“Vic, is something the matter?” Allison asked him with a worried gaze. “You look like a soldier volunteering for a suicide mission.”

“I am,” Victor replied, reddening, as he finished the bottle.

You have recovered all your HP... for now.

“No, seriously, what’s wrong?” The dryad insisted. “I am your friend. If you are in trouble, I will do anything to help.”

“I slept with Chocolatine.”

Allison marked a short pause. “Slept, or slept-slept?” Somehow, she made the question sound like. “*Have you considered suicide?*”

“Slept-bred.”

The dryad looked at him with a mix of astonishment at his stupidity, pity for his cruel fate, and a strange kind of awe for his boldness. “Vic, you are a lion-hearted man,” she finally said. “But you are also an idiot.”

“You helped set up the date!”

“Yes, a friendly *date*, so she would stop pestering you and move on. I didn’t think you would actually cross the point of no return.” Allison shook her head, biting her lip. “You know it’s mating season for werewolves until the end of the month?”

A chill went down his spine. “She said she was on the pill.”

“Not to transform into a werewolf during the full moon, but not for *that* part.”

Victor’s eyes turned empty, as a hellish frost seized his heart, and crushed his hopeful spirit.

“Thankfully for you, I don’t think a half-dragon and a werewolf can have children,” Allison tried to reassure him. “But to be sure, don’t do it again until June. She’s upstairs right?”

“You have to save me,” Victor begged her, “You’re her best friend and a priestess of the goddess of love. Relationship advice is your job.”

Allison joined her hands, furiously considering the matter as if her friend’s life depended on it. Because it *did*!

“Maybe you can learn to live with it?” she suggested sheepishly. “She’s... kind and loyal, when you get to know her. You learned to live with a dragon; you can survive her eccentricities and learn to enjoy them.”

“She hides a blood-covered knife under my *bed*.”

"But you still liked her enough to go on a date with, and plan a second one. Maybe you're just getting cold-feet because you are afraid of commitment."

"She's... she's too intense," Victor said. "She scares me to death."

"Maybe you should just tell her then, and put boundaries. Maybe you're just not ready to go too far for the moment."

"I don't want to hurt her feelings," Victor admitted. He had grown attached to her and had no idea how to deal with this. That, and doing so right after

they tied the knot would be a major dick move. "I think she will take it as a rejection and start killing her 'rivals'."

"There are solutions," Allison said with a sigh. "But none of them are good."

"*Anything* is better than the alternative."

The terrible noise of the manor's magical alarm interrupted Allison before she could provide an escape route. "An intruder?" Saved from breeding! Victor immediately glanced at one of his undead servants. "Bring me my bazooka!"

"A *bazooka*?" Allison blinked.

"Rocket launchers solve everything," Victor replied, rushing with her and his skeletons into the entrance hall.

They discovered a giant wolf in the middle of the room, surrounded by undead soldiers and trampling the gates beneath his claws. "Where is she?" Croissant growled in his monstrous form. "Where is she?! My sister suddenly vanished from our house, and I followed her smell there!"

"Oh, Croissant..." Tears of relief began to run down Victor's cheeks. "You have come to save me?"

"You think you can blackmail me?" Croissant snarled back. "I don't know how you caught on to me, but taking my sister hostage? I'm going to kill you for this!"

"Nobody is killing anyone," Allison said, putting her hands on her hips. "Croissant, Chocolatine is... Chocolatine is fine. She's probably the only happy person about the current situation."

"Thank the gods, Croissant," Victor said, as one of his skeletons offered him the bazooka. "I take back everything I said about you. I've never been so happy to see you!"

“What does this mean?” Croissant suddenly eyed the vizier’s dressing gown. “Wait, what are those bite marks on your neck? And why... why do you have her smell on you?”

Good question. A better one was, why did Victor suddenly hear ominous opera music in the background?

“What have you done?” Croissant showed his fangs. “You half-dragon bastard, what have you *done*?”

“Croissant, forgive me; I have *done* your *sister*.”

The background music suddenly ended, replaced with a tense silence. Croissant stood there, astonished, before glaring at the Vizier with cold fury.

“Enjoy the herpes then.”

...

“What?” Victor blinked.

“Enjoy the herpes,” Croissant repeated with a smug smile.

“You’re lying,” the vizier said. “You’re lying. You’re toying with me!”

“You don’t know where she has been,” Croissant taunted him, clearly delighting at one-upping his rival for once.

Allison tried to reassure him. “Vic, if this is true, I can still cure you both.”

“That is not the point!” the Grand Vizier sighed. Even if it was true, he was immune to disease, but the very thought... ugh... “Croissant, she is upstairs. You can take her back home.”

Much to his frustration, Croissant seemed torn between his brotherly over-protectiveness, and the sheer spite he felt towards Victor. “I dunno,” he said. “You know what they say... what is *done* cannot be *undone*.”

Victor grabbed the bazooka and pointing it at the werewolf. "Croissant, you will do your brotherly duty and take her back home, to defend her honor."

"What?!"

"I have a bazooka and I'm not afraid to use it!"

"Vic, calm down," Allison tried to defuse the situation.

"The blackmail attempt failed, and you successfully rescued your sister, everybody is happy!" Victor ranted, before frowning. "Wait. Why did you think I would blackmail you with her?"

"You didn't..." At that moment, Croissant realized he had said too much. "Oh. Nothing."

"You said Victor was on to you." Allison's eyebrows narrowed.

"Because he's a piece of dragon crap!" Croissant denied it.

The werewolf thought Victor was on to him? For what? What could Croissant have done to warrant the kidnapping of his sister? It must have been something truly serious. Something to do with Charlene, maybe?

"It was you." Victor's eyes widened, as he assembled the pieces of the puzzle. "*You're* the one who intercepted Charlene's letters with the adventurer's guild, and gave them to our enemies."

At this moment, the werewolf realized he had given himself away.

So he tried to bolt out of the room, but Allison cast a spell faster. "[Accelerated Beastbane]!"

The dryad launched a sacred, green beam of light at the werewolf, hitting him in the back as he trampled a skeleton on his way to the outside. The spell immediately propelled him to the ground. "Damn it!" Croissant cursed.

“I have dealt with werewolves during the full moon for months,” Allison said. “You are not going anywhere.”

“Why?” Victor asked. “Why did you betray us?”

“Betray you? I was never on your side!” Croissant’s eyes flashed with anger. “You and that dragon ruined my life! You burned my home, put me through Furibon’s traps for nothing, treated me like crap, and stole my girlfriend! I’m sick of being humiliated all the time!”

“Stole? Charlene dumped you because you wanted to eat her, and you tried to sacrifice me first!” Victor protested.

“Your boss’s guests ate all of my sheep, and two of them mated on my house’s roof!”

“You’re going to the dungeon for your betrayal,” Victor said, crestfallen. “You can’t take her back.”

Congratulations! For arresting a mole in your midst, you earned a level in **[Grand Vizier]**!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 SKI, +1 INT, +2 CHA, +1 LCK.

“Do you have accomplices?” Victor asked.

“Doesn’t matter,” the werewolf replied. “You’re too late. I’m taking solace in the fact that you and the dragon are already BLEEPed.”

“We survived Brandon Maure,” Allison said, firmly on the government’s side. “Whatever your 'friends' have in store, we can beat it.”

“You idiot, *they’re* already in the city. You let them in.”

Chapter 57: The Dragon's Speech Check

With his head held fashionably high, so all could see his crown shine under the sun, Vainqueur paraded through the streets of his capital like a lion among sheeps. His kobold minions formed two columns at his sides, driving a wedge through the thousands of monsters singing his name.

“Vainqueur! Vainqueur! Vainqueur!”

As a good emperor, Vainqueur smugly pretended not to hear them.

Secretly though, he relished the attention. After spending so long holed up in his vault, hunting down his foes, and practicing wizardry, it was good to be reminded of how important and loved he was.

Once they reached the central square, Vainqueur sat in the middle of the area, the Kobold Rangers ordering his other minions to create a circle around him. A crowd of gnolls, goblins, fiends, trolls, undead, and countless new creatures had gathered to see him. Ghoul minstrels played drums and kobolds trumpets.

“Oyé, brave minions and citizens of the V&V Empire,” Pink Ranger announced. “Bow before our great and beloved ruler, His Majesty Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of His Name, Great Calamity of the Age, Defender of the Hoard, Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains, Greatest Gladiator in the World!”

His subjects all prostrated themselves before his Majesty, and Vainqueur basked in their adoration.

“Exceptionally, His Majesty will personally hold court before you, listen to the complaints of his citizens, and deliver justice onto the wicked!” Pink Ranger continued, while Black Ranger approached with a pile of scrolls, so she may write down this glorious day in the registry. “His Majesty will begin with great news!”

As his Vizier had asked, Vainqueur would show himself to the population of his new empire, and bless them with his enlightened dragon leadership. His greatest minion was occupied questioning Croissant the Useless in the castle, who had apparently turned into a traitor. How could he after Vainqueur treated him like a beloved minion, the dragon would never understand. How ungrateful. He had even made his sister, the Sweet Chocolatine, cry.

Vainqueur had welcomed the opportunity to change his mind after his magical training turned out to be tedious and boring. He had done everything needed to train as a spellcaster; even briefly switched his crown for a wizard hat, and uprooting an olive tree to make a wand. He had tirelessly practiced his magic on summoned demon dummies, trying to make magical weeds grow beneath them.

Nothing had worked.

Vainqueur had lost count of how many times he cast ‘*Weedgardium Leviosa*’ or ‘*Bogus Botanicus*’ on the farm soil with nothing to show for it.

Magic was hard!

Thankfully, being amazing was easier. “Yes, I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, greatest adventurer in the world, has great news for you!” the dragon addressed the crowd. “To celebrate my perfect, flawless victory in my latest quest, and my ascension to [Augustus], I hereby order the creation of a great gladiator arena!”

His declaration was welcomed with howls of adoration.

“A great arena, where you will see me and my glittering minions eat our enemies while you cheer me!” Vainqueur continued. “A great ring where

blood and gold will fall like rain! Where any minion can show his worth in front of a daring audience! A Colosseum with unique attractions, like rising water, fire, and sparkles!”

It would be like the arena where he fought grasshopper Maure for the first time, but *better! Dragonly!*

“And to inaugurate it, I announce a great minion tournament for the summer solstice! My lackeys will showcase their might for all to see! Once and for all, we shall determine who is the *strongest minion of them all!*”

The ambiance turned electrical, as lightning slimes let out thunder strikes at his announcement. None were more excited than Vainqueur’s own soldiers, from Red Ranger to Barnabas the Troll.

This would be the perfect opportunity for his minions to level up and prepare for the inevitable war with Furibon. He would show off his power *and* increase it! Win-win!

The crowd clapped and whistled in enthusiasm, Vainqueur basking in the sound.

The bloodthirsty love of your people has filled you with energy! You will recover SP twice faster today!

Vainqueur raised a hand and acclaims dying down. After the fun, time to dirty his claws and govern.

"As you have no doubt been informed, the V&V Empire now has an official currency." Blue the Koblood took steps in front of Vainqueur, raising a beautiful golden paper note. "The Vainqueur Dollar, with my face on it!"

And Manling Victor's own on the back.

"This currency will be the only one allowed in the borders of my empire," Vainqueur explained, as Blue presented variations of the dollar, such as the lesser silver version. "Your coins will no longer be accepted by my minions, even if you use the under the table manling ritual of bribery. Your gold will

be safeguarded and exchanged against Vainqueur Dollars at a fair, advantageous rate."

Advantageous for Vainqueur of course. Generosity began with oneself.

Unlike the ovation he received after the arena project, his lackeys exchanged worried whispers. As he had expected, Manling Victor's idea was a bit too radical for most of them; and who could blame them? One could *feel* the texture and warmth of gold coins, while paper was cold and soulless.

But a true dragon argued their case to the bitter end.

"I understand your wariness, and so, I will ask you a question," Vainqueur asked, raising his arms to expose his chest. "Do you see me carrying my hoard with me?"

Obviously, no one objected, and so the dragon continued. "Yet, once I did! It was so comforting, to carry my shinies with me. I thought myself invulnerable, underestimating the evilness of paupers lusting for my gold. And then... I faced the cruel Furibon, on this very mountain!"

The dragon waved a hand at the volcano in a dramatic gesture.

"My hoard..." Vainqueur's voice broke at the memory. "My hoard... was poisoned to death. I saw it die before my eyes."

Charisma check successful. The crowd is feeling your pain and grief.

As they should. The memory of this ghastly atrocity brought Pink Ranger to tears, while her teammates lowered their heads in shame.

Never forget. Never forgive.

"None should feel the pain of outliving their hoard," Vainqueur declared, his grief turning to resolute determination. "Ever since, I have stashed my gold in the most secure place known to dragonkind: my lair! A vault protected by the strongest of minions! A place which none of my foes could breach!"

Carried by emotion, Vainqueur raised his voice and went on to do the best speech of his Emperor career.

"Are you ready to live in fear, carrying your gold in your purse for thieves to take, or stashing it in your backyard for a lich to poison? Or will you sleep well, knowing you hide it in the safest place in the world? That you have put your hoard next to mine, where none will dare touch it, while you safely carry Vainqueur Dollars? Remember: I am the richest dragon in the world! If I do something, then it is right! How do you expect to become almost as wealthy as I, if you do not follow my example? Safety is the greatest tribute one can pay to protect their hoard!"

Vainqueur pumped his claws into a fist and raised it toward the sun.

"Protect your gold... with Vainqueur Dollars!"

Charisma check successful! It's a critical!

The shouts were deafening.

His undead minions moved stashes of Vainqueur Dollars, with the common people almost warring between one another to exchange their gold for them; knowing that they would be safe in the castle's vaults. "Vainqueur!" his name was shouted. "Vainqueur! Vainqueur!"

Congratulations! For your inspiring speech, extreme charisma, and popularity with the common folk, you have earned the **[El Presidente]** Personal Perk!

[El Presidente]: You gain a +10 Charisma Bonus when addressing large crowds with speeches or drunken rants.

Governing was such fun! Why didn't he think about it doing it centuries ago?

"I shall now listen to your puny complaints, and answer them with the wisdom dragonkind is known for," Vainqueur declared. "Bring me the first complainers!"

“Show us your royal tickets!” Red the Kobold ordered, sorting out the citizens. The first two were a gnoll, and a ghoul; the latter carried a green slime with him.

“Before my judgment, each of you shall kiss my ring.” Vainqueur presented his hand and blinkblink. “For I am your Emperor, and I am wealthy.”

Both did as he asked, and the dragon allowed the peons to expose their problem. “Your Majesty, this ghoul and I share the same house,” the gnoll said, “We both adopted a slime, but when I returned home, his was gone, and he pretended mine was his!”

“Liar!” the ghoul protested. “Your Majesty, this living is a jealous racist trying to deprive me of my beloved pet, after he lost his!”

“This is a difficult case,” Vainqueur said. “Are there witnesses?”

When both shook their heads, the dragon reached a decision. “Ranger Red, bring me the jelly.”

So did the kobold, raising the slime before the Emperor. The big, fatty creature watched Vainqueur back with huge eyes.

“While greed is the greatest of virtues, each of you will learn that one can gain without taking,” the dragon raised his claw. “The slime shall be cut in half.”

And with a swipe of his claw, he did so. Within the blink of an eye, Kobold Red now carried two smaller jellies, each in one hand.

You have successfully divided one Mature Green Jelly into two Young Green Jellies!

“Each of you shall now have their slime, and cherish it as they would their gold,” Vainqueur ordered, each of the citizens getting their pet. “I shall tolerate no discrimination among my citizens, for you are all equally below me.”

“The Emperor has spoken!” Pink Ranger said, having wiped away her tears.
“Bring the next citizen!”

A cadre of undead guards brought him the two new claimants: a dirty-looking werewolf, and a walking cactus wearing a scarf and a straw hat.

“The Emperor shall settle the matter of Farmer Greenspike versus Pierre the Wolf,” Pink Ranger announced after both kissed Vainqueur’s ring. “You may now expose your problem to imperial justice.”

“Your Majesty, I found this werewolf preying on my sheep flock yesterday,” the cactus said. “I called the guards for help, and he confessed his crime. Most of these sheep were destined to become part of the food tribute I owe to Your Majesty.”

“I confess my crime,” the werewolf replied, “But I only stole these sheep to feed my family—”

“Guilty!”

Vainqueur glared at the heartless thief. “I decreed that those who would not say ‘sheeps’ will be sheep! This is your first offense. Your second was your horrible, horrible crime; to steal a sheep from me is like stealing my gold!”

“But Your Majesty—” the villain protested, but the dragon did not let him finish.

“You will start with helpless cattle and then escalate to murdering baby coins! Guilty! However, you shall be allowed to feed your family.”
Vainqueur turned to the guards. “Send him to Rolo, so that he may replace the sheeps he stole.”

“No, please!” the werewolf panicked, as the guards moved to seize him,
“Please don’t turn me into a sheep!”

“Do you not wish to feed your family?” Vainqueur asked him, “By becoming a sheep yourself, certainly your pups will be well-fed.”

“I am a family of one!” the werewolf admitted to his lie, as the dragon had known all along; he had tricked him into revealing himself.

Vainqueur was many things, but a savage was not one of them.

“Then you have lied to your Emperor, making you a forsworn *and* a thief,” the dragon said, “You are unfit to be food, so you will be sent to work in the mines. Take him away!”

The guards dragged the screaming werewolf out of Vainqueur’s sight, the farmer bowing before following. “Your Majesty tricked him into revealing his lie so easily...” Pink Ranger muttered in admiration.

Of course he did. He had heard almost every thieving excuse under the sun from those foolish enough to try stealing from his hoard. The dragon took no pleasure in the decision, but it had to be done.

A ruler could be merciful, but he also had to show a strong hand to a crime against his belly.

“Farmers are the ones keeping your Emperor fed with their tribute of meat,” Vainqueur decided to explain the way things were to the population. “You shall honor farmers, the way you do your parents. This shall be henceforth known as my fourth commandment. The fifth shall be, do not steal, for there is no greater crime than thieving from one’s hoard.”

Pink Ranger scribbled the orders on paper, so that she may update the laws of the realm accordingly. Vainqueur cleared his throat to order the next one to come forth, but a shout interrupted him.

“Murderer!”

The word was said with such a strident voice, that it echoed through the square. Vainqueur’s eyes squared firmly on the cause, one of the demonic lawyers who defended his rightful case against Mot the Fomor. He and a cadre of fiends pushed away the crowd, trying to get past the guards and approach the Emperor.

“Get in line with your ticket, like the others!” Red Ranger replied, unimpressed.

“Your Majesty, Malfy has been poisoned!” the fiend ignored the ranger.
“He’s on his deathbed!”

Vainqueur’s head perked up. There could only be one culprit. “It is the work of Furibon, who is evil and at work among us! We shall stop him henceforth!”

But the fiend did not listen to his wisdom, blaming someone else.

“No, Your Majesty, it’s the angel! She poisoned Malfy with holy water!”

Chapter 58: Detective Work

Every dragon had to face a minion war at one point.

These events, where minions envying one another escalated into fighting, usually happened over breeding matters; or at least it did, the last time Vainqueur employed goblins. Two of his lackeys had dueled over a female while he was on a hunt, and he came back to his lair to find the dispute had spiraled into a full-blown civil war.

Worse, they had left his hoard unattended while killing one another!

The survivors of his furious reaction had learned their lesson, but Vainqueur had forbidden minion sexual harassment ever since. So afraid for his wealth, he had even abandoned his matchmaking hobby. His trust in Friend Victor, and his chief of staff's utter inability at breeding on his own with strangers, had been the only reasons he made an exception.

Since he had only employed one kind of creature at once in the past, the Great Calamity never had to deal with 'race conflicts' which plagued multi-species minion troops.

"You dirty pigeon scam!"

First time for everything.

Standing outside the Nethermart, with his head reaching over the rooftop, Vainqueur observed the scene with a disapproving eye.

Feathered Miel had been brought by Vainqueur's guards, mostly for her own protection. She kept her arms and wings closed, fearing for her life, while a crowd of fiends led by Malfy's lawyers surrounded her threateningly.

Tasty Malfy himself had grown sick and feeble, crumpled in a wheelchair and spitting green blood. A succubus nurse tended to him, while he sent glares to Feathered Miel. “See?” the lawyer said. “Our client recognized his attacker!”

“I did nothing to him!” Miel protested. “This is a misunderstanding!”

“You monopolistic heaven-lovers could not survive in a competitive market, so you tried to murder your competition!” the fiend lawyer accused Feathered Miel. “Infercorp patented this method! This is a violation of our intellectual property!”

“I am an angel, I do not poison people, even fiends!”

“Liar!” One of the demons, a fiendish gargoyle, showed his fangs, as if ready to jump at their rival.

Vainqueur interrupted them by shaking the whole building with his claw. “I will not allow minions to kill one another without my approval unless my chief of staff does it.”

“But Your Majesty—”

“Fiend minion, you are starting to sound like dragon food. Are you dragon food?”

The demon, once reminded of the food chain, wisely shut up.

“Explain to me what happened,” Vainqueur ordered. “We will deal with this matter the dragon way: by eating the guilty party.”

“I can testify,” the demon lawyer said. “Malfaisant, my fellow attorney and I were on our way to see Your Majesty’s grand speech when the angel interrupted us. Malfaisant, aware of her deceitful nature, told her to scram...”

“But then she said she wanted to join the winning side,” the other lawyer said. “Since Infercorp offers a sizable bonus for fallen angel headhunting,

and she oversaw Mr. Victor's insurance file, we decided to humor her on neutral ground."

"Angels are too cowardly to poison the competition, so we did not use tasters when she offered us a drink."

"Or so we thought! She served us Holy Water, and Malfaisant could not spit it out quickly enough! She ran away while we were tending to our poor manager! Even now, he cannot speak to condemn this treacherous attack!"

"Feathered Miel, what do you have to say for your defense?" Vainqueur asked.

"Look at me," the angel replied, widening her eyes in a way reminding the dragon of cat kittens. The fiends booed Feathered Miel in response. "Gaze into the face of a poor innocent lamb, sent to the slaughter."

Vainqueur did not understand her point. "You look like a mammal manling, which means ugly by default."

"Your Majesty, I was obviously impersonated!"

"Then where were you when this happened?" one of the demon lawyers snarled.

"I was working on Mr. Victor's insurance file in my office!" the angel protested. "His Karma Credit Score is so terrible, I had to rework it from scratch!"

"That is why you attacked our manager," the lawyer accused her. "You knew our Grand Vizier would choose the superior afterhealth care, and so you tried to kill the better Extraplanar entrepreneur in your jealousy."

"Typical crime of passion," his fellow added. "Your Majesty, she is obviously the Mother Teresa of Crime!"

"Mr. Victor is devoted to the safety of his soul," Miel protested, joining her hands. "I know his heart is true."

The fiends exploded into a strange kind of laughter before one of the lawyers cleared his throat. “If your heart is true, then certainly someone can provide you with an alibi.”

The angel bit her lip. “I spent the entire time alone in my office.”

“So you have no witnesses!” the lawyer accused her. “Your defense does not hold!”

Vainqueur put his peerless, brilliant deductive mind to work on the case. While on the surface, the angel was clearly the culprit, a lifetime of hearing excuses had made the dragon attuned to noticing lies; and the feathered snack sounded truthful.

Could a deceitful villain impersonate her? If so why? To exploit an existing rivalry and set his minions against one another? This sounded familiar. Too familiar.

Intelligence check successful! You recognized the criminal pattern from flimsy evidence, like a crime fiction protagonist!

“Minions, this is the same method which our foes used to send Icefang after me,” Vainqueur said. “The true enemy is trying to divide us.”

Feathered Miel breathed in relief. “Thank Heaven, Your Majesty’s eyes see true!”

“The true enemy, Your Majesty?” the lawyer asked, confused.

“It was obviously Furibon in drag and false wings,” Vainqueur said.

“Your Majesty, I do not understand,” one of the fiends said, unable to see the brilliance of the dragon’s logic. He probably had fifty in intelligence, or maybe even less!

“In the absence of evidence, we must assume the responsible party is the most likely suspect,” Vainqueur enlightened them, “who is the vile Furibon, who must be destroyed, and those who treacherously released him!”

The lawyers exchanged glances. “But Your Majesty, the most likely explanation is that *she* did it!”

“She shall be jailed until the treacherous lich has been stopped,” Vainqueur decided, ending the debate. “I trust my instincts, and I have spoken.”

The fiends fell into a heavy silence, unable to understand his genius.

Such was the burden of a sixty-four stat in Intelligence.

“So?” Victor asked.

Jules closed the metal door of Croissant’s jail behind them, deep in the dungeons below the castle. “He isn’t speaking. His accomplices put him under a magical [Protection against Truth-Detection], and the caster’s level is higher than mine.”

“Vainqueur should be able to break it,” Victor pointed out. “He can cancel any spell short of Melodieuse’s nowadays.”

“That’s not the problem,” the ghoul replied. “I don’t think he knows, but they also put a [Death Curse] deadman switch should this protection be dispelled. The one responsible is probably an experienced Necromancer, from what I could gather. I would put their Spellcaster level at more than fifty; maybe sixty.”

Furibon? He had the power and the motive, but Victor doubted he was involved. From what he had gathered, the lich had learned the lesson and wouldn’t try to mess with them again. Which other Necromancer had a bone to pick with Vainqueur, or worked with someone who did?

Victor had a likely suspect in mind. “Will the curse activates if he speaks?”

“I do not think so, but he seems to hate you more than he fears His Majesty.”

Victor sighed. Between this and Miel being under arrest, this was looking more and more like a giant mess. Amazingly, Vainqueur had made the right

call and not jumped to conclusions; the angel was many things, but a poisoner wasn't one of them.

He heard steps coming towards them, turning around to see Allison, Chocolatine, and Barnabas. The troll carried a huge crate in his hands, while the werewolf had brought a casket full of food for her brother. Her eyes were red from the tears.

"You've tortured my brother?" she asked, worried.

"What? Of course not, torture never works." Also, it was inhuman.

Unfortunately, she misinterpreted him. "You're going to trap his soul in your scythe?! Or send him to Happyland?!"

Who did she take him for, Sauron? "We're not going to do anything to his soul," Victor said. "But he isn't going to get out of that jail anytime soon."

"But you're the government!" Chocolatine protested. "Can't you make a little exception for your girlfriend's family?"

Come on, the fact they were a greedy dictatorship sponsored by Happyland did not mean they were corrupt!

"Please don't kill him," Chocolatine begged him, a far cry from her usual quirky and confident self, "I know he made a mistake, but I'm sure I can set him straight! I can set him straight..."

"I swear I'm not going to execute him," Victor promised. Frankly, if it had been almost anyone else, the Vizier would have threatened to feed him to Junior already.

"Can I... can I talk to him?"

Victor didn't see any reason to disagree. Maybe she could even get him to speak. "I'm here if you need it."

She nodded in gratitude, but didn't answer. He let her open the door to Croissant's cell, and closed behind him to give them privacy.

“Girlfriend?” Jules asked, the Grand Vizier sighing, “Victor, you are the bravest man I know.”

Yeah, right. Seeing Chocolatine mortified after her brother’s arrest had made Victor rethink about his reaction. After getting used to her quirky usual self, he hated to see her sad; it awakened protective instincts he didn’t know he had.

“How is the situation?” Victor asked the newcomers.

“The fiends still want Miel’s head, although Vainqueur cowed them into obedience for now,” Allison said. “The situation in town is tense, but there’s more. Someone attacked the farms tonight.”

Victor narrowed his eyes. “Continue.”

“Rolo noticed the guards protecting the livestock’s hens had been hypnotized into sleep, while wolves massacred the cattle,” the dryad explained. “What’s wrong is that, when, Rolo arrived to chase them, they transformed into mist before he could get close.”

“I have yet to meet a wolf breed capable of [Mistform],” Jules said.

“Vainqueur took the attack on his food supply personally and started patrolling the farms. I believe it reassured the population, for now.”

Victor suddenly noticed something wrong. “Why didn’t Charlene come to inform me?”

“Vic...” Allison cleared her throat. “Charlene is missing. She wasn’t at her house or at the office, and the kobolds haven’t found her yet.”

A chill went down Victor’s spine. “Any ransom demand, or hint of where she could have gone?”

Allison shook her head.

Damn!

“Do I hurry up and prepare to equip everyone for war, chief?” Barnabas asked, after having remained silent for a while.

“Yeah,” the Grand Vizier nodded. “What about my first order?”

“Work is done, chief,” said the troll, opening the crate to present his work inside.

Victor had ordered the troll to craft him a replica of his scythe, and a set of armor meant to synergize with his current classes. The final result was scary to behold, black plate armor with a tattered cape and a faceless, horned helmet. Barnabas had painted a crimson dragon on the torso, most probably to represent Vainqueur.

Hell Knight Armor

Quality: B+

Material: Soulsteel

Endurance: 50/50.

Protection: Physical +16/Magical +8

Weight: 16 kgs.

Bonus: +3 STR/+3 VIT/+10% Critical Damage/Auto-Regen/Unholy, Fire, Darkness and Curse Resistance/[Cursed] if wearer has good Karma.

A customized set of heavy armor once worn by the defunct order of the Hellknights (now rebranded as the politically correct Friends of Happiness); its steel has been infused with the boundless malice of a hundred debt collectors. Perfect for a dragon’s enforcer!

Speaking of Sauron, he wouldn't have disdained such armor; here died Victor's hopes of looking like a shining knight on a horse.

The scythe would be especially helpful against their enemy, for the Vizier had a pretty good idea who they were. Foes turning into mist in the dead of

the night; fond of misdirection, surprise attacks meant to maximize terror, and hypnotism...

Vampires.

Croissant was right. Victor did let them in, invited these *snakes* to operate within their borders.

The Nightblades had come to Murmurin.

Chapter 59: Fangs in the Night

“This is the Nightblades’ warehouse,” Manling Victor told his master from the back of his flaming horse, as a troop of minions encircled a stone house in broad daylight. “Where they stashed the stuff they smuggled into the country.”

“To think that I spared them the evil of taxes, and they repaid me by killing my food,” Vainqueur complained.

Their wizards and priests finished examining the house from the outside, in case the occupants had set a trap. The dragon smelled the air, the warehouse reeking of spice, grave dirt, and fresh blood; it reminded Vainqueur of a farmer’s slaughterhouse.

Corpseling Jules, as the most experienced necromancer in the country, told the group everything about vampires. “According to Lord Victor, they are alchemical vampires, created through blood elixirs rather than the Red Death plague. Which means that besides keeping their vulnerability to sunlight, they lack most of the standard vampire’s weaknesses, have higher stats, and possess special abilities such as turning into blood.”

“Lavere could walk under the sun, as did the one we fought in the Winter Kingdoms,” Manling Victor said. “We have to assume that they all can resist it.”

“Who?” Vainqueur asked, not remembering the name.

“The Nightblades’ leader.”

Oh. It didn’t matter. The queen of rats would give him no more trouble than any other of her kind. “Do vampires burn?” Vainqueur asked the important question.

“Oh, yes,” Corpseling Jules nodded. “I believe they even have a Fire vulnerability. They take triple damage from it.”

“Then, minion, why did you use so many words to describe a problem, when the solution is so obvious?”

“I am not worried about Your Majesty’s capacity for killing,” Manling Victor said. “We have enough priests to repel them, and I don’t think they’re stupid enough to pick a fight with you around. Unfortunately, they’re probably keeping Charlene as a hostage.”

“Our werewolves could not find her, even with her scent,” Corpseling Jules said. “Which implies magic.”

“No one eats my manling minions,” Vainqueur said. “Except for me, when I need emergency rations.”

“Your Majesty’s concern for my kind is heartwarming as ever,” Manling Victor said with his usual strange tone. “Perhaps he could remove the roof with the grace he is known for?”

Intelligence check...

Successful!

“Minion, there is something very strange about the way you worded your sentence.”

Manling Victor froze in place. “What about it?”

“You said a sentence, but somehow your tone implied that you believed the opposite,” Vainqueur explained. “But it is not a lie, because you are not truly disguising your intent and you would never deceive me. It was as if I were meant to divine the true meaning from your voice alone.”

His minion silently looked at his master, his face hidden behind his new helmet.

“But that cannot be since that would mean you find me clumsy, and you love me. You love me more than anything.”

His chief of staff spoke no answer in return, which made his master worry for him. “Minion?”

“Your Majesty can understand sarcasm now,” Manling Victor finally spoke up, his tone having turned emotionless and distant. “Your Majesty can understand sarcasm.”

“What is sarcasm, some kind of magic?” Vainqueur’s head perked up. “Can I learn it?”

“It’s... it’s a stress relief method manlings use when they feel tense.”

“Saying a statement while implying the opposite makes you happier?” Vainqueur frowned. “Minion, I am *very* worried about your mental health. You should work more.”

“Thanks, it really helps.”

“You did it again,” Vainqueur said. “Friend Victor, you should not feel tense. I will protect you and recover your outdated breeding partner.”

His minion simply looked away.

Vainqueur ripped the warehouse’s roof with his hand like he did with farmers’ barns when doing groceries. However, this time, he didn’t find any cattle worth eating inside, nor even a foe to kill.

In fact, he found nothing but empty crates. “The vermin have left already!”

The Kobold Rangers broke the door in response, kobolds swarming the warehouse.

“Your Majesty, Lord Victor!” Red Ranger quickly hurried out of the warehouse with a paper in his claws. “I found this in a crate!”

“[Detect Magic Trap],” Corpseking Jules cast on the paper. “It is safe.”

Vainqueur's Grand Vizier grabbed the scroll and read it. "Great. This is just *great*."

"Minion, you should see a healer," Vainqueur said. "Or breed. Mammals feel happier after breeding, do they not?"

His minion sighed. "Later, Your Majesty. They have Charlene and want to meet me at a location outside of the city's limits, at night, for an exchange. I can bring two bodyguards."

"Oh, good," Vainqueur said. "*I and my army* makes two."

"They heavily insisted against Your Majesty coming. If they see you within a mile of the location, they'll cancel the deal."

"You said exchange?" Corpseless Jules noted. "Who do they want?"

"*What*," Manling Victor replied. "They want Mot's map."

"Strange." The necromancer joined his fingers. "Why not the Bottle? Do they know you sent it back to Barsino?"

"I can only see one reason why they would want the map," Manling Victor replied without elaborating.

"It does not matter, I will not give the map to the servants of Furibon, who is evil and must be destroyed," Vainqueur replied. "Like the last name on the list."

"Your Majesty, Furibon is not behind *every* plot against you," Manling Victor said nonsense and doubled down. "In fact, he said he had learned the lesson and let bygones be bygones."

"And you believed him, minion?" Vainqueur growled, the pain of losing his hoard once still sharp in his heart. "Have you forgotten the atrocities the Goldslayer committed while he roamed the world? Someone willing to cross that line will cross any other, from lie to deceit!"

“Chief, this is obviously a trap!” Red Ranger protested. “They want to isolate His Majesty’s most valuable minion and eat him!”

“My empire shall not give in to the demands of lichlovers and manling cattle thieves!” Vainqueur roared, his minions letting out a war cry in response.

Manling Victor sighed. “I have a plan.”

“And *BLEEP!*”

His shout of misery echoed through the sand dunes, under the moonless night sky.

“Vic, what’s the matter?” As the highest level priest in the ‘Murmurian Army,’ Victor had selected Allison as his first bodyguard; she had traded her usual clothes for war, a flowery cloak, and a black wood staff. Thankfully, since V&V had steadily pushed further the borders of arable lands into the desert for the past months, her ability to move around had increased as well. “You’ve been cursing for hours.”

“He understands sarcasm now!” Victor snarled angrily from the back of his Nightmare Horse. He carried the rocket launcher in one hand, and the scythe with the other. Allison thought it made him look ridiculous, but he didn’t care. “I need a new stress relief method!”

“You could always murder demons and then cook them,” Allison deadpanned. “It worked wonders for Chocolatine.”

“You mean she was even worse before?!”

“Sir,” Jules, his other bodyguard, cleared his throat. “If you could please remain calm.”

“Yeah, you don’t need to shout, twoleg,” a third voice said.

Victor frowned, narrowing his eyes towards the source of the words.

Namely, the horse he was riding. “You can talk?”

“Uh, yeah, I can,” the horse, apparently a mare according to the voice, replied. “And from what I heard so far, I’m probably smarter than you.”

“Not impressed,” Victor snorted. “My previous mount could eat you.”

“Vic, are you talking to your horse?” Allison asked, apparently not hearing what the creature had to say. Victor assumed he only did so because his mount counted as a monster.

“Hey, you’re not the one carrying a winged dragon-slash-mammal crybaby on your back.” The horse glared at her rider. “You can *fly*, you lazy reptile!”

“Yeah, sucks to be you!”

“The name’s Noircœur, you pile of horseshit,” the beast snorted. “Since I like intelligent conversation, we’re not going to talk very often.”

“Just talk to yourself then.” Victor let out a deep sigh, ignoring the gazes Allison and Jules sent him. “I’m not crazy.”

“Vic, I can’t believe I’m saying this,” his dryad friend said. “But you should get laid more.”

Skill check successful.

Victor noticed shapes silently moving behind a dune nearby, their scent hidden by the wind. “They’re here,” the Grand Vizier warned.

His allies immediately began to cast protective wards, while Victor used the new necromancy buffs he learned from Jules. “[Protection from Undeath], [Breath of Life], [Fear Aura].”

You gain +4 check bonus against [**Undeath**] effects.

+100 temporary HP.

Chances to inflict [**Terror**] increased by 20 percent.

Within seconds, a dozen of shadowy, cloaked figures had surrounded them; Victor's Monster Insight identifying most of them as vampires. Two of them forced a bound and gagged Charlene to move forward, stopping at a respectable distance from the opposition.

Charisma check partly successful.

Lucie Lavere can only read your surface thoughts.

Good enough. He hadn't told Allison anything and ghouls like Jules were immune to mind-reading, so the Nightblades shouldn't skim anything about their two secret weapons. The fact they had chosen a location near the city implied they might intend to retreat there though.

Victor noticed Savoureuse among the assassins, waving her claws at him.
"Oh, hi Vic!"

"Oh, hi Sav!" Victor greeted her back. "What's up?"

"I'm fine! I hope you're not mad about my sudden but inevitable betrayal?"

"Eh, it's part of the job."

"I'm sorry, Vic. You are my friend, but they know where my family lives."

"We are all a big happy family," a cowed figure said, Victor recognizing the voice as Lucie Lavere's. "Even if some of them turned into black sheep."

"Sheeps," Allison replied, making Victor roll his eyes.

"I understand now how you took over the Nightblades," the Grand Vizier told Lavere. "All of the upper echelons have become your vampire spawn."

"A very sweet deal, you will agree," she replied, keeping her face hidden.
"Especially once that vulnerability to the sun is dealt with."

"Emperor Vainqueur officially revoked your invitation on these lands, by the way," Victor said, but it didn't make her bulge.

“Dalton, we are predators. Does a fox need a rabbit’s permission to hunt him?”

“Really?” Allison frowned. “Then why the myth of vampires needing invitations?”

“Usually, because they are *polite*,” Jules replied.

“We bleed people to live, but we are not savages,” one of the undead assassins said. “We are undead of culture.”

“Yeah, it’s you living who don’t respect anything nowadays!” another complained.

“I’m surprised you showed up in person though,” Victor told Laverre. “There must be a very good reason why you took the risk to face Vainqueur.”

“You have something that I want,” Lucie confirmed, offering them her hand. “Give me Mot’s map, and I will release your assistant.”

“Afraid your name is on it?” Victor taunted her, her cold silence confirming his thoughts, “You’re Destra, the fourth member of the party. That was your name while alive. I thought you said fighting dragons was stupid?”

“It is, and I’m the one who convinced my team not to wake Vainqueur up, or touch his hoard,” the vampire confirmed, the irony of the situation not lost on Victor. “It worked very well for me. Immortality, knowledge, power...”

That explained why she had Savoureuse establish a chapter in Murmurin. She didn’t care about the region but wanted to keep tabs on Vainqueur in case he chose to hunt her down. Now that he had tracked down her teammates, she had moved into action.

“But you can’t be a good criminal mastermind when anyone can locate you with that map,” Allison guessed.

“And I doubt the fomors were happy that you lied to them,” Victor added. He remembered their last discussion when the vampire explained she could walk under the sun thanks to fairy flowers. Hamelin probably supplied them to her, in exchange for favors. “You have to know you are in a no-win situation. You may be powerful, but a bunch of thieves and hired guns will never defeat Vainqueur.”

“Fighting dragons *is* stupid,” Lucie replied. “Which is why we won’t. We were tasked with disrupting this fragile country, and we will. We will starve your citizens, frighten the merchants, assassinate your leaders. We will retreat into the shadows too fast for that clumsy dragon to catch us. No one will feel safe. Your terrible economy and existing tensions will do the rest, tearing this place apart.”

Argh, she intended to attack them with basic economic principles! “Not gonna happen.”

“You’re on the losing side,” Lucie said. “You just don’t know it yet. So I’m going to make you and your friends a one-time offer: ditch the dragon, get back into the fold, or die.”

“Already did,” Victor replied. “The answer is: nope.”

“Nope,” Allison added, while Jules shook his head politely.

“Too bad, because I do not believe in second chances.” The vampire shrugged. “But we don’t have to fight tonight. The map, against the girl.”

Sure.

After Victor checked Charlene with [Monster Insight] first.

Shadowman

Doppelganger Inveigler (Fairy/Humanoid)

Strong against Fairy, Mind-Control, Poison, Illusions, Paralysis, Sleep, and Truth-Detection.

Weak against Manslayer, Cold Iron, and Silver.

A fairy working as a spy, assassin, and occasional actor. A master infiltrator capable of shape-shifting, mind-reading, and truth-hiding; very pissed that your [Monster Insight] could detect his true nature in spite of all its natural immunities to scry magic and perks. You wounded its feelings! Also, it was a trap.

Well-tried.

“That Perk of yours is so *annoying*,” Lucie Lavere said, before instantly casting a spell. “[Accelerated Nocturne].”

She unleashed a wave of impenetrable darkness around herself before anyone could react.

The terrain has been temporarily changed to [**Dark Underworld**].

Nocturnal creatures, fiends, and undeads on the field have their stats increased, and will be harder to turn. All non-nocturnal creatures will suffer from the [**Blind**] ailment. Monotype, non-undead creatures will be animated as undead if killed on the field.

His friends instantly cast spells to form a defensive perimeter, while Victor pointed his rocket launcher in the general direction where Lavere used to stand. Her spell had completely cast the area into thick darkness, preventing him from seeing anything; yet he pulled the trigger anyway. His projectile going to hit something, the explosion swallowed by the dark.

“Summon-” Victor began.

Field effect cancelled.

The darkness dissipated before he could finish his sentence, revealing the minions alone in the desert, with only a small crater for company. True to their word, the Nightblades had vanished back into the shadows, rather than to fight.

Well.

Victor would keep his door locked at night.

Chapter 60: Interlude: A Lich's Tale

Far, far east of Gardemagne sprawled the lands of Serica, the Eastern Continent. Among the countries fighting to control it, few could rival the Jade Empire.

This enormous, fertile landmass was famous for its culture, military power, riches... and the wise dragon philosopher advising the imperial family. Sometimes, it even granted audiences to outsiders looking for answers and wisdom.

Waiting in front of the golden gates of the dragon's temple, the sorcerer mused at the irony. He would seek advice from a dragon on how to escape the shadow of another.

After hours of waiting, a bald monk in golden robes came to announce him. "The Jade Dragon, great Sifu, and guru of our beloved emperor, will grant you an audience," the man said. "You are to respect the protocol. Do not contest the Sifu's logic, do not question the Sifu, do not insult the Sifu."

Most of his face hidden beneath a hood and illusions, the undead bowed in agreement, hoping the creature would not recognize him. The Jade Empire may have been half a world away from Ishfania, but Vainqueur had spread his humiliating story to anyone who would listen to him.

The doors opened dramatically, the undead warlock floating after the monk while they moved through them.

The Jade Dragon welcomed the lich in a great hall supported by golden pillars, with twenty other monks bowing to him. The beast was a much

different creature than its western cousin, a dignified, jade-scaled snake with a lion's mane, deer horns, and lizard legs. The creature rested comfortably on an enormous cushion, which the sorcerer could tell the dragon filled with golden coins instead of feathers.

"Approach, disciple," the reptile spoke.

The undead nodded, bowing before the creature. "Oh, great Jade Dragon. The rumors of your great wisdom have reached even my ears. I traveled far and wide to find you."

"You are a skeleton, you do not have ears," the dragon missed the point. The lich shuddered at being reminded of Vainqueur's stupidity. "What is your name, undead?"

"F—" Furibon stopped himself before he committed suicide by dragon again. "Flubby." The name came out on impulse, and he immediately hated it.

He had spent too much time with V&V.

"Bony Flubby, you should be very wary when presenting yourself before my kind," the Jade Dragon said. "I heard that the cursed Goldslayer Furibon, the most evil lich to have ever existed, has been set loose. The seal was broken by fairies."

"A shame," Furibon lied.

"Most of my cousins would react badly to an undead seeking audience with them, but I am wise and wealthy. Welcome to my free, and I say, *free*, introduction to cultivation."

The monks let out a chant, giving the dragon the air of a divine teacher.

"One hundred times your power, one hundred times your magic, one hundred times your life!" the Jade Dragon shouted with passion. "I, Master Jade, will teach my secret shortcut to cultivation mastery! So you can earn more wisdom than you could ever imagine!"

Furibon politely listened without saying a word, as he had been asked.

“I have been in your place, working hard, not getting what I deserve,” the dragon ranted, clearly more interested in hearing himself talk than listening to the lich’s demand. “But I invested in myself, in my knowledge, until I reached power you mortals can only dream of! Who here wants to cultivate immortality?”

This smelled like a scam of some kind, and Furibon didn’t have a nose anymore. Yet the monk who introduced him knelt before the dragon, in awe of his presentation.

“If your thoughts are holding you back, then have faith.” The dragon extended his tiny arms at the golden pillars. “For I am rich! Do you want to be rich and immortal too?”

“I already achieved immortality,” the lich pointed out.

“Undeath is not true immortality! Can you enjoy the taste of cattle now? The warmth of gold on your skin?”

“It is true that lichdom has... weaknesses...” Furibon admitted, having balked at the loss of certain fleshy bits before undergoing the procedure. “But I made peace with them.”

“Only because you have a poor manling’s mindset!” the dragon lambasted him. “You must invest in yourself! I usually charge fifty-thousand gold coins to teach my secret cultivation techniques.”

If Furibon wasn’t dead already, he would have had a stroke. “That’s theft!” he couldn’t help but complain.

“But today, I will exceptionally show you the way to enlightenment for twenty-five, yes, *twenty-five* thousand gold coins!” Which was *still* theft. “Would you expect me, the Inventor of Cultivation, to teach the secrets of ultimate power for anything less? Would you?”

Furibon suddenly realized that the differences between eastern and western dragons were purely cosmetic. This... this snake oil pitcher advised the imperial family? How had this nation not collapsed already?

The lich turned to the monks, who whispered among themselves about the ‘opportunity of ten lifetimes.’ Clearly he wouldn’t get any help from them. “Oh, great dragon—”

“Super Sifu Guru Jade, or SSGJ,” the dragon replied. “With capital letters for each. I can tell the difference. If you wish to progress on the path of cultivation, you will have to learn proper etiquette first.”

“Super Sifu Guru Jade,” Furibon loathed saying every word. “I suffer from a disease called [Stockholm Syndrome], which can affect even the undead. I began my quest to cure it weeks ago, visiting villages, fetching items for wizards, until a chain of deals led me to your doorstep.”

“There is no disease which cultivation cannot cure, with hard work, gold, and money.”

“Great SSGJ, I have no interest in cultivation.” As an undead, he would not get any of its benefits, if this meditation mumbo jumbo was even real. “I came to you looking for a cure.”

And *only* because his own magical research failed to get results.

“And when you have this cure, what will you do?”

Well, Furibon would cure himself of his irrational fondness for Victor Dalton, and then...

And then...

...

And then what?

Ishfania had fallen, and he would never, *ever* work with Vainqueur in any shape or form. Furibon firmly intended to avoid the dragon until he died of

old age or of his own greed. Managing a dungeon and creating monsters had grown stale after a century of holding watch over the Castle of Murmurin. He also had no hobby.

What would the lich do after curing himself? He had no idea!

“Exactly, you have yet to find your passion,” the Jade Dragon said, sensing his doubt. “Which you will find if you pay for the higher levels of initiation.”

“First things first,” Furibon replied. “My passion can wait for when my health begins to improve.”

“If you wish to cure your disease, you have to commit to your spiritual growth,” the Jade Dragon said. “Buy my initiation package first or scram.”

Furibon sighed, but being as desperate as he was to free himself from his past, he accepted. “I brought gifts outside your palace.”

The dragon lowered his head, the monk who introduced Furibon whispering to him. “Good, good.” The beast nodded to himself, before turning back to the lich. “Congratulations on reaching your first cultivation level! As a reward for investing in yourself, I will gladly provide you with the shortest path to a miracle cure.”

This better be worth it. Powerful spellcaster or not, Furibon didn’t have unlimited funds.

“On the northern plains of what you mortals call the New World, in the orc lands, there is a great, flying casino dungeon run by the powerful warchief Manitou,” the Jade Dragon said. “One of the prizes he offers in his tournaments is the legendary artifact, Panacea, which can cure *all* diseases. Even imaginary ones.”

Furibon’s head perked up in happy surprise. And here he thought he had flushed his wealth down the toilet!

Manitou? Panacea? The names were enough to divine the dungeon's location.

"But you don't need it," the dragon replied. "Now, if you want the *true* super-secret of immortality and health, you need to ascend to a higher cultivation level."

"I will settle on this one," Furibon replied. "Thank you for your wisdom."

"That is why you will stay mortal and *poor*," the Jade Dragon boomed him, imitated by his monk minions. "If you cannot invest in yourself, if you do not make the effort to become a true cultivator, then I can do nothing for you. You are *beyond* help."

Furibon shrugged, excused himself, and teleported away.

As it turned out, finding the dungeon had been harder than getting in. A rarity among these places, the owner opened its gates to challengers.

The few who could fly of course.

This dungeon was by far the most luxurious place Furibon had ever seen, putting even Vainqueur's new golden city to shame. All the walls and pillars were made from chiseled marble, covered with tapestries, carpets, and mosaics; gemstone candelabras cast light on slot machines, roulette, and card table.

Most of the creatures populating the dungeon were orcs, but Furibon recognized giants, elves, fairies, demons, and even a phoenix among them. Most of the orcs and fiends served as the staff, while the others played the games; and the devils present seemed familiar to the lich.

On a closer look, the undead warlock realized that most of the slot machines were actually stylized steel golems, with hands and feet; *Jackpot Golems*. Here he thought these exp bags extinct, hunted to death by adventurers.

The lich also noticed a familiar face, barking orders to succubi waitresses; a dignified, insectoid woman, whose eerie beauty matched her ruthlessness.

“Lady Maure?” Furibon recognized the delicate creature as Isabelle Maure, his late master’s archdevil mother. “You are alive?”

“Furibon, long time no see,” the fiend replied, entertained by his presence. “What a pleasure to see you out of that scythe. Why would I be dead?”

“I heard reports of your demise when the dragons stormed Happyland.”

“Hell! HELL! I did not agree to that shameful brandwashing!” The archdevil calmed herself. “My corporation went bankrupt after my son’s demise, but I escaped with my life. The mess with Vainqueur Knightsbane has been a fiasco from start to finish.”

She didn’t say.

“Thankfully I invested in other side-ventures, such as this dungeon. While my influence has been greatly diminished, I am bouncing back.”

“What about King Maure?” Furibon asked, curious.

“His powerless soul moved back to my basement, which forces him to spend time with me. Unfortunately, he is whining so much that I wonder if this is a curse in disguise.”

Furibon shrugged. While he felt some sliver of loyalty for his old master, even he had preferred to stay at the bottom of a castle rather than suffer his flamboyant presence.

A cave troll in life, Furibon had been born smaller and frailer than most of his kind; but also smarter. Unlike his kindred, who feared magic as their fomor masters’ tool, the future spellcaster obsessed over the power it could provide him. His early successes eventually caught the attention of Brandon Maure, who offered to sponsor his research on lichdom against his loyalty.

Furibon accepted the deal and rose to become his master’s second-in-command; eventually, the once-troll took levels in the [Lich] class and

reached the respectable fifty-eighth level.

As a good lich, he had done everything to secure his phylactery. First, instead of choosing something fancy or a legendary artifact, he had bound his soul to a simple golden coin; knowing that adventurers destroying him would take his treasure with them. Then, he hid it in the New World, far, far away from the Mistral Continent.

All in all, his unlife had turned out well... until the lead fiasco.

“I tell you, lich, one day we shall reclaim my son’s market!” The archdevil pumped her fist. “I shall have my revenge against Infercorp and their representative, Victor Dalton, by guile or force! There will be a place for you at my side, in the great corporate army I will raise against—”

“No thanks,” Furibon cut her off.

The archdevil looked at him in surprise. “You do not seek revenge?”

“I learned my lesson.” Even without [Stockholm Syndrome], fighting that dragon and his sidekick was just *stupid*. Furibon had dodged karmic justice so far by avoiding heroes, and he would deal with Vainqueur the same.

“Revenge is a sucker game, and I will not be trapped in a weapon again.”

“Coward! After all that my son did for you...”

“If you wish to confront them, and you will have my sympathy if you try, do not cry over the resulting disaster.”

Isabelle snorted arrogantly. “If you are not here to pledge allegiance, then what do you want?”

“To challenge the dungeon boss.”

“Manitou? You will find him at the card table.” Isabelle Maure glanced in one direction. “My door remains open if you change your mind about Ishfania. I could make use of your magical expertise.”

“Thank you,” the lich replied, although his decision was set in stone.
“Allow me to return the favor by giving you advice on your situation.”

“To cut my losses and hide?”

“Make a deal with Dalton,” Furibon advised, having grown fond of the unfortunate human against his better judgment. “You have more to gain by working with him than against him. He is... weak of heart when beautiful women are involved.”

“Hmm... I will keep it in mind.”

Furibon then moved to the card table, almost immediately recognizing Manitou on sight: an obese, monstrosly tall, tusked orc with vague goblin-like features. The green-skinned monster dwarfed his competitors in size, shamelessly flaunting his wealth by wearing dozens of necklaces, rings, a crown, and other flashy accessories.

“Oh, you are the new challenger,” the massive orc said upon seeing Furibon approach, a fiend fawning him with a giant feather. “You face Manitou, the King of Games!”

Furibon immediately cast [Advanced Magic Scan] on him, trying to glean any information he could.

Manitou

HP: 4600/4600

SP: Infinite (Artifact?)

Type: Half-Goblin Orc Champion (Beast/Humanoid)

Weak to: Manslayer, Beastslayer, Lightning, Game Addiction.

Approximative level: Unknown.

Classes identified: Gambler, Pro Gamer, Cartomancer, Beastmaster, Warchief, Unknown? Perks could not be identified; hidden by [Card Trick].

The boss of the Sky Casino, a nerd/weeb hybrid and one of the richest monsters in the world; owns an enormous collection of magical items and powerful artifacts. Manitou is obsessed with alien games from the world of Earth, which he makes real with powerful magic.

“I have come for the Panacea,” Furibon said. “Give it to me.”

“I do not *give* nor do I *trade*, but I can *wager*,” the orc lord replied, amused. “My Panacea is a priceless item...”

“I have a wealth of magic items to compensate you.”

“But none of them as priceless to a lich as their phylactery,” the orc immediately zeroed in on the undead’s weakness.

Furibon was in no hurry to become a slave again but decided to hear the creature out before blasting him to death. “At what game would I have to best you?”

“The only games worth fighting your soul over.”

The orc snapped his fingers, a fiend servant immediately teleporting to his side with a suitcase. The creature opened it before Furibon, revealing its content: decks of cards, representing monsters, humans, and other creatures.

“Human children’s card games!”

Furibon resisted the urge to put his hand on his skull. Typical orc.

“But not any games,” the boss doubled down. “*Earth* games, three of them! To gain the Panacea, you will have to defeat me at Evolve Monsters; Magik the Joining; and Egyptian Duel! And if you lose even once...”

Getting rid of his last link to that dragon was worth almost any cost.

“I will also start any game with the powerful artifact ‘Heart of the Cards’ activated,” said the boss. “Which allows me to draw any card I wish from my deck, instead of drawing them in order.”

“What?!” Furibon choked. “That’s cheating!”

“I am the boss,” the monster replied. “You did not expect the fight to be *fair*?”

Furibon suddenly wondered why bothering to play that game, when he could simply take the gift by force. With his magical might and immortality, he should crush that orc in no time!

...

No.

Too many times, the lich had rushed into battle or committed stupid deeds on impulse. Turning the dragon’s hoard to lead had been one, and antagonizing Victor when he had nothing to gain had been another.

He had to think tactically. Overpowered or not, a card was a card! Sound strategy would always prevail over cheating!

“I will consider it,” Furibon replied. “But I ask for time to learn the rules, and resources to build powerful decks first.”

“I grant you three days.” The orc grinned. “You shall have access to my entire card collection, except my Heart of the Cards. The fight may not be fair, but you shall have a chance to win. Do you have a monster theme in mind?”

“Dragons and Undead.”

And traps.

Lots of traps.

- *Three days later, four hours after the start of a desperate struggle...*

That was it, the final battle; and it wasn’t going well for him.

Furibon’s Card Points: 600.

Manitou's Card Points: 2200.

Each fighter glared at one another on both sides of the table, one illusion of a miniature monster on their half of the field. Manitou had fused a powerful and nigh-invincible slime made of liquid mercury, while a small dragon made of bones defended Furibon. The slime had destroyed it twice, slowly depleting the lich's health bar, under the watchful eyes of spectators gathered around the table.

"You have fought well, lich, but your soul is mine," Manitou gloated, drawing his last card from his deck and launching a final attack. "[Metal Slimeking], destroy his [Dracozombie] and deplete the last of his points!"

The mercury slime swirled around the zombie, ready to finish it off... but leaving itself exposed to a counterattack.

"You activated my trap!" Furibon revealed his hidden ace. "[Lead Poisoning]! All metal monsters on the field will be destroyed!"

The mercury slime began to turn to lead before it could swallow his dragon.

"Impossible," Manitou panicked. "My [Metal Slimeking] prevented you from setting any trap!"

"But by destroying my [Scythe Lord] three turns ago, you activated his special ability. I can use any trap in either of our card crypts!"

"That is... stop!" Manitou looked into the pile of discarded cards, finding the [Scythe Lord] monster among them. "I check the effect first!"

It took five minutes for the orc to read the enormous wall of text detailing the card's abilities, during which the game stalled to a boring crawl. Furibon sung to himself while waiting for his inevitable victory.

"You are not pulling a fast one," the boss said, "I missed that line between the twentieth and the twentieth one!"

"As I knew you would. Now, your time is up."

“I can still change the issue!” the orc replied, furiously looking at his hand, “I can find a solution...”

“You fool, all this duel, you have executed flashy strategies, none of them would have worked unless you drew the *one* card you needed,” Furibon gloated, “But since you set the trap on *your* turn, you will not have the chance to draw any miracle card.”

“But when did you—” Manitou gasped. “Wait... back then... back then, on the first turn... that was the card you discarded?! You planned this all along?!”

Yes. Yes, he did.

His magic finished its good work, destroying that infernal goo and leaving Manitou exposed. “Now that your [Metal Slimeking] has been destroyed I attack you directly with my [Dracozombie].” Furibon pointed a finger at Manitou and then declared with boundless joy. “This is the end!”

The illusory dragon opened its mouth and finished the duel by blasting the casino’s boss with a tiny blast of purple fire.

Manitou’s Card Points: 0.

As the illusory monster vanished, Furibon let out a blissful cackle.

Congratulations!

By defeating Manitou through judicious use of destroyed creatures, returning from the dead in the middle of the duel, and developing a new Undead Lockdown strategy, you have earned two levels in [**Lich**]! You earned the [**Undead Crown**] Class Perk!

120 HP, +40 SP, +4 VIT, +1 AGI, +1 INT!

[**Undead Crown**]: Immediately [Enthralls] other undead, and inflicts [Terror] on other types, with a successful CHA check.

It had been so long since Furibon gained levels, that he had almost forgotten how amazing it felt.

“Impressive,” Manitou said, sounding genuinely astonished. The spectators began to clap with respect for their performance. “First your midgame maneuver, now this... you shall now be known in the gaming world, as *Furibon of the Counterattack*.”

“You fought well,” the lich replied, the final battle having been a *very* close call. “I admit, I enjoyed playing these games.”

“A deal is a deal,” the orc snapped his fingers, a demon butler handing Furibon a strange, magnificent golden cup full of a strange purple liquid... and a [Crest].

Yet, this one differed from the one that the lich had used to break past level 30. This one seemed to be made not of gold, but solid, multicolored light, like a coalesced rainbow. “Is that...” Furibon trailed, astonished to see one.

“A [Heroic Crest], necessary to break past the sixty level ceiling,” Manitou confirmed. “Take it.”

“I... I cannot.” These particular Crests were so incredibly rare and difficult to obtain, that even Brandon Maure himself could never obtain one. Yet this monster gave one away so casually. “This is too much.”

“It has been a very long time since I tasted defeat,” Manitou said. “I had grown too confident in the power of the Heart of the Cards over luck... when card games are all about tension, risk, *intelligence*! Your Undead Lockdown strategy was brilliant, and rekindled my love for the sport!”

Rekindled his love...

The battle had awakened something in the lich’s heart too. For the first time in decades, he had genuine fun. Traveling the world in search for a fabled artifact, discovering new places, putting his unlife on the line... Furibon hated to admit it, but his time in Victor’s scythe had given him a new appreciation of the adventurer lifestyle.

...

That was it.

That was what he had missed all along.

The lich grabbed the cup, and lacking any throat, splattered the liquid on his skull.

You have been cured of the following ailments: [**Stockholm Syndrome**], [**Midunlife Crisis**] and [**Seasonal Depression**]!

Much to Furibon's surprise, the cup seemed to magically refill itself. Truly an artifact worthy of its reputation. At long last, he was free from the last chain holding him back to Ishfania. The lich now had a new unlife ahead of himself.

He knew what he had to do.

"Next!"

Furibon's head perked up, as he presented himself in front of a wood desk. A receptionist from Barin's adventurer guild, some petite tanned woman, welcomed him with a smile. It was a nice change from the horrified glances the rest of the staff kept sending him.

"I would like to register as an adventurer," Furibon said.

"I thought so," she chirped. "Although we never had an intelligent skeleton before."

"A troll lich." To his amazement, she didn't even blink. "You are not surprised?"

"Oh, you know, we had dragons, vampires, orcs, slimes... I must warn you that newcomers have overcrowded the market. Finding work as an adventurer nowadays is tougher than ever."

“I know, but I relish the challenge. I would like to sign with the exploration fleet I heard about.”

“Good.” Without skipping a beat, she handed him over a pile of documents, and an adventurer plate. “Please fill your file, take your plate, and welcome into the adventurer family.”

The lich glanced at the plate, and the metal it was forged from.

Lead.

It had to be *lead*. “I am level sixty,” Furibon pointed out. “Should I not skip to gold?”

“Six, sixty, same,” the receptionist replied with a cheeky smile. “Everyone starts with lead here!”

...

Call it Karma.

Chapter 61: Castlevania

“They fled.”

Vainqueur glared at his chief of staff. “What do you mean by ‘they fled’?”
Food did not flee!

Manling Victor sighed sheepishly, as more than a dozen monstrous priests imitated Vainqueur. All of them stood outside the temple of Murmurin, which had been taken over by ghoul soldiers. “Lavere shows up elsewhere on the map. She must have teleported away when we moved in.”

“You interrupted our morning rituals for nothing?!” a priestess of Shesha complained.

“You dare question our prophet, the one who will lead the chosen people to the Promised Land?” the priest of the Moon Man replied. “Don’t force us to start a religious war! We have the Old Ones on our side!”

“Everyone calm down,” Manling Victor tried to appease his angry minions, while Vainqueur confiscated the map from him to continue the hunt himself.

- *Two failed operations later.*

“Go, go, go!” Blue Ranger ordered as an elite group of kobolds swarmed the Nethermart, arresting the clients and testing them with silver to identify any doppelgangers. Vainqueur himself glanced through the windows, searching for the vampires.

After a whole hour of storming the building, inspecting every floor, Vainqueur ended up with nothing. Blue Ranger crumpled in shame. “It’s a bust, Your Majesty...”

Vainqueur took a long, deep breath, and then roared in frustration.

- *Five more police operations later.*

“Open the barn’s doors!” Pink Ranger shouted. “Hands on your back! You are surrounded!”

Vainqueur twitched in annoyance, as he watched the barn being surrounded by forty kobolds armed with garlic-stake shooting, dwarf-made rifles. The dragon was starting to get impressions of déjà vu.

“Your Majesty, their silence speaks volumes,” Red Ranger, the operation’s organizer, said.

“Of course, because they are afraid!” The dragon lost patience as he moved towards the barn, his wings casting a dark shadow in the broad daylight. He ripped off the barn’s roof with his hands, peeking inside.

Unlike the warehouse, the invaders had left a trace of their passage: slaughtered pigs, innocent cattle whose throats they cut open, and de-feathered chickens. Each of them had their blood drained, so anyone could see who did it, and why.

These savages spoiled his food!

“Empty again!” Vainqueur complained. “MINION! MINION!”

His servant teleported inside the barn, his iron boots immediately drenched in pig blood. “I assume His Majesty didn’t catch them this time either,” the chief of staff said, with a glance around the barn. “We’ll have to send them to the temple for cleansing before they rise up again tonight. Cow vampires are the worst...”

“Minion, you said the map showed her location! Yet countless times this week, I have opened a house to find no vampire within! I am starting to look ridiculous in front of my own troops!”

“We will never doubt His Majesty!” Pink Ranger hurriedly reassured him.

“I know,” Vainqueur replied, proud of his servants’ loyalty. “This is for my own sake.”

“I think this may be the point,” Manling Victor replied, just as annoyed as his master. “She knows we can track her, and so moves away anytime we approach. She plays psychological warfare with us.”

This annoyed Vainqueur to no end. How could he kill an enemy who refused to commit suicide by his hand? Like *mosquitoes*!

Worse, these insects kept causing problems. They slaughtered and spoiled his cattle with their diseases, tried to set the city on fire twice at night, and even caused a rockslide to condemn the main roads through the mountains. His minions would start to run low on food, and his lackeys had grown as weary of this fruitless hunt as him.

“At least now we know they have doppelgangers, and probably impersonated Miel, I managed to defuse the situation between Heaven and Happyland,” Manling Victor said, having spent the last few days handling that matter. “For now. Unfortunately, the cult of Shesha, the Agarthans and other guests are pushing us to find a solution. Between our economic crisis and these attacks, Murmurin no longer looks like a safe investment. They even encouraged me to *compromise*.”

“Never!” Vainqueur snarled, his voice making the ground tremble and his minions shiver. “I will not give away anything, and especially not to a fairy-lover who sullied my reputation! I will offer her naught but flames! Like this barn!”

Understanding that his master wanted to unleash his pent-up frustration, Manling Victor immediately exited the barn by flying outside it; the second he did, Vainqueur set it on fire with a roar of rage, cooking the dead cows while at it.

“I doubt Lavere will stop even if we give her the map,” Manling Victor said, while the other minions had been cowed by Vainqueur’s display of fury. “Unfortunately, she is a powerful sorceress, and she undoes any ward Jules and Allison try to set up.”

Another witch causing him trouble? “Minion, forget becoming a wizard,” the dragon said, after calming down, “I must become a witch vampire hunter. Fetch me more garlic.”

“Your Majesty, could we slow down on that front? I can smell it everywhere, we are exhausting our stockpile, and Jules said it doesn’t work against this breed of vampire.”

Speaking of smells, Vainqueur began to notice a disgustingly familiar one; even before he noticed her winged shadow on the ground. As if these vampires didn’t annoy him enough already. “She is back,” he hissed, glancing up at the skies.

His minion looked up as well, noticing the gryphon rider right above them.

“Vainqueur,” Knight Kia politely nodded at the dragon. “How long has it been?”

“Not long enough,” Vainqueur replied, frustrated at seeing that poor excuse of a minion again. Pink Ranger booed the knight until Red hushed her.

“Hey, Kia!” his chief of staff waved at her. “What’s up?”

“Minion, she is no breeding material,” Vainqueur whispered to him. He couldn’t let her influence his beloved chief of staff, the way she did with his niece. “Keep your eggs for a better stock.”

“Vic? Vic, is that you with the armor?” The paladin finally recognized Manling Victor thanks to his wings. “What’s with the new look? You’re cosplaying as Sauron?”

“I decided to upgrade my equipment after surviving an adventurer raid.”

“Did rednecks try to pick a fight with you too?” the paladin asked them, landing with her gryphon next to Vainqueur’s chief of staff. “A small army of creepy and well-armed bandits with guns tried to kill my lovely Jolie on our return trip. They kept screaming ‘they tuk ur jewbs’ while I fended them off. It was unexpected but fun.”

“*Your* Jolie?” Smoke came out of Vainqueur’s nostrils. He *knew* she would be a bad influence on his flesh and blood. “Does my niece belong to you now, instead of the opposite? You forget your way, minion!”

“How did you know where to find us?” Manling Victor asked.

Knight Kia pointed a finger at the barn on fire, and the column of smoke going up from it; the chief of staff responded with a shrug.

“Where is Jolie?” the dragon asked, his concern for his flesh and blood stronger than his contempt for her poor choice in minionship. “Safe?”

“Oh yes, she returned to Mauria to deal with her new minions. She’s fine.”

Good. Vainqueur could never forgive Knight Kia if she had abandoned her mistress.

“I would worry more about us, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor said. “Kia you came back at the right time. We’re under attack from vampires.”

“Really? Great! I *love* vampires!” The warrior coughed when Vainqueur glared at her. “I mean, I love destroying them.”

“Me too,” the dragon conceded. “But they refuse to fight me fairly!”

“Because they know His Majesty will kill them,” Manling Victor stated the obvious.

“Exactly! It is as if they lost their fear of living when they died!”

“Vampires are pains to deal with,” Knight Kia said. “But I know how to deal with them.”

“Of course you do,” Manling Victor said. Vainqueur glared at him not to feed her overbound ego, but too late.

“Vic, I am, without boasting, the most experienced adventurer in Gardemagne, and I’ve killed almost every creature inhabiting Outremonde

at least once. Including all species of vampire. Can you tell me what happened? What information do you have on them?"

Manling Victor detailed her the great struggle against this vermin, the paladin regularly nodding as she listened. "So Laverie is an alchemical vampire..." Knight Kia trailed off. "I knew that woman felt off; I will tell Kevin that his student is in cahoots with the fomors."

"Kevin?" Manling Victor frowned, Kia responding with a shrug. "If she declared open warfare, then she must have been ready to drop her civilian identity. She probably figures that she can start again somewhere else, so long as we can't track her down."

"From what you tell me, she is probably the progenitor of her vampire line, and likely a [Scholomancer]."

"Scholowhat?" Vainqueur asked.

"A student from Scholomance, a hidden dungeon and black magic school in the Nightlands. Almost every alchemical vampire that I encountered could be traced back to that place. Their alumni usually wield powerful dark magic, necromancy powers, can control the weather, and summon powerful monsters. They must also create a powerful spellbook to graduate, a [Solomonari's Grimoire], which serves as a lesser artifact with unique powers."

"You sound like you fought one," Victor pointed out.

"I did, and he was *tough*." She said it with fondness, clearly relishing the idea of killing another worthy foe. "Look, vampires are not like liches. They have to feed, and ergo they *also* have to rest in their coffins. Even if these ones can walk under the sun, it's just the equivalent of staying up past bedtime. They can't keep it up forever."

"They must use elixirs and pre-processed blood potions to extend that length of time," Manling Victor guessed. "But eventually this won't be enough."

“So at one point, our prey will stop to hibernate, and we will catch them then.” Vainqueur relished the thought.

“Unfortunately, powerful vampires always have Renfields to protect them or transport their coffins while they sleep.” Knight Kia chuckled at everyone’s confusion. “It’s a term vampire hunters use to call mortal servants, alongside the ‘Bella’ fans. They also have stronger cousins called ‘Igor’s’, but they usually serve liches or mad scientist types.”

“A chief of staff,” Vainqueur said, looking down in contempt at the manling for ignoring the proper term.

“The easiest way to deal with a vampire is usually to turn their Renfields against them, since their Bellas remain unfailingly loyal; even if they *seem* to hesitate at first. Bellas are obsessed with their masters, but Renfields are usually motivated by fear or desire for power. If they see the opportunity for a better alternative than their current master, they will take it.”

“So make their minions my minions, and eat those who are not good recruit material.” Vainqueur nodded.

“This gives me an idea,” Manling Victor said. “But it may take time.”

“They can also use others’ crypts and tombs as alternate sanctuaries,” Knight Kia continued. “Have you checked your graveyard?”

“We, uh, we don’t have one,” said Manling Victor.

Knight Kia frowned. “You don’t have a *graveyard*?”

“Well, everyone who dies in Murmurin is usually revived as an undead, or turned into fertilizer.”

“Or eaten by me,” Vainqueur said.

“That too.”

“His Majesty leaves nothing to waste!” Red Ranger chirped. “We recycle everything!”

“Yes, we are the most eco-friendly government on Outremonde,” Manling Victor said with sarcasm, which made Vainqueur worry. Obviously the presence of Knight Kia disturbed him as much as it did his master.

“Then either they transported their coffins and move them around, or you missed a crypt or dungeon buried somewhere in the area. Considering their numbers, I find that part more likely.”

“I had every tunnel and hidden passage in the castle closed after we raided the Pyramid of Sablar,” Manling Victor said. “It’s a stratagem.”

“Good call, minion,” Vainqueur congratulated him, happy that he could distinguish pyramids from towers now. “Furibon will not retake the castle by guile, and my gold will remain safe.”

“Then they’re probably under the city,” his chief of staff continued. “The presence of a Hellgate would suggest dark forces operated in the region even before Furibon took it over. A pity he escaped, we could have asked him...”

“Which is *your* fault, minion.”

“Your Majesty, we will search the entire town for catacombs,” Red Ranger proposed.

“Good idea, minion,” the dragon said and nodded. “Until we can locate their nest, I shall return to my training and prepare to crush them.”

“You already have levels in [Witch Hunter] Vainqueur,” Knight Kia said. “Promoting it into [Vampire Hunter] should be child’s play. I could train you if we have the right tools—”

“Wait,” Manling Victor interrupted her. “Could you train groups in vampire hunting?”

“If they meet the stat criteria, yes, sure. We will need the right tools though. I have no idea why, but whips and crosses are required to take the [Vampire Hunter] class.”

A whip.

Vainqueur already visualized it. The perfect weapon to fight the most annoying creatures in the world: vampires, and minion strikers. Much better than the damn ax which annoyed him in Haudemer.

“I thought we should train our minions in the ways of new classes,” Friend Victor explained himself. “Since my [Monster Insight] can identify their infiltrators, I thought I should try to get more [Monster Squires], and if you can contribute, all the better.”

“You would teach us to become dragonly like you, chief?” Red’s eyes widened in envy.

“Teaching Kobolds how to become Vampire Hunters?” The idea seemed to entertain Knight Kia. “Can it even work?”

“It’s worth a try,” Vainqueur’s chief of staff replied. “Vainqueur may not gain a new level in that class, but learning the skills of one will help.”

“All of V&V must remain in top shape against this new threat,” the dragon declared. “I shall lead by example. Knight Kia, to prove yourself worthy of my niece, I shall allow you to serve me in that capacity.”

“So... you want me to teach you, but you do not want to word it so simply?”

“You shall learn to serve me,” Vainqueur clarified, before turning to his most prized lackey. “You too, Manling Victor. You have yet to learn more Monster Perks since we fought Furibon.”

“Because it involves me surviving the attack first, and it hurts!”

“Minion, have you not tasted death already? What is there to be afraid of anymore? I too suffered pain when Furibon murdered my hoard, or when Jolie let that...” Vainqueur glanced at Kia, his voice dying in his throat at the sight of that poor excuse of a minion. “Let her do the thing we shall not

speak of in front of my other minions. Yet look at me! I remained as amazing as ever!”

Charisma check successful!

“Mmm... when worded this way... but I don’t know...”

Your Minion is seeing the wisdom of your words but remains unsure. Will you persuade him by:

A) Telling him he will become more powerful.

B) Remind him that suffering for you is the greatest pleasure a minion can experience.

C) Convincing him that he will have more opportunities to breed if he trains.

Clearly, all of the above! “Minion, by becoming more powerful, you will not only get used to the pain and learn to enjoy it for me, but you will become a more desired breeding partner!”

“It is true that high-level and fame improve your dating life, but it gets tiresome very quickly,” Knight Kia said.

“Really?” Manling Victor asked.

Charisma check successful!

“We live in a village full of monsters...” Vainqueur remained silent, letting Manling Victor make the words his own. “And since it’s getting harder to level up more, we should explore our existing abilities... For battle. For *battle!*”

“We will gladly teach you our attacks, chief,” Pink Ranger said. “So you can show us how to do them better!”

“You can learn the Perks of monsters?” Knight Kia whistled. “Nice! How many?”

“I dunno, I never tried to push this ability to its logical extremes.”

“You are my chief of staff,” Vainqueur cheered him up, “You can do anything.”

“I know I will regret saying that, but can Your Majesty...” Manling Victor struggled to spit out his demand. “*Almost* kill me?”

...

...

...

Ah. Finally.

Time to teach him the masterful art of firebreathing then!

“Say no more, minion.” Vainqueur inhaled and held his breath. “We will begin with the easiest technique: the wyrmling fireball.”

“Wait, wait, Your Majesty, I didn’t mean it right *now*—”

Too late.

Vainqueur unleashed the weakest fireball he could on his minion, creating a small crater while at it.

Chapter 62: Basement Dwellers

“Hit?” Junior asked him, its blue jelly protegee resting on its sword lure.

“With one of your natural Perks,” Victor explained, resting on an armchair in his manor’s hall, next to the fireplace. He kept his new scythe, and the bazooka, on each side. “Nothing too painful, after I prepare myself mentally —”

The blue jelly nodded at each of his words.

Then it jumped and hit him in the eye through his helmet’s chinks!

Victor let out a scream of surprise and pain, as the critter bounced off his face and landed again on Junior’s back.

[**Troll Regeneration**] activated! You gained the [**Regen**] Status.

Congratulations! You learned the [**Slime-Slam**] Personal Perk!

[**Slime-Slam**]: Technique. You can jump up to ten times your size and launch yourself at an opponent, inflicting weak physical damage.

“Hurt?” Junior asked, sounding concerned. Over time, the mimic had grown almost as loyal as a cat to its food source.

“What the BLEEP does it look like!?” Victor replied, although his eye had already recovered thanks to his regeneration.

You have recovered all of your HP.

Petting Junior’s back with one hand, the mimic purring in response, Victor glanced through the windows, where the sun had slowly vanished beyond

the mountains. Night would fall soon; the perfect time for another attack.

His priests had set wards around the mansion, to prevent new undead—outside of the staff and some members of the Raptor Rangers— from getting in. While Laverre might disable them, she would have to activate an alarm. The cult of the Moon Man had taken upon itself to protect his house, forming a formidable defense.

Finally, he had an army of cultists worthy of his spooky mansion.

Speaking of armies, Kia chose this time to walk into the hall with company.

“Tadaa!” the Paladin said, as she presented him the new and improved raptor rangers; each of them now wore light, dwarf-made armor, swords, and whips. “Here’s your new Vampire Hunter squad!”

“Only the dead can know the true power of doooooooooom,” Yellow said with his guttural voice.

“With the [Monster Squire] level we received from the chief, we finally found our toku-theme,” Red said, gleeful. “Vampire Knights!”

“The Knights of Vainqueur!” Pink added tears of joy in her eyes.

“Good, but give me just a sec,” Victor said while rising out of his chair, before using [Monster Insight] on Kia.

Kia Bekele

Angel-Blessed Human (Humanoid/Angel)

Weak against: alcohol, depression, boredom.

Strong against: everything else (epic level, duh!).

The most dangerous game in the world, a two-legged predator from the alien, unforgiving world of Earth. What this fearsome mammal lacks in strength, it more than makes up in fiendish intelligence, ruthlessness, and numbers; and their body is made of carbon. Carbon! Like diamonds!

Left to themselves, these bloodthirsty primates can conquer entire worlds with the power of SCIENCE, devastate ecosystems, and kill anything that crosses their path. You don't BLEEP them; they BLEEP you. Then they make wallets out of your skin!

In short, it's a human woman. Also, angel-blessed.

No Doppelgangers. Good. He checked every member of the Kobold Rangers, sighing in relief.

"Wait, have you just used your scanning Perk on us?" Kia said, putting her armored hands on her hips. "That's racial profiling!"

"You did it the first time we met!" Victor complained back. "The Nightblades have Doppelgangers, they could slip in assassins among you."

"I stopped karma scanning people after you pointed out its implications," Kia replied. "And I have the [Eye of Mithras] Perk. While it won't detect any physical change, I can see through invisibility and illusions. Like the invisible bat over here."

As she said these words, Victor heard a sound in a corner of the room. Kia pointed a finger, firing a small dagger of light from it, which impaled an invisible creature and nailed it to the wall. The Vizier watched, amazed, as a monstrous bat materialized before his eyes, impaled like a hunting trophy.

"How long was it in the room?" he asked, Junior growling at the beast.

"Too long," Kia replied. "It's a Vampire Familiar. Nothing on its own, but it can slip into almost everywhere."

The fact the Nightblades had slipped a spy in his home didn't surprise Victor, but it certainly disturbed him. "If you could check the rest of the mansion afterward, that would be great. Have you sent the message I asked for?"

"Of course, and Kevin is already working on it. Has your training progressed?"

“It did.” Victor looked at the list of Perks he gathered over the last two days.

[Dragonfire (Wyrmling)], [Brain Blast], [Slime Armor], [Venom Fang], [Ghoul Fever], [Hundred Needles], [Dark Thorns], [Shock], [Bullet Fist], [Raptor Burst], [Angel Heart], [Ghost Grudge], [Troll Regeneration], [WAZZAAA!], [Slime-Slam].

Truth to be told, he could scarcely remember what half of them did. This was going to be a nightmare to manage, especially with the Necromancy buffs he learned to practice. “[Brain Blast] inflicts weak psychic damage, [Hundred Needles] weak plant damage, [Bullet Fist] weak physical damage, [Shock] weak lightning...”

“So a variety of weak, forgettable attacks?” Kia didn’t sound impressed. At all.

Unfortunately, she had a point. Most of the Perks also lacked in strength, since none of the monsters in Murmurin could rival the likes of Furibon in power.

Monster Knight was truly the swiss army knife of classes though. He wondered how many Perks he could learn...

Congratulations! For learning over 15 Monster Perks through a grueling training method, you have earned the **[Perk Forge]** Personal Perk!

[Perk Forge]: You can fuse various monster Perks into a single, stronger one; however, you will permanently lose access to the Perk components and cannot relearn them.

The more he learned, the more Victor had grown convinced the System somehow encouraged specialization. “Hey, I can fuse Monster Perks now.”

“How many of them at once?” Kia asked, curious, while Junior moved to chew the bat in a corner.

“I dunno, it isn’t mentioned.”

“Why not all of them then?” Kia proposed. “You could end up with either the most overpowered ability ever... or a fusion accident.”

Since he lost the components permanently, Victor couldn't risk sacrificing highly powerful abilities like [Black Curse]. He could try Kia's idea, but he would first test this Perk by using components with good synergy.

Well then, Victor decided to combine [**ChannelHellfire (Minor)**] with [**Dragonfire (Wyrmling)**], since he had absolutely no intention of going through Vainqueur's breath again. Dragonfire hurt a lot more than normal flames, and even Victor had his limits.

Choice registered. You combined [**Channel Hellfire (Minor)**] and [**Dragonbreath (Wyrmling)**] into [**Blackfyre**].

[**Blackfyre**]: Technique, 1 SP per second. You can unleash a shadowy, infernal fire from your hands, feet, or mouth; half of the damage is [Dragon] type, and the other [Unholy]. This technique will thus bypass [Fire] resistance. When you would deal fire damage through a spell or a technique, it will now inflict an additional 20 percent [Unholy] damage.

Nice, but not game-changing. The fact it cost less than both its component techniques meant Victor should not run out of SP in the middle of a battle like he did against the adventurers.

Alright, time to test Kia's hypothesis. He decided to sacrifice most of the weaker perks, keeping only the truly useful [Troll Regeneration] and [Black Curse].

Choice registered. You combined [**Silverfang**], [**Brain Blast**], [**Slime Armor**], [**Venom Fang**], [**Ghoul Fever**], [**Hundred Needles**], [**Dark Thorns**], [**Shock**], [**Bullet Fist**], [**Raptor Burst**], [**Angel Heart**], [**Ghost Grudge**], [**WAZZAAA!**], and [**Slime-Slam**] into: [**Darwinist**].

[**Darwinist**]: When targeted by a creature type-dependent effect (such as [Undead] or [Dragon]), you always count as the most advantageous type or type-combination for the purpose of resolving that effect; your species will not change, but the system will temporarily register you as a different type.

Elements affected by this Perk include Weapons, Perks, Spells, Field Effects...

“Wait, that is all?” Victor asked, disappointed. It could definitely have its use, but he had expected something more visually impressive. “More than ten perks for this?”

“Fusion accident it is.”

Charisma check successful!

Huh?

Someone knocked on the hall’s door. “Enter,” Victor said, allowing Chocolatine and Allison to enter.

“Hi, Vic.” The werewolf waved a hand at him, although less cheerfully than usual.

“The wards are secured,” Allison said, Victor having tasked her with overseeing his home’s security.

“Yeah, well, one bat managed to slip through.” The Grand Vizier pointed at the bloody splat on the wall, Junior having finished chewing it.

“It must have been inside the mansion before I set the protections,” the dryad defended herself. “They may have watched you for longer than I did.”

Yeah... Victor used his [Monster Insight] Perk on both, just in case. This whole misadventure had made him paranoid.

Allison Lys

Dryad (Plant/Fairy).

Strong against: Plant, Water, Fairy, Disease, Life, Insta-Death, Paralysis.

Weak to: Fire, Frost, Flowerslayer, Fairyslayer, Lightning, Poison.

A reincarnated Isekai human from Earth and chosen of Cybele, the goddess of pleasure; which means that you have ***NO excuses***. Chocolatine's best friend, but would like to do the pastry with the werewolf in the barn, if you see what I mean; unlike you, she's smart enough to keep things simple. Go for the melting pot salad!

Good to know. He feared to read the new information on Chocolatine but peeked anyway.

Shadowman

Doppelganger Inveigler (Fairy/Humanoid)

Strong against Fairy, Mind-Control, Poison, Illusions, Paralysis, Sleep, and Truth-Detection.

Weak against Manslayer, Cold Iron, and Silver.

Just your natural born killer.

Victor immediately grabbed his scythe. "Doppelganger! Allison, behind me!"

"What?" both the dryad and the werewolf said at the same time. Did the doppelganger hope to mislead him by feigning confusion?

If so, it didn't deceive his Perk nor his allies. Kia instantly drew her sword and moved with such swiftness, Victor didn't even see her pull her blade on Chocolatine's throat. The werewolf let out a squeal of surprise. "Where is the real one?" Kia threatened.

"What is all the racket?" a familiar voice called out of the room, a second Chocolatine stepping through the door. She looked up at her double, exchanged a glance with her, then turned to Victor himself. "Vic, you replaced me?"

Victor and every person in the room blinked, the Vizier immediately used his Perk on her next.

Shadowman

Doppelganger Inveigler (Fairy/Humanoid)

Strong against Fairy, Mind-Control, Poison, Illusions, Paralysis, Sleep, and Truth-Detection.

Weak against Manslayer, Cold Iron, and Silver.

Just your natural born killer.

... damn.

“Stop!” Victor told Kia. “They’re using a spell to reflect false information somehow, I can’t see which one is the real Chocolatine!”

“They’re identical,” Kia muttered to herself, pushing the first Chocolatine against a wall with her free arm, and then threatening the second with her blade. “It’s not an illusion. [Karma Scan]... they both appear as strongly evil too! How could they falsify their karma?”

Victor decided not to comment on how her karma scan hadn’t misled her.

Charisma check successful! Shadowman can’t read your thoughts, and now you know it tried!

Victor eyed both women with suspicion. One, if not both, of them, was definitely an infiltrator. The Nightblades must have sent him because they couldn’t bypass the wards.

“Vic, it’s an impostor!” the first Chocolatine pleaded. “She’s trying to confuse you!”

“Oh, oh, I see!” the second Chocolatine said with disturbing cheerfulness. “It’s a spot the fake moment! I always wanted to encounter one!”

“What do I shout when I use my legendary sword,” Victor asked. Trick question.

“EXCALIBUR!” both shouted at once.

Victor face-palmed. The doppelganger may not be able to detect his own thoughts, it could probably read the minds of others, including Chocolatine herself.

“Oh, I know a way!” Ranger Pink said. “We summon two fiends!”

“Good idea,” Blue nodded. “The one who murders it in the most painful way is obviously the real one!”

“You all think I’m crazy?” the first one asked, dejected.

“Chocolatine may kill, she never does it sadistically,” Allison pointed out. “Only to feed. It’s pretty much in her god’s tenets.”

“I knew you would stand by me, Allison!” the second one chirped.

“Eat both,” Junior said hungrily. “Sure.”

“Sure!” the jelly on its back agreed.

“Vic...” Kia trailed off. “You make the call.”

The Grand Vizier examined both women, trying to figure out personal information that could tell the true one apart. If he hadn’t switched ‘mount’ in preparation for the fight with Lavere, then he could have summoned the real one, but now...

Think, Victor. How did they get around his Perk, after it managed to pierce through all their natural immunities? Why risk him telling the right one apart? Unless... unless...

Intelligence check successful.

“None of them are the real one.”

He hadn’t had the time to finish his sentence, that it was over already. Kia cut down both werewolves in the blink of an eye, letting them fall on the

ground.

Allison let out a scream of horror and surprise, putting her hands on her mouth. “Vic, what the... what have you...”

Both corpses shifted into solid shadows, before collapsing into nothingness.

“They captured the real one,” Victor explained, while Allison calmed herself. “Psychological warfare.” A ploy based on his innate acceptance of the rules presented before him? Smart, but he had learned from the best.

Then the hall went dark, all light and the fire dying out.

The terrain has been temporarily changed to [**Dark Underworld**].

Nocturnal creatures, fiends, and undead on the field have their stats increased, and will be harder to turn. All non-nocturnal creatures will suffer from the [**Blind**] ailment. Monotype, non-undead creatures will be animated as undead if killed on the field.

All stats increased by one stage!

“[Light Shield]!” Victor heard Kia shout, a round barrier of solid light forming around the group. A haunting, piper melody echoed across the hall as she did.

“Behind us, chief!” the Kobold Rangers formed a ring around Victor, alongside Junior and his protegee, “Stay back! We have a mimiczord on our side!”

A wail echoed in the darkness in response, as half a dozen, skeletal ghosts crashed against the barrier.

“This mansion...” Kia trailed, as the vengeful spirits bounced off the light barrier, disappearing as soon as they hit it. “How old is it?”

“Older than the town,” Allison replied, “A dark wizard inhabited it when Rolo first began to labor the fields. It is full of grudges and dark spirits.”

“That is odd since the architecture seems... gothic?” Kia struggled to find the right word. “It looks straight from Earth.”

A place full of spirits and dark grudges? “Wait, wait, wait,” Victor said. “Didn’t that magician do experiments in the basement or something?”

The Nightblades knew that he had the map, that killing him might destabilize Murmurin, and that this manor may have served as some nightmarish lab...

Victor searched in one of his armor’s hidden containers with his free hand, drawing out Mot’s map, and reading it by the light of the barrier.

It showed Lavere’s location right next to his own.

His basement.

The ghostly assault halted, a new shape approaching the light barrier; Victor recognized him as Emile Lavere, the vampire whom he fought before. “We only want Dalton and the map,” he announced. “Leave him to us, and we’ll let you go.”

Kia responded by bursting into laughter.

“We may not be able to kill *you*, Shining Knight, but you can’t protect them all,” the assassin replied, unfazed. “And that’s not even mentioning the civilians we’ll keep killing so long as he lives.”

“Why me?” Victor protested, putting the map back inside his armor. “What have I ever done to you?”

“If you die, this regime collapses,” Emile Lavere pointed out. “The dragon will go crazy, mismanage his troops, and return to his old ways. You’re his emotional anchor, so we’ll take you off the board. Forever.”

Warning: The manor is under a [**Soul Trap**] effect!

If you die within its radius of effect, your soul will be trapped in its focus point.

“The focus?” Victor pondered, assuming the others had seen the same message.

“The [Solomonari’s Grimoire],” Kia explained, “It will catch your soul and prevent any form of resurrection so long as it exists.”

“No more revival,” Emile unsheathed his daggers, others glittering in the darkness. “No afterlife. No nothing.”

Victor knew his angel insurance was a waste of SP.

Chapter 63: Bottomless Fear

Victor thought they would just have to wait for dawn, protected by Kia's shield. He was wrong.

Emile whistled, giving the signal for his group to attack. A cowed figure with a scythe, a vampiric grim reaper, walked through the shield as if it wasn't even there.

Reaper Deathscythe used [**Skeleton Key**] to bypass [**Shield of Light**]!

Of course vampires assassins would have a Perk which bypassed supernatural wards... Kia immediately moved to intercept the intruder, but he grabbed some kind of pendant and uttered magical words. The shield of light collapsed, and everything became dark again.

Due to the thick darkness, Victor could barely see more than a few feet away, at least before Kia formed a miniature sun in her free hand. The aster partially illuminated their surroundings, revealing dozens of vampiric assassins charging at them with sharp blades. He could see Allison near him but not the rest of his troops, although he could hear them fight in the darkness.

Of course, Kia didn't let the enemy through, cutting down one, then two, then three rogues without breaking a sweat. She didn't even bother to dodge the strikes, even though they used poisoned weapons; their blades bounced off her armor without inflicting damage. Meanwhile, it took but one slash from the Shining Knight to reduce a vampire to dust.

It was like watching babies trying to take down Mohammed Ali. A hilariously one-sided slaughter.

But it distracted her, allowing other rogues to dash at their true target: Victor himself. His sharp reflexes allowed him to dodge a vampire's blade and retaliate with his scythe, cutting the attacker in half.

Critical hit! It's a one-hit KO!

His weapon absorbed the vampire's soul, which told the Vizier that either his Helheim overwhelmed the soul trap effect, or that it spared the enemy thieves. It also gave him enough time to activate his buffs.

You gain +4 check bonus against [**Undead**] effects.

+100 temporary HP.

Chances to inflict [**Terror**] increased by 20 percent.

Your scythe will now inflict the [**Poisoned**] ailment!

You gained the [**Regen**] status!

He briefly considered summoning his trump card with [Black Horseman], but that would undoubtedly cause the mansion to collapse on everyone inside.

Emile Lavere, the assassin he fought in the Winter Kingdoms, emerged from the darkness to flank him with a silver rapier. He narrowly missed his chest, but pierced his armor through a chink.

You took medium damage! Manslayer negated by [**Darwinist**]! Insta-Death negated by [**Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)**]!

"Undead?" the vampire snarled, angry at his attack being countered. "How can you count as undead?"

Victor retaliated by blasting the killer with a dark fireball, but he dodged out of the way. The projectile exploded somewhere, making the mansion shake. The Vizier prayed that it didn't hit the Kobold Rangers or Junior by accident, forsaking this attack so long as he lacked visibility.

The enemy Reaper soon joined Emile, trying to behead Victor from behind while he fended off the vampire assassin. “[Turn Undead]!” Allison rushed to help him, blasting the enemy Reaper against a wall, and keeping Emile at bay. “Vic, get behind me!”

“Alright, I’m taking Marinette!” Victor declared, his free hand fumbling in the dark while Allison shielded him.

“Marinette?!” Allison asked before a bunch of ghosts forced her to focus back on the fight. “[Turn Undead]! [Turn Undead]!”

“My bazooka!” Victor replied, grabbing the rocket launcher with his free hand, and swinging his scythe with the other.

“You named it?” Constantly repelling undead didn’t prevent Allison from complaining. “Vic, you can’t solve all your problems with a bazooka!”

“Why *not*?” Truth to be told, he couldn’t use it in the dark without risking friendly fire, but it helped with the intimidation factor. “Flee before Marinette! [Fright Knight]!”

As he spoke those words, the Reaper glanced at the weapon with dread, before slithering back in the shadows. The ghosts harassing Allison ignored him though.

Your enemies’ Strength and Charisma decreased by one stage!

Reaper Deathscythe now suffers from [**Terror**]! [**Terror**] failed to affect Dark Spirits and Emile Lavere!

“Not running away this time?” the Grand Vizier taunted the assassin, who adopted a dueling stance with his rapier.

“I fear Mamma Lucie more than you,” he replied, before casting a spell on himself. “[Bolstering Dead].“

Allison attempted to turn him again, but this time, the assassin ignored her. He charged at Victor with murder on his mind.

The Vizier raised his scythe to kill the vampire, but the bastard moved around Allison, putting her in Victor's way. The chief of staff stopped his attack before his blade could cut his own friend, but this gave Emile an opening. The assassin raised his rapier, aiming for the throat.

Then a blue jelly jumped out of the darkness and hit him in the eye.

"My eye!" the vampire assassin screamed in both pain and surprise, the jelly hopping around happily.

"Eye!" Buzz Jelly chirped as if it found the word funny. "Eye treasure!"

"I can't see..." Having put a hand on his wounded eye, Emile missed the glittering fangs on his left. "I can't see—"

CHOMP!

Junior's jaws closed on Emile's torso, the mimic chewing the vampire around like a cat with a rat.

Oh, right. It was a team fight.

"They think we fear the dark, but they're wrong!" Victor shouted while Junior swallowed the vampire whole... only for Emile to escape its jaws in mist form. "They use the cover of darkness to hide from us! For we are the Hoard! We are *fear*!"

"Fear!" the jelly repeated. "Fear!"

[**Rally Minion**] activated! All minions' stats raised by one stage!

Victor's declaration was answered with the sound of windows breaking. It occurred to him that the cultists guarding his home must have engaged other attackers.

"Chief!" Victor heard Red somewhere to his left. After concentrating, he distinguished the shape of his ally, alongside that of Pink, in the dark. "This way, through the windows!"

“[Monster Insight],” Victor replied.

Shadowman—

He sliced both of them without warning with his scythe, their bodies dissolving into shadows, much to his annoyance. “How many doppelgangers do they have?”

“What kind of Doppelganger?” The Vizier turned to find Kia rushing to his side, having slaughtered anyone foolish enough to attack her.

“Inveigler!”

The Shining Knight cursed. “That’s the worst kind! They can create one health point duplicates at will. Unless we slay the original, more will keep coming.”

“Lavere is in my basement, we have to kill her or these attacks will never end!”

“I’ll take care of her,” said the paladin, “*after* we evacuate you.”

Victor guessed that she, like everyone, hated escort missions. “Sorry to have dragged you into this!” he apologized, as she guided him, Allison summoning thorns to protect their rear. He barely avoided a poisoned arrow aiming for his head and deflected a second with his scythe.

“You’re kidding? I’m so happy! There is a big battle...” she said while blocking a projectile with her blade, a blissful smile on her face. “And I haven’t missed it!”

Skill check successful!

Sensing something to his left, Victor leaped backward as shadowy claws emerged from a wall to try and seize him. A monstrous, ghoulish undead halfway emerged from the wall, snarling at him.

Murdefer

Wall Ghoul (Artificial/Undead)

Strong against Physical attacks, all status ailments, necromancy, Earth, and Unholy.

Weak against Artislayers, Deadslayers, Holy.

A malevolent basement dweller moving through the walls of a haunted mansion (yours) to ambush its prey (you). It can drag the people it catches to another part of the mansion. Beneath its thuggish exterior, it's a very shy creature looking for love.

Did they turn his *entire house* into a death trap?

The monster attempted to grab Victor with a dreadful shriek, but whips caught its claws. The Kobold Rangers emerged from the darkness, forcefully dragging the monster out of the wall so Red could pummel it. “We have your back, chief!”

“Vic, here! The windows!” Kia called him. She raised her blade to parry a strike from the enemy Reaper, who had returned for a second round, locking her into place. Victor rushed to help her, but then sensed cold dead hands grabbing his ankles.

He suddenly realized the Nightblades had brought more than one wall monster.

Before he could react, another ghoulish creature dragged him through the flooring as if it was water. In the blink of an eye, he landed into some kind of underground catacomb, the wall monster hanging above him.

Victor raised his bazooka and pulled the trigger.

The resulting explosion blasted the monster into tiny pieces, parts of the ceiling with it, and repelled Victor by a good five meters. The Vizier quickly got back on his feet, facing a pile of rubble.

“This thing is amazing,” the adventurer muttered to himself, caressing his bazooka with religious awe.

But it only had one projectile.

So he tossed it away, keeping only the scythe and running as fast as he could through dark, underground corridors. As he did, Victor heard a piper's melody echoing across them; while he knew he should run as far away from its source as possible, the Vizier decided to finish Lavere before she could launch another attack.

The corridors eventually led him to a much larger underground crypt, which unlike the manor above, had a few sources of magical light. Bright lanterns kept the darkness at bay, casting light on dozens of coffins belonging to the Nightblades, and a table at the center. He quickly distinguished shapes in the dark, sitting around it. Savoureuse, a strange human piper, and...

“Chocolatine?” Vic's eyes widened, upon seeing them more closely.

“Oh hi, Vic!” Savoureuse greeted him. Victor noticed a pile of cookies and cheese on the table, alongside some fine, half-emptied wine.

“Oh, hi, Vic!” the werewolf repeated and waved at him. “What's up with all the racket above? Is there a party?”

Victor glanced at her, then at Savoureuse, who shrugged, then back at Chocolatine.

... no. It had to be the doppelganger. He used [Monster Insight] on her to be sure.

Chocolatine

Werewolf (Humanoid/Beast)

Strong against Moon, Beast, Madness and Fairy effects.

Weak against Silver, Manslayer, and Beastslayer effects.

Your girlfriend, whether you like it or not. She forgets her sadness at her brother's arrest by drowning herself in Savoureuse's delicious meat cookies.

You don't want to know what they're made of... or rather, *who* they're made of.

Yep, that was the real one, against all odds. "You're not a hostage?" Victor asked Chocolatine while keeping an eye on the other people present; especially the piper.

???

A fomor. Damn. Yet somehow he ignored the adventurer to play music, and Victor couldn't hit him with a fiery projectile without wounding his friends.

"A hostage?" Chocolatine turned to Savoureuse. "I'm a hostage?"

"Oh, yes, I forgot to tell you," Savoureuse said, before turning to Victor. "I wanted to tie her up, but when she told me all about how her brother's arrest puts a damper on your relationship, I couldn't let such a cute couple break up. So I baked her cookies."

"Poisoned cookies?" Victor asked, finding the scene surreal.

"I could never poison food. People, always, but good food? Only *nobles* do that."

"You have to tell me about that secret ingredient though," Chocolatine continued, oblivious to the current situation. "Is it goblin? Gnoll?"

"It's a secret, sweetie," Savoureuse replied with a cheeky smile. "I don't want to fight you, Vic."

Him neither, against his better judgment. "We don't have to."

"Indeed. [Darkest Fear]."

A familiar dark aura swallowed Victor, who had a horrible sensation of déjà vu. His strength and vitality abandoned him, causing him to fall on his knees.

HP and SP reduced to one!

[**Terror**] and [**Necrophobia**] ailments negated!

[**Troll Regeneration**] activated!

“As they say, if you want something done,” Lucie Lavere said while stepping into sight, a screaming black book in hand and a humanoid made of solid shadows at her side. “Do it yourself.”

Victor had grown to hate, *hate* assassins hiding in shadows with passion tonight. She must have waited for her minions to soften him up before moving for the kill, like a hyena.

Charisma check successful! Lucie Lavere cannot read your mind!

Horried and snapped out of her drunkenness, Chocolatine instantly rushed to defend her crush, targeting Lavere. “[Turn Undead]! [Turn Undead]!”

Proving herself in a whole different league than her servants, the Nightblades’ leader didn’t even flinch. “[Telekinesis].” She absentmindedly raised her free hand, throwing Chocolatine against a coffin with the mere force of her mind, knocking her out. While Savoureuse watched the scene with terror in her eyes, the fomor briefly stopped playing his pipe, a crooked smirk flaring on his face.

“You should have checked your mansion for tunnels,” Lavere taunted Victor, in a good enough mood to banter with her prey.

“I did!” the Grand Vizier protested, managing to get back on his feet. “I was going to bring architects to check for hidden pathways after my seminar, but I didn’t have the time between Mot and the economic crisis!”

You have recovered a quarter of your HP!

“Annoying,” Lavere said, quickly casting another spell on Victor. “[Accelerated Anti-Teleport].”

Luck check failed! You can no longer teleport away for the next twenty-four hours!

Realizing she could diminish his HP to 1 at any time, Victor decided he could sacrifice some. “[Hades Blast]!”

He unleashed a mighty blast of purple energy at the vampire, sacrificing his very life force to empower it.

The book in Lavere’s hand let out a wail, the cover morphing into a ghoulish face. A shield of dark energy sprung around the vampire and her doppelganger ally, shielding them. Victor exploited her brief distraction to charge at her, scythe raised, as the shield dispelled. The doppelganger shielded his mistress with his body, but she didn’t need any help.

“[Blood Fountain].”

The second the words left her mouth, Victor’s body wracked in pain, as wounds opened beneath his armor. His very blood floated out of him, drained by Lavere’s vile spell.

Warning: Critical health! Your Vitality dropped by three stages!

Congratulations! You learned the [**Blood Fountain**] Personal Perk!

[**Blood Fountain**]: Technique, 50 SP. You can expell blood from every target within thirty feet of yourself as if you used the [**Vampire Kiss**] Perk, recovering half of the damage inflicted in HP and reducing the victims’ Vitality; creatures without blood are immune.

“Finally, I taste dragon blood...” the Nightblades’ leader sucked the floating blood like one would with champagne...

And immediately spit it out.

“Your blood tastes like *shit*,” Lavere cursed, her fake veneer of sophistication replaced with disgust. “Half-human blood, and half... chili pepper!”

Victor would have happily shoved more down her throat, had he not been forced to use his scythe not to fall on the ground. That perk *hurt*!

“Finish him off,” the piper said with sadistic glee, Savoureuse glancing away not to watch what would follow.

“It appears you can change type at will,” Laveré observed while spellcasting. “I wonder if you will rise as a zombie due to my field’s effects, or just die. Let’s check.”

“Does that offer of necromancy lessons still hold?” Victor deadpanned.

“No,” Laveré replied, being careful to stay at a respectable distance, in case he had a last trick up his sleeve. “[Crush Heart].”

She opened her free hand, a phantom, spectral heart forming inside her palm.

“Don’t worry, I’ll take up your role,” the doppelgänger said, before duplicating. The shadowy blob divided into two, one taking the shape of Chocolatine, and the other of Victor himself, “And more and more.”

No way around it then. He didn’t wish to do it in an enclosed space, but... “[Black Horseman],” Victor activated his trump card. The vampire may prevent him from teleporting away, it wouldn’t stop a call for help.

“Calling your horse?” Laveré mused, closing her fingers to crush the fake heart in her palm. With her foe at her mercy, she allowed herself a moment of smugness; a fatal mistake. “Fighting me is foolish.”

Yep.

But fighting was for gladiators.

A Vizier Reaper Assassin used *cheap tricks*.

“Summon Vainqueur!”

And then the entire crypt shook, as the legendary dragon teleported right on top of Laveré herself and her bodyguard, in a sitting position. His crown hit the ceiling above, causing the ceiling to crack; the teleportation effect blew dust in all directions, upturning the table and the coffins.

“Minion,” the dragon grumbled, the artificial darkness summoned by the vampire already dissipating. “You better have a good reason to summon me in the middle of a golden shower.”

Victor knew there was a dirty joke to make here, but it was beneath him.

While Savoureuse didn’t find her words, the piper fomor’s eyes had bulged out at the unexpected sight. He silently opened a circular rift in space and quickly fled without looking back, shaken.

Vainqueur smelled his chief of staff, unaware of the vampire and doppelganger crushed beneath his imperial bottom. “Have the bats bled you?”

“Yeah, but Lavere didn’t like it.”

“What do you mean by, she didn’t like it? How dare she not appreciate the blissful perfection of dragon blood?” Vainqueur asked, infuriated. “This only showcases her complete lack of taste! I will eat her cattle for this insult!”

Victor glanced at the spot where Lavere used to stand with a smug look until he noticed purple mist slipping out of Vainqueur and fleeing through the tunnels. “Not again!” the Vizier cursed, as Lavere quickly escaped.

First blood was on him, but from the lack of level-up, the war was far from over. Why they decided to attack him while he had Kia at home though, that was beyond him.

...

Unless... unless they wanted to keep her busy as a secondary objective. Another way to hit Vainqueur through others. “Your Majesty...”

“Yes, minion?”

“Have you called your niece lately?”

Chapter 64: Dawnfall

Vainqueur was *livid*.

First of all, the bats had struck at his second-most prized possession: his one and only friend. They had trashed his house, leaving only a pile of rubble before which the dragon and his minions stood. They had caught the souls of his prized lackeys—thankfully none of whom Vainqueur knew the names of—and wounded Sweet Chocolatine.

Second, these *savages* didn't appreciate the taste of dragon blood. A half-dragon, but dragon blood still! This affront to his species' honor would not go unpunished!

And finally, the bats now threatened his *niece*.

“Fetch me any vampire you find,” Vainqueur ordered the Kobold Rangers, who had survived the assault, albeit not without wounds. “So I may eat them myself!”

“What do we do with her?” Knight Kia asked, holding the treacherous Savoureuse while keeping her sword at her throat.

“How could you?” Vainqueur lambasted her. “How could you betray me? Why have so many minions betrayed my trust after I gave their lives purpose? After I made you more than food, namely, *emergency* food?”

“I care more about my life than a purpose?” Savoureuse proposed, unashamed and unrepentant.

“Sav, this doesn't have to be,” Manling Victor said, composed and dignified as befitting Vainqueur's chief of staff. “I asked Kia to send a magical message to her old party member Nostredame days ago, on your behalf.”

“I asked Kevin to set the authorities on the Nightblades in Noblecoeur, your home city, and to safeguard your family,” the paladin said. “If you cooperate with us, we can ensure your safety from reprisals.”

“But that would make me a *snitch*,” Savoureuse protested. “I would have to go back on my honor as a professional thug-for-hire and assassin.”

“The only honor in life for a mortal like you is to do as a dragon tells you!” Vainqueur responded with peerless logic. “The life of a wyrmling is on the line! Will you keep serving as the minion of creatures who will sink so low? Or will you choose to serve the best, most merciful, richest dragon in the world? Are you a *Bella*, or a *Renfield*?”

“I...”

“I am a dragon,” Vainqueur cut her off. “And I am also an uncle. Anything that stands between me and my niece’s safety is not food. It is *ashes*. Are you ashes, Scaly Savoureuse?”

Charisma check successful! It’s a critical!

Scaly Savoureuse saw the light of dragon wisdom—helped by the smoke coming out of his nostrils—and turned her back on the darkness. “If my family and I are safe, I could... give away the locations of all the hidden warehouses we set up in Murmurin.”

“What about Charlene?” Manling Victor immediately pushed, once again only thinking about reproducing. “Miel?”

“Charlene is... *sick*.”

“Sick, as in blood sick?” Manling Victor asked, worried.

“Sick as in vampire sick,” Savoureuse admitted. “As for Miel, a doppelganger impersonated her to foster strife among Heaven and Happyland. I can testify—”

“Nobody cares!” Vainqueur snarled. “Where is the bat? Where is my niece?”

In front of the treacherous creature's silence, the dragon decided to take matters into his own claws. "Give me the map, minion," Vainqueur ordered, his friend obeying at once. "We will track down this overgrown bat immediately!"

"Wait, I need to equip myself first!"

"I'm coming as well," Kia insisted.

"After you abandoned my niece? Never!" Vainqueur snarled, before turning to his minion. "No time to wait, Manling Victor! I will summon you when I catch her!" His niece's life was on the line, and nothing else mattered.

"No, Your Majesty, you can't—"

But Vainqueur had already extended his wings and flew away, the tiny map in his claws.

The sun had risen well above when Vainqueur located Lavere in the middle of the desert, far, far away from Murmurin.

The great dragon didn't have to check his map; the vermin had summoned a sphere of darkness, that 'underworld' effect, right in the middle of the dunes. While his minions may not have seen well through these thick shadows, Vainqueur did. He could also smell the bat, Mell Lin, their servants... and most importantly, his niece.

Under other circumstances, Vainqueur would have fashionably announced his presence, or stealthily activated his blinkblink ring. But this time, he did not. This vermin would have naught but flames and destruction.

Instead, Vainqueur activated his [Charged Attack] Perk and unleashed a house-sized fireball at the dark sphere.

The resulting blast turned the very sand to molten glass, shredded the vampires and other monstrous vermin camouflaging within. The shadows fled before his flames, the effect dispelled.

[DarkUnderworld] field destroyed!

As the shadowy orb vanished, the sun cast a bright light on the area. Jolie, his poor niece, had been bound by thick black chains and muzzled; a disgusting vampire, which he assumed to be Lucie Lavere, had survived his attack thanks to a shield of purple light; and Mell Lin stood nearby, his pipe in one hand and a strange, familiar bottle in the other. All their minions, Vainqueur had slain.

The dragon's eyes immediately drifted to his niece, the sight enraging him. Her scales were covered in bruises, and one of her tiny horns had been cut like a twisted trophy. She looked up at her uncle with hope, straining against her bindings to join him, yet too young and weakened to do so.

Unfortunately, these... these *cowards* stayed close to Jolie, using her as a shield. Vainqueur knew his flames wouldn't hurt her, but the blast might.

"To think I let you live," Lavere growled, a wailing grimoire floating in front of her, while Mell Lin put the bottle in the sand, before playing his pipe and dancing around it. "What a mistake... [Soul Sacrifice: Unblockable Magic]."

By sacrificing a stolen soul per spell, Lucie Lavere's spell checks will automatically succeed against you!

"I knew you could not resist the sweet, wonderful taste of dragon blood," Vainqueur said with a growl. "Your thirst for this indescribable pleasure led you to your doom. You have touched my niece, and for this crime against me, you shall perish!"

"A dragon caring for another? Laughable," Lucie taunted him while chuckling to herself. "The only thing that matters in this world, is power. [Shadow Chains]."

Black chains identical to those holding Jolie manifested around Vainqueur, trying to ensnare him. He easily broke them, his royal mantle shining as he did.

Mobility reduction negated by your [**Cloak of Golden Majesty**].

“I promise you this, batling,” Vainqueur warned, well and truly *furios*. “I will hold nothing back.”

“Then let’s finish this,” she replied with smug arrogance. “For I won’t let you, or *anyone*, interfere with my ambitions.”

Vainqueur answered by lunging towards her like a hawk diving at a mouse, claws extended. He activated [Fire Crown], his body exuding a mighty shroud of flames and burning Mot’s map in his hand; the great dragon had become a meteor falling on insects.

But as he closed the gap between his foes and himself, Mell Lin’s bottle began to open on its own; Vainqueur finally recognized it as the one keeping that fairy Mot trapped. Did these fools think the djinn could save them? It only meant more experience for the dragon to claim!

But instead of unleashing another fomor to die at his hands, the bottle began to suck air and sand.

Warning: [**Bottle of Dragonbinding**] activated by ???

If you are dragged inside, you will be [**Banished**] to a pocket dimension!

Before Vainqueur knew what hit him, the bottle turned into a mighty vortex dragging him toward itself; the great dragon suddenly found himself forced to try and fly back not to be trapped by it. He immediately activated [Spell Purge], trusting it to defeat this witchery! It reduced the vortex’s power, yet couldn’t negate it.

“The pieces are falling into place,” Lavere gloated, skipping pages from her book while Mell Lin focused on singing. “[Doublecast].”

Lucie Lavere can now cast two spells at once!

[**Bottle of Dragonbinding**] negated by [**Immovab**—

“[Perk Binding],” the vampire said, her grimoire uttering the same sentence as she did.

Your [**Spell Purge**] and [**Immovable**] Perks have been nullified!

His favorite Perk stopped working, leaving him defenseless and ever closer to this prison. Vainqueur immediately attempted a last-ditch exorcism, but the vampire negated it with a [Counterspell]. Vainqueur tried to incinerate the item, only to watch his breath drawn inside.

“MINION!” Vainqueur shouted. “MINION! GET BACK HERE!”

Victor Dalton cannot teleport for the day.

What? How could his chief of staff go on strike at this critical moment?!

“Researching your perks, cutting away your key resources, and isolating you from them took time,” Laveré spoke with confidence. “But brains will always prevail over brawn. With your defeat, I will get a [Heroic Crest], and become closer to Valhalla.”

Vainqueur let out a furious snarl, as he fruitlessly struggled to escape the binding. His sweet niece looked up at him, her once-hopeful eyes now full of fear and despair.

This could not end like this! He was the great red dragon, the Emperor of Murmurin and the Albain Mountains, the richest in the world!

And yet, the wealthy always won, because the truly rich have friends.

[**Master’s Shield**] activated! You gained the [**Regen**] status.

A rift in space opened right behind Vainqueur’s enemies, a black, winged rider rushing through.

Bat Laveré and Mell Lin barely had the time to turn at the new threat, than Manling Victor was already on to them, carrying his scythe in one hand and his strange cannon in the other. He pointed his weapon at the bottle and fired a projectile.

While ridiculously weak in comparison with Vainqueur’s own fireball, the explosion shattered the bottle, threw Mell Lin backward, and blew dust in

all directions.

“Minion!” Vainqueur rejoiced, as the vortex collapsed and died down, allowing him to land safely on the sand.

“Lavere, there’s a thing you don’t get,” Manling Victor taunted the bat, swinging his empowered scythe with moxie before trying to cut her down. “You can’t break a winning team!”

The vampire moved to dodge the attack, only to realize, too late, that she had been tricked. At the very last second, Manling Victor’s scythe deviated from her neck to her book and sliced it clean in half.

The grimoire immediately let out a final wail, hundreds, thousands of screaming souls escaping its strange pages, only to move back into Manling Victor’s scythe. When Bat Lavere managed to summon a shield between the chief of staff and herself, her prized weapon had already turned to dust.

You have recovered the use of [**Spell Purge**]!

“Winning team?” his chief of staff’s mount complained, as Manling Victor rushed back to his master’s side. “You horseslaver, you made me run all across the desert non-stop!”

The vampire’s eyes bulged in shock, yet managed to regain her composure. Jolie struggled against her bindings to escape, but the witch maintained her spell. “This is not over,” she promised. “I will find another way.”

“No, you will not.”

Mell Lin emerged from the dust cloud, almost as furious as Vainqueur himself. The fairy piper had stopped playing music and abandoned his disguise for his true, hideous, wooden face.

“That is your *last* chance,” Mell Lin warned the vampire, raising his cape to reveal a blackened crest. “Die to *them*, or die to *us*.” He tossed the item to Lavere, formed a fairy ring by rending space itself, and then fled like a coward as Vainqueur attempted to incinerate him.

“You... you traitor!” Unlike a true, dignified chief of staff, Bat Laverre had lost all composure at her master’s abandonment.

“Guess you’ve chosen the wrong crowd,” Manling Victor said. “It’s over.”

“I will just return to the dark,” Laverre replied, her ugly mammalian face twisted into a snarl, her eyes having turned crimson. “I can change my identity! Without the map, you have no way to track me down!”

“Our minions are already stamping out your hideouts in both Gardemagne and Murmurin as we speak,” Friend Victor taunted her. “You’re not going to run far, and you heard your forgiving master. Face it, either you kill us here, which you *won’t*, or they will finish you off for us. You’re cornered!”

The vampire glanced at the [Black Crest], clearly fearing to use it for some reason, and then turned to Vainqueur. The emperor could see the emotions in her eyes changing from anger, to fear, and then despair.

Good.

The dragon let out a furious roar and unleashed a torrent of furious flames at her. Laverre raised the Black Crest in response, the item crumbling into black dust, and unleashing its power.

A blast of purple, fairy energy surrounded her, repelling even Vainqueur’s fire. The vampire underwent a metamorphosis, her flesh turning purple and ripping her clothes apart. She grew enormous wings, sharp claws, and fangs. She increased in size until she almost matched Vainqueur himself in size, more a monstrous, primal bat than manling.

Lucie Laverre used a [**Black Crest**] and gained ten Levels in the [**Fairy Beast**] class.

The abomination let out a hiss, her hands suffused with dark magic. Fighting dragons was stupid, but in her eagerness to die, she would try.

In response, Vainqueur immediately activated his [Spell Purge] and launched a fireball at her. The creature transformed into a swarm of bats,

dispersing to avoid the projectile, before quickly reforming on the dragon's back. When he turned around to face her, Vainqueur found her throwing a sphere of dark energy at him.

It failed.

His [Spell Reflection] activated, sending the sphere back at the witch. Her own projectile hit her in the head, making her stumble.

"Bat, you do not understand," Vainqueur said, through playing. "You have done what only the evil Furibon and the elf grasshopper managed to do. You *infuriated me*."

The dragon saw fear and dread in the bat's eyes; as he should. Extending his own wings, his body covered in flames, Vainqueur charged at her with berserk rage, a winged incarnation of destruction.

She tried to keep him at bay with a volley of spells, of black cubes and frozen stars, only for them to reflect back at her. He punched her in the chest in response, shattering ribs and making her cough thick black blood. Except he didn't stop and kept pummeling her.

As a last-ditch effort, she summoned a purple shield to defend herself, Vainqueur hitting it with his claws and shaking the desert with each strike.

Manling Victor, who had wisely stayed out of his master's range, finally decided to speak up. "Your Majesty, can I borrow some of your immense lifeforce for a minute?!"

"This will come out of your pay!"

Manling Victor, ever ready to serve his master for free, sheathed back both of his weapons and raised his hands at the shield. "[Hades Blast]!"

Sorcery cackled from his fingertips, before taking the shape of a shining ray of purple light, whose might and shininess rivaled Vainqueur's own breath. The laser *smashed* through Lavere's defense, vaporizing the left side of her stomach while at it. Smoke sizzling from the wound.

You sacrificed a quarter of your HP!

Vainqueur punched the defenseless bat in the face, burning it. And then kept going, even as she retaliated with claws and fangs. It burned her more than it hurt him, and while she inflicted some damage, it didn't even itch!

“Unshle, shesh drashon!” Jolie encouraged him through her muzzle. “Unshle, shesh drashon!”

Through [**Master's Shield**], you have recovered all your HP!

For the first time since Brandon Maure, Vainqueur fought *seriously*.

If she had confronted him back when Vainqueur hadn't rediscovered the great, dragon-made system, she might have been a challenge... but for every strike she made, the dragon returned each hit tenfold. Her spells bounced back at her, and without her magic or trickery, the bat couldn't stand against him. He didn't leave her any opening, deflecting her punches with his mastery of brawling, and retaliated with deadly strikes of his own.

And unlike Vainqueur, she was *alone*.

“[Hades Blast]!” Manling Victor repeated the process again and again, overwhelming the witch with spells. He waited for Vainqueur to recover his energy, then struck again; when Lavere attempted to escape Vainqueur by transforming into a bat swarm, he shot them all, forcing her to reform. He cost the Emperor more health than the creature's claws, yet for once, the dragon let him play.

For it wasn't a fight.

It was an *execution*.

“Stop, please...” the monster rasped, her wings broken, her flesh burnt to the bone. “I yield... I yield... I will pay you... I will pay... the Apple... gold... *anything*...”

Vainqueur was good and merciful. He had accepted tribute for insults to his person.... but by threatening his family, she had committed a crime of *lese*

majesté. For this, there was no forgiveness.

Instead of granting her mercy, he seized the bat by the shoulders, kept her in place, and opening his mouth.

“[Charged Attack: Dragon Breath]!”

Within seconds, his almighty flames turned the sand to glass, and her body to dust. As he had promised, by threatening his niece, Bat Lavere had become ashes.

She didn’t even drop a crest, nor loot.

Congratulations! By cornering and demolishing the Nightblades’ leader, you earned four levels in [**Augustus**]! You earned the [**Shining Majesty**] and [**Golden Road**] Class Perks!

Your Witch Hunter can be promoted into either [**Hellsing**] or [**Witchfinder General**].

+120 HP, +10 SP, +8 STR, +1 VIT, +4 SKI, +4 AGI, +2 INT, +8 CHA.

[**Shining Majesty**]: Technique, 120 SP. Your scales can unleash a mighty, searing flash of light, bombarding peons with a glorious vision of your hoard. This inflicts heavy [Light] damage, and the target suffers from the [Blind] ailment on a failed Vitality check and/or [Enthrall] ailments on a failed Charisma check.

[**Golden Road**]: Technique, 30 SP per 5 seconds. You can create a [Portal] as per the spell, but only to open a spatial doorway leading to your hoard.

With Lavere’s demise, the chains holding Jolie turned to shadowy dust, finally freeing her. “Uncle!” his adorable niece cried.

“It is over, Jolie,” Vainqueur promised, rushing to her side and cradling his niece in his arms. “The evil bat is gone!”

“Am I...” She looked up at him with her cute eyes. “Am I still grounded?”

“Of course not,” Vainqueur reassured her. “You are not grounded anymore.”

“Thanks, Uncle!” Jolie replied, the tears in her eyes gone, before hopping out of his arms. Vainqueur remained speechless, with the feeling he had been tricked somehow.

Yet, as a shower of gold fell from the heavens to reward his good work, the dragon abandoned himself to the blissful feeling of absolute victory.

“Is it raining *gold*?” Manling Victor’s mount asked, in awe of Vainqueur’s ever-growing fortune.

“It’s a golden shower,” the chief of staff replied with a sarcastic tone. “It’s a president thing.”

Chapter 65: Don't Wake the Dragon

In the safety of his vault, Vainqueur Knightsbane took a handful of coins from his hoard and showered his niece with them.

He had allowed his niece to rest on his hoard, until its warmth helped her forget her captivity at the hands of the bat-beast. Yet, in spite of his best efforts, she remained quiet and slightly scared of the outside. “Uncle,” Jolie finally asked him. “Do I have a birth defect?”

“Of course not!” Vainqueur reassured her. “You are almost as perfect as me!”

“But Dad died, and they hurt me!” Unfortunately for her uncle, Jolie may be young, she was also smart for her age. Her lost horn would constantly remind her of her imprisonment. “You always told me pain was a birth defect.”

“Because you were too young for the truth,” Vainqueur said, having himself only learned about this shameful secret of dragonkind recently.

He could no longer spare her feelings.

“Pain and death...” Vainqueur struggled to find the right words, to deliver the terrible truth. “Pain and death are not birth defects! Every dragon suffers from them!”

Jolie’s eyes morphed into the purest expression of dread and horror. While she understood the truth deep down, to hear it from her beloved uncle must have shaken her to the core. “Even you?”

“Even...” Vainqueur’s voice broke. “Even I.”

The revelation scared her even more of the outside.

"Jolie, through my journeys, I learned that true confidence is not being ignorant of death," Vainqueur told her, trying to cheer his niece up. "True *awesomeness* is being *me*: fighting to the bitter end because I know that despite the risks, I will always prevail. Because I am *me*. Even Death bows before my strength, wealth, and peerless genius!"

“So if I grow strong and big and rich like you, I can overcome death?”
Jolie’s head perked up.

“Exactly!” Vainqueur encouraged her. “But you cannot become as amazing as me if you stay at home all day. You have to grow fat on cattle, cultivate the best minions, destroy your enemies, and get rewarded for it with wealth! That is the dragon way to happiness!”

His words lit up the fires of enthusiasm in his niece’s eyes.

His vault’s doorbell echoed through its walls, Vainqueur grumbling as he opened the large door.

He found Knight Kia waiting in front. “Is Jolie—”

Vainqueur began to close the door before she could finish, intent on keeping her out. But unfortunately, his niece had heard the voice. “Kia!” She immediately rose up to welcome her perverse excuse of a minion, forcing her uncle to keep the gates open.

“I’m so sorry,” the Knight apologized while hugging the dragonling; as if it would make up for her sin of minion incompetence. “I should have stayed with you all the time. Did they cut off your horn?”

“Yes, and they took my blood too! They tried to seal Uncle in a bottle!”

The Knight scratched Jolie behind the ear, the way Vainqueur often did; the sight made him envious, although he was too good to show it. “This is just

the beginning,” Knight Kia said. “Once a Fomor has its mind on something, it never stops.”

“You’re not leaving again?” Jolie asked her minion.

“No, this time I will stay with you constantly,” Kia said, “At least. until you have enough levels to defend yourself. I will train you until you become a [Paladin] so unstoppable, that you will eat vampires for dinner.”

“Good, because if I find out if *anyone* hurt my niece again on your watch, there will be nothing left of you to breed,” Vainqueur warned the manling, and he meant it.

As for the fairies, the dragon could no longer ignore their schemes.

Now was the time for *action*.

Sitting on the back of his horse, backed by a legion of clerics, kobolds, and ghouls, Victor glanced at the barricaded house in front of him. It had taken most of the day and last night, but this was the last warehouse to raid.

“Sir, what do we do?” Jules asked, glancing at the shut windows.

“If she’s not out in five minutes, break the door and kill them all,” Victor told his troops. “No quarter.”

Fortunately, the door opened and Savoureuse walked out. A dozen vampires followed her, their hands on the back of their heads. Charlene closed the procession.

As Savoureuse told them, the Nightblades had already turned her into a vampire. Her skin had turned dead white, her eyes crimson, and her body had slimmed considerably. She looked more attractive and confident, in a predatory kind of way.

“We’ll find a way to cure you,” Victor promised her, climbing down from his horse while carrying his bazooka.

“Cure what?” Charlene replied. “My newfound immortality?”

“You’re not mad about your current situation?”

“No! Being a vampire is marvelous!” She put her hands on her hips, flaunting her new figure, “I feel so much healthier and stronger! I will have to hide from the sun when I run out of elixirs, but I will stay young forever! I no longer feel the ache in my back!”

Victor thought she would feel conflicted about losing her humanity, but she took it awfully well. “Good to see you back then.”

“And let me tell you, things will change,” Charlene replied, her bloody eyes full of authority. “When I find that traitor Croissant, I will suck him dry, and not in the way he thought I would.”

Victor had already planned to decide his fate with his sister after the current matter dealt with. “Where is Emile Lavere?” he asked the prisoners. Lucie’s second-in-command was the last loose end he had to address.

“We trapped him in his coffin when he refused to surrender,” the assassin replied. “None of us here will fight for a dead woman.”

“Shoot the coffin with arrows, check the corpse, then cremate it,” Victor ordered Jules, the necromancer entering the house with an escort to do the deed. With Emile gone, they had defanged the guild’s leadership in Murmurin.

As for the minions... “You have fought the law,” Victor warned them. “Caused us a lot of trouble, sowed chaos, and threatened the emperor’s subjects. What do you have to say for yourself?”

“We surrendered?” a rogue said. “Shouldn’t you be a tiny bit merciful? I mean, Sav got away with it.”

“Not really,” Savoureuse sighed.

“I condemned her to five years of community service,” Victor said, and by that, he meant cook duties. “And unlike you, she fully cooperated.”

“Then we are sorry, and we won’t do it again?” one of the vampires responded bashfully.

“Yeah, you’re scary, sir,” another rogue replied. “And also very handsome!”

“Phooey, and here I thought you needed a backbone to become an [Assassin] these days,” a new, mocking voice taunted the cowardly killers. “I stand corrected.”

Victor raised his eyes, noticing someone on the roof.

A humanoid crow with feathers as black as the darkest night, and eyes shining like stars in the dark. He wore a ridiculously extravagant crimson harlequin costume and swung a scythe full of wailing souls. The way he hopped on the roof, he clearly delighted in his coyness; and somehow, watching him felt *wrong*.

How did he manage to sneak up on everyone? And why did he look exactly like... like...

...

It couldn’t be.

“Who the Happyland are you?” Victor pointed his rocket launcher at the newcomer.

“I’m Deathjester,” the birdkin harlequin announced himself with a mock bow, before leaping off the roof and gracefully landing in front of Victor. “God prince of crime. Accept no substitute.”

Deathjester

Deity (guess my type! Avian/Divine!)

Strengths and weaknesses mean nothing to me; all bend to my will.

Yes, that’s me, I’m the real deal. The patron god of criminals, troublemakers, tricksters, and birds (because birds are *awesome*). I’ve killed

every type of creature at least once, even Mithras at one time. I could give you the gory details, but that would make for an entire black comedy novel.

Ffffffffff....

“That’s the real one,” Victor muttered in shock. “That’s Deathjester!”

The entire minion regiment pointed their weapons at the birdkin, while the Nightblades, including Savoureuse, instantly bowed before their patron deity. “God!” they sung in respect.

Deathjester responded to the display of force by raising a talon, transforming every spear and arquebuse aimed at him into feathers, much to the kobolds’ surprise. “Now, you all know my history with the law,” the crime god said. “But I come in peace. Honest.”

Victor didn’t know how to react. He had grown unimpressed with the gods, but this one was murder incarnate, and *Evil* with a capital *E*.

“Thank you, thank you, you are too kind,” the deity responded with vanity, clapping his hands, “As implausible it may sound, I’m not here to kill anyone. In fact, I came to give you my blessing... and ask you to spare my followers, even if I’m a bit ashamed of their cowardice.”

“You’re... applauding me?” Somehow, it felt shameful.

“Victor, Vic, I’m the friend of all those who walk the path of chaos,” the deity said, patting him on the back, much to everyone’s silent astonishment. “Ever since you failed to steal that rapier from Vainqueur’s hoard, Outremonde has entered an era of change and confusion. You and that dragon are walking disasters, and I love, *love* it. Right now, you’re my favorite troublemaker. I’ve even decided to give you a sweet reward.”

Light shone on Victor’s left shoulder, through the armor’s chinks. He supposed the crow deity’s symbol had appeared on his skin.

You earned the [**Claimed by Deathjester**] Personal Perk!

[Claimed by Deathjester]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Skill or Charisma point. You can falsify your Karma as you wish, and your lies cannot be identified by any magic.

“That should take care of your angel problem,” said the deity, clearly expecting Victor to commit insurance fraud.

“You know Shesha already claimed me?” Victor pointed out. “Shouldn’t you cancel one another?”

“Oh, you know, our portfolios have many gray areas,” the deity replied. “Like drugs or prostitution.”

Having been claimed by four deities, Victor wondered if he should catch them all. “Eh, don’t expect any ‘goodish’ deity to look on kindly to you,” Deathjester said, confirming that he could read the Vizier’s mind. “Except maybe Seng or Cybele, since you’re easy as they come.”

“Hey, what does that mean?” Did they consider him a manwhore upstairs?

“Not just upstairs,” Deathjester shrugged. “Now, I have an offer for you.”

“An offer you can’t refuse, or an offer-offer?” Victor asked, doubtful.

“I had something fresh with the Nightblades, and with Lil’ Lucie gone, the organization will fall into disarray,” the harlequin replied while ignoring the question. “And while I’m all for eras of strife, it will make law-loving Mithras happy, and his pleasure is my unhappiness. I also believe you have great potential as a villain, and not only because you followed one seminar.”

“You want me to take over the Nightblades?” the Grand Vizier guessed.

“Yes, but only if you spare my lovely assassins,” the deity confirmed.

“Someone has to care for the dregs and outcasts of the world. So. Do you want to become the Napoleon of crime, Vic?”

Frankly, if he had asked months ago when Savoureuse offered him control of a chapter, he would have refused.

But now, Victor wasn't sure what to make of it. Controlling the Nightblades would help repurpose their vast resources to serve his and Vainqueur's interests, instead of the fomors'. He could reform the organization to make it something more productive than terrorists for hire. On the other hand... his karma would take another hit.

"I don't really feel like a villain, or someone walking the path of chaos, as you say," the Vizier argued. "If anything, I'm the main reason why this country is semi-functional."

"You're in league with Happyland, you lead a nation of monsters, made necromancy a state-sponsored trade, you've ruthlessly hunted your own kind to protect a greedy, destructive dragon... should I go on?"

"I did most of that for Vainqueur. I owe him my life."

"You didn't resist very hard even though he listens to you, and keyword is *most*. You're the one who allowed fiends to operate there, without Vainqueur's input. You're not evil, because only angels believe in absolutes, but you're not hero material either. Face it, Vic, deep down, you're a hoodlum; if the kind with vision and virtues."

"That's a nice sales pitch," Victor deadpanned. "What next, 'join the dark side and get cookies'?"

"That's the thing you don't get yet: there are no *sides*, just whatever you *want*," Deathjester shrugged. "So? Deal?"

Victor considered the deity's words until the answer became obvious. "I accept."

"Glad to hear that," the god replied, before sliding a talon beneath his harlequin hat, and bringing out a letter. "Also, if one day you wish to go beyond a mere seminar and further your education in overlordship, my pals and I have a whole curriculum for aspiring social climbers. Here's your invitation."

Victor snatched the letter and examining it. The seal on the back represented a black lightning bolt, and someone had written the word 'Scholomance' on the front.

"Remember, Vic," Deathjester said, ascending to the skies through a pillar of light. "Lie all the time, cheat, steal, screw the law, and paladins too! That's the purpose of life!"

"Screw in what way?" Victor deadpanned.

"That's the spirit, my boi!"

And then the deity vanished before everyone's astonished eyes.

Congratulations! For dismantling the Murmurin branch of the Nightblades through cleverness and cunning, reaping souls until you had your fill, and rescuing your master on horseback, you earned three levels in [**Grand Vizier**], two levels in [**Reaper**], one level in [**Assassin**] and one level in [**Chaos Rider**].

You earned the [**Forktongued**], [**Envious**], and [**Soulmaster IV**] Class Perks.

+180 HP, +40 SP, +5 STR, +2 VIT, +10 SKI, +5 AGI, +5 INT, +8 CHA, +7 LCK.

[**Forktongued**]: You gain a +5 bonus on Charisma checks when you tell lies.

[**Envious**]: technique, you can steal one positive ailment (such as Regen or Physical Ward) from an enemy or ally and apply it to yourself.

[**Soulmaster IV**]: Your knowledge of souls has opened you more paths to power than necromancy alone. You can now learn and use [Necromancy], [Rituals], and [Diabolism] spells up to Tier IV. Reaper levels now count as Caster levels for the purpose of class restrictions, and if a class grants you a spellcasting tier in your specialized schools of magic, they will stack with Soulmaster IV. This replaces [Necromancy III].

Congratulations! By gaining enough levels into specific classes, being chosen as the head of a criminal syndicate, and receiving the blessing of the god of crime, you can now combine [**Assassin**] and [**Grand Vizier**] into the prestigious [**Moriarty**] class.

[**Moriarty**]: An emperor of crime, a diabolical mastermind manipulating entire countries from the shadows. Specialties: Leadership, Illusions, Stealth, Small Weapons. Major growths in Skill, Intelligence, and Charisma. Perks affected: [**Is-No-Good**], [**Blade Stinger**], [**Forktongued**].

Well. He had work to do.

At the first hour after dawn, Vainqueur had summoned almost all of his minions at the central square, to address the population.

For things would *change*.

Vainqueur observed the inhabitants of his city, who had all gathered to listen to his wise words, from the lowest slime to the tallest dwarf. He could smell their worries, their fear. They had had terrible nights and seen Manling Victor's own home go down in flames. They wanted reassurance.

They would have their fill, and more.

"Citizens of Murmurin," Vainqueur cleared his throat, to begin his speech. "Long you have feared the night. For days, vampire insurgents led by Laverre the Bat have waged war against my city. They have burned your houses, slaughtered my cattle, corrupted the hearts of old minions, and threatened even what I cherish most. The rebels have cowardly hidden in shadows, trying to divide you through fear, and mistrust."

His eyes settled on Malfy the Fiend and Miel the Angel. The former remained in a wheelchair, although he had recovered a little; the latter had had her identity cleared up, thanks to Vainqueur's own genius and Repentant Savoureuse's testimony. But now, both stood united against the true enemy.

“But the battle is over!” the dragon rejoiced, raising his left hand and clenching it. “The bat leader is dead by my flames, crushed like the vermin she was! As I speak, my forces, under the leadership of my Grand Vizier, are crushing the last pockets of resistance! For as long as you remain under my wing, all will fall before the Empire’s might!”

The crowd immediately reacted with joy, enthusiasm... but all of it subdued. While the most zealous of his minions applauded, as usual, most worried that these attacks were but the beginning of a war. The tension remained palpable. Vainqueur decided to relieve it, by handing out honors to the minions he felt deserved them. “Kobold Rangers, take a step forward.”

His oldest, most prized minions after Manling Victor gathered before him, bowing in line. They had covered themselves with glory in the darkest night, and today, he would reward them.

“When I found you, you were but kobolds,” Vainqueur said. “Yet I immediately saw the seeds of true minionship slumbering within you, ready to be unleashed. Now, you have grown in power, becoming the elite of my lackeys. You are everything a master could want from his servants.”

His minions shivered at his praise, bowing so deep that the dragon worried that they may break their backs.

“As a reward for your long and dutiful service, I promote you to *Knights of Vainqueur*, and *Defenders of the Niece*,” Vainqueur declared. “Thou shall protect and guard one of my three greatest joys: my beautiful niece, Jolie. You shall defend her as you defended my gold, and prevail where Knight Kia proved herself lacking.”

“Your Majesty honors us,” Red spoke for the entire team, all of them had tears in their eyes; although it must have been water condensation for the undead ones. “And we shall bring glory to you in return!”

“I know, minions. Now, kiss my ring.” Vainqueur offered them his hand, which they all embraced; the dragon quickly moved on to the hero of the day. “Allison the Dryad, step forward.”

The dryad sheepishly approached.

“Once I disdained you, for I did not consider you minion material.” Too skinny, and he could not eat Rolo. In time, he had come to appreciate the golem’s ability to supply him with food, enough to forgive this defect. “You have proven yourself worthy of my trust.”

“Uh...” the plantkin didn’t find her words, too intimidated by the honor.
“Okay...”

“For your deeds against the insurgents, I now make you my new *wizardry teacher*. You shall assist Manling Victor in making me even more powerful.”

“So... keep doing what I’ve been doing already?”

“Yes, but now your contribution is recognized,” Vainqueur said, showcasing his generosity. “Now kiss my ring.”

After she did, albeit with less enthusiasm than the Rangers, Vainqueur addressed the crowd again. “However, citizens, as a good dragon, I shall always tell the truth. The vampire insurgents were but the soldiers of a much older threat. The *fairies*.”

“Fairies?” “The Fomors?” “They’re *back*?!”

Vainqueur listened to the whispers of his lackeys, finding out that they feared his old rivals, as much as they respected dragons. Their ancestors had died at the hands of these creatures, or toiled as slaves.

“This time, however, they have gone too far. They spat at a *volcano*.”

To punctuate his declaration, Vainqueur let out a stream of fire at the skies, instantly silencing his adoring fans.

“Minions, the fairies declared war on *me*,” Vainqueur said, smoke coming out of his nostrils. “By freeing the Goldslayer Furibon from the seal which kept his evil contained, attacking my minions, and threatening my niece, they broke the dragon-fomor peace, which has held since the morning of the

world. If they have forgotten who won the first war, I shall remind them in the second.”

The great dragon proudly extended his wings, so all his minions could bask in his full majesty.

“For I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of His Name, Great Calamity of the Age, Defender of the Hoard, Greatest Gladiator, Genius Presidente, and Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains, declare war back on the fomors!”

Charisma check successful!

His servants raised their hands in bloodthirsty acclaim, eager for revenge. “War!” they shouted all at once, their screams becoming deafening, “War! War! War!”

“The Mell clan, which has opposed me since my awakening, shall learn its place! Nowhere in this world will they feel safe from my wrath! I will burn their lairs to the ground, empty their pens of cattle, and claim their wealth as mine!”

Vainqueur waved his hand in a dramatic fashion. “As the first measure, I hereby order the creation of the *Vainqueur Watch for Thorough Fairy Destruction*; an institution dedicated to finding new and creative ways to deal with the fomor problem! I invite any creature willing to fight the good fight, to join this golden crusade!”

None applauded this decision more than the dwarves; they had eagerly welcomed his orders to prepare for the return of Furibon, and could not wait to test their weapons on new targets.

“As my second measure, it is time for the country to live up to *my* reputation,” Vainqueur said. “All of my minions will train and be equipped, so that one day, very soon, we shall take the fight to the fairies, instead of letting them invade us again! I shall expand this empire beyond this city, across the sea and into the island of Prydain! Under my wings, we shall prevail!”

As his citizens applauded the declaration, Vainqueur abandoned himself to his imagination, thinking about the future. He already salivated at the thought of the vast treasures which the fomors would surely drop. He had much work to do, for the fairies were vicious. They had crafted golems that could challenge even him. They had modernized, as he did when he embraced the dragon System.

He would have to modernize his empire too. While the growth of his hoard remained his priority, he would ensure that his empire grew stronger under his rule. While he had been content to let Manling Victor handle minion affairs, he would now provide direct guidance, until his dominion had grown tenfold.

And one day, very soon...

He would conquer even the Moon!

Chapter 66: Buzz's Jelly Adventures

- *“The Moon Disaster,” by Pink Ranger, opening crawl.*

This is a tempestuous time for the V&V Empire. The good Emperor Vainqueur, wealthy may he grow, triumphed over the Legions of Thieves who would threaten his hoard. The path to the stars is open!

Among the scraps of destroyed arrows of metal, the courageous Buzz Jelly prepares to board a ship to the Moooooon! Its mission: to claim the new planet in the name of the empire and greed! Much gold awaits in the far reaches of space, but so do dangers!

Before a crowd of Moon Man cultists, Buzz Jelly received the blessings and buffs of their prophet (and the Emperor's secret true love), Lord Victor, first among the minions. His Majesty Vainqueur himself wished the young slime luck, as it hopped to board the 'Sword Rocket.'

But none could foresee the tragedy, that would become forever known, as the 'Moon Disaster.'

The Moooooon...

Buzz Jelly looked up at the night sky, where the object of its dreams glittered true. A mighty sword of metal, the biggest Buzz had ever seen, pointed at the aster, ready to pierce the planet with its sharp pointiness. Enormous dwarves had opened its belly, into which Buzz would hop, with its adoptive spawner ready to give the stuntman a last hug.

“Young!” Vainqueur Junior, or ‘Excalidad’ as its protégées nicknamed it, protested. While it had agreed to let Buzz pursue its dreams, now that the fateful day had arrived... “Young!”

“Sword rocket,” Buzz reassured its adoptive spawner, by reminding it of the absolute superiority of swords over all other shapes. Lord Victor also had every buff possible cast on the slime, to ensure the mission's success.

“Sword rocket,” Excalidad conceded, although still worried. “Far!”

“Return!” Buzz promised, before passionately reaffirming the pursuit of its passion. “Dream!”

Convinced by the faultless rhetoric, Excalidad nuzzled against Buzz and wished it luck.

“Let us do a final rundown,” Buzz’s trainer, the dwarf Marbré, briefed it alongside the engineers. “We only have enough powerstones for a one-way trip. To hasten the date of the launch and give hope back to the people after the insurgency, we have stripped the ship of any non-essential part. Seats, air, food...”

“Anything other than a slime or ghost wouldn’t survive the journey,” an engineer said, which Buzz took as praise. “You alone can survive the acceleration, the vacuum of space, and the lack of coating.”

“I remind you that your craft is safe, for you have a chance to survive it,” Marbré added. “You, slime, are a true soldier of the Averagist Revolution. You can make it. You can export the revolution to the stars.”

“Stars!” Buzz agreed, although it privately didn’t agree with the cause. All that mattered to the slime, was to fulfill its dream and serve its country.

“Your role is twofold. First, you must survive all the way to the crash. Second, you must push the red button in your cabin, so our [Warp Projector] can open a gate between our two worlds. We will immediately move to reinforce the portal and ensure a permanent gateway between Murmurin, and the Moon.”

“Push!” Buzz repeated. “Button!”

“Remember your training,” the immense dwarf told the jelly, reminding him of the countless times *‘invisible vampiro-capitalist insurgents’* tried to sabotage the mission by blowing up prototypes. “Survive, and push the button!”

The jelly hopped in response, before turning one last time to see the crowd of legged creatures who would witness the launch. It recognized the giant among giants, the great Vainqueur Knightsbane, and the Grand Vizier Victor, who had always believed in the slime. Its heroes!

“Believe!” Buzz, fueled by passion, delivered the most verbose speech known to slimekind. “Dream! True! Work! Fly! Moon moon! Sword! Heavens!”

The speech led to much controversy amongst the audience, however.

“Did the chosen jelly say heavens? Is it a political statement?”

“It’s an angel product placement!”

“Moooooooooooooon!”

Buzz turned back and hopped inside the Sword Rocket. The metal door closed behind it, sealing the jelly inside a cabin full of steel gears, tin pipes, and other machine stuff; the big, rounded red button awaited its touch on a wall. Only a glass window allowed the stuntslime to see the outside world.

The dwarves, as eager as Buzz to pierce the heavens themselves, immediately initiated the launch. The slime shook in trepidation, awaiting the fateful moment.

And then...

KABOOOOOM!!!

Pushed by a mix of fire and gravity powerstones, the Sword Rocket flew straight to the skies at extreme speed. The sheer, overwhelming pressure

flattened Buzz like a puddle on the ground.

Almost immediately, as the craft reached past the clouds, one of the pipes broke, shoddy bolts erupting in all directions. Steam entered the cabin, threatening to heat up the entire craft!

Having grown used to botched dwarfwork, Buzz instantly moved to action. The slime twisted its body into the shape of a pipe and replaced the metal one. The steam burnt it, making its sliminess boil!

You are taking medium [Fire] damage! [**Regen**] activated!

The heat hurt, but Buzz endured the pain. It had the HP, it had the will!

For long, painful minutes, the slime held on to the ship, even as it shook and threatened to shatter like all the others before.

At long last, when the blue outside started turning black, the steam lessened, the fire powerstones exhausted. Buzz quickly caught the metal pipe flying in the cabin, hopped it back in place, and did the same with the screws. It did well even without hands, thanks to its sliminess, but a tiny bit of steam still escaped into the cabin.

But it gave Buzz enough respite to slam its body against the window, so it could fully see!

...

Beautiful!

The giant blue slime, which the legged called the ocean, covered almost the entire world! It must have eaten the other continents! Murmurin had become a large speck of sand surrounded by seas, and the jelly marveled at the perfect roundedness of the world.

The slime could see the mythical island of Atlantis between its home and the edge of another massive continent. It noticed other wonders: islands floating in the skies, anchored by beans to the earth; a tree taller than

mountains; a giant sleeping under the ocean; even a smaller, black moon orbiting around the world, hidden from view by dark clouds!

After a quick ascent, the craft slowed down, entering space. Buzz could finally gaze at the stars, these shining, maddening lights floating in the dark.

Congratulations! By being the first slime to reach into space, you earned ten levels in the ultra-prestigious [**Cosmonaut**] class! You earned the [**Starshotted**], [**Blue Ozone**], [**SpaceZ**], [**V-Galactic**], and [**Eldritch Probe**] Class perks!

+600 HP, +50 SP, +8 STR, +10 VIT, +7 SKI, +6 AGI, +10 INT, +1 CHA, +8 LCK.

[**Starshotted**] : You take only half damage from [Physical] effects; this reduction applies before factoring your natural or magical resistances. You gain Advanced Proficiency at piloting any space-faring vehicle.

[**Blue Ozone**] : You can survive in the vacuum of space as if it's your native atmosphere. You no longer need to breathe, and you gain resistance to [Fire] and [Frost] .

[**SpaceZ**] : Technique, 40 SP. You can accelerate your body to turn yourself into a deadly projectile, but you cannot stop by yourself after launch. Upon stopping, you recover a third of your total HP.

[**V-Galactic**] : You can see perfectly in darkness, and teleport to any planet, natural satellite, or asteroid which you already visited; you will always be teleported at the area where you made your first landfall.

[**Eldritch Probe**] : Spell, half your SP. You can call upon cosmic powers to summon an Eldritch Probe (Artificial/Eldritch) whose HP is equal to the SP you sacrificed. The creature obeys your orders but also serves as a beacon for eldritch old ones.

Warning: You have reached the 30 level threshold. You will not longer be able to take new levels until you find a [**Crest**].

Jelly ignored the notification, mesmerized by the sightseeing.

Then the sword rocket shook, having hit something.

Buzz's eyes peeked at the edge of the window, where a monster came into view.

The creature was unlike anything Buzz had seen on the rounded world: a pinkish, fungo-crustacean anomaly with a head covered with antennae. While it had batlike wings, it mostly hung to the craft's surface thanks to countless paired appendages wriggling beneath its body. It then watched through the windows, its alien mind making telepathic contact with the young Buzz.

"Look at that!" the creature thought-spoke in R'leyhan, the language Buzz had learned to speak with the moonlanders. "An immigrant!"

"Moon sword rocket!" Buzz mentally argued while hopping back into the cabin, surprising itself by its ability to make three words sentences. It then remembered that its intelligence had grown by ten points! "Empire peace money!"

"Don't lie to me, I know your kind! You're a dirty carbon-based foreigner intruding in our space! You play innocent, but the second I stop watching, you will molest our squids and play trumpets on our asteroids!"

"Air no sound!" Buzz pointed out that there couldn't be any music in space since it lacked an atmosphere.

"I'm just saying if you carbon creatures were good for anything, why do you need an opposite-sex mate to reproduce? Instead of face-hugging an inferior lifeform so it carries your egg?" The creature peeked through the reinforced glass and noticed the red button. "What is this, some kind of carbon egg sack?"

Buzz panicked, recognizing a threat to the mission. "NO TOUCHING BUTTON!"

The eldritch alien shrieked back and unleashed a blast of pure psychic energy, shattering the glass and throwing Buzz against a wall. “[Brain Jammer]!”

The creature assaulted Buzz through their telepathic link, invading the young slime’s mind with terrifying visions of eldritch horrors beyond the stars. Of great, forgotten gods with tentacles and mouths and eyes!

Eyes...

Eye treasures!

Buzz immediately hopped at one of the horror’s eyes...

And ate it!

[**Madness**] ailment negated!

The vision collapsed, returning Buzz to reality; that of chewing the alien’s head.

“That dirty foreigner bit me!” the alien complained, managing to throw Buzz off its ‘face.’ What little oxygen remained inside the cabin had left, alongside gravity. The slime managed to land on a wall, before exploiting the momentum to throw itself back at the invader.

“Eye treasure tasty!” Buzz roared like a lion, before attempting to slim-slam the enemy again.

No damage!

But the alien beast, being bigger, simply swept Buzz aside, before trying to invade the cabin. The enemy approached the button with one of its appendages, threatening to end the mission.

The thought of failing its country spurred the young slime’s warrior spirit. Buzz hopped the damaged pipe, and knocked it out; then, shaping its slimy body, it redirected the focused steam at the alien. The beast screamed in pain, as the jelly sprayed the heated gas at its antennae.

Buzz then closed the pipe with its body, letting pressure build-up and reach a boiling point.

“FOR EMPIRE!”

An explosion of steam threw the young slime at his foe like a cannonball, forcefully ejecting it from the cabin with a brutal collision. Buzz repeatedly bounced back into the cabin, shattering some gears, while the invader flew across space, distanced by the Sword Rocket.

Managing to glue itself to the craft’s wall, even without gravity, the young cosmonaut glanced through the destroyed window, to see the Moooooooooon with its own eyes.

It was almost as beautiful as it imagined; even if on a closer look, it seemed less silvery and more of a dull grey. The slime noticed sprawling cities of black spires and lakes of noxious tar on the surface, which the outrelanders had mistaken for spots. Tentacles sprung from craters where the dark side of the Moooooon began, wriggling in a maddened dance and spreading purple clouds to the bright side.

In short, it was the perfect place where to settle a colony!

However, as expected, the Moooooooooon had an atmosphere; which meant a hard crash.

Worse, the alien had pierced through the coating! Buzz had to protect the cabin, or the entry might damage the button!

Stretching its body, Buzz covered the hole made by the broken windows, gluing itself to the craft’s metal as it entered the Moooooon’s atmosphere. The ship ignited, burning the surface of the slime’s jellyskin.

You are taking heavy [Fire] damage!

Warning: You have lost one-quarter of your HP.

The pain was unbearable, but Buzz wouldn’t let go. No flame would enter the shuttle, so long as it lived!

Warning: You have fallen below half your HP!

In spite of everything, Buzz drew into the last of its willpower to hang on to the craft, closing its eyes. It had to live... to land on the Moooooon and look up at its homeworld... with patriotic pride!

Critical health!

The thought of its adoptive spawner waiting for its return flashed in the slime's young mind, as the Sword Rocket crashed on the Moooooon's surface. The craft shook, the fires extinguished by a storm of grey sand until the craft slowed down.

When at long last Buzz opened its eyes again, the ship had broken in half, but the cabin—and the button—remained intact. Two tentacled white beast watched the young slime from the grey shores of a tar lake.

As Buzz landed on the sand, already recovering from its burns, it thought: what a small hop for a slime.

But such a great leap... for the Empire!

You entered the [**Outremoon**] Field! Traits: [**Low-gravity**], [**Cold Atmosphere**], [**Hallucinatory Terrain**], [**Nocturnal**].

[**Abomination**], [**Alien**], [**Eldritch**] and [**Insect**] types will have their stats increased by one stage, while [**Frost**], [**Darkness**], [**Gravity**], [**Psychic**], [**Unholy**], and [**Eldritch**] effects will have their effects strengthened. [**Moon**] and [**Madness**] effects will be greatly strengthened.

Divine-classes associated with the Moon Man or possessors of the [**Claimed by the Moon Man**] Perk are immune to all negative effects of the Field and gain +5 on all checks.

“It *survived*?” the first squid asked in R’leyhan.

“You owe me twenty-thousand seashells,” the other creature replied to its grumbling companion. “I am Thul-Gathar, chosen slime. Welcome to the Moooooon!”

“Mooooooooon!”

For becoming the first carbon-based being of Outremonde to reach the moon against all odds, you earned a [**Heroic Crest**].

Buzz glanced up, seeing a rainbowy, shiny treasure descend from the sky. The slime observed it, but a quick glance disappointed the young adventurer.

Not swordy enough.

The cosmonaut decided to offer the treasure to Excalidad as a souvenir and then jumped back into the sword rocket’s wreckage to do its patriotic duty.

The mission was not over.

Buzz hopped and smashed the big red button.

When the rift in space opened, Vainqueur could barely contain his joy. The entire crowd had turned speechless, their heart overtaken by religious silence. Finally, after an agonizingly long minute, a white squid and the jelly hopped out of the gate, carrying a strange Crest.

The seafood appraised the minions, waved a tentacle at Manling Victor, and then addressed the audience. “We come in peace, gametes!” the squid declared in its kind’s primitive language. “The will of our father has been done!”

Manling Victor’s zealous minions let out a shout of joy and relief, although they probably didn’t understand the language.

“Suck my tentacle!” the squid added, the cultists shouting as happily as before. The creature let out a sound which Vainqueur took for a sigh. “Love thy flock, they said...”

“Is there air on your Moon?” Manling Victor asked, more excited than Vainqueur had ever seen him. “There isn’t any on mine.”

“Ah, it is true that you gametes need oxygen to live,” the squid said, “We have an atmosphere where your kind can survive. Do not eat the food though, unless you want a third leg.”

“Then me first!” Manling Victor immediately crossed the gate.

“Finally, a new world free of dragons, but full of quests and adventures!” Vainqueur rejoiced, taking steps to cross the portal himself.

Only for his lackey to step out, his skin drained of all colors, his expression torn between panic and shock. “Your Majesty, no!” he pleaded to his master. “Don’t cross it!”

What? Why? “I wish to see the planet moon with my own eyes, minion.”

“Your Majesty, if you... if you see what’s beyond... you will never come back from it!”

Oh? Was the moon made of *gold*? Vainqueur immediately leaped through the portal, overtaken by greed.

He slowly landed on the other side, his claws sinking in a desert of dull gray sand. The sky was dark as the grimmest darkness, Outremonde a blue sun above his head. The air smelled of dreadful, terrible scents. Vainqueur felt an overwhelming sense of dread, his intuition telling him that he had stepped into a place where no dragon should tread.

Why? Why did his dragon survival instinct went into overdrive? What could possibly threaten him? A worm biting his ankle? He looked down to check the ground.

The ground...

Vainqueur’s voice died in his throat, as he recognized the substance his legs had sunk into.

Lead.

Lead everywhere!

Vainqueur frantically glanced around himself, witnessing whole mountains made of the cursed metal surrounding him. The terrible, mad revelation dawned on him, an ancient cosmic truth blasted unto his naive mind.

The Moon...

The Moon was made of lead!

Vitality check failed!

Vainqueur felt tremendous pain in his chest, right at his heart's location. For the first time in his long life, the dragon struggled to breathe. "Min... minion..." He managed to sputter before his limbs gave out.

The emperor collapsed onto the lead, on the verge of death.

Murmurin almost lost its beloved ruler that black day. The good Emperor Vainqueur, who had triumphed over countless foes, was brought low by a stroke; his kind heart broken by the terrible cosmic truth.

Only the good thinking of Grand Vizier Victor, and the efforts of the loyal minions, saved the Emperor from death. They carried the great dragon to the one place that could save his life: his hoard. For hours they showered him with gold and gems until at long last, the great dragon's heart beat again. One minute too late, and Murmurin would have lost its beloved master.

"Minion..." were the good Emperor's first words, upon awakening.

"Yes, Your Majesty?" Handsome Victor asked his beloved master, his voice full of concern.

"The planet Moon cannot sustain dragon life..." the good Emperor lamented. His dream to fulfill quests in space had ended, shattered forever.

For we often look up to the skies, hoping for gold.

But sometimes, there is only lead.

Chapter 67: Season 2 Finale

“Weedgardium Leviosa!”

Wearing a wizard’s hat, Vainqueur unleashed his hoard-shattering magic, to bring back life to a barren land with a swipe of the hand.

And nothing happened.

The dragon let out a frustrated snarl, punching the fields with his fists. The golem farmer laboring them with a plow stopped to complain, “Yer Majesty, you’re damaging Rolo’s cultures!”

“Then tell magic to be less difficult!” Vainqueur replied, throwing away the wizard hat in frustration. It had done nothing to help!

The dragon would have rather flown all the way to the Dark Forest and burn it to the ground, but first, he had to fulfill his bet with Icefang. He needed to farm as much gold as possible before Halloween, so he could put his rival in his place. Afterward, the fairies would learn the pecking order as well.

“Minion, I have learned that by looking to the stars, we lose sight of what matters closer to us,” Vainqueur ranted, more for the pleasure of listening to his own perfect voice than his audience’s sake. “Also I believe the Moon must be destroyed.”

“Rolo agrees,” the golem answered, before adding a tiny bit of [Farmer] wisdom. “Better to labor the earth under one’s feet, than hope for greener pastures in space.”

“Which is why instead of pursuing quests on the Moon, I will turn to other continents instead!” Vainqueur agreed, his dragon spirit ignited. His favorite

minion had told him about exploration fleets to discover new lands, full of treasures, items, and new levels to claim. “If even manlings turn to the sea in search of new lands, then V&V shall lead the way! Also, I believe the Moon must be destroyed.”

Against his better judgment, the dragon could not resist the urge to gaze at the skies, glimpsing the shadowy roundness of the evil planet Moon above him.

The dreadful feeling of invisible hands crawling on his back overwhelmed Vainqueur, as terrible nightmares flared to life in his mind; the very sight of the cursed celestial object brought back flashbacks of his near-death experience. He felt his very heartbeat accelerate. His breathing grew shorter. The shadow of lead put its frosty fingers around his imperial neck to squeeze it.

With an act of extreme willpower, Vainqueur managed to turn his eyes away from the the Moon, but his wandering mind could not escape the horrors he had foreseen there.

Channeling all his pain and sadness and frustration, the dragon poured all his feelings in a final spell, extending his hands in a dramatic fashion. “Weedgardium Leviosa!”

And for the first time since he began practicing the ancient art of wizardry, the earth shook on its own, without the dragon having to beat it first. Fueled by his boundless power, a small seed pierced through the earth, revealing a small beanstalk growing.

“I did it!” Vainqueur gloated, although slightly vexed the beanstalk didn’t turn golden. “I did it! I am a wizard!”

Congratulations! By finally casting an earth-shattering spell after weeks of unrelenting training, you earned a level in [**Geomancer**]!

You earned the [**Geomancy**] Class Perk!+20 SP, +1 INT, +1 LCK!

[**Geomancy**]: Spell, 0 SP. You unleash a powerful magic effect whose effects are based on current Field and Weather.

Not even the disappointing stat gains could destroy Vainqueur's mood.

"Yer Majesty made a bean grow!" Rolo the golem rejoiced at the sight of his emperor's awesomeness.

"I promise you, tinfoil farmer," Vainqueur said. "When I am done, my whole empire will be covered in beans!"

"Apologize?" Croissant glared at Victor, chained in his cell. His sister stood next to the Vizier, a basket full of meat in hands.

"Look, I admit I treated you like crap," Victor said. "Although I only did so because you treated me like crap first."

"So the two cancel out one another?" Chocolatine asked, hopeful. A regime of healing spells had allowed her to regain her cheery disposition.

"No," Victor replied, focusing back on Croissant. "You still cooperated with the enemy, and Vainqueur will eat you if he sees you again. So I'm offering you a way out: you disappear from Murmurin. Forever."

The male werewolf glared at him. "You will dump me on a deserted island or something?"

"We are starting a new colony, and we need settlers." Non-crazy cultists at least. "I can send you there, and although you will be prevented from returning to the mainland. So long as you never show your face again, I will do my best to forget you exist and so will Vainqueur, who anyway will never visit that colony, *ever*. You can start your life anew, and we'll be sure you won't run off to the enemy."

Honestly, while he understood Croissant's motives, his sister was the *only* reason he felt merciful towards him. Had Chocolatine not talked him out of it, he would have sent him to the mines alongside the other Nightblades.

“And I will be able to visit you every weekend!” Chocolatine continued. “I will bring you baskets and sheeps!”

Croissant considered the offer. It was a *very* generous deal considering his treason, so he worried about a trap of some kind. “Where will you send me?”

“The Moon,” Victor answered.

Croissant chuckled, albeit without mirth. “Good one.”

“The Mooooooooooon,” Chocolatine confirmed. “We have a portal to it!”

Poor Croissant remained in denial about his terrible fate. “No seriously, where?”

“You leave tomorrow, Croissant,” Victor replied, leaving the cell alongside Chocolatine. Considering he would spend years alongside Moon Men cultists and their tentacled patrons, the Vizier briefly wondered if killing Croissant would have been a kinder fate.

“Thanks for sparing him, Vic,” Chocolatine told him after he closed the door behind them, before giving him a cute wink. “I know my brother can be frustrating sometimes, but he has a good side too. I’m sure he will learn!”

The Vizier doubted it, although he kept his true thoughts quiet.

“You’re holding up?” Victor asked her, concerned for her health. Especially since she suffered from her wounds trying to defend him.

“Allison patched me good,” the she-wolf replied. “But I wouldn’t mind a thorough examination!”

She approached to kiss him, but the courageous Vizier took a quick step back. “About that...” Victor struggled to find his words without ending up tied in a corner, while she looked at him with puzzled eyes. “You are... rather extreme...”

“You mean I have an overactive imagination?”

“And I... I actually like my bachelor lifestyle. Even if I like you a lot more than I thought I would... I don’t want to settle down with anybody yet... maybe one day, but not *yet*.”

There, he said it.

“Oh, me too!”

“So please, don’t murder any—” Victor froze. “What did you say?”

“I’m young and beautiful!” Chocolatine replied with a smile. “Why would I want to settle with my first crush? What I want is passion, torment, excitement, explosions!”

She began to take her crazy face again, which weirded Victor out. He simply could *not* figure her out. “If you didn’t want to settle for life with me, why were you so *implacable* then?”

“Because you never stopped looking past our friendship!” Chocolatine replied, having naively misinterpreted things. “I was sexually starved because my brother wouldn’t let any boy near me, and when I saw you brimming with authority, I could not resist! There are so many things I want to try, like the whip-knife combo!”

“I would rather avoid that part,” Victor said, mindful of his health and sanity.

“But I get very jealous and clingy if I am frustrated!” Chocolatine complained.

So either he submitted to her insane appetite and she wouldn’t get jealous, or he didn’t, but the obsession cycle would repeat all over again. Victor had parked his car in the forbidden lot, and now he had to live with the fine.

Remembering what Allison had said about the lack of a good solution, Victor realized that love—and lust—always involved a compromise of

some kind. Truth to be told, he had grown to like the she-wolf, even if he didn't want to marry her or anything.

“Okay, so, let me offer a way out,” the Vizier began. “If I hypothetically agree to fulfill your... creative fantasies... on a semi-regular basis, you would agree to not being in a committed relationship for the moment, *without* brutally murdering anyone else and baking them into cakes?”

“I'm sorry, Vic, but I can't. Even for you.”

“I mean, without murdering *potential or perceived romantic rivals*.”

“Oh, you should have said it first!” Chocolatine considered the matter thoughtfully. “So, like above friends, but below boyfriends and girlfriends?”

“Yes.”

She pondered the question for a while, before settling it with one word. “Okay.”

He didn't expect it. “Really?”

“You spared my brother, Vic,” Chocolatine said, sounding a lot more mature, “And you have been so nice to me. If you need some time to figure yourself out, it would be very mean of me not to give you space.”

That... that was an extraordinarily mature response from her. “Thanks,” he said, not knowing what else to add.

“Hey!” A male voice came from behind a cell's closed door. “When am I getting a trial? I've been there forever!”

Victor exchanged a glance with Chocolatine, who seemed as puzzled as him. “Who are you again?” the Vizier asked.

“Wizi.”

“... yes?”

The prisoner let out a very heavy sigh. “The magician, during the raid.”

Ah! That guy! Victor smiled sheepishly, unable to find a nice way to word it. “I had a great deal of trouble to deal with recently, I, uh, I kinda forgot you?”

“Y-you forgot a prisoner of war?” the magician choked. “You monster!”

“Alright, I’ll just send you to the mines for the next thirty years,” Victor decided. While Croissant had cooperated with the enemy, that one tried to abduct and kill defenseless wyrmlings.

After leaving the prisoner to his angry screams and separating from Chocolatine, Victor moved to another chamber in the castle, which Miel the angel had transformed into a temporary office.

“Ah, dear clie—I mean, Mr. Victor!” She was in an awfully good mood today, finishing arranging papers on her desk with a cheery smile. “Good to see you.”

“As well, Miel. With Savoureuse’s testimony, I hope the tensions between your employers and Happyland lessened?” Malfy at least, while struggling to recover, had taken his assassination attempt *very* personally.

“While Heaven and Happyland will never cooperate, we agreed that a third party trying to exploit our divisions complicate our distinguished market rivalry,” Miel replied. “The fomors have also been historical enemies to mortals, so my superiors agreed to offer summoned creatures support. They found this Dragon Watch a very positive direction for your country.”

“I dunno when we will act on Vainqueur’s speech though. We’re a long time away from launching an invasion of Prydain or other fomor lands, and we need to train our army first.”

Vainqueur had also been giddy since he learned about the exploration fleets and the rewards offered for discovering new lands. Fulfilling quests would help their minions at leveling, gather resources needed to build a fleet, and allow Victor to promote the monsters to higher forms.

Besides, even if Vainqueur's amazing speech had convinced the population to adopt a new currency, allowing the government to start regulating inflation, their economy remained very shaky. The Empire was in the process of stabilizing, but not fully solid yet.

“Considering your karma moved into a strong shade of chaotic good, I can only encourage your current decisions.” Miel’s smile froze, as she read the papers. “A karma rise one would call meteoritic, even suspicious. I hope magical enhancements or special Perks were not involved?”

After everything he learned about himself these past months... there was only one answer to give.

“Nah,” Victor lied. “It’s all talent.”

Charisma check successful!

“Perfect!” the angel replied, overcome by his Grand Vizier charm.

“Indeed, because now that my karma score is in the green, I wish to renegotiate more favorable terms,” Victor ruthlessly exploited the situation. “Paying half my SP and months of paperwork doesn’t sound good. I have also another idea which can benefit us both.”

“Considering your massive improvement in your karma score and standing up for my virtue while accused by heathens, this should be easy,” the angel nodded, before smelling an opportunity. “What idea do you have in mind?”

“We need a public service. Free healing, social services, education... but Vainqueur’s refusal to spend any gold makes it impossible the traditional way. So, I’ve been thinking, instead of raising taxes, we could ask citizens to donate a small part of their SP to you, in exchange for angels providing key services.”

“A Special Points levy?” The idea made Miel giddy. “If all citizens of your country even donate ten SP every week...”

“And they would rather offer a renewable resource they all have other than gold. We get the best of all worlds. I’m thinking of a three years trial period if it can be arranged.”

“This is brilliant! My superiors will love it! I may even get promoted to the higher form of [Principality], with my own angel unit!” Miel’s mood was now sky-high. “Maybe we could discuss it around a cup of coffee you offered me a while ago?”

Victor’s mind wandered off, and while he would have once jumped at the occasion... his own reluctant answer surprised him.

“Maybe another time,” he said, unconvinced.

In the heart of the dark forest, amidst black roots and snarling trees, the fairy lords of the Fomors had gathered.

The ancient terrors had answered the call of Mell Odieuse, to witness the ritual from the shadows. Giants and other thralls formed a ring around the Mell clan, to witness this historic day.

Lin stood beside his sister, a festering, burning scar on his chest; his punishment for failure. Odieuse would have done far worse, had he not successfully activated the bottle. Now that she knew that it could trap dragons, the dark witch would produce more and more.

The loss of the Nightblades and the infiltrators she had in the human realms was a harsh blow; and Vainqueur declaring war on them turned him from a secondary problem to a major one, second only to the Kingdom of Gardemagne itself.

However, dear Lucie served her purpose. She brought them the blood and bones of dragons with class levels; the key to the fomor’s greatest victory.

If you cannot beat them, become them, Mell Odieuse thought, as her father presented his newest creation: a shield of dragon bones, coalesced blood, and solid darkness, whose power eclipsed anything the witch had ever seen. The wicked fairy could sense its vile energies saturate the air.

“Behold the greatest of artifacts, the perfect blend of fairywork and dragoncraft,” Mag Mell congratulated himself, festering in his pride. “The *Soulcrest*.”

Mell Odieuse raised an eyebrow in doubt but claimed the item as her own anyway. Her fingers touched its cold surface, letting its power activate. She felt something slip inside her flesh, a strange light fill her icy heart. An artificial, black soul born of dragon blood, taking root in her empty shell of a body. She felt whole, in a way she could not properly describe.

“Did it work?” Mag Mell asked his daughter.

Mayhaps. Mell Odieuse glanced at her mortal thralls in silence, before counting them.

“Eena, meena, mina...” the witch's eyes settled on a cyclop. “Mo...”

“I won?” the giant asked. “What did I win?”

Instead of answering with words, Mell Odieuse cast a spell and impaled him through his heart with a spike. The dead thrall collapsed on the trees, his sweet red blood spraying the roots; its kindred cowered in dread at the sight.

Congratulations!

A strange, blue screen appeared to reward her good work.

Thanks to your deadly, arbitrary approach to employee motivation, you earned a level in the infamous [**Tyrant**] class. You earned the [**Tyranny**] Class Perk!

+30 HP, +10SP, +1 STR, +1 AGI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK!

[**Tyranny**]: If you inflict damage, your victim has a ten percent chance of being afflicted by the [Terror] ailment.

“Ha... ha...” a bellowing sound came out of Mell Odieuse’s throat, beyond her control. It was a strange, new sound, yet a pleasant one, “Hahaha...”

“Sister, you are...” Lin took a step back in dread. “Laughing?”

Mell Odieuse’s cackle transformed into a cruel, cold laugh, chilling her slaves and guests into silence. The newfound power, and the death of the thrall, had filled her with a new feeling; an emotion she had seen the mortals experience, without ever understanding it before.

Joy.

...

She had to feel it again.

End of Volume II

Chapter 68: Beware the Orcs!

Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of His Name, Great Calamity of the Age, Defender of the Hoard, Greatest Gladiator, Genius Wizard Presidente, and August Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains, bravely fought against the invaders with claws and flames.

The great red dragon, his majestic royal mantle swirling to the tune of the wind, shielded the pens with his very body, his crown shining under the brilliant sun. The broken bodies of the attackers laid at his feet, yet more refused to surrender their assault, spurred by greed.

His enemies glared at him with oversized black eyes, as dark as the darkest night; these mockeries of manlings, with willowy limbs and hairless grey skin, had crossed the portal in mass to try and raid his pens. Even looking at all the flesh in their bulbous, oversized head, Vainqueur could not bring himself to eat them. These critters were *evil incarnate*, worse than any fairy!

No matter how many he killed, more kept coming!

“[Psyshock]!” one of the Greys shouted, he and a dozen of his kindred uniting their forces to unleash a barrage of psychic energy at Vainqueur. The dragon shrugged it off, but some of the creatures tried to exploit his distraction to rush at the pens. Vainqueur let out a fearsome roar, opened his mouth, and blasted them apart before they could approach.

Critical hit! You inflicted super-effective damage to [The Greys].

As he kept breathing fireballs, Vainqueur realized that he should have *known*. He should have known it would come to *this*.

Once upon a time, the Moon Man came down from the planet Moon, followed by its eldritch children. In their vileness, the vermin tried to take the dragons' second-most precious possession, causing Vainqueur's kind to remind them of the food chain.

He should have known that with the portal to the moon open, the vengeful descendants of those the dragons pushed back to space would try to renew hostilities. Vainqueur had decided to take the matter in his own claws.

He had to protect *them*.

“Fight for the CLF!” the Greys' chief said, renewing the assault. “Fight for the Cattle Liberation Front! We shall save the blessed mother cows from dragon depredation!”

“You shall not steal the cattle!” Vainqueur snarled. “They want to be eaten by me!”

Protected inside their pens, cows made noises in response, defending their dragon-given right to feed their emperor.

As the Greys threatened to overwhelm him, Vainqueur decided to unleash his trump card: the forbidden spell, which guaranteed victory!
“[Geomancy]!”

Geomancy activated! Field Type: Desert Grassland.

Effect: [**Gale Slash**]!

The very winds bent to the Emperor's will, turning into sharp, swirling blades. Moving as fast as sound itself, they scarred the terrain and shredded the Greys to ribbons, down to the last one.

As Vainqueur surveyed the bloody battlefield, he let out a sigh of relief. The food was safe...

But for how long?

Vainqueur allowed himself a moment of rest, only for a newcomer to deliver more bad news.

“Your Majesty, we need your guidance.” Jules the Necromancer came to him; since Manling Victor, chief among the minions had left for a diplomatic visit with Vampire Charlene, the crimson cowed corpseling assisted Vainqueur in enforcing the imperial peace. “Troublemakers keep disturbing the peace again.”

“Who?” Vainqueur asked. With the constant influx of new minions coming in since the opening of the gate and his declaration of war against the fomors, he could no longer keep track.

“The orcs.”

The dragon grunted in frustration. “What did they do this time?”

“They caused an accident at the marketplace, throwing themselves in front of a dwarf-made automated cart,” Corpseling Jules explained. “The scene threw the merchants in disarray.”

Disturbed merchants meant less gold in Vainqueur’s hoard, and the orcs had caused no less than two dozen incidents since their tribe settled in his lands. “Enough is *enough*.”

“Do we Chocolatine them?” Corpseling Jules suggested.

“No,” Vainqueur decided. “I need more living minions to build my arena, and while I enjoy Sweet Chocolatine’s cakes, orcs are not proper ingredients. They taste of flies and dung.”

No, he would deal with the matter himself. Vainqueur had tamed worse minions.

“Clean this up,” the great dragon ordered Corpseling Jules, before extending his wings and flying away. The necromancer immediately raised the remnants of the Greys into flesh golems.

As he flew towards the marketplace, Vainqueur oversaw his territory with a keen eye. The portal to the planet Moon had grown wider, to allow more madmen to travel to this... this dragon hell; and help others escape it. Out of pure sympathy for the poor creatures trapped there, the dragon had welcomed all refugees from the terrible, lead cursed place.

Most of them, while squidly, tentacled, or many-legged, had proved themselves to be excellent minions, making nests in the formerly inhospitable desert, turning the desert purple by seeding it with new plants, and even built a strangely angled district called Little R'Lyeh.

Thanks to Vainqueur's own [Geomancer] prowesses and these newcomers, the desert was being pushed back farther and farther with each day. New mines opened every day, bringing silver and gems to his hoard to complement his gold. And as he had ordered, his minions were steadily building a great arena for the Summer Solstice, where the crowds would shower the dragon with gold.

Life was good, even without quests.

Yet Vainqueur's heart yearned for more action. With four months away from Halloween, the dragon needed to accumulate enough gold to win his bet with his rival Icefang, and show him his place; and his minions steadily trained to fight the cursed fairies who had harassed the Emperor since his awakening. The more time passed, the more impatient he grew.

Vainqueur quickly reached the marketplace, quickly finding the place of the incident.

The iron, powerstone-powered cart laid on the side in the middle of an alley, Agarthan dwarves trying to repair it. A gathering of orcs surrounded it with impatience, as if eager to throw themselves at it again; the men did at least, while their females scolded them. Merchants and customers glared at them in annoyance and sighed in relief to see Vainqueur's shadow.

Green-skinned like vegetables, the worst kind of food, orcs looked similar to manlings; except bigger, hairier, meaner, and with tusks. Unlike goblins, they garbed themselves in strange clothes, these 'shirts,' 'sweaters,' and

‘pants,’ most of them so old and dirty Vainqueur could smell them from a mile away. The female, more tribal, preferred to wear less clothes and more tattoos.

Ever since they arrived on a ship from the western continent, they had only caused trouble. Unlike the dutiful kobolds, they didn’t work, spending all their time drinking or playing at Tasty Malfy’s casino.

Time to teach them the virtue of hard work, Vainqueur thought, as he landed in front of the crowd, intimidating them.

“Yer Majesty!” one of the orcs said, his knee wounded. The dragon guessed this was the one responsible for the incident.

“Why?” Vainqueur demanded answers. “Why did you throw yourself at a fellow minion’s cart?”

“To complete the Isekai Reincarnation rite!” the orc replied. “And I would have gotten away with it were it not for this dwarf veering off at the last second!”

“Ise... kai?” Vainqueur asked, the word sounding vaguely familiar.

“We believe in the one true religion: the Esoteric Order of the New World,” the orc explained. “Founded by our Claimed prophet Orknoob, who discovered the path to the mythical world of Earth. A world where every food is fast, and all women schoolgirls.”

Vainqueur remembered where he had heard of that strange cult. Back in that peasant village of Haudemer. One of the believers had harassed Manling Victor, who called this faith a scam. “Is it not a false religion?” the dragon pondered.

“Of course not!” the wounded knee orc replied.

“We have figured out the criteria needed to be reincarnated to another world,” another said. “First, be a student!”

One of their kindred immediately began to complete their demonstration, having learned the knowledge by heart. “Second, be unemployed!”

“Third, be amazing at games!”

“Fourth, be a virgin, or build a harem! There’s no middle ground!”

“And finally, die by being hit by a car-cart!”

“It’s not faith,” the first orc said. “It’s *science*. We’re still unsure if guys and girls can both reincarnate to the mythical island of Japan, however. Not enough studies and the prophet’s scriptures are unclear.”

“Japan?” a nearby duergar merchant asked his customer, an alien creature from the planet Moon.

“I heard the local manlings do offensive things to squids they capture, as part of their education,” the moon beast shuddered. “Never send your squidspawn there, carbon creature.”

Vainqueur, who had patiently listened, squinted at these creatures. “How did your species avoid extinction *so far*?”

“We orcs are born winners, with great health and vitality!” the wounded orc replied proudly.

“We shall reach the world of Earth!” the orc men boasted as one. This? *This* was why the other dragons couldn’t learn about the shameful secret of mortality. Vainqueur shuddered at the thought of weak-willed kindred listening to these idiots.

“Certainly not!” a busty orc matron scolded her kindred. “Get a job and put meat on the table!”

“See?” the accused replied. “That is why women don’t go to Japan! You do not believe in the true religion!”

“I knew I should have found a strong partner instead of following a deluded fool!” the matron complained.

Vainqueur strongly considered sending away these idiots to Sweet Chocolatine, bitter taste or not, before finding in his heart the patience to teach these creatures the proper way.

“Orcs, you are now my minions,” the dragon reminded them. “Your men will stop throwing yourself at my lackeys’ carts and pay me back for letting you live by building my arena. You will breed with smarter minions, like Manling Victor, so my new generation of lackeys does not inherit your stupidity. Or else you will be food.”

“Mmm...” The wounded-knee orc looked up at Vainqueur, suddenly realizing how small he was compared to his Emperor. “This is a very authoritative statement.”

“But a true orc only accepts one authority,” a male orc replied, searching in his pocket and bringing out a deck of cards. “That of the duel!”

“You challenge me to a card game?” Vainqueur asked. While he would never admit it out loud, the idea made him curious.

“A *human children’s card game!*” the orc corrected. “If you win, I shall do as you say, but if I do... then you shall throw the cart yourself!”

Vainqueur scoffed. “How laughable that you would believe a dragon capable of losing! Very well, I will teach you a lesson and destroy you at your own game.”

“DUEL!” The male orcs chanted, much to their women’s exasperation, one of them tossing a card deck at Vainqueur’s feet.

Vainqueur raised a claw, prepared to draw...

Only for him to struggle to grab the tiny deck with his great claws.

“Minion!” Vainqueur called, before remembering his trusty sidekick had left for the time being. He turned to the orc matron. “You, you are now my official card holder! Draw my cards with your small hands!”

The woman nodded and drew five cards, seemingly eager to assist the dragon in putting this overmighty minion in his place.

[**King of Games**] activated.

“Ore-sama no turn,” his orc ‘adversary’ declared upon drawing a card in his deck, bringing his total hand to six. “I summon Beast King—”

“I WIN!” Vainqueur cut him off, upon seeing his hand.

“Not yet!” his arrogant foe replied. “My perfect strategy has not even begun!”

“That is what the cards say,” Vainqueur pointed out, the matron revealing his hand to his enemy, “IWIN!” Each of the five cards had one part of the message printed on them.

As his foe watched the hand, so did the colors of his face leave. “The five automatic-win card combo...”

“On a first draw?” One of his kindred froze, his fellows gasping in shock. “The chances are one in millions!”

“That’s beginner’s luck,” the one with the wounded knee said, taking over for his fallen friend, “Give him another deck! I shall be his next opponent!”

“I win again!” Vainqueur boasted, the tenth orc to rise and challenge him. “I love this game! I always win!”

By now, many more citizens had gathered to watch their emperor destroy his opposition, whistling to encourage their master. The great dragon had filled his side of the field with powerful minions, which he had fused, revived, enhanced, ritual tributed, Z-powered, and cross-summoned into a formidable army.

So many ways to crush his puny rivals!

“This is cheating!” one of the orcs accused Vainqueur. “You cheat!”

Vainqueur saw red, hitting the ground with his hand and making houses shake. “You dare accuse a fair and noble dragon of cheating?” The crowd booed the orcs in support.

“He is using his Perks, but so do you!” one of the orc women pointed out, relishing in the humiliation of their arrogant mates. “Step up your game instead of whining like goblins!”

“If you did not want to lose, you should have been born dragons!” Vainqueur lambasted these cowards.

“We need to change the game!” the eleventh challenger said. “I challenge you to Blackjack!”

“Bring it, minions!”

“Royal Flush House!” Vainqueur gloated, as his assistant revealed another winning hand. The dragon grabbed the pile of money,

Not only did he show these minions their place, he had grown even richer by winning all of their money!

“He keeps topdecking instant win cards.” One of the orc gambler’s stares wandered off in the distance, his spirit crushed by Vainqueur’s invincibility. “*How?* How does he keep topdecking the best cards? On his first draws!”

“That dragon is *grossly overpowered!*” another of his kindred complained, having himself been thoroughly bested at Blackjack before.

“As it should be!” Vainqueur stated the absolute truth. His winning streak had pumped him for more. “Bring me more money!”

“You have... you have defeated the entire tribe...” the wounded knee orc said. “We... we all lost...”

“Is this Victor meaty enough?” one of the orc matrons asked. “Does he have tusks?”

“No, but he has dragon wings, which makes him superior to all non-dragon lifeforms,” Vainqueur said. “Who else would challenge me next? I thirst for the taste of victory!”

“You are the strongest player I have seen since...” the orc gasped, before uttering cursed words. “Since that lich Furibon...”

Vainqueur’s good mood instantly soured. The orc cowered, as the dragon’s burning eyes set on him. “Did you say *Furibon*?”

“D-Does Yer Majesty knows him?”

“Where?!” Vainqueur roared, the very ground shaking before his wrath. “Where is he? What is he plotting?”

The orc fell on his ass, scrambling to flee his rightful emperor, but prevented from doing so by the very cart he tried to die too. “To El Dorado!”

“Eldorawhat?”

“The lost city of gold, beyond the Thaoten Empire! I heard he led an expedition there!”

The very picture of dragon heaven appeared in Vainqueur’s mind.

A glorious city, where all was made of the purest, shining gold. Houses shining brighter than the sun; rivers of molten platinum, gardens of gems, growing from the earth; a mountain of coins, waiting for a dragon to claim them.

And then...

All of it turning to lead. A dream turning to nightmare, as Furibon’s laugh echoed in dark triumph.

The fairies would wait.

Vainqueur had to save paradise first.

Chapter 69: Criminal Games

Noblecoeur hadn't changed at all.

One of Gardemagne's greatest cities, located near the eastern mountains and the fallen Harmonian Republic, Noblecoeur had been spared from the horrors of the Century War, making it a refugee center. Those fleeing the advance of the vicious fomors, from beastkin to northern elves, established themselves there, built new districts, brought their culture. To an outsider, Noblecoeur looked like a motley of various architectures cobbled together, fortified beastkin camps bordering elegant manors; yet somehow, the final result looked harmonious.

Victor Dalton, Grand Vizier of Murmurin, greatest of Vainqueur's minions, hadn't visited the Nightblades' Headquarters in years, yet he felt some kind of kinship to this place. This old manor, whose basement led to tunnels sprawling through the city, had a classy charm which he couldn't fully describe.

When the god Dice reincarnated him, in the wartorn countryside of Gardemagne, only thieves took him in; and at the cost of joining them. They taught him about classes, turned him into an [Outlaw], and then introducing them to their larger, more nefarious parent organization; the Nightblade crime syndicate. While mostly focused on assassination, the group had fingers in every illegal pie; and through corruption, blackmail, and threats, they made the very city of Noblecoeur their fortress.

Upon realizing that staying with the organization meant falling in further with a very bad crowd, the Claimed backed out and reconverted into an adventurer. Lucie Lavere hadn't taken over the syndicate back then, or at least not that Victor knew. The vampire had transformed the politically neutral cartel into weapons of the fomors, first against Gardemagne, then

against Murmurin itself. Lavere and most of her followers died in the struggle, leaving the winners to clean the mess she left behind.

To think he would end up, by a twist of fate, take over the organization he left.

Or rather, that was what he *thought* would happen.

“So let me get this straight,” the Vizier began. “You decided to create a *union*?”

Sitting around a large table, he and his assistant, the vampire Charlene, faced a dozen cowled assassins armed to the teeth; most of them were ratkin, rat and human hybrids, humans, or vampires. Only one very young lizardkin, with brownish scales and claws sharper than razors, stood out from the rest. With the night outside and the candles providing little light, the meeting resembled a shadowy cult’s gathering. Which it was.

“Due to the fall of the previous administration, and the huge amount of turnover that followed,” a cowled woman said, a crossbow within arm’s reach. “We decided to organize in order to preserve our livelihoods against a lay-off.”

“By turnover, you mean the fact our army killed all the assassins you sent after us?” Victor asked for an explanation.

“We have renounced the previous administration,” the assassin replied with a tone that reminded the chief of staff of PR speakers. “We turned our coat in the right direction. However, to defend ourselves, and to promote gender equality, we have created a Mixed Gender Commission to represent our professions. We will not disband until our demands are met.”

Now that she said it, Victor noted that they had an equal amount of women and men holding knives at him. Not that they had the levels to threaten him, since he wore full armor, carried a deadly scythe and bazooka, and was around twenty levels higher than the second-strongest person in the room.

“Which are?”

“We want higher wages, security of employment, a retirement plan instead of a ‘*river retirement*’ plan, and a severance package instead of the current ‘*body severance*’ package.”

“Security of employment,” Victor repeated. “You’re *criminals*. You’re by definition outside the law’s protection.”

“Which doesn’t preclude a charter. Theft is a very dangerous activity and we want shortened working days, and a better pension for old assassins who cannot kill as well in their old age as they did in their youth. If our demands are not met, we are ready to go on a nationwide strike.”

A strike? “Like what, you won’t kill people anymore?”

“Yes!” the representative replied, leaving Victor speechless. “We will no longer kill nor steal, nor run prostitution rings or distribute drugs to minors until we have improved the criminal class’ working conditions!”

...

“How did Laverre run things before me?” Victor asked with a dry tone.

“She singled out the ‘stupidest’ of us, and then murdered them to set an example,” a ratkin replied.

I am starting to understand why, the Vizier thought.

Charlene must have read his mind. “To be fair, you and Your Majesty killed, jailed, or sent to the Moon all the competent people during Laverre’s attack,” she said. “Leaving only... *them*.”

“To the Moon?” one of the assassins whistled. “Is that a new slang of execution? I didn’t know it!”

“No, the correct one is ‘Chocolatined,’” Charlene corrected.

“Mmmm... the first sounds better.”

Victor turned to Charlene, who approached her ear to listen. “Are they serious?” he muttered, his assistant nodding. “What do you suggest?”

“A good purge, to start with.” Her newfound vampirism had turned the once plump, slightly overweight blonde secretary and Victor’s voice of reason into a thin, unnaturally pale model; but also clearly made her more ruthless. “Not the bloody kind, although that would have been my first option had Deathjester not asked for mercy, but we can easily replace them with obedient minions.”

“I’m not sending minions to replace criminals abroad,” Victor replied. The only reason he even agreed to take over that organization was to prevent the fomors from making use of them. Worst case scenario, he would disband them rather than waste resources.

“We are ready to last months,” the main speaker threatened.

“Don’t listen to them, sir,” the young lizardkin interrupted him. He had remained apart from the others, refusing to form a united front with his fellow. “They’re just lazy and never did anything worthwhile. *I* can still work!”

“Why, you really need blood money?” Victor asked.

“Oh, no, I just love killing,” he replied with cheerfulness, the other assassins booing him for his eagerness to impress the authority. “I was doing it for free before Aunt Savoureuse told me I could make it a career.”

The Vizier sank in his chair, finding the teen’s cheeky smile far more disturbing than the army of thugs asking for higher wages. “You’re... Potiron, right?” Victor asked, remembering Savoureuse mentioning her nephew a few months ago.

The young lizardkin looked up at Victor with adorable eyes, in stark contrast with his next words. “Your boss is an absolute dictator, right? Do you have political rivals to silence? Or, or, maybe newspapers who need a ‘friendly visit’? Or do you want to reduce poverty by eradicating the

homeless? I'm trying to expand my CV, so as long as it's not people I know, I'm looking forward to *any* opportunity to improve!"

Was this hellion for real? He sounded *very* serious. "We, uh, we kinda enjoy a huge level of popularity in our country," Victor said, blaming Vainqueur's absurd charisma. "Our citizens love us."

"If not an enemy of the state, maybe hookers?" Potiron asked. "I don't have professional experience in that field, but I learn quickly! If you need a demonstration—"

"I will think about it!" Victor said hurriedly before the psycho went through with it. "As for the rest of you..."

"We will not budge before intimidating tactics," the speaker warned. "We are ready to die for better rights!"

"Then you will certainly enjoy our official Minion Healthcare," Victor replied. "You get the security of employment, higher wages, and even magical assistance."

"As official minions of Murmurin, you are entitled to a tenth of the profits you make, which is more than your old rate," Charlene said. "You are guaranteed a post-mortem pension either as an undead or another vertical plane of your choice, alongside universal free healthcare, education, mook promotions..."

Victor watched the assassins exchange glances, as his assistant detailed the impressive list of benefits they would receive by signing with the empire; a stark contrast with the harsher system of Gardemagne. All the work these past months had paid off.

While Potiron clapped, the other assassins exchanged between each other, until the main speak came forward. "You are not like we expected."

"You bet," Victor said.

"Well then, perhaps we can discuss other—"

“The Emperor is a dragon, and he has been known to eat entitled minions and enemies alike. He listens *only* to me.” Victor joined his fingers in a calculating pose, deciding not to spare them the rod. “I am also very, *very* friendly with the highest authorities in Hell, now rebranded as Happyland, and I capture souls in my scythe to power myself up.”

Charisma check successful! You reminded the peons of the food chain!

“Now, knowing this, do you have other, *other* requests?”

“... no sir,” an assassin replied for the rest of the strikers.

“Excellent,” Victor said, “Charlene will take over until your organization has been reorganized. You are now a branch of the Murmurin Empire, and everything you do *will* benefit it in some way. Am I clear?”

“Yes, sir!” Potiron spoke up, imitated by the others.

“Charlene will take care of managing the transition,” Victor said. “She will be my main representative, and you will obey her as you would obey me. With all modesty, I am your god’s prophet, and she is my apostle. Don’t make her go Old Testament on you.”

“Old Testament?” the lead assassin repeated. “Is that new slang?”

Victor sighed in despair, before sending the assassins away. Only Potiron remained behind. “Sir—”

“You will get an internship in Murmurin,” the Vizier replied if only to keep that hellion under watch. “With your aunt.”

“Cool! Practical experience!”

The Vizier sighed, finally alone with Charlene. “So, how do you like your promotion?” Victor asked his assistant.

“I could get used to it,” Charlene replied. “This is definitely a step up in my professional career.”

To think that they started on the wrong foot... it felt like years since Victor had met Vainqueur.

“They possess a sizeable stockpile of stolen Crests, which we can redistribute to our minions,” Charlene continued her report. Alongside Victor’s own [Mook Promotion] Perk, this would help tremendously in building up an army to destroy the fomors. “You also inherited Lavere’s cat.”

Victor nodded, then froze upon realizing what she just said. “A cat?”

Five minutes later, Charlene all but dumped a fluffy white cat in front of him. Victor glanced at the animal, who stared back with curious eyes.

“What is this, a manling with wings?” the cat spoke with a shrill voice. “Are you my new pet?”

Victor looked at Charlene, who clearly hadn’t understood. The truth quickly dawned upon him.

He could understand any *monster*.

“I am Felix IV von Meow, Emperor of the World, King of Cats, and Despoiler of Milk. But you may call me Your Catness.” The cat put himself on his back, his belly exposed. “Now you will pet me, manling. You will scratch me behind the ears and on my soft tummy. But no more than five minutes each, or I will punish you with my claws.”

“Yeah, I don’t have time for this—”

“I am a cat,” the beast brazenly interrupted him. “You are now my minion.”

Victor had a frightening impression of déjà vu. “No,” he said, already having too much with one colorful megalomaniac on his plate. “Just no.”

“Look at me. Look at me, manling!” The white cat glared at him with imperious eyes. “I am the best thing to ever happen to you! Your *god* exists, and he has *whiskers*!”

“Pfft, not impressed,” Victor replied, only for the cursed animal to leap on his legs when he least expected it.

“You should clean yourself, you smell like a dog-loving peasant! But your legs are warm, so I will grace them with my sleep.” And like that, the cat curled on his legs and fell asleep, as if he *owned* Victor’s lap.

Not amused, the Vizier grabbed him by the collar, rose up, and opened a window with his free hand. “I’m already taken.”

“Wait, wait, minion, what are you—” Victor threw the cat outside, and then closed the windows.

“You threw a cat away,” Charlene looked at him with disapproving eyes. “And you wonder why your karma is in the negatives?”

Victor shrugged as he sat back in his chair. The more he grew, the less he cared.

Last warning: Will you merge your [**Grand Vizier**] and [**Assassin**] classes into the [**Moriarty**] class?

If you refuse, you will keep leveling in the two classes separately.

Ah, true. He had almost forgotten about that part. Having disdained [**Assassin**] since he first got levels in it, Victor immediately sacrificed them.

Choice registered! Your [**Assassin**] and [**Grand Vizier**] levels have been transformed into [**Moriarty**] levels. [**Assassin**] and [**Grand Vizier**] are no longer accessible.

[**Is-No-Good**] replaced with [**Scarlet Study**]: You can assign a number of ‘Crime Tokens’ equal to your number of [**Moriarty**] levels to willing accomplices; by mentally focusing, you can telepathically contact one of them. Your ally must be on the same plane as you to be contacted, although this does not remove the token.

[**Blade Stinger**] replaced with [**Final Problem**]: Once every twenty-four hours, if your HP would be reduced to zero, you survive with one HP

instead. You can convince your killers that you are truly dead on a successful Skill check; this is an **[illusion]** effect.

[Forktongued] replaced by **[Diabolical Mastermind]**: Whenever you face a check in a criminal, commonly illegal, or morally reprehensible situation, you gain a bonus equal to half your Intelligence stat.

Now officially an evil mastermind, Victor turned to the last item on his agenda.

Deathjester's letter of admittance to Scholomance.

Besides what Kia had told him, Victor knew very little about this establishment. His predecessor, Lucie Lavere, had trained there and received a soul-stealing grimoire for her grim work. She may have become a vampire there, in fact.

Not that he thought he should attend, but curiosity overwhelmed him. He might as well learn about the place, in case he and Vainqueur ever needed to shut it down.

The second he opened the letter, the paper inside hopped out of its container and on the table, and a cheerful, impish voice came out of it.

“Have you ever wanted to take levels in ‘evil’ classes, without being oppressed by self-righteous adventurers?” the voice asked, but didn't give Victor time to respond, “Have you ever dreamed of delving into forbidden knowledge without being judged? To rub shoulders with fellow social climbers who *understand* your ambitions? Or perhaps you have followed a seminar on dictatorship, and you want to learn more about peasant oppression? Then seek no more!”

The letter's ink shifted into the shape of a foreboding castle, in the middle of a lake.

“The University of Scholomance is the answer! Created by the Dread Three, Scholomance is *the* premiere school for aspiring overlords, necromancers, and criminal masterminds over level forty! Our alumni

include celebrities such as the Masked Mage, Genociboy, or the Bloody Duchess! Become the best of the best in a mere seven years' time—”

“Seven *years*?” Victor interrupted the presentation. “I can’t be absent for seven years!”

“Yes, I’m afraid the empire will crumble in less than one without you,” Charlene lamented.

“At Scholomance, time works differently, thanks to one of our generous sponsors, Ur-Pharaoh Akhenapep!” the letter continued, Victor noticing the cat furiously scratching at the window, “One day outside, is one year inside. A whole curriculum in one week! Further your expertise without threatening your existing operations!”

Realizing he had asked the question as if he already considered attending, the Vizier shut up and let the letter finish.

“Only ten students will be allowed to enter the school, where they will remain until graduation! The valedictorian will gain access to the elite [Weathermaker] spellcaster class, but the dunce will remain in the school, to serve as the next headmaster! Do you have what it takes to become the best of the darkest?”

“[Weathermaker]?” Victor frowned, curious. “Tell me more about—”

“MINION! MINION!”

Victor felt the pull of Vainqueur’s perk teleport him across the world, and onto Murmurin’s marketplace.

“Minion, we have to save El Dorado!” Vainqueur shouted at Victor with crazed eyes. The vizier fell on his tail and crawled back in surprise, only to be stopped by a cart, “We must!”

“W-what’s happening?” Victor panicked, his dragon friend overshadowing him with a terrified expression on his face, “The fomors? Lavere rose up? Akhenapep?”

“We must save El Dorado from Furibon!” the dragon kept spouting paranoid nonsense. “The Moon, it was him! He is behind everything! *Everything!*”

Chapter 70: Heart to Heart

“El Dorado must be *conquered*!”

So Emperor Vainqueur declared atop his golden hoard, facing the greatest of his minions. From his chief of staff to Necromancer Jules, Tasty Allison, and Marbré the Dwarf. All speechless before the dragon’s bold declaration.

“For its own protection,” Vainqueur added, as the gold would only be safe when added to his own hoard. “Else the wicked Furibon will turn it to lead, as he tried to murder my hoard and poisoned the Moon.”

“Your Majesty,” Minion Victor spoke up. “That Furibon may be looking for El Dorado—whose very existence itself is only based on rumors and *orc-only* testimonies—does not mean he intends to transform it to lead. Nor do we have any proof that he transformed the Moon to lead.”

“But do you have proof that the evil Furibon did *not* turn the planet Moon to lead?” Vainqueur asked the key question.

Manling Victor exchanged glances with the other members of the council, who had no answer to this.

“See?” Vainqueur said, his theory unanimously confirmed. “It all adds up. In the absence of proof of the lich’s innocence, we must assume his culpability in all things.”

“But what does Your Majesty suggest?” Friend Victor asked, showing a lack of vision which annoyed his master. Did he not understand that the fate of gold rested on Vainqueur’s *shoulders*? “El Dorado, if it exists, is an ocean and continent away! Even Your Majesty will struggle to fly there!”

“We have the Piggybank,” Vainqueur replied.

“Indeed!” Marbré the Dwarf promoted his invention. “Our ship could travel all around the world, without exploding more than thrice.”

“That’s reassuring,” Friend Victor said with sarcasm. Now Vainqueur had learned that he used this strange ritual to deal with stress. Surely the prospect of facing the lich which he failed to keep sealed unsettled him. “Even if we survive the trip, find the city, and return, this will take us weeks, if not months!”

“We will not stop at El Dorado,” Vainqueur declared, possessed by a visionary spirit. “This dragon-created world is vast and full of lands to explore. Of dungeons overflowing with wealth! Of gems and shinies which will help me triumph over Icefang! We will continue west, and west, until we have filled the Piggybank with treasures and sailed past the edge of Outremonde!”

“Your Majesty wants to do a *world tour*?” Manling Victor choked.

“Vic, I read a book about someone traveling across the world in ninety days,” Allison said, “without a magical plane such as yours. It can be done.”

“The perfect timing to be back on Halloween, and humiliate Icefang!” Vainqueur nodded happily.

“Ninety days is three months!” Manling Victor complained. “Three months where Murmurin would remain without your protection!”

“With my [Golden Road] Perk, I can open a gate to my hoard at any time,” Vainqueur pointed out. “More of my minions can cross this portal and conquer lands in the name of the V&V Empire!”

“That’s...” Friend Victor paused, trapped in his thoughts. “Wait, if we combine this with my [Scarlet Study] Perk... we can establish a direct line of communication with Murmurin and return if there is an emergency...”

“We can create more Warp Projectors to link areas together,” Marbré pointed out. “Outposts of the revolution, bound together by the great chain of industry!”

Vainqueur could almost hear the debate going on inside his prized lackey's head. "I admit, it's *theoretically* possible," Manling Victor said. "But is it *wise*?"

"Your Majesty declared war on the fomors," Jules the Necromancer pointed out. "We have no guarantee that they will not strike first. If anything, your absence, even if temporary, may encourage them."

"We must look forward!" Vainqueur said. "Have I not become the most powerful adventurer in the world by pushing my limits? To triumph over the fairies and their wicked pawns, my minions must grow stronger! They must earn levels by accumulating glory and riches in my name! Under my guidance, the Empire has known peace; but to prepare for war, my servants must test their mettle against monsters, dungeons, and the unknown!"

[El Presidente] activated! Charisma check successful!

And who knew? These distant lands may prove a fertile ground for recruiting new, strong minions. Lackeys who would cheer him up when he invaded Prydain, to burn the fairies' forests to ashes.

Manling Victor turned to the other minions, as if expecting support; instead, their master's words had convinced them. "It is true opportunities to gain levels the traditional way are getting scarcer," Allison admitted.

"It took a raid in the sixty levels range to defeat King Balaur, and millions of soldiers to push back his army to the sea," said Jules. "While probably weaker, we have no hope of defeating Mell Odieuse on her own territory with our current forces, even if we are to raise the dead again and again. We could also use resources to develop Murmurin itself and sustain the population for the long-term."

"Our weapons need testing, testing, *testing*," Marbré added. "In live conditions."

Realizing he was hopelessly outvoted, his chief of staff finally returned to the fold. "Can we at least wait and prepare for the trip?" Manling Victor pleaded. "Just the *logistics* involved for this campaign to work..."

True, Vainqueur still had an arena to inaugurate, and a minion championship to hold. “We will launch the Piggybank after the Summer Solstice,” the dragon declared. “Manling Victor, as my official campaign manager and military advisor, I trust you implicitly with planning, preparing, and perfecting the campaign until then.”

“Perfect!” Marbré seemed especially enthusiastic about the plan. “We can finally bring the light of Averagism to populations untouched by Feudali—”

“Until then, you are dismissed,” Vainqueur spoke before the dwarf could go on a tiresome tirade. “Grand Vizier Victor, stay at my side. We must discuss a private, important matter.”

The minions left the vault, leaving the Emperor with his most trusted advisor. “Yes?” his friend asked.

“Have you bred yet?” Vainqueur asked. He had done everything in his power to help his minion tie the knot with Sweet Chocolatine, and never checked if it worked.

“Chocolatine and I are... taking a break.”

What? After all the time Vainqueur spent setting them up! “Why is that minion? What could be more important than ensuring a new generation of lackeys can fill my hoard?”

“I... I don’t know. I don’t know if I want to settle or stay free. I don’t know what I want.”

“Minion, you shall not start breeding wars with your inability to settle on a proper partner,” Vainqueur said. “To avoid jealousy among other minions, you shall service *everyone*.”

That way, Vainqueur would progress faster in the [Dungeon Breeder] class: he would get new minions, and get better at setting them up. Win-win!

His minion didn’t see it this way though. “If Your Majesty prostitutes me to the entire minion army, I will find a way to make you pay.”

“Minion, I am concerned for your future,” Vainqueur replied. “While I will make you my god of minions, so you may serve me forever, what legacy will you leave behind? None of my current minions are up to your standard. If my hoard is to grow, your line must go on.”

In spite of his attempt to cheer him up, his chief minion seemed... depressed. “Your Majesty, I owe you my life.”

“Yes, indeed, and I will never stop reminding you of it.”

“So I will do whatever you ask of me, and I always put your own good first,” Friend Victor reminded his master of his oath of minionship. “But I haven’t figured out what’s my own good. I’m burning out.”

“Minion, your dragon blood makes you immune to puny flames; you cannot burn. This is all in your head.”

“Yes... exactly. It’s all in my head.”

Vainqueur observed his friend, his majestic tail and wings attached to his ape-like body. The answer to his ‘illness’ appeared clearly.

“Minion, you have been blessed with a part of my glory, growing wings, and a tail,” so spoke the Emperor. “Yet you remain half-man. You are in-between. Your mind is torn like your body, unable to settle on one side or the other. So long as you cannot decide whether you remain a manling or fully discard this part of you for the majesty of dragonhood, neither will you decide firmly on anything!”

His manling looked up at his beloved master with his tiny eyes.

“Why have you fallen silent, minion?”

“It never occurred to me that Your Majesty had grown much wiser with time.”

“Minion, I have always been the wisest, smartest of all. You simply never listened before.”

“I doubt that,” Manling Victor replied, unaware of his own inability to recognize the absolute truth of the dragon way of life. “What is Your Majesty’s current level?”

“Fifty-four!” Vainqueur boasted. “Halfway to divinity!” He could already taste the sound of that devilish goddess giving him back his gold for her overpriced services.

“And I am fifty,” Manling Victor said, who hadn’t slacked off either, “We have one [Heroic Crest] for Your Majesty, so that you may get past the sixty level barrier.”

“Certainly this El Dorado must have a second one for you,” Vainqueur pointed out. A city of gold could only have the best treasures within its walls.

“I may have an opportunity to progress quickly,” Manling Victor said. “But I will remain unavailable for at least one week.”

“Aw, but you may miss the Minion Tournament!” Vainqueur said.

“Wouldn’t my very presence disrupt it?” his chief of staff replied. “I am twenty levels above almost everyone. It’s not really fair... and I would have time to think.”

“Minion, are you asking me for a *vacation*?” Vainqueur choked.

“If I may not be so bold...” Manling Victor trailed. “Yes. Yes, I need one.”

A minion asking for a vacation? Impossible! That was the road to strikes, rebellion, entitlement! Even for a chief of staff, no dragon had been asked time-off; rewarding a minion’s work with free days, yes, but being asked for it?

And yet, after so many months of loyal, dutiful hard work, that Manling Victor would ask such a thing raised all kinds of alarms. Vainqueur looked back into his past, when he led tribes of goblins, only to find them gone when he woke up from hibernation. He had never given them respite.

Did... did minions...

Did minions have needs *unrelated* to serving *him*?

Beyond Vainqueur's own happiness?

Could his goblins have defected because he never considered their own baser needs?

Intelligence check successful! You have learned self-reflection!

Vainqueur could not let his best minion feel like a goblin.

"Minion, plan our expedition first," the dragon ordered. "Afterward, while it pains me that you will not be able to participate in our first official gladiatorial tournament, I grant you a one week vacation. For the good of the hoard... and yours."

Manling Victor seemed not to believe his words, before bowing. "Thank you, Your Majesty."

"Now go, and rest."

Congratulations. By learning compassion for a lesser being, and helping your minion servant with his mental health problems, you have earned a level in [**Dungeon Breeder**].

+ 10 SP, + 1 SKI, +1 INT.

Somehow, watching Manling Victor be happier made Vainqueur feel fuzzier inside.

Was he starting to get sick too?

Chapter 71: Vizier Holidays

“... and here is the contract between V&V and Heaven to authorize the ‘SP covenant.’” Victor handed the council a pile of documents, “It includes the construction of a new hospital, schools, and angelic public teletransports.”

Since his mansion hadn’t been rebuilt since the Nightblades burned it to the ground, the Vizier had been forced to run his meetings in Vainqueur’s castle. In the dimly lit hall, the council looked like some criminal conspiracy gathering; even with an angel in their midst.

As promised, the Vizier had finished preparing the El Dorado trip before taking his ‘vacation’. Sort of. Victor still wondered whether they should make a stop in Atlantis or the pirate islands near the New World’s coast, or maybe both if they had the time. But he had worked out most of the details, gathered the necessary supplies, and reassured Vainqueur.

To make sure the empire ran itself in his absence, Victor had granted power to an assembly of Murmurin’s most powerful and responsible denizens: Allison, Charlene, Jules, Malfy, and Miel. Marbré had been given an honorary observator seat, but would supervise improvements of their flying ship.

Victor still wondered if inviting Malfy and Miel was the right call. At this point, even if they weren’t truly Vainqueur’s minions, they had embedded themselves so deeply in Murmurin’s infrastructures that the nascent nation wouldn’t work without them. However, considering their ideological divide, the vizier hoped Jules and the others would smooth their tensions.

He would have also liked to add Red Ranger to this assembly, but the former kobold was occupied with bodyguarding Vainqueur’s niece Jolie, in the south.

“Finally, these years of toiling to redeem wicked souls will pay off,” Miel said, hugging the documents against her chest. “I can sense my incoming promotion.”

Murmurin had a public service. Victor never thought he would live to see the day.

The rest of the ‘imperial council’ seemed divided on the subject though. “In my case, I only sense the shoddy service,” Malfy the fiend said. After his near-death experience at the hands of the Nightblades, he had recovered in time for the new ‘Heaven Deal.’ “You bureaucrats know nothing of customer experience!”

“You are jealous that we won this public procurement contract,” Miel taunted him, Malfy chittering in response.

“Allison, remember to feed Junior and my slimes in my absence,” Victor asked his friend. “My excalitrap is not a picky eater, but it barks threateningly at people if hungry.”

“Sure,” the dryad said with a smile. “I saw that it decided to participate in the minion tournament, as did many other citizens.”

“Those who pass the qualifiers will each receive a Crest we pilfered from the Nightblades,” said Charlene, who now spent half her time between the syndicate’s HQ and Murmurin itself. “With effort, the participants will be ready for a [Mook Promotion] after Victor’s return. Even you, Malfy.”

“I will not forget the courtesy,” the fiend replied, making it somehow sound like a shady favor exchange.

“I believe you should have enjoyed an overplanar vacation,” Miel told Victor. “We have an excellent Nirvana resort for clie—paragons of virtue such as you.”

“I would rather wander around on my horse, *knight errant* style.” Considering its reputation, Victor had thought it wise not to mention where

he went to study to the angel or the rest of the council for that matter. “If there is any problem, contact me and I will make my way back.”

“Sir, you’re only leaving for one week,” Jules reassured him, but then blew it. “What could possibly go wrong?”

Everything!

“You know, on second thought, maybe I don’t need to—”

“Vic, you clearly need some time off,” Allison interrupted him with a kind smile. “You can trust us. Rolo and I helped manage this village long before you arrived, we will handle it.”

“You and His Majesty have often left for a while, and even though our population has grown tenfold in size since, we need to learn how to manage things in your absence,” Jules pointed out, “Especially if we are to survive the test of time.”

“But—”

“Everything will be *fine*,” Allison insisted.

Victor relented, silently praying Murmurin didn’t blow up in his absence.

Afterward, they finished reviewing the various issues, from the budget to mining reports; being mostly sure the country would survive until tomorrow at least, Victor allowed the various councilmen to take their leave.

“Congratulations, Mr. Dalton,” Malfy whispered to him on his way out.

“You scammed the pigeon with such skillfulness, like a true master...”

“Scammed?” Victor asked.

“Thanks to your subtle guidance, the angel no longer advertises for her heavenly insurances, focusing instead on her subpar ‘public service,’” Malfy rejoiced. “By giving the feathered bureaucrats the SP they wanted, you have chased them away from our core soul market.”

Considering how difficult it had been for Miel to pitch her insurance to Murmurin's monstrous population, Victor figured out that her superiors simply considered the place a lost cause. They would probably harvest the SP to expand elsewhere. And while Malfy only saw the short-term profits, an angelic public service would allow Heaven to gather followers over time.

"Although I insist that Happyland be allowed to create private schools," Malfy said, ever the entrepreneur. "So we can tutor the elite of this nation in the proper ways, separated from the plebians."

"About schools, have you heard of Scholomance?" Victor asked, figuring out the fiend might know of it.

"Scholomance is the most prestigious establishment that Happyland ever sponsored," Malfy said with almost religious awe, before grumbling as he left. "I am still bitter that Maure Incorporated got their logo on the door first."

Allison was the last one to leave. "Chocolatine told me she would visit you after this meeting," she said. "She baked something all for you."

"Something alive?" the dryad shrugged. "About Choc..."

"Yes?"

"A while ago, my [Monster Insight] told me that you had something of a crush on her," Victor said, the dryad not denying it. "I'm surprised why you tried to set us up."

"I am a priestess of the goddess of love," Allison said. "I can tell when feelings are not returned, and when it is not proper to insist. She is... extreme."

No kidding. "I dunno, how can you say that if you haven't tried?"

Charisma check successful.

She gave him an amused gaze. “Are you trying to set up a threesome, handsome?”

Damn it, his Charisma buffs started to play tricks on him. “I’m just not sure where the two of us are headed, so it might be now or never to try your luck.”

The dryad shook her head. “Vic, you really need to learn to assert your own decisions instead of going along with the flow.”

Victor crossed his arms, as his friend left him. As she promised, no sooner did everyone leave, that Chocolatine entered the room to take over. She must have waited all her time in front of the door.

“Ta-da!” the werewolf presented her on-and-off boyfriend with a basket. “I have made you a cake for your trip.”

Victor glanced at it, noticing that the basket wriggled as if alive. It happened more and more since she had gained more levels in [Monster Patissier]. “Thanks,” he said, kissing her on the cheek. And here she made him feel a bit sweet.

“So, a full week?” she asked him. “I hope it’s not an ‘I leave a week for shopping but won’t come back’ kind of vacation.”

“Nah, I should be happy to return to Murmurin afterward.” With the time dilation involved, he would probably love to see the sun again after seven years of training. Victor knew heroes always did it in the animes he watched in his youth, but he wondered the impact on one’s sanity. “I should have figured myself out afterward.”

“Remember to summon me if you ever feel lonely,” she said with a flirty wink. “You did mark me as your mount again, right?”

Much to his secret shame...

He did.

“Are we there yet?” his horse complained, as they walked through the thick mist.

“I dunno,” Victor replied, his scythe on his back. He would rather have taken his trusted bazooka with him, but considering the school, he thought he might have more use of older weapons.

“Are we there—”

“Stop asking me this every five minutes... wait...” The mist, while still thick, cleared a little as they approached a lake, a massive structure surging from the waves in its center. “Aha!”

After traveling through the Nightlands and crossing dozens of portals, they had finally arrived at the location indicated in the letter. From outside, the school appeared as a phantasmagorical, charred castle, with ghostly flames swelling through its walls and towers. Victor smelled ashes in the air, while the structure seemed to flicker in and out of existence at random. A bridge linked the castle to the lakeshore, with two massive stone gates serving as the entrance; the architect engraved various symbols, including those of the Dread Three, on them.

In short, it looked like a warm, welcoming place!

The vizier heard steps in the mist, turning his face to watch a girly goblin walk out. Unlike the few of these critters that he had encountered, that one looked armed to the teeth, most of her body and face covered by an armor too big for her, her back arched by the weight of a bag full of weapons. He noticed spears, swords, even an arquebuse among them; and briefly wondered how that tiny creature could carry so much stuff.

“Hi there, Tall Person!” the goblin said. “Is this Scholomance?”

“Looks like it,” Victor replied, noticing that she carried an invitation letter too. “I’m still waiting for someone to come out and greet us.”

The goblin looked at him with curious eyes. “I’ve never seen your kind before. Like a cross between a manling and a dragon.”

“I’m not sure what I am anymore either,” the Vizier admitted, “I would go with [Monster Knight (Red Dragon)]. The name is Victor, by the way.”

“Goblina,” the goblin said, having the most original name ever. “[Monster Knight]... never heard of that species, although I know a bit about dragons. My dad worked for one.”

“Was his tenure a constant struggle for damage control too?”

“Those were his *exact* words!” the goblin replied, amazed by the coincidence. “Which is why he dropped his last boss while he hibernated, then went as far east as he could to avoid reprisal. Have you fled too?”

“No, that’s the one thing I will never do. My dragon is more than a boss now. It’s a friend. I even owe him my life.”

“Oh? I thought dragons only cared about themselves.”

“And why are you here? To become a better dark lord’s chief of staff?”

“Absolutely not!” she sounded downright insulted. “You think I’m some kind of minion because I’m a goblin? This is exactly the kind of stereotype that I want to change!

“I’m sorry,” Victor apologized, not wanting to look like a racist.

“Everyone says goblins are just cannon fodders and mooks, but I will prove that we can be conquerors too! My, I have even gained levels in [Bandit Queen]! I swear that one day, I will even graduate to [Dark Lord]!”

While Victor listened to the critter going on a rant about goblin social mobility, the school’s doors finally opened. Both students looked at the entrance, as a delicate creature walked out and crossed the bridge in their direction. A moth-like humanoid with golden wings and antenna, pristine greyish skin, and the most insolent dress he had seen since Chocolatine’s; the magnificent lady looked at him with makeup shades under eyes, her silvery hair flowing to the wind.

“Isabelle Maure?!”

Victor did the sensible thing and immediately readied his scythe. After all, Vainqueur killed her son.

“Dalton,” she greeted him. “I see that you still remember me; I would avoid pointing a weapon at a teacher if I were you though.”

A teacher? The Happyland? “Of course I remember you, you tried to eat me for dinner!”

“Ah!” the goblin mocked him. “Class hasn’t started, and the teacher already bullied you!”

“I have no grudge against you for escaping my grasp,” the archdevil said as if *he* was the guilty party, “Nor what your so-called master and his guests did to my company. Even if I felt vengeful, as a student under Deathjester’s protection, I could not do anything to you in my capacity of a teacher at this academy. Unless you provoke me first.”

Victor didn’t trust her at all but avoided tempting the literal devil. “So, what, you will teach me dark magic without reservation?”

“Without reservations? No.” The archdevil snapped her fingers, manifesting two floating scrolls for Victor and Goblina to grab. “You must read, fill, and sign this document first. I teach the [Summoning] class, although I also give guest lectures on specific schools of sorcery, such as [Diabolism] and [Infernal Alchemy].”

“[See Invisibility],” Victor cast the spell, to see if she had slipped words there or there. He patented that trick.

Much to his surprise, though, the document was very straightforward. After pledging to respect its core values—*Ambition*, *Cunning*, and *Selfishness*—he had to agree to spend seven years in the school; more if he finished the curriculum as the class’ dunce.

“We used to have houses you could join,” Isabelle said, as the chief of staff kept reading, “The Demons, the Devils, and the Daemons. But our divine sponsors found that a competitive system, while expected, decreases the

ability of our future overlords to cooperate. You can't conquer the world if you bicker with your fellows over grades and petty clans."

"Then why is the dunce forced to remain here?" Victor asked.

"The Dread Three want to remind our students that their success will be built on the suffering of the less fortunate."

"I see..."

Victor reached the list of dozens of subjects that he could study, most of them with charming names like [Necromantic Biology], [Infernal Alchemy], [Demon Summoning], [Conqueror Economy], [Eldritch Philosophy] or [Ritualistic Magic]. As advertised, most of the curriculum focused on statecraft and various forms of dark magic, with a few unique possibilities standing out, such as the required course [Cursed Artifact Crafting].

Much to his surprise, some of the teachers' names belonged to the Dread Three. Did they *personally* provide educations to new students?

"You seem to struggle with the courses," Isabelle said, her tone more curious than amused. "What are your personal and professional objectives?"

"I, uh, I'm not sure," he admitted. "I came here to figure it out. I guess reach level sixty?"

"It is fine not to know what kind of career you want to follow yet," the demon said, "From bloodthirsty cartel leader to dictator or nihilistic anarchist, we make sure our students find the right path for them. Simply take what interests you."

Statecraft and magic then, although some courses bugged him. "[Peasant Mathematics]?"

"The goddess of tyranny, Veran, teaches how much students can tax their populations to hunger and poverty, without causing them to rebel. Which is,

as it turned out, a very, very high rate.”

Damn, that was *evil*. “I will skip that one,” Victor said. “Vainqueur is against taxes.”

She bristled at the mention of the dragon, but not as much as he thought. His intuition told him that while she loathed the dragon, she didn’t seem all that vengeful against Victor personally. “You really do *not* have a grudge?”

“A very wise spellcaster convinced me to stay wary of you,” Isabelle Maure said. “And if you have been invited there, then you’ve almost caught up to my late Braniño.”

Victor immediately figured out that spellcaster’s likely identity, but kept it to himself. This might be the occasion to figure out what the lich was up to.

“In fact.” She smiled at him with a predatory smirk. “I have other plans for you.”

Why did Victor have the feeling that she wanted to eat him, but not in the way he first thought?

Chapter 72: Interlude: Interim Chiefs

Four hours.

Victor had only left for *four hours*, and she already hated, hated, *hated* her job!

“Minion! Minion!” The dragon repeated the word with a stronger, higher pitched voice each time, as if he thought his victim too deaf to hear him. “MINION!”

“Yes, Your Majesty?” Charlene Ennuie, vampire chief of staff, asked as it took all her willpower to keep a straight face. She could hear her pointed fangs grind together, and her fingers clench her notebook obsessively.

“I have decided that I want my arena to have an opening roof,” Vainqueur pompously declared, his head high as he inspected the nearly finished Colosseum. With his crown too big for his head and his arrogant demeanor, he reminded Charlene of a mighty king looking down on peasants like dog shit. His every step made the bricks tremble under the stars.

“An opening roof?” Charlene repeated, having been forced to follow the dragon’s increasingly nonsensical demands for hours. It had started with chairs made of chiseled jewels, escalated to kobold-made stairs for him to climb upon, and it went further downhill afterward.

“For the opening ceremony,” Vainqueur said as if one word was enough to join both of these concepts. “My minions will stay in the shade until the roof opens; the sun’s rays will shine upon my gold, which will glitter for all to see! Build me an opening roof!”

“Why?” Charlene couldn’t help but ask since the opening ceremony was already an exercise in extravagance. “What is the point?”

“A true emperor, no, an *Augustus*, must make a dazzling entrance!”

“Your Majesty, how are we supposed to create an opening roof mechanism, on a nearly finished building, six days before its opening to the public? For something which will be used only *once*?! With an empty national budget?!”

“Minion Charlene, if you were half the minion my chief of staff is, you would have already figured this out.”

Calm yourself, Charlene, the vampire thought. Calm yourself, this is just temporary, like skin rash. Stay professional, you have seen idiotic and arrogant adventurers before, you can handle—

“And I do not say this because you failed to find me any quests to grow my hoard, proving yourself inadequate.”

Intelligence check successful! [**Berserk**] negated!

“I-inadequate?” Charlene chortled at his sense of entitlement.

“Thankfully, I believe in minion professional reinsertion,” Vainqueur continued with a patronizing tone. “While you have made for a poor quest manager, I am certain that you can shine as my *Minion Secretary of Arena Architecture*.”

Charlene scribbled down this new promotion, next to *Underchief of Hoard R&D*, *Grand Seneschal of the Castle Dusting*, and *Holder of the Golden Mirror*.

To think she thought her situation had finally improved. She had spent years managing a dead-end adventurer guild in the middle of nowhere, trying desperately to climb the professional ladder, when by some twist of fate, she had become the leader in a newborn nation. A nation of madmen,

rogues, and monsters, but a leader nonetheless. She had privileges, status, new classes... and even immortality.

When Victor had departed for his holiday, she knew that the dragon would prove difficult; that without her sort-of friend with benefits, that chaotic, aimless ‘empire’ would collapse within a year. Yet in her heart, Charlene clung to the arrogant idea that she could help turn this nation into a model of bureaucratic efficiency, even without Vic’s help.

But the dragon was even worse than she thought! He wanted everything without paying for anything!

“Now, this is a very important role, and I do not deliver it lightly. If you are to prove yourself worthy of this honor, you will build me an opening roof. It does not have to close, I will have no use for it afterward.”

Charlene may be an undead now, but she could have sworn her heart beat again out of sheer frustration. “Can at least Your Majesty tell me where I can find the gold to pay for the needed material cost?” she asked with heavy sarcasm. If Victor could pull that off and make Vainqueur listen anyway, maybe it would work with her.

Charisma check...

Failed! It failed miserably!

“Pay for material?” the dragon exploded into mirthless laughter. “Paying? That is funny sarcasm, minion. But if you are stressed enough to make a joke, then clearly, you need to work more to forget your pain.”

Congratulations! Due to your vampiric nature and personal circumstances, you have earned the **[Boiling Blood]** personal Perk!

[Boiling Blood]: 40 SP per ten minutes. You can cause your own blood to boil, causing exposure to it to inflict weak **[Fire]** damage on physical contact; you are immune to the negative side effects of having boiling blood, but you become vulnerable to the **[Berserk]** ailment under the Perk’s effect.

“Now, instead of saying jokes, Minion Charlene, go make me money. My hoard will not fill itself alone.”

- *Twelve hours after the good Vizier’s departure.*

“Go home, twolegs.”

“Dear lamb,” Miel said to the giant spider, as she refused to fully crawl out of her pit home. “By the power invested by our covenant with the empire, we can provide your children with the light of knowledge.”

“No way I’ll give my spiderspawn away to birds,” the telepathic spider protested, its children cowering beneath its legs. “I will teach them the way we all do, at home over the remains of our preys!”

A warrior angel, clad in golden armor, summoned a sword of flames. “Free education is non-negotiable,” he spoke with an imperious tone. “Your children shall go to public school, or you will go burn in Hell for the sin of homeschooling!”

Miel winced, immediately recognizing her colleague as one of the ‘old-testamenters.’ This would turn very ugly unless she interfered. “Forgive these poor sinners, for it will take them time to see the light,” the insurance saleswoman pleaded. “Turn the other cheek, for they know not what they do!”

“Miel, I find your protestations a bit too...” The angel pointed his fiery blade at his trip, “*Protestant.*”

“Pointing a sword at your fellow angel is not very graceful either!”

“Get off your sacrament,” the warrior argued. “The higher-ups may consider promoting you to [Dominion] because they have gone soft, but you are no revelation deliverer! By negotiating coexistence with Hell, you have committed *simony!*”

The insult shook Miel to the core as if she had been slapped on the face. “I have always served the cause of Heaven in all things! My, we increased our

department's SP harvests tenfold with the new covenant!"

"By surrendering our soul!"

"I am already giving some of my precious Special Points to you, no way I give you my eggborns too," the spider complained. "I left the Moon thinking this would be the land of freedom and opportunity, not an avian dictatorship!"

"And you would be right, to defend your emperor-given rights."

The very sound of Malfy's voice was enough to infuriate Miel, doubly so when he showed up backed by his lawyers.

"Beware, heathen," the angel warrior threatened. "You shall not corrupt the youth!"

"The children are safer with us, than with you pigeons," one of the lawyers said. "If you received custody, you might give them to a priest."

"Instead, we can take care of your eggborns, for a meager afterlife favor." Malfy moved to proselytize the spider, safe in the knowledge that his role in the empire protected him from the angel's wrath. "We can provide your spawns with the best individual education they could ever want."

"Do not listen to them!" Miel interrupted the fiend before he could poison the mind of this many-legged lamb. "We alone provide truly free education for everyone!"

"I do not want either of you!" the spider shouted in response.

"Then you should take the third path."

Much to Miel's confusion, a third party, which had apparently observed the discussion from afar, decided to intervene: a dwarven woman whom the angel did not recognize, with her eyes hidden behind sunglasses. In fact, she looked almost identical as any other duergar, except for the lack of a beard.

“The middle path, unfulfilling, yet sustainable. The Averagist path.” The dwarf lady cleared her throat. “We champions of equality have decided to provide free education for all, in the true Averagist ways. A place where there are no grades, only *equality*. We share everything, as parts of a single organism.”

“Like a communal web?” the spider asked, suddenly more interested in the offer than either Heaven or Happyland’s proposals. “That takes me back to my youth when I learned to hunt bigger prey in groups.”

“My, bringing down the tallest is the truest Averagist endeavor!”

“Mmm... it is true my spiderspawn need to learn how to socialize with the neighbors... can you come inside my dark cavern, so we may discuss your school program?”

“Of course. I must tell you that as earth core dwellers, our schools are adapted for nocturnal creatures.”

“Amazing,” the spider chittered. “What about diet? My spiderspawn are goblin-intolerant.”

Both angels and fiends watched the scene in stunned silence, as the spider invited the dwarf in its home... and didn’t even eat her!

“The Agarthans are stealing our market share!” Malfy protested, as furious as Miel herself. “This is theft! We are the government, we must stop them!”

“You have my vote,” Miel said, and then continued before her unreasonable colleague could protest at allying with the rival planar company. “Under the condition that Happyland not be allowed to open private schools, recognizing the heavenly way as the *only* way.”

Warning: for this act of gratuitous spite, even towards a demon, you have lost karma.

The message mortified Miel until the sight of Malfy’s entire body turning red from fury made it worth it.

- *Fifteen hours after the deeply regretted Vizier's departure.*

"Junior, please calm yourself," Allison tried to soothe the monstrous mimic, as the scene caused citizens to gather in the street.

"Babies!" the creature barked back, gathering newborn jellies on its back while stomping the remains of a destroyed stand. "Protect babies!"

"Sword babies?" Buzz Jelly repeated, the famous explorer having hopped at Junior's side since it began its rampage. "Coming!"

How did Victor tame this thing? It had been completely uncontrollable since the last slime rain brought new jellies to Murmurin, smashing anything between itself and its new charges; and without Victor to keep it pacified, the creature's violent instincts had resurfaced. A poor orc shopkeeper had the misfortune of catching a fire jelly to make light, which enraged the giant mimic and made it overreact.

"This is a disaster," the orc complained. "My shop is in ruins!"

"It's the advisers," a kobold merchant in the crowd *loudly* complained, "Everything has been worse since the beloved Grand Vizier left! I'm sure they mislead the good Emperor Vainqueur with bad advice and mistreated the mimiczord!"

"I heard they want to raise *taxes*!" A gnoll added, causing the citizens to argue among themselves.

"That is wrong," Allison replied, sensing the tension in the air. "We have no intention to—"

"I feel you, gamete person, this gods-blessed country is declining before my three hundred and eight eyes!" An eldritch horror added, ignoring the dryad. The priestess suddenly realized that while she had once commanded respect when Murmurin had been a small village where everyone knew one another, she didn't recognize half of these monsters. And they didn't respect her. "They must have conspired to send the good Victor away, as they did the Kobold Rangers... the true prophet would never have let this happen!"

The worse thing was, Allison realized that they may be on to something...

“Gentlemonsters,” a gnoll spoke up. “I think there is only one way for our voice to be heard loudly enough to reach the Emperor. The *monster* way.”

He raised a spear.

“RIOT!”

“Riot!” Buzz Jelly hopped happily. “Team activity!”

“The chosen slime is with us!” a Moon Beast roared in poor commonspeak. “RIOT!”

“RIOT!” the other monsters shouted in agreement, some immediately smashing the nearest windows and tossing carts around in a frenzy.

“Stop!” Allison pleaded, only for someone to start a fire with a spell. She immediately moved to try to extinguish the flames before they spread.

“Damn it! Damn you! Damn you all!”

- *Twenty hours into the Murmurin apocalypse.*

Exhausted, Allison took solace in the one place where she always felt safe. Her temple, before the statue of her goddess.

The dryad prayed harder than she had ever been to Cybele, but the love goddess, who had so many times answered her prayers directly, remained silent. The new cathedral, built months ago, remained eerily silent. Until at long last, her best friends stepped into the room, more for her sake than the goddess’.

“What has Rolo missed?” the golem asked, always straight and to the point. “Rolo has seen smoke outside.”

“You missed sixteen murders, hundreds of wounded, riots, fires, fires everywhere, hundreds of thousands of gold coins lost in property damage, Heaven and Happyland threatening to go to war over proper youth education...” Allison trailed, her voice breaking. Since she always favored

conciliation, the rampant chaos drained her utterly. She would have rather talked to people over a drink than help quell the riots.

How did Victor manage to stay sane after *months* of this? The experience had only renewed the respect she felt for her fellow human-turned-monster.

“It is a very sensible subject, education,” Rolo said with a farmer’s wisdom.

“I never went to school, but I turned out sound in mind and body,” Chocolatine added, before giving Allison a cake. “Here, you need sugar. I mixed it with chocolate, with no meat. You will feel happier afterward.”

“Choc, you are crazy, but you are also cute, and I want to take you home with me,” the dryad declared. Now that she felt the shadow of death and destruction chase her with every step, she had finally found the courage to say it.

“Silly, your home is probably burning as we speak!” Chocolatine replied innocently. “I should be the one to take you to my place!”

“It’s a deal,” Allison said, “Rolo, can you...”

“Rolo does not need repairs. Rolo will go work, and make sure the fields do not burn in our absence. You must rest.”

“Thank you, my friend,” the dryad replied. “I will offer the last of my silent prayers tonight, and then I will leave.”

Chocolatine hugged her dearly, while Rolo patted her on the back. When they both left, the dryad thanked the goddess for sending her to this world, where she had made friends as strong as them.

Another figure ended up paying her respects to Cybele that night: Charlene. “I did not know you prayed,” Allison told the vampire.

“Neither did I,” Charlene replied, looking absolutely *destroyed*. “At this point, only the gods will save us.”

“We...” Allison bit her lower lip since she had promised herself not to bother her friend while on his soul-searching trip. “We can always contact Vic...”

“I tried,” Charlene dropped the bomb. “I tried to contact him through his [Scarlet Study] Perk, but wherever he is, it blocks the connection.”

The dryad’s heart froze, the world around her drained of color, of the very substance of hope. “So you’re saying—”

“That we are on our own.” Charlene shook her head as if lost in her thoughts. “Only Jules is happy. He called it a good day.”

Allison choked, aghast. “How can he call this mess good?”

“There have been sixteen deaths so far, which he translated as sixteen new undead births. He hopes that we can keep going with the new momentum.”

How did Victor manage to keep all these maniacs in line?

“I will have to apologize to Victor when he comes back,” Charlene said, “Keeping Vainqueur grounded is an impossible task, let alone his entire army!”

“Managing an empire of monsters is way, way more difficult than a small village,” Allison had to admit. “They are all within an inch of starting a fight, unless kept in line by a strong chief of staff. I never thought that Vic would be so... *irreplaceable*.”

“We have to make sure that he never takes a vacation ever again.”

“Agreed,” Allison replied. “No matter what.”

Chapter 73: Of Witches and Flames

“... you are asking me, your lord and master, which school my minions must attend?” Vainqueur asked the ‘interim council’ from atop his hoard, more irked with each passing second.

“No, Your Majesty,” Tasty Miel replied. “We ask you if you would kindly ban vile satanic schools, and to enforce the divine covenant drafted by your saintly Vizier.”

“Do not listen to her, Your Majesty.” Tasty Malfy glared at his rival. “She is trying to stamp out free enterprise, which has been the empire’s cornerstone since its inception! We are also very, very unsure that an Averagist education is compatible with our shared company values.”

“We are uplifting the masses and downgrading the mighty,” Marbré contested. “Certainly ours is the truest way!”

As they started arguing again, Vainqueur was starting to get a headache, and a strong urge to eat all three of them.

The council was making him *work!* *Their* work! He already had to make a grand speech to the population to quell the riots, promising sweeping political reforms, and even have his lackeys look for slimes to pacify his friend’s pet.

Although he loved ruling over peons and enlightening them, Vainqueur would have rather trained at his [Geomancer] class, so he could bury the vile Furibon under a mountain. Or the ocean. “Smart minions are productive minions,” the dragon spoke, interrupting their squabble. “But I

care not which of you teach them. For you are all equally incompetent on this matter.”

“I can only applaud this show of Averagism,” Marbré said, seeing the light in the dragon’s words.

But while Malfy the Fiend seemed to submit too, the angel was aghast. “But Your Majesty—”

“I am a dragon. If you angels were wiser than my kind, then you would have scales on your wings.” The bird fell silent in the face of Vainqueur’s implacable logic. “I have spoken. Each family must send their children to be educated in the ways of minionship, but they can choose which one. For the future of my hoard, each school program will also have courses in *Hoard R&D* and *Fairy Extermination*; and the smartest minions will be sent to my new *Vainqueur Watch for Thorough Fairy Destruction*. You three will now leave, before the sight of you makes me hungrier.”

Understanding the subtle message, half the council rushed through the vault’s door, leaving only the other two. Vainqueur immediately noticed someone missing. “Where is Untasty Allison?” he asked.

“She overtaxed her magic replanting the fields damaged during the riots,” Charlene explained, her eyes creased by exhaustion.

“Batling Charlene, that is true minion devotion,” Vainqueur said, hoping the vampire would take after her example. She smiled in response, her lips unable to reach her ears due to the emotion. The dragon then turned to Jules the Necromancer. “Corpseling.”

“Yes, Your Majesty? How may I serve?”

“I want you to make a list of every minion in my empire, living or dead,” Vainqueur said. “A list which will include their species, age, and gender.”

“That’s an interesting idea,” Batling Charlene said, surprised. “What is it for?”

“Since taking levels in [Geomancer] takes time, I will now practice my [Dungeon Breeder] class,” Vainqueur declared. “The chaos in my empire has shown me that I must foster a sense of brotherhood among my lackeys; not only towards me, their beloved ruler but to each other.”

“It is true that the nation is a melting pot,” Jules said. “Do you intend to marry off every minion?”

“A true army of minions is united in blood, as well as spirit,” Vainqueur said. “But I shall not force any of my lackeys to breed against their will... because, in my wisdom, I will organize the perfect dates with the best partners, as I did for my chief of staff.”

It was time to introduce Murmurin to the ancient dragon institution of *‘Minion Speed Dating’*.

“Why not form adventurer parties out of the population as well?” Jules proposed. “Many have formed groups of their own, but perhaps Your Majesty would have a keen eye in creating new ones.”

“You flatter me, minion,” Vainqueur said. “Do it more often, for this is an excellent idea.”

After Batling Charlene and Corpseling Jules exchanged on the ways to gain this information, Vainqueur sent them away, so he could rest on his gold, as a true dragon should.

Yet an hour later, he was woken up by the most wonderful of voices. “Uncle!” his niece Jolie called him from outside the vault, waking him up. “We are back! Can we come in?”

Vainqueur’s mood immediately improved. “Of course!”

His niece walked inside, followed by cursed Knight Kia and the Kobold Rangers. They were Kobolds in name only by now, having grown bigger and traded their silly weapons for better gear. Red had transformed into a grizzled warrior carrying both swords and firearms; Pink now wore colorful clothes Vainqueur had often seen musicians wear in manling courts; Blue

covered his bones with priestly robes and a staff; Black seemed to have taken the path of the spellcaster, if the dragon could trust his new wizard hat and belt of potions; and he almost didn't recognize Yellow beneath his glittering, golden armor.

Even his niece had changed. She covered her scales with shiny armor of fortified plates, from her head to the very end of her tail. The elder dragon recognized the metal as mithril, and while he considered it inferior to gold in shininess, it more than made up in hardness. Clearly, Jolie had learned the lesson from the fight with Lavere and trained.

"So good to see you, my niece," Vainqueur said, nuzzling his kindred. "Have you come for the games?"

"We are going north, uncle," Jolie said. "Kia said she would present me to the King, and a princess!"

"I have received news from Gardemagne," her chief of staff said. "I am recalled there for an emergency."

"Good riddan—" Vainqueur stopped himself when he realized Jolie intended to follow the knight and may miss his minion tournament. "This is terrible news!"

"I will come back soon, uncle!" Jolie promised.

"The niece shall be defended," Red Ranger said.

"But we may not return in time for the games," Pink Ranger complained.

"What could possibly be important enough to cause my niece to miss my minion championship?" Vainqueur asked angrily.

"A band of fomors is raiding the northern shores of the continent, attacking isolated villages in the old Midgard Republic and the Winter Kingdom," Knight Kia said, "King Roland believes this to be a Wild Hunt from Prydain, and he wants me nearby in case they approach Gardemagne. Reports say that even Mag Mell was sighted among them."

A Wild Hunt. The fairies' poor attempt at copying the dragons' Bragging Day. "The fairies will eat a few manlings, brag about whoever has skinned the best fur, and then they will bicker and scatter," said the wyrm, who had seen it play time and time again. "They do that every decade or so. Nothing unusual."

"Kevin said something is wrong this time though," Knight Kia replied, "Usually the fomors only attack mortals, but these ones thoroughly assault any living creature that they encounter, from animals to wild monsters. They even cleared out a dungeon."

"Obviously, the fairies wish to steal all of the treasures which rightfully belong to dragonkind," Vainqueur replied. His declaration of war must have forced them to adopt desperate measures.

"What use is there in slaying defenseless animals though?" Knight Kia shook her head. "If I didn't know that they can't, I would think that they are grinding like madmen."

Grinding. The word reminded Vainqueur of the old times, when he burnt enough demons to gain [Witch Hunter] levels...

Warning: Will you promote your [**Witch Hunter**] class to [**Hellsing**] or [**Witchfinder General**]? If you do not, you will continue to level up in the base class.

Vainqueur had almost forgotten. "Menu," the dragon said, "Detail me these classes."

[**Hellsing**]: 'You have moved beyond hunting only spellcasters, and now intend to make most classical horrors... extinct.' If you are promoted to this class, your abilities will target more enemy types than spellcasters, and your resistance to damage will increase.

[**Witchfinder General**]: 'Your hatred of spellcasters has grown beyond simply hunting them yourself. Now you command entire crusades against witches.' If you are promoted to this class, your ability to make spellcasters miserable will increase further, and your allies will join in the fun.

The dragon considered the choice before him, before quickly deciding that with that dirty scum Lavere gone, he should no longer have any problem crushing vampires, and he already had an institute dedicated to researching ways to destroy fairies.

Yet the rematch with the wicked Furibon, cursed forever may he be, approached. “I am now, and forever,” Vainqueur declared, “a Witchfinder General!”

You have promoted [**Witch Hunter**] to [**Witchfinder General**]. Your [**Spell Purge**] perk now inflicts additional [Fire] damage when dispelling a foe’s spells.

Once more, the system proved itself as dragon-oriented, in recognizing the superior ability of fire to solve every problem.

“While you take care of the fairies, my minions will train to conquer the sea, save El Dorado, and destroy the evil Furibon,” Vainqueur told Jolie and Kia. “Again!”

Knight Kia frowned, glanced down at Jolie, before shrugging. How could that manling treat the destruction of Furibon so carelessly? “In any case, once the Goldslayer is defeated, I will lay waste to Prydain myself,” the wyrm boasted.

“There is a detail that Your Majesty should know,” Knight Kia said. “Witnesses apparently sighted a dragon among the Wild Hunt. A *huge* one.”

Vainqueur exploded into laughter. “A dragon working with fairies? Your witnesses must have sighted a wyvern or some drake!”

“No true dragon would help a fomor!” Jolie nodded.

“I’m just saying, you can count on me whenever you intend to attack Prydain,” the knight said, her tone almost begging. “But don’t expect an easy fight either.”

“No, I expect, and will only settle for, *complete decimation*,” Vainqueur said with fury. The fomors had threatened his niece, his minions, and his hoard. The dragon would do what his kind should have done eons ago, and teach them a lesson they would never forget.

“We shouldn’t be long, anyway,” Kia said. “The warband does not have the power to threaten Gardemagne, so King Roland will release me when it inevitably returns to Prydain.”

“Make sure to return in time for my minion tournament,” Vainqueur insisted.

“Oh, oh, Uncle, I have an idea!” Jolie said. “A minion battle!”

“A minion battle?” Kia raised an eyebrow.

“An ancient dragon ritual where two dragons select a team of minions each and have them fight for supremacy,” Vainqueur said. “The dragon with the most minions standing at the end wins.”

“Uncle, can I—”

“Jolie, I forbid you from making yourself a minion of that manling!” Vainqueur insisted. “You will act like a true dragon should be: barking orders to non-dragons!”

As his niece narrowed her head in disappointment, Vainqueur’s thoughts turned to his favorite minion. Barely a day had passed, but he wondered what he was up to. He hoped that he could find a way to breed.

Because considering what Vainqueur planned for him, Manling Victor would need the practice.

Chapter 74: Victor Dalton and the School of Necromancy

Veran, goddess of war and fire, knew how to set the stage.

“To graduate from this academy, each of you must craft a personal artifact, according to our guidelines,” she declared, the ceiling flickering with phantom flames. Hiding her whole body behind a thick shell, she looked more like an infernal, fire-powered golem than a dwarf. “The [Solomonari’s Grimoire] is the classic, but I would prefer more imaginative proposals for this session. Like a gun! Or a *sword*, with a *gun*!”

As one of the students sitting in the amphitheater, Victor scribbled down every damn word of this [Cursed Artifact Crafting] class. His classmate, Goblina, raised a hand to ask questions. “Can a ballista work?” she asked.

“If it is magical, nigh-indestructible, and destructive!” the goddess replied. “The essence of artifact creation is to pour your soul into the task. Literally! Creating an artifact means surrendering part of your lifeforce, of your max HP, and imbuing it with a personal touch!”

“What kind of artifacts did you make in your heyday?” a regal, crowned imp asked. Victor knew him as some kind of fallen demon prince eager to make a comeback but had little interaction with him.

“Jesty created his [Deathscythe],” Veran replied. “Although he killed so many people with it, surrendering his lifeforce was just the last push. Camilla crafted the [Crystal Skulls] which first spread vampirism and so many forms of undeath. As for me... oho, it would take a whole year to list all of mine! I was, and still am, a very busy crafter! The sword [Revengeance], the [Anvil of Catastrophe], the [Slime Machine]...”

As announced, the Dread Three did give classes, although most of the teacher body included ghosts of past overlords, mad prophets, and ancient horrors whose every lecture forced a Check against [Madness].

The curriculum focused on various courses each year, with the first focusing only on statecraft and ‘mindset.’ The teachers had taught Victor classes based on Akhenapep’s one hundred stratagems, although they went deeper into the practical applications. He had lost count to the number of times he had to hide a fake artifact from classmates acting as heroes, or minion HR sessions. While it only refined things he had already learned, the knowledge would serve him well in Murmurin; it had even opened his mind to new ways of managing Vainqueur’s new nation.

For the second year, the teachers would finally teach the students sorcery, item crafting, and more practical skills. After spending a good hour listing and detailing some of her proudest artifacts, Veran began to explain the process of crafting one. Victor scribbled down some ideas; since the process would take years, he had to quickly settle on a concept.

When the class ended with Veran turning into a pillar of flames, the students left the amphitheater into the dark, dimly lit corridors of the school. “See you at the [Infernal Alchemy] course, Vic,” Goblina told him.

“Nah, I’m attending the [Necromancy] course,” Victor replied. Partly because he liked the subject, and mostly because Isabelle Maure gave the lecture on [Infernal Alchemy].

“You must be the only one,” she said, before leaving him to find the class on his own.

As Victor walked around the windowless school, he mused that the worst part wasn’t the lack of sun, the constant company of unethical psychos, the unnerving presence of Isabelle Maure, or the intense work schedule. No. What Victor struggled with was a more primal, intimate problem.

Not getting laid.

This place was worse than a monastery! His classmates ran the gamut from goblin to animated armor, and even a psychotic mad alchemist, but no female humanoids! As for the teachers... Isabelle Maure seemed to take sadistic glee in teasing him, and he didn't feel attracted to dwarves, especially world-conquering ones.

Victor had strongly considered summoning Chocolatine, before realizing that she would remain trapped with him for at least six more years if he did. He hadn't breached the subject with the teachers, so he had no idea how they would react; nor how would the werewolf. Trapping her in that castle for a quick relief from his pain sounded very selfish.

Finally finding the [Necromancy] amphitheater, Victor found himself the only one sitting on the stands. He didn't have to wait long before the teacher teleported inside amidst swirling miasma.

The creature before him... was the greatest beauty the Vizier had ever laid his eyes upon. A dark elf whose skin was as black as a moonless night, pristine, and pure; her crimson eyes were shining rubies, her hair a white waterfall. Her wizard robes fit her perfect, voluptuous curves in an entirely supernatural way. She smiled at him, vampire fangs whom he would have happily sink into his neck and—

'MINION!'

When he realized who he was looking at, Victor forced himself to focus on another mental picture; namely, Vainqueur. Somehow, imagining the dragon barking at him immediately broke the elf's spell over him.

Forced abstinence was slowly driving him mad.

"You are the only student?" Camilla, goddess of death, plagues, and the undead, asked with a disappointed face.

"Apparently. I dunno why though."

"Since undead have become accepted, necromancy no longer has a..." Camilla considered the word, "Bad Boy appeal? Being a nice, mass murder-

raiser is no longer a popular career choice.”

“Everybody wants to be some kind of crafter shieldsman nowadays,” Victor deadpanned. “But I’m all about the classics.”

“And for that, Victor Dalton, you have my sincere gratitude,” the goddess said with kindness. “Thanks to your efforts, the cause of the undeathstrial revolution is making headway in the Mistral continent... and your devotion shall not go unrewarded.”

... don't imagine her naked, she didn't mean it that way, don't do it, Vic, don't do it...

“Since you are the only student, we can make this a private tutoring class,” she said, either unaware of Victor’s less than saintly thoughts or ignoring them. “Why did you choose to study [Necromancy]?”

Yes, let’s talk magic! “I have started learning the fundamentals of magic, but I never fully explored Necromancy in depth. I know spells are divided into tiers of power, and specializations, but not what these subschools do.”

“As a [Reaper] of your level, you should have access to [Necromancy], [Ritual], and [Diabolism], correct?” Victor nodded, as the goddess took a professional tone, absorbed in her lecture. “[Necromancy] is sorcery focusing on the powers of undeath and death in general; it is obviously, my favorite.”

Figures. “What about the others?”

“[Diabolism] is sorcery focused on the lower planes, opposing [Sacrament], which calls upon the so-called heavenly planes. It gives you access to fiend summoning or sacrificing souls for wicked powers. As for [Rituals], they are very long, complex, but extremely powerful spells with a long spellcasting time, specific ingredients or needing conditions such as planetary events.”

So the virgin sacrifice to summon demon lord kind of magic.

“You also have access to [Universal] magic, which any spellcaster can use, but if anyone wanted to be a *good* one, they would have become necromancers,” Camilla said. “Luckily for you, [Reaper] has one of its best Perks for spellcasting.”

“[Soulmaster IV],” Victor guessed, “[Reaper] levels now count as caster levels for the purpose of class restrictions. What does that mean?”

“That your Reaper levels can serve as a stepping stone to access more powerful, elite spellcasting classes, like [Lich], and that your current tiers will also stack with new ones for the three schools of magic you have access to.”

“I would rather explore my existing classes before looking for new ones,” Victor replied. “I have perks like [Darwinist] which could synergize well with necromancy, like allowing me to use undead-only spells on myself.”

The goddess put a finger on her smiling lips with her eyebrows furrowing, deep in thoughts. “Most necromancy spells focus on killing or raising the fallen as undead,” she said. “But it also opens the path to many stranger abilities, which can both enhance your abilities and mesh with your natural management skills.”

“You have experience with that?” She obviously had to be good at raising undead armies.

“I’m the one who kept my guild organized and grounded,” Camilla said. “Jesty is all about striking against the establishment, while Veran *is* the establishment. Making sure everyone gets along has been a tiring experience, but a rewarding one.”

“About that, why did you create a school like Scholomance? I never imagined that kind of establishment could exist in Outremonde.”

“We Dread Three believe that we can achieve greater things if we cooperate, than if we war with each other,” the goddess replied. “If Mithras and the gods of the politically correct can band together to push their retrograde agenda, why can’t we do the same? We defeat our enemies by

making them our friends, or our zombie slaves; which is something the fomors could never understand.”

Victor thought she had a point, except for the undead slave part. “You know, I came here to think back on my life first and foremost.”

“Have you?”

The Vizier nodded. “V&V is the most unstable nation in existence, but it is also the only place where monsters from all corners of the world can live in harmony and somewhat peacefully. We succeeded at amazing things too; we even reached the Moon!”

Camilla chuckled as if laughing at a private joke. “You came a long way.”

“So even if Vainqueur created it by accident, I wouldn’t mind helping a monster civilization grow prosperous,” Victor said. “Monsters are seen by adventurers as the enemy, and vice-versa... but it doesn’t have to be. While our values differ, *peaceful* coexistence is possible. I would like to show that to all of Outremonde, with V&V as the case study.”

“So you will expand the empire’s borders until the world is united under your benevolent iron rule?!” Camilla said with a dramatic voice, making Victor raise an eyebrow. “Sorry, I was channeling Veran for a moment.”

For a goddess, she sounded like a closet dork. “I’m always going to follow Vainqueur. I’ve sworn it and I stand by my words, even if I must toil forever to grow his hoard. But besides my duties, I want to see the house I built prosper.”

Camilla listened patiently, before nodding. “Would you like to become my apprentice?”

Victor blinked. “Apprentice?”

“Since you are the only student interested in necromancy among the studies, so I might as well go further with you. I can help you progress into your [Reaper] class until you cap it at thirty, teach the tricks of the trade.”

She giggled. “If you reach level sixty by the end of your stay, I may even reward you with a little something.”

That kind of reward? He couldn’t help but think.

“Shesha did say you were *easy*,” she laughed, having read his mind much to his shame. “But let’s keep things professional within this school’s walls. We will first start by reviewing every spell under Tier IV...”

Congratulations! For receiving the private tutelage of the goddess of Undeath, you earned two levels in **[Reaper]**! You earned the **[Nightmare Lord]** class perk!

1 VIT, + 2 SKI, +2 AGI, +2 INT, +2 CHA, +1 LCK.

[Nightmare Lord]: By sacrificing half your max SP, you can change an area up to a mile wide into a **[Nightmare Realm]** Field for thirty minutes. Each minute, non-mindless creatures must pass a Charisma check, with each failure inflicting a status ailment. One check failed: **[Drain]**. Two checks failed: **[Terror]**. Three checks failed: **[Madness]**. Four checks failed: **[Nightmarish Sleep]**. Five checks failed: **[Insta-Death]**, with the soul trapped as if targeted by **[Helheim]**. Any successful check resets the cycle. **[Nightmare Realm]** ignores ailment Resistances, but not Immunities.

Very nasty, if costly, effect, but by *Dice*, his stat increases didn’t turn out good.

Victor knocked at the door, but no answer came.

[Skeleton Key] activated!

His perk caused the door to open on its own, the Vizier stepping in as he heard a voice beyond the threshold.

“No, Braniño, I will not pay the goddess Shesha to revive you! I no longer have the funds! I have asked the goddess Camilla and... yes, I know you do

not want to become an undead matador, yes, but this is the cheapest... yes, I love you..."

The Vizier walked inside Isabelle Maure's room, although condo might have been a better term. The Dread Three had granted Isabelle Maure a royal suite fitting her ego, including a boudoir, a large bedroom, and golem servants to attend her needs. The archdevil herself sat around a dinner table, speaking in front of a silver mirror, whose surface shifted like smoke.

"No, Braniño, I... I am in a temporal anomaly, of course, I cannot call anytime!" She frowned upon seeing Victor enter. "Braniño, I have a guest... yes, I will call you back..."

With a sigh of frustration, the archdevil put down the mirror. "He's just as entitled in death as he was in life, isn't he?" Victor guessed.

"I am getting tired of it. He wants me to use all my remaining assets to revive him, so he can take revenge as if I could afford it." The archdevil made a hand sign and the room's door closed behind Victor. "How did you get into the room? I warded it magically."

"A special Perk of mine."

"Wonderful for assassination attempts," she replied, although clearly not intimidated in the slightest. "To what pleasure do I owe your presence?"

"I decided to attend the [Diabolism] class and bolster my spell list," Victor said, much to her amusement. "Since I missed the first few lectures, I thought you might have documents to recommend."

"So you have come for private lessons?"

Of course, she chose that wording on purpose. "I will cut straight to the chase," Victor said. "What do you want from me or Vainqueur? A settlement?"

"Sort of," Isabelle Maure said, inviting him to sit; which he did. "Furibon told me that I had more to gain by allying with you."

“He’s right.” Becoming Vainqueur’s enemy hadn’t worked out well for her, like everyone else who tried to take the old wyrm down.

“The slim possibility of bringing my company back from the brink is the only reason I entertain the idea, instead of fighting,” she replied, serving them wine. “I still harbor a grudge against Infercorp for stealing my market, so you better have excellent terms.”

Victor smirked at her arrogance since he held most of the cards. “What do you bring on the table?”

“I will drop my revenge against you.”

“We beat Brandon, we can beat you too,” Victor replied, unimpressed. “If you are even considering the deal, then you no longer have the strength necessary to enforce threats.”

“I can live forever, gather resources over centuries...”

“So can Vainqueur. Who do you think will be in a better position in the long term?”

Charisma check successful!

“Then let me rephrase,” the archdevil said. “Tell me what you want, and I will tell you what I want, and we will see if our goals can align.”

“We indeed need you to drop your vendetta, but also soldiers, magical weapons, anything which can help our country prosper in the long-term,” Victor said. “Have you considered a merger?”

“A merger?” Isabelle snickered. “With those upstarts of Infercorp? Never!”

“Then I have a proposal,” Victor said. “Why not become one of the empire’s officials? Like a governor?”

“You want me to bow to the dragon?” Her expression twisted into one of absolute disgust.

“With favorable terms,” Victor said. “You will be granted a permanent foothold in Ishfania or the new territories we intend to annex in the future. While not as large as what Maure controlled, you could administer a region of our empire as you see fit so long as you remain loyal, provide soldiers and support for our wars. You will be allowed to offer services in the empire like Malfy, and granted protection from adventurers trying to unseat you.”

Isabelle listened, her face softening. “I will be allowed to rebuild Maure Incorporated with no reprisal?”

“We won’t allow Brandon to return, which will be enforced through contract.” Not after the trouble the so-called Demon King caused them. “But otherwise, if you sign guidelines ensuring you won’t be aggressive towards us or cause too much trouble, you can go and sell souls in your territory. We already allow that in Murmurin.”

“This is not optimal,” she said. “But these are generous starting terms. I am surprised why you even offer them if you are truly in a strong position.”

“As a wise goddess said, I defeat my enemies when I make them friends.”

Charisma check successful!

The answer seemed to satisfy her. “Let’s discuss the fine print then...” she said, serving them both wine.

They ended up talking for hours about the details of a peace settlement, eventually reaching out an agreement. *She has a prodigious appetite*, Victor thought, as the archdevil wanted no less than an area the size of Indiana and complete autonomy; the Vizier, a hard bargainer himself, eventually talked her down into accepting an area the size of Maryland and with oversight, albeit a lax one. In exchange, the archdevil accepted to swear fealty to Vainqueur and V&V in general, provide access to her resources, her web of contacts... and as he expected, she had an ace up her sleeve.

“You know Furibon’s current location in the New World?”

“I knew this would interest you,” she said, sensing an opportunity. “Now, I am not giving up an old ally to his demise for free, even if he abandoned my son.”

“He saved my life and decided no longer to antagonize us,” Victor pointed out. Hell, he had grown slightly fond of the cranky lich. “So I am tempted to simply let him be. I just want his location to talk to him if needed.”

“Of course,” she said while clearly not believing him.

After they finally settled on an agreement, which was to be signed under the supervision of demon lawyers, the discussion turned to more personal subjects. “... and you did not sleep with the angel?” Isabelle Maure asked, mocking him. “Not that I can blame you. Like their services, they are overrated.”

“I dunno,” Victor said. “I wanted to. Still want. But I didn’t want to cause a mess by breaking Chocolatine’s feelings either, so I forced myself not to indulge.”

“The werewolf seemed open to the idea, from what you told me,” Isabelle replied. “And neither did she seem willing to settle down yet. The problem comes from you... although I do not see what it is.”

“I’ve thought about it, and I’ve come to the conclusion that I am simply wary about committing.”

“You said that you *forced* yourself,” Maure pointed out, before making an elaborate guess. “I understand. You want to return to your homeworld, and deep down you are afraid that if you attach yourself to one or more women, then it will end in tears.”

Victor nodded. “I even considered asking one of the Dread Three if they could send me back after Vainqueur and I are done with the fomors.”

“My advice is, do whatever you want. I spent my whole existence building a career, never taking vacations, sacrificing my youth to build my company! Before I knew it, centuries had passed, and I had an ungrateful brat for a

son and no time left. Besides, you should have no problem enjoying yourself.”

“Come again?”

“You are nothing like the scrawny twerp that you were when we first met,” she said, “Now you are strong, confident, and even dashing. The way you negotiate advantageous terms without disrespecting me... you would make for the perfect diplomat. I thought I would have to put on my charm to gain more concessions. I may still.”

Victor guessed managing V&V did improve his confidence, and he had had a major increase in Charisma lately.

"You said *considered*," the archdevil noticed, "Not consider."

“I’ve thought about it here in Scholomance, and in the end, I am where I should be,” Victor said “Sure, I would like to send a message to my family on Earth, if they still live... but I am building Outremonde’s future. I am making a difference, and I want to continue.”

As for his romantic aspirations... After a long period of soul searching, Victor decided he would rather remain a bachelor. As the archdevil said, he had all his life ahead of him, and while he had grown fond of a certain werewolf girl, Victor didn’t want to settle.

It didn’t help that any romantic relationship would come *after* his own duties to Vainqueur.

“I wish I had an assistant like you working under me," the archdevil said, clearly teasing him with the phrasing. “I still cannot believe you started renovating that sandy dumpster you call a country.”

“Brandon never tried?”

“Braniño loved titles and the glory, but never development,” she said, before mimicking his voice. “*Mom, I am the demon king! Mom, buy me a*

brighter red capote! I swear, I did not raise him like this. When I think of all that I sacrificed, and yet nothing satisfies him.”

“I trust that the settlement will make up for the mess he causes.”

“I might have actually won more than what I started with,” the archdevil said, “A flourishing, populated region under my direct control is worth more than a country-wide desert left to the whims of an unruly son.”

The mirror let out a sound similar to a phone, causing the archdevil to sigh as her son called her. “I can solve this,” Victor said.

“You can?” She raised an eyebrow.

Victor brazenly took the mirror, and simply threw it away. The fall shattered it while Isabelle’s eyes bulged at the sight, ending the buzzing sound; the silence caused the archdevil’s features to soften, while golem servants worked to pick it back up.

“The mirror’s price will be coming out of your grade,” she said.

“Guess I will need more private lessons then,” he joked, before realizing his mistake. *Don’t imagine her naked, don’t imagine her naked...*

Her amused eyes met his own, and it was all over.

Congratulations! For sleeping with twenty women since you arrived in Outremonde, almost all of them monsters, your [**Romantic**] Perk has evolved into [**Seducer**]!

[**Seducer**]: You gain +10 CHA when interacting with the opposite sex, and +5 CHA with your own. This replaces [Romantic].

Chapter 75: Pocket Minions

- *One very long week after Manling Victor's departure...*

“Vainqueur! Vainqueur! Vainqueur!”

Carried by the voices and adoration of his fans, Vainqueur descended upon his Golden Colosseum while the roof opened on its own. The sun shone on the glittering golden walls of the majestic building, the citizens on the stands blinded by the light.

“Yes! I am your emperor! Love me!” Vainqueur unleashed a stream of flames on the sandy ground of the arena, turning it to glass. The dragon circled the whole Colosseum before sitting on his royal promontory, which supervised the entire Colosseum. Batling Charlene waited at his side, protected from the sun by a heavy umbrella.

Only the presence of his Friend Victor would have made Vainqueur happier. Almost all of the city's population had gathered into the overcrowded stands to praise him; and Jolie, who had returned early from her errand in Gardemagne alongside her minions, had been granted a spot on a smaller promontory opposite to his. Vainqueur had one built for his dragon guests, for he was a wyrm with a sense of hospitality.

While Batling Charlene had shamelessly copied the design of the late Maure's arena— may that wretched fiend be forever grounded in the afterlife—Vainqueur loved his Colosseum, for every wall, every stone, had been coated with gold. He already imagined the day where he would reveal his hoard and pile it in the Colosseum's midst, before the eyes of the envious Icefang.

“Minions!” Vainqueur roared to the crowd. “Welcome... to my Golden Colosseum! A place where the best of minions can fight for dominance! A place, where you will see your emperor crush those who threaten the peace! A place of glory, glamour, and gold! And a place where you can find the perfect breeding partner!”

[**El Presidente**] activated.

He quickly surveyed the audience, finding that many minions held a letter in hand. Batling Charlene had managed to distribute them in time.

“Each of you has also received a printed *Letter of Breeding*!” Vainqueur explained. “Each letter assigns you a number, and provides you with a list of *other* numbers; those of the perfect breeding partners, selected by me, your beloved master!”

He had spent many nights reviewing Corpseling Jules’ records, crafting entire trees of potential minion combinations.

“The letter also contains the coordinates of a location where compatible numbers must gather at the end of the day!” Vainqueur declared. “There, if you take the time to search, you *will* find the perfect soulmate, hidden among the choices presented to you!”

By turning this important matchmaking into a game, Vainqueur’s tactic would force his minions to exchange between themselves, to foster bonds while trying to find the perfect mate.

As expected, his announcement was warmly welcomed, for so long as the dragon lived, none of his minions would die unloved.

Congratulations! By creatively encouraging your minions to get busy, you have earned one [**Dungeon Breeder**] level! You earned the [**MonsterHusbandry**] Class Perk!

+30 HP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK

[Monster Husbandry]: Your minions gain +5 to checks against negative status ailments, with their future children gaining permanent Resistance to [Disease], [Paralysis], and [Poison]. The conditions for your minions to spontaneously evolve into higher forms are lowered; promoted minions keep their previous class levels.

No longer would he suffer from poor goblin stock; the dragon would ensure the new generation would be up to his standards, dedicating their entire bloodlines to the betterment of his hoard.

“Now, welcome the minions who passed the preliminaries!” Vainqueur ordered. “Each of them granted a Crest for their prowess! Each of them with the power to shake the walls of this arena, and paint the sand with sweat!”

A golden door opened in the area below, the contestants walking into the arena under the acclaims of the bloodthirsty crowd.

Junior, as expected, was the favorite; the overgrown mimic had scared away all his opponents with fangs and blades. His spawn, Buzz Jelly, had also secured a place, leaping after its adoptive parent.

Barnabas the troll followed after them, covered head to toe in heavy armor and carrying a heavy mace as his weapon. Jules the Necromancer, ever discreet, slithered with his hands together next to Rolo the golem. The sixth contestant, Miel the angel, stuck her tongue out at Malfy in the stands, having defeated the fiend in the preliminaries to secure her spot.

Batling Charlene suspected that the angel only entered the tournament to beat her rival, and get ‘free exposure.’

While the audience kept acclaiming the contestants, who bowed before the emperor amidst a ring of molten glass, Vainqueur immediately noticed problems with the line-up.

“What are you doing here, farmer, instead of taking care of my food supply?” the dragon asked Rolo. The golem did not even need a Crest.

“Rolo wanted to try gladiator battles,” the golem said with enthusiasm.
“Rolo has interests other than farming!”

Vainqueur couldn't scold such dedication to the sport. However, he counted only six of them, out of eight. “Minion Charlene,” the dragon whispered to his Arena Architect. “Where are Sweet Chocolatine and Untasty Allison? You told me they passed.”

“Allison is sick, and Chocolatine volunteered to help her recover her health. Since you intend for a minion... ‘gathering’ after the tournament, and Allison is the priestess in charge of these events, I thought better to let her rest. Why? Is this a problem?”

Yes! Vainqueur could not hold a one-on-one tournament with only six fighters! There would be an odd number on the second turn! His eyes surveyed the stands, the solution instantly coming up upon catching sight of Jolie.

“Minions,” Vainqueur addressed the crowd. “You came here for a show, and I will give you the best of the best! A battle the likes of which you have never seen!”

His fans whistled and clapped at his announcement, their bloodthirstiness pumping him with energy.

“To honor the presence of my beautiful niece, Jolie,” Vainqueur's niece's head perked up, the minions clapping at her. “I will inaugurate this Colosseum by dueling her in a minion battle, using the six contestants as my fighters!”

His ‘champions’ exchanged glances, while his niece squealed in happiness at the surprise. “Uncle, I accept the challenge with great joy!” said Jolie. “My Kobold Rangers and my Kia will fight for my favor!”

Vainqueur winced at her wording, but his disgust was drowned by his excitement, as the crowd kept chanting, “*Battle, battle, battle!*”

“Each dragon trainer can select up to six minions,” Vainqueur laid down the rules. “Any trainer can switch between their minions at any time, but cannot support their pets with either Perks or items. Neither can minions summon other minions, and a minion who can no longer fight is considered out. The match will end when all of a trainer’s minions have fainted.”

[**King of Games**] activated.

Vainqueur’s mind explored every possible team combination, every minion management tactic that could help him prevail. The dragon had experience and power on his side, but Jolie had a legendary minion on her team... and the emperor’s one remained unavailable. This may prove a close match.

But if his minions managed to defeat Knight Kia before Jolie’s eyes, then he could finally destroy the blinding respect his niece had for her!

Vainqueur observed his champions with delight, the *perfect* strategy assembling in his mind.

After a few minutes, Jolie’s team, made of the Kobold Rangers and Knight Kia, entered the arena and faced the other contestants. Knight Kia, in particular, seemed eager to fight all but Angel Miel, a detail the dragon memorized for later. He knew that Jolie would keep her precious ace for last.

“Buzz Jelly, I choose you!” Vainqueur roared, his slimy champion hopping at the center of the battleground.

“For Empire!” the slime shouted with patriotic pride.

Jolie sent Black Ranger into the fray first, who immediately opened the hostilities with volleys of purple magical projectiles. The jelly hoped around them, while the grown-up kobold escalated to throwing lightning bolts, arrows of flame, and basic spells.

Vainqueur briefly marveled at how quickly the reptile had mastered magic—and found himself vexed that he himself still struggled with [Geomancy].

“Slime, use tackle!” Vainqueur ordered, giving his old kobold minion no mercy in this battle. “Find a chink in his defense, and smash him!”

“[SpaceZ]!” Moving almost faster than the eyes could follow, the tiny slime hit poor Black Ranger and ferociously slammed him against a golden wall. When Buzz unstuck itself, the reptile laid defeated, his bones broken by the *brutal* attack.

“Black Ranger is...” Batling Charlene began, as Vainqueur glared at her for her complete lack of enthusiasm in her announcements. “Black Ranger is unable to continue! The victory belongs to the slime!”

“I recall my Jelly, and send Angel Miel to take its place!” Vainqueur announced while the crowd cheered for their chosen slime, to shake things up.

“Blue, go crush that puny angel!” Jolie said in return.

“No, Jolie!” Knight Kia protested. “This is a terrible idea!”

Indeed. Blue was a priest type, and so from what Vainqueur understood, weak against an angel type. What a costly tactical mistake!

“I will prove myself to the great niece!” Blue insisted, raising his holy staff.

“Strike me, and I shall turn the other cheek,” Angel Miel said, confusing both her master and opponent by joining her hands together.

“Attack!” Vainqueur ordered, but the angel refused to obey him. That kind of thing always happened with traded minions! “Now is not the time to disobey your master!”

“Here I go!” Blue Ranger exploited the opportunity, incanting a spell and summoning a sphere of flames. “[Fireball]!”

The undead launched the projectile at the angel, only for the sphere to extinguish itself before it could even burn her wings. “What?” the priest protested, trying to summon a new one. “[Fireball]! [Fireball]!”

Yet his magic failed him.

“To strike an angel, except in self-defense, is against Mithras’ scriptures!” Kia warned. “He won’t grant you his power if you attack first!”

“This is ridiculous!” Blue complained. “I can lose my phenomenal cosmic power by breaking a stupid rule? I knew I should have turned to the Moon Man!”

“By striking against Heaven, thou undead shall be punished!” Angel Miel said, tightening her hands. “[Judgment]!”

A beam of light, weaker than the one Knight Kia once used on Vainqueur long ago, fell from the skies and hit Blue in the head. When the shining flash weakened, the poor ranger laid unconscious in the middle of a small crater.

“Blue Ranger cannot continue,” Charlene decided. “Miel is the victor!”

“Excellent, my bird of victory!” Vainqueur congratulated his minion, most of the audience clapping while the fiends remained silent. “You have followed my perfect strategy to the letter!”

“You planned this, Uncle?” Jolie asked with amazement.

“Of course,” Vainqueur said. No need to trouble her young mind with the thought that he may be fallible.

“I owe this victory to my superior heavenly education, and afterlife insurance,” Tasty Miel spoke to the audience. “You too can take care of your soul, by subscri—”

“Next!” Vainqueur roared before the angel could bore him to sleep. “Junior!”

“Treasure treasure!” The excalitrap replied in mimicspeak, while Pink Ranger took the field against it with a harp in hands.

“Pet of my minion, go easy on my bard!” Vainqueur asked, who while ruthless in a game, still wanted Sweet Pink to sing his praise later. “I will not tolerate you harming her too grievously!”

Not that he needed it, for Junior seemed to hesitate at striking the bard on its own; perhaps moved by a strange kind of familiarity. In response, Pink began to sing a powerful lullaby about swords coming to punish the naughty mimics. The excalitrap stumbled, threatening to fall asleep, and forcing Vainqueur to recall it for later.

This time, the dragon sent Barnabas. The troll wasted no time in trying to smash poor Pink with his mace, but the smaller reptile proved herself slippery and quick, dodging attacks while stringing her harp. The musical instrument released powerful shockwaves

Yet every time the sonic attacks seemed to damage Barnabas, his bones put themselves back in place, or his wounds closed.

[Troll Regeneration] activated.

As expected, the troll would recover from whatever damage his enemy could inflict, wearing down Pink even if he couldn’t hit her. However, Jolie seemed to have a few surprises in store. “Use the scary story!” she shouted to her minion. “Use the scary song!”

Pink Ranger began to play a dark, sinister song, a dark aura wearing down Barnabas. “*Bad to the Bone, chapter one...*”

Vainqueur trembled as Pink sung a heretical, scary song. Terrible rhymes sung a nameless lich’s warped, obsessive love for a dragon, and his desire to turn his hoard to dust to get his rival’s attention all for himself. Many in the audience seemed to throw up as Pink shamelessly went into adult-only details, grossing out even her troll opponent.

Pink Ranger’s **[Requiem for a Lich]** prevented **[Troll Regeneration]** from activating!

When Pink next used a sonic attack, the troll staggered but didn't heal again. Yet, eager to make his master proud - and the cursed song end - the blacksmith kept pursuing the bard, shrugging off her attacks with single-minded determination.

In the end, the cat and mouse ended when Barnabas tackled Pink while bleeding from the sonic damage. Proving herself as frail as she was quick, one blow was enough to defeat Pink, but the troll collapsed from the strain of the song, unable to go on.

“Double knock-out!” Batling Charlene decided when neither contestant could rise up.

Vainqueur's first loss of minion, but he still held the lead. The struggle wasn't to win, but to keep most of his team in reserve for when Knight Kia would take the field. Kobold minions dragged the wounded contestants off the area to recover.

“Prepare to face your doooooom!” Yellow readied himself for battle, clad in golden armor and carrying a sword of light.

“An undead [Paladin]?” Batling Charlene seemed astonished. “It's *possible* to be both?”

Vainqueur hesitated to send Angel Miel, before deciding to keep her in reserve for the true threat. He hesitated between which minions to use when one of them volunteered on its own.

“Sword!” Junior grabbed its sword lure with a hand to wield it. Yellow took a step back in fear at the sight of the bigger ‘swordsman,’ but held steadfast in his resolve.

“[Elemental Saber: Fire]!” Junior wreathed his sword lure in flames and raised it high under the sunlight.

Junior's Sword will now inflict additional [**Fire**] Damage!

Both fighters exchanged a series of parries and swings, Yellow showing surprising finesse, while Junior embodied relentless power. For a moment, it seemed that both would remain locked in a long duel.

That lasted until Junior lost patience. “[Phantom Blade]!”

The excalitrap raised a free hand, a spectral, fantasmal curved saber materializing in its palm. Before poor Yellow could retaliate, the overgrown mimic unleashed a savage flurry of blows with both weapons, forcing the paladin on the defensive.

While to Vainqueur’s eyes, the mimic lacked any sense of technique, it more than compensated with speed and frenetic fury. Yellow managed to hold his ground for a few seconds, but the moment he failed to parry one strike, Junior shattered his arm with a well-placed swing, before savagely battering him into unconsciousness. The excalitrap let out a victorious roar, before viciously smashing his opponent’s blade underfoot.

With that ranger down, Jolie had only two minions left; her strongest. As expected, Red Ranger took over to avenge his kin, a blade in his left hand and a musket in the right.

“Sword defeat,” the mimic told Red menacingly, swinging both his blades.

“This is not like before!” the raptor replied, casting spells. “[Skill Up], [Agi Up]!”

Junior used his deadly fury of attacks again, but moving at a speed exceeding even that of Pink, Red easily dodged each and every strike. The more he avoided it, the more the mimic grew angrier and sloppier.

“Junior, return to me!” Vainqueur ordered, but the mimic ignored him. “MINION! GET BACK HERE!”

But the beast refused to listen, too obsessed by the thought of crushing its opponent’s blade.

Eventually, after driving the bigger monster mad with frenzy, Red circled around it and shot Junior in the ankles. Junior stumbled, then collapsed as the raptor hit all its legs. Red then jumped on the creature's back while avoiding the twin swords, riding the beast like a bull while needling its back.

Eventually, exhausted, the mimic stopped struggling and admitted defeat.

"Sorry, mimiczord," Red Ranger apologized while he leapt off the creature, as other kobolds dragged the monster out of the arena.

"Sword..."

"Tinfoil!" Vainqueur ordered. "Prove yourself!"

The golem farmer happily faced Red, boasting of his power before the smaller minion. "Rolo will make a sheep out of you!"

"If you can catch me, that is!"

"Rolo will, for Rolo has an ace," the golem said. "[Hasten]."

Vainqueur recognized the word as one of the vile Furibon's spells; the match had ended before it began.

As he did against Junior, Red attempted to circle around the golem, shooting at his ankles... but the construct bull rushed him with incredible swiftness, time itself seemed to accelerate around the machine. Surprised, Red attempted to fall back, only for Rolo to punch him right in the chest.

THOMP!

Critical hit!

Vainqueur winced as he heard Red's ribs cave in with a sickening crack, the poor minion knocked out in one blow. The raptor, stronger than his fellows, struggled to put himself back on his feet but eventually collapsed under the strain.

“You did well,” Jolie comforted her minions, before glancing at her final champion. “Kia, avenge them!”

“Angel Miel, go!” Vainqueur ordered, switching minions again. The trap was set.

“I don’t want to fight you, Miel,” the knight said, as both fighters faced one another.

“Me neither, my friend,” the angel replied, once again praying. “So I shall stand there, leaving my fate in the hands of the heavens and waiting for you to fall in guilt after striking me.”

Perfect. Knight Kia couldn’t hit Angel Miel without losing the favor of her so-called godly patron, which would soften her for the later fights. Vainqueur wouldn’t lose sleep over sacrificing an unruly minion if it meant taking down that cursed manling.

“Yeah... not gonna happen.” Knight Kia pointed a finger at the bird. “[Banishment].”

Angel Miel popped out of sight without a sound. Vainqueur blinked in surprise, as did the audience.

“I sent her back to Heaven,” Knight Kia explained. “She can’t fight anymore, so it should count as a victory?”

Charlene looked up at Vainqueur, who grumbled in frustration. Technicalities... “Miel is unable to continue,” the Batling said. “The victory belongs to Kia Bekele.”

That was bad. Vainqueur had counted on the angel at least weakening the legendary minion, but her poor performance disappointed him. The dragon sent Buzz Jelly to soften Manling Kia up, counting on the slime’s immense resistance to damage to wear down the knight.

The cosmic jelly immediately hopped and prepared to launch itself at Manling Kia. “[SpaceZ],” it muttered with its adorable voice.

Meanwhile, Kia adopted a strange position, holding her blade in the direction opposite to her foe, with one hand around the pommel and the other at its end. “[Iaijutsu Counter]!”

Warning: Kia Bekele will counter any single-target Physical attack and inflict four times the damage!

Four times? Vainqueur panicked. “Jelly, stop—”

Too late!

The patriotic slime launched himself at blinding speed at the knight, who hit it with her sword in the middle of the jump. The flat part of her blade hit the jelly’s face like a staff, the ground below them trembling from the aftershock.

Yet Kia’s strike prevailed, sending the jelly flying through the clouds like a cannonball. Vainqueur didn’t even see it land.

“Buzz Jelly cannot continue! The winner is Kia Bekele!” While Knight Kia expected applause, the audience instead booed her for striking at a national hero. The manling sulked without a word, her face grim.

Vainqueur sent Rolo next, growing tense. The knight had disrupted his perfect strategy without even trying! He hoped that the world’s most powerful farmer could match the power of this eyesore.

“[Hasten],” the golem accelerated time around himself and charged at the knight, seemingly to smash her with his fists.

Knight Kia immediately adopted the same defensive stance as last time, preparing to retaliate with a fearsome counterattack.

“[Earthquake]!”

Instead, Rolo hit the ground with both fists at the last second, causing the entire arena to shake and throwing debris in all directions. Kia was hit head on, disrupting her defense, and allowing the golem to land a punch on her shoulder.

However, while a single blow had demolished Red, it only managed to dislocate the manling's shoulder.

“Finally, a challenge!” Knight Kia rejoiced as she leaped back to put distance between both fighters, raising her blade to the skies. “[Solar Judgment]!”

A massive, blinding ray of light fell upon the golem, pinning him to the ground.

“[Full Heal].” A green aura surrounded Knight Kia, healing all her wounds and putting her shoulder back in place. She then quickly threw a miniature sun at the golem with her free hand, Rolo powering through. “How many HP do you have?!”

“Enough!” Rolo replied, engaging his opponent in close combat.

What followed was a repetitive cycle of Knight Kia and Rolo exchanging blows, the manling backing down to heal herself back to full health, before jumping back into the fray. For a while, both seemed evenly matched.

But the longer the duel lasted, the more Vainqueur grew worried. The farmer didn't recover from his wounds, while the knight did. The battle had turned into one of attrition... and the golem didn't have the advantage.

In the end, it took *twenty-five* minutes for Knight Kia to finally bring Rolo down, beating him into scraps with her sword after she wasted too many SPs to keep casting strong spells. Kobold servants dragged the body out of the arena, alongside those of the other contestants, leaving Kia victorious, but exhausted.

But it didn't matter. What mattered was that Vainqueur had lost almost his entire team, while Knight Kia remained mostly unharmed, even if SP deprived. The dragon only had Jules the Necromancer left, the corpse-ling clearly aware, deep in his bones, that he couldn't win.

Impossible! Who could save Vainqueur's honor from defeat at the hands of this accursed knight?!

A portal suddenly opened in the middle of the arena, answering the dragon's prayers.

Chapter 76: Graduation Day

- *Year Two: “Victor Dalton and the Archdevil’s Chambers.”*

“This is an excellent idea for an artifact,” Isabelle Maure said. “But without Hell’s Prime Contract to which all souls are bound, it will never work. You will need to summon and convince all demons of the Ars Goetia.”

“Can you teach me?” Victor asked, waiting for the foul price she would certainly ask.

“Yes,” she sensually crossed her legs. “But not for free.”

“I have nothing to offer,” Victor began his well-oiled speech. “But my body and soul!”

“Then strip.”

“... and that is how you animate a flesh golem,” Camilla told Victor, as the necromancer sewed dozens of corpses into a single giant. “As you can see, while the process is similar to animating zombies, the crossing of necrotic streams makes it much more difficult...”

“You call *that* a deathtrap?” Deathjester complained, after examining the poisoned bloody spikes. “You aren’t supposed to give the captive an escape route! Again!”

What? That was thirty of them so far! How many trapped hallways would Victor have to design before he gained a level in [Architect]?

Congratulations! For judiciously training your soul-fu, you earned a level in **[Reaper]**!

+30 HP, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK

- *Year Three: "Victor Dalton and the Half-dead Matador."*

"Maure shall not be sent overplane!" the specter of Brandon Maure shouted, having stolen enough life energy from Isabelle to regain some amount of corporeal substance.

"How could you do that to your own mother?" Victor said, disgusted. Cock-blocking him was one thing, but that part was beyond irredeemable!

"She is my mother, my property! I do what I want with it!"

"This will be a true test of your necromancy skills," Camilla told him, putting her hands on his shoulders. "Remember what I taught you... use your soul... channel your spirit..."

"Dalton! For sheathing your sword where you shouldn't have, you shall perish by Maure's own!"

"Like Happyland I will!" Victor replied, spellcasting with his scythe. "I will send you back where you belong, Braniño... to your mother's basement!"

"You saved my life back then," Goblina told him, after catching him in a hallway. "You could have let Jack Frost freeze me to death, but you didn't. Why? I don't understand!"

"It's just..." Victor shook his head. "After years of intense academic rivalry, I guess... I guess I consider you a friend."

"Even after I tried to poison you? After I burned your homework?"

"Forget it, Goblina," Victor replied. "It's Scholomance. It's weird."

The goblin struggled to grasp the concept, for a while. "I guess... I guess we could form an overlord alliance?" she said, using terms she understood. "We take out all the competition for valedictorian, and then we fight for the post in the last year! What do you say?"

She offered her tiny hand.

Victor shook it. “Deal.”

Congratulations! For exorcising Brandon Maure’s spirit from his mother’s bedroom and forever grounding him, you earned a level in [Reaper]! You earned the [**Vicious Ankou**] Class Perk!

+10 SP, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA

[**Vicious Ankou**]: You steal the future of those you kill. Whenever [Helheim] traps a soul in your Scythe, you gain immunity to [Aging] for one year (multiple victims stack). The corpses of your victims age to dust after extraction of the soul; this is a [Time] effect.

“Guys, I’m *immortal*!”

“Shush!” Goblina told him, as she finished reading the *Book of the Wicked*, while the tentacled librarian glared at them both. “I have an [Eldritch Philosophy] exam tomorrow.”

“Sorry, I can’t hear you over the sound of my ill-gotten eternal youth!”

The library’s books wailed in response to his bragging, much to Goblina’s annoyance.

- *Year Four: “Victor Dalton, and the Goblin Princess.”*

Chocolatine de Gevaudan cannot answer your summon right now.

Please try again later.

Again? Did the time anomaly interfere with his Perk, or had something gone wrong in Murmurin? He had tried to contact people for months, to no avail. If only he could leave the school grounds...

Well, in that case, he had no choice but to use this newly crafted [Diabolist] Tier IV spell he designed. He couldn’t believe nobody else thought of it

before him. Or maybe they simply never lived long enough to distribute that spell...

“[Succubus Booty Call]!” Victor cast in his bedroom, a pentagram of crimson light manifesting on the ground as a winged, curvaceous shape appeared within it...

Congratulations! For inventing new soul-based spells to fulfill your darkest desires, you earned a level in [**Reaper**]!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA

“Goblin, I don’t want to fight you!” Victor panted as his blood dripped on his scythe.

“Neither do I,” the goblin he had once called a friend replied, her sword too, red with Victor’s blood. “But I won’t let you get in my way!”

“We were supposed to unite against the Headmaster and expose his treachery!” Victor protested. “You weren’t supposed to *join* him!”

“I must avenge my clan... and kill that paladin! Only Sablar can give me the power needed. The power of time itself.”

“I thought we were friends!”

“We’re not friends!” Goblin snarled. “There can only be one Valedictorian!”

“So that’s it,” Victor glared back at her. “From now on... we’re enemies!”

Congratulations! For fighting an up and rising goblin overlord into a bitter tie, you earned a level in Reaper! You earned the [**Soulmaster V**] Class Perk!

+1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK

[**Soulmaster V**]: You can now learn and use [Necromancy], [Rituals], and [Diabolism] spells up to Tier V. Reaper levels now count as Caster levels

for the purpose of class restrictions, and if a class grants you a spellcasting tier in your specialized schools of magic, they will stack with Soulmaster V. This replaces [Soulmaster IV].

- *Year Five: “Victor Dalton, and the Order of the Ghouls.”*

“From the Outer Gate, we call upon the guidance of Yog-Sothoth,” Victor chanted alongside five other students, all of them surrounding a sacrificial goat. “Line our brains with eyes, so that we may glimpse the cosmic truth! [Ritual of Eldritch Insight]!”

But something was wrong... the energies... the streams of energies didn’t align! The stars weren’t right!

They weren’t summoning Yog-Sothoth! They were summoning... something ancient... something inhuman...

Something *racist*.

Congratulations! For accidentally summoning and befriending Cthulhu through an ancient, foul ritual, you earned a level in [**Reaper**]!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK

“Brains?” the ancient, mummified ghoul asked, as the eldritch spirit settled in its rotten flesh. “Babies?”

Victor glanced at Camilla, who was raising a thumbs-up in pride.

“Babies’ brains?” the ghoul asked again, with a hopeful look on its face.

Congratulations! For reviving the ancient Order of the Ghouls to oppose the Headmaster’s machinations, you earned a level in [**Reaper**]! You earned the [**Reanimator**] Class Perk!

+10 SP, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK

[**Reanimator**]: By sacrificing money or items, you can revive a living being as an intelligent undead; alternatively, you can place back one of the

souls trapped in your scythe inside a corpse, the resulting undead retaining the original soul's class levels. The funds needed to revive someone depends on the soul's value, whom you intuitively understand. This replaces **[Animate Dead]**.

- *Year Six: "Victor Dalton, and the Timeworm of Sablar."*

"You..." The dark, demonic figure of the Headmaster glared at the two students. The teachers of the school laid frozen in time, while the wormlike abomination powering the time distortion strained against its bindings. "Goblinna, how dare you betray me?!"

"I was never on your side," the goblin replied.

"We planned this since the beginning," Victor added. "Your plan to free the Timeworm of Sablar failed before it even started!"

"The beginning? No..." the wicked fiend showed his fangs. "It can't be..."

"That's right," Goblinna said. "We staged a fake rivalry for *three years straight!*"

The Headmaster let out a roar of pure rage and frustration, as both students prepared themselves for the final battle.

Congratulations! For saving the Nightlands from the Timeworm of Sablar, and finally defeating the Headmaster, you earned **two** levels in Reaper! You earned the **[Soulmaster VI]** Class Perk!

+60 HP, +10 SP, +1 VIT, +2 SKI, +2 AGI, +2 INT, +2 CHA, +1 LCK

[Soulmaster VI]: You can now learn and use [Necromancy], [Rituals], and [Diabolism] spells up to Tier VI. Reaper levels now count as Caster levels for the purpose of class restrictions, and if a class grants you a spellcasting tier in your specialized schools of magic, they will stack with Soulmaster VI. This replaces [Soulmaster V].

- *Year Seven: "Victor Dalton, and the Relics of Evil."*

As he stood on the amphitheater stage, watched by students, teachers, and three deities, Victor held his breath. Goblina remained at his side, just as tense.

Seven years had passed, although he hadn't physically aged much since acquiring the [Vicious Ankou] Perk; life was just that dangerous at Scholomance. Seven years practicing dark magic until he could cast spells all the way to Tier VI. Seven years working on a dark artifact, foiling the Headmaster's dark intrigues, and offering his body to all kinds of extraplanar outsiders.

"Seven years," Victor muttered.

"So many adventurers, you could fill a whole book," Goblina whispered back, before chuckling. "If we censor the Shoggoth in the basement."

"Don't remind me." He still showered three times a day, even after the stink left. "Seven years, dammit."

Seven years leading up to *this* moment.

"You two have been the best students of this session," Veran acclaimed them. "Goblina has proven herself the most promising bandit overlord of her generation, while you Victor, have become a skilled necromancer; both of you reached level sixty under this roof, which is almost as much as the champion of Mithras. You bring glory to this ancient institution."

"Yet it is now time to decide a valedictorian, who will be granted access to the prestigious [Weathermaker] Spellcaster class," Isabelle said. "The Dread Three will make that decision."

"We'll vote on your chosen artifact," Deathjester said. "The best-made one will win."

"I promise not to favor my apprentice in this case," Camilla added.

"You should have claimed them both like me," Deathjester pointed out. "Since you go both ways."

“Shut up Jesty,” the dark elf replied, although more amused than annoyed. “Now, show us the fruits of your labor.”

“Good luck,” Victor wished to his friend, shaking her hand. “May the better one win.”

“You too, Vic.” Since she went first, she wasted no time in showing off her treasure: a long, one-handed black mishmash of a sharp sword and a primitive rifle, made of the purest alloys.

“I present you the ultimate fusion of the two best weapons in the world, the [Deathgun Blade]!” Goblina boasted. “This powerful artifact combines the brutality of a sword, with the modern savagery of a gun! It can fire an unlimited number of [Unholy] energy bullets which bypass any resistance to that element, and thanks to its corrupted Starmetal alloy, the sword itself cut through anything!”

“Anything?” Veran asked, immediately seduced by the weapon.

“This is the most powerful weapon ever created! Perfect to conquer the world! And, *and*, it can think for itself! It can subtly corrupt the wielder, making him as malicious as the previous holder! This way, one may kill a warlord, only to become the next one!”

“That way, only the strongest wielder keeps the sword,” Veran whistled. “Ensuring every new warlord is more powerful than the last!”

“This is a very good concept,” Deathjester said. “Albeit a classical one. I wish you had shaken up the formula a little, but it’s a proven strategy.”

“But does it have any utility outside of combat?” Camilla asked.

“It is not made for combat, but victory!” Goblina boasted, but the goddess still noticed the chink in the presentation and kept asking questions.

As expected, Victor’s rival had perfected the combat part, exalting all the way it could help kill heroes in direct confrontation. This weapon was certainly the best, most dangerous sword in the realms, and would clearly

become in very high demand among conquerors. Swords had that timeless appeal, especially among artifacts.

The Vizier, meanwhile, had chosen another path to explore, one that he hoped would win him the vote.

“Thank you for your presentation, Goblina,” Camilla said, glancing at her apprentice next. “Victor, if you would. I cannot wait to see what you have in store.”

“You do not know?” Deathjester asked, his fellow deity shaking her head. She had made a conscious effort not to read her student's mind on that matter. “Interesting.”

The necromancer had gone at great lengths to keep it under wraps, pouring his very soul into this item. Literally. “Gentledeities, gentledevils,” Victor said, unveiling his artifact from under his cloak. “I present you the [Black Grail].”

A chalice made of bones coated in black, soulsteel metal, the artifact could be held with one hand; its maker had crafted a dragon-like face on its surface, with two rubies for eyes.

“A cup?” Veran asked, immediately disappointed.

“This cup is the most powerful, insidious, and versatile weapon of mass destruction ever seen in Outremonde. This is a *revolution!*” Victor put the chalice on the ground. “But a demonstration would be quicker.”

Putting the chalice on the ground, he slightly cut his wrist with his scythe, drawing a few ounces of blood and pouring them into the cup. The audience watched, mesmerized, as the blood turned into a black mud through the power of the grail.

“Once blood is shed, the Chalice turns it into a black substance,” Victor said. “If this black blood is poured from the cup onto a corpse, it immediately revives it as they were right before their demise.”

“This is not undeath?” Camilla asked.

“The person *looks* alive, but its body is actually animated by the chalice’s power, preventing them from aging; we will call these pseudo-undead [Arisen]. They no longer age, but appear living to themselves and others. The [Black Grail] can only revive two kinds of people though; those whose souls have been captured by my [Helheim] Perk, or condemned to the infernal plane called Hell.”

He literally had to sleep with an archdevil to get the necessary contract, and she had insisted he use the old brand Hell instead of Happyland for the presentation.

“This is an interesting concept,” Deathjester commented. “But I feel it lacks a certain... I don’t know... a catch.”

“Ah, but you should read the fine print,” Victor joked, the demons who assisted him chuckling. “For when an [Arisen] is revived, they are secretly bound to a [Soul Pact], which allows me to [Enthrall] them at will, with no check allowed!”

“No check?” The other students gasped, while Camilla beamed more and more as the presentation continued.

“And, the cherry on the cake,” Victor trailed. “If I am ever killed, the chalice will automatically capture my soul, which will take over the artifact.”

“So if any minion pours back black blood on your corpse...” Deathjester guessed.

“I will revive,” Victor said. “And I can still telepathically command the [Arisen] from within the [Black Grail] as my minions.”

“This is brilliant!” Veran understood the implications. “You can loan it to a warlord to raise back armies, again and again, unaware that you can snatch away his soldiers at any moment!”

“The artifact will attract the attention of all sorts of suckers eager to raise their loved ones, and since the revived are not aware of the catch,” Deathjester muttered. “You can turn people into timebombs. Even if the catch becomes known, desperate people will still flock to it.”

“And [Arise] are one of the most advanced forms of undead that I have heard of,” Camilla said. “Well done.”

The students and teachers applauded Victor, who bowed politely. He recovered the cup and stood next to Goblina. “It is now time for the vote,” said Isabelle Maure. “What will our patrons choose?”

“The choice couldn’t be more obvious to me,” Camilla spoke up first. “While the [Deathgun Blade] is certainly a very fine artifact, it lacks the sheer potential of its competition. My vote goes to Victor.”

“I am very tempted to vote for the [Black Grail] too,” Veran said, Goblina fidgeting, “I am very, *very* tempted, but...”

Victor tensed, while his goblin competitor rejoiced.

“I cannot vote against an unholy gun,” the goddess said. “I choose the [Deathgun Blade].”

All eyes settled on Deathjester, who would cast the final vote. The silence became unbearable, as the deity seemed intent on dragging out the tension. “Veran,” he finally spoke up.

“Yes?”

“Do you remember what I told you back in our last session?” Deathjester asked, the goddess sinking in her chair. “*Because too many guns.*”

Victor’s heart skipped a beat. Could it be?

“The valedictorian of this year,” the god of crime pointed his index finger at the Vizier, “Is Victor Dalton of Murmurin!”

The amphitheater exploded into cheers and applause, leaving Victor speechless; especially since the gods were the most vocal about it. While clearly disappointed, Goblina ended up congratulating him as well.

Congratulations! For being chosen as the valedictorian of Scholomance, you can now take levels in the ultra-prestigious [**Weathermaker**] spellcaster class!

All these years of raising the dead to master the essence of souls, and opening his mind through eldritch rituals, had finally paid off!

“Congrats, Vic,” Goblina said. “You have been the best frenemy a goblin could hope for.”

“You too. We’ll stay in contact, I hope?” The two had become thick as thieves over all their adventures. “I mean, we still have that Jack Frost loose end to deal with. I’m sure he will come back to haunt us again.”

“Sure!” Goblina replied. “If you ever come across my new empire, I will have a few jobs for you! But no squids.”

“No squids,” Victor fist-bumped her.

“As promised,” Camilla said upon approaching her protegee before touching his shoulder. The physical contact made him shiver in both pleasure and subconscious fear. “Here is a little reward.”

Victor sensed a mark appear on his back, another joining the collection.

[**Claimed by Camilla**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Vitality or Agility point. You automatically gain the secondary [Undead] type, including all of its strengths and vulnerabilities.

Perk conflict detected! Priority affected the oldest Perk! Change to [Undead] type negated by [Darwinist]!

“I believe it was long overdue,” the goddess said. “I did make a proposal to get your soul when you first died. That will be difficult now, but I encourage my followers to haunt the realm of the living however they can.”

“So... what happens now?” Victor asked, eying Isabelle Maure, who would follow him to Murmurin.

“What happens next?” Camilla repeated with a coy smile. “It’s all up to you.”

“I would like to continue our [Necromancy] lessons,” Victor said. “I intend to cap [Reaper] after gaining a [Heroic Crest] and to master necromancy as a whole. I feel like I only scratched the potential of sorcery here.”

“With pleasure,” Camilla said. “I believe that you have great potential, and I would enjoy furthering your education. But those are extra hours, and I have a revolution to manage... I will not be as available as I was in this academy. Neither will I put in the effort for free.”

“Do you want my money or liquid assets?”

She laughed at his brazen, dirty joke. “Oh, I have a few errands a champion of undeath could make on my behalf, especially in the New World,” the death goddess said. “Your artifact might find an audience there, but we shall see when the time comes.”

Well, here ended Victor’s vacation. He wondered what happened to Murmurin in his absence.

He hoped it was still standing.

Chapter 77: Starter vs Legendary

Like a savior, Vainqueur's friend rode through the portal on his dark horse's back.

He looked exactly the same as the day he left, covered by his armor and swinging his scythe. Yet his posture had changed. He seemed more confident, with his back straight and his shoulders high. Vainqueur knew his friend had become the apex of a chief of staff, second only to his dragon master. Two skeletal servants followed after him, carrying bags and a black cup.

The crowd exploded into cheers at the Vizier's triumphant return, much to his silent surprise. "Wow, they look really happy to see me," Friend Victor muttered to his mount.

"Don't count me among them," the horse complained. "You've somehow gotten even heavier to carry around."

Manling Victor narrowed his head at the sight of Knight Kia standing on the opposite end of the arena, before glancing up at Jolie, and finally his master. "Have I come back just in time for the tournament, Your Majesty?"

"You could not have said it better, minion!" Vainqueur cleared his throat. "Citizens of Murmurin! To celebrate the return of my chief of staff, Grand Vizier Victor shall do the thing! He will fight Knight Kia instead of Corpseling Jules!"

"Oh, thank Camilla," Jules rejoiced, knowing his master's honor was saved.

"Fight Kia? What?" Manling Victor looked at his future opponent. "What the Happyland?"

“Come on, it will be fun!” Knight Kia said, eager to be defeated by a dragon; even half of one.

Vainqueur’s Vizier didn’t sound keen on the idea, perhaps out of a misplaced fear of embarrassing his master. “You actually *want* us to fight?”

“Actually, I’ve daydreamed about it for a while,” Knight Kia admitted, before quickly adding. “In a friendly spar way!”

“Kia will crush you like the rest!” Jolie boasted on behalf of her minion. “She is the strongest minion in the *world*!”

“Your Kia may be a legendary chief of staff, but mine is better trained!” Vainqueur defended his chief of staff, who had been his starting minion since he started adventuring. “And he has the overwhelming [Dragon] type advantage!”

Victor let out a sigh, before climbing off his horse. The animal immediately teleporting away with a moan of relief, the skeletal servants after them. “Can somebody tell me the rules?”

As Vainqueur reminded everyone of them, the Vizier listened in silence, before muttering, “Six fighters, you give us orders as our trainers and... Wait, is this a dog fight? Are *we* the dogs?”

“Kia Kia,” Manling Kia replied with heavy sarcasm, clearly stressed at the thought of fighting a half-dragon.

“Oh you, shut up,” Friend Victor replied while swinging his scythe. “I can’t summon minions, but are animated items allowed?”

Vainqueur considered the matter, the problem having never presented itself in a previous minion battle. “Yes,” the dragon said. “So long as they stop working in the unlikely case you are defeated, for the sake of fairness.”

“Good, although it sucks hard that I can’t summon,” Victor complained. “It removes a third of my spell list.”

“I will let you take the first swing then,” Kia said, jumping on place to stretch her legs. “Impress me.”

“Alright, your loss of sleep then,” Victor replied, raising his scythe. “[Nightmare Lord]!”

The very world shifted around Manling Victor, unnatural energies spreading through the arena. A noxious, purple miasma filled the air and covered the ground while screaming, ghostly figures made of mist swirled around Knight Kia; fanged skeletal maws surged from below, while yellow eyes grew on the walls alongside a thick, crimson moss.

Kia backed down, as the Colosseum became *alive*, the walls growing decorations such as mosaics of whispering humanoid skulls. The strange effect stopped right at the border of the arena before it could spread to the stands, although the phantom eyes glanced at the citizens in the stands with hunger.

Your arena turned into a **[Nightmare Realm]** Field!

Of course, the minions cheered at the spectacle. “*Best special effects!*” “*Crush her, Lord Victor!*” “*Show her!*”

“What the...” Knight Kia bristled, as the mist ghosts passed through her chest, turning her skin whiter.

[Kia Bekele] is being **[Drained]** of her HP/SP!

“Kia, use the beam!” Jolie barked orders to her minion. “The sunbeam!”

Her chief of staff raised her sword, calling upon her last reserves of SP to use her most powerful ability. “[Solar Judgment]!”

“Minion, dodge!” Vainqueur ordered, but his minion disobeyed.

“[Spirit Shield].” A purple, spherical barrier of ghostly energies surrounded manling Victor, deflecting the pillar of light. “[Victor’s Summoned Skulls].”

Two dozens floating golden skulls—Vainqueur approved of his minion’s taste—appeared around the shield, before flinging themselves at Knight Kia. The paladin adopted the defensive pose she used against Buzz and Rollo, expecting a physical attack.

Instead, the skulls opened their mouths and fired ghostly rays at her.

The knight deflected the beams with her sword, but the skulls soon circled her and attacked from all directions. Meanwhile, the arena’s specters kept draining the legendary minion.

“[True Breath of Life], [Protection from Holy], [Necromantic Ward], [Eldritch Benediction], [Fallen Auspices], [Elemental Veil], [Vorpal Blade]...” Manling Victor replied, casting spells to reinforce himself from the safety of his shield. “[Fear Aura], [Breath of Plagues]...”

All your minion’s stats have been raised by one stage!

Your minion will now resist [**Fire**], [**Earth**], [**Wind**] and [**Water**]!

Your minion’s [**Killer Scythe +**] has been greatly bolster—

As a long, long list of messages appeared before Vainqueur’s eyes, one of the skulls managed to hit Kia in the shoulder, making the knight angrier. “[Sunburst],” she declared, her body radiating a burst of holy flames, vaporizing the skulls and even repelling some of the specters. “[Full He—]”

“[Black Curse]!” Manling Victor cast, a dark aura surrounding Kia and negating her healing. Vainqueur guessed the minion’s strategy: exploit the field to weaken the legendary minion, prevent her from healing, then catch her after wearing her down enough!

“I *hate* disruption tactics,” Kia said, summoning a circular barrier of light around herself. “[Mithras’ Grace], [Hasten]...”

She copied his chief of staff! What a hack! “Minion, do not let her make a fool of you!” Vainqueur ordered. “Attack!”

“It will cost me HP, but here I come...” Manling Victor replied, “[Pact with the Archfiends]!”

Sinister energies converged around the Vizier, whose body underwent a radical transformation as his spirit shield collapsed.

What? [**Victor Dalton**] is evolving!

The *Doer of the Thing* grew in size into a twelve feet tall behemoth of muscle, with cloven hooves for feet; a stinger grew at the end of his dragon tail, and his face changed into that of a skeletal ram. His armor and scythe grew to fit his new size, turning him into a fearsome figure.

Congratulations! Your [**Victor Dalton**] evolved into [**Demonling Victor**]!

While the few angels in the audience recoiled and booed at the sight, the fiends in the audience became all but possessed.

Vainqueur, meanwhile, was *furious*. “Minion!”

“**What, Your Majesty?**” Demonling Victor replied, his voice transformed into a guttural growl.

“You were supposed to become closer to the majesty of *dragons*, not to *livestock*!”

“Oh, you know that spell?” Knight Kia replied, more curious than surprised. “It’s been years since I saw a wizard cast it. Don’t you go to Hell if you die afterward, though?”

“**Not if you have soul stock-options,**” Demonling Victor spoke, as a dark aura surrounding Knight Kia. “[**Death Hex**].”

[**Demonling Victor**]’s successful armed attacks against [**Kia Bekele**] will become critical hits.

With a dragonlike roar, Demonling Victor charged at his rival, carried on by Vainqueur’s cheers.

And charge he did. Even if tainted by livestock blood, his chief of staff moved faster than ever before, almost as much as the Maure insect in his prime. He crossed the light barrier as if it wasn't there, and raised his scythe for the kill.

Knight Kia, worn down by the misty specters swarming the arena, shrouded her sword in light and parried the blow. Even with the difference in size, the warrior matched the Vizier in strength; even if Vainqueur hated to admit it, she had been one of the few beings capable of harming him, and it showed.

Demonling Victor parried the strike, as both fighters engaged in a deadly dance of blades. Knight Kia, moving inmanlingly fast, dodged the scythe time and time again; while the Vizier parried a few swings, the paladin proved herself too difficult to counter, her blade piercing his armor on half a dozen occasions. Yet at no point did she manage to shed blood, much to her frustration.

[**Demonlayer**] effect negated by [**Darwinist**]!

While he slowly pushed his foe against the arena's walls with a flurry of attacks, Demonling Victor failed to get past the knight's guard. She hopped around the demonic chief of staff like a slime, her speed slightly exceeding his own.

“[Freezing Edge].” The warrior's sword released a chilly glow, before piercing Demonling Victor's hide again. This time, the sword cut deep and made the chief of staff snarl in pain. “I knew it! Your Perk doesn't cover elemental weaknesses, only type-determined ones!”

“[**Envious**],” Victor replied, the chilling edge of the sword vanishing to reappear around the Vizier's scythe instead. Before Knight Kia could recover from the surprise, Demonling Victor hit her in the chest with a cheap shot, the sheer strength of the blow propelling her against a wall. Jolie let out a squeal of horror, worried for her minion, while Victor's wounds healed on their own.

Critical hit! [**Insta-Death**] negated!

Knight Kia almost immediately stood back to her feet, avoiding a new swing by lowering herself. Victor's scythe slashed through the wall like butter, much to Vainqueur's horror.

The knight reapplied the chilling effect to her blade and attempted to backstab her foe, but Demonling Victor acted quicker. He summoned a wall of bones below his feet, rising above the blade before it could pierce his hide. Then, using the high ground, he leaped on the knight and attempted to crush her under his heavier body. The knight barely managed to dodge, with the demodragon instantly forcing her on the defensive with a series of vicious attacks.

"Minion!" Vainqueur shouted, as his minion failed to get past the knight's impervious guard. "Use your V-Move!"

"**The what?**" his minion replied, as he barely blade-locked the paladin's sword before it could hit him in the eye. Knight Kia began a counterattack, inverting their positions.

"**THE V-MOVE!** The Vainqueur-Move!"

"**Oh, right!**" Demonling Victor inhaled, locked Knight Kia's blade with his own, and then unleashed a mighty stream of flames at the paladin from his maw.

"I'm immune to fir—" Knight Kia let out a groan of pain and surprise, as it turned out nothing could resist dragonfire. Her flesh and armor began to melt from dark flames. Why was Demonling Victor's firebreath black though? Vainqueur wondered. Did his chief of staff indulge in drugs?

"Kia!" Jolie shouted in fear, seeing her legendary minion pushed to the brink. "I believe in you! Use your V-move too!"

Knight Kia, now cornered, used the last of her strength for a final counterattack. "[Holy Sun of Mithras]."

She opened her free hand and materialized a miniature sun within it, and then shoved it against Demonling Victor's face. Determined to win, the

chief of staff kept overwhelming her with his dragonbreath.

What followed... was completely unexpected.

Both attacks resonated with one another, the energies of the holy sun mixing with Demonling Victor's unholy dragonbreath. Both swirled and contracted, before violently exploding.

The mighty detonation that followed shook the entire Colosseum, and even Vainqueur struggled to stay on his promontory as a blast of flames and holy energies cracked the walls and terminated the Field effect. A massive cloud of dust covered the battleground, leaving the fate of the battle ambiguous. The crowd turned silent, at the edge of their seats.

When the cloud of dust settled, the outcome became obvious.

Both fighters laid unconscious on the ground, with Demonling Victor having regressed back to Manling Victor—a relief to Vainqueur, who wouldn't stand a half-goat chief of staff. Knight Kia still breathed, but couldn't get back up.

“Double knockout!” Batling Charlene decided. “It's a tie!”

“Kia!” Jolie immediately flew to her minion's side.

Vainqueur sighed in relief. While he would have preferred for his champion to win, the empire's honor had been defended. “Citizens, it is time to congratulate the two winners of the day,” the dragon said. “My niece and I, for raising the strongest minions in the world!”

The crowd erupted in cheers, which made the emperor happy.

“Now minions, go heal my chief of staff!” the dragon ordered. “The rest of you, breed, and sin no more!”

Murmurin. The one place where you can leave for seven years/days, and then be expected to fight a paladin five minutes after your return. He would have been proud of tying with Kia, if he didn't owe that result to dumb luck.

Last time he used an [Unholy] attack against a [Holy] one.

At least the citizens looked very, *very* happy to see him again, the Vizier mused from below the thick blankets of his king-sized bed. Not only did they pile up tons of healing spells on him, even though he still had a long way before recovering, his fans spent minutes touching his skin as if he was Jesus reborn.

What happened to make them miss him so much?

They had even rebuilt his mansion, down to the last detail. Vainqueur's minions had painstakingly recreated every room into identical copies of the original, from the hall to the chimney room. Even his bed *felt* the same.

Instead of undead servants though, Charlene had replaced the staff with female living monsters, most of them strong, fit, greenish orcs. Each of them carried strange letters and had leered at him with less than pure intentions; although the Vizier wondered if they just found him appetizing as a potential meal.

Speaking of Charlene... "Vic, thank the twelve gods you are back." The vampire said for the tenth time. "We missed you so much!"

This sent up a whole lot of alarms. The vampire was never too affectionate with him, even while in a good mood, and yet she had remained at his bedside for the entire evening. He also noticed the 'glow' marking her for the [Mook Promotion] perk surrounding her body. "Thanks?" he replied, unsure how to deal with her strange behavior.

"You don't have to worry about taking a break anymore," she said. "Savoureuse will always prepare your favorite dishes now, the best trainers in all of Ishfania will take care of you after work, you will be protected from every poison, disease, toxin, assassinations, everything that could possibly threaten you. Nothing bad will ever happen to you again."

"Uh, okay?"

“But you have to *stay*,” she insisted as if her unlife depended on it. “You don’t need to leave anymore.”

While it had started comforting, her behavior now raised a huge number of alarm bells. “Charlene, what is wrong? Are assassins listening in a corner?”

“No, of course not. If you need anything, everyone *will* have it. Because we *love* you, in Murmurin. You are finally *home*, forever.”

What the Happyland happened in his absence? She sounded like she wanted to chain him up in his basement forever. “Why did you replace the undead servants with orcs?” the Vizier asked, smelling a trap.

“Vainqueur organized a speed breeding event at your manor,” Charlene said. “They’re here for you. All for you. So long as you *stay*.”

If this was meant to be a speed dating event, why was he the only guy in the manor, as far as he could tell? Did Vainqueur expect him to—

Oh.

Oh no, not this mess again.

"Charlene, I just took a *sun to the face*," Victor grumbled, "And my entire body feels sore, even the *dragon tail*. I am not in the mood for *breeding*."

"So what do I tell them then?" the vampire asked with astonishment.

"Tell them to come back when I’m healed, and maybe have an orgy in the basement if they can’t wait," the Vizier deadpanned, tired and annoyed.

"Lavere probably did worse down there."

“But you won’t leave?” Charlene suddenly asked again. The Vizier looked at her, then at his wounds, then back at her. The vampire understood the silent message and left him alone, closing the door behind her.

Victor could still hear her discuss with the orcs outside. “So? Who goes first?”

“He doesn’t want to breed.”

“Damn, he’s very, very sick...”

Did they take him for a pervert? True, he liked female company, but he didn’t think about them all the time either. Victor wasn’t a rabbit.

Anyway, the Vizier allowed himself to close his eyes and rest... but his respite didn’t last long.

“Mr. Victor, how good to see you back!” Victor opened his eyes, seeing a very familiar angel at his bedside with a pile of documents in her hands. “So we can talk about your karma!”

How the Happyland did she always manage to enter his room without raising an alarm? Probably an angel Perk. Still, Miel’s presence felt way more comfortable than Charlene’s right now.

“Good to see you too,” Victor said, especially since he noticed the glow around her; she was ready for a monster promotion. “What do you want to talk about? My karma files should be stainless.”

“That is what I do not understand,” she replied, too sharp for her own good. “Your karma still appears as chaotic good, after you used a spell to transform into an *archfiend* to fight a *paladin*.”

“I had to learn the spell to fight one of the most skilled villains of the age.” Which was technically true. “A teacher mastermind so dangerous, so relentless, that a friend and I had to fake a rivalry for *three years* just to stand a chance of catching him off-guard. We even had a real, dangerous battle with spells and tricks and everything.”

“Three years?”

“It was in a time anomaly, it’s complicated.” Victor shrugged off. “In any case, I won’t let the power corrupt me.”

“I will put it as a ‘heroic sacrifice,’ but do not abuse this spell,” Miel said, clinching his files with a worried look. “Please?”

“It’s a last resort,” Victor said. “I will do my best not to cause you harm with your higher-ups, especially now that they finally accepted to promote you. Congrats by the way!”

Much to his confusion, her face crumbled. “No. An Old Testamenter wrote a scathing review and the archangels vetoed my promotion for the next decade.”

“What? But you have done an excellent job! And I can [Mook Promote] you just fine, so you definitively met the conditions!”

“You can promote me?” Her head perked up before she caught herself. “No, I cannot... I cannot have a mortal promote me, it’s against the rules.”

“Look at me,” Victor said. “I can literally transform into a demon, and still keep my good karma! Because I chose what’s *right*, over what is *ordered*! Because I buried my hands deep in trashes, so others could keep their own clean!”

The angel listened, before frowning at him. "Mr. Victor."

"Yes?"

"The armor you wield," she said, "I asked my superiors about it. They said that it applies the [Cursed] ailment to pure souls who follow the path of goodness."

"... yes?"

"Then, if your karma remains truly pure... why are you *not* [Cursed]? You do not seem to have immunity to it."

...

Victor was tempted to tell the truth. He truly was.

[Diabolical Mastermind] activated!

You gain a +30 check bonus to get away with your insurance fraud!

But then, reflexes honed over seven years of [Eldritch Philosophy] classes kicked in. "Well, that's exactly my point," the Vizier replied, "Heaven's methods are outdated."

The angel's frown deepened. "Excuse me?"

"If Heaven considers me good karma, but my armor doesn't, then it means karma is fundamentally *subjective*," Victor argued, "And thus useless as an objective measurement of one's worth."

"But that's impossible!" the angel protested, "Our karma analysis has been refined over centuries! My, it is even confirmed by the System ruling Outremonde!"

"Then how do you explain the contradiction? Or the fact that someone's karma can suddenly change from good to neutral or evil through only one action? That one action can condemn you forever to *Happyland*, even if you change your mind afterward? Does that system seems *fair* to you?"

Miel remained silent, pondering the weight of his words.

"I'm just saying that instead of following the judgment of someone else, you should do what you, yourself, believe is right. Because in a purely subjective world, this is the only true answer!"

Charisma check successful!

"You are right, Mr. Victor," the angel believed his helpful lie, "I should follow what I feel is right, instead of bowing to outdated regulations! My methods are unconventional, but they brought the most SP to Heaven since the Karma+ Insurance! I *deserve* a promotion."

The angel seemed to pump herself up until she finally said. "You know what? I quit!"

"You quit *Heaven*?"

"Yes, but not for Happyland! I will promote myself to my own boss, and create the best afterlife service across the planes! The *Miel's Little Angels*

Company! I will show them all!”

“Then I will gladly be your first employer,” Victor encouraged her. “You have the talent and my support. The empire’s support. Would you like to become a governor?”

“A governor?” The angel’s eyes shone brightly. “Like a regional manager?”

“With unlimited resources and very little oversight,” Victor said. “I’ve been toying with the system, and with the Empire expanding overseas soon, I believe you more than earned a chance to manage things as you wish.”

After all, how many angels would have had the patience to deal with him and Murmurin? Precious few, from what he had gathered. Victor would rather keep good recruits on the Empire’s side, especially with a war on the horizon.

“Thank you, Mr. Victor,” the angel said with gratitude. “You are the best client an angel could want. I will pack my belongings, and then... I will take you up on your offer.”

The angel vanished in a flash of feathers, leaving Victor alone.

The Vizier wondered how she would react to Isabelle Maure, though. He would keep their territories as far from the other as possible.

Someone knocked on the door. “Yes?” Victor called.

“Viiiiic, it’s me!” Chocolatine called out. “I’m with Allison!”

“Come in!” Victor replied, relieved to hear the werewolf safe and sound. Ever since he failed to contact her through his Perk, the Vizier had worried if something had happened to her.

Chocolatine entered the room dressed like the little riding hood and with a huge basket in hands, while Allison waved a hand at the Vizier from beyond the threshold. Then the dryad politely closed the door, giving the two some privacy.

And they would need privacy.

“I baked you a medicine cake to help you recover,” Chocolatine said, after kissing the Vizier on the cheek and sitting on the bed. “I hope you like it.”

That woman was sugar. Bad for the health, but sweet.

That was what Victor thought until he opened the basket. A scaled hand stood on top of the bloody cake like a twisted candle.

“Oh, I mixed them up!” She immediately took back his cake and put it out of his sight, as if ashamed of it. “I’m sorry, this one was for Croissant...”

Victor took back what he said. Chocolatine wasn't sugar, but LSD. Pure, undiluted LSD. Still, he had grown surprisingly fond of her. “Choc, I have to admit something,” the Vizier said with a sheepish face. “Which you may take badly.”

“Uh, me too...” she replied with the exact same tone. “We go at the same time?”

Both inhaled, and then quickly said, “I cuddled Allison!” “I cuddled Satan!”

“Satan?” Chocolatine blinked. “Who’s that?”

“Not *actually* Satan, but an archfiend... and her cousin... and her trainee...”

“Then you cooked them with beans and ate them?” the werewolf asked with morbid curiosity. “Is that how you transformed into a demon? Can I do it too?”

“No!” Victor protested. “No, you can’t!”

“Oh,” she said, very disappointed but not mad at him either.

"So, you and Allison?"

“She was really lonely and burning out with all the city management work. I invited her home to console her, and I was lonely because you were gone and we had broken up and one thing led to another, and... and... and you're not mad?”

"That's why I asked for a break, no? So we could both figure ourselves out. Thing is... I *did*, one [Eldritch Philosophy] class at a time."

The werewolf listened in silence, suddenly tense and dreading his answer.

"I really like you, more than I should," Victor admitted. Like a drug, take it once and you can no longer do without. "But I value my freedom more than anything, and while a committed relationship probably has its own Perks, I don't want the compromises that come with it. I don't want to settle with someone, and I don't want to string you along either."

The werewolf listened with growing sadness but showed surprising maturity afterward. "I can't tie you up," Chocolatine admitted, before adding, hopeful. "But can I still tie you up? With ropes?"

“Sure, why not?” He had done much worse in Scholomance, and if that made her happy, he was willing to stay open-minded. “We can stay friends with Perks.”

“I can live with that,” she said, before resting her head against him. Victor let her and scratched the werewolf behind the ears. "You're still totally going to fall in love with me. Give it time."

Someone knocked on the door, and Allison walked inside, smiling at the sight of the ‘couple,’ but also carrying a huge pile of files. “You listened to everything, didn't you?” Victor asked her.

“I have, although I didn't intend to,” the priestess replied. “You seem a lot more confident, as if you cleared up an internal conflict. And if I am not mistaken, you seem to have aged a little more than seven days.”

“I have,” Victor replied. “I'm no longer on the fence about what I want with my life.”

“Good, because no way I’m filling in for you as a chief of staff, *ever again*,” she said, all but dumping the paper pile on the bed. “Here are the incident reports for the last week. I must also inform you that I covered the entire mansion with protection spells and that you may wish to avoid the basement for a few days. It will smell terrible.”

“And you’re fine with...” Victor trailed, glancing at Chocolatine and then back at the dryad.

“Vic, I am a priestess of the goddess of pleasure,” Allison replied. “If anything, free love is my religious service.”

Goddamn hippies. Victor grabbed the papers with one hand, while still cuddling Chocolatine with the other. *I guess it’s too early for a democratic council*, he thought upon reading the long list of catastrophes. *Definitively local governors*.

"Seven days, Allison!" Victor complained as he went through the reports, "I left for seven *days*."

"Ah, I also forgot the damage bill," the dryad handed him another paper with far too many zeroes. "Charlene said you would find the budget to cover it."

...

That was his student debt all over again.

Spoiler: V&V Updated Stats

Vainqueur "Best Dragon" Knightsbane

Level: 56 (Augustus 27/Witchfinder General 10/Kaiser 15/Dungeon Breeder 3/Geomancer 1)

Type: Dragon.

Party: V&V.

Health Points

6,635

Special Points 1560 Strength 148 Vitality 110 Skill 49 Agility 74
Intelligence 39 Charisma 121 (+10) Luck 72 **Personal Perks****Class Perks**
Dragonfire Breath Born in the Purple Fire Immunity For the Emperor Red
Dragon Lifeforce King of Games Dragon Arrogance Dynasty Dragonscale
Crowd Favorite Super Senses Supercrit Virgin Princess Radar Spell Purge
Lesser Poison Resistance Witch Burning Deadfriend Lesser Magic
Resistance Taunt Exorcism I Crested Hunter's Resolve El Presidente
Stipend Dungeon Owner (Castle of Murmurin) Victory Fist Summon
Herald (Victor Dalton) Imperial Authority Malefic Secrecy Monster
Empathy Charged Attack (Dragon Breath) Victory Roar Mirror Scale Fire
Crown Immovable Show-off Gold Shower Shining Majesty Golden Road
Geomancy Monster Husbandry

Victor "Minion" Dalton

Level: 60 (Monster Knight: Red Dragon 20/Reaper 29/Moriarty 9/Chaos
Rider 2)

Type: Humanoid/Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points

1305

Special Points 420 Strength 38 Vitality 39 Skill 72 Agility 60 Intelligence
61 Charisma 65 Luck 54 **Personal Perks****Class Perks** Claimed by Dice
Skeleton Key Observer Eye for Treasure Deadfriend Scythe Lord Seducer
Monster Kin Claimed by the Moon Man Minion Trainer Black Curse
Monster Student Blackfyre Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon) Claimed by
Shesha Monster Rider Crested Monster Insight Vizier Education
Reanimator Troll Regeneration Soulmaster VI Perk Forge Helheim
Darwinist Steal Life Blood Fountain Mook Promotion Claimed by

Deathjester Slayer of Men Claimed by Camilla Scarlet Study Master's
Shield Fright Knight Lethal Hades Blast Final Problem Black Horseman
Diabolical Mastermind Envious Nightmare Lord Vicious Ankou Rally
Minion

Chapter 78: The Storm

After so long, the fateful day had come.

The *Piggybank* ship, after a long time being repaired, was now ready to cross the ocean and reach the New World. The golden aircraft shone brightly under the sun, Vainqueur marveling at his own perfect reflection on its surface. His elite lackeys, from Charlene to Malfy and his Pocket Minions, observed him with awe, fear, and hope.

For the road to El Dorado would soon open!

Congratulations! For successfully causing your minions to breed on an incredibly large scale, you earned a level in [**Dungeon Breeder**]!

+10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK.

Vainqueur should have felt happy about this, but something bothered him since morning. He couldn't put his claw on what. A tension was in the air. An invisible weight on his wings.

It must have been the presence of Knight Kia, who had kept pestering Manling Victor for a rematch since she recovered. Jolie had stayed at her other minions' bedside, to cheer them up until they recovered.

"You were going very easy on me," Victor whispered to her. "I could tell."

"True, and Rolo exhausted me beforehand," the knight replied, unable to accept her defeat. "But that doesn't diminish your accomplishment either. Do you know how long it has been since *anyone* could even slightly push me? Imagine if we fought at full strength—"

Sensing the spotlight getting away from him, Vainqueur cleared his throat, interrupting the discussion.

“Today is a great day!” the dragon began his speech. “I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, will do what no dragon has done in the past! I will cross the ocean alongside my chief of staff and a crew of loyal dwarves! The Empire of Murmurin, at last, shall expand beyond the horizon!”

“For the international revolution!” Marbré raised a fist in support.

While Vainqueur expected his minions to rejoice, only Marbré, Buzz, and Junior did so. The rest glanced fearfully at Manling Victor as if fearing he would not return. In response, the chief of staff handed them floating skulls, similar to those he summoned against Knight Kia.

“These are [Whispering Skulls], which allow long-distance communication,” Manling Victor explained. “Even if [Scarlet Study] is blocked, you should be able to contact us through them.”

“I will have one planted in central square, to remind everyone you’re only leaving temporarily,” Batling Charlene said.

“As soon as we land, I shall open a [Golden Path] to my hoard, and allow settlers to claim lands in my name,” the dragon laid out his plan. “Dwarves will build a portal linking both continents, so the empire may expand without the need of ships. I expect you minions to be ready to build a new colony the second the gate opens. Anyone caught touching my hoard in my absence shall be eaten.”

“We’ll cross the ocean too, if a bit later,” Kia said. “Jolie wants to join one of the exploration fleets led by Gardemagne’s princess Merveille, so we will meet again on the other side.”

Vainqueur ignored her, turning to his elite minions. “You have proven yourself the most powerful of my lackeys, and your strength shall be called upon once we have crossed the ocean; for the wicked Furibon awaits on the other side, stronger than ever.”

Manling Victor shifted, worried about fighting the vicious lich again. As if to comfort him, his mimic pet approached him with a rainbow crest, offering it to its master. “Gift,” Junior insisted.

“Not swordy enough,” Buzz added.

“Not swordy,” Junior grunted. “Shieldy.”

“Your Majesty should use it first,” Manling Victor said, ever dutiful, “Even if you have not reached level sixty yet, the fomors will target you first.”

“And I shall teach them to fear again,” Vainqueur replied. “Minion, must I remind that when you *begged* to become my eternal servant, you had more levels than I did? If you reached the threshold before me, then you should make use of this Crest. If there are any side-effects, it is better for you to serve as my level tester than trying it myself.”

Also, the item came from the cursed Moon, and the dragon wanted nothing to do with it.

“Your concern is always touching,” Manling Victor said, accepting the [Heroic Crest] and immediately using it; the shield dissolved into a blinding cloud of multiple colors, surrounding and empowering the Vizier.

Congratulations! Your minion broke past the sixty levels class ceiling! His [Crested] Perk has been upgraded to [Epic]!

[Epic]: Marks one as a mythical adventurer and demigod. Allows access to the most powerful of classes and entrance to [Valhalla] upon reaching level 99. This replaces [Crested].

Vainqueur could not wait to gain that Perk too; he could almost smell the riches that would follow his coronation to divinity.

“Now, time for promotion,” Manling Victor declared. “Some of you can gain access to higher forms as per my [Mook Promotion] Perk. Now, a promotion grants greater power, but as Junior here can attest...”

The mimic let out a growl, scratching his back.

“This comes with physical changes.”

“Can I grow wings like you?” Chocolatine asked. “That would make it so much easier to hunt food!”

“I have no idea what you will turn into,” Victor replied. “So the choice is yours.”

“With a war on the horizon, I believe higher power should be embraced,” Jules said. “Even though I am not ready to ascend into a greater form yet.”

“Only Buzz, Charlene, Miel, Allison, and Chocolatine meet the criteria currently,” Victor confirmed.

“Mr. Victor, not I?” Tasty Malfy asked, disappointed. “After so many bribes?”

“Sorry,” the chief of staff replied, “You should come with us to the New World once we have established the permanent gateway there. Maybe you only need more practical experience?”

“So will the others who are not yet fit to lead my armies,” Vainqueur added. The dragon had organized the tournament to test the strength of his servants, and while some like Rolo the golem had proven themselves powerful, most needed more training to match the fairy lords. “I will have all of you become worthy of becoming my minion generals.”

Allison sighed. “Just go through with it, Vic.”

The chief of staff activated his Perk, five minions immediately undergoing a transformation before Vainqueur’s eyes.

Miel the angel grew taller, thicker, and gained two new sets of wings in addition to her existing ones; the lowest set of wings, however, belonged to bats instead of birds. Her once pristine white skin darkened a bit, and her eyelids developed an unnatural dark shade.

Untasty Allison grew sweet-smelling flowers all over her body, from her hair to shoulders. Antler-like horns of wood grew from her head, taking the

shape of a small crown.

Buzz Jelly, who had bravely crossed space and fought off the lead wasteland on the Moon, transformed into a slime of liquid steel, strong, yet flexible.

Sweet Chocolatine's transformation... was most disappointing. Her human ears turned into those of a silver wolf, and nothing else.

Meanwhile, Batling Charlene changed spectacularly. She gained two enormous bat wings from her shoulders, and two smaller ones from her waists, which instantly closed around her legs like a robe. Curved horns grew among her hair, and her nails became claws. Her skin grew paler still, like that of a corpse, while a third crimson eye opened right below her throat. She smiled, her lips revealing sharp fangs everywhere.

Alchemical Vampire Charlene was promoted to [**Blood Trismegistus**].

Buzz Jelly was promoted into an [**Iron Slime**].

Angel Miel was promoted into a [**Heartless Angel**].

Dryad Allison was promoted into a [**Hamadryad**].

Werewolf Chocolatine was promoted into an [**Alpha Werewolf**].

"I don't feel all that different," Chocolatine complained, her new ears wagging.

"Speak for yourself!" Batling Charlene replied, carressing her body with her claws. "I can feel the bloody power coursing through my veins!"

"Yes, that's what is inside that counts!" the werewolf rejoiced on a second thought.

"Finally promoted, and to *Seraphim*!" Miel rejoiced, flaunting her new wings, before noticing the batlike pair among them. Malfy chuckled at the sight. "What? Why do I have a set of these?"

“Nothing,” the demon cackled. “Nothing at all.”

“Sword of empire!” Buzz rejoiced, Junior petting it on the head. “I sword!”

“I definitely gained new Perks out of it,” Allison observed. “More charisma, more luck too... oh, and my range has expanded!”

“How much?” Chocolatine asked, curious.

“I can only move within one mile of a tree,” Allison said. “*Any* tree, with which I can meld and teleport through at will with the [Greenbond] perk. I am no longer bound to my orchard!”

“You should check your new abilities before we open the portal,” Manling Victor said. “And welcome the new western governor, when she deigns showing up.”

“Mr. Victor, you should have that woman killed,” Malfy said with a grumble. “She is treacherous, old money, and most importantly, competition. She's outdated.”

“For once, I agree with the fiend,” Flying Miel said. “Giving governor power to an archfiend of her caliber, this is bound to backfire!”

Vainqueur, who hadn't paid attention to that part, frowned. “If a new minion wishes to become another meatshield against the fairies, then I welcome them with open arms,” the dragon said, proud of his all-inclusive policy.

“At least limit her powers!” Miel protested. “Like red tape! Nothing better than red tape!”

“Well, if you hadn't shown me that a democratic council didn't work in Murmurin, maybe I would have considered it,” Manling Victor replied. “But since iron fists can maintain order here, she will have the freedom to do as she wishes within her borders, within reasons. Same as you for your territory.”

“If it comes to it, Miel, I will kill that fiend myself,” Knight Kia reassured the angel, but not much.

“Do you agree with *this*?”

“No, absolutely not,” the paladin replied. “But I am only an ambassador and thus my powers are limited. However, Vic gave me permission to carry out the sentence, if she steps out of line. And believe me, when she inevitably does, I *will* cut her down.”

“As Manling Victor suggested, most of you will be granted an area to manage, with the power of a sous-chief of staff,” Vainqueur declared. “As the most sensible among you, Corpseling Jules will manage Murmurin while we cross the ocean.”

“I have found that an army of the undead do wonders to enforce peace and quiet,” Jules added.

“Now that the matter is dealt with,” Vainqueur said, impatient to leave. “It is time to track down Furibon, who is evil and will be destroyed.”

Under the gaze of his minions, the dragon moved to enter the *Piggybank*, his eyes set on only one thing.

“El Dorado, here I come!”

For most of the trip, Vainqueur elected to stay on the ship’s back, even as a thunderstorm arose.

The trip had been incredibly boring. For hours, the *Piggybank* had crossed what seemed like an endless ocean, albeit one full of giant fish, sea serpents, and other creatures. Vainqueur thought they would stop at this large island called Atlantis on their way, but the ship only passed by its coast.

The dragon understood the need for quickness to reach Furibon before he could poison El Dorado, but he wouldn’t have minded a little activity. Beyond the dark thunderclouds and the raging waters below, the dragon had nothing to entertain himself with.

Yet...

Why did he feel such disquiet in the atmosphere? His dragon instinct kept telling him something terrible would happen soon.

Eventually, his loyal friend emerged from the ship, struggling against the wind to join his master. “The weather is not very good, but the duergar captain said that we should reach the Dagger Coast soon,” Manling Victor said. “I heard it is full of pirates, but nothing we cannot handle.”

“If thieves are eager to donate their money to me, I will gladly accept,” the dragon replied.

“Afterward, we will make a stop at the Thaoten Empire in the south,” the Vizier said. “From what I gathered, they could help us find El Dorado since they are familiar with the jungle.”

Vainqueur only vaguely listened, for he couldn’t help but glance around, at the thunderous skies. He could sense a distant, yet *increasing*, pressure around him.

“Your Majesty?” Manling Victor asked. “Is something the matter?”

“Do you not feel it, minion?”

His chief of staff glanced around, sensing it too. “That tension in the air...”

And that *smell*... the smell of a fomor, but not just any of them...

Vainqueur froze upon recognizing its owner.

King Wotan.

Dragonbane.

“Minion,” Vainqueur extended his wings, suddenly on edge. “Get back into the ship.”

“What?”

“Get back into the ship!”

A thunderbolt struck the ship's wing, making it tremble. Manling Victor barely held on by using his scythe to cling to the metal. Vainqueur immediately activated [Fire Crown] and [Spell Purge], bracing himself for a fight to the death.

“[Supreme Thunder: Dragonslayer]!” a thunderous voice echoed through the clouds. “[Maximize Lightning]!”

King Wotan's [**Lightning**] attacks will ignore Resistance, and inflict additional [**Dragonslayer**] damage!

[**Lightning**] element greatly strengthened!

“We're under attack!” Manling Victor shouted, casting buffing spells on himself.

“By King Wotan!” Vainqueur added with a fiery roar, glaring at the thunderclouds to look for the challenger, “The worst of the fairies!”

“Huh? A fomor? Then why... why did the name appear on...”

Friend Victor didn't finish his answer, as the enemy flew into sight, emerging from the thunderclouds seething with bloodlust.

A titan among the fomors, King Wotan was a giant who matched Vainqueur himself in size. Riding a giant, six-legged silver horse racing on the air currents, he looked even more fearsome. His skin was silver, but without the metal's shininess, and he wore very little in the way of clothing beside a winged helmet and a regal mantle—which couldn't match the beauty of Vainqueur's own.

Mostly because the fomor wove it with dragonscales.

Wotan's visage superficially looked like that of a manling, with a long golden wizard beard. But while his right eye had turned white, the skin still bearing the scar of Grandrake's claws, the left one radiated with a golden glow. A twenty-foot long crimson spear, shaped from a wyrm's spine, cackled with lightning in his hand, hungry for blood.

Following in his wake were his thralls, the Valkyries. Armored, vicious copies of princesses meant to bait dragons, the creatures flew through the skies thanks to white wings. Each carried a spear and a shield, their face hidden behind a closed helmet.

“Vainqueur Knightsbane.” The storm lord spoke as he reached the *Piggybank*, his voice booming and imperious. His Valkyries immediately formed a defensive line between their master and the ship. “I have come for your head.”

Vainqueur responded by blasting him with a fireball, a projectile which Wotan swiftly deflected with his spear. The dragon’s eyes bulged in surprise.

No one can deflect dragonfire! Not even that cursed golem could fully resist it!

“You declared war on my kind and broke the peace agreement, which bound my *Gungnir* to my trophy wall,” the fairy lord spoke without condemnation, only vicious eagerness to fight. “This is retaliation for your transgression... and me settling a debt.”

“Here to lose another eye then?” Vainqueur taunted him. “I will complete Grandrake's set!”

“You are welcome to try. [Charged Attack].”

His spear coursed with almighty lightning. Once, Vainqueur wouldn’t have cared, confident that he could take even this infamous dragonslayer and come out on top. Grandrake once demolished him, and the emperor had grown bigger than the princess hunting pioneer.

And yet... yet something felt dramatically different about this fairy. Vainqueur could sense the raw, absolute power within the spear; an overwhelming strength which he *knew*, deep in his bones, could harm him.

The dragon, spurned by an ancient survival instinct, immediately flew toward the mighty fomor to cast him down from his horse. He unleashed a

stronger breath, but three Valkyries instantly formed a triangular barrier of light to protect their creator. To Vainqueur's surprise, the shield held against his flames, although barely.

The dragon let out a roar and decided to charge through that protection, trusting his [Spell Purge] to shatter it. Four Valkyries moved to intercept him, cladding their spears in light.

Friend Victor immediately flew after his master, repelling the flyers before they could stab him in the back with his scythe. "[Shining Majesty]!" Vainqueur roared, his scales unleashing a brilliant flash. A perfect picture of his marvelous hoard burnt the Valkyries, blinding them with glory. The dragon's mere touch caused the shield to collapse into nothingness, incinerating the fomor's minions.

Yet they had brought their master enough time.

"There it comes!" the storm king shouted over the sound of roaring thunder, as he raised his spear to the skies, "The supreme lightning, which guarantees victory!"

Vainqueur didn't have time to react, as the skies turned white.

"[Spirit Shield]!" Friend Victor summoned a purple shield above them, just as a massive, *mountain-sized* thunderbolt fell from the skies upon both fighters and the *Piggybank*.

"[Ragnarok]!"

A flash of light swallowed Vainqueur upon impact, and then...

Silence.

Chapter 79: Dragon on the Shore

When Victor regained consciousness, it was with a mouth full of sand, and his armor drenched in saltwater.

His entire body was in pain, his nerves scrambled by the dragonslaying lightning. His head hurt, and his ears struggled to distinguish sound from his newfound tinnitus.

[**Final Problem**] activated! You survived with 1 HP, and your body will look dead thanks to a powerful [**Illusion**] effect!

[**Troll Regeneration**] activated!

You gained the [**Regen**] status! [**Master's Shield**] activated!

That fomor did *not* mess around.

What about Vainqueur? His own [Darwinist] perk had protected him from the [Dragonslayer] additional damage, but the dragon must have suffered it head-on. If the sheer power had brought Victor so low - and would have one-shot him without [Final Problem] - he dared not imagine what the dragon endured.

From whatever signals he received from his body, he was face-down on the sand, battered by waves and rain; his scythe within reach of his hand, but his legs buried. He had to rise up, find his friend...

“Is he dead?” a female voice asked.

They were here. Right next to him.

Victor laid still, not giving any hint of survival away.

Skill check successful!

“I think so,” another woman replied, her voice cold and vaguely Swedish-sounding.

Yes!

“Is the corpse still warm?”

... No.

No, no, *no*!

“Why? His Majesty Wotan said no desecration of the dead.”

“But with our hours, we never had fun!”

Charisma check successful! [**Terror**] negated!

“Enough prattle, my Valkyries.” The thunderous voice of King Wotan boomed from above, the very air crackling with lightning. The fomor clearly brimmed with impatience. “Have you found Knightsbane’s corpse?”

“No, Your Majesty!” Victor managed to move his head just enough to get a glimpse of the attackers. As he expected, two armored Valkyries stood right next to him, spears ready to impale him at any time. His vision was too blurry, even for [Monster Insight] to activate.

“The current must have carried him north, into the high sea,” the fomor, Wotan, mused from above. “Valkyries, gather! Until I have the dragon’s skull tied to my horse, the hunt goes on!”

The two women muttered something about overworking under their breath, before blowing sand into Victor’s helmet with their wings. He heard them fly away, the sound of thunderbolts, the winds, and lightning flashes growing weaker.

Victor waited a long while until the thunder had become a distant sound, and his regeneration patched him up enough to move his legs out of the

sand.

You have recovered half of your HP!

The Vizier rose up and observed his surroundings.

From the look of it, he had ended up on a sand and rock island, barely capable of sustaining a few palm trees before the storm turned them into firesticks. A faint rain kept drenching him, washing away the sand from his armor.

Hundreds of electrified fish laid on the sand, the victims of Wotan's [Ragnarok]; and unfortunately, Victor noticed a few members of the dwarf crew among them. Unlike him, they weren't faking death.

Thankfully, he also noticed his [Black Grail] left on the shore, so he could maybe raise them, but *damn...* the remnants of a wing of the *Piggybank* laid as a testament of the attack's overwhelming savagery.

Very far into the horizon, Victor could see violent thunderclouds move towards the high sea. The storm followed this [King Wotan] everywhere he went, as he relentlessly searched for Vainqueur. They had moved far away, but Victor had no guarantee they wouldn't return.

He had to find Vainqueur, and quickly.

Where was he anyway? The fomor believed the current had dragged him away, but [Master's Shield] needed close proximity to activate. Victor immediately guessed what happened, and cast a spell on the shore. "[Naglfar]!"

Hundreds of pallid, corpselike hands, appeared on the beach and began to excavate the sand. Over a few minutes, the tip of Vainqueur's horn began to appear, the dragon buried right under the fomor's nose.

"Charlene! We have been attacked!" Victor attempted to contact her through the [Whispering Skull] but received no tonality. "[Scarlet Study]."

We are sorry. This mortal is not available right now. Please leave a message, or try again after long-distance scrying, teleportation, and communications, are no longer impaired by a Field effect.

What kind of Field?

Field: [**Devil's Triangle**].

... aka the Bermuda Triangle.

Great. Just great! At least he knew he was north of the Dagger Coast, but if the legends about that location were a reality in Outremonde... Come to think of it, Wotan must have ambushed them here on purpose, in a place where they could not contact their allies.

He and Vainqueur could always fly back south, escaping the triangle, and rejoining civilization to bring back reinforcements. He needed to gather whatever supplies had survived the crash, free the dragon, raise the dead if possible, and get out of here before the fomor returned for a second round.

Wait.

There was something else on the plane... something dear to him.

“No!” Victor panicked, flying above the island in search for *her*, only to come back empty-handed. “No, no, no! Marinette!”

His bazooka!

She had been on board when Wotan brought down the plane! These bastards drowned his bazooka! His loyal weapon, with which he had threatened dozens, killed vampires, and partied with so much!

“Murderers!” Victor collapsed on the beach, hitting the sand with his hand. “She was too young! Too *young*!”

The vizier cursed, his eyes looking at the endless, merciless ocean, where his beloved weapon would rest forever. A burial at sea.

That fomor... the system never registered fomors by their names before, probably because they lacked a soul. Why did this 'King Wotan' appear in his screens and notifications then? Maybe because it wasn't a true fomor, but another creature pretending otherwise? How could he be powerful enough to demolish Vainqueur with a single attack, even if it was optimized to damage dragons?

Unless... Could it be...

Intelligence check successful!

A shiver ran down the Vizier's spine, as a terrifying possibility formed in his mind. A very outlandish one, and one he couldn't confirm unless he analyzed Wotan with [Monster Insight]. But if it was correct, then Murmurin's troubles had only just started.

A new event interrupted his trail of thoughts. Victor slowly squinted, as he noticed a shape on the sea. He briefly worried about a Valkyrie, before realizing otherwise.

A ship.

A large ship, getting closer! And its crew had even sent a small boat, manned by two people, to rescue Victor. They must have seen the smoke from the burning palm trees, mistaken it for a distress call.

The Vizier briefly canceled his [Naglfar] not to disturb the newcomers, Vainqueur excavated enough to look like a whale buried in the sands. In his experience, it was better to gradually introduce new people to the dragon way of thinking, instead of overwhelming them with worrying information. Still, he grabbed his scythe, just in case his saviors weren't friendly.

The small boat soon reached the beach, allowing Victor to see its passengers. The first was a birdkin, a humanoid parrot with flamboyant emerald feathers and a rounded hat, and the second a one-eyed orc. Both carried sabers and muskets around their belts.

“Well, well, well, look at that mess,” the parrotkin said, as he climbed down from the boat, followed by his orcish companion. His eyes set on the remains of the *Piggybank*’s wing. “What kind of shipwreck is that?”

“Greetings,” Victor welcomed them, as they noticed him. “How good to see friendly faces. I’m Victor, Victor Dalton.”

“Hello, I am Jean-Micheng Robbery,” the parrot beastkin playfully nodded at him. “And this is my first mate Maurice Ransom. Always glad to rescue survivors. If you can come with us, so we can introduce you to Mr. Giveusallyourstuff?”

“That would be very kind of—” Victor stopped, understanding the not so subtle message. “Oh, wait, I get it.”

“Good,” the orc scavenger added. “Very good. Give me your underwear too.”

“He collects them,” his fellow raider added. “You don’t want to learn why.”

“Well, unfortunately, I have a date with Miss Screwyou on that island, so I must decline.”

“Oh, look at that,” the birdkin said with an even more sarcastic tone than before. “Another member of the Ain’t-you-a-dead-smartass family. This is so cute.”

“Guess we’ll have to introduce him to my cousin Sarah Slavery soon,” the orc added. “She’s very mean, and she never lets go.”

“But she pays well, especially for half-fiends bastards like you buddy. She’ll probably cut off your tail too; I heard devil tails make for good aphrodisiacs.”

Victor sighed at these stupid crooks. “Guys, I am a winged half-dragon wearing armor made from loan sharks’ souls and wielding a scythe with an [Insta-death] feature. I have sand in my boots, and I’m pissed. So for your sake: Go. *Away*.”

“Ain’t that terrible,” both drew muskets and aimed at Victor's head. “You have a scythe, we have guns.”

“And I have a dragon.”

The two exchanged glances. “I don’t understand that metaphor, either,” the orc admitted to his companion.

[**Vainqueur Knightsbane**] recovered all his HP, and so did you!

“You will,” Victor said, as the shore around them moved on its own.

The two would-be pirates took a few steps back, as Vainqueur’s neck fully emerged from the beach, his body dusty with sand. They immediately shot at him with their muskets, the bullets bouncing off his scales.

“Minion... what is all the racket?” Vainqueur complained, clearly struggling to wake up. He hadn’t even registered the attack.

“Angry locals, apparently,” Victor deadpanned, pointing his scythe at the pirates. “They proposed to carry us on their boat to the mainland.”

“Ah, new minions.” The dragon narrowed his head at the two crooks. The orc fell on his lap, having wet himself, while the birdkin was too terrified to fly away. “And you start your new lifelong employment by threatening my chief of staff, from what I heard. Do you have coins on yourselves?”

“... yes?” the birdkin responded. “Yes?”

“Give them to me. Give me all your money.”

The two would-be robbers exchanged an astonished glance, then reluctantly grabbed purses around their belts and threw them in the sand. Victor would have almost felt sorry for those two if they hadn’t tried to pull a fast one on him first. Call it karma.

“Nothing like the feeling of my hoard growing bigger in the morning,” Vainqueur said before glancing at the big boat nearby. “Is that your ship over there?”

“Y-yes?” the orc cleared his throat. “Yes.”

“Give it to me too. I *demand* to be spoiled.” The dragon shook himself to get rid of the sand on his scales. “You see, Manling Victor, this is how you talk to uneducated strangers. You kindly ask them to give you all their possessions, in return for extending their short lives a little longer.”

“And you sweeten the deal by bringing them civilization afterward?” Victor replied with heavy sarcasm.

“Of course not. Giving back is a minion’s job. A dragon only receives from the universe.” The dragon scratched sand off his horn. “Friend Victor, why does my head feel naked?”

The Vizier glanced up at his master’s head and winced upon noticing the broken remnant of a crown lodged between the horns.

“Minion? What is wrong?”

They all had lost something dear to them today.

Chapter 80: Swimming with the Sharks

“My crown...” Vainqueur mourned, as he rested on the ship’s deck. “My imperial crown...”

“I know, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor reassured him, while his undead dwarf lackeys oversaw the pirates. After salvaging whatever they could from the shipwreck and raising their dead minions with the power of Victor's cup, the adventurers had spent hours in that Devil’s Triangle, with no shore in sight. “We will get you another!”

“You better, minion!” Vainqueur had taken the captain’s hat as a replacement—after the birdkin pirate kindly ‘gave’ it to him—but it wasn’t the same! Neither did his accommodations befit his station!

After the pirates offered Vainqueur the ship out of the goodness of their hearts, the dragon had climbed on its deck and managed to fit between two masts. It was incredibly uncomfortable, but the dragon considered himself too good to fly when minions could transport him instead.

He still mourned the destruction of his *Piggybank* with all his heart though.

So he had renamed the ship the *Piggybank II*.

“Troll Barnabas will have to remake another crown from scratch, even shinier!”

“I will try to contact him again, as soon as we leave the triangle,” Friend Victor said, turning to the two pirates who tried to rob him. “How far are we from civilization?”

“I dunno, traveling in the Triangle is weird,” the birdkin grumbled. “The currents, magnetic forces, and even the skies change at random!”

“We rarely venture there, and only after storms wreck ships there,” the orc added.

“And it would be way faster if our ship didn’t have weight in excess,” the birdkin said, glancing at the dragon. The Emperor wondered if he was supposed to understand something, before brushing it off.

“That is not an answer,” Vainqueur replied, his bitterness making him sound raspier.

“Give us a few days, until we find the way out again,” the birdkin said hurriedly. “Then we can reach the pirate city of Port Damn  and resupply there.”

“And then you’ll let us go?” the orc asked, pleading.

“Of course not,” Vainqueur replied. “Minionship is for life, and death.”

“I used to think Averagism was the only form of equality,” a revived dwarf muttered. “I stand corrected. Undead Averagism, where all are equal in death, is the purest equality of all.”

“How about we make everyone undead?” another dwarf added. Like his fellows, except a paler skin, he looked as he did in life.

“Patience, my equal fellow. Patience. All comes to Death.”

Obviously, the exchange made the living work harder to reach civilization.

“I tell you, Friend Victor, Wotan will pay tenfold for this humiliation.” Vainqueur hadn’t felt so vengeful since Batling Lavere.

“Actually, who was that guy?” Friend Victor asked. “We were lucky to survive one round, but I’m pretty sure he will come back for another.”

“He is a fomor who styles himself as ‘King’ Wotan.” Vainqueur loathed the title since he had copied it from the dragons. “When they were younger, when fairies and dragons fought one another, my fellow Grandrake taught him his place and took his eye.”

“I assume they didn’t see eye to eye afterward,” Manling Victor joked.

“Ever since he has hunted my kindred so he could practice his vengeance against his target,” Vainqueur said. Once he had disdained the fomor’s victims as handicapped dragons but now knew better. “By using fake princesses called Valkyries, he lured many of my kindred to their death. We nicknamed him *Dragonbane*, but he retired to his northern domain after the fairies sued for peace...”

"Until Your Majesty declared war on them again," Victor finished, "I'm surprised he didn't break his agreement like Melodieuse."

“Wotan is many things, but tricky and treacherous he is not. When he gives his word, he abides by it, and he only believes in strength.” Vainqueur remembered the battle, and the pain he felt from the fomor’s lightning. “Stronger he has grown, if he can wound my pristine scales.”

But his previous tactic only worked because of the surprise. The dragon would take him down next time they crossed paths.

“About that, there’s something that bothers me,” Friend Victor said. “He used [Charged Attack] right before using his devastating lightning attack.”

“Like me with my breath,” Vainqueur nodded.

“Yes, like *you*.”

Intelligence check successful.

“You believe Wotan copied my classes?!” The thought made Vainqueur restless, enough to sway the ship.

“Which is impossible, since as far as I know, you need a soul to gain levels, and the fomors have none.”

“Minion, before I arrived, was it not believed that dragons could not gain levels too?” Vainqueur reminded his servant. As a true detective who had solved Furibon's conspiracies, he knew not to exclude a possibility because it invalidated prior facts.

“Yeah, and fomors can create corrupted [Crests],” Manling Victor added. “Even if it seems difficult to believe... they could have exploited a flaw in the System to empower themselves with classes. If I’m true, then the worst is yet to come...”

“I will not abide by fairies stealing from the dragon-made System,” Vainqueur declared. “I defeated them with or without classes, and I will do it again.”

“We need to return to Murmurin, prepare our defense—”

“No.”

Manling Victor paused. “No?”

“Obviously, Furibon sent Wotan to delay us, so he could corrupt El Dorado as he did with the entire planet Moon,” Vainqueur enlightened his minion on the wider conspiracy. “Us turning back from our quest is *exactly* what he wants.”

His Vizier remained silent in awe of his master’s deductive power, before putting his hand on his helmet in a sign of respect. “Your Majesty, leaving Murmurin—”

“My minions can take care of themselves,” Vainqueur brushed off his lackey’s worries. “If we cannot expect them to defend my hoard and empire in our absence, then how can we ever feel safe? You have to learn to trust, my dear Victor.”

“Yes, but—”

The sound of a bell interrupted the chief of staff, as the watchkeeper sounded the alarm. “Weresharks! Weresharks in the water!”

Vainqueur glanced over the deck, noticing at least thirty shark fins quickly surrounding the ship from all directions. While Manling Victor and the undead remained calm, as befitting of true minions, the pirate crew panicked.

“The Teeth of Dagon!” the orc pirate panicked. “We’re doomed!”

“Look, we can repel them,” Victor replied, casting buffing spells on himself. “Vainqueur will boil them, I cut them, you nail—”

“They have a [Fisherman] leading them!” the birdkin snarled back at him.

Vainqueur snickered, but much to his surprise, his manling froze in fear. “A [Fisherman]?” he repeated with dread. “How many levels?”

“Twenty!” The birdkin, showing himself unworthy of minionhood, tried to fly overboard and abandon the ship. He barely flew a few meters away before being cut down by a harpoon from below and dragged screaming under the waves.

“And BLEEP!” Victor looked up at his master. “Your Majesty, don’t hold anything back! This is a fight to the death!”

“Minion, why should I fear a fish hunting other fishes?” Vainqueur asked, casually putting his hand in the water and catching a humanoid shark in his fingers. The animal tried to bite his hand but broke his teeth on the dragon’s scales.

“Because they have a capped [*Fisherman*]!” Victor parried a wereshark’s teeth, as one of the creatures jumped overboard and attempted to bite his head off. By swirling on himself, the chief of staff tossed him overboard. Yet half a dozen blue sharkmen climbed on the ship, assaulting the crew with fangs and tridents.

An enormous, white-skinned wereshark leaped from the waters, making the entire deck tremble. Blasphemous markings covered his hide, and a necklace of fangs glittered around his neck. “You mammals will fear the wrath of Jajambe, chosen of Lord Dagon!” he roared while brandishing the

harpoon which killed the birdkin. “I will rip your legs with my steel-cutting tee—”

“Jaja?” Manling Victor said, seemingly recognizing the creature.

The shark captain immediately stopped barking threats, his crimson eyes squinting upon noticing the chief of staff. “*Vic*? Vic, is that you?”

“Jaja!” Victor rushed to the sharkman’s side, his fear turning to joy.

“Vic, you son of a mammal!” The wereshark and Vainqueur’s chief of staff immediately underwent a strange kind of brotherly hug. “What are you doing here? Wait, is that your boss over here?”

“We crashed on an island nearby, and we ‘recruited’ this ship’s crew. And indeed, the dragon is my ‘master.’” Vainqueur noticed something strange about how his friend made the word sound but guessed his minion needed to unload stress.

“Happy to meet you, Lord Vainqueur. Vic couldn’t stop talking about how much he missed you.” The shark turned to his fellow fishmen, who had stopped their assault in confusion. “Drop the attack, he’s a pal of mine! We went to school together!”

“School?” Vainqueur asked his chief of staff, releasing the sharkman in his hand when the others stopped harassing his minions. Both groups glared at one another threateningly, save for the leaders.

“Scholomance,” Friend Victor said, without explaining himself. “We followed the same [Ritualistic Magic] class.”

“I was taking remedial courses to learn how to awaken my own monster lord, the great Dagon, from his slumber beneath the waves,” the wereshark explained. “Vic helped me practice, and we had a lot of fun. ‘Member the shoggoth?”

“How could I stop ‘membering that? Wait, wait, wait, don’t tell me your master causes the Field Effect?”

“I won’t tell you, then,” Jajambe replied with a smirk. The sight of his three rows of teeth made Vainqueur’s newer minions recoil. “We are so close to waking him up, I can almost smell the blood in the water. Pity that ship is yours though, I would have taken it.”

“I can only respect such dutifulness from a chief of staff, even not my own,” Vainqueur said. “However, I fail to see how attacking us would help your master.”

“Oh, we need sentient tributes to sacrifice,” the wereshark replied. “Since it’s a slaver ship, I thought nobody would miss it.”

“Slaver ship?” Vainqueur squinted his eyes at the fish.

“Why, yes? I mean, I could smell all the elven blood in the ship’s hold from fifty miles away.”

Both Vainqueur and Victor exchanged a glance, then glared at the pirate crew.

As it turned out, the ship carried more than one hundred chained ‘slaves’ in its hold, overcrowding a space made for half that number. Being too large to see for himself, Vainqueur had sent his minions down, and they brought back a sample of elves, diseased, beaten, and frightened like mice.

They probably expected him to eat them.

“Apparently, the crew preys on, and *enslaves*, would-be colonists or exploration ships having run aground in the Devil’s Triangle,” Victor told his master with clear distaste. “With a particular focus on endangered sentient species.”

“Port Damn   is a slavering pirate port, and elves fetch a great price there,” one of the weresharks said.

“I’m just sayin’, if you need to lighten your ship,” Jajambe the shark glanced at the pirate minions, who stood in a straight line, pissing themselves. “I can help.”

“No eating slaves, Jaja,” Victor immediately shut him down.

“We do not eat elf slaves,” Jajambe the shark protested. “They have so little meat on them, it’s like chewing bones. We aren’t *dogs*. I can settle on the crew.”

Vainqueur grew impatient with his lack of understanding. “Minion, what is slavery?”

His chief of staff looked up at him. “Your Majesty does not know?”

“I keep hearing about it from lesser species, and they all seem to agree it is bad... but then I do not understand why they do it.”

“Because it pays well!” one of the pirates shouted as if it would save him from punishment.

“You shut up!” Victor lambasted him for speaking out of turn, although it appealed to Vainqueur’s curiosity—and greed. “Slaves... they’re like minions, except it sucks a lot more for them.”

“Minionship cannot be bad,” Vainqueur replied. After all, the only alternative was food. How could anyone turn this promotion down? “So why are these creatures... disheveled? Are they not taken care of?”

“No, because slaves are merchandise,” Friend Victor explained. “They can be bought and sold at their master’s will.”

“You cannot buy a minion!” Vainqueur protested. “You have to earn them, and their adoration!”

“Also, they have no rights at all, are never paid for anything, are never taken care of, and have no vacations, ever.”

“They have no vacations?”

“No,” Victor said ominously.

“Then, if they have no gold, no rights, no time off, then what do they have?” Vainqueur asked, puzzled.

“Nothing. Nothing at all, and that’s the problem.”

The more he heard, the less the dragon liked it. After Friend Victor finished explaining the ins and outs of slavery, there was only one way for a dragon to react.

“By the Elder Wyrn, that is indragon!” Vainqueur blamed the pirates. “You make me ashamed of being your master!”

The pirates lowered their heads, in penitence for their sins.

“But I forgive you,” Vainqueur spoke, channeling the spirit of wyrn forgiveness. “Because I see that the evil you commit, is born of ignorance. Ignorance of the dragon way of life, which is the purest, truest way to live, as taught to us by our Elder Wyrn progenitor. And because true minionship is taking care of their servants, as if they were part of their hoard. For minions have feelings beyond their master’s wishes!”

[El President] activated! Charisma check successful!

Friend Victor remained eerily silent, awed by Vainqueur’s passion.

“Clearly, this *‘slavery’* is a debased corruption of the minion institution,” the dragon continued to enlighten his audience. “A minion is no item to be worn and cast aside! Minions are sentient beings who must be cared for, so much that they *want* to be minions! They need to be respected, even *honored*, for their contribution to the hoard, and a dragon cannot eat them without proper reason. This is not Prydain! And I have not even breached the *worst* consequence of this slavery business...”

“There’s something worse?” one of the weresharks asked, curious.

“Yes! By poaching elves to extinction and mistreating them, slavers make it harder for new princesses to be born!” Vainqueur shook his head. “As an environment-responsible dragon, I shall not stand by it!”

“Then... What does Your Majesty suggest?” Manling Victor asked.

“First, you will unchain all these ‘slaves,’ so they can be set free, healed, and cared for. Then we set sail to this ‘Port Damn  ’ on our way to El Dorado, to bring it dragon civilization immediately. I will not abide by minion abuse on my watch.”

“Oh, that should be fun,” Jajambe the shark relished at the thought. “If you spare us a few captives for our [Rising Deep Ritual], we can show you the way there.”

Vainqueur glanced at the horizon, to the savage, lawless lands he couldn’t glimpse. Lands free of dragons, and thus, of hope in a better life.

Vainqueur the Minion Liberator.

That new title sounded *right*.

“Minion?” Vainqueur asked, suddenly realizing something worrying.

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“Am I becoming a *cattletarian*?”

Chapter 81: Goldbeard the Pirate

Shopping for princesses was morally right!

It was true that Vainqueur hadn't eaten a minion in a long while... and that he had come to realize that they had feelings beyond serving dragons... but catching princesses was a dragon's duty! He also ate manlings on occasion, just not his minions!

He wasn't a cattletarian!

"... Grandrake, you said?" Jajambe the shark asked Manling Victor, the two having been glued together for the entire voyage out of the triangle. The weresharks in the waters below had guided the ship through reefs and currents, under the light of the midday sun.

"You've heard of him?" Friend Victor answered, completely unaware of Vainqueur's existential crisis.

"The lost hoard of Grandrake is a famous legend in the Dagger Coast. It draws adventurers and treasure hunters every now and then. Not that they have any chance of finding it."

The mention of a hoard drew Vainqueur out of his existential depression. "It is true that Grandrake is a bit..." The wyrm struggled to find a word which wouldn't demean the inventor of princess hunting. "Senile."

"Dragons can become senile with age?" Manling Victor asked, obviously horrified that his own beloved master might forget him.

"Not age," Vainqueur protested. As if the noble dragon race wasted away with age, instead of growing ever more powerful! "A curse from a

princess's magician lover. As if a princess did not want to be shown off as a priceless trophy!"

"Yes, indeed, how strange," Victor said with sarcasm, obviously horrified.

"Grandrake suffered one of the greatest ignominy's known to dragonkind," Vainqueur said. "He forgot the location of his first hoard... including his favorite princess! She must have grown into a queen by now!"

"Why did you say nobody could find it?" Manling Victor asked Jajambe.

"Because I know where it is," the wereshark replied. "And unless they are a dragon and can fly, they aren't going to claim it anytime soon."

A flying lair for the hoard? Why hadn't Vainqueur thought of that?!

"Minion, we shall make a stop to that place on our way to El Dorado and recover the lost hoard."

"To return it to its previous owner?"

"Of course not. An abandoned hoard is free for all dragons to claim for themselves."

"And there might be a weapon we can use against Wotan there," Manling Victor said, ever dutiful.

You have left the [**Devil's Triangle**]. Field effect negated.

"Finally!" Vainqueur's Vizier crossed his arms and meditated. The dragon assumed that he contacted Murmurin through his [Scarlet Study] perk.

The dragon left his servant to his duty, watching the sea until they finally reached a large, tropical island. The locals had built an immense port, the biggest Vainqueur had ever seen, on its shores. Hundreds, maybe more ships similar to the *Piggybank II* had dropped their anchors there, while a group of them formed a defensive perimeter around the bay.

Even from a distance, Vainqueur could smell wonderful scents coming from this place: spices, meat, elves, and most importantly, gold aplenty!

“Here is Port Damn  ,” Jajambe the shark said. “The most rotten place on Outremonde. You can’t trade there if you’ve half a soul.”

Vainqueur quickly realized why the locals had fallen so low as to corrupt the institution of minionship. The surplus of gold had corrupted them, and without a dragon to provide a tribute to, they had let their wealth go to their heads.

So Vainqueur would relieve them of it.

“Well, as expected, unrest followed after we lost contact, but Jules ‘handled’ it,” Manling Victor said, after emerging from his trance. “Our army has grown by one hundred sentient zombies, fifty-five ghosts, and one penanggalan.”

“Penawhat?”

“Your Majesty doesn’t want to know.”

“Then, Manling Victor, you shall announce my presence to these *sea peasants* of Port Damn  , and order them to submit to my imperial authority. Tell them that I bring dragon civilization as the ‘*Minion Liberator*,’ which is non-negotiable.”

“You should use a pirate nickname to inspire fear,” Jajambe suggested. “These mammals only respect strength and beards.”

“That is ridiculous,” Vainqueur replied. “Superior beings have scales, not hair.”

“Thank you for the kind comment, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor replied with sarcasm, tired from the journey.

“He’s not wrong,” Jajambe shrugged as if it was ever in question.

The dragon thought about a fitting title and eventually settled on one. “Then announce me henceforth as Vainqueur Goldbeard, Emperor of the Pirate Sea.”

“As Your Majesty wishes. [Widen Voice].” Manling Victor finished to cast a spell, his words now resonating across the sea.

“People of Port Damn ! I am Victor Dalton, Grand Vizier of the V&V Empire, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains! His Majesty, the great dragon Vainqueur Goldbeard Knightsbane, Emperor of the Pirate Sea and Minion Liberator, has come to conquer your city and free all the slaves!”

“Tell them to give me all their gold too,” Vainqueur said. “For the baby coins’ safety.”

“The Empire will also take a one-time tribute of gold in exchange for bringing you dragon civilization! Think of the baby coins! The *baby coins*!”

“I shall give them a few hours to submit,” the dragon decided, feeling merciful.

“I think we won’t have to wait that long... and they don’t seem to want dragon civilization.”

Manling Victor pointed a finger at the defensive perimeter of ships, all of them moving towards the *Piggybank II*. Vainqueur heard the sound of firearms in the distance and then watched black spheres landing in the water near their own ship.

Cannonballs. How quaint.

“Then I shall give these pirates a taste of my power,” Vainqueur declared, deciding to start with his weakest ability. “[Geomancy]!”

Geomancy activated! Field Type: Ocean.

Effect: [**Tsunami**]!

...

“Minion, what is a Tsunami?”

His Vizier didn’t have the time to answer, as his Perk activated first.

Under the strain of Vainqueur's magic, the sea suddenly rose right below the ships which would do him harm. An immense wall of water sent five of them flying straight to the skies, then advanced towards the rest while getting higher and higher. Vainqueur's attack crushed everything in its path, rising as high as forty feet.

"Ohoh, brutal!" Jajambe the shark relished at the sight of the devastation. "Father Dagon's wrath is upon us!"

Vainqueur raised his head in pride, happy with the result.

Except the wave did not stop at the fleet.

As it kept going towards the harbor, threatening to devastate it, Manling Victor turned to his master in panic. "Stop it, stop it, stop it!"

"[Geomancy]!" Vainqueur raised his arms, unleashing the full might of his magic to steer away the destruction. His efforts slowed down the tsunami but failed to steer it away.

"[Demonic Arcana]," Manling Victor cast spells on his master. "[Misunderstood Genius Inspiration]!"

[Elemental] spells have been strengthened!

Your intelligence has increased by two stages!

"Seagardium Leviosa!" Vainqueur shouted, the wave bowing to his whims. By extending his arms, the dragon caused the tsunami to split in half, collapsing on itself.

Bending to his magic, the very sea kept widening. A dry pathway opened in front of the *Piggybank II*, revealing reefs, coral, and the remains of ships on the seafloor. Both halves of the ocean laid separated by Vainqueur's might alone.

"Ha, it worked!" the dragon gloated, while the weresharks whistled at his seascaping. He had saved his new colony from his own spell!

“I think Your Majesty just pulled off a Moses,” Manling Victor replied, astonished by his master’s power.

Vainqueur had no idea what a Moses was, but it sounded awesome.

Congratulations! For surviving Wotan’s storm, bringing the wrath of **Motha Nature** on these puny pirates, improving your geomancy, and devastating an entire city-state’s military with a single spell, you earned a level in **[Geomancer]**!

+20 SP, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK.

“Minion, I gained a level!” Vainqueur rejoiced. “You will fetch me a new [Heroic Crest] soon!”

“Your Majesty, what about the city?”

“Tell them that this Tsunami was the first plague of Vainqueur, sent to punish their sins against dragon civilization,” the wyrm declared. “The second will be the plague of fire... and I shall not need to send a third!”

In the end, after the sea had returned to normal, the crew landed on the city, whose authorities had promptly sued for peace. The crew planted Murmurin’s flag on the tallest building available, and the Empire won its first colony.

Vainqueur had opened a portal back to Murmurin with his [Golden Road], ripping space in half and allowing his minions to cross the ocean. When Jules stepped out of the portal as the first settler, the ghoul glanced around at the remains of the pirate fleet floating near the harbor, rubbed his hands, and then spoke words that would become famous.

“I can work with that.”

“You will,” Vainqueur had replied, from atop a pile of magical items which his victims had dropped into the sea. “For I henceforth rename this new conquest ‘Port Vainqueur.’ Slavery and piracy are sins in the eyes of the Elder Wyrms and shall be forbidden. One day, I shall split the sea again, and

all slaves will cross the ocean floor to the promised land of Murmurin; where all minions are equal before thine eyes. Now, go, and make me money.”

And so, dragon civilization arrived in the New World, heralding the end of the golden age of slavery. Jajambe called dibs on the heads of rich slavers as payment for his services as a guide, and Vainqueur agreed so long as he led them to the Lost Hoard of Grandrake.

Seven years in a school for evil masterminds made someone numb to a lot of things.

Afterward, Victor spent an entire day recovering corpses thrown on the shores by Vainqueur's tidal wave, spraying them with blood from his [Black Grail], or helping Jules and his necromancers raise conventional undead. Vainqueur, as ever, simply toured the city in search for gold.

“Arise, my child.” Victor spilled black blood on the corpse of a pirate, his magic restoring the corpse to life... or an illusion of it. Funny how almost everyone in a pirate city was bound to Happyland.

“I’m... I’m alive...” the pirate, a rat beastkin, couldn’t believe it, as he looked up at Victor. “Are you...”

“I am not Jesus, Mithras, Death, or whatever god you were about to name,” Victor interrupted him. Why did everyone ask that? “See the scythe?”

“I was about to say Orknoob,” the man said, looking at the shipwrecks on the shore. “Is this Japan?”

The Vizier frowned. “No. No, it is not.”

“Oh.” The pirate sounded disappointed. “Can you kill me again then? Maybe it will work next time.”

Victor remained silent, before pointing a finger at a dwarf-made, rounded metallic vehicle crushing the harbor's pavement below its legs. The machine

looked superficially like a cross between a tank and a spider, with a heavy cannon and loudspeakers on its back.

“CLASS AND GENDER EQUALITY SHALL BE ENFORCED!” Marbré shouted through the loudspeakers, as the machine patrolled the docks. “EMBRACE AVERAGISM OR BE ERADICATED! WE COME TO HELP!”

“Is that a car-cart?” the undead asked, before rushing at it to die again. “Sweet!”

By now, Victor had stopped caring. He just moved on with the next corpse, silently praying this one didn’t worship the Esoteric Order of the New World.

Congratulations! For being Scholomance’s valedictorian, surviving a meeting with King Wotan, helping your master control his magic, and then mass-raising an army of undead, you have earned a level in the ultra-prestigious [**Weathermaker**] class! You earned the [**Devil Archmage I**] Class Perk.

+30 HP, 10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +2 INT, +1 CHA, +2 LCK.

[**Devil Archmage I**]: You can learn and cast spells one tier above your current one. You can also learn and cast spells with the [Evil], [Fiend], and [Weather] traits, but only those equal or below your current tier access; if they belong to an exclusive school of magic, you count as if you met the other requirements.

So he had access to seventh tier spells? Sweet! And the stat bonus didn’t look too shabby either!

“I see that you enjoy your new class.” The goddess Camilla manifested in a puff of smoke near him, observing the harbor with interest. “I sensed a strong influx of necromancy, and I see that I underestimated it.”

Underestimate? They almost sank Jamaica! “If you could lend me a hand in raising these people, that would be great.”

“I have limits to what I can do without causing Mithras and other gods to knock on my door,” she said, and she sounded genuinely saddened by her chosen’s burden. “On the bright side, you should gain experience, although not enough for a new level.”

Victor would rather have this mess done quicker. He doubted a new level would make the difference against King Wotan.

Camilla seemed to notice his anguish and materialized a bag full of scrolls for him. “These are spells mattering to your specializations, especially [Weather],” the goddess said. “If you master them in tandem with Vainqueur’s own [Geomancer] abilities, it should give you an edge against the fairy lord.”

“About that, I have a very important question,” Victor turned dead serious. “Do the fomors have class levels?”

“I cannot say,” the goddess replied, her tone just as dreary as his. “Sablar is shrouding my sight on their activities, and his cultists have started flocking to Prydain. Which makes me worried.”

Worried enough to inform Victor directly. “Any suggestion?”

“Deliver your [Black Grail] to the high priest of the Thaoten empire, south of the Dagger Coast,” the goddess replied. “In exchange for the opportunity to study it, and upon learning that I favor both of you, he should provide help. Both to reach El Dorado, and in your war against the fomors.”

“If Vainqueur doesn’t pick a fight with Furibon on the way there.”

“The lich already reached the golden city days ago,” Camilla said, almost absentmindedly. “And I do not think he will leave it either.”

Chapter 82: Raiders of the Lost Hoard

Vainqueur had to give it to Grandrake. Nobody would try to steal a hoard hidden there.

Springing from both the waters and the air, a huge tornado formed an impenetrable barrier of swirling winds in the middle of the ocean. Unlike other similar phenomenons, this particular twister did not move from its particular spot, far south of Port Vainqueur.

“The island is in the eye of the tornado,” Jajambe said, swimming in the water while Vainqueur and his chief of staff flew over him. “The only way to get inside is to fly through it. At least, my sharks said that’s how Grandrake kept getting in.”

“Grandrake is a lightning dragon,” Vainqueur said. “A mere storm could never harm him.”

Having left his new conquest to his minions, the dragon had decided to immediately claim the treasure while he could. According to his most prized minion, one day later and they could reach the New World’s southern continent, where new minions, gold, and Furibon awaited them.

“This is clearly supernatural in origin,” Manling Victor noted, now carrying a bag of scrolls on his back, “if it has held for years.”

“I will brave the storm and summon you on the other side, minion,” Vainqueur declared. “You lack the strength and vitality to make your way through without sinking.”

“Actually, if Your Majesty would give me a few seconds, I could perhaps end the storm on my own.” The minion raised his scythe, wielding it like a wizard’s staff. “[Weather Control: Clear Skies]!”

Manling Victor’s scythe surged with dark energies, releasing a wave of magic over the sea. The tornado collapsed on its own, the unnatural winds dispersing over the horizon and revealing a small tropical island smaller than the city of Murmurin. A dense forest of palm trees covered most of its surface, and a small, pointy mountain stood proud in its middle.

“Minion, with your control of the weather and my ability to bend the cosmos to my geomantic will, we shall redraw the maps as I see fit!” Vainqueur boasted for both of them.

Jajambe whistled. “Look, if you ever need help in sinking an island beneath the waves, just gimme a summoning call. I’m sure Lord Dagon would enjoy laying waste to landwalkers after I wake him up.”

“And for assisting the Empire, you shall be spared,” Vainqueur agreed. “All those wishing to lay waste to Prydain are welcomed in my armies.”

“I’m sure my boss will spoil us after his long nap,” the sharkman replied. “Anyway, a fish’s gotta go do his duty; continue south and you’ll reach the Thaoten’s capital of Kukulcan in no time. Been nice to see you again, Vic.”

“Before you go,” the Vizier said. “Why didn’t you tell me you were a [Fisherman]?”

“I thought you would think less of me,” the sharkman replied. “I mean, we have a terrible reputation. Most think we have to eat human babies to get a class this powerful.”

“Is it true that when you reach level twenty—”

“Yes, we can do *that* with fishes. All [Aquatic] creatures even.”

Manling Victor shivered. “Man, that’s evil.”

“Guess how I got invited to Scholomance?” And on these words, the sharkman swam away, followed by his retinue.

Vainqueur flew towards the island, hungry for gold. He could only imagine the fortune the good Grandrake had accumulated before his unfortunate curse. The old wyrm said he had gathered a most impressive hoard, one he would have bragged about for centuries—

BLEEP!

His [Virgin Princess Radar] went into overdrive.

“Princesses!” Vainqueur’s head twisted, possessed by his dragon instinct. “Many princesses!”

More than he had ever sensed in a single location!

“Your Majesty—”

“LATER!” Vainqueur surged towards the island while ignoring his minion, his mighty wings blowing tropical trees. “PRINCESSES!”

The hunting season had begun!

Victor watched Vainqueur crash onto the forest’s island with a sigh, birds and other critters fleeing the forest as the dragon rampaged through. Thank [Monster Knight] he didn’t develop that particular dragon weakness.

“Then again,” he mused as he flew over the island’s sandy shores, looking for a cavern where Grandrake could have hidden his hoard. “Pretty women in general are my kryptonite.”

The Vizier didn’t have to look for long, for he found one of the strangest sights on a beach.

A garden of giant, overgrown crimson mushrooms, turned into improvised houses. He could see whole cultures of enormous fungi, enough to sustain a small settlement. A woman tended to them, near the frontier with the forest.

The creature looked like a mushroom version of Allison, a dryad with mushrooms growing out of her body instead of flowers, and purple skin instead of olive-colored. She sensed his approach and glanced up as Victor landed right in front of her.

“A man?” the dryad asked, looking at him with curious eyes. “Are you a fiend? You ended the storm?”

“Yes for the storm, and technically not a fiend. My name is Victor, and my boss and I are looking for—”

“You’re a boy, you have to run,” the mushroom lady interrupted him, not sounding quite right in the head. “Quick, before they notice you.”

“Who’ll notice me?” Victor asked, only to hear sounds coming from the forest and the village. He immediately cast buffs on himself, even if the [Weather Control] spell had drained a good chunk of his SP.

Within a minute, a dozen women, each from different species, emerged from either village or the forest to gather around him. While all of them were humanoids, they ranged from a pink catkin, with the rarest shade of pink fur Victor had ever seen, to a centaur. With the exception of the catkin, all of them belonged to long-lived species.

Unlike the dryad though, they looked far from healthy. While they probably used to be strikingly fair maiden, they looked disheveled, sick, dirty, and malnourished; their nails had grown into claws, and their teeth had turned yellowish. They gazed at him as if he were some kind of alien traveler, and worryingly, they had a certain crazy glint at the edge of their eyes.

And not the cute, Chocolatine kind.

“Hello there, traveler!” the leader, an elf dressed like an amazon, grinned at him in a way that *should* have felt reassuring, but wasn’t, at all. According to her fur-made clothes, she must have been forced to survive on the island for a long while. “I am Elf Princess, from the Sablaris Empire.”

“Victor, Victor Dalton,” the Vizier replied with a frown. She sounded as if she thought the elf empire still existed. “Don’t you have a name?”

“We forgot them,” the centaur admitted. “The dragon called us by our species, and it stuck. I’m Centaur Princess.”

“You’re looking for the treasure too, are you not?” the Catkin asked, the Vizier reluctantly nodding. He had a *very* bad feeling about this meeting.

“We are the hoard, the ‘bragworthiest’ a dragon could ever gather,” Elf Princess said; meanwhile, the mushroom lady kept making discreet signs to Victor in the background. “A hoard of *forty princesses*, each from a different species.”

“I only count a dozen of you...” the Vizier let his sentence unfinished, as he tried to make sense of the mushroom dryad’s sign messages.

Get... away...

Not right... in the head?

“Most died of old age, or hunger,” ‘Cat’ Princess said. “The dragon left us here for decades! I lost two of my nine lives on this backwater island!”

“Without Mushroom, we would have starved to death,” Elf Princess agreed, the dryad stopping making hand signs when her fellow turned to her. “She’s very good and kind.”

“A few haven’t returned from gathering duty on the rest of the island,” Centaur Princess said. “We’ve been so hungry... mushrooms are not enough!”

Poor girls... no wonder they looked half-mad, isolated and malnourished for so long.

“We can save you,” Victor promised. “We can get you out of this mess.”

“Indeed you will.” Elf Princess licked her lips. “We didn’t have enough meat. But you... you will do.”

Oh.

Oh...

And BLEEP, cannibals!

“Don't you dare try to eat me!” Victor took a step towards the forest, only to find his back against a mud wall.

“Oh no,” Elf Princess’ fingers shone with magical power, having backed him into a corner. “We’re *cannibals*. We can’t eat a half-human.”

“We can only savor the flesh of other *princesses* now,” Cat Princess added.

“We tried to eat the few unlucky adventurers who managed to brave the storm, but they tasted terrible,” Centaur Princess said. “We ate the corpses of our short-lived princess friends.”

“But we don’t have any to sustain ourselves anymore,” Elf Princess finished. “We need to *make* more princesses. And this is where you come into play.”

...

This was Hell.

This place was *his* Hell!

“Back off, ladies!” Victor raised his weapon to protect his manhood. “I have a scythe, and I’m not afraid to use it!”

“It will be much easier for all of us if you don’t resist,” Cat Princess said, drawing a bone knife. The others, with the exception of a terrified Mushroom Princess, surrounded the Vizier from all sides threateningly. “There is only one part of you that we need.”

“Look, I really don’t want to hurt you, but if you take another step—”

A rumbling sound shook the ground, trees collapsing on the beach. The ladies turned at the source of the commotion, a crimson dragon with a pirate hat, and a wriggling treasure bag.

“Found you!” Vainqueur’s voice boomed across the island, as he raised a bag with one hand; he must have had summoned it with his [Golden Road] perk. “Get into the princess bag!”

The woman looked at the creature with shock. “A *dragon*?”

“I said, get into the princess bag!” Vainqueur grabbed Elf Princess with his free hand while she screamed, and put her in the bag like one would do with grocery. Realizing what would follow, the other princesses immediately attempted to run back to the village. “You will not escape my hoard!”

With a sigh of relief, Victor watched on as the dragon quickly pursued and caught all the cannibals in his bag, only Mushroom Princess managing to escape by burrowing herself into the ground. Proving himself the best princess hunter of his generation, Vainqueur had little trouble capturing all of them.

“Your Majesty, I...” Victor fell in adoration before his protector. “I love you. So much.”

“Minion, we already had this conversation. I value you too, but only as a friend and minion.” The dragon shook his head in disappointment. “See? This is why we dragons should not raise princesses in captivity. They become feral and violent if left out of their natural environment for too long. I will have to ask a veterinarian to take care of them before I return them to the wild.”

“This happened *before*?”

“Not that often...” Vainqueur cleared his throat, sweeping the unfortunate subject away. “We had princess hunting mostly figured out after the first century.”

Victor just tightened his pants, to reassure himself.

“Now, where is the last one?” Vainqueur walked towards the woods, trying to find Mushroom Princess. “Kitty, kitty, kitty...”

The Vizier watched the dragon leave, collapsing on the sand with relief.

He needed a comforting shoulder, a familiar sight to wash away this sinister encounter from his mind.

“[Black Horseman: Chocolatine de Gevaudan].”

His sort-of friend with perks materialized right in front of him, with a delightful expression, and boots drenched in a red liquid.

“Vic, I thought you would never call!” The werewolf smiled at him, a crimson spot on her cheek, a bloody knife in one hand, and a giant insect’s head in the other. “I’m sorry, I’m not dressed well. You summoned me in the middle of a meal.”

The Vizier glanced at the head, and on a closer look, realized it belonged to an insect demon.

A moth.

“That’s...” Victor recognized the creature. “One of Isabelle’s guards...”

“Oh, yes, I knew we agreed on an open relationship, but I was feeling a bit jealous anyway... so we had a friendly talk,” Chocolatine chirped, playing with her knife; and Victor suddenly wondered whose blood was on it. “I had to make sure she was cut out for the job.”

The wording made the Vizier shiver.

“Anyway, Viiiiic... did you call me for something? Maybe... practice?”

“You’re a good girl,” Victor lied to protect himself. “I just wanted to tell you that.”

“Silly, of course I am! Was that ever in question?”

Finally!

It had taken him a good hour, but Vainqueur had finally cornered and caught the last virgin maiden! His bag was full and heavy with the weight of their princessness; with so many of them, he would triumph over Icefang's contest with no trouble at all.

Unfortunately, he had yet to find any piles of gold on the island. Grandrake must have hidden it well.

Vainqueur would have loved to stay here for a few more hours until he could locate it, but each minute wasted there gave the wicked Furibon more time to find El Dorado. The dragon would settle on tossing the princess bag on his hoard through his [Golden Path], leave minions to scout the island in his stead, and then move on with his friend to the south.

Above in the skies, a faint rain began to fall. Vainqueur wondered if his Vizier had changed the weather again, before a glance at the horizon told him otherwise.

A cloud of lightning had approached the island at full speed; a fairy lord riding at its helm.

Vengeance was at hand!

Chapter 83: The Burning Fields

“I suggest we run,” Manling Victor pleaded to his master.

The dragon glanced down at his minion. The two had gathered, alongside Sweet Chocolatine—why a disaster happened whenever his lackey prepared to breed, Vainqueur would never understand—in the tropical forest to make their stand, before Wotan’s arrival. The gate to his hoard, created by [Golden Road], remained open next to them; the dragon had tossed his full princess bag atop his mountains of gold.

“We will not retreat, minion,” Vainqueur replied, the overwhelming pressure of the enemy's aura growing stronger. “We shall make our stand there. Wotan cost me a crown, and I will have Troll Barnabas craft me a new one from his bones.”

“It was a miracle we survived his [Ragnarok] spell the first time,” his Grand Vizier pointed out. “While we have advance warning this time, we are fighting a lightning user in the middle of the ocean. If we laid an ambush on more favorable terrain...”

“On the contrary, minion, I believe we must face him in this place. We have the power, we have the skills, we have the will. Wotan will not relent in his hunt, and a dragon does not run.”

“You have me, Vic!” Chocolatine said with conviction. “I can summon help!”

“If the terrain does not favor us, we must change it,” Vainqueur decided. “The foe we face is strong, but V&V does not know defeat! We have bested grasshoppers, vampires, fairies, and all foes who stood in my way! The empire *will* prevail!”

Charisma check successful! You have reminded your servant of your own invincibility!

“Alright, in that case, no time to waste,” Manling Victor said, with the true authority of a tactical chief of staff. “I will call allies with my [Diabolism] spells, and so will Chocolatine. Meanwhile, His Majesty must burn the forest to the ground.”

“This will reveal our location, minion,” Vainqueur pointed out.

“But the smoke and flames will reduce their air maneuverability, and both of us are immune to fire. Not them.” He turned to Chocolatine. “Can you —”

“[Fire Ward],” the priestess replied, casting protection on herself.

Vainqueur moved to action. Closing his [Golden Road] to keep his SP, he unleashed his mighty breath on the trees. Within seconds, he started an inferno so powerful, even the rain could not extinguish it. His flames spread all around the group, smoke, and steam filling up the skies.

“[Summon Prayer of Isengrim]!” Chocolatine prayed, two giant golden wolves materializing at her side. The sweet girl herself soon transformed into a silver-furred werewolf, her clothes adapting to her new size, and she quickly cast fire protection spells on her allies.

Manling Victor’s own summoning sounded decidedly more impressive. “[Ars Goetia: Happyland Battle Harem]!”

In total, eight creatures materialized to answer his chief of staff, each of them female. Four manling-like females with velvet bat wings and sinuous pointy tail; two dark cousins of Miel the angel, with black feathered wings and wielding bows of fire; and finally two womanly creatures with the lower body of snakes and six arms instead of two, each carrying a different weapon.

“Oh, hi Mr. Victor,” one of the serpentlike women said, sounding like the leader of the troop. “Good to see you again. Why did you call our company

for? Security service, or the group massage special?”

“Vic...” Chocolatine trailed, sound half jealous, half hungry. “What are these, a buffet? Succubi are not good at fighting!”

“We find the term ‘succubi’ old fashioned and racially demeaning,” one of the bat-winged demoness’ replied. “We prefer the term *‘horizontal angels.’*”

“I swear they are very good at close combat,” Manling Victor said. “I checked. Also, battle special.”

"Oh," one of the winged creatures said, disappointed.

“The happiness of our major shareholders is the paramount goal of our VIP security company,” the second snake creature said. Vainqueur found it very pleasing to see his minion had recruited more 'scaled' creatures. “Ladies, form a perimeter.”

“I cannot cast protection spells on His Majesty since your [Spell Purge] will remove them,” Manling Victor lamented, raising his hands at the skies. “But I can take away that storm [Control Weather: Sunny Day]!”

Obeying the might of Manling Victor’s sorcery, the rainy clouds dispersed, letting the bright sun shine strong in the skies.

The weather condition changed to [**Sunny Day**]! [Fire], [Plant], [Light] and [Sun] effects will be strengthened, while [Water], [Darkness], and [Frost] effects are weakened!

“Good, now [Spirit Shield].” The minion summoned his protective barrier around himself, but no sooner did he do so, than dark clouds and lightning bolts reappeared.

King Wotan’s [**Storm Caller**] passive Perk changed the weather to [**Heavy Thunderstorm**]! [Lightning], [Wind] and [Water] attacks will be greatly strengthened, [Fire] attacks will be weakened!

“Argh, the storm is a passive ability,” Victor complained, as he kept casting buffing spells on himself. “I can counter it, but whenever my focus slips

away, it returns... and he can strengthen [Ragnarok].”

Once, Vainqueur would have flown straight to the enemy, fearlessly engaged him in aerial combat without bothering to prepare. He would have fought Wotan the *dragon* way.

But Bat Lavee had taught him a very important lesson when she had almost trapped the dragon in a bottle. That some foes could hurt him, and underestimating them could be fatal. If Wotan had trained all his life to fight dragons, then Vainqueur would defeat him as a *dragon tactician*.

“Then minions, you shall protect my Vizier, while he clears the weather,” Vainqueur declared with his commander voice. “Do not let Wotan summon his lightning. [Fire Crown], [Spell Purge]!”

As flames surrounded his body, incinerating his captain’s hat but leaving his kingly mantle unharmed, Manling Victor once again cleared the skies of the thunderstorm... only for an arrow of light to pierce the smoke clouds, aiming straight at Manling Victor.

“[Heartseeker Spear]!”

“[Victory Fist],” Vainqueur said as he flew towards the projectile, deflecting it from its course with his hands. An electrical shroud around the weapon damaged his claws slightly, but the spear landed on cindered trees nearby, having widely missed its targets.

Here came *Dragonbane*.

Riding on his monstrous horse’s back, King Wotan flew through the clouds of smoke, eight valkyries following him. His spear returned to his hand without a word, while Vainqueur’s wounds closed on their own as [Master’s Shield] activated.

The fairy lord offered no word of warning, no unworthy boast. He offered Vainqueur only the swift promise of a fight to the death.

“[Call the Hunt],” Wotan thundered, two monstrous fairy beasts appearing in a puff of smoke among the flames, trapping Manling Victor’s group in a pincer attack. These elephant-sized hounds of pure darkness growled back at Chocolatine’s wolves, who howled back. Meanwhile, the fomor’s valkyries called upon a ghostly, warrior spirit each, doubling their numbers.

“Sigrun!” Wotan pointed his spear at Vainqueur. “Leave the dragon to me, and slay the rest!”

“[Master’s Aegis]!” One of the valkyries, which Vainqueur assumed to be the leader, called upon her magic. Silvery bonds of light briefly linked Wotan and his escort before vanishing.

Half of any damage King Wotan receives shall be distributed to his Valkyries!

Good, that way Vainqueur could kill them all at once!

“For the empire!” the great wyrm roared, as he lunged at Wotan in the skies, leaving his minions to fight in the burning forest. “For my hoard!”

[**Victory Roar**] activated! All enemies had their strength lowered by one stage!

Stat decrease negated by King Wotan’s [**Fomor Arrogance**]!

The dragon and the fairy lord circled one another above the burning forest, while on the ground their minions fiercely engaged one another amidst the flames. Vainqueur opened his mouth to unleash a devastating fireball, opening the hostilities.

The fairy lord called upon a shield of swirling winds, deflecting the flames around his horse and himself. He charged at the dragon, intending to pierce his hide, and Vainqueur welcomed the closer proximity. Trusting in his abilities, the Emperor attempted to grab the spear and disarm Wotan, pulling him from his horse.

But the fairy lord, sensing a trap, immediately backed down, the dragon pursuing him relentlessly.

“You fight better, Knightsbane, but not well enough.” King Wotan enhanced his spear and lightning, clearly intending to replicate the strategy that allowed him to surprise Vainqueur last time. “[Supreme Thunder: Dragonslayer], [Maximize Lightning].”

King Wotan’s [**Lightning**] attacks will ignore resistance, and inflict additional [**Dragonslayer**] damage!

[**Lightning**] element greatly strengthened!

The dragon didn’t let him. “[Shining Majesty]!”

Vainqueur’s scales brightened to gold, and then unleashed a searing, blinding flash of light. King Wotan, too certain that his windy shield would protect him, was hit head-on.

A glorious vision of Vainqueur’s boundless hoard manifested in the light, burning the fomor’s skin and blinding his last eye. While his magic protected the fomor from most of the damage, his horse let out a scream of pain, as the light cleansed his flesh from his bones.

Now a shining, burning star, Vainqueur lunged at Wotan and dragged him from his dying mount, crashing the now unhorsed fairy on the fiery ground below.

Wotan attempted to free himself, his body coating itself in electricity; lightning which bypassed both his [Mirror Scale] and [Spell Purge]. His wounds regenerating as soon as they opened, Vainqueur kept the fomor firmly in his claws, knowing his flames and light would hurt his foe more.

And harm him he did. Vainqueur kept flying while hammering the fomor against the fiery ground, leaving a trail of cinders in his wake. Finally, he opened his mouth to try and breathe directly in the hunter’s face, as he did against that golem in the north.

“[Eye of Odin],” Wotan snarled, a phantom blue eye appearing where the right one should have been. Somehow able to now withstand the vision of Vainqueur’s beautiful hoard, the fomor speared the dragon through the shoulder, his thunderous spear piercing his scales like butter.

You took heavy [**Dragonslayer**] damage!

Vainqueur let out a cry of pain, the wound forcing him to release Wotan from his grasp. He took his flight, circled around the burning battleground, and prepared to firebomb the fomor lord from above.

“[Hasten], [Skill Up].” Having risen up and recovered, the fomor began to move at incredible speeds, dodging Vainqueur's attack and retaliating by raising his spear at his flying foe. The weapon’s tip unleashed a mighty thunderbolt at the dragon, hitting him in the chest.

You took massive damage! You lost a fourth of your HP!

The sheer power of the blow interrupted Vainqueur’s [Shining Majesty] and propelled him backward, to crash near the bottom of the island’s mountain. His scales hit the rocky ground with a loud noise.

[**Master’s Shield**] negated by distance!

Vainqueur barely had the time to get on his back legs before Wotan charged at him, faster than ever. Having changed the field enough, the dragon immediately switched to magic. “[Geomancy]!”

The very ground shook under the might of his magic, causing Wotan to lose his footing and interrupt his charge.

Geomancy activated! Field Type: Volcanic Island.

Effect: [**Eruption**].

At the center of the island, a mountain’s tip detonated, casting rocks, ashes, and flames all across the island. The sun vanished, obscured by the natural disaster, while the entire landmass trembled.

Vainqueur let out a roar as he charged to continue the battle anew, the volcano answering with a mighty explosion.

The battle had turned into a brutal fight, long before the ground trembled.

Protected behind both his barrier and allies, Victor had spent the last few minutes struggling to prevent Wotan's supernatural storm from reasserting itself, a task which needed almost all of his concentration. He had been reduced to watching his allies fight on their own, which frustrated him to no end.

But thankfully, Chocolatine could handle herself.

Leading her wolves like a pack, she had engaged Wotan's shadowy hounds, breaking the pincer maneuver and allowing the fiends to engage the valkyries without interruption. Their preparations had paid dividends; with their magical fire resistance, the forest fire burned their enemies but not the V&V member or her wolves, giving them a slight advantage.

Still, the hounds fought back with fury, outmatching the wolves in size and power. Each blow of their clawed hands created small craters, and one bite would break the wolves in half... if they could touch them. While Chocolatine's wolves circled around one of the hounds, the first serving as a lure while the second attacked from behind, the priestess had engaged the other fairy beast on her own. She kept praying to Isengrim, casting spells on herself to move faster, hit harder, and wound the beast with rays of light. The fairy beast had lost one eye and searing flames immolated it from head to toes, while the werewolf remained unscathed.

In fact, she seemed to be enjoying herself.

She can spellcast while in monster form, Victor realized. That [Mook Promotion] hadn't been in vain! Eventually, Chocolatine jumped at the hound's throat and tore it out, the monstrous creature collapsing among the flames. The werewolf immediately moved to help her summoned allies against the remaining beast.

Meanwhile, though, the valkyries and their undead soldiers had proved themselves a lot more difficult to fend off. Having figured out his role in weakening their master, they kept launching spears of light at Victor, healed themselves from their burns with spells, and fought together as a well-trained warband. While the smoke filling the air had forced them to the ground and on unfavorable terrain, they outnumbered his fiendish bodyguards by two to one.

Although they struggled to hold against the siege, his summoned fiends managed so far. Their tactic was deceptively simple: the succubi used spells to create protective wards and walls of ice to delay the attacks, or enthralled the warrior spirits into attacking the valkyries whenever they could wrest control. Meanwhile, his serpentine mariliths ruthlessly cut swaths of fury and steel through the enemy formation, preventing the valkyries from making any focused push. The erinyes remained behind as the last line of defense, supporting their coworkers by firing arrows of destruction.

“The more you kill, the bigger the golden parachute!” Victor shouted to encourage them. “And you get a company dwarven car, *each!*”

[Rally Minion] activated! All your minions’ stats increased by one stage.

Enhanced by his tirades, his fiends had defended him well. Often, one of the Valkyries burned without warning or found herself vaporized by searing light; Victor assumed they took on the damage which should have hit Wotan himself.

The more he observed, the more he had grown convinced some of them had levels in a variant of his own [Monster Knight]. [Master’s Aegis] effect was too close to [Master’s Shield] for it to be a coincidence.

How long could they hold? How long would it take for Vainqueur to defeat the fomor?

The mountain exploded in an orgy of smoke and flames, answering his question.

The Vizier's concentration allowed him to maintain the weather effect, but as the skies darkened and the very ground beneath his feet trembled, he realized the island was doomed. The eruption would wipe away its entire surface, leaving nothing but ashes behind.

Meanwhile, Victor could see the flashes of his master fighting Wotan at the bottom of the mountain. Watching the duel of the titans from the distance was something to behold, but the hunter pushed Vainqueur away from his allies, and closer to the devastating eruption. Without his regeneration, the dragon might die from attrition or the island's destruction, even without the fomor activating [Ragnarok].

In spite of the distance, Victor tried to use his [Monster Insight] perk on Wotan, to check his class fomor theory...

And much to his horror, instead of nothing, the system provided him with a screen.

Storm King Wotan

Soulcrested Fomor (Fairy/Elemental)

Level: 35 (Kaiser (Fairy Lord) 15, Dragonslayer 10, Stormbringer 9, Berserker 1)

Strong against: all status ailments, stat debuffs, Fairy, Fire, Dragon, Lightning, Water, Earth, Wind, critical hits, Insta-death, non-cold iron
Physical attacks.

Weak against: Fairyslayer, Elementslayer, Poison, Beast, and Starmetal.

The mightiest dragonslayer among the fomors and Odin's inspiration on Earth, Wotan gained a soul through Mell Odieuse's Soulcrest, and thus the ability to level up. In return for this favor, the fairy tyrant asked him to bring her Vainqueur's head. Bound by an alien, but ironclad, warrior king code, Wotan will not relent until he keeps his word or dies trying. Maybe both.

In short, kick his fairy ass!

“Your Highness!” As if sharing the Vizier’s very thoughts about their master’s well-being, one of the valkyries, the leader, abandoned the fight to rush towards the mountain.

That was it. “[Pact with the Archfiends],” Victor cast his best [Diabolism] spells, his body transforming into a paragon of demonic majesty.

You sacrificed half your HP to gain the power of an [Archfiend].

[Troll Regeneration] activated!

Best combo ever, but it cost him his focus on the weather, allowing lightning to once more crackle in the skies. No time to waste.

“Evacuate the island!” Victor ordered, dispelling his shield and cutting down a warrior spirit in his way, his scythe gorging itself on his soul. “I will go help Vainqueur!”

“But Vic—” Chocolatine began to protest as her wolves chewed the last fairy hound to death, but he didn’t give her time to complain.

“You!” Victor turned to his demonic employees. “Take my girlfriend to Happyland if you must, but *go!*”

Somehow, his wording was enough to silence Chocolatine - in fact, she swooned in response. As a succubus immediately started spellcasting to open a portal, Victor charged towards the volcano, cutting a swath of destruction through whoever stood between him and the mountain.

No friend left behind.

Chapter 84: A Clash of Kings

Fire and ashes.

That was what Vainqueur's world had been reduced to, as he kept battling that fomor who just *wouldn't die!*

Warning! You have lost half your health!

The dragon ignored the pain, as Wotan's spear gored through the scales on his chest, shedding golden blood. The spear still embedded in his body, the dragon grabbed the fairy lord's neck and lifted him above the fiery mountain, through clouds of pyroclastic flows. They went through a whirlwind of ashes, melting Wotan's pristine skin.

The fairy lord's body radiated lightning, the electricity surging through Vainqueur's body and threatening to make him lose control of his flight. While he held Wotan with one hand, the dragon had to use all his strength in the other to prevent his spear from progressing deeper into his body.

The wyrm quickly reached the highest point he could, right above the raging volcano. The eruption sent debris and stones the size of houses flying through the skies, each powerful enough to bring Vainqueur down.

Finally, as he sensed the lava below, Vainqueur opened his mouth and unleashed a fireball right in that dirty fomor's face. Releasing his hold as the blast hit, the dragon propelled Wotan towards the crater, carried by a giant fireball.

Beforehand, Vainqueur would have gloated, spoke to the food, boasted about his inevitable victory. But now, he only had roars to offer. If Wotan would not rest until he died, then the dragon too would fight to the end.

As lightning thundered in the background, Vainqueur flew down, falling upon the fomor like a fiery comet. His claws cleaved through the fairy lord's torso, accelerating the descent.

Both crashed through the crater's edge and unto the raging lava below, an arena of molten rock and heat. The private baths of a red dragon... and the best arena where to make a final stand.

His lower body below the lava and his royal mantle now ashes, Vainqueur raised his fists to finish the fight the gladiator way.

[**Show-off**] activated! Your precision and evasion increased!

Wotan's upper half rose from the fiery hell too, his mantle consumed by the flames; his helmet melted on his face, changing his appearance from that of a dignified manling to an incarnation of fury. His spear had fallen during the crash, embedded into the crater's edge. The fairy raised a hand to summon it to his side, but Vainqueur didn't give him the time.

With a furious roar, the dragon punched Wotan in the face, tossing him backward against a wall of molten stone, and shaking up the entire mountain.

And keep pummeling the fairy's face, Vainqueur did! He hit him twice, then thrice!

Driven by grim determination, Wotan clenched his teeth and retaliated with a punch of his own, hitting Vainqueur squarely in his beautiful face.

The two titans exchanged blows, each attack causing the crater to tremble. Walls of stones collapsed around them, bursts of lava sprayed their scales and skin, and fresh blood mixed with the magma.

But no matter how hard Vainqueur hit his enemy, the fomor kept coming. And while the dragon had his foe beaten in punching expertise, Wotan moved faster and resisted blows better. The dragon felt organs he didn't know he had itch, bones break, scales torn apart.

Critical health! Critical health! HP and SP critically low! [**Bravo Bull**] activated! Your strength increased! **Critical health!**

Pushed back, Vainqueur decided to use his remaining SP for a final push to victory. “[Shining Majesty]!”

His scales flashed bright, searing the fomor’s flesh and disorienting him at a critical moment; even if he could see through the illusion, the light was all too powerful. Pushed by the knowledge granted to him by the system, Vainqueur took a step back to build momentum, raising his fist to deck Wotan in the face.

“[Holy Spear]!”

A spear of light hit Vainqueur right in the right eye, blurring his vision.

Vainqueur roared in unbearable agony, as a Valkyrie descended into the crater and the pain canceled his [Shining Majesty]. The dragon opened his mouth at her to blast her with flames...

He couldn’t finish.

His hands moving like snakes, Wotan forcefully closed the dragon’s maw shut, turned around, and threw Vainqueur against the crater’s edge. Tons of stone collapsed on the dragon, keeping him down. The sharp agony of his wounded eye didn’t help either.

“Sigrun, thank you,” Wotan said, with a tone that reminded Vainqueur of how he often spoke to his prized chief of staff. “Now leave, and live.”

“I cannot abandon Your Highness in a place like this!”

“My storm has returned,” Wotan said, flying through some magical power above the lava and finally calling back his spear to his hand. The sound of thunderbolts dwarfed even the tremors of the eruption in strength. “I can finally call the supreme lightning of victory.”

“You will kill us both if you use your attack here, you stupid fairy!”
Vainqueur snarled as he struggled to free himself from the rubbles, knowing

that the bolt would cause the crater to collapse and bury them all alive.

“Good.”

The disdainful word surprised the dragon, who knew fomors prized their own life above all others. Yet that primal fear that drove the fairies on was nowhere to be seen in the warrior’s single eye.

“You are the greatest threat to the fomor race since Balaur’s foolish war on the mortals, Knightsbane,” Wotan declared, sounding proud of fighting such a powerful opponent. “If you are to die here, buried under the earth by your own foolishness, then my life is a small price to pay. Now that I have a soul... I no longer fear a *warrior’s death*.”

How could he do that? How could *any fomor* do that?

No... the System had given him vision; the unthinkable will to lay down his life for the sake of his species' survival.

It was like sacrificing one’s hoard to save a minion’s life!

That copycat, Vainqueur did it first!

“Sigrun!” Wotan ordered as he raised his spear to call upon his ultimate lightning. “This is your last warning! Leave!”

“I will not abandon Your Highness,” the Valkyrie replied, shielding her master with the courage of a true minion. “Until the very end.”

“Then to oblivion with all of us.” The smoke clouds lightened with electricity. “May my thunderbolt be the last thing you ever see, Vainqueur! Glory to the fomors! **[Ragnar—]**”

“YOUR HIGHNESS, BEHIND THEE!”

[Master’s Shield] activated.

Demonling Victor emerged from the clouds of smoke above the crater, falling upon Wotan from behind, his scythe raised for a surprise attack. The

Valkyrie launched a spear of light in her hand to intercept him, but missed.

King Wotan turned his head around, to watch death descend upon him.
Demonling Victor's scythe lowered towards his neck...

Splash!

Blood splattered King Wotan's body, as Demonling Victor's scythe cut through his valkyrie's flesh, gorging itself on her soul.

Unable to stop Vainqueur's minion in time, the fairy thrall had flown in the scythe's way, taking the fatal blow for her master. Her aging body fell towards the magma, while Wotan turned around. A swing of his spear sent Victor crashing against the crater's edge, breaking his bones and wings with a loud, sickening noise.

"Sigrun!" Wotan let out a roar of fury as he failed to recover his servant's corpse before it fell into the magma, vanishing beneath waves of lava.

"Sigrun!"

Panicking at the sight of his wing-broken servant barely hanging to the crater's edge, Vainqueur managed to free himself from the rubble, preparing to take flight and rescue his friend.

"What is this?" King Wotan's face twisted into a manling expression, which Vainqueur recognized as pain and confusion. "This feeling of *weakness*?"

King Wotan's emotional confusion sharply lowered all his stats!

"What have you done to me?!" the fomor's anguish at losing his chief of staff almost made Vainqueur pity him. Almost. "The pain is *unbearable*!"

"It's called sadness," Demonling Victor struggled to scoff, the fomor's mighty blow having shattered his ribcage. While he could survive the heat, he couldn't breathe through the smoke well. **"Get used to it!"**

Unable to process these feelings the way a dragon could—by focusing on their own awesomeness—the fomor pointed his spear at Demonling Victor,

to fry him with his lightning. “You shall take your wits with you to the grave, mortal! **[Ragna-”**

Exploiting that single moment of inattention, Vainqueur charged towards Wotan, opening his wings to fly at him. The fairy heard Vainqueur coming...

And the dragon poked the fomor in the eye!

Wotan let out a wail of fury and pain, losing his focus as he put his free hand on his face. “Stay,” Vainqueur raised a fist and punched Wotan with all his might. “Down!”

The sheer power of the blow blew smoke and ashes in all directions and sent Wotan falling down into the lava, his entire body vanishing below the magma.

This time, he didn’t rise up.

The tremors increased, and Vainqueur realized they had no time to waste before his [Geomancy] destroyed the mountain. “Minion!” He shouted as his wounded eye started to recover thanks to [Master's Shield]'s regeneration, flying towards his Vizier. “My hand!”

Demonling Victor used the last of his strength to jump into Vainqueur’s palm, allowing the dragon to seize him. Both flew out of the crater, as an earthquake caused half of it to collapse into the magma. “Sweet Chocolatine?” the dragon asked, having very little time before the final explosion.

“She’s fine!” Demonling Victor replied. **“Your Majesty, fly us out of there fast!”**

And Vainqueur did, navigating through clouds of smoke and beyond the island, just as the volcano *exploded* behind them.

The mountain collapsed on itself, as a titanic column of stone and ashes took to the skies, raining fiery rocks upon the burning island and the sea.

Great waves battered its shores, drowning them below the water. The island had turned into a candle that could be seen for miles.

Vainqueur and Victor grimly watched the apocalyptic devastation from a safe distance, wounded, hurt, exhausted... and most importantly, victorious.

Congratulations! For prevailing over King Wotan in an epic battle and sealing him beneath the earth, you earned two levels in [**Geomancer**]. You earned the [**Terraform: Landmass**] class perk!

+30 HP, +40 SP, +2 SKI, +2 AGI, +2 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Terraform: Landmass**]: 50 SP per fifty meters radius. You can permanently terraform a flat land into the following [Fields]: [Forest], [Marsh], [Desert], [Hill], [Snowland], or [Plains]. If you use this ability in a mountainous area, you can only apply the [Forest] or [Snowland] Field effect.

You earned a [**Heroic Crest**].

A gift from the heavens descended upon Vainqueur, a shiny, rainbowy crest floating before him.

He would have preferred a more pleasurable golden shower... but it would have to do.

Use [**Heroic Crest**] to break past the level 60 class ceiling?

“Yes!” He had lost his mantle and crown for this victory! He deserved it!

Congratulations! You broke past the sixty levels class ceiling! Your [**Crested**] Perk has been upgraded to [**Epic**].

[**Epic**]: Marks one as a mythical adventurer and demigod. Allows access to the most powerful of classes and entrance to [Valhalla] upon reaching level 99. This replaces [Crested].

“**This isn’t over,**” Demonling Victor said, before shapeshifting back into his manling form, “There must still be Valkyrie survivors, and Wotan may

not be dead. We have to expect more—”

“Minion,” Vainqueur interrupted his friend. “Shut up, and appreciate the feeling of hard-won victory.”

His Vizier fell silent, and enjoyed the moment.

Chapter 85: Interlude: Jolie Dragon vs the World

- *Defenders of the Niece, Volume III, chapter four, “The First Princess.”*

Disaster! The worshipers of Sablar, worm god of destruction, have made their way to the New World! The vile Frank the Anark has captured Oriane, princess of the wood elves tribes! Everywhere, evil triumphs!

But a hero has come! The beautiful dragon Jolie, eager to rescue princesses everywhere (so she can keep them for safekeeping), tracked down the villain to his lair in the heart of the jungle. At her sides are the Shining Knight, Kia Bekele, and the fearsome Kobold Rangers, bane of rabbits and Defenders of the Niece. Together, they can overcome any princessnapper.

But the opposition is strong. As they approach the enemy’s stronghold, the air grows foul and thick with the stench of poverty...

Jolie, dragon [Paladin] adventurer, shivered in excitement. Today was the day.

The day when she would become an adult by capturing her first princess, all by herself! An elf princess!

True, her uncle had once given her one for her Bragging Day, but to be acknowledged as a true princess hunter, a dragon had to claim a maiden by themselves. Unwilling to abduct a manling, since they had feelings, the young dragon had crossed the ocean on a ship towards the New World. The one place where elves still had tribes large enough to produce princesses.

After a long search, they had finally located a fair maiden... only to discover that the evil cult of Sablar had abducted her first! Confronted with her duty to gather all princesses for safekeeping, Jolie had immediately given chase to the villains.

Maybe she would gain her thirtieth level while at it?

“Kia?” Jolie asked her best friend, as they moved through the dense jungle. The Kobold Rangers surrounded the young dragon from all sides as her true defenders, while her own armor’s noise made birds and insects fly away.

“Yes, Jolie?” Kia responded, cutting vines with her shiny blade.

“Are there Perks that can drop princesses?”

The knight paused and glanced at her dragon squire. “I’m sorry?”

“Uncle has a Perk that showers him with gold when he is awesome. If I become marvelous like him, will I be showered with princesses?”

“Jolie, that is not how the [Gladiator] class works, at all.”

“But can it be done with another class?” Red asked, curious. “If Chief Victor can summon skulls, can a dragon summon princesses?”

“I... maybe?” The knight shrugged her shoulders. “I haven’t heard of any class like this, but you cannot rule out the possibility.”

A [Princess Maker] class? Awesome! Jolie couldn’t wait to gain it!

The young dragon’s [Virgin Princess Radar] bleeped, causing her to raise her head in excitement. Her maiden sense wasn’t as powerful as her uncle’s, but she could sense her target nearby. “She’s near!” she said giddily. “Very near!”

“Looks like we found the cult,” Kia said, pointing a sword through the foliage. Jolie and the rangers peaked above her shoulder, gazing at a large camp full of tents. While tall grass usually covered the ground, the entire area had been scourged of vegetation, leaving only dry dirt. As she focused

on the source of the princess signal, Jolie noticed a huge, closed stone gate at the northern edge of the camp.

“Alright, if we are discreet, we can take them by surprise,” Kia hushed to the group, before frowning as she caught a glimpse of flags in the middle of the camp. Each of them had the symbol of a badly drawn blue planet on their surface. “At my signal, one, two, three—”

“Oh, visitors!” Kia froze, as an orc came from the camp to welcome them, spoiling the infiltration. “Have you heard about Orknoob our Savior? He died on Earth for our sins!”

“What is an Orknoo—”

“Don’t ask!” Kia interrupted Blue before he could ask the question, sounding more annoyed than she had ever been. “Don’t encourage them!”

“Is this not the camp of Sablar?” Pink asked.

“Oh, the cult of Sablar has always supported the Esoteric Order of the New World,” the orc said. “In their own words, *‘the sooner you all reincarnate on another planet and leave this one a lifeless husk, the better.’* Their priests are very kind and do their best to supply us with carts. You can find their leader Frank in the north of the camp if you’re here to meet him.”

“Infiltration successful!” Jolie said gleefully, while Kia put her hand on her face for some reason.

“Milady is so cute that all these peons can only do as she wants!” Red flattered her.

“Anyway,” the orc said. “If you want I would gladly tell you all about the teachings of Orknoob our Savi—”

“We’ll be on our way, thank you,” Kia interrupted him.

“Oh, can I get spells from this guy?” Blue asked. **“I am looking to convert away from Mithras, too restrictive.”**

“Oh, unfortunately, no, Orknoob doesn’t offer special classes. But, but, if you donate to the true church, they can show you the path to Japan, where everyone is a school—”

“Next,” Jolie’s chief of staff interrupted the conversation yet again, raising her voice this time.

“Yes, no time to waste!” Jolie said, fired up by her dragon paladin instincts. “We will defeat all these villains and rescue Princess Oriane! For my hoard!”

“For the hoard!” the rangers shouted in response, uncaring about warning the puny orcs.

“Jolie, we cannot keep an elf hostage,” Kia protested, unable to understand the tenets of Cattletarianism. The orc looked at them as if they were mad and then departed without a word. “They’re almost extinct!”

“But Kia, it is fine to keep elf princesses! Elves do not have souls!”

“Jolie, we already had this discussion. Elves may be vegetarian, that doesn’t make them *cows*.”

“But that is what the Elder Wyrms said when it created the world!” Jolie protested. “It made grass to feed cows! Hence anyone who only eats grass is cattle!”

“And what about a human vegetarian? Are they cows too?”

“Silly Kia, if a manling abstains from eating meat, then it is no different from me abstaining from eating manlings!”

The shining knight surrendered in front of Jolie’s implacable dragon logic. “This discussion will wait until we actually rescue the princess.”

Spurred on, Jolie ran through the orc camp with her minions in tow, the local orcs looking at her in amazement of her dragonliness. “Sorry, sorry!” Kia pleaded with the locals, as the dragon paladin crushed a few carts and card games on her way to the gate.

Soon, Jolie found herself right in front of the stone doors sticking out from the ground, and there she found the princess kept in a steel cage.

She was perfect in every way, a beautiful, dark-skinned elf with green hair and shiny jewels that radiated princessness. Even in the face of capture and surrounded by orc dung, she looked dignified.

Her jailers were a trio of orcs, two of them thugs armed to the teeth with axes and knives, and the third something else entirely. The leader overshadowed his minions by more than a head, pushing more than eight feet in size and examining symbols on the stone doors. Thick steel armor covered most of his body save the arms, with a planet-eating worm symbol painted on his chest. The monster breathed through a strange mask with a tube linking the mouth to his back, leaving only vicious eyes exposed.

All turned at Jolie's group with frustration, as the dragon and her minions formed a line to face them.

"That thing is an orc?" Even Kia seemed perplexed in the face of such a fearsome princessnapper.

"He's enormous!" Blue complained. "He's as big as a troll!"

"I'm Frank the Anark!" the villain boasted, glancing at the heroes of justice with annoyance. "Who the Happyland are you?"

"Jolie Dragon, greatest dragon paladin in the WOOOORLD!" Jolie howled to the sun, while her rangers clapped in response. "I have come to rescue the princess from your clutches, vile villain!"

"Another, other rescuer?" The orc let out a growl of rage. "Could you goody-two-shoes please mind your own business? I ain't hurting your princess or anything!"

"We know you stole her from the Wood Elf Tribe!" Pink recounted the orc's crimes. "That you intend to sacrifice her to the vile Sablar!"

“Sacrifice... oh, *that’s* what it’s all about, right?” The orc’s eyes turned disdainful. “Just because we are orcs worshiping the god of destruction and abduct an elf maiden, you think we will sacrifice her? Like savages?”

“... yes?” Kia answered the stupid question.

“Well, that’s racial stereotyping! All we will do is dump her on the other side of that planar gate, alongside these idiots,” the orc pointed at the camp. “As soon as we figure out how to open the doorway.”

“W-why?” Jolie couldn’t grasp her head around his ill-intent. “Why kick a princess through a door to nowhere?”

“Because princesses represent the aging establishment, and Sablar thrives on its destruction!” Frank the Evil ranted. “And destroy civilization we shall! We’ll create a world without rulers, without kings! Without queens!”

“Without princesses?” Jolie panicked.

“Without *princesses*!”

The words echoed through Jolie’s skull like a haunting echo, filling her mind with images of an apocalyptic future. A world of darkness, where dragons would roam the world without purpose, without princesses to shelter.

Charisma check successful! [**Terror**] negated!

She faced the greatest threat to the dragon way of life since Furibon the Goldslayer. Jolie had grown convinced of it. “You’re evil!” she declared. “You’re evil, and you have to be *stopped*!”

“What is wrong with you people?! When we massacre your villages to depopulate the world, you complain, and when we offer you a non-violent alternative, you still do it! Make up your damn mind!”

“Yeah, you make genocide look like the easy way out!” one of Frank’s henchmen accused them. “You should be ashamed of yourself!”

“Hey, Frank!” the third orc pointed a finger at Kia, with terror in his eyes. “That girl... it’s Kia Bekele!”

“Kia Bekele?” Frank’s eyes widened in surprise, his anger replaced with apprehension. “The Shining Knight? The woman who killed *Balaur*?!”

“And I am her squire!” Jolie said proudly.

“... oh,” the villain noted, intimidated in the face of true justice. “Well, ain’t that a big problem? I only see one solution to it.”

“The secret technique?” one of the henchmen asked, dumbfounded. “But we never used it before! It’s unorcish!”

“There is a first time for everything!” Frank adopted a menacing stance. “Prepare yourself, men!”

“Minions, to me!” Jolie called, the rangers and Kia brandishing their weapons, ready to lay down their lives for the greater good.

And then, it happened.

Frank and his henchmen turned around, towards the jungle, and ran. They ran, perhaps having summoned a powerful beast right behind the heroes, or sprung a trap. Yet Jolie could not sense anything extraordinary. Perhaps they had called upon an invisible creature? Or...

Or...

“Not again!” Kia jumped after the fleeing orcs. “Come back! I’m not that strong! [Hasten]!”

“My exp!” Jolie panicked, running after the villains. “My exp is running away!”

“Catch them!” Red ordered, the Kobold Rangers chasing after the orcs before they could take cover in the jungle.

“[Chrono Summon],” Frank cast a spell while running, as Kia started catching up to him. “[Brachiosaurus]!”

Kia answered with a laugh. “It’s an herbivore, nothing to worry about!”

A huge shadow formed right above the group, and Jolie realized *where* the orc had summoned the creature.

[**Heroism**] activated! You get a stat bonus to rescue allies in distress!

“Minions, get down!” Reacting on impulse, Jolie grabbed her closest minions, Black and Blue, and pushed them away from the growing shadow; Kia, Pink, and Red were fast enough to dodge, while Yellow simply raised a shield and summoned a barrier of light around himself.

BAM!

An enormous, Vainqueur-sized scaled beast fell into the clearing, blowing dust and rocks in all directions. Tents went flying, orcs ran screaming, trees collapsed, and even the princess’ cage fell to the side. Only the stone gates remained intact.

“Kia! Pink!” Jolie blew away the dust with her wings, while the scaled beast let out a growl of pain, its bones broken by the fall. “Yellow!”

“We are fine, Milady!” Pink shouted. “We are alright!”

After checking Black and Blue, who were more surprised than hurt, the dragon rushed after the villains, only to find them long gone.

No! The evil orc had fled! The princess had been saved... but at what cost?

“Poor beast,” Pink said as she examining the scaly beast howling in agony. “The fall broke its legs.”

“To cowardly abuse one’s minion like that orc,” Red shook his head. “Loathsome.”

“Blue, help me cast healing spells on it,” Yellow said, emerging from the dust unharmed. The Kobold Rangers gathered around the beast, to nurse it back to health.

“Why?” Kia complained, hitting the ground with one fist. “Why do they always flee? *Why?*”

“It is okay, Kia!” Jolie reassured her, as she approached the steel cage to check on the princess. “We have saved Oriane anyway!”

And indeed they had! The blast had weakened the cage, enough for Jolie to break it open with her bare claws! While covered in dust and bruised, the princess was unharmed. “Thank you, fair dragon,” she said in elf with a delicious, honeyed voice. “You have saved me.”

“And now I will bring you home with me!” Jolie nodded happily.

“To my tribe? You will bring me back to my tribe?”

“No, to my home!” Jolie gently caught the princess by her robes, lifting her like a kitten above the ground. She let out a squeal of surprise, which made her even cuter. “Yoush ash now my prinshesh!”

“Jolie!” her beloved chief of staff started nagging the dragon. “Release her! She’s scared!”

“Shia, elvesh mashe the besh prinsheshes!” Jolie continued, her mouth full from the princess’ dress. “Thasish the trush!”

“Can we at least return her to her tribe first?” the knight pleaded. “If not, they will assume that the cult killed her. Have you thought about her relatives, Jolie?”

The dragon froze, something in her friend’s tone somehow making her ashamed of herself. It was true that by stealing away the princess without her family’s permission, she would be no better than these orcs.

And dragons, as the supreme beings, had a duty to show themselves better than everyone else.

“I’m shorry,” Jolie apologized, putting the princess back on the ground and releasing her. “I should make you happy to become part of my hoard, instead of abducting you as those orcs did. We will bring you to your family first, I promise!”

The princess was too shy to answer, and so simply nodded. Kia gave the maiden a pat on the shoulders, whispered a few words in elven to her ear, and calmed her. “I still wonder where that gate leads though,” the knight said, glancing at the stone gates. “If Sablar worshipers wanted access to it... there can be nothing good on the other side.”

“Oh, maybe it leads to fairyland!” Jolie replied, before examining runes on the door, “*There lies the first gate to the Elemental Plane of Earth.* Never heard of it.”

“You know how to read this language?”

“Uncle Genialissime taught me the tongue of the fomors, so I could insult them in their own language!” Jolie boasted, “They made doors like this one everywhere since dragons created the world, you know?”

Her chief of staff looked at her with her big eyes, amazed by her friend’s knowledge. The dragon felt so proud! “Silly Kia, do you not know how dragons created the world?”

The knight’s lack of answer started to worry Jolie, while the Kobold Rangers tended to the scaled beast’s wounds out of the goodness of their heart. “You do not?”

“I heard conflicting stories,” she admitted.

Conflicting stories? From the fairies? No wonder she had such confusing ideas about elves and cows! The dragon couldn’t let that stand, and so decided to open her friend’s mind to the truth, the *dragon* truth.

“Long ago, there was only void and earth,” Jolie recounted her uncle Genialissime’s favorite tale, the one he told her all the time when she was a child. “The earth was without form, and the darkness unshiny. Then came

the Elder Wyrms, first of all dragons, who was just passing through. And it said, *'let there be shinies!'* And it created the stars with its breath."

"That... sounds familiar."

It should! "And then the Elder Wyrms said, *'let there be gold and gems for my hoard!'* And it shaped the earth, so it could produce riches for the great hoard! But the Elder Wyrms felt lonely because it had no one to brag to about its immense wealth! And so, it created the dragons in its image!"

"Oh, I know what happens next!" Pink interrupted the conversation, having climbed on the scaly long-necked beast's back to pet it. The creature had responded by licking its rider. "The Elder Wyrms realized that its dragon children were too good to gather the gold and the gems for the great hoard themselves. And so, the first dragon created the minions, to harvest wealth from the earth."

"But then the dragons and minions became hungry, and so the Elder Wyrms invented cattle to feed them, and then fruits and vegetables so the cows would not starve," Jolie continued. "Because the Elder Wyrms is nice and considerate!"

"Is that the official dragon creation myth?" Kia asked, Jolie nodding furiously; then she added, with a very strange tone. "That explains a lot of things..."

"After having bragged to its children for seven days, the Elder Wyrms said, *'This whole world is your hoard now, my sons and daughters! Be fruitful and multiply, and breed minions to make hoards of your own! For one day I will return, and you will all brag about your wealth to me!'* And then it departed to add new suns to its piggy bank."

"That's an interesting tale Jolie," Kia smiled. "But what does it have to do with the gate?"

"I'm getting to it!" Jolie said, having grown engrossed by the sound of her own voice. "Dragons and minions lived in harmony... until the fomors attacked! They rose from below the earth, looked upon the land the Elder

Wyrms made, and said, *'this is our hoard now! We created it!'* Then they built doors, to capture manlings, elves, and dwarves minions through them."

"Wait, the fomors created planar doorways?" The plot twist had taken her chief of staff aback. "To where? The elemental planes?"

"From far, far away, but that's not important," Jolie brushed her questions away. "The dragons said *'this is not your hoard, we made the world first'*! But the fairies kept lying, so Grandrake stole one of their princesses. And that is how fairies and dragons went to war."

Her chief of staff glanced at Jolie's princess, then at the gate. "Could it be..." she trailed, a thought on her mind.

Intelligence check successful!

But Jolie finished it for her. "Oh, Kia, I understand! I understand what you are thinking!"

"You do?" The knight grinned at her best friend. "You think it is possible?"

"Yes! If the planet moon cannot sustain dragon life, we can go to other worlds instead! I am sure they are full of treasures and princesses!"

Kia's smile stopped reaching her ears, the strain of the emotions too strong for her.

And so, Jolie Dragon, most beautiful and only niece of the good Emperor Vainqueur, captured her first princess; becoming an adult in the eyes of dragons and minions alike. Princess Oriane was brought back to her tribe, who kindly gifted her to the dragon of justice. For they knew the vile Frank remained afoot, and that Oriane would only be safe as part of a dragon's hoard!

With the reveal of the gate, the promise of new worlds encouraged the Niece to reach for new heights in her quest for wealth! For her heart is pure, and her hoard golden!

Yet, sometimes, I, Pink Ranger, glimpse at Kia the Shining giving strange, morose looks at those doors. For she had glimpsed at the trials beyond.

But fear not, for in the end, dragons will always prevail!

Chapter 86: Advanced Civilizations

Congratulations! For helping your master defeat King Wotan and trapping his right-hand woman's soul in your scythe, you have earned a level in **[Weathermaker]** and a level in **[Reaper]**!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +2 VIT, +2 SKI, +2 AGI, +3 INT, +2 CHA, +2 LCK.

By reaching level thirty in **[Reaper]**, you maxed out the class! You can no longer take levels in it, but you gained the capstone ability **[Charon's Grim Harvest]**!

[Charon's Grim Harvest]: Reaper Capstone, 5 SP per second. You summon phantasmal, flying sickles in a wide radius around yourself, which will instinctively seek out all non-undead creatures within your vicinity to harvest their souls. The sickles inflict medium **[Spirit]** damage on contact, and if one kills a target, their soul is transferred to your main scythe as if affected by the **[Helheim]** Perk. With each soul harvested, the Perk's radius will increase exponentially.

By consuming many fresh souls and your capping of the **[Reaper]** class, your scythe evolved into a **[Scythe of Charon]**!

[Scythe of Charon]: +30 critical; inflicts a STR/VIT debuff on successful hits.

Well, it was bound to happen. Maxing out the **[Reaper]** class and Vainqueur breaking past the level 60 cap made Victor somewhat happy, but didn't make up for the post-battle exhaustion.

"Are we there yet?" Vainqueur asked as they flew over the shores of the New World, leaving the Dagger Coast behind them.

“The pyramid is there,” Victor pointed his scythe at a tipping point over the horizon. Although the sun had almost set, he could see dozens of winged, crimson ships flying over the area, the first sign of civilization since they sank Grandrake’s island. “This is the great pyramid of Kukulcan, capital of the Thaoten Empire.”

It didn’t take them long to reach the city, built in the middle of a lake of blood.

Beyond that ominous bit, the place couldn’t look more awe-inspiring. Far larger than any city of the Mistral Continent, the Thaoten capital was an entire island linked the lake’s shores by four bridges, one for each cardinal point. Built almost entirely of orange bricks, the houses were aligned in a very organized fashion, a stark contrast with the chaotic Murmurin. Immense alleys all lead to the city’s center, a massive mesoamerican pyramid as tall as the Empire State Building.

“I smell undead everywhere,” Vainqueur said, aiming for the pyramid. Unlike Port Damn , no ship attempted to stop them; in fact, they moved out of their way.

“This is a vampire theocracy, ruled by undead priests,” Victor explained. “The vampiric Red Plague came from here, brought by explorers from the New World to the Old. Most of the citizens are reptilian lizardkin, and the worthiest citizens are rewarded with unlife.”

He had also heard they sacrificed their enemies to feed their elites, but thought it wiser not to mention it.

“Batlings, hm?” Vainqueur grunted, gazing at a population of humanoid lizards watching at him with awe. “At least these ones have scales, which is a mark of utmost patrician refinement.”

“It’s fine, Your Majesty, these ones are friendly,” Victor said, noticing a crowd waiting for them at the main plaza, right at the pyramid’s base. Since night had now fallen, mists swirled around the pyramid, taking the shape of albino lizardkin.

As always, Vainqueur made his presence loud and clear by landing on the plaza, blowing bricks in all directions. Victor's own landing was a lot more discreet.

The crowd that welcomed them was almost entirely reptilian, but the species making it up were surprisingly varied. While many were lizardkin, some of them obviously vampires, Victor noticed many winged kobolds, serpent-like creatures, and even wyverns among them.

The vampiric lizardkin obviously led them, each wearing elaborate, Aztec-like dresses of feathers. One of them stood out from the lot, an albino lizardkin with an elaborate winged hat and a staff resembling a mighty mosquito, the symbol of Camilla. Victor immediately used [Monster Insight] on him.

High Priest Xolotl

Lizardkin Vampire Progenitor (Undead/Reptile)

Strong against Holy, Unholy, Moon, Berserk, Darkness, Fire, Lightning, Blood, Frost, Necromancy, Drain, Insta-Death, Mind-Control, Disease, Poison, Fatigue, Sleep, and Beast.

Weak against Sunlight, Life, Manslayer, and Scaleslayer.

One of the first vampires of Outremonde, a follower of Camilla older than most countries. As personable as an undead, bloodsucking abomination against nature can be, he is currently on a 'socially responsible' vampire diet, feeding only on the blood of disgraced politicians.

"Welcome, great guests!" the priest said, his voice old but brimming with power. "I am one of the Thirty-One spiritual guides of the Thaoten Empire, Xolotl. Mother Camilla foretold your coming."

"Ah, a dragonian speaker," Vainqueur said. "Perfect. Minion, announce ourselves."

“I am Victor Dalton, Grand Vizier of His Majesty Vainqueur Goldbeard Knightsbane, August Emperor of the V&V Empire, Ishfania, the Pirate Sea and the Albain Mountains. He is also known as the Defender of the Hoard, Minion Liberator, Greatest Gladiator, Billionaire Adventurer, and bringer of Dragon Civilization.”

“A great evil lies close, priest,” Vainqueur declared. “The vile Goldslayer Furibon will soon turn the golden El Dorado to lead! We *must* stop him!”

“That too.”

“We Thaoten will help you on your holy quest,” the priest replied. “You shall be guests of honor for the night, and the nights afterward. A great feast of cattle shall be ordered to celebrate your coming.”

“I also demand a lava bath!” Vainqueur ordered. “I am weary, wealthy, and important.”

“You will have it.”

This made the dragon pause. “You... you have a lava bath?”

“Of course we have one,” the priest replied, shocking Vainqueur. He clearly hadn’t expected them to deliver on his usual impractical demands.

“Dragons are great and mighty beings, and we have honored the few who delivered their wisdom to us since the empire’s early nights.”

“I also want minions to cater to my every whim,” Vainqueur demanded, pushing his luck.

“Bring the dragon-kissers minions,” the vampire priest ordered while raising his staff. Immediately, a group of a hundred, winged kobolds arrived to serve Vainqueur. Many of them wore strange fur mantles.

And then, before the Vizier knew it, the kobolds threw themselves at V&V’s feet, their back exposed. On a closer look, Victor could finally see the mantles closer, and what they truly looked like.

Doormats.

“Our guests are too important to walk on the ground of common citizens,” Xolotl continued. “Our minions will make sure you never have to go outside your private quarters. Go on, and try them.”

Victor glanced at his master, who was completely speechless at this degree of servility, and hesitantly stepped on a kobold’s back. “Is it painful?” the Vizier asked, hoping he didn’t crush the poor creature’s back. “Am I too heavy?”

“It is perfect!” The kobold replied with an... *aroused* voice. “The feeling of being trampled by a higher being fills me with joy!”

“We are experimenting with minion chairs, who will allow guests to sit anywhere,” the priest continued. “And fawners, who will fawn over you while you bathe. They will remind you of how good and wise you are for the entire duration of your stay.”

Victor could almost see the gears turn in Vainqueur’s head, as he probably imagined new ways to order his minions around. “Manling Victor, this is the greatest archeological discovery since gold mining!” he declared. “We found a lost, advanced minion civilization! Far more advanced than yours!”

“I’ll do my best to reach that stage of development, Your Majesty,” Victor deadpanned.

“It is fine, minion, I forgive you. You are only half a dragon.”

Victor had to admit it, these vampires knew how to greet guests.

They had given Vainqueur and Victor each an entire wing of the pyramid as their own, each bigger than the Vizier’s manor. The Reaper’s own room included a king-sized golden bed, a magical mirror serving as some sort of interplanar tv, a jacuzzi, a sauna, a hammam, and, the pinnacle of *luxury*, a small, private, primitive soccer field.

How did the architects manage to fit all of that in a single place?

In any case, Victor traded his armor for a dressing gown, kindly offered by kobold servants eager to serve him. He jumped in the bed, whose feather-made mattress felt so soft, he could sink in it.

But unfortunately, he had a few things to check out before enjoying that warm place.

“Isabelle?” Victor closed his eyes and mentally focused on the demonic CEO, praying she was alright. He would have contacted Chocolatine first if her being overplane didn’t hinder his [Scarlet Study] Perk. “Isa?”

“*Yes, darling?*” the voice responded warmly through telepathy.

“Oh, thank the archfiends, you're alive!”

“*Why would I be dead?*” the governor responded, sounding irritated.

Because he thought a certain werewolf had killed her. “Oh, we, we almost died on our end, I had to check you out; especially since you’re starting out on your new job. Chocolatine said she exchanged a few words with you.”

“*That werewolf girl? We had a very pleasant conversation, I like her. She understands how Hell works so well she could have been a demon herself. We will definitely do business in the future.*”

Really?

“*However, I came back home afterward to find my guards slaughtered, and a cow’s head in my bed,*” she admitted. “*Why is that?*”

“Because the only horse in Murmurin is mine,” Victor replied, sighing. Clearly, while Chocolatine had agreed not to murder the competition, godfather-style intimidation remained a viable strategy.

“*I see... any idea who the culprit might be?*”

“No,” the Vizier lied.

"I see," she replied with a tone that implied she believed in the opposite, before adding, sensually. *"When are you coming back?"*

"At least a month or two."

"I will have a surprise on your return, but I will not spoil it telepathically. Take care."

Victor ended the communication, puzzled, before mentally checking up on his allies in Murmurin and Port Vainqueur. Since they would open an embassy in the Thaoten Empire, probably with a permanent portal towards their own empire, he asked Allison, Malfy, Miel and Vainqueur's main minions to be ready to cross over soon.

"We will take care of the princesses Vainqueur brought to us," Allison said. *"Poor girls, isolation did terrible things to their sanity."*

"Can you try to locate their still living relatives?" Victor asked. "We should try to return them to their loved ones if we can."

"Vainqueur won't be happy."

"I will cook up some excuse, and dragons have a catch and release program. He will understand."

By now, Victor understood how dragons worked, their levers, and what arguments could convince them. While uncaring, Vainqueur was no longer inconsiderate of people's feelings now either; he would probably be more open than ever to such suggestions.

"Also, I have come across disturbing news," Victor dropped the bomb, "We have come across a fomor with class levels."

Allison's answer took a while to arrive. *"Are you **sure**?"*

"Certain, and I doubt that he is an isolated case. Vainqueur buried that fairy lord under an erupting island, but I doubt he died." As a good Vizier, Victor refused to believe the enemy dead until he had disposed of the body

personally. "I will share you the coordinates of that place, and I want it watched at all times."

"It will be done. I will tell everyone to remain on high alert as well."

Victor nodded, stopping the communication after sharing the island's rough coordinates. His [Monster Insight] had mentioned a soul crest... could it be an unknown type of Crest capable of granting class levels, even to fairies?

"You will die," a new voice said.

The Vizier interrupted the communication, glancing at his scythe, and the new soul in it.

"My master still lives, below the earth, raging against his bindings," the Valkyrie, Sigrun, taunted him. *"My sisters will find you! You may run, but you will never escape His Highness' justice—"*

Victor mentally muted the sound of the scythe, leaving the Valkyrie to fruitlessly try to scream at him. One of the tricks he had learned at Scholomance.

A sulfuric portal opened in the room, causing the Kobold servants to panic before Victor raised a hand to calm them. About time, he thought, as Chocolatine stepped through. He was starting to wonder if the fiends intended to keep her for ransom.

"Ta-da!" Chocolatine had traded her dress for an indecent black corset, with tiny wings and a demon tail attached. "How do I look? How do I look?"

"Amazing," Victor replied, before noticing the receipt in her hand. "What is this?"

"The expenses," she said, giving it to him. "The succubi said the overplane travels cost extra."

That was a way to put it! "Thank the gods I make as much as a third world dictator," Victor said out loud, upon reading the number on the check. "Before Vainqueur's cut that is."

“What is this place?” Chocolatine asked as Victor hid the receipt under the mattress, the werewolf putting her arms around his neck. “A tomb?”

“The Thaoten Empire’s central pyramid.”

“The Thaoten? Awesome! You should invite Jules too, he always wanted to visit this place. Is it true they built their capital in the middle of a blood lake?”

“Yes, and I still have no idea how they did it.”

“Silly, obviously one demon at a time!”

Her childish excitement made all his worries and exhaustion melt away.

“We can go sightseeing if you wish,” Victor said, putting his arms around her waist and drawing her closer to him.

“Oh, can we try the local cuisine? I want to add new recipes, and I believe you can only understand another culture by tasting them.”

Victor didn’t comment on the ambiguous wording, and he didn’t have the strength of heart to deny her. “Whatever you want,” he said, briefly kissing her on the lips. After the very tense situation with Wotan, he felt relieved to be in her arms again. He couldn’t put a word on it, but the werewolf’s company made him feel somewhat at peace, in ways other women didn’t. And that was in spite of her general insanity.

“You’re so sweet, Vic,” she said, after breaking the kiss. “I’m sure we will learn a lot! I mean, you cannot build a country as big as their own without making many species coexist together. I know they have a bad reputation because they brought vampires to us, but Charlene is one, and she’s super nice!”

As if to answer her thoughts, a cloud of mist intruded into the chamber, soon coalescing into the high priest Xolotl. If he was surprised by Chocolatine’s appearance, he didn’t show it, and simply greeted her. The spellcaster probably had them under tight surveillance. “Dear guest and

chosen of the goddess, I hope that you found your accommodations appropriate for your rank.”

“I’m thankful for your hospitality,” Victor said, frankly impressed by it. “And I’m sure Vainqueur is too.”

“You see me rejoiced,” the priest said with an archaic manner of speech, before showcasing his own Claimed branding on his arm, below his priestly dress. Since he didn’t speak like a reincarnated human, Victor guessed the goddess claimed the reptile as a personal favor. “I would delight in tasting your holy blood as you taste mine, so we may blood-bond as fellow chosen of the Goddess.”

“That’s... intimate...”

“Vic, I bit you everywhere that counts, and I’m sure Charlene did too,” Chocolatine said with a happy grin. “Shouldn’t you be used to it?”

“You’re not helping.”

“If blood drinking is too close, we can perhaps each cut a lump of flesh and taste the other’s?” the priest suggested as a middle ground.

“Oh, do you make cakes out of demons too?” Chocolatine interrupted, suddenly interested.

“We have many unique recipes,” Xolotl replied, clearly proud to showcase his culture to a foreigner. “Fiendish Pathé, Chocolate-stuffed Phoenix Heart, Imp Filet... still, I insist on the exchange ritual. Among Thaoten, to share one’s blood is the supreme expression of trust and friendship.”

In diplomacy as in the bedroom, sacrifices had to be made... “Sure,” Victor said. “But please be gentle when we get to it, okay?”

Now he realized that wasn’t the best way to describe it...

“Excellent. As expected of one worthy of the goddess, and the supreme servant of a dragon lord.”

“About that, how did you achieve such a level of... *cultural refinement*?” It hurt just to say it.

“We Thaoten are a highly advanced society,” the priest said like he was repeating a script. “Yes, a very advanced society.”

“You can drop the mask,” Victor said. “I recognize a kindred spirit.”

“Oh, thank the goddess, you understand the *pain*,” the priest said, the word resonating with the Vizier. “One dragon at a time, scaled brother. Our empire is old, and while we have only met a few of them, dragons embody chaos. We found these guest rituals easier to placate them with, than having the fiery ones scour our countryside of its cattle.”

“Oh, can you give us a tour of your city?” Chocolatine asked. “I want to visit every corner!”

“With pleasure. Truth to be told, we Thaoten would enjoy fostering good relationships with an oversea nation. Our attempts to establish contact with countries beyond the ocean ended in disaster, when they rejected Mother Camilla’s gift and slaughtered our envoys.”

Vampirism. A plague for some, a gift for others. “We’re preparing for war though,” Victor warned. “Against the fomors.”

“Good. To fight in the goddess' name against the soulless heathens is a Thaoten’s duty, and we need more sacrifices. The lake of life needs fresh new blood.”

“Do you know of Isengrim, the best god ever?” Chocolatine preached for her deity. “He is kind and amazing!”

“We know of the Great Hunter, and he is granted a temple in our Holy City, but we exalt Mother Camilla above all others,” Xolotl replied, before focusing back on Victor. “While I will answer the call of the goddess, we Thaoten are an equal necrocracy. My Thirty fellow rulers will ask for gifts and tribute in exchange for help. Especially to access El Dorado.”

“Oh?” Victor frowned, “They would be more open to a war than going there?”

“The Golden City is a cursed place. I told the dragon that he was not the first of his kind to seek it, but he still wishes to go there.”

“Cursed how?” Victor asked.

“It has drawn many foreigners, thieves, and would-be conquerors, and let few of them leave,” the priest said. “There is a great calamity trapped there, a ‘superbeast,’ or so it is called. It cannot escape the city’s vault, but it can still call the greedy to him. The lich you hunt must have answered its lure. In any case, my fellows will not risk bringing the curse on their own pyramids without proper compensation.”

“Would this be appropriate?” Victor asked, showcasing his [Black Grail] on a bedside table. “It is an artifact of great potency, which Camilla asked me to deliver to you; it can raise the dead under specific circumstances, providing the illusion of life.”

“Interesting,” the priest nodded, casting a few spells to identify the object. “This is a holy artifact.”

“I can let you borrow it for studies, in exchange for a passage to El Dorado, and the opening of negotiations for military help.”

“That should do,” the priest declared, happy with the proposal. “We priests of Camilla always study the undead condition, so that we may share the gift of immortality to all. Once we have perfected vampirism, we shall embrace as brothers while the sun rises. One night, we shall cure death for all beings of Outremonde!”

“Also, if you are part of a cult, could you provide me with equipment?” Chocolatine smirked. “I really need ropes, a sacrificial knife, and a pig for later.”

“We do not have any ‘pig,’ but we do have llamas,” the priest replied. “Do you wish to sacrifice it? Does your god demand blood?”

“It’s just for, uh...” Victor shivered, struggling to find the right way to say it in polite society, before abandoning. “Breeding.”

“Breeding? With a beast?” The priest suddenly understood. “Oh, I understand. You make a sacrifice to improve virility before the bedding of the bride.”

That was a way to put it... “Can you help, then?” Chocolatine asked, clearly eager to do the deed after visiting the city.

“I will see that the temple’s acolytes bring you what you need, and more. [Summon Item].” The priest raised his staff, and a crimson potion materialized in his hand. “This sacred elixir brings great health to the living. Yes, great health!”

“But you priests are undead,” Victor frowned.

“On the undead, it offers *spiritual* health,” the priest replied. “I would not advise partaking it with a mortally blessed person unless you can keep them in a safe, secluded environment. The effects are very strong for the uninitiated. Take it now, and it will cleanse your body of its impurities before the event.”

Xolotl then graciously excused himself to ‘see to the cattle feast,’ leaving Victor and his favorite werewolf with the bottle. The Vizier took the first sip, and while it tasted nothing like blood, he couldn’t put a word on the mixture.

It didn’t feel effective either.

[**Darwinist**] activated. You will count as [**Undead**] for the purpose of the [**Mushroom Wine of Power**].

The cosmic trip will begin shortly. Prepare yourself.

The cosmic trip? Like what, teleportation?

...

Why were his fingers starting to look like snakes?

Chapter 87: The Trip

Victor's hands had transformed into snakes, and his legs into tentacles, but otherwise, everything was fine.

The world had turned orange, and the stars into red eyes looking down on him. The pyramid now looked like a Freudian representation of pent-up sexual energies, and the spirit of slaughtered cows danced around it.

“Viiiiiiiiiccccc!” Chocolatine said, walking and talking in slow motion.
“Aaaaarrrrrrrrreeee yyyooooouuuu aaaaallllrrrrrrriiiiigggggghhhhtttt?”

“Yes,” Victor said. “I feel *amazing*.” He felt warm inside, as if the energies of the cosmos heated him up.

“Yyooooouuu doonnnottt loookkk aallrrrrrigggghttt!”

“MEEENYYYYEEEEOOONNNSSS!”

Victor looked up to see Vainqueur flying under the crimson eyed sky. The dragon had gained a pony-shaped crown and the look of a drunk psychopath in his eyes.

“LLLUUUUVVV MEEE!”

And the dragon ripped the skies in two and showered the Thaoten city with gold and minions. He could see them fall, all of them. Allison, Charlene, Miel, Malfy, Jules, Rolo, all of them falling like a rain of bodies with bright baby smiles on their faces.

Okay, maybe there was something wrong with the universe.

That was what the intellectual, rational part of Victor thought. But somehow, he couldn't bring himself to care. He felt happy, like never before.

So the Vizier hopped happily in the street with Chocolatine, as the other minions landed on their feet among the cow ghosts and the giant lizards eating them. Allison transformed into a tree upon landing, Charlene into a swarm of bats, Malfy into a giant centipede with a thousand contracts in each pincer, showing them to the lizards. Houses turned into candy and sweet cakes; everything smelled like orange.

And Vainqueur vomited honey on everyone.

"This world is amazing!" Victor declared, climbing up a tree so he could see the beautiful landscape better. He found it strangely difficult.

"VVIIIIICCC!" Chocolatine called him from below, as he continued his ascension upward. "Stttttttooopp! Peeeeeeeoopppllee aaaarreee waaatttchhhiiiiinnngg!"

The great cosmic eyes looked down on him with curious interest, for a reason Victor couldn't explain. The tree of life put a branch in his face, but as he kept climbing, it started helping him get up. From below, Chocolatine howled and transformed into a wolf, before chewing the roots.

The Vizier finally reached the top of the tree and looked at this amazing world with fresh new eyes. A message boiled within him; a message of peace and harmony, that he couldn't wait to share.

"MRRR. Viiicctooooor!" Miel called him, flying above the tree where he had taken refuge. "Yooouuurr kkaaaaarmmmaaa! Thiiinnnkk aaaboooutt ttthhee kaaarmmmaa!"

With the beautiful energies bursting within him, Victor couldn't lie any longer. "I lied! I lied about everything!" he said, flying toward her and dancing with her above the ground, far away from the tree below and everyone else. "I have a Perk!"

And he blessed her with the light of truth, unloading every lie he had ever said. They all transformed into flies, making him lighter and warmer.

Miel then transformed. She transformed before Victor's very eyes, her eyes turning red, her two hands multiplying into four, eight, twenty, thousands! They slapped, and punched, and clawed him everywhere that counted.

He should have felt pain, but instead, he could sense himself approaching enlightenment.

A hand sent him flying back, and he bounced back a building, then on a bat, then on a soft marshmallow thing that propelled him back on his two feet.

Congratulations! For daring to venture through the street of a metropolis completely naked, you earned the **[Exhibitionist]** personal Perk!

[Exhibitionist]: You gain a bonus to Evasion when fighting naked.

What?

He looked at himself and realized he had no armor anymore. But he couldn't see his fleshy bits, for his skin now shone with the power of love. He had become a walking neon star, illuminating the universe with love radiation.

Warning: for publicly confessing your insurance fraud, you have lost all the benefits of your Karma Insurance plan!

Just in time for a horde of winged monsters to charge at him from all sides, waving underwear and pants at him.

“STTTTOOOPPP HIIMMM!” a thunderous voice shouted hysterically.

“UUSSEEE TTHEEE PAAANTTS!

FRRRAAAUUDDDDSSSSTTTTEEERRR!”

“MIINNIIIOONNN!” Vainqueur shouted from above, vomiting honey.

“KIIICCCKKK TTTHEEIRRR ASSS! YOOUU CAAANNN DOOO ITTT!”

Victor could, for he now wielded the one true power of love. He raised his hands, and fired a rainbow at the hateful masses from his snake-fingers. He kept showering everyone with his light, defeating all those who dared approach.

God.

This was what being a god felt like!

“Do you see, Vic?” Chocolatine’s voice echoed in his head, except no longer in slow motion. “It always looks like this to me!”

“It’s wonderful!” Victor shouted back, blasting everyone with rainbows.

At long last, once he had overcome all the hate, he summoned a cup of chocolate to his hand and showered the winged creatures with the substance. They quickly rose from the dead as chocolate statues, delicious and sugar-full.

Bats and loving people surrounded him, to partake in his love radiation. They took his chocolate cup and he shared his warmth like a lamb, letting them bite him everywhere. They absorbed his energies, and while he felt weaker, he had to share it with everyone.

Congratulations! For being bitten by dozens of vampires eager to drink your holy blood—and Charlene—as part of a feast gone awry, you have earned the **[Vampire Kiss]** monster Perk!

[Vampire Kiss]: You can drink the blood of the living to replenish yourself by biting them, consuming a liter of blood every minute of sustained effort. You recover half the HP damage you inflicted, and the victim contracts the **[Vampiric Red Plague]** unless they possess resistance or immunity to **[Disease]**. Creatures without blood are immune to this Perk.

Warning: critical health!

“Uussee ooouuurrr poooweer!” Xolotl’s voice echoed, as the bats all offered their own holy energies in return. “Uussee ooouurr poooweer!”

Victor raised his hands and collected all the radiation offered to him, the rainbows flowing into his heart and refreshing him.

[**Blood Fountain**] activated! You recovered all your lost HP!

“Come to me!”

A voice called from above. From the Moooooon!

“Come to me!”

And Victor answered, riding a rainbow toward the shining celestial object. The city became a speck, as he flew out of the atmosphere and through the dark cosmic void.

“Minion!”

Victor turned his head behind him, for the voice did not belong to Vainqueur.

It was that cursed cat he inherited from Lavere, Felix von Meow! Chasing him on his own rainbow! “Your lap is mine, manling!” the feline boasted with fiery determination, claws extended. “Come back to me!”

“How can you fly?!” Victor asked.

“I am a cat! I can do anything!”

Quick, Victor accelerated, trying to outrun his furry pursuer. Thankfully, powered by envy instead of cosmic love, Felix couldn’t catch up to the Vizier, who entered the Moooooon’s orbit.

He watched Croissant, dressed like a barbarian, fending off spiders and looking up at him. “Croissant!” Victor waved a hand at him, “I love you!”

“BLEEP you!” the werewolf flipped him off in response.

Victor continued his flight around the Mooon, past the dark tentacles on its back, until he reached a light behind it. A floating orb of green goo,

radiating love and warmth.

“Welcome, Victor!” the wise creature spoke to his mind, bringing him clarity. “I am your spirit animal, your totem! The green slime!”

The slime? Awesome! And here he thought he would have a rabbit for a totem!

“The signs were there since the beginning, slimy one! You have finally embraced your inner stickiness!”

Congratulations! For meeting your spirit animal, the mighty green slime, you earned the [**Slime Totem**] personal perk!

[**Slime Totem**]: Mindless [Slime] type see you as one of their own and do not attack you unless provoked first; otherwise, +5 to charisma when interacting with sentient [Slimes].

“The sliminess is the key, Victor!” his spirit animal told him. “To glue all species together is the key to peace! Your soft stickiness must conquer all! But you cannot glue the hateful one, no, for she is unjellifiable!”

“What must I do?” Victor asked as both flew beyond the Moooooon, towards a strange black wall beyond the edge of reality.

“You must stick to your dragon! Be the slime armor that coats his scales, the shield that will protect his life! For if he dies, the hateful one’s arrows of light will burn everything! Only Vainqueur can defeat the hateful one! Only him! But only you can end the war! Stickiness, slimy one! Only stickiness can end the cycle of destruction!”

“I will jelly them all!” Victor promised his totem, as he kept flying forward and left the slime behind. “I swear!”

“May the glue be with you!”

And then Victor’s flight ended when he crashed against the black wall like a window, landing on soft paper.

“... Vic? Vic is that you?”

Victor recognized Camilla’s voice, rising back to his feet to find himself in the middle of a giant map. Five colossal deities, the Dread Three, the Moon Man, and Shesha, looked at him with surprise. From their point of view, he must have looked no taller than a mouse.

“How did he get in?” Deathjester asked. “No, seriously, how? How did he get in?”

“Victor, I am sorry, but this is a private, god-only gathering,” Camilla said with an embarrassed smile. “I will have to kindly ask you to leave...”

The goddess paused, as she examined his fleshy bits and the bite marks all over his skin. "Oh, my..."

“Why is he naked?” Shesha asked, more confused than anything. “Did Cybele send him?”

“Hey, friends, what are you doing in my hallucination?” Victor asked, still high.

“Gamete prophet, what are you doing in my hallucination?” the Moon Man answered, just as high as his chosen.

“I knew it was your fault!” Veran complained. “I told you all we shouldn’t have let him gamemaster this session! It never ends well!”

Deathjester sighed. “Moon Man, please send him back home.”

“Yes, Gamete Prophet, come back after defeating the Final Boss, if you can,” the Moon Man asked kindly. “And congratulations for your thirty-two new eyes.”

“What eyes?” Victor asked, having only two.

“Oh, sorry, I am looking a bit too forward.”

“Roll me!” Dice, the only god with Victor’s size, jumped on the map next to the Vizier, crushing Atlantis while at it. “Roll me for my turn!”

Pushed by insanity, and the drug, Victor lifted the dice above his head and stood in front of the gods, *menacingly*.

“No, no, no, human, don’t!” Veran panicked, trying to throw him off the board.

And Victor rolled Dice.

“Twenty!” the luck god shouted like a child. “Natural twenty! New stuff!”

A surge of world-shattering magic swallowed Victor whole, and all went dark.

Victor woke up with the worst headache of his entire life.

Oh, gods... oh gods, the pain... he could barely feel his body, and the sun on his eyes didn’t improve his mood.

For undergoing a harrowing spiritual journey, you have gained a natural Resistance to all forms of recreational drugs. You may or may not come to regret it.

His eyes acclimated to the sunlight, his ears to the sound of the jungle, and his skin to the sensation of grass on his back.

“Minion, you are awake!” Vainqueur looked down on him with a joyful look. “Finally.”

“My... my armor...” Victor panicked, for he was cold, and covered with bite marks. “Where did my armor go?”

“You desecrated it,” Vainqueur replied absentmindedly. “Thankfully, Sweet Chocolatine recovered your scythe and underwear.”

Desecrate? Uh...

“Friend Victor, I am so proud of you,” Vainqueur said with fondness. “You tried, and that is the important thing. I admit that I was very worried when you flew towards that cursed lead hellhole in the skies after you *destroyed* these puritanical birds... but you tried to fulfill your minion duty.”

“Did what? I don’t remember... uh, my head, it hurts so much...”

“It is my fault, minion,” the dragon reassured him. “I should have told you we red dragons have a serious dwarf intolerance, and you inherited it. I do not know how many you ate to get *that* drunk, but one was too much already.”

“I... I don’t understand...”

“I know. We are superior beings. We think we can control our dwarf addiction, that you can contain your thirst with one or two. But we cannot. You cannot dwarf responsibly, minion. No dragon can. To dwarf, or not to dwarf, that is the only choice. So, when you are confronted by dwarves, do the courageous thing. Say no. Say no to dwarves.”

What kind of nonsense...

"In any case, we are almost to El Dorado, so get back up. Furibon will not commit suicide alone.”

And there was something sitting on his lap. Something warm. Victor managed to raise his head, to peek at it.

It was that damn cat.

Looking up at him with smug, triumphant eyes.

Chapter 88: El Dorado

The sun was high in the sky, yet darkness had taken over the earth.

Vainqueur could sense it all. The grim nightmares that awaited them behind the trees. The malevolence lurking at the heart of the jungle, the disgusting stench of paupers grasping for the gold of the well-to-do. The same, wordless evil that he had faced on the planet Moon, had returned to lay waste to Outremonde.

The curse of lead poisoning, and the evil lich that spread it.

“FURIBON!”

Vainqueur’s roar echoed through the dense jungle, chasing birds away. “Was that... necessary?” his chief of staff complained, wincing from the noise. “My ears...”

“I want him to *know*!” Vainqueur declared. “To know that *justice* is coming and that he will have to answer for his *baby coin genocide*.”

The mere thought of the wicked Furibon corrupting the golden perfection of El Dorado, as he did with the moon, filled the dragon with fury.

To rest until his chief of staff returned from his hangover-induced flight, Vainqueur and a minion expedition had set camp in the heart of the forest, near the golden city. Xolotl the priest had guided them through, protected from the sun by parasol-wielding minions of his own. Other kobolds fawned over Vainqueur, constantly reminding the dragon of his greatness, wealth, and genius in whispers. The dragon made a note to recruit an elite fawner force to serve him in Murmurin.

Otherwise, only three minions of Vainqueur had dared to follow him in the war against Furibon's cruelty: Sweet Chocolatine; Untasty Allison; and Tasty Malfy.

Manling Victor hadn't recovered from last night's overdwarfing and struggled to stay standing even when using his scythe. He had needed Sweet Chocolatine's help to put his boxers on, and couldn't use a Perk to save his life. The adorable werewolf had cast every healing spell she knew on him, to no avail.

For dwarf intolerance had no cure. Vainqueur knew that well.

Manling Victor's return to the camp was met with a variety of reactions. Allison reddened like a tomato and moved her hands on her mouth to suppress her laughter. Malfy looked at the Vizier with near-religious admiration. And Xolotl...

"Brother, you are back." The lizard priest moved to give the greatest of all minions a passionate hug. "I pray to the goddess that you achieved illumination on your spiritual journey."

"I... I don't remember much..." the half-dragon admitted. "I think... I've been bitten..."

"Brother Victor, you have bloodbonded with the entire city's priesthood. You are more than a guest. You are part of us, and we are part of you."

"They said... I was easy..." Victor muttered as the priest broke off the embrace, before noticing Allison. "Hey, it's... it's Al..."

With her hands still on her mouth, the dryad turned away from Victor, doing her best not to look at him. Such shyness. "Did I do... something wrong?" the Vizier blurted, before putting a hand on his mouth too.

"Yeah, I mean, you started dancing while throwing off your clothes in public," Chocolatine said. "She even tried to slap some sense into you. Don't you remember?"

“No... Oh, gods, I want to puke...”

“But then you removed your underwear and you started ranting about ‘universal cosmic love,’ and she couldn’t stop laughing, and me too... and we would have gotten to the *really* funny part if it wasn’t for that meddling angel!”

“What... what is that?” Friend Victor asked upon noticing a pile of items in the middle of the camp.

Vainqueur had been meaning to ask as well. Since Manling Victor’s dwarf-fueled rampage, imp messengers had kept piling up stuff for the dragon and his minion. Cakes, gems, letters, golden watches, refined pens, demon-leather notebooks... by now it had reached the size of a small hill, and more imps added to the pile.

“These are all the gifts from the Corporate Overlords, the letters of congratulation, the alliance proposals, the invitation to private orgies, the codified offers of bootlicking, and... and...” Thick black liquid poured from Malfy’s insectoid eyes. “Mr. Victor, I... you...”

“You’re... crying...” Manling Victor frowned. “Malfy, are you *crying*?”

“I am moved to tears,” the fiend cried. “I never thought this day would happen... but you did it. You *did it*. You and Your Majesty, you are more than business partners. You are *heroes*.”

“I know,” Vainqueur said, always proud of himself. “I know, minion. But thank you for reminding me.”

“Did what...” Manling Victor would have been happy for his master too if he wasn’t suffering from his dwarf hungover. “Can’t remember...”

“I want to be your trainee!” an imp immediately asked Manling Victor. “Take me!”

“See this, imp?” Malfy said, managing to wipe away his tears of joy. “This is not the face of a mortal. This the face of a *hero*. Not the one Happyland

expected... but the one it needed!”

“All minions of my minions are my minions,” Vainqueur declared. “I will gladly accept your fealty, imp.”

As the critter rejoiced, Manling Victor frowned. “I have the feeling I have done... something *terrible*...”

“You have done your duty, minion, and this is what matters,” Vainqueur said. “I am also pleased to learn you did *not* cheat on me with this cat, however refined a master he may be.”

“Cheat...” Manling Victor glared at Felix the cat, who had followed them back to the camp. “Why is he here? How is he here?”

“I am a cat, I can do anything,” the feline spoke in his native tongue, which was a close enough variant of dragonian for Vainqueur to understand him. Indeed, he had never known ‘meow’ was a variant of ‘minion’ until today.

“Because he is cute!” Chocolatine said. “Look at him. Look at his tiny eyes!”

“Felix claimed you as his *Doer of the Thing*, and I very carefully reminded him of your minion vows,” the dragon replied in his native tongue. “We talked it over a cup of milk, and I found him to be an extraordinarily refined and intellectual creature.”

“Your dragon master is the most exquisite being I have met who is not a cat,” Felix flattered Vainqueur. “He is such a paragon of kingship, with such novel ideas about minion management... what enlightening discussions we had.”

“Truly, I am marvelous, and I wish more creatures shared my understanding of true nobility and quality breeding.”

“These are the hallmarks of true superiority over the common rabble,” the cat agreed. “The splendor of nobility.”

“If only the plebeians could reach our level of culture, we would have worldwide peace,” Vainqueur said. “Alas, we can only take solace in ourselves, our native species, and our well-trained chiefs of staff. Such is the burden of a square root sixty-four intelligence.”

“I dream about the day when minions will finally understand how to fulfill my every need,” Felix nodded in complete agreement. “And when I find a lap as comfortable as your chief of staff’s.”

“Remember my words,” Vainqueur told the feline. “Only once, I allowed you to experience this rapturous contact with my most prized possession. To give you a taste of the essence of *ultimate minionship*.”

“What about my lap?” Sweet Chocolatine proposed. “I will cuddle you on the belly and scratch your ears!”

“No,” Manling Victor said, jealous. “No...”

“Yes!” Felix jumped at the werewolf. “Mine, mine, mine!”

“Oh, I will give you milk, and food, until you are so full of fat around the bones, you can no longer walk!” Sweet Chocolatine rejoiced, taking the cat in her arms and the feline purring in response. Malfy eagerly took her place in helping Manling Victor stand up, barely repressing a joyful sob.

“But enough self-congratulations.” Vainqueur cleared his throat, using his [Golden Road] to teleport the pile of gifts to his hoard. “We must reach the golden city before Furibon turns it all to lead.”

“Maybe he isn’t... isn’t there to turn the city to lead...” Manling Victor blurted out

“Why else would he be there, minion?” Vainqueur asked a simple question. “After what he did to the Moon, how can you *doubt*?”

“This is... a conspiracy theory...”

“Yes, exactly, a worldwide conspiracy against gold itself, and we have to stop it. For the baby coins.” The dragon turned to priest Xolotl. “Lead the

way, foreign minion.”

And so, after a two hours trip through trees and foliage, Vainqueur and his minions finally came into view of El Dorado.

Never before Vainqueur had witnessed such a beautiful spectacle.

Great walls protected a magnificent city the size of Murmurin, one created in the same style as the Thaoten's; the ramparts themselves surrounded by a river of molten gold. Tall pyramids stood side by side with house-covered hills and ancient temples, while four colossal, armored statues of ancient lizard warriors stood watch over all cardinal points of the city.

Everything, everywhere, from the tree to the ramparts to the pyramids, was made of solid *gold*. A shade so *pure*, it reflected sunlight in all directions, turning the city into a shining jewel whose sight would burn the eyes of the unworthy.

Dragon heaven existed, and Vainqueur had found it!

“Amazing,” Allison gasped, all minions present speechless at the sight.

“This is as far as I can lead you,” Xolotl said. “I must return to Kukulcan and offer gifts to the goddess. You must fulfill your holy mission on your own, oh great scaled one.”

“You have done well, small minion of the gods,” Vainqueur said graciously, amazed by his level of lackey technology development. On his return to Murmurin, he would have his own servants import that doormat mantle in bulk.

“I will return and discuss with your dwarven emissaries on how to keep a portal between our lands open, so our civilizations may bathe in one another’s blood,” the priest declared, before bowing politely before Manling Victor. “I will await your return, so that we may partake in the potion of power together—”

“No...” the Vizier weakly panicked. “No more mushrooms!”

“As you wish,” the reptile said with obvious regret, before excusing himself and returning to his jungle alongside his own minions. Vainqueur instantly regretted the loss of the fawners, but now was not the time for fawning.

Now was the time for *action*.

For as he smelled the lich’s terrible presence in these walls, Vainqueur looked for any sign of his wicked nemesis’ presence. And he didn’t have to look for long.

In this perfect picture of heaven, the dragon noticed an anomaly. The pyramid farthest from their own position. The metal that coated it differed from the others, an alloy dark and foreboding.

A pyramid of *lead*.

“No!” Vainqueur panicked. “We are too late! Furibon is already at his vile work!”

“Can’t be...” Manling Victor’s eyes widened, upon realizing that his master was indeed right all along. “He is... he is really transforming the city into lead?”

“I was right! I was right about everything!” Vainqueur immediately extended his wings. “Minions, with me! We must stop Furibon! Form the battle line!”

With Malfy carrying Manling Victor in his arms, the dragon opened the charge, crushing any tree or foliage between him and the golden city’s gates. His minions followed, but Vainqueur paid them no mind.

For in that moment, only the thought of saving heaven from lead poisoning ruled the dragon’s mind.

You have fallen under the [**Curse of Greed**]’s influence.

Curse of greed? Pfft, as if greed was a curse, instead of the universal truth to which all bowed to.

...

And soon, all this gold would be *his*.

Chapter 89: The Life we Lead

Beautiful.

Simply *beautiful*.

Vainqueur had never seen such an exquisite city. *Everything*, from the pavement to the walls, was made of gold. The builders had even painstakingly recreated an entire park, replacing the flowers, trees, and grass with superior golden duplicates.

“Look at these,” Allison said, pointing at gold statues standing all over the streets. While most represented lizardkin and other reptiles, they also included a great variety of species, such as manlings, elves, beastkin, and orcs; each statue having a wildly different clothing style, although all shared a look of unbridled desire on their faces. Truly the ancient civilization that built this place was a model of minion inclusiveness.

They even had a gold statue of the great wyrm Grandrake, greedily rubbing his belly with a maddened look on his face, in the central plaza. What a refined, dragon-friendly city! Vainqueur could spend an eternity there.

He would. “Minion!”

“Yes, Your Majesty?” His Doer of the Thing answered.

“After the goldslayer is vanquished, we will move the capital of my great empire, and my hoard, to El Dorado,” Vainqueur decided. “I finally found a place worthy of me.”

“There is something wrong here,” Untasty Allison said, growing more and more agitated. The lich’s nearby presence must have put her on edge. “I do not sense any plants inside the city’s walls.”

“When everything is made of gold, there is no need for green,” Vainqueur replied with pride, but it didn’t improve the dryad’s mood. But not even her whining nor Malfy crying out of joy every time he looked at Manling Victor could spoil the dragon’s mood.

“It is so clean,” Felix the cat commented. “But where are the minions cleaning it up?”

Indeed, El Dorado was incredibly silent. Vainqueur couldn’t hear any bird or local minion for the life of him, and he had excellent ears.

Not that he cared. Indeed, the more time the dragon spent walking on these roads of golden bricks, sensing the metal’s warmth on his scales, the more he felt at home. Vainqueur was not entirely fond of the Thaoten-like architectural style of the buildings, but he would get used to it.

With this city added to his hoard, he would win his bet with Icefang easily!

A look at a lead pyramid returned him to reality, and reminded him of the threat the city faced. “Sweet Chocolatine,” Vainqueur said. “Do the thing.”

“Do the thing? With whom?”

“The smelling thing.”

“Oh, right.” The werewolf sniffed the air, her excellent sense of smell put to the dragon’s use. She quickly caught a scent and guided them through a wide street, eventually leading the group towards a plaza, right at the steps of a flat-top pyramid.

And there...

They found him.

That fleshless, floating incarnation of pure evil. A monstrous abomination of golden bones and jeweled teeth, whose very appearance mocked a hoard's beauty. Silver-stained robes covered most of its unnatural body, which flew through the sacrifice of orphaned baby gems. Like a serial

killer, he had poisoned five gold statues of manling warriors with the curse of lead, and prepared to murder a sixth with his bare hands.

“Furibon!” Vainqueur shouted.

“Vainqueur?” The lich recoiled in fear of dragon justice, cowardly using the surviving statue as a *hoard shield*. “VAINQUEUR!”

“FURIBON!” Vainqueur shouted louder. “I have crossed the ocean, conquered countries, defeated giants, so I could finally track you down!”

“... and you had *nothing* better to do?” the lich asked with contempt.

“What could be more important than destroying you, despoiler of the gold?! After you turned the moon to lead?!”

The lich remained silent for a long moment, as he absorbed the words. “That may be the stupidest thing I have ever heard you wyvern say,” Furibon rasped.

And like that, the lich added *reptilian racism* to his long list of negative qualities. “So you deny transforming the planet moon into a lead hellhole?”

“Happyhole, Your Majesty,” Malfy corrected. “The politically correct term is *happyhole*.”

“Oh, I see where this is going,” the lich let out a sound sounding like sarcasm, which made sense when faced with suicide by wyrm. “I turn a dragon’s hoard to lead once, *once*, and it is *all* people remember me for. Wonderful.”

“You turned a dragon’s hoard to lead?” Felix asked, hanging from Sweet Chocolatine’s arms. “That was stupid, even for a pile of dog food.”

“... it seemed like a good idea at the time,” Furibon said, reveling in his *odious* historical negationism. “Why am I defending my choices to a cat? Truly I have hit rock bottom today. I feel my intelligence score decreasing just by talking to you.”

“Hey, Furi!” Having partly recovered from his dwarf addiction, Manling Victor waved a free hand at the enemy. Vainqueur wanted to scold him, but instead focused entirely on the lich; he needed to save the gold statue hostage, no matter what.

The lich pointedly ignored the chief of staff, before noticing something out of the ordinary. “Dalton, why are you only wearing boxers and a scythe? No, on second thought, I do not want to know.”

“Get away from the gold statue, you monster!” Vainqueur ordered. “She is innocent!”

The lich let out a deep bellowing sound, which Vainqueur took for a sigh. “I was genuine when I said I *never* wanted to see you lizard again, and every word you say only reminds me of *why*. Can we not coexist by ignoring one another?”

“So long as you threaten all that is golden in the world, I shall never rest!” the dragon emperor roared, the ground shaking from the strength of his belief. “I saw the lead pyramid, Furibon! Once your [Transmute Gold to Lead] was a weapon against dragonkind, but now it has become a twisted, perverse addiction!”

“This is different! I am trying to save *everyone* from this self-replicating gold! If I do not transform El Dorado to lead, the New World is doomed!”

All of Vainqueur’s fears came at the forefront of his mind, as he realized just how deep the lich was willing to sink into depravity. Worse, his minion seemed corrupted by his foul, twisted words. “What do you mean?” Manling Victor asked, his mind overtaken by the villain’s insanity.

His heart torn at the thought, the dragon decided to sacrifice the gold statue hostage for the sake of the greater wealth. With a fearsome roar, Vainqueur opened his mouth and unleashed a mighty fireball at his nemesis before he could drive Manling Victor insane.

“[Za Warudo]!”

Time seemed to freeze for a brief instant, and a split second later, Vainqueur's fireball only melted gold. The lich had teleported out of the path, coating his body in a stone-like substance and magical protections.

[Curse of Greed] activated.

You can now turn matter to gold on touch.

Oh?

Awesome! "Fall to the poke!" Vainqueur unleashed his ultimate attack, rushing at his foe with a lone finger raised; empowered by greed and fury, the dragon moved faster than lightning.

"You... you reptilian fool!" the lich snapped. "The more you spread it, the stronger the curse gr—"

The dragon poked his foe in the skull without a word.

At once, the blessed power of greed activated, instantly turning the entire lich into the purest shade of gold. The floating undead crashed on the ground, sealed once more.

"How did Your Majesty do this?" Malfy asked, amazed by his master's goldliness. "Did you gain a new level?"

"That was... easy..." Friend Victor said. "Too easy."

"This is divine punishment from the gold itself!" Vainqueur replied, refusing to let his minion's sour mood spoil his victory. All his new levels had paid off! "I saved El Dorado! And now it is *mine*!"

"I still think we should look around for a trick," Manling Victor said.

Vainqueur grumbled. "Fine, fine," the dragon said absentmindedly, too eager to test his new power to look for imaginary enemies. "As you wish, minion. I will repair the damage Furibon did to my city with my golden poke in the meantime."

“Oh, can we come with you?” Chocolatine asked. “This place looks amazing!”

“Certainly, my minion,” Vainqueur said, glancing at her and the cat in her arms with interest. “Certainly.”

Empathy negated by [**Curse of Greed**].

He wondered how much they weighed in gold...

This place gave Victor the creeps.

He couldn't put his finger on why, but that whole city gave him chills on his back. And no way could Furibon be taken down so easily.

Climbing the stairs of the pyramid and examining the temple at the top had only exacerbated his intuition. The hall he, Allison, and Malfy currently occupied should have looked magnificent, with its shining column and its central altar illuminated by a hole in the roof above.

But outside the main effigy representing a startlingly beautiful woman at the center of the room, the many statues around him felt wrong; from the greedy looks on their faces to the scenes of fighting they represented.

“Mr. Victor, this temple is [Cursed],” Malfy said, his usual cheeriness replaced with unease. “I can tell.”

“Vic, I...” Unfortunately, the second she laid her eyes on him, Allison put her hand on her face as she struggled not to laugh.

Victor tightened his hold on his scythe, embarrassed. What the happyland did he do while drugged? Miel no longer answered his telepathic calls, which meant she had probably left the plane, and whenever he asked for an explanation, Malfy started crying.

“Sorry.” His friend managed to somewhat regain her composure, although she clearly struggled to. “Vic, there is indeed something very wrong with this place. This is a temple of *Cybele*, but my goddess does not respond when I try to contact her for advice.”

“How is that even possible?”

“I assume another deity has a stronger influence over El Dorado and blocks out the others.”

Yeah, that wasn't suspicious at all.

As for that gold transformation, when did Vainqueur gain a new level? True, Victor hadn't checked all of his favorite dragon's abilities recently, and he had a way of pulling powers out of nowhere... but why did he have the feeling it was connected to the strange statues outside?

Intelligence check successful!

“Allison, Malfy, we have a big problem,” he said, the two looking up at him with shared unease. “I do not think the statues outside are actually statues. I think they're *people*.”

“And you would be right,” said a rasping voice.

Victor turned around almost lazily, the lich floating from behind a golden pillar. “Dalton,” Furibon said, very much ‘unalive.’

“Furi? That was a decoy outside?”

“Yes,” the lich replied, annoyed by the nickname. “I learned my lesson. Fighting dragons is stupid, and *yours* even moreso.”

Aha, he was right! “So... how is your [Stockholm Syndrome]? Hanging on?”

“I cured it, but thank you for asking. How is your [Lima Syndrome]?”

“Still coping with it.”

“I have a cure if you need one.”

“Vic, didn't he capture you?” Allison asked, astonished by the surreal scene. “Why are you treating him like a friend?”

“Eh, we decided to let bygones be bygones a while ago,” Victor shrugged. “I would have rather talked to you before Vainqueur, but...”

“We do not have much time,” Furibon cut through the pleasantries. “I need your... your...”

Since the lich clearly struggled with that word, Victor cleared his throat. “Our help?”

“Yes, your *help*. We do not have much time. Knightsbane fell under the curse’s influence, like the members of my expedition. You only have to look outside to see the results.”

“Expedition?” Allison frowned.

“He is a registered adventurer now,” Victor shrugged. “I kept tabs on him.”

“I assume Vainqueur doesn’t know about that.”

“I stand by what I said, I have no intention of ever setting a foot in Ishfania again,” Furibon declared. “If you leave me be, so will I. But in his current state, your dragon will not listen. He can already turn what he touches to gold, and the worst is yet to come. After a time, his greed will get the better of his sanity.”

An ugly picture formed in Victor’s mind. “They turned each other to gold,” he realized, horrified.

“When the cursed ran out of flesh to turn to gold, they started touching themselves,” Furibon said, before stopping. “Not the best phrasing, but you understand my point.”

“What about Choc?” Allison frowned, suddenly worried. “Why haven’t we been affected?”

“If they are not Claimed, undead, or fiends, they are already doomed. Undead and fiends are naturally resistant to curses like this, and the Claimed in my group were shielded from its influence. It makes me believe it has a divine origin. And the more the curse spreads, the stronger it gets.”

If Vainqueur fell under its sway, it would become unstoppable. “How do we stop it?” Victor asked, remembering what Xolotl told them. “Our guide told us an ancient evil slumbered in the city. Maybe it is the cause?”

The lich shrugged. “I have pinpointed its source to a sealed temple in the city’s center, but I cannot break the magical barrier around it. I settled on turning all the gold I could find to lead to weaken the curse, but with Knightsbane under its influence...”

“I can get in with [Skeleton Key],” Victor said. “If we can slip past—”

“Miiiiinnnniiiiiooonnnnsss...” Vainqueur called from outside the temple; his voice should have been endearing, but just came across as sinister. “Where are yooooouuu?”

... oh gods.

It was a horror movie, and Vainqueur was the slasher villain.

Chapter 90: The Shiny-ing

Greedy fools, all of them!

Vainqueur could smell their treachery. They *all* lusted for his hard-worn gold. “Minions, get out!” the dragon called from outside the pyramid, crushing the statue of the vile Furibon underfoot. “Minions! Minions!”

He had activated the Blinkblink ring, turning invisible to catch them in the act of stealing. For the dragon knew, deep in his heart, that they were busy pilfering his treasure.

Why, they even dared not to acknowledge their emperor’s order!

“Minion!” Vainqueur summoned his friend to his side when no one answered. Manling Victor appeared next to the dragon, a strange, worried look on his face. “Here you are!”

“Y-your Majesty.” The dragon sensed hesitation in his voice, as he looked for his master. “W-where are you?”

“Shush, minion,” Vainqueur said, his lackey looking at his general direction. “I’m using my Blinkblink ring to surprise them.”

“Them?”

“The traitors! Tasty Malfy, Untasty Allison, they are traitors and thieves! I can feel it in my bones!” The very thought infuriated him. “But you... not you, my chief of staff. You are the only one I can trust. Because you worship me more than anything. You still love me, right?”

“Y-yes, of course!” Manling Victor reassured his master. “I owe you my life!”

“Yes, you do. That is why I can trust you. Because you are my friend. Not like the others, those ingrates. Now, where are they?”

“I, I do not know!” Manling Victor said. “We separated earlier to look for Furibon!”

“A mere excuse to hide their duplicity!” Vainqueur illuminated his minion’s mind, dispelling his idealistic delusions. “They must be stealing as much gold as they can before they escape! We must find them!”

“I—I heard them talking about another temple in the city!” Friend Victor said, remembering an important piece of evidence. “I can lead you—”

“LEAD?” Vainqueur’s roar made his friend stumble. “Where?!”

“It’s, it’s the verb, Your Majesty, the verb!”

Vainqueur calmed himself, but only barely so. “Minion, do not play tricks on me. My patience is at an end.”

“Certainly, Your Majesty...” Manling Victor cleared his throat. “I can guide you to the temple and then we will interrogate them.”

“I will have them kiss my finger,” Vainqueur said. “If they love me as you do, they will. Not like the others.”

“About that...” Manling Victor trailed, as if afraid of the answer. “Where is Chocoline?”

The dragon briefly hesitated about sparing his friend’s feelings but decided he should better be warned of what they were up against. “I had to do it, minion. She was fifty.”

“Fifty what? Years? Werewolves live that long?”

“Fifty kilos,” Vainqueur explained.

Manling Victor opened his mouth, before noticing her near the plaza.

The gold statue of Chocolatine, still holding the treacherous Felix in her arms, and that greedy look still on her face.

“I had to do it, minion,” Vainqueur told his friend, who looked at the statue in horror—horror at her treachery. “They lusted for my gold with their greedy eyes, then tried to turn me into treasure... after I gave them a minion job! Do you know the unemployment rate among your kind, Manling Victor? You do not, and you do not want to know. While *I* achieved full employment!”

“I...” Friend Victor was speechless at the revelation.

“She was full of lust for my gold!” Vainqueur ranted. “She would have turned you to gold too, but I saw it coming! I saw them both coming, her and that money-grubbing cat! How you may ask?”

Manling Victor said nothing, listening to his master’s wisdom.

“I have a sixth sense to detect a minion’s inner shininess: the *Shiny-ing!*” Vainqueur ranted to his servant. “I can tell how much they will weigh in gold! I can! Because I am wealthy in gold, but poor in minions! Do you know how much a kobold is worth?”

Intelligence check successful!

“The average kobold weighs twenty kilos, and we have more than five thousand of them! Which translates into a hundred tons of gold, if we do not fatten them first! Imagine the size of my hoard afterward, minion!”

“I... I can’t...”

“Because you lack imagination,” Vainqueur replied. “But we will start with the traitors first. Allison weights forty-five kilos, and Malfy more than one hundred-twenty kilos.”

His chief of staff answered with a quick nod and immediately flew towards the new temple. Vainqueur followed on foot, invisible and subtle. Now that

he thought of it, Icefang probably weighed tons in gold; after rubbing his superior wealth to his face, he could add his rival to it.

“Even Jolie is full of greed, minion,” Vainqueur said. His shiny-ing sense told him she lusted for his hoard; all the time she behaved like a lovable niece, he now realized that she only wanted the inheritance.

“Your Majesty isn’t considering turning his own niece to gold?” Manling Victor asked with a strange tone.

“I...” Vainqueur marked a short pause, as his head began to hurt. His shiny-ing told him how much his niece weighed, which made him happy, but a part of him screamed, *‘Vainqueur, no!’*

Charisma check successful! You temporarily regained your empathy!

“Of course not,” Vainqueur said, horrified that the thought even crossed his mind. “She is worth more than gold to me, no matter how much I spoiled her.”

Manling Victor let out a sigh of relief.

“But I am cutting her out of my will, and you too, for the sake of fairness. I will keep everything for myself.”

He would simply turn himself to gold after doing the same with his empire, becoming part of this grandiose hoard of El Dorado. He would stay the richest dragon forever until the sun died out in the sky!

Vainqueur entertained these shiny thoughts for the entire trip, as his favored minion led them to a new golden pyramid, albeit one different from the others in architecture. The statues represented giant insects, and the stairs circled the pyramid towards the top like a coiled worm.

Vainqueur sniffed the air. “I do not smell the treacherous minions nearby...” The dragon glanced at his beloved lackey. “But I can smell the lich’s odious odor on you, minion. You should bathe, and very quickly.”

“Yes, of course,” Manling Victor said, as he landed on the stairs towards the flat top. Vainqueur tried to climb them up as well and...

BAM!

He hit his head against an invisible wall. The dragon hit it with his free hand, then blasted it with flames, to no avail. “Wow, I guess I will just catch the minions inside!” his chief of staff said with a strange tone. “I will get going—”

“Wait here, minion,” Vainqueur said, activating his trump card. “[Spell Purge].”

His ultimate Perk activated, weakening the barrier and stripping him of his invisibility.

His chief of staff recoiled in horror.

For it was true that Vainqueur had changed a little. Some of his scales had turned golden, empowering by his newfound [Curse of Greed]. He also carried a long, golden axe in his hand. His eyes must have shone with the glitter of gold.

As for the axe? He had found it laying around. The dragon had no idea why, but he had the compulsion to take it with him. Still, just like Ogron’s weapon the past year, it was a constant struggle for the dragon to wield it within his claws.

Still, he immediately smashed the barrier with it. “Here is Vainqueur!” the dragon snarled, the weapon shattering the invisible wall and collapsing it.

Nothing could stop the power of gold! He even felt his shiny-ing flare up, stronger than ever.

Empathy negated by [**Curse of Greed**].

The dragon’s shiny-ing activated, making him suspicious of his chief of staff’s strange behavior. He had been acting shifty for the past hour, and it bothered Vainqueur.

He sniffed his chief of staff and noticed the smell of Tasty Malfy and Untasty Allison on him. He would have shrugged it off as the consequence of close proximity, but the scent seemed a bit too strong.

Like he was *wearing* them. “Minion Victor, have you been hiding the traitors from me?”

“O-of course not!”

Having known his chief of staff for so long, Vainqueur didn’t need magic to identify the sentence as what it was.

A lie!

His chief of staff lied to him!

No, no, his friend would never do that. That was his imagination. But his shiny-ing told him there was only one way to be sure. “Minion,” Vainqueur presented him his royal free hand. “Kiss my claw.”

Gold-to-be Victor froze in place.

“Minion, I won’t hurt you! I only want to touch you!” Vainqueur insisted, wagging his hand at him. “If you truly love me, you will kiss my claw!”

Much to his consternation, his lackey hesitated, as if torn between his loyalty and treacherous compulsions. Vainqueur prepared to grab him by force...

“Okay.” His chief of staff straightened up. “I will kiss your hand, Your Majesty.”

“Yes, you will, because I am your master.”

“No,” Manling Victor replied, quickly adding before the infuriated dragon could chastize him. “I will kiss your hand because you are my friend, Vainqueur... and because I trust you.”

The dragon emperor frowned, his minion climbing down the stairs toward his beloved dragon until he was right in front of his scaled hand. Manling Victor took a long deep breath, closed his eyes, and prepared to kiss his master's finger.

He would be perfect as a statue, the most beautiful of Vainqueur's collec—

Charisma check successful! You temporarily regained your empathy!

No.

No!

“Wait!” Vainqueur hastily distanced his hand from his minion, although his body refused to budge. “Wait, minion!”

So did he.

Empathy negated by [**Curse of Greed**].

No, this was a ploy!

The minion pretended to obey, hoping his master would change his mind at the last second! Such a subtle trickery, only a dragon could uncover it.

“Kiss my...” Vainqueur's throat tightened. “Kiss my...”

No!

What was he doing? That was his friend, the one minion he had sacrificed his entire hoard to raise from the dead! The one destined to follow Vainqueur all the way to godhood! He was worth more to the dragon than any weight in gold!

Gold...

If he transformed everything he had to gold, he would never be able to keep every part of his treasure in sight. Thieves would pilfer his statues, and share them with paupers. And then... and then...

It would create inflation!

Intelligence check successful!

Too much gold in circulation would make him *poorer*!

It had to *stop*!

[Curse of Greed]—

Curse nothing! “Go away!” Vainqueur willed it, and the universe obeyed. “Vainqueur Knightsbane bows to *none*!”

Charisma check successful! **[Curse of Greed]** negated by **[Dragon Arrogance]**!

Instantly, Vainqueur’s scales regained their crimson luster, and the overwhelming pressure of the shiny-ing vanished from his mind.

Congratulations! For successfully breaking the **[Curse of Greed]**’s hold over yourself through the twin powers of dragon-minion friendship and economical theory, you have earned a level in **[Kaiser]**!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA, +1 LCK.

“Your Majesty did it!” Manling Victor congratulated his master. “I knew you could shrug that curse off!”

“Who else but a dragon, Friend Victor?” Vainqueur grumbled. He glanced at the axe in his hand, before casually tossing it away. “A dragon-chief of staff bond of trust is unbreakable.”

No sooner did he say it, that the consequence of his recent actions dawned on him. “I turned my minions into gold,” the dragon panicked. “I turned my sweet, lovable minions into cursed gold.”

“Yes, and if we want to change that, then we still have work to do.” Manling Victor put a hand in his boxer, before bringing something out.

“You can come out!”

Instantly, black specks inside the palm of his hand grew larger, eventually transforming into a bug fiend, a dryad, and...

“FURIBON!” Smoke came out of Vainqueur’s nostrils.

“I saved your servants from yourself, wyrm,” the undead replied haughtily.

“I wish there was another place where to hide,” Allison said, looking traumatized. “But Your Majesty took us by surprise.”

The dragon didn’t care, his eyes set on the undead in their midst. He should have known the lich would be linked to this disaster! “Minion, get out of my way, so I can burn the lich to cinders!”

“I hate you too, Knightsbane,” Furibon replied bluntly. “But we both have allies trapped by the city’s curse.”

“We need to cooperate,” Manling Victor said. “With Your Majesty’s destruction of the barrier, not only can we move all in, but whatever is trapped there *will* try getting out. I have no idea what kind of creature lays in wait inside, but the more numerous we are, the better.”

“Cooperate? With the goldslayer? The *enemy*?” Vainqueur almost snarled ‘never,’ before the picture of Sweet Chocolatine summoning fiends that he could poke flared in his mind; as well as Felix flattering him in a very exquisite way.

Eventually, his concern for his minions overcame his hatred for Furibon.

“Temporarily,” Vainqueur warned with a threatening tone. “*Very* temporarily.”

The lich let out a shrug, Manling Victor putting a hand on his shoulder. “Let’s go,” he said, the group turning towards the pyramid.

Ready to claim their rightful loot.

Chapter 91: The Superboss

The temple on top of the pyramid looked a lot larger from within than outside.

Victor could have fit two copies of his manor in these golden halls, although the building had clearly degraded over time. A pillar holding the roof had collapsed, wall mosaics had eroded into incomprehensible gibberish, and a thick layer of dust covered the ground. It appeared no one had stepped in this place for eons.

Yet, the sealed evil of El Dorado had made its lair there, waiting on the other side of the hall.

The beast lurking in this hall was a terror to look at. A monstrosity long, crimson worm with an armored exoskeleton covering its entire body, the entity had six clawed insect legs to support it and the tail of a scorpion. Six blue eyes circled its mouth, a lamprey-like abyss of golden teeth.

While already an unnatural mishmash of verminous animals, what terrified Victor the most was its size. It was even bigger than Vainqueur, reaching eighty feet in length from the tip of its tail to its mouth.

And yet, the group found it reading a book.

Victor blinked at the surreal sight of a giant abomination even bigger than Vainqueur lifting a book and flipping its pages through telekinesis, paying no attention to its visitors. The Vizier recognized the cover as “*The Denial of Death, by Ernest Becker;*” with a quick glance, he noticed a tower of volumes, folios, and treaties at the creature’s right, and a smaller pile of miscellaneous toys on the left. They looked a lot like...

“Wait, is that a Super Nintendo?” Allison recognized one of the items on the pile.

Her words echoed through the walls, making the creature peek from his book towards the disparate group crossing the temple’s threshold. “Yes?” the creature sounded like a horde of locusts painfully trying to imitate human words. “What do you want, mortals?”

“Are you the source of the Shiny-ing, wormling?” Vainqueur asked with haughtiness.

“Yes,” the creature replied, not bothered at all by the silly name. It looked a lot like paintings of...

...

Victor activated [Monster Insight], and started praying.

Sablar, God of Destruction

Deity (Insect/Divine)

There is absolutely nothing you can do to me. Go home.

I am the Worm who Eats the World, and I am too lazy to say more.

Holy sh—

“Sablar!” Victor had never seen Allison angry, but a demonic spirit seemed to have possessed the priestess of Cybele. Her face had twisted into a raging snarl, and she immediately channeled magic through her fingertips.

“[Blackthorn]!”

“Allison, this is a terrible idea—” Victor protested, but she already launched a volley of spiky thorns at the deity. Vainqueur instinctively imitated her by unleashing a mighty fireball, while only Malfy did nothing, knowing it was useless.

Even Furibon started casting a spell in panic, as the projectiles threatened to hit the giant worm. “[Za Waru—”

Sablar peeked from his book, as the group crossed the threshold. “Yes?”

Victor blinked and glanced at his surprised companions. The projectiles had vanished as if they never had been launched. While Furibon quickly understood the situation and Allison remained confused, Vainqueur immediately went on the offensive again.

“[Spell Purge]!” The dragon used his favorite defensive perk. “Ah! Now you can do nothing to—”

“[Spell—” Vainqueur paused, realizing time had rolled back right before he launched his spell. This time, he simply glared at the worm of the world. “How do you do this, wormling?”

“I erased time,” the god replied flatly.

“That makes no sense—” Victor protested.

Time rolled back again before he could finish his answer.

“You cannot roll back time anytime someone contradicts—”

He did.

“What were you saying?” the god asked, sounding vaguely smug.

“It totally makes sense when you think about it,” Victor grumbled.

“Yes, it does.” Sablar closed his book, the volume joining the top of the pile. “Why are you here, mortals? I have no desire for crude violence, especially during my holiday.”

“Your holiday?” Victor blinked at the surreal answer. Was he dreaming?

“This is my vacation resort,” the god said. “I cannot destroy the world seven days a week. I have been overworking these past centuries, so I am

taking it easy for the current millennium. While my rivals roam the planes to play games together, I prefer alone time in the ruins of Outremonde.”

“But...” Furibon struggled for words, completely at a loss. “What about the seal outside? How can anyone keep a deity sealed?”

“That weak barrier? I raised it to keep wandering explorers out of my room. I can come and go as I wish.”

Yeah, it seemed Xolotl's info might have been a little unreliable. “You read and play games at home all day long?” Victor frowned. “Are you a shut-in?”

“Social distancer,” the deity defended his lifestyle. “I am currently playing *Last Fantasy VI* since a Claimed of mine brought it from Earth.”

“Really?!” Victor had always wanted to play that game!

“Vic, this is Sablar, the god of destruction and despoiler of the environment!” Allison seethed, her hatred for the vile deity overwhelming her better judgment. “Don’t cozy up to him!”

“A Claimed of Cybele.” Sablar let out a heavy, condescending sigh. “I do not understand you people. We both love nature, so should we not get along?”

“A nature lover? You?” Victor had to admit it, the dryad showed complete fearlessness even in the face of her own deity’s nemesis. “You turn forests to sand, and people to gold!”

“I wish to return Outremonde to its *original* environment, a perfect sphere of earth and metal,” the worm responded much more calmly. “I do not comprehend what beauty you find in trees. They are ugly and full of noisy creatures. Can you not see the beauty in silent, motionless mountains? Of lifeless gems and gold?”

“There is nothing more beautiful than a shiny hoard,” Vainqueur said, defending his own way of life. “They would agree with us if they had any

taste.”

“Indeed, Vainqueur,” the god added. “Dragons and I share a belief in the superiority of minerals and metals over life itself.”

“You know us?” Victor could have sworn the worm’s words had shaken his dragon friend, albeit only a little.

“Of course he does,” Vainqueur replied, showing his chest. “Who would not?”

“The dragon raised a disgusting city where my followers left a beautiful desert landscape, and you, earthling, created a landmass where there was nothing but water. Yes, I know you both.”

“What are you calling disgusting, wormling?” the dragon’s mood soured instantly.

“Island?” the Vizier repeated, more confused than insulted. Sablar was... surprisingly laid-back for a god of destruction. Seeing the deity in the flesh shattered every myth Victor had created in his head about him.

“Did you not roll Dice yesterday?” the worm god asked. “You willed a new island into existence, west of this continent.”

Victor did his best to ignore the glances Malfy and Allison sent him. “I have no idea what you are talking about.”

“This is a waste of time,” Furibon said, at his wits’ end.

“The lich speaks true, no matter how unlikely that sounds,” Vainqueur raised his voice. “Free my minions immediately, fairyspawn.”

“Wait, that soulcrest thing, Wotan gaining levels...” Victor glared at the deity. “It was your doing?”

“No,” the deity replied, “Mag Mell may have created me for his wars against mortals, but I have no love for the fomors. I support those who walk the path of annihilation, and I will not release anyone. Children of the earth

your minions have become, and they will remain so until this world comes to an end.”

Malfy, who had remained silent until now, cleared his throat. “If I understand the divine laws—and since I attended Hell Law School I do—you should not be able to directly interfere with the life of those who do not worship you.”

“We deities have a ‘gentlemen’s agreement’ with loose rules,” the god corrected. “We can affect Outremonde and grant miracles within our purview. Dice rains destructive weather, Camilla unleashes undead plagues, and Shesha fulfills requests paid with money.”

“At an overpriced rate!” Vainqueur complained, still obsessed with getting a refund.

“Prices are a meaningless, abstract value,” Sablar added with a nihilistic tone. “The citizens of this city petitioned me, wishing to turn everything they touched to gold. I granted their request, and those foolish enough to let greed overcome their heart deserve their fate. That is all.”

“This is not satisfactory,” Vainqueur let out smoke from his nostrils.

“Your Majesty, this is a *god*,” Victor protested. “He could kill us all without blinking, and I do not even know why he hasn’t yet!”

“I have found that patience and stoicism are the keys to a peaceful, fulfilling life,” Sablar replied calmly. “Time consumes all eventually. You will all die in the end.”

Yeah, Victor suspected the deity was just being lazy. No wonder the world still existed.

“If you granted a wish, that means you must have crafted a contract with the citizens of El Dorado,” Malfy guessed, ever the cunning one. “I cannot imagine any mortal foolish enough asking a blessing from a higher power without building a strong legal case. If we could examine the wording...”

Great idea, if they could find a loophole in the curse, they might have a shot at freeing their allies without violence.

“They did make a very long wish.” Sablar’s eyes blinked, a floating long scroll appearing before the group. “I granted it to the letter.”

Malfy immediately seized the scroll and read it, Furibon peeking over his shoulder to find a line. “There,” the fiend found a weak spot. “Disputes over the wording of the wish or amendments to its nature shall be decided in contests of wits and skill.”

“It seems the citizens of the city were smart enough to leave a backdoor,” Furibon noted.

“There!” Allison pointed a finger at the destructive deity. “If we win, you will cancel the curse!”

“I am under no compulsion to agree, and I am starting to wonder if I should simply turn you all to sand,” Sablar replied, starting to get annoyed.

“I am blessed by the goddess Cybele,” Allison replied.

“And I by *five* deities,” Victor boasted, his dryad friend glancing at him in shock and jealousy, “Do you truly wish to piss off *half the pantheon* over such a trivial matter? Not that you are very popular already...”

The worm examined the group in silence, weighing his options. “You will not leave me alone until you have your way...” he trailed off, before reaching a conclusion. “I have neither the time nor the will for games with mortals. If you only seek only the freedom of a few, then I can offer you... a compromise.”

“Afraid you will lose, wormling?” Vainqueur taunted him. “You should be.”

“I was a mortal too once,” the deity replied, “Only fools underestimate others, no matter the rift between our respective strengths. So I make you a proposal: I will release your friends and the lich’s allies from my [Curse of Greed]. You will be allowed to leave El Dorado alive and free.”

“But the city, the curse, and its other victims will remain,” Victor saw the huge catch.

“And it will keep claiming more people,” Allison added, very much against it.

“My city of gold will stand, and keep expanding into this forest,” Sablar promised. “But you will be long dead when it is time to suffer the consequences.”

“Like global warming?” the Vizier joked, Allison glaring at him.

On paper... it wasn't a bad deal. For them. They avoided a very risky endeavor and pissing off a deity, and they left unscathed. No win, but no loss either.

The rest of the New World would be BLEEPED though. People would still come to the city even if forewarned, and El Dorado would keep claiming victims. The curse would infect more people, and they would probably spread it outside its confines.

“We can't accept that,” Allison said, and Victor mostly agreed. Abandoning hundreds of thousands of people to an eternity as gold statues was just plain *wrong*.

“I believe it is a fair deal,” Malfy countered. “His Majesty came here to find the lich, and we have. Once we free Lady Chocolatine, we have nothing else to gain from this risky venture.”

Much to Victor's surprise, Furibon too seemed hesitant. “You said you were saving the world from that curse,” the Vizier reminded him.

“Before I knew the god of destruction was behind it,” the lich replied, probably afraid. The creature in front of them was one of the entities capable of killing the undead permanently. “Confronting him is an all-or-nothing gambit, and even if we win, he will certainly bear a grudge.”

“I *refuse* your compromise.”

Victor looked up at Vainqueur in surprise, and so did Sablar. “Why?” the worm asked, voicing the Vizier’s own thoughts. He would have expected the dragon to at least consider the offer.

“I am the minion liberator,” Vainqueur replied haughtily. “You transform would-be minions into lifeless furniture, however shiny. Like *slaves*.”

“They are worth more as gold than as flesh,” the worm god replied with cold disdain.

“They are worth more if alive, and I have the proof right here,” Vainqueur glanced at Victor. “Your scheme is a cruel mockery of everything a dragon should stand for; making gold something shameful instead of praiseworthy. How could I look at a golden statue now, without wondering if it was not created by your foul sorcery?”

“If I strip the curse, the city will return to its original state,” Sablar attacked Vainqueur’s weak point. “Do you truly wish to see all this gold vanish forever?”

The dragon bristled but stood firm in his decision. “A true dragon has quality standards. Your wealth is what *lead* is to *true gold*.”

At this point, Victor thought he had never respected Vainqueur more.

Sablar observed Vainqueur for a moment, then turned to look at Furibon. Even though he hated the dragon, his sheer arrogant resolve convinced even the lich to stand firm.

With his ultimatum denied, the deity finally lost patience. “Fine,” he declared, “It is, as they say, your funeral. If you beat me in a fair contest, I will lift the curse and return this city to its original state. But if I win, and you will swear that my rival deities cannot complain about it...”

The deity moved until his head reached the golden hall’s ceiling.

“You *die*.”

...

“Is there nothing else you could want from us?” Victor asked innocently.

“You die *permanently*.”

He walked right into that one.

“I agree,” Vainqueur replied with pride. “Prepare yourself for defeat, wormling! I will defeat you at the only game worth gambling this city's fate over!”

The dragon let fire from his nostrils, preparing to make his grandiose announcement.

“Cards!”

Victor facepalmed.

“This shall be the ultimate test of my dragon skills,” Vainqueur declared confidently as if he had already played the game a thousand times before.

“Sound strategy will always prevail.” To Victor’s astonishment, Furibon seemed to support the decision. “Vainqueur! For this time alone, I shall fight by your side!”

“You will only drag me down with your poverty!” the dragon refused. “Never!”

“Are you two seriously considering to gamble our lives over a *card game*?” Allison panicked.

“There will be no cards,” Sablar buzzed threateningly. “My kind of social entertainment is of the... *rougher* sort. I thought more of an ancient tradition, practiced by both dragonkind and my own creators.”

“The minion battle.” Vainqueur glared back.

“Of a sort,” Sablar replied, “You and your four minions will fight my favored champion to the death.”

“I shall not be treated as that wyrm’s animal!” Furibon protested, but the deity ignored him.

Instantly, golden collars materialized around the mortals' necks, with an annoyingly tight hold. “If you leave the city’s confines until a winner decided, you will die,” Sablar declared, a summoning circle appearing before him. “Now come, my prophet. Let loose sweet destruction. Your god commands it.”

A familiar creature materialized, projecting an overwhelming, suffocating aura.

A malevolent mummy of black bones and scroll bandages, clad in dusty green robes resonating with sheer arcane power. The funerary mask covering his face only revealed two glowing lights in place of the eyes.

“My fellow Vizier.” Akhenapep, master of Mot the genie and destroyer of the southern continent, glanced at his one-time student Victor. “Long time no see.”

Chapter 92: Fallout

Vainqueur had a strange feeling at the sight of this bandaged corpseling.

The exact same pressure that came off from Wotan, if not *worse*. His minions seemed to recognize the newcomer: Manling Victor had turned paler than a corpse, and Untasty Allison was speechless.

“Oh, Great Sablar, is it apocalypse o’clock already?” the mummy minion asked his master. “Is it time to lay waste to the living?”

“Start with these five,” the worm said, before raising a barrier around his toy hoard and himself. “Kill them all. I do not care how.”

“Ah, nothing better than a massacre in the morning.” The strange undead turned to the group, glancing at Manling Victor in particular. “I see that you have gotten far in the world, cultist. Mayhaps you can entertain me before we start indulging in violence?”

The Vizier, who had remained a silent statue since the mummy’s appearance, recovered his words. “In hindsight,” he finally spoke up. “This may have been a mist—”

The mummy quickly raised his finger and zapped Manling Victor with a ray of green light in the middle of his sentence. The magic blast sent him flying through the threshold and out of the pyramid, the Vizier’s flesh burning where the spell hit.

“Vizier stratagem six,” the corpseling mused, his finger still shining. “*The law of no talking.*”

Vainqueur immediately lunged at the cowardly mummy, only for a screen to appear before his eyes.

Akhenapep's [**Spell Trap**] triggered.

Instant casting of the spells [**Timeleap**], [**Sablar's Repulsion**], [**Meteor Rain**].

Vainqueur barely had the time to watch the undead glitch out of existence, before an almighty invisible force propelled everything backward. The temple exploded, its walls shattered, and all people present but Sablar were repelled in all directions.

The dragon ended his brief, uncontrolled flight by smashing into a lead pyramid, crashing through the outer walls. The dragon grunted as he recovered his bearing, the top of Sablar's pyramid having been blown apart. While the deity calmly read a book from within his barrier, the dragon could see neither the enemy nor his minions.

He did notice the rain of stones in the sky though.

Dozens of meters-wide fiery stone fell from the heavens towards El Dorado and the surrounding jungle, ready to devastate it on impact.

His minions! His goldified minions!

Vainqueur immediately flew up and started blasting the falling stars with his breath, destroying them before they could hit the ground and devastate the city below. He couldn't vaporize all of them, some hitting gold pyramids and collapsing them, others devastating the jungle beyond the city walls. Mighty forest fires started everywhere.

The sound of magical explosions caught the dragon's attention, as he noticed the mummy engaged in an aerial, magical duel with the vile Furibon. While the lich flew by his own means, a dust tornado carried Akhenapep up from the ground. Furibon unleashed fiery stones of his own and ice spikes; the mummy casually blasted the projectiles with green rays, while coating himself in protective spells. Activating his Blinkblink ring, Vainqueur prepared to attack from behind.

“[Za Warudo]!” Furibon briefly blinked out of existence, only to reappear with his jaw broken, Akhenapep’s fist within an inch of his skull. The lich went flying down, near a meteorite crater.

The mummy then turned to Vainqueur, and the dragon realized that the creature could see him even while invisible. “[Accelerated Entropy].”

Instantly, Vainqueur’s rings crumbled to dust, his Blinkblink effect cancelled. The dragon let out a roar of rage at the undead’s cruelty while flying straight at him, claws extended.

“[Nuclear Winter].” Akhenapep unleashed a mighty storm of shining green ice at Vainqueur, damaging his scales and inflicting *excruciating* pain.

Warning: You are losing 100 HP per second of sustained fire! You have been **[Irradiated]**! Healing effects will be greatly weakened for you!

You have lost a quarter of your HP.

Vainqueur activated his [Spell Purge], his defense pushing away the biting cold. Even better, the negation of the spell activated the new benefit of his [Witchfinder General] class, burning off the mummy’s hands. The dragon opened his mouth, ready to blast him apart.

“[Greater Seal: Dragonfire], [Accelerated Minor Seal: Holy Fire].” The dusty undead quickly covered himself with protective spells, his scroll-skin turning to black steel and a complex symbol materializing on his chest. “[Adamanskin], [Accelerated Glyph of Sablar].”

The dragon immediately unleashed a stream of fire; but instead of consuming the mummy, his witch-burning flames swirled around him like harmless flickers, absorbed into the chest tattoo. Vainqueur wisely chose not to activate his [Fire Crown]. Instead, he used [Shining Majesty] to radiate light with his scales while getting closer.

His golden beauty was too much for the mummy, who hissed in pain and retreated before the dragon could grab him. “[Alacrity], [Accelerated Hasten].”

Akhenapep's spellcasting time is drastically reduced for all Tier III spells and below for thirty minutes.

Tier III? What purpose did it serve—

“[Piercing Magic Arrow].” Akhenapep fired a volley of five golden arrows at Vainqueur, and they *hurt*. The mummy unleashed a second, then a third group before the dragon realized that these spells somehow bypassed his [Spell Purge].

Furibon, who had recovered enough to fly back into the fray, shouted a warning at his 'ally.' "[Pierce Magic Arrow] ignores all magical protections, wyvern!"

“[Piercing Magic Arrow], [Piermagarrow], [Pimarrow], [PMA]!” The more Akhenapep cast, the shorter the name of his spell, until they became incomprehensible noise. The constant magical artillery barrage only increased in violence, the rain of golden arrows itching his body and piercing his hide.

Warning! You have lost half your HP!

As his HP dwindled faster than Manling Victor's pants during breeding, Vainqueur had no choice but retreat, only for Akhenapep to direct his magical artillery at his left wing, shredding its skin. The dragon lost control of his flight and crash landed into a goldified street.

He couldn't fly anymore.

He couldn't *fly*!

All dragons could fly! This was heresy!

Akhenapep attempted to nail Vainqueur on the ground, but lightning bolts from Furibon forced him to focus his rain of arrows on the lich. Furibon teleported away each time the artillery barrage threatened to hurt him, causing the mummy to adopt a new strategy.

“Come to your Ur-Pharaoh, armies of Sablar!” Akhenapep raised his hands from the top of his dust tornado, while his meteor rain subsided. “[Ur-Pharaoh Defenders], [Accelerated Uranium Elementals Summon].”

In a flash of light, animated masses of green, shiny rocks appeared around the mummy, instantly rushing at the grounded Vainqueur. At the same time, two giant gates of stone rose around the left and right sides of Akhenapep, opening to reveal a dark, underground tomb on the other side. Giant, armored undead knights and rusted copies of Rolo the Golem walked through in regimented battalions, trampling the golden street under their footsteps.

“This is cheating!” Vainqueur protested, blasting the green rocks with his searing flames before they could approach. “Minions cannot summon more minions in a minion battle!”

Dodging a spell from Furibon, the mummy spat on the ancient tradition and vanished inside his dust storm with a final curse. “[Radioactive Sandstorm].” The dust tornado turned greenish and radiant, before slowly expanding across the city, forcing his lich foe to fly back.

The undead’s minions noticed Vainqueur and charged at him. The dragon rose on his back legs and activating [Victory Fist] as they closed the gap between them, punching an undead knight through the chest and then another. The smaller golems, though, jumped at him, hanging from his shoulders, wings, and neck. Vainqueur snarled as he took a few steps back, the minions threatening to overwhelm him.

Blasts of black fire and jagged beams shot off most of the golems, while hordes of insects started eating the undead alive, disrupting their battalions.

On the right side of the devastated street, Tasty Malfy and Untasty Allison appeared, the first summoning demonic locust clouds, the other vines to entangle the mummy’s summons. The wicked Furibon flew above them, containing the expanding sandstorm with a purple barrier.

On the left, Friend Victor led the group of demons he had called against Wotan, having himself transformed into his overgrown goat form. They

immediately engaged the undead knights, turning the entire area into a warzone. Dozens of gold statues shattered or broke from the fighting, the dragon thankful they had brought the battle away from Sweet Chocolatine and Felix's trapped forms.

“Take a message to... don't care about extra cost... transport them...”

Vainqueur barely heard Demonling Victor's conversation with his troops, their words drowned by the noise of spells and weapons clashing. A succubus opened a portal to Happyland and fled through, while Demonling Victor raised his scythe to cast a spell, **“[Control Weather: Sunny Day].”**

Demonling Victor immediately negated the mummy's unnatural sandstorm, causing it to collapse before its diseased winds could reach Vainqueur. The skies cleared, the sun shining brightly on the disoriented Akhenapep and the warzone around him.

“[Permascan].” The wicked Furibon cursed the mummy with his magic by surprise, a floating screen appearing above his head.

Akhenapep, the Ur-Pharaoh

Type: Black Pharaoh (Undead/Eldritch)

Level: 85 (Ur-Pharaoh 20/Sablaris 20/Chronomancer 30/Dark Lord 10/Sealmaster 5)

HP: 2214/2550.

Weaknesses: Spirit, Life, Holy.

“Level 85?” Untasty Allison panicked, while the gates remained open, more reinforcements coming.

“A capped [Chronomancer] *and* [Sablaris]?” Even Furibon was afraid!

But Vainqueur? Against an enemy with less than three thousand HP? The dragon wasn't impressed, having more than twice that amount. His [Witchfinder General] instinct told him that like any non-dragon wizard,

that mummy could hit hard, but couldn't take much damage in return. "[Geomancy]!" he snarled, after shaking off the last of the golems.

Field Type: Ancient Ruins.

Effect: [**Earthquake**].

While Tasty Malfy was accidentally knocked back and Untasty Allison endured, both Furibon and Friend Victor simply flew as the first tremors started. The very ground around Vainqueur shook, houses collapsing and enemy minions being thrown off their feet. The road of false gold broke, rifts appearing everywhere. One of the mummy's gates crumbled, but the other endured the attack, allowing more monsters to go through.

"[Za Warudo], [Accelerated Scrying Shield]," Akhenapep vanished once more, replaced by flying stone spears, piercing golden arrows, and a monstrosly huge, winged, many-eyed squid. The wicked Furibon repelled the projectiles with his own spells, while the newly summoned creature raised its tentacles threateningly at Victor.

"Ah'mglw'nafh shuggoth!" it hissed in the ancient, lead-laden language of the Moon.

Charisma check successful! [**Madness**] negated!

"**Y' ymg' mgepuln gnaiih!**" Demonling Victor answered in the monster's language. The squid stopped, exchanged a few words with the Vizier, then let out a sound which the dragon took for a laugh.

Then it turned on the mummy's armies, smashing golems with its tentacles on its way to the last gate.

"Vic, what did you do?" Untasty Allison asked, breaking rank with Malfy and Furibon to cast healing spells on Vainqueur. "[Full Heal]."

You recovered 10 percent of your HP. [**Master's Shield**] granted you the [**Regen**] status!

“Oh? I told her that I knew her dad, and we exchanged pleasantries,” Demonling Victor said as he cut off a golem in half with his scythe, while Allison used the same spell again and again on her master. **“She made a very inappropriate black cat joke though.”**

Akhenapep suddenly teleported into their midst, taking the trio by surprise. He hit the ground with his talon, causing spears of stone to rise from the pavement below the group. Demonling Victor immediately raised his [Spirit Shield], stopping the deadly spell, while Allison quickly cast a spell. "[Cybele's Tree of Life]!"

A tree of pure, sacred green light erupted below Akhenapep, its holy energies making it squirm and shamble.

“[Mean Look],” Akhenapep retaliated, his funerary mask somehow glaring menacingly at them, with a particular focus on Untasty Allison.

[**Instadeath**] negated... for you.

V&V stood proud, but the dryad instantly collapsed, her eyes lifeless. Before Manling Victor could even shout her name, the mummy disintegrated her with a green ray. “You will raise her later, minion!” Vainqueur tried to inspire hope back in his minion’s heart. “For now, we prevail!”

Charisma check successful! Your minion’s stats increased by one stat each in desperation!

Both members of V&V lunged at the mummy, scythe and fist raised. Akhenapep glitched out of existence before Vainqueur’s hand could squish him, unleashing a disrupting wave of energy in all directions.

Most of your minion’s buffs have been removed!

[**Master’s Shield**] re-activated! You gained the [**Regen**] status.

“He leaps through time!” Furibon shouted from afar, while he and the demons tried to contain the constant reinforcements by reaching the last

gate. Malfy was busy shaping a bridge of ice over the enemy army to better circumvent them. “[Time] effects are useless against him, and he can move even inside my own [Za Warudo]!”

“Leap through time?” Demonling Victor quickly figured out the enemy’s technique, **“He teleports to the future, bypassing all attacks! That’s his strategy! He summons monsters, traps and area of effect spells before skipping town!”**

"Then he will reappear at the same spot where he last vanished." Vainqueur raised his hand, and as he had expected, the mummy popped back where he had vanished the first time. The dragon immediately poked him in the face.

The godly minion raised his arms in protection, and instead of being snapped in half by Vainqueur’s blow, simply stumbling back. His metal scroll-skin mostly resisted the attack, although the proximity with [Spell Purge] lifted some of the mummy’s protective spells, wounding him with fire. Furibon's screen above his head showed the damage.

HP: 1720/2550.

That was *all*? Vainqueur decided to simply eat the mummy alive, but it started retreating at indragon speed, retaliating with a quick volley of golden arrows. His minion immediately rushed to his side, his [Master’s Shield] activating to help Vainqueur recover from his wounds.

Unfortunately, the mummy immediately noticed.

“Feel the power of decay, dragon. [Fallout]!” Akhenapep cast another spell, his body turning greenish. His scroll-skin radiated a sickening light, making Vainqueur ill.

All creatures near Akhenapep will lose 2 **Max** HP per second, except [**Undead**], [**Eldritch**], [**Alien**], [**Insect**], [**Elemental**] and [**Artificial**] types.

If your current HP surpasses your new Max HP limit, you will develop a [**Radioactive Tumor**].

Demonling Victor unleashed a stream of black fire that, instead of being fully drawn into the mummy's seal protections, both overwhelmed the mummy's defenses and wounded him. Vainqueur rejoiced at the sight of that minion killer's pain, once again preparing to squash him.

Raging with frustration, Akhenapep raised his hands, unleashing the same repulsion effect he used at the fight's beginning. His pulse sent both members of V&V backward, throwing Vainqueur against a pile of golden bricks, and his Grand Vizier on another. The dragon quickly found himself buried beneath debris.

Vainqueur barely had the time to raise his head, to see his prized minion cornered. "[Victor's Skull Sentries]." Demonling Victor's summoned skulls swarmed Akhenapep and briefly distracted him, allowing their scythe-wielding master to get back on his feet.

"[Black Curse]!" Vainqueur's chief of staff shouted, but his magic failed to affect the mummy, forcing him to engage the mummy with his scythe. Empowered by his magic, Akhenapep dodged every attack.

"You force me to desperate measures!" Demonling Victor raised his free hand...

And ripped his boxers away!

[Exhibitionist] activated! Demonling Victor's evasion increased!

The mummy trembled before the minion's sheer manliness, as he was forced into close combat.

Demonling Victor had the advantage in close combat, swinging his scythe and briefly forcing his foe on the defensive while avoiding any spell. Yet Akhenapep stopped time again, and when it resumed, all of the flying skulls exploded mid-flight while shadowy chains restrained their summoner. Demonling Victor found himself trapped on one spot, while Akhenapep charged a powerful attack.

The dragon struggled to escape the rubble and rescue his minion, but his wounded wing worked against him. When he managed to throw off the last of them, he was too late.

“[Atomic Ray]!”

The mummy unleashed a devastating blast of energy at Demonling Victor’s waist, snapping his body in half.

Vainqueur’s eyes saw red, as both halves of his minion fused back into the shape of an unconscious manling Victor. Was he... was he dead?

“Stratagem thirteen,” Akhenapep mused, “*the rule of corpse disposal*. [Piercing Magic Arrows], [Accelerated Disintegrate]!” A volley of golden arrows transpierced Manling Victor’s corpse before a green ray of light disintegrated his flesh. Within the blink of an eye, only his minion's scythe remained behind.

No...

Not again!

[**Berserk**]! status applied!

It already cost him a fortune the first time!

Vainqueur’s vision turned red, unleashing a stream of flames to the heavens in fury. He clawed Akhenapep, this time the blow powerful enough to force him on the defensive. Meanwhile, Malfy, the wicked Furibon, and their allies struggled to close the gate, the number of monsters going through having turned unmanageable.

A Happyland portal opened once more, Manling Victor’s winged servant slithering through... only for the gate to widen further and further, and a familiar red dragon to step through, unnaturally being ridden by her minion.

“Uncle!” Jolie shouted, like a true dragon [Paladin]. “Golden justice is here!”

At this point, Vainqueur was too pissed to care.

Chapter 93: Golden Leaders

[**Master's Shield**] negated! You have lost your [**Regen**] status!

The reminder of his chief of staff's demise made Vainqueur more furious than ever. If he could still fly, he would have bathed the entire city in his holy flames from above, melting the false gold and the mummy with it.

Instead, he still blasted everything nearby with fireballs, while fruitlessly trying to smash the fireproof Akhenapep with his claws. In spite of his own immense agility and speed, the mummy's magic allowed him to dodge every attack.

Meanwhile, his beautiful niece had joined the fight, casting spells while Knight Kia rode her—the very sight only fueled Vainqueur's berserk rage further. “[Aura of Justice]!” Jolie shone like silver, bathing her uncle in holy light.

You gained +2 to all attack-based checks, and your unarmed attacks will inflict additional [**Holy**] damage!

Holy? That was the mummy's weakness! The knowledge only bolstered the dragon's determination to bring the undead down. Akhenapep attempted to retaliate with golden arrows, but Vainqueur's onslaught gave him little opening.

He barely noticed the infernal portal widening further, an immense, long-necked lizard passing through. With the Kobold Rangers on its back, the beast trampled golems underfoot on its way to the last gate; Malfy had reached it thanks to his ice bridge trick, trying to freeze the doors while Manling Victor's tentacled abomination kept undead soldiers away from

him. Meanwhile, the evil Furibon flew towards Vainqueur after noticing Victor's leftover scythe.

"Furibon!" Jolie showed her tiny fangs at the vile lich and fired a small, fiery projectile at him. "You will pay for your crimes against Uncle and hoardiness!"

"Jolie, no!" Kia called out from the niece's back, cutting down an undead knight with her shining sword.

"Not me, you inbred lizard!" the lich complained while dodging the attack and stealing Manling Victor's scythe. Vainqueur knew they may be an ally, but his niece's response made him proud.

"Uncle? Is that your niece over here, dragon?" Akhenapep noted, renewing the spell protections Vainqueur had disabled during their close encounters. "Because I cannot, in good conscience, let her dedicate the rest of her life to revenge after I kill you."

The words snapped Vainqueur out of his rage-fueled rampage, replacing his fury with fear. "Don't you dare!"

"That would violate Vizier Stratagem thirty-eight," Akhenapep interrupted his assault on Vainqueur to point a finger at his niece. "'*The law of family sets*'! [Atomic Ray]!"

Vainqueur's heart skipped a beat. "Jolie!" He rushed to his niece's rescue, as the mummy unleashed the same beam that killed his chief of staff. But the red dragon was too far... too far!

Instead, the vile Furibon flew at Jolie's side, touching her pristine scales with his dirty hand. "[Teleportation]!"

The lich, the dragon, and her rider vanished out of the beam's way, dodging death. They reappeared a few feet away, safe and sound. "You villain..." Jolie couldn't believe what happened. "You, a villain, saved me?"

“No, I saved *her*,” the lich replied, glancing at the rider. “You should be optimized to destroy him.”

Knight Kia climbed down from her master’s back. “Jolie, go help the others.”

“But, Kia—”

“Go help the rangers and the others close the gate,” Knight Kia repeated with calm, her blade shining with heavenly energies and her eyes with a greater fury. “That one is too strong for you.”

Akhenapep pointed one hand towards Vainqueur, and one towards Jolie’s group. Everyone had fallen into a tense stand-off.

“Jolie, go,” Vainqueur ordered, his eyes set on the minion slayer. This time, the niece obeyed, flying above the remaining enemy minions and burning them. Akhenapep’s funerary mask briefly shifted to his summoning gate, which Malfy had trapped in ice.

“[Sacred Sword of Mithras].” Knight Kia’s blade doubled in length, transforming into an iridescent solid rainbow. She took a few steps towards Akhenapep, and then outright rushed at him. “[Miracle of D’Arc], [Blade of Dispelling], [Accelerated Hasten]!”

“[Atomic—”

“[Accelerated Ancient Meteor]!” Furibon unleashed a mini-meteor at Akhenapep before he could attack Knight Kia. The mummy glitched out of time to dodge the blow, allowing Vainqueur and Kia to close in. Akhenapep dodged the dragon’s poke, but not the paladin’s blade.

And he screamed for it.

Much to Vainqueur’s consternation, unlike his fruitless attempts from before, Knight Kia’s blade actually hurt the mummy. Her sword cut through his reinforced leadskin like butter, sparkles glittering in its path.

Akhenapep’s HP screen also dwindled tremendously.

HP: 670/2550.

The mummy let out a roar of rage, unleashing the same repulsion attack he used before. An invisible force slammed Furibon against the pavement and forced Vainqueur a few feet backward. Meanwhile, a rainbow armor appeared around Kia, shielding her from the attack.

In fact, she didn't seem bothered by the mummy's radioactive aura either.

"You are a [*Saint*]?" Akhenapep prepared to zap Knight Kia with a spell, astonished by his attack's failure. "[Greater Dispel—"

Too late.

Knight Kia's holy blade swiftly cut him in half from the skull to the pelvis, killing him instantly.

Or so Vainqueur thought, as the mummy glitched out of existence and reappeared a few feet away, Furibon's screen still showing his HP above his head.

HP: 670/2550.

The mummy barely had the time to regain his composure before Vainqueur hit him from behind, crushing him with both hands on the street. His immense strength shook the ground with deafening noise, sending pieces of the pavement in all directions.

Yet the mummy reappeared afterward, shaken, but alive.

"Why won't he die again?!" Vainqueur roared with consternation, trying to squish the undead like a game of whack-a-mole; Knight Kia backing him up, their enemy furiously struggling for his unlife.

"[Save Scum], the [Chronomancer]'s fearsome capstone!" Furibon let out a hiss of frustration, supporting his nemesis with a jagged beam. Akhenapep used his [*Za Warudo*] to avoid the attack and break the encirclement, reappearing on a pile of debris twenty meters away from them. Vainqueur immediately pursued him before he could recover. "Every time death

should claim him, he reverts to a ‘quicksave state’ right before the last blow!”

“He cannot be killed?!” Kia launched a holy sun at the mummy, who dodged by time leaping.

“The ability consumes SP and doesn’t recharge them, so he cannot recover once he runs out of them,” the lich replied. “There are other workarounds, like killing him in an [Antimagic Zone], canceling the Perk outright, or judicious use of status ailments...”

Then Vainqueur simply had to outlast this vermin. Force him to waste every drop of his magic until he had nothing left to power his ability.

The dragon blasted the mummy with his mighty flames while running at him, forcing the villain to reapply his chest seal to absorb them. In the background, Malfy and the rest had managed to condemn the summoning door, and now focused on the stranded minions of Akhenapep.

“Enough!” the mummy snarled, realizing the brilliance of the dragon’s plan and switching strategies. “[Ur-Pharaoh Ascension]!”

A golden glow surrounded the mummy, empowering him, changing him. His body grew in size, quickly casting a shadow upon the dragon, and threatening to crush Knight Kia underfoot. The paladin had to run away. Vainqueur looked up... and up...

And up.

Gone was the mummy, replaced by a giant of armored gold, his funerary mask now a soulless, condemning visage. His head reached more than a hundred feet above the ground, and he could easily grab even Vainqueur himself within his hands.

The giant raised his knee, extending it back, and then—

BHAM!

The giant kicked Vainqueur with more strength than Wotan's lightning or Maure's wind spear, shattering his ribs and propelling him backward.

The dragon smashed through one of the last pyramids still standing, came out on the other end, and finally ended his trajectory against one of the city's outer walls; his body having made a hole within.

Vitality check successful. Death averted.

Warning: you have **less than one hundred HP** remaining!

Critical health! [Bravo Bull] activated, strength increased!

Vainqueur struggled to remain conscious, his eyes dizzy and his body wracked with pain. He could hear the steps of the giant, as he trampled houses on his way to finish off the dragon; Knight Kia sliced his leg, but her blade barely dented his reinforced skin. Even Furibon and Jolie couldn't do anything, flying near the Ur-Pharaoh's shoulder while unleashing fireballs and bolts at his head.

Thankfully, Vainqueur's minions proved more effective. Having disposed of the remaining minions of Akhenapep, Malfy froze the titan's right foot with a breath of ice, briefly slowing him down; while the Kobold Rangers, their beast of burden, and Manling Victor's summoned allies climbed the mummy's left leg and tried to anchor him.

The emperor glared at this incoming insult to gold, which strangely hadn't cast a spell at him yet. Perhaps the vile mummy couldn't do so in this shape, having transformed to continue the fight while saving his SP.

The dragon wondered if his breath could melt that statue from that far...

...

False gold.

Intelligence check successful!

"Furibon!" Vainqueur roared to his nemesis. "Do the thing!"

The vile lich heard him, and seemingly understood the atrocity asked of him... Only for the glow in his empty eye sockets to somehow turn smug. “Say it!”

“Never!” Vainqueur refused to lower himself to his level.

“Say it, wyvern!” the lich insisted in his boundless cruelty. The gold giant looked at them with confusion, before realizing the threat Furibon presented. Instead of continuing his course to finish off Vainqueur, he raised his hand to smash the flying skeleton like a bug.

Vainqueur closed his eyes, the memories of his poor minions and his beloved niece flashing in his mind. He had to do it for them.

“Turn him to lead!” the dragon roared, tears in his eyes, sacrificing his morals for the greater wealth. “Turn him to lead, you evil, sadistic monster!”

The lich instantly raised his hands, as Akhenapep’s finger threatened to close around him. “[Transmute Gold to Lead]!”

And so, in a flash of sinister magic, the wicked Furibon turned the golden Ur-Pharaoh into a vile statue of lead. The spell spread throughout the titan, transforming him in a matter of seconds; the mummy didn’t even have the time to counter the curse through his own magic.

The giant pharaoh was petrified; weakened by lead poisoning.

“[Charged Attack]!” Vainqueur gathered his remaining strength, the power building up in his belly, and then unleashed it upon the giant.

The dragon fired a massive beam of pure energy at the giant’s heart, the attack melting it, and then worked its way on the other side. His minions wisely dispersed, as a rain of molten lead overflow from the wound.

The giant’s [Save Scum] activated, rewinding him to his previous state; that of a statue of lead. Vainqueur kept unleashing his attack, melting his heart a second time... and then a third...

On the fourth try, the titan stopped rewinding time, and Vainqueur's breath incinerated him whole. Like a wax candle, the giant collapsed into a lake of boiling lead, spreading across the streets of El Dorado like a diseased flood. Knight Kia took refuge on a pile of rubble, Jolie flying down to catch her in her arms and bring her to safety. The surviving minions of Vainqueur fled the flood, deeper into the city.

As Vainqueur breathed his last flame and inhaled again, he let out a sigh of relief. The mummy didn't come back.

As the lead lake cooled off and solidified, a humongous pile of items appeared at the mummy's last spot; the battle's spoils. The mummy's funerary mask, a dragon-sized ring, a scepter, piles of gems and treasures... his minions had also dropped many rewards, spread all over the battlefield.

Not worth his chief of staff.

"Uncle!" Jolie flew at his side, Knight Kia in her hands. The upstart minion immediately cast two spells on him: [Greater Restoration] and [Full Heal].

[**Irradiated**] status and Max HP reduction removed.

You regained all your HP.

Vainqueur could feel his wings again, and his chest no longer itched. Perfect.

Right afterward, the worm god Sablar teleported in the middle of the lead lake, a killjoy to the end.

"The racket is over. Congratulations, my prophet..." The deity looked around him, noticed the pile of treasure, and then the dragons, lich, paladins, and minions surrounding him with murder in their eyes. "Oh."

"Your actions cost me two minions, vile worm," Vainqueur hissed, while Knight Kia barely restrained herself from attacking him.

"A shame, I hoped for more," the deity replied callously, his eyes full of malice. Time seemed to rewind for the lake of lead, as it gathered back on

the spot of Akhenapep's defeat. It quickly coalesced into the mummy's shape, shaken, surprised, and defeated. "My prophet, the march of time will not claim you today."

The minion instantly knelt at his master's clawed feet. "My lord Sablar, I failed you."

"A single defeat doesn't invalidate a lifetime of atrocities in my name," the deity reassured his chief of staff. "You have done your best. This battle was but a sideshow, to the troubled times to come."

"We've won, get on with it." Furibon sounded as exasperated as Vainqueur himself.

The worm god glanced at the lich with contempt, before letting out a buzzing sound.

Instantly, the false gold plating of the ruins vanished into flying dust, eroding at indragon speed. El Dorado quickly transformed from a false vision of paradise to a devastated ruin of red, bloody bricks and concrete. The collars around Vainqueur's, Furibon's and Malfy's neck turned to dust. "Do not expect the citizens to be grateful for your deed," the god mused. "Learn that you have made a powerful enemy of me today, mortals."

"Go back to your ruins, fairyspawn!" Vainqueur snorted back.

"Now I have to find a new vacation resort," the deity complained. "Such a waste."

"My pyramid trumps this city," Akhenapep told his patron deity. "It is quieter, deep below the earth."

"Oh? It sounds like my kind of safe space." The worm god teleported both of them away.

The battle was over.

Congratulations! For leading friends and foes to victory against a mighty archmage, you earned three levels in [**Augustus**], one level in [**Kaiser**], and

three levels in [**Witchfinder General**]**!** You earned the [**Pontifex Maximus**], [**Malleus Maleficarum**], [**Incinerator**], and [**Master of Silence**] class perks!

By capping the [**Augustus**] class, you earned the [**Glitzy Theater**] class perk!

+150 HP, +70 SP, +8 STR, +7 VIT, +6 SKI, +6 AGI, +5 INT, +10 CHA, +5 LCK.

[**Pontifex Maximus**]: 60 SP. Your near-religious authority inspires your allies to greater heights; for five seconds per charisma point of yours, all their attacks and spells inflict fifty percent additional [Holy] damage.

[**Incinerator**]: any creature killed by one of your [Fire] attacks (be they your breath, spells, or perks) has their corpse instantly disintegrated, preventing future revival attempts. Even effects such as transformation into an undead post-mortem cannot bring back the deceased.

[**Malleus Maleficarum**]: Variable of 20 SP. You target a single target within one hundred feet of yourself with a phantom hammer, inflicting [Spirit] damage. If the target has levels in a spellcaster class, the attack becomes super effective; for each 20 SP you sacrifice to the spell, the hammer has a chance of dispelling one magical protection of the target on a successful Luck check.

[**Master of Silence**]: 80 SP. You infuse all allies within thirty feet of you with your silent hatred for spellcasters. For ten minutes, all unarmed and armed attacks have a chance to inflict the [Silence] ailment on a successful Luck check, preventing magicians from using verbal spells.

[**Glitzy Theater**]: 100 SP. You can summon a golden theater over a mile around yourself, trapping everyone present until you release it; [Teleportation] effects to escape the trap's confines always fail, but teleportation inside and within the cage remains possible. The theater counts as a gladiator arena for the purpose of your Perks.

“I... I gained levels.” Knight Kia had tears in her eyes, immediately embracing her mistress by the neck. “Jolie, I gained new levels!”

“Me too Kia!” the dragon replied, nuzzling her minion’s cheek. “So many at once too!”

Malfy raised his pincers, as if expecting a promotion of some kind... which didn’t happen. “Why?” the fiend complained. “Why will I not evolve into a CEO? I sinned so much!”

“Oh, a new class?” Furibon’s glee angered his nemesis.

“You are unforgivable,” Vainqueur lambasted him. “Your saving of my niece is commendable, but nowhere near enough to atone for your sins. And if you wish to survive for the next five minutes, you would better leave my minion’s scythe alone.”

“It is the only memento of him, wyvern,” the lich replied. “If you wish to revive him—”

“You would blackmail me?” Vainqueur let out smoke from his nostrils. “Tread carefully, lich.”

“Your Majesty, I can deal with the matter of Mr. Victor,” Malfy coughed. “I know exactly where his soul is.”

“You do that, Tasty Malfy,” Vainqueur ordered, his eyes set on the lich even as his demon minion opened a portal alongside the other fiends present. “And do not even think about touching my rightfully earned loot, Goldslayer.”

“Rightfully earned? *I* defeated the mummy and saved your worthless life!”

Both glared at one another, although newcomers quickly interrupted their tense contest.

The victims of the lifted [Curse of Greed] invaded the devastated warzone; most of them lizardfolk similar to Xolotl, although Vainqueur noticed

manlings and elves among the crowd. Best of all, Sweet Chocolatine and Felix showed up.

“You... are you the one who freed us?” one of the lizardkin asked.

“Yes, yes,” Vainqueur raised his head haughtily, prepared to receive his daily dose of praise and adoration. “It is I who saved you all.”

“You dirty pauper, how could you?!”

Vainqueur paused, glancing down at the crowd; almost every native lizardkin staring angrily at him. “Excuse you?”

“How dare you bring your poverty here, to the richest civilization in the world?!” The lizardman kept shaming his savior. “El Dorado was the brightest place on Outremonde, and now it looks like *lead*! No tourist will ever come fill our coffers now!”

“Give us back our gold!” another lizardkin complained. “You made us poor, so you better reimburse us!”

“Refund!” the crowd chanted. “Refund! Refund!”

Even Vainqueur’s minions and allies were too shocked by the sheer ungratefulness to properly lynch them. The manlings and elves present wisely put distance between themselves and the locals.

The dragon glanced at this collection of idiots, the biggest piles of lead crap he had ever seen in his very long life. Remembering that his best minion died for them, Vainqueur raised his head, closed his eyes, and took the higher road. The dragon road.

CHOMP!

With one bite, the dragon swallowed the lizardkin whole, silencing the angry crowd.

It was strangely tasty, like *hate food*.

“I am going to eat you,” Vainqueur declared with cold fury. “I am going to eat you *all*.”

And so he did, running after the ungrateful lizards as they screamed for their worthless lives; Manling Victor’s star squid, which had survived the fight, soon imitated the dragon.

“Uncle!” Jolie protested while the minions chanted ‘Vainqueur best dragon’ in the background. Furibon washed his hands of the spectacle, retreating in a corner with Manling Victor’s scythe. “That is not very Paladin!”

The holy niece prepared to rush between Vainqueur and his food, but Kia put a hand on her shoulder. “Don't bother, Jolie,” the knight said. “They brought it on themselves.”

At this moment, Vainqueur felt much better deep down, a burden lifted off his shoulders. He still had *it*.

He was no cattletarian.

Chapter 94: That time I reincarnated as a cup!

Victor Dalton, Grand Vizier of the V&V Empire, woke up with one hell of a body change.

Gone were his limbs, his mouth, his wings, and his tail. He could feel a ghostly impression of them as if he had been amputated, but he had no hand to facepalm with. Scratch that; Victor no longer felt, or at least, not in a human way. He could no longer distinguish cold from warmth, scents, or tastes. He could only see and hear as if watching through a television screen.

Observing the world through the sculpted eye sockets of his [Black Grail], Victor Dalton had become something more than a man.

He had become a cup!

As expected, his soul had moved into the [Black Grail] after Akhenapep murdered him. He had cheated death, even after losing his Heaven Insurance. And from what he could see, Xolotl had the [Black Grail] placed on an altar inside an underground sacrificial chamber, like a holy relic.

Nobody was around, except for two skeleton guards standing watch over the entrance.

Victor was finally safe.

Congratulations! For pulling off a karma houdini, avoiding the consequences of violating your Karma Insurance, and dodging divine judgment through your villainous artifact, you earned two levels in

[**Moriarty**] and two levels in [**Weathermaker**]! You earned the [**Asteroid Dynamics**] and [**Zmey Rider**] class perks.

+60 HP, +40 SP, +2 STR, +2 VIT, +3 SKI, +1 AGI, +8 INT, +4 CHA, +6 LCK.

[**Asteroid Dynamics**]: Whenever you are in combat, your evil genius predicts the movements of your enemies by subconsciously analyzing all variables, granting you a boost to precision, evasion, and criticals equal to half your Intelligence.

[**Zmey Rider**]: You can summon a unique [Zmey] as a familiar. A [Zmey] is a fiendish, dimwit lesser cousin of true dragons bringing rainfall wherever they go. If your [Zmey] is killed, you lose the Perk.

Sweet. Since he gained experience and Sablar hadn't come to kill him permanently, Victor assumed Vainqueur and/or Kia had prevailed against Akhenapep. He hoped there weren't too many casualties...

Wait, he could gain stat boosts as a cup? Without a body?

Huh, interesting. Could it be that the stat increases, Perks, and system benefits were linked to his soul, instead of his body?

"Hello?" Victor attempted to talk to the skeletons, but no sound came out. Not even a telepathic contact of any kind. "Take me to El Dorado, and I shall grant you more power than you can possibly imagine!"

The skeleton guards ignored him.

And here he thought that diabolical whispers was a feature of all evil artifacts... He attempted to call for help through [Scarlet Study] and came back with a system screen.

Usage of Perks impossible while inhabiting improper vessel.

He would have to solve that design flaw next time. Thankfully, he could still control all the [Arisen] his Black Grail had created, [Enthralling] them

to do his bidding. He just needed one to bring him to El Dorado, spray his ashes with black blood, problem solved.

Now that he thought of it though... did [Enthralling] sentient beings count as slavery? Even if they literally owed their unlife to him, and that it was only for one task? Considering Vainqueur's own stance in the matter, he had to tread carefully with it.

Victor decided he would just send a telepathic SOS message through their bond, and hope his undead creations would feel grateful enough to help.

"Minions! Minions!"

Nearest [**Arisen**]: 15 kilometers.

Only fifteen kilometers? Had he raised new undead during his drug trip in Kukulcan? Victor hesitated to call that good but thanked his luck all the same as he called out for rescue.

Your [**Arisen**] are moving to your position.

Great, he just had to wait.

How long could it take?

As it turned out, a long, long while. Gratitude was much less persuasive than magical command.

Victor first tried to entertain himself by counting sheep, then asking riddles to the skeletons. After a while, it grew boring, so he considered what new name he should use while in cup form.

Victograil?

Cuphead?

Grail-kun?

Grail-kun it was.

"Hey, I'm Grail-kun! I'm immortal, but don't tell anyone!" Victor called out to the skeletons, feeling like an idiot afterward. Truly, he was going mad. How long had it been since he sent a SOS?

You have been a [**Black Grail**] for two hours.

Two *hours*? What were his undead saviors doing?

Nearest [**Arisen**]: 5 kilometers.

Damn, the confinement would drive him mad. He had to do something. Maybe the skeletons would sound the alarm if he moved?

Ngh...

Ngh...

Nnnngghhhh!

Argh, moving as an inanimate item was hard! No wonder the One Ring became such an asshole, Victor felt like a quadriplegic!

Finally, using all of his willpower, Grail-kun managed to tip himself over, falling from the altar. "Freedom!" Victor screamed in silent satisfaction, as he hit the ground and rolled towards the skeleton. "Suck my cup!"

And it worked! The skeleton glanced down at Victor, seizing him gently... and then put him back on the altar before returning to its post.

This body was a mistake.

What else could he do? His Grail had been linked to both Happyland and his scythe, allowing him to transfer souls to an [**Arisen**] vessel. While he couldn't send his own soul to his scythe without risking the disruption of his own tenuous anchor to Outremonde, he could always summon a captive. If his scythe remained intact, he could use them as messengers.

"Come to me!" Victor ordered. "Grail-kun commands it!"

A shade appeared right next to the cup, invisible to the skeletons, but not to Victor. The Vizier instantly recognized her as Wotan's Valkyrie, Sigrun... although, for some reason, she appeared to him naked.

She was a beauty, a Scandinavian, muscled beauty with long, braided blonde hair and ocean-colored eyes. With her feathered wings, she reminded Victor of Miel.

On a closer look though... she looked somewhat wrong. The lines of her face were too symmetrical, her body proportions a bit off. She looked like a statue shaped by someone with only a rough academical understanding of humans. Since Wotan had created her as false princess bait, it didn't surprise the Vizier much.

Victor should have probably lusted after her, but didn't. He assumed his new body's lack of hormones and brain chemistry prevented him from feeling arousal, or even physical pleasures. No more of that sweet dopamine.

Why can't cups have nice things?

"You..." The woman glared at him. "Was condemning me to silent suffering not enough for you? You have to degrade me with your cold stare?"

He did gain a strange kind of satisfaction from her annoyance though. His evil artifact instincts had already kicked in.

Also, he recognized her voice. "Wait... you're the one!"

"The one?" At least she could understand him.

"On that island, after our first battle with King Wotan—"

"Your crushing defeat at my master's hands, you mean," the Valkyrie replied with pride.

"You asked if my corpse was still warm!" It had bugged Victor for days.
"Why?"

“... I have no idea of what you are you talking about.”

Victor glared at her, and then remembered he had no eyebrows. What an underrated body feature. Instead of giving that liar the *stare*, he gave her the *silence*.

After a long, awkward moment, the Valkyrie glanced away, embarrassed. “We are not called *shieldmaidens* for nothing,” she admitted.

...

"So not only would you have violated my corpse, you would have done a *hack job at it*? I am deeply offended, on both counts!"

“You were supposed to be dead,” she said as if it was *his* fault. “Do not remind me of that missed opportunity, dragon slave.”

"I assume you aren't going to help me call for assistance?"

She answered with a silent glare of her own, except she had the eyebrows to make it work. Victor grumbled to himself as he furiously pondered what to do next.

He could always hope for an [Arisen] or necromancer to make their way into the chamber, true. But the more he waited with that infuriating shade for company, the more he wanted a quick way out.

“Even if your allies survive, you will stay a cup for all eternity,” Sigrun taunted him. “My sisters and my king live. They will come for you, for your dragon master. There is only doom for your damned soul.”

Wait.

That was it! The [Black Grail] could select damned souls from Happyland to return to the material plane! Since he was the cup itself, Victor could probably project his consciousness into the infernal planes!

"Sigrun, you are a genius!" Victor thanked the surprised Valkyrie, focusing on his link to Happyland and leaving her hanging.

Victor Dalton awoke in a dark room, back in his original body; or rather a ghostly, astral projection of one.

Was it Happyland? He couldn't see anything, although he heard a few whispers in the background. "Hello?" Victor called out. "Is someone there?"

Someone switched on the light.

"SURPRISE!"

Victor backed down, as he found himself surrounded by a *massive* crowd of thousands of demons, all acclaiming him.

The Vizier noticed Malfy, his lawyers, and his usual summons among them, alongside the host of archfiends and succubi he dealt with at Scholomance. But countless others he didn't recognize, from many-eyed green slimes to fallen angels in business suits. Imp ninjas acted as security, their tiny eyes were hidden behind sunglasses.

The room they occupied looked like a demonic variant of Wall Street's famous stock market room, with screens showing the latest 'soul dividends yields' and 'corporations' credit notes' embedded in skull pillars. Multiple banners with slogans such as '*Happy Damnation Victor!*', '*Our Hero Dalton,*' and '*Happy Hellday*' had been attached to them.

"W-what the?" Victor blinked, not having expected something like this. "What's happening?"

"Mr. Victor, I am so glad to see you again!" Malfy couldn't suppress his tears, a demon lawyer wiping them away with a bloody handkerchief. "I threw this party at the last minute after His Majesty defeated Akhenapep, and I was starting to wonder if you would ever fall downstairs! Unfortunately, Mrs. Maure couldn't make it in time."

"Gentlefiends!" The biggest demon in the room clamored, silencing everyone. Victor recognized the entity, a massive, crowned black fly-human hybrid, as the dreaded Beelzebub. "Your attention please!"

The fly lord raised a cup of bloody champagne and started an inspiring speech.

“You all know me as Beelzebub, CEO of Infercorp and honorary Chairman of the Corporate Overlords Board. I have been, to some of you, a boss, a father, a competitor, or a cutthroat challenger. In one case, all at the same time. But tonight is not the time for rivalries in Soulwell Street; tonight is a friendly Sabbath for all of demonkind, where we can all celebrate our collective achievements.”

“Thanks to our efforts, we have lowered the average age of work on the material plane to six, *six* years old! We created millions of jobs for children everywhere!” The demons clapped, while Victor stood there, his mind unable to compute the scene before him.

“Thanks to our progressive policy of constantly lowering mortal salaries, we managed to achieve man-woman equality of wages! I could go on, talk about how our rebranding increased our damnation conversion rate by fifty percent or this year’s historical soul dividends. I will do none of that. For today, we gathered to acclaim one, who is a *hero* to us all.”

The fly lord raised his glass to the Vizier. “All of us, a round of applause for our shareholder Victor Dalton!”

The crowd acclaimed him instantly, their warm congratulations deafening. “Uh, thanks,” he said, completely lost.

“For your extraordinary act in the service of Happyland, the Board of Corporate Overlords *unanimously* decided to grant you the *Medal of the Order of the Fly*; the highest decoration known to demonkind.” The fly archfiend approached Victor and put a winged cross medal on his ghostly chest, while the cheers redoubled in intensity. “You are a hero, Mr. Dalton, and you will always be welcome among us.”

What the Happyland did he do? Definitely something terrible.

Afterward, the demon lord called for an orgy, and trumpets resonated through the market room. Lines of naked succubi and their male

counterparts, the incubi, walked into the marble-paved hall, playing instruments or carrying golden plates full of drinks, toasts, and cocaine.

With a completely clueless Victor in the middle of it all.

Demons swarmed to the Vizier like a horde of groupies, so many at once that he could barely make sense of their words. Some congratulated him, one offered him drugs, a few offered alliances, and a fiendish slime even asked to bear his child.

“Get away from me!” the chief of staff shouted, confused and lost. “I only want fresh air!”

Immediately, his summons formed a ring around him and pushed away most of the crowd, allowing him to breathe at last. Only Malfy could get past the safety cord.

“Congratulations, Mr. Victor.” The bug fiend handed the Vizier a glass of bloody champagne. He also noticed a demon lawyer sniffing cocaine off a succubi’s breast in the background. “I had that gut feeling you would become Happyland’s greatest champion, and by Mammon did you shatter all my expectations!”

“What did I do?” Victor asked. “Is it about Heaven? What did I do to Heaven?”

Malfy still threatened to cry in joy but managed to keep his composure this time. “They gave up.”

Victor froze. “They gave up?”

“The angels gave up!” Malfy replied cheerfully, before finally realizing his associate didn’t get it. “The pigeon. She tried to stop you when you undressed in public. Don’t you remember?”

“No.” He didn’t even know Miel had attended the party. It made sense in hindsight since Vainqueur had activated [Golden Road] to bring reinforcements.

“But then you put her right in her place by revealing your insurance fraud to everyone!” Malfy relished in the memory. “She slapped you many times in return, but you seemed to enjoy it very much.”

Oh, gods. The Vizier vowed to apologize to Miel after this mess.

“As usual for fraudsters, the pigeons arrived in mass to ‘smite down the wicked one.’” Many demons chuckled in the background. “And you beat them all!”

“I beat up *angels*?” If the insurance fraud hadn’t barred him out of Heaven, that part certainly did.

“Yes! And then... and then you revived them with your [Black Grail] to ‘apologize’!” By now Malfy could barely make coherence sentences, laughing in the middle of his sentence.

“So the angels gave up on me.” Victor accepted it as just and fair, having brought it upon himself. “Does it really warrant all this partying?”

“You don’t get it, Mr. Victor,” one of Victor’s marilith bodyguards said, clearly struggling against her mirth. “You raised angels with your [Black Grail].”

“But...” Victor finally got it. “The Black Grail can only raise souls bound to...”

“As it turns out...” The marilith began to tear up.

“Angels go to Hell when they die!”

Every demon within earshot exploded into diabolical laughter afterward, no one even contesting the use of Happyland’s old branding.

“The face they made... I nearly choked,” Malfy caught his breath. “You almost killed me back then, Mr. Victor. You almost did.”

The unresponsive Vizier guessed centuries of exhorting mortals for SP *did* decrease karma.

“After that humiliation, their whole system crumbled!” An imp ninja provided Malfy with a wine glass of his own. “They reevaluated their old client files and realized that a large chunk of them had committed frauds like you. Twenty-three point five percent, according to my inside sources. I heard Mithras is *furious*.”

One out of four? That could happen with a *lot* of angelic corruption. Victor really, *really* didn’t like where this was going. “They... the angels no longer sell insurance?”

“No!” Malfy gloated. “Oh, certainly, they will keep accepting pure souls on merit, but not only have they completely backed down from the neutral karma market, but they also canceled all their existing subscriptions! You destroyed the pigeons’ credibility all by yourself!”

...

“Malfy, am I evil?”

“Only ‘accidentally’,” Malfy reassured him, only to ruin the sentiment right afterward. “Which gives you plausible deniability in a court of law. You are a model for all of us, Mr. Victor. Oh, also, do you want wine with your cocaine?”

“No, no drugs!” Not ever! “I need to go back to Outremonde, and get revived, *now*.”

“You can always become a Fiend, Mr. Victor,” Malfy proposed. “Your soul only needs to absorb Happyland’s energies to trigger a transformation. Usually, you would start at the bottom of the corporate ladder, but as a major shareholder, we can speed up the climbing process.”

“Wait, my soul becomes a demon? What happens if I die again?”

“Maybe you will go to Heaven!” Malfy teared up, throwing his wine everywhere on the marble floor.

Yeah, he would rather go back to a human body instead of becoming a giant fly. If only to properly make up with Miel.

“Victor?”

The Vizier heard Camilla’s voice in the back of his mind, sensing the goddess speak to his cup form. And she wasn’t alone.

“Return to your cup,” the goddess Shesha spoke to his mind. “We must talk.”

Chapter 95: God Game Night II: Good Expansion

Mithras hated game nights.

The god of order, the sun, and medicine didn't quite remember how these gatherings started. But he knew how they always ended up: with him patching up a new cosmic mess.

This time, Cybele hosted their gathering. She had set aside a large room in her planar realm of Arcadia, an open space with a floor of moss and pillar-shaped trees. A giant mushroom served as the gaming table, surrounded by fungi thrones, while bioluminescent plants and fireflies provided a faint light. This place truly was a vision of a natural paradise; even as the god of civilization, more at home in cities than forests, Mithras felt soothed.

The sight reminded the deity of his time in the ninth legion, defending Britannica from the Caledonians. He had been a worse person back then, fighting to conquer the people of the earth out of misguided loyalty for one nation.

Manifesting into the room in his sun-king form, Mithras found Cybele and Isengrim already present. His friend Leone, goddess of nobility, teleported right afterward, a golden knight as beautiful and fair as daylight.

"Welcome, my dears," Cybele greeted them, her skin and face hidden beneath a hooded cloak of woven moss. As the goddess of pleasure, anyone witnessing her exposed face couldn't help but... well... pleasure themselves. Simply hearing her melodious voice would have brought mortals low.

“Greetings!” A white deer with blades for antlers, the god of hunters Isengrim had somehow managed to sit on his throne, his hooves on the table. “My friends, you look terrible!”

“We had a difficult day,” Leone said, exhausted. Once having been Mithras’ squire while a mortal, the two had remained friends after she conquered Valhalla. While Cybele kept trying to push them into a romance of some sort, the sun deity saw their relationship as that of a mentor and student.

“So it was true that angels were swinging both ways—”

“We shall not speak about it,” Mithras interrupted Cybele, the mere mention of this disaster making him burn with anger. To think that he had ordered his paladins and clerics never to harm an angel unless in self-defense... how could he have been blind to their corruption for so long? “I wish to relax, not open new wounds.”

“Well then, I will not probe deeper.” The goddess invited them to take their seat, as the last invited member of the gathering arrived.

Seng, goddess of the sea, dreams, and alcoholism, was a *wreck*. An eastern mermaid with black octopus tentacles for legs, she seemed to have just left a rabble-rouser party, her short raven hair messy and her black eyes creased. She only wore a blue bra and a purple flower in her hair; tattoos of plunder and obscenities covered her arms and neck.

She was the *one* goddess they should have barred from this table, and Leone reminded them why once Seng took her seat, a bottle of alcohol in her left hand. “No booze at the table.”

“It’s whiskey!” Seng protested.

“You’re only allowed to play if sober,” Mithras reminded her sternly. “Nobody wants another flood.”

“It was an *accident*, alright! Gimme a break!” The goddess pouted her hand tight around her whiskey. “Just one bottle!”

“One, and pace yourself,” Cybele said, more tolerant than the others. “Or else I will prematurely eject you from this gathering.”

“Since when did you turn into a bore?” Seng grumbled while Cybele set the map of Outremonde on the mushroom table. Mithras observed the gaming board of Outremonde with melancholy.

Centuries ago, when the System was new and the deities few, Mithras had ruled the first mortal empire directly as a god-emperor. He had defended a small city from fomor depredations, helped it form alliances with other settlements, and slowly united the fairies’ slaves into a strong nation covering most of the Mistral continent. The *Mithraic Empire*.

Mithras himself never had any intention to rule it forever. His role was to serve as civilization’s guiding hand to the New Folk, be they humans, elves, dwarves or beastkin. In time, he might have broken the fomors’ power over Outremonde entirely and prevented future tragedies. Most mortals worshiped him during that time, to the point of nicknaming him the *One God*.

In his own arrogance, he hadn't foreseen the Dread Three ascending to godhood together. They challenged Mithras for supremacy and even killed him; when he revived in Valhalla one year afterward, his empire had already fractured.

An era of chaos followed, as deities old and new directly fought for control of Outremonde. Chaotic gods rose during those troubled times, from the Moon Man to Sablar the World Eater. Since the supreme power in Valhalla revived deities a year and a day after their avatar’s death, none could gain the upper hand for long.

After years of disastrous fighting, Cybele, the second oldest deity after Dice, brokered a gentlemen's agreement between her fellow divinities; arguing that they restrain themselves to affect the world through their portfolio, Claimed, and worshipers. The war had exhausted everyone, and the gods agreed to make peace.

In the end, isolated and outnumbered, even Sablar submitted. The worm god knew his ambitions would cause the other gods to unite against him should he make a fuss, and he played the long game since. If anything, patience made him even more insidious.

Over time, Gardemagne had managed to recover its predecessor's western and northern borders, but it remained a shade of the old empire. The vampiric Nightlands, in particular, remained a sore point for the god of law. Gardemagne had been Leone's pet project, while Mithras had mostly focused on the Eversun Empire farther east, where his church held great sway. The nation hadn't performed as well as he had hoped, surrounded by hostile powers and mired in political corruption. Would this session change things?

A dice fell from the heavens on the table, to no one's surprise.

"Roll me!" Dice shouted. The gambling deity always managed to land on the gaming table whenever they began a session. The gods had found it easier to include that living disaster for the purpose of damage control, rather than letting it run rampant. "Roll me!"

"I would like to go last, as usual," Mithras asked politely, ignoring the dice.

"At the bottom?" Cybele replied.

Why did she always have to sound like she meant something dirty? As far as Mithras could tell, Cybele didn't even do it on purpose. The ascended [Paladin] simply nodded, and the goddess of forests opened the session.

"Today, we continue our long-term campaign of Outremonde: Crusader Realms Edition," Cybele began, acting as the Game Master. "We shall each play a chosen country and guide them. The campaign ends when the entire world is at peace or destroyed. Before you ask Leone, one country taking over Outremonde still counts as a victory condition."

"Roll me!"

“Shesha will not be among us?” Isengrim asked, ignoring the petulant dice. She usually participated in their sessions, pitting her Nagastan against Mithras’ own Eversun Empire.

“She said she had a *rendezvous* with Camilla and one of her Claimed.” Leone tightened her fists at this. “Since it concerns one of my beloved Claimed, I proposed to fill in for her.”

“Roll me for initiative!”

“She also told me the meeting could shed light on the fomor problem.”

“Is it true that they can level up now?” Mithras asked immediately, having heard the rumor. If true, then the time for games would end.

The memories of his own abduction to Outremonde came back to haunt him. He still remembered leading his centuria to investigate barbarians raiding the shores of Britannica, expecting to return home by noon. Only it hadn’t been pirates, but tyrants from another world, looking for slaves to torment.

King Balaur was still the size of a mere man back then, but just as brutal as ever.

The five years Mithras had spent as the fomor’s thrall was a blur, a nightmare full of screams and slaughters. He didn’t even remember his original roman name, erased one whipping at a time. When the [Paladin] had finally escaped after learning of the class system, he had vowed to protect the mortals of the world from the evils he had experienced.

“I cannot say for now,” Cybele replied, Sablar having shrouded the fairies’ activities to her sight. She rolled Dice four times, once for each deity except Mithras. “The turn order will be Leone, Isengrim, myself, Seng, and finally, Mithras. Since Dice has no country, he will serve as, well, our dice.”

Of course, no one would roll Dice if they could help it, but the possibility satisfied the chaotic deity for now.

Mithras played the Eversun Empire, the easternmost country of the Mistral continent, while Leone influenced Gardemagne. Seng oversaw the Jade Empire from which she originated, and Isengrim the vast plains of the Beastlands. Cybele herself usually managed the wild Dark Forest, which she disputed with the fomors, but would manage Shesha's commercial empire of Nagastan instead for this session.

"The fomor Mell Lin's rat plague spreads east, killing thousands across the Serica continent. The Teikoku Empire walled its shores to prevent the infection, while the Jade Empire and Nagastan manage the disease the best they can. Westward, Sablar's El Dorado..." Cybele all but spat the word with contempt, "is gone. Wiped out. Destroyed. Crumbled. Annihil—"

"We get it, Cy," Seng interrupted.

"Elsewhere, the fomors marshal their forces after the V&V Empire's declaration of war against them, while the dragon establishes colonies in the New World. Leone, what will you do?"

"I declare a holy war against the V&V Empire."

"What?!" Isengrim protested, "No way, I have worshipers there!"

"Leone, holy wars are not the only solution to every problem," Cybele tried to temper her.

"I hate to be the rule stickler instead of Mithras, but you need a *casus belli* to start a holy war," Seng grumbled. "BLEEPING nobles, always thinking laws apply to others..."

"They destroyed *Heaven*!" Leone said with wrathful intent. "Heaven! With insurance frauds!"

"I too take this fiasco *very* personally, Leone," Mithras told his one-time squire. Corruption always infuriated the god of law. "And I swear that I shall go Old Testament wrath on the angelic authorities responsible. But the mortals only exposed existing, institutional problems in Heaven's administration. A beautiful afterlife should never have been for sale."

Heaven needed to reform and return to its original, humbler roots, and Mithras would help spearhead the reform personally. In his experience, most angels meant well, with their system corrupting them; only by changing their institutions themselves, could the forces of good get back on the road to redemption.

“They destroyed an island and almost sank another,” Leone pointed out. “That dragon and his human partner are living disasters. Neither can I tolerate a nation of fiends, undead, and eldritch horrors from space arming themselves right next to a peaceful Gardemagne. Isengrim, you of all deities should support me in this.”

“Why would I support a war involving my sweet, lovable worshipers?” the hunter god protested.

“*You shall respect the hunt,*” Leone quoted Isengrim’s own scriptures. “*Hunt to feed, or to thin the herd, but never for profit or pleasure, and never to extinction. Except demons and undead. Demons and undead can be hunted for pleasure, for profit, and to be made extinct.*”

“Oh, yes, I said that,” the white deer nodded. “With emphasis on the *can*. Not *must*. Neither of those monster types have any ecological niche besides leeching off the living, and so I do not begrudge my worshippers for hunting them.”

“Hence you should see nothing wrong with culling off this so-called V&V Empire’s population.”

“I disagree,” Isengrim replied firmly. “Because so far, they have worked hard to bring life back to the desert Sablar’s chosen left in their wake, and they built a community where all species can coexist. I wholly support the initiative.”

“We cannot put an entire species into one box or another,” Mithras said, Leone frowning at him.

“Even the fomors?” she asked the hard question.

“Even them,” Mithras said, firm in his belief. “Everyone should be judged on their individual merit. Humans, dragons, fairies, demons... angels. This is *justice*. Victor Dalton is bound to Hell for his deplorable behavior, but his followers should not be punished for his misdeeds.”

“They broke the slave trade in the New World,” Seng argued. The mermaid goddess was very attached to the notion of freedom, albeit not the point of rivaling Deathjester’s brutal brand of anarchism. “How can you want to pick a fight with slave liberators?”

“V&V also brought down that vile insult to nature called El Dorado,” Cybele defended the two. “The chaos they bring, while worrying, is ultimately balanced by the good.”

“And of the two nations of monsters preparing for war,” Seng said. “You should focus on the *other*, Ms. Stickintheass.”

This gave Leone pause, the goddess of knights glancing at Prydain. Their Wild Hunts had already raided Gardemagne’s shores and kept rampaging elsewhere across the world for an unknown purpose.

“Fine,” she said. “But I’ll keep the *holy warcasus belli* for later. Mmm...”

The goddess of knights hesitated to attack Prydain but decided against it for now. The fomors had barricaded themselves in their stronghold, and it was more sensible to keep troops at home, to protect their borders against Wild Hunts and the V&V Empire alike. Instead, the deity chose diplomacy.

“I ask my church to serve as matchmakers between Prince Dimitri of Gardemagne and the Witchdom of Tsaria’s queen; and between Princess Merveille of Gardemagne and Prince Komnius of the Eversun Empire, for the purpose of political alliances through marriage.”

“Prince Dimitri is no longer pinning after Kia?” Cybele asked, sounding *extremely* disappointed. She had worked so hard in the background to set these two up.

“He gave up after she left for the V&V Empire,” Leone replied, leaving the ascended dryad to ponder the implications. “I want Gardemagne to grow stronger through diplomacy and refinement. With most of the rebuilding from the Century War done and the Age of Discovery bolstered, I now launch a renaissance of the arts across the kingdom. Gardemagne will conquer the continent not through force, but with its culture. I end my turn.”

As usual, Isengrim shepherded his flock on Outremonde, asking them to push the frontier further. The white deer had ascended while protecting small communities from monster and fomor depredations and had little interest in larger nations. As far as he was concerned, humble, small victories mattered more than large scale events.

“I will also ask my [Fairy Hunters] to move to Gardemagne, just in case,” Isengrim said as he finished his round. “Your turn, my dear Cybele.”

The goddess of forests glanced at the map of Outremonde, then snapped her fingers. An enormous wooden board rose from the ground to her side, covered in pictures. Mithras recognized the faces of his chosen Kia Bekele, Victor Dalton, and countless others; crimson links joined two photos together, such as Vainqueur Knightsbane and an *obscene* pile of gold.

“What are you doing?” Leone asked for everyone there, as Cybele summoned a feather to her hand.

“I am updating my mortal relationship board, now that the Kia-Dimitri ship sank.” The goddess scratched the back of her hood with her free hand.

“With whom could I set her up...”

“JoliKia!” Seng immediately jumped on the occasion to push her favorite pairing. “Love transcending species!”

“They are cute together, but...” Cybele didn’t seem keen on the idea. “I don’t know... it’s missing something...”

"Roll me!" Dice insisted, "Roll me for the romance route!"

“Kia deserves nothing but the best,” Mithras said. His Claimed had done the world a great service, and he would do his best to make her happy. “Is there no charming, dashing young man or lady with whom she could have a fulfilling relationship?”

“We should let her make her own choice,” Leone replied. “She is young, give her time to find herself without help.”

“I have tried *everything*,” Cybele complained. “Can you even fathom the number of lads and ladies I sent her way through the Century War and afterward? Most find her too impressive to approach, and the rare time someone does, like Dimitri, she never settles!”

“Maybe relationships simply do not interest her?” Leone suggested, herself having only ever loved adventure. “There is nothing wrong with that.”

“Is ChocoVic still strong?” Isengrim asked, deeply invested in the matter. Cybele nodded in response. “Good. I will defend that mating pair with my life.”

“I shall not give up on Kia’s case,” Cybele insisted. “Although I do not see who could replace Dimitri.”

“What a *noob*.”

The voice of Deathjester put Mithras on edge. He glanced at his left, finding the assassin grinning at him in a corner.

“Are you here to play or fight, murderer?” Leone asked with cold professionalism, while Mithras simply glared at his nemesis in silence. It took every ounce of willpower not to smite that feathered fiend where he stood.

“Oh no, don’t mind me, I just came to defend my champion’s honor.” The jester whistled as he stole Cybele’s feather. “Cybi, you’re not seeing the easy solution there.”

The dryad remained silent, as the god of crime started editing her pairing board.

“You just need to set *every woman on your board*,” Deathjester redrew all pairings until they all converged into one face. “With my favorite Claimed, Victor Dalton.”

“Even Kia?” Cybele asked.

“*Except* Kia,” Deathjester clarified. “And that’s the genius part. With no alternative, every male on your board will zoom on her instead, like *Helen of Troy*, until one is successful at winning her heart.”

“That is...” Cybele pondered it. “Innovative...”

“As long as ChocoVic remains the one true mating pair, I have no objection,” said Isengrim.

“And as long as I draw breath, harems shall never be allowed at this table!” Mithras declared, incensed. He knew Deathjester only did that to mess with the sun god through his Claimed chosen.

The jester chuckled at his nemesis. “Hey, Mithras. Didn’t you hear?”

The god of justice’s eyes turned into supernovas.

“Dead angels go to Hell!”

Mithras summoned a pillar of holy flames to strike down his loathsome nemesis, only for Deathjester to vanish while cackling like a maniac. “How does he keep sneaking up in our gaming rooms?” Seng asked, confused.

“He is the god of thieves and spies,” Mithras replied, joining his fingers to suppress his righteous anger. “Ignore him. He’s a nuisance. If you snub him enough, he goes away.”

To his frustration, Cybele remained mesmerized by the altered board. “He does make a good case—”

“No harems,” Mithras shut the proposal down. “Shall we return to Outremonde? You must guide Nagastan.”

Cybele put away the relationship board, grumbling all the way. “For Nagastan... with the plague still going on, I will encourage mortals to confine themselves at home and do nothing; priests and casters will cast [Cure Disease] spells, while alchemists and other crafters shall work on cures.”

“Would it not be better to have all the sick people quarantined in one place?” Leone suggested. “Instead of everyone?”

“Every person at home is a hero,” Cybele replied with wisdom. “Every sofa, a battlefield.”

Mithras had the intuition this was just an excuse to encourage matings at home but kept it to himself.

It would soon be his turn, and he already considered what to do. Leone had a point; a new war was on the horizon. Not between nations, but between fomors and mortals.

Mortals had exhausted themselves after the Century War, but the events of the past year told him the fairy lords were quickly rising in strength. Perhaps it was time to bring back his Shining Crusaders together, and prepare. The V&V Empire might have caused troubles, but the sun god felt that they would become a bulwark against the fairy’s forces; they needed every help they could get.

Of course... if Outremonde survived the next turn.

Every deity glanced at Seng with a tense silence, much to her chagrin. “Why are you looking at me, like I’ve eaten a baby?”

As the god of honesty, Mithras couldn’t help but say the truth. “We are waiting for you to screw up somehow.”

“You aren’t going to try and sink Atlantis again?” Cybele asked, having worshippers there. Dice's latest rolling had also caused an earthquake there, and while the continent had survived, it remained vulnerable.

“W-what, of course not!”

“The Teikoku Empire?” Leone pushed. “The western islands?”

“What, just because I caused a flood one time while drunk—”

“Four times,” Mithras corrected her. “You did it four times.”

“You’re just jealous that I’m on the ascendancy with the Age of Discovery!” Seng protested angrily, tossing out her open bottle in her anger. “Mortals are finally crossing the seven seas in my divine name—”

Leone panicked first. “Your whiskey!”

Seng’s bottle unloaded its content in the pacific ocean, divine alcohol flooding everything.

“Oh, BLEEP, oh BLEEP I BLEEPED up!” The sea goddess apologized, pushing her bottle away, but too late. A massive spot of alcohol spread through the sea. “I, I created a whiskey ocean!”

Mithras sighed, knowing he would spend his next turn mitigating this disaster.

Yet another round wasted keeping the world in one piece...

Chapter 96: Need a Raise

“I need a raise,” Victor said while in cup form.

“Me too,” the goddess Shesha replied. The reptilian deity and Camilla had settled in the hidden chamber, the skeleton guards bowing before them. Apparently, the divinities had no problem hearing Victor's thoughts in item form.

“You need a raise?”

“Although I have been commissioned by your dragon friend to revive you and Cybele's chosen, bringing a mortal back to life is much more expensive without a vessel to work on.”

“We can discuss it a bit later,” Camilla said. “There are a few things we wish to confirm with you first, Victor.”

The cup waited in silence.

“Yesterday night... you achieved a greater understanding of the universe through drugs.” Camilla seemed deeply embarrassed. “Do you remember anything? Like seeing us gods in a compromising position?”

“I don't remember much,” Victor wisely kept the truth to himself. “It was very blurry after the slime totem part.”

“Good,” she said with relief. “Good. Our worshipers are not ready.”

“And now, for my own concern.” Shesha nodded, her gaze turning harsh. “Can fomors level up?”

Victor would have nodded if he had a head. “Yes. Yes, they can.”

Both goddesses listened to him, as he gave them a report of the battle with Wotan, including what he had learned through [Monster Insight]. The more he spoke, the deeper the divinities frowned. “This is very worrying,” Camilla declared. “I will share the information with everyone.”

“There has been an increase of fomor *Wild Hunts* around the world,” Shesha added. “First in Gardemagne and the Winter Kingdoms, then to Serica, the eastern continent. Now I understand why.”

“They’re *grinding*,” the Vizier realized, horrified. “Like us. They’re preparing for war.”

“Usually, the locals of Serica would have organized and pushed them back by now, but the magical plague spread by the fomor Mell Lin disrupts everything,” Camilla lamented, herself the goddess of illnesses. “I’ve had my worshipers work on a cure, but progress is slow.”

“Can a fomor become a god?” Shesha asked the scariest question. Both Sablar and Dice had been created by one, so... perhaps a fairy could ascend to Valhalla upon reaching level ninety-nine.

The mere *possibility* of a fomor deity silenced everyone for a good minute.

“It’s not going to happen,” Victor swore.

“No, it won’t,” Camilla replied with firm resolve, “And for that, Vainqueur will need you alive and well.”

“Unfortunately, you do not meet my cost requirements,” Shesha said.

“Surely, we can draw into Murmurin’s gold reserves,” Victor proposed.

“No, you barely have enough funds in your *entire empire*, to fund both resurrections,” Shesha corrected. “With yours being slightly less expensive, since your soul remains anchored to the material plane.”

“What? That’s bullshit!” Victor protested. “You can alter reality on a whim, but rebuilding a mortal body from scratch cost too much?”

“Do you take death for a revolving door?” Shesha replied. “As strange at it sounds, yes, rebuilding a mortal coil tailored to the original soul is harder than it looks, especially when the target has already been reincarnated already.”

“Even for you?” Victor asked Camilla. “I mean, I don’t want to beg for favors, but you are the goddess of necromancy.”

Camilla shook her head with reluctance. “Victor, what do you know about deities? How do we function?”

“You triumph at Valhalla and gain phenomenal cosmic powers?”

“True, yet far from the whole picture,” Camilla replied. “When we proved ourselves in Valhalla, we won our hundredth level: that of the supreme [Deity] class. Among many, *many* benefits, it upgrades our mortal classes and perks into divine variants. I, for example, have thirty levels in [Ascended Necromancer], and ten levels in [Ascended Plague Doctor].”

“Ah, and that’s what determines your portfolio as a deity?” Victor guessed. “Shesha must have been a capped [Merchant], and you a [Necromancer].”

“But that also means that our cosmic powers, while vast, are bound by our choice of classes, and we cannot change them after apotheosis. Thanks to a divine Perk, Shesha can buy *anything*, even a new life, if mortals pay her enough money by the System’s standards.”

“Of course, I take a twenty percent cut,” the goddess of commerce said. “I cannot let a crisis get in the way of my profits.”

“Since I never had levels in classes that could allow true resurrection, I can only revive my followers as undead beings,” Camilla said with sadness. “As far as I know, outside of Shesha, only Sablar and Dice could fully revive you, each through a different method.”

“While you... you can revive me, but only as an undead?”

“As the goddess of death, I can do so indeed,” Camilla said. “But I would prefer you to return to full life.”

Huh? Victor too, since he liked being alive, but why was the goddess of necromancy opposed to him becoming an undead? Because she wanted him to become one on his own?

“If you are destroyed as an undead, you will have no more do-overs,” Camilla explained. “Unless you take levels in the [Lich] or [Dracolich] class, and you do not meet the requirements for either. Considering your propensity for getting yourself killed...”

“It’s just my third time!” Victor complained but realized that she had a point. Becoming a fiend could perhaps help, but he would rather avoid becoming hellbound for the rest of his existence.

“I cannot proceed with the revival without your consent,” Shesha said. “The choice is yours.”

“Doesn’t my *Claimed by Shesha* Perk grant a discount?”

“Yes, and I already applied it.” Damn. “Out of curiosity, who killed you so thoroughly this time?”

“Akhenapep, Sablar’s prophet.”

“Him *again*?!” To Victor’s surprise, the greedy goddess’ serene face transformed into pure fury. “He is alive?”

“I wouldn’t say *alive*, but yes, he still exists. You know him?”

“That wicked *bastard* ruined my entire resurrection business!” Shesha loudly complained, her divine voice making the walls tremble. “Once, heroes paid me *mountains* of gold each year to raise their own, until he designed his cursed Vizier Stratagem list and shared it with every would-be overlord in the world! At the apex of its popularity, no villain left a body behind to raise within an adventurer party’s budget!”

Camilla made discreet sign language sentences to Victor while Shesha kept ranting. *'Don't tell her we have a course based on his teachings at Scholomance,'* the cup interpreted it.

“In spite of my best efforts to obscure that fact, elite criminals now either destroy the bodies or seal the souls of their victims, to deny me my rightful market share!” Shesha kept going on, completely oblivious to her fellows. The more she spoke, the more she reminded Victor of a demon marketer. “Now villains who simply leave corpses behind like this Mell Odieuse can be counted on one hand! Has Vainqueur destroyed that wicked one for good?”

“I... I dunno, maybe?” Victor replied, disturbed by the fire in the goddess' eyes.

“If he has, I will make him a [Saint],” Shesha declared. “With a lifetime reduction card.”

Since the goddess had finally calmed down, Victor pondered his own case. While he wanted to return to life, the cost of raising both Allison and himself would economically cripple Murmurin, at a time when it needed every resource available.

“Revive Allison alone,” Victor decided.

“Are you sure?” Camilla asked him. “Do you want me to raise you as an undead? Or return to Happyland?”

“Give me time before either,” Grail-kun replied. “With my soul anchored to that cup and my existing resources, I'm sure I can figure out a way to revive myself. Even if nobody's found out a way before!”

“That's the entrepreneurial spirit.” Shesha appreciated his resolve. “When the existing offers aren't satisfactory, innovate and conquer the market.”

“To motivate you further, if you manage to revive yourself without divine help, I will grant you a present.” Camilla winked at him.

“Oh? What kind of—”

“MINION!”

Before Victor knew what hit him, his cup body teleported all the way from Kukulcan to the ruins of El Dorado, right before a furious dragon.

“Minion!” Vainqueur glared at the [Black Grail], “How dare you refuse to work? After I invested so much in you?!”

“Your Majesty, I swear I did it to save you money! I can raise myself at a cheaper cost!”

“You better!” Vainqueur complained, a bit calmer than before. Victor noticed that he had grown much fatter, his belly full; had the dragon feasted on cattle while he partied in Happyland?

Thankfully, as he had expected, the group had managed to defeat Akhenapep, turning El Dorado from a pile of golden rubble, to a pile of stone rubble. Chocolatine and Felix had recovered, alongside Furibon’s explorer buddies. Kia was busy praying next to him, while he noticed Jolie and the Kobold Rangers tending to a giant dinosaur in the background.

The cup almost asked where the locals had gone, before marking a short pause. “Wait, you can understand me?”

“I adapted your soul frequency so it works as telepathy.” Furibon glanced down at Victor, holding his scythe in his hands. “That was how I could communicate with Lady Maure while trapped in your scythe, during your first visit to Happyland.”

“Huh? Thanks.”

“I only did it because the dragon would not stop pestering me, not because I care,” Furibon shrugged with a tsun-tsun skull face.

“Do not believe for a single second that it makes us even, lich.” The two nemeses glared at one another, Victor almost seeing the lightning between their eyes.

“Finally, manling, you have taken a form befitting of your station.” Felix the cat licked his whiskers, while Vainqueur was too busy glaring at his enemy to pay attention. “You have become the perfect litter box.”

“No!” Victor complained, but the cat already started climbing him. “Somebody save me! Help!”

“Felix, bad cat!” Chocolatine quickly grabbed Grail-kun and kept her close to her chest, far away from the feline’s vicious attention. Victor would have found the situation comfortable, could he feel anything.

“So, Vic, I only ask the goddess Shesha to revive Allison?” Kia briefly interrupted her prayers. “I can only cast [Contact Deity] so many times.”

“Yes, I will figure out a cheaper way to revive myself, and as they say, ladies first,” Victor replied.

“You better. I would be loath to adventure with a crippled party.”

Victor paused. “What?”

“No way I’m letting you go anymore, your party always gets the best fights,” Kia declared with an air of finality. “I have also come across highly sensitive information that we need to discuss.”

“Me too. It’s about the fomors, isn’t it?”

The [Paladin] nodded. “You remember the adventurers who ambushed both our teams?”

“Those with the rifles and Earth weapons? A fomor was among those who attacked us in the Winter Kingdoms.”

“I wondered where they got all their advanced weapons, and I believe I do now.”

“Yes, yes, we will deal with the fairies in due time,” Vainqueur interrupted the discussion. “Now get on with the resurrection, minion, and end my wallet’s silent agony.”

“It’s a shame we don’t have remains of your body, Vic,” Kia sighed.

“I kept a strand of your hair,” Chocolatine purred to Victor. “Would that be enough?”

“... why did you keep my hair?” Victor asked.

“To sniff them in your absence, of course!”

He cupwalked right into that one.

“Hair could have served as a [Phylactery] or a [Torc of Soul Vestment], but not a full resurrection,” Furibon replied. “Could you not leave a bone behind for safekeeping?”

How could Victor know Akhenapep would vaporize his body? Even Wotan’s Valkyries had settled on molesting it instead.

Besides his allies, with his Perks negated, he could only call upon the [Black Grail]’s abilities. The Vizier could use the black blood to restore an [Arisen] and perhaps transfer his soul within, but he would only count as an undead.

Victor had designed the [Black Grail] to restore a person’s body, no matter the damage, by spraying it with magically transformed black blood. It could restructure flesh, even only for the purpose of creating undead.

Yet... yet if he used the [Black Grail] to coalesce its prepared blood into the shape of a body, using a DNA strand as a template...

Intelligence check successful!

Yes, that was it! “Choc, can you throw my hair inside my cup, and add a *lot* of fresh blood?”

Millions of gold coins!

Million of gold coins from his castle’s gold reserves, thrown down the drain to revive *one* minion and not even his best one at that! If Vainqueur hadn’t

been generous, fair-minded, and a perfect paragon of wealth, he would have rampaged afterward.

Yet the dragon managed to keep his self-control, as the vile Shesha answered Knight Kia's silent prayers. Untasty Allison's body reformed in a flash of green light right in front of the [Paladin], completely restored.

"I am... I am alive again?" she asked, surprised that her minion deathcare covered destruction through disintegration. "I can't believe it..."

"You better change your tune, because you are indebted to me for the next..." Vainqueur caught his breath. "Four thousand, five hundred, and ten years! Which is the time it will take to reimburse that cursed goddess' resurrection fee! I expect you to work for *free* until you fully pay back my *due*!"

"As usual," the dryad replied with a strange tone but wisely bowed before her emperor. "I am... I am very thankful for Your Majesty's decision. I thought you would only ever raise Vic."

"You may be a lowly minion, but you died in the line of duty, to save the honor of gold itself," Vainqueur replied. "I would be an inconsiderate master if I did not recognize your extraordinary service."

Over time, the dragon had come to recognize that minions should not be thrown away casually. They had feelings of their own, and more importantly, they fueled the hoard's growth more alive than dead. Vainqueur's fortune had increased exponentially as his minion count did, ergo, both sustained one another.

"Now, go make me some money and help my chief of staff," the dragon dismissed her. Leaving Cup Victor to his cheaper revival attempt, Vainqueur had asked his minions to gather today's loot in one place—from the battle and what he recovered from eating all the local inhabitants—so he could personally claim it all for himself.

He refused to give an inch to Furibon, not even after their short-lived alliance. The second his chief of staff would return from the dead, he would

send that lich to the crypt from whence it came...

“Uncle, Uncle!” Jolie brought him a shy, intimidated elven maiden.

“Look!”

Vainqueur’s [Virgin Princess Radar] bleeped at the sight. “Jolie, is that what I think it is?”

“Yes!” The young dragon boasted proudly. “I caught my first princess, all on my own!”

“Congratulations!” If Vainqueur were a weak, soft-hearted manling, he would have cried of joy. Instead, he nuzzled his niece kindly. “I am so proud of you, to catch a princess at your age! I cannot wait to tell Genialissime!”

“Stop Uncle, you’re embarrassing me,” Jolie weakly protested, as her uncle showered her with affection.

“Did I hear *princess*?”

Vainqueur and his niece looked, as the shadow of a third dragon circling above the pile of loot, before making a dignified landing right next to it.

The red dragon instantly recognized the gold statue from El Dorado’s main square, brought back to life after the curse ended. The great, famous princessnapper hadn’t much changed since the emperor’s childhood, although he had grown bigger; even more than Vainqueur himself, by a head and a half. The lightning dragon’s blue scales were marred with scars, and a row of metallic horns formed a beard-like decoration around his head. His azure eyes crackled with lightning.

“G-Grandrake?” Jolie’s tail wagged in giddiness, at the sight of the draconic legend.

“Ay ay,” the old dragon said. “It is I, Grandrake. I came to this El Dorado looking for golden princesses, and that is all I remember.”

“A wicked villain put this area under a curse of false gold,” Vainqueur said, still furious over that fiasco. “I had to lift it.”

“That voice... is that you, young Vainqueur?” The older dragon looked at his crimson fellow with impressed eyes. “My, last time I saw you, you were but a wyrmling! How much you have grown, almost as big as me!”

“Indeed, great Grandrake, I am now the strongest and richest dragon in the world,” Vainqueur boasted, while Jolie gazed at the princess hunter with awe. Her uncle nuzzled her to approach the dragon legend. “This is my adorable niece, Jolie, who just captured her first princess!”

“An elf princess?” Grandrake examined the shy elf, who took refuge behind her dragon catcher. “And a pure-blooded one at that! Not one of these human-elf mongrels. I see that you have an eye for quality, even at your young age, young Jolie. Elf princesses are canny, and are rarely found in the wild! She reminds me of that one I caught in the Sablaris Empire...”

“We found that one and your princess hoard, almost all of them rabid from isolation,” Vainqueur pointed out, “I will have our family's veterinarian, Genialissime, domesticate them back into princess society.”

“That one? That was my first hoard... or maybe my second? I keep losing them since that fairy-blooded wizard cast his spell on me.”

“Is this Grandrake? The *Princessnapper*?” Knight Kia casually approached the dragon group like the uppity minion she was. “I heard they ask princesses to disguise as men in the Winter Kingdoms, to prevent you from claiming them.”

Grandrake frowned. “What did that manling say?”

“He cannot hear Kia?” Jolie asked her uncle.

“Ah, yes, Grandrake has grown deaf in his old age,” Vainqueur told Jolie. “But only to poor people.”

“So wyrmlike,” Jolie said, impressed by Grandrake’s dragonliness.

“That’s degrading!” Knight Kia complained.

“What did the little homeless manling say?” Grandrake asked.

“That you were too wealthy for her,” Vainqueur taunted the [Paladin].

“That is true indeed!” Grandrake said with an utmost expression of dragon snobbery. “I have lost more wealth than you will ever earn!”

“Please, can you tell me about one of your *Princess Hunter* adventures?” Jolie begged the elder dragon. “My uncle Genialissime always read me one when I was a wyrmling!”

“Ohoh, with pleasure! What about the time I caught a *Mermaid Princess*?” Jolie listened with rapturous focus, ignoring Kia sulking next to her. “After hunting the Crocodile Princess in the jungle of Scirocco, I looked for a challenge in the eastern sea. I knew she would be a most difficult animal to catch, for the Mermaid Princess is shifty. Do you know that they can stay seven days and nights underwater, without having to breathe at the surface?”

“Seven days?” Both Vainqueur and Jolie repeated at once, amazed.

“Seven days and they only need five minutes of breathing before repeating the cycle! I knew that if I wanted to catch her, I needed to pursue the Mermaid Princess until she had no choice but to return to the surface. For seven days and nights, I chased her across the eastern sea, never sleeping, never giving her a respite. The beast, cunning as she was, led me to the Great Barrier Reef, where her kind created a coral colony; the same place where I felled a leviathan in my youth. I knew the creature could camouflage among coral, and perhaps, she intended to use her own fellow mermaids as a decoy while she slipped away. But a true Princess Hunter always prepares. To catch a princess, you must *think* like a princess.”

Jolie inhaled. “What did you do? What did you do?”

“I laid a *trap*,” Grandrake boasted. “I let the animal believe that she had lost me, and then—”

“AAARGH!”

The dragons turned at the source of the scream, facing a most horrible sight.

A stillborn abomination of bones, flesh, and chicken dragon wings laid on the ground, covered in black blood. “Oh gods...” Cup Victor panted, like Jolie’s mother when she laid her eggs. “Oh gods, trying again!”

Every minion onlooker except Chocolatine—who looked at the spectacle with hunger—took a step back in horror, as a half-formed hand rose from the black blood spilling from the cup.

Vainqueur immediately understood the situation.

“My chief of staff is giving birth and just miscarried! Stop shaming him!” The dragon ordered his horrified minions, before looking at the screaming cup with sympathy. “Do the honorable thing, and support him in embarrassing silence!”

So they did, patiently waiting as Cup Victor kept screaming.

Chapter 97: The Dragon's Share

In the end, Cupling Victor miscarried six times.

With each attempt, the newborn's quality improved, from half-formed insults to dragons, to a perfect copy of Manling Victor without the skin. The grail kept wailing, surrounded by an enormous pool of blood and corpses, while everyone else watched him in silence. None dared to speak up.

As the grail produced a bubble of blood, Tasty Malfy joined the party, stepping through an infernal portal. "What did I miss?" The fiend noticed the cup and the lake of blood, his mood improving noticeably. "Is that... is that what I think it is?"

"My minion is giving birth." Vainqueur wondered if he had misunderstood the minion biological cycle. "To himself."

"A satanic resurrection!" Malfy raised his pincers. "I never saw one before! Mr. Victor, you can do it!"

"Minions, stop saying nonsense," Vainqueur said, glancing at Indebted Allison. "You, help my chief of staff carry the body to term!"

"How, Your Majesty?" The dryad dared to talk back, Vainqueur blaming her stressful debt rather than lack of minion education. "Putting my hands in the blood?"

"Do not speak, minion! *Do!*"

"Do *what?*"

"The *thing!*"

“The body...” Victor the cup screamed, as the blood bubble became bigger than a house. “The body is coming!”

“I hope it’s a girl!” Jolie said with giddy joy.

“I hope it’s a princess!” Grandrake added.

“I’m going to vomit,” Knight Kia said, showing a complete lack of support for Cupling Victor’s suffering.

Finally, the bubble exploded, releasing Manling Victor back into the world with a flood of blood.

The body washed up on the pavement, groaning all the way while the cup turned inanimate. Vainqueur glanced at the newborn, and to his pleasure, the seventh time had been the charm. No more mismatched wings, no more mismatched organs, and no more snakes for fingers.

“Oh BLEEP,” Manling Victor said, as Sweet Chocolatine and Untasty Allison helped him get back to his feet. “Oh BLEEP that *sucked*.”

“But it was cheap,” Vainqueur declared, proud of his Vizier saving him money.

“I think my liver is in the wrong place,” Manling Victor complained, Knight Kia casting healing spells on him. “It felt worse than King Wotan’s lightning.”

“Wotan?” Grandrake scratched the back of his head. “That name sounds familiar.”

“A lightning fairy that would not die,” Vainqueur reminded him, before dismissing him. “I buried him under a volcano.”

“Yes, that petulant fairy child!” Grandrake laughed as if reminiscing a funny joke. “I still remember him trying to get my attention by throwing lightning at me and take back my Fairy Princess. It was amusing for a while, but I had to gently poke him in the eye to make him stop.”

“Well, this was a complete waste of time,” Furibon said, backed up by his expedition’s members. “Now, can we decide what to do with the reward? I will take my leave and forget you all afterward.”

“The reward?” Vainqueur glared at the lich, before glancing at the enormous pile of loot left behind by the mummy and El Dorado’s locals. Everything there impressed him with its shininess, but he would need his chief of staff to identify the exact value with his [Eye for Treasure] Perk.

“Furi, is that the dragon you kept telling us about?” Vainqueur once more paid attention to Furibon, finding him backed up by a group of would-be minions. One elf, one orc, a ratkin, and a birdkin; they carried themselves with the confidence of experienced adventurers. “Vainqueur Knightsbane?”

“No, it is another dimwit dragon,” Furibon replied with heavy sarcasm, before calming himself. “It is him, unfortunately.”

“He’s so huge!” The ratkin looked up at Vainqueur with awe.

“Yes, it is I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, but you will call me Your Majesty,” the dragon declared with pride. “With a capital M. I can tell the difference.”

“How?” The elf frowned, before taking a step back as Vainqueur glared at her.

“What do these paupers say?” Grandrake asked.

“Nonsense I should expect from a lich’s lackeys,” Vainqueur said.

“Ah, a lich, is that what you are?” Grandrake nodded at Furibon, unaware of his depravity. “That reminds of that *Lich Princess* I caught in Tsaria, after a long chase through a winter storm. A remarkably proud and ancient creature she was, but alas, incapable of socializing. She kept killing my minions for no reason, due to undead rabies; I had to euthanize her.”

“There are dangerous princesses?” Jolie asked, eager to learn from the best.

“Of course, the world of princesses is full of wild predators... none worse than the Manling Princess. Beware *Manling Princesses*, young Jolie. For

out of all animals, they are the only ones who kill for money.”

“Yes, yes, can we split the loot now?” Furibon said hastily, consumed by greed. “We can divide it into three parts, one for each group that contributed to the battle.”

“Excellent idea!” Vainqueur replied, separating the hoard into three shares. The brightest, which included the dragon-sized ring, he took for himself.

“Jolie, here is yours.” To his beautiful niece, he granted a large share, including armor made of shining stones. The pure-hearted dragonling immediately jumped on her loot, as if it was her own hoard.

“And the third part,” Furibon threatened to take it, so Vainqueur immediately grabbed the loot for its own protection. “Is mine too, as the elder dragon’s share.”

“What?” The Goldslayer dared contest this fair sharing of resources. “This is theft!”

“Furi, don’t mouth off at the giant dragon...” his orc friend pleaded, while the lich remained full of hate.

“If you take it, you will turn it to lead!” Vainqueur glared at Furibon. “Never again will you touch a baby coin on my watch!”

“Turn it to lead?” Grandrake frowned.

“He is Furibon the Goldslayer, enemy of all hoards!” Jolie showed her excellent judgment, glaring at the lich. “He turned Uncle’s gold to lead with evil magic to hurt him!”

“Once!” Furibon replied as if it excused his loathsome crime. “Once!”

“Once too many!” Vainqueur replied.

“I do not understand you, young lich,” the elder dragon told Furibon. “With that kind of magical talent, you could have used your powers for the greater greed.”

“I turned a hoard to lead *once* in my entire existence!” The lich let out a scream of rage. “I have no interest in antagonizing you dragons anymore, and I have helped you loyally against Sablar’s chosen! Am I not entitled to a second chance?”

“It is true that you saved my Jolie from death and a costly resurrection,” Vainqueur granted him that. “But it does not even begin to make up for your crimes against dragonkind.”

“What will it take *then*?”

Vainqueur frowned at the undead. He had taken his protests as mere deception, but the more he listened, the more he doubted. Could Furibon truly desire to atone for his sins against him?

“You,” Vainqueur turned to the lich’s allies, who hide behind their undead master, “Why do you stand with the wicked one?”

The lich’s minions exchanged glances, until the elf mustered the courage to speak up. “Look, Your Majesty, I know Furibon is hard to live with sometimes. He is an undead abomination against nature, cranky, he has no sense of humor—”

“Your support warms my heart,” Furibon lied, since he had none.

“—but he is a good teammate.”

“He has been with us since the country of Barin put us on an exploration fleet,” the ratling added. “I can’t remember the number of times he saved us from monsters.”

“Yeah, he helped us map out the jungle so people can settle the frontier, and he never asked for anything in return!” the orc said. “I know there’s bad blood between you two, but... maybe you could... consider burying the hatchet?”

Vainqueur was confused. How would burying a weapon settle the matter?

Still, the lich's minions did not appear mentally controlled, or entranced by Furibon's vile power. Did they... did they genuinely like him? Had Vainqueur's nemesis truly turned away from his evil ways?

Jolie seemed confused. "Uncle, what do we do?" she asked. "He is evil, but my [Paladin] class asks that I give a chance at redemption to any villain who asks for it."

"I have already helped you," Furibon said. "What more proof do you need?"

"Well then, I have been under a tiresome curse, and I have been looking for a wizard capable of lifting it." Grandrake cleared his throat, ready to dispense wisdom. "Since I can hear you, that means you are wealthy enough by my minion standards."

The lich froze. "What is that supposed to mean?"

"You can repay your debt to dragonkind by assisting me in my princess hunts," Grandrake offered, leaving Vainqueur in awe of his boundless dragon generosity. Could the wyrm truly offer a second chance to that puny lich?

Even Furibon was left *floored* by this magnanimous offer. "Neve—"

"I am a dragon," Grandrake reminded the undead warlock with a paternal smile. "You are now my minion."

"Furi, maybe we should listen to that proposal," the lich's elf ally said. "It can't be that bad."

"Do you want to be a dragon's slave?" the lich insulted the ancient dragon institution.

"Minion!" Vainqueur defended the rightful dragon way. "Slaves do not have vacations!"

"I mean, we get paid for our work, right?" the lich's orc friend asked the difficult question.

“One one-tenth,” Grandrake answered with a kind nod.

“From what you told us about Victor Dalton, he ended up gaining sixty levels and untold riches in less than a year,” the orc explained his reasoning, “We get to explore the world with a dragon to protect us—”

“You are seriously doing this to me right now?” Furibon said, astonished.

“Do you refuse to reform the proper dragon way?” Vainqueur asked.

“I will not become a dragon’s servant like Dalton!” Furibon refused the offer for rehabilitation, bound by his evil ways.

“Then,” Vainqueur fearlessly expanded his wings. “There is only *one* way to settle our differences, lich.”

“Bring it,” Furibon replied, lightning crackling between the two rivals’ eyes.

Uh...

Ugh, Victor felt terrible.

Your soul has a new vessel. You regained use of your class and personal Perks, and your bond to your [**Black Grail**] and [**Scythe of Charon**] has grown stronger! Your type has been changed to [**Slime/Dragon**].

Permanent +6 VIT, -6 SKI and -6 AGI. You gain immunity to [Unholy] and Critical Hits, but you are now vulnerable to [Holy] and [Blood] effects.

You gained the [**Bloodborn**] monster Perk.

[**Bloodborn**]: You gain a +4 bonus for checks against physical stat debuffs, disease, paralysis, poison and hostile polymorph effects. Blood-draining and blood purification attacks inflict super effective damage against you.

... a slime. He counted as a slime. This day just kept getting better and better.

Oh, gods, Victor had become a humanoid mimic. Better not to mention that to anyone. He was clearly slower and had a harder time with limb coordination, probably due to his mind adapting to his new flesh. “That was horrible,” he stated. “I’m not doing it ever again.”

“We women do that for eight months instead of hours,” Allison teased him. “You got off lucky.”

“Stop comparing it to childbirth!” Victor replied angrily. “I’m not a male seahorse!”

“I’m sorry, you’re just too amusing,” the dryad said, her face turning sympathetic as she put a comforting hand on his shoulder. “Thanks for carrying on that burden for me, Vic. I will not forget it.”

“It’s fine, just make sure I don’t die a fourth time. I get the feeling it will be the last.”

Victor managed to hang on his feet, regaining enough motor control to stand up without help. Chocolatine gave him a towel to hide his fleshy part, while Kia handed him his scythe back. “Thanks,” he said, using his weapon as a cane. “I, uh, I need a shower.”

“Yes you do,” Kia pinched her nose with two fingers.

“And new armor, Mr. Victor,” Malfy said, patting him on the back, “With Happyland’s logo on your back.”

“About that, Kia, can you help me contact Miel?” Victor asked the [Paladin], “She won’t answer my telepathic calls.”

“Well, it’s weird because I haven’t been able to summon any angel since yesterday, not even during our battle with Akhenapep.” The knight glared at Malfy, as the demon chortled on his own laughter. “*What?*”

“I need to apologize for something,” Victor said. “Is there a way to enter Heaven? Except dying?”

“You can always walk there,” Kia shrugged. “We found a portal to the elemental planes, so there must be one for Heaven somewhere.”

“Like the one in the castle’s basement?” Chocolatine asked, Felix the cat jumping in her free arms. “How do angels taste?”

“Like fiends!” Malfy said, before rolling on the ground uncontrollably.

“That’s what I wanted to speak about,” Kia said, crossing her arms. “I have discovered that fomors created gates to various planes of existence across the world, which they used to catch slaves and bring them to Outremonde. The hellgate in Murmurin may be one among many more.”

Remembering her previous statements, Victor instantly guessed what weighed on the [Paladin]’s mind. “You think the fomors have access to at least one doorway to Earth, and that they smuggle weapons through it.”

Now that he thought of it, it made a lot of sense. His [Monster Insight] told him that Wotan had inspired the Odin legend, which implied he had visited Earth at least once in the past.

“I have considered the matter, and I now firmly believe the local humans descend from fomor captives, brought from Earth to Outremonde in ancient times,” Kia explained. “As were the elves, the dwarves, and many other species inhabiting this planet.”

“If they had access to Earth for so long, why didn’t they conquer it though?” Allison asked. “It’s not like our ancestors could have been a match for a monster like King Balaur.”

“Perhaps their powers are limited there,” Kia suggested. “Outside of reincarnating Claimed, even the gods have no influence on our world.”

“The fomors are born of raw, wild magic,” Allison considered the matter. “In all likelihood, on a plane devoid of it, they can only maintain their existence for a short while before needing to return home to 'recharge'.”

“Do any of you want to return home?” Chocolatine asked, her ears down. She dreaded the thought of her friends leaving her alone.

“No,” Allison replied with a sour face. “I have nothing to return to.”

Kia shook her head. “There is too much to do here.”

“Same, besides informing my family I am still alive,” Victor replied. “I agree with Kia. If the fomors have a gate to earth, they aren’t only threatening our world, but Earth as well. Now that they can level up, they are even more dangerous.”

“Level up?” Kia asked.

“Fomors can level up now,” Chocolatine said. “I recognized some of Wotan’s Perks as those of the [Stormlord] and [Kaiser] classes.”

“I don’t know how, but they've gained souls of their own,” Victor said, Kia’s fists tightening. “Camilla and Shesha informed me the fomors are running Wild Hunts in Serica, for the purpose of grinding.”

“Since Outremonde is round, if we continue West, we should reach whatever version of Japan or Australia this world has.” Kia hit her left palm with her right fist, clearly ready to take names. “I say we hit them hard while they remain vulnerable.”

“Agreed.” Victor nodded. “If they widen the level gap, they may become... huh?”

For the first time since the beginning of the discussion, he noticed Sigrun’s shade in the background. It had always been there while he remained in Grail-kun form, but... she should have vanished now that he had a body of his own.

“What are you doing here?” Victor asked the naked shade. The Valkyrie just glared at him.

“Vic?” Chocolatine asked. “Vic, who are you talking to?”

“I think I see dead henchmen now...”

Chapter 98: Scaled Woes

The more he thought of Furibon, the more it vexed Vainqueur.

The dragon knew, deep within his bones, that the lich was the secret mastermind behind everything wrong in his life. The planet Moon could never have turned to lead on its own, and Wotan would not have assaulted V&V, had Vainqueur remained safe at home instead of chasing the lich. Ergo, all the lich's protestations of innocence didn't add up.

This was just a trick! Yes, a trick to avoid his just punishment!

But then... why did he accept Vainqueur's challenge, to settle their war once and for all? Why did adventurers come to defend him out of their own free will? Why did they call him their teammate, with the same care Manling Victor showed to his master?

Could he... could he have *friends*?

Of course not! Furibon couldn't have friends, or else he wouldn't be Furibon!

And yet...

"A class system you say?" Grandrake frowned at Jolie. "Is it anything like that *cultivation* Jade keeps prattling on about?"

"The System is no scam!" Jolie defended her livelihood. "It grants power over life and death, gold and lead! Even wizardry!"

Grandrake tried to access the System, blinking repeatedly. "[Princess Hunter]?" he said, having tapped into the ancient power of dragonkind.

“What a strange device... this must certainly be ancient dragon magic, but I never heard of anything like this before. Odd, very odd.”

“Dragons can do magic on their own?” Jolie asked, her eyes glittering with curiosity.

“Jolie, who else but dragons could invent something so advanced?” Vainqueur replied, before making a joke. “*Manlings?*”

Grandrake exploded into laughter, before answering Jolie’s question. “Our Elder Wyrms progenitor and the first generations of dragons used magic to grant souls to the first minions, or so the tales said. But since they were already perfect and invincible without it, our ancestors never bothered to train new generations in sorcery. Instead, we focused on what truly mattered: getting richer!”

“This only confirms what I always thought,” Vainqueur replied proudly. “That this ancient System was created by dragons, for dragons.”

“Indeed, although it is vexing that minions rediscovered it first,” Grandrake replied. “Maybe I will study it in-depth after I have my soon-to-be minion Furibon lift my curse of forgetfulness.”

“You do not need the lich for that!” Vainqueur protested. “I can lift it myself!”

“You can?” Grandrake asked.

Of course Vainqueur could! He hesitated to test his [Malleus Maleficarum], for that would hurt the older dragon. Better to try the simpler option. “[Spell Purge]!” Vainqueur’s magnificent power washed over Grandrake, lifting negative effects from the older dragon.

Or so he thought.

You could not lift Grandrake’s [**Grand Hex of the Forgetful Otaku**].

Once applied, curses of the [**Grand Hex**] series can only be lifted through the exit clause detailed in their original wording.

“Oh, a new message,” Grandrake said, receiving the same information as Vainqueur himself. “The original wording? Damnation, I did not pay attention at the time.”

“A wizard minion can certainly find back the original wording and the weakness in it,” Vainqueur suggested. “I will have my Vizier call his lawyers.”

“Lawyers? Are they a kind of wizards?” At Vainqueur’s confirmation, Grandrake thanked the younger dragon with a nod. “I am grateful.”

“Thank nothing of it,” the emperor replied. “I would never have become such a skilled princess hunter without your stories and example.”

“Ah, seeing young lads like you and your niece invigorates me,” Grandrake raised his head proudly. “I feel the urge to hunt in my very bones.”

“Oh, can you teach me?” Jolie begged the older dragon. “Prettyplease!”

“You wish to learn the ways of the true princess hunter, young Jolie?” Grandrake observed Vainqueur’s niece with a fresh gaze. “Do you have what it takes? The path of the princess hunter is long and arduous. One must be patient, curious, refined!”

Jolie nodded harder than ever, in awe of the ancient wyrm’s wisdom. “I want to be the greatest princess defender there ever was! I will protect them from orcs and any villain who seeks to harm them!”

“My Jolie is environmentally conscious,” Vainqueur defended his niece with great pride. “She is mindful of the wildlife.”

The young dragon’s eagerness to learn pleased Grandrake’s vanity. “If you wish to discover new species of princesses and protect them like a true *Connoisseur*, then I will gladly teach you the ropes.”

The niece immediately let out a squeal of happiness.

Vainqueur let his niece and Grandrake exchange on how to protect princesses from poachers, before noticing his chief of staff and Knight Kia

approaching him. “Your Majesty, we need to discuss a very important matter,” Friend Victor said.

“No time to waste on words, my manling,” Vainqueur replied firmly. “We must go.”

“Go where?”

“Train!” Vainqueur said, glaring at the lich discussing something with his 'teammates.' “Furibon and I will soon settle our grudge once and for all, and we must prepare accordingly.”

“You’re going to *battle*?” Kia asked, eager for bloodshed.

“Yes.” Vainqueur glanced down dramatically at his chief of staff, to better impress on him the gravity of the situation. “With cards.”

His manling remained silent for a moment, before exchanging a glance with Knight Kia, who shrugged her shoulders. “You are going to settle your entire rivalry with an ancient lich sorcerer over a *card game*?”

“Not any card game,” Vainqueur corrected his minion. “The only civilized card game worth gambling the future over! Monster Poker!”

His manling put a hand on his face, worried for his master, while Knight Kia blinked repeatedly.

“I too was skeptical, when the orcs introduced me to this game,” Vainqueur declared, remembering his battles fondly. “But then, as I kept winning, it began to fascinate me. Instant winning hands, deck out, destruction of the enemy... so many ways to crush those who defy me! I never experienced a game like that, where I simply gain money with no cost, nor any risk of defeat! It is a self-perpetuating loop, minion! I win, I raise, I win more, I raise more!”

“But...” Manling Victor choked. “Furibon *accepted*?”

“Yes, because Monster Poker is a card game, with a heart,” the dragon said with wisdom. “Even the lich cannot resist its lure. You would understand if

you were a true *duelist*.”

He didn’t.

“Since my fingers are too big to wield cards, I will need your power, minion,” Vainqueur explained. “For Furibon is no easy prey. We will go west, to uncharted seas, so that we may gather the strongest rare cards, build the most powerful deck in the world, and perfect the art of the winning draw. Once I have defeated the lich, he will atone for his crimes by following the path of minionship.”

“*If* you win, wyvern.”

The trio turned to Furibon, whose voice resonated with evil bitterness.

“For if Iwin, not only will you leave me alone at long last,” the lich said, his teeth morphing somehow into a sickening grin. “But I will take a *heavy* tribute in retribution.”

“Can’t you simply talk it out and become friends?” Manling Victor offered, too idealistic.

“Never!” Both the dragon and lich snarled at the same time, the manling sighing.

“I cannot let him get away with his crimes!” Vainqueur insisted, glaring at his forsworn enemy.

“What crimes?” The lich protested. “Have I not done enough good?”

“I am the first to say one alliance doesn’t wash away a lifetime of service to Brandon Maure’s regime,” Knight Kia spoke up. “But everyone deserves a second chance if they’re willing to take it. I can always execute him when he screws up.”

“My victory will prove your culpability,” Vainqueur said. “Name the battleground, and I will meet you there.”

“A new landmass appeared in the western sea, surrounded by strange waters,” Furibon declared, pointing a bony finger at Vainqueur. “A suitable stage for our final battle.”

“Here or in the very heavens, you shall never succeed!” Vainqueur roared. “Three days, Furibon! We shall duel in three days at noon! Show up, or suffer my wrath!”

“I cannot wait to get rid of you forever, wyrm!” Furibon said, before teleporting out with his team. “Three days!”

Vainqueur turned to Manling Victor. “See?”

“Is this truly a priority, Your Majesty?” His chief of staff spoke nonsense. “I have information that the fomors are up to no good in the west.”

“The fairies will be dealt with in time, but Furibon remains the greatest threat, and I shall not rest until he is finally defeated,” Vainqueur replied.

“Vic, since we are moving west in any case, we can deal with it on the way to the Serica continent,” Knight Kia said.

“We?” Vainqueur repeated, glaring at that uninvited guest.

“I would like to join your party if that’s okay with Your Majesty,” the knight said. “Jolie has grown to level 30, and the Kobold Rangers have broken past it. They have become very strong, but not enough to confront the fomors.”

Vainqueur almost told that unworthy excuse of a minion off, before realizing that he could separate her from Jolie for a long period of time. Without that Paladin’s nefarious influence, Grandrake could certainly bring his niece back onto the proper dragon path; and the older wyrm would defend her better than this wicked [Paladin].

“I shall allow you to serve me in the fights to come, manling,” the dragon declared with false magnanimity. “Should my niece allow it.”

“Great!” Knight Kia smiled. “I will talk it out with Jolie and be right back.”

“Yes, yes,” Vainqueur dismissed her, before turning to his chief of staff. “Now, my Vizier, I need you to check the value of my new treasures. Especially what I can wear.”

His minion looked into the pile of items, immediately identifying the dragon-sized ring among them; a beautiful golden circle of interwoven worms and dragons eating their own tails.

“Wow, that’s... that’s a powerful [Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh]!” Manling Victor marveled at the item's shininess. “I’ve never seen something so overpowered. +10 to Luck, immunity to hostile [Earth] effects, *and* it can reflexively cast [Hasten], [Protection from Elements], [Greater Dispel Magic], or [Cure Any Ailment] on the wearer once per day, depending on the situation. Cannot be worn by non-[Dragon] types though.”

“As it should.” Vainqueur put it around his finger, fitting it perfectly, “I still want my blinkblink ring back. You will ask Troll Barnabas to fashion me one.”

“Let’s see... no armor for me... ah!” Manling Victor raised a shining, rainbowlike jewel from the pile. “Here is something for Your Majesty as well. A [Psi-stone].”

“Psiwhat?”

“A [Psi-stone]. Can Your Majesty lower their head?” Vainqueur followed the proposal, lowering his head to the ground. His minion slammed the item between his master’s horns, the dragon sensing the stone melding with his scales.

You have been psi-bonded to a [**Psi-stone of Mind-Shielding**]. You are now immune to [**Mind-affecting**] effects so long as the stone remains intact.

“[Psi-stones] are items that you can equip to your brain and spine, providing psychic powers to the wearer,” Manling Victor explained. “If you have more than one, they create additional effects.”

“Gems that can be worn forever as armor?” This was a dragon’s dream come true.

“Nothing for me in the pile, unfortunately,” Manling Victor complained. “And the [Black Grail] will return to the Thaoten for safekeeping. A shame.”

“You will have other opportunities to equip yourself, minion,” Vainqueur reassured him, glancing at the horizon; he already wondered what he would receive after beating Furibon once and for all.

The next day, after a great feast, Vainqueur decided to leave at dawn. He gathered his minions and allies in the city’s devastated plaza, to give a speech; Manling Victor had finally found clothes made of some furred beast's skin.

“Minions, El Dorado is mine, by right of conquest. This city shall be rebuilt... but as it should be. A city of true gold, fueled by my own empire’s bottomless wealth. While Manling Victor and I,” Vainqueur purposefully snubbed Knight Kia, whom no one liked anyway, “go on to end the threat of Furibon once and for all, you shall rebuild this place, as the second imperial colony of...”

Vainqueur let a few seconds pass, before uttering the name he had worked on for the entire night.

“El Goldorado!”

Of course, everyone applauded, some more than others... and not enough for Vainqueur’s taste. The dragon kindly encouraged his minions to renew in their devotion by raising his hand, until the clapping became acceptable.

“Thank you, thank you,” Vainqueur said. “You are too kind.”

“I will make my new lair there,” Grandrake said, his new apprentice Jolie at his side. “Long have I considered to open a princess wildlife refuge, and this jungle seems the perfect place for it.”

“Everyone working together to build a new place.” Chocolatine had tears in her eyes. “It’s like Murmurin’s old days.”

“We have to do even better.” Allison nodded.

“When you get back, I will prepare you a new recipe,” Chocolatine chirped to Manling Victor.

“I shall delightfully indulge in it,” Felix said with feline pride.

“Oh, it cannot be done without you,” Chocolatine reassured the cat, petting him between the ears. “You will be the guest of honor.”

“I will have new armor made for you, Mr. Victor, within the coming days,” Malfy told the Vizier. “One worthy of a Happyland hero.”

“Thanks, I will summon you back in a few days.”

“Now, it is time to leave,” Vainqueur declared, wishing to be early for his final showdown with the lich.

“See you soon, Kia!” Jolie told her chief of staff, as she summoned her griffin to ride.

“I can finally test that new mount,” Manling Victor said, raising his scythe. “[Zmey Rider].”

Zmey?

Vainqueur didn’t have the time to question his minion, as the bright skies turned dark, rain falling without warning. For a moment, he wondered if Wotan had returned, only to realize that it was something far, *far* worse.

The beast flew through the clouds, smashing one of the few pyramids left standing on its way down, and landed among the minions, blowing off most of them in all directions. Knight Kia immediately readied her sword, while the dragons present reeled in horror.

A *Zmey* had come.

An inbred, primitive cousin of true dragons, this particular Zmey was big for its kind, roughly fifteen feet in length. The green-skinned beast had batlike wings and four legs barely carrying its bulky body, and its three heads resembled serpents instead of lizardy elegance. All in all, the creature looked like a twisted parody of dragonkind.

“Gorynych is there, master!” the beast looked at Manling Victor with stupid yellow eyes, speaking with his three heads at once. “Gorynych avoided all the traffic!”

Grandrake looked at the creature with pure disgust, with even the kind Jolie being uncomfortable in its presence. “Minion, what is that *thing*?” Vainqueur asked disdainfully, as Knight Kia lowered her sword.

“Gorynych is a good Zmey!” the inbred wyvern replied, wagging his tail. “Oh yes!”

By the Elder Wurm, the creature looked at Vainqueur now. The dragon turned his head, to better deny that vermin’s very existence. “Minion, send that thing away and use your horse.”

“I can’t, I registered Chocolatine,” his chief of staff replied. Worse, he seemed mesmerized by the creature, as if he commanded a genuine dragon. “Besides, my horse cannot fly across the ocean.”

“But you can!” Vainqueur dared glimpse at the Zmey, whose three tongues laid down like a dog. The creature’s mere presence diminished the glorious reputation of true dragons. “You do not need it!”

“Gorynych is not loved?” The creature crumbled on himself, devastated. “Gorynych is sad.”

“You are of dragonkind, show dominance!” Vainqueur lambasted the creature, before instantly regretting it. To acknowledge it as a scion of the dragon family made the emperor sick.

“Your Majesty, that’s uncalled for!” To Vainqueur’s astonishment, Manling Victor came to the creature’s defense... and he wasn’t the only one.

“Poor beast...” Allison whispered.

“Your Majesty, look at him, he’s a giant scaled puppy!” Sweet Chocolate said, immediately comforting the Zmey. “You’re making him cry!”

What? They favored that abomination over their lord and master?

“Betrayal! *Betrayal!*” Vainqueur looked at Grandrake, pleading for support.

The older dragon had completely turned his back on the scene, denying the Zmey’s existence like a true wyrm. Jolie hesitated between supporting her uncle’s point of view, and imitating the princess hunter.

“It’s fine, Gorynych,” Manling Victor comforted the beast. “His Majesty is just a bit surprised by your arrival. He didn’t really mean it.”

“I did!” Vainqueur protested, leaving the Zmey crestfallen and his servants glaring at their master. “Minions, are you shaming *me*? *Me*?”

The silence became oppressive. The emperor tried to stand his ground, but he could feel the invisible, unspoken social pressure weight on him. He almost turned away, unable to stand the silent, judgmental gazes of his own minions.

“Zmey eat their own feces!” Vainqueur reminded the minions.

“Your Majesty, I hate to say it,” Tasty Malfy cleared his throat, “But you sound... politically incorrect.”

Politically incorrect? He was the emperor, his will was the politically correct choice! Why this reaction?

... feelings.

Yes, Vainqueur remembered that minions had feelings that didn’t revolve around their master. Maybe seeing the Zmey hurt awoke a feeling of minion solidarity among them. *Do not alienate your minions or they will run away while you sleep*, Vainqueur reminded himself.

In the end, Vainqueur handled the matter the true dragon way.

By turning his back on the Zmey, and snubbing him.

“... Your Majesty, are you going to pretend he does not exist?” Manling Victor asked.

“Yes!”

Certainly, if Vainqueur ignored him hard enough, the Zmey would go away.

“His Majesty will get used to you.” Vainqueur subtly peeked over his shoulder, watching Manling Victor lying to the Zmey.

“Is that a stick?” the three heads of Gorynych looked at the Vizier’s scythe with attention. “Gorynych good with sticks, master! Like dogs!”

This was going to be a *long* trip.

Chapter 99: Dice Island

Riding a dragon across the ocean was *awesome*.

“Is master liking Gorynych’s back?” the zmey asked, eager to please like a good dog. Vainqueur led the group, while Kia flew on her own griffin nearby.

“It’s a bit rocky, but I will get used to it,” Victor replied. In retrospect, his [Monster Rider] perk synergized extremely well with his [Chaos Rider] and [Weathermaker] classes. “I just wish you didn’t bring rain everywhere though.”

The zmey couldn’t help but summon rain around him, making the trip very uncomfortable. At best, he managed to make it a faint drizzle instead of a heavy downpour. It bothered Victor as much as Sigrun’s ghost glaring at him in silence.

“Gorynych can change it to [Hailstorm] or [Thunderstorm] if master wishes it!”

“Minion, do not enjoy this!” Vainqueur complained. “To ride on the back of a dragon is contrary to the spirit of minionship!”

The zmey tilted his three heads in giddiness. “Big V recognized Gorynych as a dragon!”

“An inbred, poor excuse of a dragon!” Vainqueur loudly complained, while doing his best to ignore Victor’s mount. “Minion, I am sure his mother and his sister are the same!”

“My mother is my sister’s niece!” Gorynych defended himself.

“Hey, guys, is that normal?” Kia glanced at the waters below them. The sea had suddenly turned from blue to orange, the corpses of dead fish floating on the surface. The very smell had changed from algae to that of a cocktail bar.

“It looks like alcohol to me,” Victor said as he glanced down. Having seen much weirder things in Outremonde, it wouldn’t surprise him.

“Who cares?” Vainqueur replied, catching sight of an island in the middle of that strange sea. “I see our destination!”

Floating in the middle of that strange orange sea, the new island that would become the final battleground between Vainqueur and Furibon was small; smaller than Grandrake’s own private resort. Covered in green grass, it would have seemed almost unremarkable except for its location.

However, Victor noticed hundreds of head-like statues lined up on the shore.

It appeared that they had found Outremonde’s version of Easter Island.

The group landed on the shore while the sun began to set. “So, what do we do now?” Victor asked, climbing down from his zmey’s back. “We train for cards?”

“Now, I rest,” Vainqueur said, falling on the sand. “I burned tons of fat to reach this place.”

“Me too!” Gorynych rolled in the sand, laying on his back right next to Vainqueur. The bigger dragon instantly crawled farther, turning his back on the happy zmey with snobbish zeal. Kia simply let her griffin go hunt the dead fish in the orange sea, following Victor on foot as they approached the head statues.

They all represented the same guy: Victor himself.

Everywhere, he could see dozens and dozens, maybe hundreds, of statues with his face, each wearing a different hat.

Only one statue, in the middle of the main line, differed from the rest. Instead of a head, it represented a muscled, idealized version of Victor carrying the giant god Dice on his back. The scene reminded the Vizier of statues of the titan Atlas lifting the world on his shoulders.

The builders had engraved a sentence on that statue's pedestal.

"The rolling of the Dice."

"Wow, the resemblance is astonishing," Kia said, completely oblivious to the statue's true nature. "What a coincidence."

"Indeed," Victor deadpanned, realizing that they had landed on *his* island.

The Island... of *Daltonia*.

Or maybe *Dicetopia*? Since they were the first people to set foot on the island, Victor could give an amusing name.

"I BLEEPed up!"

... or maybe not the first.

Kia and Victor turned to the shore, noticing a strange mermaid sitting nearby while drinking away her sorrows. Unlike most members of her kind, she had a squid's tentacles for her lower body instead of a fishtail, and held a bottle with each of them; the upper part reminded the Vizier of a Japanese yakuza, with all the tattoos on her skin and only a bra for modesty.

"Are you okay?" Victor approached her, worried. She looked completely depressed.

"I screwed up!" The mermaid complained, completely drunk. "I screwed it up!"

"You too?" Victor asked, curious. "How?"

"I, I turned the sea into whiskey!"

“Whiskey?” Kia *immediately* moved to the sea to investigate.

Victor, meanwhile, comforted the mermaid by patting her on the back and sitting next to her. “Hey, it’s fine. I mean, I destroyed Heaven, which is *way* worse.” Thankfully, Kia was too far away to listen.

The mermaid handed him a bottle with one of her eight tentacles. “Do you want a drink to forget too?”

“Sure.”

“Guys, it’s really whiskey!” Kia shouted, having somehow summoned a bottle to gather as much of the precious liquid as she could.

“That would explain all the dead fish,” Victor noted out loud, sipping his drink.

“Yeah, I figure a whiskey sea sounds fun for us... but for the aquatic wildlife? It must be a very *hostile* environment.”

“I shouldn’t have!” the drunk mermaid kept ranting to Victor, having adopted him as her talking board, “I’m Seng! Goddess of the sea, dreams, adventure, and alcoholism! I shouldn’t have killed all these fishes!”

Just in case, the Vizier checked up on her with [Monster Insight].

Seng

Screwup Deity (Aquatic/Divine!)

Strengths and weaknesses: aim for the liver.

Sounds of crying

“How can you become a god of alcoholism?” Victor frowned.

“[Drunken Brawler] class,” she said, raising each tentacle. “With eight melee attacks.”

“Vic, please don’t encourage the drunk mermaid’s delusions,” Kia said absentmindedly, as she joined them.

The mermaid spat out her own alcohol. “Delusions?”

“Kia, that’s the actual goddess,” Victor pointed out.

The knight smiled at him as if he had said a particularly stupid joke. “Vic, honestly... does that shipwreck look like a goddess to you?”

The mermaid instantly began crying.

“I didn’t say that to be mean,” the [Paladin] tried to comfort the siren. “It’s just I have met three actual gods, and they looked much better.”

“You!” Seng crawled to Victor, “You know the truth! Defend me from this unbeliever!”

The Vizier opened his mouth until the situation dawned on him.

He was facing a red-drunk mermaid with a maddened look in her eyes, carrying bottles with each appendage, and who somehow turned the sea into whiskey.

“W-why are you looking at me like that?”

... yes, that *thing* was a *goddess*.

“Unfortunately, she really is the goddess Seng.”

“See, see!” Seng gloated to Kia, completely missing the *unfortunately* part.

“Look, I heard the rumors, Victor is very biased when it comes to pretty women,” the knight replied, the Vizier glaring at her. “It’s true! And telling that drunkard that she is the goddess Seng is blasphemous towards the real one!”

“S-screw you, paladin, I’m going back to my underwater palace!” The mermaid goddess fled to the sea, spewing insults and tears in equal

measure. “I’ll show you! One day, I’ll show you, and sink your entire BLEEPing country!”

Seng vanished into the whiskey waters, while the Vizier silently sipped his drink.

Did it never occur to her that she could simply claim him or Kia and prove her divinity?

His eyes moved to his drink. How strange. It tasted like a very, very strong vodka, the kind that should have made him roll over... yet he felt perfectly fine. He finished the whole bottle, forcing himself to ignore the disgusting taste, and waited.

Nothing.

“I have gained resistance to recreational drugs,” Victor realized, crestfallen. “Including alcohol.”

“So?” Kia asked.

“So I can’t get drunk anymore.” Even a goddess’ alcohol wasn’t enough.

“You can always drink it for the taste,” the [Paladin] replied with smugness, consuming her own bottle with delight.

“Nobody drinks whiskey for the taste!” Victor replied. “Alcohol tastes like shit, and we only pretend it doesn’t because we won’t admit that we only want to get drunk!”

This day couldn’t get any worse.

A portal in space opened right next to them, the Vizier glancing at it. He expected Malfy to step out, his new armor ready.

But it wasn’t a fiend.

“You two-timing little pile of horseshit!” Victor’s nightmare horse, Noircœur, glared at her rider, the rift closing behind her. “How dare you?”

How dare you dump me for a zmey!”

What the...

“Somebody called Gorynych?” The zmey immediately ran to the shore, throwing sand on everyone. “Is that a treat for Gorynych?”

“You... you... after everything I’ve *done* for you!” If looks could kill—and Akhenapep’s did—Noirceur would have murdered her rider a thousand times. “You rider of loose morality!”

“How did you—”

“How did I know that you dumped me? I’m a *horse*! I sense these kinds of things!”

“You didn’t even like me!” Victor complained, Kia looking at the scene as if he had gone insane.

“I’m your horse! I’m not supposed to like my riders to do my equine duty!” Noirceur glared at Gorynych. “What does he have that I don’t? *Wings*? I’m a horse, I can’t have wings!”

“Master likes me because I’m pretty!” the zmey replied with his three heads.

“Vic, are you having a conversation with your horse?” Kia asked, worried for his mental health.

“It’s a Perk,” Victor shrugged. “She is jealous that I cannot mark her as a mount all the time.”

“You can’t? Don’t you have a riding class of some kind?”

“I have. [Chaos Rider].”

“What’s the problem then?” she asked, before frowning, “Wait, how many levels do you have in it?”

“Two.” Victor frowned. “You know that class, Kia?”

“One of Balaur’s elite servants, the Green Knight, had that class and promoted it into [Horseman of Death]. He was a horribly persistent hunter of heroes, until Kevin and I put him down.” Kia shrugged. “From what I know of the class, you can increase the number of mounts as you level up in it. You should be able to create a stable of monsters and train them.”

“How many mounts could I have?” Victor asked.

“The Green Knight used at least five of them. Usually, he exhausted one to death hunting crusaders, and then switched for another.”

“Can Gorynych get levels too?” the zmey asked, wagging his tail. “Can Gorynych hump another Gorynych?”

Victor crossed his arms. “Thing is, I thought I should focus more on magic-oriented classes, increase my Tier access.”

“About that...” His fellow hero glared at him. “You don’t know [Hasten], Vic! How can you? It’s a spell tax everyone pays, and it’s only Tier III!”

“Give me a break, my curriculum mostly focused on necromancy and summoning,” Victor defended Scholomance. “Can [Hasten] cheat death, huh? Can it?”

“Maybe you wouldn’t have died in the first place if you could cast it,” the [Paladin] replied. “Vic, even if your build focuses on summoning allies, you should definitely get better at direct combat. You would shine as a magic knight hybrid.”

“So you suggest what? That I take a level in a hybrid class?”

“I think you have all the tools to excel in a fight, but you don’t exploit the synergies between your various classes the way I or even Vainqueur do. That’s why we have [Class Scholars] to help us milk our abilities for all they are worth. I can help you master your abilities.”

“You will max out this [Chaos Rider] class so we can get back together,” the horse declared with jealousy. “I can tolerate you fooling around with another mount on the side, but *nobody* dumps a Nightmare!”

“And where am I supposed to level up?” Victor replied. “By beating Furibon at cards?”

Kia opened her mouth to say something, then stopped. Her eyes became obsessed by something right behind Victor.

The Vizier turned around, to find himself facing a group of dodos.

As in, the actual, extinct dodo bird. They looked oddly cute from up close, like one-meter tall mutant pigeons with colorful feathers. They showed completely no fear, just animal curiosity at newcomers.

“Vic.” Kia couldn’t believe her eyes. “Do you see what I see?”

“Dodos?” Victor asked, unimpressed.

“They’re [Exp Dodos]!” Kia looked at the peaceful creatures with raw desire. “I thought adventurers hunted them to extinction! Do you know how much experience points they are worth? And I’m not talking about the loot that they leave behind!”

Natural twenty indeed.

“Can Gorynych take their feathers?” the zmey asked, the poor birds not fleeing as they should. Apparently, having been summoned to this world, they had never met a predator. “Gorynych wants feathers.”

“This must be a gift from Mithras,” Kia said, readying her sword. “It’s just too much. This can’t be a coincidence.”

“Wait,” Victor said, looking at these huge, peaceful pigeons. “Are you suggesting we exterminate the Dodo species *again*?”

Kia opened her mouth, closed it, and then sulked.

“On the other hand...” Victor considered the practicality of it. “We are going to fight fomors soon. We need all the levels we can get, and if they really give as much exp as you say... maybe we should. For the greater good.”

“Vic, you sound like a shoulder devil and you aren’t even doing it on purpose.”

“I mean, if it’s not us, it will be other explorers,” Victor said, trying to convince himself. “What is the worth of a bird’s life, compared to the countless children of Murmurin? I... I have to think about my country’s future.”

“Yes, murder them, level up in [Chaos Rider], and then take me back,” the nightmare horse encouraged her rider. “Nobody will ever know! Do it!”

“Minion?”

Victor realized that Vainqueur had woken up, his head raised above the dodo flock.

“I listened to your conversation, and I heard a very beautiful word,” the wyrm said, glancing at the bird. “*Loot*.”

The poor birds looked at the hungry Vainqueur, with the eyes of someone facing their entire race’s extinction.

Status of [**Exp Dodos**] of [**Daltonia**]: Endangered!

The sight of the message caused Victor’s conscience to awaken. He had brought these adorable, suicidal birds into existence; he couldn’t exterminate them.

“Your Majesty, this would be wasteful!” Victor told Vainqueur before he could roast the poor animals where they stood. “If we kill them all, there won’t be any more [Exp Dodos] in the world!”

Charisma check successful!

“Once again, my Vizier, your forward-thinking astounds me,” Vainqueur said. “I now understand the meaning of gold farming.”

The dragon suddenly grabbed two dodos with both hands, the other birds finally getting the memo and running away.

“I am going to breed them into a self-renewing loot source!”

... somehow, Victor wondered if that solution wasn’t even worse than the genocide option.

Vainqueur rubbed the two birds against the others, in a way that reminded his Vizier of a Neanderthal trying to make fire with silex stones. The dragon managed to send feathers flying everywhere but seemed increasingly annoyed by the lack of results.

It suddenly occurred to Victor that Vainqueur’s knowledge of other species’ reproduction may be... *lacking*.

“Minion.”

“Yes, Your Majesty?”

“Fetch me a slime. I am going to... *experiment*.”

Chapter 100: The Winning Card

The time of the final battle had come.

Vainqueur had to give it to the lich. Furibon may be wicked, but he did honor his word. At noon, on the appointed day, he teleported on Dodo Island, backed by his supporters and a huge orc.

Meanwhile, V&V's supporters dwarfed them in numbers. Fiends, moonlanders, mounts, and a flock of dodos had gathered to encourage the winning team, carrying banners with Vainqueur's name on it.

"I spared no expenses, Your Majesty," Manling Victor explained, as he revealed the final deck. "I refreshed this deck with forbidden cards from all corners of the multiverse, Happyland, the Elemental Planes..."

"And even from the cursed Planet Moon?" Vainqueur asked, Manling Victor nodding gravely. Even now, the dragon glimpsed Tasty Malfy and the squid Thul-Gathar among their supporters. "If we are to defeat Furibon, we must resort to extreme measures. May the Elder Wyrn forgive us."

The orc conjured a massive wooden table with magic, allowing both the lich and Manling Victor to sit at each side, the crowd surrounding them. Vainqueur remained behind his chief of staff, to give him orders while he manipulated the cards with his tiny hands.

"I am Manitou, the arbiter of this battle of Monster Poker," the orc declared, who would also provide the special effects. "On one side... the tactical genius, Furibon of the Counterattack!"

Everyone but the lich's supporters booed him. Even the dodos!

Knight Kia didn't count. "This is stupid," she said. "A card game of all things..."

"The gods play cards," Thul-Gathar replied in his slippery tongue, "This is duel of fate."

"On the other," Manitou extended a hand to Vainqueur's side of the table. "The invincible duo, dragon and minion, brain and brawn... V&V!"

This time, the cheers became deafening, the dragon raising his head with pride at his genius being recognized by all.

"I will remind everyone of the new Monster Poker standard format rules," Manitou explained. "Each of you will play with a deck of forty cards minimum, and you cannot have more than three copies of a card in your deck. You have ten spots on your dungeon zone, five for minions, five for traps. Spells can be used from the hand, and equipment can be added on top of your minion card."

Both Furibon and Vainqueur's minion shuffled their deck, the rivals glaring at one another. Five giant coins floated behind each side.

"You start with a hoard of five gold coins, representing your life. If you have no minion to defend yourself, a enemy can destroy a coin. If your hoard is depleted, you lose; same if you have exhausted your deck and can no longer draw at the beginning of your turn."

"Five coins is too little for me, and too much for a pauper like him," Vainqueur told Furibon.

"A pauper you will become after I am done with you, wyvern," the lich replied with sadistic glee.

"Now, I put these face-down special cards in the middle of the field." Manitou set five cards in the middle of the table, close enough for each player to barely grab them. "At any point, you may switch cards of your hand with these. They can be extremely powerful... or completely useless. It's a gamble, but such is the spirit... of *Monster Poker*!"

“There is one thing I will not budge on: you cannot discuss strategy together,” Furibon warned V&V. “Dalton, you can state the obvious and encourage your master as any supporter can, but no tactical advice. This is between me and the wyrm.”

“My minion is my hand,” Vainqueur declared with pride. “The hand that shall crush you!”

“The wages are such,” Manitou concluded. “Should V&V prevail, Furibon shall surrender to an eternity of atonement through minionship. Should Furibon win, V&V shall be bound by a restraining order, and their entire hoard shall be turned to lead, *permanently*, as a fine. Finally, the loser shall surrender his best card to the winner!”

Vainqueur’s heart skipped a beat. His mind refused to accept the thought of losing, but the danger was real. The fate of the true gold, of all the world’s wealth, laid in his hands.

“Now.” Each party put a deck to their side and drew five cards. “Battle!”

[King of Games] activated!

“[IWIN!]” Vainqueur gloated, revealing the five cards, automatic victory combination.

“Or so you think,” Furibon replied, showing a card from his hand. “For you activated the hand spell, [Dice’s Reroll].”

An illusion of a twenty-faced dice appeared above the board, canceling the [IWIN!] message.

“It forces you to send your five [IWIN!] cards to the crypt, cancel the effect, and draw five more cards to replace them,” Furibon explained. “Did you truly think I would not do my research? I know you *always* win with your first hand, so I prepared accordingly.”

“But how could you be sure to draw that counter on your first turn?” Manling Victor asked, suspicious.

Furibon chuckled. "I trimmed my cards."

"You cheated!" Vainqueur roared. "Disqualify him!"

"Card tricks are not against the rules of Monster Poker," Tasty Malfy noted. "Neither is the use of Perks like your [King of Games]."

"Monster Poker is all about outside the box thinking!" Manitou shouted while Furibon's supporters kept shouting his name. Vainqueur grumbled as Manling Victor had no choice but to discard the winning hand. Yet, the dragon smiled inwardly, as he would win with the next draw.

For he had *three* copies of the [IWIN!] card combo in his deck.

"I am not finished," Furibon declared, revealing a new card. "By sending cards from your hand to the crypt, I can activate this spell from my hand: [Harem Ban]!"

The card's picture represented a paladin in shining armor, chasing away five monster girls, a boy, and a slime.

"It forces you to send every copy of the cards you discarded this turn, from your deck to the crypt."

Vainqueur blinked, as the words registered. "What?!"

Before he knew what hit him, ten cards magically moved from his deck to the crypt, his two remaining copies of the [IWIN!] series destroyed. The dragon fumed with shock and fury, as he could no longer pull off his favorite combo.

Impossible... *no one* had survived past his first draw before!

"What's the matter, wyvern?" the lich taunted him. "Speechless?"

"That's Furibon of the Counterattack," Manitou said with a smirk. "Always one step ahead."

Vainqueur clenched his fangs but kept his cool as his minions chanted his name, drowning out his nemesis' taunts. "You have only delayed the inevitable, lich," the dragon declared, as Manling Victor drew five cards. "I trust in my Vizier's deck! It has more winning strategies within than you have ribs!"

Furibon snorted, as Vainqueur could finally resume his turn. While it was no winning hand, his minion had drawn powerful cards.

"I summon the level 10 minion [Goblin Hero]," Vainqueur declared, a red-capped green goblin appearing on the field, wielding a tiny sword.

A minion's level represented their power; if two minions with the same level fought, they destroyed one another. Minions with a level above 30 were Crested Minions and needed the tribute of a weaker minion on the field to appear. While epic minions, with a level above 60, were so powerful that they each had an individual, unique summoning method.

"[Goblin Hero] allows me to summon an extra minion each turn, so long as they are level 10 and below. I choose the [Kobold Commander]."

A purple kobold joined the goblin, fist-bumping it.

"[Kobold Commander] allows me to add a Crested minion from my deck to my hand," Vainqueur didn't even have to tell Manling Victor which one, for it symbolized his own vow of minionship. "The [Scythe Lord]."

"Obviously," the lich said. "But you cannot summon him this turn without a special effect."

Vainqueur ignored the lich. "Since I cannot attack on the first turn, I place a trap in my dungeon zone and I end this round."

With a wall of minions to protect his hoard, the dragon had nothing to fear.

Or so he thought!

"I discard two minions from my hand, [Wicked Priest] and [Fortress Knight]," Furibon threw almost half his hand into the crypt. "Which allows

me to summon this minion per its special effect!”

A skeletal warrior clad in tight, green clothes appeared, wielding a curved blade and a familiar, crimson capote. His level, 60, appeared right next to his head. “[Undead Matador]!”

“Be wary, Your Majesty, this creature cannot be destroyed in battle!” Manling Victor warned his beloved master, “and he can attack a hoard directly!”

“Indeed, and I equip him with [Metal Glider],” Furibon summoned a miniature plane right below the monster’s feet, allowing him to fly. “Which grants my matador the ability to attack twice a turn!”

Which he *did*.

The matador flew over Vainqueur’s defenders, and swiftly cut through *two* of his coins. The dragon reeled from the pain of watching his hoard depleted, while Furibon added his final card on the board. “I place a trap in my dungeon zone, and I end my turn.”

“Manling Victor, draw!” Vainqueur ordered, his partner obeying. “I call—”

“Not yet,” Furibon said, revealing his trap. The picture showed a manling accepting a poisoned apple from Mag Mell. “I activate the trap, [Fairy’s Poisoned Gift]. By paying one coin, I can draw until I have six cards in my hand.”

“You would sacrifice your own gold?” Vainqueur could only watch as the lich descended into depravity, turning a coin to lead and drawing cards to refill his hand. “You shall not get away with it! I sacrifice [Goblin Hero] to call my level 53 [Scythe Lord]!”

His mighty servant rose from the goblin’s ashes, a wicked, armored reaper of souls, swinging a scythe of screaming ghosts. The card that represented Manling Victor’s faith in his master, and dedication to him.

Vainqueur reminisced about the trials they undertook to complete the ultimate deck. Manling Victor had been skeptical about this card battle, almost as much as Knight Kia; but as they completed their harrowing spiritual journey through Dodo Island together, he had finally understood his destiny. To help his master defeat evil, at Monster Poker!

Words could not describe the ordeals the two faced to earn the [Scythe Lord]... but through them, they won this card's allegiance.

And with it, they would win!

“When [Scythe Lord] is summoned, I can revive any minion from my crypt as an Undead Type.” [Goblin Hero] returned from the dead, a tiny skeleton animated by [Scythe Lord]'s will. “And my reborn minion's effect activates, allowing me to bring another reinforcement! The level 10 [Slime Knight]!”

A childlike blue slime swinging a tiny sword joined the minion army, bravely standing next to the [Scythe Lord].

“I see V&V strategy now,” Manitou mused. “A beatdown deck.”

“Beatdown?” Knight Kia asked, having zero knowledge of such a high-stakes, intellectual game.

“He will summon as many minions as he can to overwhelm his foe,” Manitou explained. “It's a good strategy... but of no use against Furibon's immortal defense!”

“None of your creatures can defeat my [Undead Matador],” the lich taunted his rival.

“Which is why I activate my trap, [Ultimate Minion Sacrifice],” Vainqueur revealed his trap. “Two of my minions will give their life to destroy any one of yours!”

His [Goblin Hero] and [Kobold Commander] bravely rushed at the matador, exploding upon contact. When the dust settled, all of them had perished.

Vainqueur almost cried a tear of regret, but decided to honor the sacrifice through victory.

“Minions, take back his hoard!”

Furibon chuckled, as a ghostly armored knight appeared right in front of his hoard, parrying scythe and slime. “What?!” Vainqueur’s eyes widened.

“Remember the [Fortress Knight] I discarded earlier?” the lich taunted him, the ghost vanishing. “By removing him from the crypt and from the game permanently, I can shield my hoard from attacks this turn.”

Argh, the lich had planned for everything! “I place two traps in my dungeon zone and I end my turn, coward!”

“Coward I may be, but the winning one,” Furibon replied, drawing. “I activate the spell [Adventurers’ Guild Reinforcements], which allows us both to draw two cards.”

Both rivals increased their hands by two, Furibon chuckling as he drew the second one. “You know, Vainqueur, when you challenged me to battle, there was *one* card that I *immediately* added to my deck, before even considering my overall strategy. A card I knew would bring you to your knees. A card I just *drew*.”

The dragon remained strong and proud. “Bring it.”

And so, Furibon cast the most wicked of spells. “[Lead Buster]!”

One of Vainqueur’s coins turned to lead and then collapsed into dust.

The dragon froze for a few seconds, reliving the darkest days of the War of the Hoard. The dark times when Furibon roamed the world freely, murdering baby coins and abducting minions to his cursed fortress. Vainqueur had flashback of the conflict, of baby coins screaming in agony and minions dying all around him.

No, Vainqueur thought, forcing himself back to reality. He could not let the lich sink its claws into his mind.

“Next, I activate the spell, [Vampire Raid],” Furibon revealed his newest card “While I cannot summon normally this turn, we can both call every undead in our hands to battle, so long as they are level 60 and below.”

Once again, Vainqueur’s supreme genius had worked out in his favor, for Manling Victor had added a few of those critters to the deck. Regaining his presence of mind, the [Augustus] immediately summoned the only undead in his hand: [Zombie Averagist].

A rotting dwarf from the underworld, [Zombie Averagist]’s level equaled the average level of all monsters on the field, narrowed to the lowest number.

“As for me, I call a level 60 [Vampire Witch], and my favorite minion...” Two monsters appeared on Furibon’s side, a vampire dressed like a wizard, and a golden skeleton atop a throne of gems. “[Golich, the Wealthiest Undead], level 58!”

[Zombie Averagist]’s level grew to 44. While Vainqueur had more minions on his side, none could defeat any of Furibon’s own.

“When [Vampire Witch] is summoned, I can add one copy of a spell in my crypt, from my deck to my hand,” Furibon said, bringing out a card, “Guess which one?”

Vainqueur’s eyes widened, as he braced himself for impact.

“[Lead Buster]!”

The dragon’s hoard shrunk to only one coin, much to the audience’s horror. “That’s how Furibon will win,” Manitou analyzed. “A Monster Poker battle is a mental marathon. Vainqueur is a dragon, and so vulnerable to stress... while as a brainless undead, Furibon will always keep a cool head.”

“His Majesty has faced worse odds, and came out victorious!” Malfy reminded the dragon, the minions cheering him up. “Happyland stands by you! BLEEP his soul!”

“Now, my servants, attack!” Furibon ordered, his [Golich] unleashing a tsunami of gold against the weaker [Scythe Lord].

“You set off my trap, [Level Switch].” Vainqueur revealed one of his face-down cards. “Our minions switch levels during a single battle!”

His [Scythe Lord], now stronger, leaped over the gold tsunami and cut down [Golich], destroying him. The sight of the gold throne vanishing with it broke Vainqueur’s heart. That cursed lich used psychological warfare to weaken him.

“You have only brought time, Vainqueur!” Immediately, the lich ordered his vampire to attack the victorious [Scythe Lord], and this time, she skewered him with an icy spike.

“Minion, I could not protect your card,” Vainqueur apologized to Manling Victor, as the [Scythe Lord] vanished into dust.

“You did what you could,” his Vizier comforted him. “He will return. A chief of staff’s job is never done!”

Once again, Vainqueur relived a flashback of his training days on Dodo Island, as Manling Victor practiced his winning draw hour after hour, night after night. His minion had remained determined to fulfill his duty, no matter what!

The words gave Vainqueur his faith in himself back, as Furibon added *four* more traps and ended his turn. Immediately, the ground on his side of the field opened, [Golich] rising back from the crypt atop his hoardlike throne.

“As long as I have more coins than you, wyvern,” Furibon rubbed the wealth inequality to the dragon, “[Golich] will return from the dead at the end of my turn.”

“Minion, he is using the power of gold against us!” Vainqueur panicked.

“It has begun,” the orc nodded. “Furibon’s fearsome Undead Lockdown. He will slowly deplete the enemy’s hoard while reviving his minions again and

again.”

“Indeed, it seems that I have secured—”

“Do you not dare say it!” Vainqueur interrupted the lich, who grinned smugly in response.

“—a serious *lead*.”

The dragon growled, Manling Victor putting a hand on his scales to calm him. “We can still win,” his Vizier reminded him, drawing.

“I activate two of my four traps,” Furibon revealed two of his face-down cards before Vainqueur could react. “[Return of the Lich King] and [Signs of the End Times].”

The first card revealed itself, boosting Golich’s level to 68. “All revived minions on the field will gain ten additional levels,” Furibon explained. “This card will remain in the dungeon zone until it is destroyed.”

As for [Signs of the End Times]... The trap revealed itself, showing a picture of the wicked god Sablar. A counter of three appeared on it. “Minion, what does this card do?” Vainqueur asked.

“On your third turn after its activation, Furibon will summon an *extremely* powerful Epic minion,” Manling Victor warned his master.

Neither the card nor its user could be allowed to survive that long. They had to win. For the dragonlings, and the baby coins.

Vainqueur analyzed the situation. With the current field, [Zombie Averagist]’s level increased to 46; not enough to defeat any enemy minion. The dragon glanced at the five special Poker cards, feeling, deep within his bones, that they held the key to victory. Trusting his instinct, the dragon decided to make an exchange.

“I invoke the Poker Equation, and switch two of my cards!” Manling Victor dramatically raised his hand, having practiced the ‘miracle draw’ technique

for three days. In an instant, he exchanged two good cards with two almighty ones.

“How predictable!” Furibon revealed a trap, representing a werewolf spying on a gathering of kobolds at night. “[Moonlight Sabotage]! I send one of your hand’s cards to the bottom of your deck, where it will stay even *after* your deck is shuffled, and allow you to draw a new one in return!”

Vainqueur could only scream in rage, as one of the two almighty cards was buried below his deck while Manling Victor drew a replacement. Still, the other was more than enough. The dragon and his Vizier exchanged a look, nodding at one another.

“I use the almighty, [Supreme Fusion],” Vainqueur revealed the cheat spell. “I can fuse three monsters from my deck, moving them to the crypt, and the result will arrive at the beginning of my next turn.”

The ultimate, all-powerful minion.

“Next, I sacrifice my [Slime Knight] to summon a stronger minion, [Excalighost].” His slimy champion transformed into a living, floating ghostly blade with a Level of 60. “Which means my [Zombie Averagist]’s level rose to an average of 62!”

His dwarf grew stronger from the power of shared mediocrity, demolishing the [Vampire Witch] with his mighty Equality Punch attack!

“Then I activate the spell, [Level Cap],” Vainqueur used the last card in his hand. “All minions whose level has been artificially increased will be destroyed!”

“You are going to destroy both my [Golich] and your [Averagist] if you do this!” Furibon didn’t understand such an advanced strategy.

“I am counting on it!” A powerful magical light cleared up the field, leaving only [Excalighost], “And now you are wide open. Minion!”

The sword immediately cut one of Furibon's coins, finally bringing down the bastard's wealth from four to three.

"Finally, I then activate my remaining face-down trap, [Loot Finder]," Vainqueur revealed the final part of his masterful, genius move. "I can remove a multiple of five cards from my crypt from the game, and I gain an additional coin for each."

Removing *fifteen* cards and voluntarily keeping a few special ones in the crypt for later, Vainqueur watched gleefully as his fortune increased from one to four, overcoming Furibon's own. "Now that I am the wealthiest of all, [Golich] will remain in the crypt where he belongs."

"He broke the lockdown!" Kia shouted, now excited by the battle.

"And Furibon has no cards left in his hand," Malfy noted, while the lich's supporters remained stone-faced. Furibon himself let out a snarl of frustration; clearly, his only remaining trap couldn't help him out of this situation.

"Ready to give up, lich?" Vainqueur taunted him.

"Furibon will not give up." Everyone glanced at the orc commentator. "He is a true duelist. So long as he believes in his deck, his cards won't let him down."

The lich simply drew.

... and chuckled. "Perfect. I discard the Level 0 [Card Djinn] from my hand!"

A bottle materialized on the field, a tiny blue goblin peeking from within.

"When discarded, [Card Djinn] allows us both to draw five cards from our deck," Furibon said, both players increasing their hands' size from zero to five while the genie vanished.

Why add a card that helped his opponent as much as himself? A look at his depleted deck told Vainqueur why.

“Minion, how many cards do we have left?” Vainqueur asked, worried.

“Only *seven*,” Manling Victor replied grimly.

That lich bastard intended to force Vainqueur to deck out!

“First of all, I activate the spell [Unjust Tax],” Furibon played the most *evil* card in his entire deck. “Each time you lose a coin this turn, I will gain one in return.”

Did that mean the lich expected to bring down Vainqueur’s wealth this turn? How?

“You are not the only one with three copies of a card, Vainqueur. [Lead Buster]!”

One of the dragon’s four coins turned to lead, a golden copy appearing on Furibon’s side; inverting their net worth!

“Next, I use the spell [Minion Recycling].” A brown, colored smoke-spewing cup appeared behind Furibon. “Which allows me to recycle one of the spells I used this turn by discarding a minion from my hand. [Lead Buster]!”

Vainqueur stumbled back from the illusory onslaught, his heart broken.

“Last but not least, since I discarded my [Card Djinn], I can still summon a minion this turn. The one from your worst nightmares’, wyvern.” Furibon raised a card to the very skies. “The legendary **[Gold Eating Insect]**!”

“Impossible!” Vainqueur shouted, the skies darkening from the coming of this monstrous, ancient evil. “We dragons destroyed every single trace of their existence!”

“Not all of them,” Manitou said grimly. “A single copy of the card survived this ancient dragon purge, protected by the legendary order of duelists.”

It appeared, exactly like in Vainqueur’s most sinister memories.

A tiny golden ant, whose single level couldn't hide its aura of pure evil.

"During each of my turns, this vermin will devour part of your wealth!" Furibon raised a finger, the insect launching himself at one of Vainqueur's two remaining coins.

"No!" The dragon screamed in horror, relieving through the darkest moment of dragonkind. The ignoble animal swallowed the coin whole, bypassing [Excalighost], and popped up another one on Furibon's side.

In one round, the lich had reduced Vainqueur's wealth to one and increased his own to *six*.

"Finally, I set a trap," Furibon said, "and I end my turn."

With his master's newfound, ill-gotten wealth, [Golich] returned from the crypt, joining the vicious insect; once again, [Return of the Lich King] increased his level to 68, more than Vainqueur's remaining monster.

So it was with a heavy heart that Vainqueur ordered his chief of staff to draw.

"You have pressured me thus far, Furibon," the dragon declared, as the enemy trap's counter fell to two. "But this ends now."

For at long last, his ultimate minion had come!

"Behold, the most powerful champion a dragon could ever want!" Vainqueur hyped up his ultimate card, as [Supreme Fusion] summoned it on the field with a flash of burning light. "[Vainglorious, the Ultimate Three-Headed Dragon], level 90!"

His arrival cowed *all* onlookers.

For it was a vision of perfection; an immense, majestic, three-headed dragon, each of his heads crowned! His mighty roar inspired fear in even the lich's cold black heart.

"A zmey!" Gorynych wagged his tail.

“A dragon!” Vainqueur snarled back. “That can attack three times in a row! More than enough to demolish your army! As for your hoard, I play the spell [Hungry Master’s Call]! It allows me to summon a number of minions whose combined levels are below that of my strongest champion on the field!”

Namely, he could summon all three minions in his hand!

“Behold my army!” Vainqueur boasted, as two level 10 [Slime Knights] and one white-furred, level 25 [Werewolf Girl] hit the field, bringing his army to five. “Attack!”

His mighty dragon obeyed his master, two of his heads incinerating the [Gold-Eating Insect], and that cursed [Golich]. Then, the last head led the assault, all minions charging at Furibon’s coins.

Only for a ghostly knight to block all their attacks.

“Remember the card I discarded to use [Minion Recycling]?” Furibon gloated. “Another copy of [Fortress Knight]!”

“Damn!” Manling Victor cursed, as the enemy’s hoard escaped destruction.

“It is fine, minion,” Vainqueur reassured his chief of staff. “Our army will finish him off next turn. I set one trap, and I end my turn.”

The situation favored them. He had an invincible card in play, an army, and Furibon had emptied his hand last turn.

Still... the lich kept two face-down traps in play, with one he had been sitting on for numerous turns now. Did he keep it as a last resort? What about the new one? What if he had another dangerous, instant coin destruction card in reserve?

Not that Vainqueur doubted of his victory, but... the dragon held his breath.

Furibon dramatically drew a card, looked at it...

And let out a snarl of sheer rage. “I end my turn,” Furibon said bitterly, unable to use his newest card. “[Golic], return to me!”

The immortal undead prepared to return, but Vainqueur put a nail in his coffin by revealing his own set trap: [Golem Dysfunction].

“My trap prevents an enemy minion’s summoning and cancels its effect permanently,” Vainqueur revealed with smug satisfaction, the picture of a golem’s wreckage crushing [Golic]. “Your undead servant will never return!”

The lich clenched his fists, now completely vulnerable for the final blow.

“My *final* turn,” Vainqueur dramatically declared, his minion preparing to draw as [Signs of the End Times]’s counter dropped to one.

“Indeed!” Furibon finally revealed the mysterious trap, representing a broken clock. “[Kingu Kurimuzon]! I skip one turn of time for each of us!”

Before Vainqueur knew what hit him, the very world briefly distorted into a flash of red, the counter of [Signs of the End Times] hitting zero. The card exploded, summoning the lich’s own ultimate minion.

“Here it comes.” Furibon raised his hands, as a monstrous, colossal minion appeared on his side. “[Fomor King Balaur]!”

The creature that appeared was no mere large and mighty dullahan, but a colossus matching Vainqueur’s own ultimate dragon in level. A knight with burning blue flames for a head, and wielding a mighty axe of flesh and bones.

“You created a card after that *bastard*?!” Knight Kia shouted in outrage at Manitou.

“When summoned, [Fomor King Balaur] destroys all minions on my enemy’s side,” Furibon revealed, the titan raising his axe. “This power cannot be countered, and for each card destroyed by this effect, you,

Vainqueur, must send an equal amount from the top of your deck to the crypt. And I count *five*.”

Which left Vainqueur with...

“One card!”

The crowd shouted, as the enemy minion brought down his axe and cut through Vainqueur’s entire army; and in flagrant defiance of historical accuracy, even the dragon! Manling Victor had no choice but empty the deck down to one; the final card he could draw.

It took a moment for Vainqueur to process the sight, as his entire crowd of admirers had fallen silent, while Furibon’s few fans sung his name in admiration.

The dragon only had one card in his deck. The magical card. If Vainqueur didn’t end it this turn, Furibon could simply skip his turn and automatically win. And with one coin left and no protection, the lich could always attack if his rival somehow replenished his deck.

Vainqueur had been backed into a deadly corner.

The dragon glanced down at his chief of staff, who looked back with eyes full of determination.

No. The battle wasn’t over. So long as he breathed.

“Now, draw your last pathetic card, Vainqueur,” Furibon said, his colossal fairy swinging its axe.

“This deck, crafted by my minions, contains no pathetic card!” The Emperor prevented Manling Victor from drawing. “But before I end this, I want to ask you something, lich!”

“Ask away, but be quick. I want to end this farce and be done with this period of my life.”

“At no point did you exchange your cards with the mystery ones,” Vainqueur pointed out. “Why?”

The spellcaster scoffed. “Why rely on luck when you can decide your own fate?”

“Is there no place in your black heart for surprise and showmanship?”

“No,” Furibon replied bluntly. “Be it at cards or in life, practicality, predictability, and sound strategy will always prevail.”

Vainqueur had expected something so base. “And this is where you are wrong. For you have not considered one key element. What separates a beautiful dragon like me, from the likes of you.”

“Your friendship with Dalton?” Furibon mocked him.

“My *popularity*!” Vainqueur roared, rousing his fans. “For when you play a card, it is carried only by your own strength! While every move I play is supported by the love and wishes of thousands of minions! And they won’t let me lose!”

And so, carried on by the cheers of Vainqueur’s admirers, Friend Victor drew the ultimate card and revealed it. A kobold raised from the dead by his beloved dragon master.

“[Minion Revival]!”

“That card cannot revive any minion above level 60!” Furibon cackled, before freezing. “No...”

“Yes! I revive [Scythe Lord]!” The undead warrior rose from the dead, his effect immediately activating. “Who can revive any minion in the crypt, ignoring its summoning conditions! And with your [Return of the Lich King] still active, both gain ten levels!”

His majestic, three-headed dragon returned from the dead, his level skyrocketing to *100*. With one head, it blasted the fairy lord, and then two coins of Furibon’s hoard with the others.

“I still have four coins left, and you only one minion,” Furibon boasted about his stolen wealth. “You lost with dignity, but you still failed.”

“Have you forgotten the last card in my hand, Goldslayer?” Vainqueur had Manling Victor reveal it. “The spell, [Unfusion]!”

Instantly, his three-headed revived champion divided into its components: three beautiful crimson, level 60 wyrms.

The lich’s confidence crumbled, right as the dragons shattered one coin each while their fans *exploded* into cheers. “Carry this pain with you to the grave, Furibon!” Vainqueur shouted, as the [Scythe Lord] prepared to give the coup de grace, “It is by doubting my popularity, that you reinforced it!”

With a resigned, disgusted look, the lich raised his hand. “[Troll Button].”

The final trap on Furibon’s field revealed itself, representing a troll smashing a big red button with explosions in the background.

“When I lose my last coin, I can destroy one of the enemy’s.”

Vainqueur’s last coin exploded, right as [Scythe Lord] cut Furibon’s own.

The illusions collapsed into nothingness, revealing the lackluster, final result to every onlooker.

“A draw?!” Every supporter from both sides shouted at once, *pissed*. Furibon looked away, bitter.

“I demand a rematch!” Vainqueur snarled. “Immediately!”

“*Enough!*”

The Emperor glanced at his favorite manling, who rose up from his seat before making his way to the lich. “Furibon,” Manling Victor looked deep into his foe’s eyes. “Through this battle, I think I understood you.”

“This is ridiculous,” the lich said.

“Not so much,” Manling Victor said, seizing Furibon’s final card, “[Troll Button]. A card that can never allow its user to win, and whose only use is to force a draw... so a new battle can take place. You could have switched this card for another, one that could have helped you win, but you didn’t.”

Furibon fell silent, the chief of staff’s words taking root in his cold, dead heart.

“Deep down, you enjoy this rivalry. You don’t hate us enough to give it your all, but Vainqueur bothers you just enough that you wish to deny him victory. This card...” Manling Victor raised Furibon’s ace, that of a big fat troll smashing a button with a smile. “This card represents your true feelings!”

Manitou the orc had tears in his eyes at the sight.

“We fought side by side once,” the Vizier finished, “If you both come clean, we won’t have to continue this endless, pointless struggle.”

“Of course we have,” Vainqueur declared. “He is the Goldslayer, the enemy.”

“Your Majesty, this is going to sound very cliché,” Manling Victor cleared his throat. “But don’t you defeat your enemy when you make peace with him?”

The dragon blinked, having difficulties processing the concept. Making peace with Furibon? After what he *did*?

“I... I apologize.”

Vainqueur immediately looked at his nemesis.

“I apologize for turning your hoard to lead, Knightsbane,” Furibon struggled to spit out every word, but did so sincerely. “I acted on impulse, and I regretted my act ever since. I will not do it again. *There*, I said it!”

With that out of the lich’s empty chest, his empty gaze settled on Vainqueur.

After everything... after everything, the lich had asked for a dragon's pardon.

"I... I... I...f..." The dragon struggled to find his own words. "I...f..."

"I forgive you?" Manling Victor tried to help.

"I *forget* you!" Vainqueur finally said it, with tears in his eyes.

The lich remained speechless, while Manling Victor facepalmed in shame at the sight of his beloved master crying.

"Go and sin no more, I forget you!" Although it took him all his strength, Vainqueur took the high, dragon road, and granted Furibon mercy. "I forget you, Goldslayer! I *forget* you!"

The lich exchanged a glance with the Grand Vizier. "That's the best you will ever get," Manling Victor said, smiling and extending his hand.

"Bygones be bygones?"

Furibon examined the hand with apprehension, before finally shaking it.

"Bygones be bygones."

And so, at long last, as fairies and wyrms once did, surrounded by the cheers and tears of minions...

Liches and dragons, at long last, made peace.

Chapter 101: Empathy Training

Fourth day of the experiment.

Progress had been slow, especially with the final battle against the wicked-yet-forgotten Furibon, but resumed immediately afterward. The Dodo Daycare, or “Dodocare,” was almost entirely operational. [Exp Dodos] could roam the island freely inside vast, demon-guarded pens, interacting with one another and the wildlife the empire would introduce.

With his dwarf lackeys having opened a portal linking the island to Murmurin, Vainqueur had converted the whole island into a minion breeding resort, under Tasty Malfy’s supervision. The fiend intended to build facilities such as hostels, beach services, and cruises. In time, Vainqueur hoped to even open a princess wildlife sanctuary there.

But for now... now it was time for the final stage of the Dodocare experiment.

Vainqueur looked over a group of dodos sleeping beyond a fence, then at his lab assistant. “Minion Victor.”

“I have the slime.” His Vizier raised the chosen creature, a pinkish jelly struggling within his arms. “The [Pink Molester], which can reproduce with anything. This thing is the Mick Jagger of slimes. If it moves and isn’t a minor, it will BLEEP it. Sometimes, it’s not even that discriminate.”

“What about the genes? Does it have *perfect* genes?”

“It has elite stats in every category. Malfy even told me that some of its offspring... could shine on their own.”

“Like gold?” Vainqueur asked, immensely interested. If true, then his dream of making the ultimate, golden dodo might finally be within his grasp! “Is it willing to breed?”

“Oh yes!”

But clearly not with the bird; the slime simply couldn’t resist Manling Victor’s raw sexual energies, and the Vizier barely kept it from hugging his face. “For... some *unexplained* reason... it has taken a liking to me.”

“Good. We shall redirect its breeding frustration towards the birds.”

“Are you really sure you want to do it though? Once unleashed, *nothing* will stop it.”

“Minion, we must save the [Exp Dodos] from extinction, no matter the cost. It is for my own good.” Vainqueur gave the fateful order. “Release the beast.”

And so, Manling Victor painfully threw the lustful slime beyond the fence, introducing the [Pink Molester] to the dodo pen. Sulking angrily at the Vizier’s rejection, it turned towards the birds, ready to breed with every last one of them. It immediately tackled the one nearest to it into a bush.

Manling Victor turned away, too soft-hearted to see what would happen very soon, but Vainqueur could not allow himself to do the same. He had to guarantee the breeding program would stay on track.

So he watched *everything*.

Congratulations! For creating a wildlife sanctuary for the [Exp Dodos] to save them from extinction (whether they like it or not) and making peace with the lich Furibon, you earned one level in [**Witchfinder General**] and three levels in [**Dungeon Breeder**]! You earned the [**Improved Hybridization**] and [**Rabbit Plague**] class perks!

+60 HP, +30 SP, +3 STR, +2 VIT, +3 SKI, +3 AGI, +2 INT, +4 CHA, +2 LCK.

[Improved Hybridization]: Your minions can now produce hybrids that should not make anatomical sense... such as the mighty OWLBEAR or the elusive Manbearpig! Monsters that do not share a common [Type] will create a dual-type offspring that possess one type from each parent. This Perk will not affect creatures unable to reproduce at all, such as golems or skeletons.

[Rabbit Plague]: If you or any of your minions use an ability meant to summon another monster, they call an additional creature of the same type. Can you breed the ultimate minion?

Oh yes, he would!

“That’s disgusting.”

Vainqueur glanced at the evil Furibon and his living followers, who vomited at the sight. As if they had never seen a bird and slime breed before! “You cannot understand free love between species, lich,” the dragon said. “I said I would forget you. Do not remind me for too long.”

“Believe me when I say that I do *not* intend to meet you *ever again* after we teleport out.”

“I haven’t thanked you for saving my hide from those adventurers,” Victor told the lich. “I still owe you one.”

“You convinced Knightsbane to stop bothering me,” Furibon replied, Vainqueur doing his best to ignore him. “As far as I am concerned, that makes us even.”

“So, what’s next? We’re going west after this ‘experiment’ is done.”

“There is too much of the New World to explore to cross the sea further,” Furibon replied. “Maybe I will try to find this ‘Holly Wood’ you earthlanders keep babbling about.”

“So this is farewell?” Why did the Vizier seem sad? “It was just a one-time deal?”

“At least until Sablar comes after all of our heads,” the lich replied grimly. “And he will.”

“Furibon is just being gloomy,” his elf cohort replied. “I’m sure we’ll meet again soon. I’ve got the feeling things are about to get funnier as time goes on.”

“Now that you are finished with cliché, stupid lines, I will teleport us away before my diabetes worsens,” Furibon declared, before casting his spell, sending a final glance at Manling Victor. “Dalton.”

“Yes, Bone Daddy?” The minion braced himself.

“You are an unbearable manwhore and a complete screw-up,” Furibon insulted his chief of staff back, making the dragon glare at him. “But I had fun.”

And so, with those words, Furibon finally vanished, allowing Vainqueur to forget him. Finally, they could go back to the truly important thing.

“Minion.”

“Yes?”

“Grab a dodo and help.”

His Vizier made a very strange face, as if he was silently screaming.

“Find them good partners whose loot-worthy Perks can be passed on to the lineage,” Vainqueur clarified his intent, since his chief of staff couldn’t see as far he did.

In three generations, he would have his golden dodo.

Riding on a dodo’s back wasn’t fun for either party.

Victor shifted uncomfortably on the back of his mount, as the bird carried him away from the daycare and towards the beach, where he was to meet with Kia for the purpose of training. While the creature had enough strength

to carry his new rider, it clearly had no training with it. It was a constant struggle just to stay on it.

Still, the beast endured with great courage. Victor had decided to name him ‘*Dodolion*’ to honor his bravery.

As the mighty team strolled through the beach, they caught sight of another unlikely duo training on the sand. Victor couldn’t help but blink at the sight.

“Master!” Gorynych wagged his tail, while Noirceur the horse struggled to sit on his back. “Gorynych gained a level in [Ranger]! Because Gorynych is good with horses!”

Victor and Dodolion looked at the inbred dragon’s rider, who glared back.

“What, you think a *horse* cannot be a [Chaos Rider]?” the nightmare asked. “You two-legged racist, I will show you.”

Victor and his mighty bird looked at them for a full minute and continued forward without a word.

They found Kia tanning on the sand, wearing only a black swimsuit with her sword and blade within arm’s reach. Hearing them arrive, the Paladin looked at Victor, then at the dodo, and then struggled not to laugh.

“Shut up,” the Vizier said. “I’m doing this for the exp.”

“Is it working?”

Congratulations! For loyally serving as your liege’s hand against Furibon, proving your worth as a true duelist, and fearlessly riding the rarest of all monsters, you earned two levels in [**Chaos Rider**]! You earned the [**White Rider**] class Perk!

+60 HP, +2 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +2 INT.

[**White Rider**]: While you fight mounted, when you cast a spell or use a Perk with you as its target (such as a buff), your mount counts as an

extension of your own person and will gain the ability's benefits. You can add two more creatures to your marked mount stable.

“Yes.” Incredibly, Dodolion was worth so much exp, that just riding him helped him level up faster. At least now his horse would stop complaining about not being marked. They would stay a few more days to train and then continue the journey west.

Kia glanced at the creature, then decided the extra experience wasn't worth the humiliation.

Victor couldn't help but examine her closely, having never seen the [Paladin] without her armor on. As expected, she was the very picture of an amazon, with the body of a professional athlete that would make Chocolatine, Charlene, and probably all the women he knew jealous. He didn't notice any scar or blemish he would have expected from someone with her lifestyle, which he attributed to her healing spells.

Victor could have sworn she had gained fat and then lost it recently though, a glimpse at a whiskey bottle next to her telling him why.

“You're making me uncomfortable,” she said, noticing his gaze.

“Sorry,” he said, focusing on her face. “Kia, can I ask you a personal question before we begin? Why do you look so unhappy when you drink?”

She shrugged. “I don't feel alive unless I'm fighting.”

That wasn't an answer, but Victor read between the lines. “I don't understand you,” he said. “How can you be unhappy? You're a hero, everyone loves or admires you... I get that you feel at your highest in a fight, but you shouldn't feel down the rest of the time.”

“It's not... did you ever have a purpose in life? Like Vainqueur watching his hoard grow?”

Victor thought about Vainqueur, Murmurin's development, the war with the fomor, the gods, and everything that brought him all the way from the

Albain Mountains to this island. “Making Vainqueur happy, and creating a place where monsters and civilized species can coexist in peace.”

“I didn’t have a purpose on Earth, and it always gnawed at me,” she replied. “Then Mithras and Leone gave me a literal divine mission to defeat Balaur. For a decade, I had a clear goal. My life had meaning. It was like playing a game where you know you have to keep pushing forward until you reach the ending. Those were the best times of my life.”

“But then you reached the ending, and your life kept playing.”

As Victor had guessed, while she hid it well, Kia struggled with depression.

“And I only recapture that sense of fulfillment when I fight,” she admitted, her hand aiming for the bottle; and not in a funny way.

The sight spurred him to action. “Maybe you can find another,” Victor suggested, trying to keep her attention away from the drink. “Like conquering Valhalla. You’re by far the closest, and it would keep you motivated.”

“I thought about it, but what afterward? I become another ascended [Paladin] like Mithras and Leone?” She shook her head. “They want to expand their chosen countries, improve Outremonde step by step. They have visions. Call me unimaginative, but I always saw myself as a soldier.”

Victor wondered how she would feel if she realized the gods played dice with the universe but kept it for himself. He had the sense to keep it quiet for Camilla, he wouldn’t blurt that out now.

“Don’t get me wrong, I’m not complaining about my life, my status, or anything. I just don’t feel happy in general when I have no higher calling to aspire to.”

“What about your teammates?”

“Kevin found his calling in politics. He always liked ‘Kingdom Building’ and translated it into real life. The others... depends. A few hit the road,

others looked for a way to return to Earth.”

And none of that interested her. “What about adventuring with Jolie?”

“It’s fun, but without an overarching goal...” She smiled at him. “Look, Vic, you’re very kind, but Kevin spent two years asking almost the same questions and it got us nowhere.”

“I won’t give up on you,” Victor replied. He may not be as close to her than most of his other friends, but she had repeatedly come to his and Vainqueur’s help when they needed it. No way in Happyland would he turn his back on her.

“Maybe we can talk about something a bit less gloomy?” Kia suggested, changing the subject. “Have you managed to learn [Hasten]?”

After he confirmed it, she jumped back on her feet and stretched. “Good. From what I gathered from our battles, you really don’t fare well in a close encounter.”

“Easy for you to say, you’re literally optimized to kill monsters in close combat.”

“Yes and no. I did plan my classes to improve that way, but I mostly figured out how my Perks and spells could synergize best on my own. What I don’t understand is that with your level, equipment, and abilities, you should be a *lot* harder to kill.”

Victor sighed. “Thing is, I have many powerful Perks with devastating synergies, like [Charon’s Grim Harvest] and [Nightmare Realm], but they do *not* prevent friendly fire.”

“Ah, I get it. You have a Boss build. You’re not meant to fight with a normal party, except summoned minions.”

“Sort of.” On his own, he could simply summon undead or fiends immune to his most dangerous abilities, then control the battlefield with his other abilities. Pretty much like Akhenapep. “And while I’m good at creating and

leading undead, the fight at El Dorado taught me that I've very few ways of damaging them. They're my kryptonite."

"There are necromancy spells that harm the undead as easily as the living," the knight pointed out. "That's not my field of expertise so that I leave you to solve that on your own. Which leads me to what I believe is your Achilles' heel."

Victor listened in silence, finding it refreshing to discuss with a professional ahead of him in the [Epic] department.

"I think you have too many Perks and options," Kia said. "Which is a problem my party faced when we reached a high level. We end up with so many abilities we do not quite figure out which ones have become obsolete, which ones have untapped potential, and so on."

"I always figured out it was better to have many options."

"That's where you're wrong. A good Perk isn't one that can solve a single problem, but many problems at once. Like your [Darwinist] saved your hide many times."

"Except with drugs."

"Except with—" She marked a short pause, looking at him if he was joking, then straightened up. "If you have too many abilities to draw on, it creates decision paralysis in battle, which can cost you a lot. The most dangerous [Epic] level foes I've met are those who mastered a few, but very powerful strategies. Masters of None don't get anywhere."

"So you suggest that I cut *down* my options? Like using [Perk Forge]?"

"Yes." She nodded. "If you haven't used a Perk in say, a month, you should consider discarding it, especially if you can make a stronger one. As for the rest, I suggest we develop a few go-to strategies that maximize your effectiveness. Would you mind showing me your stats?"

"No harm in that."

They spent a good half an hour discussing his Perks and build, identifying the monster Perks he should fuse, which spells he could now ignore—his old [Death Candle] spell would no longer help in dangerous fights—and Victor's key strengths.

But most importantly, after reviewing his stats, Perks, and equipment, the two realized that the Vizier *always* inflicted critical hits with his scythe. “Wait,” Kia said with a frown. “You have a Perk that allows you to use your [Scythe] as a spellcasting wand?”

“Yeah, it was one of the earliest ones I got from [Reaper].”

“Then your crit chances should transfer to the spells you cast,” Kia realized.

“You can crit with spells?”

“With some offensive ones, yes. You never noticed?”

Victor shook his head. He had almost entirely focused on buffs and summoning spells and rarely used direct damage ones. “Why didn’t Deathjester tell me this?”

Kia made a face at the reminder that opposite deities claimed them, but remained professional. “Deathjester was an *assassin*. He killed the old fashioned way, using illusions to disorient his foes before he landed a killing blow.”

“And he never considered the feature.”

“Unfortunately, your best Perks combination, [Nightmare Realm] and [Charon’s Grim Harvest], will target anything that isn’t you, an undead, or summons immune to their effects. If you were a ruthless dark lord leading hordes of undead, you would be very tough to fight.”

“So you suggest that I instead focus on offensive spells that can crit when I fight with allies?”

“Yes.” She nodded with a smile. “Alongside buffing yourself up with tricks like [Hasten], especially with your Skill stat. While most of your physical

stats are average or mediocre for your level, your Skill is through the roof. If sufficiently enhanced, you should be night impossible to hit.”

““Magicrit Dodgetank,”” Victor mused.

“You also need to get new armor,” Kia warned. “You’re hard to hit, but squishy. We will also need to practice your reflexes.”

Why did it sound like she would use him as target practice?

Skill check successful.

Victor froze, as he noticed something at the edge of his vision. He turned to face the whiskey sea, noticing a flock of birds flying straight towards them.

No.

Not *birds*.

Kia’s hand grabbed her sword, while Victor raised his scythe, Dodolion making a shrieking sound.

“Our sister,” one of Wotan’s Valkyries pointed a blade at Victor, as the others formed a flying circle around the group, “give her *back*.”

Chapter 102: Dialogue Options

On one side, a flock of twenty Valkyries armed to the teeth.

On the other side, two Epic level adventurers and a ferocious dodo.

Yeah, not a fair fight. The poor ladies had no idea how outmatched they were.

Victor examined the flock, and realized that many of them had already been killed on the island. Yet somehow they formed a battle line right before him. “You can revive your own,” the Vizier guessed. “That’s how you knew I captured her soul.”

“We Valkyries can collect worthy warriors who wish to fight forever in Lord Wotan’s halls. That is our [Einherjar] ability.” The new leader of the flock, a black-haired maiden wielding a spear of light, landed on the beach right in front of the Vizier. She pointed her weapon at his head. “But you trapped Sigrun, and we cannot bring her back. Release her at once.”

“I don’t understand everything, but you won’t get far making threats.” Kia raised her sword, surrounding it with light.

“This does not concern you, human,” the Valkyrie replied, very much oblivious to the [Paladin]’s true identity. “We have no quarrel with you.”

Kia wasn’t impressed, and neither was Victor. Since Gorynych and Vainqueur were in the vicinity, their group had the advantage. Even Dodolion looked placidly at the flock, calm and serene.

Still, the Vizier would rather avoid a fight if he could. “I think we all need to calm down here.”

“Release our sister and we will be on our way,” the Valkyrie leader insisted, “We will take her back by force if needed.”

“Wait,” Victor caught on. “Would you be willing to negotiate peacefully for her release?”

The war maidens exchanged glances, while their leader frowned at him. “Why would you give her back without a fight?” The concept of a peaceful discussion sounded almost foreign to her. Apparently she only made her demand as a courtesy.

“I dunno, because threats and violence aren’t the answer to everything?”

Charisma check successful!

“What do you want then, dragon thrall?”

“I know your master yet lives,” Victor said. He had learned from Akhenapep that every buried evil would escape at one point, no matter how tight the seal. “I want him to stop coming after us. Talk him out of it.”

“Impossible,” the woman shook her head. “Lord Wotan made an oath to the fairy queen, that he would bring her the dragon’s head.”

“His word once given he never breaks,” Sigrun’s shade added with pride, seen only by Victor. “Not like you shifty mortals.”

An honorable kind of fairy? Good, the Vizier would work with that. “What was the *exact* wording?”

“Bring me Vainqueur Knightsbane’s head, and I shall grant you the soul you crave.”

As he thought, he had found a glaring loophole in it. “Then, here are my terms then,” Victor said. “I will release the soul on three conditions. First, you will answer all our questions as best as you can. Second, after we are done, you will depart this island peacefully. And third, if and when Wotan comes after us again, I want you to convince him to parley instead of attacking on sight. If he picks a fight with Vainqueur afterward, that will be

his funeral, but I want him to sit down and negotiate with us for ten minutes.”

Charisma check...

Successful!

The Valkyrie leader pondered his offer, before answering. “I cannot promise my lord will listen, but otherwise... you have our word. We will answer your questions, leave this place without harming anyone, and we shall carry your message to Lord Wotan. *If* you release our sister.”

Finally, a villain with common sense.

“Are you sure about it, Vic?” Kia whispered to him, low enough for the fairy thralls not to hear them. The [Paladin] hadn’t relaxed at all, her blade firmly pointed at the flock. “We can take them. If you release that soul and let them go, that means problems later.”

“Maybe, but we won’t get many opportunities to learn about the fomors’ operations,” the Vizier replied. “I say it’s worth the risk.”

“Stop whispering among yourselves and ask your questions,” the Valkyrie leader ordered. “I have no desire to stay on this island any longer than needed.”

Right, right. “What’s your name?” Victor asked the leader.

“Brynhildr.”

“Brynhildr, who is the fairy queen who sent your master after us?” He already suspected the answer, but he wanted confirmation, and to see if the ladies lied to him.

“We know her as Mell Odieuse,” Brynhildr replied truthfully. Apparently, while loyal to their master, the Valkyries couldn’t care less about the other fomors. “She looks like you humans yet is anything but. She is a cruel beast of great power, and many fairy lords crowned her as queen.”

“Fomors elect a common leader *only* during wartime,” Kia pointed out. “They are too proud to stand a higher authority otherwise. What do you mean by *many*?”

“Many fairy lords of Prydain and Mistral bent the knee, save our own Lord, Baba Yaga, and loners like the Jack O’Lantern. She sent emissaries north, west, east, and south across the world, to the unseelie, the yokai, and the rakshasas, offering power in exchange for loyalty.”

“And for what purpose?” Victor asked grimly.

The entire Valkyrie flock looked at him, as if he were an idiot to even ask. “To exterminate the mortals.”

He walked right into that one.

“Lord Wotan said no though,” Brynhildr admitted.

Victor frowned. “He refused?”

“There is no honor in killing creatures who cannot kill you in turn,” she replied with great pride. “A true warrior’s worth is determined by the mettle of his foes.”

“Lord Wotan coexists with the people of your Winter Kingdoms,” another battle maiden added. “So long as they leave him alone and do not interfere in his dragon hunts, neither does he bother them.”

“You won’t convince me that a fomor can care about humans,” Kia spat.

“Lord Wotan cares not,” Brynhildr admitted. “But he does not take pleasure in killing your kind either. He only seeks the blood of dragons and other worthy foes. While his kindred attacked civilians to gain levels, he hunted zmeys and dragons to prepare for *yours*.”

Well, Victor guessed that like on Earth, not all psychopaths were genocidal serial killers. “In the volcano, I heard him speak about Balaur’s crusade. He said it had been a threat to his own race.”

“It was,” Brynhildr nodded, Kia stiffening at this. “Lord Wotan thought this war pointless, and time proved him right. Fomors were few and are now fewer. Unlike you mortals, they cannot replenish their numbers easily. Since he would not bend the knee nor serve in her armies, the fairy queen asked him to hunt your dragon lord for her gift.”

“So, if I follow,” Kia said. “This Odieuse can somehow give fomors souls, and thus access to the System, in exchange for their service. How does she do that?”

“Mag Mell, Odieuse’s father, used the blood and bones of dragons to create a new crest: the Soulcrest. One that empowered our Lord with a soul of his own.”

Bones and blood? “The kidnapped dragons!” Kia immediately guessed the obvious cause.

“Grandrake told Vainqueur that old dragon magic could create souls,” Victor grumbled, putting a hand in his hair. “Damn, Mag Mell must have reverse-engineered it somehow.”

“I am not familiar with the term,” the Valkyrie admitted. “Nor do I know how it works. I leave magic to spellcasters.”

“How many Soulcrests does Odieuse have?” Victor asked.

“One. But unlike your System’s crests, it can empower as many warriors as needed.”

Victor didn’t know what to make of this. On one hand, reliance on one artifact meant that destroying it could cripple the fairies’ war effort. On the other hand, the item could reasonably give the entire fomor race access to the System in a short amount of time. “Where is that crest?”

“I do not know,” the Valkyrie replied. “I only saw it once at a stone circle in Prydain, during our lord’s soul ceremony.”

“Mag Mell must probably keep it on hand all the time,” Kia suggested.
“Too many of his experiments backfired in the past to let that artifact out of sight.”

“Do you know what Odieuse is planning?” Victor fished for info.

“She said that she would summon ‘*arrows of light*’ on Samhain, the night when fairy magic reaches its apex. Arrows that metal men would fire with great bows, to burn all the formors’ enemies to ashes. Lord Wotan brushed her off, so I do not know the details.”

So the slime prophecy foretold. In all likelihood, Victor had found that ‘Hateful One’ he should help Vainqueur defeat. “And what will they do once they have these arrows?” the Vizier asked. “Attack Gardemagne?”

“Not Gardemagne,” Brynhildr said while looking straight into the Vizier’s eyes.

...

“BLEEP.”

“You declared war first.”

“Where is Odieuse?” Kia asked, frowning when Wotan’s servants failed to come up with an answer. “Mag Mell?”

“Probably Prydain,” Brynhildr replied evasively.

“*Any* lead you could give us?”

“We do know the location of their kindred, the piper Mell Lin. The fairy queen put him in charge of a place where fomors could gain levels quickly, near what you call the Jade Empire. The stables, I believe.”

“The [Exp Farm], Brynhildr,” another Valkyrie said. “That was its name.”

The title somehow sent a chill down Victor’s spine. “What do you know about that place?”

“Only that Lord Wotan wanted nothing to do with it.”

“That Mell Lin is probably the same piper that helped and then left the Nightblades to die,” Kia said. The two asked for more details, but the Valkyries didn’t know much. As it turned out, Wotan’s attack on Vainqueur was a one-time favor only.

And since this proud lord of lightning never swore fealty, Odieuse didn't let him into her plans. The Valkyries knew nothing of Prydain’s defenses, the fairy queen’s forces, nor even what Odieuse could do.

“Do you have any other question, mortal?” Brynhildr asked, growing impatient with the interrogation. Victor exchanged a glance with Kia, just as worried as him, but they had no idea what else to ask. The Valkyries already gave the group a lot to think about.

“We honored our word,” the Valkyries pointed their weapons at the duo, “Now it is your turn.”

A part of the Vizier, the one that went to Scholomance and dealt with devils regularly, didn’t feel bound to honor an agreement with a group who tried to kill him. Now that they knew enough, he and Kia could probably slaughter this flock now and not have to fight them later.

On the other hand... something else came to mind, and if there was a single chance to pull it off...

“Well, Sigrun, I would have said we had fun,” the Vizier told the soul in his scythe, “but that would be a lie.”

“I hope Odieuse kills you,” the ghostly Valkyrie replied, completely unrepentant. She made Victor miss Furibon even more than he already did.

“How kind, but she already did.”

Using tricks learned at Scholomance, Victor let her soul go free, the ghostly shade escaping its prison as a tiny speck of light. Brynhildr immediately

caught it in her free hand, appraising the [Reaper] in silence. “Surprised?” he asked her.

“A little,” Brynhildr replied, keeping her sister’s soul within her tight fist. “But next time we meet, it shall not be as friends.”

“Should we truly leave, Brynhildr?” one of the maidens asked her captain, considering going back on her words the same way Victor did. “He and his fellows can kill us permanently.”

“About that ‘leave’ part of our bargain, I have a way to make you stick to it...” Victor cleared his throat and then shouted. “GORYNYCH!”

“Yes, master!” The zmey immediately rushed at the beach, Noircœur the horse struggling not to fall off his back; rainfall started right as he showed up, obscuring the sun much to Kia’s chagrin.

The three-headed dragon noticed the Valkyries, his tail instantly raising up like a dog having spotted a rabbit.

Victor pointed a finger at the horrified warrior maidens. “PRINCESSES!”

Facing an inbred, three-headed dragon rushing in their direction while throwing sand everywhere, even the fearless Valkyries backed down.

“Retreat!” Brynhildr fled and her comrades fled while Gorynych opened his wings to pursue them, throwing Noircœur off his back in his hurry.

“Retreat!”

Congratulations! For successfully exchanging non-violently with fomor thralls and learning valuable information, you earned +2 charisma points.

“So?” Victor asked, watching his mount chase after the Valkyries across the whiskey sea.

“This is bad,” the [Paladin] replied. “This is *really* bad. Samhain is Halloween so we have... what, two months before the fomors attack Murmurin?”

“Unless we can catch Odieuse and strangle this new Century War in the crib,” Victor said, Kia giving him a strange look, “Sorry, too much time spent among demons.”

“Where should we start? We don’t know where she or Mag Mell will be outside of Prydain. As for that [Exp Farm], we could spend years exploring the Serica continent without locating it.”

“Brynhildr mentioned *yokai*.”

Kia considered his words, and then put a hand on her face. “I hate Japan.”

Chapter 103: Kaiju Day

After saving the dodos from extinction—so he could harvest their exp later—Vainqueur led his flying pack west, towards the Serica continent. His manling chief of staff had insisted on making a stop at the Teikoku Empire, an island located near its shores.

For some reason, he and Knight Kia often called it ‘Japan’ while discussing together.

Vainqueur had expected a warm welcome, as befitting of his rank.

Instead, he found the island’s shores walled up, covered in cannons, and the nearest port city on fire. Flying ships similar to the Thaoten’s had crashed against pagoda-like houses, pillars of smoke turned the skies dark, and the dragon could barely hear himself think over cannon fire noise.

Vainqueur circled the skies to observe the ground below, watching manlings fight an army of goblins, orcs, beastkin, and horned ogres. All of them wielded arquebuses, swords, and spears, attacking the other side with fierce anger.

Yet, both sides froze in fear at the sight of a true dragon.

“Gojira!” The locals pointed fingers at Vainqueur in awe of his majesty.

“Gojira!”

“GOJIRA!”

Vainqueur unleashed a mighty roar and a breath of flames at the skies, to get the point across. He then landed in the middle of a street, crushing houses below his feet.

Of course, killjoy that he was, the zmey tried to imitate him, one of his heads spitting acid, the other fire, and the last one cold. Instead of groveling before the beauty of Vainqueur, the locals screamed in terror at the knockoff. “Kingu Gidora! KINGU GIDORA!”

“You scare them, zmey!” Vainqueur lambasted his minion’s mount, who lowered all his heads in shame as he made a shy landing. “Turn around, nobody likes you!”

“Your Majesty, please stop bullying my zmey!” Manling Victor complained.

“Gorynych is sorry,” the zmey apologized, retreating in a corner. The rain the inbred creature summoned wherever he went started extinguishing the fires. “No flying princesses make Gorynych sad...”

Seeing the zmey submit to Vainqueur calmed the locals, especially as they noticed Manling Victor petting the creature. Knight Kia joined him, almost no one paying attention to her and her silly griffin mount.

“Manling Victor, announce my presence to these peasants,” Vainqueur ordered his herald, as he climbed down from his mount, Knight Kia imitating him.

The Vizier stepped towards the fearful locals, even as they pointed their weapons at him. Tasty Malfy had finally delivered the Vizier a new armor to wear, one better than the last; mostly because it used Vainqueur’s favorite golden and crimson colors alongside that bland black. The armor was leaner than Manling Victor’s previous one, mixing plate, chainmail, and crimson clothes covered in unholy symbols. Spikes formed a crown on the helmet.

The sight reminded Vainqueur of his loss, the dragon promising himself not to leave this land without a new crown of his own.

“Citizens of Teikoku! I am Victor Dalton, Grand Vizier of the V&V Empire, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains! His Majesty, the great dragon Vainqueur Goldbeard Knightsbane, Emperor of the Pirate Sea, Minion

Liberator, Conquistadores of El Goldorado, and Savior of the Dodo Race, has come in peace!”

The locals exchanged worried, confused glances and answered in a strange tongue Vainqueur didn’t understand.

“Japanese,” the Vizier said.

“I will cast a translation spell,” Knight Kia declared.

“Wait!” Manling Victor stopped her. “Can... can I talk to them without the auto-translation? Just once.”

“You speak Japanese, Vic?” the [Paladin] asked, doubting his chief of staff.

“Oh no, not at all, but...” Vizier seemed embarrassed. “But... but when I lived on Earth... there was something I always wanted to do if I ever went to Japan.”

The chief of staff approached the crowd, instantly commanding their attention. He inhaled, gathered his breath, and then spoke.

“Keikaku dohri!”

The locals seemed to both understand the words, and miss the meaning completely. Slightly bothered, the Vizier tried again with a longer sentence, pointing his scythe at them.

“Omae wa mou shindeiru!”

Many ran away screaming while Knight Kia put a hand on her face in annoyance; Manling Victor laughed wickedly, strangely blissful.

At least, until he was challenged.

“Ara Ara...”

Only a lone orc dared to stand up to the Vizier. Frail and lean for his green-skinned kind, he wore a ridiculous jacket and shirt with a badly painted

planet symbol on it. He didn't wear any weapons; he didn't need them.

"Oh, you're approaching me?" Victor asked in common, as the creature walked towards him with confidence.

"I can't meme the shit out of you without getting closer," the orc replied in the same language.

"He can speak common?" Kia almost took a step forward, but Vainqueur put a hand before her.

"Do not interrupt the ritual," the dragon ordered, as his chief of staff and the orc approached each other. "You could ruin it."

Soon, both his chief of staff and orc stood face to face with only a few inches of distance.

"Okay, I admit, I, I had a short phase when I was a teen," Victor said suddenly. "There is a part of me that I don't want, that I *hate* whenever I see that Esoteric Order of Isekai. I just wanted to get it off my chest, bury it."

"Then you need to accept that part of yourself, before you can let it go," the orc declared with pride. "Mudkips is mai waifu."

"Is it OK to be gar for Archer?" Manling Victor replied, Vainqueur unable to make sense of the strange wordplay.

"Stupid sexy Lockon," the orc replied.

"Don't..." the Vizier said, looking shy, before mustering all his courage and retaliating. "Don't believe in yourself! Believe in the me who believes in you!"

"You are a true man of culture, and you deserve my respect. Do you feel happier now?"

"Yes," Manling Victor said. "I think I can finally lay that childish phase to rest."

“It is okay to move on, but there was nothing shameful in the first place either.” The chief of staff shook the orc’s hand in manly friendship. “Go, and weeb no more. You are born again, a new man.”

“I don’t understand what I’m seeing,” Knight Kia said.

“Because you lack the necessary genius,” Vainqueur replied since she probably had only square root nine in intelligence. Apparently, from what the dragon understood, they belonged to the same ancient, secret brotherhood; and Manling Victor had officially left it through a primitive ritual.

Since the orc had fought on the side of the goblinoids, the manlings mistook the friendliness for an alliance and did the sensible thing; fleeing in all directions, with their enemies on their tail.

“Are you this rabble’s leader?” Vainqueur asked the orc, before glancing at his motley army.

“Oh no, I’m just the herald.” The greenskin barked orders to goblins, who scampered away, “I called the boss. We were winning that battle anyway, and seeing a dragon buddy-buddy with us probably helped even more.”

Vainqueur didn’t have to wait for long, until the vermin’s leader showed up, backed up by a cadre of armored ogre bodyguards.

Much to his surprise, the leader wasn’t an orc or a giant, but a tiny female goblin, wearing exquisite golden armor and a strange, half-gun half-sword weapon. An older goblin with a red cloak and iron teeth followed her, immediately hiding behind an ogre at the sight of Vainqueur.

“Vic?” the goblin leader asked, recognizing the Vizier.

“Goblina?”

“Vic!” The goblin immediately moved to hug Vainqueur’s chief of staff. “Good to see you! You traded your horse for a zmey? *Nice!*”

“I kept both,” the Vizier replied, summoning his nightmare horse with a snap of his fingers. “Although she’s still as cranky as ever.”

“About time you marked me,” the horse grumbled.

“Vic, you know this goblin?” Kia asked, worried.

“Yeah, we went to school together! We were rivals in everything!” Manling Victor whistled at the goblin’s armies. “And you have your own army now!”

“I wanted to dominate the continent first, but then I remembered the lessons of the [World Conquest] course.” Goblina pumped her chest. “Don’t conquer landlocked areas first, or the heroic nations will invade you! Start with isolated islands! One week later I raised an army and invaded these shores.”

“So you’re going to take over with a horde of monsters?”

“Oh no, no, I will do it the Vizier way. March on the capital, seize the emperor *‘for his own protection’*—and my legitimacy—then declare myself Shogun Regent. I will rule in his name through military force, claiming the credit for everything that goes well and blaming the emperor for what doesn’t.”

“You were the most promising of all of us,” Manling Victor said, a tear of pride in his eye.

“Vic, you always bested me at magic, but *who* aced the [World Conquest] classes? Uh?” The goblin pumped her tiny fist. “My friend, join me. Together, we can bring order to this lawless land. With your magic and my army, we will be *unstoppable*! I will give you riches, and all the emperor’s harem!”

“That’s...”

“No poaching my chief of staff!” Vainqueur defended his property.

“Then ally with me!” The goblin offered, speaking like a tiny dragon. “Help me conquer these lands, one overlord to another! One day our bloody alliance will rule the *WORLD!*”

Vainqueur barely paid attention, his attention captured by someone else.

His eyes had set on the older goblin, trying to hide from him behind a just as terrified horned red ogre. “Have we met?” Vainqueur asked, the critter too shy to answer. He looked *familiar*.

“It’s my Daddy and advisor,” Goblina said. “He served a dragon like you!”

The cloaked old goblin looked *incredibly* uncomfortable at these words. Somehow Vainqueur knew he had seen him somewhere. He smelled familiar, but all goblins looked the same...

Skill check...

Failed!

“What? Revise your poor judgment!” Vainqueur insisted, but the screen disobeyed him.

“I’m sorry, Vainqueur had a terrible experience with goblins in the past,” Manling Victor told Goblina.

“I swear, one day I will track the cowards who abandoned me in my sleep and eat them all,” Vainqueur replied, the old goblin pissing on himself as if it concerned him. “Now, about this offer of alliance...”

“It’s very interesting, but we have a war of our own,” Kia said hurriedly, ever the killjoy.

“Yes, we believe our enemies have started recruiting local fairies,” Manling Victor told Goblina. “We came to investigate.”

“The fairies?” The goblin cackled in laughter, before snapping her fingers. “Vic, don’t worry, we got that covered.”

A group of orcs approached with a familiar bottle, showing it to Vainqueur's group.

"Is that the bottle of Mot?" the dragon asked, letting smoke out of his nostrils as he recognized the cursed item.

"I got the idea when Vic told me about it!" Goblina declared, knocking on the bottle. "I had my mages replicate them, and we started using captured fairies to provide energy instead of powerstones."

"You keep tormented fairies as power batteries?" Manling Victor asked, highly impressed.

"We don't 'torment' them. We just beat them half to death, then we catch them, and sometimes we make them fight. I cannot allow fairies to disturb my fair and benevolent iron rule. Two rulers cannot ta—" The goblin quickly caught herself as Vainqueur's gaze turned sharper, sensing that she might utter a cursed word, "take tribute from the same peasant."

"I see that someone paid attention to [Peasant Mathematics]," Manling Victor said. "Could you give us a few of these bottles?"

"Sure. If you help me conquer the island. You don't have to stay long; with you and your dragon master on our side, this war is as good as won. Just burn a few castles, raise the dead, and help me invade the capital with an army of fiends."

"We could do that." The Vizier turned to his master. "I mean, we already did it once with Port Vainqueur."

"You are *seriously* considering helping a goblin overlord take over a civilized nation," Kia noted disapprovingly at Vainqueur's chief of staff.

"Paladin?" Goblina asked Victor with a voice full of disdain.

"She's really nice when you get to know her."

"I don't think that's what Deathjester meant when he said '*screw the law and paladins too.*'"

“You cannot help a goblinoid army take over!” Kia insisted to Vainqueur.
“It is inhuman!”

“But not indragon,” Vainqueur replied.

“They will enslave and exterminate all humans from the island for all we know!” The [Paladin] pleaded for her kind.

“Is that true?” Vainqueur asked the goblin. “Slaves are an insult to minionship.”

“I vouch for Goblina’s honor,” Manling Victor said. “She won’t enslave anyone. She will conscript all species as her minions equally.”

“Like me?” Vainqueur asked, pleased that he had inspired imitators.

“Yes, but she will be more heavy-handed.”

“I have a dream,” the goblin conqueror spoke up. “Where all people of the world will be united under my rule. A world where goblins can have minions of their own too!”

“As long as you respect the *dragon code of minion deontology*, I see nothing wrong with it,” Vainqueur declared.

“I will modernize this country,” the goblin overlord said, putting hands behind her back in a strong pose. “We will build factories, educate the masses in a government-friendly way, and provide jobs to everyone so my war machine can remain fully functional.”

“Yes, she’s just going to do what the local emperor already does, but *better!*” Victor argued to Kia.

“We do not have time and helping her will destroy your nation’s reputation with civilized ones,” the knight said, running out of dragon arguments.
“How do you think Gardemagne will answer when they learn a nation of monsters helped another topple an empire?”

“But if we form an alliance, we could gain her help against the fomors. Right, Goblina?” Victor asked the goblin overlord, who nodded furiously.

“You have both good arguments, but you forgot one key element,” Vainqueur decided. He alone remembered the first reason for this world tour, and why he had started adventuring at all. “Goblin, I have one question alone.”

He raised his hand and snapped two claws together.

“How much?”

The goblin warlord asked for a pen and a scroll, wrote down a number, then showed it to the dragon.

Three days later, they had conquered the country.

For a crown, and a mountain of coins.

Chapter 104: The Mermaid's Revenge

“This is an indignity!” Vainqueur roared from atop a mountain of coins. “I will file a complaint!”

After conquering the capital city of the Teikoku Empire, Onogoro, Goblina the goblin had granted Vainqueur quarters in the palace’s rookery. Once used to welcome giant birds, the area was the only place capable of accommodating a dragon. Placed on a high pagoda, the group could oversee the entire city from here.

“What’s the matter?” Goblina the goblin was in an extraordinarily good mood, sipping a glass of red wine alongside Manling Victor. “We won! The Teikoku Empire is mine!”

“Yeah, and Your Majesty even got a crown out of it,” the Vizier pointed a finger at Vainqueur’s new [Crown of the Conqueror], a black circlet surrounded by rubies and metal horns. It was much more intimidating than the previous one, and more powerful; providing +6 to Charisma, Luck, and Skill, alongside immunity to [Terror].

Vainqueur found that part redundant, but complained about something else.

“Minion, we conquered this entire country in three days, and I did *not* level up!” The riches they earned and his monthly stipend soothed his wrath, but not by much. “The *zmey* leveled up!”

“Well, yes, he was very low level, so it made sense he would get a few out of it,” Manling Victor replied. “While we are both [Epic] level. This conquest was also a large effort, and Your Majesty and I only helped.”

“Helped? We burnt every fortress between the goblin and this silly manling capital!” Vainqueur had empowered Manling Victor’s summoned armies with his Perks, such as [Pontifex Maximus] and [Master of Silence], before unleashing air bombardments with the zmey. The manlings put up a valiant effort, but nothing that could rival a dragon.

“Your Majesty, not all soldiers in a conflict gain levels because their army won a short-lived war. Although I do ponder what it means when conquering a country becomes banal...”

“Vic, you’re, what, seventy?” the goblin asked.

“Sixty-nine.” The goblin looked up at the chief of staff with a strange look Vainqueur didn’t understand. “Don’t you *dare*.”

“With your level, you need legendary feats to level up,” the goblin replied. “Nothing short of world conquest will do.”

“I already own it by right of dragon calamity, but never pushed my claim,” Vainqueur said, considering it. “Minion—”

“I suggest we start with Prydain and then see if we need to go further,” Manling Victor replied hastily, bogged down by tiny administrative details. “We should focus on that first and foremost.”

Vainqueur grumbled, before seeing the wisdom in it. “Oh, yes, they are probably worth more in experience and loot,” the dragon reminded himself of what truly mattered. His bet with Icefang was still on, and he needed to accumulate a bigger hoard as soon as possible. Especially after Untasty Allison’s untimely death depleted his assets. “Where do we start?”

“The local fairies are called Yokai,” Manling Victor explained. “They’re distant cousins of the fomors, like Asian dragons to Your Majesty. If Odieuse is truly recruiting, she will probably start with them.”

Asian? What was that, some kind of food?

“Most of the surviving fairies make their lair in the mountain, at the island’s center.” Goblina pointed a finger outside the rookery, Vainqueur peeking. “Mount Yagami.”

Indeed, he had already noticed an enormous rock, almost as tall as the Albain Mountains, while rampaging through the countryside. Snow covered most of the summit, alongside cherry trees, while a strange, rainbowy-like light surrounded the summit. It reminded Vainqueur of a crown, one made of aurora.

The dragon was too good to ask *why* himself, so he glanced at his Vizier. “Why does it shine like that?” Manling Victor asked Goblina. By now, he could read his master’s mind without an exchange of words.

“Mount Yagami is the greatest powerstone deposit in the world; and houses multiple elemental strains at that. The stuff attracts monsters and fairies like a magnet, making the mountain exceptionally dangerous.”

“Powerstones,” Vainqueur repeated the word. “The unshiny stones Manling King Roland wanted for himself?”

“They’re stones infused with elemental magic,” Manling Victor explained his master. “The dwarves used it to power our moonlanding rocket.”

“A rocket?” The goblin jumped in place. “To the Moon? You never told me! *HOW?!?*”

“Minion, you shall not mention that regrettable incident in front of foreign dignitaries!” Vainqueur interrupted before goblins got the idea to go there. “The planet Moon cannot sustain dragon life!”

“But I want to know! It is true you can fly by yourself on the Moon?”

“Goblin, you cannot imagine the horrors making their nest there,” Vainqueur replied, suddenly having terrible flashbacks of his experience. “There... it was there... everywhere... like a poison...”

The goblin looked up at the Vizier, who wisely refused to say anything. The empire's honor was safe. "Anyway, that mountain was next on my conquest scheme," Goblina said, disappointed by the lack of explanation on the moon landing. "The empire sent adventurers and soldiers to gather powerstones for their flying ships, but the local fauna prevented long-term, large-scale exploitation. Once the island's fully pacified in a few months, I intend to clean it up of monsters for good."

"We can't wait that long," Manling Victor said.

"I agree, my bet with Icefang is due on Samhain," Vainqueur said. "We shall destroy the fairies of this mountain, collect all their treasure, and then move on west."

"If you want to clean it up for me, that's great!" Goblina immediately jumped on the occasion. "Just say the word and I will supply you with all you need!"

"Excellent choice," Vainqueur said, happy to be paid for something he would have done for free. "I want gems assorted to my [Psi-stone], to cover my scales with, a throne, and an army of carriers to lift me all the way to the summit. I am too important to walk, and I must preserve all my energy for the fairy hunt."

"A mountain dungeon crawl should motivate Kia to help," Manling Victor nodded.

"What about her?" Vainqueur asked, annoyed. "She did nothing to help with the conquest! She just sat and sulked!"

"I say you ditch her, Vic," Goblina said. "Remember our Vizier curriculum? Trying to corrupt a [Paladin] fails more often than not. It's not worth the risk."

"Yes, you should breed with finer stock," Vainqueur nodded fiercely.

"It is Your Majesty who tried to set us in the first place!" the Vizier pointed out, confused.

“That was *before* she corrupted my niece.” The dragon shuddered. “I will admit that she is a powerful minion, but she needs to correct her undragonly behavior.”

“I’m sure she will get around it,” Manling Victor said, too hopeful and innocent to give up on Knight Kia.

“Also, Vic, if you could save our wine cellar from her, that would be great.”

Vainqueur dismissed his chief of staff. “Minion, I give you two days of holiday, until I have eaten my fair share of cattle and rested. Now, goblin, about this throne...”

Since he had some time off, Victor decided to pay a visit to Kia first, before exploring the city. Knowing her, he aimed immediately for the palace’s bar.

As he walked through the corridors among guards and oni soldiers, Victor thought that while he preferred the old armor’s design, [Moloch’s Hide] felt more comfortable, warm and light. He blamed the strength increase it provided, alongside its fire-based abilities. From what he had understood, the armor was a gift from Happyland’s board of directors, shaped from the corpse of the archdemon Moloch and empowered by runes from all its corporate overlords.

Thinking about it made him want to apologize to Miel all the more.

He finally found his way to his destination, a hall-sized bar in the most exquisite Japanese style. Orange pillars held the roof over a large, mahogany counter, while red lanterns provided elegant lighting; a noble statue of Seng occupied the middle of the room—one much more flattering than the actual goddess. Soldiers from all species, humans, goblins, beastkin, and horned oni, gathered around tables or sofas having a good time.

And of course, Kia remained at the counter, looking grumpy with three bottles of various alcoholic beverages within arm’s reach. Victor immediately noticed something wrong.

The bottles weren't empty, and she didn't look drunk.

Okay, something terrible had happened. He immediately sat next to her.

"Kia, are you alright?"

"Of course not," she grumbled back while glaring at him.

Ah. "You're still mad?"

"Why wouldn't I?! I thought you were a good influence on Vainqueur, and then you convinced him to help that goblin!"

"But people love the new government! They call Vainqueur, Goblina, and I the *Three Unifiers!*"

"Because you shattered the country and then pieced it back together!"

"Kia, Goblina and I go seven years back," Victor defended his choice. "Isn't it the [Paladin] way to help a true friend in need?"

"Not when it involves them conquering a country!" she protested. "And by the way, are you on a first-name basis with all the world's dictators?"

Probably, Victor thought but wisely kept it for himself. "You say that like it's a bad thing," he joked.

Her gaze became unbearable. "This is serious Vic. I'm starting to think that we may have... how to say it..." Kia cleared her throat, as a tentacled, beastkin barman provided her with a bottle of saké. "Irreconcilable karma differences."

"Hey, I'm not evil, just a loyal friend!"

"You wear demonic armor and summon fiends in battle, what more do you need?" Kia took the bottle, sipped its content, and then spat it back. "And why does every drink here taste like saltwater?!"

"What do you mean?" Victor frowned, examining the four bottles. It looked like alcohol alright.

“Try it,” she said, giving him her saké. The Vizier grumbled, removing his helmet as the barman gave him a glass.

Ugh, he hated it the second it touched his tongue. Not his kind of drink.

“Tastes like saké to me,” Victor said after sampling it, Kia immediately handing him a beer bottle. He sipped and found this beverage strangely tasty. “It’s... it’s...”

It was great!

By the gods, this flavor... this perfect mixture of fruitlessness and sugar, of milk and honey. It was the taste of a lost carefree childhood, of his first kiss, of his happiest days, all distilled into one unique sensation.

It felt like drinking divinity itself!

“Hey barman, what is this?” Victor asked, immediately addicted to the stuff. Not getting drunk no longer sounded like a punishment.

“Onigumo Beer, Victor-sama,” the barman answered. “We milk giant spiders for their juice and then distill it with alcohol. I am pleased that you like it.”

“When I drink it, it tastes like saltwater,” Kia grumbled while looking at the other bottles, all of them local beverages. “All of them.”

Could it be... “Barman, do you have foreign drinks?”

“Very few of them, Victor-sama. With the plague on the continent, the government closed the borders to avoid its spread. We can no longer import much.” Still, the tentacled barman looked under the counter for another bottle. “However, for you Victor-sama, our secret stash will always remain open.”

“Vic,” Kia spoke up grimly, her hand tight around her bottle.

Ah, here it was. The reason why she had to get drunk in the first place. “What’s going on?”

“He is in town, Vic. *He* is in town.”

Victor’s hold over his scythe tightened. “Mag Mell?”

“No. Worse.”

Kia turned to face him, her eyes looking into his own like twin abysses capturing all light in the world. The eyes of a shell-shocked veteran of countless harassment attempts, door proselytism, and random stupidities.

“*Orknoob.*”

Victor remained shell-shocked for several seconds, as his mind struggled to process the cursed word.

Orknoob. Orknoob in fantasy Japan.

“Oh, gods.” Oh, gods, it made so much sense. “He is here? In the bar? Is he behind me?”

“I heard the guards talking. He is on a ‘holy pilgrimage,’ spreading his ideas to ‘waifus and husbandos’ to the capital.”

“Oh, gods... oh, gods, this may be our only chance to get him.” He had lost count of the number of times the Esoteric Order of Isekai harassed him or got on his nerves. “It has to stop, Kia. It has to stop. Someone has to make it *stop!*”

“Are we up for the task?” the [Paladin] asked, unsure of herself. “I can’t fathom the number of people who want that nuisance gone... and he’s still alive.”

Victor grimly pondered the problem. “We may need to bring Vainqueur,” he admitted. “Burn it from above. Don’t give him a chance to escape. Where is he?”

“The *Waifu District.*”

“The Waifu... the red-light district?”

“That’s why I hate Japan.”

The barman finally found what he was looking for, a foreign red wine bottle. Victor asked for two glasses, one for him, and the other for the [Paladin].

“Saltwater,” Kia said, while Victor found the taste exquisite. She turned to the barman with an angry scowl. “Is this some kind of joke?”

“Of course not, sinful apostate.”

“Then could you please bring me another—” Kia demanded, before stopping mid-sentence. “Wait, what did you say?”

“Of course not, scumlike unbeliever.”

The Paladin instantly unsheathed her sword, the guards turning at her while ready to intervene. “You poisoned my drinks!”

“Of course not, godless trash. This is divine punishment from the goddess.”

Intelligence check successful.

Oh.

Oh...

How could he tell Kia without breaking her sanity?

“Vic, what’s going on?” the [Paladin] asked, immediately noticing his unease. “W-what’s happening?”

“Kia,” Victor cleared his throat. “Promise me that you will remain calm.”

“Why are you looking at me as if I got cancer?”

“There is no need to be kind to scum like her, honorable Victor-sama.” The Vizier found it amazing how that barman could mix respectful politeness and passive-aggressiveness in a single sentence.

“What is happening to me?” The Paladin asked, losing her cool. “What’s happening?! I demand to know!”

Victor rehearsed his next words in his mind, trying to find a way to deliver the news softly and painlessly. “You remember the mermaid, at the whiskey sea?”

“The one pretending to be Seng?”

“Yeah, she... she wasn’t pretending, and she didn’t take it well.”

And then Kia understood.

It was astonishing to somehow see her black, tanned skin turn white in an instant; her strong eyes betraying an expression of abject terror, as she glanced at the bottles with a look of pure, absolute despair.

And then the barman delivered the *coup de grace*.

“Yes apostate, for denying the goddess Seng’s divinity, all alcoholic drinks, from the poorest grog to the reddest wine, shall taste like saltwater to you!” the barman declared loudly. “No longer will you get drunk! The pleasures of taverns are forever barred to you!”

That day, Victor learned that in the world, there were sentences that could utterly *destroy* someone. Words carefully tailored to tear even the strong-willed to pieces.

At that very moment, something broke inside of Kia and never came back. Victor hugged her, and let her cry on his shoulder for five hours straight.

For she would remain sober, in a world where Orknoob yet lived.

Chapter 105: Orknoob Unchained

Welcome to Loli House.

Victor observed the building in front of him with a mix of astonishment and awe at the sheer audacity. Orknoob's lair in the Waifu District looked like a giant pink and white dollhouse straight out of a Barbie commercial. He counted at least two floors, with the windows closed for privacy. It contrasted strikingly with the other buildings nearby, which were clearly brothels; if anything, it reinforced the uncanniness of the place.

How did they manage to make something so *innocent* look so *shady*?

"Oh, is this a dollhouse for Gorynych?" his zmey asked, hitting the ground with his back leg like a rabbit. "Gorynych loves elf dolls! They're *pretty*!"

As he glanced at the wooden doors, Victor strongly considered calling Vainqueur and carpet bombing the place. He couldn't be seen entering this establishment!

But for the sake of ending Orknoob's reign of terror, all sacrifices were acceptable. The fomors only killed their victims; Orknoob made them live forever in stupidity.

"We have surrounded the building and cast all the spells you asked for, sir," a skeletal spellcaster, one of his newest recruits, told Victor.

"[Dimensional Ward]? [Anti-Teleportation]? [Non-Detection]? [Shroud of Misfortune]?"

"Yes, we checked your *entire* list, and then double-checked it," the creature somehow sighed, in spite of lacking lungs. "Isn't it a bit excessive for a single orc?"

“This guy is a malicious Bugs Bunny,” Victor replied. “Can you imagine the number of people who want him dead, and yet never got around to do it? So triple-check!”

The spellcaster rolled his bony shoulders and returned to his post, grumbling about paranoia. “Just stay outside and catch anyone who isn’t me,” Victor told Gorynych. “*Especially* if it’s an orc!”

“Aw, Gorynych doesn’t like orc dolls! They smell worse than Gorynych’s home!”

Gathering all his courage, his scythe in hands, and his body protected by the best armor in all of Happyland, Victor opened the doors and stepped inside the dollhouse. At least Kia was too devastated by her curse to join and watch this fiasco.

The owners had gone so far as to perfume the entrance hall and paint its walls with flashy colors. Victor approached a desk right next to stairs towards the rooms above, finding a doppelganger behind it.

It wasn’t the first time he met one—having fought a few during the Nightblades’ attack on Murmurin—but this one was slightly different. His body was completely white and featureless, like a statue of white clay, save for a tie and a red ribbon. The creature immediately waved a hand at him.

“Oh hi, honored guest!” the receptionist spoke, Victor immediately understanding it thanks to [Monster Kin]. “Welcome!”

“I’m just visiting,” Victor said hastily.

“They all say that,” the doppelganger replied with a laugh. “It is fine, client-sama. You are not going to go to jail.”

The doppelganger sounded so nice and yet so sleazy, that it gave Victor shivers. “I’m, I’m just looking for one of your clients, an orc called Orknoob...”

“Mr. Orknoob? How nice! He is one of our best clients, I am so happy that he recommended our establishment to you. You can find him on the second floor, room eight. Do you want the threesome or the ‘Little Sister’ formula then?”

“No, I just want to talk to Orknoob.” And probably kill him. “Then I will leave and never come back.”

“Come on, don’t be shy! You risk nothing.” The doppelganger raised a little bell, a door opening in the wall. Victor hadn’t even noticed it due to the paint work. A new doppelganger stepped into the hall, glancing at Victor, before instantly changing its shape.

“Onii-chan!”

Within seconds, Victor found himself staring at would have looked like his little sister, if he ever had one. A teenage or so tiny creature with long black hair, amber eyes, and a feminine version of the Vizier’s own face. She wore a cute little brown dress that made her even more adorable.

“Onii-chan!” The false little sister smirked at him with big fake eyes. “I love you, onii-chan!”

[**Madness**] negated by [**Claimed by the Moon Man**].

“What the Happyland is that *thing*?!” Victor protested.

“As you can see, all our lolis are adult, consenting doppelgangers,” the receptionist said with a cheerful tone. “You can satisfy all your fetishes with a clean conscience, and without violating any law.”

“No, seriously, I’m not interest—”

“*Onii-chan!*” The loli jumped at him like a lion on a zebra. “I’m a virgin!”

Skill check successful!

Victor quickly protected his purity by using his scythe as a pole, keeping the tiny monster away from him. “Don’t approach me!” the Vizier kept the

creature at bay, the false little sister trying to find a way to get past the weapon. “I’m telling you if you don’t step back...”

“Girls, a client cannot overcome his psychological blocks.” The receptionist cast a spell, its nice, beautiful voice echoing through the building. “Please come help him ease up with our Moe overload special!”

More hidden doors opened, and a pack of ravenous monsters surrounded Victor.

Dozens of fake, shapeshifting little girls with colored hair entered the hall, each of them catering to a different fetish. A pink-feathered magician girl; a blonde angel looking like a younger version of Miel; a tiny creature with tanuki ears; even a goth!

Victor immediately did the brave thing.

He fled through the nearest stairs, pursued by a pack of false, screaming little girls.

Faster than his pursuers, he reached the first floor of the hotel, long hallways with numbered doors. Some of them opened, doppelgangers trying to flank and jump at him. Using his wings, the Vizier flew over one, pushed another back with his scythe, and raced across the hallway while trying to locate the stairs to the second floor.

“I like mature women!” Victor shouted while dodging the doppelgangers, his training bearing fruits. Unfortunately, he quickly found himself surrounded in a T-shaped hallway.

“Onii-chan, I’m one hundred years old!” a girl with long green hair shouted, dressed like some ancient priestess. “That makes it okay!”

“[Ars Goetia: Happyland Battle Harem]!”

A group of mature succubi, marilith, and Malfy appeared to shield him from the enemy horde. “Sir, what—”

“No time, protect me!” Victor ordered one of the marilith, as one of the succubi was tackled to the ground by five doppelgangers. His summons immediately formed a defensive battle line, keeping the teenage-looking monsters at bay.

“Wow,” said Malfy, as he glanced at the enemy and instantly put the two and two together. “Even *we* didn’t go this far! I am impressed!”

“Why are you even here?” Victor asked, trying to find an opening.

“You summoned me, Mr. Victor. When a *hero* calls, I answer.”

Victor remembered Vainqueur boasting about a new Perk of his improving the summoning ability among his minions. Nice.

He remembered using [Black Horseman] to summon Noircœur the horse without an additional freerider though. Did it only work if he had another minion that fit the same category as the one called?

Also, why was Malfy summoned by a *demon harem* spell?

...

“Questions for later,” Victor spoke out loud, locating the stairs to the second level, leaping over the battleline, and leaving his soldiers to contain the doppelgangers flood. He quickly found the door of room eight, opened it, closed it behind him, then barricaded it with his scythe without looking back. Furious tiny hands scratched on the other side, but couldn’t get in.

This place needed to be *burnt to the ground*.

“Hey, it’s a private gathering!”

Victor turned around, finally meeting Orknoob face to face.

He looked exactly as the Vizier had imagined; a skinny, green-skinned orc with short red hair, wearing the standard Japanese novel attire of pants and a sweatshirt. A silver-haired loli with crimson eyes had tied him to a chair, sitting on his lap like some twisted hostage interrogation scene.

“Onii-ch—”

“[Sleep],” the Vizier immediately cast a spell, the fake loli falling unconscious to the ground. Crisis averted. “[Chains of Misfortune].”

Fiery chains bound Orknoob, making the orc moan in a way that bothered Victor.

The Vizier quickly scanned the area with a glance, identifying it as an expensively decorated bedroom. Besides Orknoob and the unconscious doppelganger, a dashing rogue sat around a table in a corner, looking at the scene with apathy and a glass of wine in hand. A dandy with hair and a short beard dyed red, the man dressed in an outrageous, feathered costume that wouldn’t disgrace a peacock.

“What’s happening here?” Victor asked, asking the dandy for his angle.

“I don’t know,” he replied in common while sipping his wine. “I’m hanging out with that trash because he paid me to.”

“You aren’t going to interfere?”

“No.”

Great.

On a closer look, it appeared that Orknoob and his host were busy reenacting a scene from some kind of manga or anime...

“After careful consideration, I don’t want to know,” the Vizier said, moving in front of the captive orc.

“Oh, you’re approaching me?” Orknoob asked, immediately sending terrible alarm signals. He sounded awfully calm and confident for someone bound to a chair.

“So we finally meet, Orknoob,” said Victor. “You can’t imagine how long I waited for this moment.”

“You’re a fan? You know it isn’t the first time I get chained by an admirer, but you’re the first to look like Momon!”

Victor didn’t understand the reference and didn’t care. “A fan,” the Vizier replied icily. “Yeah, you could say that.”

“Well then, you got lucky! Since my powers are at their maximum on this waifu day, if you donate me three thousand gold coins, I can send you to America, where all women are cowgirls!”

Victor removed his gauntlet, revealing the Moon Man’s mark on his left arm.

“Oh,” Orknoob said, realizing that Victor came from Earth too. “Oh... Sayonara then!”

You activated Orknoob’s [**Spell Trap**]!

Instant casting of the spells: [**Accelerated Teleportation**], [**Help Signal**], [**Summon Planar Bodyguards**].

Teleportation negated. Signal countered by [**Non-Detection**]. Summoning spell bounced back.

“Ah, I see you came prepared,” Orknoob said with a cheeky smile, as he tried to free himself. “Nice try.”

He struggled against the chains, expecting them to drop...

But they didn’t.

“Ugh!” Orknoob struggled against the chains. “Why? Why are they holding?”

“Paralysis from [Chains of Misfortune] cannot be negated by items nor Skill checks,” the dandy observed lazily, while Victor moved behind the orc to remove all his magical gear. “You need to succeed on a Luck check.”

“Damn!”

Thankfully, adventurers rarely buffed their Luck.

As Victor had expected, Orknoob had a wealth of magical items on himself. Two [Rings of Skill Boosting], one [Ring of Emergency Teleport], one [Brooch of Free Movement], [Hastened Shoes], a [Belt of Perfect Disguise], [Bracers of Improved Bluff], and a [Mini-Circlet against Greater Divinations]. A short magical examination also indicated a miniaturized [Magical Rope of the Escape Artist] hidden in his ass.

No wonder nobody else caught him before. Victor felt glad to have attended that [Ultimate Jail Security] seminar at Scholomance.

“What’s your name?” he asked the prisoner.

“Orknoob!”

“No. What’s your *real* name? Your Earth name?”

“... Timmy,” he said, sounding ashamed.

“Why, Timmy?” Victor couldn’t help but ask. “Why, *Orknoob*?”

“Because you have to be gay to play with the Alliance!”

Victor slapped that homophobic Horde-scum right in the face.

“You hit me!” Orknoob complained, reciting a script. “Even my father never hit me!”

Victor slapped him again.

“Begone, thot!” Orknoob giggled as if he enjoyed it.

“Stop talking like that!” Victor snarled, slapping him for the third time while the nameless dandy watched on with mild curiosity. By the Dread Three, the orc was even worse in person than in the Vizier’s imagination! It felt dirty to touch him!

“Okay, okay, I’ll stop!” Orknoob pleaded as Victor prepared to hit him again, the Vizier holding his hand back at the last second. “Is this about the lolis?”

“I don’t give a damn about the lolis! Even if I’m burning this place to cinders when we’re done, and salt the earth afterward.” Frankly, sleeping with fiends probably trumped that particular fetish. Victor couldn’t really criticize Orknoob on that front. Everything else, however...

“What do you want then? A refund?”

“Let’s start with answers. Why did you spread all those stupid lies?”

“Man, you don’t get it! This world *sucks*!” Orknoob complained, the wording giving Victor flashbacks of his early years. “I was just living my life when that giant dice reincarnated me among the orc tribes! They were all stupid and insane!”

“So you invented a scam religion? Where is the logic in that?”

“It was an accident alright! I told them about Earth and they were stupid, so I figured I could make some money out of the donations and sleep with lots of gullible girls... All according to—”

“If you say ‘all according to Keikaku,’ I’ll strangle you with my bare hands.” Indeed, as Victor suspected, it was all an ignominious scam. He didn’t even believe in his own farce, making Victor’s own insurance fraud look saintly in comparison. “Can you imagine the number of times your followers harassed me? You give every Claimed a bad name, and your scam defrauds innocent people!”

“Look, I, I died in the throes of a midlife crisis, it wasn’t my fault!” The wretch attempted to appeal to Victor’s sympathy, but it didn’t work. *At all*. And since neither magical escape nor sympathy could help, he moved right down to bribes. “I dodged taxes all my life, I can pay you a lot if you let me go!”

Victor just glared at this humongous pile of shit, before casting a quick [Silence] spell on him. He didn't have ground to pass a moral judgment on that hateable orc, but getting rid of him would feel so good.

"What are you going to do with him?" the nameless dandy asked, as Orknoob kept begging silently.

"Shove him in a dwarf rocket and exile him to the Moon. Or maybe Mars."

The man raised an eyebrow, vaguely interested, before offering him a glass of his own. Victor politely declined. "Who are you anyway?" the Vizier asked.

"Ludvic Van."

The name jogged some memory, with Victor remembering Henry's old advice about class specialization, an eon ago. "Wait, you're the one who discovered the [Fiendish Rake] class?"

"Alongside [Red Mage], all the seduction-oriented Perks, and most diplomacy oriented classes. Orknoob hired me to coach him in persuasion and pick-up, although the current setup is entirely his idea; I hate this place as much as you do."

"You're an expert on the [Seducer] Perk?" Victor asked, happy to have someone to discuss it with.

"[Seducer]?" the dandy chuckled. "That's *cute*. In my life, I have slept with twenty thousand women, fifteen thousand men, and one thousand two hundred genderless creatures. I have bedded creatures from all species of Outremonde, visited all available planes of existence, tried everyone and everything. I even wore a [Belt of Gender Swapping] for five years, to experience love from both sides of the fence."

"You did... *everyone*?"

"*Except* the creatures of this house. Even I have standards, unlike the orc."

"Sorry, but you don't seem that attractive to me."

Ludvic Van put his glass away, then showed a ruby necklace around his neck. “This is an [Amulet of Repulsiveness],” the dandy explained. “It reduces the wearer’s charisma by eighty percent.”

He took it off.

Charisma check failed!

All went white.

It was as if a bomb had exploded right before Victor, blinding and deafening him for several seconds. When he returned to reality, the dandy had put the amulet back on, while Orknoob had started drooling, his pants soiled and a blissful smile on his face.

“You’re still standing?” Ludvic said, sounding impressed. “You must have an iron will.”

“How... how many?” Victor asked, astonished.

“More than three hundred. I only took levels in classes with S in charisma, used stat boosters, collected every Perk available... Without that amulet, I can no longer function in society.”

“Werewolves?”

“Their moon orgies got boring after the first. Also, they have fleas.”

“Angels?”

He simply laughed.

“... dragons?”

His face clearly darkened. “I seriously don’t recommend it. They’re only after your money, and they charge a *fortune* for the privilege.”

“I feel like a naive young student meeting the master.”

“You’re goddamn right.”

“Why do you sound so... so bored then?” Victor asked, frowning. He had stated his incredible feats with complete emotionless detachment.

“I have nothing left to discover,” he sighed. “That’s sad to say, but you get tired of everything. I yearn for new interesting challenges, wandering the world in case I missed something...”

“Like telepathic spiders?”

The dandy raised an eyebrow. “How many legs?”

“Ten.”

He shifted on his chair. “I’m listening.”

“Moonbeasts? Shantaks? Star Spawns of Cthulhu?”

“You had my interest... but now you have my arousal.”

As Victor thought, he may have explored all of Outremonde and the planes, but not everything. And he had even fewer standards than the Vizier himself. “I can send you to the Moon. Not the Orknoob way. We have a portal there for guests, with a carpet.”

“And what would I have to pay for this service?”

“You said you had visited the planes? Heaven?”

Ludvic nodded slowly, every movement suddenly oozing sex appeal. “Yes, you can easily planeshift with the [Fiendish Rake] class. That’s its purpose, to visit partners from all corners of the multiverse; one cannot limit their pleasure to three-dimensional existence. I can teach you that class if you wish, but I have to ask: for what purpose?”

“First, I need to go to Heaven. There’s an angel I need to apologize to, and I would like to do it in person. Second, I have died three times already, and I

would like a way to talk my way out of confrontations. I figure increasing my charisma is the way to go.”

The dandy played with his beard, considering his words. “Do you have fifty or more points in vitality, charisma, and agility?”

“Yes.”

“Did you have ritual sex with a demon lord?”

“Only for better grades.”

“Then you should have everything to gain a level in that class, but I must warn you... the way of the [Fiendish Rake] is long and arduous. You will need to go through deadly ordeals, and even with your current stats, there is no guarantee that you will survive. Is your quest truly worth the trouble?”

“It is.” Victor knelt before this paragon of seduction, while Orknoob drooled and the loli knocked the door in the background. “Please teach me, master.”

Chapter 106: Last Minute Merchants

Silence ruled the mountain.

As he flew over the forests surrounding it, Vainqueur's sharp senses failed to pick up any sound outside of the wind. The goblin had warned him of fairies making their lair around the area, but none had intercepted them so far. Birds and animals had also emptied the area for miles. He could smell warm, decomposing flesh on the ground, listen to the sound of buzzing flies, but otherwise, the land seemed *empty*.

"Your Majesty!" Manling Victor called out from his zmey's back, a depressed Knight Kia holding him by the waist. "Look!"

Vainqueur glanced down, noticing a trail of rotting plants starting in the middle of a forest and progressing all the way to the mountain's shining crater. Grass had turned purple, trees had been uprooted, and the remains of deers, pigs, and fairy thralls paved this sinister road. The line was completely straight, unnatural and methodical.

Vainqueur briefly thought of his poisonous dragon cousins, who ruled the marshes and bogs of the world. Yet, if one had caused this disaster, he would have expected acid pools, random devastation, and vermin to settle in the area.

Instead, whatever creature did that made a beeline for the crater, killed *everything* in its path, and chased away all the locals for miles.

"This reeks of undeath and rot," Vainqueur hummed the air.

“Yeah, I can *feel* the necromantic energies from up here. No wonder normal wildlife ran away.” Manling Victor turned to his fellow rider. “See, Kia? We may fight someone tough enough for you!”

“It’s all meaningless,” she replied, her eyes wandering in the distance. “All meaningless.”

Useless! Vainqueur knew she would prove unworthy of being in his party, and time proved him right! She didn’t even have the strength to ride on her own griffon, forcing Manling Victor to give her a lift on his zmey’s back!

The dragon said they should have left her behind, but Manling Victor, thinking only with his breeding sword, insisted on taking the knight along. He truly needed to push his minion into the arms of a tastier, better partner. Where was Batling Charlene when he needed her?

As they reached the frosty mountainside, Vainqueur smelled a familiar scent nearby, immediately diving instead of continuing the ascension. Within seconds, he found a fellow dragon eating roasted pigs, surrounded by a manling, a wyrmling, and a pile of items.

“Cousin Genialissime!” Vainqueur announced his presence from above.

“Cousin Vainqueur!” The other dragon abandoned his food to wave a hand at him, his dragonling looking up at his parent.

“Henry!” Friend Victor greeted his fellow manling. “Long time no see!”

“Gorynych says hello too!” the zmey said with much less gracefulness, landing nearby.

“A zmey.” Genialissime looked at the creature with disgust, but unlike Vainqueur did not ignore its existence. Instead, he turned to his dragonling, to better warn him. “And that is why you cannot hump your sister!”

“Gorynych too young for that!” the zmey defended his nonexistent honor, while his rider climbed down from his back, Knight Kia remaining where she was, lost in her own mind.

“Is that the Shining Knight?” Manling Henry asked upon noticing Kia, completely mesmerized. “Oh my gosh, oh my gosh...”

“She’s had a tough day,” Friend Victor replied. “She needs rest.”

“Yes, forget her,” Vainqueur replied, focusing on dragon matters. “What are you doing here cousin? Eating trolls and burning forests for money?”

“I *am* making money, but we have nothing to do with this slaughter.”

Manling Henry glanced at a roasted pig. “Something killed it with an [Insta-death] effect, alongside scores of animals and plants. A very powerful [Lich], [Reaper], or more probably, a local Shinigami monster.”

“And it left no loot behind,” Genialissime complained.

“Whatever it was, it came only to kill,” Manling Henry said grimly.

“Concerning,” Vainqueur replied, but figured out he would kill whatever caused it when they raided the crater. His eyes settled on the pile of items nearby. “If it is not the loot left behind, then what is this?”

“Ah, but my newest stroke of genius!” Genialissime boasted. “You see, I was discussing with Henry the best way to make money as a dragon, and I realized something. You remember how many people asked me for help committing suicide in the past?”

“Sometimes, I wonder if the lesser races take our help for granted,” Vainqueur nodded. “We do not have to help them die, but we do it for free. I say we should charge them for the privilege.”

“My thoughts exactly. I always collected the things they left behind, swords, ringies... but they weren’t shiny enough for my hoard. So Henry suggested we sell them!”

“Like a merchant?” Vainqueur was appalled. “But that’s minion work!”

“Which is why Henry does the sale while I provide the unshinies and supervise,” Genialissime replied with pride, having found the perfect

loophole. “My chief of staff even oversaw a deal with this goddess of commerce, Shesha.”

“That greedy snake?” Vainqueur breathed smoke. “She is treacherous and overpriced.”

“I know how much she hurt you, Cousin Vainqueur, but Manling Henry managed to secure an advantageous deal.” Genialissime showed them his hand and the golden, Ouroboros ring on it. “This tele-ring teleports us to the entrance of dungeons where adventurers are ready to pay extra for emergency supply, and in exchange, we grant her a one one-tenth! Win-win!”

“Money!” the dragonling said.

“My son Courageux is helping us with the business,” Genialissime said, proud of his runt. “I am teaching him how to negotiate, so that he can one day lead his own minion team.”

“We also recover the stuff left behind by adventurers who do not survive the dungeons and sell it again,” Manling Henry said. “It’s working very well so far.”

“Ah, corpse looting,” Friend Victor nodded. “The cornerstone of the adventurer economy.”

“It pays well, at almost no risk to myself,” Genialissime said, proud of his discovery.

“Interesting concept, but I leave it to you,” Vainqueur told his cousin. The dragon preferred to earn his money the dragon way, through conquest and eating lesser creatures. “Still, it would be shameful of me not to help. Minion.”

“Yes?” Manling Victor asked, immediately ready to serve.

“Buy an item for me, with your own money,” Vainqueur asked. “I want a gift.”

“This will be your first sale, my son!” Genialissime told his dragonling.
“Go supervise Henry!”

The dragonling nodded, observing Manling Victor while the minion examined the stash of items. The Vizier immediately zeroed in on a white, translucent gem. “A [Psi-stone of Positive Energy]?” Henry said. “Great choice.”

“Yeah, especially since it can help against whatever creature destroyed the countryside,” Manling Victor said, turning to the dragonling. “I’m ready to give ten thousand for it.”

“More!” the tiny dragon answered.

“Twenty thousand?”

“More!” the dragonling insisted, accepting nothing but the best. “Seventy thousand!”

“Seventy thousand?!” Manling Victor panicked in the face of such a ruthless negotiator. “That’s theft!”

“You too poor?” the dragonling asked. “You too poor!”

“I’m not paying that much!”

The dragonling pouted, looking up at his angry father with confused eyes. “Friend Victor,” Vainqueur whispered to his minion. “Indulge my little cousin once removed.”

“But Your Majesty, my [Claimed by Shesha] perk already offers a twenty percent reduction,” the Vizier whispered back. “It’s *that* overpriced.”

“Minion, if a wyrmling doesn’t understand that the world revolves around his whims, he will grow into a shy dragon. Like a manling! I will not allow this. A dragonling’s confidence and self-esteem must be constantly reinforced, so he grows bold and confident.”

“I assume Your Majesty speaks from experience?”

“Of course. I mean, who else would the world revolve around? Knight Kia?” Vainqueur laughed at his cunning joke.

“I also suppose that Your Majesty won’t share this purchase’s cost?”

“Minion, do not be stupid. Do your duty.”

The Vizier sighed, cast a spell, and summoned a bag of gold.

“Getting bullied by a dragon child...” Manling Victor grumbled, before offering the payment to the happy Courageux. “I wonder how long it will take for my checks to start bouncing now.”

“Congratulations, Courageux!” Vainqueur acclaimed the dragonling, who raised his head with dragonly pride.

“You negotiated like a true dragon!” Genialissime added while patting his wyrmling’s head. “That’s how you do it my son! You show them how much you’re worth!”

Vainqueur immediately claimed his gift, the stone embedding itself in his spine, right behind his skull. It magically resonated with his own [Psi-stone of Mind-Shielding], creating a soothing sound before returning to dormancy.

You gained Resistance to [**Necromancy**] effects, and you gain twice as much HP from healing magic!

Your [**Psi-stones**] are resonating! You gain +2 to INT and +2 to LCK as long as you wear both!

“I recently recovered a few items, which may interest you,” Manling Victor told Henry. “Especially a magical rope, but I wouldn’t touch it without gauntlets.”

“No money!” the dragonling interrupted, showing himself a true dragon once more.

“Nah, I was looking towards trading it for [Potions of Increased Vitality] or [Elixirs against Fatigue], if you have any. I’ve found a teacher willing to introduce me to the [Fiendish Rake] class, but due to my extremely high level, he suggested a very dangerous, Cybele-sponsored ritual.”

“A ritual for [Fiendish Rake]...” Manling Henry blinked. “The Kamacybele?”

“The Kamacybele.”

“Can you give me an address? I will send you them in bulk. I still owe you one for putting Lavere six feet under; now I can finally show up in Haudemer without risking an assassination attempt.”

“How is Lynette by the way?”

“She is... open-minded.”

Leaving the manlings to discuss their breeding tactics, Vainqueur turned to his cousin. “Will you join us? We shall hunt fairy quarry in the mountain’s crater.”

“I will pass on this one,” Genialissime replied. “My tele-ring is already tingling. However, I heard about you declaring war with the fomors. Is it true that they sent Dragonbane Wotan after you?”

“Yes, and I *destroyed* him.”

Genialissime whistled, impressed. “Well, if they unleashed Dragonbane, then this is truly getting serious. If you ever need help burning the fairy’s nest in Prydain and put them back in their place, my mate and I will happily answer your call.”

“Come to Murmurin on Samhain,” Vainqueur advised. “I must settle a bet with Icefang on that day, and I will go on the warpath right after my inevitable victory.”

“Ah, with pleasure! It would be great if Jolie and my wyrmlings could play together again.”

“A party? Can Gorynych come?”

“No!” Vainqueur snarled, the zmey lowering all his heads.

The dragons exchanged farewells, Vainqueur returning to his ascent while his cousin and his retinue teleported away. Manling Victor and Knight Kia followed right after him.

As they approached the crater above, the energies from the mountain pushed back all clouds in the vicinity; even those summoned by the zmey’s mere presence. Vainqueur pierced through the aurora, sensing its power.

[**Elemental**] attacks will be greatly empowered while in the [**Supercharged Powerstone Field**].

As he flew over the crater’s edge to look within, Vainqueur found his suspicions confirmed.

The mountain was more powerstones than dirt. The inside of the crater wasn’t full of snow or lava, but a landscape of unshiny, rainbow-colored crystals. Crimson and blue stalactites rose amongst flat pink plates, next to countless mining pits. Someone had dug up tons of these crystals recently, turning the area into a radiating cheese.

And as he flew over the place, Vainqueur quickly noticed something within this alien place.

An enormous, reptilian creature was trapped within the crystals below, like a bug in amber. Vainqueur couldn’t properly see the entity beyond a vague, dark shape, but it was huge; even bigger than him!

A disgusting fairy and its minions had settled in the middle of the crater. Manlings wearing black robes with the symbol of that worm, Sablar, formed a circle right above the sealed creature’s head, chanting obscenities in the ancient fomor tongue.

As for the creature leading the congregation, Vainqueur immediately identified him; a monstrous vermin made of various bugs combined into the

shape of a nightmare. The progenitor of the Mell clan, general of King Balaur, and foremost sorcerer among the fairies.

“Mag Mell.” The sight of the creature awoke Knight Kia from her depressed trance, putting a nasty snarl on her face.

Still, he had changed a bit since the last time Vainqueur saw him. A monstrous amalgam of various insects, Mag Mell had kept his spidery lower half and his left centipede arm. But the rest of his body had evolved; a scarab-like exoskeleton covered most of his upper torso, while translucent, moth-like wings allowed it to fly. His eight-eyed head had grown longer and more fishlike, gaining a fleshy lure and gills. A shroud of flies, locusts, bees, and maggots crawled on his body like a living, ever-shifting armor.

And he noticed Vainqueur.

“Knightsbane,” the fairy hissed, turning its horrible head to look at the two dragons looking down on him from above. “Bekele. You *live*.”

Vainqueur did not hesitate, and neither did Knight Kia. Both unleashed fire and flames upon the group without warning; empowered by the area, they burnt twice more than usual.

“[Enhanced Beehive Barrier].” The bees from Mag Mell’s vermin shroud projected hexagons of green light, forming five layers of a thick shield. Knight Kia’s ray of light pierced two and Vainqueur’s flames four, but the protection held. “I sent King Wotan, and he failed. I sent Mell Lin, my own spawn, and he failed. I sent King Balaur, and he failed! Mag Mell is tired of being *disappointed*!”

“And you will die disappointed, fairy!” Vainqueur declared boldly, activating his [Spell Purge] and falling upon that insect like a falcon.

“[Swarmwalker].” Mag Mell’s whole body collapsed into a wide swarm of slithering insects, spreading across the crater like a flood and avoiding Vainqueur’s claws. His manling assistants weren’t so lucky though, the dragon crushing them under his feet.

“Damn, a freaking [Druid]!” Manling Victor spoke up, while his zmey circled above the crater. He and Knight Kia rained spells from above, but swats of the swarm already fled through the mining pits.

“You are late, Knightsbane, too late by half.” A pile of maggots assembled into a facsimile of Mag Mell’s face. “We excavated the stones we need, and the great beast will wake up soon. The servants of my worm already sung it their song.”

“You slaughtered your own thralls, warlock?” Kia taunted the fomor from above as she incinerated its head, only for another to spring up.

Much to Vainqueur’s surprise, the dragon could have sworn Mag Mell’s new swarm face briefly twisted into the briefest hint of regret. “I asked the lords of this land to join us, to share in our power and victories. They refused. So my daughter asked them herself, and when they would not be allies, she made them fuel for her ascension. I wished to create the ultimate weapon against the New Folk who spoil our world... and I *succeeded*.”

He did not sound happy about it.

“Show yourself, coward!” Vainqueur ordered as he incinerated the swarm, hoping that he could somehow kill the fairy this way.

“This is useless, Knightsbane,” the fairy hissed, the last of his swarm crawling away. “The Kaiju will wake up soon, to trample your city to dust. And Mag Mell will *watch*.”

What was a Kaiju? Some kind of food?

The crystals below him began to shake, answering his question.

Chapter 107: Kings of Monsters

Having witnessed an eruption once, when the mountain began to tremble, Victor did the responsible thing.

“RETREAT!”

Gorynych immediately flew away, Vainqueur wisely following right afterward. Within a minute, a resonance spread through the crater, its powerstones fracturing; within the blink of an eye, the crystal landscape shattered like glass.

Instead of an eruption or a fiery explosion, powerstone shards simply flew in all directions. A destructive rain of crystals fell upon the mountainside and the surrounding forest, although both dragons successfully navigated through them. The shards pierced the earth like arrows, becoming shining hills.

“Gorynych saved master from shiny stones!” his mount said with pride, as the stone rain quickly ended. “Gorynych is a good zmey! Oh yes!”

“Holy...” Kia pointed a finger at an enormous shape breaking through the crater.

Mag Mell’s monster had woken up and escaped.

The creature was a true titan, and a terror to behold; a gigantic, one hundred and thirty feet long dinosaur straight out of prehistoric times. The colossus had six limbs, four legs carrying it while two served as its arms.

Meanwhile, the crimson beast’s horned head reminded Victor of a T-rex, albeit one with armored plates protecting most of its upper jaw. A spiky bone carapace covered its back like a turtle, and its long tail ended in a scorpion stinger.

The creature was twice as big as Vainqueur, and the dragon could already lift a horse with one hand!

Worse, it was *fast*. The last of the powerstones hadn't even landed, and the creature had already climbed down the mountainside, trampling trees below its clawed feet.

"A Tarasque!" Kia immediately recognized the monster, even before Victor analyzed it with [Monster Insight].

Tarasque Emperor

Type: Reptile/Giant

Strong against: Debuffs, most magical attacks, Drain, Disease, Fire, Mind-affecting effects, Paralysis, Petrification, Poison, status ailments, Fairy.

Weak against: Acid, Cold, Giantslayer, Scaleslayer.

This progenitor of all lesser Tarasques is a prehistoric dinosaur which grew to gigantic size thanks to powerstones, and one of Outremonde's superbosses. Magical attacks are reflected back at the sender by its carapace, and it can regenerate from almost anything. Programmed to destroy Murmurin by Mag Mell's [**Worldshaker Ritual**], it will move in a straight line towards it, trample half the world on its way there, and finally return home to sleep. Real estate crisis incoming!

Recommended party level: 75.

"It's aiming for Murmurin, in a straight line!" Their empire was on the other side of the world, and even if it would take weeks for it to reach the capital, the creature would kill thousands on its way there. And while weaker than Akhenapep, it shouldn't be underestimated either.

"Onogoro is on its path!" Kia warned, the creature moving towards the Teikoku's imperial city at twenty-five miles per hour.

Intelligence check successful.

“Three hours,” Victor calculated, using both the distance between the city and the creature’s rough speed as a metric. “Three hours before it reaches it.”

“That creature will not get anywhere near my hoard!” Vainqueur declared, caring more about protecting his gold than the city. “I will take care of that animal myself. You, Friend Victor, find me that fairy! I have had enough of his constant meddling!”

The dragon immediately flew after the beast, leaving Mag Mell to his chief of staff. Victor hoped that he could handle the creature on his own. “He cannot have run far,” the Vizier said. “Gorynych, can you survey the mountain?”

“No, Victor, you don’t know Mag Mell the way I do,” Kia replied, having fought the fomor during the war with King Balaur. “He is a crafty coward, who fears anyone stronger than him; enough that he sends proxies after Vainqueur instead of risking a direct battle. He will only go after targets who *can’t* defend themselves against him. Now, knowing that his only goal is to kill as many mortals as possible, what is the most devastating move that he could make right now?”

“... prevent Onogoro city from evacuating, maximizing casualties when the Tarasque reaches it.” With the bonus of luring them away from Vainqueur. “Gorynych, ignore the crater and return to the city.”

“But it has a fence around it!” Gorynych said as if it was some sort of impossible obstacle.

“You can do it, Gorynych!” Victor encouraged the zmey. “I believe in you! You’re in-bred to win!”

[Rally Minion] activated! Your positive reinforcement increased all of Gorynych’s stats!

“[Hasten]!” Kia cast the spell on the zmey, their ride moving so fast, that it quickly out-spaced both the Tarasque and Vainqueur, flying straight towards the capital city.

When the group reached Onogoro within less than an hour, they found out that Mag Mell had gotten there first.

Enormous vines had breached the outer walls, casting down pagodas and houses; everywhere, poisonous flowers released toxic pollen while animated trees, werebeasts, and giant worms fought soldiers in the streets. Victor noticed Goblina confronting a band of giant spiders and fairy hounds at the imperial palace's gates, firing at them with her gunblade. And above, flying ships engaged giant birds in battle.

"How did he summon so many monsters so quickly?" Victor wondered. Everywhere, he could only see chaos. "It can't all be his [Druid] levels."

"Mag Mell can create fairy rings, and teleported entire armies to our backyards during the Century War," Kia said, pointing a blade at the city's port, where huge swarms of insects had gathered. "Look!"

Mag Mell had taken over the deck of a massive frigate, keeping a rift in space opened as monsters crawled through. His creatures swarmed the docks, fighting the surviving crews of nearby fishing ships or military vessels.

"Bekele!" Mag Mell's voice echoed through his insect swarms as the zmey reached the port, his [Hasten] buff dissipating. "You ruined everything. If not for you, Balaur would have... if it hadn't been for *you*..."

"You're not running away this time?" Kia taunted the fomor while unsheathing her sword, "Did it take a soul to give you an ounce of courage?"

"For centuries, I empowered champions, and none succeeded. As you mortals say, if you want something done right, do it yourself. As for *you*," the insectoid warlock glared at Victor, "it is you, human vermin, who taught the dragons how to harness this cursed System."

"Hey, I taught one dragon, who told everyone else!" Victor protested, casting his buffs and activating [Monster Insight].

Mag Mell

Soulcrested Fomor (Fairy/Insect)

Level: 40 (Druid 20 (Entomancer)/Fisherman 20)

Strong against: all status ailments, Poison, Disease, Fairy, Water, Earth, Wind, Insta-death, Physical attacks.

Weak against: Fairyslayer, Bugslayer, Dragon, Fire, Starmetal, and insecticides.

The progenitor of the Mell fomor clan, and one hell of a giant dic—

“[Fisherman]!” Victor shouted before he could finish reading the rest.

“[Fisherman]?” Kia asked, panicked.

“[Fisherman].” Mag Mell raised his monstrous arms, before activating one of the most *broken* Perks ever designed. “[Primeval Abyss]!”

The fomor unleashed a wide, blue pulse across the port.

In the blink of an eye, all the fishing vessels erupted, their cargo growing to enormous size. Monstrous, serpentine fish the length and size of *trucks* emerged from the waters, spilling off the docks, and eating people whole.

Within a second, the docks were overflowing with an army of screaming sea serpents.

All fish within a mile have been transformed into [**LesserLeviathans**].

Fairies. Always trying to imitate dragons, only to come up short.

While his minions left to pursue that cursed vermin Mag Mell, Vainqueur flew after his newest pet. The creature had scales, which were a marked improvement over fairy hounds, but otherwise proved lacking.

It didn’t even have wings!

Vainqueur decided to roast it with his breath and be done with this mess. From above, he unleashed a torrent of flames upon the creature's back, already salivating at the idea of eating a roasted turtle.

His mighty dragonbreath hit the creature's carapace and seared its scales...

The Tarasque did not slow down.

In fact, it didn't even notice! It kept moving towards the city, Vainqueur's flames failing to even affect it!

“[Charged Attack]!” Vainqueur empowered his breath with the mighty power of a [Kaiser], turning his flames into a fiery beam of light.

The light that scourged Lavere and that mummy Akhenapep hit the Tarasque head-on like a rain of destruction; it vaporized trees around the creature and scoured the land itself. Even if the creature was bigger than Vainqueur himself, the empowered, supercharged beam engulfed it entirely. Hitting the carapace first, the dragon flew lower than before, aiming at the right side of the creature.

This time, the beast's scales melted under Vainqueur's almighty power.

As the dragon emperor regained his breath, chunks of burnt flesh had fallen off the Tarasque's right side, while the carapace had turned black. The arm, in particular, had lost so much meat that Vainqueur could see the bones below its festering veins. The dragon smiled to himself.

Yet, the creature did not stop.

It kept moving, and to the dragon's astonishment, its cauterized flesh began to regenerate. A new layer of meat grew below the burnt parts, expelling them onto the ashen ground; the beast shed its skin like a snake, a new arm replacing the old.

Within a minute, the beast was as good as new, with only the ashes on its carapace as a reminder of Vainqueur's failed attack.

Worse, adding insult to injury, the monster hadn't even *peeked* at Vainqueur.

“Look at me!” the dragon ordered, flying right in front of the creature’s head. “Look at me, turtle! [Shining Majesty]!”

His body radiated with the grandiosity of the most beautiful hoard of all. A vision of absolute beauty, that should move even that inbred reptile to tears!

Skill check failed!

BAM!

The beast headbutted Vainqueur out of its way and kept going.

The dragon crashed on the ashes created by his own Perk, only to instantly rise up with rage in his eyes.

This insult would not stand!

Vainqueur glanced at his surroundings, noticing the countless powerstones fragments which crashed through the land; most them big enough to form makeshift pillars, or even hills.

An idea crossed his mind. “[Geomancy]!” he commanded the earth to strike this beast down.

Field Type: Supercharged Powerstone Field.

Effect: [**GreaterElemental Storm**].

Dozens of stones resonated, shining brighter than the sun all at once.

Each unleashed a mighty elemental attack: some exploded into fiery tornadoes, others into icy storms; strong, searing winds swirled around the Tarasque, tearing apart whatever plants had survived Vainqueur’s own carpet-bombing attempt; the very ground opened, spewing spears of stones.

[**Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh**] reflexively cast [**Protection from Elements**]! You are immune to [**Fire**], [**Earth**], [**Wind**], and [**Water**] for twenty minutes.

Even Vainqueur struggled to maintain his balance, battered by the winds and the explosions. The forces he had summoned put his previous eruption and tsunami to shame: the fiery tornados reached up to the clouds, the icy shards could cleave a ship in half, and the stone fragments could easily devastate a manling's house. Even the powerstones that summoned this effect cracked under the strain of the rampant wild magic.

The Tarasque suffered the brunt of it, flames and projectiles hammering it from all angles. Some of the spikes on its back fell off; a stone spear impaled one of its left feet; a cataclysmic explosion blew off half its face.

It kept going.

The chaos slowed it down, but it *kept going*.

The beast powered through the elemental storm like a proud bull through rain, weathering all attacks. When the storm of power died out and left the land in ruins, Vainqueur watched, amazed, as the creature continued its course. Its body repaired the damage done to it in mere seconds, even spewing out the stone spear embedded in its foot.

Nothing could stop this tarasque?

Only because it had never met *Vainqueur* before.

Running on all four, the dragon pursued that creature, refusing to give up.

[Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh] reflexively cast **[Hasten]**! You will move and react twice as fast as normal!

The world became a blur, as Vainqueur ran faster than the wind, catching up with the beast.

Extending his arms, the dragon caught the creature's stinger tail and anchored himself to the ground with his legs. His feet buried themselves in the mud, carried forward by the Tarasque's unrelenting momentum.

Strength check... failed!

Vainqueur tried to stop the creature from moving, but failed. The Tarasque lazily attempted to shake off the dragon from his tail by flailing it around, but the emperor held his prey with an iron grip.

“Stop ignoring me!” the dragon roared in defiance. “[Glitzy Theater]!”

Answering his call, his glorious arena appeared.

It was the first time Vainqueur witnessed it and had he been a soft-hearted manling, he would have been brought to tears. A massive, mile-wide dome of solid, golden light had formed around him, trapping both the dragon and his savage foe within. One could see through its walls, with beautiful pictures representing Vainqueur’s countless victories covering them.

That savage beast didn’t even look up.

Instead, it kept moving forward and hit the nearest wall with its stupid head. The whole dome shook...

And held.

The beast let out a snarl of annoyance, propelling the spikes from its back towards the wall. The bone projectiles bounced off the [Glitzy Theater], unable to pierce through it. The stupid animal hit the wall with its head, unable to figure out a better solution.

The Vainqueur let out a laugh of delight.

At least, until a screech echoed through the dome, as the walls began to move.

The Tarasque pushed the entire cage forward with its hands and head, albeit at a snail's pace.

“No, no, no!” Vainqueur anchored himself on the ground and pulled. With its momentum interrupted, the beast could no longer advance and entered a battle of strength with the dragon.

Strength check successful!

Splash!

Vainqueur fell on his back, the creature's stinger still in his arms. The Tarasque let out a roar of pain as the dragon severed its tail.

Congratulations! You castrated the dinosaur!

That wasn't very nice!

This time, the beast *did* stop: it stopped ignoring Vainqueur. It turned around as its stinger regenerated, staring down at his newfound *master*. The dragon rose back on his back legs and looked up.

And up.

While standing, Vainqueur probably reached fifty feet in height. He could crush a manling beneath his feet, and grab a cow with one hand.

He only reached up to the creature's waist.

The Tarasque towered over the [Augustus], its yellowish eyes oozing animal rage. Vainqueur wasn't impressed. "I will rip off your head the way I cut your tail," the dragon warned, tossing the stinger away and activating [Victory Fist].

Charisma check successful! You infuriated the [**Tarasque Emperor**]!

Emperor? "The only emperor is the one standing before you, you *zmey*!"

Insulted, the Tarasque raised a fist and attempted to squash the dragon like a child. While the beast had great strength, it lacked finesse or any technique whatsoever.

With pathetic ease, Vainqueur dodged the blow, jumped at the creature's head, and poked him in both eyes!

"[Malleus Maleficarum]!" The dragon activated his new weapon, empowering it with a massive chunk of his SP reserve. A phantom, purple

hammer of spiritual energy manifested above the blinded monster's head and hit it.

The mighty blow sent the head back into its shell and caused the Tarasque to stumble. Exploiting the opening, Vainqueur landed on the ground and caught one of the beast's forearms in a choke-hold.

For he was about to expose the turtle to its only weakness.

Strength check successful!

Using all of his limitless might, Vainqueur let out a fearsome roar as he turned the beast's own weight against itself. The much smaller dragon flipped the Tarasque over him, and tossed it on its back!

The monster's carapace hit the ground with a loud crack, blowing dirt in all directions and shaping a small crater. As the creature's head emerged from its shell, its newly regenerated eyes marveled at its own helplessness. All it could do was thrash around, a turtle on its back.

Some would have said the impossible happened...

But impossible wasn't dragon!

"What are you going to do now, turtle?" Vainqueur taunted the creature, preparing to take flight and roast it from above.

The Tarasque embedded its stinger into the ground and forcefully flipped itself over.

Vainqueur blinked at the surreal sight, for the dinosaur now stood back on its legs, its bestial face twisted into an expression of absolute, primal fury. The creature let out a roar that shook the very walls of the [Glitzy Theater], a crimson aura flaring around the ancient dinosaur.

You made the [**Tarasque Emperor**] go [**Berserk**]! It gained the benefit of the [**Hasten**] spell!

Vainqueur didn't see the fist that hit him, even as it sent him flying through his [Glitzy Theater] and halfway across the countryside.

Chapter 108: Pride and Prejudice

That BLEEPing class...

For the first nineteen levels, [Fishermen] were nothing to write about. Low growths, useless abilities like breathing twice longer underwater, a fish animal companion. And yet most civilized nations heavily regulated that class, often killing would be [Fishermen] on sight. Only a destructive maniac could want to max it out.

Because once they capped at level 20, [Fishermen] earned that *broken* Perk!

Victor could only marvel upon seeing it in action. He estimated Mag Mell had raised at least a thousand sea serpents; the scaled terrors swarming the port, its ships, and sometimes fleeing towards the open sea. The fomor had created an army from nothing.

[Lesser Leviathans] were roughly as strong as a level twenty warrior. Dangerous, but individually no match for Victor, Kia, or a Crested adventurer.

When facing *thousands* of them though...

Worse, while the transformation wouldn't last forever, the Perk didn't grant *any* control over the monsters. Mag Mell's [Fisherman] Perk, [Fishfriend], protected him from attacks from most aquatic creatures, like Victor's own protection against [Undead] and [Slime], but a swarm of sea serpents slaughtered his fairy hounds all the same. These things would eat everything in the city, leaving no survivors.

"Gorynych, transform your rain into a [Thunderstorm]," Victor said, extending his own wings to leap off his back. "Kia is in charge now."

“You want to fight the snakes on the ground?” the knight asked, while Mag Mell summoned insect swarms with magic, burying himself beneath a mountain of worms and maggots. “They’re too numerous!”

“I can handle them,” he replied. “Just take care of Mag Mell.”

The Vizier checked his items, including the stuff he stole from Orknoob and pouches of diamond dust hidden in his armor, then leaped off Gorynych’s back before Kia could protest.

Obeying his master’s command, the zmey altered the weather, changing the faint rain that usually followed him with a cackling, windy thunderstorm.

Gorynych’s [**Storm Dragon**] passive Perk changed the weather to [**Thunderstorm**]! [**Lightning**] and [**Wind**] attacks will be strengthened, [**Fire**] attacks will be weakened!

It was nowhere near as powerful as Wotan’s overwhelming tempest, but that would do, zmey. That would do.

Flying down towards the docks, Victor opened the hostilities by carpet bombing them with [**Blackfyre**], incinerating the walkway next to the water. Dozens of sea serpents had their scales seared to its very flesh, the winds only enhancing the fires' spread. Within seconds, a wall of flames stood between the port and the city itself.

The rampaging serpents answered by targeting him, leaping over the water to try and bring him down. Victor defended himself with his scythe, cutting the head of one creature. Instantly, the corpse crumbled to dust, the beast’s soul captured and its life energy drained.

Skill check successful! Critical hit!

As he landed amidst his own flames to fight on the ground, dozens of [**Critical Hit**] messages flooded Victor’s sight, every scythe swing landing a death blow. “[**Pact with the Archfiends**],” the Vizier cast, switching to his demonic form. His armor adapted to his new shape, transforming him into a mighty, armored juggernaut covered in unholy flames.

Unfortunately, the berserk creatures didn't turn back to the sea. They kept coming in waves, forcing him to stay constantly on the offensive to avoid getting swarmed. His vision turned into a blurring image of fish being slaughtered; so much blood was shed, and so many ashes thrown around, that they threatened to extinguish the flames.

Meanwhile, Gorynych and his rider carpet-bombed Mag Mell's vessel with fire and lightning; the fomor had transformed himself into a colossal monster, a hive of millions of maggots united into the shape of a human. The giant swarm attempted to crush the dragon within its hands, only for Kia to blast its 'face' off with a magical sun. The [Paladin] rode the Zmey with such skill, hastening him into a flying killing machine, that the sight made the Vizier jealous.

"[Contagious Lightning]," Victor cast one of those 'critical' spells Kia told him about, raising his scythe at the nearest sea serpent. A crimson lightning bolt came out of the blade, empowered by the thunderstorm, pierced the creature, and then jumped to its three closest fellows.

Critical hit!

Nice, but unreliable.

Unlike Vainqueur though, whose reserves were so huge he could afford to spam his best abilities, Victor had to pace himself. His scythe's life-draining ability allowed him to ignore healing, but he ran the risk of burning through his SP if he only used offensive spells.

Still, he could finally let loose a bit.

"[Nightmare Realm]," Victor cast, upon realizing that he had put enough distance between his allies and himself. "[Charon's Grim Harvest]."

The combination of both attacks was something to behold.

Reality twisted around him, an alien, horror dimension overlapping with the port. A purple mist spread through the area, carrying screaming ghosts with

it. Moaning hellmouths formed on the burning pavement, alongside yellow, phantom eyes and pillars of skulls.

Field changed to [**Nightmare Realm**].

At the same time, phantom sickles floated around Victor, shredding through sea serpents like butter. With their crap Charisma, the beasts couldn't resist the field-effect either; suffering through worse and worse ailments.

[**Lesser Leviathans**] are being [**Drained**]; you are passively regaining HP and SP.

“Fun fact, if you are immune to your own area of effect's damage, go wild!” Victor relished, as he cut through sea serpents left and right. With his SP being automatically refilled, he kept [Charon's Grim Harvest] effect on, the spirit sickles growing more numerous and dangerous. The souls they reaped filled the Vizier's scythe, suffusing their master with necromantic energies.

In fact, he recovered HP faster than the monsters could hurt him. Victor considered calling Noircœur and Chocolatine for help, but neither could survive the current battleground conditions. His demon summons would ignore the flames, but not the effects from [Nightmare Realm] nor the flying sickles.

All in all, he could manage on his own.

“[Piercing Blizzard].”

A howling blizzard hit Victor head-on, extinguishing his flames, smoldering his heated armor, and throwing him backward. The attack hit in spite of his weaker magical protections.

You took supereffective [**Frost**] damage! You lost half your HP!

[**Troll Regeneration**] activated!

Victor quickly regained his footing, looking at the source of the attack. One of the sea serpents, with scales of wood stronger than steel.

His [Monster Insight] identified the creature as a transformed Mag Mell.

Victor glanced at the worm titan fighting his allies. The bastard must have used a [Druid] spell like [Animal Transformation], leaving Kia and Gorynych to fight a decoy. “Even now, even after gaining forty levels and becoming just as overpowered as Vainqueur... you’re *still* afraid of her.”

The remark hit the fomor right where it hurt. “Mag Mell fears no mortal!” the serpent hissed.

“You literally hide beneath a mountain of maggots rather than fight Kia!” Victor taunted him back, casting a spell on himself. “[Frost Immunity].”

You gained immunity to [**Frost**] for ten minutes.

“[Command Animals],” Mag Mell rasped. At these words, a red glint appearing in the eyes of the [Lesser Leviathans]. Instead of rampaging around like before, they all glared at Victor with unified intelligence.

I hate munchkins, Victor thought, realizing why the fairy had taken [Druid] levels.

“[Accelerated Tidal Wave],” the fomor quickly cast once more while still in serpent form, a wall of water surging from the docks to swallow the walkway whole. While the waters barreled against the Vizier, dragging him towards the city, the fomor changed his shape from a sea serpent to a massive shark.

Riding the wave, Mag Mell attempted to bite Victor in half, while backed by sea serpents. Instead of a thrashing mob, the beasts attacked the chief of staff like a coordinated unit, flanking him from all sides.

Thankfully, with the [Brooch of Free Movement] that Orknoob ‘gave’ him, the Vizier reacted faster. He swung his scythe and hit the transformed [Druid] in the head.

However, when he did, the scales unleashed a powerful sonic burst, expelling Victor from the waters and repelling Mag Mell’s own serpents.

Congratulations! You gained the **[Sonic Scales]** monster perk!

[Sonic Scales]: You can grow a layer of singing scales; when they are targeted by a physical attack, the scales resonate to unleash a powerful sonic burst; this is a [Wind] damage effect. You are not immune from [Sonic Scales] damage.

When Victor finally landed, it was in a flooded, devastated park near the port. The wave had uprooted cherry trees and formed ponds amidst the grass, transforming the area into a swamp. Thankfully though, the attack had done more damage to Mag Mell's summons than Victor himself.

Mag Mell emerged from a pond, having regained his true form now that they had moved safely away from Kia's own fight. "[Enhanced Disinte—"

"[Emergency Teleport]!" Victor activated another of Orknoob's items before the lethal spell could hit him.

The item teleported him straight to his room in the palace, where Henry was busy placing the items Victor had ordered before today. He screamed upon seeing a giant demon teleporting right next to him, never having met the Vizier in this shape.

"Later, Henry!" Victor grabbed the potions, raised his helmet, and drank them in bulk in front of the terrified human.

You recovered all your HP and SP! Vitality increased by two stages for half an hour! You are no longer fatigued!

He then used the [Ring of Emergency Teleport] to return to the park, before his area of effect spells could take over the bedroom. His stolen item had a limited number of charges, but it would work well.

Victor appeared right behind a confused Mag Mell and raised his scythe for a killing blow. Maybe he would have, if a sea serpent hadn't shrieked a warning, lunging at his face; another moved in front of the fomor, acting as a shield.

“[Magnetic Field: Repel].” An invisible force pushed Victor back, his armor and scythe repelled backward. The Vizier regained his footing, but found himself on the defensive; cutting down the druid’s creatures took all his focus. The fomor then used the opportunity to buff himself further, adding another layer of thick wooden scales over his body. “[Ironwood Skin].”

Mag Mell’s triumph was short-lived, however, when a phantom sickle bypassed his protection and hit him in the chest. Following its caster, [Nightmare Realm] began to twist the battleground into its Field type, helping Victor deal with the enemy summons.

“[Spirit Ward],” Mag Mell buffed himself, the sickles bouncing back his skin, and then cast spells to increase the size and power of his serpents, “[Poison Fangs], [Monster Growth].”

The sea serpents grew twice larger than before, their sharp teeth growing purple and oozing acid. While Victor’s stellar speed and reflexes allowed him to keep dodging, he found himself overwhelmed; and every time he tried to target the fomor himself with a spell, one of the serpents moved between his scythe and its master.

“You are weak,” Mag Mell rasped, commanding his monsters while remaining safely between an elite guard of them. “I studied you, Victor Dalton. You are the weak link, the keystone. The man behind the dragon, as I was the hand behind King Balaur. Your demise will cripple Vainqueur.”

Victor would have answered with a clever retort, had he not been struggling against giant leviathans.

“You are strong, but we fomors are magic itself. We are power without a soul; power without growth, which can never evolve. You humans are growth without power, weak, but with limitless potential. And now, your potential will go unfulfilled. [Anti-Teleport].”

You can no longer teleport away!

“Wait, you *are* magic?” Something clicked in Victor’s head. “The powerstones...”

“The fossilized remains of my dead brethren,” Mag Mell replied, relishing the spectacle of his summons ganging up on a lone target. “They are ours by right.”

“I assume you aren’t going to tell me why you needed those?” Victor asked since the fomor loved to hear himself talk.

“My daughter needs them for her arrows.” Mag Mell let out a grunt of disdain. “Her foolish belief in this ‘technology’ will be her undoing. *Magic* alone is supreme. This cursed System, this weapon against my kind which Dice foolishly tapped into, was the only thing that allowed you animals to challenge us. But now, I...”

Mag Mell cast a spell, doubling in size until he became as big as Vainqueur himself. This time, he decided to join the fray personally.

“I am power that can grow without limits!”

Gaining classes had caused him to go on a power trip. Good. “I think you forget something. Three things, actually.”

“I forgot more than you will ever learn, mortal,” the fomor replied with supreme arrogance, raising his centipede arm to strike. His blow missed the Vizier, and was never intended to land at all: the magnetic field surrounding the fomor instead propelled the Vizier into the waiting maws of the serpents. “You are slaves to this System; you react to it, while I direct it. I *optimized* it. I created the most powerful class combination in the *world*.”

“Then here’s a lesson about tactics: first, never fight a necromancer by throwing more bodies at him. [Reanimator].” Victor activated his necromancy, exhausting his diamond dust reserve while using the souls trapped in his scythe as material.

Three colossal, ghostly hydras made of dozens of sea serpents’ spirits combined surrounded Victor, their spectral wail repelling their living relatives. The sea serpents attempted to crush and bit the undead, only to phase through.

Aha, he knew it! While powerful, the serpents had no magical attacks capable of hitting incorporeal targets! His [Ghost Hydras], though, tore the animals apart, pursuing them through the park and forcing them away from their master.

“Now it’s just you and me,” Victor told the angry fomor, having pushed his summons away. The fairy attempted to crush the [Reaper] with a summoned boulder rain, but the chief of staff moved faster. “Well, mostly you and me. [Victor’s Skull Sentries].”

Five floating skulls appeared around Victor, firing beams of energy at the giant fomor. After only succeeding in turning the park into a ruin, Mag Mell responded by opening his mouth, unleashing a breath of noxious black slime at both Victor and his necromantic servants. Two melted, while the Vizier barely dodged. A splash of slime hit his armor, seeping through the crack and burning the skin below.

You took heavy [**Poison**] damage! Vitality check successful! You avoided being [**Corroded**]! You lost half your HP!

You earned the [**Bad Breath**] and [**Corroding Poison**] Monster Perks.

[**Bad Breath**]: 90 SP. You can breathe a cone of venomous slime inflicting heavy [Poison] on contact; all those who touch the noxious slime must succeed a hard Vitality check or be [Poisoned].

[**Corroding Poison**]: Passive. When you should inflict the [Poisoned] status on someone, you instead apply the [Corroded] ailment. [Corroded] function as [Poisoned], but can affect even those with [Poison] Resistance and Immunity: Poison Immunity is treated as Poison Resistance, while standard Poison Resistance is ignored.

A perfect combination of classes, powerful natural abilities, a keen tactical mind, and survival instincts honed through centuries. Mag Mell was an ancient monster, and near-invulnerable. The more he thought about his foe, the more Victor knew that he would only drop his guard on *one* occasion.

The moment when he thinks he already won.

“[Darkest Fear],” the fomor cast the dreaded spell on Victor, probably hoping that his poison would instantly kill him once his HP plummeted to one. A lethal combo.

The Vizier felt the dark claws of the fomor’s magic sink into his soul and collapsed into the mud. He made no sound, looking dead while dispelling his sickles and field effect.

“Learn your place, mortal,” the fomor rejoiced, blinded by the idea of a flawless victory. “You [Claimed] have never been worthy.”

Victor held his breath.

“Dispel [Magnetic Field],” Mag Mell said, committing a fatal mistake. His centipede arm approached Victor’s body, to finally claim his trophy. “And now, the things I will do with this half-dragon vessel...”

“[Hasten].”

You will move and react twice faster than normal.

Before Mag Mell could react, Victor cut off his centipede hand by surprise; the blade slashing through his reinforced skin.

The fomor let out a scream of pain, while the Vizier quickly got back on his feet before reactivating [Nightmare Realm] and [Charon's Grim Harvest]. “You should have gone to school,” the Vizier said, covered by the fomor’s green, acidic blood. “Your lack of foresight is *disarming*.”

“[Darkest Fear]!” Mag Mell tried his tried-and-true tactic again, perhaps having thought that he merely missed the first time.

The dark magic traveled through the divine connection between the deities that selected Victor and his own soul, to hit him hard. The perfect weapon against [Claimed], refined over centuries.

Using *his* connection with the [Black Grail], Victor redirected the attack to his artifact, the lethal magic skidding over his soul like water on a windshield.

“Impossible,” Mag Mell rasped in pure shock, before letting out a hiss. The Vizier’s scythe had cut through his chest, but it appeared the fairy had no organ to speak of.

“Second.” Victor raised his scythe at the fomor to strike again, now that his magnetic field no longer shielded him. “You would think someone might figure out a counter if you people keep spamming the *same goddamn spell* at him. I don’t know how long you designed that [Darkest Fear] spell, but it only took me seven bloody years to figure it out!”

“[Iron—”

"[Contagious Lightning]!”

His lightning hit the drenched fomor in the chest, spread to the three remaining floating skulls, and then converged back at the fairy. The sheer volume of electricity surging through the beast turned him into a living neon light.

Critical Hit!

“[Magn—argh!” Victor kept slashing at the fomor, never giving him any time to focus on his spell. He cut one insect leg, then another, moving too fast for the fairy to dodge or retaliate.

One of the things he had learned from Akhenapep. Never give a powerful spellcaster breathing room.

“You want to know why your kind keeps losing?” The Vizier cut one of Mag Mell’s wings as he tried to take flight, grounding him. “It’s not because of the System, because we have the best classes, or because you lacked a soul. It’s because you keep underestimating us, again, and again, and *again!*”

Covered in his own blood, Mag Mell imitated his piper son; he tried to run. “[Swarmwalker],” he rasped, instantly transforming into a hive of insects.

Victor would have none of this. “[Blackfyre],” he said, incinerating the swarm before it could spread and escape like at the crater. The flames spread through maggots and beetles, while [Nightmare Realm] leeched them off. Within seconds, the fairy was forced to reform, this time brought back to his normal height.

Now cornered, Mag Mell opened a portal and tried to crawl through, Victor rushing after him. The desperate fairy came within an inch of the gate...

“[Solar Judgment].”

A beam of light fell upon Mag Mell, incinerating the grass around him and making him collapse. Gorynych overshadowed the wounded fairy from above, its current knightly rider preparing another spell.

But this time, Victor would not let anyone else take the credit.

“And third,” the Vizier raised his scythe, “having a soul isn’t always a boon!”

The fairy looked at the blade, finally realizing that all was lost. “It does not matter,” he declared, arrogant to the end. “My work lives on.”

And with these words, the [Reaper] claimed his due.

His scythe beheaded Mag Mell in one swing, the portal vanishing with his life.

As the blade fell, covered with the fomor’s thick green blood, a screaming, bloody shadow emerged from Mag Mell’s disintegrating corpse; an unnatural, Frankenstein's monster of a soul, a patchwork ghost. Victor couldn’t even properly describe it, as it moved inside his scythe.

With these new additions, the countless souls coalesced within the scythe, changing it. Its magic burnt in Victor’s hands, reshaping it. The rod changed into twisted black wood, covered in whispering faces, while the blade vanished, replaced with an ethereal, phantom edge.

Congratulations! By consuming Mag Mell's artificial soul, your scythe has become the artifact [**Harvest**]!

For defeating the fomor Mag Mell in a magical duel and feasting on his soul, you earned three levels in [**Weathermaker**]! You earned the [**Devil Archmage II**] and [**Apocalypse Storm**] class perks!

+90 HP, +30 SP, +2 STR, +2 VIT, +3 SKI, +2 AGI, +6 INT, +3 CHA, +6 LCK.

[**Devil Archmage II**]: You can learn and cast spells two tiers above your current one. You can also learn and cast spells with the [Evil], [Fiend], and [Weather] traits, but only those equal or below your current tier access; if they belong to an exclusive school of magic, you count as if you met the other requirements. This replaces [Devil Archmage I].

[**Apocalypse Storm**]: When you try to alter the weather, such as with the [Control Weather] spell, add the following conditions to your options: [**Blood Rain**], [**Slime Rain**], [**Acid Rain**], [**Fire Hail**], [**Ghost Storm**], and [**Plague Winds**]. You are immune to the negative effects of these weather conditions, even if you did not summon them yourself.

Kia chanted his name above with her sword, making Victor feel warm inside.

Putting his scythe on his shoulder, Victor prepared to go help Vainqueur, when he noticed new winged forms in the sky. He at first thought about Wotan's Valkyries, especially when he noticed their feathered wings.

Unfortunately, they were far less pleasant to look at.

“Fraudster!” A host of thirty angels circled above him, all of them looking unhappy to be there. “We have answered your call for help, fiend!”

His call? Wait, were these the revived angels that he called more than a week ago? While still in cup form?

...

And they arrived *now*?

Victor facepalmed.

"Public service."

Chapter 109: Minion Recipe

“Tonight, I dine on turtle soup!”

So vowed Vainqueur Knightsbane, as he rose up with a dizzy head and a heart full of wrath. Dirt and grass covered his beautiful scales, the trail his landing had caused going on for hundreds of meters.

The Tarasque’s blow had sent him flying for miles, his golden theater a distant glow collapsing on itself; which angered him even more. The dragon noticed a cloud of dust moving at full speed towards that goblin’s city, far away from Vainqueur himself. The beast would not take its mind off its target, leaving its enemy behind to return to its deadly course.

To a dragon, being ignored numbered among the greatest of insults; right behind having their hoard turned to lead.

Vainqueur almost took flight to chase after the giant in his fury, before stopping himself. Their last clash had shown the dragon that while stupid and lacking in finesse, the beast could match him in brute force. Even his mighty [Geomancy] and a [Charged Attack] could not put it down for long.

Vainqueur needed a *strategy*.

Should he recall Manling Victor and make use of his [Master’s Shield]? That dinosaur cheated with its regeneration, it would only be fair to return the favor. The idea was tempting, but the dragon quickly decided against it. Minions existed to make his triumph greater; to admit that he *needed* them to win his battles would be shameful. Also, the Vizier had already been given a mission, to find that cursed fairy Mag Mell and end his meddling once and for all.

Also, he would only receive a golden shower if he won a duel.

No. For the sake of his pride and income, Vainqueur would win this battle on his own.

What else could help? The Emperor oversaw the battlefield, noticing the fragments of powerstones left behind by the mountain's destruction. These shards had empowered his breath and geomancy both; they even helped send a rocket to the cursed planet Moon!

A magnificent idea crossed Vainqueur's mind.

Quickly, before the Tarasque had enough time to outpace him for good, the dragon flew and grabbed every crystal he could get his hands on. Vainqueur selected only two kinds, for he had standards: the red ones, as beautiful as his own scales; and the green ones, to complement the other color.

These ones glowed a little and made him a little sick, but certainly, they couldn't damage his health. He was a dragon after all.

When he had his arms full, Vainqueur chased after the dinosaur. He waited for his ring to cast [Hasten]... but it never did.

“Ur-Ring, quicker!” the dragon ordered his trinket. Having been hastened itself, the Tarasque now moved faster than Vainqueur could follow.
“Quicker I said!”

[Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh] can only cast **[Hasten]** once per day.

Once per day? What kind of shoddy minion work was that?

Vainqueur strained against the wind, putting all his might into flying faster. His wings flapped so hard, that they raised clouds of dust and uprooted plants on the ground.

Tapping into energy reserves he always knew he had, the dragon flew faster than ever. Faster than the wind. Faster than—

Agility check successful!

BOOM!

Vainqueur caused a shockwave as the world became a blur, powerstones slipping from his claws. His crown almost fell off, and probably would have had it not been anchored to his horns; his vision turned into a tunnel, singularly focused on the distant Tarasque.

By now, the rampaging beast had reached the walls of the goblin city, threatening to punch his bloody way through.

Vainqueur couldn't care *less* about it, but the dragon had said that he would stop the beast beforehand. His honor as a dragon *demand*ed that he triumph. "For my hoard!" the dragon roared, before swallowing his unshiny powerstones.

His stomach hurt, as his inner furnace struggled to incinerate the crystals.

Warning: You have taken [**Fairy**] and [**Nuclear**] damage!

What did fairies have to do with these stones? They always found a way to ruin his day.

In any case, Vainqueur finally reached the Tarasque and hit it from behind, preventing it from smashing through the walls.

Instead, the collision propelled *both* of them through!

Vainqueur tackled the surprised and much larger Tarasque, pinning it to the ground by slamming its head against the pavement. The beast was both bigger and stronger than the dragon, forcing him to use every ounce of strength to keep it down.

Just in time for his stomach pain to stop.

Congratulations! Through assimilating a heavy dose of [**Fire**] and [**Nuclear**] powerstones, your [**Dragonbreath: Fire**] has evolved into [**Dragonbreath: Atomic Fire**]!

It will now inflict an additional fifty percent [**Nuclear**] damage, and give cancer to the survivors!

Vainqueur opened his mouth and fired.

His mighty breath turned into blinding, white flames; the same that the Elder Wyrn used to craft the sun in ancient times. He unleashed it right on the Tarasque's ugly face, melting its flesh away.

The beast let out a roar and freed itself, slamming Vainqueur against a pagoda with one hand. The tower collapsed behind the dragon, crushing a horde of goblins and fairy hounds beneath tons of stone.

“Gojira!” Vainqueur suddenly realized that the tiny people of this city were busy fighting monsters, running in fear of both the dragon and his current opponent. “GOJIRA!”

The Tarasque let out a fearsome roar and stopped trying to move through the city. Instead, it focused on the dragon, slamming him against the ground, and then throwing him against another building.

Activating [Victory Fist], Vainqueur engaged the beast in a brawl; or what could pass for one. Since the Tarasque was twice larger than the dragon, Murmurin's Emperor must have looked like a child trying to beat up its parent.

The dragon waited for an opportunity and focused on defense, avoiding the monster's fists as they pounded the pavement into craters, often decking his foe in the head whenever he could afford to. While he moved faster than his enemy could hit him, any punch from the dinosaur would be lethal, while Vainqueur's own felt no more inconvenient than slaps.

Just fighting in the city caused buildings to collapse around them, and houses to turn into paste.

Finally, the Tarasque briefly tripped on the debris of its own making, Vainqueur using the opportunity to grab it by the arm, turn its weight against it, and toss the monster to the side. The creature rolled on the ground and crashed against some kind of military garrison, stones falling on its back.

While the Tarasque was busy trying to get back on, Vainqueur prepared his trump card. “[Charged Attack]...”

The Tarasque emerged from the debris with a roar, just in time for Vainqueur to unleash his devastating breath. This time, his flames turned bright green; a blast so destructive that it devastated the entire district on impact, melting the ground below and vaporizing anyone unfortunate enough to be in the vicinity. The holy fire turned stone to ashes, and flesh to steam.

The dinosaur walked through the breath, its flesh falling from its bones. It struggled to charge through the flames, slowly yet perilously coming closer. Yet Vainqueur held his ground, his blinding blast powerful enough to nearly toss him off his back.

The fateful blow never came.

When Vainqueur was finally out of breath, only the Tarasque’s charred skeleton stood before him amidst a sea of molten stone. All flesh, every organ had been stripped away by the dragon’s mighty flames, leaving only a towering mass of bones and an empty carapace behind.

“Victory!” Vainqueur raised his arms to the skies. “None can stand before me!”

Finally, he had won!

Once again, he had proved the innate superiority of dragons over all other reptiles. And it had only taken destroying half a city!

Vainqueur’s joy knew no bounds... until the skeleton twitched.

The dragon froze, astonished, as tendons, veins, and then flesh regrew over the bones. Layers upon layers of meat, and then scales, claws, and very angry eyes. Within *seconds*, the Tarasque had fully recovered.

Except now, it shone green.

Congratulations! The [Tarasque Emperor] is now [Radioactive]!

Vainqueur was too shocked to dodge the next blow.

The Tarasque headbutted the dragon so hard, that he felt his ribs *break* for the first time in his long, *long* life. The blow propelled Vainqueur through a pagoda, then another, and finally against the walls of the imperial palace four streets away. The blow briefly knocked the dragon out, his vision blurring.

Warning: Critical Health! [**Bravo Bull**] activate—

As he regained consciousness, Vainqueur suddenly realized the absurd truth.

He had found the *one* creature in the world that he couldn't defeat with force.

The Augustus took some solace in that the creature couldn't defeat *him* either, locking them in an endless duel, but not much. Dragons were at the top of the food chain! They didn't share that spot with some dumb dinosaur!

"I refuse to accept this!" Vainqueur said, vowing to defend the honor of his race. He regained his footing, absentmindedly crushing a giant spider and a goblin squad under his feet. His gaze noticed Goblina and her guard fighting nearby, but the dragon ignored them. He only had eyes for the giant reptile charging at him *right now*.

If brute force wouldn't do... then Vainqueur he would use his brain! *He*, who started with the amazing *root sixty-four* Intelligence score before the System increased it tenfold, would find a solution!

"Menu!" Vainqueur quickly opened his stat screen, reviewing all the Perks he had accumulated over his glorious adventurer career. Maybe he had gained something which could give him the power to win.

His eyes quickly scanned his long, long list of abilities, including some he never used. [Hunter's Resolve], [Imperial Authority]...

... [Monster Empathy]?

[Monster Empathy]: You can make a Charisma Check to improve the attitude of monsters toward you, making them friendlier. This ability works even on wild monsters such as Beast types. Monsters who hate you for a personal reason or mindless automatons such as golems will ignore the Perk.

The very first perk he earned from [Dungeon Breeder], and that he never found any use for. The dragon suddenly remembered what his minion had said, after the final battle against the Forgotten One.

“Your Majesty, this is going to sound very cliché... but don’t you defeat your enemy when you make peace with him?”

At long last, Vainqueur finally understood what Manling Victor had tried to convey.

The dragon had treated the reptile like an enemy when it should have been considered a potential minion! All he had to do, was to show this beast reason and convert it to minionship!

“[Monster Empathy]!” he activated the [Dungeon Breeder] perk, just as the Tarasque lunged at him, claws first. Vainqueur extended his arms, channeling the spirit of dragon forgiveness upon this rueful heathen.

Charisma check with a -30 malus for castrating the **[Tarasque Emperor]** once...

-30? But it regenerated! Nothing personal!

Charisma check...

The Tarasque’s claws stopped within an inch of Vainqueur’s neck.

Successful!

The **[Tarasque Emperor]**’s attitude moved from hostile to neutral.

Floored by the dragon's charisma, the Tarasque couldn't bring itself to harm a true dragon anymore.

So, without skipping a beat, the creature immediately turned its back on Vainqueur and continued its course towards the hoard half a world away.

"Wait!" Vainqueur ordered, moving in front of the beast to make it stop. "How can you wish to destroy my hoard? My beautiful hoard? Why will you not turn the other coin, as I did?"

The creature looked at Vainqueur with its horrible eyes, and let out a series of grunts; [Monster Empathy] translating these signals into rough feelings. Pictures of Murmurin flashed in the dragon's mind, of his overflowing hoard.

*"Destroy, destroy, **destroy!**"*

Such was the looping thought implanted in the creature's head, driving it insane with rage. A magical compulsion that forced it to move forward, to ignore the pain and the glory of a dragon.

"Thou are possessed by the lead spirit," Vainqueur said, putting his hands on the creature's shoulder. "Accept the Elder Wyrn, of which I am the messenger, and you shall be freed from fairy sin! [Spell Purge]!"

Vainqueur bathed the Tarasque in his holy energies, expelling the darkness that took root in its heart. Through the power of his boundless charisma, the beast was soon purged of fairy sin.

Charisma check successful! You lifted the [**Mag Mell's Geas**] from the [**Tarasque Emperor**].

And lo and behold, Vainqueur won.

Instead of a bloodthirsty, rampaging beast, without Mag Mell's ritual driving it mad, the Tarasque immediately became placid. No longer did the fairy's curse force it to chase after the sacred hoard. It had seen the light of Vainqueur's words, and accepted his message of minion peace.

Instead, the Tarasque conveyed a single intent through the empathy bond.

Hungry.

“We shall feast upon cattle, as master and minion,” Vainqueur declared, patting the creature’s carapace. “Serve me and you will never be hungry again; and never shall I! For you shall be my minion, now and forever.”

Minion food?

“Only in emergencies,” Vainqueur reassured the beast. “Only in emergencies.”

The creature seemed to lack the intellect needed to understand the concept, but the promise of free food pacified it.

“Did you... did you befriend *that*?” Vainqueur glanced down, noticing Goblina nearby. The goblin and her forces had slaughtered the fairy thralls, her tiny armor plastered with blood. Clearly, she had been left floored by Vainqueur’s evangelization power.

“I tamed that,” the dragon corrected. “The Tarasque embraced the light of Hoardism and shall henceforth be my minion.”

“Well I guess we won, even if you caused more damage than the invading army,” the tiny goblin said, looking at the trail of destruction the two reptiles left behind. “Hey, who attacked us in the first place?”

Vainqueur extended his arms again, expecting a golden shower for his victory. After all, he had won this battle alone.

But after a minute of waiting, the dragon realized that his minion had been mistaken.

Making peace with your enemies did *not* count as defeating them!

Congratulations! For befriending and taming the [Tarasque Emperor], you earned three levels in [Dungeon Breeder]. You earned the [Alpha Magnetism (Scales)] class Perk!

+60 HP, +30 SP, +1 STR, +3 SKI, +2 AGI, +3 INT, +2 CHA, +2 LCK.

[Alpha Magnetism (Scales)]: Lesser reptilian creatures see you as an alpha worth following. When interacting with [Reptile], [Aquatic], and [Amphibian] creatures, they must succeed on a Charisma check or prostrate themselves in submission; this is a [Mind-affecting effect].

The Tarasque fell before Vainqueur and raised its stinger, a new thought competing with its hunger in this hour of peace.

Breed?

“Not with *me*,” Vainqueur replied, before pointing his left index claw at his new minion. “But I have the perfect island for you!”

Two species saved from extinction.

Vainqueur couldn't wait to brag about it.

Chapter 110: The Heaven Talk

Victor Dalton, Grand Vizier of the V&V Empire, thought he had developed tinnitus for a minute. The world had gone completely silent after he heard Vainqueur's latest words.

"I'm, I'm sorry, what did Your Majesty just say?" the Vizier asked as he regained his hearing, the demolished imperial palace standing to his left as a ruined testament to today's chaos.

"Manling Victor, meet my new minion." The dragon patted the Tarasque's carapace, as the glowing, giant monster feasted on sea serpents. After the battle, Goblina had wisely ordered all the dead [Lesser Leviathans] piled up next to the imperial palace, before the two giant creatures could turn their hunger on the citizens. Even now, goblin and oni guards kept all but throwing food at the reptiles. "It shall breed with my dodos, to father a new generation of emergency rations."

Yeah, Victor still didn't understand. Or rather, he didn't *want* to understand.

How the Happyland did Vainqueur even manage to tame that *thing*? "Sir, it's... it's a Tarasque."

"Yes, minion, you have a gift for stating the obvious."

"Gorynych thinks that it is cute!" Victor's mount said, having been granted fish of his own. The Tarasque looked at the creature's three heads, letting out a moan of happiness while the zmey wagged its tail in response.

"Gorynych has a friend!"

"Your Majesty, these monsters are said to eat entire countries!" Victor protested. "Where will we find the meat needed to sustain it?"

Also, the Tarasque glowed green now. Nothing suspicious there.

“Minion, you do not see as far as I do,” Vainqueur replied. “This creature can regenerate from anything. *Anything*. So we will rip out its entrails, feed them to cattle, and then my new servant shall feast on the cows! The perfect solution to dragon world hunger!”

“How are we even going to transport this thing around?! It’s too big to fit in a portal!”

“Minion, simply mark it with your summoning Perk and stop spoiling my good mood with unimportant details,” Vainqueur dismissed his concerns cheerfully. “For today is a great day! That vexing fairy Mag Mell is, at long last, dead!”

True, and Victor had a new scythe to show for it, but the problem of the Tarasque remained. The Vizier thought about it, figuring out that he could mark the beast with [Black Horseman] while summoning Gorynych with [Zmey Rider]. The [Chaos Rider] imagined himself mounting the Tarasque, a creature greater than even Vainqueur, becoming an almighty lord of destruction that would make Sablar blush.

“Oh...” His vision went white for a second. “Oh...”

On second thought, maybe he could get used to this new monster.

Leaving the reptiles to their victory feast, Victor walked towards the palace’s gate, where Goblina had a drink with her generals and Ludvic Van. Meanwhile, Kia was praying to Mithras in a corner alongside the Arisen angels, doing their best to ignore everyone else with one exception.

She always kept a bound and gagged Orknoob within arm’s reach.

“Nice new scythe, Vic!” Goblina raised a goblet of wine in his direction, imitated by her men. “A great weapon, worthy of today's hero!”

“I still haven’t checked what it does,” the Vizier said, examining it more closely.

Harvest

Quality: S- (Minor Sentient Artifact)

Purpose: Gather as many souls and knowledge as possible.

Material: Fomorian wood.

Endurance: ∞/∞

Weight: 4,5 kgs.

Bonus: +10 SKI damage, +30 critical, bypass non-magical protections. Inflicts a STR/VIT debuff on successful hits. Wielder can cast [**Darkest Fear**] at will and inflicts [Insta-death] on a critical hit. [Reaper] only.

A scythe created from the remains of Mag Mell, Harvest is still animated by the fomor lord's lust for knowledge. Instead of existing independently, souls reaped by Harvest become part of a hive-mind devoted to its wielder, sharing their knowledge truthfully. In addition, Harvest's edge does not cut through flesh, but souls; as such, while it bypasses all physical protections and damage incorporeal targets, it cannot harm a soulless creature.

"Neat!" Goblina said, having looked at the stats with one of her own Perks. "The more people you kill with it, the smarter you will get!"

"Let's not go down that road," Victor said, although he vowed to interrogate Mag Mell's spirit as soon as more urgent matters were dealt with. "You're surprisingly chill about this disaster."

"I cannot believe that the resistance sank as low as to ally with the fomors to stage a terrorist attack," Goblina said while offering him a goblet, which he politely declined. "*Fomors!* I will have to double the number of guards to better protect our citizens against their treacherous attacks."

"The resistance... ah, the [Propaganda Machine] course!" Victor remembered that one; it was one of the few courses that he didn't ace. "And don't forget that your army managed to fight back the fairy armies, while we cleaned up Mount Yagami on your orders!"

“Exactly! Finally, the citizens of the Teikoku Empire know that their Shogun can protect them from anything. Especially from themselves!”

“I must say this was an interesting turn of events,” Ludvic Van told Victor. “But it distracted us from what *truly* matters. The sooner we finish your training, the sooner you can live up to your end of our delicious bargain.”

“I spent all the potions I intended to use for the ritual,” Victor admitted sheepishly. “And it will take a few more days to set up a portal and gather the reinforcements needed. Can we put it back to a few days?”

“If we must... then I encourage you to take a few days to indulge yourself, make peace with your family, you know. Even with all the preparations, your chances of survival are slim.”

“Hey, Vic, what did you get into this time?” Goblina asked, confused.

“I’m going to attempt the Kamacybele,” Victor explained, the goblin’s face turning white, “to level up in a prestigious class.”

“Vic, don’t do it!” the conqueror all but *begged* her former academic rival. “It’s suicide! You *know* what happens at the end!”

“I have to try,” the Vizier said, having made peace with the risks. “I *must*.”

“You aren’t going to survive it on your own!” Goblina insisted, but the Vizier remained firm in his decision. “Fine, I’ll help then!”

“No, no,” Victor protested, trying to let her down gently while Ludvic raised an eyebrow. He must have found his student a bit disappointing. “I’m sorry, but you can’t. You just *can’t*.”

“Nonsense! I have the best spellcasters on hand, I will figure something out. I’m not leaving you to die... not like this. Not like *this*.”

“It’s fine, Goblina,” Victor hugged her as if they were meeting for the last time. “It’s the thought that counts.”

Kia chose that moment to end her meditation, moving towards the group with a scroll in hand. “Vic,” she said, blatantly ignoring the goblin conqueror. “We need to address a crucial matter.”

“Orknoob,” Victor said, glancing at the captured orc.

“Orknoob,” Kia nodded grimly. “What are we going to do with him?”

“I asked Marbré through [Scarlet Study] to prepare a Moon rocket with his name on it, but Thul-Gathar put his veto on it. He said that criminals and exiles are welcome, but sending that orc will be interpreted as an act of war.”

“How far can your rockets go?”

“In the dwarfs’ words, *as far as needed*,” Victor replied firmly. “Mars, maybe this dimension’s equivalent of Pluto.”

“Make it Pluto. The farther, the better.”

“I will have the launch ready for Samhain,” Victor decided, while the captive orc silently protested. “May the gods forgive us.”

Now that the fate of the villainous orc was decided, Victor turned to the other problem: the flock of winged insurance salesmen glaring at him. “Fraudster,” one of the angels said, as Kia and the Vizier approached his group.

“Scammer,” Victor replied calmly, the angel immediately reaching for a flaming sword in fury. The securities the Vizier had put in the [Arisen] revival process prevented the bird from striking, much to his frustration. “What do you want from me?”

“Send us back to Heaven, you thief of souls,” another angel all but ordered. “We came to your help in your hour of need. Reward us appropriately.”

“You came to my hour of need fifteen minutes late!” Victor replied, astonished by their entitlement. “I owe you nothing!”

“You cast us down to Hell, heathen!”

“No, I didn’t! I sent you to Happyland, and you earned your stay there!”

“Heaven will not take you back,” Kia said. “I asked my patron, Mithras, and he said that you need to *‘repent for your deceitful ways’* first.”

“Repent?” one of the angels laughed with contempt. “What, like *mortals*?”

“We are angels, we are good by definition,” another replied.

“And that mindset is the root of your problem,” Kia replied firmly, raising her arms. “Look, neither Vic nor I make the rules. Stick to them or go back downstairs.”

The angels exchanged glances. The Vizier suddenly realized that after living off the souls of mortals for so long, they had lost all understanding of ethics beyond vague concepts.

“Look,” Victor pointed his scythe at the devastated city, “if you want to make up for your afterlife scam, start by helping the living. The capital is in ruins, thousands are homeless, and there’s a plague sweeping the continent outside this island. If you aren’t all talk, then act *now*.”

The flock grumbled, but saw the wisdom in his words and took flight, to help rebuild. “It’s not going to help,” Kia pointed out once they were out of earshot. “They still haven’t admitted that they did anything wrong.”

“Shouldn’t good actions matter, even if the intent behind is selfish?” Victor asked, more for himself than the angels. The [Paladin] shrugged her shoulders, having no answer to this. “What about your drinking problem? Can you celebrate Mag Mell’s death with us?”

“Mithras told me that he couldn’t lift another deity’s curse, but that he would try to talk to Seng,” Kia said, her neutral face slowly turning into a gloomy expression. “Which means that, when the adrenaline and dopamine from our recent fight leave my body, I will have to face the meaninglessness of existence without booze.”

She looked devastated, and the Vizier hated to see her like this. It reminded him of his early days as Vainqueur's sidekick. "Maybe you can transfer your alcohol addiction to something healthier?" Victor suggested.

"Like what, cigarettes? I don't think Outremonde even *has* tobacco."

"I was going to suggest sarcasm or sex since they are my own coping mechanisms. I know that your [Full Heal] spell will cure your lungs, but I can't recommend smoking."

Kia scowled. "Why is this happening to me?" she asked out loud, sounding well and truly angry. "I saved the world and I feel *miserable*, while you conquer countries on a whim and get rewarded for it! Major villains run away screaming when they see me, while they keep throwing themselves at you, even if we are evenly matched in levels!"

"Why, yes," Victor replied, letting her blow off steam. "If you're the strongest [Paladin] in the world, of course every sane villain will flee. While if you're painful annoyances like Vainqueur and I, *everyone* wants you dead, angels, and tyrants alike."

The [Paladin] looked at him with a strange look.

Charisma check successful!

Huh?

"Mithras warned me that if I keep associating with you, the only direction is down," Kia said suddenly.

Victor put his scythe on his shoulder. "That's a bit harsh. I do admit I may have been a bad influence on Miel, but I'll make up for it."

"About that..." Kia made a face, before handing him the scroll she carried. "I asked Mithras about your intent to go to Heaven, and he teleported this to my hand. It's her writing."

"She's doing okay?" Victor asked, immediately grabbing the message.

“Apparently, she managed to turn her resignation into some kind of political protest and established her independent afterlife agency. She’s fine.”

Victor understood the message.

Miel could have met him directly, but chose not to.

The Vizier opened the scroll with his free hand and quickly recognized Miel’s writing. The more he read though, the more his mood soured.

“Vic?” The Vizier was thankful the concerned [Paladin] couldn’t see his crushed face beneath his helmet. “Vic, you’re alright?”

“No,” he said, closing the scroll and extending his wings. “I’ll join the feast later.”

“Vic, you let me cry on your shoulder for five hours, you can do the same with mine if you need it.”

“Thank you, but I would rather be alone for a while,” the Vizier replied, flying away much to the [Paladin]’s consternation.

Victor moved above the devastated city, watching angels grudgingly helping the locals clean up debris; he briefly stopped by the carpet-bombed ruins of the Loli House, before wandering off aimlessly. He thought moving and stretching his wings would clear out his mind, and it helped, but only a little.

Eventually, he sat on the city’s outer wall, as far away from people as he could. He removed his helmet, put it next to him alongside his scythe and the scroll, and then watched the sunset in silence.

He had no idea how long he waited there, watching the sun slowly vanish beyond the ocean while Vainqueur and everybody else feasted to their heart's content. But eventually, he sensed a presence manifest next to him, a superb lady manifesting from nothing.

“Greetings Victor.” The goddess Camilla had traded her usual dress for a fancy purple yukata with white flower symbols. Her Claimed smelled a

sweet, honeyed perfume coming from her. “I am sorry I could not come to you beforehand; as the goddess of plagues, I have been very busy lately.”

“I see.”

“I wish I had been there when you unlocked the eighth tier of spellcasting; at this point, the balance completely breaks down and the real fun for magicians begins! I have so much to teach you, especially with that new scythe of yours.”

Victor said nothing.

The goddess winced at his depressed mood, before sitting next to him. She quickly noticed the scroll he was carrying. “What is this?”

“A letter of resignation, a restraining order, and the lifelike picture of a ship sinking.”

“From the angel girl?” Camilla shook her head. “It could not end otherwise, Victor, and you knew it.”

“I try to do good deeds, but I don’t find them enjoyable or they backfire; I don’t have the stomach to go full Akhenapep either,” the Vizier complained. “Is there something wrong with me?”

“Of course not, Victor,” she said, her soft hand moving to his armored shoulder. “You are just bi-neutral.”

“Bi-neutral?”

“You are attracted to both good and evil. You’re young, so you’re still exploring your karmic identity. It’s *fine*. I had a bi-neutral phase too when I was younger.”

Victor looked at her with an eyebrow raised. “You did?”

“Yes, there was that dashing paladin my adventurer party kept fighting...” Camilla sighed as if reminiscing about shameful days. “Victor, it is time I give you the talk.”

“The talk about what?”

“About where falls and redemption come from. You see, when a [Paladin] and a [Necromancer] get close enough, sometimes, they start having unprotected charisma checks. It’s fun, very fun, but eight months later, it results in a redemption or a fall. It’s a really messy process.”

“Are we talking about sex or [Paladins]?” Victor blurted out.

“About [Paladins],” Camilla clarified her intent. “There was a knight my party had a feud with when we were both mortals. He had a high charisma stat, me too, we kept having close encounters... you can see where it led. We never went beyond kissing and making out, but it was *passionate*. I even left my party and necromancy behind for a time; Jesty tried everything to make me reconsider, shouting that I was making a mistake. He was right, but I was curious, and smitten.”

It didn’t take a genius for Victor to figure out who was the [Paladin] in question. “The scriptures never mentioned *that* part.”

“Because it ended poorly, for both of us. I was making efforts to mend our alignment differences, but he wanted more than I was willing to give. He asked me to have a redemption, while I didn’t want that kind of commitment; I was ready to make a compromise, stop necromancy if I could keep a harem on the side, but he wanted it all. So-called good guys think they mean well, but in the end, all they want is to *control* you. Reshape you in their image, make you *conform*. Very narcissistic when you think about it.”

He could practically *taste* the bitterness in her voice. Of course, while the Vizier kept it for himself, he knew that she was probably biased; he only had one side of the story to listen to.

“We had fights, and I returned to my necromancy to blow off steam. Eventually, he tried to lock me up after I woke up an ancient Cyclops [Lich] to get his [Wand of Mass Destruction]; I felt so betrayed, that I invented vampirism to spit on that sun my white knight loved so much. *Nasty* breakup, I hope that you never experience one like it. But you know who

stood by me when the dust settled? My party. They always had my back, even after I blew them off.”

Victor thought about Vainqueur, Jules, and the other people who had stuck with him one disaster after another.

Camilla must have read his mind. “Karma, lovers, and [Paladins] come and go Victor, but friends like your dragon? They remain.”

“Is *that* the moral of the story?”

“No, the moral is, do not have unprotected charisma checks with Kia Bekele. Use [Protection from Good], maybe [Protection from Order] if you feel paranoid.”

The Vizier felt a strong urge to facepalm. “Okay, but it doesn’t apply to my situation. Miel was a friend that I did manipulate for my personal gain.”

“Which fits my point,” Camilla replied. “Friends are special people that you must always treat with respect, because they will stand by you when you make a mistake. Everyone else is expendable, but you must never take a friendship for granted. Do not abuse their trust or goodwill, lest they run out of it. Now, why did you want to get into that dreary Heaven?”

“Because I liked Miel, that I thought that she was bi-neutral too and that I could get into a good afterlife by paying for it.”

As he spoke, he suddenly understood the hidden question. No, he hadn’t tried to get to Heaven on merit; his own scam proved it. Neither did the good, unforeseen consequences of his own fraud make up for the selfish intent behind it.

While it *hurt*, Miel was within her right to ghost him. She had genuinely tried to help him, and he repaid her trust with lies because deep down he had been unwilling to fully commit to her program. Camilla was right; if he had respected Miel he should have been honest with her from day one.

Maybe he should start with being honest with *himself*. Accept that he had made bad choices and live with the consequences.

“I’m fine with a balanced life,” Victor realized. “I’m fine with not living up to Heaven’s standards nor going all the way down like Goblina did; I should just do what I feel is right and makes me happy.”

“Exactly, and there is nothing wrong with being neither an angel nor a fiend,” Camilla gave him a supportive nod. “You can be both.”

“I’m *bi-neutral* and proud of it!” the Vizier declared. “And who cares if I can’t get into Heaven anymore? I’m still going to get that [Fiendish Rake] class!”

“And I would be very glad to help with that,” his patron goddess said. “I did promise you a gift if you managed to revive yourself on your own...”

“About that, I have a friend in trouble with Seng,” Victor said. “Can you help with that instead? As you said, I have to stick to my party.”

Camilla looked *extremely* disappointed.

Chapter 111: Interlude: The Princess Documentary

“Far away, in the depths of Castle Gardemagne,” the dragon said, as a beautiful keep with shining white halls appeared on the reflective surface, “lives a deadly predator; the remnant of a bygone age where manling kings numbered in the thousand, fighting both themselves and the wild.

His trusty [Scrying Crystal Ball] zoomed in on the castle, onto a bedroom located at a tower’s top.

“An insidious, cunning beast, whose beauty is only matched by its cruelty. The most dangerous game of all.”

A fair, human maiden with long green hair peeked out the window, looking down with envy at the castle’s gardens. Her beautiful skin turned red with envy, as she noticed a blonde, busty woman talk with a dashing prince near a patch of flowers; her eyes were set on the competitor's pendant and jewels.

“The Manling Princess.”

The maiden left with a hiss, to protect her territory against the intruder. As the apex predator of decadent manling courts, this savage conflict could only end in two ways.

She would kill, or be killed.

“Princesses are smart,” the dragon said, leaving his den and crystal ball behind, his princess bag in hand. “They need to, to become queens. They kill for many reasons: to mate, for status, for pleasure. But out of all the

beasts populating the animal kingdom, only the Manling Princess will kill for money; for humans are born greedy. That makes her the most dangerous princess of all; the *dragonlied* princess.”

The dragon flew over the ruins of the city, and the pens outside its confines. His apprentice’s minions had built large, district-wide walled areas, one for each feral princess. The wyrm had taken exquisite care in their development, recreating the natural environment of each princess within; an arid sandcastle for the Elf Princess, a small plain for Centaur Princess, a fungi garden for Mushroom Princess...

“I am Grandrake, and I have been a *Princess Hunter* all my life; long before the dragon-made system recognized it officially.” The wyrm looked down on Mushroom Princess’ pen, watching her have tea with Allison the Dryad. She was the closest to being released back to the wild. “Princesses and dragons are not meant to coexist for long. But most of the princesses here, at my new Wildlife Reserve in El Goldorado, had to be removed from the wild. They turned feral, dangerous to each other... and to themselves.”

All because of this forgetful curse’s fault!

Grandrake had felt great guilt at having left these poor princesses to fend for themselves; he would not rest until they could regain their true nobility. Thanks to a dwarf-made portal, the dragon empire of V&V had allocated resources and staff to the project, making the wildlife reserve fully functional. Kobolds watched from above the walls, careful that the princesses didn’t escape, nor that outsiders disturbed the experiment.

Grandrake approached Elf Princess’ pen, finding her lording over a group of succubi from the ruins of her sandcastle. When the dragon landed near her den, the posse instantly turned tense. He opened the bag and grabbed a cake.

“Elf Princesses are very territorial; when interacting with them, you must play by their rules.” Grandrake left the royal strawberry cake at the periphery of the princess’ vision, showing deference. “When you feed them, you must do it subtly, presenting it as a gift; or else they may refuse your

food out of pride. Some are even ready to starve themselves to death; for no cost is too high, to psychologically dominate the dragon.”

“Is he talking to himself?” a succubus said, rich enough for Grandrake to hear her. She must have been upper middle-class, maybe an office worker.

“Always,” Elf Princess said with an unhappy face.

“Having fed on princess flesh for decades, she must get used to her natural diet,” Grandrake said. “Chocolate, truffles, brioche, oysters... do not ever give these beautiful creatures bread though. If a Princess is fed commoner food, then in time, she becomes half a peasant herself. Let them eat cake.”

The dragon discreetly left the pen, watching from above until the princess accepted the gift. Happy, Grandrake left to continue his feeding tour, checking out how all of the captives handled their newfound courts. No fair maiden shared their pen with another.

“Princesses are pack animals, but they cannot stand each others’ company for long except in extreme circumstances,” Grandrake explained. “For when they do, jealousy sets in, and they fight to become queens. Instead, their natural pack is a *girl posse*; a Princess dominates lesser female nobles as the alpha and then bullies commoners. During the mating season, males flock to them, fighting for the princess’ favor; sometimes, even dueling to the death.”

But it was too early to introduce fair maidens to male partners yet. After years of princess cannibalism, these maidens had lost their kind’s normal social behavior. They had forgotten the habits needed to thrive in the wider world.

Due to a lack of elves, the empire had instead sent what could pass for noble ladies: female vampires and succubi. The dragon had introduced groups of them to the captive princesses, so they could form posses.

“It is not an optimal solution, but the only one we have for now. It will take years before we can return most of these princesses to the wild.” Grandrake shook his head sorrowfully, as he watched Centaur Princess run around her

pen in frustration. “Princesses aren’t meant to be herded. To flourish, princessness needs to be atop a social hierarchy; if a dragon looms over it, it cannot express itself. These flowers need light to bloom.”

However, with the number of princesses decreasing, many dragons had tried to preserve the species however they could. Some even tried to raise them in captivity, but desperate measures can never result in anything beautiful.

“Once, princesses were common across the land, but my kind overhunted them for their princessness. So princesses adapted, rearing a male subspecies called knights to defend themselves; the rarity and danger only made them more desirable.”

The rediscovery of the dragon-made system, though, could change everything. Grandrake had heard that Blightswamp had managed to turn her daughters into princesses; if true, then it could be the greatest breakthrough in Princessology since the invention of the [Virgin Princess Radar].

After touring the pen, Grandrake flew to the dense jungle.

“My assistants informed me that a knight was sighted nearby,” he said, looking at the trees for any sign of movement. “Knights are dangerous, both to princesses and to Princess Hunters themselves. I like to think that my lessons about how to treat their metal sword bites saved many young, inexperienced dragons from death. Yes, I am an explorer and collector first, but education will always be important to me.”

For the elder dragon wasn’t stupid. He knew that he lived a dangerous lifestyle and that one day, a fomer knight might get lucky and end his life; his near-death experience from the Curse of Greed had taught him well. His mind might get duller, his body slower from wounds garnered in dangerous hunts. He could not let his knowledge die with him.

“If a knight captures a princess, it will attempt to breed with her by guile or force. If the knight is a prince or a noble, then the result of coupling will be a trueborn princess.” Grandrake shook his head. “But this one is another kind entirely; an invasive species.”

A commoner.

“If allowed to mate, the commoner will pass on inferior bastard genes onto the progeny,” Grandrake explained the danger. “Which disrupts the entire princess social hierarchy. It often takes generations for a princess lineage to recover from bastardry, and with their current, dwindling population, this *cannot* be allowed.”

Grandrake looked at the horizon with sorrowful eyes, at the distant bright sun.

“Dwarf princesses have become extinct because we...” He stopped.
“Because *I* wasn’t vigilant enough.”

He couldn't allow elf and manling princesses to vanish too.

“An operation like this needs teamwork.” The dragon reached a clearing, where an armored red dragon and her scaled minions had gathered. “This is where my new apprentice Jolie comes in, alongside our Kobold Ranger assistants.”

“Your Majesty, who are you talking to?” Red Ranger asked. Since he was a true minion, Grandrake managed to hear his words, even though he lacked the net worth needed to break past the wealth sound barrier.

“To myself. I simply love the sound of my own voice, it makes for exquisite conversation.”

“So wyrmlike,” young Jolie said in adoration.

“It will come with age,” Grandrake told his apprentice. “Practice every day. Even when others ignore you, you must keep going. A true discussion is never about them; it is all about *you*.”

The younger wyrm nodded ferociously, flying after the older dragon as they patrolled the jungle, both humming the air. The kobold rangers formed a circle, to force the knight into action.

The creature was cunning, scouting the pens from afar and then retreating in the wilderness. In time, he may slip inside a princess' lair and then lay his eggs where he shouldn't.

Grandrake couldn't leave this operation to chance, so he had hired a specialist. The lycan known as Chocolatine scoured the forest in wolf form, sniffing the ground. While no refined werewolf princess, this professional minion could smell prey from miles away.

It didn't take her long to locate the intruder. "Over there!" she shouted, Grandrake noticing movement in the thick, high grass.

There! Under the shadow of a tree!

A manling knight, with steel armor painted green! The perfect disguise in this thick, dangerous forest.

The knight's mouth moved in silence, threatening the dragon with his tiny weapon, an icy halberd. Clearly this one had come prepared, ready to fight a dragon by exploiting their common weakness to frost.

Yet, he had made an error, mistaking the Princess Hunter for a fire dragon, instead of a lightning wyrm.

"I cannot understand his barking," Grandrake noted. "Which means that he must live in a barn. This one looks young, inexperienced, but I cannot take any risks. I must shoot it with my breath quickly and decisively. Thankfully, a lightning dragon like myself is a knight's natural predator."

The ancient wyrm opened his mouth, crackling electricity building up in his stomach. Grandrake opened his mouth, unleashing a mighty blue bolt at the creature. Covered in steel as he was, the knight became a living lightning rod; he was fried on the spot and collapsed.

"Then, I crush the body under my claw," Grandrake explained, landing on the animal. "You see, while noble knights are eager to kill themselves, commoners have a strong survival instinct. They play dead. As a Princess Hunter, I must eat them whenever I can, poor taste be damned."

Which the dragon did.

“When I was young, a commoner knight tricked me this way, impregnating my freshly caught Werewolf Princess with a bastard litter.” So said Grandrake, as he swallowed the knight whole, sword first. “I only learned the truth after finding his half-eaten bones in a hole, the pelvis missing.”

“Teacher, teacher!” Jolie called, as she landed next to him. “Who is the most beautiful princess of all? Should a dragon limit themselves to certain species?”

“In the eyes of a true hunter, all princesses are beautiful, Young Jolie,” Grandrake taught her. “A true dragon does not discriminate!”

Jolie listened religiously. Grandrake knew that he had found a worthy apprentice; eager to learn, confident enough to ask, to question.

“Our task is not yet done, Young Jolie,” the older dragon declared, examining the spot where the manling intruder hid. “For knights always travel in groups of two. The master and the squire.”

Which of them did they hunt? The master... or the squire?

“It must be the squire,” said Young Jolie. “I know because I am one too! I always charged first while Kia lagged behind!”

“A dragon can become a squire?” Grandrake asked, astonished.

“Yes, thanks to the System!” Jolie said proudly. “And one day I will become a true knight too!”

This... this challenged many of his beliefs. But a true Princess Hunter had to be willing to learn. He had to assume that the master was out there, waiting for his moment.

“Young Jolie’s insight gives me hope. That a new generation of dragons will rise, empowered by this System, and more mindful of the environment than their elders. The heroes that could save princesses from extinction.”

Grandrake looked at the horizon as if he could glimpse the trials to come.
“Only time will tell.”

How long would they have to keep these princesses captive? To shield them against armored poachers?

Could he even release some of them? Mushroom nobles were long gone, and elves extremely rare. For some princesses, finding purebred partners to continue their lineage would be difficult; sometimes, near-impossible.

Young Vainqueur had suggested breeding them with his chief of staff, arguing about the quality of his genes, but Grandrake was skeptical. While he might count as a noble prince of the V&V Empire, the child wouldn't be purebred; and he worried about long-term inbreeding. Still, he couldn't let these proud creatures become extinct.

There was no easy solution to this problem.

“The life of a Princess Hunter is full of hard choices, and tough compromises,” Grandrake said, knowing that today's monologue would soon come to an end. “As dragons explore the world in search of levels, we must learn to give these fair maidens their space. Only then, will we be able to coexist in peace.”

For a true Princess Hunter's job was never fully done.

Chapter 112: Baths and Munchkins

What a wonderful looking place.

Vainqueur glanced at the enormous, steamy bath in front of him, bordered by natural stone walls and wooden pipes. The pagoda-like inn that oversaw the area overshadowed it from a hill above, blocking out half of the sun.

"You could fit an army inside!" His chief of staff observed, wearing only a toga fitting his wings and tail as he walked on the stone pathway. "It's as large as a lake!"

"Minion, what do they call it again?" the dragon asked, touching the water with his claw and finding it to be *just* the right temperature. The locals had wisely left the place, offering it for dragon use alone.

"Onsen, Your Majesty."

"Could they not call it a *bath*?" Vainqueur said as he slipped inside the hot, steamy waters, letting out a moan of pleasure. He couldn't put his finger on why, but it felt like lava. His mighty body caused the water level to rise up, swallowing stones and bonsai. "Perfect."

You have entered the [**Onsen**] Field.

Your status ailments will be cured, and you will recover HP and SP at an accelerated pace.

After saving the world from hunger with his new Tarasque feeding plan, Vainqueur had decided to take a short break on his trip across Outremonde. Since they had around forty days left before Samhain, he thought he could afford some *pleasure time*.

“Minion, what are you waiting for?” Vainqueur asked, as his Manling didn’t join him in the bath. “It is not lava by any means, but it should do.”

“Later, Your Majesty,” the minion said, ever dutiful. “I still have stuff to do before I can relax; reforge my Perks, extract information from Mag Mell’s soul, check up on Kia...”

“What has that poor excuse of a [Paladin] done this time?”

“She’s having withdrawal symptoms. Allison had to lock her in her bedroom to avoid a scene.”

Vainqueur sighed. After having opened a new portal between Murmurin and this country's capital, his chief of staff had summoned key minions to handle administrative matters. “That was inevitable. Spending weeks in my naked presence has made her addicted to me. It happens to my minions all the time.”

His chief of staff said nothing; he alone had the strength of will to resist his *Vainqueur addiction*, and even then never for long. “Your Majesty, I still think we should use this break to train a little. With Mag Mell’s soul on hands, I have been able to locate the fomors’ exp farm, and in all likelihood, we will face heavy opposition there.”

“Minion, I am considering why we should even make a stop there.”

“But that’s the place where they level up!” his minion protested.

“And instead of growing as it should have, my wealth has been slowly depleted!” Vainqueur said, vowing to remind Indebted Allison of how much she cost him. The money they received from conquering the country had barely returned his hoard to its pre-Akhenapep size. “Hunting fairies is good, but it makes us lose sight of this trip’s true goal: gathering enough money to shame Icefang on Samhain! The few time we fought fomors, they did not drop any gold at all!”

“I’m sure the locals will pay a heavy price to get rid of them—”

“If they do, yes, I shall deign to burn that farm to the ground,” Vainqueur interrupted. “But I want you to focus on money-making quests first. Like my dodo trade plan.”

“I admit selling homegrown male dodos to exp-starved nations while maintaining a monopoly on the females should prove lucrative,” Manling Victor said as if it wasn’t obvious. “But it will take months to breed a sufficient population; same as with opening our portal network to foreign trade and global tourism. Samhain will pass by in either case.”

“Friend Victor, you do not see that we can leverage one of the most powerful forces in the world,” Vainqueur said. “Dwarf addiction.”

His chief of staff raised an eyebrow. “Dwarf addiction?”

“We have access to a Whiskey Sea, which from what I understand your species use as a substitute to dwarf consumption,” Vainqueur said. “I will have minions pump it dry, then sell bottles to your kindred. The Agarthans will be so glad that we spared them from dwarf addicts depredations, that they will pay me a greater tribute.”

“That’s... that’s actually very smart,” Manling Victor said, considering the matter. “We could quickly pump the whiskey sea and sell cheap drinks to Gardemagne and Barin.”

“I order you not to overdwarf on our own product though. One time was one too many. ”

“That’s still going to take time to set up,” his Vizier said, always a pessimist. “And I doubt we can sell enough bottles to grow Your Majesty’s hoard in forty days.”

“What about conquering a new country?” Vainqueur suggested. “It worked wonders for me so far.”

“There is a southern landmass which has yet to be settled at all, and which should be rich in natural resources, in particular gold...” Vainqueur’s head raised above the waters with interest, making the minion cough. “But it’s

Hell on Earth in my homeworld. I cannot imagine how bad it must be in Outremonde.”

“I shall conquer Prydain in due time,” Vainqueur said, unafraid. “I welcome the practice run. For the greater hoard, no sacrifice is too low.”

“Alternatively, we could go to Nagastan or the Jade Empire,” Manling Victor said. “They’re the richest countries in the world, and Nagastan, in particular, pays well for quests. As a Claimed of Shesha, I could get us deals there.”

“Yes, yes, I trust you to map out our destinations,” Vainqueur replied dismissively. “But I will accept no less than a million coins per task. I am a star, minion, and you know it. We must increase our wealth standards.”

Manling Victor excused himself to prepare the trip, leaving Vainqueur alone. The dragon quickly rested against the stones like a crocodile on a riverbank; the experience couldn’t match resting on his hoard, but it helped ease the pain from his wounds. The Tarasque’s minion conversion had left bruises.

The dragon closed his eyes and enjoyed the warmth, his mind slipping into thoughts about the future. While he had sacrificed short-term wealth to revive his minions, such was the duty of an Emperor to reward those who died for him.

The dragon suddenly wondered what would happen to his empire once he reached godhood. While the place only served to fuel his hoard first and foremost, he had grown to enjoy ruling it. Could he keep doing so after passing the Valhalla trials?

He was three-quarters of the way through after all.

“It *burns*.”

Vainqueur’s eyes snapped open, as he recognized the voice.

A dragon’s voice.

“I warned you, you should have leveled up in [Paladin] of Mithras instead of [Pyromancer],” someone else commented. “You would have gotten a [Fire] immunity Perk by now, instead of a mere Resistance.”

“And Skill is one of your dump stats,” a third, female creature said. “[Paladin] would have boosted your Strength *and* Charisma.”

Vainqueur immediately pinpointed the source of the noise as behind the nearest stone wall. He immediately looked above and at the large bath beyond it.

Three smaller dragons occupied a steamy lake there, one black, one green, and the last one...

“ICEFANG!” Vainqueur roared, bringing the three dragons’ attention upon him.

“VAINQUEUR!” his white-scaled rival roared back, extending his wings in defiance and throwing water all around.

“Oh, Vainqueur!” the green dragon waved a hand at the Emperor. Vainqueur identified him as Magnifique, one of the guests at his latest Bragging Day and an adventurer he met while hunting the Blue Rose Legion. “Great to see you.”

“What are you doing here?” Vainqueur glared at Icefang. “You have come to sabotage me again?”

“I am a [Ninja]!” Icefang hissed in response. “I train in this city!”

“Suboptimally,” said the third member of the dragon trio, a black wyrm with two long horns. *Suffisante*, Vainqueur remembered, *her name is Suffisante*. “Why he chose a puny class with such a high Skill threshold I will never understand.”

“This ‘puny class’ allowed me to dominate Vainqueur in our last spare!” Icefang lied through his teeth.

“That is not how I remember it!” Vainqueur replied angrily, now mostly out of the water with his two hands on the wall. To think that his rival would ruin his vacation by showing up unannounced! “My minion had to beg me to spare your life!”

“You will be the one begging on Samhain when my hoard humiliates yours whole in its shininess!” Icefang showed his fangs. “How is *yours*, by the way? Smaller than a hill I imagine!”

“Bigger than a mountain!” Vainqueur lied, refusing to lose face.

“Boys, can you tone it down?” Suffisante asked, as the noise caused birds to fly away. “You’re making the minions flee!”

“What are you doing with this silver-lover?” Vainqueur glared at her and Magnifique.

“We joined his guild a while ago,” Magnifique said. “The *Silver Dragon Adventurer Company*. ”

“We cooperate for quests and share the loot.” Suffisante nodded. “Money without risks!”

“And no minion kickbacks!”

“I thought you had better tastes,” Vainqueur grumbled. How could any dragon worth their weight in gold join this second-rate Frost Dragon?

“Speak for yourself, you lost the Goldslayer,” Icefang taunted his rival. “How much gold did he pay you for it? Or maybe... or maybe did he pay you in *lead*?”

The Emperor’s eyes saw red. “You take that back!”

“Come on, we are dragons, we are better than this,” Magnifique said, cheerful. “You can fight on Samhain.”

“Indeed, my net worth will speak for itself,” Vainqueur replied haughtily, refusing to sink to Icefang’s level of pettiness. “The hoard that made even

Furibon repent from his evil ways.”

“Mmm,” Icefang replied dismissively, smirking arrogantly. “Haven’t you heard, Knightsbane? I have become the richest dragon in the world! And I would have become even richer were it not for that goblin...”

“The previous Daimyo hired us to save his empire from some goblin warlord, but when we arrived, he had already been eaten and replaced,” Suffisante explained the situation to Vainqueur. “We complained to the new goblin minion administration, who reimbursed our travel costs and offered us free vacations as apologies.”

“Ah!” Vainqueur mocked Icefang, rejoicing at having taken a quest right under his nose.

“I swear, when I find my [Heroic Crest], I will make you choke on your arrogance,” the frost dragon hissed.

“A [Heroic Crest] like the one I received from Wotan Dragonbane?” Vainqueur raised his head with pride, as the other dragons looked at him as if he had grown more heads than a Zmey.

“You defeated Dragonbane?” Magnifique had stars in his eyes.

“You can get a [Heroic Crest] from defeating a fomor?” Suffisante asked, only interested in growing stronger.

“Even if you had the Perks needed to see them, the sight of my,” Vainqueur took a deep breath, “seventy-five levels would have left you blind!”

“Lies!” Icefang complained.

“Let me check...” Suffisante’s eyes widened. “[Augustus] thirty, [Witchfinder General] fourteen, [Kaiser] seventeen, [Dungeon Breeder] ten, and [Geomancer] four! Seventy-five!”

Vainqueur pumped up his chest, happy to receive the spotlight he deserved.

“What kind of subpar build is that?” Suffisante said, half-amazed, half-mockingly.

“Yes, Vainqueur, how do you get anything done?” Magnifique replied, astonished.

The Emperor frowned, astonished by the reaction. “Excuse *you*?”

“I know you are a pioneer in the dragon System, but your classes are all over the place!” Suffisante said. “You do not even try to optimize!”

“Why should I optimize perfection?” Vainqueur pointed out the obvious. “Your argument is illogical.”

“Dragon perfection can always be built upon,” Suffisante replied.

“I still think it is better to cover our natural weaknesses than increase our strength,” Icefang argued, seemingly almost as annoyed by the other dragon’s arrogance as Vainqueur himself. “I solved my Skill weakness and [Fire] vulnerability! Soon, I will become immune even to [Fairy]!”

“You can become immune to fairies?” Vainqueur asked, his contempt for his rival overcome by curiosity. After all, fairies and dragons had warred for so long that they had become vulnerable to one another; if Wotan Dragonbane could overcome this problem, so could Vainqueur.

“I have, by becoming a [Priest],” Magnifique boasted. “One of the manling gods provides [Fairy] resistance at level seventeen, which can be increased to immunity with the right magical item!”

“A [Priest]?” Vainqueur was aghast. “You became the minion of a *manling*?”

“Far from that. I made the goddess Leone *my* minion, and now she gives me beautiful spells whenever I order her too!” The green dragon proudly showed a small pendant around his neck, representing a shield and a pen joined together. “Alongside [Fairy] resistance, as the goddess of might, she

can provide a Strength bonus equal to my [Priest] level, on top of magical buffs!”

“We calculated that he could deal thousands of damage with swords if he gains Perfect Proficiency in them,” Suffisante added, losing Vainqueur’s interest with her technicalities. “Hence why he took levels in [Paladin] too!”

“I have to follow a code of minion deontology, help manlings solve their problems, but this is just a technicality,” Magnifique said dismissively. “I hope that they solve this design flaw soon.”

“I agree, why should dragon class features require that you help lesser beings?” Suffisante shook her head. “At least you have it easy. I have to garden and tend to forests to keep my [Vestal] of Cybele perks active.”

“Stop complaining, you can use your Vitality as your main stat for spellcasting instead of that useless Intelligence... or Skill!”

“Skill is not useless!” Icefang snarled. “You have seen the [Jutsu] I can use with it!”

“Yes, yes, we know, you always land critical hits,” Suffisante replied dismissively. “But once I get Crested, *I* will be the one capable of turning the raw forces of nature into my minions!”

“I wonder if [Witch] wouldn’t be better as your new class after getting past level thirty,” Magnifique pondered. “[Chronomancer] is very powerful, but difficult to level-up in and runs on Intelligence, while [Witch] uses Charisma and meshes better with [Vestal].”

“She should get [Bard] to buff herself up!” Icefang said. “Like a [Ninja]!”

“I still do not understand why these deities refuse to claim us,” Magnifique whined. “Imagine the stats we could have if we were claimed by all twelve. Yet not one of them accepted!”

Vainqueur watched the trio argue about numbers, stats, and values, clearly having lost sight of what truly mattered.

“My fellow wyrms,” he spoke up, “have you forgotten that all classes are good, so long as you are an invincible dragon?”

“Yes, obviously,” Magnifique admitted, “But some classes are classier than others.”

“Your [Dungeon Breeder] has zero fighting applications,” Suffisante added.

“Because you lack imagination!” Vainqueur defended his hard-won levels. “I tamed the strongest minion in the world, and soon I shall breed an army of them!”

“I can easily [Enthrall] any animal with the right [Prayer], and I can create powerful minions from seeds,” Suffisante said. “*Seeds!*”

“They are not as powerful as a [Fisherman]’s minions though,” Magnifique added.

“That Perk, no matter how powerful, does not make up for the nineteen useless levels that come before it.”

“Are they always like this?” Vainqueur asked Icefang as they continued arguing, his rival seeming to share his frustration.

“Sadly,” the frost dragon replied. “I fear that once they get past level thirty, they will become unbearable.”

“You can still arrange things a little, Vainqueur,” Suffisante said, after realizing that the bigger dragon had lost interest in the conversation. “While it is true that you can never achieve our power once we reach your level—”

“*If* you reach my level,” Vainqueur pointed out. Considering their lack of dragon common sense, he did not believe it likely.

“But if you take levels in [Crusader] now—”

“Classes and Perks matter, but not as much as how they are used, and by whom,” Vainqueur replied. “Look at me. I am *me*. Why should I gain new classes when those I have already allowed me to prevail time and time again?”

Magnifique and Suffisante exchanged a glance. “I do not get it,” said the former. “Do you mean that you can gain powerful personal Perks when using suboptimal classes?”

Vainqueur shook his head, annoyed at his dragon brethren. Couldn’t they understand that the only classes that mattered, were those making them richer and more glamorous? Who cared who had the highest statistical score, when they already had the perfect measure of one’s worth in a hoard?

Such were the woes of a visionary. His impact on dragon society had unforeseen side-effects.

“Anyway, my wealth will prove that my path is the best,” Vainqueur declared proudly, preparing to return to his bath.

“Leaving so soon, Vainqueur?” Icefang hissed. “Have we touched a nerve? Are you afraid that your class combination pales before mine?”

“Even the best classes in the world cannot turn silver to gold,” Vainqueur taunted him.

“But the worst of them can turn gold to lead!”

The red dragon turned around, glaring at his rival. “Careful. You sound suicidal.”

“You could not best me in combat, and I am sure you could not best the Goldslayer either!” Icefang persisted in his madness. “Even with fewer levels, I am better optimized. I can take you *anytime*.”

“Hey, stop!” Magnifique interrupted both before they could come to blows. “There are more civilized ways to settle your feud! Like a minion battle!”

“That will not do,” Icefang replied, lightning cackling between his eyes and that of his nemesis.

“What about a quest then?” Suffisante said. “We pick a quest, and we see who can solve it the fastest!”

Vainqueur considered the proposal, an idea coming to mind. “If you insist,” he said. “There is this fairy farm I have been meaning to burn...”

Chapter 113: A Slice of Cat

My name is Victor Dalton, and if you read this, then it means that I am dead. Again.

As he wrote down his will, the Vizier realized that this line had lost its impact.

In his will, the Vizier distributed his belongings between his friends. Chocolatine had the lion's share with ownership of his manor, but he also rewarded Malfy, Jules, Isabelle, and Charlene with his magical items. Allison would get custody of Vainqueur Junior; Kia, of Gorynych and his horse. He also donated all his undead servants to Camilla's church, as thanks for training him personally.

He knew that he had done everything he could to achieve immortality, with enough back-up plans to recover from his potential fourth death. But he remembered vividly how Mell Odieuse murdered him *before* she earned any levels.

One day, Victor's luck might run out, or he could confront something capable of stealing his soul the [Reaper] way. He had followed enough Evil Overlord seminars to know that no one was invincible and to prepare for the worst.

After writing down everything, Victor put the scroll near his desk, then moved to the window. He had rented the local inn's biggest bedroom, a condo decorated in an elegant, minimalist, Japanese style. Vainqueur was arguing with the other dragons in the private baths, which should leave the Vizier with a day off to do as he wished.

[Skeleton Key] activated!

Huh? Odd.

Someone knocked on the door. “Come in,” the Vizier asked, Jules and Malfy stepping inside. The necromancer carried a scroll in hands, and the fiend a pile of papers.

“Sir,” the necromancer bowed respectfully, before examining his scroll. “Every hour of your day off is booked. You start with a training breakfast with Kia Bekele, a morning walk with your pets, the Infercorp shareholder assembly, blood tea time with Charlene after sundown, a dinner with miss Chocolatine, and then your suicide.”

“You don’t think I will make it?” Victor asked.

“Sir, only one out of twenty people have survived the Kamacybele, and the ones who do often lose their soul,” Jules replied calmly. “Statistically speaking, while you possess exceptional abilities, I must assume the worst. Thankfully, in your case death will be the metamorphosis into the undead you were always meant to be.”

“And your soul will reincarnate as a demon afterward,” Malfy nodded. “This is the very definition of a zero-soul emission scenario.”

“Please don’t make my corpse a zombie though,” Victor pleaded, suddenly wondering if leaving his remains for Jules to manage was a good idea. “A handsome skeleton or vampire I can handle, but no zombies.”

“Sir, you need to be alive for vampirism to take root, and your disease resistance makes that a moot point.”

Victor realized that the necromancer hadn’t promised anything. “What about Allison? Isabelle?”

“Miss Chocolatine invited Allison to the dinner, so I booked both at the same time,” Jules replied. “As for Isabelle Maure, she had a medical rendezvous and couldn’t make it.”

What was up with her lately? Victor promised himself to investigate later. “Since I’m having Chocolatine sleep over tonight—”

“Miss Allison set the protection spells in the building,” Malfy said. “Also, you should be happy to learn that I commissioned the ‘Close Team Building’ special for your shareholder assembly. All your succubi associates will attend, alongside our horizontal office interns.”

Did the demons even know to have an assembly without drugs and whores? Still, since the fiend had stuck with the Vizier through almost everything, being nothing but loyal and supportive, Victor overlooked it.

“Malfy, I know you wish to be [Mook Promoted], but my perk won’t let me and I don’t understand why,” Victor said. “I mean, you helped us with *Akhenapep*! What more should you need?”

“I have figured it out,” Malfy explained. “It appears that my superior’s continued existence prevents social mobility. He is expected to have his Chocolatine severance package soon.”

“Anything I can help with?”

“No.” The fiend shook his head. “Although, if I could ask a favor...”

“Anything for a friend,” Victor said.

“Then here is the bill to legalize hellhound fights.” Malfy handed him a paper. “Which should prove a trendy alternative to all those underground hobo arenas.”

“You sponsor hellhound fights?” Jules asked.

“No, but my nephew opened a start-up in that field. He is family, and as a member of the government, it would be rude not to give him a state monopoly.”

The breakfast with Kia was... awkward.

She had eaten her eggs and bacon, but she hadn't touched her coffee, milk, or orange juice. She stared at the liquids like a zombie at a brain.

"So, uh... you're doing alright?" Victor asked, having traded his armor for casual clothes to put her at ease. Clearly it hadn't worked.

"I'm managing," she lied.

It was even worse than he thought. "I know you are feeling vulnerable, and that you may have some dark ideas in mind," he said, trying to preempt an accident. "You should consider using [Protection from Chaos] or [Protection from Evil] when we interact."

"Mithras gave me the talk about unprotected charisma checks."

Wow, did the entire pantheon refuse to have them interact? "Then you safely confide in me," the Vizier said, having taken Camilla's advice about friendship seriously. "Your mood is getting worse and worse. It cannot just be about alcohol."

"No, it isn't," she admitted. "Everything tastes like saltwater."

Victor frowned. "Wait, even coffee?"

"Coffee, and milk, and juices." Kia's eyes darkened. "The bartender was wrong. She didn't stop at alcoholic beverages."

"*Tea* too?"

"*Everything* but unsalted water tastes like saltwater!" She had tears in her eyes. "Even potions!"

It would have been kinder for Seng to sink her country, as she had threatened. "Kia I promise I will do everything to solve this," he swore. "I have called upon my godly patrons. Just be patient."

"Thanks, but I just want to think of anything else right now," she grumbled. "When are we hitting the road again?"

“In a few days. Thanks to [Harvest], I have found the location of the fomors’ Exp Farm, but I will need a bit more time to gather every piece of information available.”

“You have all of Mag Mell’s knowledge kept within it; it will probably take months to get everything,” she said, sighing. “Maybe we can train then? I want to focus on something, anything!”

“I have some time.” Victor nodded. “I thought I could finally get around to using [Perk Forge] and fuse the unnecessary Perks.”

“Leave it to me,” she said, latching on the first opportunity to focus on martial matters. “We’ll review your monster perks and find the best combinations in no time.”

Choice registered. You combined [**Blood Fountain**], [**Sonic Scales**], and [**Vampire Kiss**] into [**Blood Pulse**].

[**Blood Pulse**]: Technique, Sound effect, 80 SP. You can emit a sonic pulse causing the blood of every creature within three hundred and fifty meters to boil, causing massive [Blood] damage and death on a failed [Vitality] check. A successful [Vitality] check avoids death but causes a [Strength]/[Vitality] debuff.

Choice registered. You combined [**Blackfyre**], [**Bad Breath**], and [**Corroding Poison**] into [**Noxious Fire**].

[**Noxious Fire**]: Technique, 1 SP per second. You can unleash purple, poisonous flames from your hands, feet, or mouth; half the damage is [Dragon] type, the other [Unholy]. Contact with the flames and the smoke will inflict the [Corroding Poison] ailment on victims, bypassing Poison Resistance and downgrading Immunity.

“Babies?” Junior asked, upon looking at Gorynych. Out of the entire menagerie, Victor only kept these two monsters leashed as they toured the city’s outskirts

Unfortunately, he had been forced to leave the Tarasque behind to avoid a mess. That creature just never stopped eating stuff, to the point that Goblina had even not-so-subtly encouraged him to take it away as soon as feasibly possible.

“No, Gorynych has no sister-wife yet,” the zmey replied, somehow being able to understand the mimic. Their tamer was happy to see them get along. “But Gorynych will hump anything! Like horses!”

“Sorry, but no,” Noirceur said, Buzz Jelly leaping off from its back to Dodolion’s, and back again. “Being a single mother mare is a pain, thank you.”

“Can you actually...” Victor asked, but didn’t dare finish it.

“Dragons can breed with anything,” the horse replied, shuddering. “Anything. Where do you think my ancestors got their cool flaming hooves?”

Charlene was radiant tonight, dressed all in white and pampered like a princess.

Victor, not so much. He struggled to focus as he brought his tea to his lips, the world dark beyond the windows; from the noise, Vainqueur was *still* arguing with his fellow dragons. “Victor, you look terrible,” the vampire said, noticing his exhaustion. She hesitated between the *Dwarf Blood Whiskey* and the *Goblin Blood Beer*, before settling on the *Sparkling Elf Vodka*.

“I had an intense demon shareholder assembly,” he said, drinking a [Healing Potion], “and I am spent.”

And he hadn’t even touched any cocaine.

“What are you doing right now?”

“We have multiplied the Nightblades’ profits by three,” Charlene said with pride. “I am proud that we moved their core business away from murder

and theft to what a criminal syndicate should truly be about: blackmail, extortion, and money laundering. Fewer risks, more profits; that is my motto.”

“That’s great, but I was asking about more casual activities.”

Gods, it sounded even more awkward than in his mind. Even Charlene seemed confused... and a tiny bit ashamed. “I’ve been reading novels.”

“Oh,” he said. After trying to find a subject of conversation other than Murmurin’s management, he decided to cut to the heart of the matter.

“Usually we only meet to talk about work or sleep together. I suddenly don’t get the feeling we know each other very well.”

“I am a workaholic, so I love talking about work,” Charlene replied. “As for knowing each other, we are colleagues with benefits. Nothing more.”

“I lost a friend recently, and I realized that I took most people for granted,” Victor replied. “Like you, Charlene. I mean, you have done a wonderful job setting up the V&V Empire as the semi-stable nation that it is today, and I never asked what you liked outside of work.”

“Semi-stable?” She smiled, revealing her vampire fangs. “You are so cute, Vic. And I would be lying if I said I didn’t take you for granted too.”

“Oh?” Victor quickly caught himself. “Don’t take me wrong, I’m glad, but I’m surprised. We didn’t start off on the best terms.”

“I thought you could be replaced, but Murmurin almost collapsed in days when you took a break,” she replied, sounding still distressed over it. “And no offense, you were an immature screw-up the first time we met, and not that handsome either. You’ve changed for the better, physically, and mentally.”

Victor crossed his arms at the ‘not so handsome part,’ but tried to take it in strides. At least it was proof of his improved Charisma. “I appreciate the attention though,” Charlene said, relaxing sipping her blood drink. “The last person who tried to know me better did it to fatten me up for food.”

“Maybe we start with exchanging book recommendations,” Victor said.

She made a terrible face. “You promise you won’t judge?”

“Why would I?” Victor asked, surprised, as Charlene put a red book on the table. The Vizier took it, reading the title on the cover.

“*‘The Breeding Frenzy, by Anonymous Super Bard,’*” Victor said while flipping the page. “*Chapter one, summary: the Dragon gets his minion at last.*”

As he started reading the first lines though, he felt an invisible, overwhelming pressure take over the room. A malevolent shadow crawling on his back, death itself moving its icy hands on his shoulders.

“It’s bad, I admit it,” Charlene said, while a supernatural power compelled Victor to keep reading the hellish, poorly written script. “But it gets so bad, it becomes entertaining.”

“*‘Minion, you have failed to breed on your own too many times,’ said the dragon as he put his mighty claw onto his manling’s legs.*” Victor kept reading, finding the anonymous dragon and his trusty Vizier disturbingly similar to Vainqueur and himself. “*‘Now, it is time for me to take the matter in my own hands. To put my eggs in you!’*”

Then came the details, and the icy hands moved to his neck—

[Insta-death] negated!

Victor managed to close the book, the wail of a thousand screaming souls silenced in the background. He panted heavily, having barely survived.

“Who wrote that?” he asked Charlene. “So I can strangle them?”

“Vic, is something the matter?” Chocolatine asked as she served the main course of the meal.

“Nothing,” he replied, scratching his shoulders. “I still feel the icy hands...”

“You have read one of Pink’s novels,” Allison said, sitting on his left while Chocolatine moved on his right; she placed a bonsai tree near the dinner table, apparently having bonded with it to move around better. “I heard they get worse. I don’t know how, but they get *worse*.”

“Pink?” Victor almost choked. “She wrote this crap? Why? Why would *anyone*?”

If the perfect argument against freedom of speech existed, it was that book!

“You are always with Vainqueur, and you became half-dragon...”

“Shush, Allison, he needs the right recipe to take his mind off those silly books!” Chocolatine said with pride, presenting her masterpiece: a stuffed pig missing its head, with vegetables for Allison. “And the right people.”

“Indeed,” he said, putting his hand on her own. “Thanks for setting this up, Choc. We’re definitely going on a culinary tour if I survive the Kamacybele.”

“Of course you will!” she laughed. “You have [Monster Rider]! You are overprepared!”

“I’m not so sure,” Allison replied, less enthusiastic. “Even experienced Cybele priests never dare to undertake it. I still don’t know what to make of this [Fiendish Rake] class.”

“You are a priestess of the goddess of *pleasure*,” Victor pointed out. “Your *job* is to oversee orgies!”

“She is the goddess of forests, pleasure *and* knowledge,” Allison turned defensive. “It is different. We have *primal wisdom* wild orgies, not frivolous ones.”

Yeah, right. “You’re just jealous you can’t bear witness.”

“A bit.” Although it was for her own protection; and unlike Victor, she wasn’t eager to die again. “Shouldn’t a simple orgy be enough to access [Fiendish Rake]?”

“According to Ludvic Van, my level is so high that nothing short of the Kamacybele will get me into the class,” Victor replied, as he cut the pig and vegetables, before serving everyone. “I still want to get it, mostly for the Charisma and diplomatic applications.”

“Please tell me that you don’t intend to make a truce with the fomors by sleeping with them,” the dryad giggled. “Not that I wouldn’t mind a peaceful solution.”

“Vainqueur managed to talk a Tarasque into submission, I figure I can do the same.” He tasted the stuffed pig, and found it *perfect*. “Choc, I *love* it.”

“You better appreciate it, he took a long time to fatten,” she replied happily. “But don’t eat too much. I want to finish what we started in the Thaoten Empire, and I have the sacrificial altar ready downstairs.”

Victor sighed, but accepted the sacrifice. “As you wish,” he replied, briefly kissing her on the lips, while Allison watched with a strange expression. “You won’t mind, Al?”

“I am worried about you,” the dryad said. “You should be training instead.”

“Goblina proposed something like that, alongside buttering me up with all protective spells known to her mages,” Victor replied. “But with the hopefully final battle with the fomors approaching, I figured I should focus on making time for my loved ones. You included.”

The dryad smiled sheepishly. “Thanks Vic,” she said, “And that reminds me I have yet to pay you back for convincing Vainqueur to raise me up.”

“Just drink for both of us, since I am now immune to alcohol.”

Allison shook her head, as if he had said something stupid, before exchanging glances with Chocolatine. “What?” Victor asked.

“It’s a secret,” Allison replied.

“As long as it doesn’t involve that insufferable cat,” the [Reaper] replied.

“It’s fine, Felix lives on in both of us now,” Chocolatine replied cheerfully.

Victor looked at the meat in his plate.

On a closer look, it didn’t look like a pig all that much...

...

“Choc?”

“Yes, Vic?”

“Can I take another bite?”

Finally, the time had come.

Victor had prepared extensively, wearing his full plate armor, having drank his fill of potions, and cast twenty-five buff spells he knew. And he still felt naked before the storm to come.

“Are you ready yet?” Victor asked as Ludvic Van started drawing a summoning circle around his bed, the moon now high in the night sky. “My buffs will expire at this rate.”

“I found myself distracted by a most entertaining book I found in your trashcan,” Ludvic replied.

“And you... you survived it?”

“I wish I could meet the author,” Ludvic Van replied, “I have so many tales worth committing to paper.”

“That’s a great idea!” That Victor would make sure *never* became reality.

“Anyway, I finished preparing the beacon,” the dandy said as he completed the circle, taking a few steps back, “Now she must accept the invitation, but since I sent it myself as her chosen, she has no reason to refuse.”

“And I am ready.”

“Your armor won’t protect you from this,” Ludvic said bluntly. “Either you survive, or you don’t.”

“It’s too late to go back.” Victor shook his head. “Will there be pain?”

“If you fail, you will be vaporized in the blink of an eye, with no check allowed.”

“No checks allowed?”

“No checks allowed. Do *not* touch her, or your soul will explode from the ecstasy with no check allowed either. You just pray, and watch.”

And so Victor fell to his knees, praying to Camilla. Out of all the deities that claimed him, she was the one who helped him the most. He did place a little prayer to Deathjester and Shesha though. He knew it probably wouldn’t help, but prayer was a man’s last refuge.

“I’m ready,” he said, rising up. “I prepared my whole stay in Outremonde for this moment.”

“Then step into the circle. Once I cast the spell though, I will have to teleport out and lock the room behind. I survived the sight once, but I am not tempting my luck. May the goddess smile on you.”

Victor took a long, hard breath, and then stepped inside the circle.

The second he did, a green barrier of light formed behind him, trapping the Vizier within his own bedroom. Ludvic Van popped away, abandoning him to his fate.

Victor remained silent and still for a minute, the bedroom deserted.

“Victor Dalton.” The voice was like music, as she appeared on the bedside. A hooded woman covered with a dress of moss, with only her green hands remained visible. “I have received your invitation.”

“Lady Cybele,” Victor said respectfully, a chill down his spine. The tone was warm, affectionate, but he couldn’t glimpse at what was under the hood

for the life of him. “You know me?”

“Of course. You served me well in destroying Sablar’s wicked city, and making the desert of Ishfania green again.” She put a hand on the sheet. “Lay on the bed, and relax. You are among friends.”

He obeyed, tense as Happyland, and careful not to touch her.

“I have been observing you for a while, ever since Deathjester messed with my relationship table,” Cybele explained with kindness, although the Vizier didn’t understand half of it. “And you are indeed as easy as they said. It pleases me.”

Victor probably should have taken it badly, but she made it sound like praise. “Uh... thanks.”

“While I am most certain that you will never be claimed by Mithras for your promiscuity, you have earned my favor. Few men have proven themselves worthy, but you did. I shall reward your dedication to hedonism and nature appropriately.”

Victor felt something burn on his left ass cheek.

You earned the [**Claimed by Cybele**] personal perk!

[**Claimed by Cybele**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain an HP or SP boost. You are immune to [Enthrall], [Charmed], and STDs.

“Now, I know that you have called me for a purpose,” she said, putting her hands on her hood. “You want a level in the [Fiendish Rake] class.”

“Could I get it without the dangerous part?”

“Unfortunately not,” the goddess shook her head. “But you only need to see my face for a second. If you survive this harrowing experience and remain sane, your hand must immediately reach for the potions.”

“Will it be like Ludvic?”

“I roughly had the same Charisma stat as Ludvic when I ascended. Since my Perks have been upgraded to a divine level, now my face as goddess of pleasure is a weapon of mass destruction. The last mortal to see it turned into a pillar of salt, and even my fellow gods cannot help but pleasure themselves in my presence.”

“That sounds... inconvenient.”

“It is,” she said with a heavy sigh. “Since this feature destroyed my dating life, I entertain myself by setting up other couples instead. Like *yours*. I lost track of how many times Isengrim petitioned me to set you up with his priestess.”

“Well it worked out,” Victor replied. “I still don’t understand why, but it worked out.”

“It did,” she said, sounding as if she knew something that he didn’t. “Now, are you ready?”

“Yes.”

She removed her hood, and the room exploded in a flash of fire.

V&V Stats

Vainqueur "Best Dragon" Knightsbane

Level: 75 (Augustus 30/Witchfinder General 14/Kaiser 17/Dungeon Breeder 10/Geomancer 4)

Type: Dragon.

Party: V&V.

Health Points

6,965

Special Points

1810

Strength

162

Vitality

121

Skill

66 (+6)

Agility

89

Intelligence

53 (+2)

Charisma

138 (+6)

Luck

85 (+18)

Personal Perks

Class Perks

Atomic Dragonfire Breath

Born in the Purple

Fire Immunity

For the Emperor

Red Dragon Lifeforce

King of Games

Dragon Arrogance

Dynasty

Dragonscale

Crowd Favorite

Super Senses

Supercrit

Virgin Princess Radar

Spell Purge

Lesser Poison Resistance

Witch Burning

Deadfriend

Lesser Magic Resistance

Taunt

Exorcism I

Epic

Hunter's Resolve

El Presidente

Stipend

Dungeon Owner (Castle of Murmurin)

Victory Fist

Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)

Imperial Authority

Malefic Secrecy

Monster Empathy

Charged Attack (Dragon Breath)

Victory Roar

Mirror Scale

Fire Crown

Immovable

Show-off

Gold Shower

Shining Majesty

Golden Road

Geomancy

Monster Husbandry

Terraform: Landmass

Pontifex Maximus

Malleus Maleficarum

Incinerator

Master of Silence

Glitzy Theater

Improved Hybridization

Rabbit Plague

Alpha Magnetism (Scales)

Inventory:

- **[Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh]**: minor artifact. +10 to Luck; immunity to hostile [Earth] effects; reflexively cast [Hasten], [Protection from Elements], [Greater Dispel Magic], or [Cure Any Ailment] on the wearer once per day, depending on the situation. Cannot be worn by non-[Dragon] types.
- **[Crown of the Conqueror]**: +6 to Charisma, Luck, and Skill; immunity to [Terror].
- **[Psi-Stone of Mind-Shielding]**: Immunity to Mind-Affecting Effects.
- **[Psi-Stone of Positive Energy]**: Resistance to [Necromancy] effects: regain twice as much HP from healing magic; +2 to INT and +2 to LCK if worn with another Psi-Stone!

Victor "Slimy One" Dalton

Level: 72 (Monster Knight: Red Dragon 20/Reaper 30/Moriarty 11/Chaos Rider 4/Weathermaker 7)

Type: Slime/Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points

1575

Special Points

510

Strength

45 (+6)

Vitality

52 (+6)

Skill

75 (+8)

Agility

60

Intelligence

82

Charisma

77 (+6 when lying)

Luck

70

Personal Perks

Class Perks

Claimed by Dice

Skeleton Key

Observer

Eye for Treasure

Deadfriend

Scythe Lord

Seducer

Monster Kin

Claimed by the Moon Man

Minion Trainer

Black Curse

Monster Student

Noxious Fire

Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)

Claimed by Shesha

Monster Rider

Epic

Monster Insight

Vizier Education

Reanimator

Troll Regeneration

Soulmaster VI

Perk Forge

Helheim

Darwinist

Steal Life

Blood Pulse

Mook Promotion

Claimed by Deathjester

Slayer of Men

Claimed by Camilla

Scarlet Study

Exhibitionist

Master's Shield

Slime Totem

Fright Knight

Bloodborn

Lethal

Claimed by Cybele

Hades Blast

Final Problem

Black Horseman

Diabolical Mastermind

Envious

Nightmare Lord

Vicious Ankou

Devil Archmage II

Charon's Grim Harvest

Asteroid Dynamics

Zmey Rider

White Rider

Apocalypse Storm

Inventory:

- **[Moloch's Hide]**: armor (minor artifact)
- **[Harvest]**: weapon (Minor artifact)
- **[Brooch of Free Movement]**: wearer can move normally no matter the terrain.
- **[Ring of Emergency Teleport]**: 20 charges (18 left). Allow the caster to use [Emergency Teleport] to quickly teleport within a five kilometers area.
- **[Rings of Skill Boosting]** x 2: +4 SKI (total +8)
- **[Belt of Perfect Disguise]**: can magically polymorph into a humanoid of the same size.
- **[Bracers of Improved Bluff]**: +6 on Charisma when lying.
- **[Mini-Circlet against Greater Divinations]**: immune to scrying/magical location effect.

Chapter 114: Looking for a Farm

It had to happen one day.

Vainqueur had pushed his minion to breed, something which he had proven surprisingly terrible at. No matter the setbacks, his chief of staff had persevered, trying to do his duty and satisfy his master.

And he had overbred.

“Minion!” Vainqueur barked. “Minion!”

His chief of staff didn’t respond, laying on the drenched inn’s courtyard with his armor on. The warm, steely plates looked as if they had been hit by King Wotan’s lightning, and his manling inside was half-dead. Even his tail had gone limp!

They had found him like this, among the wreckage of his bedroom. And he hadn’t woken up hours later.

“I told him not to do it,” Goblina lamented with a sorrowful look, while Chocolatine held the unconscious chief of staff in her arms. Vainqueur’s minions had gathered in a circle around Manling Victor, alongside a few faces the dragon didn’t recognize; all the magic-users present kept casting spells on the Vizier, to no avail. “I warned him! I warned him!”

“It seems the shock was too much.” Corpseling Jules shook his head. “It is a miracle he didn’t die on the spot. If he hadn’t reached for his potions before falling unconscious, he would have left us...”

“You, healers.” Vainqueur turned to Untasty Allison. “Wake him up!”

“We’re trying, Your Majesty!” the dryad said, Knight Kia casting [Full Heal] on the dragon’s friend. “His body functions are normal, but his soul...”

“His soul almost reached enlightenment,” some redheaded manling explained. “He has experienced a bliss so great, that his soul is afraid to return to its mortal coil and find everything else disappointing. Until Victor realizes that this universe still has pleasures to offer, othan what he saw, he will not wake up.”

“What greater pleasure could there be than serving me?” Vainqueur replied, looking down on his chief of staff. “Minion! Minion! I have a challenge to win! MINION!”

His friend’s body didn’t even twitch.

“I should not have pushed him,” Vainqueur realized, his heart full of regret. “If his boundless love for me is not enough to wake him up...”

“He is still alive,” the redhead said and shrugged. “So he is still bound to this world. Just give him time to recover from his divine vision.”

“How long will it take?” Allison asked the redhead.

“It depends. It took me a full week of mind fantasies to work myself back to the waking world.”

“A *week*?” Vainqueur frowned. “My fairy hunt challenge is due to begin in a few days! I cannot wait for a week!”

“Fairy hunt?” Kia asked, looking up at the dragon with raw desire.

“Will there be princesses?” Gorynych asked, salivating.

“You are not invited!” Vainqueur lambasted both of them, before turning to his other minions. “No matter. I will carry him in my hand.”

“No, Your Majesty, don’t!” Allison pleaded. “He is completely helpless in this state, and he needs medical attention.”

“There is no place safer than my side,” Vainqueur insisted. “You can heal him on the way to the fairy farm.”

“Your Majesty intends to attack it while carrying Victor in their palm?” Knight Kia asked. “It’s too dangerous to take him there. A random spell and he would die for good.”

The dragon grumbled but considered her words. His minion may indeed be too vulnerable, and the dragon lacked the funds to raise him again for now... “Dragonly goblin.”

“Yes,” Goblina asked, her face the very picture of worry.

“As befitting of our alliance, I shall leave my chief of staff in your lands, until my minions nurse him back to health and I can summon him back to my side,” Vainqueur said. “If anything happens to him while I am away, I will burn this island to cinders. Am I clear?”

The goblin reeled a bit at the threat but nodded. “I have the best minions in the world,” she said. “A week? We will have him woken up in three days flat! But what about the Tarasque?”

“Obviously, you feed him while I am absent. Minions, I expect you to prove yourself better than her servants,” Vainqueur told his own lackeys. A little minion competition could only increase their productivity. “I must leave and put Icefang in his place by burning the fairy farm first.”

“I’m coming with you then,” Knight Kia said.

Vainqueur looked at the uppity manling. She must have had a square root nine intelligence score not to understand that he didn’t want her around. “No.”

“Can you take me, please?” the [Paladin] all but begged him, joining her hands. “Please, I need action!”

“How much then?”

Knight Kia froze. “How much what?”

“How much will you pay me for the privilege?”

Since he knew Grandrake couldn't hear her, the dragon took the knight's silence for an admission of poverty. When she mustered the courage to speak up, it was to haggle. “You want me to pay you for *working*?”

“I do not want, I *require* to be paid to overlook your uselessness,” Vainqueur explained in terms that she would understand. “Being on an *exclusive* adventure with the best dragon in the world is an honor, of which you are unworthy. Without proper tribute, I cannot look the other way.”

Now that he thought of it, he could make an income out of it.

“That's—” Knight Kia stopped herself from trying to overstep her minion station, and instead let out a long sigh. “You will need someone to talk with the locals. I can fill in for Vic.”

“As you filled in as my niece's minion?” Vainqueur replied with contempt. “And I assure you that the locals will beg for the privilege of granting me guidance.”

“They won't if they can't understand you,” the [Paladin] replied. “Victor wrote down the farm's location near Nagastan, and they don't speak common or dragon there.”

Vainqueur opened his mouth to mock her further. “Ah, I will have a minion cast a translation spell on me before I leave! Your logic is flawed!”

“The spell will wear off by the time you reach the country. While I can cast it at will.”

Vainqueur was about to deny her anyway until he realized that without [Master's Shield], he would have no way to heal himself in a pinch. The [Paladin] may be a subpar minion, she could help him recover from wounds...

“Fine,” Vainqueur said. “But you shall ride the zmey. My hand is too good for you.”

He could already imagine the moment when his chief of staff would sweep that inbred dragon right from under the knight's nose...

Leaving the island of Teikoku behind, Vainqueur flew in a straight line towards his destination, flying across the sea and then reaching the massive mainland. Knight Kia told him that they would cross the Jade Empire first, the name stimulating a memory. Something about a dragon helping the local manlings "cultivate."

Vainqueur would have loved to boast back and forth with this mighty kindred, but he was short on time. Icefang and his party had already left, and he needed to meet them at the farm not to default on the challenge.

The wyrm flew over the mainland for a full day, through the night and onto the next sundown while Gorynych struggled to follow. They crossed verdant forests, rice fields, and mountains; yet the manling cities they passed through seemed mostly deserted.

Their journey led them to dry lands between the ocean and an enormous chain of mountains which made the Albain Mountains look like hills. Vainqueur smelled the scent of scaled beastkin, from serpentine nagas to lizardmen, on the ground.

The dragon decided to stop at a large city on the way, a hive of round terracotta houses near a local forest. Unlike the manling stone and wooden hives to which Vainqueur had grown accustomed to, this place had been built mostly with red clay and bricks. Architects had focused on columns, pillars, and rounded roofs, while the dragon noticed the presence of tigers and elephants in vast pens nearby.

Like all the other cities they had flown over, this one seemed deserted; yet Vainqueur's sharp senses noticed people inside the houses, too shy to face him.

"We arrived sooner than I thought!" Vainqueur rejoiced, as he landed in the empty plaza. "We may have time for a quick quest."

“A quick quest?” Kia asked, leaping off Gorynych’s back as the zmey collapsed in exhaustion.

“Gorynych is thirsty...” the zmey said. “Gorynych needs mother’s milk...”

“I must train in my classes, and fill my hoard with new gold,” Vainqueur reminded Knight Kia of the purpose of life. “Now, announce my presence.”

“Like what, a herald?” Knight Kia asked, showing her lack of minionship.

“My chief of staff always announces my great and magnanimous presence to primitive natives,” Vainqueur told the uncultured biped, already regretting taking her on this trip. “Tell them that I bring them dragon civilization.”

“Ah, alright,” the knight said, quickly casting the translation spell on both herself and the best dragon of all. “Oyé Oyé, brave citizens, we come to help!”

“For money!” Vainqueur reminded her, the manling making a face. “And tell them to bring me their cattle!”

The door of the rounded houses opened, a manling-sized black cobra slithering out. Vainqueur recognized it as a serpent beastkin, or naga; one wearing a red scarf around his mouth. “What is all this racket?” the naga hissed, before noticing Vainqueur and the paralyzed Gorynych. “Oh, another dragon adventurer party. Great. Look, if you come for cows, I will have to politely ask you to leave and never return.”

[Alpha Magnetism (Scales)] negated by **[REDACTED]**.

“Is this the village of Dhanyakuria?” Knight Kia asked, having been in charge of mapping out the trip; the naga nodded, quickly as eager to be done with her as Vainqueur himself. “We are looking for a fomor stronghold in the area. Did you see any sign of fairy activity recently?”

“No, because everyone stays at home,” the naga replied. “We haven’t heard anything from nearby villages for a while, but I can’t tell if this is a fairy’s

or the plague's doing.”

“Can you give us the direction of these villages—”

“Minion Kia, you are losing sight of what truly matters,” Vainqueur walked towards the naga, getting exhausted at the knight's incompetence. “I have time for a short quest.”

“Quests? Nobody is questing with this bloody plague! All the adventurer guilds are closed and our economy is ruined!” the naga hissed while wagging its tail. “And respect my safety space!”

“You have nothing to fear,” Kia said. “I have immunity to [Disease], and as a [Paladin], I can cure it at will.”

“A [Paladin]?” The naga instantly turned towards Kia, observing her with such intensity that it made the manling uneasy. “Which deity?”

“Mithras,” she replied, the naga wagging his tail in excitement.

“That changes everything! Yes, I may have a quest for you!” The naga cleared his throat. “Our architect guild is running its yearly building competition. A team must visit and rate our designs, but they need to include a [Paladin] of Mithras or Leone. With all healers mobilized to deal with the [Fairy Plague] and the social distancing, we can't find anyone fitting our criteria.”

“Why would you need a [Paladin] for an architecture competition?” Kia asked with a frown.

“Because [Paladins] of these gods are compelled to say the truth and to act with chivalry,” the beastkin replied. “So we can trust them to give their honest opinion. Since we can't restrict the competition to only one class, their partners can be anyone or anything.”

“How much and how long?” the dragon asked the hard questions. “I am the best adventurer in the world with the highest rates, and we are short on time.”

“One million gold if you win the competition,” Vainqueur salivated, only for the next words to crush his hopes, “But it may take a few days.”

Argh, too long! “You will have to wait until after I burn the fairy farm for your winner.”

“And I won’t take that quest,” Knight Kia said, whose lack of greed marked her as unworthy of minionship. “I have no need for gold.”

“Winners also receive a powerful magical item from our guild’s divine patron,” the Naga said, “Some even received a [Heroic Crest].”

“Why would someone receive a [Heroic Crest] for an architecture competition—”

“Less questions, more gold,” Vainqueur interrupted, finding her lack of enthusiasm for hoarding aggravating. What did Manling Victor see in her? She lacked any true dragon value!

“Don’t you see this quest is fishy, Your Majesty?” Knight Kia asked.

“When someone offers a quest with a reward that high, he is either mistaken or treacherous.”

“If you doubt my words, then simply cast magic on me,” the naga said. “I have nothing to hide.”

“I said I would stop profiling, but I will make an exception then; [Enhanced Karma Scan],” Kia cast a spell, reading the Naga’s karma. A smile quickly spread on her face. “Moderately good and orderly... that’s refreshing after almost so long in Murmurin, I had forgotten people like that existed.”

“Where can I find the gold when I have the time to claim it?” Vainqueur asked, now that this part was settled.

“First, vow to participate and give it your all first,” the snake insisted. “Our divine patron really insists on that part.”

“Certainly, I swear to win,” Vainqueur shrugged.

“I swear on my honor,” Kia replied, “if Shesha needs reassurance.”

“Oh, my guild doesn’t worship Shesha,” the naga replied. “She tolerates us because of the business opportunities our dungeons provide, but our adventurer death ratio is a bit too high for her taste.”

The [Paladin] blinked. “Did you say dungeons?”

“Yes, dungeons. I am a [Dungeon Architect] and [Trap Master]. What, you thought trapped tombs grow on trees? Who do you think designs all those snake pits and secret passages? Nobody ever respects our hard work.”

“Do not remind me,” Vainqueur said. “When I order them to build arenas and more towers for my castle, it is a constant struggle to direct my minions. Alas, their minds cannot grasp my peerless, visionary design.”

“So the contest would be a... a dungeon architecture competition?” Knight Kia drew her sword. “Wait, which deity would sponsor a guild like that?”

The naga looked at her strangely. “I find your attempts to have me confess my faith an attack on my religious freedom.”

“But you just asked which god I served—”

“Yes, but that doesn’t mean I have to tell you. What if I worshiped Seng? Would you treat me differently?”

“Yes,” Knight Kia replied ominously.

“My point exactly.”

“I care not which ‘deity’ you became the minion of,” Vainqueur said. “Where is the gold?”

“Do you have a map and a feather?” Knight Kia reluctantly handed the naga one, the serpent struggling to scribble a small cross on it. “Damn twolegs, can’t make a map adapted to armless people... now if you excuse me, I have to flee from the germs.”

“Your Majesty, are we really going to do this?” Knight Kia asked, glaring at the snake as he returned home.

“Yes, but after I burn the fairy farm first,” Vainqueur replied. One million gold coins would more than help crush Icefang’s delusions of wealth.

Speaking of Icefang... the dragon hummed the wind to pick up his rival’s smell, in case he had managed to sneak up ahead of him.

Skill check successful.

Vainqueur froze.

“What?” Knight Kia asked.

“I smell...” Vainqueur couldn’t believe it. “Dragon blood?”

Chapter 115: Item Farming

The fairy's nest stank for miles!

The longer he observed it from above, hidden amidst the clouds and positioned against the wind, the angrier Vainqueur grew. This... this *insult* to the dragon way of life would not survive the day.

It had taken him hours to locate it, due to powerful illusions shrouding the area from sight; phantasms that his [Hunter's Resolve] Perk and magical items had easily negated. And when they had finally found the farm in the midst of a forest, Vainqueur had to struggle not to attack it on sight.

For the fairies had copied his Dodocare design, to make a mockery of it!

Instead of breeding birds for their own protection, the fairies had captured large groups of malnourished manlings, beastkin, kobolds, and other intelligent species in large cages, with twenty of them sharing a six square meters space. The prisons were arranged in rows, overseen by a black wood fort and a pack of fairy hounds.

In short, this was a *slave* breeding ground.

Vainqueur would have been appalled at how the fairies treated their minions on principle, but something else infuriated him. The stench of dragon blood that pervaded this insult to dungeon breeding.

“Gorynych doesn’t like this place,” the zmey said, Knight Kia on his back.
“Can Gorynych go back to master?”

“Not yet,” Kia said, glaring at the pens. “Not yet.”

“I want this place burnt to the ground,” Vainqueur said. “This insult to the dragon way of life shall not stand.”

“Your Majesty, we may prevail if we attack head on, but we also risk harming the prisoners,” Knight Kia said, speaking like Manling Victor. “They may have more in the fort. We need a plan. I suggest you distract them while I free the captives.”

As she spoke, three figures walked out of the wooden fort and moved towards the pens. The dragon and his substitute minion observed them more closely.

Vainqueur recognized one of them as Mell Lin the piper, Mag Mell’s cowardly spawn, who assisted nuisances like adventurers and Batling Lavere. This time though, he had abandoned his manling disguise to reveal his true shape, that of an emaciated, ghoulish figure with bark skin. Some kind of armored orc taller than average with that worm Sablar’s symbol painted on his chest followed him, alongside a humanoid black tiger.

“Frank the Anark,” Knight Kia recognized the orc. “A Sablar follower that I ‘fought’ with Jolie. The other must be a rakshasa. They use illusions—”

“Quiet,” Vainqueur replied, as serious as he had ever been. “I am *trying* to listen.”

Focusing on his sharp dragon hearing, capable of distinguishing the M from the m, the wyrm attempted to hear their conversation even with the great distance separating them.

Skill check successful.

“... interesting,” the tiger spoke. “What about elves?”

“Elves, being a rarer species, tend to drop better items when killed by an [Old Money] user,” the orc replied. “The target’s level does affect the quality, but the species matters more. The more powerful and rare the base creature, the greater the reward for killing it.”

“And of course, humans have the lowest yield, while dragons provide the highest,” Mell Lin stated the obvious. “What about [Crests]? Any new discoveries on that front?”

“Adult dragons almost always drop one, and someone of Knightsbane’s caliber is probably worth a [Heroic Crest].”

“I meant, for creatures *other* than dragons,” Mell Lin replied icily, examining caged kobolds.

The tiger shook his head. “No matter our efforts, we haven’t found a way to make the lesser races drop [Crests] when they die.”

The orc made a strange hand gesture at the rakshasa, raising his third finger. Maybe they were exchanging hand signs as part of a code? “The System encourages the weak to fight the strong, so we ‘lesser races’ can reach ever greater heights. You need *heroic feats* to prove yourself worthy of a [Crest]. Trying to ‘cultivate’ them like fruit is pointless.”

“And I say that if Lord Mag Mell could create [Black Crests] imitations, then we can breed manlings capable of dropping [Crests] in a few generations.”

“They won’t have generations,” Mell Lin replied. “My sister wants them all exterminated within two years, if bombing them back to the stone age won’t finish the job. We need more [Crests] *now*, and [Heroic Crests] even more. The longer my sister stays level 60, the more impatient she becomes.”

The orc and the rakshasa exchanged a worried glance. “Maybe other planes?” the former proposed. “The enemies there are stronger on average than Outremonde’s. You could start with the angels.”

“They will yield more experience?” the tiger asked.

“No, but nobody will miss them. Destroying the world is one thing, but afterlife insurance scams? That’s just *low*.”

Mell Lin shrugged in response. “In any case, prepare to pack your things when my sister returns from her ‘harvest.’ Our dear father bit off more than he could chew, and while she can’t scry on Knightsbane due to his Perks, my sister believe that he will be on his way to this location soon.”

“What do we do with the captives then?” the tiger asked.

“Use [Black Crests] on the toughest of them, to bolster our ranks with more fairy beasts. The rest, round them up for target practice.” Mell Lin chuckled to himself. “Now, orc, as my class planner, should I kill them with spells or music?”

“You would be better served with more [Bard] levels, to expand the reach of your melodies.”

“Music then.”

The group reached a suspiciously empty cage, whose soil was red with blood. Vainqueur suddenly realized that this spot, in particular, reeked of fresh dragon blood.

“Where is my wyrm pet?” Mell Lin asked the tiger, causing the Emperor above to ready his claws.

“Lord Ravana accidentally got carried away while he practiced his [Rune Knight] class, and killed him with a spell-boosted hit.” Vainqueur saw red, trembling with rage. “We harvested the blood and bones for your sister’s use though.”

“My, and I had grown attached to him.” the piper shook his head, before scolding his acolytes. “You should have been more careful. While dragons yield less exp when beaten within an inch of their life than killed, this blunder cost us a renewable source of easy levels. Adult wyrms are difficult to capture alive.”

“Well, the good news is, he got a [Dragonslayer] level out of it,” Frank the orc said, the fairy chuckling in response.

Intelligence check successful! [**Berserk**] negated!

Vainqueur had heard *enough*.

“Do we attack?” Knight Kia asked, having heard nothing, but saw Vainqueur’s furious expression.

“*Yes!*” the dragon snarled, gathering his breath for an attack. “Let no fairy escape!”

“Gorynych, at my signal, you dive down while I create a barrier between these monsters and the captives’ pens,” Knight Kia said, raising her blade. “Our priority is to protect the slaves first. Your Majesty, can I leave the fomor to you?”

Indeed. Time to emancipate these minions.

“[Charged Attack]...” Vainqueur prepared to blast the damn piper all the way to planet Moon, although he was very careful to aim his attack so there would be no minion casualties.

With the benefit of surprise on the dragon’s side, the piper would never escape—

“ICEFANG FOREVER!”

Screaming his name, Icefang dived from a cloud, trying to steal Vainqueur’s kills right before his nose.

The sudden noise caused Mell Lin to raise his head and notice the dragons above him. Realizing the surprise was lost, Vainqueur hurriedly launched a beam of light at the piper, although wary not to hit the caged minions.

Reacting *far* quicker, the fomor opened a fairy ring and leapt through it, the orc managing to jump in right afterward. The rakshasa, not so lucky, was instantly vaporized by Vainqueur’s focused nuclear light, the soil turning to molten glass.

Icefang, meanwhile, stomped a fairy beast upon landing, roared to announce his presence, and then unleashed his breath. A cold, icy blizzard came out of his mouth, freezing the fairy hounds that dared to challenge him *and* the slaves unfortunate enough to get caught in the way. Dozens of manlings were transformed into ice statues, while Manling Kia screamed at the dragon to stop.

Knight Kia and Gorynych hurried to rescue the captive minions, raising a wall of flames between Icefang and the pens to shield them from his breath. The farm erupted into such chaos, that Vainqueur no longer knew where to begin. When fairy hounds almost trampled the pen while fleeing Icefang's rampage, the Emperor moved to protect the slaves, punching a hole through a monster's chest, and then sending a second flying towards the forest.

"Ah!" Icefang taunted his rival, who had only killed a few fairy thralls. Icefang's compatriots, Magnifique and Suffisante, descended from the clouds, to tally the dead. "You have already given up?"

"You silver-loving idiot!" Vainqueur hissed, as the last of the fairy servants escaped to the forest. The Emperor took the time to launch a fireball in their direction, blasting trees apart, and then focused back on his 'rival.' "You let the piper escape!"

"As if I would let you claim the lead!"

"Well, at this rate, we can already declare Icefang the winner," Magnifique said, landing with his colleague among the crater left by Vainqueur's blast. His eyes settled on the caged manlings. "Free minions!"

"I want the elves," Suffisante insisted, noticing a tiny, leaf-eared child among the captives. "Look at this one! She is so adorable!"

"What were you *thinking*?!" Knight Kia snarled at the trio, as she cast healing spells on the slaves Icefang had turned to ice. "You harmed them!"

"Vainqueur, your minion is talking back," Icefang complained. "Teach her the food chain or I will do it myself."

“Is that a *zmey*?” Suffisante reeled at the sight of Gorynych, who had the decency to lower his head and tail in submission. “Vainqueur, you travel with a *zmey*?”

“Is that your long lost cousin?” Icefang mocked him. “That explains a lot! He has your eyes!”

“He is the minion of my minion!” Vainqueur defended himself.

“You think this is a game?” Knight Kia ignored the minion way of speaking, but since she did it to Icefang this time, Vainqueur let it slide. “These captives are barely clinging to life, you could have killed them with your stupid stunt!”

Suffisante laughed. “Manling, they are not people. They are minions!”

“Yes, they are like goblins,” Magnifique added. “You leave a cave empty for a month, and before you know it a new population has resapa—reasa...”

“Respawned,” Suffisante said. “The proper, System-approved term is *respawned*.”

“Respawned, yes. Minions are renewable, the dragon-made universe provides them to us on command. Lose some, win some.”

Knight Kia remained speechless for a second. “This isn’t sarcasm,” she said. “You truly believe everything you said.”

“What is sarcasm, some kind of food?” Magnifique asked.

“Minions are *not* renewable!” Vainqueur hit the ground with his fist, making the other, smaller dragons shake in surprise. “They cost a fortune to raise, and can be made near-extinct! And these creatures are slaves, a fairy mockery of the proud minion institution!”

“They’re minions,” Icefang replied, too dim to understand the profound nuances of the dragon way of life. “They’re food. That’s why they’re minions.”

“They are *emergency* food,” Vainqueur reminded him. “They have feelings, and their loyalty must be earned. No true dragon disposes of them for no good reason!”

“Vainqueur, you have been talking to your breakfast for too long,” Icefang rasped in disgust. “You sound like your niece!”

“I turned a city into a buffet!” Vainqueur defended his regime.

“I can attest to it,” Knight Kia spoke up.

“Guys, don’t get worked up over how to treat minions.” Suffisante rolled her eyes while ignoring the [Paladin]. “Can we just agree that dealing with individual minions should be left to their dragon master’s judgment?”

“Yes, we came here to see which one of you could kill the most fairies, and the only fomor in sight has escaped,” Magnifique pointed out. “He cannot have gone far.”

“There is something more important at hands here!” Vainqueur roared, pointing a claw at the empty cage, “A dragon died in this place!”

“Oh, that smell?” Suffisante hummed the wind. “Indeed, that is worrying.”

“Pff, who will mourn a handicapped dragon?” Icefang shrugged. “Although this insult to dragonkind shall not stand, I agree with you. The fairy’s days are numbered.”

“Death...” Vainqueur caught himself but realized he could no longer keep this secret. “Death is not a birth defect. Every dragon can die.”

For a moment, the three dragons said nothing, exchanging glances among each other.

Then they burst out laughing.

“This is the truth,” Vainqueur insisted, remaining a dignified visionary even when faced with mockery. “Every dragon can die, and if you keep laughing, you will discover it yourself. Even *I* can die.”

The trio immediately stopped laughing, although they remained blind to their own ignorance. “Vainqueur, I was once *proud* to be your rival, but clearly you have gone soft and mad,” Icefang said after he calmed himself. “No true dragon can die!”

“True dragons do not believe themselves immortal.” Vainqueur remained firm. “To be a dragon is to look at Death, and burn its sorry face!”

“Say what you want, I have a fairy head trophy to claim.” The frost dragon extended his wings, to go after Mell Lin. “I will leave you with the zmeys and food you prefer over your own kind.”

“At least they make better conversation than you!” Vainqueur roared back, as the frost dragon flew away.

“Vainqueur, you truly need to form a dragon adventurer party,” Magnifique said, as he and Suffisante followed after Icefang. “Don’t lose your way!”

The Great Calamity of this Age sneered as these children, only to notice Knight Kia and Gorynych giving him strange looks. “What?”

“You and Victor are definitely *not* heroes, but...” Kia scratched the back of her head, “You aren’t without your good sides either.”

“Big V defended Gorynych!” the zmey wagged his tail in happiness.

Vainqueur ignored him, focusing on the disgusting smell pervading this place. Following it towards the wooden fort, the dragon punched his way through the wall; the sight welcoming him made him freeze.

Bones.

The bones of a dragon hung from the ceiling above pools full of its distilled blood. Some strange machinery pumped the golden, tarnished fluid into a half-made crest of solid darkness.

Vainqueur remembered the dragons he and Manling Victor had rescued in the Winter Kingdoms. About how happy the Emperor had felt, how bothered he had been over Furibon’s escape, and how he had thought the

matter settled. It had never occurred to him that the fairies could have hunted other members of his kind elsewhere.

He had been wrong.

They didn't save them all.

In the end, Vainqueur had used his [Golden Road] to evacuate his new minions to Murmurin. Since they had been abducted by fairies, most of them choose to live under the fair, iron hand of a dragon, rather than risk capture again. They had taken the bones of his kindred through, so he could be buried in a dragon's empire rather than fairy-tainted soil.

Finally, he had burnt the fairy farm to the ground, the wooden fort first. He remained there watching the bonfire for a good hour, Gorynych resting nearby.

"For all of what it is worth, I think you were in the right," Manling Kia said, trying to comfort him as a true minion should.

"Of course I am in the right. But such is the burden of the visionary, to swim against the current of their own kind." He had thought himself invincible too, before discovering the *TRUTH*!

"Yeah... being good sometimes means going unrecognized, or not being rewarded at all," Knight Kia said. "But someone has to do it."

"Not being rewarded?" Vainqueur asked. "Of course I have been rewarded. I gained hundreds of new minions for remaining true to the dragon way of life."

"Yes, but... you know what, forget what I said. You still did good. I just wish we could do more slave liberating than country conquering."

Truth to be told, Vainqueur was tired of *both*. "Time to return home," the dragon decided. "This trip was entertaining while it lasted, but I miss the warmth of my hoard. We move west, do a few more quests to fill my wallet, and then we put this behind me."

“Doesn’t Your Majesty want to attack the local fomors?” Knight Kia suggested. “They must be hiding somewhere.”

Vainqueur froze, as he suddenly remembered something.

“Mell Lin said that his sister would return from harvest,” the dragon noted out loud, looking at the direction where Icefang and his group went flying.

Mmm... should he even bother? If Icefang and his group won, it was one less problem for him to deal with; if they died, well, they had mocked him and it was not his problem.

...

No.

Species first.

“Minion, to arms.”

Knight Kia beamed and immediately jumped on Gorynych’s back.

Vainqueur extended his wings and flew after his foolish rival.

Vainqueur had gone soft.

Even if he loathed that arrogant, self-proclaimed ‘Great Calamity of this Age,’ Icefang couldn’t believe that any dragon worth their salt would act as he did. Preserve the life of minions? Dragons not being immortal? What next, the Moooooon was made of lead? He had already doubted Vainqueur's sanity when he had sacrificed his hoard to revive his chief of staff, but his mental state had clearly worsened since.

The title of greatest dragon in the world needed a new holder, and fast. Someone who *deserved* it. All his kind would see it on Samhain.

Skill check successful!

In any case, it didn't take Icefang long to locate the fomor; he could have tracked his smell halfway across the planet with his awesome [Ninja] skills. The piper and his orc lackey had retreated to a naga village, meeting up with a female fairy witch with crimson eyes. She was listening to her fellow fairy's hasty words with a cold expression, surrounded by corpses.

The local nagas had dropped dead. There was no hint of battle, no scorch mark, no destroyed houses. They must have been instantly slain by the fairy's magic.

Icefang didn't care. More fairies meant more glory and more rewards. The dragon announced his presence with a roar, circling the village before making a dramatic landing right in front of them. His mighty body blew dust in all directions and collapsed the nearest house.

While the piper and the orc shielded their face from the dust with their arms, the third member of the trio didn't even flinch. The female fairy simply looked at Icefang with crimson eyes, her purple hair falling upon her shoulders. "A new volunteer."

Icefang answered by unleashing an icy breath at the fomors. The female fairy casually conjured a spherical, purple barrier around her group, shielding them from the attack. "Return to Prydain, Lin," she ordered the piper, her protection vanishing. "Leave them to me."

"Do you need golem reinforcements?"

"No."

The lesser fomor didn't even question the order, opening a fairy gate and vanishing through with the orc.

"Leave them to me, she said," Magnifique chuckled, as he and Suffisante landing right behind Icefang. "Since she asked so nicely, maybe we could share?"

"If you dare steal my kill, I am cutting your share of the next quest," Icefang told the others. This fairy was clearly stronger than the piper, and as

such worth much more. Maybe she would drop an [Heroic Crest]?

“Aw, but we only get levels if we intervene!” Suffisante protested. “You already all but won the contest with Vainqueur! You can at least share this one!”

“Knightsbane is nearby?” The fairy raised her head, a glimpse of satisfaction in her eyes. “Good.”

The fact that she cared more about that sorry excuse for a red dragon rather than *him* infuriated Icefang. “You should fear me instead of Knightsbane! You face the leader of the *Silver Dragon Adventurer Company*, the great Ice —”

“I do not care for your name,” the fairy brazenly cut him off. “I will not remember it.”

“Bold words for a nameless fairy,” the frost dragon hissed back.

“The three of you are already dead. Tell me where Knightsbane is and I will make it painless.”

“You face the most powerful dragon party in the world,” Suffisante taunted her back. “A [Paladin] [Priest], a [Vestal] [Druid], and... a [Ninja] [Pyromancer].”

“It is a perfectly valid combination!” Icefang snarled.

“All that I face is three walking corpses,” the fairy said, a purple aura flaring around her. “Dragon blood is a source of power, but the one coursing through my veins only served to bolster my divine fomor nature.”

Icefang would have taunted her, had the air not suddenly gotten heavier.

An invisible, overwhelming pressure overtaking the atmosphere, crushing him beneath its weight.

“Although, I would not have been able to access this class without it.”

The fairy's body exploded into a shroud of purple darkness, a monstrous, titanic shape erupting from it; an *oh-so-familiar* shape, that made the three dragons step back in shock.

Icefang didn't know what he felt at this moment, but it *itched*.

[**Dragon Arrogance**] overcome by [**Terror**].

Icefang and his party members prepared to fight for their lives, as the abomination before them let out a soul-rending wail.

Chapter 116: TPW

Icefang had caught up to the fairy first, and lost.

As Vainqueur reached a destroyed village, he found Magnifique and Suffisante motionless on the ground amidst the corpses of a dozen nagas. Houses had been pounded into dust, while ice shuriken and laceration marks scarred the landscape.

A good mile away, he noticed a swirling tornado of icy winds and miasma devastating all in its path, uprooting the entire forest. Icefang and whichever fairy had trounced his party were still fighting bitterly.

“Magnifique, Suffisante!” Vainqueur called, as he landed next to his fellow dragons with Gorynych in tow. “Wake up!”

No response, even though none of them looked wounded. They must have been beaten into unconsciousness or fallen asleep due to a spell.

“All these people...” Knight Kia said while riding Gorynych’s back, the zmey too intimidated to speak. “An [Instadeath] area of effect?”

“You, minion!” Vainqueur pointed a claw at his fellow dragons. “Heal them!”

Knight Kia remained silent for a moment, before shaking her head. “I can’t.”

“What do you mean, you cannot? I knew you were useless!”

“I can’t cure *death*.”

Vainqueur paused.

Cure death? But they didn't have any wounds!

Vainqueur glanced at the two dragons in disbelief and gave them a closer look; he noticed the white blank in their eyes, the pallidness of their scales, the complete lack of warmth. The truth hit him like his own magical hammer.

Vitality check successful. Shock negated.

Vainqueur stared at their faces, frozen in terror.

They died of *fright*?

“This is not [Instadeath]...” Knight Kia said, analyzing the corpses with magic. “Their souls have been extracted while they were still alive.”

Vainqueur ignored her, his furious eyes settling on the icy cyclone. He expanded his wings and flew towards it with revenge on his mind, while Knight Kia and Gorynych quickly followed.

The dragon activated [Fire Crown] and [Victory Fist] as he entered the vortex. Ice shards melted before they could touch his scales, and he braved the battering winds to reach the center.

You are taking heavy [**Wind**] damage! Necromantic damage reduced by [**Psi-stone of Positive Energy**]!

[**Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh**] cast [**Protection from Elements**]!

With his trinkets shielding him from the storm, Vainqueur entered the eye of the cyclone, where two dragons were dueling to the death.

Icefang was fighting a beast as big as Vainqueur himself and losing badly. Blood flowed from his scales and horns, his right eye had closed forever due to a wound, and someone had dug a hole where most of his ribs should have been. The larger wyrm savagely strangled Vainqueur's rival, its bony claws tightening around his windpipe while smashing him against the ground.

No.

Not a *dragon*.

The monstrous creature that fought Icefang had the *shape* of a dragon. It had the wings, the neck, the tail, the fangs, and the claws. It breathed purple flames and roared its dominance for all to hear.

But that *thing* was no dragon. It was an abomination of white bones and putrescent moss, a corpse animated by ghostly purple flames and reeking of foul fomor magic. Two bright crimson stars shone in its empty eye sockets, and a spherical core of suffused energy radiated within its ribs. Its ragged wings had holes everywhere, reminding Vainqueur of an ancient bat rather than a majestic wyrm. A magical, prismatic layer of light covered its body, providing magical protection.

This creature was an unliving insult to dragonkind!

As Vainqueur charged to face it, he sensed something foul in the air. An invisible, sinister pull drawing him towards the monster.

You have entered [**Dracolich**] Mell Odieuse's [**Voracious Syphon**]!

If you die within its area of effect, your soul will be devoured!

[**Terrifying Aura**] negated by [**Crown of the Conqueror**].

The undead dragon heard Vainqueur arrive and reacted by casting multiple spells at once. "[Death X], [Accelerated Hellzone]."

Level high enough! [**Instadeath**] negated!

[**Hellzone**] negated by [**Immovable**]!

Vainqueur tackled the fairy monster with his hands, forcing it to relinquish Icefang. The half-dead Frost Dragon collapsed to the ground, profusely bleeding golden blood.

“Knightsbane,” the undead creature muttered, recognizing her superior. Albeit twisted by a whispering echo, Vainqueur immediately identified the voice, and the smell. The fairy that murdered his chief of staff, stole his items, and cost him a fortune! “Is your manling with you?”

“He has better to do than clean up fairy trash!” Vainqueur snarled, shining with the bright, golden light of his hoard. “Like breeding new minions!”

[**Shining Majesty**] couldn’t affect [**Prismatic One**] Mell Odieuse!

“A pity. I relished the thought of killing him again.” The false wyrm let out a screeching wail and opened her mouth, unleashing purple, ghostly flames at Vainqueur. The attack didn’t damage his scales but sapped his very will, his soul.

Massive [**Spirit**] damage!

[**Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh**] reflexively cast [**Hasten**]

Moving at an incredible speed, Vainqueur powered through the attack and pummeled the fairy with a dozen punches, faster than she could defend herself against. The creature fought back with vicious ferocity, but she had neither the Tarasque’s strength nor Wotan’s awe-inspiring skill.

“How many?” the [Augustus] snarled. “How many dragons?!”

“Not enough.” The monster vanished, transformed into a ray of light, only to reappear a hundred meters away from Vainqueur. Ten tiny flying black prisms materialized around her. “[Prismatic Shards].”

The tiny prisms fired a potent laser, each a different color, and all aimed at Vainqueur. The dragon moved around the battlefield to dodge them, while Mell Odieuse used his distraction to cast another spell. “[Magical Suppression].”

The effects of your magical items will be suppressed for five minutes!

Charisma check successful! You ignored [**Terrifying Aura**]!

Vainqueur felt his body slow down, and rays of light hitting his scales; he considered using his [Geomancy], but relented out of fear of harming Icefang.

Thankfully, minion reinforcements chose this time to cross the cyclone.

“Leave... leave Big V alone!” Gorynych opened his mouths to attack Odieuse but froze at the mere sight of her. Unlike Vainqueur or his own rider, the zmey became paralyzed by terror.

“What is this *thing*?” Knight Kia shouted in disgust, before casting a spell on the monster; information appeared over Odieuse’s head, revealing her true nature.

Mell Odieuse the Overlord

Type: Soulcrested Dragonblooded Fomor (Fairy/Dragon; also count as Undead whenever beneficial)

Level: 60 (Dracolich 10/Prismatic One 10/Tyrant 10/Deathlord 30)

HP: ???/5280

Weak to Starmetal and Cold Iron.

“I am an existence that transcends fomors and dragons,” Mell Odieuse lied proudly, as she began assisting her prisms into attacking Vainqueur, firing ghostly fireball after ghostly fireball. The dragon retaliated with his own flames, but the fairy teleported out of the way like the annoying Furibon. “The strengths of both, the weaknesses of neither.”

“Yeah, I heard that one before,” Knight Kia shrugged off, before raising her sword and calling upon her [Solar Judgment].

[**Solar Judgment**] canceled by Mell Odieuse’s [**Anathematic Horror**].

No light fell from the heavens to smite the fairy. “Your gods will not save you from my jaws, Bekele.”

“No, but my sword will!” Knight Kia countered, wreathing her blade with wind and light. Unfortunately for her, the zmey refused to budge, paralyzed by his overwhelming fear of the false wyrm.

“[Gorgon Gaze],” Mell Odieuse whispered while glaring at the zmey and his rider. The three-headed reptile immediately turned to cold hard stone, falling on the ground. Meanwhile, Knight Kia ignored the spell and jumped off her mount’s back and towards the fairy. The [Paladin]’s blade cut through bones and carrion like butter.

“Why?” Knight Kia snarled as she landed on the ground, leaping to avoid being trampled by the larger creature. “Why kill these people? You shouldn’t gain any exp from them, so *why* you sick—”

“I believe you mortals call it *happiness*.”

The fairy’s body radiated an otherworldly, unnatural light as she expanded her wings, becoming a mockery of Vainqueur’s own [Shining Majesty].

All of Mell Odieuse’s stats have been raised by one stage, and her [**Light**] attacks will inflict twenty percent more damage!

“This feeling I experience whenever I extinguish a life; this rapturous sensation, that fills me with such bliss; this pleasurable heat that warms my innards whenever I devour a soul. I am *drunk* on this feeling. This is the purpose of my existence.”

The expression on her rotting, shining face made even Vainqueur pause.

For it was one of pure, adulterated *bliss*.

“To be *happy*.”

The abomination let out a wail while her starry eyes brightened, unleashing a potent curse on everyone present. An invisible pressure crushed both Vainqueur and Knight Kia, weakening them.

Mell Odieuse’s [**Evil Eye**] decreased all your stats by two stages!

Charisma check failed! You have been affected by [**Terrifying Aura**]! [**Terror**] ailment!

The world turned darker, and for the first time in the entire fight, the crushing reality of the power difference dawned upon Vainqueur. The creature before him had been created to kill his own kind, and that for all of his might, he couldn't defeat it.

His limbs shook in dread, as the prisms kept hitting him with beams of light.

Heavy [**Light**] damage! You have lost a quarter of your HP!

“There is no future for your kind, Knightsbane,” the abomination whispered, approaching the emperor of Murmurin while the prisms kept firing. “I shall rain arrows of searing light, so bright that all will burn. Poisonous smoke will reach so high in the skies, that it will choke the very gods of Valhalla. But for you, there will be no light; only the darkness of my gullet. All will go pitch black, as your soul is digested and your blood dries on my kingdom's soil. You shall become dust as I ascend, the thirteenth and last goddess of Outremonde.”

Her claws tightened around his neck, ignoring [Fire Crown]. He felt the chill from her fingers, his soul forcefully pulled away from his mortal coil.

The monster's rib cage opened, revealing her core in its full, sinister glory; hundreds of thousands of souls swirled within this prison sphere, wailing and begging for release. Among them, Vainqueur glimpsed Magnifique and Suffisante.

“Once I have purified Outremonde of the vermin that infest it, I shall cleanse the Earth, and then the world afterward. For all life I extinguish, from the smallest vermin to the greatest dragon, grants me equal satisfaction... and I shall never stop pursuing happiness.”

Vainqueur just had to close his eyes, and it would be over. His soul would be drawn into the vortex, and darkness would claim him forever.

She was *death*.

And there was only one way a true dragon could answer it.

Charisma check successful! [**Terrifying Aura**] negated by [**Dragon Arrogance**]!

Vainqueur opened his mouth, and blasted the fomor right in her ugly face!

Mell Odieuse screamed in pain and surprise, as the [Augustus] kept incinerating her rotting carcass; the agony too great for her to focus on teleporting away. The prisms once again attempted to hit him with lasers, but the wyrm increased his fiery output and melted them in atomic flames.

Then Mell Odieuse poked him in the right eye with her sharp claw, and Vainqueur screamed.

Half his vision turned bloody red.

Warning! You have been [**Blinded**] in one eye! You will take a penalty to all visual percep—

Vainqueur punched Mell Odieuse in the chest, her ribs closing to protect her magical core. The undead dragon teleported again out of sight, the Calamity of the Age guessing that she would strike from his blinded side. He turned his head around, noticing the undead false wyrm unleashing a volley of icy shards at him.

[**Mirror Scales**] activated!

His protection caused the spells to bounce back at the sender, hitting Mell Odieuse by surprise. Vainqueur countered with one of his new abilities and pumped as many SP in it as he could afford. “[Malleus Maleficarum].”

A spiritual hammer hit Mell Odieuse right in the head, fracturing her skull and dispelling the otherworldly light empowering her.

All of Mell Odieuse’s spell protections have been dispelled!

You have lost half your SP.

“I can’t believe it...” Minion Kia muttered to herself, as she managed to shake off the [Terror] effect. Icefang himself rose back to his feet, albeit struggling against his wounds. “Your Majesty’s build is the perfect counter to this abomination!”

“I am the counter to everything!” Vainqueur boasted, unleashing a volley of fireballs at his fairy rival. The creature dodged by teleporting around, but couldn’t find any opening to retaliate.

“Get back, Vainqueur!” Icefang shouted, channeling ice in one hand and fire in the other. “She is mine!”

“You cannot handle her alone,” Vainqueur replied, but this only infuriated the frost dragon.

“I do not need your help!” Icefang snarled while charging, Knight Kia after him. “I have enough! I have enough of you being better, bigger, more loved than me while you do *nothing* to earn it! I will live in your shadow *no longer!*”

That idiot! “Time to perish like your fellow Mag Mell, fairy,” Vainqueur snarled, trying to draw the enemy’s attention on him.

[**Taunt**] unsuccessful.

“My father’s only worthwhile action was to create me,” Mell Odieuse whispered with cruel disdain, before opening her rib cage again, “[Soul Slaver].”

Two clouds of smoke escaped from the magical core, then quickly morphed into ghostly dragons.

Vainqueur froze, as savage, shadowy copies of Magnifique and Suffisante appeared to protect the false wyrm. The first immediately lunged at him, forcing the red wyrm to defend himself in close combat, while the latter engaged Manling Kia in battle.

Icefang, meanwhile, slipped past both shadows and attacked Mell Odieuse, hitting her with his elemental claws. He handled himself well for a second-stringer, fighting with savagery even with his heavy wounds.

For a moment, Vainqueur was almost proud to have him as a rival.

“Be still, weakling,” the fairy hissed angrily. Her core pulsed with energy, repairing her skull and healing the damage inflicted faster than her rival could damage her.

“Never!” Icefang snarled back with draconic pride. “A true dragon does not surrender!”

“Then *die*.”

Icefang opened his mouth to unleash his breath, only for Mell Odieuse to grab his maw with both hands and keep it shut. The frost dragon fruitlessly attempted to free himself, but the fairy kept him down before widening her own jaws.

Vainqueur attempted to rush to his fellow dragon’s rescue, but Magnifique’s enslaved shadow tackled him aside.

And the inevitable happened. Mell Odieuse unleashed her purple breath at Icefang.

Purple flames came out of the magical core, traveled through the throat, and came out as a torrent of destruction from the fairy’s maw. Icefang let out a final roar as the ghostly power washed over his scales, his own *soul* becoming visible to the naked eye. The unnatural breath's power separated the frost dragon’s spirit from his body, the ghost instantly drawn into the fairy’s gullet.

Icefang’s body went limp, and a ray of light shone from the skies; a rainbowy crest descending from the heavens.

“Icefang!” Vainqueur snarled as the fairy tossed his rival’s corpse aside, punching Magnifique’s shadow through the chest. The apparition collapsed,

its smoky substance returning to the false wyrm's core.

“At last,” Mell Odieuse whispered, swiftly grabbing the crest and opening a fairy ring portal her size, “I have what I stayed for.”

“A [Heroic Crest]!” Knight Kia shouted while beheading Suffisante's shadow, whose smoke-like substance returned to Mell Odieuse. “Vainqueur, don't let her—”

“[Charged Attack]!” Vainqueur gathered all his energy for a final attack, to finish the fairy off once and for all.

Without turning around, Mell Odieuse casually pointed her free hand at the petrified Gorynych and fired a shadowy sphere at him.

His body moving on its own, Vainqueur leapt into the attack's path, tanking it.

Heavy [**Darkness**] damage! You have lost **half your HP!**

Why? *Why?*

Vainqueur couldn't believe that he did *that* for a zmey, even a minion!

Knight Kia hastened herself and rushed after Mell Odieuse with her blade raised, closing the gap in seconds. While she did so, Vainqueur attempted to quickly summon his arena and trap the fairy. “[Glitzy Theat—”

Too late.

The fairy crossed the portal and closed it behind her, Knight Kia's blade hitting only air.

When the cyclone collapsed into a harmless breeze, Vainqueur could only stare at his brethren's corpse, a freezing chill filling his chest.

His old rival had died for nothing, and his killer lived on.

Chapter 117: Sleep Disorders

All was as dark as the blackest abyss.

It was far from silent though. And it smelled of honeyed cake.

“Is he waking up?” Chocolatine asked, having been at Victor's side since he fell into a coma. “Is my delicious cake working?”

“No,” Allison said. “No sign of recovery.”

“Can I take a slice?” Goblina asked, followed by some noise. “Ouch, the cake bit me!”

“That happens at random with Choc’s [Monster Pâtissier] class,” Allison said. “Ludvic, is there no way to hasten the recovery?”

“Tempt him back to the physical world, with the promise of greater pleasures.”

“I made the smelliest cake ever! If only Felix was alive, I could have cooked him... he seemed to really like my *Stuffed Garfield* recipe.”

“Choc, maybe we should tell him?” Allison suggested.

“But I wanted it to be a surprise!” Silence. They must have all been staring at her. “Vic, you know that sacrificial altar I keep pestering you about? The one with the goat?”

“Since Choc is meeting both of us, and you saved my life... I thought I could replace the goat.”

...

“Choc, is it working?”

“Just a twitch.”

“Damn, I was certain it would wake him up,” Allison sighed, “I am sorry, but I have run out of ideas.”

“Not me,” Goblina said, followed by a loud sound. “Oh, look at that. A million gold coin purse slipped from my pocket and fell on the ground! Enough to buy lots of stat-boosters! My, what would happen if someone were to pick it up before me?”

“His fingers moved, but only a tiny bit,” Chocolatine said.

“Enough with the carrot,” he heard a new voice. Charlene’s. “Time to try the stick.”

“That’s... Charlene, you’re not considering reading him that book? It almost killed him the first time!”

“Exactly. Reading the *‘Breeding Frenzy’* out loud will force him to wake up or die!”

... no.

“He’s twitching!” Charlene rejoiced. “I am opening the book! I am about to read it!”

No, no, no!

“Wait, you’re killing him!” More noises to his right, as if they were fighting. “Give me that!”

“That’s enough!” Allison’s voice echoed. “Out, everyone! Out, out, out, we let him rest!”

“But—”

“No Pink literature!”

Charlene grumbled, he felt soft hands briefly hold his own, and then the sound of a door closing.

Phew. He wouldn't have survived past the first chapter.

How long would he have to stay this way though? It must have been days at least.

"Slimy one." His totem animal's voice echoed in the darkness, a call to action. "Slimy one, you must wake up."

'I'm trying!' he complained, unable to articulate his words. He lacked the strength to even open his eyelids, let alone return to his [Black Grail]!

"Your dragon is in danger and needs your stickiness. The Hateful One is growing stronger. You must focus on your glue. Use the glue, Slimy One!"

Use the glue? Like what, his bonds?

Alright, focus on Vainqueur. Focus on your friends, focus on the mess that Murmurin will become once you're gone.

...

Nope. Nothing. He should have known it only worked in movies.

"Oooo...."

Was that Felix's voice?

Wait, what was that warm burden on his lap?

"Ooooo!" Felix's voice hissed. "I'm haunting you! For the sin of eating me, I will haunt your lap, minion!"

In retrospect, he should perhaps remain asleep and stop dealing with this nonsense.

"And now I shall make a litter out of your body!"

Victor's eyes snapped open.

Felix the cat hissed in surprise, while the Vizier's hand lunged at him like a snake. The cat attempted to leap away from the bed, but Victor caught him by the neck.

"You feel very solid for a ghost, Felix." The [Reaper] narrowed his eyes at the overfed cat, a screen suddenly appearing.

Congratulations! For meeting its requirements and witnessing the goddess of pleasure's true face, you earned a level in the prestigious [**Fiendish Rake**] class! You earned the [**Planeloved**] class perk!

+30 HP, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +2 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Planeloved**]: You can teleport to a different plane of existence of your choice on a successful Charisma check, except Earth; the more familiar you are with the target location, the more precise the transportation. Additionally, you gain a permanent Charisma bonus equal to half your total level rounded down (currently +36).

Was this class worth it? Was it worth the pain of having his soul torn from his body from the mere sight of Cybele's beautiful face? Was it worth spending days trapped in his own body, unable to move a muscle?

Yes. Yes, it was.

The bedroom's door opened, Allison, Chocolatine, and Ludvic rushing in. "Vic!" the dryad called, beaming in happiness like the werewolf. "You're awake!"

"I told you he simply needed time," Ludvic said with a shrug. "The multiverse has so much to offer."

"Felix!" Chocolatine focused on the feline with primal hunger. "You are alive?"

"Begone, cateater!" The feline struggled, but couldn't escape Victor's hand. "You cost me a life out of nine!"

“Felix, this is wonderful!”

Chocolatine grabbed the cat from Victor’s hands and held him against her chest.

“I can cook you more than once!”

The cat screamed in fear, but much like Victor before him, he couldn’t escape the iron pull of Chocolatine’s bosom.

“I am so glad you made it, Vic,” Allison said, helping him stand out of bed. The Vizier stretched, noticing his scythe next to the nearest wall. “I thought you wouldn’t make it.”

“Yeah, I guess I built up a tolerance to gods after being claimed by half the pantheon.” At this rate, he might try to collect them all. “She was really nice though. If Camilla hadn’t come up first, I might have prayed to her more often.”

“How did she look?” Allison asked, stars in her eyes. “Cybele? How did she really look?”

“She was... have you ever watched a good *Death Note* movie?”

“I can only imagine it.”

“Exactly,” Victor replied, snatching his scythe and feeling complete once more. “Also, about that goat bit...”

“You heard everything?” Allison seemed a bit embarrassed, putting a hand in her hair. “After you recover, handsome.”

“Aw,” Chocolatine pouted in disappointment. “Can I get the chain and the knife out of storage early?”

The things he did for lust.

Ludvic put his hands on both Allison's and Chocolatine’s shoulders. “Since he is awake, I need to have a talk with him. Could you give us five minutes

alone?”

“You aren’t going to lead him to his near-death again?” Allison frowned. “I can’t handle another extended vacation.”

“It’s fine,” Victor said, before joking. “It’s a matter of state diplomacy.”

The dryad struggled to believe him, but did so anyway; she took Chocolatine and the doomed Felix with her, before closing the door behind.

“Have you taken a level in [Fiendish Rake], my apprentice?” Ludvic asked after Victor cast a [Lock] spell on the door, his protegee nodding. “How much charisma with the bonus?”

“One hundred fifteen. One hundred thirty-five with [Monster Kin] active, and five to ten more with [Seducer].”

“Good, you should be able to talk your way out of anything short of a dragon’s jaw. Be *very* wary when you reach the one hundred fifty thresholds, because you will be on every stalker’s radar. A three-digit Charisma stat is a double-edged sword that must be handled with care. With great persuasion, comes great responsibilities.”

Yeah, Ludvic could probably talk his way to world domination with a Charisma stat as high as his own. “You think I could talk down a fomor?” That was one of the main reasons he had taken this class, alongside improving his dating life.

“It is worth a shot, but speaking from experience, I strongly suggest you keep a hidden fortune to get an emergency revival,” Ludvic said, before handing him a bag. “Here are a few items that I wished I had when I was your age: a [Ring of Friends] to buff your Charisma in a pinch, an [Amulet of Repulsiveness] like mine, and a [Belt of Genderbending], which inverts the sex of anyone wearing it.”

“Thanks, I appreciate it.” The Vizier bowed in thanks. “But I’m not sure I will have any use for the belt.”

“You told me that you could cast tier VIII spells. One of them, [Fetch], allows you to create temporary duplicates of yourself.”

Victor blinked, upon realizing what was implied. “Isn’t that a bit narcissistic?”

“When you want something done right, sometimes you must do to yourself.”

“I feel like you operate on a higher level of existence that I can scarcely understand,” the Vizier admitted. “I will take the belt just in case it can be useful, but I doubt I will ever go *that* far.”

“It will come with age,” the dandy replied, before clearing his throat. “Victor, your dwarf friend has arranged for my trip to the Moooooon; by now you should have everything to shine on the road to pleasure. But before I leave this planet in search of new sensations, I have a few words of advice I must impart onto you.”

“Please teach me, senpai.”

“Use your [Planeloved] perk and an eighth-tier spell to create your own private corner of the multiverse, then furnish it as the most expensive resort possible. Opportunities never come twice, so always be ready to teleport your date there; but never reveal its location to anyone else, and always stash it with weapons, potions, and emergency rations.”

“I was already planning to do that,” Victor admitted. “Mostly as a private sanctuary.”

“Good.” Ludvic patted him on the back and looked at him straight in the eyes. “Next, there will come a day, which I feel will be very soon in your case, when you have an *accident*. You think the protection ward worked, but it didn’t; that well-endowed troll matron will say your two species can’t reproduce, but they can; or that eight-legged telepathic spider is a deranged stalker who will do anything to keep you in her web. Do you follow me so far?”

“... yes?” Victor said, a bit uncomfortable with the subject.

“When that happens, I want you to look at the sun.” Ludvic turned him towards the windows, pointing at the skies. “You look at that bright guiding star.”

“And then?”

“And then you *run*. You run as fast as you can. They will shout your name, try to hold you back, but you don’t listen. You run, you run and you keep running until your legs can’t carry you anymore. And then you use your wings and you fly away some more.”

“That’s a bit cowardly and irresponsible, now?”

“When you have a spawn in every web, you will understand. Next, the most important advice I can impart. No matter how cute she looks, no matter how much you pity her or how tempting, do not ever, and I mean *ever*, touch—”

“MINION!”

Victor left his bedroom for a devastated wasteland and exchanged the best mentor ever for a giant red dragon.

“Minion, you are awake.” Victor froze, for Vainqueur sounded more solemn than he had ever been. His right eye had also a new, thin claw scar, as if someone had just recently applied a healing spell to it. “Good. I have a question of the utmost importance.”

“Uh, yes?”

“Where do dragons go when they die?”

Victor frowned, and then looked around. Kia was casting spells on a Gorynych statue among upturned houses, near a pile of reptile corpses. The Vizier recognized Icefang and two dragons among them.

It didn’t take him long to guess what happened. And he didn’t know what to say.

So he simply put his hand on his grieving friend's leg. "Your Majesty, why are you asking me?"

"Because I do not know myself," Vainqueur replied grimly. "I never asked before."

The whole misadventure had left a bitter taste in Vainqueur's mouth, and not because he hadn't even gained a level out of it. His right eye still itched a bit, even after Knight Kia healed it.

He should have been happy for Icefang's demise; he had even considered doing the deed himself in the past.

But for all their faults and foolishness, Icefang and his party were dragons. They deserved better than *this*.

"Big V took a hit for Gorynych," the healed zmey said, as Vainqueur oversaw Manling Victor reanimating the nagas as undead while Knight Kia prayed in a corner. Even on a hard day like this one, the minion labor division would remain absolute. "Gorynych is sorry..."

"You are a poor, inbred excuse of a minion," Vainqueur said, Gorynych making three sad faces. The emperor remained silent for a few seconds, before adding with more warmth. "But you are still *my* minion."

The zmey raised all of his heads, wagging his tail. "Big V cares for Gorynych!"

"I do not!" Vainqueur turned his back on the zmey and ignored him. "Report, minions."

"I can only revive them as mindless undead," Manling Victor said. "The souls cannot be returned to their bodies so long as Mell Odieuse holds them. Or if they can, none of my spells are powerful enough to."

"Maybe draining them is what allowed her to reach level sixty in such a short time," Knight Kia wondered, after ending her prayer. "She did mention digesting them."

“You can eat souls for easy levels?” Knight Kia glared at Manling Victor. “I mean, it’s interesting academically speaking. I would never do something *that* vile.”

Since he lacked the funds to raise one dragon, let alone three, Vainqueur decided to give Icefang’s party a worthy funeral. The thought of being reanimated by a minion would be unbearable to their living selves, and the emperor owed them that much respect.

He gathered his breath, and then unleashed a holy nuclear fireball at the three dragon corpses, setting them on fire.

Vainqueur thought he should add a few words, as the corpses burned bright before the group’s eyes. “I met Icefang while capturing one of my first northern princesses,” the wyrm declared, “I was young, and he was smaller. I introduced myself as the Great Calamity of the Age, with a hoard full of gold. He answered that his hoard of silver was equally valuable.”

Manling Victor remained silent as if expecting more. “Wait, that’s it?”

“To deny the supremacy of gold was a crime I could never forget,” Vainqueur confirmed. “He had been my self-proclaimed rival ever since. He was never successful, but he managed to become the leader of a dragon group and push me a little. A good dragon needs a rival to keep them sharp. What is gold without silver to compare its shininess to?”

But now he and his fellows were gone, and they would not be forgotten like Furibon.

“The fairy will pay for her crimes against dragonkind and minions both,” Vainqueur declared. “She may be half-dragon, half-Furibon, but I will destroy her all the same.”

“She cancelled my [Prayer] spells and my [Solar Judgment],” Knight Kia said as if anybody cared about her. “It never happened before. I asked Mithras, and he answered that one of her [Dracolich] Perks negates most of my [Paladin] abilities.”

“It would make sense that she took levels in a class that can counter the person who killed her predecessor,” Manling Victor pointed out. “And with a [Heroic Crest], she will keep growing stronger.”

The [Paladin] shook her head. “I just wasn’t good enough.”

“You were not,” Vainqueur agreed. “But I do shoulder some of the blame. I thought my breath would have been enough to finish that abomination when I should have trapped her in my beautiful theater first.”

“That’s why Kevin always insisted we have a well-oiled strategy before confronting high-level opponents,” Knight Kia said, fired up. “We need better plans, and I need new classes.”

“We need a Tarasque,” Manling Victor added.

“Yes,” Knight Kia said. “She can’t be allowed to win. No matter what.”

“Odieuse won’t become a goddess, Kia,” Manling Victor nodded. “I swear.”

“No, she won’t, because *we* will beat her to it, minion,” Vainqueur declared. “When we return to Murmurin, instead of celebrating my victory over Icefang, I will call upon a Dragon Conclave to deal with the fairies.”

“A Conclave?” His doer of the thing asked.

“A great gathering of dragons never seen since we won the first fairy war,” the wyrm explained. “Bragging Days are for bragging; Conclaves are for war.”

His two manlings exchanged glances. “How many dragons will attend?”

“If I have my way, and I always do,” Vainqueur looked at the burning pyre, “*All* of them.”

Chapter 118: Home Again

“Finally!” Vainqueur rejoiced upon reaching the coast and seeing the ocean.
“At long last!”

After days of flying nonstop through the desert, the sight of clear water filled him with boundless joy. Watching the sun setting on the water had never felt so pleasurable.

“This is the inner sea east of the V&V Empire,” Manling Victor said, riding Gorynych with Knight Kia behind his back. “We’re almost home.”

“Is Your Majesty sure they do not want to tackle that dungeon quest yet?” Knight Kia asked, a bit disappointed. “While definitively fishy, we need more levels and magic items.”

“My hoard calls me,” Vainqueur said. This journey had exhausted him, especially the last stretch. “I may be a tireless, beautiful dragon, but I need to feel the warmth of my gold under my claws.”

Also, the hoards of Icefang and his crew were left unattended. If they had no next of kin to claim them, then he would recover them himself. A rival’s memory should never get in the way of profit.

“I say we should do as many difficult quests as possible,” Knight Kia argued. “Maybe look for artifacts like the legendary [Plot Armor]. Wouldn’t that help against Odieuse?”

“You are surprisingly enthusiastic today,” Manling Victor said. “You’re usually more... I dunno, nonchalant?”

“Remember what I told you in Daltonia?” Knight Kia asked, the chief of staff nodding. “I finally have a purpose again, and I’ve never felt more

pumped. I could clear dungeons all by myself!”

“Well, since I can cast eighth-tier spells now, I can finally learn decent teleportation spells,” Manling Victor said. “We can easily do this quest after putting our more important affairs in order.”

“Indeed, since a Dragon Conclave’s buffet is the organizer’s responsibility,” Vainqueur explained, Manling Victor’s skin turning white. “Minion, you fed everyone in time for my Bragging Day while I ruled a desert, instead of the verdant minion utopia it is today. You can manage.”

“I think Your Majesty is a bit optimistic, but... well, we have a teleportation network and a Tarasque food supply now. I’ve also received a [Scarlet Study] report telling me that the Agarthans successfully transported the beast to the Dodocare.”

Knight Kia made a strange face. “Can a Tarasque reproduce with dodos?”

“Yes!” Vainqueur nodded.

“No,” Manling Victor replied, ever pessimistic. “Or at least, if they can, I pray that I never see the deed in action.”

Speaking of a buffet made Vainqueur even hungrier. “I demand a feast of cattle!”

“Gorynych hungry too,” the zmey complained. “Gorynych hungry enough to eat himself!”

“There’s a Nagastan trading post nearby,” Manling Victor said, pointing west. “We can resupply there.”

“They have colonies that far west?” Knight Kia asked, crossing her arms. “I would have thought that Barin would have assimilated the area already.”

“Nagastan managed to establish a trading route through the dusted remnants of the Sablaris Empire,” Manling Victor said. “From what I understood, it causes tensions with the local powers like the Eversun Empire, who

interpret these trading posts as prelude to military expansion. I suppose the plague probably delayed a full-out conflict in the region.”

Vainqueur cared nothing for manlings' squabbling, and neither did his stomach. “Friend Victor, find me a cow soon or we shall call upon Knight Kia’s service.”

“Me?”

“I don’t think she can summon any food,” his chief of staff said.

“She is a minion,” Vainqueur reminded Manling Victor of the food chain. “If we do not find food soon, we will have to make a sacrifice to avoid starvation.” Since she was the least valuable minion of the group, he would rather start with her than with Gorynych.

“What does that mean?” Knight Kia asked, oblivious to her duty. “Victor, what does he mean?”

“Oh, nothing!” Manling Victor replied hastily. “Let’s just find that trading post!”

Thankfully for the [Paladin], it didn’t take long to locate it. The owners had built a large brick house on a cliff, near a sandy road and a pen full of goats. The place could probably welcome dozens of manlings, but lacked any dragon accommodations.

Was it too much to ask for a lava bath?

After everyone landed, startling the goats, his minions climbed down from Gorynych before knocking on the door. A decomposing ghoul with a rounded hat opened the door, immediately noticing Vainqueur. “Oh, two dragons at once!” he said with a gruff voice. “That’s a first.”

“Where is the other?” Vainqueur glanced around, ignoring Gorynych.

“Have you come for healing?” the innkeeper asked. “If so, please fill out your afflictions in our document.”

“Wait, I recognize this voice,” Knight Kia muttered, “Nestor?”

The ghoul squinted, before quickly recognizing the [Paladin]. “Lady Kia? Is that you?”

“Nestor, you crusty old ghoul, it’s been years!” Knight Kia smiled at the undead. “How have you been?”

“You know him?” Manling Victor asked,

“He was a crusader back when I fought during the Century War,” Kia said. “Best archer I ever knew!”

“That feels like a lifetime ago,” the ghoul said, before whistling at Vainqueur. “Then, you must be the famous V&V Adventurer Company!”

“Certainly, the words of my deeds pale before my magnificence!” the emperor boasted proudly.

“Well, either they say you’re heroic champions of freedom, or a greedy warlord bent on conquering countries for a nickel. It’s odd, it’s always one extreme or another. Sorry I didn’t welcome you properly, the place is a mess.”

“What are you doing here in the middle of the desert?” Knight Kia asked him, perhaps hoping to get a discount. “I haven’t seen you since the last battle with King Balaur.”

“I retired from adventuring, and Nagastan’s naga lords pay me a small fortune to maintain this trading post,” the undead replied. “I mostly service the few adventurers or merchants brave enough to cross the desert.”

“Wait, you’re a ghoul, a carrion eater,” Manling Victor stated the obvious. “How do you feed in the middle of nowhere?”

“Let’s just say I don’t accept tabs,” the ghoul replied with a crooked smile. “In your case though, since you got Lady Kia on your side, your stay is free. There are sick people in most of my beds though; infected merchants I’m trying to keep alive.”

“You are a healer?” Manling Victor asked.

“I am a capped [Innkeeper]. Thanks to my class and personal Perks, my inn can heal almost anything. HP, SP, status effects, petrification, mutilations...”

“Wait, how does that work?” Manling Victor pushed. “We pay for a bed and we grow back arms?”

“You need to pay for a bed and have eight hours of sleep in it, and you’re healed at the end of the stay,” the ghoul explained. “With the plague going on, I have become the de facto hospital.”

“Can you cure dwarf addiction?” Vainqueur’s head perked up. “Asking for a minion.”

The ghoul made a strange noise, before disappointing the dragon. “I can’t cure either addictions nor the rare [Stockholm Syndrome] disease. I can heal [Enthrall] though.”

“You can cure total mind-control, but not alcoholism?” Knight Kia squinted.

“I don’t make the rules, Lady Kia. Anyway, that nasty plague resists magical healing, even my own perks. But since I can refresh everybody’s HP every eight hours, at least I can keep the sick alive until we find a cure.”

“I will cast [Full Heal] on them,” the [Paladin] offered, but much to Vainqueur’s confusion didn’t ask for a fee first.

“That would help a lot, but please be wary with them milady,” the innkeeper replied. “The infected look normal for days, and then they start spraying infected blood everywhere.”

“Oh, is that how diseases work?” Vainqueur pondered curiously. He had always wondered how that mammal birth defect happened. “Sometimes, I wonder how you minion species managed to survive on your own.”

“Come to think of it, dragons are immune to diseases, and I developed a resistance to them when I leveled up in [Monster Knight],” Manling Victor

said. “Maybe there’s something to explore there.”

“So far, even experienced alchemists and healers have yet to find a remedy,” the innkeeper shrugged.

“I have trained under Camilla herself,” Manling Victor replied, the ghoul sneering. “Yeah, I know, I shouldn’t boast about it in the current circumstances, but if anyone can find a cure, it would be me.”

Vainqueur immediately understood his chief of staff’s plan. “And then we sell it for a high price,” the dragon rejoiced. “Brilliant!”

“You want to profit from the misery of the sick?” Knight Kia argued angrily, failing to see the big picture.

“Look at me, manling,” Vainqueur said, staring into the [Paladin]’s eyes. “What would minions say if I, the richest dragon in the world, provided them with a cheap remedy?”

“That you are kind and magnanimous?”

“No, that the remedy is worth nothing!” Vainqueur replied. “Have you even considered the cost? Time Manling Victor spends on it, is time he does not spend attending to my every whim!”

“This discussion can wait until *after* we find a vaccine,” Manling Victor said, while the innkeeper somehow rolled his rotting eyes.

“I will settle on sleeping in the sand, but I demand a tribute of cows in return,” Vainqueur insisted. “Goats will not do.”

“I’ll check if I have beef left in the pantry.”

“Also, Nestor, we’re close to the Tower of Sablar, right?” Knight Kia asked, “I’ve been considering hitting that place up on our way back.”

“The *Pyramid*,” Vainqueur corrected, still remembering the genie disaster that started there. “I am not sullyng my claws there again.”

“You’re a bit late for that,” the ghoul said. “Place has been emptied two weeks ago. Apparently, it still had a crazy mummy and an army of undead at its bottom, but they all left.”

Vainqueur suddenly remembered that his minion once told him that the mummy Akhenapep made his lair at the bottom. “Explain,” the dragon ordered.

“The mummy called upon all the damned Sablar worshipers across the desert to join him. Some stuff about the ‘end is nigh,’ the usual. He even had golems with signboards.”

“Their end *is* nigh,” Vainqueur said. “That mummy owes me millions.”

“Any idea where they went?” Manling Victor asked, eager to avenge his master’s lost wealth.

“I dunno,” the [Innkeeper] shrugged. “From what I heard they opened magical portals and vanished through. Still, almost every crusader I’m still in contact with moved back to Gardemagne soon afterward. I dunno what’s happening, but I heard the fomors in Prydain are acting up.”

And they should. For their days were numbered.

“Since you’re here, can I get an autograph?” the ghoul asked the group. “I get the feeling that it will cost a fortune in a century.”

“Do not worry about that,” Vainqueur reassured him. “It costs a fortune *now*.”

Two more days of flying with a full belly, and Vainqueur’s group returned home.

Murmurin had grown even larger since they had left it, mostly thanks to the dwarf portals opened all around the city. Countless new faces had poured into the capital, whether they be goblins from the Teikoku Empire or manling traders from Port Vainqueur. The desert had been pushed further back, golems and sorcerers tending to verdant fields.

Vainqueur let out a roar to announce his triumphant return, the citizens raising their eyes to the skies in response. Cheers and clapping soon echoed across the streets, his minions welcoming their beloved ruler back the proper way.

The dragon moved towards his castle, which had remained unchanged since his departure and first conflict with King Wotan, before making his way into his vault and to his one true love.

“Good to be home,” Vainqueur said, upon resting on his hoard.

His gold reserve had recovered from Untasty Allison’s revival, but it hadn’t grown either. The dragon took solace in the fact that his new colonies would eventually increase its size tenfold; he simply had to wait for the gold to flow.

Congratulations! For completing the first world tour of Outremonde, you and your trusty chief of staff earned the [**Magellan**] Personal Perk!

[**Magellan**]: You can teleport to any city or dungeon that you already visited at will.

Manling Victor, Knight Kia, Corpseling Jules, Tasty Malfy, Marbré the Dwarf, and other minion dignitaries joined him in his vault. “Minions,” Vainqueur cleared his throat. “May the empire sing my name in joy, for I return victorious!”

“Indeed,” Corpseling Jules said, examining a pile of papers. “With the new conquests, our resources have increased dramatically. We have already started exploiting Port Vainqueur’s remaining naval infrastructures, extracting the whiskey sea, and established trade treaties with foreign nations. Our monopoly on the first worldwide teleportation network is expected to double our national revenue for the next year.”

“You will be happy to know that your army is prepared, and armed with the safest equipment ever designed,” Marbré added happily.

“What about the *Piggybank II*?” Vainqueur asked, having mourned the loss of the first to Wotan’s lightning. Never again would he fly across half the world by himself again. The dragon had lost so much fat that he could see his ribs!

“Almost finished,” the dwarf promised.

“And the Orknoob rocket?” Manling Victor asked, much to Vainqueur’s confusion.

“Ready to launch on Samhain,” Corpseling Jules replied. “We are keeping the surprise until the key moment, to avoid a riot from his followers.”

“Wonderful,” Knight Kia said. “Can I oversee the preparations? It’s not very [Paladin], but it has to be done.”

“With pleasure,” Tasty Marbré said. “And you will be happy to know that our guiding system and passenger safety protocols have been tested, tested, *tested*.”

“There are a few negative points to address though,” Corpseling Jules said. “Namely Heaven. The angels drastically cut down their investments in the empire, and while they still maintain hospitals and schools, Miel’s departure is a blow to our administration.”

“Happyland is more than happy to compensate the Empire for this loss,” Malfy said hastily while glancing at Manling Victor. “For we do not forget our heroes.”

Knight Kia made a face but focused on the real threat. “Are we ready to attack Prydain?”

“We can organize a landing on their coasts after Samhain,” Corpseling Jules nodded.

“Then Minions, I have a mission for you,” Vainqueur said while enforcing silence. “You shall spread across all corners of the world, meet with every chief of staff, and have them transmit a message to their dragon masters.”

All his minions readied himself, waiting for him to enlighten them.

“The fairies violated the ancient truce that bound our species; they abducted helpless wyrms to harvest their blood, and escalated to stealing their souls! This cannot stand!”

[El Presidente] activated!

“I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, have already declared war on Prydain, but this is no longer about me!” The dragon raised a fist. “The fomors must be taught a lesson, and for that, in the name of the Elder Wyrms, I call upon the first Dragon Conclave since the end of the first Fomor-Dragon war! And there shall not be a third!”

Most of his servants raised their fists, ready to conquer Prydain in dragonkind’s name. “For the Revolution!” the dwarves in attendance shouted.

“Free real estate!” said Malfy.

“And new undead!” Corpseking Jules added.

“For the world!” Knight Kia raised her blade.

Manling Victor clapped and smiled, although he looked strangely bothered.

“And now...” Vainqueur trailed, his minions all waiting for his final words.

The dragon nested on his treasure.

“And now I take a nap.”

Chapter 119: Prophecy Fulfilled

What a bright sunny day. What could go wrong?

So Victor asked himself, as he flew over Isabelle Maure's corner of the V&V Empire. Tonight was Samhain, the Outremonde equivalent to Halloween. A time when undead and monsters acted up, like the ones making up *his entire nation*.

And they had failed to kill Odieuse before this date.

Which meant that she *would* get her hands on those 'arrows of light' he had been forewarned about. Between the missing Apple of Knowledge, Brandon Maure's Wind Spears, and the Fomors' access to Earth technology, Victor had a pretty good idea of those weapons' true nature.

The future looks dire, but not all is lost, the Vizier told himself. They had magic, allies, levels, and resources aplenty. They defeated Maure, the Nightblades, Wotan, Akhenapep, and even recruited a goddamn *Tarasque*. They would soon face their most dangerous enemy yet, but there was hope. With [Harvest], he could focus on extracting every information Mag Mell had accumulated on Prydain, and prepare for the coming war.

Still, Victor would need a pocket dimension sanctuary as soon as he could manufacture it.

He finally reached the settlement that the Archdevil had established, a fortified town in the middle of the desert. Unlike the semi-anarchic Murmurin, the governor ruled her patch of *Maureland* with an iron fist; almost all of the settlers were bug-like fiends, and Victor noticed an armored hellknight at every street corner. Workers built new houses and

fortifications everywhere, while sorcerers were busy growing plants on the dry soil.

He quickly located Isabelle managing a group of fiends establishing the foundations of a new watchtower. The archdevil oversaw the construction with a pleased gaze.

“Isa?” Victor called her as he landed. “How is my favorite private teacher?”

“Darling, you are back!” she said, smiling at his arrival. In fact, she looked much happier than he had ever seen her before; she had taken some weight though, especially at the hips and the belly.

“I see that you have adapted to your new role well,” he replied, removing his helmet.

“As you did to your new armor,” she said, appreciating it. “You feel different. Did you earn new levels?”

“And a huge charisma increase.”

“I can definitely see that,” she said, looking at him like an appetizing dinner. “Maybe we should put it to the test?”

“Actually, I can cast Tier VIII spells now,” Victor said, taking her in his arms, “I thought I could fashion my own private dimension.”

“Mmm, I have scrolls for spells that you could learn,” she replied, pushing him a bit. “I will be more than happy to teach you that trick if I am allowed to furnish the place. I have high standards for private leisure sanctuaries.”

Truth to be told, if he could do it, Victor wanted to build more than one sanctuary. To have back-up escape sanctuaries for Murmurin’s citizens, planar hidden caches, maybe intermediary checkpoints between the colonies. But that was long term planning.

“I would be very glad to resume your magical studies, especially in [Diabolism],” Isabelle said. “That will take my mind off this urban development project. The raw fabric of Happyland will bow to our will.”

They would certainly need it. “I’m always up for a private lesson, but you also wanted to tell me something important, no?”

“You are looking at it,” she replied, a hand on her stomach, “Or rather, at her.”

“Oh, that you have gotten ffffffffffffffffffffffffff—”

Victor’s brain stopped working, as the truth hit him like a truck on a highway.

His mind rewinded several memories in quick succession, linking them all together into a simple, terrifying picture.

“I have something to tell you on your return.” “She couldn’t make it in time.” “A medical examination...”

Intelligence check successful!

“BLEEP.”

“It is a girl!” the archdevil rejoiced, “I hoped for a Braniño II at first, to replace the old one, but this is even better. *Braniña* will grow into a marvelous CEO warlord, cruel *and* beautiful. My, I even asked Fiendo Bugcci to design all of her wardrobe until she reaches eighteen.”

Victor wanted someone to pinch his arm and wake him up. But nobody did. “This is serious? This is not a joke?”

“I am serious. I know I spoiled Brandon rotten, but none of my children will dress like a blue-collar worker.”

“No, I meant, how can this be happening?!” Victor freaked out.

“Darling, we have been seeing each others for days... years...” The archdevil hesitated, before settling on a time period. “Years. It was bound to happen.”

“But, but, but—”

“I know,” Isabelle replied. “After the first dozen tries, I thought this could never work between us, but it simply took a few hundred more! My healers told me that she would be a [Demon/Humanoid] instead of the [Bug/Dragon] I hoped for, but she will inherit excellent genes from us both. She will have twice Braniño’s starting stats and unique Perks!”

Victor listened, but he could only focus on one thing. “A daughter.”

“Our daughter.”

Thanks for reminding me. “C-can we discuss it more in length?”

She stroked his face. “You are afraid?”

“Of course I am!” That’s completely unexpected! “We aren’t even married!”

“Darling, I am a demon,” she replied, offended, “I would never marry you. This is against my principles.”

“I, I meant that we aren’t even exclusive!” Or at least he wasn’t, and he made that clear from day one. “And I never wanted to!”

“Darling, I am still fine with you keeping mistresses on the side,” she replied softly, apparently unable to understand his problem. “However, as *my* consort, I insist that you recognize Braniña as your true-born daughter. This is very important, since as the hero of Happyland, this may make her eventual ascension to Corporate Overlord much easier. Maybe she will become Outremonde’s very first [Demon Queen]! Wouldn’t that be wonderful?”

Frankly, Victor didn’t know what to answer. He didn’t know how to deal with this situation at all.

“I know this is a very big change in our lives,” the archdevil conceded. “But, as a Grand Vizier, you need an heir. Maybe even a few spares. We could create a dynasty that will one day rule all of Outremonde.”

Wow, she was skipping a lot of steps there!

“I need a moment to process this,” the Vizier admitted, his breathing short.

“It is fine, Darling, but do not process too long. If she is anything like her half-brother, she will start clawing her way out in a couple of months once I use elixirs to hasten the process. I cannot afford to take a parental leave in these troubled economic times, you understand.”

A couple of months? That wasn’t nearly enough time! A couple of *years* wouldn’t be enough!

“I... I will come back later,” Victor said, having too much on his plate right now to react with a cool head.

“Take your time, Darling,” she replied happily, before immediately barking orders to her workers. “More to the left, the new watchtower!”

Victor walked away towards the desert, before using his newly earned [Magellan] perk to teleport back to his mansion for some alone time. He needed to breathe, to return to his place, see his lawyers, do something, *anything*!

Except he found Allison and Chocolatine waiting at the door.

While the dryad seemed only concerned, the werewolf looked outright *devastated*. Had something happened to her brother on the Moon? Unfortunately, he could do without more shenanigans right now.

“Ah, good morning girls.” Victor saluted them, doing his best to look cheery and not anxious. “If this is about the cat, I heard very shocking news and I’m not in the mood. Can this wait?”

“No, Victor, it cannot,” Allison replied, while Chocolatine anxiously bit her lower lip. “This is urgent. Very urgent.”

Victor was almost ready to brush them off, until a second look at the werewolf’s distraught face. His empathy kicked in. “What happened?” he asked, worried.

“It is about Choc,” the dryad explained, putting a hand on her female friend’s shoulder in support, “She learned something very important from her god during her morning prayers, and Cybele confirmed it to me. I believe that you should hear it as soon as possible.”

The werewolf didn’t look ready to say anything until Allison whispered encouragements in her ear. The Vizier braced himself for what he sensed would be more devastating news.

“Vic...” Chocolatine looked at him with terrified eyes. “Vic, you promise you won’t get mad?”

“Yes?” Victor tried to project a comforting smile, sensing a disaster coming. “No?”

“Vic, if you...” Chocolatine gulped. “If you... if we accidentally... if the protection ward didn’t work on me, and... you know...”

The Vizier kept smiling, even if he was screaming internally.

“Vic?” Allison asked him. “Vic, I think your face broke.”

Sitting on a chair inside a Nethermart lawyer’s office, Victor’s mind blanked out. The light from outside the window burned on his white, sweating skin.

“Sir?” one of his lawyers asked him, a pile of files on their mahogany desk.

“Can you...” the Vizier struggled to find his words. “Can you repeat?”

“You are sued with a class-action lawsuit by the *Happyland Battle Harem*, for ‘unlawful impregnation of horizontal angels during work,’” the lawyer said. “You risk eight child support condemnations, as per the ‘Sugar Daddy’ jurisprudence.”

“Since you are the hero of Happyland, and the judge is my cousin, we are confident that we can handle the matter quietly,” the other lawyer added, before browsing through files. “However, we anticipate new cases in the

near future. There is the matter of Miss Chocolatine, a paternity test demand from a certain Lynette from Haudemer, that Scholomance intern...”

“Thankfully, we have covered up Head of State/intern affairs since the dawn of democracy. We call this an ‘oval office cleanup.’”

“How did this happen?” the Vizier asked while tightening his fists.

“Well, sir, with all due respect, you are a whore.”

“I always use protections, including magical wards, and I shouldn’t even be able to breed with half of them!” Victor argued angrily. “What, next you will say that Charlene is on the list? That an undead vampire and a half-dragon can procreate?!”

“Well, while Miss Ennuie is not among your confirmed cases, according to modern vampire literature—”

“That’s not how DNA works!” Victor protested.

“It appears His Majesty’s new Perk allows for minion interbreeding according to our research, no matter how unlikely anatomically,” the lawyer replied. “Which would explain all the post-Perk interactions like Miss Chocolatine. As for the protections falling, both magical and otherwise, we have no clue. It is as if you ignored them entirely.”

Intelligence check successful.

“[Skeleton Key],” Victor realized, his eyes widening in realization.

“Excuse us, sir?”

“One of my [Reaper] Perks causes me to count as ‘invited’ in any location magically protected and unlocks any lock on a successful [Skill] check,” Victor said. “If it applies to *any* part of me, and has a broad understanding of *locks*...”

That was why the Perk had activated at the inn last time! He hadn’t considered the implications, but now he could only curse his naivete!

“Oh gods, this is really happening,” the [Reaper] panicked. “I’m going to have kids.”

“Babies?” Victor almost jumped out of his chair, as he heard Vainqueur Junior scratching at the office’s door. “Babies?!”

How did it even get there? “Not yours,” the Vizier replied with a haunted voice. “*Mine.*”

“Babies, Vic?” he heard Buzz Jelly ask from behind the door.

“Babies?!” Vainqueur Junior responded, clearly more happy for his master than Victor himself. “Babies!”

“Don’t worry, sir,” the lawyers tried to reassure their client, in a way only fiends could. “We will make sure you get away with everything and do not pay a cent to your, sorry for the politically incorrect term, many bastards.”

“Wait, how many?” Victor asked the lawyers, his gaze empty. “How many?”

The fiends exchanged glances in awkward silence. “Well, if we believe our projections, the confirmed cases, and the propensity of werewolves to have litters between four and six, a conservative estimate might indicate-”

“How many?!” Victor snapped impatiently.

“Sixteen.”

Vitality and Charisma checks successful! [**Paralysis**] and [**Terror**] negated!

“*SIXTEEN?!* ” Victor choked.

“Maybe only fifteen, Sir!”

He wasn’t ready to have one, let alone *SIXTEEN*! How was that even possible?!

Intelligence check successful!

“Congratulations for your thirty-two new eyes,” Victor muttered, remembering the Moon Man’s words during his bad trip. He glanced through the window, at the moon half-hidden by clouds in the skies. “That godly bastard!”

“Sir?”

“He knew! That squid knew and foreshadowed it!”

The fiends looked at him as if he had gone mad, before awkwardly straightening their ties.

“This is karma, isn’t it?” Victor asked. “This is karma punishing me for my lustful lifestyle.”

“Sir, I understand that the situation may feel hopeless, but we are your lawyers. You pay us to protect you *from* karma, and this is nothing we haven’t faced before. We have solutions.”

“Like what?” Victor almost begged for an easy escape.

“We can make the problems go away, *away*.” One of the two demons mimicked a beheading with his hand. “Or we falsify all the paternity tests. Maybe even threaten the offenders with lawsuits, if you prefer a non-violent solution?”

“Threaten is a strong word,” his colleague replied. “I suggest a slander campaign, followed by an insulting settlement offer.”

“Yes, that is more civilized. Good call.”

The Vizier ignored them debating amoral solutions, from putting the children in a rocket for the moon, to faking *his* death so he could legally avoid paying child support. For Victor, who had done everything to avoid any kind of serious romantic entanglement, this was a nightmare made real.

He turned to the window and looked at the sun. That bright, brilliant guiding star that Mithras had claimed as his own. He remembered Ludvic’s

word and realized that events had probably played out the same for his mentor.

If he followed his example, opened the windows, and ran, he could escape. Even with Vainqueur, he had grown powerful enough that he could easily vanish after dealing with the fomors. It would be cowardly and irresponsible, but he would remain without responsibilities. He could become a free spirit like Ludvic, roaming the world as he wished. He could even skip Outremonde outright and move to the other planes.

But that meant abandoning Vainqueur, his people, his children, and all the people who had grown to depend on him. That would probably be the most selfish thing Victor could ever do.

He immediately decided against it.

No running away. He had built a life there, and he couldn't throw it away.

What about the *other* solution? Isabelle would keep her daughter, he knew that for sure, and for the others... Chocolatine had said that she didn't want to settle down either, but she was just as confused as Victor himself right now. While the Vizier did have a say, he wasn't the only one making that decision.

He still had no idea what to do. What did he learn in Scholomance? What parental wisdom did he learn from Akhenapep?

Vizier Stratagem Eighteen: The law of no sons, because they are would-be usurpers and distractions.

Okay, what about daughters? *Vizier Stratagem Nineteen: The law of no daughters, because they are one check away from being turned around by a handsome [Paladin].*

Achieve immortality instead, because you are the only one right for the job.

... that didn't help! That didn't help at all!

College didn't prepare him for parenthood!

Should he ask the gods for guidance? He had been claimed by half the pantheon, *someone* should at least answer his prayers. Maybe Camilla?

“No.”

“Sir?”

“No, not them,” Victor replied, more to himself than to the lawyers.

“There’s only one friend that I need to consult.”

The person that knew him most.

Chapter 120: Season III Finale

Of course, the *one* time Victor came to Vainqueur for advice, the dragon was asleep on his hoard, belly exposed. “Your Majesty?” Victor asked, the dragon softly snoring like a cat. Vainqueur had remained like that for the past week, even as his Vizier prepared the country for war and Samhain. When would he wake up?

Wait, hadn’t the dragon’s last nap lasted fifty years?

...

“Your Majesty!” Victor panicked, shouting into the wyrm’s ear. “Your Majesty!”

“*What*, minion?” Vainqueur grumbled while waking up.

The Vizier breathed in relief. “Oh thank the gods, you weren’t going to sleep for decades!”

“I was taking a *power nap*,” Vainqueur replied, stretching his neck. “Also, do not thank your paltry gods. Thank me.”

“Thank Your Majesty for his kindness.” Victor meant for it to come across as sarcasm, but couldn’t help but crack a genuine smile. After so long putting up with Vainqueur’s insane ego, he had grown somewhat amused by it.

“Now, minion, why did you wake me up early? Are the fairies attacking? Have the dodos gone extinct again?”

“Not yet,” the Vizier replied, although he heard disturbing news about a high rate of ‘unexplained’ mutation in the Dodocare. Goblina had also

informed him of an abnormal rate of cancer in the Teikoku Empire after their last battle there. “I need to talk to Your Majesty. I need advice, and... well, you’re my friend and the one I trust the most.”

“Of course I am.” The wyrm observed him in silence for a moment, before making a decision. “We will go to the roof.”

“For privacy?”

“That, and to watch the fireworks in my honor.” The dragon marked a short pause. “Because there are fireworks in my honor, am I right?”

“Yes.”

Victor knew his dragon all too well.

This should be a joyous day. She had made the best sweets in the city and even brought her Red Riding Hood costume out of storage.

Yet Chocolatine de Gevaudan didn’t feel happy at all.

Everybody enjoyed themselves outside, knocking on doors asking for sweets; the werewolf had done the same in the previous Samhain, although there was much less diversity back then. But she wasn’t in the mood to participate.

“I’m sorry, Al,” Chocolatine said, stepping away from her home’s windows to sit around her dinner table, “I think I’m staying home tonight.”

“It’s fine.” Her friend, who wore a black cloak and fake vampire fangs, tried to comfort her. The dryad had planned to disguise herself as a mummy, but dropped it after it reminded her of the fiasco with that nasty Akhenapep. “I will stay with you. We can even play the new *Boards & Conquests* game I bought.”

“The one with the trolls and werebeasts nations?”

“That one.”

“Thanks,” Chocolatine replied, reviewing the pie and sweets that she had cooked for tonight. She had prepared a few for her brother and Savoureuse, intending to visit them tomorrow on the Mooooooon.

“We can use a spell if you do not want *them*,” Allison said suddenly.
“Personally, if I were in your situation, I would cast it.”

“I don’t know, Al,” Chocolatine replied. She did intend to have children one day, and had even fantasized about Vic impregnating her. But not now, not even in years.

Chocolatine knew a few people thought her crazy for her eccentricities. But she knew she would be a good mom if she wanted to! She would show her kids how to hunt demons for sustenance, and all the skills needed to survive in the wild! Vic wouldn’t bail out on her, so she could raise them with him too!

But Chocolatine was still young and cute. She could do without the eight months and all the hassle that would follow afterward.

She simply couldn’t make a decision yet.

Someone knocked on the door, probably her first visitor. “Coming!”
Chocolatine welcomed the distraction, moving to open the door.

The creature at the threshold was a tall, willowy humanoid as thin as a noodle. His body was that of a wooden scarecrow, except for a pumpkin head lit by unnatural flames. The figure wore a cloak on his back, a peasant hat on his head, and a blue lantern around his belt. He smelled of forests, ashes, and sweets.

“Trick,” the monster extended a hissing bag full of screaming faces, “or treat?”

“Sure, I have cake!” Chocolatine smiled, giving a slice of pie to the visitor.
“Here, I hope you like it.”

The strange creature looked at the piece, took it in one hand, and tasted a bite. “So sweet,” he said before swallowing the slice whole. “Jack O’Lantern thanks you.”

“Are you new?” Chocolatine asked with a smile. “I don’t think we’ve met!”

“Jack only goes out once a year on Samhain. Jack doesn’t like mortals, but he loves the taste of their sweets. Jack will return next year for a full cake.”

“You can eat it with us now,” Chocolatine replied kindly. “I love having new friends for dinner, and the cat is still in the oven.”

“Jack allowed in?” the creature sounded surprised as if it was the first time someone ever invited him for dinner.

“Sure. You don’t mind ghouls and vampires? My friends, Jules and Charlene will be joining us, but they’re very nice.” Rolo had declined, still too busy with farming.

“It is fine. Jack loves the taste of manlings too.”

“Then you will get along perfectly! Just don’t ask Charlene about book recommendations.”

Kia looked at the moon rocket with great satisfaction.

More specifically, at Orknoob being forced to board it at crossbow point by Kobolds. Buzz Jelly followed them, looking at the rocket with a mix of awe and nostalgia.

“Today,” she began addressing a crowd of monsters and Isekai followers that came to witness the launch, “we are gathered to celebrate the departure of Orknoob, Founder of the Esoteric Order of the Isekai, as he was 'persuaded' to leave the planet forever.”

“Yeah!” one of the Isekai worshipers acclaimed. “Time to bring the word of Japan to the stars!”

“Go get the green-skinned waifus!”

Executing him might have made him a martyr, and no attempt to expose his shady ways had worked. It was strange; the more proof they gave that Orknoob was a scam, the more his followers believed in him.

So instead, they would make this pest go away.

“Just so we can confirm,” Kia asked the dwarf engineer overseeing the launch, having insisted on giving the order herself. “You will send him to a planet at the frontier of our solar system?”

“Yes, as far as the rocket can carry him. Which is the safest, most tested rocket we have ever designed.”

“And he has *no* way of coming back?”

“No.”

“I will return!” Orknoob shouted in response. “I will gather a harem of alien waifus, and then build an army—”

Buzz Jelly leaped forward and hit the orc in the face. “Board!” it ordered while bouncing back. “Get sword rocket!”

“But—”

“Get sword! For *country*!”

The wounded scammer looked ready to argue, but the tiny slime intimidated him into silence. Orknoob climbed into the rocket, the metal door closing behind him.

“I love how even our prophet needs coaching sometimes,” an orc said. “This reminds me of the time Oji had doubts about letting the carriage run him over.”

“Yeah, everyone has doubts about going to Japan. He’s showing us that it’s okay.”

Kia kept her mouth shut, rejoicing at finally being rid of this idiocy. These cultists had harassed her about her 'Isekai levels' since she had first arrived in Outremonde; with Orknoob off the planet, she hoped that this scam religion would die out in a few generations.

Or maybe that was wishful thinking, but hope kept her alive. Even her patron Mithras hadn't managed to lift her curse yet, and she needed whatever pleasure she could find.

"Three..." Kia counted down, with a happy smile. "Two, one... ZERO!"

With a catastrophic sound, the rocket flew upward, blowing dust everywhere. Kia put a hand on her visage to protect herself from the smoke, everyone watching the carrier go up and up. Buzz Jelly, in particular, looked mesmerized by the spectacle.

The rocket reached the clouds, ready to pierce them and continue its path beyond the atmosphere. Kia breathed in relief, finally freed from that odious annoy—

BOOM!

The rocket exploded into a thousand pieces in the middle of the ascent.

The [Paladin] froze in shocked silence, as she watched the debris go down in flames around the launch site. "Sabotage!" Buzz Jelly shouted. "Sword broken!"

"Invisible fairy bourgeois sabotaged the rocket!" shouted the dwarf engineer, but the crowd wasn't panicking nor rioting.

In fact, Murmurin's citizens looked more curious than anything. "Do you think we can go to Japan by getting blown up by rockets?" one orc asked another.

"I'm not sure... we should try and check."

Kia looked at the smoke above her, and while she knew she should have felt somewhat regretful, Orknoob's sudden death made her happier. It wasn't

very [Paladin], but after being forced to drink saltwater for the rest of her life and agreeing to fight a new Century War, she deserved it.

...

"I need a hobby," she told herself, once the dopamine wore off.

Maybe she should try Monster Poker?

While sitting atop his castle's highest tower, his minion resting on his back next to him, Vainqueur observed his city at night. As usual, at this time of the year, Samhain had caused spirits to act up; ghosts swirled in the skies; flocks of bats gathered around buildings; werewolves, vampires, and other creatures paraded in the streets.

It felt like a lifetime ago when this place was nothing but a dirty farm.

"We are late!" Vainqueur complained as they watched a rocket explode above the ground.

"No, that's just a test run," Manling Victor said, although he sounded unbelievably pleased with himself. "Very nice view though."

"It did not spray the sky with colors," Vainqueur pointed out. "I want to turn all this black into gold and red."

"Just five more minutes, Your Majesty."

Vainqueur grumbled impatiently, as he realized that he could have napped longer. "What did you want to tell me, Manling Victor?"

"That I am going to have kids."

The dragon instantly turned his head away from the rocket and towards his chief of staff. "About time!" Vainqueur rejoiced. "Minion, at this rate, I thought I would have to breed you myself at breathpoint!"

"I am thankful that Your Majesty trusted me to do it on my own."

“How many?” the dragon asked for more details. “You did not breed with Knight Kia, I hope? You are too good for her.”

“No, I didn’t breed with her,” Manling Victor replied, before adding with surprising concern. “But I apparently have at least sixteen babies coming.”

Sixteen? “That is all?”

His minion didn’t understand. “That is all?”

“You must make more,” Vainqueur ordered his prized lackey. “We are at war, minion. My army needs *at least* three hundred more quality minions. Get back to work.”

“Your Majesty, I...” his minion struggled to find his next words, “I’m not comfortable with these ones, let alone having more.”

“Why so?” Vainqueur asked, puzzled. Was not breeding his second reason for existing, after being the dragon’s chief of staff? Then why did he sound so... vulnerable?

“I don’t think I’m cut out to be a father,” Manling Victor explained.

“Minion, I somewhat understand that this may feel a daunting task considering your obligations to me. While many wealthy wyrms have tried to court me, I was never interested in having spawns myself. They are a bottomless money-sink. But you are my Grand Vizier, your brood will always be properly cared for.”

As in, they would always get food and a minion job.

“I’ve got assets, connections, and plenty of magic,” Manling Victor replied. “While Your Majesty only allows me to keep one one-tenth of what I earn, I know I can provide for them. But I don’t want to be just a breathing purse, yet...”

“Friend Victor,” Vainqueur interrupted him. “How do you *feel* about this?”

His Vizier remained silent, trying to figure himself out.

“I’m afraid,” Manling Victor admitted. “I’m afraid because I know myself. I’m no father of the year material. I am bi-neutral, always on the move, and completely unable to stay faithful to one woman. It’s like getting a job I know I’m unsuited for, but that I must do anyway! I’m afraid because I never planned for this, and it fell on my lap without warning!”

Vainqueur turned away from his friend and pointed at Murmurin. “Minion, look at this. Look at this place that we made.”

His minion did so, although his master’s point escaped him.

“Now, do you remember why I came here in the first place?” Vainqueur asked.

“Your Majesty wanted a bigger cave to stash his gold.”

“Exactly. I never planned to rule an empire on which the sun never sets, but here it is. None of this was intended, but I have grown to love ruling this beautiful minion utopia all the same.”

“Your Majesty implies that I will grow to love my children, even if I never planned to have them?”

“I do, minion,” Vainqueur nodded.

His manling didn’t seem convinced, so the dragon further elaborated.

“Minion, children are like the gems of your hoard. You may have started gathering a treasure for the love of gold, but you have a duty to care for and protect your personal wealth in all of its forms. Sometimes you will feel that a treasure that a suicidal manling delivered is not up to your standards, or you do not know how to clean that platinum statue, but you have to take care of them anyway.”

“Your Majesty lost me a bit with the analogy, but I think I understand the lesson,” Manling Victor replied. “I have a duty to take care of my kids, and that even if I may not be the father they need, I should at least try my best? And that I may grow to like it?”

Vainqueur nodded. “Take care of your hoard, all of it.”

Manling Victor’s sad face turned into a smile. “That is deep.”

“I know. I rarely share my dragon wisdom with you, because you are almost the perfect minion already.”

“And Your Majesty is the best friend a manling like me could ask for.”

“Who else?” Vainqueur asked rhetorically. “Now stop worrying about the future, and enjoy the moment.”

For his minions had finally decided to launch the fireworks. Both V&V members looked up at the skies, as exploding rockets sprayed the darkness with colorful smoke and lights. Vainqueur and Victor spent the evening watching the celebration in a happy kind of silence, until the dragon broke it.

“Not even the fairies will take this place from me, Friend Victor.”

“About that, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor trailed sorrowfully. “Do we really have to kill them all?”

“What do you mean, minion?”

“If they have souls and feelings now... is endless war the only way anymore?”

On a distant island, near the New World’s coasts, a group of winged women labored on an ash-filled ground.

They had worked for weeks, months, to dig out their buried master. Never once did they waver in their determination, especially after recovering their missing member. A woman named Sigrun gave orders, as they hit the volcanic stone with their spears and commanded ghosts to remove debris.

Finally, the earth trembled, and they formed a circle.

A mighty hand emerged in their midst, wielding a lightning spear.

And thunder echoed across the sea.

- *Earth, Baltic Sea.*

There was blood in the water tonight, and it brought a smile to his face.

The world of men was such a dreadful place for a fomor like Mell Lin. He could feel the magic that fueled him slip away, and even the System didn't work on this side. The Pied Piper remained strong, but some of his Perks refused to activate. How odd.

It doesn't matter, he thought, as he glanced at the human corpses carried by the waves. The golems that had carried out the massacre stood over the bridge of a metal vehicle, floating on the water; a great whale of steel, used by the apes to spy and exterminate one another.

The rift in space that they had used to cross the border between worlds remained wide open, large enough to make an army pass through. His sister Odieuse awaited on the other side, using ancient fairy magic to keep it open for the next hours. Long enough to move this whale to Outremonde.

What did the monkeys call it again?

A Typhoon-class nuclear submarine.

"Fascinating." The mummy Akhenapep, Sablar's envoy to his fomor 'allies,' examined holes in the metal whale's hide. "Beautiful."

"Indeed," Mell Lin said, peeking inside the holes to look at the giant arrows kept within. "To think that they keep them in storage to gather dust."

Well, if the apes didn't want to use their own weapons, the fomors would gladly requisition them. With the Apple of Knowledge to understand how to operate these arrows, they could equip his sister's *Crom Cruach* and burn all their enemies away.

With the dragon's farm first in line.

“Lord Sablar demands retribution,” Akhenapep said. “But this is the moment I have been waiting for.”

“Mmm?” Lin asked, somewhat curious.

“I said I wouldn’t wake up until Doomsday O’Clock... but I like to be early.”

End of Volume III.

Spoiler: V&V stats

Vainqueur "Best Dragon" Knightsbane

Level: 75 (Augustus 30/Witchfinder General 14/Kaiser 17/Dungeon Breeder 10/Geomancer 4)

Type: Dragon.

Party: V&V.

Health Points

6,965

Special Points

1810

Strength

162

Vitality

121

Skill

66 (+6)

Agility

89

Intelligence

53 (+2)

Charisma

138 (+6)

Luck

85 (+18)

Personal Perks

Class Perks

Atomic Dragonfire Breath

Born in the Purple

Fire Immunity

For the Emperor

Red Dragon Lifeforce

King of Games

Dragon Arrogance

Dynasty

Dragonscale

Crowd Favorite

Super Senses

Supercrit

Virgin Princess Radar

Spell Purge

Lesser Poison Resistance

Witch Burning

Deadfriend

Lesser Magic Resistance

Taunt

Exorcism I

Epic

Hunter's Resolve

El Presidente

Stipend

Magellan

Dungeon Owner (Castle of Murmurin)

Victory Fist

Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)

Imperial Authority

Malefic Secrecy

Monster Empathy

Charged Attack (Dragon Breath)

Victory Roar

Mirror Scale

Fire Crown

Immovable

Show-off

Gold Shower

Shining Majesty

Golden Road

Geomancy

Monster Husbandry

Terraform: Landmass

Pontifex Maximus

Malleus Maleficarum

Incinerator

Master of Silence

Glitzy Theater

Improved Hybridization

Rabbit Plague

Alpha Magnetism (Scales)

Inventory:

- **[Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh]**: minor artifact. +10 to Luck; immunity to hostile [Earth] effects; reflexively cast [Hasten], [Protection from Elements], [Greater Dispel Magic], or [Cure Any Ailment] on the wearer once per day, depending on the situation. Cannot be worn by non-[Dragon] types.
- **[Crown of the Conqueror]**: +6 to Charisma, Luck, and Skill; immunity to [Terror].
- **[Psi-Stone of Mind-Shielding]**: Immunity to Mind-Affecting Effects.
- **[Psi-Stone of Positive Energy]**: Resistance to [Necromancy] effects: regain twice as much HP from healing magic; +2 to INT and +2 to LCK if worn with another Psi-Stone!

Victor "Slimy One" Dalton

Level: 73 (Monster Knight: Red Dragon 20/Reaper 30/Moriarty 11/Chaos Rider 4/Weathermaker 7/Fiendish Rake 1)

Type: Slime/Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points

1605

Special Points

510

Strength

45 (+6)

Vitality

53 (+6)

Skill

76 (+8)

Agility

61

Intelligence

82

Charisma

79 (+36; +6 when lying)

Luck

71

Personal Perks

Class Perks

Claimed by Dice

Skeleton Key

Observer

Eye for Treasure

Deadfriend

Scythe Lord

Seducer

Monster Kin

Claimed by the Moon Man

Minion Trainer

Black Curse

Monster Student

Noxious Fire

Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)

Claimed by Shesha

Monster Rider

Epic

Monster Insight

Vizier Education

Reanimator

Troll Regeneration

Soulmaster VI

Perk Forge

Helheim

Darwinist

Steal Life

Blood Pulse

Mook Promotion

Claimed by Deathjester

Slayer of Men

Claimed by Camilla

Scarlet Study

Exhibitionist

Master's Shield

Slime Totem

Fright Knight

Bloodborn

Lethal

Claimed by Cybele

Hades Blast

Magellan

Final Problem

Black Horseman

Diabolical Mastermind

Envious

Nightmare Lord

Vicious Ankou

Devil Archmage II

Charon's Grim Harvest

Asteroid Dynamics

Zmey Rider

White Rider

Apocalypse Storm

Planeloved

Rally Minion

Inventory:

- [**Moloch's Hide**]: (Minor Artifact)
- [**Harvest**] (Minor artifact)
- [**Brooch of Free Movement**]: wearer can move normally no matter the terrain.
- [**Ring of Emergency Teleport**]: 20 charges. Allow the caster to use [Emergency Teleport] to quickly teleport within a five kilometers area.
- [**Rings of Skill Boosting**] x 2: +4 SKI (total +8)
- [**Belt of Perfect Disguise**]: can magically polymorph into a humanoid of the same size.
- [**Bracers of Improved Bluff**]: +6 on Charisma when lying.
- [**Mini-Circlet against Greater Divinations**]: immune to scrying/magical location effect.

Chapter 121: Breeding for War

Vainqueur, best dragon of all, looked at the map from atop his hoard with skepticism. “Why manlings?”

His minion advisors, gathered around the war board, exchanged glances. “Excuse us, Your Majesty?” Marbré asked.

“Why are we using manling figurines to represent my kobold minions?” Vainqueur repeated. His minions had created a map of the western part of the Mistral continent, showing Prydain, Gardemagne, and his own empire. Hundreds of tiny figurines represented the armies on all sides of the conflict.

But most of Vainqueur’s own soldiers were manlings miniatures!

“We are using *Boards & Conquest* miniatures,” Allison explained with a frown. “My miniatures I should add. Kobolds, goblins, orcs, mimics, and other monsters don’t have representative armies in B&Q.”

“Neither do ghouls, even though vampires of the Nightlands have their own miniatures,” Corpseling Jules said. “Which I find racist.”

“This lack of Averagism thinking is exactly why a consumption-based model is doomed to fail,” Marbré nodded.

At least they had a tiny dragon to represent Vainqueur himself, but it infuriated him that the fairies and their monsters had their own miniatures. “You will order Troll Barnabas to craft new figurines for each of my minions, after he is done forging my new War of the Hoard veteran medals,” the dragon ordered, “because this is very confusing.”

“What is confusing is Victor’s absence at this gathering,” Knight Kia said, looking at a missing seat. “Alongside Maure's.”

“My minion is working on a great magical project that will give us the edge in the conquest of Prydain,” Vainqueur recounted his minion’s own words. “And hopefully, breeding our reserve force.”

“I still can’t believe he found the time to have sixteen kids,” Knight Kia said. “At least whores get *paid* for their service.”

“Maybe he should,” Batling Charlene said with a knowing smile. “But back to the matter at hand. Taking into account our colonies and the fact that every single one of our citizens can fight, we may field around seventy-thousand soldiers. However, even with access to the Nightblades’ black market and stolen reserve of Crests, only a tiny fraction of them are [Crested].”

“Five hundred and fifty-five, without including Your Majesty, Victor, or myself,” Knight Kia explained. “Obviously, we are also the only people above level 60 in the entire peninsula.”

"And Rolo," Untasty Allison pointed out.

"And Rolo," Knight Kia admitted, eager to swipe her shameful showing against the golem under the rug.

“The good news is, we can raise three-quarters of our fallen as undead if they die,” Corpseling Jules pointed out.

“We can also raise an additional fifty-thousand from our allies in Happyland, Agarth, the Teikoku, the Mooon, and the Thaoten Empire,” Charlene said. “Bringing the total to one hundred twenty thousand troops.”

“That gives us a credible chance to attack Prydain, but they possess powerful magic, Fomors with class levels, and warbeasts,” Knight Kia said. “Not to mention Odieuse herself. A monster that powerful is an army in itself.”

“This sounds straightforward to me,” Vainqueur replied, annoyed by the ambient pessimism. “I am a dragon, you are minions. I burn a path forward, you clean up afterward. I will even empower you with my army-friendly Perks!”

“That approach may have worked in the Teikoku, but you had the backing of a goblin army then,” Knight Kia pointed out with a distasteful face. “I say you send emissaries to Gardemagne to gain their support. They are the nation with the strongest military, a bone to pick with the fomors, and I know their leadership personally.”

“More bodies to throw at the enemies are important, but we need something else more,” Corpseling Jules said. “Namely, [Crests].”

“I agree, Buzz Jelly has been thirty since forever, and have you *seen* his stats?” Untasty Allison pointed out.

“On Mr. Victor’s orders, I have used my contacts to gather Crests and stat boosters,” Tasty Malfy explained. “While we got our hands on boosters, in spite of the heavy expenses, Crests remain difficult to obtain.”

“Why?” Vainqueur asked, confused. “Do they not drop out of the skies after you win a difficult battle? Should they not fall into my minions’ hands as we attack Prydain?”

“Not necessarily,” Corpseling Jules replied. “No one can predict when Crests will appear. It would be better to locate existing ones than hope for new items to drop.”

“Nations hoard Crests to empower their own elite,” Knight Kia said. “And to prevent the proliferation of dangerous, [Crested] criminals.”

“My Nightblades gathered all of those available on the black market,” Batling Charlene complained. “We will have to go to foreign authorities for more, or invade dungeons ourselves.”

“That could open our soldiers to another venue of gaining more power,” Corpseling Jules said. “Namely, [Mook Promotions].”

“Now, you are speaking my language minions,” Vainqueur decided since the discussion had started boring him. “Is there not a dungeon competition waiting for us to win it?”

“Yes, but only small teams can participate,” Knight Kia said. “And they’re fishy as He—”

“Happyland,” Tasty Malfy cut her off.

“There are a few dungeons in the empire that remain unexplored,” Marbré said. “And in the underground tunnels of Agarthia.”

“Then send experienced minion legions there, so they grow stronger and gather Crests,” Vainqueur ordered.

“Your Majesty, this is a good idea,” Knight Kia began.

“I know, it is mine.”

“—but I would like your authorization to return home to Gardemagne and lobby King Roland for Crests. I know I can convince him to send us a few more. Most importantly, my old party lives there, and most of them are either level 60 or above. They would be tremendous boons to our war effort.”

“Why would they help and empower a nation of monsters right next to their border?” Charlene asked.

“Because Gardemagne and the V&V Empire signed an alliance pact when His Majesty overthrew Brandon Maure,” Kia pointed out. “While Odieuse threatens us all.”

“Certainly, go home minion,” Vainqueur said, more than happy to get the [Paladin] away from his capital. With Manling Victor on a breeding frenzy, the dragon couldn’t let her tempt his chief of staff with her knightly wiles.

“I believe a thousand Crested would give us the advantage,” Corpseling Jules said, shifting the miniatures. “If we move an army on the west coast,

another on the eastern, we can form a pincer attack and take over the southern part of Prydain.”

“Minions, I notice a startling lack of dragon figurines,” Vainqueur said suddenly, noticing the flaw in his lackeys' strategy.

A heavy silence followed until Untasty Allison coughed. “Your Majesty, about that...”

“How are we supposed to welcome thousands of dragons when two hundred almost bled us dry?” Batling Charlene said.

“A Tarasque feast,” Vainqueur pointed out the obvious.

“What about the water, the space, the—”

“Nonsense,” Vainqueur cut her off in annoyance. “My chief of staff said that he would do the thing, and he will succeed.”

“If Murmurin even survives this Conclave, how are we supposed to feed a dragon army for more than a day?” Batling Charlene kept arguing, while the other minions made strange hand signs at her.

“Easy, the battle shall not last more than a day,” Vainqueur replied, proud of his species. “Do not mistake the situation, minions. This is not a war. This is an execution by dragonfire. Your role is to sort out the ashes.”

“Dragon air support will be decisive,” Knight Kia said. “But the fomors have been preparing for such an attack for years. We need more advanced tactics—”

An imp messenger popped up in the middle of the meeting. “Your Majesty, emergency! Emergency!”

“This is a war meeting,” Malfy said. “Can’t this wait?”

“It’s Daltonia!” the imp hissed. “Daltonia... dodo hybrids have escaped Daltonia’s pens! The Tarasque has gone out of control!”

What?

“I will deal with this myself!” Vainqueur declared, roused to action. “None shall spoil my feast!”

When Vainqueur crossed the portal to Daltonia with Knight Kia in tow, they found themselves in front of a monster feasting on a demon’s entrails.

The creature had the head of a *dodo* and the body of a *bear*.

“A [Dodobear]!” Vainqueur exclaimed in happiness. The experiment had been a rousing success!

“You named it?”

“I bred it!” Vainqueur boasted, Knight Kia taking a step back upon seeing the giddy joy in the dragon’s eyes. “I bred a dodo and a slime, then a bear and a slime... and then I bred the results! To create a [Dodobear]!”

“Why would Your Majesty do that?” the [Paladin] asked, unable to grasp her master’s grand vision.

“Because we are at war!” Vainqueur shouted, the knight taking another step backward until she hit a tree. “We are at war with *nature*! Two species, driven almost extinct by accident! Should I accept it? No! So I bred a new species, taking the best of both! Dodos that can thrive everywhere! What will you manlings say when they see these mighty creatures put their eggs into bears, only to have dodo-headed children coming out?”

Charisma check successful! You terrified Kia Bekele!

“Yes, minion! They will say that I, Vainqueur, bred a [Dodobear]! If there is a god of breeding, it is me!”

Vainqueur gathered his breath, while Knight Kia remained eerily silent. In the meantime, the [Dodobear] had finished eating, letting out a mix of a bear roar and a bird's screech.

The dragon looked around, realizing that the breeding program had gone out of control. The animals had escaped their pens, massacring the staff, and rampaged through the dodocare. Only the Victor-faced statues on the beach remained unscathed, dodos gathering around them to honor their maker and savior. A group of birds had sacrificed a fiend before Manling Victor's 'Rolling of the Dice' statue, feeding on its entrails.

"Your Majesty!" A lone, winged bone demon had managed to escape the slaughter, flying to avoid the claws of two ferocious dodobears. "Your Majesty has come to save us!"

"What happened here?" Vainqueur asked, grabbing the two dodobears with his hands as if they were tiny horses. The creatures went limp in his hands.

"We did as your Majesty asked, creating the ultimate monsters!" the demon said. "Half exp bag, half superboss! But the first clutch started mutating due to radiation, and we couldn't control them!"

"H-how?" Knight Kia asked, astonished. "How?"

"We cast a [Giant Size] spell on a fertile dodo broodmother, fed gallons of aphrodisiac to the [Tarasque Emperor], and—"

Fearsome roars echoed through the island, as its forest's trees trembled. Vainqueur smelled the Tarasque and its progeny approach in great numbers. "Here they come!" the demon hissed, hiding behind a disturbed Knight Kia while she drew her sword.

Then they poured out of the woods, as beautiful as they were terrifying.

"Beware... the [**Taradodos**]!"

Dozens of dodo-headed, bipedal lizards the size of elephants trampled the trees. Their crimson scales were covered with fresh blood, while their eyes radiated with fury and hunger. A spiked carapace protected their back, while their sharp claws and iron beak could tear through flesh and metal both. Their radioactive, greenish father followed, a tiny, normal dodo nesting on its head.

“WEEEAHA!”

The Tarasque let out a roar, his brood screeching in response like an army from the depths of Happyland itself.

“Minions!” Vainqueur snarled in response. “MINIONS!”

[**Alpha Magnetism (Scales)**] activated! Charisma check successful!

The taradodos and their mighty father immediately submitted to Vainqueur, belly against the ground.

“Return to your pens,” the dragon ordered, the creatures immediately protesting with screeches. “No *weeaaing* with me, minions. Return to your pens!”

The creatures dispersed, the Tarasque leading them back into the ruins of the dodocare.

“See, minions?” Vainqueur told his lackeys, releasing the [Dodobears] in his hands; the beasts wisely fled. “They only need a firm, strong dragon master to teach them the minion way of life.”

“You bred a Tarasque,” Knight Kia muttered to herself. “Your Majesty bred a Tarasque.”

“I did!” Vainqueur boasted, proud of saving so many species from extinction. He should receive an award for it.

The dragon-made System apparently agreed.

Congratulations! For creating a new, horribly dangerous monster that will become the bane of adventurers long after you are gone, you earned a level in [**Dungeon Breeder**]! You earned the [**Miniboss Breeder**] Class perk.

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Miniboss Breeder**]: All your monster minions permanently gain the [**Miniboss**] Personal Perk (+120 HP, +40 SP, +4 to all other stats, and +10

to damage with their personal Perks). They will keep the benefit of the Perk even if they return to the wild.

“Now, gather all my dodos and rebuild the dodocare,” Vainqueur ordered his fiendish lackey.

“The [Taradodos] regenerate faster than we can harm them, Your Majesty,” the demon said. “And their claws bypass all physical and magical protections. We need better guards.”

“I am half-horrified, half-amazed,” the [Paladin] admitted. “On one hand, these things can make for amazing shock troops, but on the other hand, I dread how many levels a fomor can gain from killing one.”

“Then we shall keep them to ourselves,” Vainqueur decided, amazed by his own brilliance.

And then they would raise them as undead, for double the exp.

Chapter 122: Slimonies

This was probably the most awkward breakfast in Victor's life.

He and Chocolatine stood at each end of her kitchen table in embarrassed silence, neither of them willing to address the elephant in the room.

"So... did you enjoy Samhain?" the werewolf tried to make conversation, but only made both of them cringe.

"Sort of," he replied, shifting uncomfortably on his chair. "It was enlightening."

"Oh."

You have taken weak [**Psychic**] damage from the awkwardness.

Yeah, at least the last rendezvous had been refreshingly direct.

He had just left a meeting with Isabelle, his demonic mistresses, and all of their assorted lawyers. The exhausting session had ended with a settlement, although one that left the Vizier less than pleased.

"That's an agreement I signed for most of my progeny." Victor finally mustered his courage, showing Chocolatine a document. "To make it short, I recognize all of my children as trueborn, although my daughter with Isabelle Maure goes first in the inheritance order. Isa signed a separate agreement with the other fiends, with all their children being guaranteed a place among Braniña's corporate board once she becomes a demon CEO in exchange for specific concessions. I agreed to pay alimonies, child support, and provide housing in my mansion."

“Alimonies?” Chocolatine said, refusing to look at the document. She had never cared about legal technicalities.

“Yeah,” Victor sighed. “There was a clause in the summoning contract saying that if I were to ever impregnate members of the Demonic Harem by accident, I become their *exclusive* employer. Which means that I must pay a ‘perpetual concubine retainer fee’ until I die for the fourth time.”

“This sounds like a nuptial agreement,” Chocolatine said, clearly frustrated with this.

“They didn’t use the term, but yeah.” The financial penalties were so high, that the lawyers had suggested suicide and revival as a cheap alternative. “They say it’s to guarantee that all new children will ‘belong to the hero of Happyland’, but truthfully, they’re just ripping me off.”

And his troubles weren’t done. He still had to visit Haudemer to do a paternity test there.

The werewolf seemed angry, but for what he expected. “I can’t believe you married demons first!”

“I thought you were okay with an open relationship?” Victor frowned.

“Yes, but...” She crossed her arms, embarrassed. “I would have loved a pretty fur dress.”

Victor sighed. “Choc, I am telling you this so you know where I stand about us.”

The werewolf remained awkwardly silent.

“If...” Damn, why was it so hard to speak about the subject?! “If you decide to keep them, I will legitimize our children and take responsibility.”

“If I decide?” Chocolatine cut him off, uncomfortable with this conversation. “Vic, don’t say that. The two of us have to decide.”

“I will be okay with either choice,” Victor replied. “If you decide to... you know, I will respect your decision, and nothing will change. I’m addicted to you, and if you will have me, I shall remain by your side. It will be like before.”

“You’re addicted to me?” Her face brightened.

“I am,” he said. “I can’t explain it logically. I’m not sure if this is love, but if all the girls I messed with had ghosted me, you would have been the one I would have fought tooth and nails to keep in my life.”

In spite of her eccentricities, in spite of her dangerous grip on sanity, she held a tighter grip on his heart than anyone else.

By now, the werewolf had turned red. Chocolatine was horribly cute that way. “Vic,” she spoke up. “I told you before that I had no intention to settle down.”

The Vizier nodded.

“But... I’m addicted to you too, and I think we have something special: two weredragons, and two wereslimes.”

Victor thought he had misheard. “Two *wereslimes*?”

“Oh yes! According to Isengrim, they’re like werewolves, but they become slimes during the full moon!”

Which god decided to make this *crap* a reality? “Choc, I must warn you. You know me, I don’t think I’m the best person to be a dad.”

“You will learn,” she replied warmly. “I will help.”

He rose from his chair, she did the same, and they hugged.

As he held her tight against his chest, Victor remembered the early days of their relationship; the fear he had felt, compared to the anxious warmth he experienced now. True, she was crazy, but also caring and loving.

At this moment, he wouldn't have traded her for anything.

A newcomer that the Vizier had never seen before suddenly entered the kitchen, shattering the tender moment. A creature looking like a scarecrow with a pumpkin for a head, and clearly in need of a fix. "Jack is hungry!"

"Choc, who is this?" Victor asked, still keeping the werewolf in his arms.

"Jack, my new tenant!" Chocolatine said. "I'm renting him Croissant's old room since Samhain. Jack, this is my boyfriend Vic!"

"Jack says hello," the creature said before immediately focusing on the important matter. "Jack asking where are the Garfield cookies?"

"In the freezing slime fridge!" the werewolf said. "But you will get fat if you keep eating my pastries! Allison said I put too many calories in them!"

"Jack never gets fatter," the monster replied while searching in the kitchen.

Victor raised an eyebrow, using [Monster Insight] to read the strange entity.

Jack O'Lantern

Soulcrested Fomor (Fairy/Undead).

Strong against: Fire, Necromancy, Plants, Unholy, Spirit, Fairy, Magic, Curses, all negative status ailments.

Weak to: Dragon, Deadslayer, Frost, Cold Iron, Starmetal, Candies.

The patron fairy of Halloween/Samhain, and the inspiration of the Jack O'Lantern myth on Earth. A maladjusted loner among his kind addicted to candies, Jack declined to join Odieuse's crusade, but stole one of her Soulcrests as a prank. Benign if bribed on Samhain, he is now confused by his newfound, perverse fascination with Chocolatine's food (and Murmurin in general).

The Vizier froze, ready to fire a deadly spell at the monster. "Choc, behind me."

“What?” his girlfriend replied, clueless.

“Do you know what he is?”

“A fomor.”

“A f—you *knew*?”

“Yeah, he told me,” the werewolf replied casually. “But Jack is very nice! He is helping us with farming since he doesn’t have any money.”

“Jack confused,” the fomor rasped. “First time Jack lives among mortals without a disguise.”

Victor blinked repeatedly, before whispering into his lover’s ear, “Choc, what are you thinking?”

“Vic, I helped build Murmurin so all monsters could live in peace and be good neighbors,” Chocolatine pointed out. “Even fairies. He’s behaving, and he isn’t even from Prydain, so what is the problem?”

“That he is living at *your* place,” Victor replied protectively.

The werewolf blushed, before kissing him on the cheek. “I’m fine, I swear! Besides, he will never harm a cook as good as me!”

“Jack has been treated,” the fomor said. “So Jack will play no trick.”

“See?”

The Vizier looked on as Jack knocked on the fridge with his finger, as if expecting someone to open from the other side.

Victor was torn. True, he had wondered if they could make peace with fomors in the first place if their souls allowed them to empathize with the ‘lesser races’ that they denigrated. But even if this one looked clueless, Jack remained a fomor; a creature about as dangerous as a dragon. To have one living in Murmurin, at his lover’s place to boot...

Still, Chocolatine had a certain talent for dealing with monsters, and his [Monster Insight] hadn't detected any ill-will from that pumpkin scarecrow. He was willing to take the risk; although he would have the fairy watched at all times.

Wait.

A Soulcrest? "Jack?"

"Yes, werewolf boyfriend?"

"Could you show me your Soulcrest?" the Vizier asked. "Just for a short while."

With his newfound Tier VIII spellcasting, Victor had funded the acquisition of magical scrolls to learn new spells; including the famed [Pocket Dimension].

A spell which he had, of course, promptly mastered.

His private sanctuary was relatively small as far as dimensions went, roughly six hundred meters square, divided into three 'floors.' The dimension took the form of a mansion floating in the middle of a dark, cold void between dimensions. How gravity still worked as normal escaped him, but who was he to contest such powerful magic?

As she had asked, Isabelle had decorated the place in the most expensive style, from marble pavement to fine wood doors. She had even found a way to include a planar-powered Jacuzzi in the bathroom, and a magical laboratory for Victor's own use.

It was there, on an operation table meant to create undead, that the Vizier examined a crest of bones and solid darkness.

Although Victor did have an assistant to help him with it. A double of himself, who had traded his heavy armor for a plague doctor's uniform.

His [Fetch].

A [Fetch] was a clone created by the tier VIII spell of the same name, a duplicate born equipment, and fueled by a piece of his soul. While it kept most of his Perks, the duplicate had only half his stats, lost HP and SP at a slow rate, and couldn't recover them. It couldn't gain exp, nor create a second clone of itself.

Thankfully though, the clone's memories returned to Victor once it exhausted its health points, so it halved paperwork and research time. The Vizier had all but delegated the task of gathering information from [Harvest] to his double.

Congratulations! As a powerful monster and Vainqueur's breeding policy officer, you earned the [**Miniboss**] personal perk!

[**Miniboss**]: you permanently gain +120 HP, +40 SP, +4 to all other stats, and your personal/monster perks will inflict +10 damage.

Uh?

It sounded a little insulting, but also welcome.

However, he noticed that the System now openly considered him a monster instead of a human. Was it because of his [Monster Knight: Red Dragon] class? Or because he had slowly drifted apart from his human roots?

"Or both?"

Victor looked up from the table, to see the goddess Camilla sitting at the edge.

"I see that you haven't waited for our lesson," his mentor said, examining the extraplanar laboratory. "You learned some of the best spells of that tier already."

"It's a shame the [Fetch] can't gain levels or exp," Victor said. Although he did discover that the clone could learn new spells and transfer that knowledge back to him afterward. "Because that would have made an excellent spell fantastic."

“I told you balance broke down around Tier VIII,” the deity replied, “Fighter-classes get better at killing people, while we spellcasters get better at killing the laws of physics.”

“I sense an undercurrent of *classicism* there.”

“I do not denigrate other classes. I wouldn’t have gone as far as I did without Jesty or Veran to cover my weaknesses, and vice-versa. However, I always thought that Spellcaster-classes offered more options for creative people.”

Probably. Victor freshly remembered his encounters with Furibon and Akhenapep. The former could stop time, the latter demolish an [Epic] level team single-handedly.

“Once you cap off [Weathermaker], you should be able to cast Tier IX spells, perhaps even Tier X with your other classes.” She smiled at Victor’s confusion. “[Moriarty] is a swiss-knife class with many powerful abilities, but nothing that can increase magic. [Fiendish Rake] however...”

Both Victor and his [Fetch] groaned at once.

“Did you know?” the original asked Camilla. “About [Skeleton Key]?”

“I admit I didn’t. Jesty was our only [Reaper], and whenever I tried to set him up with a cute dark elf, he abandoned the dates midway to build a Mithras-tailored deathtrap. In retrospect, that sounds a bit suspicious...”

“Any way to get around it?”

“Physical protection, but with your current Strength...” Camilla gave him a sympathetic look. “There is a more permanent solution, but I doubt it will take due to your high Vitality and regeneration. Between your Perks and stats, you have become too powerful for standard methods.”

The Vizier grumbled, much to his patron’s amusement. “Victor, you will get used to it. I maintain a harem, and I also had *accidents* at your age. You shouldn’t let that stop you.”

“You are starting to sound like Vainqueur,” Victor complained.

“Well, Jesty suggested we switch to a *Dynasty*-based game and—” The goddess caught herself. “You will soon face the fomors, and you need as many levels as possible. [Weathermaker] caps at ten, [Chaos Rider] too, and I believe [Moriarty] ends at twenty. You will need to fill the rest.”

“I’m sure there are other ways...”

“Victor,” she gave him a knowing gaze. “You know that there is only one way to level up [Fiendish Rake]. And at your level, it is nigh-impossible to level up in a new class.”

Victor gathered his breath. “BLEEP.”

“That was why you worked hard to get this class in the first place, no?”

Yes, but he didn’t understand the terrible consequences when he did!

The karmic irony wasn’t lost on him. The Vizier had chosen one of the most difficult and powerful classes to better get laid, but he couldn’t level up in it without risking getting more troubles eight months down the line.

“I will try to get a new class anyway,” Victor replied dryly. “I have made a vow of abstinence.”

He would rather have less children than more levels. His agonizing wallet would thank him.

“We will see how long that holds,” said an amused Camilla, before she glanced at the Soulcrest and changed the subject. “Is this what I think it is?”

“Do you know the worst part?” Victor asked. “That this thing could have been made without killing anybody. A tiny amount of blood and bones were enough to achieve the same result. Mag Mell simply went with the most violent solution available.”

“But without this device, the fomors’ power is crippled.”

“They have more than one,” Victor replied. “From what I gathered from [Harvest] and the tidbits Jack told me, I believe that they have at least five of them. Maybe more.”

Like it or not, as dragons before them, fomors with class levels would remain a fact of Outremonde.

Camilla remained silent for a while, as she pondered the implications. “You need to learn more spells,” she declared.

“Anything that could help me with animal growth?” Victor asked. “Because we are going to welcome a thousand dragons, and we don’t have enough cattle to feed them all.”

His current solution was to open portals to the elemental planes and lure food into Murmurin, like when the dragons ate their way through Happyland during Vainqueur’s Bragging Day.

“Clones,” Camilla replied with a smile. “Clones solve everything.”

“You are not feeding me to Vainqueur’s guests over and over again,” Victor’s [Fetch] warned.

“I wasn’t going to!” the original replied.

“We are the same person, I know how you think!”

“The lesson will wait,” Camilla interrupted. “I mostly returned because I made progress on your favor.”

Victor’s head perked up. “You can cure Kia’s curse?”

“While I would have preferred something more pleasurable than helping a [Paladin],” she said, sounding a bit bitter, “I have convinced Seng to grant you an audience. Although I did have to bribe her with a gallon of ghoulish vodka first...”

“Grant me? Not Kia?”

“No, she doesn’t want to see the *apostate*,” the goddess said, before adding with quiet sarcasm, “I wonder why.”

So Victor had a chance to argue with the goddess and convince her to overturn her decision. Time to put these new Charisma bonuses to the test. “So, where and when?”

“In her planar realm, and right now.”

“Can’t this wait?” Victor asked. “I know I’m asking for much, but we have a war—”

“That will not wait,” Camilla replied firmly. “She wanted to sink Bekele’s country last time we spoke, and one whiskey ocean is enough.”

Chapter 123: One for the Team

“[Terraform: Landmass, Plains]!”

As Vainqueur shouted these magical words in the middle of the desert, a screen appeared right before him.

How much SP will you use? 50 SP per fifty meters radius.

“All of them!”

1800 SP consumed.

In the blink of an eye, the dragon’s beautiful magic expanded all across the land, spreading across an area almost two kilometers-wide in radius.

Instantly, the dry, lifeless desert transformed into grasslands before Vainqueur and his trainers. Tasty Malfy, Corpseling Jules, Untasty Allison, and her tinfoil golem ally could only whistle as plants grew beneath their feet, the sand turning into flat dirt. The effect expanded under the sun until it reached its limit, turning the area into a green enclave amidst a barren landscape.

You have transformed the [**Desert**] field into a [**Plains**] field. [**Plant**], [**Wind**], and [**Earth**] attacks will be strengthened; grounded creatures will gain a bonus to Agility checks.

The sight had floored all minions present. Untasty Allison, in particular, loudly rejoiced, her portable bonsai at her feet. “Amazing!”

“Rolo very happy,” the golem agreed. “Rolo says we should need more marshes and forests west, more grass east...”

Murmurin's emperor listened to the praise, congratulating himself for his brilliant idea. Since they needed more arable land for the Conclave, and Vainqueur had to level up fast, the dragon had decided to use his [Geomancer] Perks to repair the entire desert.

He would eat two cows with one bite.

Unfortunately, while he could keep transforming the desert all day, his SP reserve was almost emptied after this show of force.

"I need meat juice!" the dragon ordered, so he could get back to work. Corpseling Jules presented a barrel for his master to consume, but Vainqueur couldn't recognize the substance. It smelled of mint, berries, and chemicals. "What is this, minion?"

"[SPeroids]," the ghoul replied. "Your Majesty asked us to help him with his leveling, and Malfy and I devised a training regiment."

"Indeed," Tasty Malfy said while pointing at one of a crate full of strange food and trinkets. Another right next to it contained unshiny powerstones. "These are stat boosters. Extremely rare and valuable items that can increase any stat, except HP or SP, with a +2 enhancement. They cost a fortune and come in very limited supply, but we have managed to gather quite a few."

"[Strength Spinach], [Skill Candies], [Agility Lettuce], [Vitality Milk], [Intelligence Powder], [Charisma Bars], [Luck Amulet]," Corpseling Jules added.

"They are also forbidden in official competitions," Untasty Allison said. "And Your Majesty can only gain a total bonus of +10 after consumption. Every stat booster consumed after this threshold is wasted."

"Which is still the equivalent of ten levels in pure stat growth," Rolo said.

Vainqueur immediately noticed something very, very wrong in that scenario.

“Minion,” he looked at Tasty Malfy with a judgmental glance. “If they are this expensive, how could you afford them for me?”

If he had dared skim money from Vainqueur’s nine-nine-tenth...

“Easy, through Your Majesty’s brilliant decision to pump the Whiskey Sea!” the fiend explained, sounding very happy with himself. “By selling it through the Nightblades, we cornered all illegal bootlegging activities!”

“And then making undead out of the enraged competition, before putting them to work in the gold mines,” Corpseling Jules said. “Murmurin is basically printing Vainqueur Dollars at this point, even after Your Majesty takes their share.”

Ah, yes! Vainqueur had almost forgotten that plan. “Has the rate of dwarf death by dragon fallen?”

“Uhm, I suppose, although I do not see how that tracks?” Tasty Malfy replied.

Vainqueur did and congratulated himself again. For his plan was proof that one could make money without exhausting the most important natural resources.

Minions.

“All of these stat boosters are for Manling Victor and me?” Vainqueur asked, greatly interested. While it wouldn’t increase his monthly stipend, more luck, in particular, meant more items from monsters.

“Well,” Untasty Allison scratched the back of her neck, “I suggested that we keep some [Intelligence Powder] for Gorynych though, due to his... handicap...”

“My idea is to combine a steady diet of stat boosters with [SPeroids] for Your Majesty,” Jules explained. “Since [SPeroids] temporarily boost SP recovery, Your Majesty should periodically consume them whenever you exhaust their points practicing your [Terraform] Perk.”

“Rolo and I will supervise the process so we can preserve an ecological balance long-term,” Untasty Allison said. “But I believe that for the first time since centuries, making Ishfania green again is within sight.”

“Which means more pasture for cattle.” Vainqueur nodded. “How many [SPeroids] do you have?”

“Enough for Your Majesty to geomance for four hours,” Corpseling Jules replied.

“That is not enough, minion. Gather everything.” Since his lackeys apparently failed to grasp his design, the dragon pumped his chest gloriously. “I shall not stop until I have reshaped this entire desert in my image.”

“Your Majesty wants to transform all of Ishfania in *one go*?” Untasty Allison asked.

“Unlike a manling, no dragon retreats in the face of adversity!” the emperor boasted. “You said that worm Sablar is responsible for the lack of greenery? Then I shall not rest until I have proven that *I alone* decide my empire’s fate!”

“This is...” The dryad struggled to find her words, before turning towards Corpseling Jules and Tasty Malfy. “Can it be done? Mathematically?”

“Are you doubting me, minion?” Vainqueur asked, finding her lack of faith in him disturbing.

“If we gather all SP potions available under short notice,” Corpseling Jules meditated. “We’ll need to order emergency production too, but in theory, we have enough.”

“Your Majesty, if you can do this, I...” Allison joined her tiny hands together. “I won’t be able to contain my joy. It will be a dream come true.”

“Do not ask if I can do it,” Vainqueur replied mercifully, “but when I do it.”

“Rolo will not rest until the vile Akhenapep’s work is undone,” the golem replied. “But Rolo will be greatly thankful. So will the goddess.”

“Happyland will also benefit from this.” Malfy nodded. “No longer will it be accused of greenwashing. Instead, we will help make the desert green again, and *then* exploit its newfound natural resources.”

“Enough talk,” Vainqueur declared. “Now, add the unshiny stones to the mix before I show nature who runs the place.”

His minions all frowned.

“The powerstones,” Vainqueur clarified. “I need to increase the power of my breath further.”

“Your Majesty, while I have reviewed your recent improvement of your breath attack,” Corpseling Jules coughed, “I am not certain consuming powerstones at all is a good idea. You could explode, die, or maybe—”

“I am a dragon,” Vainqueur reminded them of this timeless wisdom. “Add the glowing stones to my SP juice.”

Corpseling Jules wisely opened the second crate, revealing an assortment of powerstones. “Which element, Your Majesty?”

“Why not all of them?” Vainqueur asked, eager to add more elements to his breath.

“Your Majesty, allow to speak in place of Victor for a moment.” Untasty Allison made a strange face, which the dragon thought to be an excellent imitation of his Vizier's pessimism. “This is unbelievably dangerous! You can’t mix powerstones of opposed elements!”

After pondering it, Vainqueur admitted that she had a point. One should not mix gold and silver. “Add the golden ones,” the dragon ordered Corpseling Jules. “Those with the perfect color.”

“The [Light] ones, Your Majesty?”

[Light]? Argh, that was the element the cursed fairy had mastered! Of course she would corrupt everything golden in the world!

Vainqueur considered which element to add to his breath until one candidate came to mind. “No,” he changed his mind. “Add [Frost].”

“Excellent choice,” Corpseling Jules complimented. “It will cover your reliance on [Fire].”

And allow Vainqueur’s rival some measure of vengeance from beyond the grave.

At long last, Corpseling Jules added the stones to the mixture. The dragon grabbed the barrel and drank all its content, before the worried eyes of his minions.

Full of energy, the dragon glanced at the endless desert, pumped his chest, and showed his muscle. He could feel the stones and the drugs mix in his belly, refined by his stomach into the ultimate weapon of mass—

Vitality check...

Failed!

“What?!” Vainqueur snapped at the System for this obvious mistake.

You suffer from [**Unstable Magic**] for twenty-four hours! Your magic and breath will behave erratically!

Erratically?

That did not sound so unmanageable...

As Camilla teleported them in Seng’s abode, Victor could barely restrain himself from vomiting. This place stank of both alcohol and saltwater!

The reason being, that he was floating in both.

As befitting of her portfolio, Seng's realm was an underwater bar beneath the waves. The decorations reminded Victor of a sunken ship, with fishes floating in and out of a hole in the ceiling. Jellyfishes provided light, while a mechanical octopus acted as the barman, serving sunny cocktails to the mermaid goddess. How the content avoided floating around remained a mystery.

As for Victor himself, he had no problem breathing or swimming. The water felt weightless and tasted like salted beer, while his fiery armor released some steam around him.

"This is unbecoming of your divine station, Seng!" Victor noticed a fiery man arguing with Seng, a marble king with a crown of flames and suns for eyes. While Seng was sitting near a map on the counter, the man remained standing. "Both cursing my chosen for a meager mistake, and threatening to sink a country!"

"M-meager?" the octopus mermaid complained, red with anger. She sounded completely drunk. "How would you react if a chosen of Deathjester ignored your divinity?!"

"I would ignore him, instead of lowering myself to that level of childishness." The fire king looked ready to argue further, when he suddenly noticed the newcomers, glaring at the goddess of undeath. "Camilla."

"Mithras."

You have taken heavy [**Lightning**] damage.

Victor could feel the sheer tension between these two, especially as the goddess smiled hypocritically. "Still struggling with stamping out the Nightlands?"

"Still struggling to get your undeathstrial revolution off the ground?" the solar deity replied calmly, although Victor could taste the sheer hostility behind it. Bad breakup indeed.

“Victor, please leave us,” his patron goddess told the Vizier, her hand touching his shoulder like a hunting hawk's claws. “I hope you will defend your friend better than her patron deity.”

The Vizier wisely and silently left the two enemy deities behind to approach Seng. No sooner did he that they started arguing violently; their mermaid host raised a hand, the insults somehow muting into background noise.

“Hmm... hello?” Victor said upon sitting next to Seng.

“Victor!” she replied, clearly happy to see him. “My defender! You alone never doubted my divinity!”

Actually, the Vizier *did* doubt it, but unlike Kia, he had bothered to check before making a comment first. Not that he would mention this out loud. “Thank you for granting me an audience, Lady Seng.”

“How could I not? You and Vainqueur are among my favorite mortals! You ended slavery in the New World, crushed feudal governments left and right, and even finished the first world tour of Outremonde!”

Oh, this may go better than he expected! “If so, could you...”

“I know why you are here, Camilla told me,” Seng replied, trying to sound dignified. “Only someone capable of recognizing my greatness could prove caring enough to defend that sinner.”

I'm taking one for the team here Kia, Victor thought, unimpressed. *I'm doing this for you.*

“But I swore I would sink her country for her blasphemy!” The goddess showed him a map, pointing to an eastern country with her finger, “I am not a monster, so I won't actually sink, *sink* it. Just unleash a little flood in the middle. Nobody will die!”

The Vizier frowned. “She's not from there.”

Seng paused. “W-what do you mean?”

“You’re pointing at the Eversun Empire, and Kia is from Gardemagne,” Victor pointed out, putting his finger on the map. “That’s the wrong country.”

Seng said nothing. Instead, her hand reached for her cocktail, and she swallowed it the same way Vainqueur ate disobedient minions.

“Also, she is a reincarnated human from Earth,” Victor added, remembering his few discussions with the [Paladin]. “I believe she was born in Ethiopia before moving to the UK. So technically, if you want to sink her country of origin—”

“BWAHA!”

Victor took a step back, as Seng suddenly exploded into tears.

“I screwed up!” she cried in her own arms, face against the counter. “I screwed up again! First, they ban me from the table after that whiskey sea incident, and now this!”

“It’s... look it’s okay,” Victor tried to comfort her, putting a hand on her shoulder. “Mistakes happen, even for gods.”

Charisma check...

Failed!

What?!

“Even mortals pity me!” Seng cried even louder, the barman octopus putting a beer bottle within arm’s reach of the goddess’. “I’m a goddess... a goddess! Why does nobody respect me?”

... she was a Vainqueur.

Outwardly regal and confident, but insecure inside; she didn’t want pity or sympathy. Thankfully, if Victor’s adventures in Outremonde had taught him anything, it was how to deal with this kind of majestic creature.

“I meant that such an action is perfectly understandable, Your Godliness. You operate on a level too high for mortals to understand.”

Flatter her to death!

“Y-your Godliness?” Seng raised her head at him, sounding both pleased and embarrassed.

“With a capital G,” Victor replied mirthfully. “Your fans can tell the difference.”

Charisma check successful! You flattered Seng’s ego!

“I mean, you oversee all the seas of Outremonde, millions, *billions* of creatures! How can you be expected to remember one mortal’s country of origin, when you decide the fate of the *world*?”

“Y-you’re just saying that to make me feel better,” she replied, unconvinced.

“But does that make it any less true?” Victor replied, knowing that she really wanted more praise, not less. “If I am reminding you of your exceptional successes, is this truly flattery? Or *history*?”

Charisma check successful! It wasn’t very hard!

“Are you a goddess, or are you not?” the Vizier kept tempting the fish with his lure.

“Yes, but... I don’t remember how I became one,” Seng admitted sheepishly. “I was drunk when I ascended.”

“Really?” Victor blinked, astonished. “That’s even more amazing.”

“R-really?” Seng looked at him in confusion. “How?”

“Yeah, that means you weren’t even trying!” Victor said with sincerity. “In my case, I brought down Heaven while drunk on mushroom wine. I thought I had screwed up, and I did... but in retrospect, I’m also proud of myself.”

“*What?!*”

Somehow, Mithras’ shocked voice echoed through Seng’s background muting. The Vizier did his best to ignore it and focus on the mermaid.

“Yeah, I mean,” Victor gathered his breath. “Isn’t it impressive that I accidentally succeeded, in one night and all on my own, where all of Happyland failed for eons? Imagine if I *hadn’t* been high. It would have been a slaughter!”

“Yes!” Seng pumped a fist. “I became a goddess without even meaning too!”

“And isn’t that impressive, when it took centuries of efforts from the others to do the same? Yes, they worked hard, but you, Your Godliness? It was all talent.”

Charisma check successful! You kissed Seng’s ass, and she loved it!

She loved it very much!

“You’re right,” Seng realized, her self-pity replaced with enthusiasm. “I’m a goddess, whether they like or not. I shouldn’t doubt myself.”

“Yes,” Victor agreed. “And that’s why I have come to petition Her Godliness, to please take mercy on one of her closet worshipers.”

The [Reaper] could feel burning eyes glaring at his back, but he ignored them in favor of the mission.

“Kia has been praying to you since the end of the Century War,” Victor argued. “When she took a bottle to drown her sorrow, you think she was looking for Mithras’ guidance? No. When she looked at the bottom of her glass, she was looking for yours, Your Godliness. *Yours.*”

“This is ridiculous!” Victor heard Mithras shout behind him, only for Camilla to drag him back into their quarrel. The Vizier vaguely heard her threaten to kill one thousand [Paladins] with vampiric syphilis, and not much afterward.

“I...” Now Seng looked positively embarrassed. “When you word it this way, that was very mean of me.”

“I’m sure she can take a quest to show how sorry she is,” Victor said softly.

“Maybe we can discuss it in the back?” Seng proposed. “I have a TV, and it’s almost time for the latest episode of *Grandrake, Princess Hunter*.”

The Vizier’s heart skipped a beat. “An actual TV?” He hadn’t seen one since his reincarnation!

“Yes! I get all of Earth’s channels, and I can look at most of Outremonde too! Except for the areas which the other gods block.” She made an annoyed face. “Damn encrypted channels.”

“You know what?” Victor said as the barman gave him a cocktail while Camilla and Mithras still threatened each other with holy wars. “That will be a pleasure.”

Chapter 124: The Return of the King

Breathing heavily, Vainqueur raised his hands and unleashed his magic for the sixtieth time. “[Terraform: Landmass]!”

His power spread across the desert beneath his and his minions’ feet; but instead of green grass, the sand transformed into bright, multi-colored sugar. A hill of cream appeared to his left, a chocolate lake to his right. Candy flowers bloomed across the land, next to licorice trees and cake boulders.

In a few seconds, the area had transformed into a baker’s paradise.

You have transformed the [**Desert**] field into a [**Candyland**] field! You increased local [**Diabetes**] rates!

Cooking-based abilities will be greatly enhanced—

“How?!” Vainqueur complained, interrupting the notification. “How does this keep happening?!”

He had been trying to make the desert green for hours, only to make it multicolored!

The dragon glanced at the previous transformed landscape behind him, a patchwork of floating islands, snowy mountains, metal tinfoil dungeons, and other aberrations. Worse, not once had he managed to create a golden land worthy of his rule!

“Obviously, Your Majesty’s [**Unstable Magic**] creates fields at random,” Untasty Allison declared, turning towards the other minions. “We had,

what, thirty different types of fields so far?”

“In total, we have four [Lost Woods], three [Crystal Caverns], one [Magical Lake], two [Floating Islands], one [Gear Factory], two [Onsen], one [Grave Canyon]...” Tasty Malfy kept reading a list, rejoicing at the next item on it, “one [Demonic Sanctuary]!”

“We are still unsure how the [Outer Space] and [Outremoon] nodes even work,” Corpseling Jules added.

“Your Majesty, this cannot continue,” Untasty Allison argued. “The local climate will be in complete chaos!”

“Rolo happy with this,” the farmer replied, opening the sugary ground to find *mochi* growing inside it. “Rolo can work this land!”

“Our citizens would welcome more environmental types,” Corpseling Jules said. “But I agree with Allison. Adding so many different fields next to one another will create ecological problems in the future.”

“I shall not stop,” Vainqueur decided. “I said I would not stop until I have kicked the desert out of my empire, and I will not compromise!”

Not even in the face of so many cakes!

“Your Majesty, I understand the sentiment, I truly do,” Untasty Allison kept arguing. “But what will happen if an [Acid Lake] causes poisonous rain to spread through the [Slime Paradise] and [Gear Factory] nearby? We cannot control the entire ecosystem!”

“Manling Victor can,” the dragon replied, trusting his chief of staff to handle the boring minion parts. “He will do the thing.”

“Oh, good idea,” Corpseling Jules nodded. “With his [Weathermaker] levels, he could create magical weather conditions.”

“But [Control Weather] has only a limited duration,” Allison pointed out.

“Not if [Permanent Enchantment] effects are applied,” the ghoul replied. “He should be of a high enough tier to cast this.”

“That’s how our Corporate Overlords covered up climate change,” Malfy added.

“And once more, I want to remind everyone that there is no scientific proof that releasing necrotic magic in the atmosphere negatively impacts the environment,” Corpseking Jules said.

The dryad raised a finger, lowered it, and then realized that Vainqueur’s logic could not be argued with. “High-tier magic is absurd.”

“The universe bends to my imperial will!” the dragon declared loudly, swallowing his [SPeroid] barrel before wiping off the liquid from his mouth. “Next!”

Victor had missed TV so much. And Seng had a full-size plasma-screen one!

“... and this is why no Princess Hunter goes hunting in the cold north without camouflage,” Grandrake explained behind the screen, as he stalked a group of giants while hidden beneath a cover of snow. Why the dragon was talking to himself remained a mystery, but it made for good television. *“If I make a wrong move, they will notice my warm breathing and attack. For Ice Giant princesses are half-knight, half-giant... one hundred percent princess!”*

“Wow, I didn’t think ice giants even existed in this world, let alone had princesses,” Victor noted, sharing a sofa with Seng. Both slouched over it like slob, a glass of alcohol in hand, and the remains of a fish pizza in a corner of the room.

“Democratic climate change destroyed their natural habitat,” Seng said.

“Aren’t you the goddess of revolutions and freedom though?” Victor asked, curious. “Why are you watching a show about saving outdated monarchies from extinction?”

“Guilty pleasure,” Seng admitted. “I hate nobles, so I love watching Grandrake capture them.”

“Do you know that Vainqueur saved me from most of his current ‘wildlife reserve’?” Victor smiled. “He put them in a bag like candies!”

“A bag?” Seng laughed.

“And then he tried to call a dragon veterinarian!”

The two exchanged their outlandish stories about their adventures in Outremonde, from Victor’s escape from the Loli House to Seng helping aliens after a UFO traffic crash. “... and he tried to pay for the damage with *seashells*!”

“Really?” Victor couldn’t stop laughing. “That’s hilarious!”

“Yeah, the town was never the same after that Lightning Gun Mexican standoff,” the mermaid said. “I think it’s where the Moon Man got the Chaos part of his portfolio. Then there was a big pillar of light and poof, Valhalla time for him.”

“And he was *still* high when he ascended?” Victor asked while looking into his cocktail glass, Seng nodding while restraining tears of hilarity. Damn, it made his own drug trip look *restrained* in comparison. “Also, is it me, or is the alcohol working? I’m supposed to be immune to this stuff.”

“Not in my planar realm, you aren’t!” The goddess and the Vizier toasted. “Where the Hell were you, best slime?”

“Happyland,” Victor replied. “And where were *you*, best mermaid?”

“Now come on, don’t be a corporate sellout,” she laughed, before looking a bit sad. “I don’t get it. How do the other gods get so many nice followers to hang out with?”

“What do you mean?” Victor frowned, “Aren’t you, like super popular already?”

“No, I’m just before Sablar and the Moonies, and tied with Isengrim!” Seng grumbled. “Yeah, Camilla is sexy and brooding, with that outsider charm, but come on, *Mithras*? He doesn’t have a stick up his ass, but a spear! So why does every twoleg love him?”

“Well, I gotta hand it to Mithras,” Victor said, even if he doubted they would ever get along. “He showed up to *personally* defend one Claimed when he probably has a dozen more important tasks to deal with. I don’t remember Dice ever doing the same for *me*.”

Maybe he was stern and stiff, but Mithras clearly cared about helping people. Victor respected that.

“I’m trying to help too!” Seng complained. “I’m trying, but I always screw up!”

“Your Godliness,” Victor said, identifying her problem. “You can’t make people believe in you if you don’t believe in yourself first.”

She looked at him, as he had casually delivered an ancient universal secret.

“What you need, Your Godliness, is someone constantly reminding you of how amazing and caring you truly are,” Victor said, remembering Vainqueur’s lesson about raising young wyrms. “Until greatness becomes second nature to you. You ‘screw-up,’ and I use the term loosely, because you *believe* that you will.”

“But—”

“Your Godliness.” He put his glass out on the sofa’s side, took her hands in his own, and looked at her straight in the eyes. “Believe in yourself... for *I* believe in *you*.”

She became so red, he could almost see the steam coming out of her forehead.

Charisma check successful!

How does licking boots taste like? Because she has eight legs!

“Victor...” Seng trailed, one of her tentacles brushing against his thigh.

If she asks “Do you like Hentai?” I’m teleporting out.

“Do you want to be my prophet?”

Oh, thank Dice! “Yes!” Victor hurriedly responded before she changed her mind and asked for something obscene; he was drunk enough to accept the job. “But, full disclosure, I already serve half the pantheon and Vainqueur.”

“I know, being a prophet is like being a sidekick,” Seng said, apparently too drunk to realize the insensitivity of her words. “You have a lot of experience!”

He felt something burn against his thigh, where Seng had brushed against him. A new symbol probably.

Congratulations! You earned the [**Claimed by Seng**] personal perk.

[**Claimed by Seng**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Skill or Agility point. You can breathe and survive underwater, and you always benefit from aquatic terrains’ bonuses; you are immune to the negative health effects of alcohol, but you can still get drunk.

Damn it. He had become a professional lackey.

“Your first mission will be to oversee Kia Bekele’s redemption, according to the tenets of my faith,” Seng said, trying to sound like a dignified, forgiving deity, but utterly failing at it. “And then you will remind everyone that I am a great and caring goddess, until I believe it myself.”

“I will,” Victor said, taking it as the price to lift Kia’s curse.

Someone knocked on the TV room’s door. It was Camilla, from the voice. “Victor!”

“Yes, vampire Mom?”

“We’re leaving!” She must have finally stopped arguing with Mithras.

“Can I come back to this place?” Victor asked Seng. He wouldn’t mind hanging out with the mermaid more often; she was a lot of fun, and she had a TV.

“Anytime!” Seng replied, before switching channels.

Victor walked to the door, finding Camilla and Mithras waiting on the other side. While the god of justice remained still like a statue, the [Reaper]’s patron had her arms crossed and looked ready to murder someone on the spot.

“Have you made progress on your [Paladin] friend’s case?” she asked Victor.

“Yes,” he said. “I’ve got the authority to solve the case.”

“Good,” Camilla replied, glaring at Mithras. “At least *my* chosen is pulling his weight.”

Victor sincerely hoped his friendship with Kia would never follow the same path as these two.

“Thank you,” the god of justice told Victor, ignoring Camilla. “I am grateful for your good deed.”

“Do I get a Perk out of it?” the Vizier asked, pushing his luck.

“You already received one,” Mithras replied, before teleporting away. “Do not get greedy for doing the right thing.”

Well, Victor was half-dragon now. Greed was part of the package.

“And he wonders why I dumped him,” Camilla replied angrily, before waving her hand. In the blink of an eye, Victor found himself back in his pocket dimension’s laboratory, where his [Fetch] was busy tinkering with the Soulcrest.

“Are you okay?” the Vizier asked the dark elf goddess, sensing her anger and frustration.

“No,” she replied, quickly changing the subject. “Victor, have you *Grandrake and Chilled* with Seng?”

“We watched a documentary, but no, we didn’t chill that way.”

“Good, because even if I appreciate you, I won't tread anywhere Seng has gone first. I have standards, and I need to blow off steam right now.”

The Vizier froze. “What does that mean?”

Camilla looked at Victor, then at the lab’s undead operation table, then back at him.

[**Herpes**], [**Syphilis**], and [**Succurus Warts**] negated by [**Claimed by Cybele**]. Warning: you have taken super-effective damage from the blood loss! You have fallen below one-third of your HP!

Congratulations! For your charming ways and deeds, you have earned four levels in [**Fiendish Rake**]! You earned the [**Curse of Diarmuid**] and [**Emotion Magic I**] Perks.

+ 120 HP, +10 SP, +4 VIT, + 2 SKI, +4 AGI, +3 INT, +8 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Curse of Diarmuid**]: technique, 60 SP. You can cause your naked face to become cursed for five minutes, which manifests as a spot on your cheek. During this duration, anyone looking at your visage must succeed on a Charisma check or become obsessed with your face, dropping everything to gaze at it. This is an [Curse] effect that will affect the victim until it is magically lifted.

[**Emotion Magic I**]: You can learn and cast tier I spells; additionally, you can learn spells with the [Mind] or [Emotion] descriptors, even if you do not have access to their relevant specialized school. This stacks with other tier access perks that you may have from other classes.

The night had long fallen and the cursed Mooooon risen in the skies, when Vainqueur unleashed his magic for the... hundredth time?

In truth, he had lost count.

“[Terraform: Landmass]!”

Once more, the desert bent to his will, all the way to the stone coast separating it from the sea. A layer of moss-covered the sand, while giant mushrooms the size of trees and houses grew all around them.

You changed the [**Desert**] field into a [**Fungi Forest**] field!

[**Plant**] creatures will gain a boost to all stats, while [**Plant**] and [**Poison**] effects will be greatly strengthened. Physical ailments will last twice as long.

“Next,” Vainqueur declared, unhappy that he had yet to create a [Gold Farm] field.

“Yer Majesty, there is no next,” Rolo the golem replied.

“I have plenty of energy left,” the dragon argued proudly.

“Yer Majesty, there is no next,” the tinfoil creature repeated. “That was the last patch of desert in Ishfania. We reached the frontier.”

His dryad friend looked at the ocean with a strange, serene face. “It is done,” she said, the weight of her words heavy on her. “It is *done*.”

Vainqueur gathered his breath, raised his arms, and shouted the following truth to the sea.

“VAINQUEUR BEST DRAGON!”

Congratulations! For reshaping ALL of Ishfania on your own, in one go, you earned four levels in [**Geomancer**]! You earned the [**Terraform: Non-Magical Terrains**] and [**Nature Wonder**] class perks.

+120 HP, +80 SP, +3 SKI, +2 AGI, +4 INT, +3 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Terraform: Non-Magical Terrains**]: 50 SP per fifty meters radius. You can permanently terraform an area around you into the following [Fields]: [Forest], [Marsh], [Desert], [Hill], [Snowland], [Plains], [Tundra], [Rock

Mountain], [Ice Mountain], [Volcano], [Beach], [Lake], [Flower Garden], [Canyon], and [Oasis]. You need to be grounded to activate this effect. This replaces [Terraform: Landmass].

[Nature Wonder]: Technique, 100 SP. You can draw upon ambient natural energies to boost all your stats by two stages, and cure any physical-based ailment affecting you. You need to be grounded on natural soil to activate this technique.

Thanks to your levels in **[Geomancer]** and **[Dungeon Breeder]**, you can combine both classes into the prestigious **[Fisher King]** class!

“Where are my other minions?” the dragon asked since the ghoul and the fiend were missing. It irked him that only two of his lackeys witnessed his triumph.

“Malfy went to sleep, and Jules is updating the country’s map,” Allison replied. “He has a lot of work ahead of him.”

“The work of Akhenapep is undone in Ishfania,” Rolo said, looking at the distant landmass beyond the sea. “Other countries remain covered in Sablar's sand, but today? Today, we served the goddess well.”

“I was reincarnated to repair you and this land, Rolo, and half of the work is done,” Untasty Allison replied, a tear in her eye. “I am sorry, this... this is really an emotional moment for me.”

“Cry tears of joy, my servant,” Vainqueur gave her his imperial permission. “Today, I have granted your wish. For I am good and generous.”

At long last, he had spat in the eye of this worm Sablar, and molded his empire into a place where all creatures could live to serve him.

As if to ruin his mood though, a storm gathered on the horizon, covering the sea. The dragon prepared to boast again, when he realized that the clouds were flying straight at him.

“This is not a natural storm,” Vainqueur realized, as the pressure in the air grew stronger. He immediately understood the situation. “Minions, hide.”

“But—”

“Hide,” the dragon replied more firmly, the golem and the dryad retreating away. Untasty Allison fused with a giant mushroom, hiding within the plant, while Rolo moved behind it. Vainqueur refused to allocate funds to revive more minions.

Soon afterward, a flock of winged, false princesses surrounded the dragon, announcing their gigantic leader’s arrival. A fomor titan looked down on the dragon from atop his flying horse.

“Dragonsbane.” Vainqueur glared back.

“Knightsbane,” King Wotan replied, his spear crackling with wild lightning. “You have ten minutes.”

Chapter 125: The Third Way

“It will take me less than ten minutes to destroy you, Wotan!” Vainqueur Knightsbane declared, expanding his wings threateningly.

“It seems you have forgotten how our last physical encounters ended,” the stormlord replied, barely restraining himself. “You would have died in that crater, had your servant not rescued you at the last minute. Although I welcome the opportunity to settle our score, I am here to honor my word first.”

“Your word?” the dragon asked, surprised when no thunderbolt followed. King Wotan never talked for long, and always fought until the bitter end. So why was he staying his hand this time? “What is your fairy’s word worth?”

“An oath once given, I never betray,” King Wotan replied, one of his winged allies landing on his shoulder like a crow. “Although I did not make a vow myself, your 'chief minion' agreed to release the soul of my Valkyrie Sigrun if I vowed to talk peacefully for ten minutes. Nine now, I should say.”

What rubbish was this? Manling Victor would never act behind his friend’s back.

Vainqueur briefly wondered if this was a fairy trick, but he couldn’t see any benefit. If anything, the fomor had wasted a potential surprise attack.

Intelligence check successful.

Unless... maybe the trick was on Manling Victor’s part, so they could defeat the fairies more easily. He had always been crafty.

“Minion!” Vainqueur roared. “MINION! GET BACK HERE!”

Answering his call, Manling Victor teleported right before his dragon master.

And what a scene it was. His minion had abandoned his clothes to revel in his dragon nakedness, with blood dripped profusely from two holes in his neck. He smelled of bats and wild breeding.

“*EXCALIBUR!*” he shouted with a blissful face, crawling on all fours with both tails—the long dragon one, and the tiny manling one—raised.

Silence fell upon the gathering, as the manling’s face turned from bliss to shame.

“[Emergency Teleport]!” Friend Victor shouted, touching his hands and waist. “Damn it, my items!”

“Oh, my...” one of the valkyries muttered, a few of the flying princess looking at Manling Victor’s lower parts with fascination. Vainqueur also noticed Untasty Allison’s eyes peek out of the giant mushroom where she had hidden herself.

“I see that your thrall has taken levels in [Berserker],” King Wotan mused. “Excellent strategy.”

“[Golden Pantaloons]!” Manling Victor cast a spell, golden trousers of solid magic appearing to protect his little tail. “Your Majesty, please issue a warning first next time!”

“Minion, I am naked too and you do not see me make a scene about it,” Vainqueur replied with great wisdom.

His friend opened his mouth, closed it, then looked at his dragon master with a newfound curiosity. “Your Majesty is naked,” he muttered. “Your Majesty was naked all along.”

“Minion, I have always been naked *power*,” Vainqueur replied.

“Yes, I *knew*, but I didn’t *understand*.”

“Minion, we dragons have no shame in flaunting our natural beauty to everyone. It is you manlings who need to hide their insecurities below clothes.”

“Seven minutes,” Wotan spoke up, waving his spear as he started losing patience. “Speak, or fight.”

“Minion,” Vainqueur told his chief of staff. “The fairy pretends that you made a deal with him; to release one of his false princesses for a moment of his time.”

“Technically, I only talked to the Valkyrie, but...” Manling Victor rose up on his feet, looking at Wotan, and then at Vainqueur himself. “Does Your Majesty trust me on this?”

“Friend Victor, by now you should know the answer to this question. You are my most valued companion, and I trust you unconditionally.”

If he had an idea, then Vainqueur would support it; or at least give it the benefit of the doubt.

“Thank you,” Manling Victor bowed, before turning to the fomor. “Lord Wotan, I have asked that you please talk to us before we fight, because I believe we don’t need to fight at all.”

The statement surprised Vainqueur almost as much as Wotan. Did he expect the fomor to become a minion? If so, he was mistaken.

“You attacked us to prevent a war,” the chief of staff argued. “Because you believed that Your Majesty here was the greatest threat to your race.”

“He is,” Wotan replied.

“I am!” Vainqueur boasted.

“No, he isn’t!” Manling Victor shouted, much to both titans’ surprise. “The greatest threat to the fomors, are the fomors themselves!”

King Wotan remained entirely silent, his lone eye looming over Manling Victor. Vainqueur readied himself to pounce on the fomor, should he make any threatening move towards his manling.

“You fomors are the ones who keep waging pointless, costly wars on humans, on dragons, on everyone who doesn’t belong to your so-called ‘master race’,” Manling Victor said. “Certainly, nations of our world often bicker, but sentient species have managed to live in peace for centuries. Why not fomors too?”

“A lion does not make peace with sheep,” King Wotan replied. “This is the law of nature.”

“You are wrong. Lions need to kill to eat. You fomors don’t. You don’t *need* to kill or attack other races to survive. You don’t need to kill *at all*! Thing is, the only thing that sustains this cycle of destruction, is your *sociopathic ego*!” King Wotan’s face remained a mask of ice. “Do you want proof? One of your kindred is renting a goddamn room in Murmurin as we speak!”

“What?” Vainqueur glared at his minion, incensed that a fairy had made his lair near his own.

“Jack is the living proof that our species don’t have to kill each other,” Manling Victor continued. “Maybe the Soulcrests were born of great evil, but they granted your kind souls. They granted Fomors the capacity to change, to learn, to *care*; we have seen that in the volcano.”

The Valkyrie on Wotan’s shoulder shifted uncomfortably, while the others moved to shield their master. Vainqueur couldn’t help but see a mirror of his own minions in them.

“All I ask, King Wotan, is that you meditate on your old ways, and ponder if they have done your race any good.”

“The New Folk conquered the lands that belonged to my kindred,” King Wotan spoke. “They keep doing so.”

“Because you keep trying to recover lost glory, instead of accepting that the world has changed,” Manling Victor replied. “You can make treaties with the other races and kingdoms. Divide the world fairly. Or you can keep this eternal war going and see your kingdoms shrink century after century.”

“The Mell Clan will never stop,” King Wotan said. “You may be right, wise manling, that our species could coexist, but the fairy queen will never listen. She will kill or be killed.”

“Then do away with that psychopath,” Manling Victor said. “We’ve seen how you acted in the volcano. You cared. You cared about someone less strong, less mighty than yourself. We have killed many of them; do you want to lose more?”

The valkyries readied their spears in challenge, but Wotan raised a hand to stop them. “I swore an oath,” he pointed out.

“You promised to bring His Majesty’s head to the fairy queen,” Manling Victor said, “Never to separate it from his body first. I say you honor your word to the letter.”

While he would never suspect his friend of treason, Vainqueur had to think twice about his sentence.

Intelligence check successful!

“Oh, brilliant minion!” Vainqueur caught on. “He is bound to bring me to this false wurm abomination, so I can destroy her!”

King Wotan’s lone eye narrowed. “This violates the spirit of my oath.”

“But respects the letter, and allows you to walk away from all this. With luck, we can even destroy Odieuse before the Conclave, and this pointless war will end before it begins.”

“A Conclave?” The Fomor Lord tensed up dangerously, his fingers crackling with lightning. “Knightsbane, what have you done?”

“Your fellow fairies shed dragon blood to power their Crests,” Vainqueur hissed dangerously. “Those responsible shall learn *fire* and *wrath*.”

The thought of a dragon-fairy war seemed to tear apart Wotan’s heart. On one hand, Dragonbane had earned his title, and yearned for a conflict worthy of his skills; but Vainqueur could also see a hint of worry in his gaze. The knowledge that his threatened race may very well go extinct gnawed at him.

“Your Majesty,” a Valkyrie spoke up, turning to her master. “The ten minutes mark has passed.”

The fomor lord did not attack. Instead, he turned to Vainqueur. “Lord Knightsbane, your servant has made his case. What do you have to say in this?”

Vainqueur thoughtfully pondered the question.

He had been as surprised as the dragonslayer when Manling Victor made his case. They had discussed the possibility of making peace with the fairies.

The old him, who had conquered this land for a bigger vault, would have brushed this proposal as a feeble dream and a waste of time. The new Vainqueur, however, had something else to say.

“I hate you fairies.”

Manling Victor made a panicked face, but Vainqueur ignored him and doubled-down.

“You are treacherous, vicious, and you treat your minions with great cruelty. We made peace once, but you never stopped abusing my kind’s mercy. You threatened to have me killed in my sleep before this feud with Mell Odieuse even started, and I suspect that you planned to renew our war for a long, long time. I will not call off the Conclave, and the Mell Clan shall be wiped out.”

Vainqueur marked a short pause, heavy with danger. King Wotan let out a shrug of disappointment, raising his [Gungnir].

“However,” he said, interrupting Dragonbane. “I have created a dragon utopia where all creatures can live in peace. Even monsters from the cursed planet Moon, whose evil nature you cannot begin to comprehend. It would be hypocritical to deny your kind the same treatment. If you fairies agree to reaffirm the ancient peace that bound our two species and *respect* it this time, then I shall reserve my judgment for the wicked Mell Odieuse and her allies. The rest of your kind shall be left in peace.”

“And if not?” Wotan asked. “If there is no will for peace?”

“If not, I swear that I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, shall lay waste to all your petty kingdoms and destroy them one by one. You will never rise to threaten my kind and minions, *ever again*. Because I will not stop until your power is forever shattered.” Vainqueur let out smoke from his nostrils. “One way or another, there shall be no third fairy-dragon war.”

The tension in the air became almost unbearable, both sides looking at the other. Rolo the golem peeked out from his hiding spot alongside Untasty Allison, both ready to join the fray at the first sign of movement; Manling Victor hesitated to cast a spell; and the Valkyries looked at their lord for his command.

Vainqueur knew that Wotan would strike. Dragonbane had only ever understood violence; he breathed it, lived for it. The idea of compromise was alien to him.

But he didn’t attack.

This alone shocked Vainqueur, who realized that he didn’t face the same brute who dedicated his entire life to avenging his wounded pride, after Grandrake had defeated him. This, this *Wotan-shaped creature*, seemed at war, but only with himself.

The dragon could read the internal conflict all over the fomor’s face. A struggle between a vicious instinct compelling him to settle for nothing but

a bloody victory; and a reasonable voice, arguing for a better course of action.

King Wotan had gained a soul, and he had changed.

“Hm.” A sorrowful shadow appeared at the edge of the fomor lord’s eye. “I do believe my kind’s path is wrong. I admit it. Hence why I wanted nothing to do with the Mell’s war and vile farms. I intended to slay you, honor my oath, and ignore war entirely; but clearly, I can no longer sit on the fence.”

Vainqueur prepared to summon his [Glitzy Theater], but he had misread the fomor’s intent. Wotan looked at the horizon as if he could glimpse something beyond it. Perhaps he understood that he was about to make his life’s most important decision.

“Show it to me.”

“Show you what, Dragonbane?” Vainqueur asked.

“This place that you have made. This ‘utopia’, where my kind can live as equals with the New Folk. Show it to me, and then... then I shall *see*.”

“Your Majesty...” one of the Valkyries trailed off.

“There shall be no battle tonight, my Valkyries,” the fomor lord said, his horse letting out a thunderous noise. “Whether there shall be one tomorrow, however... it will depend on how much your word is worth, Knightsbane.”

“Then come to Murmurin, and be amazed,” Vainqueur replied proudly.

King Wotan said nothing, before pointing his spear north, towards the V&V’s capital. His horse carried him in this direction, his Valkyrie flock following.

“Holy Happyland, it worked,” Manling Victor let out a heavy breath, relieved. “It worked.”

“Did you doubt it, minion?” Vainqueur asked, Untasty Allison and Tinfoil Rolo emerging from their hiding holes.

“Yes, yes I did!” the manling admitted. “I worried it would end in a fight anyway.”

“For all it is worth, I believe you both did the right thing,” Untasty Allison said. “Even if it doesn't work, it was worth a shot.”

“We should present him Felix,” Vainqueur said, an idea crossing his mind. “Such an exquisite, refined creature can only help turn the fairy around.”

Manling Victor said nothing, causing the dragon to squint at his prized friend. “Minion, what are you hiding from me?”

“I ate him!”

Vainqueur frowned, as his lackey collapsed to his knees, crushed under the weight of his sin.

“I ate him!” Manling Victor confessed, breaking down in tears. The dragon couldn't say if they were of joy or sorrow, however. “I ate him twice, and he tasted so *good!*”

“Minion, I am *highly* displeased,” Vainqueur chastised his chief of staff, disappointed by his behavior. “Why have you eaten Felix?”

“Because I hated him! I hated him so much!”

“Minion, sometimes, you must ignore your feelings and use your reason,” Vainqueur scolded him. “You should have eaten the orcs first.”

Manling Victor stopped crying and looked up at his partner with his big, adorable eyes. “Your Majesty is not mad that I ate the cat?”

“Friend Victor, eating minions lower in the food chain is your right,” Vainqueur explained. “But you must learn to *prioritize*. You *start* with my least favorite minions, and you *finish* with the ones I like more. I should have explained to you these subtleties first.”

Vainqueur should definitely make a *list of minion priority*, to clear out his friend's clouded mind. He would raise Manling Kia to the middle, alongside

the zmey, push down Useless Croissant to the bottom...

“If you ever eat the moon veteran Buzz Jelly when you have *any* alternative, I shall never forgive you,” Vainqueur stated, before realizing that something bugged him with the situation. “Friend Victor, how can you eat the same minion twice?”

“Cats have nine lives in Outremonde, Your Majesty,” Untasty Allison explained. “They automatically revive one day after their demise.”

The dryad took a step backward when Vainqueur’s full gaze fell upon her; unaware that she had stepped on a great discovery.

“Minion, this changes everything about what I just said!” the dragon declared. “No longer will minions need to eat lesser ones to avoid starvation! Instead, they can eat a single, nine-times renewable one! This will save *thousands of lives!*”

Vainqueur swore it.

Every one of his soldiers would have their own cat ration.

Chapter 126: Relationship Boards

This wasn't how Victor imagined his first 'ultrasound' session as a future father. Then again, he never expected to have one in the first place, and especially not in a ghoul-run undead clinic.

“As you can see,” Jules explained, projecting his divination spell on the white wall opposite to the patient's bed. “The living fetus is developing at an accelerated rate compared to a standard humanoid, probably due to her fiendish nature. Since fiends are ‘born’ ready to fight, we must assume little Braniña should at least be able to walk on birth.”

“Is she going to claw her way out?” Isabelle asked, laying in a bed while Victor sat at her side, holding her hand. “Braniño was insufferably impatient, I had to kick him out early.”

“Unlikely, considering your resistance to Physical damage.”

Victor slightly zoned out, as Jules went into details about demon morphology. The picture of his daughter on the wall obsessed him; a tiny baby with wings, a tail, and sharp nails. Something he should have been disturbed by, but in truth?

In truth, she was the most beautiful thing in the world.

“She has your tail and your wings,” Isabelle noted.

“And she has your everything else,” Victor noted as well. “I thought she was half Humanoid though, not half Dragon?”

“Dragon blood is strong,” Jules said. “It is bound to assert itself in some way. In fact, she may even inherit a breath of some kind.”

“After this, Darling, I want to be spoiled,” Isabelle said, caressing his cheek with her finger. “Because I intend to spoil you too.”

“I have prepared the best vacation resort,” he replied.

Unfortunately for him, she aimed a little higher. “You lack ambition. While Hellhound fights are the latest fad, I will settle for nothing less than gladiatorial games in my honor.”

“What?” Victor panicked. “In the middle of a war?”

“Darling, this is your heir and *me* we are talking about,” she replied pompously. “Bring those lesser tarasques you have been breeding, and have them fight for my amusement.”

“I... I’ll see what I can do,” he said evasively.

“Mr. Victor.” Victor’s succubi summons entered the room, surrounding a prisoner whom he identified as Sigrun, Wotan’s head Valkyrie. At least the fact that he was now their ‘exclusive’ employer meant that they did bodyguarding full time. “We caught her sniffing around.”

“I did not come to threaten you,” the Valkyrie protested. “Lord Wotan asked us to behave.”

“Then why are you here?” Victor asked, slightly on edge with his unborn children in the building.

Charisma check successful.

“I was curious,” Sigrun admitted. “We Valkyries, we never...”

“Battle maiden?” Victor squinted when she left her sentence hanging.

She glared at him, before looking away. “I do not understand how any female warrior could accept this indignity,” she declared, looking at Isabelle Maure. “How can you fight in this state?”

“With [Insta-Death] spells and brimstone,” the archdevil replied with cold disdain. “I usually have others fight for me anyway.”

The Valkyrie crossed her arms, unable to find a good answer.

“Mr. Victor,” one of his marilith spoke up. “Since we are all gathered in the same room, perhaps we can discuss the honeymoon.”

The Vizier froze. “The honeymoon?”

“Part of the settlement is that we are treated with the care of official mistresses,” the serpentine demon replied. “Since our company has a strong esprit de corps, we have decided to form a union and equally share our privileges.”

“As such, we want an official romantic honeymoon to celebrate our new, exclusive partnership,” a succubus added. “We thought a luxury group trip to the Elemental Plane of Water would be more than adequate.”

“Do not worry about the cost calculations for all the expensive dinners, massages, spas, etc, we did it for you.”

“You do know we are about to declare war on Prydain soon?” Victor asked them with heavy sarcasm.

“We understand the political climate, which is why we agreed to postpone after your inevitable victory,” the marilith replied mirthfully. “But we want to make the reservations early.”

“We also want more emotional care,” a winged demoness added. “We wish to be considered as more than lust objects; we want each of us to have dates, dinners, intimate emotional connections... our customer value is almost as important as money to us.”

Victor sighed. Much to his shame, he didn’t actually remember the *names* of half of them, so he had a long way to go.

“Oh, also, that reminds me!” Jules spoke up. “The Lynette paternity test returned positive. She agreed not to file charges in exchange for a pension,

a vacation house in Murmurin, and an official title.”

“What?” the [Reaper] almost jumped back, knowing the agony his budget already experienced. “Another, *other* alimony payment? I haven’t even seen her in more than seven years!”

“Darling, if this peasant is causing you problems, we can purge her,” Isabelle suggested happily.

“Nobody is purging anyone!” Victor replied firmly.

“I take back what I said,” Sigrun said, having observed the scene. “The male is obviously the most miserable in this arrangement.”

“VICTOR!” The bedroom’s door opened wide, an angry goblin stepping through. “YOU TRAITOR!”

Why did he have the feeling the day was only about to get worse? “Goblina, I swear I was going to tell—”

“You are going to have a child with our *teacher*?” Goblina glared at the Vizier, before violently pushing a surprised Sigrun out of her way. “And you didn’t make me the godmother?! I thought we were *friends*!”

“We wanted to announce it under better circumstances,” Isabelle replied, having considered the goblin her second most favorite student at Scholomance. “Maybe even organize a class reunion, to see how far everyone has gone.”

“It’s fine, I forgive you both, so long as I get to be the godmother,” the goblin brushed it off, instantly fascinated by Isabelle’s stomach. “Is that why you always had top grades in [Diabolism], Vic?”

“I had private lessons,” he admitted.

“I am going to spoil her rotten,” Goblina gushed. “I will give her a gun for her first birthday, so she can snipe rebels as soon as she can aim.”

“My, that is very thoughtful of you,” Isabelle replied, with a smile. “Victor told me that you have conquered your first country? I am recruiting the best trainers for my Braniña, perhaps you would be interested in taking her as an apprentice once she comes of age?”

“I would be delighted to show her the ropes!”

Victor suddenly realized that his daughter may grow up surrounded by *bad* influences. “Oh jeez, look at the time,” he said, eager to escape the room. “I have to visit Chocolatine.”

“Your other woman,” Isabelle said, looking at him strangely, “Darling, you remember that Braniña is your *heir*? I’m sure she will be delighted to have half-siblings, as long as they remember she is the eldest and first in line. You know how decadent courts full of intrigue develop.”

He had followed enough courses to know he wanted to avoid such a setup at all costs. “I’ll make sure everyone gets along, family first,” Victor replied, although the discussion soured his mood a little.

He moved to another room of the clinic, where he found Chocolatine on a bed, attended by undead and Allison. “Hello, handsome,” the dryad told him.

“Hi, Vic.” Chocolatine waved at him, a ghost casting detection spells on her. “Isn’t it a bit early for a magicography? I am only a few weeks pregnant.”

“They’re just checking for potential biological problems early,” he replied. “I mean, you are a werewolf, the kids are wereslimes and weredragons. There may be complications, like the kids chewing their way out.”

“Oh, can we visit my brother when they’re done? So he knows he will become an uncle soon?” she all but begged him. “Do you know he settled down with Savoureuse on the Dark Side of the *Mooodooon*?”

Yeah, he had heard. Charlene had come barging into his office when she learned the news, furious that her loathed ex was happily settling down.

Victor was pretty sure that it gave ideas he could have done without right now. “Sure,” he said, before making a face.

“Vic?” Chocolatine asked as he moved on the opposite side to Allison. “Is something wrong?”

“I will have to remove you from my [Black Horseman] perk.”

The werewolf said nothing, blinking in surprise, then gave him a quick kiss. “Vic, you have touched her first,” Chocolatine said, her ear lowering in disappointment. “Are you replacing me with her?”

“No!” he replied hastily, holding her. “But Choc, things are going to keep getting worse from now on. I don’t want to put you in danger.”

“I’m [Crested], Vic,” she replied proudly. “I can take care of myself.”

“I know,” he said. “But you’re not alone anymore.”

Chocolatine bit her lower lip, but saw reason. “Choose someone who can help then,” the werewolf said. “Like Al, or Charlene!”

“I’ll consider those with the best fighting abilities,” he promised. “I’ll keep visiting you whenever I can.”

They hugged, but this time, it felt sadder than comforting.

As he exited the room and prepared to teleport out, Allison stopped him, closing the door so Choc wouldn’t listen. “Vic,” she said. “You are clearly unwell.”

“Is it that obvious?” he asked. Truth be told, the stress of keeping the peace, of managing his newfound family, and preparing for war gnawed at him.

“I am a priestess,” the dryad replied, holding his hand. “People come to me when they need to confide, or to release tension. I can serve as your therapist, if you need it.”

“I’m not sure you’re supposed to sleep with your therapist.”

"In Cybele's church, it's part of the healing process," the dryad replied, confirming what he had always suspected about the hippie church. "I know you use physical intimacy to cope with the pressure of your position, but in your case, I believe that you need an ear. We can simply talk. I will listen and I won't judge."

He considered it, before letting out a heavy breath. "I would prefer talking," the Vizier admitted. "Someone to help unload the burden."

"Then tell me—"

"Breeder Dalton!"

The walls of the clinic trembled, the booming voice coming from outside. Victor and Allison immediately rushed to the window, opening it to find a blue, lightning wyrm right outside. "Lord Grandrake?" Victor blinked.

"The world needs you!" the wyrm shouted. "I crossed the sea to seek your help!"

"Are the fomors attacking El Goldorado?" Allison panicked.

"No." Grandrake shook his head. "I cannot find any Mushroom Prince, all remaining elf royals are more inbred than *Zmeys*, and orc males are too stupid to breed. Many of our captive princesses may go extinct in two generations."

Oh, good. *Viva la democracy*.

Wait, wait. "You don't mean—"

"I have heard the wonderful news," Grandrake confirmed. "You can breed half-dragons, which makes you the next best thing to a true prince. You can *enhance* true princessness with perfect dragon genes."

Victor and Allison exchanged a glance.

"Breeder Dalton, follow me," Grandrake declared as if laying some kind of great chosen one prophecy before the [Reaper]. "Follow me, to Goldorado!"

You must fulfill your destiny!”

Victor nodded, once, twice, and then spoke two words.

“[Emergency Teleport]!”

To honor Seng and relieve tension before the Conclave, Victor had organized a Monster Poker tournament in her honor.

Countless monsters had gathered in the central plaza to either play or observe the battles; demon and orc entrepreneurs had quickly set stands and improvised bars to service everyone, running through stocks of whiskey and tarasque food.

Vainqueur himself played, using an orc woman as his hand; since the tournament involved teams of two to foster cooperation, the dragon played alongside a conscripted Gorynych. Surprisingly, their opponents, Rolo and Jack, seemed to hold their own, mostly thanks to the Zmey's stubborn attempts to play the tiny cards with his big hands.

And King Wotan stood nearby, observing the scene in silence. While some of his Valkyries mingled with Murmurin's citizens and seemed to get along, nobody dared break the ice with the mighty fomor.

Walking through the crowd under the cover of a [Perfect Invisibility] spell — one capable of hiding his body odor and the sound of footsteps— Victor decided to let the fomor alone for now, noticing Kia near to a bar stand. “You’ve stopped playing?” he asked the [Paladin], startling her as he sat right next to her. “I thought you had jumped on the Monster Poker bandwagon.”

“Vic, is that you?” she looked around, “Are you invis—”

“Shush!” he replied, putting a hand on her shoulder. “Grandrake has been stalking me for hours and is *incredibly* perceptive. He always finds me.”

This was insane. How could a giant creature be so good at ambushing someone a hundredth of his size?

Kia looked at him strangely—or rather, in his rough direction—but didn't comment. "I went to the quarterfinals with my partner, but Rolo and his fairy 'friend' demolished us."

"Looks like they're doing well," Victor said, surprised. He could count the number of players who had survived past the first round against Vainqueur on one finger.

"Rolo plays a broken [Farmland] deck, and Jack is almost as nasty. I didn't even know [Plants] were competitively viable." Kia glanced at Wotan with a hint of paranoia. "How did you convince two fomors to behave?"

"Blame Chocolatine for Jack, and five charisma checks for Wotan," he replied. "You're worried?"

"Yeah, I am. I spent a decade fighting them." Still, Victor took the fact that no fight had broken out yet as a good sign. "I've also been meaning to ask, is this Seng prophet rumor true?"

"Yes," he said, "I did it for you."

"Oh, Vic." She made a face full of compassion. "You sold your body for me?"

"No!" God damn it, Victor didn't solve all his problems by prostituting himself! "I simply agreed to help spread her faith after she put her tentacle on—you know what, nevermind."

"How is..." The [Paladin] shook her head. "How does your mess of a love life even *function*?"

"Besides the alimonies-fueled bankruptcy, the jealousy, the politics, and trying to make time for everyone?" He let out a heavy sigh. "It's a lot more tiring than I thought it would be. Like Murmurin, there would have been a war by now without me to keep the peace. Managing an extended family is *hard*."

“On one hand, I feel compassion for you; but on the other hand, you also brought it on yourself.”

“I know,” Victor replied. “But I didn’t think it would be this bad. And now that they know I can have half-dragon kids, I get *stalkers* now. It’s even worse than after Vainqueur defeated Brandon Maure.”

“I know how it feels,” Kia said. “To pursue a goal, and realize that it wasn’t what they made it out to be. I’ve been there too.”

Victor shook his head, wanting to change his mind. “What about *your* love life?”

“Actually,” she stroked her hair, “I’ve been seeing people.”

“Really?” he looked at her curiously, but being invisible, she probably didn’t notice.

“Yeah, there’s that half-orc [Paladin] of Isengrim, and that handsome dark elf I play Monster Poker with,” Kia explained. “It’s thanks to you actually. Since every fertile female monster in Murmurin is after you, *except* me, the lack of options forced the guys here to muster the courage to approach me. It is a very weird setup.”

“You’re exaggerating.”

“Vic, is there seriously a female creature between ten and—”

“Eighteen.”

“Between eighteen and thirty in Murmurin that you haven’t slept with, or who didn’t try to get in your pants?”

“Well, easy. *You*.”

Kia seemed a little offended at this. “Vic, did you never make a move on me because I am a [Paladin],” she marked a short pause, “or because I am black?”

“Oh, no, I find you very attractive,” Victor reassured her. At one point at Scholomance, he had even asked his succubus intern to polymorph into... well... “It’s just, honestly, you’re a straight-laced [Paladin] in the service of my patron goddess’ mortal enemy, and we have completely opposite outlooks on life.”

Also, Camilla was already distraught about Vainqueur's last minute teleportation, and he had no intention to piss her off further. "I would rather have *fewer* women in my life right now, not *more*," Victor admitted.

“Yeah, don’t take it personally when I say a Hell-sponsored conqueror is not my type either,” Kia replied. “Now that I have suitors I get along with, though, I’m not sure which one I should pick.”

“Why not both?” Victor asked the simple solution, before realizing how much that way of thinking had cost him. Old habits died hard.

“I’m not a skirt-chaser like you, Vic,” Kia replied, although without any condemnation. “I want a person I can truly rely on, since my last serious boyfriend killed us both on Earth. Quality over quantity.”

Yeah, it would mean less headaches. “You remember the dungeon architect quest?” Kia suddenly said.

“The one you found fishy?”

“I asked Charlene, and besides learning *which* criminal church sponsors it,” she said, with an angry sneer on her face. “I learned that the prize for this year is the [Plot Armor] artifact.”

Victor had heard of it. “You want us to participate?”

“It might be our last chance to gain levels before fighting Odieuse, and we could use a magic item that powerful.”

Speaking about levels... Victor summoned a bottle of wine and put it on the counter. Kia didn’t react.

The Vizier suddenly realized that the invisibility spell was still active, and lifted it for the bottle. This time, Kia made a face at the sight.

“That’s a bottle from Seng’s realm, which will make you drunk but not lift the curse. You must use it to earn a level in one of Seng’s chosen classes.” Thankfully, he put his veto on [Fisherman]. “[Drunken Brawler]. If you succeed, as Seng’s prophet, I will confirm that you atoned for your apostasy.”

“And if I do, the curse is lifted?” she asked, her eyes full of hope, before towards the person behind the counter. “Bring me a pot of grease please!”

Victor wondered why she would order that until a busty orc barmaid delivered. Kia drank the whole bottle in one row, broke it, before putting her hands in the grease. Then she rolled them in the glass shards. “That’s not very [Paladin],” Victor said, astonished.

“But it’s very [Drunken Brawler],” she replied with a savage face, the alcohol seeming to take effect. “And I can’t take saltwater anymore. I will do *whatever it takes*.”

What had he done? What had *he done*?

Silently walking away from what he expected to be a bar brawl of epic proportions, Victor wondered if he should approach Wotan, before deciding to let the titan and his Valkyrie posse make his own opinion about Murmurin. The Vizier wouldn’t always be present to smooth things over, and for his plan to work, the fomor lord needed to choose peace of his own volition.

Still, he would hang around, in case a catastrophe happened.

“Breeder!” Victor froze, turning his head to find Grandrake’s eye peeking over his shoulder. “Breeder Dalton, I have found you again.”

How? How did Grandrake manage to sneak up on him?! That mammoth was more than sixty-feet long, and the invisibility spell still active!

“Breeder Dalton, you may have the cunning of a mermaid princess, but I have hunted far subtler prin—”

Grandrake’s boasting suddenly ended, as the dragon caught sight of King Wotan. The atmosphere became immediately suffused with ambient electricity, as the two ancient enemies looked at one another.

...

Uh, Charisma checks incoming.

Chapter 127: Interlude: The Tomb of Furibon

Somewhere in the New World, Holly Woods' mountain,

Months after the battle of El Dolrado.

Sitting on his throne, in the deepest, darkest room of his dungeon, Furibon was giddy with excitement.

At long last, his contributions had been recognized!

“Hello everyone, welcome to another episode of *Today's Dungeon*,” a tall, bulky red fiend spoke to a floating mirror, transferring the images back to Happyland. “I am your host Pepito, and today, we are going to interview this year *Deadie Awards*’ favorite, the lich archrival of Vainqueur Knightsbane himself... Furibon!”

“Former rival. We forgot one another.” Furibon observed the demon more closely, finding him vaguely familiar. “Weren’t you the announcer in Brandon Maure’s arena?”

“Yes, I lost my job shortly after Vainqueur ate the audience,” the fiend said. “But after six months of despair and homelessness, I bounced back to take the world of monsterbiz by storm!”

Good to see the survivors of Ishfania’s old regime had all turned a new leaf, even Miss Maure. This only confirmed Furibon’s belief that revenge was a pointless waste of time. After all, if he had spent all his time plotting Knightsbane’s demise, he wouldn’t have achieved his dream of building a famous dungeon.

“Mr. Furibon, your dungeon, ‘*The Tomb of Furibon*,’ has been nominated for the *Deadie Awards* in five categories, including ‘*Most Lethal Dungeon*,’ ‘*Best Supporting Miniboss*,’ ‘*Best Dungeon Boss*,’ ‘*Best Dungeon Design*,’ and ‘*Best Dungeon Sound Design*.’ Since this is your first official work, you must feel honored.”

“I am very proud,” Furibon replied. “Especially the best sound design one. My team struggled a lot to put all these rats in the walls. A dungeon is more than a place; it’s an atmosphere. Truth to be told, I intended to participate a year ago with my *Castle of Murmurin*, but...”

“Knightsbane?”

“Knightsbane.” A shame, he had been very proud of his Black Beast miniboss. “It is true that I have become an adventurer, and achieved fame fighting the evil [Toon] monsters inhabiting Holly Woods. But at heart, I will always remain a dungeon hobbyist.”

“Well then, you may have a new chance to pit your passion against Vainqueur Knightsbane! Do you know that he is expected to participate as one of the adventurers’ team, alongside [Paladin] superstar Kia Bekele?”

Furibon chuckled. “Very funny.”

“This is not a joke.”

The lich marked a long pause, as he realized the fiend was serious. “I never thought I would feel empathy for a [Paladin of Mithras],” the lich admitted, after considering the implications. “I hope that she is safe.”

“To showcase his dungeon design, Furibon and his team agreed to give us a full, live demonstration,” the fiend declared, immediately changing the subject. “Let’s meet our contestants.”

“[Furibon’s Scrying Ball],” Furibon cast a spell of his own design, a spectral crystal ball showing the dungeon’s entrance room appearing before him. His teammates had gathered in a great stone hall, separated from the dungeon’s first corridor by a purple energy barrier and a dragon statue.

“Sarat Dillon,” the fiend commentator pointed at black-furred, female beastkin. She carried a bandolier full of bombs, potions, and Monster Poker cards. “A Ratling [Alchemist] [Gambler] whose absurd luck protects her from everything!”

“It’s not luck, it’s fate,” the ratkin protested, the fiend’s voice having carried through the divination mirror. She had served Furibon as his training partner, before the final duel with Knightsbane.

“Marty Orcling, goblin-slayer extraordinaire.” The unofficial leader of the team was a mighty orc, covered by an iron armor and wielding a magical bow. “A [Bowman] [Mercenary], he combines combat effectiveness with a keen tactical mind.”

“Just because my classes have low Intelligence growths, doesn’t mean I’m stupid,” the orc declared.

The fiend then pointed at the fairest member of the group, a pink-haired elf dressed like a belly dancer; her beauty hiding her saber’s deadliness. “Jenny Starflower, half [Bard], one quarter [Fencer], and one quarter [Dancer]. A murder machine who kills evil with style.”

“I’m bi-neutral, so I can go both ways,” the elf replied.

“Finally, Mister Raptor.” The last, a hawk-like member of the team hung on his staff with a defeated expression. “A birdkin [Wizard] and [Priest of Dice], the main reason why his team has survived despite their suicidal urges.”

“Until now,” the birdkin complained with a gloomy voice. “BLEEP you, Furi.”

“I have the [Panacea], I can cure you of almost anything,” Furibon replied calmly. “And you still owe me your life, for that El Dorado mess.”

“Yeah, but I thought we would pay you a vacation or something. Not give you a free torture session!”

“Raptor, you’re exaggerating,” Jenny said. “Sure, Furi is cranky, but he would never go that far.”

“He is right though, the goal of a dungeon is not to have fun,” Furibon whispered to the fiend reporter, low enough that his team wouldn’t hear. “It is to emotionally drain the will of adventurers, to destroy them *physically* and *mentally*. I prefer the old-school approach of crafting every room to heighten the pain.”

“What do you have to say to the new ‘*randomized rogue dungeon*’ movement then?” the demon asked him. “They’ve had a lot of success in recent years, especially against the unpredictable dragon adventurers.”

“They’re hacks! A dungeon is art! Each room must be exquisitely crafted, or else it is not memorable!” The lich did have a trap room summoning random high-level monsters, but it was only a one-time gimmick. “As for dragons, I have found the ultimate defense against their dungeon raids.”

His team was already scouting the barrier, Marty shooting an arrow through, only for the projectile to disintegrate on contact. They turned to examine the dragon statue, noticing a hole in the mouth, and inscriptions written on the jaws.

2500 gold coins per person.

“I make them pay.”

“We have to *pay a fee* to get in?!” Jenny complained.

“Everytime,” Furibon replied through the scrying ball. “And even for a demonstration, I won’t give you free tickets.”

“After everything we’ve been through together?” Sarat complained. “You traitor!”

The entire team loudly protested and tried to find a way through the barrier without paying for it. In vain; only a spellcaster in Furibon’s own league could even hope to get through.

As for the rest of the dungeon, he had it built with the best material. Even dragons couldn't break through it, and the multiple magical defenses canceled favorite tactics such as teleportation, intangibility...

"It's to force them to commit," Furibon explained to the demon, as his team ended up paying the tribute after failing to bypass the barrier. "The problem with adventurers is that they scout dungeons. They go in, kill monsters, get out, heal, and then come back. By inflicting a monetary penalty each time they enter, I force them to commit to finishing the dungeon in one attempt."

It also paid for the dungeon maintenance.

These traps weren't cheap.

Furibon was very proud of his *death course*.

Magically lengthened with spatial magic, this tremendously long hallway was a marvel of engineering. As soon as the team stepped inside, they had triggered the main trap: a rolling boulder launched right behind them. Since the hallway went down into the earth, like the entire dungeon, they quickly found themselves with no way to go but *forward*.

The boulder was made of Starmetal, the most powerful alloy on Outremonde, and completely immune to magic. It couldn't be teleported, moved out, or stopped. It could even crush intangible creatures.

And Furibon had set it on fire with oil.

Of course, the lich wanted his challengers to struggle for their life, so he had booby-trapped the entire hallway too. His poor team was frantically racing through it, trying to dodge spells cast at them by booby-trapped wands hidden in the walls. Lightning bolts, fireballs, acid... the necromancer had spared no expense.

"Oh, I see that someone loves the classics!" the fiend said, as Sarat triggered a hidden hole on the ground and barely hanged to the edge; a trap that could hold a humanoid, but not big enough to stop the boulder. "Is that a snake pit?"

“Somewhat. I have found that snakes in the pits end up eating one another and starving unless they are fed a steady supply of meat.”

“That’s why ancient tombs’ traps tend to degrade, folks, they were never made to last past a hundred years,” the demon told his fiendish audience. “Even Akhenapep, who held the record of awards for a single dungeon with Sablar’s Tower, had to turn his snakes into undead.”

“I thought about undead too, but then my teammate Marty suggested an innovative solution,” Furibon explained, zooming inside the pit, “*Robots.*”

“Robots?”

On a closer look, the pit was full of acid-spewing, mechanical serpents. They hissed at the ratkin, whose orc ally struggled to get her out before the boulder crushed them both.

“Robot snakes, robot sharks, robovermin,” Furibon explained. “All environment-friendly golems that can endure the test of time.”

“So your teammate is trapped between a rock and a hard place?” the fiend laughed, while Furibon wasn’t amused. “So you deny allegations that golem automatization causes job losses?”

“I feel golem automatization completes a dungeon’s workforce instead of replacing it,” Furibon said, although he was thankful for the decreased labor cost.

“Why won’t you die, you stupid sword thing?!” Jenny the elf snarled, as she frantically stabbed a screaming excalitrap. The beast kept Raptor the priest against the ground, while the rest of the team kept two chest mimics at bay.

After wisely ignoring all ‘free supplies’ Furibon had left on their way—all of them poisoned—the group hadn’t been able to resist the lure of a room full of chests. “I am still amazed that adventurers haven’t wised up to this predatory tactic,” the fiend commentator said. “Someone should have developed spells to tell chests from mimic apart by now.”

“It wouldn’t help,” the lich said, loud enough to be heard by his team.
“Every chest in the *first* half of the dungeon is a powerful mimic immune to magical detection.”

“Every chest?” Raptor complained, outraged.

“Every last one, each more powerful than the last,” Furibon replied, before whispering to the fiend commentator. “But the treasure chests in the second half are genuine, and full of powerful treasures.”

“But if challengers have been expecting all chests to be mimics, won’t they ignore them?” the fiend asked, keeping his voice low enough for the team to remain in the dark.

“Exactly. I want them to ignore the genuine treasures, only to feel regret and cry tears of pain when they realize the truth.”

“That is brilliant in its cruelty.”

“A friend has a saying,” the lich said. “They are so doomed, it becomes art.”

By now, the group had managed to kill the mimics, with no loot to show for it. They only earned the key for the next room.

Carefully, wary of traps, Marty the orc opened the nearest lock, and then quickly backed away when the door opened. He raised his bow and aimed at whatever awaited beyond the threshold.

Only to find an innocent duck. The bird looked up at the orc, who frowned in confusion.

Jenny the elf’s eyes widened in horror. “Marty, shoot the duck.”

“What?” the archer asked back, as a sadistic gleam filled the bird’s eyes.

“Shoot the BLEEPing duck!”

The monster quacked and threw itself at the group. Much faster, the archer reacted on instinct and shot the bird dead.

BOOM!

A mighty explosion of flames and feathers threw Marty against the opposite wall, shaking the entire room.

“W-what was that?” Raptor asked, rushing to his ally’s side to heal him.

“A [Suicide Duck]!” Jenny shouted. “They explode on contact as a defense mechanism, inflicting around three hundred [Fire] damage!”

“Wait, they *kill themselves* as a *survival mechanism*?” Sarat asked. “Isn’t that self-defeating?”

“Predators tend to go extinct around them very quickly,” Furibon replied mirthfully.

Jenny sighed. “Marty, just shoot the ducks when you see them.”

Furibon pushed a button on his throne, a wall opening in the treasure chest room.

Dozens of bird eyes looked at the adventurer crew from the shadows, and ominous quacking sounds echoed through the dungeon.

After losing arms and eyes, after suffering wounds and humiliations, the team finally made it to the true treasure room.

A hoard worthy of Knightsbane’s awaited them, a mountain of gold, gems, and magical items, buried in a vault the size of a city district.

But as soon as they entered, the room’s doors locked up behind them. The adventurers prepared themselves for battle, as a mountain of coins shifted and adopted a humanoid shape. The treasure gained arms and legs, to better crush the thieves.

A [Mythical Coin Golem] miniboss.

“[Desperation]!” Marty the orc readied his bow, empowering it with all his might; his arrow became a searing missile of fiery light, hitting the golem at the speed of cannonballs.

Much to Furibon’s astonishment, the arrow pierced through the golem and blew it up in one strike. The projectile continued its course and fragmented the vault’s ceiling upon hitting it.

“I knew Furi would pull off something like this when we reached the hoard,” Marty boasted, as the miniboss collapsed, “so I brought [Artislayer] arrows in bulk.”

“I empowered them with alchemy before we came here,” Sarat added, raising her newly amputated left arm. “See? You’re so predictable, Furi!”

“Well, that’s disappointing,” Furibon admitted. One should never underestimate adventurers. “But you aren’t done yet.”

He clicked on a new mechanism in his throne, the layout of the entire dungeon changing. New areas replaced the old, traps rebuilt themselves, and the death course adopted its *true form*.

“For now, you have to get *out* of the dungeon,” the lich explained. “By braving its second half!”

“I lost an arm, Furi!” Sarat the ratkin complained. “That’s not funny!”

“I said I would cure you, physically and emotionally.” He had even set an enormous bank account—his entire fortune and all winnings from his adventurer days—aside to fund an emergency revival, if needed. Even if Furibon would never admit it... he had grown fond of this group of screwups. “But even if we are f...”

“Friends,” Jenny said. “It’s called being friends, Furi.”

“Yes, yes,” the lich cleared his throat, embarrassed. “Still, I must treat every challenger all the same, for the sake of fairness.”

“In that case...” Raptor the priest brought out a pendant, hidden beneath his robes. “You won’t complain if I use this!”

Furibon froze, upon recognizing the item. “No...”

“An [Amulet of True Recall],” Raptor explained. “It teleports us back to our sanctuary and *ignores* teleportation blocks! It cost me all my money!”

“Oh, could it be that the dungeon master forgot to patch out that one weakness?” the fiend commentator asked.

“I did not anticipate this,” Furibon admitted. The amulet was powerful enough to bypass his own wards. “It won’t change a thing.”

Although his last trick would have a bit less impact.

“Everyone, take everything you can carry, and let’s teleport out,” the priest told his team. “I set the teleport point right before the barrier.”

“Where is my [Bottomless Bag]?” Sarat complained, checking her bandolier.

“I think the ducks blew it up,” Jenny replied icily, grabbing all the gold she could in her arms. The others had brought two bags and filled them to the brim with gold. Having enough of the dungeon, they very much wanted to escape as hastily as possible.

The priest activated the amulet, its power bypassing even Furibon’s mighty magical protections. The group vanished from the treasure room, teleported back to the entrance.

Furibon had his scrying ball follow the group, just as his last trap activated.

“What the...” Raptor’s eyes widened in terror.

Much to the group’s horror, their hard-won gold had lost its luster.

For the second they had crossed the barrier marking the dungeon’s frontier, they had triggered a contingency spell. One last joke, meant to punish

adventurers for their greed and teach them the value of prudence.

In a second, all their gold had turned dark grey.

“Lead.” Marty the orc’s eyes became empty pits of despair. “It’s all lead.”

“The gold turns to lead when taken out of the dungeon,” Furibon said. “The best items in the vault were the unremarkable ones.”

This trick was why he had developed the [Transmute Gold to Lead] spell in the first place.

He had expected the first adventurers to discover this feature to cry. But instead, they stood in silence around their worthless loot, their face white and their gaze devoid of hope. They didn’t make a sound or scream in frustration.

They just *broke*.

“Beautiful.” The fiend nodded to himself. “So what do you reply to scaled people accusing you of lead addiction?”

“I admit that it has become a...” Furibon struggled to find a word, “a guilty pleasure.”

Still, when he looked at his destroyed team, he felt pain in his ribcage. Which said a lot, since he didn’t have a heart left.

“I am treating you all to a trip to Las Vegasnos,” Furibon said through the scrying sphere. “I will pay for your gambling tabs.”

“And you invite us to *Leviathan Sushi*?” Jenny looked up, hopeful.

Furibon sighed. “Yes.”

“Aw, I have tears in my eyes,” the fiend commentator said. “If only for the sake of the camera.”

“I hope you enjoyed this demonstration of passionate dungeon design,” Furibon said. He couldn’t wait to win his first *Deadie Award*.

“Indeed, dear audience, this is the dungeon behemoth that will certainly smash all competition,” the demon said to his mirror, before turning back toward Furibon. “Since we have five minutes before the interview ends, could you could give us your thoughts on the new Dragon-Fomor war?”

Furibon pondered the question, before realizing that he had no idea of what the fiend was talking about. “Excuse me?”

“What do you have to say about Vainqueur Knightsbane’s decision to call a dragon Conclave and burn Prydain to the ground?”

Oh.

Oh, it finally happened.

Furibon’s first instinct was to ignore the matter entirely. Nothing good could come out of associating with Knightsbane and Dalton, even if they had their good times; he would have a lot less headaches by remaining in his own hemisphere, far, far away from Murmurin.

However, he had heard the rumors. That fomors had gained levels and gathered weapons for war. His experience with the Century War had taught him that pointless conflicts led nowhere productive, but he had the feeling that *this time*, things might end differently.

...

Maybe he should look into it, just in case.

Chapter 128: Opening Salvo

This may be the toughest battle Vainqueur had fought yet. While he had the greatest hoard, his enemies were strong, and his minion was weak.

“Zmey!” Vainqueur snarled to Gorynych, who couldn’t decide which Monster Poker card to play. “What are you waiting for?!”

“Gorynych is anxious,” the zmey replied, his field empty of any defense to protect his last coin against an army of vicious [Carrot Warriors].

“Gorynych hates vegetables!”

“You can do it!” Noirceur the Nightmare Horse encouraged the three-headed inbred dragon. “Use your heads!”

The zmey hesitated, before clumsily playing a minion. “I summon the cutest [Black Rabbit], level 5!”

The illusion of a mighty, horned rabbit appeared on the field; after the final battle against the *Forgotten One*, Vainqueur had decided to employ a [Illusionist] dwarf minion to animate his duels full time. Kobolds screamed in fear at the sight of the vicious beast, doubly so when it devoured a [Carrot Warrior] thanks to its special ability.

“By eating a [Plant] minion, [Black Rabbit] calls help!” Gorynych said, a [White Rabbit of Inaba] appearing on the field. “Level 10!”

“My [Pumpkin King] is stronger!” Jack the fairy boasted ingloriously, his crowned pumpkin servant letting out a maniacal laugh. “I have fed him with [Strength Candy Bars]!”

“Rolo will turn these rabbits into sheep next turn,” his golem partner added.

Vainqueur refused to admit defeat, and especially not against a tinfoil-fairy duo, but he had to admit the situation was dire. Tinfoil Rolo's [Farmland] field allowed him to summon [Vegetable] monsters each turn, which Jack's [Pumpkin King] empowered. While nothing impressive, their overwhelming numbers of [Carrot Warriors] were a strength in themselves.

If Vainqueur could draw his [Best Dragon's Breath] spell and incinerate the field...

Scrying attempt negated by [**Malefic Secrecy**].

"Are you trying to read my cards?!" Vainqueur glared at Jack. He knew he couldn't trust a fomor to play fair!

"Jack never cheats," the fairy protested. "His word to behave once given, he never breaks."

"Hm, not that it will change anything," the dragon replied, secure in his superiority. He then turned towards the minion in charge of drawing and holding his cards, while the audience cheered him up. "I have faith in my deck! Draw—"

Vainqueur stopped, as he sensed hostility and lightning in the air.

He glanced at the source on his left, to see King Wotan and Grandrake glaring at one another.

"Finally, Grandrake." The fomor lord readied his spear, his Valkyries flying around him like a minion escort. "How long have I waited for this moment."

Grandrake remained silent, while Vainqueur readied himself to intervene, even after his minion drew his winning card.

"You bested me once, and took my eye," Wotan declared, pointing at his scar with the tip of his spear. "For centuries, the fires of revenge nursed my wrath. I have prepared, and trained, and sharpened my skills until I could

grow powerful enough to avenge myself. The day of reckoning has come. An eye for an eye.”

“Excuse you,” Grandrake finally spoke up with a frown. “Who are you?”

A short silence followed.

“You do not remember me,” King Wotan said, his anger replaced by disappointment.

“I should?” the dragon asked, confused.

“You took my eye when I tried to rescue Princess Titania from your den.”

Grandrake observed Wotan more closely, trying to recognize him.

He didn’t.

“After the first ten, you fairy knights all started blurring together,” Grandrake admitted.

The fomor king’s face remained a stone mask, but he could hardly hide his disappointment. Clearly, Wotan had put more effort into this rivalry than Grandrake, who had crushed the fomor and then promptly forgot about it.

“So wyrmlike,” Vainqueur said in admiration. Truly, forgetting your enemies was the best way to defeat them.

“I am King Wotan,” the fomor insisted. “Ruler of Asgard and Laponia.”

“Wot-Ah!” Grandrake nodded upon finally remembering Dragonbane. “You were that adorable child I slapped that time! My, you have grown into a fine knight!”

“Your Majesty?” A Valkyrie looked at her speechless creator. “Do we attack?”

“This meeting feels much less satisfying than I thought it would,” the fomor king admitted, clearly confused about how to proceed.

“I would be delighted to slap you again, but I have to find Breeder Dalton,” Grandrake replied, quickly dismissing the fomor in the face of much more important concerns. “The fate of countless princesses depends on him.”

“I cannot allow you to monopolize my chief of staff, Grandrake,” Vainqueur interrupted his fellow environmentalist. “While I am mindful of princess preservation, Friend Victor is already very distraught about his current litter. He already overbred once, I will not have him do so again.”

“I understand, Vainqueur, but can you imagine a world without elf princesses? The survival of the species trumps the desires of one minion!”

“Maybe,” Vainqueur conceded. “But Friend Victor is not any minion. He will reproduce when he feels like it.”

“Thanks, Your Majesty!” Manling Victor’s voice echoed in the minion crowd, although Vainqueur couldn’t pinpoint his location.

“You shall ignore me no longer, wyrm,” King Wotan thundered, raising his [Gungnir] at Grandrake’s throat. “I demand retribution. I challenge you to a duel to the death.”

“I will tolerate no such thing,” Vainqueur replied icily. “But if you want to settle this, I will gladly arbiter your dispute. You will duel the civilized way.”

“A minion battle?” Grandrake asked, hopeful. “It has been eons since I had one!”

“I meant something more epic,” Vainqueur replied, before glancing at his own Monster Poker battle.

While wise, his visionary proposal was met with denial and obscurantism. “No,” Wotan said. “This is ridiculous. I am not settling a grudge over a card game.”

“A card *battle*,” Vainqueur insisted. “And *I* did. I made peace with the Forgotten One, the most evil creature to ever walk Outremonde, in an epic

Monster Poker match for the fate of the world.”

Vainqueur’s hoard was his world, after all.

“I am not playing a game,” Wotan replied haughtily. “I am a warrior.”

“If you are afraid to lose, you can simply admit it,” Vainqueur replied. “No one will mock you mercilessly, except me.”

Charisma check successful!

By passing the 150 charisma benchmark thanks to your items, you gained four stalkers!

“King Wotan fears nothing,” the fomor lord replied, minions swooning at Vainqueur’s cunning trick. “But I shall not settle a grudge over a game of chance.”

“Monster Poker is no game of chance!” Vainqueur replied, defending his new hobby. “It is a game of strategy, cunning, guts, and glory! Only square rooted intellects can comprehend its depth!”

However passionate his words, King Wotan remained doubtful. However, he wisely remained true to his word not to cause trouble in Murmurin. “I shall agree to an honorable trial by champion,” the fomor finally told Grandrake. “My Valkyries against your servants.”

“Ah, finally a civilized fairy.” The wyrm nodded. “I will bring my anti-knight defense force. They have been trained to fight false princesses, this will be a good test of their abilities.”

Scrying attempt negated by [**Malefic Secrecy**].

Vainqueur snorted as he returned to his Monster Poker party, wondering who could possibly try to spy on him right now.

Wow, crisis averted! And for once, Victor didn’t have to play mediator.

The Vizier found it rather relieving, standing on the roof of a house while still invisible. Although he would remain incognito until the festivities ended, he allowed himself a moment of rest.

Scrying attempt negated by [**Mini-Circlet against Greater Divinations**].

Goddammit, had Grandrake taken levels in a divination-oriented spellcasting class?

Speaking of spellcasting, now that he had access to Tier IX, there was a spell he had been dying to try out for a long while.

“[*Za Warudo*]!”

Time stopped.

To Victor, the world appeared covered by a purple lens, muting every color. Sound abruptly vanished, people stopped moving, and Vainqueur never finished playing his card.

“Nice,” Victor said. “I could cast a few spells in the—”

Time resumed, the world returning to normal.

Victor hung to his scythe in disappointment. The spell actually lasted ten seconds, instead of stretching much longer.

“Vic! Vic!”

Kia’s voice calling him from below. Victor looked down, to find his [Paladin] friend below, drunk, bloodied, and looking like a mess. “Wait, you can see me?”

“I could hear you scream your spell’s name, dummy!” she replied clearly drunk as Happyland. With strength and skill he wouldn’t expect from someone in her state, the knight quickly climbed the house to join him. She extended her hand, touching his face. “Here you are!”

“That’s my nos—” Victor complained before she accidentally put her finger in his eye. “Hey!”

“Sorry!” Kia apologized, sitting next to him while managing to grab his shoulder. “Why are you hiding from me?”

“I’m not hiding from you, I’m hiding from everyone,” he replied. “I just wanted some quiet.”

“Quiet is for people who don’t have fun!” Well, her current state broke the picture of a perfect Paladin she usually projected, but at least she seemed to enjoy herself. “Vic, I, I got the level! I got the level and I can taste the beer! Punched that minotaur and that giant squid to kingdom come, it did the trick!”

“That’s great,” he replied, although he worried about her hangover. “Just don’t insult Seng again.”

“I knew who she was deep down, but I hated it!” Kia blurted out, putting an arm around his shoulder. It reminded him of his old university parties when his fellows ended up so drunk that they started rambling random shit at him. “I hated it because when I looked at Seng, I saw myself!”

Realizing that she would drunkenly confess him all her sins—and not leave him alone—Victor sighed and patted her on the back. “It’s okay, Kia. It’s okay.”

“Vic, I’m just saying, I, I know one day we’re going to fight, and it’s going to be glorious, but I’ll be sad too. Because I’m having fun hanging out with you and Vainquy? Can I call him Vainquy?”

“No, you can’t, and I don’t want to fight you.”

“Vic, you’re my Sasuke,” she told him with what could pass for a straight face. “I’m Naruto, and you’re going to be my Sasuke. We’re going to fight and then I will beat you, then you will be redeemed.”

What the Happyland? Was that how she felt deep down? “Beating up someone into agreeing with you is not redemption,” he protested, “That’s bullying!”

“I was afraid when my boyfriend drove our car into a car too,” she replied, apparently not really listening to him. “But I kept thinking, and I realized it was not a car, but a *truck*. Did he drive into the truck, or did the truck attack us? Now I know the truth, Vic. I know the *truth*.”

“That trucks are out to kill us?” Victor joked. He remembered Allison mentioning that one of them had killed her under embarrassing circumstances, sending her to Outremonde.

“Not trucks, Vic!” Kia replied, her eyes so feverish that she looked possessed. “*The* truck! It’s always the same truck! It’s a conspiracy-driven truck that sends people to other worlds! I kept warning Kevin, but he never believed me!”

Victor chuckled.

But doubt crept into his heart, so he tried to remember how he died.

He had been shanked in an alley trying to protect a girl from being mugged, that was certain. However, Victor struggled to make sense of the memories that followed; people gathering around his body as he bled to death while half-delirious; the sound of an ambulance carrying him away to the hospital; the feeling of a deadly crash sending his body flying, and headlights rushing at him to—

...

“We were all killed by the same *truck*?” he shouted, causing a few people to look up at the roof. Since only Kia was visible, they probably thought that she had lost her mind.

“It’s Truck-kun,” Kia blurted out. “It’s a serial killer car, Vic. A serial killer car!”

Thing is, at this point in his life, it wouldn't surprise Victor much. "Still, I'm not going to fight you," he replied. "I'm not a saint, I admit it, but can't I just confess my sins to you and then get right back at it, like a civilized person?"

"That's not the [Paladin] way," she replied. "I would love to have an on-and-off switch though. Not the good part, the lawful one."

"Isn't there a flexible good class equivalent?" Victor suggested. "Then again, so far, Mithras hasn't punished you for associating with us."

"Yeah, I asked him. He considers you guys a necessary evil, and since it makes me happy he's giving me some leeway. He's horribly blunt, but he's pretty nice. You know Gardemagne wants to help against Prydain?"

"Really?" Victor's head perked up. "How do you know that?"

"Kevin sent me a message. Mithras wants a new crusade, and King Roland wants to stop the Wild Hunts." She put a hand on her face, before regaining her bearing. "We really need that [Plot Armor] Vic. We need it extra thick."

"We'll tackle the dungeon contest when we have the time," he promised, letting out a yawn. "Damn, I want to sleep. Today was exhausting."

"Huh?" Kia said with a frown, "I got a screen. Somebody tried to scry me."

"Somebody is trying to scry on the both of us?" Victor realized. Who could

Intelligence check successful.

The fomors. It could only be the fomors, but why? Why did they want to know their location?

"Hey, look!" Kia pointed at the sky. "There's a new star up there!"

The Vizier glanced above him, watching a greenish, fiery falling star making its way from the west.

“What the Happyland is this?” Victor wondered as the star seemed to get closer and closer, aiming for Vainqueur’s castle on Mount Murmurin. They weren't the only ones to notice this phenomenon. Wotan and Grandrake, who oversaw a fight between a Valkyrie and a kobold, both glanced up at it; the fomor seemingly more bothered than the wyrm. Even Vainqueur interrupted his victory dance over his latest card battle to look up.

Luck check—

“Vic, get down!” Kia screamed while forcing his face against the roof, her reflexes taking over. The shining star hit the north side of the mountain, the one opposite of Murmurin.

The flash that followed was *blinding*.

The earth shook, a brutal shockwave spread through the air, and the city's windows all exploded at once. To Vic, it seemed that the entire country *trembled*. Minions screamed at the sudden explosion, although the mountain protected the city from the blast; even Vainqueur was shaken by the mighty explosion, although he hung on. Wotan looked at the impact point with a shocked face, his lone eye widening in surprise.

Victor himself could only watch in terror, as the night sky turned ablaze.

A gigantic, mushroom-shaped mass of fire erupted behind Mount Murmurin, a dire warning of things to come.

Chapter 129: Retaliations

His castle! His beautiful castle!

As he flew high in the skies with Gorynych after him, Vainqueur's heart was filled with concern. Concern for his beautiful, hard-won lair, the elite minions staffing it, and his marvelous hoard in the vaults. Not necessarily in that order.

Thankfully, as he passed over the mountain's summit, he found his castle unscathed, shielded by a crimson barrier. The same protection which once safeguarded the *Forgotten One* from the dragon's wrath, had now saved the hoard.

He couldn't say the same for the rest of the mountain, though.

The explosion had caused an entire pan of it to collapse, letting lava fall off the mountain and towards the sea nearby. The ground glowed with a green light and molten powerstone shards, while the air was choked with dust that itched in the eyes. The weapon had left a glaring hole in the mountain where it hit, one big enough that it could have certainly covered all of Murmurin had it hit the city.

Even if the weapon had missed, it had unleashed tons of poisoned smoke in the atmosphere. "[Control Weather: Clear Skies]," Manling Victor cast while on Gorynych's back, dispersing them harmlessly before a venomous cloud could consume Murmurin.

As his minion handled the weather, Vainqueur dived down, to see the devastation up close.

You are entering a [**Tchernobyl**] field. [**Fire**], [**Nuclear**], [**Earth**] and [**Poison**] attacks will be greatly strengthened.

Non-[Undead], [Eldritch], [Alien], [Insect], [Elemental] and [Artificial] types will lose 10 max HP per minute, unless they are protected against [Nuclear].

Vitality check successful. [Irradiated] ailment negated.

He would have to use his [Geomancy] to change this field, once his magic finally stabilized. However, the sheer destructive power of the blast left him speechless. This was no *Wind Spear* of Brandon Maure or even Wotan's mighty [Ragnarok]. It would have taken Vainqueur at least a minute of uninterrupted carpet bombing to cause that much damage.

This falling star had done it in the blink of an eye.

"They have nukes," Manling Victor whispered to himself while riding Gorynych, deeply afraid even with Knight Kia at his back. "The arrows of light."

"They have missiles," Knight Kia added with a frown. "Any idea from where they launched it?"

"They used powerstones to propel that missile," Manling Victor said, pointing at the fragments littering the mountainscape. "Our spellcasters tracked the magic from its origin point. Prydain."

Of course, the cowardly fairies had cheap-shot his castle while safe from retaliation. *Not for long*, Vainqueur promised himself, *not for long*.

"Some ICBMs can hit targets more than ten thousand kilometers away," Knight Kia said, although Vainqueur didn't fully understand everything. "Why didn't they simply open a portal in Murmurin and drop the bomb?"

"Well, we invested in—" Manling Victor caught himself, as Vainqueur glanced at him, "I had the Agarthans and Happyland set-up anti-hostile teleportation defenses in the V&V Empire's cities and their larger region. They zap any attempt to open a portal from unauthorized minions or V&V members. We also set-up anti-air defenses, but clearly the missile moved too fast for them to shoot it down."

“Wise thinking, Manling Victor,” Vainqueur congratulated his chief of staff, before trying to figure out what happened.

Intelligence check successful.

“They were targeting me,” Vainqueur realized, making sense out of the chain of events. “But they missed.”

“Maybe they have the nukes, but not the infrastructures that allow them to hit targets with deadly precision,” Manling Victor said. “They don’t have GPS, maps, knowledge of the terrain...”

“You think that’s why they tried to scry on us?” Knight Kia muttered. “To pinpoint our location?”

“I believe they tried to scry His Majesty first because they wanted him dead, personally,” Friend Victor explained to his fellow manling. “Then they tried to target me since I’m always at Vainqueur’s side. When they couldn’t locate me, they attempted to locate you, Kia, and when *that* failed, they lost patience and launched the bomb at Murmurin’s rough location.”

“Why use powerstones though? If they have a nuke, they should have the whole rocket package.”

“Well, either they have ICBMs but didn’t realize how to use them, and so switched the warhead to a copy of Maure’s *Wind Spears*, or...”

“Or?”

“Or they’re trying to make their own nukes, and this was a test run.”

The [Paladin] marked a short silence, before finally speaking up. “I’m going to Gardemagne to request an invasion fleet and pull back my old party *right now*. If the fomors develop a nuclear arsenal, the entire continent is at risk. No country will be safe from a bombardment.”

“The castle’s shield managed to protect it from the blast,” Manling Victor said. “Maybe he could design a city-wide version?”

“Yes, find him,” Vainqueur finally spoke up, although he loathed to say these words.

His words shocked even his truest friend. “Your Majesty, did you agree to *ask Furibon for help?*”

“I hate it as much as you do, Manling Victor,” Vainqueur replied with grim seriousness. “But if he can protect my subjects from these arrows, then my minions’ safety takes precedent.”

His decision hammered it home to his best minion.

These were no ordinary times.

This was *war*, and anything went.

Even summoning the Forgotten One.

After the disaster, Murmurin’s population was most shaken. Vainqueur decided that he would calm them with a speech, but first, he summoned all his elite minions and allies to his hoard. His war council had gathered to discuss the threat, with guests such as Grandrake invited to offer their opinion.

“I understand now why you called for a Conclave, young Vainqueur,” the elder dragon said with a frown. It was rare to see him bothered by anything. “Never before have I seen such destructive power outside of a wyrm flight, and I was awake before those manling gods walked this dragon-made world.”

“Then you will support my cause?” Vainqueur asked. Many dragons respected Grandrake as a wise elder and the forerunner of princess hunting.

“I shall.” Grandrake nodded. “You can also count on my support in the war to come, young king.”

“We cannot wait for the Conclave,” Knight Kia spoke up. “We have to attack Prydain *now*.”

“The sooner we land on Prydain’s shores, the better,” Marbré the Dwarf agreed. “The fairies aren’t stupid enough to bomb their own home.”

Tasty Malfy cleared his own throat, dubious. “I am torn. On one hand, our assets are completely exposed to financial ruin, but on the other hand, I expect a market crash if we attack the shores without additional support.”

“I will call a class reunion,” Isabelle Maure suggested, standing next to an armored Manling Victor. “I am certain they will share in the conquest.”

“Yes, most of my class wants to rule the world, not burn it,” Manling Victor said. “Jaja and Goblina already agreed to help.”

“How reassuring,” Knight Kia replied with a frown. “But I stand by what I said. We need Gardemagne, and I can have them mobilize. If we attack from multiple fronts, the fomors won’t be able to deploy their weapons and blow us to sky high.”

“That’s just a hypothesis,” Untasty Allison countered. “We need a surer method to counter the bombs.”

Intelligence check successful.

“We have two,” Vainqueur declared, bringing their attention where it belonged, on himself, “Manling Victor can alter the weather to send their arrows away, while I can shoot them down with my breath.”

“That could work, but Murmurin will remain unprotected while you are away, Your Majesty,” Corpseling Jules said.

“Minions that cannot fight or contribute to the war effort will be evacuated to the Planet Moon,” Vainqueur declared. “That is a place so dark, not even the fairies will dare attack it.”

“True, even missiles shouldn’t be able to reach it,” Untasty Allison said, “or at least I hope they can’t?”

“The [Tchernobyl] field will remain there for the fashionably early dragon guests, so they may see for themselves the fairies’ newfound threat,”

Vainqueur declared, now in general mode. “Until the Conclave is done and I wipe it out with my [Geomancy], the area shall be condemned. Manling Victor will make sure the smoke does not contaminate the area.”

“It will be done.” Manling Victor nodded. “Your Majesty, how many dragons could we expect to help, if the Conclave goes well?”

“All ten tenth,” Grandrake replied, much to everyone’s confusion.

“Minion Victor, we dragons are voracious creatures,” Vainqueur explained. “We need many cows and fat to remain in top shape. Unfortunately, this world is too small to sustain all of us, so in our genius, we figured out a solution. We hibernate for centuries, often millennia.”

“I see.” Corpseling Jules nodded. “That way the prey population can return to a sustainable level. But considering Your Majesty’s appetite...”

“Only one-tenth of our race is active at a given time,” Vainqueur confirmed. “The Conclave is the moment when awake dragons gather to vote on waking up the sleeping other nine-tenth, for the purpose of war. We sing the Elder Wyrms’ song, and our entire race moves to destroy its enemies.”

"Such as the Gold-Eating Insects," Grandrake added. "May their evil never taint Outremonde again."

“But if only one-tenth of all dragons are active that means at least...”
Manling Victor tried to calculate the numbers. “Dozens of thousands?”

“Enough to wipe out Prydain from the map,” Vainqueur confirmed.
“Arrows of light or not.”

The rest of the discussion focused on methods to protect Murmurin, evacuating civilians in anticipation of an attack; either to the cursed Moon or to the underground realm of Agartha as Marbré proposed. Having expected an assault for months, Vainqueur’s army was prepared to deal with anything.

They wouldn't let the fairies win the war, whether on the ground or in their hearts.

Finally, Vainqueur ordered his minion fleet to prepare for a landing in the coming days. Knight Kia would return to Gardemagne to call upon her kind's help, while the V&V Empire would summon all its allies to join the invasion force.

"Anything else?" Vainqueur asked, as he prepared to dismiss his council before reassuring his population.

"Yes," Manling Victor said. "King Wotan is still waiting outside. I think he has reached a decision."

About time.

Vainqueur teleported out of the castle with his minion, finding Dragonbane on one of the castle's towers with a Valkyrie on his shoulder. The fomor observed the devastated mountainside with contempt.

"An almighty arrow that can hit targets from afar while the user remains safe from any counterattack." Wotan shook his head. "This is a cowardly weapon, unfit for warriors."

"It's used as a deterrent in my world," Manling Victor said. "A weapon so destructive, that the threat of it enforces peace."

"Clearly Odieuse does not deal in *threats*," the fomor lord said.

"And it bothers you, Dragonbane?" Vainqueur guessed. "My proposal still stands."

His former rival crossed his arms, thoughtful. "I will not be able to transport you to the Mell Clan's stronghold in Prydain without bringing the full force of my kind upon your head," he said. "But there is a place where I can fulfill my oath."

Vainqueur remained still, like his chief of staff.

“The Mell Clan has a doorway to this world you call ‘Earth’,” King Wotan explained. “They used it to capture slaves and thralls when Mag Mell had not yet been exiled for creating the System. His daughter recovered it decades ago. I can lead you there and lure the fairy queen to a fight.”

“Where is the door?” Manling Victor asked immediately.

“In the Dark Forest, in an area between the Winter Kingdoms and this Tsaria country. I can open a fairy ring to it. Afterward...” The fomor lord shook his head. “I shall not take arms against my own kind, but if you hold true to your promise to limit your vengeance to the Mell Clan, I shall not stop you either.”

“Your Majesty, we need to condemn this gate before they can pull more weapons through,” Manling Victor told his dragon master.

“This is the gate to your homeworld, minion,” Vainqueur pointed out. “Maybe the only one. Are you truly sure that you wish to close it forever?”

“My home is at your side,” his friend replied, warming the dragon’s heart. “My family has probably moved on by now. And I will sleep more soundly knowing Odieuse won’t be able to threaten them.”

“So long as she lives, the gate can be rebuilt,” King Wotan coldly pointed out.

“You’re not helping.”

“When?” Vainqueur rasped.

“The sooner I am done with this pointless struggle, the better.”

“You will not be able to remain neutral forever,” Vainqueur replied, having gained some insight into his new mortal enemy. “The vile Odieuse only has thralls or foes. If you do not serve her, she will kill you.”

Charisma check successful.

In spite of the message, King Wotan remained stone-faced. “Maybe she will try,” he admitted. “But she remains my kin still.”

Species first. Vainqueur didn't know how to feel about this.

“Manling Victor, prepare yourself,” the dragon said. “We teleport to this gate as soon as I finish my speech.”

The fairies had attacked his realm for too long.

Time to give them a taste of their own medicine.

Chapter 130: Nova Tactics

“[Elemental Burst],” Manling Victor cast spells on his master with his scythe, geared up for war, “[Veran’s Acid Mantle], [Delayed Hasten]...”

Your **[Fire]**, **[Water]**, **[Earth]**, and **[Wind]** attacks will be greatly strengthened for half an hour. You will receive the benefits of a **[Hasten]** spell within ten minutes. You gained immunity to **[Acid]** for one hour and will inflict **[Acid]** damage on physical contact.

“Are you done?” King Wotan asked, surrounded by his Valkyrie flock. He had been watching Vainqueur and his minions buffing themselves for almost half an hour.

“Soon,” Vainqueur replied after Manling Victor cast his final spell, checking on his new potential class combination.

[Fisher King]: The legendary incarnation of a nation, its people, its land, its joys, and sorrows. Specialties: Monster Creation, Geomancy magic, and Leadership. Major growths in HP, SP, Vitality, and Charisma. Perks affected: **[Monster Husbandry]**.

Good. If it had affected prized Perks like [Geomancy], he would have refused the fusion. Vainqueur gave his blessing to this combination, having the feeling that it would be his last class upgrade.

Choice registered. Your **[Dungeon Breeder]** and **[Geomancer]** fused into **[Fisher King]**.

[Monster Husbandry] changed to **[Genius Loci]**. **[Genius Loci]**: You are intimately familiar with the region you rule, allowing you to intuitively sense disasters befalling it. Additionally, all your stats are raised by one stage when you fight within your nation’s borders.

“You’re sure you don’t want to go warn Gardemagne first?” Manling Victor asked Knight Kia, who had insisted on joining the battle.

“I want to see this gate for myself,” the [Paladin] replied, finishing activating her own Perks. “And if Odieuse is there, you will need all the help you can get. You all remember the ambush raid strategy? Is everyone immune to fire and acid?”

Vainqueur nodded. After the last disastrous battle with Odieuse, his minions had developed a strategy to corner the fairies and prevent them from escaping. Trap the enemy, change the field, go straight for the commander. Manling Victor’s mightiest spell would signal the beginning of the attack.

This time, no more playing around.

“You ride Gorynych, I ride Noirceur,” Manling Victor said while mounting his nightmare horse. “I switched my [Black Horseman]’s mounts, tested the potential synergies with Your Majesty’s [Rabbit Plague], and I forewarned everyone with [Scarlet Study]. They’re ready.”

“Aww, but Gorynych wanted to show master his new [Ranger] perks,” the Zmey complained, as the [Paladin] climbed on his back. “Kia is nice, but she is not master!”

Vainqueur was somewhat happy that his chief of staff had seen the unnatural error in trying to ride a Zmey, but clearly Knight Kia would remain knee-deep in sin. “Open the gate, Dragonbane,” Vainqueur all but ordered the fomor lord, before drawing upon the power of the land. “[Nature Wonder].”

His body brightened, as natural energy moved from the soil to his limbs.

All your stats have been raised by two stages. Your [**Unstable Magic**] condition has been fully lifted.

“I take no orders from anyone,” Wotan replied, but did open a giant-sized fairy ring, large enough for the group. “Move forward, Knightsbane. I will close the march.”

Vainqueur went first, preparing himself to unleash a torrent of dragonfire at the first sign of attack, while Manling Victor and Knight Kia followed on their respective mounts. King Wotan and his servants went last.

In an instant, the dragon left the borders of his empire, for the heart of the Dark Forest.

Even under the morning sun, the area felt gloomy and darkened, the foliage so dense that even sunlight struggled to break through. The grass beneath his claws was poisonous weeds, and red-eyed, carnivorous trees glared at the manlings present with hunger. However, Vainqueur's mere presence caused them to subtly back away in fear.

Before them stood a throne of blackened wood and thorns, which smelled of the vile, half-Furibon fairy, and enormous gates of stone. Vainqueur immediately recognized them as fomorian design and Mag Mell's vile work.

As he closed the march with his own soldiers, King Wotan closed the fairy ring behind him. He then hit the ground with his spear, a thunderous sound echoing across the forest. Birds flew in all directions, and the woods turned eerily silent.

A new fairy ring opened in front of the group, a pied piper made of wood stepping through, backed by two metal giants. The two machines immediately reminded Vainqueur of the tinfoil golem he had scrapped in the Winter Kingdoms. These ones, however, were streamlined, nimble metal knights with wings, swords of light, and cannon shields. The fairies had painted them with silver and gold as if to mock the very essence of a hoard; each machine could match Vainqueur himself in size.

As for the piper, the emperor would recognize this dragon-killer anywhere.

Mell Lin.

Mell "Hamelin" Lin

Soulcrested Fomor (Fairy/Plant)

Level: 50 (Eldritch Piper 25/Necromancer 15/Verminlord 10)

Strong against: All status ailments, Critical Hits, Necromancy, Sound, Disease, Fairy, Plant, Darkness, Poison, Insta-death, Physical attacks.

Weak against: Fairyslayer, Plantslayer, Dragon, Fire, Starmetal.

The vicious and cowardly Piper of Hamelin, brother of Mell Odieuse, and the source of the fairy plague scourging the continent. His music can raise the dead, unleash plagues, and summon monsters; tried to have both you and Vainqueur assassinated on dozens of occasions, and now keenly aware that his much more dangerous sister's patience with his failures is running out. What this bad seed lacks in bravery, he more than makes up in cunning and weediness.

Get it? Bad seed, weediness? Because he's half [Plant]!

A [Bard] promotion with some nasty [Performances], good spellcasting, summoning capabilities... but easily exploitable vulnerabilities. Victor frowned, however, as his gaze turned to the golems next. As he had worried, the last one had been a mere prototype. How many could the fomors field?

"Where is Odieuse?" Wotan asked, glancing down at the monstrous piper with contempt.

"She is busy planning the lesser races' annihilation, and sent me instead to take your tribute." The pied piper glared at Vainqueur. "Why is he still alive? Don't tell me that you wish to kill him before my eyes, the *warrior way*?"

"Odieuse asked that I bring his head to her. Since you represent her, I did."

The pied piper seemed truly shocked by this response, as if the idea of Wotan turning against him was *unthinkable*. "You betrayed the master race?"

"I did not betray myself," Wotan replied with aloof disdain. "I fulfilled my oath."

“Then you know the consequences.” The piper glared at Wotan, the atmosphere even tenser than before. “Your kingdom will burn for this. Only if you kill them *now*, will my sister overlook this treachery.”

“I welcome her challenge,” the fomor lord replied, unconcerned, before opening a portal of his own. “But I do not believe you will live long enough to threaten me. War does beget war. Let us return to Asgard, my Valkyries.”

The shieldmaidens nodded, most of them crossing the portal. “Farewell, Knightsbane,” Wotan said, a last nod at Vainqueur.

The dragon grumbled but returned the gesture. The fomor lord vanished and collapsed the fairy ring behind, leaving the two groups to stare at one another.

“I do not understand him,” the pied piper said, “Why court death for principles? Even with a soul, this is beyond me.”

And to punctuate his words, he immediately attempted to open a fairy ring and escape.

“[Glitzy Theater]!” Vainqueur snarled, an immense cage of golden energy covering most of the forest like a dome.

Bump.

Mell Lin hit his face against his own portal, unable to cross it. He touched it with his hand, before suddenly realizing that [Glitzy Theater] prevented him from running away. “Oh,” he said, before turning to face the group. “You truly wish to fight good ol’ Hamelin?”

“You say this as if we should be afraid of a battle,” Vainqueur taunted him. “You, cowardly rat, spent years trying to avoid one.”

“Maybe, but you know what they say Knightsbane.” Mell Lin brought out his pipe to his lips, ready to play a melody. “A cornered rat will bite a cat. I thought our friendly warning last night would have taught you that.”

“Not only do you threaten entire nations with bombs best left in storage, but you are the source of the plague scouring the continent,” Kia realized, her gaze turning to hard steel. “You are not going anywhere.”

“The plague... one of my best ideas, won’t you agree? I wonder how many tears were shed this year.”

The knight raised her sword, only for the two golems to shield the fomor, the atmosphere growing even more electric. Victor quickly scanned them.

Talos Titan

Advanced Talos Golem (Artificial/Fairy)

Strengths and weaknesses variable (depends on [**Barrier Change**]).

The finalized version of the Talos golem, Mell Odieuse’s chosen soldiers and instruments of destruction. These relentless automatons have their souls and free-will suppressed because of Odieuse’s trust issues. These killing machines can inflict [Dragonslayer] damage, shift their weaknesses to adapt to any current threat, fly, and are equipped with magically-enhanced Earth weaponry.

You aren’t dealing with the average mooks anymore.

“Your Majesty, they’re even more powerful than the one we fought in the Winter Kingdoms,” Victor warned Vainqueur. While the plan called for them to target the piper first and they had gained forty or so levels since they fought the prototype, these two golems couldn’t be underestimated.

“Golems designed to kill, well, everything,” Mell Lin mused. “But mostly dragons. We have thousands of them waiting in Prydain.”

“A million of them would not protect you from me,” Vainqueur warned, more focused than Victor had ever seen him. Yet both groups maintained a tense stand-off, unsure who would make the first move.

“If we fight here, the Earthgate will not survive.” The piper channeled magic through his fingers. “Watch what you’re missing out on.”

While Victor raised his scythe and almost gave away the signal, the giant stone gates slowly opened.

Instead of showing the rest of the dark forest behind, the area beyond the threshold was awfully familiar, Victor having seen it in pictures. A vast touristic landscape under a grey sky, covered by a circle of huge, druidic stones. The vision flickered in and out of existence, as if the world beyond the portal was a mere illusion.

“Stonehenge,” Knight Kia said, just as astonished as Victor himself.

“You came from this place, didn’t you?” Mell Lin asked. “You can return. Your loved ones are waiting for you on the other side.”

“I only see a circle of stones,” Manling Victor deadpanned. “I had a course on [Evil Temptation] you know, you get passing grades.”

“Are you sure, manling?”

The picture of Stonehenge shifted, the open field of nature replaced with a familiar apartment.

Victor’s eyes snapped wide open, as a familiar couple of humans came into sight. After almost a decade spent in Outremonde, both in and out of Scholomance, he had almost forgotten how they looked. The long brown hair and that motherly face, turning strict whenever she pushed him to study; this stern-looking man whose *Uncle Ben-like* lessons his son had always pretended to hear, without ever following them.

They were cooking the same way they always did, as if he had never left.

“Mom?” Victor blurted out. “Dad?”

“You see, I have been researching both of you, Bekele, Dalton. While opening the gate is draining, we can see anything through just fine.” Hamelin gave them a nasty smirk. “And I know where your families live.”

Mell Lin waved his hand, and the portal split in two, a second vision coexisting with a reminder of Victor’s own life. Kia froze, as a Morgan

Freeman lookalike appeared beyond the portal, teaching a five years old child how to fish.

“Your mother died of grief, Bekele,” Mell Lin taunted the [Paladin]. “She blamed herself for your death. Because she let you date that stupid boy. As for your father, your death took something that never came back. Look at him, struggling to fill the void with a new family, a new child... don’t you feel sad watching this?”

“Shut up,” Kia replied, her hold over her sword tightening dangerously. “You think you can scare us by threatening them?”

“Oh, far from it. No, I reveal this to you as a peace offering. If you let me go without a fight, I will open the door for you and let you join them. Not a bad deal, eh?”

“Do not listen to his lies, minions,” Vainqueur said, tensing like a leopard ready to pounce on its prey, but still waiting for Victor’s signal. “His promises are naught but cruel jests.”

“I am genuine in my kindness,” Mell Lin argued with a soft, honeyed tone. “Why won’t you return to a pointless, normal life and leave us Outremonde natives to fight our own wars? Walk away. Return to your loved ones.”

Victor instantly noticed something odd in the fairy’s wording.

Intelligence check successful.

“You said normal life,” the [Reaper] said, guessing what he meant. “The System doesn’t fully work on the other side. We are powerless there.”

“You overestimate yourselves,” Mell Lin mocked them, toying with his pipe. “You are always powerless. My sister cannot be defeated, you know that. Resistance is pointless.”

“Big words, from cowards who ran away to escape me every time we fought,” Vainqueur replied, unimpressed.

So of course, when he saw his argument didn't work, the piper immediately aimed for the heart. "Are you truly so cruel as to let your own blood suffer in ignorance of your survival?" he said, looking especially at Kia. "The people of this world do not need you... but the ones beyond this portal do. Are you that *selfish*?"

Victor *knew*, in his head and in his heart, that the fomor was toying with them, preying on their emotional weaknesses. But while he had always thought that he had moved on, the sight of his parents alive and well made the Vizier hesitate.

They looked so close, and yet so far away.

"No," Kia said, at first hesitant, and then more firmly. "No. *No*."

Victor exchanged a glance with her and immediately understood what she thought.

Even if she might have loved returning to her world and father, she would never abandon this planet to Odieuse for *anything*.

As for Victor...

"Why?" Hamelin asked, genuinely puzzled by Kia's reaction. "I don't understand."

"Why? I have sixteen reasons why!" Victor shouted, before sending the signal. "[Za Warudo]!"

Vainqueur immediately lunged at Mell Lin, although time shifted before he could reach him.

When time resumed, the effect of Manling Victor's spells had become visible. Poisonous clouds covered the Dark Forest, both within his [Glitz Theater] and out. A mighty figure overshadowed the golems, as he had towered over Vainqueur when they fought; and a new, friendlier golem had joined the fray.

Weather condition changed to [**Acid Rain**]. Everyone exposed to the rain will take continuous [**Acid**] damage, with damage doubled for [**Plants**]. [**Acid**] and [**Poison**] effects will be strengthened, while [**Plant**] and [**Life**] effects will be weakened.

His [Delayed Hasten] activating and enhancing his speed twofold, Vainqueur moved past the golems protecting Mell Lin and punched him in the face. His closed fist being as big as the fomer himself, it sent him crashing against the stone doors of his own portal; the portal flickered in response, becoming blurry and indistinct.

“Thralls!” the piper snarled while dodging another [Victory Fist], Vainqueur’s punch creating a small crater. Instantly, all carnivorous trees around began to move, uprooting themselves and swinging their branches like flails. Those outside the arena scratched it furiously, while those within attacked Vainqueur’s minions from all sides; the acid droplets melting their bark did nothing to delay them.

“Rolo farms!” So Rolo the golem answered both Manling Victor’s call and the challenge before him. The [Farmer] *hastened* himself before punching his way through every plant monster between him and Hamelin; his every move shattered trunks.

Mell Lin’s golems moved to intercept Vainqueur and protect their master, only to be stopped by a larger shape. They looked up.

And up.

The [Tarasque Emperor] let out a bestial roar, casting a great shadow upon the forest; even the golems barely reached up to his waist.

As Kia summoned her [Solar Judgment] to incinerate the plant monsters, and Gorynych tackled a golem from behind, Manling Victor joined the Tarasque attacking the other one. The reptilian titan was so huge, that he easily lifted the machine like a toy and savagely plastered it against a wall of the [Glitzy Theater]. The entire landscape trembled, as his feet crushed dozens of tree monsters with every step.

[**Talos Titan**] used [**Barrier Change: Poison Wurm**].

[**Talos Titan**] became immune to [**Acid**] and [**Poison**].

The poisonous acid rain dripped down the golem's armor, unable to harm them. Neither could it affect Vainqueur's own allies though, shielded by protective spells.

With no one left to protect him, Mell Lin suddenly teleported within a few meters of Vainqueur himself, much to his surprise.

“Ah, I see, your arena blocks portals and teleportation out, but not into or within its confines,” the piper observed, bringing his musical instrument to his lips while putting as much space as he could between Vainqueur and him. “Come, my servants. [Vermin Shield].”

A horde of cat-sized black rats crawled out of the grass below Mell Lin's feet, forming a monstrous barrier.

While Vainqueur wanted nothing more than smash or incinerate the piper, he remembered the strategy and stuck with it. Instead, he anchored himself to the ground, and called upon his magic, leaving the piper to Tinfoil Rolo's care.

“[Terraform: Non-Magical Terrains, Volcano]!”

Answering Vainqueur's order, magma seeped through the earth and set the grass ablaze. Almost every plant within a mile caught fire, the monstrous trees wailing in pain as the world turned hostile to them. Some rats died from the heat, but most survived the flames by using the corpses of their brethren as a bloody carpet.

Meanwhile, Mell Lin prepared to sing a song, only for Rolo to reach and tackle him with his shoulder. Even with his native resistance to physical attacks, the blow made the fomor bleed golden blood through the mouth.

While Vainqueur focused on terraforming the land, he glanced at his allies to oversee their progress. The acid rain and the magma, both against which

his minions had been protected again, had quickly felled most of the tree monsters. Only the golems were left.

One of them had engaged Knight Kia and Gorynych in an aerial battle near the arena's ceiling and amidst acid clouds; the machine tried to impale the zmey with its blade, while he and Knight Kia retaliated with elemental breaths and light rays respectively. Both sides were [Hastened], but the golem took more than it gave.

The other machine fared terribly against the Tarasque, who was busy tearing in half with brute strength alone. Manling Victor even abandoned the reptile to take care of its prey to assist Tinfoil Rolo.

"Rolo remembers how you burned his fields," the [Farmer] told Mell Lin, ignoring the rats biting his ankle to punch the fomor once in the face, then twice. "Rolo will use your corpse as a fertilizer."

"I do not remember all my victims," the piper replied as his vermin servants managed to slow down the golem by drowning him under their sheer mass, giving him a brief respite. The fomor brought his musical instrument to his lips and sang a melody. "But they all remember me."

As the song echoed across the burning battlefield, a horde of diseased, greenish specters swirled out of Mell Lin's pipe. They looked like plague victims, diseased humans, beastkin, and other creatures howling their grudge against the living with a strident sound.

Mell Lin's [**Hamelin Melody**] summoned the ghosts of his victims.

Rolo protected his face with his hands, but couldn't stop the flood of specters attacking him from all sides. While he was strong, he couldn't hit intangible foes, and the rats impaired his movements. Rushing to the rescue on his nightmare horse's back, Manling Victor started targeting the ghosts with his scythe, consuming the souls.

"You're sure Cybele won't be too mad?!" the Vizier shouted to the [Farmer], while Vainqueur finished terraforming the area and the Tarasque swallowed his last foe's scraps whole.

“Old trees must often burn for new seeds to bloom,” Tinfoil Rolo replied, before turning his attention back on Mell Lin with the last ghost gone. His role in the battle was to occupy enemy spellcasters in close combat, preventing them from mounting a defense against other minions’ assault.

The lion’s share of the work, however, befell Vainqueur. Even his favorite Manling’s purpose was only to buy him time, so he could unleash his overwhelmingly powerful attack.

His rats forming a barrier of flesh around him, Mell Lin began to sing a strident, horrifying dirge, and surrounded himself with eldritch power.

Mell Lin’s [**Azathoth Lullaby**] will su—

“You do not face a magnanimous dragon today, fairy!” Vainqueur roared, as the stage was set. “You face the *Great Calamity of this Age*! [Geomancy]!”

Geomancy activated! Field Type: Volcano.

Effect: [**Eruption**].

Everything inside the [Glitzy Theater] erupted in blinding flames.

Shielded from fire and acid by spells, only Vainqueur and his allies survived the magical firestorm; some like Tinfoil Rolo were thrown away by the blast’s power, but the heat could not harm them.

All of Mell Lin’s rats, meanwhile, were instantly vaporized, as was the last enemy golem. The fomor’s song was laced by a howl of pain as his wooden skin burned from the searing flames, his magical pipe melting in his hands.

You inflicted massive [**Fire**] damage!

The stone gates shattered before the mighty blast, unleashing rainbow-colored lightning in all directions. Space itself seemed to tear itself apart into an unstable rift, flickering in and out of existence before collapsing on itself.

Surrounded by ashes, the dragon turned to the last enemy standing. The scene reminded him of his first confrontation with Wotan, whose powerful [Ragnarok] had shattered the *Piggybank* and cast the dragon down before he could retaliate. The wyrm had to thank Dragonbane for teaching him this tactic.

Yet, alone, agonizing, and with all his enemies converging on his location, Mell Lin kept singing.

In response to his odious song, more rifts in space appeared within Vainqueur's [Glitzy Theater], but these were black holes opening to the heart of Hell itself.

The lead side of the *Moouoon!*

Purple tentacles bigger than the towers of the dragon's castle emerged from the rifts and thrashed around. The Tarasque roared at the challenge, only to be seized by the throat and the limbs, struggling against an unseen monster even bigger than him. Another tentacle caught Rolo from behind and tossed him against the ground.

Vainqueur unleashed a dozen fireballs at the new enemies, but Manling Victor focused on the piper. "Ignore the summons, hit the summoner!" the [Reaper] shouted before unleashing a [Hades Blast] at the fomor. Mell Lin leaped away, singing desperately while almost tripping on ashes.

Descending from the skies, Knight Kia and Gorynych dived towards the fomor. A tentacle stopped the zmey midway, but the [Paladin] leaped off his back and reached the fomor.

Slash!

In one swing of her blade, Knight Kia severed the fomor's right arm, the one holding the pipe. Mell Lin let out a snarl of fury as his melody was interrupted, the rifts closing and cutting the tentacles. The fomor tried to dodge a lethal strike from the [Paladin]'s blade...

... only to move closer to Vainqueur.

“Wait!” The fomor raised his last hand in desperation. “Please, I can—”

Vainqueur crushed him with his fist, shutting him up and pinning him to the ground.

With the portals closed, Gorynych landed next to the group, while the Tarasque happily feasted on the tentacles. “We won!” the zmey rejoiced, Rolo patting him on the side. “Gorynych helped!”

“You tried to have me killed in my sleep, Mell Lin, and you hurt dragons when they could not fight back,” Vainqueur told him. “Your death will not be a dignified one. Manling Victor.”

His chief of staff raised his scythe.

“Good ol’ Hamelin may die...” Mell Lin replied with a glare of utter *hatred*, slamming the ground with his left hand.

“Carry out the sentence,” Vainqueur ordered his Vizier.

“But never alone!”

Manling Victor beheaded him in one swing like he did with Mag Mell. Hamelin’s twisted soul let out a final scream, as it was dragged into the spectral scythe; his body turned to ashes, returning to the blasted earth that gave that vermin life.

The brutal, one-sided battle had lasted less than five minutes; as he cancelled his [Glitzy Theater], Vainqueur realized that he hadn’t even taken a single wound.

Congratulations! For organizing your minions and leading them to an overwhelming victory, you earned a level in [**Kaiser**]!

+30 HP, +10 SP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 CHA.

Even the System seemed to find it too easy.

Luck check failed.

Manling Victor's eyes widened in horror, upon noticing a glowing inscription where Mell Lin had slammed the ground. A green rune.

"We need to evacuate!" he shouted. "Right now."

Skill check successful.

Vainqueur immediately sensed why, as he raised his eyes at the skies; seeing them aim for their location even with the clouds obscuring them.

A falling star.

"[Golden Road]!" Vainqueur opened the path to his hoard, his minions rushing through his portal... with one exception. "You, get through!"

The Tarasque looked up at the missiles, unimpressed, and then returned to feasting on the leftover tentacles.

Vainqueur almost used [Alpha Magnetism (Scales)] to make him behave, but realized that he didn't have that much time. With great annoyance, he crossed the portal and closed it behind, right before the bomb fell.

Having left the Dark Forest for the warm confines of Vainqueur's vault, the group let out a sigh of relief. "Wow, that's... that went well," Manling Victor said, his horse letting out a proud *humph*. "Epic Parties, uh?"

"We had a Tarasque," Knight Kia replied from atop Gorynych's back, before frowning. "Where is it?"

"Check up on him, minion," Vainqueur ordered. He knew the creature was all but indestructible, but he worried about its safety still.

"[Camilla's Scrying Mirror]," Manling Victor cast, a phantasmal mirror appearing in front of him. The surface shifted into a representation of the Dark Forest... or rather, what was left of it.

Hamelin's last curse had razed a large chunk of the region, turning miles of woods into smoking craters. Tons of debris and flames had elevated into the atmosphere in the shape of a giant mushroom, a testament to the fairies'

willingness to destroy their own home if needed. A rainbowy crest had appeared near the ashes of Hamelin, a trophy waiting for the victors to claim.

And amidst the devastation, the Tarasque was busy feasting on *cooked* tentacles, none the worse for wear.

He was glowing even greener than before though.

"Well," Manling Victor said, "I guess cancer rates aren't going down anytime soon."

Chapter 131: The Gathering

And so, the Dragon Conclave started, with the arrival of the fashionably early guests.

Vainqueur, Grandrake, Manling Victor, and Gorynych had gathered at the meeting point right outside Murmurin, a grassy [Plains] field vast enough to accommodate a dragon army. Thousands of minions were already at work, preparing the food and drinks for the guests while flying wyrms could be seen flying towards their location.

With the vile Mell Lin defeated and the Earthgate destroyed, the new fomor-dragon war had already begun in fire and flames. But the true battle would be decided here.

“Minion.” Vainqueur turned to Manling Victor, who had left his scythe to some minion for study. “Are you certain that no falling bomb shall spoil this gathering?”

“The Isekai Anti-Nuclear Defense is fully operational, Your Majesty.” The [Reaper] pointed at hills near the grasslands, which housed dwarven rockets.

The system was brilliant in its design. Suicidal members of the Esoteric Order of Isekai, wishing to be reincarnated in that mythical Japan like their founder, would pilot rockets and crash them against any incoming bomb long before they could reach the ground. Not only would Vainqueur protect his shores from attacks, but he would also help natural selection in weeding out his most stupid minions.

“You will also reinforce my hoard vault’s door,” Vainqueur said. “I woke up this morning to find a spider stalker drinking my sweat and promising that

we were meant for each other. I had to eat her.”

“I have the same problem, but that’s an interesting solution. I also have an amulet to reduce charisma, which should help with stalkers.”

“Minion, why would I ever be less charming? Especially at a time like this? No, it is better to eat privacy invaders one at a time.”

“I hope this will go well,” his manling shook his head. “I’m not sure the taradodos’ regeneration and our snack-cats farms can keep up with the guests’ appetite.”

“The taradodos? Why not their father?” Vainqueur asked. Having grown fat on the spoils of the last raid, the Tarasque would benefit from losing some weight.

“Since the [Tarasque Emperor] is now so radioactive that it kills almost anything in the vicinity, I wouldn’t risk serving his flesh to anyone, even Your Majesty’s kindred. We can’t even keep it in the Dodocare anymore without risking the life of the staff or our dodos; we’re lucky the lead side of the Moon’s citizens can handle him for us.”

Good. That would make him even more effective against the fairies, although he would be kept away from the other minions.

“Breeder Victor, I am having trouble hearing your voice clearly,” Grandrake said with a frown. “Can you repeat yourself, but louder?”

The emperor immediately frowned, as the esteemed [Princess Hunter] struggled to understand his Grand Vizier. “It seems the wealth sound barrier is catching up to you, Breeder Victor,” Grandrake said. “You must work on your hoard.”

“But Manling Victor is a true minion!” Vainqueur protested. “He is beyond the wealth sound barrier by default!”

“Yes, which is why I can still hear him, but only in the middle-class volume range.”

Vainqueur panicked at the revelation. “Minion,” he faced Manling Victor, who looked down at his feet in shame. “Are you... are you *poor*?”

“Your Majesty, I pay child support to a lot of people,” the poor Vizier admitted. “Between the legal fees, my manor, and my research... I’m stretching the limits of my one-one-tenth.”

Beyond the fact that Vainqueur would never tolerate having a pauper for a chief of staff, something else bothered him. “Manling Victor, is this why you do not want to breed? Because more children than your current count will make you poorer?”

“That’s... one of the reasons. I admit that... if Your Majesty...” the Doer of the Thing struggled to find the right words, “that if Your Majesty could... increase my one-one-tenth...”

“Minion, are you asking me for...” Vainqueur struggled to get it out of his throat. “For a *raise*?”

Manling Victor nodded slowly, looking like a puppy expecting to be thrown out.

A raise? That was insane, even for Manling Victor! Every dragon knew that when a single minion received a raise, every other slacker wanted one! Raises were the beginnings of strikes, of minion wars!

But, if Manling Victor refused to breed because he needed more gold to spoil his progeny, then it reduced Vainqueur's resources in the long-term because his best lackey would breed fewer minions. If all of his servants followed the same rule, then it would explain their lackluster fertility.

The dragon considered the matter with great care, his mind losing itself in complex mathematics only a mind like his could comprehend.

If two one-one-tenth meant one more minion, who could each give him ninety-eight percent of its earnings... then, considering the overwhelming amount of wealth waiting for a dragon to claim, the total final wealth would be, in fine, greater than if Vainqueur maintained his usual rates! And if the

breeding rates doubled with every one-one-tenth added, then the total would grow exponentially to ad infinitum!

Intelligence check successful!

You discovered circuitous long-term investing!

“Manling Victor, let you be the witness of the sixth commandment, that I shall deliver unto the world below,” Vainqueur channeled the Elder Wyrmspirit of bountifulness. “That henceforth, all of my minions are entitled to one-ten-tenth of their earnings.”

The declaration brought gasps from both Manling Victor and Grandrake. “Your Majesty means a full tenth?” his chief of staff asked, too shocked to fully grasp his master’s generosity. “We can keep a tenth of our earnings?”

“Yes, one-ten-tenth,” Vainqueur said, raising his head with magnanimity and expected to be praised for his generosity.

“Are you certain, young Vainqueur?” Grandrake asked, astonished. “This is... this has never been seen in the entire history of dragonkind.”

“I am not a dragon that repeats himself,” Vainqueur replied. “Visionaries take risks, so that they may change the world for the better. And for themselves.”

“I can certainly say it changed a lot for the better in my case!” Manling Victor rejoiced, all but kissing Vainqueur’s ring finger in adoration. “I bow before Your Majesty’s kindness!”

“Breeder Victor, I hear you more clearly than I ever did,” Grandrake rejoiced. “You have entered the millionaire volume range.”

“Well yes, if I keep even a tenth of what I should earn...” Manling Victor pumped up his fist. “Oh gods, I feel so much lighter now!”

“Shush, minion, you will brag to my rivals when they arrive,” Vainqueur told him, as the first dragons landed.

As expected, his close family members arrived before everyone else, with his niece and cousin rejoicing at seeing him.

“Uncle!” Jolie nuzzled Vainqueur, now wearing a beautiful golden armor on every inch of her body. Unfortunately, she carried the Kobold Rangers on her back, since Knight Kia had abandoned her duties. “Look at me, I have become a true [Knight]!”

“I am so proud of you,” Vainqueur said, vowing to spoil his niece once the celebration is over. “What is your level?”

“Forty-one!”

“We are so proud of you, Jolie,” said the second guest, Genialissime. Unlike his niece, he carried his chief of staff the proper dragon way, in his hand, and reserved his back for his son Courageux. “Great Grandrake, it is an honor to meet you again.”

“Ah, Young Genialissime, I remember when you were your mother’s tiniest spawn!” the elder dragon nodded to himself, before looking at Courageux. “I see you have caught a dragon queen of your own, to produce a scion!”

“M-Money!” Courageux replied, too intimidated by the older dragon to say anything coherent. “I am *money*!”

“Your Majesty, if everything is going well, could I teleport away for a few hours?” Manling Victor asked as the dragons exchanged wealthy pleasantries. “Kia left to petition King Roland Gardemagne for help already, and I need to meet someone in Haudemer.”

Already, Vainqueur’s fertility public policy bore its fruits! “Go breed, minion! I shall summon you if needed!”

“Thank you, Your Majesty,” said Manling Victor before bowing and teleporting out in a puff of smoke.

Unfortunately, no sooner did Manling Victor leave, that a new form in the skies ruined Vainqueur’s mood.

The one problem with the Conclave was that *all* dragons were invited.

“A zmey!” Gorynych rejoiced, a purple, female member of his kind landing on the grass. She was even more inbred than Manling Victor’s mount, with *mammaries* and *hair*.

“Cousin, what is this thing doing here?” Genialissime asked, while Grandrake simply turned his back to snob the newcomer.

“I am a dragonz!” the female zmey lied, unable to speak well. “I have ze right to be zhere!”

“Is it true?” Jolie asked, confused. Due to her age, some of the *unsavory* aspects of the gathering had been kept from her.

“Lesser cousins of dragons such as intelligent drakes and zmeys lobbied for the right to participate in the Conclave,” Vainqueur admitted. “We granted them the right to witness the debates, like our chiefs of staff.”

“Thankfully, zmeys don’t have the right to vote, Jolie,” Genialissime said. “They’re an oppressed minority.”

“But if we could vote with all our zree zeads, we would outnumber you!” the female zmey complained.

“Look at you!” Vainqueur lambasted the creature. “You have hair! You are so inbred, that you have hair!”

“While I’m alive, Zmeys will never vote!” Genialissime vowed. “What else, give voting rights to wyverns? Does nobody else see the slippery slope?”

Vainqueur would have expected Gorynych to complain or whine, but the zmey was entirely enamored with the newcomer and made a pass at her. “Gorynych finds you beautiful!”

“Zhank you!” the female, inbred horror replied, her three heads flustered. “My nephew is my grandzather!”

“Me too!” Gorynych wagged his tail. “You are perfect!”

Vainqueur did the proper dragon thing and ignored them, welcoming new guests as they arrived.

Congratulations! For riding at your master’s side and opening the first battle of a war, you earned one level in [**Chaos Rider**]! You earned the [**Red Rider**] class perk!

+30 HP, +1 STR, +1 VIT, +1 SKI, +1 AGI, +1 INT, +1 CHA.

[**Red Rider**]: You and your mount’s movements are never impaired by [Field] or [Weather] effects; additionally, while mounted on a monster, you and your creature ignore all forms of damage reduction and resistance to [Physical] attacks, including armor (you do not ignore immunity). You can add two monsters to your mount stable.

Finally, all his [Claimed] Perks offset his class’ lowest growths!

A lifetime ago, Victor remembered defending the port city of Haudemer from the Scorchers early in his adventures; he had been less than level twenty back then, and barely survived an intense battle with two bandits. Some of the Kobold Rangers had even perished, forcing him to embrace [Necromancy] to bring them back.

How far he had come since. The port city hadn’t changed at all, besides having repaired the houses destroyed by the Scorchers and V&V’s battles; but Victor certainly did.

Surrounded by the statues of three guards, his helmet removed, the Vizier knocked on the door of Lynette’s inn. The citizens had deserted the street upon seeing the [Reaper], either because they didn’t recognize him... or because they *did*.

“Coming,” a woman’s voice said beyond the threshold, before opening the door. “Yes?”

“Lynette,” Victor said. “It’s been a while.”

More than a year for her, eight for him.

Much like the city, she hadn't changed much. She was still the same busty innkeeper easy on the eyes, with long blonde hair arranged in a ponytail and emerald eyes. She wore a dress and a pendant with the symbol of Shesha, matching her patron deity in greed.

"Victor? Victor Dalton? I'm sorry, I almost didn't recognize you for a moment, and..." She squinted at the statues around him. "Why are there petrified watchmen surrounding you?"

"I think that with my burning armor, wings, and dragon tail, they mistook me for something else. They will recover in a few hours."

"I see," the innkeeper said, definitively surprised. She eyed him head to toe, very much impressed by his intimidating appearance. "I had heard the rumors, but..."

"Can I come in?" he asked. "I only have a few hours ahead before I have to teleport back to the V&V Empire."

"Certainly," she said, inviting him inside and closing the door behind them. Much to his surprise, the inn was almost empty.

"Tough times?" Victor asked.

"No, but I closed the inn for a while," Lynette admitted. "I heard rumors of a new war with Prydain, so I am moving out east to Barin before the fairies start raiding our shores."

Wise choice. "Actually, I came to discuss this, and our son."

"When you asked me to breed instead of a monetary reward, I was so eager to do it that I forgot to take my usual precautions," she admitted. "I guess I lucked out. The other options were... subpar."

"They didn't have my good looks?"

“They weren’t rich and heads of state,” she replied bluntly. “I was ready to raise Armand on my own, but keeping some extra money on the side is well and good. I can save wealth to buy eternal youth from Shesha, instead of paying for my son’s education all by myself.”

Armand. Beautiful name. “I can arrange that.” He showed her his [Claimed] brand. “I’m sure she will give you a discount on my behalf.”

Lynette’s eyes widened in surprise. “You have been chosen by the goddess?”

“For almost a year since,” he said, before showing her his other marks. “And more than half the pantheon.”

She looked up at him as if he were a completely different man than a second before. “What is your level?”

“Seventy-eight.” She almost choked. “And we also have a new [Heroic Crest] in storage.”

It would probably go to Allison, to have an [Epic] healer among their officers, but nothing confirmed yet.

Now, he could tell that Lynette’s merchants instincts had awakened. “Is there a job opening in your empire?” she asked out of the blue.

“An *actual* job opening?”

“Victor, frankly, you don’t interest me personally, but your money does.” At least she was open about her motives. “I can tell staying around Vainqueur opens many opportunities. I’m also an excellent organizer, merchant, innkeeper...”

“[Innkeeper]?” Victor’s head perked up. “The class?”

“Capped,” she said proudly.

“Well, I have a pocket dimension where one would come in handy.” And it would be the safest refuge on Outremonde soon, for her and many people.

“Could I see my son first though, before we discuss anything?”

“Of course. He is upstairs, sleeping.”

She led him to a room with a baby bed. And in the middle of it, his son.

It wasn't the first time Victor had seen a perfectly human baby, but after having expected fiends and weredragons for weeks, it was a refreshing sight; and somewhat unsurprising, considering the timing. The baby must have been a bit older than six months old, a tiny creature with the barest hint of hair, soft and wet.

As the baby opened his big green eyes, Victor found himself overwhelmed by strange emotions he had never experienced before.

“Armand, here's your father,” Lynette said, taking him in her arms. “Here, Victor. Take him.”

Immediately deactivating all spells and innate protections that may harm the child, especially the fire effects, Victor carefully took the baby in his arms, unable to utter a single word. His son looked up at him, confused, but somewhat at ease.

Armand Dalton.

His son.

At this moment, all of Victor's fears and anxieties about being a parent vanished. All the stress accumulated over managing the crazy women in his life was lifted off his shoulders. Even his lingering doubts about the Earthgate's destruction left the building.

Everything was replaced by pure bliss.

“I'm going to murder them all.”

“What?” Lynette asked, surprised.

“Everyone who threatens my beautiful kids,” Victor said, giggling at his *adorable* son. “I will murder them, raise the corpses as undead toys, and have them dance on their own grave.”

Congratulations! You’ve unlocked [**EvilDad Mode**]!

Your daughters’ boyfriends will date them on nightmare difficulty.

“You will love that, huh?” Little Armand made cute baby sounds at his father’s cruel smile. “You will love it when I kill the fairies who scare you at night, huh?”

Parental love often brought out the best in people.

In Victor’s case, it brought out the worst.

Chapter 132: The Dragon Conclave

It had been eons since Vainqueur had seen so many dragons gathered in one place. This assembly made his Bragging Day look like a small family gathering!

Everywhere, as far as his eyes could see, dragons from all corners of Outremonde feasted in a great brotherhood of scales; not only the majestic true dragons, but armies of their lesser cousins, such as brutish wyverns, tiny drakes, zmeys, and even the wingless linnorms.

A Life Dragon talked with a Poison Dragon, the former granting life to the grass that the latter corrupted with his mere presence; a flock of wyverns played some kind of board game with chiefs of staff from multiple species; Genialissime and his extended family, from his mate Blightswamp to their children, listened to Jolie's tales of protecting El Goldorado from knight poachers; even Sifu Jade the Wise had made his way to this gathering, pitching his cultivation techniques to dragonlings.

Hundreds of dragons in one place would devastate a countryside, but thousands could have brought Vainqueur's empire low in a single night. Thankfully, harvested taradodos and whiskey sea cocktails satisfied the ravenous hunger of the guests; although the emperor pitied the minions who would clean up afterward.

Still, the sooner the Conclave ended, the better.

"Where is Gorynych?" Vainqueur asked Genialissime, having lost sight of his inbred minion. Not that he would ever care for the zmey's safety, but... he could end up attracting the wrong attention at this gathering.

“Humping in the western woods,” his cousin explained with a sneer of disgust. “It turned out that female zmey and he were siblings by marriage, and nature ran its course.”

“Oh.” Good for him, Vainqueur supposed.

Grandrake cleared his throat and let out a mighty roar, silencing the gathering and bringing a thousand gazes upon himself.

“Young wyrms, it is a pleasure to meet all of you for this fifth edition of the Dragon Conclave!” Grandrake declared. “Indeed, the last one was more than five thousand years ago. Few of you were alive and awake back then! I am very proud of our species, which has endured the test of time and ruled Outremonde with justness, magnanimity, and enlightened greed!”

The dragons present all roared in response, the noise so deafening Vainqueur could have sworn he had taken [Sound] damage.

“As the eldest wyrm present, I, Grandrake, shall arbitrate the debates,” the famed [Princess Hunter] declared, to no one’s protest. “While Young Vainqueur called for this gathering to discuss a new Fomor-Dragon war, as per the rules of the Conclave, any participant can push for a subject. It shall be discussed by the assembly, which shall not disband until they have settled everything. If you wish to propose a motion, say it now, or stay forever silent.”

Vainqueur sighed, knowing that his own demand would be treated last in spite of the urgency. But the Conclave was an institution that went back from the days when the Elder Wyrm flew among them, and its traditions had to be observed.

“I zemand that we, zmey, wyverns, and drakes, and all dragonkinsz, all get the zright to vote!” a zmey spoke up with terrible grammar, backed up by lesser dragons. “Equality for all [Dragon] zypes! Down with the dracozrazy!”

“Never!” Genialissime shouted, his roar mightier.

“Rejected!” all true dragons shouted at once. “Rejected!”

“No!” Vainqueur replied, horrified. That would be anarchy, and blur the frontier between true dragons and dragonkin!

“Motion unanimously rejected,” Grandrake said in the face of the overwhelmingly negative response, the zmey lowering his three heads in disappointment. “But you are still allowed to make proposals and participate in the debates.”

“Me, me!” Jolie raised her hand. “Pick me!”

“Yes, Young Jolie?”

“We should discuss minions’ rights!” Jolie spoke up, although everyone who knew her immediately accused Vainqueur’s niece of cattletarianism. “Yes, minions are sentient, and eating them for nothing is wrong!”

“I agree,” Vainqueur said, much to everyone's surprise. He immediately reassured them about his eating regime. “I am no cattletarian and while I still eat them when needed, minions have souls, and thus, rights.”

“All minions?” Grandrake asked, taken aback by this progressive vision.

“Except elves, who eat grass like cows,” Vainqueur clarified, most of the dragons nodding in agreement.

However, many remained doubtful. “Minions’ rights are subjective, and left to the individual will of their dragon overlord,” a fire dragon argued. “It is not a Conclave’s purpose to take away this right granted to us by the Elder Wyrms!”

“I strongly disagree,” Genialissime replied, his human chief of staff hiding in his shadow. “In my travels with Manling Henry, I have encountered many dragons who used this excuse to abuse their minions. My, I have seen a life wyrms beating his troll chief of staff, with a golf club! Not *eating*, *beating*! My poor son was almost traumatized.”

“They’re minions, they don’t know up from down!”

The comment was met with many boos, much to Vainqueur's surprise. "My new career as a dragon adventurer taught me the value of good minions, and that they should not be taken for granted," a frost dragon spoke up. "By condoning abuse, we send a terrible message to our wyrmlings! Think of the wyrmlings!"

"As a [Paladin of Leone], I say we should ratify a declaration of minions' rights!" a silver dragon added. "Both to keep my class privileges, and because we must protect those weaker than ourselves."

"Cattletarian!" "Somebody throw a cow at him!"

"I shall tolerate no cow throwing!" Grandrake cut the debates short. "Everyone in favor of reviewing the rights of minions, say gold, everyone against, say lead."

After much gold and a little less lead, Grandrake added the proposal to the agenda, much to Vainqueur's surprise. It appeared that the adventurer lifestyle he inspired had opened the eyes of many of his kindred.

"Next?" Grandrake asked.

"I also want to make a proposal for the future safeguard of princesses," the black dragon Blightswamp spoke up. "New breakthroughs in the nature of princessness, and the destruction of their native monarchy environment at the hands of global democratization, must be addressed."

"I second this proposal," Grandrake said, many dragons voicing their agreement with roars of 'Gold.' "Motion added to the agenda."

"We should discuss the shininess standard!" a Frost Dragon spoke up. "As a member of the 'silver first' movement, I say gold should no longer be the standard of hoard wealth."

"Lead!" Vainqueur snarled in response, imitated by most southern dragons. "Lead, lead, lead!"

“The leads have it, motion rejected,” Grandrake said, the disagreements drowned in a maelstrom of ‘lead.’ “Anyone else?”

When nobody had anything else to propose, the oldest wyrm decided the agenda. “We shall start by discussing minions’ rights, then the princess proposal, and finally, Young Vainqueur’s declaration of war against the fomors. On the matter of minions, the first thing I believe we should address is...”

Grandrake observed the assembly.

“Do all minions have souls?”

The resulting chaos, shouts, and roars made Vainqueur sigh.

This was going to be a *long* assembly.

- *Six hours later, well into the evening.*

After countless debates, chiefs of staff testimonies, secret oaths, compromises, duels of honor, and tribulations, the Conclave was finally ready to review the final draft of the *Declaration of Minions’ Rights*.

Vainqueur cleared his throat before swallowing a barrel of water offered by his kobold minions. Having passionately argued for his vision of minions’ rights, he needed the refreshment.

“I am sorry that your proposal to forbid minion eating could not come to pass, Jolie,” Genialissime comforted his saddened niece. “But the dragon world is not ready for cattletarianism. And I do not think it will ever be.”

“One day they will see,” she vowed, refusing to let the disappointment wear her down. “One day.”

In the end, Vainqueur thought she should call it a win. While cattletarianism hadn’t caught on, many dragons had changed their mind on treating minions as mere tools over the last year. Enough to feel some empathy for their native weakness, and thus grant them their generous protection.

“Young Jolie, please read the final draft,” Grandrake said, presenting his assistant with a scroll full of modifications, “of the *Declaration of Minions’ Rights*.”

Vainqueur’s niece cleared out her throat, and read the document with grace. “Article 1, all minions are born free and average in dignity and rights, but below dragons in the natural order. They all have souls (*except the elves*). Article 2, all minions are entitled to a share of their hoard, after subtraction of their life tribute to their dragon overlords. Not even the dragon overlords will deny them this share, which is established at a minimum of one-one-tenth, but can be increased to one-ten-tenth if a dragon master wishes it. No distinction of any kind shall be made between minions (*except elves, who have no souls*).”

Vainqueur nodded to himself, although he was a bit saddened the Conclave didn’t fully embrace his revolutionary one-ten-tenth proposal. *Dragonling steps*, he thought. *Dragonling steps*.

Still, he was so proud to see his niece read this historical declaration.

“Article 4, slavery is an insult to the minion institution and shall be prohibited in all its forms... article 9, no minion shall be arbitrarily eaten without a good justification, unless in times of famine. Article 10, all minions are entitled to a fair and public hearing by their impartial dragon overlord, or their chief of staff if their master is absent... article 14, dragon overlords must provide for their minions in return for their loyalty and life tributes; this includes protection from outsiders, access to food, universal employment, and minion healthcare... Article 16, all minions have the right to breed with any other minion without facing prejudice...”

“*Gold or lead?*” Grandrake roared, after Jolie finished reading.

At the end of the day, two dragons out of three voted on the twenty articles-long declaration, consecrating minions’ rights.

“Adopted,” Grandrake said. “Next is the love of my life, princess preservation!”

Compared to the tense debates that preceded it, the sanctification of princesses as an endangered species was adopted unanimously, alongside restrictions on poaching seasons so they could rebuild a sufficient population. The many promises to provide for Grandrake's sanctuary pleased the old wyrm greatly.

"Gold, gold, gold!"

"I am..." Grandrake was at a loss of words, almost crying. "I am sorry for this outburst, but witnessing a dragon generation embracing conservationism so thoroughly... it is a dream come true."

"We could not have progressed socially as a race without your efforts, Grandrake," Sifu Jade patted the older wyrm in the back. "You have been a sifu to all of us at one point."

Grandrake took a moment to calm himself and then recovered his bearing. "Finally," he turned to the organizer of this gathering, "we shall hear Young Vainqueur's proposal of starting a new war against the fomor race."

As Vainqueur prepared to make his case, he suddenly realized that he should have proposed a motion on banning overdwarring. *Too late*, he thought.

The dragon said nothing for a moment, having learned the value of silence to gain attention. When he was certain everyone focused on him, Vainqueur began his long rehearsed speech.

"Many of you know me as Vainqueur Knightsbane, Great Calamity of this Age," he began the dragon way, with a good boast. "Some witnessed my Bragging Day last year, where I revealed the existence of the forgotten, Dragon-made System."

Many nodded in response, and to his joy, it appeared that the emperor's actions had brought him a great deal of goodwill among his kindred.

"Today, I summoned you because whether you like it or not, our race is at war," he said, extended his left arm towards the horizon and Mount

Murmurin. “When coming here, you have seen a side of my beloved mountain, turned into a glowing wasteland. A single arrow caused all this devastation!”

“What?” “Impossible!” “An arrow? An actual arrow?” “They bounce off our scales!”

“Young Vainqueur speaks the truth,” Grandrake spoke up, underlining the gravity of the situation. “I witnessed it, with my very own eyes. An arrow of light, with the power of an entire dragon flock!”

“This is but one of the weapons the fomors have developed to hunt us,” Vainqueur continued. “They raised great minions of metal, unleashed plagues among our minions, and even abducted wyrmlings to steal their dragonliness!”

“I can testify,” the silver dragon Snowsweep spoke up, her little brother Windi at her side. The emperor recognized him as one of the dragonlings whom he and Manling Victor had saved in the Winter Kingdoms. “Had Vainqueur and his chief of staff not intervened, my brother would have been killed, his blood harvested like cow milk!”

“I saved him, but I could not save everyone,” Vainqueur admitted with regret. “My rival, Icefang, and his fellows Magnifique and Suffisante... were slain in battle, by the fairy queen Mell Odieuse.”

“I always knew he was handicapped.” Genialissime shrugged.

“He wasn’t!” Vainqueur snarled, surprising his cousin. “Death is no handicap!”

His words were met with an eerie silence.

“Death is no handicap,” Vainqueur dropped the terrible truth. “Death is a natural feature. Every dragon suffers from it.”

Blightswamp immediately covered her children’s ears, as if she could protect their innocence. “Genialissime, say something!” she panicked. “He

is your cousin!”

“I almost died too,” Jolie blurted out, much to everyone’s shock. Yet, in spite of admitting this shameful truth, she held her ground. “I almost died, many times.”

“But you did not,” another dragon pointed out. “Which proves you are a healthy dragon.”

“Do not project your weakness on our entire race!” a frost wyrm snarled.

“All dragonz can diez!” Vainqueur turned to his left, seeing Gorynych and his female kindred return. All of her hair was in shambles. “My, every zmey knowz thiz!”

“Yes, Big V had to save Gorynych!” Gorynych tried to help, but it had the opposite effect.

“Vainqueur, when a zmey agrees with you, you must realize that you are saying something inane,” Genialissime argued.

“Many of you have forgotten, but there were times when we dragons were not the absolute masters of this world.” Grandrake took a stance, much to everyone’s astonishment. “Times when the fomors contested us for supremacy. Times when we died as much as we killed. Times when we starved, because we did not follow the hibernation system.”

“Death is no handicap,” Vainqueur continued; having learned from Icefang, he decided to turn the truth into a call for arms, instead of a shameful secret. “Death is a natural feature, granted to us by the Elder Wyrms so we do not grow complacent! Should we deny it? No. Should we fear it? No! A true dragon does not ignore death, but looks at her in contempt!”

[El Presidente] activated! Charisma check successful!

“The fomors are trying to bring us death?” Vainqueur raised a fist. “I say we return the gesture, with dragonfire!”

In spite of his successful charisma check, his words were met with a division. Some wyrms seemed willing to entertain the thought of death as natural, but many others remained strongly in denial; even among Vainqueur's own family.

"I am not convinced about death being a natural feature," Genialissime replied, many dragons nodding in support. "But I agree the fairies are in need of a long-overdue spanking."

"The fomors have unleashed a plague among my disciples," Sifu Jade declared, to support the motion. "Only those who paid for my seminars survived, but the lack of healthy trainees cost me money! Retribution!"

"We must exterminate the fomors!" an Earth Dragon proposed, many others nodding in support. "They never followed our agreement and broke the truce. Let us burn their forests from orbit, to be sure there is no third war."

"No," Vainqueur declared. "We should not go this far."

His response caused some whispers and muttering among the crowd.

"I am the one who called this gathering for war," Vainqueur confirmed. "But recent events have taught me that while difficult, coexistence with the fairies might be within reach."

"Peace?" "Is he serious?" "Fomors know nothing of peace!"

"My chief of staff, while struggling with parental wisdom, taught me a great lesson," Vainqueur held his ground. "That sometimes, one can defeat their enemies by making peace with them. True peace, not the truce which we *mistook* for peace. I have set Furibon, the Goldslayer, straight, and forgotten him; a fomor now lives in peace among my minions, and even Wotan Dragonbane decided to lower his weapon and walk away."

Charisma check successful!

His words surprised the gathering, who had grown to fear Wotan as a vicious dragonslayer; the thought of him making peace with them was as

shocking as learning the Moon's shady secret. And while the *Forgetting of Furibon* was a more well-known event, to have it confirmed forced many dragons to reconsider what they thought for granted.

While he could not yet convince his species of the inevitability of death, Vainqueur could teach them mercy.

“There can be no peace as long as the vile Mell Odieuse remains, for she desires nothing less than the complete destruction of Outremonde; but perhaps for the first time since we started fighting, fomors and dragons may coexist. Albeit unwittingly, we granted the fairies souls, and thus, the possibility for change. While the path may be hard, we must tread it. War, yes, but not one of *extermination*; a *just war*, against the Mell Clan and those who would stand by them!”

Charisma check...

Successful!

And so, his motion came to pass, with a roaring applaud.

“War!” The word spread through the gathering. “War! War! War!”

“Gold!” Jolie shouted in support. “Gold! Gold!”

Congratulations! For running a dragon Conclave and convincing your species to war against Mell Odieuse, you earned two levels in [**Kaiser**]
You earned the [**Sublime Dragonbreath**] Perk!

+20 SP, +2 STR, +2 VIT, +2 SKI, +1 AGI, +2 INT, +2 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Sublime Dragonbreath**]: Technique, 100 SP. For one hour, you can change the base element of your breath, so long as your choice is associated with a type of true dragon (for example, you can choose to breathe [Frost] or [Poison], but not [Time]). If you want to change your element again, you must pay the SP cost each time.

By reaching level twenty in [**Kaiser**], you maxed out the class! You can no longer take levels in it, but you gained the capstone ability [**Wurm**

Sovereign].

[**Wyrm Sovereign**]: Your draconic majesty brings luck to your allies. All allies within 120 feet of you gain +5 to any checks they make and immunity to Critical Hits.

By redeeming your species' main flaw into a virtue, your [**Dragon Arrogance**] monster perk has evolved into the [**Dragon Honor**] variant!

“My brothers and sisters, let us sing the song of the Elder Wyrn!”
Vainqueur roared, before humming it to himself.

“Shinies!”

Following his lead, all of dragonkind sang, from the lowliest wyvern to the greatest of dragons.

“Oh, my Shinies!”

So glittering, My Shinies!

Golden to the core, Our Hoard!

So beautiful, so blissful!”

All around Outremonde, panic spread as a strange sound echoed across the globe.

Sands shifted in the Deadsea desert, as fossilized stones cracked from within.

Birds flew away from marshes, as great shapes emerged from their depths.

Mountains shook, as great titans emerged from caves deep below the ice.

Everywhere, the skies darkened from their numbers, soaring through the heavens.

For the whole dragon race had awakened, and flocked towards Prydain.

Chapter 133: Rent-a-Prophet

It was evening, and he was high on *love*!

So thought Victor Dalton, as he worked on a new mixture in his lab, his heart full of happiness. He had never been so productive, so energetic, so thoughtful! The warmth in his chest had fueled him through the day, finishing years-long research projects in hours while he awaited for Vainqueur's summon.

"I'm so happy!" Victor shouted, out of nowhere.

"Me too!" his [Fetch] clone replied with the same enthusiasm, while Lynette dusted the pocket dimension in the background. In time, it would count as a magical inn, with all the benefits that came with it. "We should share the word!"

"Yes!" Victor looked in the screaming souls in his [Harvest] scythe, wielding it with one hand and his new potion with another. "I'm so happy! I'm so happy I could release all of you, even if I never will! But I could!"

Nothing could ruin his day!

"Mortal!"

His body shifted from his private dimension to another, but instead of finding himself in front of Vainqueur as he expected, the [Reaper] faced angry deities.

The marble temple around the Vizier reminded him of the afterlife antechamber, with which he had grown accustomed to after his repeated deaths. However, this place was clearly part of heaven, if Victor could trust the golden clouds and shining light all around him. A giant map of

Outremonde had been drawn in the middle of the room, its borders shifting on their own.

Two giants, one of them Mithras, and the other a shining knight whom Victor recognized as Leone oversaw a gathering of mortal heroes.

“Vic.” Kia nodded at him, dressed in full armor, and backed by what appeared to be a small band of elite adventurers. Victor recognized the dark elf sorcerer he had met at Vainqueur’s Bragging Day, ‘Kevin.’ “We need to discuss—”

“Kia, I have a son!” Victor shouted, interrupting his friend. “I am so happy!”

“Oh, congratulations,” she said, happy for Victor, but not as much as the father himself.

“His name is Armand, and he pees everywhere!” the Vizier gushed over his progeny. “But he makes that giggling sound and he’s so adorable, that I always forgive him!”

The Paladin wasn’t sure what to answer, while the deities and crusaders looked at the scene with confusion. “Okay...”

“We have more pressing matters to address, mortal,” Mithras spoke up, his voice grim and imperious.

“More pressing matters, speak for yourself!” Victor replied, before frowning behind his helmet. “Wait, how could you summon me in your planar realm in the first place? I thought you needed to claim me first for that.”

“We rented you for thirty minutes,” Leone replied, without elaborating. While Mithras was simply neutral, the goddess didn’t sound happy to see the Vizier.

“You are here at my chosen’s behest, Victor,” Mithras pointed a finger at the Outremonde map, “to see how we can handle *this*.”

The Vizier looked at the map, realizing that it was fully animated. Thousands of tiny dragons flew from all corners of the map towards the Mistral continent, converging towards its shores.

“That’s a lot of dragon miniatures,” Victor said, before connecting the dots. “The Conclave worked!”

“More than sixty thousand dragons and their lesser cousins are making their way to Prydain, with most of them expected to reach the island in three days,” Mithras explained.

“Everywhere, chaos and confusion have spread,” Leone replied, summoning dozens of phantom pictures. The gathering watched scenes of humans, beastlings, and elves screaming in fear, as dozens of dragons flew over their cities. Drakes, wyverns, and zmey followed their greater cousins, nabbing cows and goats while at it. “Most countries believe the end of the world has come, and tensions are at an all-time high.”

“Meanwhile, Prydain remains completely shrouded from our divine sight and divination,” Mithras added. “We ordered a crusade against Mell Odieuse, even before her attack on the V&V Empire revealed the existence of her ‘light arrows.’ Now we’ve hastened it.”

“King Roland Gardemagne and Barsino of Barin agreed to lend their support,” Kevin explained. “We put back together the Shining Crusade and called every elite adventurer who participated in the final battle against King Balaur. All in all, the entire civilized world is arrayed against Prydain.”

“Sixty thousand dragons,” Victor muttered.

“Yes, and *dragons*,” Leone said, clearly not happy at all with this development. “If the fomors do not destroy the world, their hunger will. They devastate the countryside on their path, devouring all cattle they find!”

“We were already forced to send all dwarves underground, for the world’s own safety,” Mithras said. “Outremonde will not survive a dragon drunken

riot.”

“This Conclave was a disaster,” Leone complained, clearly more of a hardliner than her fellow, “The dragons already caused such disorder, but something of this magnitude hasn't been seen since the godwar!”

“Odds favor us, but as Mell Lin pointed out, a cornered rat will bite a cat,” Kia cleared her throat. “Odieuse has fortified her dominions, and if she is willing to launch five of them at once, then she probably has a large stockpile of nukes. Why she hasn't used them to devastate our shores yet is worrying.”

“Oh, it's okay, we are going to sink the island after we are done leveling it to the ground,” Victor replied casually. “We will drown their arsenal like Atlantis.”

His solution was met with confused silence.

“My friend Jaja woke up his master Dagon, and he is very good at destroying civilizations,” Victor explained cheerfully. “We hit the Mell clan from everywhere, and then we sink their entire stronghold. Problem solved, and my kids will be safe.”

“This seems disproportionate, not to mention irresponsible,” Mithras said.

“It's the only way to be sure.” Victor suddenly stopped though, as he remembered something important. “Kia, most of my kids are monsters and half-demons. You're not going to go [Paladin] on them once this is over, are you?”

“What do you mean?” The knight frowned, as the atmosphere turned positively oppressive, “Why is the temperature increasing?”

“Because, Kia, you are my friend, but they are my kids. They come first, and I will do anything to protect them.” He looked at her with the fires of Happyland in his gaze. “*Anything.*”

Charisma check successful!

“Vic, I owe you one for the curse of Seng thing,” Kia reassured him, although deeply disturbed alongside all the people present. “I’m not going to discipline your children without picking a fight with you first. You have my word.”

“Oh good,” the Vizier replied, calming himself. “Because I am a dad first, and a friendly soul-stealing warlord second.”

“You will not threaten my Claimed in our presence!” Leone's voice boomed, her eyes shining with burning wrath.

“Why, you want to harm my kids?” Victor glared back.

The goddess seemed surprised by the defiant response, and a little offended. “No, of course not. I am a knight, I do not harm children.”

“Good for you, because if anybody threatens them,” Victor ominously looked at the shining Heaven around him. “I would be very *unhappy* about it.”

A short silence fell on the gathering.

“Get it?” Victor asked, the lack of reaction bothering him. “Happyland, unhappy?”

“Kia, you are friends with this loon?” Kevin asked his teammate.

“He’s usually nothing like this,” Kia replied, embarrassed. “I don’t understand what’s going on. He sounds bipolar now!”

“Fatherhood drove him mad,” Mithras said, nonplussed. “His karma was already all over the place, but it is getting increasingly difficult to keep track of it.”

“This already happened in the past?” his own Paladin asked him.

“Countless times.” Leone looked at her fellow deity with a frustrated ‘I told you so’ gaze, but the sun god ignored her. “Kia, Victor, you will work on your very platonic friendship after the world is saved from devastation. We

will coordinate to assist the dragon's assault in three days, but until then, we must ensure order among the civilian populations and protect Mistral's shores from fomor retaliation."

"The magical shield designed by Furibon to protect his castle could be extended across the coast or at least major cities," Kevin the mage coughed, slipping the last discussion under the rug, "if we could reverse-engineer it."

"Why haven't you asked him directly?" Victor asked the deities.

"Unfortunately, the lich is under the protection of Deathjester, at least for the duration of that... that loathsome dungeon contest," Leone spat.

"Which is where you come in," Mithras explained. "Use your Claimed privileges to intercede on the world's behalf. We will also need your help to pacify the dragons and prevent things from getting out of hand."

Why did everyone always hand him over the dirty work?

"Also, how far are you into developing the plague's antidote?" Kia asked.

"Oh, I have it already!" Victor showed them the potion in his hand. "I had to rough up Mell Lin's soul to make him confess, but it was worth it!"

Kia's face deflated, but Mithras' eyes instantly shone up. "Then give it to me, Victor," the deity said, "I will have my church distribute it to the population for free. I have the religious infrastructure to spread such a cure quickly."

"Vainqueur wanted to commercialize it, at an overpriced rate," Victor pointed out, ignoring the offended responses. "You know what, I can give it away, but under one condition."

"You would—" Leone seemed ready to crush him, but Mithras silenced her by putting his hand on her shoulder.

"I want the answer to one question," Victor cleared his throat. "Where is Miel?"

“That is all?” Mithras asked, having expected more. But the Vizier didn’t want to go to what he sensed would be his final battle, without putting that unresolved issue to rest. “Then in this case—”

Ding!

The sound echoed not in the air, but in Victor’s own mind.

“The time is up already?” Leone asked with a frown. “It was barely twenty minutes!”

Before the Vizier knew what hit him, a powerful force tore him away from Heaven and dumped him into an enormous warforge of brass and steel. Hundreds of golems and ghostly dwarves shaped cannons on a near-endless assembly line, toiling endlessly to make weapons. Windows provided a view of the world outside, that of a metal fortress floating amidst a volcanic, hellish landscape.

“Ah, Victor, right on time.” The dwarf goddess Veran had switched place with her more heavenly counterpart, most of her body hidden beneath some kind of golem suit. “I am glad to see the customer service is on point.”

“Lady Veran?” Victor blinked, his armor and immunities protecting him from the ambient heat. “Where are we?”

“This is my planar realm, at the junction between the Elemental Planes of Fire and Earth,” the goddess explained. “I need both heat and materials for my best work. Now, this renting prophet service is a first for me, but Shesha made me an opening sales offer and with the war starting, I could not resist. Let us make the best of our allocated time.”

“I don’t understand.”

“I rented you for two hours,” Veran said as if it explained everything. When she realized Victor remained clueless, she snapped her fingers and an imp flew to her side, carrying some kind of primitive laptop.

The Vizier looked at the screen.

rentaprophet.outremonde

Victor blinked, as he watched the imp scroll down an entire website with his own face plastered on it. Texts and pictures oversold his past achievements while a video of Shesha pitched the idea to listeners.

“You want a Moses, but nature gave you a Christ? You want to develop your cult in these troubled times, but you don’t have the right person? Approved by half the pantheon and with almost eight years of experience as a professional prophet, Victor Dalton is the perfect assistant, capable of handling any divine task set for him. For what is a prophet, but a god’s minion?”

Victor’s eyebrows lowered in despair.

“By renting my allocated Claimed time while another deity hasn’t requested him, you can get the best of the Claimed marketplace for a fair retainer fee of—”

“She had the idea during our last table session,” Veran explained before Victor could have a heart attack over the price. “Since many gods couldn’t agree when you were supposed to serve them, Shesha set this system to allocate your time. Since she rarely used you, and won Dice’s allocated time at the table, she now rents her time to the highest bidder.”

...

Victor should have felt unhappy about it, especially since he probably wouldn’t get paid over it.

But he was so *happy* to be a parent, that he refused to let it drag him down. “What do you want me for?”

“I need a sounding board for new weapons,” the goddess explained, showing him the blueprints of an enormous cannon. “With the dragon-fomor war incoming and these new arrows of light, my church needs a *boost*. This continental conflict is my chance to test out new stuff, and I

will! There is this big railgun idea in particular that I can't out of my mind..."

"What about something more innovative?" the Vizier suggested.
"Something they will never see coming?"

"Like a smaller gun?"

One hour and a half later, Victor was the one pitching weapons to Veran.

"... and then with the sun blotted out, everyone is blind *but* our armies," the Vizier explained. "Since most of our troops can naturally see in the dark, this gives us a tremendous tactical advantage."

"Then we can *finally* get these intimidating night-goggles out of storage for diurnal soldiers."

"And with eternal night, half-vampire kids can properly go out during the day. This weapon is entirely child friendly."

"You've given it a lot of thought," the goddess said, even if they both worked hard on brainstorming the concept.

"Ever since I had a son half a day ago, I have been considering world domination," Victor explained, Veran remaining silent. "Most of my children are half-demons, meaning that by nature, they will be targeted by heroes and paladins. Ergo, the only way to create a world where they can live safely, is to preemptively take it over first."

"With military might?" Veran asked with enthusiasm.

"With a mix of intrigue, economic power, *and* overwhelming military might." Victor raised his scythe. "The V&V Empire will become the most powerful nation, where my kids will grow in a safe, family-friendly environment!"

"*That* is the attitude I want in a prophet!" Veran pointed a metal index finger at his face. "Victor, you are hired! I want you in my church!"

The symbol of a fiery whip appeared on his right arm, joining the other marks.

[Claimed by Veran]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Strength or Intelligence point. You can craft any item with medium proficiency as if you had the necessary perks.

“Any item?” Victor asked, pumped up. “Even a wereslime crib?”

“Any item as long as you have the necessary materials, and if you ignore the slim chance of devastating, catastrophic failure.” Veran checked the website next. “I will see if I can extend the weapon brainstorming session for an extra hour...”

Wait, if he could craft anything, then maybe... Maybe even a Soulcrest? Since they could be made without harming any dragon, if he had the skills needed to craft the device, then Victor could produce his own ethical version.

“Oh, your next appointment is a Jesty session about the new Dalton Dynasty idea he wanted to pitch us after we end the current War Edition. I guess he won’t be too mad if our current meeting spills over ten more minutes.”

“Dalton Dynasty?”

"Very interesting concept. We each choose a Dalton child and guide him while they accumulate ‘prestige points’; the dynasty with the highest prestige at the end of the campaign wins. Isengrim called dibs on your werechildren, while I would guide your eldest daughter through my chosen Goblina. However, Cam wants to play undead and is saddened by your lack of progress on that front, while Cybele would like a descendant of Allison as her charge. The game is only a vague concept for now, but it is gaining traction.”

[Evil Dad Mode] activated!

“Undead?” Victor tensed. “Are you gods discussing killing my kids?”

“What? No, no—”

“Because if any of you tries to kill my kids and reanimate them as undead, I’ll ascend to Valhalla just to crap on your gaming table!”

“Someone beat you to it, and it took months to clean up Atlantis afterward,” Veran replied. “Do not worry, Victor. Cam simply wants that you could get down with having a half-vampire scion, or maybe a half-ghoul.”

“Oh,” Victor calmed himself. “Good. I knew Camilla would never do anything that could jeopardize our fulfilling relationship, but I lost control for a minute. I am a parent now.”

"Yes, although I heard you were anxious about it."

"That was before I actually had a kid!" It was as if he had been neurotic all his life, only to receive a vaccine upon seeing Armand. "What about the other gods?"

“Shesha would like to play Armand,” Veran said. “Dice will roll for his chosen, and the Moon Man is planning to guide someone not conceived yet.”

Good, all his kids would have a deity’s protection, and would never struggle the way Victor did before he met Vainqueur. “What about Seng? Whom did she choose?”

“What about her?” Veran replied. “She is not invited.”

“She should,” Victor defended the mermaid goddess, taking his role of prophet seriously. “She claimed me and she’s pretty nice when you get to know her.”

The dwarf goddess looked at him as if he had lost his mind. “Do you want *Seng* to mentor one of your children?”

Victor opened his mouth, then thought about it. “... yes?”

“No, you do not.”

“She will never gain self-confidence if nobody trusts her, and all my children need divine protection,” Victor argued, more firmly this time. “Give her a chance.”

Veran remained silent for a moment. “Your funeral,” she replied. “Now, about that sun-blotting plot...”

Chapter 134: Interlude: A Flight of Dragons

“Minion! MINION!”

A frown on her face and dark circles under her eyes, Allison opened her house’s door to face a large group of thirsty dragons.

Even if she lived with Rolo in the farms at the city’s outskirts, the entire area was overcrowded by all kinds of dragon types, from recently awakened true dragons to talking wyverns. Most of the newcomers had slept below Murmurin’s countryside, only to emerge when Vainqueur's Conclave started singing their awful music.

Surprisingly, the capital of the V&V Empire had taken the arrival of hundreds, if not thousands of new dragons relatively well. Allison herself had grown used to these insane events and set enough meat aside to satisfy the ravenous horde for a short while.

“Minion,” a blue, wingless wyrm which Allison identified as a serpentine [Linnorm] glanced down at the dryad with pompousness. The creature was not as big as Vainqueur but could swallow the priestess whole if he wished so. “Where are the dwarves?”

“I am sorry?” the dryad repeated, struggling to stay awake. The ruckus from their Conclave could be heard all the way to Murmurin, and had ruined her night. Hard to sleep when you could hear dragons argue about whether or not they should ban elf eating.

And that damn hoard song! Even now Vainqueur and his compatriots kept humming it, with a zeal that would make hyper capitalists blush. It could

have been somewhat bearable, but as it turned out, the entire dragon race was *tone deaf*!

“We know you have a dwarf cellar,” a wyvern rasped, licking its fangs. “We can smell it.”

“If you are hiding dwarves in your basement, hand them over right now,” the linnorm ordered haughtily.

“Why would you need dwarves, I thought they had souls?” Allison replied dryly.

“I am wingless!” the linnorm roared. “I refuse to swim across the ocean without getting wasted first! It is cold and the salt sullies my scales!”

“Yes, you lower-class minions cannot understand our suffering, and the burden of ruling the world!” a young purple dragon the size of Jolie complained.

“When I was awake, every dragon worth their hoard had a dwarf cellar!” another linnorm complained. “You hibernate for six centuries—*six centuries*—and everyone lowers their cultural standards!”

“There are no dwarves in my basement,” Allison lied. “We do not have a dwarf cellar, and all Agarthans fled underground when you started waking up.”

“Then why do your walls smell of them?” the blue Linnorm hummed the air, like a hound hunting a rabbit.

“I am a priestess of Cybele, goddess of pleasure,” the dryad explained, although she hated using these stereotypes. “I organize minion orgies in my basement. That included dwarves, and they left a lasting smell.”

“Oh, you are a minion breeder?” the linnorm immediately changed his tune. “It is true you smell a lot...”

“This minion city has no dwarf cellar?” the talking wyvern complained. “By the Elder Wyrn, we woke up in the boonies!”

“If you ever need to get rid of extra dwarf babies, call us,” the Linnorm said. “In these times of shortage, we will take anything we can eat.”

“Certainly,” Allison replied with a false smile, closing the door while the reptiles went to harass another house. Once certain that they were gone, the dryad moved to the staircase leading down her basement. Dozens of dwarves and the fomor Jack hid in the darkness, waiting for the storm to end.

“Are they gone?” Marbré asked, worried, while his compatriots dug a tunnel to escape back into their homeland.

“For now,” Allison reassured them. That was the fifth group today, but thankfully, no dragon alive had a Skill stat worth a damn.

“The Agarthan race owes you much,” Marbré said, a hand on his chest. “The Averagist Revolution shall not forget your contribution, Comrade Allison.”

“Thanks. Do you need anything? I’m afraid they’re going to stay for a while.”

“Are there cats left?” Jack asked with candidness. “Jack is *hungwy!*”

Whistling to himself, a cup of coffee in hand, Furibon exited his dungeon base to embrace the morning sun. With his base taking up most of the mountain overseeing the Holly Woods, the entrance was located at the summit and gave him an incredible view of the western ocean.

Sitting on a deckchair, the lich faced the sun while drinking his beverage. Not that he could actually *taste* it as an undead; Furibon mostly drank coffee to blacken his remaining teeth and better scare children. The vague sensation of a warm liquid going down his innards was one of his small pleasures, outside of annoying people.

However, his peaceful morning ritual was interrupted by background noise.

“*Oh, my Shinies! So glittering, My Shinies!*”

The song came from the east, a terrible noise coming straight from Hell's bowels.

"What is this?" the lich muttered to himself, as flying shapes appeared all across the horizon, following the song back to the source.

A second later, a flight of dragons flew over the mountain.

Hundreds, thousands of greedy lizards roared in a maddening cacophony above the lich's abode. Dragons, wyverns, zmeys, an entire menagerie that darkened the skies with their numbers sung this terrible tune.

For a moment, the lich simply observed the display in an eerie silence, his hand shaking around his '*misunderstood genius*' coffee mug. Then a wyvern let out a pigeon-like squawk, a disgusting white substance dropping on the left of Furibon's deckchair.

Some of the dung ended up on the lich's sleeve.

"Sarat!" Furibon turned his head and shouted towards the dungeon's entrance. "Sarat!"

"Yes, Furi?" his teammate called from inside.

"Where is my lead armor?!"

"I threw it away!" the ratkin replied.

"What?" the lich almost jumped out of his deckchair. "Why? Why would you do that?"

"Because it gives me nightmares!"

"And because you are a sick BLEEP, Furi!" one of his other teammates, Raptor, joining the shouting contest.

"There is an army of dragons right above us!" the lich replied angrily, pointing a finger at the skies.

“Why don’t you turn all their hoards to lead, then?!” Raptor screamed angrily. “I’m sure they will fly away!”

Furibon sighed as he watched the dragons singing about gold for the entire world to hear.

“I hate this planet,” the lich muttered.

Nothing here was worth all the hassle.

Her whole life had led her to this moment.

Watching from the Nightblades HQ’s windows in the Gardemagnian city of Noblecoeur, protected from the sun by her umbrella, Charlene Ennuie observed the chaos with a cynical eye. Once upon a time, the sight of a thousand dragons passing through a city on their way to the western shores would have given her a stroke.

Today, she just saw it as a business opportunity.

Most dragons came from elsewhere, but some had slept beneath the city for eons, bringing down houses as they woke up. The population had mostly evacuated to the countryside while screaming for their lives; every goat, cow, or chicken in sight had been hunted to extinction by ravenous reptiles. Most of the city’s houses had been emptied, left behind by its panicked occupants.

Which made it the perfect day for criminal enterprises.

“Alright, so we’ll follow the plan,” one of her lieutenants explained to the gathered Nightblades, showing them a map of the city on the room’s central table. “First the banks and noble estates, then all the suburbs. If it shines, you take it. If it doesn’t shine, you still take it, just in case.”

“You will not rob the poorer districts,” Charlene clarified. “Too much work for little gain, and we are not monsters. You will also raid the adventurer guild for [Crests].”

Vainqueur wanted more of them, and she would deliver.

“You will spread these orders to every Nightblade chapter on the continent,” Charlene ordered. “Remember that is not theft, but redistribution of wealth. We take from the rich, to fill our own empty pockets.”

The gathered criminals nodded at once, and then prepared their tools for the raid. Charlene, however, approached the youngest assassin present, a tiny lizardkin with a positive attitude and an impressive murder pedigree.

“Not you, Potiron,” Charlene said. “I have a job for you. A private one.”

“Business?” The tiny assassin was positively giddy. “Who, where?”

“My ex, on the Moon.”

“Sweet, I love exotic murder locations!”

“I can get you in and out,” Charlene said. “But otherwise you will be on your own, and this cannot be traced back to me.”

“Alright, do you have a special execution method in mind?” the assassin started scribbling notes. “Anything is on the table, including sharks. Otherwise, I will go quartered.”

“I don’t want him dead, I want his current relationship destroyed,” Charlene replied. After what he did, she wanted him to suffer more, not to die.

“Oh.” The assassin didn’t bother to hide his disappointment. “Not even a few ‘accidental’ casualties?”

“He is meeting your aunt Savoureuse,” the vampire ignored his whining, “but she is too good for Croissant and deserves better. It is for her own good.”

Charlene couldn’t let the dragon apocalypse get in the way of petty revenge.

Everyone prayed to Sablar today.

Deep inside his chosen Akhenapep's pyramid, the worm god found his precious social distancing interrupted by the prayers of countless mortals across the globe. Demands to be delivered from an apocalypse by dragons, from the sky falling on their head, or other nonsense.

It seems that with the apocalypse coming, Sablar had newfound popularity.

"Enough," the god of destruction complained, furiously smashing his SNES' buttons with telekinesis. He was struggling with a powerful boss, and humans found nothing better to do than to bother him.

It wouldn't even help them. He was the god of *destruction*, not of *mercy*.

While he backed the fomors in this conflict, Sablar did not care for the outcome. Whoever won, would cause enormous collateral damage; and even if dragons had been summoned to save the mortals, they would leave great chaos in their wake.

You have 5,802,059 prayers on standby in your Godmail.

Overtime work again. "How many are asking for the destruction of someone or something?"

60,008.

Good. Quality over quantity. "Filter all the non-destruction, non-earth related prayers into my prayer spam folder. I will examine the rest later." Sablar prided himself on taking a personal interest in his worshipers.

Your prayer spam folder has reached critical mass. Do you want to **erase** or **answer** these prayers?

Sigh... truly, being a god was a thankless job.

"Answer all the spam prayers by telling them to bother the Moon Man instead," Sablar rasped. "Only he can save them now."

Spam folder cleaned!

Finally, the voices fell silent, allowing the worm god to enjoy his peace and quiet.

At least, until his game's screen went black.

Sablar waited a few seconds in front of his tv, before realizing that his SNES had breathed its last. As always, entropy had prevailed.

But now he couldn't play.

Sablar could not rewind time and restore his item; neither could he create a new one. That would undo entropy, and go against everything he believed in. He could always summon Akhenapep to repair it, but his prophet was doing important work in Prydain.

He could summon a repairman, but...

...

Too much work.

He would just cause an earthquake somewhere.

Somewhere in Prydain, an army of golems toiled tirelessly to build the world's greatest castle.

A fortress with sharp towers of dizzying height, not made of stone, but steel; its rune-reinforced curtain walls were so thick that they could withstand dragonfire. The rooms inside had been designed for giants and the elite of the fomor race; its stables could shelter thousands of fairy beasts and monstrous flyers; flying golems nested in the towers, adding the finishing touches, putting on the last gears.

Crom Cruach. The ultimate creation of the Mell Clan.

Its construction had needed so many resources that the countryside had been scourged of material for miles. Entire forests had been devastated, every last drop of wood used to fuel the forges spewing the needed steel. The smokes covered large swaths of the island, obscuring the skies.

Such destruction pleased Mell Odieuse, who oversaw the construction in her humanoid guise.

Crom Cruach was as much a weapon as it was a palace. Its towers sheltered the weapons that would cradle the lesser races to sleep, rip their souls from their bodies, and end this cycle of failures in one final act of annihilation.

In the background, she could hear the dragons' song, even past the magical protections that made Prydain near-impenetrable. She did not care. Soon, so very soon, the music would end. A symphony of screams would follow, the last wail of all life in Outremonde.

And then, at long last... silence.

"Milady?" Frank the Anark, one of Sablar's priests sent to support her war effort, bent the knee behind her. She could smell his warm soul, ripe for the taking. How hard it was, to quell her greed... "Wotan betrayed you."

"How so?" the fairy asked, a bit surprised, but not that much. Dragonbane never had the guts needed to put the mortals back in their place.

"He spared Knightsbane, and led Mell Lin to his death."

"I do not care about Mell Lin," Odieuse replied with apathy, her eyes set on her castle. "What about my golems?"

"Their barrier worked, and while they held their own for a while, they were no match for the wyrm and his allies," the priest argued with a pessimistic tone.

"Anything that can fight against Knightsbane will wipe out anything less than [Epic] adventurers," Odieuse replied, who had thousands of these golems. They were her greatest creations, stripped of the free-will that caused so many of the fomors' servants to rebel.

The humans of Earth had the right idea. Mindless drones did not question orders, and she could make as many of them as needed.

“However, Mell Lin activated a [Homing Rune] before his demise,” the [Chronomancer] added, perhaps believing Odieuse would kill him if he did not bring any good news.

“Excellent.” After the successful test run against Vainqueur’s insect farm, increasing her arrows’ precision had been her primary concern. “Add Wotan’s realm to Crom Cruach’s targets, and order Akhenapep and Ravana to prepare the shores for an invasion.”

“As you wish,” Frank the Anark replied, before teleporting away.

With the dragons’ song audible across the world, they would need to hold the line a few more days, until her castle could rise up. It would answer this noise with fire and fury.

A few more days and she would paint this blue planet red.

Chapter 135: The Last Sidequest

“So, if I understand right, you want advice on how to change mortals’ perception of you?” Victor asked the goddess Cybele, scribbling notes while they sat on fungi thrones around a mushroom table.

“Most mortals only remember me for the pleasure aspect of my portfolio,” the goddess complained, her face and body hidden beneath a white cowl. “I cannot shake the stereotype and it bothers me. The few times mortals acknowledge my focus on nature and forests, they only imagine wild orgies in the woods; even my early sponsorship of Mithras, when he was a mortal [Paladin], has been forgotten. I thought that as a professional prophet, you might have ideas to help my church’s reputation... *perform* better.”

“It is true that this stereotype is widespread,” Victor admitted, and it was the main reason he had even considered worshiping her in the first place.

As expected of Cybele, forests and natural locations made up most of her planar realm, with a strange focus on fungi. Victor found their current, grove-like location quite relaxing after the previous dimensions. Especially after visiting Deathjester’s realm in particular.

So many traps...

“Is something wrong?” Cybele asked, Victor shuddering as he remembered that prophet session. “Was that too much to swallow?”

“It was nothing,” the Vizier promised, adjusting his fungi throne. The plant squealed as he did so, much to his shock. “Nothing at all.”

“I also wished to apologize for our last meeting,” the goddess said with warmth, the mere sight of her face having almost killed the [Reaper]. “I am glad that you managed to tighten through the Kamacybele.”

“I asked for it, and the [Fiendish Rake] class was worth the hassle,” Victor replied. “Speaking of your condition, I have perhaps a solution.”

“There is none,” Cybele replied with a heavy sigh. “I tried everything to solve this issue. But I appreciate the attention, Victor.”

“Through Mag Mell’s captured soul, I have gained an understanding of Soulcrests and Black Crests, and how they interact with souls,” Victor argued. “You said you had Ludvic’s charisma before you ascended?”

The goddess nodded. “My current charisma score is the result of the [Deity] class, which juices up my original stats.”

“So it only builds upon the original charisma stat.” As Victor had guessed. “In this case, have you tried an amulet like Ludvic’s?”

“Yes, but they cannot affect a deity. I cannot be debuffed by any profane effect.”

“Then I believe that with my current knowledge, resources, and your assistance, I could create an artifact version that would reduce your original charisma stat. Perhaps enough to counteract the inflation from your [Deity] class.”

It couldn’t be more complicated than creating a Soulcrest, or a Black one. Black Crests in particular were... not a cheat, but an exploit in the system. They passively shored up magic, then boosted the user’s soul to trigger a very specific class and a set of Personal Perks. Unfortunately, [Fairy Beast] prevented the user from receiving any experience afterward, trapping them in their current state.

All in all, it meant that while the System’s rules couldn’t be broken, they had loopholes that one could exploit.

“You will have my gratitude if you succeed,” Cybele replied, before adding with cynicism. “But I remain skeptical.”

Well, Victor liked his odds. “For your image, I believe you need to add more prestige to your priests.”

This offended the goddess. “Are you saying that it is not prestigious to serve under me?”

“Not at all, milady,” Victor replied quickly while taking a deferential tone. Unlike a Seng or a Vainqueur, Cybele didn’t need to be flattered, but she expected respect. “But they are too accessible. I mean, the first time I met Allison, we couldn’t arrange a friendly date because she was overbooked managing werewolf orgies. If you are too *easy* with your worshipers, then they will take you for granted.”

“But I believe in free love and happiness for everyone,” Cybele replied. “Except for Sablar and his worshipers, whom I strike with infertility.”

“Well, I—” Victor frowned. “Wait, you can do that?”

“Victor, I am the goddess of agriculture, and thus fertility. I can turn it on and off for any mortal.” Her fingers fidgeted in subtle embarrassment. “This is how I curse people who annoy me. Why? I cannot make you infertile, Victor; I bet too much on your family line.”

“Oh no. I would have asked before I actually had kids, but now that I realize they are *cute* and *wonderful* and that I *love* them and I want as many as I ca—” Victor suddenly calmed himself, before he went into another rant. “But, isn’t there a way to turn it on and off? It would remove many headaches.”

“I do not understand.”

“Lady Cybele, look at me.” Victor extended his arms. “I am *easy*.”

The goddess marked a short pause, as if he had stated the Earth was round. “I know. That is why I Claimed you.”

“But since I made myself easy, now everyone takes me for granted and wants a piece of me,” Victor argued. “It was flattering at first, but now I

literally had to clone myself to complete important work. You have the same problem; you and your priests are so nice, that you are taken for granted.”

Charisma check successful.

The goddess shifted in her seat, a bit uncomfortable. “My vestals and followers can say no to pleasurable activities. I strongly believe in the right to consent or not. My problem is that people *only* approach my priests *for* these activities, instead of other services.”

“That is why I suggest putting separation between various religious services,” Victor said. “A time for blessing the fields, a time to provide ancient knowledge, etc... this will allow you to weed out false worshipers only interested in indoor activities, and cater to potential followers interested in other aspects of your portfolio.”

The goddess silently pondered the proposal.

“Instead of having vestals providing pleasurable services to everyone all the time, I suggest making sacred prostitution a special occasion once a month,” Victor pressed his point, “Make your religious service a big ceremony where supplicants must follow a strict protocol to receive ancient wisdom, bless the fields to favor fertility, and *then* have the kinky stuff at the end.”

It worked for the Greeks’ oracles. Cybele only had to do like every civilization, copy them, and rebrand their ideas.

“So you suggest improving my godly prestige by making access to my vestals something rare and exclusive?” the goddess asked, Victor nodding. “You know you sound a bit too much like Shesha?”

“Maybe, but does it make it any less true?” Victor smiled behind his helmet, having pinpointed her problem. “Do you want people to *like* you, or to *respect* you?”

Charisma check successful!

Cybele nodded to herself with newfound enthusiasm. “A ceremony that honors all my portfolio without a singular focus on one domain...”

Well, Victor knew that it would always be about pleasure for some people, but it was her best chance to rework her image. “How about the ‘Greenhand Reunion’ for your ceremony’s title?”

“How about the *Sutra Cybele*?” the goddess replied, making Victor squint behind his helmet; unfortunately, she took his silence for something else. “Sutra Cybele it is.”

Reforming her image was going to be a tough and difficult war. “So about the fertility issue, it is not that I don't want any new kids now; but I want to know when and with whom I have them. Exclusivity and rarity.”

“In that case, if you do not want a child, you simply have to say a safe word,” Cybele said. “Scream my name.”

Well, won't that be awkward. But at least it removed a thorn in his foot. “Thank you, Lady Cy—”

Ping!

Cybele seemed rather surprised. “But the time is not up yet!”

“Minion... minion... minion!”

Not even the gods could prevent Vainqueur from summoning Victor to his side, as his body was torn from Cybele's planar realm and brought back to his friend's hoard.

“Minion...” Vainqueur whispered, sitting on his golden hoard. “There you are... there you are, minion...”

“Your Majesty?” Victor frowned, surprised by his master's voice. “Why are you whispering? Are we being listened to?”

“I sang for a day and a half...” Vainqueur rasped, massaging his neck with his hand. “My throat is *sore*...”

A day and a half? Gods damn it, the pantheon won't let him get anything done.

As if to answer his thoughts, Kia teleported in the vault in a flash of bright light, ignoring just about every magical defense they had set in place.

"Thanks for the lift, Lady Leone!" the [Paladin] shouted, before turning to the V&V members. "Here you are."

"Manling Kia... heal my golden voice..." Vainqueur ordered, the shining knight casting a [Full Heal] spell on the dragon. A second later, the dragon could again speak normally. "Better. Now I can sing once again!"

"No!" Kia panicked, much to Vainqueur's displeasure. "I mean, Your Majesty flooded the entire planet already!"

Finally, after so much time spent around dragons, she had learned how to handle them. Almost.

"Minion, why should I deprive the world of this pleasure?" the dragon asked pompously.

"If Your Majesty does it again, it will lose its luster!" Victor came to her support. "Please, do not turn this imperishable memory into something mundane! Let the bards sing for you instead!"

"Excellent idea, minion," Vainqueur said. "Order Pink Ranger to create a new war song, to inspire my troops as they carry on to our inevitable victory."

That may have been even worse.

"About that, we have *just* enough time before the invasion of Prydain to finally do this dungeon sidequest," Kia said, still determined to claim its prize, "and obtain the [Plot Armor]."

"I received a divine mission to participate in it as well," Victor added. "If only to meet one of the nominees."

“Then it is settled,” Vainqueur declared, enthusiastic at the idea of winning a prize and stretching his legs. “We complete this quest, right after I take a gold shower.”

Vainqueur was in a great mood for this last-minute quest.

Not only had he improved the living conditions of minions worldwide, but the Conclave had listened to his wise words and awoken the slumbering dragons all across the world. It had been a tiring, exhausting ordeal, and the dragon enjoyed the feeling of his hoard against his scales.

His chief of staff and Knight Kia had prepared themselves for this adventure with care, fully equipping themselves with armor and weapons. The Vizier had knelt before Vainqueur while holding his scythe, praying his godly minion to bring the quest to them.

“Please, Lord Deathjester, can you summon us to the dungeon contest?” Manling Victor closed his eyes, as if listening to an invisible voice. The more he heard, the less he liked it. “Do I have to say that? She is right next to me, you know. That would be rude.”

“He wants you to insult Mithras in my presence, doesn’t he?” Knight Kia asked, her arms crossed. “Before you do it, I will remind you that *my* god kindly agreed to *your* selfish request.”

“Hey, *I* have nothing against Mithras personally: it’s not my fault my patrons and yours don’t get along.”

“Minion, get on with it,” Vainqueur ordered. This was their last quest before their final dragon-fomor war, not a minion dispute.

Manling Victor sighed, before raising his scythe [Harvest]. “*Screw the law, and paladins too.*”

As he spoke these words, a flash of bright light swallowed the trio whole.

You are being forcefully teleported! [**Immovable**] activated...

[**Immovable**] overridden by [**Deathjester**].

In the blink of an eye, Vainqueur found himself transported in the middle of a sandy, dome-like arena of solid stones; and duly welcomed by thousands of cheers. Knight Kia fumed in anger at his left, and Manling Victor stood at his right.

Separated from the trio by high walls, the stands were packed with hundreds of cloaked undead, Agarthans, beastkin, fiends, and other creatures. The dragon even noticed the strange naga that originally proposed the quest to them in the higher rows.

“Greetings everyone!” Vainqueur glanced at a promontory overseeing the arena. A raven beastkin, an armored dwarf, and an elf vampire were sitting on thrones there, the first of them talking with a showman’s charm. “Finally, I thought we would never have a decent adventurer team for this year! Now, I know the current times are a hard one for the dungeon industry, with dragons demolishing them left and right...”

“The adventuring market is changing so fast these days,” the dwarf added, before pumping her fist. “But that only means our engineers must innovate and adapt.”

“I am so excited about our current edition,” the dark elf added, before blowing a kiss to Manling Victor; the Vizier returned the gesture, much to Knight Kia’s annoyance. “Even more since our challengers are none other than the mighty V&V!”

“Who else?!” Vainqueur showed his chest proudly, acclaimed by the audience. “Behold, the greatest dragon in the world, and the most perfect minion!”

“And Kia Bekele,” the birdkin added, the audience booing the [Paladin] upon recognizing her unworthiness as a minion.

“Mithras protects us from this madness,” Knight Kia whispered, trying to keep some dignity.

“I’m afraid prayer won’t help here, unless they’re prayers for *death*!” the raven said, clapping his hands. “Can these three survive all our architects’

best traps? You will know it by staying tuned on this new edition... of the *Deadie Awards!*”

The stadium erupted in cheers, Vainqueur basking in their adoration.

“This competition shall be shown to all of the lower planes in real time, thanks to our partnership with our co-sponsors from Infercorp and Maure Hellcorporated,” the birdkin announced, flying mirrors appearing all around Vainqueur’s group. “I am Deathjester, this is Camilla and Veran; together, we are the Dread Three.”

“While we sponsor this event and ensure everyone will respect the rules, the choice of best dungeon will be left to the V&V team's judgment,” the dark elf, Camilla, took over. “So far, only a few dungeons were nominated for this year. If the entire team survives, they will receive a monetary prize and ___,”

“How much?” Vainqueur immediately asked the important question, wanting to hear the magic number.

“One million gold coins!” Veran the dwarf shouted in response, much to Vainqueur’s—and the audience’s—delight, “Alongside the famed artifact, the terror of overlords everywhere... the terrifying [Plot Armor]!”

“Let us introduce our nominees!” Deathjester snapped his fingers. “Who have been recently reduced to two, after the competition vanished under *‘mysterious circumstances’!*”

Two pillars of flames erupted in front of Vainqueur and his minions, familiar faces manifesting before them. The first was the dark shape of the Forgotten One, his ancient and now ignored enemy, the evil lich Furibon. The second a goblin with blackened nails and a crimson cloak.

The lich waved at the audience with smugness, before noticing Vainqueur and freezing in place. The goblin simply pissed himself at the dragon’s sight. The critter looked vaguely familiar too, like the one they had met in the Teikoku Empire...

“Oh, hi Furibon!” Victor waved a hand at the lich with friendliness, overtaken by the undead's fiendish charm. “It’s been a while! We need to talk as soon as possible.”

“First of all, our favorite,” Deathjester announced with a booming voice. “The lich Furibon—”

“No,” the Forgotten One declared immediately, shaking his head once, then twice. “Just no. I give up.”

“Me too!” the red-cloaked goblin screamed for his life.

“Wise choice!” Vainqueur replied although the public didn’t share his vision. Every spectator started booing the nominees.

“You *forfeit* your dungeon’s nomination in the Deadie Awards?” Deathjester asked the nominees, most displeased. “We do *not* tolerate quitters in this competition. Turn back, and you shall never be nominated again!”

While doubt overtook Furibon, the goblin persisted. “I give up!”

Vainqueur squinted at him, now sure that he had seen that critter somewhere...

Skill check successful!

...

His old chief of staff, who abandoned him in his sleep!

“It was you!” Vainqueur roared with such anger, that it made the entire arena tremble. “You cowardly, good for nothing goblin! It was you all along!”

“Send me back!” the goblin pleaded, as Vainqueur opened his mouth to eat the treacherous creature. “Send me back!”

CHOMP!

Vainqueur's jaws closed on an empty spot, the goblin having teleported away at the last second.

"Veran, you could have let him finish his meal," Deathjester chastised the armored dwarf, "That would have been appropriate for the current situation."

"Jesty, he is my chosen's father," Veran argued. "You know how much I value family."

"Oh, that makes me think, your wedding anniversary is next week, right?" the dark elf of the trio asked her colleague. "I am almost finished with creating the [Zombie Clowns]."

The birdkin coughed, forcing his two colleagues to focus. Vainqueur himself growled in frustration, but reassured himself in that he knew where this treacherous goblin lived. "Furibon, give us your answer. I would be loath to cancel this competition, so make the right choice."

Everyone looked at the lich, including a furious Vainqueur. He seemed trapped in an inner conflict, debating with himself. "Knightsbane..." he muttered. "But my award! But Knightsbane... but no competition!"

"Furibon, if it reassures you, personally I'm mostly here to have a serious conversation about the shield you set around Murmurin's castle," Manling Victor said. "We can skip straight to it without trashing your dungeon first."

"Truly?" the lich asked, clearly eager to spend as little time in their presence as possible.

"Minion, what are you talking about?" Vainqueur chastised his chief of staff. "I am not giving up on one million coins!"

"I would like the [Plot Armor] too," Knight Kia said.

"In that case, we can discuss the matter while tackling your dungeon, Furibon," Manling Victor changed his tune, trying to save the one million

coin prize. “It will be like when we attacked your castle during the *War of the Hoard*.”

“That does not help your case,” the lich hissed angrily. “At all.”

“But we will do it *right* this time!”

“We will do it by the book,” Knight Kia argued. “Quickly and efficiently.”

“That’s what he said,” Deathjester cackled, the knight glaring at him.

“Don't you dare deny me one million coins, Forgotten One,” Vainqueur warned. “I may have forgotten your past transgressions, but do not remind me of why I despised you in the first place.”

“Do it!” the crowd shouted, “Do it! Do it!”

In the end, the Forgotten One had no choice but to submit to the people's will. “Fine,” Furibon said, before dramatically waving his hand at the crowd. “But you brought it on yourself. We shall discuss this shield matter as you suffer in the Tomb of Furibon... the Painful Dungeon!”

Chapter 136: Dungeon Waltz

5000 gold coins per person.

“Never!” Vainqueur roared almost immediately, his head hitting the ceiling and causing the entire hall to tremble. “Never!”

“That’s evil,” Friend Victor added, a flying mirror floating near his face, as he examined the barrier preventing them from accessing the dungeon’s depths. It was a purple replica of the shield around the Murmurin castle. “I’m sure he raised the price somehow.”

Vainqueur had thought the Forgotten One reformed after he put a dragon statue in his dungeon’s first hall. But instead, the lich made a twisted mockery of it, forcing noble, generous dragons to make the ultimate sacrifice!

The lich hadn’t abandoned his old tricks. If anything, he had become even worse!

“Paralyzed by indecision yet?” Furibon’s voice echoed through the walls, the Forgotten One having hidden in the depths of his domain while V&V had been teleported at the entrance. Safe from the dragon’s wrath.

“A dragon does not pay a fee!” Vainqueur declared, activating [Spell Purge] and attempting to get through the barrier. Instead, the field around him hit the magical protection like two pieces of armor colliding with one another, one unable to break past the other.

Your [Spell Purge] couldn’t affect [Furibon’s Anti-Vainqueur Barrier]!

“Did you truly think I would not counter that Perk, after you used it to take over my castle?” Furibon’s voice cackled at Vainqueur with great smugness.

“I will break the ceiling and get around it!” the dragon snarled back, refusing to give up in the face of the lead devil.

“Your Majesty won’t be able to do so,” Manling Victor said, he and Knight Kia inspecting the magical defense. “I’ve analyzed it with spells, and it forms a dome around the dungeon.”

“Could you disable it?” Knight Kia asked the Vizier. “You can cast Tier IX spells now, no? That barrier must be in the same tier range.”

Furibon’s laughter echoed through the dungeon. “Tier X, [Paladin]! Tier X!”

“Even if it was, it would take me months to create a counter,” the chief of staff replied. “Don’t you have in-built antimagic? I thought [Saints] could ignore most spells.”

“I already tried,” the [Paladin] replied. “If it can resist Vainqueur’s [Spell Purge], no anti-magic will pierce it.”

“In that case...” Manling Victor casually strolled through the barrier and walked to the other side, none the worse to wear. “Ta-da!”

“What the...” the Forgotten One’s voice turned almost embarrassed. “How did you do that?”

“[Skeleton Key],” Manling Victor replied with great smugness, having turned the tables on the lich. “It makes me count as invited for the purpose of any magical protection. It caused me a few problems, about time it was useful.”

“I accounted for anti-magic effects, but not Perks playing on the entry condition...” Furibon grumbled to himself. “I will patch it out.”

“Can you carry us through, minion?” Vainqueur asked, his friend shaking his head. Apparently, his Perk only counted *him* as ‘invited.’

It appeared that, for the sake of the one million coins prize, the dragon had no choice but to compromise.

“Manling Kia,” the wyrm said with a heavy heart, looking at the frail, unworthy creature in the eye. “Pay for me.”

The [Paladin] was so floored by the fact Vainqueur *deigned* to give her life purpose, that her tiny mind couldn't handle the request. “I am sorry?”

“I shall not fold before the Forgotten One’s greed!” Vainqueur declared. “We cannot let him win the war for our hearts. So pay for me.”

“Why me?” Knight Kia protested, pointing her blade at Friend Victor. “Why not him? That’s his job!”

“Spoiling me is your destiny!” Her insolence annoyed Vainqueur; he kept giving her chances to prove herself as a minion, but she always disappointed. “And unlike you, Friend Victor has children to take care of.”

“Yeah, I just received a parental raise,” Manling Victor replied, before looking at the ceiling. “Hey Furi, is your spell a souped-up version of [Spirit Shield]?”

“It was an inspiration,” the dungeon’s owner replied. “Though I am surprised you know that spell. Clearly, you have studied magic since we went our own ways.”

“Since it can cover a whole dungeon, do you think it could protect a city?”

“Could be. How big of a city are we talking about?”

While Manling Victor and the cruel lich engaged in a spell debate, Vainqueur kept his attention all on Knight Kia. He gave her a stern, focused stare, that of a parent asking a naughty child to behave.

“Guys, could I...” Knight Kia cleared her throat, finally realizing that there was no evading her duty this time, “could I borrow some money?”

“No,” Vainqueur said flatly.

“Kia, you can’t pay your fee?” Manling Victor asked, astonished by the female manling’s stinginess. “It’s just five thousand, ten if you pay for

Vainqueur's fee. It shouldn't be such a big deal."

"I'm, I'm short right now, but I'll pay you back as soon as I can, I promise!"

Charisma check... **Failed!**

Knight Kia didn't sound in the black!

Friend Victor wisely doubted her words, and assessed the financial risk. "How short?"

Knight Kia made an embarrassed face. "... a short shade of red."

"You're in debt?!" The Vizier replied, making the [Paladin] wince.

"Don't say that out loud, they're live streaming it to *Hell!*" the knight protested.

"I knew it!" Vainqueur shouted, caring nothing about poor-shaming her. "That was why Grandrake could not hear you!"

"Kia, how can *you* be in debt?" Friend Victor was at a loss of words. "You're the Shining Knight! The greatest hero in the land!"

"I have a noble domain, but wandering alcoholism is not a sustainable lifestyle!"

"But we were paid a fortune to conquer J—" Manling Victor stopped, as the knight glared at him. "Oh right, you didn't participate."

"This is on you," Vainqueur declared. "This is the Elder Wyrms' punishment for your poor money-management skills."

Instead of taking this wisdom as a chance to improve, the [Paladin] held to her insane delusions. "I would rather live poor, than get rewarded for unethical behavior."

“You know what, alright,” Manling Victor said before Vainqueur could taunt her mercilessly, “I’ll loan you ten thousand, so you can pay for your and His Majesty’s fee.”

“How much will I owe you?” Knight Kia squinted, suspicious.

“No usury, no interests... although I may take your soul as collateral...”

“Don’t push it, Vic.”

After Knight Kia paid Vainqueur’s entry fee with borrowed money, the group progressed down the cramped stairs of the dungeon, quickly making their way into an immense, incredibly long underground hallway. The path went down, and down, and down...

Skill check successful!

Click.

When they were a third of the way down, something heavy fell right behind the trio. Vainqueur peeked over his shoulder to look back. “What is it?”

An enormous, fiery boulder the size of the dragon himself had fallen behind them, rolling down and threatening to crush the group.

Unable to turn around due to the cramped space, Vainqueur lazily raised his tail at the boulder...

And whipped it!

Strength check successful!

The rock crashed against the back entrance with a loud noise, embedded in the stone. The flames had licked Vainqueur’s scales, filling them with a pleasurable sensation.

“Seriously, a boulder trap?” Manling Victor asked, clearly disappointed.

“That’s cliché!”

“I knew this would happen,” Furibon’s voice complained. “I knew this would happen, and I still let them sweet-talk me into it...”

“Wait, it’s Starmetal,” Knight Kia walked below Vainqueur to observe the rock more closely. Her face turned red with outrage. “You have tons of Starmetal. The most precious material in the world, which is super effective against the fomors... and you used it to make a *trap boulder*?”

Furibon marked a long pause afterward. “Once again, my artistic soul remains unappreciated. Alas for you, even if you stopped my rockfall, you shall never survive this hallway of dea—”

“Sweet!” Manling Victor shouted as he discovered a trap hidden in the walls. “Booby-trapped wands! Who wants one?”

“Give them to me, minion,” Vainqueur said, always eager to add new trinkets to his collection.

“I’m sure there is a pit going forward,” Knight Kia said, slowly advancing while checking the ground with her blade. “Stay behind me, I got this.”

Friend Victor, meanwhile, had the time of his life disabling the magical traps. “A wand of [Dire Wilting]! I always wanted one!”

The Forgotten One’s frustrated sigh was music to Vainqueur’s ears.

What followed was a casual waltz through the dungeon, with Vainqueur taking the time to rate the architecture of each room. While the vile Furibon was best left forgotten, the dragon had to admit that he had a talent for building cramped spaces.

“Eight out of ten, leaning on nine,” Vainqueur decided after he and his minions went through a wall full of gargoyles. The statues had briefly animated to stop them, noticed the dragon, then wisely returned to their original spot. “I find the dedication to perfect symmetry dizzying, but this dungeon seriously lacks in warmer color. Such as red and gold.”

The sound of rats in the walls was a nice touch, although it made him hungry.

“Oh, a wand of [Big Metal Unit],” Knight Kia rejoiced, upon observing the pile of magical items Manling Victor carried in his arms. “I thought no one could cast it directly? Can I—”

“No touching, until you pay your debt first.”

The [Paladin] punched the Vizier in the arm, before opening the doors to the next room. Unfortunately, they proved very small by dragon standards, forcing Vainqueur to squeeze through.

“Three out of ten!” Vainqueur snarled, as he struggled to get through once reaching the halfway point. “This dungeon is not dragon-friendly!”

“This is a design feature,” Furibon’s voice mocked him. “Just tall enough to let a large dragon through, but cramped to make it as uncomfortable as possible!”

His cruelty knew no bounds!

In the end, Manling Victor and Knight Kia had to push him through, Vainqueur’s back reaching against the ceiling.

Thankfully, his efforts were rewarded with the sight of a dozen treasure chests; poor, lonely coffers waiting for a caring dragon to loot them.

Only Knight Kia, in her pauperness, remained doubtful and drew her sword. “This smells like a mimic trap.”

“Of course, stay back,” Manling Victor said. “I’m good with them.”

Upon hearing him speak, one of the chests immediately hopped in Victor’s direction, startling Knight Kia. The Vizier looked at the animated item, radiating warmth and caring.

The mimic asked, almost hopefully, “*Daddy?*”

Manling Victor gasped. “Kids!”

“Daddy!” All the chests in the room grew legs and rushed towards the Vizier. “Daddy!”

In a display of fatherly affection, the [Reaper] dumped his wands and scythe on Knight Kia, before rushing to embrace the loving chests. “I’m adopting you!” Friend Victor all but squealed like a little girl, as the mimics purred in happiness. “I’m adopting you all!”

“You see, minion?” Vainqueur shamed Knight Kia, who watched the scene with a strange face. “This is what true minion brotherhood looks like. This is something you will never experience!”

“This has gone on long enough!” Furibon snarled, the walls opening.

Immediately, Knight Kia adopted a fighting stance, while Manling Victor was too busy hugging mimics. Ferocious quaking echoed through the room, as ducks emerged from the secret passages. Their eyes burned with anger, and the primal desire to see the world *burnt*.

The dragon in the room rejoiced. “A free buffet, at long last!”

Then the ducks noticed Vainqueur... and the saliva going down the wyrm’s mouth. The birds’ expression turned from cruelty to abject fear.

Singing for days made a dragon very hungry, and he could never say no to roasted ducks.

In the end, Friend Victor adopted half the monsters in the dungeon, after Vainqueur ate everyone else. The ducks in particular were so spicy and delicious, that the dragon considered breeding them with cats, to enjoy devouring them again and again.

“You know, I was worried about this being a 'painful' dungeon, but so far it is a very pleasant and relaxing experience,” Knight Kia said, a trail of monsters following Manling Victor like children at kindergarten. “I would come back.”

“Me too!” Manling Victor carrying a purring, tiny metal slime on his shoulder.

“No!” Furibon’s angry voice echoed. “No!”

“Quiet,” Vainqueur ordered his minions, old and new. “I smell gold.”

A short while later, they finally made their way to the dungeon’s hoard!

And what a treasure it was! Hills of coins, gems, and shinies, sealed in a vault even bigger than Vainqueur’s own! Just the thought of adding all this wealth to his own filled his heart with rainbows!

Yet as soon as the entire group walked in, and before the dragon could engage in a golden bath, the door closed behind them. The coins shifted on their own...

“No...” Vainqueur shook his head in panic, as the hoard took the shape of a humanoid. “Impossible!”

He faced the ultimate defense against dragons. A living hoard!

A humanoid coin golem challenged V&V, a monster bigger than the ones defending Vainqueur’s own hoard. The creature shone bright with the splendor of a million coins and gems, something as terrible as it was shiny.

Vainqueur could not harm true gold, could not bear to do the deed himself.

So he had no choice but to throw a pauper at it.

“Knight Kia, do it!” he ordered, before turning his head away as the [Paladin] charged forward with a wicked grin. The dragon couldn’t bear the sight of the following massacre.

Yet he heard every sickening moment. Every clash of poverty against wealth; every sword strike cutting a coin in half. Manling Victor had to pat his master on the arm during the whole ordeal, to appease him.

A minute later, powered by her drive to alleviate her debt, Knight Kia had murdered the poor hoard. She would carry this sin, and the guilt, for all her life.

“Is it done?” Vainqueur asked, averting his gaze until Manling Victor assured him it was safe. The dragon looked at the treasure left for him, taking comfort in that the gold would alleviate his wounded heart.

Intelligence check successful!

Vainqueur immediately turned suspicious. “Forgotten One, are you up to your old mischief again?”

The lich waited a moment to answer. “No...”

“He doesn’t change gold to lead,” Manling Victor said after examining the hoard, before immediately changing his tune, “Because *this* is already lead turned into gold. A spell simply reverts the coins to their original state once they get past a certain perimeter.”

“Makes sense,” Knight Kia said. “A dungeon like this one must be crazy expensive. It would surprise me if Furibon had enough funds to maintain it *and* afford a treasure so big.”

“You could turn lead to gold at any time, Forgotten One?” Vainqueur was *outraged*. “Why? Why did you even use your power for lead in the first place? You could have saved the Moon!”

Furibon sighed in true and utter defeat.

“Just take the items and go.”

Chapter 137: The Plot Armor

After many joys and triumphs, Vainqueur and his minions finally made it to the ‘boss room,’ or so Manling Victor called it.

Unable to unlive past his crushing defeat in the War of the Hoard, the Forgotten One had recreated his old throne room down to the very last detail. The dragon recognized the ghostly candelabras, the armored statues on each side, the chains hanging from the ceiling... ah, the nostalgia.

Furibon observed the group smash their way into his lair, crumpling on his throne. A horde of slimes, mimics, and assorted minions poured into the room, shattering the silence with a noisy cacophony.

“Children, please calm down!” Manling Victor whistled, his newfound minions looking up at him in religious silence. “We are now in the boss room, the place where the most powerful monster in the area waits to kill adventurers. If you do not behave, Furibon will eat you!”

“I resent this slander on my person,” the lich rasped, while the slimes cowered behind their Vizier protector.

“True, for once, you not only ate baby minions, but baby coins too!” Vainqueur accused him. For he may have been forgotten, never would he be forgiven!

Knight Kia, however, could barely restrain her excitement. “I’m so pumped for the final battle! Can I solo him? Paladin versus lich, it was meant to be!”

“Furi, you made yourself the final boss?” Manling Victor asked the Forgotten One.

“Yes, but I do not care anymore,” Furibon replied, sounding utterly defeated on his throne. “You win. You win! Happy now?”

“Oh come on!” Knight Kia complained, itching for a fight. “Just a short battle! You can’t back away now!”

“The boss was in you all along,” the lich said as a lazy excuse. “By facing your fears, you defeated it.”

Clearly, Vainqueur had crushed the undead’s hopes and dreams. Broken as he was, he would never disguise lead as gold ever again. This satisfied the wyrm, but not Knight Kia, who booed the lich. "Refund!"

“You made a mockery of my dungeon!” Furibon complained. “All this work designing the hardest, most painful experience an adventurer party could ever know... wasted!”

“Furi, the time of dungeons challenging people ended with dragons,” Manling Victor argued. “And that’s fine. We adventurers don’t go to a dungeon for torture, no matter what the name would imply; we dungeon-crawl to have fun, for loot, and levels!”

“For what it is worth, I enjoyed myself today, up until now,” Knight Kia added, her eyes looking at the throne with longing. “The nostalgia made me relive my early adventuring years.”

“While this dungeon was not up to my standards, it was somewhat passable,” Vainqueur replied with disdain. “The ducks were a plus.”

Furibon’s ghostly gaze flared up when the dragon demeaned his dungeon, but instead of unleashing deadly spells, he simply sighed. “I do not have energy left for anger.”

“Come on, just a boss speech,” Manling Victor pleaded, holding a metal slime in his hands. “For the children. For the *children*.”

Faced with a hundred minions gazing at him with their cute, adorable eyes, Furibon had no choice but to oblige. Muttering under his nonexistence

breath, he rose up from his throne, dark magic crackling in his bony fingers.

“You went farther than you should have, mortals!” Furibon’s voice echoed with the power of Happyland itself, terrifying the slimes. “But you have yet to meet *Furibon* either. Your journey is over, tiny ones. Time... to DIE!”

The entire minion horde erupted into tears and screams.

Furibon sank back into his throne, happy to have traumatized so many children.

A strange sound echoed in the dungeon, the flying mirrors that watched the participants during their entire adventure moving in circles around the throne.

“Time for the final vote,” Camilla’s voice spoke through the devices.

“I thought this dungeon would be a tragedy, but then I realized it was a comedy all along,” Deathjester added. “Even better!”

“Let our participants give their final judgment,” Veran finished. “Rate this dungeon on a scale from one to ten.”

“Ten out of ten!” Manling Victor rejoiced, petting a crying mimic. “It’s cute, family-friendly, and scares children straight for life. We have to teach our kids how the real world works, for their sake.”

Knight Kia hesitated but remained professional. “Nine out of ten. It was just the right balance between a relaxing experience and a power-trip. The lack of a final boss subverted my expectations, but not in a good way. But I would still come back.”

“Mmm...” Vainqueur hesitated. On one hand, Furibon built his dungeon with great cruelty, and the dragon could never give a ten to a place needing a fee to get into. The murder of the innocent, living hoard could not go unpunished either.

Yet, the dragon had come out of this place with new minions, great rewards, and a full belly. The ducks in particular earned Furibon a few points.

“Six out of ten,” Vainqueur settled on his final score. Let it not be said that the Emperor wasn’t merciful to his former enemies.

“Six out of ten?” An ember of wrath lit up in Furibon’s empty eye sockets. “Six out of ten, wyrm?!”

“This is not the worst cave I’ve been in, but not the best either,” Vainqueur defended his visionary judgment.

Yet, in his wickedness, Furibon did not respond to this wisdom with humility, but with anger. “Change your vote, wyrm!” the lich ordered. “No dungeon of mine shall ever get such a poor rating!”

“Nothing can change a dragon’s mind, Forgotten One!”

“Defeat shall!” Furibon snapped his finger, a table materializing between his throne and the dragon. “A ten if I win, a zero if I lose!”

“Bring it!” Vainqueur roared back. Manling Victor, ever prepared, searched in his armor’s pouches and brought out his master’s deck.

And so, Vainqueur fought a boss battle worthy of him.

After the Monster Poker rematch of the century, the group was teleported back to the arena, where the Dread Three delivered awards. Only Furibon had survived all the way to this ceremony, backed by his adventuring party and dungeon architects.

From the ‘innocent’ smiles which Furibon’s team wore on their face, Victor had a pretty good idea of what happened to the other competitors. Everything was fair in war and television.

“Congratulations, Furibon,” Deathjester declared, handing the lich five golden statues, each representing a paladin dying in fun and unexpected ways. “You earned a Deadie Award in ‘*Most Lethal Dungeon*,’ ‘*Best Supporting Miniboss*,’ ‘*Best Dungeon Boss*,’ ‘*Best Dungeon Design*,’ and ‘*Best Dungeon Sound Design*.”

“How?” the lich asked, sounding both astonished and somewhat pleased. “Even if I avenged my honor at the end, they crushed my life’s work on live divination!”

“I will show the lich vengeance...” Vainqueur mumbled to himself, still angry after his loss at Monster Poker. The dragon had fought with ferocity, but not even the heart of the cards could prevail against the enraged lich.

Such a spectacular duel though, Victor thought. He would remember it for all of his life.

“All your competition either died or fled,” Camilla explained. “Since you alone were brave and strong enough to survive V&V’s presence in your life, you win by default. Your Monster Poker battle was by far the most-watched match in the game’s history.”

“At the Deadie Awards, we reward determination.” Veran patted the lich on the back. “Furibon, this team wrecked almost everyone they encountered, but you? You survived to antagonize them again and again.”

“I believe you are bound to do that forever,” Deathjester added mirthfully.

“I should feel insulted. I should. This is an unjust victory.” Furibon then claimed the prizes. “But you are right. I *deserve* these awards.”

Victor didn’t pay much attention to the congratulatory speeches and clapping that followed. He was too busy tending to his hundred new *adorable* slimes and finding names for each of them.

Jean-Pierre Boxy; Boxonaro; Slimella; Glunine; Mr. Jellydean; Sticker; Emmanuel Money...

Junior and Buzz Jelly would have such a good time with all these new friends!

“Where is my reward?” Vainqueur demanded, interrupting a birdkin’s speech about how Furibon crushed all his hopes so much, that he had grown to enjoy it. “I came for a prize, and I do not see it!”

The Dread Three exchanged a glance, making a strange face; it was as if they feared what would follow. “Give it to us,” Kia said, giddy like a child. “You cannot stop it.”

“A promise is a promise, [Paladin].” Camilla frowned in response, insulted.

“I don’t feel particularly bound to honor an agreement, but I have the gut feeling that you will screw this up somehow,” Deathjester replied, waving his hand dramatically at an empty spot to his right. “Here it is... the [Plot Armor]!”

The most terrible piece of clothing ever designed immediately appeared.

It could barely be called an armor at all, being crafted from crimson, folded paper. This hideous, giant origami creation looked like a knight’s armor, helmet included, but seemed about to fall apart on itself at any moment. Words appeared scribbled on every inch of it, as if someone had used trashy novels as the main material.

“This thing will not protect anyone,” Vainqueur stated the obvious. Besides being made of folded paper, it had holes everywhere it shouldn’t. “I could burn it with embers!”

Less convinced, Victor analyzed it with [Eye for Treasure], just in case.

Plot Armor

Quality: S+ (Major Artifact)

Material: Badly-written novels and villain’s tears ink.

Endurance: ∞/∞

Protection: Physical +1 and Magical +1 per friend and true believer.

Weight: Flavorful.

Bonus: +500 Luck to all checks to avoid dying. Can only be worn by someone with good karma, or else the bonuses become penalties (the armor

will identify Karma frauds).

An ancient suit of armor worn by spoony bards, plucky farmland boys, noir detectives, and countless other unlikely heroes chosen by destiny. As long as you wear it, this gear will protect you from death, although you can be defeated/K.O.ed, especially if it would raise narrative tension. If you somehow die while wearing the [Plot Armor], you will soon be revived with a stat increase and newfound determination.

However, the armor will force the wearer to say corny, cliché lines at inappropriate times. You are warned.

+500 *Luck*?!

“Many of our students at Scholomance doubted the power in this armor, and it cost them,” Camilla explained, upon noticing Victor’s astonishment. “It took us great pain and effort to claim it.”

“With the fomors’ acting up though, it will find no better a user than you,” Deathjester said, although he blatantly dismissed Kia’s presence.

“As for the other part of the prize.” Veran snapped her fingers. “One million coins!”

A torrent of gold started raining from the heavens, showering Vainqueur’s whole body. The audience just went wild, as the dragon let out a happy roar, rolling himself on the ground while coins fell down his scales.

“[Leone’s Peeping Shield].” A fitting room appeared out of nowhere around Kia, velvet curtains protecting her modesty from the crowd, as she grabbed the [Plot Armor] to put it on.

While Vainqueur and Kia amused themselves, and the Dread Three addressed the crowd to pitch the next year’s edition, Victor approached Furibon. “No offense if I take all the slimes with me?” the Vizier asked his sort-of *‘Stockholm friend.’*

“No, you showed me that I should stick to the classics. I will replace them with mindless, carnivorous undead and merciless golems.” Furibon teleported his awards away, emptying his hands. “I have given thought to what you told me, about the era of hard, painful dungeons ending. Maybe there is truth in it.”

“Your Tomb will find more success as a horror-themed tourist attraction,” Manling Victor suggested.

“I am a purist through and through,” Furibon said, before changing the subject. “So... you will invade Prydain?”

“We need all the help we can get, especially to shield population centers from their arrows,” Victor argued. “Even your Starmetal boulder would be a huge help if we could reforge it into weapons. What I mean to ask is, will you join us?”

The lich fell into silence, considering the matter deeply. The thoughtful undead probably pondered the hassle in helping Vainqueur, against Odieuse’s odds of victory.

“A world devastated by the fomors is not one I would call home,” Furibon finally spoke up. Unlike previous times, Victor didn’t even have to pass a charisma check to convince him. “I refuse to fight side by side with the wyrm, but... I will contribute.”

Kia soon emerged from her dressing refuge, having traded her metal armor for a paper one. She didn’t notice a *‘kick me’* sign Deathjester quickly scribbled on her back.

“How does it feel?” Victor asked, wondering how it could even hold on to her skin.

“In one word, uncomfortable.” The [Paladin] forced herself to smile. “Come, try it! Try to kill me!”

“Not while you owe me money,” Victor reminded her of his leverage. Now that he owned her financially, she would never dare touch his kids.

Vainqueur meanwhile, suddenly stopped playing with his coins and looked at the knight with hope in his eyes; as if her words had awoken an ancient instinct buried for years. “You ask to commit suicide, minion?”

Kia put her hands on her waist and opened her mouth. Yet, while it was her voice, her words were those of someone possessed. “Danger is my middle name!”

Vainqueur immediately rose to try and incinerate the [Paladin]...

Only to trip over his piles of coins.

Victor watched his best friend crash on his left shoulder with a terrible noise, blowing gold in all directions. The entire crowd fell silent, while Deathjester clearly struggled not to laugh.

Letting out a fearsome roar, Vainqueur moved back on his feet and switched to physical force. He raised his hand and attempted to smash a very smug-looking [Paladin] like a bug.

“I will protect my friends!” Kia shouted, unable to control her own mouth.

BOOM!

Something deflected Vainqueur’s palm as he brought it down on Kia, deviating the blow. Instead, the wyrm hit the nearby stand, sending the closest spectators flying.

A shield of blue energy had formed around Kia, deflecting the attack. “What is this?” Furibon asked, analyzing the protection with magic.

“The power of friendship,” Camilla sighed. “It fuels the armor, alongside love, wishes, and hope.”

“Sometimes friendship manifests as a physical force,” Deathjester added, looking at the scene with disgust. “Although it only ever did for heroes, and never for *us*.”

“Oh yes, I learned that in Scholomance,” Victor remembered. “That’s why you always advised killing the rest of the party before the leader?”

“Whose friendship?” Vainqueur complained. “She is Knight Kia, she doesn’t have any friends!”

“Jolie’s faith gives me strength!” Knight Kia recited a scripted line, causing Vainqueur to see red and try to smash her. Once more, a shield of light protected her from harm.

That armor was ridiculously overpowered.

“We are more than a team,” Kia said, reciting scripted lines, as Vainqueur stubbornly tried to kill her—and always failed, “we are a family!”

Chapter 138: Before the End

In Murmurin, the day before the invasion of Prydain, the dragons played a very loud game.

“Open fire!” Vainqueur declared, as two dozens true wyrms unleashed their breaths at a crater. [Fire], [Frost], [Lightning], [Poison], [Earth]... almost every element known to dragonkind was used, turning their target into a delightful show of light and destruction. The ground trembled for miles, minions fled in all directions, and a single figure stood in the middle of the destruction, unmoved.

“Uncle, you are harming her!” Jolie protested, as the only dragon present who refused to participate.

“I wish I did!” Vainqueur replied with wounded pride. “More power!”

“Cousin, I have a piano!” Genialissime said as he landed next to Vainqueur, showing off a black, half-crushed manling musical instrument. “I found a piano!”

“Throw it at her!”

So his cousin did, launching the musical instrument like a projectile. Linnorms and Zmeys, who lacked imagination, imitated their trueborn brethren by throwing boulders, stones, houses, trees... and in one case, even a *cow*.

“No cow throwing!” Vainqueur snarled, trying to keep this contest civilized. Gorynych lowered all his heads in shame, apologizing for being born.

At long last, the dust settled, and the dragons groaned in frustration.

Their target lived.

Unscathed, Knight Kia kept muttering nonsense, standing alone amidst ruins and devastation. She had shielded the cow with her body, as a true minion should.

“Congratulations, Kia!” Jolie chirped, shouting encouragement at her failure of a chief of staff.

“Believe in yourself!” Knight Kia replied, her words no longer her own. “I believe in you!”

While Vainqueur remained obstinate in his desire to overcome this [Plot Armor], quite a few dragons were starting to *doubt*. “There has to be something that works on her!” the emperor complained. They had been at it for six hours!

“It only protects her from death and direct damage,” Genialissime noted. “What if we throw her into the Mooooooon? Or have a minion teleport her away?”

“No!” Jolie protested.

“No,” Vainqueur said hastily. “Even she does not deserve such a horrific fate.”

Even if Manling Victor had sent many minions unto that faraway, dark planet to protect them from fairy retaliation, Vainqueur privately thought they may have been condemned to a fate worse than death. He hoped that they could retain their sanity long enough for him to eat Odieuse.

What was the Forgotten One doing? Could he not turn that cursed lead ball to gold?

“Guys, it has been amusing, but I’m taking off the armor,” Knight Kia said, as she left the crater, “or else these lines will give me diabetes.”

“Maybe we can harm her this way,” a dragon suggested. “With the power of this ‘diabetes’.”

“What about the [Life] element?” Genialissime asked, “Does anybody here breathe cancer?”

While his fellow dragons discussed how to best overcome the [Plot Armor], Vainqueur decided to take a short break and oversee his army. Tomorrow would be the moment a flight of dragons and V&V’s forces landed against Prydain’s shores. Vainqueur Day.

V-Day!

In preparation for this historical event, his minions had gathered on great ships near the shores, or boarded copies of the *PiggyBankII*. Each soldier, from the tiniest kobold to the mightiest ghoul, carried an overfed cat on their back. Vainqueur somewhat regretted that he didn’t have the time to breed these felines with cows, but took solace in knowing no minion would die of starvation.

All other minions, those who couldn’t fight, were being evacuated through portals to Happyland, the Planet Moon, or other safe zones. Were it not for the presence of dragons, Murmurin would have become a ghost town. Only the monsters necessary for the war effort remained behind, to help support the main army.

One of them was Troll Barnabas, whom Vainqueur had summoned to his castle alongside goblin smiths—the dwarven ones had all fled underground, to avoid the thirst of drunken wyrms.

“Your Majesty,” The troll bowed, as Vainqueur landed in front of his castle’s entrance, “you have need of us?”

“Yes, minion. For I wish to keep my hoard on my person at all times.”

Although the thought barely crossed his mind, the dragon understood that he might perish in this conflict. Unlike Icefang, he could not bear to leave his hoard behind, to die away from his hard-won fortune.

“You want us to create a [Bottomless Bag]?” Troll Barnabas asked. “They often eat what they are fed.”

The mere thought of coins spilling from a purse horrified Vainqueur. “No. I wish to wear my hoard on my person. To feel my gold and gems against my scales at all times; to always have them within sight, so I may protect it with my last breath if needed.”

“So...” Troll Barnabas scratched his throat. “You want me to take all of your hoard, and make what, an armor out of it?”

This was a new, innovative dragon solution to hoard management. It didn’t surprise Vainqueur that a minion failed to understand his vision, and so the dragon shared his reasoning.

“That [Plot Armor] is powerful but ridiculous,” Vainqueur said. “My hoard is the most beautiful, most perfect in existence. Its brightness blinds the strong and kills the weak on sight! If I wore it, I would be beyond invincible. I would be... *shiny!*”

And, although Vainqueur would never admit it publicly...

His true hoard was his empire and the minions that followed him.

They were the ones making the gold come in, the ones who died to fuel Vainqueur’s everlasting wealth. Just as Manling Victor was the crowning jewel of his fortune, every minion was a coin the dragon needed to protect.

Vainqueur had to remind his minions of what they stood for. The naked sight of his hoard, shining on his person, would bolster their morale and carry them to victory; the other dragons would also understand that they fought for the very survival of the dragon way of life. That they had to win at all costs.

Vainqueur’s fortune would become more than a pile of riches.

It would become a golden symbol!

“You shall take my hoard, my beautiful hoard of gold and jewels,” Vainqueur said. “And you shall use it to craft me a [Hoard Armor].”

Something shinier than the [Plot Armor], that will remind Knight Kia of her innate poverty. I want it ready for tomorrow at dawn.”

Unlike the [Paladin], Vainqueur already knew which wise lines he had to say.

By the time the war ended, all would fear the *power of gold!*

Croissant had done well for himself.

As he waited in front of a cottage built from the remains of elephant-sized spiders; with Chocolatine’s arm around his, Victor took the time to study the V&V Empire’s Moon colony.

At first glance, it looked like any ordinary hamlet, except built inside of a lead valley and with the blue planet of Outremonde in the skies above. The settlers had farms, although they cultivated strange alien trees and raised tentacled black horrors instead of goats. A portal to Murmurin pulsed in the village’s central square, newcomers crossing into the area to find a refuge away from the war.

Victor recognized a few familiar faces among the village’s inhabitants, mostly the people he had exiled here over his Vizier career. He did notice an unusual settler though, sitting on a bench in cephalopodian company.

“Victor!” Ludvic Van raised a hand at his former apprentice, a monstrous, squid-like horror sitting at his side. One of the creature’s tentacles caressed the [Fiendish Rake]’s hair, while another brushed against his left leg.

“Fancy meeting you there!”

“I see you didn’t waste time!” Victor shouted back.

“All along, I tried to find happiness in men and women,” Ludvic said, looking into his new lover’s hundred eyes. “But as it turned out, a genderless outer space squid fulfills me completely.”

“Oh, sweetie!” the abomination replied in her horrifying R’Lyehan language, holding Ludvic’s hand with its tentacle. “You make my

pseudopods all sweaty!”

Victor wisely focused back on the cottage, having no desire to watch a live Japanese porn movie. “Come on, come on!” Chocolatine couldn’t stay in place, furiously knocking on the door. “What is he doing?”

“Choc, relax,” Victor said, patting her hand to help her calm down.

“I can’t help it,” she replied, her eyes bloodshot like those of a drug addict suffering from a high. “All my stats are raised here! I want to howl all the time!”

Seeing her in this state made Victor wonder if having her stay with her brother for a while was a good solution. According to Jules, it wouldn’t harm the babies, but she had been over-excited since they set a foot on the Moon.

Isabelle had already returned to Happyland, while the rest of Victor’s family had been dispersed either across the planes or welcomed into his own pocket dimension. He would rather avoid having everyone in the same place, both for their safety and to prevent jealousy.

Finally, the lizardkin Savoureuse opened the door. “Vic, Choc, my favorite couple!” she said upon seeing them, overjoyed. “I’m so happy to see you again!”

“Me too, Sav,” Victor said. She hadn’t changed much in the last few months after the Nightblades incident, although she had traded her adventurers’ clothes for an apron and a chef’s hat. The Vizier had somewhat forgiven her for her betrayal, as he did with Croissant’s, but still condemned them both to community service.

“Come inside.” Their host let the couple enter her place before closing the door. The [Reaper] smelled a delicious scent of fish and honey, as he was led into the dining room. “I already set Chocolatine’s room upstairs. I even made four cradles, each with a different color!”

The main room reminded Victor of some hunter's sanctuary. The walls around the dinner table proudly displayed trophies straight from seventies sci-fi movies, from the head of a xenomorph-like aliens to hundred-eyed spiders.

It appeared Croissant had to fight dearly to protect this community.

Speaking of the werewolf, he was waiting for them expectantly. "Sis!" Croissant immediately hugged his sister, as if he hadn't seen her in years. Compared to last time Victor had met him, the werewolf had grown taller, heavier, and wore a suit made of some pink creature's fur. "Welcome home!"

"You're squeezing me too tight, brother!" Chocolatine complained, although clearly pleased by the attention.

The male werewolf then turned to his in-law, although the atmosphere became considerably colder. "Victor," he said, somewhat neutrally.

"Croissant," Victor replied with the same tone, shaking his hand. There was no warmth in the contact, but no animosity either. Water under the bridge.

Something else, however, bothered the Vizier greatly. "Sav?"

"Yes, Vic?"

"Why is there a bound child in your dining room?" the Vizier asked, pointing at a chained, tiny humanoid lizard forcefully sitting at the table's end.

"Silly, he's the main course!" Chocolatine replied with a smile, much to Victor's horror.

Thankfully, his brother-in-law reassured Victor. "I found him sneaking inside, trying to put a space shark in my bathtub. He was good and stealthy, but he had nothing on the spiders..."

Croissant's gaze wandered off, like a war veteran undergoing a traumatizing flashback. "The spiders... crawling everywhere... the Moonlanders, they

were watching...”

“A space shark?” Victor asked with a frown, as he sat around the dinner table next to Choc. “I heard of sand sharks, but *space* ones?”

“There are space and sand versions of every sea creature,” Savoureuse said. “Like moon squids.”

“Yes, but...” Although Victor had grown used to strangeness—enough to casually discuss over a dinner table with a child assassin bound in a corner—space fish crossed a line. “I dunno, it sounds like a god got lazy somewhere.”

“They had a UFO...” Croissant said, completely trapped in some horrifying memory, “They had a UFO, and they were drunk... but it wasn’t my cart! It wasn’t my cart!”

“Brother?” Chocolatine asked, shaking Croissant out of his PTSD episode.

“S-sorry,” the older werewolf said, regaining his sanity. He shook his head a few times, before settling in his chair and continuing with the previous discussion as if nothing happened in-between. “I would have eaten little Potiron, but he’s apparently Sav’s nephew.”

“You have been a naughty child, Potiron,” Savoureuse scolded the prisoner. “No dessert for you!”

“I wasn’t trying to kill anyone, Auntie!” the tiny reptile argued, clearly more sorry about the dessert than his attempted wolfslaughter. “Just a life scar, maybe a little maiming too.”

“Charlene asked him to ruin our relationship, and make me suffer,” Croissant explained, sighing. “She will never let me live it down.”

“You tried to eat her,” Victor pointed out, although he didn’t agree with her methods of payback.

“Haven’t we all tried to eat a boyfriend or girlfriend in this family?” Chocolatine replied. “Vic, that’s how our relationship started!”

Ah yes, she had considered making a stew out of him the first time they met. Victor had forgotten that detail. “I will have a word with Charlene,” the Vizier told Croissant. “These attempts will stop, I promise.”

He couldn’t let these events spiral into a feud.

“You should.” Chocolatine nodded. “Nobody harms my dear Croissant but himself!”

“I would appreciate it,” Croissant said, ignoring the remark. “Thing is, I deserve her scorn for trying to eat her, yes, and I understand how she feels. I have made peace with the fact I screwed up something amazing.”

“It allowed you to meet me,” Savoureuse tried to cheer him up, the werewolf smiling thinly in response. The display shocked Victor, who could never imagine Croissant as... wiser? Friendlier?

The werewolf [Ranger] had definitely grown since the last time they met. Managing a penal colony had done wonders for him.

“You could try to make up for your past,” Victor suggested, but more for himself than Croissant.

“I tried,” the male werewolf replied, scowling sorrowfully. “But... she isn’t interested in forgiving me, and clearly never will. When a door remains closed from the other side, you should walk away instead of trying to force the lock.”

“You are all so negative!” Savoureuse said, forcing everyone to sit in a perfectly symmetrical way around the table; even her prisoner. “We are here to celebrate wonderful news.”

“Yes, Victor, thank you for impregnating my innocent sister,” Croissant said with cutting sarcasm. Thankfully, Chocolatine was too happy for the free meal to notice. “How about Charlene? Did you impregnate my ex too?”

“... not yet,” Victor replied, knowing his terrible luck. “As far as I know.”

Croissant said nothing for a while, clearly displeased by the lackluster answer. “You are not going *anywhere* near my lonely single mother.”

“Agreed. So long as you protect Chocolatine while I’m away.”

“Aw, Vic.” Chocolatine rested her head against Victor’s shoulder; while Croissant remained in a sour mood, the shadow of a smile formed at the edge of his lips. “I wish that I could keep an eye on you in Prydain.”

“I wish I could keep you close too,” Victor replied, scratching her between the ears. However, he stopped Savoureuse before she could give him cutlery. “I won’t stay for dinner.”

“Victor, I cooked a space calf whale,” Savoureuse complained. “Do you know how rare they are, and how difficult to catch?”

“Is it legal to hunt whales?” Chocolatine asked, mindful of the environment. “Not that it would stop me if I am hungry, but...”

“In space it is!” Savoureuse replied happily.

“Vainqueur has a level safari planned, and he requires my presence alongside our elite warriors,” Victor justified himself. “This may be their last chance to level-up safely and evolve into more powerful forms.”

Even Allison had agreed to participate, although the event offended her sensibilities. Only Furibon wouldn’t attend, the lich being busy setting up shields around Gardemagne’s major cities.

Someone knocked on the door. “You’re waiting for someone?” Victor asked Savoureuse, who shook her head. The Vizier rose from the table, using the opportunity to let the werewolf siblings catch up.

Victor opened the door, to find an angel on the threshold.

“Mr. Victor.”

The Vizier froze, as he faced an old face from a lifetime ago. A blonde angel with mismatched wings, and an adorable face frozen in an

expressionless mask.

“Miel! I’m so happy—”

“Mr. Victor, I am only present because Lord Mithras himself asked me to,” the angel quickly replied with impersonal professionalism. “I have no intention of seeing you any longer than necessary.”

Victor froze at the cold reaction but somewhat expected it. He decided not to waste any time. “I just wanted to say sorry,” he said, “for my scam.”

“Mr. Victor, I do not begrudge you for your fraud.”

She didn’t? This surprised Victor. “You don’t?”

“In a way, I think I always knew, but I was in denial,” the angel admitted, sheepishly joining her fingers. “I did some soul-searching, and I understood that I may have been a little... a little corrupt.”

Duh. The [Heartless Angel] should have been a giveaway.

“But Mr. Victor, you lied to me, abused my trust, and destroyed my reputation in front of all of Heaven,” Miel continued. “I may have been pushy with your Karma Insurance, but all I wanted was to save your soul and push you to do good. I should have seen you for what you are: a karmic sink.”

“I did good,” Victor defended himself, although the excuse sounded weak even to him. “I mean, I exposed heavenly corruption. Shouldn’t it count for good behavior?”

“That your action resulted in good means little if you never expected that result,” Miel replied. “If you try to kill someone, even if you fail, you still wanted to harm someone else. You cannot separate action from intention, and while you may have done some good Mr. Victor, it was rarely done out of altruism.”

“Okay, I am not perfect, or even a good person,” Victor admitted. “I don’t have what it takes to become someone like Kia. But I’m trying to make up

for my mistakes and take responsibility for them.”

He had a lot on his plate, but so far, Victor thought he was making progress. He took responsibility for his kids, helped Kia with her issues, convinced Furibon to set up protective shields around major cities, found the cure of the plague and went behind Vainqueur’s back to make it free... maybe he was no saint, but he was no devil either.

“You are trying to improve,” Miel conceded, “So am I, especially with Lord Mithras’ guidance, but I do not want any temptation. Your company is *trying*, and I have enough of it.”

“I understand,” Victor replied, before turning silent. He wanted to ask her so many questions. What had she done since leaving Heaven? Did she do well for herself? Where did she work now?

But he said nothing.

He could feel that their old friendship was irremediably gone... and that as much as it hurt, he had to respect Miel’s right to keep her personal space. Even if it hurt him, she didn’t exist to make him happy about himself.

He had to let her go.

“Here is the cure for Hamelin’s plague,” Victor said, searching in his armor’s pouches for the potion and handing it to the angel. She carried the bottle in her immaculate hands as if he had granted her a holy treasure. “I wanted you to have it.”

“Me?” she asked, surprise breaking through her emotionless mask.

“I hope some good will come out of this mess... and that you will benefit from it,” Victor said. “I don’t know if it will make up for the shame I brought upon you, but this is my dearest wish.”

He owed her at least this much.

Miel’s lips twisted into some expression of concern, although she quickly regained her composure. “I pray that you do not die in Prydain, Mr. Victor.”

With nothing else to add, she opened her wings, glowing with a halo.

“Miel,” Victor said, his old insurance advisor sparing him a few more seconds. “Thanks for giving me closure. For all it is worth... you were an awesome shoulder angel.”

She hesitated for a second, then gave him a short, final nod.

The angel vanished in a flash of light without a word, leaving Victor alone with the cold silence of the Moooooooooon.

At twilight, Vainqueur crossed the portal to Daltonia, where his minions and closest allies awaited him next to a dodo pen.

Junior the Excalitrap, who carried Buzz Jelly and a dozen slime children on his back; Corpseling Jules and Tasty Malfy, eager to begin; Untasty Allison and Tinfoil Rolo, who weren't; the Kobold Rangers, and his beautiful niece Jolie; Batling Charlene and Knight Kia, who had traded the [Plot Armor] for her normal one; even Gorynych and his horse friend had been allowed to participate.

Manling Victor teleported in, completing Vainqueur's minion set. “Sorry to be late,” he apologized. “Choc just wouldn't let me go.”

“We understand, minion,” Vainqueur replied, the dragon having shared one last golden shower with his hoard before letting Troll Barnabas do his work. “We all need hoard time, to prepare ourselves for harsh trials.”

As if to answer their master's desire, a dodo looked over the pen's fence, offering his body for the dragon's pleasure.

“Is there no other way?” Untasty Allison asked, touched by such display of self-sacrifice. “Killing helpless animals is... I know we need these levels, but it leaves a sour taste in my mouth.”

“He lived a good life,” Vainqueur replied. “This is the bird that fathered so many slimes.”

“Also, does this one look helpless?” Batling Charlene pointed an athame at a ferocious dodobear, resting on the grass.

“We need to cull the hybrid population,” Manling Victor argued to the dryad. “We are preserving the local ecosystem, not harming it.”

“This is my last chance for promotion,” Tasty Malfy added, clearly the most enthusiastic of the group.

“I always wanted to check if [Exp Dodos] could be raised as undead.” Corpseking Jules joined his hands. “For double the experience.”

So did Vainqueur. So did Vainqueur.

Chapter 139: V-Day

- The Hoardnational, Lyrics.

Stand up, minions of the Earth!

Stand up, prisoners of fear!

Greed thunders in its volcano!

This is the golden eruption!

Of the lead let us make coins,

Loyal slimes, stand up, stand up!

The fairies will lose everything!

We are minions, we are the Hoard!

Possessed by patriotism, Pink furiously scribbled her new song's lines on a page as a drop of blood fell from the sky.

Putting her notebook in her backpack, the bard raised her eyes at the stormy heavens, where crimson clouds had gathered in spite of the sea wind.

Squeakie, her gray, overfed cat ration, let out an adorable meow on Pink's back. Every Kobold Ranger had such a bag of fur and meat leather-strapped to their supplies, so they couldn't escape. Pink still remembered the drilling lesson about how to cook them.

“Remember, even if they are too fat to run, don't take any chances!”
Chocolatine had explained during her cooking seminar, using her personal

ration Felix as an example. “Since they always respawn within ten meters of where they died, set traps just to be sure!”

While she had listened to the instructions religiously, Pink wasn't sure she could bring herself to eat something this *cute*.

Alongside the other Kobold Rangers and their Brachiosaurus Dinozord, Pink currently waited inside a ship-shaped mimic carrying them towards Prydain. In truth, few of the ships making up the V&V's armada were of wood or metal; most were monsters, mimics, or undead boats made from the bones of their defeated enemies. Sea monsters, fishmen, and deep ones led the invasion force, guiding them through the currents. All of them braved the stormy sea, titanic waves crashing against their hulls as the dark shores of Prydain came into sight.

The armada was divided into multiple fleets, with one, in particular, almost composed entirely of undead. They surrounded the mighty Tarasque Emperor and his half-dodo brood as they swam like a band of sharks, for undead resisted this family's radioactive presence. Above them, flocks of monsters surrounded copies of the *Piggybank*, his Imperial Majesty's own dwarf-made plane; all in all, the Emperor's armies numbered in the hundreds of thousands.

The thought of His Majesty, who had remained absent so far, made Pink anxious, but the sight of other heroes filled her with hope.

Leading the aerial forces, Lord Victor, greatest of the minions, conjured the bloody clouds while on the back of Gorynych—may the vile zmey be ignored. Instead of water, the skies rained blood, to both provide cover for the fleet and allow vulnerable undead like vampires to operate during the day.

His rival, the Paladin Kia, led the human fleet from Gardemagne further east; she rode her own master, the Imperial Niece Jolie, in battle, much to the kobolds' despair. While they had grown used to this strange quirk of the Niece, they would rather have been at her side in this dire moment.

For the island-fortress of Prydain had come into sight.

Pink couldn't call what she faced shores. Stone walls and black towers stood strong on sharp cliffs, while black thorns covered the beach, preventing normal ships from landing. Magical wards and shields protected the island's inner areas, while giant birds, ghosts, and evil spirits freely roamed the skies.

There it was. The sanctum of the fomors, of the vile villains that never ceased to threaten His Majesty since his awakening.

"One minute, prepare to clear the ramp!" Red shouted, his face against the wind. "Move fast and clean out these fairy holes!"

"We don't have a ramp!" Blue screamed in panic, his stress getting the better of him.

"We're doomed!" Yellow howled to the winds, the mimic ship letting out a roar in answer.

"I know, but I just wanted to say it!" Red shouted back. "The ramp, not the doomed!"

"Show-off," Black complained, before pointing a finger at the skies. "They are here!"

A song of gold and shininess overwhelmed the sea's noise, as its singers dived through the bloody clouds.

The mighty dragons summoned by the Conclave descended upon Prydain like a jolly flight of hawks. Thousands of dragons, drakes, and wyverns sung and exchanged pleasantries, so confident in their inevitable victory that they treated this war like it was an amusing party. Their sheer moxie and confidence emboldened the kobolds.

"See?!" she told Yellow, who kept ranting about doom. "We have nothing to fear! We have the greatest of monster lords on our side!"

"It's going to be clean up duty!" Black boasted. Only Red remained somewhat neutral, focused on the mission ahead.

Faced with their dragon destroyers, the fomors answered by unleashing their own armies. Creatures crossed the fairy wards by flight to fight the invaders in the skies, from gigantic birds with metal beaks, to winged golems. The numbers were evenly matched on both sides, although the fomors' forces moved in organized formations.

Immediately, without warning, the battle started.

Pink didn't see who attacked first, but within seconds, the skies erupted in a dazzling display of fire, lightning, and ice. Dragons unleashed their elemental breaths on the winged golems, while the smaller wyverns and drakes swarmed the bird warbeasts. Swords clashed against scales, explosions thundered above the armada and roars echoed across the savage sea.

Pink could only stare in awe, as the dragons her kind worshiped trounced the fairies' forces, smashing golems while minions below watched in astonishment. The remains of warbeasts fell into the sea, while drakes reached the fortifications and tried to get past the wards.

Black was right. Although it would sadden Pink not to sing her new anthem, she could settle for cleanup duty.

And then, an arrow of light flew from the west and hit a black dragon in the chest at a speed greater than the wind.

A blinding flash illuminated the skies, while a terrible blast caused the entire armada to tremble. The same weapon that almost destroyed Murmurin had exploded in the dragons' midst, far above the fleet, and expanded outward. Clouds were blown away, warbeasts and wyverns vaporized, dragons' flesh melted. The golden song of the Dragon Conclave was drowned by a terrible noise.

The corpse of a burnt dragon fell into the sea, left of the rangers' ship, and sunk a mimic boat whole.

Pink screamed in horror, imitated by most of her teammates, as the great scaled ones fell by the hundreds into the sea; to be washed up on the shores,

or dragged to the abyss below.

The surviving dragons reacted first with horrified surprise, then with fury. They unleashed their breath weapons towards the enemies, bathing them in fire and cold.

But the tide of the battle suddenly changed. The golems started shrugging off the dragons' breath, while their swords cut through scales like butter. Holes opened in the fortifications, revealing heavy artillery. As the armada came within range, they started firing in its direction.

"Get down!" Red shouted, forcing his team to bend their back as lead projectiles hit the hull of their ship. Their brachiosaurus was hurt, letting out a moan of pain as blood flew from its scales.

The artillery fired evil lead bullets at the minions and powerstone cannonballs at the dragons above. Already, the battle was nothing like the overwhelming dragon victory that took place in Murmurin, more than a year ago. This time the dragons died as much as they killed, the sea turning golden from the blood. As the minion fleet came into range, the fairy defenders targeted it, unleashing evil lead bullets at them.

"We're all gonna die!" Black screamed like a little manling child.

"I died once, I don't want to die again!" Blue screamed louder.

"Hey!" Red shouted, trying to calm down his team. "Hey!"

SLAP! SLAP! SLAP!

Red slapped every member of his team, ending with Pink. "Scale up!" he shouted, forcing them to focus, even silencing the panicked cat rations.

"Are you minions or whiners?"

"But, but, they killed dragons!" Black said, his bravado shattered. "They are at the top of the food chain! They can't die!"

"Everything I believe in is wrong!" Yellow screamed, which earned him another slap.

“They are fighting, dying for us!” Red pointed a musket at the brave dragons, who kept attacking even while taking heavy losses. “This is what His Majesty always risked, whenever he defended us from liches, vampires, fiends, and nasties! Now, will you honor your monster lord and country with *cowardice*... or with *victory*?”

Red’s inspiring words, and a successful charisma check, brought the team back to their senses. “Yellow, you heal the zord!” their leader started barking orders. “Pink, you sing, Blue, you cast buffs. Black, with me at the vanguard. We are going to take these shores, for the Hoard!”

“For the hoard!” the kobolds said as one, their dinosaur and cat rations letting out panicked moans in response.

Above them, the minion aerial forces reached the battlelines, assisting the dragons in their fights. Flying fiends and vampires overwhelmed the golems, Lord Victor’s zmey mount forcing a path forward.

That was it. Pink knew it, deep in her tiny bones, as the cat rations meowed all at once.

The final battle!

The kobold bard gathered her breath and then sung the melody she had composed for this historical day.

“This is the final struggle

Let us group together, and tomorrow

The Hoard

Will be the minion race!”

“I will see you on the beach...” Red shouted, firing with his musket at the skies while his cat ration furiously attempted to escape its bindings, “or in Happyland!”

They had firearms.

The realization dawned on Victor, as his [Moloch's Hide] armor caused bullets to bounce off him. Holes had opened in the fortifications to reveal machine guns, mortars, and cannons; while their design reminded the Vizier of WWII movies, they had an archaic bent to them, having been modified with runes and golem parts.

Victor beat himself mentally. Of course, the fomors had firearms, they had *nukes*. It would have been child's play to smuggle these weapons and mass-produce them with magic. He could only hope class levels and the inherent power of Murmurin's monsters could make up for the technological disparity.

After the nuke had decimated a large dragon flight—although Victor knew many more would follow—the fomors had started unleashing hell on the invasion force. Their heavy artillery focused on the air force, especially large targets like the wyrms and planes, while less devastating weapons like machine guns focused on the ships, trying to snipe the kobolds, ghouls, and other minions. So far, with the weather and distance, they struggled to hit anything, but the landing would be a slaughter if these defenses weren't taken down.

For now, Victor focused on maintaining his [Blood Rain] with [Control Weather], both to empower the undead members of the fleet, and to provide protection from the nuke's radioactive fallout. He had noticed the missile coming from the west, but a telepathic report from Kia through his [Scarlet Study] Perk informed him that a second projectile had been fired at her own fleet. They needed to identify the site from where the fomors launched their nukes, or else their losses would accumulate.

The dragons were powerful and prevented most of the artillery from hitting the naval force, shrugging off all but the most devastating, powerstone-fueled cannonballs, but the nuclear weapon had wiped out hundreds of them. The Vizier suddenly realized that Vainqueur was a *beast*, even among his kind.

As V&V's troops engaged the fomors' defenses and Victor commanded them from above, the System finally saw fit to reward him for all the dodo blood on his hands.

Congratulations! For violently massacring cute, helpless **[Exp Dodos]** hybrids—and totally going to Happyland for it—you earned three levels in **[Weathermaker]** and two levels in **[Chaos Rider]**! You earned the **[Hail-bringer]**, **[Devil Archmage III]**, and **[Black Rider]** class Perks!

+150 HP, +40 SP, +5 STR, +5 VIT, +5 SKI, +4 AGI, +7 INT, +5 CHA, +8 LCK.

[Hail-bringer]: Spell, 100 SP per hour. You can passively change the weather, to **[Blood Rain]**, **[Slime Rain]**, **[Acid Rain]**, **[Fire Hail]**, **[Ghost Storm]**, and **[Plague Winds]**. Additionally, while the ability is active, you can switch between each of them at will without spending SP. If a spell such as **[Control Weather]** overwhelmed **[Hail-bringer]**, they need to focus on the spell, or else your ability will reassert itself.

[Devil Archmage III]: You can learn and cast spells three tiers above your current one. You can also learn and cast spells with the **[Evil]**, **[Fiend]**, and **[Weather]** traits, but only those equal or below your current tier access; if they belong to an exclusive school of magic, you count as if you met the other requirements. This replaces **[Devil Archmage II]**.

[Black Rider]: Technique, 80 SP per minute. You create a ten-foot draining field around yourself, which devours HP and SP; this is a **[Drain]** effect. Additionally, spells of tier VI and lower will be canceled and consumed, unless you wish them to affect you. If you are fighting while mounted, your mount projects the field too. You can add two more mounts to your **[Black Horseman]** stable.

By reaching level ten in **[Weathermaker]**, you maxed out the class! You can no longer take levels in it, but you gained the capstone ability **[Foul Metamagic]**.

[Foul Metamagic]: When you cast spells with the **[Necromancy]**, **[Diabolism]**, **[Evil]**, **[Fiend]** and **[Weather]** traits, you can either **[Accelerate]** (cast a second spell at the same time as a normal one) or **[Enhance]** them (double their strength and duration) by doubling their SP consumption.

Haha! “Tier X, here I come!”

[**Hail-bringer**] activated!

Keeping his storm active passively, Victor started summoning additional reinforcements, opening gates towards Happyland. Hordes of flying demons emerged from the rifts, joining the dragons in fighting the fomors’ golems and warbeasts.

Malfy, whom Victor had finally Mook Promoted to [Demonbug CEO], was the first to fly through. The insectoid had transformed into a greater form, or more precisely, splintered. Instead of a single entity, he now appeared as a living swarm of blue, icy flies, organizing themselves into the form of a winged, nine-foot-tall fallen angel.

Although they had, at their back, the greatest army of monsters ever assembled, Victor could tell this would be a *long, hard day*.

And what was Vainqueur doing? He should have been at the forefront of the invasion, instead of vanishing after Daltonia.

“MINIONS!”

Here he came.

Falling through the bloody rain clouds like a shiny star, his body surrounded by the flames of his [Fire Crown] Perk, Vainqueur Knightsbane announced his presence to all.

Yet instead of proudly displaying his crimson scales, the wyrm emperor now wore armor as ostentatious as his pride. Almost every inch of the dragon’s body, except for the eyes and mouth, was protected by heavy plates of gem-encrusted gold. The areas protecting the wings and belly were made of gems, while the claws were coated in silver; and Victor could have sworn he noticed the rapier that started this whole mess at the tip of the tail. In spite of the heat coming from Vainqueur’s body, the armor didn’t melt, held together by powerful magic.

“I HAVE RETURNED!” Vainqueur roared, proudly flying straight at the aerial battleground.

All in all, the wyrm looked *awesome*.

His face hidden beneath his helmet, Victor couldn't help but smile. His best friend sure knew how to make an entrance.

They all looked at him!

Vainqueur let out a fearsome roar as his minions rejoiced at his shininess, and his enemies cowered in fear.

[**Victory Roar**] activated! The strength of every enemy within earshot has been lowered by one stage!

Congratulations! You killed helpless birds! For this daring, courageous deed and compensating with your new [**Hoard Armor**] artifact, you earned four levels in [**Fisher King**]! You earned the [**Symbol of Hope**] and [**Healing Mantle**] class perk.

+120 HP, +80 SP, +1 STR, +8 VIT, +3 SKI, +2 AGI, +3 INT, +4 CHA, +2 LCK.

[**Symbol of Hope**]: While you are above 25 percent HP, all your subjects feel bolstered, gaining a bonus of +6 to STR, VIT, AGI, CHA, and LCK. If you fall below 25 percent HP, your subjects instead take a -6 penalty on these same attributes; if you die, the penalty becomes permanent.

[**Healing Mantle**]: All your allies within twenty meters of you gain the benefit of the [Regen] positive ailment. Additionally, healing effects will help them recover double the usual HP.

And Vainqueur was only getting *started*.

“[Charged Breath]!” He gathered all his might into his belly, the fairies' projectiles bouncing off his [Hoard Armor] and his flames melting any warbeast getting too close. The dragon dived down, straight at the defensive fortifications, and opened his mouth.

He unleashed a nuclear breath so hot, that it turned green-white. The blast vaporized a watchtower, shattered the magical defenses, and caused a blinding explosion as impressive as the fairies' arrow of light.

Vainqueur would eat anyone who disagreed.

Within seconds, dragons flew into the breach, entering the fairies' lands to devastate them. Odieuse's golems moved to intercept the invaders, and while Vainqueur smashed many of them, many of his brethren fared poorly against these creatures. Their metal blades could cut through dragonscales and for one tinfoil destroyed, two more replaced it.

While the sight of many of his kindred dying all around him infuriated the dragon, Vainqueur felt great pride upon seeing his minions land on Prydain's shores. The [Tarasque Emperor] arrived first, shrugging off everything in its path and smashing through the defensive walls. His Taradodos spawns followed in his wake, tearing apart giant soldiers and warbeasts by swarming them; the reptiles kept moving forward, carving a bloody path into Prydain.

The ferocious, Moon-veteran Buzz Jelly was the first slime on the front lines, leaping over the Tarasque's back and ignoring his radioactive effects. Although he hadn't been [Mook Promoted] while in Daltonia, the metal slime had great strength, reaching level 50!

Bullets bounced off his body, as Buzz Jelly declared his patriotic pride for all to hear. "FOR EMPIRE!"

His brave father Junior followed him, having evolved into a mighty [Mimic Witch Hut] on Daltonia. The [Excalitrap] had transformed into a living house more than five meters tall, its timber-looking walls carried by six legs with hands. Its windows were eyes, its door a fanged mouth unleashing hundreds of slimes on the beach. With one hand, the mighty mimic hut wielded a sword, and with another, it cast protective spells on its charges.

Linnorms and other creatures emerged from the ocean to invade the shores, while minion ships managed to land. They were welcomed by a hail of gunfire, the vile fairies having weaponized lead against their dragon

nemeses; while many invaders fell, more charged forward, spurred on by the sight of Vainqueur's shininess.

For today, dragon and minion knew that they didn't fight for gold, glory, or fun.

They fought for the dragon way of life itself!

Roaring again, Vainqueur made a circle in the skies and prepared to carpet bomb the fairies to protect his minions.

He would not rest until victory was his.

And so began the final Dragon-Fomor war: in fire and gold! Together, our Good Emperor Vainqueur and his greatest minion led the charge, to hand the fairies their asses!

But unknown to them both...

This would be their final adventure together.

- ***Prologue, "The Last Adventure," by Pink Ranger.***

Chapter 140: Landfall

Nothing could harm him.

Bullets, mortar, and cannonballs bounced off Vainqueur's thick [Hoard Armor], as the dragon tore down the island's walled fortifications. None could stand before the power of a true hoard.

"I am the gold that haunts your lead!" the dragon boasted loudly, as he pushed a watchtower down, stones crashing on the shores and crushing the tiny doppelgangers manning it. Behind him, minion ships landed on the beach, singing Vainqueur's name while his success emboldened the dragons in the skies.

[**Imperial Authority**], [**Healing Mantle**], [**Master of Silence**], and [**Pontifex Maximus**] activated! Your [**Ring of the Dragon Ur-Pharaoh**] cast [**Protection from Elements**]!

The dragon's very presence turned even the tiniest kobold into a self-regenerating killing machine and infused their weapons with holy energies. While the volleys of artillery slowed down their advance, they kept walking forward, tearing down any fairy thrall unlucky enough to get in the way.

Vainqueur landed on the ground and led the charge, shielding his troops with his body as he tore down the artillery; for a true dragon led from the front.

A pack of four large fairy hounds emerged from behind the murals to assault the wyrm and stop his rampage. Unfazed, Vainqueur welcomed them with swift punches, tearing a beast in half with each strike.

You inflicted supereffective damage to [**Fairy Hound**]!

The armor's claws had been reinforced with Silver, Cold Iron, and Starmetal; second-rate, unshiny metals, but alloys which the fairies feared more than gold.

Even better, with every kill, the monsters dropped an item! A golden statue, a gem, a sword!

[Hoard Armor] improved your chances of item drops!

Combined with [Crowd's Favorite], Vainqueur would get richer with every victim he claimed. "I am the shining heart of the universe!" he roared after demolishing the hound pack, drunk on his greed. "The greatest financial wizard in the world!"

These were novel boasts, unknown to dragonkind, but they suited the visionary emperor well.

Within seconds, Vainqueur carved a sizable hole in the defensive fortifications, having single-handedly removed most of the defensive artillery. Without suppressing fire, the fairies' thralls could no longer prevent most of Vainqueur's fleet from making landfall. Mimic and bone ships crashed onto the shores, pouring out minions.

Corpseling Jules led an undead cohort by bolstering them with spells, while Untasty Allison and Tinfoil Rolo led a second force. The ghoul waved his hand and unleashed a pulse of necromantic energy, raising fairy beasts as undead hounds without touching them; the golem simply charged towards the fortifications, smashed through them, and kept going; and Untasty Allison healed kobolds back to full health, and summoned creatures of solid stone to assist.

Above, Manling Victor cast down thunderbolts on the fairies' remaining aerial forces, surrounded by Batling Charlene's vampires and fiends from Happyland. It quickly became clear that the battle's tide was changing, and not in the fairies' favor.

So, with the walls destroyed, monstrous reinforcements emerged from the fairies' forests beyond the fortifications. A battalion of one-eyed ogres,

doppelgangers, and animated trees arrived to swarm the V&V ground forces.

Much to Vainqueur's annoyances, the tiny doppelgangers all carried copies of Mot's bottle. They opened them upon sighting dragons, sucking air within them; Murmurin's Emperor immediately activated his [Spell Purge], remembering his last confrontation with Batling Lavere.

You avoided being caught in [**Bottle of Dragonbinding**]!

Several of Vainqueur's kindred didn't share his iron will and anti-sorcery defenses, their massive bodies sucked into the tiny jars; the others pulled back, although more in surprise than fear.

"No bottle can hold a dragon!" Vainqueur shouted to encourage them, before unleashing his mighty breath at the doppelgangers to release his brethren. Giants and animated trees attempted to flank and interrupt him, but his minions came to Vainqueur's defense, swarming the bigger monsters with sheer numbers.

Charisma check successful!

The dragon's bravado inspired his kindred, who backed him up with an aerial bombardment. Within seconds, a rain of fire, lightning, acid, and other elements ravaged the thralls' reinforcements, forcing them to run for their lives back inland. Unfortunately, the doppelgangers with the bottles managed to escape, prioritizing their cruel captures over winning the battle.

At the same time, a terrible noise echoed as the storm battered the shores. A dozen long, metal arrows descended from above. Wind Spears.

"Minions, behind me!" Vainqueur ordered as he and fellow wyrms shot down a few of the projectiles, but not enough. They rained down onto the entire battlefield, unleashing mighty blasts of winds turning hard stone to paste.

Unlike the arrows of light, these projectiles didn't devastate the entire region nor instantly kill dragons, but they *hurt*. They fell at random

everywhere on the ground, with no regard for friendly fire, hitting dragons and giants alike. The detonations shredded kobolds into bloody puddles, tore animated trees apart, and caused a few dragons to break a wing and make an emergency landing.

For a minute, Vainqueur's entire world was reduced to explosions, kobolds, and ghouls hiding behind or below his mighty body. Much to his fury, many of his servants couldn't take cover in time and drop like flies; his [Healing Mantle] regeneration unable to protect them from such a powerful force.

When at least the bombardment ended, the beach looked like the devastated surface of the cursed planet Moon.

"Kobold down!" Pink Ranger screamed, tending to a wounded Red alongside her teammates. "Kobold down!"

They killed the Kobold Rangers *again*?!

Above, Manling Victor and his zmey flew towards the attack's source, only to barely avoid being shot down themselves; for more projectiles emerged from the sea itself, an uninterrupted rain of destruction.

"[Glitzy Theater]!" Vainqueur summoned a golden cage around the shores, protecting his surviving minions from a second bombardment. Even his mighty arena shook from the sheer intensity of the attack. Unfortunately, the dragon couldn't activate his more destructive abilities without risking friendly fire. "Manling Victor, do the thing!"

"I'm trying!" his Doer of the Thing shouted back, Gorynych furiously trying to keep his rider alive by making circles in the skies and dodging the wind spears.

Suddenly, the assault ended as abruptly as it began, an explosion erupting below the water. A swarm of shark beastkin gathered around the source of the attack, while a dark shape started to emerge; a familiar face led the amphibious reinforcements.

“Jaja!” Manling Victor shouted from above, Vainqueur’s sharp hearing picking it up over the battle’s noise.

“Vic, you son of mammal!” The sharkman raised a spear, surfing on a wave. “You can’t sink an island without me!”

Mighty tentacles raised a captive monster above the sea’s waves, Vainqueur finally seeing the attacker.

A dolphin.

A giant, black metal dolphin with an iron tower for a back fin. The creatures had tiny metal legs, a fanged, eyeless metal mouth, and holes all over its body.

The creature holding the metal dolphin captive half-emerged from the waters, an entity almost as big as Vainqueur himself. The beast appeared to be some sort of giant centaur, with the upper half of a deformed green, fishlike beastkin, and the bottom half of a kraken. Its terrifying visage inspired dread in the minions ashore, although Vainqueur’s presence calmed them.

Charisma check successful! [**Madness**] negated!

“Lord Dagon, Lord Vainqueur!” the sharkman shouted across the battlefield. “Lord Vainqueur, this is Lord Dagon, first spawn of the Moon Man!”

The enormous fish let out a wail, its tentacles struggling to ensnare the giant metal dolphin. This Dagon fellow attempted to throw it on the shores, where it wouldn’t move, but the giant machine responded by firing a volley of projectiles from the holes on its back.

The Moon Man’s child let out a scream as the projectiles almost blew off its face, and tossed the dolphin backward; the machine sank back into the sea with shark beastkin giving pursuit. Dagon let out a snarl and returned to the deep, alongside its servants.

At the sight, Prydain's remaining aerial forces panicked and fell back, except the golems. Even then, the machines were outnumbered and quickly demolished by dragons and Manling Victor's forces.

"Action!" Vainqueur ordered as he undid his [Glitzzy Theater], allowing his troops to move further inland. "Let none escape! Recover the dragonbinding bottles!"

The shores were his, and soon, the entire island would follow.

The battle ended in victory, although a costly one.

They had seized the beach, and thus a landfall point on Prydain; but the shores were covered in corpses, destroyed ships, golem parts, craters, and ruins. The dragons had borne the brunt of the massacre, both from the nuke and the aerial bombardments, but the V&V Empire also registered thousands of dead.

"So much work to do," Victor sighed, while Jules was already hard at work to raise the deceased as undead labor; having recovered his [Black Grail], the Vizier would assist him soon. Allison had joined in too, but provided healing for the wounded instead; with her new levels, her group healing spells had improved enough to help many recover quickly.

She had been too late for a few minions though.

"He was too young!" Pink cried over Red's remains, the Kobold Rangers having formed a wake around their leader's body; the Wind Spear had shredded half his chest. Buzz Jelly was holding the wake, carrying the V&V Empire's flag while humming the *War of the Hoard*. "He was too young!"

"Why is she acting like this?" Victor asked, puzzled. "I mean, he's just dead. That's not the end of the world."

It wasn't even the first time it happened to this team, as Blue and Yellow could attest.

“After the first resurrection, death lost its luster,” Allison commented, although she only sounded half-serious.

“Pink said it is a [Bard]’s duty to hold a tragic death scene,” Black answered, while his teammate kept crying over Red’s corpse. “She never got to do yours, chief, so she’s making up for lost time.”

Oh. Alright.

While Vainqueur and most of the surviving dragons were cleaning up the remnants of Prydain’s forces further north, Victor raised a group of goblins as [Arisen] with his [Black Grail]. This earned him a lot more attention than he thought it would from unlikely sources.

“Vainqueur’s chief of staff can cure minion death!” a Linnorm shouted, like a medieval peasant in adoration before the discovery of electricity.

“I cannot believe that minion repairmanship progressed this much in my century-long slumber...” a true dragon muttered in astonishment. “What about lead poisoning, minion of Vainqueur? Have they found the cure?”

“Somewhat,” the Vizier replied, the dragons whispering to each other, to ponder this wondrous discovery. Victor dared not tell them about the [Transmute Gold to Lead] spell.

“What about the dragon birth defect? Can it be undone?”

That was Victor’s next order of business. Upon finding the first dragon corpse which a nuclear bomb hadn’t *completely* vaporized, the Vizier covered it with black blood.

Your [**Black Grail**] could not raise [**Green Wyrms**].

... why? Because the dragon’s soul wasn’t bound for Happyland? With all the greed and pride, he would have thought otherwise.

In any case, Victor tried to raise the corpse as a normal sentient undead with [Reanimator], only to receive a blue screen of death.

ERROR 404: Soul not found!

Soul not found?

This was exactly like after Icefang bit the dust.

Victor frowned, doubly so when he realized Jules had no problem raising minions killed by warbeasts and firearms. Was it because this wyrm had been killed by the nuclear bomb? Other dragons had been decimated by Odieuse's golems, did something prevent them from being raised too? He would have to check as soon as possible.

But all in all, unlike what Victor joked about, it appeared a lot of people would *stay* dead today.

His lack of success also disheartened the dragons present; they looked at the death toll and the corpses of their brethren with a cowed expression. Victor guessed that this was the first time most of them witnessed slaughter on that scale.

Kia chose this moment to arrive, riding the back of Jolie. "Vic, I'm so glad you guys made it," the [Paladin] said, climbing down from the dragon's back. Many of the wyrms present responded by turning their back on the newcomers as if to deny their very existence; Victor guessed they wouldn't share a bus with minions anytime soon.

"Hey, it's Loon Dad," the dark elf Kevin said, as he landed next to the [Paladin]. Unlike Kia, he had flown over through his own magical means.

Victor was immediately upon him. "Loon Dad?" he asked Kevin while invading his personal space. "Why do you say that? You think I have a hidden child?"

"Calm down, Vic, he was just joking!" Kia pulled him away from her disturbed teammate.

"Oh," the Vizier calmed himself, disappointed. "Don't scare me like that. How was your battle?"

“We took heavy losses, but our army made landfall in the Essex equivalent,” Kia explained. “King Roland established a permanent stronghold, and we await reinforcements there.”

According to the maps they had gathered, Prydain covered what would have been Great Britain and Ireland on Earth; with the V&V fleet having landed in Hampshire. Two large islands, both heavily fortified. Odieuse’s lair could be located in any of them and considering the difficulties in taking one area even with dragon support, conquering the country would be an uphill struggle.

For now, the allied forces intended to make a pincer maneuver and secure Prydain’s southern part. This would make it easier to progress north and organize a landing on the second island.

“I shall avenge your death!” Pink cried loudly over Red’s corpse, before wiping off her tears. “I’m done, chief.”

“It was a great death scene, Pink!” Jolie told the [Bard], having immediately understood the situation. She had even faked a tear over Red’s demise.

Victor took a second to splatter Red with his [Black Grail]. The body reconstituted itself, the Kobold Rangers’ leader rising up none the worse to wear. “I am so glad to live in a country where death is a temporary inconvenience,” Red declared. “Thanks, chief.”

“Don’t thank me,” Victor replied. “Thank your Deathcare Insurance.”

“I guess this rules out suicide as a permanent solution,” Kevin the mage deadpanned, Kia elbowing him.

“The Undeathstrial Revolution cannot be halted,” Jules cleared his throat in the background, with a tone of smug satisfaction.

“Revival made me hungry though,” Red said, eyeing Pink’s overfed cat with hunger.

“Squeakie helped us!” the [Bard] shielded her cat protectively. “He shielded me from a blast!”

“Squeakie is food! He has to die!”

Victor had the feeling that they had just spearheaded some kind of cat genocide, and felt a little remorse. “Anything on the submarine that attacked us?” the Vizier asked his fellow Claimed, having sent them a report through [Scarlet Study]. “Jaja’s amphibious force gave pursuit, but had to order a retreat after being ambushed by nautical warbeasts.”

“According to my divinations, it’s a Typhoon-class Russian submarine transformed into a golem by magic,” Kevin explained, drawing gazes. “Was nobody into WMD on Earth?”

“No,” Allison replied, with slight condemnation. Victor, meanwhile, was aghast. The fomors animated a nuclear submarine as a *golem*? No wonder they could hit Murmurin half a continent across!

“These things can hold up to twenty ballistic missiles, each of them with ten nuclear heads,” the mage continued. “So in short, their missiles unleash ten smaller projectiles past a certain point to target more ground. The whole arsenal could probably wipe out all civilized lands in Outremonde if judiciously applied.”

“Even the missiles used on us by Hamelin didn't fit that category,” Kia noted. “All of them, including the one that targeted Murmurin, were modified wind-spears holding only one nuclear warhead.”

“Then...” Victor trailed off, disturbed. “Where are the real missiles?”

Hoard Armor

Quality: S+ (Major Artifact)

Material: Various metals (Gold, Silver, Starmetal, Cold Iron...), gems, and Powerstones.

Endurance: ∞/∞

Protection: Physical +50/Magical +50

Weight: 57 tons.

Bonus: [Metal] Immunity (except Adamantine and Starmetal)/[Dragon] only/weight divided by ten if worn by a true red dragon/Breath Weapon damage +25/+20 to checks about item or money drops.

A massive magical armor crafted from Vainqueur Knightsbane's legendary hoard, refined through magic and powerstones. This massive, dragon-shaped suit of armor is too heavy for anyone but a mighty wyrm to wear, although its magic doesn't impair flight nor movement.

Besides its high defenses, the Hoard Armor possesses several abilities. At will, the user can try to transmute matter to gold on touch with a successful Charisma check (this is a [**Polymorph**] effect), although only an amount equal to the armor's weight at once; once per day, the wearer can summon molten gold from the Elemental Plane of Earth in the form of a flood centered around the armor; and the armor is immune to metallic weapons, except those made with Adamantine and Starmetal.

Finally, the armor's claws and tail have been reinforced with Cold Iron, Silver and Starmetal; [Fairy] types are thus especially vulnerable to the wielder's physical attacks.

Chapter 141: F&D

Tree. Tree. Tree.

Oh, another tree!

“Minions, the fairies know nothing of landscaping!” Vainqueur snarled, flying above a gigantic, impenetrable forest of oaks and alders. Minion Victor followed him on Gorynych’s back, while Knight Kia trailed them while riding her griffin, having traded her [Plot Armor] for her normal clothes for the day when she couldn’t stand the artifact's terrible lines anymore.

It had taken Vainqueur some effort, but he had convinced Jolie to lead a group of minions further west rather than carry this sorry excuse of a knight on her back. Even after the *Declaration of Minions’ Rights*, many of his kindred looked at his niece’s behavior with condemnation.

“Their forests all look the same!” Vainqueur kept complaining, although a flock of his kindred were busy redecorating it with their deadly breaths; each of them escorted by a group of flying minions, in case fomor thralls ambushed them with dragonbinding bottles. Further west, the Tarasque Emperor moved in a straight line, he and his brood eating anything in their path.

As it turned out, they weren't picky about whom or what they consumed.

“Can Gorynych help with redecorating?” the zmey asked, eager to please a true dragon. “Gorynych good with drawing faces!”

“Mmm, I expect nothing, but I will allow you to show me your zmey art.”

“Thanks, Big V!” Gorynych began to scribble a large drawing with his breath. The result was a hideous sphere with a mouth and eyes, colored somewhat yellow by the embers.

Much to the Emperor’s concern, his chief of staff had remained silent so far. “Minion?”

“Isabelle will give birth anytime soon!” Manling Victor shouted anxiously at once, startling the group. “I will miss my daughter’s birth if this war continues!”

“Where is Odieuse?” Knight Kia grumbled to herself, just as restless. “It’s been three days since the landing, and there’s been no trace of her!”

“We have fought countless thralls so far,” Vainqueur rasped. “And yet, no fomor dared challenge me. The enemy minions are suicidal, but their masters are hiding from my wrath.”

“I take this as a warning sign,” Knight Kia said, turning towards Manling Victor. “Any news on the dragons’ souls?”

“Jules successfully raised a dragon killed by the golems,” the Grand Vizier answered. “Only creatures - dragons and minions alike - vaporized by the nuclear blast could not be revived at all.”

“Odieuse must have enchanted the warheads,” the [Paladin] guessed. “With the question being... where did the missing souls go?”

Vainqueur guessed *where*, and it infuriated him.

After taking over Prydain’s shore, the V&V Empire and the dragon army—helped by their Gardemagnian minions—had progressed deeper within the fomors’ territory, destroying forests, annihilating legions of warbeasts, and establishing outposts all over the southern part of the island. Yet neither did the fairy lords nor their dolphin thrall showed up to confront the dragon army ravaging their home. No new arrow of light fell from the skies. And the thralls who trapped Vainqueur’s kindred inside bottles managed to escape.

“We are near the area where Stonehenge should be on Earth,” Knight Kia said. “Since the place was of significance to the fomors on our world, I assume its Outremonde counterpart must be too.”

“There.” Manling Victor pointed at a lone clearing amidst a sea of trees.

The area instantly reminded Vainqueur of his battle with Mell Lin, and the world beyond the Earthgate. A circle of carved white stones pulsed life at the area’s center, surrounded by cats and dragons.

A group of wyrms, among them Genialissime, laid on their backs near the bones of seasoned cows. Vainqueur immediately landed nearby, imitated by his minions. “Cousin!” The dragon rushed to his family member’s side. “What happened?”

“Too spicy...” Genialissime complained, clearly suffering from a *nasty* indigestion. At least he had been sensible enough not to bring his children to the frontline. “The sauce...”

“Too much...” another dragon groaned, paralyzed. “It was too much...”

What kind of terrible creature could bring his kindred so low?

Vainqueur smelled the leftovers of their meal, before his eyes focused at the stone ring's center.

The area seemed to be some kind of cat sanctuary, for hundreds of felines had made this strange temple their home; according to their fattened looks, they used to be minion rations before deserting. They formed an assembly, surrounding a lone purple cat with boots and a fancy, feathered hat.

The furred creature cooked a sweet, tasty sauce in a cauldron, waving a paw at the newcomers. “Oh, hello there!” he said with a honeyed, sweet voice. “Have you come for the free meal?”

“[Monster Insight],” Manling Victor said the second he set his eyes on the purple cat.

“A free meal?” Vainqueur asked, recognizing the sauce’s smell. “Could this be...”

“My secret family recipe of ‘*special guest sauce*, ” the booted cat explained proudly. “Your fellow wyrms could not resist it!”

The poison sauce... Vainqueur salivated upon remembering this sweet, delightful taste.

How could it bring dragons down, when it had given Vainqueur his first personal Perk, and fond memories? The thought brought him back to his early, carefree adventurer days, when he didn’t have the shoulder the fate of all of dragonkind. That his fellow wyrms could not stand nor appreciate the taste disappointed Vainqueur greatly.

“Come on, take a sip!” the purple cat tempted Vainqueur. “My treat!”

“You cats have always been excellent hosts,” the dragon declared, happy to meet someone civilized in this savage country.

“Holy Happyland...” Manling Victor raised his scythe from atop Gorynych. “That’s not a cat! That’s a fomor with class levels!”

A fomor? Impossible, he didn’t smell like one... although the dragon wouldn’t put it past a fairy to cause such mischief, and he trusted his chief of staff unconditionally. “Finally!” Knight Kia said upon climbing down from her griffin and unsheathing her sword. “I thought they had all fled!”

“A fomor?” The cat cleared his throat, anxious, “Manling, be serious! Would a fomor offer a delightful, tasty sauce to dragons?”

The scheme suddenly became clear to Vainqueur. “You foul villain!” the dragon roared, claws extended. “You took the shape of a beautiful feline to lead my kindred astray with your sauce, and steal their cat food!”

“Wait, wait, let me explain!” the purple cat protested, backing away as the group prepared to pound his temple into dust; the other felines cowardly hid behind him. “I am not a fomor, but a future cat!”

“The future?” Vainqueur frowned, puzzled.

“The cat resistance sent me to the past,” the fairy furball explained, detailing his outlandish tale. “In the future, cats have almost been exterminated by dragons, their descendants becoming *even more* advanced beings to survive!”

“That’s ridiculous,” Manling Victor said. “You can’t expect us to believe that!”

“Is it more believable than a fomor taking the shape of a poor, lonely cat?”

Intelligence check...

Successful!

“It does not add up, false cat,” Vainqueur said, immediately finding the hole in his lie. “If you came back to the past and changed it, then your new self should not have any reason to return to the past. This is a *paranormal*.”

“Paradox, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor said. “It’s called a time paradox.”

“Or maybe by going to the past, the cat set into motions the events that led him to travel back in time in the first place, creating a time loop proving that free-will is meaningless.” Everyone turned to Knight Kia, who became a bit embarrassed by the attention. “I like thoughtful time-travel stories.”

“Personally, I believe in parallel universes,” Manling Victor said, using words even his master did not understand.

“Also, I’m pretty sure the only creature capable of time travel is Sablar, and he’s a lazy asshole,” Knight Kia added, threatening the purple cat with her blade. “Even capped [Chronomancers] can’t pull it off, and you clearly aren’t one.”

“Does Gorynych have a sister-daughter in the future?” the Zmey asked the purple cat, having completely missed Vainqueur’s logical argument.

“You will die alone!” Vainqueur brought the zmey back to reality, the lesser reptile saddened. “As for you, false cat, I shall answer your lies with flames!”

“Hey, hey, no need for violence!” the purple feline complained, raising his paws in surrender. “I was joking! *Joking!* Damn, usually, dragons’ brains freeze from confusion when I tell them that, but everyone is a skeptic nowadays...”

“I started with a square root sixty-four intellect,” Vainqueur pointed out, proud of his genius. “Your cunning is no match for mine.”

Knight Kia, however, was most disappointed by the fairy’s cowardice. “I have yet to meet a fomor surrendering...” she complained. “Not that you look impressive.”

“I am Cait Sith, the fairy king of cats,” the tiny fomor protested, his furred fellows meowing in response. “I sat out of this war, but these felines are my people and descendants. I will not let you wyrms eat them.”

“Now I understand where cats’ arrogance came from,” Manling Victor mused, before frowning. “You’re a Soulcrested Fomor, which means you received your soul from Odieuse. That doesn’t inspire confidence.”

“Yes, yes, I received a soul from a Soulcrest, and I was all for eating manlings... but then I realized it would threaten my feline people, and that I cared for them more than I thought I would,” the cat admitted, before glaring at Vainqueur, “You wyrms are the worst! You enslaved my people and turned their nine lives gift into a curse!”

“I resent that term,” Vainqueur defended his choice of army ration. “This is war, and war calls for desperate measure. Cats are the solution to dragon hunger, and their suffering will save countless minion lives!”

“You were never meant to eat cats, dragon!” Cait Sith protested. “We created cattle to get you off our back! Stick to cows!”

“Now, furball, you forget yourself,” Vainqueur said. “The Elder Wyrms created all cattle for us dragons to feed on.”

“Fomors created cows, cats, and all the creatures of this world,” the feline lied through his fangs, raising his paw. With a wave of his claws, the cat summoned a beautiful, meowing cow from the earth. “See?”

“I heard of this fomor ability, but this is the first time I see it in action,” Knight Kia muttered, astonished by this simple trick.

“We dragons can do the same!” Vainqueur protested, trying to keep face. “We simply never bother, for the Elder Wyrms filled the world with bountiful minions already.”

“I doubt that,” Cait Sith replied with a sarcastic tone.

“Are you calling me a liar?” Vainqueur replied while giving the fairy cat a stern stare. “For you are starting to sound like food.”

“That is the whole problem,” Cait Sith said, valiantly holding the dragon’s gaze. “My cats have *feelings*! You cannot eat them again and again!”

“Wait, if you can create life, why did Mag Mell need dragon blood to make a Soulcrest and thus a soul?” Manling Victor asked, confused. “Can’t you manifest a soul from nothing?”

“We fomors can bring life to items, plants, and animals,” Cait Sith explained, relaxing a bit now that Vainqueur held off on eating him. “But we cannot create souls. They come from somewhere else.”

“From dragons,” Vainqueur stated the truth, while Cait Sith shrugged.

Manling Victor took this information with great reverence. “Dragons,” he muttered to himself. “Souls come from dragons.”

“Obviously, minion.”

“No, Your Majesty, don’t you see?” The Vizier looked his master in the eyes. “At one point, fomors and dragons got along!”

What? What kind of rubbish led him to this conclusion? “Impossible,” Vainqueur declared. “Us, getting along with fairies? Pff...”

“Think about it, Your Majesty,” Manling Victor insisted. “We know only dragons and fomors are true natives of Outremonde. If fomors can only grant life but not souls, then how do you explain all the sentient species present in this world? Not all of them were like us humans, abducted from other worlds.”

“Because we made them!” Cait Sith lied, boasting wrongfully about his species.

“We made the world first!” Vainqueur contested.

“What if...” Manling Victor thought out loud, clinging to his insane theory. “If dragons wielded soul magic, then maybe they granted fomors souls, and in exchange, the fomors created creatures for the dragons to feed on? That would explain all the monsters running around. The System links class levels to the soul, which was the purview of dragons, but it was only activated when Dice, a fomor sentient artifact, went on a rolling spree. The System needed *both* of the species’ magic to activate.”

“That’s a bit farfetched, Victor,” Knight Kia said something sensible for once.

"You have a better explanation?" Manling Victor rasped.

"It's Truck-Kun," she replied with firm belief, "It all comes down to Truck-Kun."

“This is a conspiracy theory,” Vainqueur replied, brushing it away. “As far as elders like Grandrake can remember, we dragons and fairies were at war with each other.”

“This is a debate for another time,” Knight Kia agreed. She pressed her shining sword against Cait Sith’s throat before he could react, the Starmetal blade within an inch of drawing blood. “We need to find Odieuse before she uses her nuclear arsenal.”

“You will not find her there,” Cait Sith hissed. “This is a fairy cradle—my cradle—not a lair.”

“A cradle?” Manling Victor frowned.

“This is one of the spots where the Eldest, the progenitor of all, breathed life into the first fomors,” the false cat meowed with pride. “The wild magic in this place often grants life to more of us on Samhain.”

“If Odieuse is not there, where is she?” Knight Kia asked threateningly.

The furball immediately found an opportunity to bargain, as fairies do. “You will leave my cat children alone if I tell you?”

“Now, you are asking too much!” Vainqueur snarled. “You ask me to weigh the salvation of the entire minion race against this information!”

“If we don’t find Odieuse, Your Majesty, there won’t be a minion race to care about,” Manling Victor argued. “Time is not on our side.”

Mmmm... his minion, once again, had a point. Vainqueur imagined many breeding solutions that could solve dragon hunger, but none that could survive in a radioactive wasteland.

“Fine,” the dragon said. “I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, vow to outlaw cat eating once the war is won.”

He would replace them with half-Tarasque hybrids.

“See, not so hard,” Cait Sith replied, proud of himself. “The other fomors are boarding the *Crom Cruach* on the western island. From what I understood, it’s due to launch anytime soon.”

“The Cromawhat?” Vainqueur asked.

“The flying castle with which Mell Odieuse says that she will wipe out all life in Outremonde.” Cait Sith marked a short pause, as the silence stretched on. “Hello? I thought she had advertised enough about it.”

Vainqueur let out smoke from his nostrils. “Explain yourself, false cat.”

“Odieuse built an ark for the fomors, full of those miracle weapons,” Cait Sith explained with heavy contempt. “It will reach the skies, and then shower all the earth with flames. Only those aboard the castle and Prydain shall be spared from the devastation, so I have been trying to get as many cats safely on the island before the deadline.”

The dragon and his minions exchanged tense glances. “Can it be done?” Manling Victor asked Knight Kia. “Blowing up the whole world?”

“If the castle can fire the missing nuclear missiles and reaches a certain orbit, she could credibly hit all of Outremonde’s major population centers at once,” the [Paladin] admitted, horrified. “Even if some cities survive thanks to Furibon's shields, the resulting nuclear winter will devastate them.”

“That’s why we have only fought thralls so far,” Manling Victor muttered under his breath, “They aren’t trying to win, just to stall until they can wipe us all out.”

“The fairies would rather burn the world than let us dragons have it?” Vainqueur snarled, amazed but not surprised by their insanity. He turned to the furred fomor. “You, cat, shall lead us to it.”

The purple cat hesitated, torn. He probably weighted Vainqueur’s chances of success against those of Odieuse, and clearly needed help to see the light.

“I have sworn, on my honor as a dragon, to stop hunting your kind,” Vainqueur argued. “Has the vile fairy Mell Odieuse? I think not, for nothing will ever satisfy her thirst for blood! She will not stop at killing dragons, as she feeds on life itself! Your cat children may satisfy her cruelty nine times, in the end, they too, will die!”

Charisma check...

Successful!

“Alright,” Cait Sith said, albeit hesitantly, “I will guide you to the Crom Cruach.”

Chapter 142: The Yarn Solution

“How do you make holy water?” Victor’s [Fetch] asked the original. “You boil the hell out of it!”

Sitting on a tooth chair next to a tongue-shaped table, the Vizier raised his eyes from his scrolls and maps to look at his clone, who expected approval. Cait Sith was sleeping on a cushion in a corner, having been granted milk and a steady supply of food for his help in reaching Odieuse’s lair, while blood boiled inside the [Black Grail] nearby.

Victor would rather have reached Crom Cruach already, but it would take some time before all of their allies could mobilize; knowing the fairy queen, she would launch everything she had at them, and even Vainqueur understood he needed all the help he could get. They couldn’t afford to retreat this time.

For if they failed, there wouldn’t be a world left to save.

“I don’t think her mother will like it,” the [Reaper] admitted. “Even if she’s opposed to political correctness in Happyland, Isa will be offended.”

“Hear me out, I got a better one,” the fetch coughed, before unleashing the bomb. “If a child refuses to sleep during nap time, are they guilty of resisting *a rest*?”

The ‘wooden’ house they inhabited seemed to groan, and it probably did.

A bat took the opportunity to enter through an open window. The V&V army had set up a night camp outside as they made their way through Prydain’s western borders.

“Victor, what are you doing?” the bat asked him, before shapeshifting into Charlene. She must have returned from her latest mission, scouting the fairies’ territories to prevent ambushes.

“Practicing dad jokes for Braniña’s birth,” Victor explained, the [Fetch] unmoved by the lack of warm reception from his audience. “And learning Tier X magic.”

“Babies?” a voice echoed into the house, startling Charlene.

“Not yet,” Victor replied. Since Junior had evolved into a [Mimic Witch Hut], the Vizier had turned his former pet into a walking command tent. Not only was it an excellent defense, but the creature’s [Witch’s Lair] Perk cut the SP cost of all spells cast within in half. Perfect to practice new magic.

Unfortunately, the house had a kid obsession that rivaled Victor’s own.

That came out wrong, the Vizier thought, while Charlene sat at the edge of the table, a leg over the other. With this pose, she looked like some *Twilight* vampire commercial. “What kind of spells can you cast now?” she asked Victor. “Having seen what Tier IX spells can do, I can scarcely imagine Tier X’s potency.”

Neither did Victor until he laid his eyes on these scrolls.

Tier X spells were as absurd as they were rare. Since very few spellcasters reached that level, only a few spells of that level had been discovered. Thanks to the gods backing him up, Victor had managed to get his hands on a handful of them, and even then he lacked the specializations needed to cast the best ones.

“[Idoun],” Victor read a scroll to Charlene. “Grants a target one thousand years of eternal youth. [Red Moon], Tier X [Ritual] exclusive to Moon Man worshipers and Claimed, causes a lunar eclipse driving everyone seeing the Moon to [Madness] for a single night. [Private World], folds an area of space into a private world. [King In Yellow], Tier X [Performance], summons the eldritch deity Hastur to destroy a city...”

“You can grant eternal youth on demand?” the vampire asked, immediately sensing an opportunity. “You could sell that service to fund the war budget.”

“Our finances and supply lines are that bad?”

“Not as bad as I thought,” she said. “Minions have been a lot more productive since Vainqueur raised them, and our beloved dragon keeps piling up new items.”

The [Hoard Armor] was truly a modern cash machine. Almost every creature Vainqueur killed dropped something now.

“But I wouldn’t wish for the war to last long,” the vampire said, “Our monstrous troops are clearly better at taking positions rather than holding them, and a prolonged conflict will cause our war effort to collapse on itself. In particular, while powerful, our dragon allies are a logistical nightmare when it comes to feeding.”

“It won’t last more than a week.” Either Odieuse would blow them all up, or they would kill her first. “What is the situation on the front?”

“According to Kia, Gardemagne’s army should join with ours in two days, in time to cross the sea between Prydain’s eastern and western islands,” the vampire explained. “We will come into sight of the western sea tomorrow. On the bad side, Grandrake and Jolie’s forces have been delayed. I heard they encountered heavy resistance.”

“Anything we should worry about?” Vainqueur would be willing to abandon everything to rescue his niece, even if Buzz Jelly and the Kobold Rangers had been assigned to her protection.

“I sent Jules to help,” she replied. “And their group has a *Tarasque*. They will be fine.”

“Charlene, we can’t solve all our problems by throwing a Tarasque at them,” Victor replied, the vampire smiling. “Any sign of the submarine?”

"No," she shook her head, "Nor of Akhenapep, or any fomor lord."

Victor had the distinct feeling they were about to face a marathon of harsh battles very, very soon. "Unfortunate, but still, good job. Information is key to victory, and your intelligence so far is top-notch."

"Thank you," she said, happy to have her work recognized. "Also, I appreciated you convincing Vainqueur to give us a raise. Now I have so much money, I don't know what to do with it if we win this war."

"Gamble it away? Please just find a new hobby other than ruining Croissant's life."

"He doesn't need my help for that," she replied, although clearly unhappy with the compromise Victor forced her into. "You promised me a three weeks of vacation a year and that you would spend more time with me if I dropped my vendetta; so far I see none of these promises fulfilled. I feel betrayed."

"We're at war," Victor pointed out.

"I know, we're both busy," Charlene said. "But we could take the evening to relax. Neither of us may be there to enjoy a moment in the future."

"I don't intend to die, and neither do you," Victor said.

"I didn't mean it that way," she replied. "You and Vainqueur are on your way to godhood; if you save the world, what could come afterward?"

Valhalla.

"Vainqueur and I swore to become gods together," Victor said. "But I never thought it would be possible for us to actually reach it; it sounded like another pipe dream to me. I mean, didn't it take Mithras decades to reach level 99?"

"I heard it took Sablar two years to ascend, although he destroyed a few countries and islands to do so. I'm pretty sure he's half the reason for the once-extinction of the [Exp Dodo]."

“Oh, then we aren’t treading on new ground,” Victor deadpanned, the vampire chuckling. “I haven’t given it much thought. I always figured Vainqueur and I would scrape together a solution at the last minute.”

“You should plan for this eventuality,” the vampire replied. “This empire will collapse without the two of you, and no god has ruled a country directly since Mithras. Most [Epic] level people die either trying to become a god or dying to other [Epic] level people trying to reach level 99.”

Yeah, after so many exp plateaus, fighting other [Epic] adventurers was one of the few ways left to reach Valhalla besides Dodocide. Maybe this was why Akhenapep had joined with Odieuse, for the chance to end the world and ride a tide of blood all the way to Valhalla. “You worry about my safety, Charlene?”

“I do,” she admitted, although she made it sound like she didn’t care all that much. “You’re the only person who can manage this mess of a country. All I’m saying is... please have a back-up plan.”

Victor crossed his arms, thoughtful. “I’ll think about it.”

“Yes, do,” she said before shapeshifting into a mist and leaving him alone.

Soon after she did, his [Black Grail] finished restructuring the blood within its cup.

“Hey,” Victor called out to Cait Sith. “Hey, cat!”

“What?!” the fomor growled angrily, his nap interrupted. In spite of his fairy nature, the creature behaved like a housecat in almost everything.

“Can I ask you for a service?” Victor asked. “About the war?”

“I told you, Mell Odieuse can close my fairy rings the second I open them. I will bring you as close I can, but afterward, you are on your own.” The cat meowed and rested on the cushion. “I died too many times already, I am not risking my neck for you mortals.”

Victor could relate, somewhat. “I just need information, and only a tiny little bit of work on your part.”

“Oh, I see where this is going.” The fomor a bit offended that a lowly half-dragon would ask anything of a cat. “You want me to teach you the secret of my nine lives?”

Could he even do that? Thanks to [Monster Student], Victor could learn Perks from monsters, even if he didn’t suffer the attack first. In particular, Barnabas had taught him [Troll Regeneration] by healing the Vizier the ‘troll way.’

Painfully.

Victor would have loved to learn the Tarasque’s regeneration—which would probably make him invincible—but the beast lacked the higher understanding necessary to teach it, let alone understand classes and level-up. This may have been a blessing in disguise.

Gods, an intelligent Tarasque [Wizard] would be *terrifying*.

“I already have a revival method of my own,” Victor said, proud of his black cup. “No, I have something else in mind.”

“What do I get in return?” the cat replied, brazenly scratching his tummy. “I am a feline. I am not like you manlings. My evolved, immortal body needs eighteen hours of sleep to work, and you’re delaying my rest.”

Victor summoned a bright ball of red yarn in his hand.

The fomor looked at the item with big, fascinated eyes. “Give it to me,” the cat ordered Victor like a petulant child, extending his tiny paws. Of course, the fairy was too lazy to actually rise up from his cushion and take it by force. “Give it to me, manling!”

“Why does your kind follow Odieuse?” Victor asked, dangling the yarn ball in front of the critter.

“Because they want the power of a Soulcrest,” the cat replied with a sarcastic, condescending tone as if talking to a slow child. And people wondered why Victor hated cats. “It’s not like dragons will give us their blood willingly.”

Won’t they? The more he thought of it, the more Victor was convinced dragons and fomors had some sort of symbiotic relationship at one point; their innate magic seemed to complement each others too much, even if wyrms had forgotten their own.

Heck, from what he had seen, their blood was even of the *same color*. Coincidence?

“The good thing is,” Victor said, taking out his homemade [Soulcrest] out of the Black Grail. “I’m half-dragon.”

His creation was only a third of the size of Mag Mell’s but should work the same. Even Cait Sith instantly recognized its power.

“My [Black Grail] can produce black blood with the same properties as a true dragon’s humors,” Victor explained. “As long as the artifact remains, you fomors can gain souls without killing anyone, or owing anything to Odieuse.”

“What do you want me to do with it?” the fomor asked, his playfulness replaced with seriousness.

“I want you to spread the word to your kindred, to anyone who has doubts about this war or Odieuse’s genocide. Those of you with souls, and thus a conscience; and those who don’t have a soul yet, but are pragmatic enough to understand that this crusade will only end in our mutual annihilation. Carry the word and show them this crest, and tell them there is another way. She isn’t your only choice and never was.”

“Why are you doing this, manling?” the fairy cat asked, genuinely puzzled. “My kind did terrible things to yours.”

“Because I believe people can change, and that all species can coexist together if they make the effort,” Victor said. “Vainqueur and I, we created a place where monsters can live together. In time, through trade and diplomacy, they will truly coexist with humans too. I truly think this is the only way to break this cycle of war.”

“It’s too late,” Cait Sith shook his head with resignation. “Your kind will never forgive us. They will not move past centuries of death and oppression. I’ve seen it, meow. Your people hate us.”

“I think they can move on with time,” Victor said. “Not all of them, because people are complicated and old grudges die hard. But I think most will give peace a chance. If you take a stand.”

Germany had done terrible things under the Nazi regime, but the country reformed itself and helped foster peace in Europe for decades. Maybe Victor was mistaken in his hope things could improve... but he would never forgive himself if he didn’t at least try.

Cait Sith remained silent for a long, long while. “You are naive, manling,” he finally spoke up. “Your idea is doomed to fail.”

“You said your fellow followed Odieuse because she could offer them power.”

“But they would kill your kind for free,” the cat replied. “They hate you with a passion because you mortals are weaker than us and yet you bested our kind many times. My uncatlike fellows have fed on their hatred for more time than it takes for your kingdoms to rise and fall; souls helped them change, but not that much.”

“You think Odieuse has more willing supporters than unwilling?”

“Yes. And even if you manage to kill the fairy queen, they will never stop trying to wipe you out.”

He had a point, unfortunately. If anything, gaining a soul had made the Mell Clan even crueler. For each Wotan or Jack, there was a Hamelin; change

had to be a choice, and not all fomors were willing to make it.

But still, between trying to make peace and total genocide... Victor would always choose the first. Even Vainqueur had come around to believing peace was possible, and the Vizier trusted his friend.

Somehow, that dragon would change the world.

“But you will still try my idea?” Victor asked the cat. "Even if you don't think it will work?"

“Yes, meow. I will. For the yarn.”

Victor tossed it to the cat, who began to spin it with giddy abandon.

As a wise man once said, *Alea Iacta Est*.

“Hey, I got a good one,” the [Fetch] suddenly said, having a eureka moment. “How do you call me when I’m wearing a crown and a [Belt of Genderbending]?”

... oh no, please no.

“Queen Victoria!”

Chapter 143: The Line

Vainqueur felt it in his bones. The Fairy Queen Mell Odieuse was nearby.

Her foul stench filled the air, carried by the wind.

After crossing the dense forests of Prydain, Vainqueur and his mighty army had reached the island's western shores, destroying its defensive walls from behind. Thousands of minions and dragons had lined up, as dawn appeared behind the clear, crimson horizon. Sharkmen and their giant fish master had occupied the sea, to help carry troops on the other side.

"Here it is, meow," Cait Sith declared, his tiny paws on the sand. "Cross the waters, and you will see."

Beyond the tumultuous sea, Vainqueur watched a second, smaller island, fortified by powerful magical wards. Smoke came out of these distant shores, as if entire forests burnt to fuel some giant forge's appetite; the air choked with the smell of radioactive fumes and dust.

"How long until the castle takes its flight?" Manling Victor asked the cat, standing near his master's side as he summoned dark clouds to allow vampires and other sun-fearing creatures to move. He was himself surrounded by the minion elites and Knight Kia, in full [Plot Armor].

"Meow, she said in two days, but that was before you arrived. It has yet to rise, but maybe it will soon." Cait Sith looked up at the dragon emperor. "Do not forget your promise."

"I shall fulfill my oath," Vainqueur replied to the furball. "After the war is won, your meowing kind shall go free."

"You've got a part to play in this mess too, Cait Sith," Manling Victor told the fairy cat.

"Meow, do not expect anything to come out of this," the fomor replied, before showing them all his royal butt. "Good luck, yarn people. Superior species, out."

The fomor opened a fairy ring and vanished, leaving the army behind.

His body protected by the warmth of his [Hoard Armor], his shininess enhanced by the sun, the emperor turned to face his troops.

Never before had a dragon led such a strange motley of minions and allies. Kobolds, goblins, werewolves, fiends, undead, gnolls, trolls, spiders, taradodos, dwarves, orcs, slimes... in his journeys, the V&V Guild had grown into a great and terrible force, a horde gathering all kinds of monsters. Many dragons, among them his cousin Genialissime, Grandrake, and many others, had joined under Vainqueur's leadership. More would follow soon, flocking through the skies when the emperor would call the signal for the last battle.

The human Gardemagnian Army would join them too, as would Jolie's group... although Vainqueur secretly hoped that his niece would remain safe, and let her uncle bear the brunt of this devastating conflict.

His people looked at Vainqueur with anxiety, none daring to speak up. The tension was palpable.

"Minions," Vainqueur cleared his throat. "Beyond these shores, awaits our final battle."

[El Presidente] activated!

"You have my thanks for following me this far," Vainqueur spoke up from the heart. "A little more than a year ago, when I rose from my slumber to grow my hoard, I never imagined that I would stand here before you. Although I knew minions would flock to my banners and serve me unconditionally... you all made me proud. You fought with me against

countless enemies, from the Forgotten One to the grasshopper Brandon Maure. Together, we smashed the wicked Mot and the Batling Lavere, and we built a great city upon their ashes! We conquered the East and the West until we crafted a great empire on which the sun never sets! It took me a long, long time to understand it, but my hoard was not made from coins and gems alone. It was made of you, minions."

The dragon nodded at his lackeys, who had tears in their eyes.

"You are my hoard! All of you!"

Hurrahs and shouts answered his declaration. His minions clapped in joy, while the dragons present nodded in support.

"Today, we stand with my fellow wyrms as one, against a threat menacing all hoards!" As manling Victor cast buffs on his master, Vainqueur continued to make his case. "A bright dawn will rise on a new world tomorrow! One where dragons and minions can live in peace, to gather their hoards! A world free of lead! We shall storm this island, and bring the fairies' castle to the gro—"

"[Za Warudo]!"

For a second, Vainqueur thought the Forgotten One had joined the fray, but the voice was different. Familiar, but different.

Time seemed to stop for a second, and when it resumed, Vainqueur turned his head behind him to face an army.

A massive force of golems, greater than the one who prevented them from landing on Prydain, had gathered in the skies, a swarm of steel and swords. Orc and human priests of that worm Sablar rode flying warbeasts, summoning monsters and deadly magic. Explosions detonated beneath the sea, the sharkman Jajambe propelled on the shores by a mighty detonation.

The metal Dolphin which attacked Vainqueur upon first landing rose from the waves, covered in the blood of fishmen, its Wind Spears ready to take to the skies.

Those cowards, they didn't even let him finish his speech!

"Someone triggered the anti-teleportation wards," Victor declared, while Knight Kia drew her blade. "They tried to teleport a nuke to our face in the stopped time."

Only a vicious mind could imagine such a destructive strategy, and Vainqueur caught a glimpse of the responsible. On the back of the Dolphin stood an ancient, rune-covered mummy, a wicked foe from an age bygone. The undead who slew his minion for the second time, costing Vainqueur a fortune.

The vile Akhenapep, Vainqueur recognized him, before letting out a furious roar. "Minions, to arms! Dragons, to me!"

As his mighty roar and the flapping of his wings echoed across the skies, dragonkind answered. The horizon was filled with an army of wings and claws, flocking to the final battle.

More dragons came from the west, some of them as big as Vainqueur himself; primordial great wyrms who had slumbered beneath the earth for centuries, millennia! Their shouts became a cacophony, drowning the buzzing of flying machines.

"[Black Horseman: Noircœur]," Manling Victor shouted. In the blink of an eye, a dark horse appeared below him, the [Reaper] ready to reap and tear. "Kia, are you ready?!"

"Nakama Desu!" she replied, the armor taking her over, before climbing on Gorynych's back.

"Minions, I shall break the Dolphin, you bury the mummy!" Vainqueur ordered, blasting a Wind Spear launched at him with a well-placed fireball.

His hoard he would defend.

Time for payback.

You changed the weather to [**Slime Rain**]. Slime type chosen: [**Thunder Jelly**].

As he altered the weather, electric slimes falling from the skies and charging clouds with electrical energy, Victor saw the area around him erupt into chaos. Spells and elemental breaths were unleashed from one side, bullets and shells fired from the other. Owing to the chaotic nature of both armies, it appeared as if two hordes of savage barbarians had met on the battlefield, to engage in a furious melee.

“Allison, Rolo, with me.” Victor picked up the dryad as his support, lifting her on Noirceur’s back, before casting a spell on the steel golem. “[Windy Cloak].”

A swirling cloak of wind surrounded the golem, turning him as light as a feather. The golem did some footwork, preparing himself to take a leap of faith; this time, he was determined to end Akhenapep, his maker, once and for all.

"So what's the plan, handsome?" Allison asked, sounding a bit worried. She hadn't forgotten her death at the pharaoh's hands.

“Rolo says we end this today. Rolo will not let him make the green a desert again.”

"Allison, heal and focus on buffs; the rest of us will go on the offense.” Victor then cast a few spells on himself. “[Rainmantle], [Hasten].”

For ten minutes, you will recover 1/8 of your HP each minute and walk on water. Your reaction time and speed will be greatly increased for ten minutes.

[**White Rider**] activated! Your buffs will be extended to your mount!

A shroud of water surrounded Victor and Noirceur, her fiery hooves turning to steam. “Worship me!” the horse roared, following Vainqueur’s lead and chasing after the submarine by running on the stormy sea itself. Allison

grabbed Victor's waist to hold on. "Worship me, worms! I am the goddess of horses!"

While the submarine began to dive down into the sea as Vainqueur and Kia approached it, Akhenapep summoned a sandstorm below his waist and used it to fly straight at Victor. Instead of casting spells at his former trainee yet, the mummy summoned reinforcements of his own. "[Chronosummon: Pterodactyls]!"

As he spoke these words, rifts in time opened across the open sea, a flock of six-meters wide flying dinosaurs teleporting through. Akhenapep seemed a bit bothered; clearly, he would have preferred to summon monsters amid the V&V army, not in front of it.

If Victor hadn't unlocked Tier IX and up, he might have succeeded.

Rolo, who had taken some momentum, leaped from the shores at high speed. Thanks to the spell empowering him, he jumped hundreds of meters in the air and landed on the back of a pterodactyl, forcefully driving the beast away by holding it by the neck. Allison focused on casting buffs, raising Victor's stats while his nightmare horse raced on the open sea to dodge the flying dinosaurs.

Strength and Vitality increased by two stages! You gained Resistance to **[Nuclear]**.

"These wards were your doing I presume?" Akhenapep asked Victor, keeping a safe distance from his enemies; clearly, he understood how much the group outmatched him in physical combat. "You have grown powerful, cultist. A pity you chose the wrong side."

"Guess surviving your last lessons gave me the levels I needed to kick your ass!" Victor replied, raising his scythe. "[Black Horseman: Tarasque Emperor]!"

In a flash, Victor teleported the radioactive Tarasque right above Akhenapep's head, a towering heavyweight falling on a much smaller target.

Using the same defensive strategy as in the battle of El Dorado, the mummy leaped through time, the Tarasque falling through an empty spot.

Akhenapep reappeared a second later, narrowly dodging a claw attack from the giant, glowing radioactive reptile.

Even with the protection set by Allison, Victor had Noircœur put some distance between the Tarasque and them. A giant radioactive pseudo-Japanese lizard, fighting the literal high priest of a nuclear god... poetic, in a way.

"What a coincidence, I gained a few levels too." Seeing the Tarasque roar and open his mouth to swallow him, Akhenapep slammed his hands together and summoned an item within his palms. The most terrifying weapon of all.

A dirty teapot.

"[Great Beast Containment Seal]!"

A mighty force pulled the Tarasque towards Akhenapep, alongside tons of waters and some of the dinosaur summons. Noircœur managed to pull away from the device's range, while Rolo leaped from dinosaur to dinosaur like Super Mario. The Tarasque Emperor wasn't so lucky though; a vortex pulled him inside the teapot and quickly trapped him inside.

Once the beast was contained, Akhenapep slammed the cover shut, then casually tossed the teapot out into the sea. "Strategem Twenty-Eight: I shall always keep dangerous monsters in secure cages. [Alacrity]."

Akhenapep's spellcasting time has been greatly shortened for Tier III spells and below!

"Oh come on! Do you know how many kids that thing left behind?" Victor complained. "How many monsters you just orphaned?"

The mummy responded by attempting to skewer him with a rain of golden arrows, forcing the Vizier and his minions to run away. The pharaoh's body began to radiate a green aura, polluting the air with nuclear energy.

All creatures near Akhenapep will lose 2 **Max** HP per second, except **[Undead]**, **[Eldritch]**, **[Alien]**, **[Insect]**, **[Elemental]** and **[Artificial]** types.

If your current HP surpasses your new Max HP limit, you will develop a **[Radioactive Tumor]**.

[Darwinist] activated! You will count as **[Eldritch]** for the purpose of the effect!

Eldritch? Must have been his inner slime showing. “You’re holding up?” the Vizier asked Allison and Noircœur.

“For now, my magical protection will hold,” the dryad replied. “But he might dispel them at any time.”

Meanwhile, Vainqueur engaged the submarine alongside the V&V amphibious forces, destroying Wind Spears before they could hit him with his breath. Kia and Gorynych, trusting the dragon to handle the superweapon, switched focus to circle behind Akhenapep and take him down.

Braving his radioactive aura, the **[Paladin]** raised her blade and tried to impale the pharaoh. The **[Chronomancer]** had no choice but to drop his assault on Victor to defend himself against the new challenger.

“Lightning,” Victor told Allison his battle plan, while Kia and Akhenapep engaged in a deadly aerial dance. “We go for lightning.”

“You’re sure?” she asked, looking at the clouds and then at Vainqueur’s confrontation with the submarine. “We’re near the sea, we risk friendly fire.”

“Buff my precision,” the Vizier replied. Akhenapep was unfortunately too dangerous and too high-level, with a radioactive aura that only weakened his opposition with time. They needed to kill him *fast*.

Nodding, the dryad cast spells on the Vizier, the necessary preparations for an ultimate attack. “[Protection from Lightning], [Accelerated Lightning]

Up]; [Lightning Pierce], [Accelerated Precision Up].”

You gained resistance to [**Lightning**] for ten minutes! [**Lightning**] spells will inflict 20 percent more damage and will bypass Resistance. You gained +20 to precision-based checks for five minutes!

Struggling against a Paladin optimized to damage him, Akhenapep collapsed space within his hand, creating a small black sphere. “[Black Hole].”

He launched the sphere at Kia and Gorynych, the projectile growing from the size of a tennis ball to that of a truck. The attack drew in anything unlucky enough to get close to its event horizon, from the [Chronomancer]’s summons to the very clouds. Rolo himself managed to drag his current dinosaur ride afar, instead regrouping with Victor and Allison.

Kia was much luckier.

Her [Plot Armor] radiated a blue light, forming a sphere around the knight and Gorynych. The shield and the black hole collided, fusing like yin and yang before both magics abruptly vanished; the [Paladin] and her Zmey mount ended up unharmed.

“What happened?” Allison asked, as astonished as Akhenapep himself.

Intelligence check successful.

“Friendship is pure positivity, while a [Black Hole] is created from negative energy,” Victor realized. “The sum of Kia’s bonds, magnified by the [Plot Armor], created a reverse polarity which canceled the black hole!”

The dryad remained silent for an instant. “That doesn’t make any sense!” she protested.

“And yet, it does!”

"Justice will prevail!" Kia shouted, more and more ashamed of her own speech. "I'm sorry, I'm nothing like this normally!"

"The [Plot Armor]," Akhenapep realized, recognizing the artifact; however, unlike what Victor would have thought, he sounded *more* confident than before, not *less*. "A very tricky defense, but one with a glaring weakness."

"It makes me want to puke?" Kia frowned, summoning a [Solar Judgment].

"You are protected from death, hero," Akhenapep mused upon dodging a pillar of light, "and *only* death."

The Ur-Pharaoh flew towards the [Paladin], Gorynych opening his three mouths to target him with his elemental breaths; instead, the mummy teleported right in front of Gorynych's chest and slapped him in the belly. "[Time Push]."

POOP.

Kia and Gorynych popped out of existence with a strange, ridiculous noise.

Victor saw red. "What did you do?!"

"I pushed them further down in the timestream," the Ur-Pharaoh replied, proud of his cunning. "They will reappear later at the same spot, safe, unharmed... and surrounded by defeat."

"How long?" Allison asked, horrified by the sudden loss of one of their strongest warriors. The mummy responded by targeting the two with a blast of radioactive energy, unwilling to give his foe any tactical information. Noircœur managed to dodge, while Victor maintained his focus on the thunderstorm above.

Poor Kia, that was the cruelest thing the mummy could ever do to her: force her to sit out of another epic battle. Even the [Plot Armor] couldn't offset her terrible luck.

Rolo, having gained some sort of control over his pterodactyl mount, prepared to attack his maker, but Victor dissuaded him with a glance.

The [Weathermaker] was ready.

“I heard you caught a fairy too, cultist,” Akhenapep said, preparing to unleash another [Black Hole], this time at the Vizier. “But you should have kept Mot chained and bound. A well-crafted wish would have saved you.”

"Mag Mell's soul knew more than how to create a Soulcrest," Victor replied, confident. "He had knowledge of fairy magic; in particular, of spells so powerful that no humans could ever cast them... until a few levels ago."

The slime storm had reached its apex, carrying the lightning Victor needed to cast this ultimate technique. Allison protected her face while she cast [Protection from Lightning] spells on herself and Rolo.

"Here it comes!" Victor waved his scythe like Wotan once did with his spear. "The supreme lightning, which guarantees victory!"

"Impossible," Akhenapep muttered, astonished, before attempting to skip time and dodge, "[Time Le—"

"[**Ragnarok**]!"

Thunder swallowed Akhenapep whole, and the whole sea flashed brightly.

Chapter 144: The Arrows of Light

The skies were bright with explosions, but Vainqueur's light blinded them all. "[Shining Majesty]!"

The dragon radiated the holy light of the hoard on the Sablarian heathens, incinerating those closest to him, and melting even their mighty war golems. A shooting star made wyrm, he pulverized everything in his path, creating a golden road for his fellow dragons to follow; behind him, Grandrake and Genialissime led the reptilian charge, raining elemental breaths on their outmatched enemies.

The fomors' last line of defense couldn't hold against the fury of dragons. Yet they held the line with suicidal stubbornness, fighting to the death for masters who refused to risk their own worthless lives.

The metal Dolphin, whom his minions had called a nuclear submarine, remained the greatest threat fielded by the fomors against the united minion armies. But unlike last time, it unleashed no Arrow of Light at Vainqueur's allies; Wind Spears and other artillery were its main weapons today.

Had the fairies learned their lesson? Or had it exhausted all its offensive weaponry fighting the fishmen's master, Lord Dagon, in their previous encounter?

No. The fairies must have kept their arrows in reserve in their hidden castle, sending the submarine as a sheep to the slaughter; a final, last-ditch defense to halt the V&V army's advance.

Having finished clearing the skies enough to safeguard his minions, Vainqueur allowed his kindred to take over the aerial battle and returned to his assault on the submarine. The machine was engaged in a fierce battle

with the V&V Empire's amphibious forces, from fishmen to monstrous squidlike immigrants from the dreaded Planet Moon. They were swift and strong, but their speed could only safeguard them so much against the barrage of cannonballs and missiles the golem submarine fired in every direction.

Roaring at the challenge, Vainqueur dived down to bombard the submarine with his breath; the machine, fueled by a simple yet effective intelligence, dived down below to the safety of seawater. The dragon's fireballs turned waves to boiling clouds of steam, and some might even have hit their target, but the ocean provided protection difficult to overcome.

What could Vainqueur do? Use Geomancy to alter the sea, raise stone from the ocean floor? He would need to be grounded to do so, and it would deprive his seafaring forces of their own safety net.

No. He would confront the metal beast in its nest, and force it to duel him on the land.

The dragon dived down, dodging artillery, before falling into the water like a harpoon; his scales hit the waves and pierced through saltwater. Sharkmen followed after their emperor, the creatures swimming with almost as much grace as Vainqueur himself.

Vainqueur kept going down until he reached the undersea rift where the submarine had retreated. Instantly, upon catching sight of its enemy, the machine fired a dozen torpedos in the dragon's direction.

Agility check successful!

Like a magnificent water wyrm, Vainqueur skillfully moved to dodge the torpedoes, circling the golem. His aquatic minions, meanwhile, went for the frontline approach, assaulting the submarine head-on by launching lightning spears at it. The scene reminded the dragon of those silly knights, who tried to tickle him with their ridiculous sword toothpicks.

Useless... but distracting.

This offered the dragon an opportunity he didn't waste, moving below the submarine's hull and grabbing it with his hands.

With great might, Vainqueur attempted to lift the Dolphin from below, defying the very laws of physics.

Strength check...

Successful!

But impossible wasn't for dragons.

Even underwater, the flapping of his great, mighty wings could carry Vainqueur through anything. They allowed him to push up until even the sharkmen pulled back, as the dragon carried his prey towards the surface.

Unbalanced, the Dolphin began to break down under the strain of its own mass, even as Vainqueur raised it further and further high. The dragon emerged from the waves, lifting the giant golem above the ground.

Then, gaining momentum, Vainqueur threw the submarine at the distant shores, like the very same arrows it rained upon the dragon. The machine hit the ground in a catastrophic crash, blowing dust in all directions, but survived. Even as Vainqueur unleashed fire upon its iron hide, the golem raised itself on tiny mechanical legs and tried to return to the sea; its steel hide turned red from the heat, yet remained too strong for Vainqueur to pierce through.

But the dragon was cunning and had planned ahead. Time to activate one of his new Perks.

"[Sublime Dragonbreath: Icefang]."

Your breath element changed to [**Frost**].

Next time he breathed, Vainqueur's gullets produced not hot, nuclear flames, but a blizzard; as chilling as his departed rival Icefang had ever produced. After the searing heat, the freeze damaged the metal hide, turning it brittle.

When he knew that one final push would destroy the beast, Vainqueur prepared to land the coup de grace.

“[Sublime Breath: Earth]!”

As he changed its element one more time, Vainqueur’s breath transformed from ice to earth. Instead of releasing a chilling blizzard, he rained sharp stones from his gullet; each shard thick enough to cut a tree in half.

Weakened by the heating and freezing, the rain of projectiles devastated the Dolphin’s hide, piercing its metal skin as easily as arrows with mammal flesh. The barrage of stones cut the metal monster in half, explosions devastating its body and blowing steel in all directions.

When the dust settled, the golem submarine looked like a gutted fish, dead and smoking.

“I am the wyrm of countless breaths!” Vainqueur roared to the heavens, victorious once again.

“You wasted too much time, Knightsbane.”

It took a few seconds for Vainqueur to recognize the voice and its source. “Dragonslaying fairy,” he hissed. “Show yourself.”

“Foolish dragon,” Odieuse's voice echoed out of the Dolphin's dorsal fin, and the tiny loudspeakers hidden there. *“You believe you cornered me when all you did served my design.”*

“Then you must be very good at losing,” Vainqueur replied with pride.

“You gathered my enemies in one place, including the dragons of the world... so that I may slay you all at once. Your souls will fuel my belly, unleashing a tide of blood that I shall ride to Valhalla. The dead of this conflict almost made me a goddess already. I simply need... a final miracle.”

Sound erupted from the distant island, beyond the magical wards.

Victor had to admit it, Wotan had a good reason to favor Ragnarok as his chosen spell; it had killed Akhenapep in one strike, while it had taken Kia's epic sword or Vainqueur's [Charged Breath] before.

A pity it didn't stick.

As expected, a few seconds after the mighty thunderbolt vaporized him, the mummy reappeared unharmed at the same spot. Floating under the power of a sandstorm, he cast a mighty buffing spell on himself. "[Greater Seal: Lightning]."

Akhenapep gained temporary Immunity to [**Lightning**]!

Meanwhile, Victor and Allison still rode on the back of Noircœur the Nightmare, who could run on the seawater as easily as grass; while they lacked Akhenapep's flight advantage, they outmatched him in speed and maneuverability. Rolo the golem rode a captured pterodactyl above them as support.

The golem [Farmer] and his mount attempted to smash Akhenapep by diving up, but the mummy leaped through time to avoid the attack. When he reappeared, the undead immediately put some distance between his foes and himself, Victor and Rolo giving pursuit on their respective mounts; one above the target, the other below.

"[Leaf Storm]!" While Victor focused on chasing after the mummy, Allison cast a spell at his back. She pointed her fingers at Akhenapep above them, unleashing a mighty storm of leaves and green energy.

"[Space Slash]!"

Akhenapep sundered reality itself with an index finger, creating a moving rift in the fabric of space itself. The 'slash,' while no longer than three meters, cut through the leaf storm, the water, the very air. It was a fast-moving, horizontal black hole erasing anything unlucky to be in its path; a blade of pure nothingness.

Victor's horse swiftly dodged the attack by leaping to the side, even as the blade bent its course, but the attack kept going long afterward. The slash cut through a fairy golem, cutting it in half, and beheaded a fishman swimming in the waters; the blade cut through the shores and traced a razor-thin line in the sand, and then continued past Victor's line of sight. Maybe it would continue its deadly course all the way to Gardemagne, crossing the earth and finishing its travel in the deep darkness of space.

While the attack had been ineffective, Victor could only approve of Allison's initiative. His [Chronomancer] capstone allowed Akhenapep to return from death by unwinding time, as long as he had enough SP to fuel his Perk. As a purely arcane build, the more the mummy had to cast powerful spells, the faster his reserves would dwindle.

Of course, no sooner did the thought crossed his mind that the Ur-Pharaoh shattered Victor's hope. One scroll making up his mummy's bandages shone bright, its runes vanishing.

Akhenapep's [**Scrolls of Fomor Cheatery**] allowed him to recover 999 SP!

...

That optimizing bastard! And he looked at Victor with smugness too!

However, the sound of battle horns filled him with hope.

A new army came from the east, cavalry on the ground, their horses pounding the sand; griffins, flying mages, and pegasi in the air. Their spears hit the fomor forces' flank, while their flying forces backed up the dragons.

All of them proudly wore white armor and the flag of Mithras.

"The Gardemagnian Army!" Allison rejoiced behind Victor, clearly happy to see reinforcements.

Kia's ally, the dark elf archmage Kevin, left the bulk of the army to fly straight to the Vizier's rescue. He pointed his palm at Akhenapep and cast a spell. "[Enhanced Polar Blizzard]!"

The archmage unleashed a mighty beam of blue energy from his hand, which turned into a powerful freezing blast. Akhenapep [Time Leaped] once more to dodge, the attack phasing through him and turning an entire span of the sea to ice.

“Where’s Kia?” the dark elf archmage asked, flying down towards Victor and Allison while their mount skidded on the new floe with grace. Akhenapep reappeared on the other side of the makeshift arctic, hovering above the ice a few meters away from the group.

“He teleported her away!” Allison protested.

“What? This *again*?” Clearly this was nothing new to Kia’s allies. Akhenapep quickly interrupted their discussion by gathering a [Black Hole] in his palm. “Raid boss?”

“Raid boss. Akhenapep. Can’t kill him without depleting his SP, and he has items to recover them.” Victor shook his head. “I don’t see many options.”

“I have a tactic. The same we used to demolish every high-level spellcaster so far,” Kevin replied, landing upon the ice and joining his hands to unleash a mighty Tier X spell. “[Enhanced Magic Eater].”

A feeling of emptiness spread across Victor’s surroundings, almost all his magical enhancements vanishing. Noircœur’s water mantle, which had allowed the horse to walk on the sea, vanished at once; the nightmare’s fiery hooves regained their brightness as they slowly melted the ice below her feet.

Akhenapep’s [Black Hole] collapsed into nothingness in his hand, while the sandstorm carrying him above the ground vanished. The mummy managed to land on the iced sea, although Kevin’s attack stripped him of his radioactive aura and other enhancements.

Intelligence check failed! You cannot use spells or SP-based abilities within two hundred meters of [**Kevin Nostredame**]! All magical buffs are dispelled, and the effects of non-artifacts will be temporarily suppressed!

That was why he had turned the sea to ice first, that clever bastard. To give them a space to stand on the water.

Considering Akhenapep's sheer level, Victor doubted anyone else could have pulled off this strategy; someone with a level short of [Epic] would have failed to affect the mummy. Even then, Kevin had clearly optimized his Perks or equipment to raise the power of his antimagic ability.

Even deprived of his overwhelming arcane might, Akhenapep remained a deadly combatant and a powerful mummy. The second he got back on his feet, he rushed at Kevin with astonishing speed, clearly intending to crush his neck and undo the magical field before physical fighters closed in. Since his revival needed SP to activate, this was the first time he was truly vulnerable.

Victor guessed that Kia's team usually trusted her to finish off the weakened spellcaster, but with her absence, the duty fell on the Vizier instead.

While she had slowed down without her buffs, Victor's nightmare horse still moved faster than Akhenapep. The horse reached the mummy before he could come anywhere close to threatening Kevin.

[Red Rider] activated!

Thankfully, Victor's build may be all over the place... many of his Perks didn't need SP to activate. And as artifacts, both his scythe and armor still worked fine.

Like a truck racing toward a helpless granny, Victor ran over Akhenapep and hit him with his scythe [Harvest].

Agility check...

Failed!

Much to Victor's astonishment, the mummy, showing some of his Rogue levels, dived below the phantom blade and kept running towards Kevin.

The Vizier hurriedly had his horse turn around, but immediately knew he wouldn't catch up to his former mentor in time.

Fortunately, this was a raid boss... and one never solos a raid boss.

A shadow grew above Akhenapep's head, as he was within an inch of grabbing Kevin and crushing his skull.

“ROLO SMASHES!”

Akhenapep barely had the time to look up before a rusty iron golem landed on his back, shattering his dusty spine. The aftershock was so great, that it caused the ice to fracture below them.

“Release me, golem!” Akhenapep ordered, unable to move under the golem's sheer weight and might. “I always treated your kind with kindness!”

Rolo, who clearly hadn't heard about *Vizier Stratagem Forty-Eight*, grabbed the helpless mummy and threw him straight in Victor's direction. The Vizier raised his blade high, while Allison cheered him on.

Akhenapep accepted his fate with grim resignation, a second before the blade hit him in the face. “I was a better teacher than I thought.”

Critical hit!

Victor beheaded the Ur-Pharaoh, trapping the mummy's soul inside his scythe Harvest—the only place that would ensure Sablar could not revive him. Without his buffs or the necessary SP to fuel his ability, the weapon killed the Ur-Pharaoh in one strike.

Victor's victory was short-lived though, as a rumbling noise shook the sea and the world.

It emerged from the distant island with a great rumbling, casting the sea in its dreadful shadow.

Its sight and appearance brought a temporary end to the fighting, paralyzing all creatures present. Even Vainqueur, who feared nothing, paused in astonishment.

An enormous castle had risen, an omen of the end.

A massive fortress of steel, glass, and spikes, its size put Vainqueur's own domain to shame. All of Murmurin probably could fit within its thick walls. Cannons and harpoons covered its surface, manned by golems, while every dragon for miles could smell the stench of fomor lords within the structure.

The castle itself rested on a flying rock almost as big as it, equipped with steel cylinders the size of hills; all of them unleashed white hot streams of fire, lifting the entire construct in its ascent.

A purple shield surrounded the enormous fortress, fueled by the howls of trapped souls. Its baleful energy cleared the skies of Manling Victor's thunderclouds, only to turn them red. Vampires and sun-fearing creatures immediately took cover or caught fire.

[Crom Cruach] transformed the Weather into **[Blood Skies]**! Everyone will take 20 percent more damage, and healing effects will be greatly weakened!

Within seconds, lifted by its fiery propellers, the castle ascended through the skies, pulverizing the wards which had protected its island from attack. Its flames and smokes vaporized anything unlucky to be in their vicinity, from warbeasts to pegasi riders.

Vainqueur chased after the castle, intent on destroying it. His fellow dragons followed his lead, unleashing their breaths at the castle while it was still within range; their attacks were easily repelled by the shield.

"Kill them all!" Odieuse ordered her voice echoing from the fortress above.

One of the castle's towers fired an arrow of light, the shield briefly opening to let it through.

Realizing the danger, Vainqueur immediately flew after the projectile and attempted to blast it with his flames.

It was in vain. As his fireball approached it, the missile broke into ten tinier arrows, each of them carrying a deadly kind of power.

Vainqueur did his best to destroy them before they could fall on his minions, but they were fast; much faster than the wind spears, faster than sound, faster than any other dragon could move. Seven of them detonated in the heavens, spraying the skies with light, but three more escaped destruction; they were now too close to detonate safely.

None of his kindred could stop them, and neither could Vainqueur. Even if the dragon destroyed them, at so close a range, the explosion would vaporize his soldiers.

Intelligence check successful! [**Dragon Honor**] activated!

There was only one solution to save them.

Vainqueur flew straight at the missiles, and at the last second, uttered fateful words. “[Glitzy Theater]!”

A golden arena formed around himself, a golden sphere over a mile in radius...

Trapping the missiles inside with the dragon emperor.

The great red wyrm roared and detonated the projectiles with a defiant stream of fire, as they were within an inch of his face.

The world flashed bright, and the light swallowed Vainqueur whole.

Chapter 145: Interlude: Fullmetal Jelly

So big...

Buzz Jelly looked at the world's map with light in his tiny eyes. The Empire's territories were painted gold because it was the best color, and everything else in silver, because they weren't rich enough.

The Empire was so small... but it glittered true. One day, Prydain would belong to the Empire.

One day, the whole world would be the Empire!

Buzz Jelly couldn't wait to invade everyone else, especially Gardemagne. Excalidad would be so proud to see a slime leap over their castle in triumph!

Its curiosity satisfied, the [Cosmonaut] leaped down from the map table and joined the other minions inside the war tent. They were the Kobold Rangers, war heroes of the Empire; they were so huge compared to the tiny slime, although not as huge as a dragon!

Together, they formed an elite squadron under the orders of the imperial princess Jolie Dragon, niece of the good Emperor Vainqueur. Their regiment would soon rejoin the main army, and conquer the castle of the evil fairy Mell Odieuse.

But today... they had been chosen for a special mission.

A cloaked undead entered the tent, the minions forming a line before their superior officer. Jules Rapace was the ghoul commander overseeing their

unit, the imperial princess' personal aide-de-camp, and chief of staff of substitution. The *Ghoulmander General*.

“Thank you for coming,” the Ghoulmander said to the gathered minions. “You are the best minions we have on hand, and this is a sensitive mission.”

“What is the matter, commander?” Red Ranger asked, the most experienced of the group.

“This is a rescue mission, but I won't lie,” the ghoul replied, putting some drawings on the table, “odds do not favor us.”

The minions looked at the table and the animated pictures on it. Buzz Jelly immediately recognized its fellow slime on one of the drawings, having been born during the same [Slime Rain]. “Molester! Pink Molester!”

“Its name is *Private Molesty*.” Ghoulmander Jules nodded, showing the group a picture of a pink slime and a dodo watching the sunset. “Father and mother of hundreds, Private Molesty is one of our best breeders and in a committed relationship with a dodo harem on Daltonia. Yet it didn't hesitate to answer the V&V draft, leaving its family behind to protect its homeland from fairy invaders.”

“So cute...” Pink Ranger said since she and the slime shared the same color.

The Ghoulmander showed them a photo of Molesty, its cheeks painted green, and a bandana around its tiny head. Another showed the slime boarding a Sword Rocket; Buzz Jelly was still sour about not having been granted its own to pilot during the invasion.

“During Operation Hoard Landfall, Private Molesty was Isekai'ed with a dwarf rocket called the *Rambo Warrior* behind enemy lines,” the Ghoulmander explained. “Its mission was to commit savage acts of sabotage and to terrify the fomor warbeasts through breeding warfare. We believed that as a veteran of the Daltonia campaign, Private Molesty could operate unsupervised and rejoin the main army. We were wrong.”

The Ghoulander showed them a new drawing, this time representing a devastated herd of fairy hounds, broken and defeated; it appeared a tornado had walked through the camp. “We lost trace of Private Molesty at a warbeast pack lair east of our location, where it single-handedly incapacitated a fighting force of thirty and seeded them with its brood.”

“What is his level?” Red Ranger asked, impressed by the slaughter.

“He used to be thirty, mostly in Vitality and Agility-focused classes, but he received a Crest before boarding the rocket,” the Ghoulander explained. “War being a quick source of exp, he probably reached level forty and accessed a Riding-focused class.”

“Forty,” Buzz Jelly repeated, having surpassed that level not too long ago. Although it would have loved to gain more [Cosmonaut] levels, it had to settle on [Artillerist]. So many firearms had been pointed at Buzz during the invasion, the slime had to spit out bullets for hours afterward.

Ghoulander Jules showed them a point on the map, and then the drawing of an orc in silly armor. “We believe Private Molesty has been cornered and, if not captured, trapped in the eastern region. Unfortunately, according to our vampire intel, the area is under the control of Frank the Anark, a minor [Chronomancer] and [Priest] of Sablar.”

“He steals princesses!” Pink Ranger snarled, incensed.

“And now he stole our slime,” Blue Ranger said gravely.

“His Majesty asked that no minion be left behind,” the Ghoulander said. “As his commander, it is my duty to rescue Molesty; nothing forces you to follow. I’m warning you, this may very well be a suicide mission. Princess Jolie is on a timer to rejoin His Majesty, and so we will have no reinforcements.”

“We Kobold Rangers will die for our country.” Red Ranger nodded. “And half of us did.”

“Good, because death is but a step in the right direction,” the Ghoulmander said, his undead eyes glancing at each minion in turn. “Will you help me return Private Molesty to his family?”

“Yes, sir!” all Rangers said at once.

“For Empire!” Buzz Jelly vowed. “Molesty return home!”

Having made their way through the forest until nightfall, alongside the Rangers’ pet dinosaur, the minions stopped under the shadow of trees and rested around a campfire. Ghoulmander Jules had retired into the darkness, praying to his goddess Camilla for success, while the Kobold Rangers roasted a feline.

“Do you want a cockroach with your cat?” The cook, Yellow Ranger, offered Buzz Jelly.

The slime shaking its tiny head, for it only fed on the crushed hopes of the Empire’s enemies. Yellow Ranger shrugged and offered a leg to Pink Ranger. The bard receded in disgust. “I’m not eating Squeakie,” the [Bard] complained. “I would rather starve!”

“Oh come on, it’s like, the third time we ate your cat,” the cook protested. “You’re going to become skinny and frail if you keep skipping meals.”

“Do you want another sixth ranger situation?” Blue Ranger asked the minstrel.

“We don’t talk about the sixth ranger,” Black Ranger replied, glaring at his teammate. “There has *never* been a sixth ranger.”

“Sixth?” Buzz Jelly asked, all the reptiles looking away in shame. So mysterious! “But you five!”

“It’s...” Red Ranger shook his head, paling as his breathing accelerated. “It’s a terrible story.”

“It wasn’t our fault.” Black Ranger shook his head, apparently lost in a flashback. “It was war!”

“He was silver,” Pink Ranger said. “He was cute, but...”

“He was annoying,” Blue Ranger cut in. “You can say it, he’s dead.”

“His name was Scrappy,” Red Ranger told Buzz Jelly. “At El Goldorado, Lady Jolie trusted us with protecting the Princess Wildlife Reserve, but knights kept coming. So we recruited a new Kobold to help in our scouting. I thought he had the attitude and the right color.”

“We told him he should change his minion name to Silver to fit the team’s theme, but he refused!” Yellow Ranger shouted, shaking. “He was insufferable! Obnoxious! Always trying to take the spotlight!”

“It was an accident!” Black Ranger, meanwhile, was still lost in his flashback. “I didn’t mean... I didn’t mean it!”

“At a point, a vicious human squire trapped us in a cave, closing the exit with a boulder so he could abscond with a princess,” Red Ranger said, his eyes looking at the roasted cat. “We couldn’t get out.”

“We spent days inside the cave, trying to dig our way out,” Blue Ranger continued. “Pink had to sing us terrible songs to make sure we didn’t fall unconscious from exhaustion. But Scrappy... Scrappy didn’t help, he just complained!”

“You know about the food chain,” Red Ranger asked Buzz Jelly, who nodded religiously. “We made a list between us. Who would sacrifice themselves first for the good of the Emperor. We never thought we would apply it ourselves, but... we were starving. We all looked at Scrappy, and he *knew*.”

“As an undead, I didn’t need to eat him to survive,” Blue Ranger admitted. “But I hated him. I *hated* him.”

“I always wanted to know how I tasted, yet I was too afraid to try. He tasted like veal.” Yellow Ranger looked deep into Buzz Jelly’s eyes, his gaze full of horror. “We taste like veal! Like cattle!”

“He was cute,” Pink Ranger had tears in her eyes. “But he didn’t run fast enough.”

“It was war,” Black Ranger kept repeating. “It was *war!*”

“When Lord Grandrake excavated us days afterward, there was nothing left to raise Scrappy with,” Red Ranger said grimly. “Not even bones.”

...

“That all?” Buzz Jelly asked, having expected something more impressive. That was part of the course in Murmurin, with no pun intended; Chocolatine had told the slime so many of these stories. “Was princess saved?”

“Oh?” Red Ranger nodded. “Oh yes, yes, she was. Lord Grandrake trapped the squire with a fake legendary sword in a stone. They just can’t resist those.”

“Like Excalidad?” Buzz Jelly asked, immediately entranced by *this* part of the story.

“It was a bit different,” Red Ranger explained. “Imagine a mousetrap, but with a sword replacing the cheese. The squire tried to pull it out and then —”

The sound of something being dumped next to the campfire interrupted the discussion.

“Gentleliving, gentledead,” the Ghoulmander said, tossing a paralyzed, white-skinned humanoid amidst the minions. “Look at what I caught spying on us.”

“I won’t talk!” the captive Doppelganger shouted, bound by tight ropes and kneeling on the grass.

“We know that you know the location of the fairy resistance’s base,” the Ghoulmander told the faceless prisoner. “We have ways of making you talk.”

“I won’t! Whatever you do to me, Frank will do it double!”

“Tickle him,” Red Ranger ordered, Blue and Black Rangers brandishing Dodo feathers. They ferociously tickled the doppelganger’s feet, to break his will.

But thirty minutes later, the humanoid hadn’t laughed even once!

“Moon!” Buzz Jelly showed the doppelganger a drawing it had scribbled with its mouth and crayons, trying its glue at interrogating that enemy of the state. “Moon!”

“What is this, a lead-colored landscape?” The shapeshifter shrugged it off. The sight of the Moon didn’t affect him.

“Damn, he has been trained against interrogation techniques.” Red Ranger shook his head. “We have no choice. Pink, brings out the banjo.”

“You sure?” Black Ranger asked his leader, a bit afraid. “He may not survive!”

“I will take full responsibility,” the Ghoulmander said. “Besides, we can raise him as an undead if he dies from the shock. Pink Ranger, make him talk.”

“Which songs do I play?” the bard asked, raising a banjo threateningly at the fairy thrall.

“[Requiem for a Lich], [The Passion of the Wyrn], [Vainquorio and Victoria]. If he doesn’t speak afterward, he never will.”

Pink Ranger cleared her throat, her fellow minions protecting their ears with their hands. Buzz Jelly didn’t, because it had no arms.

The slime listened, as the bard began a trio of songs: complex music, with complicated words that Buzz Jelly was too young to understand. Not familiar with mammalian nor reptilian biology, the slime didn’t catch most of the references.

They sounded disgusting though.

Charisma check successful! [**Madness**], [**Terror**] and [**Puking**] negated!
Ignorance is bliss!

Even as the songs cast the world in a blanket of gloomy darkness, the doppelganger resisted defiantly, remaining as silent as a tomb. Pink Ranger ended up finishing her performance without any victims.

A first in the history of her music.

“He can resist Pink’s singing,” Blue Ranger commented, astonished by the thrall’s mental resistance. “What an iron will.”

“I believe he just removed his sense of hearing,” the Ghoulander noted. “That’s the problem with shapeshifters...”

Buzz Jelly thought about it, then found a solution: one of its least used Perks. “[Eldritch Probe]!”

A rift in space opened, an alien, egg-shaped machine floating through. The creature reminded Buzz Jelly of a squid, with metal tentacles swirling beneath its underside; each of the appendages ending up in blades or sharp claws. A single glass eye blinked at the center of the construct, scanning the group.

You summoned an [**Eldritch Probe**] by sacrificing half your SP. It will obey your orders, but serve as a beacon for the Great Old Ones!

“Entering inferior creature communication mode.” The probe’s voice tweaked into a cheery recording. “*Subtle condescension*: good morning carbon lifeforms! We come in peace!”

“Can you make this doppelganger talk?” Red Ranger asked, surprised by the creature’s strange appearance.

“*Joy*: probe location detection. Inserting probe through opening.” The machine’s egg body opened a metal arm with a sharp, pointy object at the end emerging. It attempted to shove it into the doppelganger’s face, to no

avail. “*Disappointment*: primary opening rejected. *Enthusiasm*: second opening detected, please assume the position.”

“Hey, what are you—” The probe’s tentacles flipped the doppelganger on his chest, his behind exposed.

“*Barely-restrained sadism*: position assumed,” the [Eldritch Probe] buzzed, aligning his strange machinery with the useless, empty space between the doppelganger’s legs. “*Unrestrained sadism*: preparing insertion.”

“Wait, wait, stop!” the doppelganger panicked. “I am a prisoner, I have rights!”

“Commander, did we sign any minion prisoner of war convention?” Red Ranged asked, clearly disturbed by the interrogation process. Clearly, he did not understand that rebels didn’t have rights!

“Yes, but we don’t respect it,” the ghoul replied casually. If anything, he seemed curious about what would happen next.

“*Cruel glee*: starting forceful insertion.”

“No, wait, I’ll tell you!” the doppelganger pleaded before the probe could touch him. “I will tell you everything!”

“Stop!” Buzz Jelly ordered, the machine interrupting its probing process.

“*Frustration*: procedure interrupted?” the probe changed its tune, dangling the sharp object like candy. “*Blatant lies*: it won’t hurt at all.”

“Frank cornered the slime in an old temple!” The doppelganger shouted even harder after this last comment, “Problem is, the slime took a sniper position with a stolen arsenal, and we can’t approach without getting shot; and when we send summons to scout, it makes babies with them! Knowing Frank, he’s probably going to firebomb the place soon!”

“There’s no time to waste then,” Red Ranger said, showing a rough map of the region to the fairy thrall. “Where is that temple?”

As the doppelganger told them everything, the probe hanged back, clearly disappointed. Buzz Jelly decided to cheer it up. “Big battle soon!” the slime said. “Need help!”

“*Hope*: killing inferior lifeforms is my joy in life. *Politically correct apology*: I do not believe carbon-lifeforms are inherently inferior. Some of my best friends are carbon-based.”

“Thank you for your help, Mr. Jelly,” the Ghoulmander thanked the slime as the Rangers continued the interrogation, making the slime swoon with pride. “Tell me, why did you join the V-Army?”

“I patriot!” Buzz Jelly shouted with nationalism. “Empire best!”

“You’re a good slime,” Jules replied. “It is true the V&V Empire is the most progressive country in the world. It made me dare to dream again. After Vainqueur allowed undead labor, I could no longer sit back and watch Gardemagne’s [Paladins] spread their Negative conspiracy, you know.”

“Negative conspiracy?” Buzz Jelly asked. This sounded very serious!

“They try to libel the Undeathstrial Revolution by releasing vast amounts of Negative Energy into the atmosphere,” the Ghoulmander explained. “They say it’s us undead who negatively affect the environment because we threaten their monopoly over life essence.”

“Life essence?”

“[Paladins] can only heal living creatures; instead they harm the undead. Now, when the majority of people and adventurers are *alive*, this makes them invaluable. But what happens when everyone is *undead*? Have you thought of this?”

Buzz Jelly shook its tiny head. This sounded so complicated, and Jelly was a soldier, not a thinker. Maybe it was linked to the ‘elf-capitalo-bourgeois-conspiracy’ the dwarves kept ranting about.

“The [Paladins] did,” the ghoul said. “Lady Camilla saw it too. Do like she did; when a [Paladin] offers you their life essence, deny them. Say no.”

“[Paladin] no.” Buzz Jelly nodded. “Undead yes.”

The Ghoulander patted the slime on the head, like a good soldier.

Hiding behind trees and bushes, the minions observed the enemy camp.

Since the approach required stealth, the imperial soldiers had left the dinozord behind, Ghoulander Jules protecting them with illusion spells. After abandoning the doppelganger, they had stealthily advanced through the forest, reaching the outskirts of an old stone temple built in the middle of a clearing.

Private Molesty had established a barricade in front of the building, made from trees and the corpses of fomor warbeasts. A group of two dozen orcs laid siege to the area, armed to the teeth and carrying the symbols of the worm god Sablar.

“That’s Frank the Anark.” Red Ranger pointed at the orcs’ leader, a tall humanoid in heavy armor. He was big and scary, as all rebel scum were. “We can take him.”

“We have to,” the Ghoulander replied, observing the camp’s soldiers acting up. “They’re clearly going to launch an assault.”

The [Eldritch Probe], which had followed Buzz Jelly, cheered them up. “*Passive aggressiveness*: you are wonderful people, it would be a shame if any of you died tragically.”

Meanwhile, the orcs lost patience, Frank the Anark pushing one of his minions forward. The weaker enemy minion cleared his throat, Private Molesty peeking above the barricade.

“Give up, slime!” the orc minion shouted at the temple. “You’re surrounded!”

“Never surrender!” Molesty leaped over the barricade and fired a bullet at the army, somehow wielding a rifle although it had no hands. The orc minion was forced to take cover. “Draw first blood! Draw first blood!”

The orcs retaliated with arrows, Private Molesty hiding back behind the barricades.

“How do you keep getting delayed by a slime?” Frank the Anark thundered at his subordinate. “We have to board the [Crom Cruach] within six hours, or we’ll all be stranded behind! Do you want to miss the firework from the VIP seats?!”

“I, I don’t know, sir!”

“Well, I won’t!” The leader snarled and vanished inside a large tent. “Screw this, I’m bringing out the tank!”

Buzz Jelly didn’t know what a tank was, but it sounded awesome.

“This is bad,” Ranger Red said, turning to Ghoulander Jules. “What do we do, commander? We won’t make it without casualties.”

“Buzz Jelly, you rescue and evacuate Private Molesty,” the Ghoulander ordered, before turning to the Rangers. “Bring the dinosaur; I will distract them in the meantime. Come what it may.”

“Save Molesty!” Buzz Jelly leaped out of cover. “[SpaceZ]!”

His Perk activating, the slime accelerated, transforming into an unstoppable cannonball. Before the orcs could react to the newcomer, Buzz Jelly flew through them at the speed of a bullet, tearing one humanoid apart into a bloody smear, before going through the barricades. He landed right behind, having made a small hole in the protection.

“Jelly!” Private Molesty rejoiced at the sight of its friend. The [Pink Molester] breathed a strange, fiery stick with its little mouth, keeping a rifle close. “Came!”

“Friend!” the [Cosmonaut] replied happily, glancing at the stick. “What this?”

“Last cigarette,” Molesty replied sadly, releasing smoke from its tiny mouth. “Low HP. Not make it.”

“Family waiting!” Buzz Jelly tried to encourage its fellow slime. “Fight for them! Fight with you!”

“Not your battle!” Molesty protested, ready to make a last stand for his country. “Delay you! Save Jelly!”

“No! You friend!”

A mighty explosion blasted the barricade apart, propelling both slimes backward.

When Buzz Jelly regained consciousness, the defensive barrier had collapsed, the enemy orcs moving out to give way to an enormous machine. It looked like a cube of metal with strange, rounded wheels, and a trunk of steel coming out from above.

An iron elephant!

“Say hello to my little friend!” Frank the Anark’s voice came from within the machine. “[Agility Up], [Accelerated Hasten]!”

The enormous vehicle charged straight at them, moving at an incredible speed for something so big.

“Leave Jelly!” Molesty panicked, unable to leap away. The pink slime had turned all puddly from the shock!

“Bring you home!” Buzz Jelly insisted, forcefully carrying the other slime on its back. “To Dodoland!”

The [Cosmonaut] leaped away, dodging another projectile and escaping from the temple into the clearing. The tank pursued them at high speed,

crushing trees and minions alike in its mad rampage while its metal trunk fired projectiles at the escaping slimes.

As if taking cues from the chaos, the Ghoulander courageously entered the fray, unleashing a necromantic storm in the middle of the enemy encampment. Orcs fell dead, only to rise again as undead, forming a defense around the necromancer, while the [Eldritch Probe] joined the fray.

“Fake affability,” Buzz Jelly’s summoned ally stated, threatening the enemy minions with its tentacles. “I look forward to probing you intimately today.”

The orcish minions immediately encircled them, and the camp erupted into chaos.

Buzz Jelly continued its mad dash forward, as explosions detonated all around the Moon veteran. Trees were blasted apart, the earth below turning into smoking craters as shells fell from the skies. The vehicle ignored the Ghoulander’s distraction, focused entirely on killing the jellies.

But no matter how quickly Buzz leaped, it couldn’t outspeed the tank while carrying another slime. “Not fast enough!” Private Molesty panicked. “Jelly leave!”

“Never!” Buzz replied, switching tactics. it reached a tree still standing, and moved Molesty behind it for cover. “Stay there! Beat it!”

“Suicide!”

“Heroes never die! Dine in Happyland!” Buzz Jelly boasted. The tiny slime closed its eyes, thinking about Excalidad and its gluelike siblings waiting at home, and then leapt into battle.

The jelly faced the metal monster, as it dashed straight forward. “[SpaceZ]!” the slime shouted, transforming into a bullet. The world flashed bright, as the [Cosmonaut] launched itself at full speed against the tank’s thick hide.

What happens when a metal slime bullet hits a machine two hundred times its size?

It bounced back.

Buzz Jelly hit the ground like a bouncing ball, while two tiny openings at the forefront of the tank unleashed streams of fire. The metal slime swelled to protect the tree behind which his fellow slime hid, absorbing the heat.

[**Fire**] damage reduced by [**Blue Ozone**].

The tank blasted the jelly once, then twice, the shells inflicting heavy damage. Yet the slime endured the pain with bravery.

Physical damage halved by [**Starshotted**].

The mission was to save Private Molesty, and Buzz Jelly wouldn't fail! The V&V Army counted on it!

As the tank prepared to blast it once more with its trunk, the cosmonaut finally saw an opportunity. Using [SpaceZ], Buzz Jelly once again launched itself at the bigger machine. This time though, it targeted the cannon, plugging it.

KABOOM!

Massive damage!

The blast propelled Buzz Jelly against a tree's bark, as the tank's projectile exploded in the middle of its cannon. The metal trunk turned into steel scraps, the vehicle reeling from the damage.

Buzz Jelly slithered on the grass, heavily wounded and struggling to move.

"Roll him over!" Frank the Anark ordered from within the machine. "Roll him over and send him to his Japan afterlife!"

Buzz Jelly looked up helplessly, as a seventy ton machine charged straight at it. After so many adventures and so many worlds left unexplored, this

was the end. A family photo of its slime family flashed in his mind, as the [Cosmonaut] prepared to close his eyes and await the fatal crash.

A pink slime leaped in front of Buzz Jelly, struggling against its own wounds, but refusing to cower.

“No!” Buzz Jelly shouted. “Flee!”

“Protect you!” Private Molesty replied, glaring courageously at the tank while shielding his fellow slime. “For Empire!”

Both slimes faced death, a titan of metal preparing to roll them over.

The triumphant shout of a dinosaur’s voice echoed across the forest, like the trumpets of victory.

Smashing trees below its enormous legs, a golden brachiosaurus trampled all trees in its path, ridden by the Kobold Rangers. The beast charged straight at the tank from the side, while Pink Ranger sang the *Hoardnational* to give it strength.

BAM!

The dinosaur hit the tank at full speed and pulverized into scraps! Metal parts and the orc crew flew as their vehicle exploded into nothing.

“What the—”

The dinosaur grabbed Frank the Anark with his mouth midflight before the orc could finish his sentence, gathered momentum with his long neck, and then tossed the [Chronomancer] towards the horizon.

The orc flew towards the heavens like a Sword Rocket, but he wasn’t swordy enough to reach the moon. Instead, he fell down and crashed down farther in Prydain’s forest.

Meanwhile, the Ghoulmander had single-handedly sent the orcs packing with necrotic blasts, raising the dead as undead. The [Eldritch Probe]

pursued the cowardly thralls, pointing its pointy thing at them. “*Objective statement*: you exist to die!”

Feeling the strain of its wounds and the adrenaline leaving its body, Private Molesty collapsed on his back.

“Molesty!” Buzz Jelly rushed to support its fellow slime, preventing the [Pink Molester] from turning into a puddle. “You alright?”

“Alive,” the other slime replied, smiling. “Need cigarette. And hookers.”

In the end, only Ghoulmander Jules seemed unhappy with the result.

“This was a suicide mission,” the Ghoulmander said, crossing his arms in disappointment. “But nobody died!”

Chapter 146: The Darkest Hour

As the missiles exploded in the skies, Victor watched a new sun in the heavens above. A sun of golden light containing a massive explosion, with a dragon at its core.

It flashed bright and then exploded into shards, the echo of the explosion spreading through the atmosphere, all glass for miles exploding at once. The sea itself rippled, and the skies were cleared of all clouds. The heavens turned crimson, as Crom Cruach's weather effect overcame Victor's own.

A smoking shape fell from the heavens, like a fallen angel.

Vainqueur.

For a second, it appeared that the world had briefly stopped. The battlefield turned silent, everyone in awe of the explosion, of Vainqueur's sacrifice, and the dragon's fall.

[Symbol of Hope] turned to despair! -6 to STR, VIT, AGI, CHA, and LCK!

“Go after him!” Victor ordered his horse, hastening his mount, and forgetting *everything else*. The horse switched focus and raced so fast, that Allison barely avoided being thrown off from it. Vainqueur would soon fall down on the beach. “Faster!”

“I’m trying!” his Nightmare complained.

“Don’t try, do!” Victor activated [Rally Minion] to make the horse accelerate, the world becoming a blur. Allison held on against his back, while the distant form of Vainqueur hit the ground.

Meanwhile, Crom Cruach continued its ascension, a colossal rocket aiming for the sun. The shock of Vainqueur's fall dissipated, dragons and mortals alike returning to fighting. Grandrake rallied a flock of ancient, massive wyrms to attack the castle directly, followed by dwarven flying machines and Gardemagne's pegasi corp.

Grandrake and mighty dragons fired at the fortress with their breath weapons, unleashing a devastating torrent of lightning, flames, ice, stones, and all elements known to dragonkind. Most of these beasts rivaled Vainqueur before he accessed the System in power, while Gardemagne's pegasi riders assisted them with spells and buffs.

Their attacks bounced off the barrier shielding the castle, like water crashing against a mountain.

Nobody had the firepower needed to break the shield.

"Your champion has fallen. This is the end."

Odieuse's voice, coming from the castle. Her words, magically empowered, spread across the battlefield; a final speech before Armageddon.

"Within less than two hours, my castle will reach the upper reaches of this world's atmosphere, and obscure the sun above your head. My Arrows of Light will rain upon all of your cities, all across Outremonde. Murmurin, Noblecoeur, Onogoro, Kukulcan... all will be wiped out by searing light. In a blink, they will be gone, leaving nothing but dust. They will never have existed."

Victor ignored her insane rambling, even as many people around him lost hope, kobolds shuddering in dread, Gardemagnian soldiers standing still like statues, slimes gathering together in close groups in fear.

Others like Grandrake and the dragons, proved too stubborn, chasing after the castle and continuing their assault; but the flying fortress continued its ascension, and would soon outpace them.

The Vizier rushed towards the point where Vainqueur had crashed, ignoring everything else.

“The oceans will boil. The earth’s skin will be scorched until its molten blood overflows from all mountains of the world. The lesser races will scream at once, and then all will be silent; radioactive clouds will choke the survivors until the last pitiful life is extinguished. Cradle your loved ones, for you will soon join them in my belly. I shall feast on your souls and break the doors of Valhalla, while my kindred claim this world from your ashes. This will be the end of the lesser races... and a new beginning for the fomors.”

Charisma check successful! [**Terror**] canceled!

“We are the fomors!” Odieuse boasted. *“We are the master race! The supreme masters of the world!”*

Noirceur stopped abruptly, near the edge of a crater in the middle of the sand. Minions had gathered around it, from Charlene to Malfy, but none dared to enter it.

Warning: You are taking [Nuclear—

“[Mass Protection from Nuclear],” Allison cast on the group, Victor leaping off the horse just as the spell took effect. He rushed inside the crater, to his best friend’s side.

The sight horrified Victor.

The [Hoard Armor], as a mighty artifact, had survived the nuclear blast, even if it had heated up enough to turn the sand below into glass. The psi-stones and the crown the Emperor carried had been vaporized, the ring around his finger melted into the armor.

But the dragon beneath the regalia had been cooked alive. His scales had been vaporized, his eyes dried up. Festering flesh was exposed for all to see, alongside dried veins.

By Camilla, Victor could see the *bones*. Vainqueur's bones!

Yet the cadaverous beast still breathed, too stubborn to die.

"He's still alive," Victor said, breathing anxiously, the dryad joining him alongside Malfy, Charlene, and a few other elites shielded from the radiation.

"He's dying." Allison paled, horrified by the dragon's state. "The radiation..."

"Barnabas," Charlene said, protecting herself from the sun with an umbrella. "When he designed the armor, he added hidden lead sheets below the gold, just in case. Maybe they reduced the [Nuclear] damage."

Victor doubted that it had made any difference; Vainqueur was just *so goddamn powerful*, with so much HP and Vitality, that he had managed to hang on from this devastating attack. Just as he had tanked Wotan's full-powered [Ragnarok] once.

But why didn't the dragon regenerate? Victor approached closer, to activate his most helpful perks.

[**Master's Shield**] canceled by [**Necrophobia**] and [**Anti-Heal**].

"Mell Odieuse cursed the missiles," Victor panicked. "My Perks can't heal him!"

"[Cybele's Grace]!" Allison added, unleashing her most potent healing spell, but she, too, couldn't bypass Mell Odieuse's overwhelming power.

"Vainqueur!" Genialissime, Vainqueur's cousin, flew at his family member's side. The flapping of his wings cast sand in all directions, as his fellow wyrm struggled for his life. "Cousin! Minions, help me cast spells on him!"

Everyone capable of casting spells immediately did so, with as much determination as Genialissime himself.

To Victor's despair, nothing worked.

Vainqueur exhaled slower and slower, like a great whale awaiting death on a shore.

Kevin the dark elf teleported in their midst, panicked. "Everyone, we don't have time! You heard Odieuse, we have only a short window to crash that castle, or the world goes down in flames! I will teleport as many flyers as I can close to the shield, and if I get cover fire maybe I can open—"

"I'm not leaving my best friend to die!" Victor snarled back, interrupting him.

"The world—"

"He's my world!"

The outburst caught everyone unaware, making even Kevin shut up.

"Most of it," Victor added. He would still fight to protect his children and loved ones from the incoming apocalypse, but Vainqueur... "I'm not leaving him. Help or go."

The dark elf glared back but said nothing. He understood that with Kia out of commission for a while, he couldn't afford to go to the battlefield without all [Epic] level warriors available.

"[Disjunction]!" Victor cast the mightiest spell he had that could lift the curses.

Intelligence check failed. You could not overcome [**Mell Odieuse**]'s spellcaster power.

"[Magic-Eater]!" Kevin assisted him reluctantly, although careful to reduce his range to Vainqueur and not debuff everyone else. But even the anti-magic spell that brought Akhenapep to his knees couldn't prevail over Mell Odieuse's curse. "I'm sorry. She's too powerful, even for me."

"There has to be a way!" Victor panicked. "A spell, an artifact, a—"

“Victor.”

Camilla’s voice interrupted the Vizier.

The goddess appeared before him, as did Mithras, Leone, Deathjester, Shesha, the Moon Man... titans overshadowing even dragons with their presence; Allison and Rolo bowed to Cybele and the whole Gardemagnian army to Mithras and Leone.

In fact, almost the entire pantheon had appeared, Victor recognizing the one deity he hadn’t met yet, the white deer Isengrim. *Seng* was present, and *sober*, with Sablar alone missing from this gathering.

Nothing like the end of the world for a miracle.

“Can you stop this?” Victor pleaded, but his hopes were immediately dashed.

“If we do or act directly, such as healing Vainqueur, Sablar will devastate Outremonde himself with quakes and radiations,” Cybele replied grimly. “He will cause as much damage as Odieuse, if not more.”

“This is in mortals’ hands,” Camilla replied, clearly distressed; even her prized undead would not survive the following nuclear annihilation. “We can’t do much but provide encouragement.”

“Speak for yourself,” Mithras said, glancing down at Victor. “Have you leveled up yet?”

“No, but—”

Mithras didn’t let the Vizier finish, raising his hand. Instantly, a mark appeared on his and Allison’s neck.

Scratch that, it appeared on *everyone*’s neck. Every single soldier, every monster, every creature short of a dragon. Even Charlene, a vampire which Mithras *loathed*, received the Claimed mark.

“Damn it, Sablar, you made me agree with Mithras!” Deathjester said, reluctantly applying his mark to a few people himself, including Charlene. The other gods, after seeing the two nemeses agree on something, followed their lead.

“Roll me for my chosen!” Dice asked the Moon Man. “Pray for twenty!”

“The new one awaits,” the Moon Man replied cryptically.

“Sales for everyone,” Shesha said, clearly unhappy with this turn of events, but agreeing to participate.

“I should have done this long ago!” the white deer said, applying his own mark to Victor’s shoulder, as he did to Allison’s. “Protect my priestess and make her happy!”

Even Leone joined the group effort and granted her mark to Victor, although she clearly *hated* it.

They were *that* boned.

Congratulations! You earned the [**Claimed by Mithras**], [**Claimed by Isengrim**], and [**Claimed by Leone**] personal Perks!

[**Claimed by Mithras**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Charisma or Strength point. You are also immune to all [Fire] and [Holy] effects, except those caused by Mithras or his servants.

[**Claimed by Isengrim**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain an HP or Agility point. You can speak to and understand [Beast] types, and they are always well-favored towards you.

[**Claimed by Leone**]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Vitality or Skill point. You gain a 30 percent experience bonus whenever you finish a quest or slay a monster.

Congratulations! For proving yourself to be the Outremondian pantheon’s collective whore and defeating Akhenapep on horseback, you earned three

levels in [**Chaos Rider**] and two levels in [**Fiendish Rake**]! You earned the [**Pale Rider**], [**Hades Rider**], and [**Witch Mark**] class perks!

+150 HP, +10 SP, +4 STR, +5 VIT, +4 SKI, +5 AGI, +3 INT, +5 CHA, +3 LCK.

[**Pale Rider**]: You and your mount become immune to [**Insta-death**]; while you are mounted, every hostile creature looking at you must succeed a Charisma check or suffer from [**Necrophobia**]. You can increase your stable of monsters by two.

[**Hades Rider**]: While you fight mounted, your mount does not die if brought to 0 HP; instead, they remain fueled by your life force, with any additional damage they take being transferred to you. If you dismount while the mount's HP remains at 0 or if you perish yourself, they die instantly. You can mark an unlimited amount of monsters as your mounts.

[**Witch Mark**]: while in an act of passion with a willing creature, you can mark them with a demonic crimson mark. So long as they wear the mark, the target gains a Charisma bonus equal to your [**Fiendish Rake**] level and access to the [**Diabolism**] spell school. A single creature can only have one [**Witch Mark**] active at once. As long as the effect persists, you can communicate telepathically with the target across any distance, and use [**Dream**] and [**Emotion**] spells on them with no check allowed. The mark can only be removed by powerful [**Prayer**] spell or your own will.

Not enough. Not enough!

“What about dragons?” Victor asked, noticing none of the wyrms had been granted the mark. “Claim them!”

“We... can't,” Mithras admitted.

“It's forbidden,” Camilla added.

“By whom?” Victor asked, the gods remaining mute. He turned to Shesha. “You can heal Vainqueur and stay within your silly divine pact's boundaries!”

“Victor, the cost—”

“Everything I have!” Victor declared. “My life! I will sell my soul!”

Shesha shook her head with grim resignation.

As much as it terrified Victor, the gods had done everything they could.

“Everyone,” Kevin cleared his throat, while Genialissime prepared to reluctantly take flight. “Time is running out.”

“I... everyone, prepare for emergency teleportation,” Victor told his elites. “I’ll... I’ll stay with him.”

“Victor...” Allison trailed.

“I’ll join you,” the Vizier said, his eyes set on Vainqueur. “Go!”

Charisma check successful!

Everyone exchanged glances, before dispersing; either to take flight after the Crom Cruach or to prepare for teleportation. Even Genialissime left, although he sent one last glance at his cousin, leaving the Vizier alone with the dying Vainqueur. The gods vanished into thin air, perhaps to check on Sablar, although Camilla briefly put a hand on Victor’s shoulder to comfort him before returning to the heavens.

Victor collapsed on his knees, remaining at his dying friend’s side.

Vainqueur was dreaming.

It was a dream of pitch black darkness, like a night without stars. It was freezing, a cold more chilling than the meanest of the Winter Kingdoms. It was a dream without sound, without pictures, without warmth.

A dream of lead.

The darkness called him. A cold emptiness awaited the dragon at the end, the promise of annihilation.

Was this... *death*?

That was how death felt like? Awful? Lonely? Empty?

To think his minion had gone through this more than once... yet, as his mind faded into nothingness, the dragon felt strangely at peace.

Two years ago, the old Vainqueur would have snarled and roared in anger; not that he would have risked his life to save his servants, nor would he have cared about Odieuse's cruelty. He would have slumbered, gathered gold, and watched the world burn while only missing the cattle.

Some part of him thought his minions had made him *soft*.

The rest thought it had made him *better*.

For instead of feeling fury at this turn of events, Vainqueur felt... nothing? Like that brief moment before he entered hibernation; a brief moment before his consciousness switched off.

Except there would be no awakening afterward. The dragon knew it, deep within himself. And he was alright with that.

Vainqueur had gathered the greatest, most beautiful hoard in the world, and died to protect it. Like a true dragon should. He had saved his kindred and servants from death and given them a chance to carry on the fight.

Vainqueur had long accepted the possibility that he could die. He no longer feared death, so long as it mattered.

He hoped his niece, cousin, and chief of staff were alright. He hoped all his minions could make it. They were strong; they were *his*.

"Please, Vainqueur..."

His minion's voice.

It was but a distant echo, faint, yet clear.

“You’re supposed to be invincible!”

He was! Vainqueur ate thousands, and in the end, none truly bested him in battle. Even Wotan Dragonbane couldn't finish the job.

“Please don’t go...”

If Vainqueur were to vanish now, sinking into the dark, it would be without regret. The pull felt stronger with each passing second, his life slipping away. Death was awful but strangely peaceful.

“You made me something,” his minion pleaded. “I was a loser before I stumbled on your cave, and if you hadn’t been there... I would have stayed the same. You saved me so often... you saved so many people, so many times...”

Vainqueur’s body long felt numb, but he briefly sensed a warm liquid pouring down his nose. It smelled salty.

Tears.

His chief of staff was crying for him.

“Please...” Manling Victor pleaded. “I don’t think I can make it farther without you... I’m... I’m just the sidekick. No matter how many people think otherwise... you’re the one always driving everything forward.”

Well, yes. That was a dragon’s job.

“I should have died instead...”

Minion, you died too many times already.

It had cost Vainqueur a fortune each time!

“We made a promise to reach Valhalla together... please...”

Valhalla?

The absolute apex of the world. The highest honor the dragon-made System could grant.

He *had* promised his minion that they would become gods together true... and Vainqueur was no liar.

As his friend's pitiful words echoed in the void, Vainqueur's memories flared up. They brought him back to his first personal encounter with death, back in Nagastan. When he had faced the vile Odieuse in battle.

A true dragon didn't cower in the face of death.

A true dragon looked at it in the eyes, and then breathed at her sorry face!

No, no, he couldn't allow himself to fall into this dark abyss! He was Vainqueur Knightsbane, First of His Name, Great Calamity of the Age, Defender of the Hoard! Emperor of Murmurin, Ishfania, and the Albain Mountains! Conqueror of Port Vainqueur, El Goldorado, and the Teikoku!

Vainqueur's memories flared up, from the moment when Manling Victor had woken him up. He remembered the destruction of the Scorchers, and the War of the Hoard; both of his duels with Brandon Maure, and the conquest of Ishfania; his battle with a golem in the Winter Kingdoms, to the destruction of Batling Lavere; he had overcome Wotan Dragonbane, tamed a Tarasque, and sent Mell Odieuse packing!

The very land bowed to his will!

Even if he could die... he refused to!

He had made a promise, and so many people counted on him!

[Dragon Honor] activated. **[Necrophobia]** and **[Anti-Heal]** canceled.

The darkness slowly receded, replaced by a strange white expanse as Vainqueur willed himself to life.

[Master's Shield] activated! You gained the **[Regen]** positive status!

Sensations filled his body again. First of all, a sharp, indescribable pain; an itching far, far worse than anything he had ever experienced, everywhere! Even his eyes felt terrible!

Speaking of his eyes... the whiteness slowly gave way to dark grey shapes. The sun, the shadow of a castle; an armored face.

“You’re blocking the sun,” Vainqueur told his minion, as his eye regenerated enough to see colors.

“Fuck!” His minion held his neck, tears pouring down through his helmet. “Fuck! I thought you were done for!”

“Friend Victor, this world’s history is *my* story,” Vainqueur boasted with great pride. “Of course it cannot end this way!”

“Don’t joke about it!” His minion held against his scythe, wiping away the tears.

For tanking three nukes to save your subjects and willing yourself back to life, you earned three levels in [**Fisher King**]! You earned the [**Avalon**] Class Perk.

+90 HP, +60 SP, +2 STR, +6 VIT, +3 SKI, +3 AGI, +2 INT, +3 CHA, +1 LCK.

[**Avalon**]: Technique, 100 SP, ten minutes duration. You emit a one-hundred feet wide veil shielding you and your ally from all negative ailments.

“I am not joking, Victor,” the dragon replied, flesh reforming over his bones. He started forcing himself back on his feet, his claws stomping the ground.

His manling marked a short pause as he stood back, confused. “You forgot the manling, or minion, Your Majesty.”

“I did not forget,” Vainqueur replied. “Victor, you have been more than a minion, or even a chief of staff. You have been my truest friend. One half of

V&V. The two of us are but halves of a greater whole; formidable on our own, invincible together. No one made me prouder than you.”

“Your Majesty...”

“Vainqueur,” the dragon replied. “With a V. I can tell the difference.”

His friend looked up, floored by the honor, then nodded. “Vainqueur, are we flying towards the castle?”

“Yes and no.” Vainqueur shook his head, when at long last his scales had regrown, bringing him back to full health. “Today will be our last battle, one way or the other... so let us fight as one, as we were meant to be.”

Vainqueur extended his wings, as soon as they had regenerated enough to carry him.

“Climb.”

In her throne room at the heart of Crom Cruach, the fairy Mell Odieuse rested on her throne in human form, chaffing from the disappointment. Screens above her head showed each city of the world, each target for her final rampage. Soon, she would watch the end of all life on Outremonde but the fomors personally; just as she had watched Knightsbane’s suicidal fall with delight.

This should be a moment of delight and triumph. Thousands had fallen, their souls fueling her spiritual core. Every life taken had filled her with renewed joy, and she shuddered at what she would feel when her arrows wiped the lesser races from the face of her world.

It would be a perfect moment of pure bliss. A milestone on her path to personal happiness.

Nothing else gave her pleasure. She felt no love for anyone, not even her fellow fomors; the fairy queen was proud of being a member of the master race, but her kindred were tools, to be sacrificed and discarded should they

prove wanting. She needed no friends, nor thralls, nor gold nor luxury. She enjoyed no other activity, treating them as chores.

The murder of the apes, the elves, and all these meowing children would satisfy her, but only for a time. Odieuse would never stop shedding blood; never wanted to stop. She would carve a path of murder across the very stars until nothing remained. Only when all had become pitch black and no one remained to satisfy her, would she stop.

Mell Odieuse suffered from a void in her heart, that only death could fill.

Then why did she feel robbed of her triumph?

Each bomb sent the souls directly to her. The dragonbinding bottles had been harvested of their content, allowing the Fomor Queen to swallow the souls of countless wyrms and thralls. All this power should have catapulted her straight to Valhalla already, allowing her to pursue greater happiness as the thirteenth goddess of Outremonde.

Even the System agreed with her, as she consulted her stat screen.

By feeding on the souls of dragons and harvesting their magic, you have reached level 99. You can now access [**Valhalla**] and attempt [**Apotheosis**].

“Open the path,” Mell Odieuse rasped for the tenth time.

Access to [**Valhalla**] denied.

The same message, over and over again. “Why?” the fomor asked angrily. “What will it take? Why am I denied the eternal happiness that is rightfully mine?”

YOU ARE UNWORTHY.

Unworthy? Her, the ultimate being who transcended fomors and dragons alike?

Who decided this? The force making gods out of apes and worms?

She had been ready to settle on devastating Outremonde before pursuing happiness on Earth, but the System's response infuriated her on a primal level. Mell Odieuse was born a creature above all others and had killed countless on her way to the apex of the world. Certainly, she had bypassed the usual channels by harvesting souls, but this only proved her cunning and strength.

None would deny her happiness.

The would-be goddess turned to a pile of [Black Crests], manufactured to empower thralls. She had stockpiled them instead, believing they could have helped her cheat to level 99 had her other plans failed. Perhaps now was the time.

"Enemy incoming, Your Majesty," the voice of one of her commanders echoed through loudspeakers.

The lesser races mounted a pitiful final resistance. How droll, but she would delight at watching the light of hope leave their eyes, before ripping them out. "How many?"

"Th..." the voice marked a short pause, as if new information entered the picture, "Thousands, but... one dragon is leading the charge so fast, it will collide with us long before the rest."

Already, Odieuse knew *whom*, even before she ordered one of the screens to show her. All of them showed a massive shape chasing after the Crom Cruach, piercing through the clouds at a speed even the fomor had to admit was impressive.

A crimson dragon wearing armor of gold.

Knightsbane. Alive.

And as always, he carried Victor Dalton with him; but not in his hand, as he usually did.

Instead, the dragon carried his human slave on his back.

They alone, through spells and agility, managed to catch up to the Crom Cruach while everyone else lagged behind. They were the tip of an arrow, to make a crack in the shield while dragons and fools followed.

Always them. Always these two, every step of her way. Always preventing her from succeeding. Always getting in the way of her happiness, turning it to bitterness and emptiness.

Mell Odieuse would never feel whole with these two around.

The [Dracolich]'s mind cleared up, as the path to Valhalla became clear.

“Send our remaining troops after them,” Odieuse ordered, as she prepared her transformation into a mighty [Dracolich] and her consumption of the [Black Crests]. She would force her way into Valhalla, whether the System liked it or not. “Initiate the countdown for the missiles’ launch.”

“How many troops do we send, Your Majesty?”

“All of them.”

Chapter 147: Endgame

Vainqueur had always disdained wyrms letting their minions riding them as cattletarian, unworthy of calling themselves true dragons.

But as he carried Victor through the skies, their army unable to keep up with his sheer speed, Vainqueur realized he had been mistaken. His loyal friend didn't feel like a false master on his back, but as an extension of the dragon emperor himself.

Now having fully recovered from his previous wounds, Vainqueur had used his ring to [Hasten] himself and aimed for the sun, the shadow of Crom Cruach rising towards the heavens. The fortress was quick, but the dragon was faster, quickly closing the gap.

"Here they come," Victor said, readying his scythe.

Tiny holes opened in the magical shield protecting the castle, like a cheese. An army of flying mice flew through, eager to die at Vainqueur's hands.

Some were golems, but the bulk of the army were fomors. Having hidden behind all their minions until they had exhausted them all, the fairy lords finally deigned to show up. They were a chaotic menagerie of horrors and nightmares; ghostly riders carried by skeletal, fiery horses; wicked, child-eating hags; tiger-headed Rakshasa ancestors; giants and twisted fairies, screaming for blood, their body heavy with ill-gotten magic.

The Wild Hunt.

Hundreds, thousands of fomors were arrayed against V&V, diving down on them like a swarm of doves trying to overwhelm a hawk. Each was a match for a single adult wyrm, and a bane to minions everywhere.

Vainqueur only had one word to qualify the opposition.

“Mediocre!” The dragon shouted as his war cry. “Minion, support me while I carve a path paved with fairy blood!”

His minion immediately started to spellcast. “[Pact with the Archfiends]!”

As Victor transformed into a demon, his [Chaos Rider] class extended the transformation to Vainqueur himself. His [Hoard Armor] stretched to accommodate the transformation, as his size doubled, his scales turned to molten lava, and the tip of his tail grew a smaller dragon head.

Your minion rider’s buffs will extend to you!

You have been imbued with demonic strength. Your type has temporarily changed to [**Dragon/Demon**], and your [**Fire**] attacks will inflict additional [**Unholy**] damage!

“[Fire Crown],” Vainqueur activated, his body burning with hellfire.

“[Hail-bringer: Fire Hail]!” Manling Victor shouted as he changed the weather, overwhelming even the castle’s special effect. Fiery clouds formed all around the duo, raining flames and molten projectiles.

To outsiders, Vainqueur must have appeared in all his burning majesty, a meteor blazing through a firestorm. And like a meteor, the dragon didn’t stop, even as the screaming warriors of the wild hunt came within reach of his claws. A star didn’t deviate from its course.

Instead, Vainqueur smashed through his foes.

The vanguard of the Wild Hunt folded like paper, or water crashing against a mountain. Their golems exploded into scraps as Vainqueur hit them, their swords breaking upon his [Hoard Armor]. His mere contact burnt the flesh of a mighty dullahan, the headless rider and his soldiers falling to their death into the firestorm following V&V.

They didn’t even slow him down.

Obedying his partner's command, Friend Victor cast buffing spells on himself, his class spreading the effects to Vainqueur.

[**Fire**] damage increased by fifty percent! [**Physical**] attacks will ignore Resistance! You gained immunity to [**Frost**], [**Fairy**], [**Nuclear**]—

This. This was what V&V's respective class builds had led them to. Two invincible forces becoming one.

Vainqueur quickly lost count of all the improvements, for he required no higher thoughts. He trusted his dragon instincts, empowered by the System meant to serve him.

After demolishing the vanguard, Vainqueur continued his relentless ascension, the fomors retaliating by tapping into their own classes. “[Fire Immunity]!” hags cast upon their allies, while close-combat fighters braved the firestorm to engage Vainqueur in melee. A giant Rakhasa flew straight at him, the tigerlike humanoid raising a runic blade to pierce the dragon's hide.

Vainqueur responded by opening his mouth and unleashing a torrent of hellfire. The fomor lost his focus, unable to see through the flames, and couldn't dodge the fist aiming for his face. The dragon's punch tore the Rakshasa in half in a single strike, both halves falling to the ocean beneath them. Beyond the sea, he could hear the sound of approaching thunder...

As more creatures kept trying to slow down V&V's ascent, Vainqueur pulverized them all, through claws and fangs; thanks to [Master's Shield] and his enhancements, the wyrm healed faster than they could hurt him. They might have been a threat before he gained levels, but right now, they proved no more troublesome than powerful manling knights.

Soon, the dried blood of a dozen fomors splattered his golden armor, both Vainqueur and Victor were drenched in the warm fluid.

“I AM THE LEAD THAT HAUNTS YOUR NIGHTMARES!” Vainqueur boasted.

Terrified by this primal vision of horror, a wiser group of fairies retreated and started casting offensive spells. In answer to his own fire, they rained down stones the size of castles, sharp fairy winds, rays of golden light, and raw elemental forces.

Although most attacks bounced off the duo, some did scratch them. This time, the fomors forced Vainqueur to deviate from his course, the dragon retaliating with fireballs as he tried to find a way through the opposition.

“[Za Warudo]!”

As time briefly froze, Vainqueur thought it had been Victor’s work.

But then, he saw two of the fomors turned into lead statues, creating a hole in the enemy’s defense. An explosion detonated behind the enemy lines, meteors raining from nowhere and hitting fomors in the face, as a ghostly shape teleported multiple times in short succession among their ranks.

Vainqueur realized *who* had come to assist, teleporting halfway across the world to ambush the fomors from behind; as he had sadistically murdered a dragon’s hoard once.

A flying lich, transformed into a ghostly shadow by a spell, had opened a second front behind the fairies.

Exploiting the situation, Vainqueur forced the fairies to disperse with his breath, returning to his ascension. This time, the castle, and its crimson shield would soon be within reach.

“Furi!” Victor shouted while the lich flew at their side; and for once, Vainqueur was happy to see his skeletal nemesis. “You came!”

“Because you wouldn’t shut up telepathically!” the Forgotten One replied crankily, lazily counterspelling some hag’s attack.

“Of course he came, but not out of goodwill,” Vainqueur warned Friend Victor. “He cannot transform the world to lead if it is destroyed!”

“You... you wyrms seriously...” Furibon screamed in anger at his vile intent being unmasked. Yet he insisted on lying again. “After all the work you made me do to shield your cities, no way am I letting you screw this up!”

“You came because you care,” Victor said, taken over by the lich’s false charm. “We love you as you are, Furi.”

“Shut up, Dalton, I hate you both.” The Forgotten One wisely focused back on the battle. “Can you break the castle’s shield, or must I do everything?”

“Fly back and watch!” Vainqueur replied, preparing a [Charged Attack]. “First the shield, then the fortress!”

“Thing is, if we destroy it, we risk setting off the nukes aboard,” Friend Victor replied. “Not only will we die, but the fallout will devastate the world.”

“And how would that be terrible?” Vainqueur glared at Furibon’s callousness, who shrugged. “Perhaps push it outside the atmosphere and into the void of space?”

The dragon half-considered throwing the castle at the cursed planet Moon, but some of his minions lived there.

“I can create pocket dimensions,” Victor replied. “Fold space itself. If I am allowed to focus, I could seal Crom Cruach inside one; it would contain the nuclear detonation.”

“Think quickly, then,” the lich replied, as the fomors reorganized. The fairies chased back after the group, trapping the trio between the castle and their forces.

At this point, the sound of distant thunderbolts grew so powerful that Vainqueur could hear clouds gather below him, pushing away his friend’s fiery hail. The fomors briefly halted their assault, as an overwhelming pressure filled the air.

A familiar message appeared before Vainqueur’s eyes.

King Wotan's [**Storm Caller**] passive Perk changed the weather to [**Heavy Thunderstorm**]!

A mighty thunderbolt fell among the fomors, striking one of them dead.

A second army of fairies came from the east, smaller than the first, but deadlier. At the forefront rode King Wotan on his flying horse, followed by his Valkyries; behind him, Jack O'Lantern carried fiery pumpkins, carried alongside Cait Sith through the skies by a giant bat. The other fomors Vainqueur didn't recognize, from thunderbirds, to mothmen and nightmarish titans made of crackling lightning. The storm followed them, rain and thunder and downpour.

They hadn't come to help their kindred. Instead, they immediately engaged the Wild Hunt in battle with merciless ferocity, sowing chaos among their ranks.

"It worked," Victor whispered, as Wotan's force assaulted their pursuers much to everyone's total confusion. "They listened!"

"Traitors!" a hag fomor follower of Odieuse shouted at the newcomers, only for one of Jack's pumpkin bombs to explode in her face.

The situation only worsened for Odieuse's defenders, as the flight of dragons and minion armies following Vainqueur finally caught up to the battle. A manling army followed from the west, led by a dark elf and the wyvern-riding, manling King Roland. "For Gardemagne!" he shouted, raising an axe as his minions' war cry became deafening.

"Uncle!" Vainqueur's beautiful niece, Jolie, was the first of the dragon flight to reach the Wild Hunt, wearing shining silver armor. Much like her uncle, she carried a group of minions on her back; the Kobold Rangers, Corpseling Jules, and Buzz Jelly in this case. "Paladin time!"

"For Empire!" The tiny Buzz Jelly was the first to enter the fray, leaping off his master's back to land on a fomor's face, hopping from one fairy to the other. The Kobold Rangers and Corpseling Jules remained on Jolie's back, supplementing her breath with spells, songs, and bullets.

Grandrake roared, leading the dragons as they bombarded the Wild Hunt, the skies exploding into an orgy of devastation. Vainqueur's flying minions and Gardemagne's Pegasi riders cast spells, opening gates through space itself. Hundreds of fiends and pigeon-like angels poured through them, swarming the fomors.

Odieuse's servants were mighty, but the dragons could match them, and the minions overwhelmed them through sheer numbers. After ordering his Valkyries to set up a defensive perimeter at his back, King Wotan left his horde to join Vainqueur's own team.

"Knightsbane, Dalton," Wotan greeted both members of V&V politely, frowning upon seeing the lich, who he didn't recognize. Thanks to Vainqueur's size enhancements, the mighty titan looked like a child next to the dragon.

"I thought you wanted to see this one out, and not take arms against your kin?" Friend Victor asked the fomor lord, shocked to see him there.

"I did, but Cait Sith informed me Mell Odieuse had marked my realm for destruction. There are battles a warrior *must* fight, not for himself, but for others." The thunder lord readied his spear. "Tell me, where do fomors go when they die?"

"I do not know," Vainqueur replied, having finished building up his breath.

"Let us find out together then."

Vainqueur couldn't have agreed more. "[Charged Attack]!"

Opening his mouth, the dragon unleashed the most potent beam he ever produced; first, it took the shape of a stream of hellfire, before growing into a solar flare that would shame the sun itself. His blast expanded in wideness until it could have swallowed a mountain whole in its shininess; the sheer recoil forced Victor to hold onto his partner's neck, to avoid being propelled backward.

The mighty hellfire ray crashed against the Crom Cruach's crimson field, the defense holding for a while; fomor magic against dragon magic. Yet, like fairies folded before the true rulers of the world, the barrier bent.

Within seconds, the beam pierced through the shield, shattering one of the castle's towers and melting its steel fortifications. As Vainqueur finished and caught his breath, a large opening had opened in the defensive shield. Large enough to let him through.

"Now!" Victor shouted as the shield began closing back on itself, Vainqueur immediately slipping through the crack. Wotan and Furibon followed, the barrier closing behind them before anyone else could follow. "Your Majesty, you know we could have slipped through with my [Skeleton Key]?"

"A true dragon doesn't enter by the backdoor!" the emperor replied, the castle's artillery defenses arrayed against him. "He makes his presence known to all!"

"[Souldrinker Breath]!"

A blast of ghostly energies exploded the walls of a nearby tower to Vainqueur's left, aiming for the dragon. [Hastened], the dragon and his rider dodged the attack. The sneak attack blast instantly vaporized the slower Furibon, or so it appeared to Vainqueur; the lich's soul didn't fly away into his destroyer's belly, as Icefang's did. He must have teleported away at the last second. Meanwhile, Wotan forced his horse back and settled atop a metal tower, his Gungnir raised.

The final enemy emerged from the hole, smaller than Vainqueur, but far more twisted. A skeletal insult to dragonkind fueled by hate and envy, she flew over her castle's towers, overseeing Vainqueur and Wotan from above. Much like her enemy, she wore her hoard in battle, having covered her chest with a makeshift armor of black crests tied together. The screams of captive souls echoed from within her core.

"Odieuse," King Wotan said, with no respect whatsoever.

“I shall deal with you in time, race traitor.” Mell Odieuse’s eyes blazed with ruthless cruelty, before setting her full attention on where it belonged. “You have gotten farther than you should have, Knightsbane. Far, *far* farther, but it ends here. Time to die.”

And then without wasting any more words, the [Dracolich] opened her skeletal maw, light shining at the end of her throat. Vainqueur roared like a dragon, flames flickering in his mouth.

Their breaths collided in a catastrophic storm of energy, and the skies burnt bright.

Chapter 148: Drifting Lights

Fighting on a true dragon's back was a dream come true for Victor.

Fighting a [Dracolich] was a nightmare.

Vainqueur had already informed the Vizier of Mell Odieuse's true form, but to see that horror in the flesh was something else entirely. The fomor had transformed into a half-rotten skeletal dragon the size of Vainqueur, her bones animated by unholy energies. The [Black Crests] covering her core only enhanced her menacing aura, a ghastly armor to match Vainqueur's golden regalia.

Even with Furibon and King Wotan at their back, Victor felt as outmatched against this monster as he did against Akhenapep in El Dorado. The very air choked with the monster's oppressive aura, her pull calling his very soul to its final demise.

You have entered [**Dracolich**] Mell Odieuse's [**Voracious Siphon**]! Your connection to your [**Black Grail**] has been severed! If you die within its area of effect, your soul will be devoured! [**Terrifying Aura**] negated.

Warning: Ten minutes before the missiles launch! If you fail to defeat Mell Odieuse within that timespan, Outremonde will be **annihilated**!

If the *System itself* gave them a warning directly, then the situation couldn't possibly get worse!

Wotan and his horse stood atop one of Crom Cruach's numerous towers, while Vainqueur, Victor, and Furibon flew amidst the giant castle's steel structures; Mell Odieuse had positioned herself above them all, at the frontier where the shield separated the castle from the outside world. The

battle raged beyond these confines, the V&V army dueling Odieuse's last followers.

“Cover me!” Victor shouted, raising his scythe to spellcast. One could shape their own pocket dimension with tier VIII, but at tier X, the Vizier could create a semi-functional, mini-plane of existence, with its own rules; a plane large enough to swallow a castle as big as Crom Cruach. “I’ll need time to cast my pocket dimension spell and contain the explosion!”

“How long?” Furibon asked as he teleported next to the V&V duo, starting to buff himself while King Wotan immediately rode after the Dracolich on horseback, racing through an air zone as large as Murmurin. For the first time since Victor met him, the lich sounded truly afraid, his bones bristlier than normal.

The full spell took hours to complete, but Victor wouldn't need to finish it entirely. He simply had to do the first part, folding space around the castle into its own smaller dimension. It would contain the nuclear blast, as Vainqueur’s [Glitzy Theater] shielded his army from the missiles.

However, the fortress and the area kept within the barrier were as large as a city; casting that entire place into another dimension would be a tremendous test of spellcasting prowess.

“Hold her off as long as you can,” Victor said, unable to come up with a decisive answer, “and make sure she does not interrupt me!”

“Five minutes,” Furibon replied. “She severed my link to my [Phylactery], and it puts a drain on my magic.”

“Five minutes?” Vainqueur asked, following it up with a boast as he took flight amidst Crom Cruach’s towers. “That’s four too many to bring this vile fairy down!”

That was the spirit.

Victor began to cast his spell, focused his full attention on channeling magic through his scythe, while the others moved to battle.

By now, Wotan had closed the gap with Mell Odieuse, who looked down on the treacherous fomor like minion shit. Thunder echoed in the background, and as the dracolich's eyes lit up with magic, burning circuits appeared everywhere on Crom Cruach's surface.

[Technomancer] Mell Odieuse assumed direct control over **[Crom Cruach]**!

A ballista bolt of Starmetal flew straight at Wotan's horse, piercing the mount's heart at supersonic speed. The attack slew the beast in one shot, causing it to fall alongside its surprised rider on the castle's ground.

Like clockwork, Crom Cruach's towers shifted, the fortress' layout rearranging itself. Holes in the walls opened to reveal artillery cannons, Starmetal-pointed ballistae, and archaic laser beams. All arrayed against Vainqueur and his allies.

"Hang on, Friend Victor!" Vainqueur barely had the time to shout a warning before diving down to dodge an artillery barrage; Victor's supernatural **[Chaos Rider]** Perks allowed him to remain bound to his partner, even as the wyrm looped around towers, but it didn't make it comfortable in the slightest.

Vainqueur managed to dodge the attack but was forced to move closer to Crom Cruach's ground to avoid the artillery, like a fighter jet skillfully dodging anti-air defense. This left Mell Odieuse in control of the skies, a hawk watching doves struggling below her.

The Vizier lost sight of Wotan, the fomor forced to run on foot to avoid both a rain of bullets and Crom Cruach's walls closed down on him. Furibon, meanwhile, remained close to the wyrm and focused on shielding Victor; he often summoned his **[Anti-Vainqueur Barrier]** to block blasts which the dragon wasn't fast enough to avoid.

Instead of going on the offensive herself, Mell Odieuse remained sky high above the group and buffed herself up. "[Overheal]!" the dracolich shouted, her core shining beneath her armor of Black Crests. "[Soul Consumption]!"

[**Fairy Queen**] Mell Odieuse will temporarily be able to heal over her max HP without ill effects! Every soul consumed will grant her 999 HP!

“[Permascan]!” Furibon quickly cast on Mell Odieuse, her stats revealed for all to see.

Mell Odieuse the Overlord

Type: Soulcrested Dragonblooded Fomor (Fairy/Dragon; also count as Undead whenever beneficial).

Level: 99 (Dracolich 10/Prismatic One 10/Tyrant 10/Deathlord 30/Technomancer 30/Fairy Queen 9)

HP: 7665/6666

Weak to Starmetal and Cold Iron.

“Level 99?” Victor shouted, his concentration faltering at the terrible sight.

“I am on the verge of godhood, and your death shall be my apotheosis,” Mell Odieuse proudly declared, before summoning tiny flying black prisms. “[Prismatic Shards].”

“Cheating!” Vainqueur snarled, melting a Starmetal ballista with a fireball. “I call cheating! No way you earned more levels than me in a shorter time!”

Mell Odieuse responded by sending her shards after the dragon, the prisms unleashing fiery beams of light in his direction. Unable to use [Spell Purge] without disrupting Victor’s own spellcasting, Vainqueur used the environment to his advantage, moving behind one of Crom Cruach’s walls to take cover. However, his respite was brief, for more weapons kept firing at V&V, forcing the wyrm to remain constantly on the move.

What followed was a game of constant movement, as Vainqueur and Furibon moved among Crom Cruach’s towers and labyrinth-like fortifications. Always avoiding artillery fire by the skin of their teeth, but never finding the opening to move in the skies above the castle and threaten Odieuse directly.

As his team protected him, Victor began the Tier X spell [Private World], spending the SP needed and starting the ritual. He began to expand his magic to claim the area around Crom Cruach, in preparation for folding it into a separate plane. Casting the spell *at all* would be extremely difficult, but doing it while in the middle of a battle was an heroic feat.

Intelligence check successful!

But even as a laser hit Vainqueur in the leg, Victor continued to focus. Camilla hadn't trained a quitter.

Why couldn't [Claimed by Mithras] protect against [Light] though? He was the sun god, damn it!

Above, Mell Odieuse's HP bar had grown tenfold.

[56616/6666]

And it kept climbing.

Vainqueur snarled in pain, as a bolt of Starmetal pierced his [Hoard Armor] from the left side, destroying a scale and piercing his flesh.

Supereffective damage! You have lost a fourth of your HP!

The dragon removed the bolt with his hand, his flesh regenerating thanks to his rider's [Master's Shield], but the castle's defenses didn't give him any respite.

Everywhere, automated machines and minions kept hounding them! Even as he circled Crom Cruach's fortifications and rained fire on its artillery, the prismatic shards pursued and bombarded Vainqueur with rays of light!

The streets and walls of the castle moved on their own; steel barriers rose up whenever he discovered an escape route, fortifications closed when he found a line of fire to shoot the ballista, and so on.

The very land was fighting them!

“Forgotten One, do something!” Vainqueur ordered the lich, blasting a laser-firing prism with a fireball. The lich turned mechanical defenses to lead with transmutation, reducing deadly Starmetal-firing machines to useless statues. Above them, Mell Odieuse increasing her HP reserve to astronomical level without going on the offense; after the resounding asskicking Vainqueur dealt her during their last encounter, she had revised her entire strategy to keep him away. “Bring that coward down, so I may poke her!”

“Sablar probably Claimed her, making her immune to [Time] effects,” Furibon replied, barely teleporting out of a cannonball’s way. “My [Za Warudo] will only paralyze you, and I cannot aim my spells with these weapons blasting us from all directions!”

A thunderbolt answered Vainqueur's wishes, striking the fairy queen.

It bounced off her, but it was the thought that counted.

Having [Hastened] himself, King Wotan emerged from the castle’s depths, covered in wounds. Starmetal bolts and bullets had opened holes in his mighty body, all shedding golden blood. He hadn’t looked so battered up since his last confrontation with Vainqueur.

Yet the fomor king was itching for a fight. He leaped over artillery, tore away cannons from walls with his bare hands, and shattered ballistae with his spear. Prismatic shards abandoned their pursuit of Vainqueur to attack the fomor, unleashing beams of light at Dragonbane.

Showing supreme skill and reflexes, the fomor king dodged all attacks with catlike agility, the tip of his Gungnir shattering every shard approaching him.

It felt like watching a tornado rampage through a town, leaving only upturned steel constructs and debris behind in its trail. An unstoppable force which had felled many powerful dragons, and nearly Vainqueur himself once.

“[Supreme Thunder: Dragonslayer]!” Wotan shouted, readying his Gungnir.
“[Maximize Lightning]!”

King Wotan’s [**Lightning**] attacks will ignore Resistance, and inflict additional [**Dragonslayer**] damage!

[**Lightning**] element greatly strengthened!

Wotan Dragonbane had earned his name by killing wyrms; surely, his masterful tactic should work on half of one.

“Wotan!” Mell Odieuse snarled, although she didn’t alter her [Overheal] tactic. Above her, Gardemagnian mages attempted to bypass the shield protecting Crom Cruach and join the battle, but they failed to pierce the magical defense. “You dare to betray me?! Betray the master race?!”

“You mastered nothing!” Wotan replied, channeling lightning through his weapon. “I have not betrayed myself.”

“Yet you help these animals against your own kind! [Soul Slaver]!”

Souls slipped through Mell Odieuse’s chest armor, taking the shape of three ghostly dragons... and a zmey.

It proved to be a poor choice, as Wotan casually blasted them into nothingness with lightning. “[Ghostouch],” the fomor lord kept empowering himself with magic, while Odieuse sent more undead after him. This time, however, the fomor lord’s spear hit them as if they were solid.

Solid paper, that is.

Meanwhile, Furibon formed a barrier around Vainqueur and Victor, shielding the group from an onslaught of projectiles. Yet, although he took no wounds, the Forgotten One’s body was crumbling. “Furibon?” Vainqueur asked, and much to his surprise felt somewhat concerned.

“As an undead, her [Voracious Siphon] drains my lifeforce away,” the lich explained. “I do not have much time left, Knightsbane.”

Nobody made the lich miserable but Vainqueur himself!

“Then cover me,” the wyrm said, knowing how to destroy this castle. He only needed a brief respite and a place where to anchor himself for a few seconds.

“You granted us souls, Odieuse,” Wotan told the fairy queen, as he slew every ghost she sent her way, the trapped souls returning to her core. “You gave us a power greater than you could imagine; the power to look beyond our primal needs, to care for creatures less fortunate than us. The power to become true kings. The power to fight without fear.”

“You call *this* power?” Mell Odieuse replied contemptuously, her body radiating light. A second later, she unleashed beams in all directions like a burning star, her rays searing her own fortress, and casting down her fortifications. Vainqueur and Furibon immediately moved to take cover wherever they could. “You suffer from the same sickness as dragons, Wotan. You forgot yourself, and let your food dominate you!”

“This is your mistake,” the storm lord replied, deflecting the lasers with his spear. “No one should be dominating anyone; this is not an inevitable law of nature, nor a privilege of the strong. Dalton and Knightsbane showed me that. We unlock our true potential when we respect one another. As my Valkyries grew stronger in their desire to protect me, I too, found strength in protecting my creations.”

The dracolich marked a short pause, struggling to understand his point.

“Who fights with you in your final hour, Odieuse?” Wotan asked, the barrage of attacks dying down for a few seconds, as the fairy queen processed the storm lord’s wise words. “Machines? Golems? You have no desire to protect anyone, so no one will risk themselves to save you. You fill the void in your heart with bloodshed as I once did, but certainly, a part of you must realize this is only half a life.”

For a brief moment, Vainqueur thought Dragonbane's speech may have impacted the fairy queen a little. Perhaps not enough to make her reconsider her madness, but at least seed her black heart with doubt.

But there was no place for doubt or compassion in that wicked beast.

Instead, Mell Odieuse's eyes shone with contempt and cruelty.

"You are weak," she spat in disgust. "You, my father, Mell Lin... you are all too weak to seize true happiness, forcing me to take matters in my own hands. I am done with being disappointed. I will kill you, Wotan. I will kill *all* of you, fomors and lesser races alike, until I am alone, in a quiet world. This universe only needs one of me."

She renewed her assault with a barrage of lasers, aimed solely at the wiser fomor.

Wotan, the greatest of his puny race, deflected the attacks with his spear. "Even if you succeed, others will keep standing against you," he warned. "Because we will learn not to fear you."

"Let us put that resolve to the test." The vile fairy extended her arms and cast a mighty spell. "[Gigante]!"

Mell Odieuse's body multiplied in size until she overshadowed her own castle's towers; even with his enhancements, Vainqueur looked as small as against the Tarasque Emperor in comparison. A layer of prismatic light covered her bones, an armor of solid light.

As for her HP...

[507165/6666]

Vainqueur didn't feel fear, but the sight of that number made him pause.

The colossal dracolich landed on the steel ground, causing all of Crom Cruach to tremble, and immediately attempted to stomp Wotan. The fomor lord dodged, her feet crushing one of the castle's artillery platform. Possessed by fury, the giant pursued her smaller kindred, devastating her own lair and paying little attention to Vainqueur.

A terrible mistake. Exploiting the respite which the Forgotten One's shield offered him, Vainqueur landed on the ground and anchored himself to Crom

Cruach.

Then, he called upon his best Perk.

“[Geomancy]!”

Geomancy activated! Field Type: Crom Cruach.

Effect: [**Short-Circuit**].

A pulse of lightning spread through the castle, burning the circuits fueling it. Artillery and ballistae fired wildly in all directions, the will controlling them gone; bolts of energy fried the prisms, shattering them while the entire castle creaked like a broken clock.

The voltage shocked both fomors present, briefly stunning Mell Odieuse while Dragonbane ignored the lightning. Wotan raised his Gungnir and channeled the ambient electricity, as he once did with storms.

“[Ragnarok]!”

A blinding flash swiftly overtook Vainqueur’s sight, while the mightiest lightning spell struck Odieuse right at the chest.

She didn’t even flinch.

The thunderbolt inflicted some damage, and had Odieuse been a lesser wyrm, it might have slain her in one strike; but the Dracolich had grown so big, her HP reserve so colossal, that the attack barely fazed her.

However, Wotan ended up winded after launching his strongest attack, leaving him open for retaliation; and both Vainqueur and Furibon were too far away to help.

Quick as a snake, Odieuse’s giant hand seized Wotan and lifted him above the ground. She then smashed the fomor against Crom Cruach’s pavement, as the Tarrasque Emperor did with Vainqueur himself in the Teikoku Empire.

In this beatdown, there was no honor, no tactic; only raw, naked savagery. The inner beast within Odieuse was exposed for all to see, a rabid animal in the twisted shape of a dead dragon.

In defiance, Dragonbane launched his spear at her chest, but the Black Crest deflected the blow. The weapon grazed her core, without inflicting much damage, and ended up embedded in a disabled cannon.

[497166/5667]

“This is the end,” Mell Odieuse said, grabbing the Gungnir within her fingers; with the difference in size, it looked like a toothpick. “Die.”

“A coward like you dies a thousand deaths,” King Wotan replied defiantly, facing death the dragon way, “I will taste it only once, with no regret.”

The dracolich raised Gungnir and brutally impaled Wotan through the forehead with his own weapon. The spear went from one side to the other in a sickening noise.

Vainqueur's eyes widened in shock, as Dragonbane Wotan's body went limp. The echo of distant thunder suddenly turned silent.

King Wotan's [**Storm Caller**] Perk canceled.

The dracolich then opened her maw and devoured the fomor lord whole, his remains and weapon vanishing in her gullet. The sinister display horrified Vainqueur, who had never even dreamed of eating his own kind. She treated her own species like... like food!

“Your turn,” Mell Odieuse told Vainqueur, the monstrous titan glaring at him and Furibon next. “You are too late to change anything.”

“So are you!” Friend Victor replied, his scythe brimming with magic. “[Private World]!”

The effect was instantaneous.

Space around Crom Cruach's protective shield bent, cracks in existence itself widening all around it. Darkness spilled forth, reality folding on itself. The sound of the battle around the castle grew weaker, as Crom Cruach shifted away from this dimension to another.

"No!" Mell Odieuse snarled, tossing a steel tower away to clear her line of fire, the construct collapsing to the side. "You will not stop me, Knightsbane! Not today!"

"I can and I will, fairy!" Vainqueur snarled back, having recovered from his geomancy display.

The fomor attacked with her spirit breath, a ghastly stream of broken souls in the shape of a deadly ray. The dragon and his rider flew away, towards the open skies which the fairy had previously occupied.

"[Meteor Rain]!" the lich cast while following Vainqueur, summoning fiery stones to hit the dracolich. While Vainqueur's geomancy attack hadn't destroyed Crom Cruach, this spell finished the job. Mell Odieuse's enormous size prevented her from dodging, but her HP bar was so high that she barely registered any damage.

But they did not need to kill her. She would be sealed with her own castle for all eternity, never to threaten anyone ever again.

The fomor let out a roar of pure fury, the items on her chest shining with cursed light. "[Black Crests]! Grant me your strength! Open the path to victory!"

Answering her call, the crests brightened with unholy energies, as they once did for Batling Lavere. Space-time began to crack around the [Dracolich], her magic clashing with Friend Victor's own.

"[Accelerated Teleport]!" Furibon shouted, quickly disappearing before he could be trapped inside the spatial effect. Both V&V members attempted to do the same, using their own Perks to teleport before being trapped alongside the fairy.

“[Magella—”

Too late.

[**Immovable**] negated by Mell Odieuse.

A black hole swallowed them all, and Vainqueur’s world turned into darkness.

Chapter 149: The Last Battle

Victor had done drugs once.

It had been a surreal experience, which broke a friendship, made him a hero of Happyland, and allowed a mortal to access the realm of gods. Higher understanding of the universe through mushrooms.

It didn't prepare him for his current trip.

Victor felt his soul separated from his body, his flesh taken over by alien sensations as the universe twisted and folded. The black hole which swallowed him, Vainqueur, and Crom Cruach transformed into a corridor of swirling light. Victor's spirit moved inside a chaotic rainbow, his mind bombarded with information.

Images flashed inside this strange, spatial hallway. Visions of Happyland, of Heaven and Earth; pictures of nine realms linked together by a giant tree, of an ancient city ruled by an undead abomination; the vague, incomplete design of a colossal machine constantly rebooted; the sight of a crew of men, harpies, and minotaurs navigating an endless ocean, of martial artists meditating around a black lotus, of an alternate earth where potions could grant the power to rule the world.

Victor had heard many people call Outremonde a crossroads between realities. Now he understood why. The visions continued, from pictures of worlds straight out of the wildest works of science-fiction, to phantasmagorical dimensions which made absolutely no sense to his human mind.

These visions were but a mere *glimpse* of the endless multiverse, of which Outremonde was only a small corner.

The journey seemed to stretch for eons condensed in the span of seconds, only to end as abruptly as it began.

Victor's soul and body suddenly resynchronized without warning, granting him back his five senses and motion controls. The lights of the infinite corridor were replaced with a starry sky, and the back of Vainqueur for some kind of marble platform.

Owing to his luck, the Vizier crashed against it face-first.

"Ugh..." Victor heard Vainqueur complain next to him, the dragon had landed next to his rider. Whatever space-time mojo they went through had removed some of their buffs, returning the duo to their original mortal forms. Perhaps their spells had simply run out of duration inside the time corridor.

"Your Majesty, are you alright?" Victor asked his friend, rising back to his feet.

"I am," the dragon replied, shaking his neck and leg as he rose back up too. Having recovered from the emergency landing, Vainqueur looked at the skies. "Where are we, Friend Victor?"

The Vizier had no idea. He glanced around, and the more he saw, the more impressed he grew.

The duo had crash-landed on a large, circular marble platform the size of a football stadium, floating aimlessly in the void of space. Or at least a dimension that *looked* like space; the stars in the heavens glowed with weird and lurid colors, from green to purple. Crimson nebulae swirled in the shape of storms and hurricanes, while constellations rearranged themselves in an incredibly complex dance. Suns fell down like meteor showers on the horizon, while wonderful cosmic auroras provided light.

Beautiful. Simply beautiful.

Victor turned away from the alien skies and examined the platform, the ground covered in ancient pictures carved in stone. Most represented scenes

of dragons and fomors, or of ancient creatures which the Vizier didn't always recognize. One carving represented the Dread Three, facing down an army of angels; another represented Mithras radiant, defeating a fomor as mighty as Mell Odieuse. Each god had a scene consecrated to their success, showcasing an epic feat.

Immense gates thirty-meters tall, made of an alien black metal, stood in the middle of the platform, closed, and locked.

What was this place?

A System notification answered him.

You have entered [**Valhalla**].

... impossible.

"Friend Victor, you told me one needed to reach level 99 to access this place," Vainqueur said, having received the same notification.

"I thought so, and we aren't high level enough yet," Victor replied. "Mell Odieuse *was*, however. She must have accidentally pulled us in when she attempted to achieve divinity."

"Did she succeed?" Vainqueur asked warily. The fomor was nowhere to be found, nor was her castle, but if she managed to become a deity...

"I don't know." The dracolich had tried to force her way through, and Victor had the feeling the System didn't treat would-be cheaters kindly. "Maybe she died."

The Vizier tried to check on his new private plane of existence, to see if they had managed to seal Crom Cruach before the apocalypse, only for his magic to short-circuit.

Teleportation and outside summoning impossible while a trial is ongoing.

"[Emergency Teleport]. [Magellan]." Victor frowned. "[Succubus Booty Call]."

Teleportation and outside summoning impossible while a trial is ongoing.

That was a hard rule. Victor pitied the summon-oriented adventurers who made it this far, only to find themselves deprived of any outside help. “I cannot transport us out,” the Vizier told his dragon partner. “We’re stranded there.”

“Stranded? We are where we should be, Friend Victor.” Vainqueur moved towards the gates with confidence, dramatically raising his hands to open them. “This is where we belong!”

Except the doors didn’t budge.

“I said, this is where we belong,” Vainqueur repeated, pushing further, to no avail. The dragon grew frustrated as the doors refused to open.

Victor attempted to help, knowing his [Skeleton Key] would help him overcome any form of magical lock. But neither his feeble hands nor his perk could overcome these doors.

Level insufficient. You cannot achieve [**Apotheosis**].

Only the thirteenth may pass.

“The thirteenth god?” Victor asked.

“I have not journeyed so far to be stopped by closed gates!” Vainqueur snarled, punching the doors to no avail. These gates could not be opened by anyone short of level 99, and V&V were short dozens of them.

Now, if the duo couldn’t pass the gates nor return home through magic, what could they do? Buffing Vainqueur and casting so many spells in quick succession had drained Victor of his SP reserve, leaving him with very precious few options.

Wait. Why hadn’t they leveled up yet? If they bested Odieuse and sealed her nuclear arsenal, they should have—

A chilling cold filled his bones.

You have entered [**Dracolich**] Mell Odieuse's [**Voracious Siphon**]!

“[Darkest Fear], [Accelerated Piercing Magic Arrow].”

The attack struck Victor before he could even shout a warning.

With his connection to the Black Grail severed and no way to protect his soul from it, the fomor spell took root in his spirit and drained it away.

HP and SP reduced to one! Charisma check successful! [**Terror**] and [**Necrophobia**] negated!

And then, before the Vizier could even turn around, a projectile went through his back, pierced his armor, and impaled his heart.

His body went numb, his eyes widening as he collapsed on the ground. Victor heard Vainqueur shout a cry of surprise, and the Vizier closed his eyes.

Vainqueur's sight turned red, as his friend's body collapsed on the ground, a golden arrow shot in his back.

“Victor!” the dragon shouted, catching his friend's lifeless body. He immediately attempted to heal him back. “[Healing Mantle]!”

[**Anti-Heal**] applied by Mell Odieuse! You can no longer regenerate HP! [**Healing Mantle**] and [**Master's Shield**] negated!

“I told you I relished the thought of killing him again.”

The dragon turned to the source of the voice, smoke coming from his nostrils.

Mell Odieuse flew over the platform, having hidden below, out of sight, for the last minute.

The [Black Crests] on her chest had vanished, and she had regained her original size like Vainqueur, but the journey through space had affected her in a spectacular way. Most of her flesh had been cleansed from her body,

leaving only a skeletal body fueled by spiritual flames. Once shielded, her core was exposed within her rib cage, the whispers of thousands of anguished souls coming out of it. As her empty eye sockets flared with a spark of pure, undiluted hatred, Vainqueur thought that she looked closer to an incarnation of death than a rotting dragon.

The Forgotten One's [Permascan] was still active, revealing her HP bar.

HP: [497166/5667]

Unfortunately, it hadn't returned to normal.

"Just you and I, Knightsbane," the skeletal horror stated as it landed on the marble ground, facing Vainqueur. Without their respective size-buffs, both foes were evenly matched in size. "As it was meant to be."

You are challenged by **Final Boss Mell Odieuse**.

According to the [Dracolich]'s gleeful face, she must have received a similar notification. "This is why you could access this place," Odieuse whispered to herself, her voice brimming with malice. "You are not the new god... you are my Valhalla trial. My final challenge."

"No," Vainqueur glared back, putting his minion's body behind him for eventual revival. "You are *mine*."

Without a word, both foes opened their final battle with their breath weapons.

Holy nuclear flames and a stream of tormented souls clashed in a massive explosion, covering the arena in a cloud of smoke. Vainqueur immediately activated [Spell Purge] and [Fire Crown], covering his body in flames and protection from spells.

"[Fire Immunity]!" the dracolich cast on herself as the dust fell down, Vainqueur's flames licking her body without inflicting damage. Why she bothered to protect herself from this element in spite of her enormous HP bar, the dragon didn't understand.

Did she believe that Vainqueur could deplete it in a prolonged battle?

If so, she was right.

Vainqueur immediately rushed to engage Odieuse in close combat, much to her disdain. Rather than confront him in physical combat as she did with Wotan, she called upon her vilest ability. “[Soul Slaver].”

The dracolich hung back as her rib cage briefly opened, two enslaved ghosts emerging to challenge Vainqueur on her behalf.

A mighty fomor king of thunder, carrying a spear of lightning, and a frost dragon whom Vainqueur once called his rival.

This was a dirty trick meant to weaken both his heart and spirit, but the dragon remained steadfast. He would give both the final, glorious death which both his worthy rivals had deserved.

“[Glitzy Theater]!” Vainqueur covered the platform in a golden dome, to better exploit the passive arena bonus that his homefield provided him with; he stopped the dome's expansion at the edge of the platform, preventing Odieuse from escaping it. “[Victory Fist]!”

Both specters rushed at him while Odieuse hastily closed back her rib cage, Wotan's ghost assaulting Vainqueur with lightning, Icefang's with ice shuriken. The frozen projectiles melted before they could hit his scales, but the thunderbolt managed to bypass [Spell Purge], and it *hurt*.

You have fallen below **half your HP!**

His previous wounds from the earlier battle had remained, but Vainqueur had fought against worse odds. He engaged both ghosts in close combat, Starmetal claws extended. All his battles, all his trials, all his class progression had meant to prepare him to this day; for this last trial before godhood.

And Vainqueur would not falter.

What he lacked in firepower, Icefang's ghost made up in agility, dodging a mighty strike. Wotan's specter, however, took a punch to the face, [Victory Fist] allowing Vainqueur to hit the incorporeal target. His paltry specter, unworthy of the great deeds he had achieved in life, collapsed into nothing, its remains returning to its captor's cold embrace.

Wotan had asked Vainqueur where fomors went when they died. While he had despised Dragonbane, the emperor swore to offer him a better afterlife than Odieuse's belly.

Icefang, more stubborn, continued his assault by covering his phantom claws with sharp magical icicles. The ice survived contact with [Fire Crown] and grazed the [Hoard Armor], both dragons engaging in a deadly dance of claws. The same foolish ferocity that Icefang had shown to Mell Odieuse, he now unleashed on Vainqueur.

“[Overheal]!” Odieuse took the opportunity to replenish her HP-boosting effect while Vainqueur fought off her own victim. The red dragon's lifeforce slowly depleted as the fight went on, while her own only grew. If she engaged Vainqueur in melee, her colossal HP reserve would put him at a disadvantage.

But she didn't.

Instead, she cowardly remained at safe distance and focused on supporting her servant. “[Magical Suppression].”

Mell Odieuse failed to suppress [**Hoard Armor**]!

Her feeble magic couldn't outshine a true hoard!

Still, Vainqueur's instinct told him something was wrong. Odieuse hadn't hesitated to engage Wotan in melee, and she shouldn't fear it with her lifeforce reserve. Something was amiss.

“How about making you fight your own slave next?” Odieuse chuckled, only for her laugh to turn to confusion. “Wait, where is it? Where is his soul?”

The dracolich glanced at the spot where Vainqueur had left his friend's body, and found nothing.

As Vainqueur pushed Icefang back against the Glitzy Theater's closest wall, a shadow leaped over Odieuse's back and hit her between the ribs from behind. The dracolich let out a snarl of surprise and rage, her foe having sneaked up on her while she had focused on Vainqueur.

"Victor!" Vainqueur recognized his friend as he landed on the ground, but Icefang's specter prevented him from assisting. The red dragon attempted to reduce his maneuverability, but the phantom reptile proved as slippery as an eel. "You are alive!"

"How?" Odieuse tried to squash the chief of staff with her hand like a cockroach but proved too slow to do so. Every failed attempt infuriated her further. "*How?!?*"

"It's called [Final Problem]," Friend Victor taunted her, as he dodged the fairy's phantom breath by leaping to the side. "You should have followed Akhenapep's seminar!"

Vainqueur suddenly remembered that this Perk allowed his chief of staff to survive with one HP... and Mell Odieuse's [Anti-Heal] prevented him from recovering. A single hit would finish him off.

"Victor, fall back!" the dragon ordered; since he couldn't hit Icefang in physical combat, he prepared to get rid of his specter with an area of effect attack.

But his minion refused to listen to his wisdom and went on the offense by leaping through the air. The much bigger Odieuse stepped back and protected her body with her arms, but in a masterful display of dragonliness, Friend Victor used his wings to slip past her defense. He hit the [Dracolich] in the chest again with his scythe, the phantom edge bypassing the rib cage and hitting the core beneath. The fairy let out a roar of fury and humiliation, a frustrated lion having been bitten by a flea.

“Two of them, Your Majesty!” Friend Victor shouted, recognizing something as he landed on the ground. “She has tw—”

Without warning, Odieuse opened her maw and blasted the Vizier with her terrifying breath. This time, the attack snuffed his chief of staff’s life, the body falling on his back alongside his scythe. His soul emerged from his corpse, only to be swiftly absorbed into Odieuse’s vile heart.

“You should have stayed down, Dalton,” the fairy rasped angrily.

Vainqueur’s gaze hardened. “[Shining Majesty]!”

His body radiated light in all directions, vaporizing Icefang’s ghost and forcing it to return to Odieuse’s core. The flash couldn’t affect the fairy due to her [Light] immunity and astronomical lifeforce.

HP: [567166/5007].

“[Soul Slav—”

Vainqueur answered this display by opening his mouth the second she opened her rib cage. “[Sublime Breath: Wind]!”

His flames turned into a tornado, hitting Odieuse head-on by surprise. The Dracolich hastily closed her rib cage, protected herself with an armor of solid light, and began radiating an unholy brightness.

All of Mell Odieuse’s stats have been raised by one stage, and her [Light] attacks will inflict twenty percent more damage!

Two? Two what? Why had his minion sacrificed himself for such a foolish, suicidal move? Why target the chest? Vainqueur observed Mell Odieuse, and the HP bar displayed over her head in an attempt to figure it out... and noticed something strange.

Why had Odieuse max HP gone down, but her main bar up? Vainqueur remembered Wotan grazing the core and depleting her amount—

...

Odieuse's maximum HP had gone down when Wotan hit her core. After which she had avoided melee entirely. She hadn't cast [Fire Immunity] because she thought Vainqueur could destroy her body, but because its area of effect may damage something even more precious.

Two of them.

"Two HP reserves." Vainqueur understood what his minion had meant to tell him, as he caught his breath. "You have two HP reserves, one for your body, one for your core!"

Like the vile Furibon, Odieuse's body was a mere decoy, which she could revive at will! She could increase the body's HP, but the core, the vessel of her soul, always remained vulnerable. Attacking the body was a waste of time and effort, a distraction.

The fearful glint in the dracolich's cold eyes told Vainqueur that he had guessed true.

She immediately widened her skeletal wings and took flight, Vainqueur pursuing her. Odieuse attempted to open a hole in the [Glitzy Theater] with her breath, but she was no Tarasque Emperor. Her spiritual attack bounced off the proud golden walls.

Vainqueur's [Wind] breath, though, hit her at full force. While she protected herself with her body, the sharp blast of air slipped through her ribs, grazing the core.

HP: [563466/4917].

As he had thought.

"Fairy ring, open!" Odieuse snarled, frustrated when her fomor magic failed her. Instead of retaliating against her enemy, she kept trying to evade and distance him while spellcasting. "[Teleport]! [Emergency Teleport]!"

"All this power," Vainqueur muttered with contempt, as he kept hounding her, "and all you can think about is running away?"

Even a soul couldn't cure cowardice!

“[Summon Talos Golem]!” Odieuse frantically attempted to call reinforcements, before realizing she was on her own and cornered. “[Morrigan].”

Her luminous body divided into a murder of crows made of light, each growing into a copy of the dracolich. All dispersed across the [Glitzy Theater], confusing Vainqueur. Had she shapeshifted?

No. It was a mere illusion. Smoke and mirrors were the trade of fairies, and Vainqueur had grown used to their tricks. The dragon focused on his sharp hearing, capable of distinguishing the M from the m...

Skill check successful!

Vainqueur identified the real one; Odieuse had landed on the ground to his left, gathering light. He immediately dived down in her direction, claws extended.

In response, Odieuse collapsed her illusions and unleashed a devastating attack. “[Rain of Destruction]!”

Her body exploded into a massive flare of light, unleashing beams in all directions. Vainqueur barely had the time to protect his face with his hands as the onslaught hit him head-on.

Massive [**Light**] damage!

Stray rays of light hit Vainqueur's wings and pierced them, forcing the dragon to make an emergency landing. He managed to land on his legs, only to become the target of more deadly beams; the attacks were so powerful, that they pierced his [Hoard Armor] and the scales beneath.

Warning: You have fallen below **one-quarter of your HP!**

Critical health! [**Bravo Bull**] activated! Strength sharply raised!

A ray almost brought Vainqueur down, but the dragon refused to kneel, his Perk and desperation empowering him. Even as his body bled out gallons of golden blood on the marble ground, he refused to show weakness.

“I was born the supreme existence,” the fairy boasted arrogantly, as she kept unleashing her barrage of attacks. As always, Odieuse remained at a safe distance, giving Vainqueur no opening to exploit. “The strength of fomors and dragons, the weaknesses of neither! The blood of the world’s makers runs in my veins! All will fear my name!”

[**Terrifying Aura**] negated by [**Dragon Honor**].

“I am not afraid of you, fairy,” Vainqueur replied, his eyes shining. “*You* are afraid of *me*. [Geomancy]!”

Geomancy activated! Field Type: Valhalla.

Effect: [**Godlike Spark**].

A powerful, divine energy filled Vainqueur's flesh and bones, his senses sharpening, his might increasing. An influx of power greater than anything he had ever experienced.

All your stats have been raised by six stages for five minutes!

The world seemed to slow down, Vainqueur’s senses and agility heightening. The rays seemed to move at the speed of slugs.

For the first time, the dragon dodged a beam, found an opening, and stepped towards the dracolich. When a panicked Odieuse renewed her assault, he avoided the rays, closing the gap between the two opponents.

“You are always afraid to face me!” Vainqueur snarled. “Like you were afraid of Friend Victor!”

“I fear nothing!” Mell Odieuse replied, frantically trying to blast Vainqueur with light and breath, but always missing. From the dragon’s side, it appeared she spoke slowly, like a stupid zmey. “For no one is beyond my power to kill!”

“You are afraid of *everyone!*” Vainqueur shouted back, quickly gaining ground. “Why do you try to exterminate all minion races, if you are so mighty? Certainly they should be no threat to you!”

Always, the fairy had hidden and fled. She had hidden behind an entire army, wasting all her minions until she ran out of them. She had created weapons to hit Vainqueur’s capital at a distance, without ever endangering herself. Whenever threatened, instead of facing danger, she tried to escape it.

Beneath all her mystic and the terror she tried to inspire, Odieuse was a coward. She spread death because she feared her own.

The vile fairy panicked as the dragon closed the gap between them, using her last trump card. She opened her rib cage as quickly as she could, unleashing another soul from her reserve.

A winged half-dragon, and the one creature whom Vainqueur would never hurt.

The dragon emperor blinked, as his chief of staff’s specter stood before him.

“Obey, thrall!” Mell Odieuse ordered, immediately closing her ribs to shield her weak point. “Kill your master!”

An expression of determination appeared on the ghost’s face. And then, Vainqueur understood. Why Friend Victor had given up his life without fear, after having tasted death so many times already.

Odieuse wasn’t the only expert at trapping souls.

Suddenly, instead of attacking, Friend Victor’s ghost flew back into the core, much to Odieuse’s surprise. The dracolich let out a roar of pain and surprise, as her heart let out a flash of ghastly light.

Instead of whispering, the souls inside Odieuse began to scream. The ghastly reflections of Dragonbane Wotan, of Icefang, of countless wyrms

and deceased minions formed a chorus of the dead, drowning their captor's roar.

Your friend's spirit weakened [**Dracolich**] Mell Odieuse's core from within! Her captured souls are revolting! Mell Odieuse can no longer unleash trapped souls or use her [**Souldrinker Breath**]!

Friend Victor had created an artifact called the [Black Grail] to house his soul, and capture others. He knew how a device like Odieuse's core worked from within... and how to exploit its vulnerabilities.

Vainqueur doubted this inner conflict would last long, but Victor had willingly sacrificed his life to give the dragon a fleeting tactical advantage. This was a bold and risky gamble, one that relied entirely on trust. An iron bond forged through tears and laughs and blood, but stronger than the fairy's own castle.

Struggling against this inner rebellion, Mell Odieuse couldn't continue her bombardment, allowing Vainqueur to close the gap.

With all his might and fury, the dragon punched her in the chest, the mere shockwave of his attack causing the platform to tremble. The blow propelled Odieuse against the wall of the [Glitzy Theater], her core leaking energy.

Supereffective damage!

HP: [532166/3917].

Claws extended into the fearsome poke style, Vainqueur started pummeling Odieuse at full speed. His hands moved as fast as bullets, the golden walls trembling as the dracolich became trapped between the anvil and the hammer.

In every strike, Vainqueur put all his wrath and desire to win. Each claw carried his anger at his friend's death, his sorrow at Icefang's brutal demise, and his fury at the fairy's cruelty towards his minions. A single strike would have leveled a castle, and Vainqueur unleashed dozens of them.

HP: [505356/2617].

The dracolich attempted to bite his neck, but Vainqueur backhanded her, sending fangs flying. He kept his fury focused on the chest, pummeling it until every single rib laid shattered on the ground. Her bones bent backward with sickening noises; the same sound Wotan's body made when Odieuse slew him.

"Hoard!" Vainqueur found his battle cry, as he relentlessly poked her in the heart. "Hoard, hoard, hoard, hoard!"

Yet, while some of his words carried the pain of losing his gold to her schemes, his mind mostly remembered all the minions she murdered in their endless feud. Every crack in her core made him closer to releasing their trapped souls, and the thought fueled him more than the [Geomancy].

Unable to muster a defense, the dracolich almost crumbled on herself, kept only from collapsing by the assault's momentum. The golden wall in her back had cracked, while her core was leaking energy.

HP: [472166/517].

Both her HP bars plummeted at full speed, one faster than the other, until Odieuse's core was one poke away from destruction.

Instead, Vainqueur grabbed the core and ripped out of the dracolich's shattered rib cage, the undead body collapsing on the marble ground. The Calamity of this Age built up energy within himself, intent on thoroughly annihilating this beast once and for all.

Vainqueur raised the core above his head and opened his jaw.

"No," Odieuse whispered, her broken skeletal body struggling to move without the core. "If you take my soul, I will lose... *everything*..."

"You deserve nothing," Vainqueur replied. "[Charged Attack]!"

Nuclear energies built up inside the dragon's gullet, coming out in a stream of destruction.

The devastating force hit Odieuse's core while she let out a final scream, and Vainqueur's light blinded all of Valhalla.

Chapter 150: Valhalla

Mell Odieuse's core exploded in a shower of light.

As Vainqueur's breath died down, the [Dracolich]'s skeletal body crumbled to dust, the death she had spread to others finally claiming her. The core's remains widened, taking the shape of a screaming woman of purple energy; the vile artificial soul of Mell Odieuse, straining from the destruction of her vessel.

The cruel ghost let out howls of agony as her body grew, and grew, and grew...

Until at long last, with a final wail, her soul tore itself apart. Like a balloon pierced from within, her essence dispersed and allowed all her enslaved spirits to escape. Vainqueur's [Glitzy Theater] collapsed on itself after this explosion of spiritual energy, golden dust raining upon the arena.

Hundreds, thousands of specters escaped in all directions, finally released from her iron grasp. Dragons, minions, manlings, and all species known to Vainqueur, finally found their freedom back and fled towards their final resting place.

A few ghosts didn't follow immediately. King Wotan's golden soul offered a sharp nod of respect to Vainqueur, the one foe he had respected, before riding on his horse to some warrior's afterlife.

Another icy ghost flew at Vainqueur, an old face whom the dragon had never made peace with.

"Icefang," Vainqueur recognized the wyrm, bowing his head in respect. "We could never settle our score... but know that I will never forget you,

my only rival. May the Elder Wyrms grant you another life, so that we fight again.”

Icefang’s spirit made a face, but as Vainqueur paid him his respects, the frost wyrm returned the goodbye; making peace with his rival.

Wyrm’s souls bowed before Vainqueur, as did the minions until finally, only one soul remained.

“Victor,” Vainqueur extended his hand towards his chief of staff’s ghost, the manling returning the gesture. With his [Victory Fist], the dragon should be able to touch him.

But alas, Friend Victor’s ghost collapsed into nothingness as his finger was within an inch of his partner’s claw, dissipating into the ether.

Vainqueur watched the scene, exhausted, bleeding, and morose.

Congratulations! For saving Outremonde from nuclear annihilation, leading a grand coalition to its ultimate victory, and defeating the nascent deity Mell Odieuse in her official [Valhalla] trial, you earned four levels in [**Fisher King**] and five levels in [**Witchfinder General**]! You earned the [**Fertile Feet**], [**Enclave**], [**Exorcism II**], [**Greater Magic Resistance**], and [**Salem Trial**] class perks!

+270 HP, +130 SP, +5 STR, +10 VIT, +4 SKI, +6 AGI, +3 INT, +9 CHA, +6 LCK.

[**Fertile Feet**]: Spell, 100 SP per hour. When you walk on the ground, you create a [Plant] creature with every step. The [Plant] is chosen at random and can go from roses to an intelligent creature like an [Elder Treant].

[**Enclave**]: Once per day, you can decide to declare an area within one mile of yourself as part of your territory. This area will count as your land/nation when using your perks.

[**Exorcism II**]: You can cast [Exorcisms] up to Tier II. This replaces [Exorcism I].

[**Greater Magic Resistance**]: You gain Resistance to [**Magic**] (this includes all spells and similar effects, but not techniques nor magical weapons), and you aren't effected by spells of Tier VI and below unless you wish to be. This replaces [**Lesser Magic Resistance**].

[**Salem Trial**]: Technique, 80 SP. You accuse a single target within sight to confess their witchery and find penance. If they have levels in a spellcaster class and fail a Charisma check, their SP is reduced to 0, and they take HP damage equal to the lost amount. You waste the technique's cost even if your target isn't a spellcaster.

Congratulations! For capping [**Fisher King**], you earned the capstone perk [**Holy Grail Incarnate**].

[**Holy Grail Incarnate**]: Your blood carries healing properties. Exposure to your blood will have the same effect as healing potions, with a pint regenerating 500 HP; undead will take damage instead. You cannot heal by drinking your own blood.

You have reached level 99. You can now enter [**Valhalla**] and attempt [**Apotheosis**].

Level 99. Finally, godhood was within reach.

But it was worthless without his best friend at his side.

Vainqueur turned to Victor's body and then disabled his buffs, the battle over. The dragon gently carried the remains of his loyal partner in his hand, scythe included, and then walked towards the gates at the platform's center.

This time, the doors budged the second Vainqueur touched them. Five female, friendly voices came out, speaking at once.

“Come in!”

The gates widened, revealing themselves as a portal towards another space. A golden stairway floating across the strange universe, leading up. The

dragon climbed it, carrying his dead friend in his hand. If Vainqueur needed to become a god to raise him, so be it!

It didn't take long for the emperor to reach the summit, a golden platform even larger than the one where he fought Odieuse.

A mighty dragoness awaited him there, sitting on her royal bottom with regal excitement.

The creature dwarfed Vainqueur in size and majesty, for she was even larger than the Tarrasque Emperor. Each of her five heads wore an elaborate crown, showcasing her gem-like eyes. The span of her wings could cast an entire city in its dread shadow, and her golden claws shamed even the [Hoard Armor] in their shininess. Her scales, instead of settling on a color, constantly shifted between all of them, like a living rainbow.

This entity was the paragon of the dragon race, mixing all the best features from every scaled creature in Outremonde. From Zmey to linnorms to true dragons, all the members of the wealthiest species in existence descended from her.

The legendary Elder Wyrn.

All along, Vainqueur had known this would play out this way. Who else but the ultimate wyrn could have created this dragon-made System? Who else could welcome Vainqueur and elevate him to his rightful place, as a supreme being overseeing all creation? The red dragon raised his head high, preparing himself for the great honor that would be bestowed upon him.

Then the Elder Wyrn spoke and shattered Vainqueur's delusions.

"Congratulationz, my child!" the creature said, tongues coming out of each of her heads like a dumb animal and *destroying* her appearance of majesty. Much to his horror, it suddenly reminded Vainqueur of Gorynych. "I am ze good Elder Wyrn! Oh yes!"

Vainqueur froze in shock, as his entire worldview brutally crumbled before his eyes.

“I am zo happy!” the creature spoke while wagging her tail like a dog. “One of my dragonlingz finally made it!”

Vainqueur looked in silence at her behavior, at the multiple heads, at the flash of stupidity in her eyes, and suddenly realized the horrible truth.

The Elder Wyrm...

The Elder Wyrm was a *Zmey*!

“My life was built on a lie!” Vainqueur complained, shaken by the heresy before him. “God... god is a *Zmey*!”

“All dragonz are equal before my eyes!” the divine ancestor of all wyrms said kindly. “No matter how many heads!”

Vainqueur felt *ashamed* and *dirty* to descend from... from this *thing* but managed to contain his horror. Even if the scriptures had been terribly wrong, this... this entity was his ancestor, and thus deserved his respect. He couldn't afford to make a scene when his chief of staff remained dead in his hand.

“Please, oh great Elder Wyrm.” Vainqueur laid his minion's body before the divine *Zmey* as an offering. “Can you raise my chief of staff from the dead?”

“Oh yes!” The Elder Wyrm waved her hand as she called upon ancient dragon magic. “Zippity Zappata!”

Life flowed back inside Friend Victor, his chief of staff gasping.

“Oh gods,” the manling said, propelled back to his feet by the shock of the sudden revival. “Oh gods, there was a truck! Where's the truck?!”

“My friend, you have returned!” Vainqueur was so happy that he forgot himself and nuzzled his minion. Friend Victor was slightly embarrassed but returned the gesture by holding the dragon's nose in his arms.

“He is so cute!” the Elder Wyrn gushed over Vainqueur’s perfect minion, looking at him closer with her five heads. Friend Victor took a step back in surprise. “His wingz are so pretty!”

“I bred and trained him well,” Vainqueur declared while showing his chest, his pride in his choice of partner stronger than his disgust. “His genes are impeccable, and he has proven his competence countless times.”

“Wait, wait, this is the heart of Valhalla?” Friend Victor looked around, confused. “The source of the System?”

“Friend Victor, have I not told you the System was made by dragons for dragons?” Vainqueur replied, before bowing before the Elder Wyrn. Divine zmey or not, her power and kindness couldn’t be overstated. “Thank you for this free revival, oh Great Elder Wyrn.”

“It is fine, I do it every time my minionz die!” the giant zmey replied.

“Your minions?” Victor asked, sounding suspicious.

“Oh yes, they’re shy with strangers!” The Elder Wyrn cleared her throats and started summoning her servants the dragon way. “Minions! Minions! MINIONS!”

Twelve giants teleported around the platform.

Vainqueur immediately recognized the vile worm Sablar among them, who didn’t bother to hide his disappointment. The destructive deity must have wished for the vile Mell Odieuse to stand in place of her destroyer. Others, Vainqueur vaguely recognized from the statues on display in temples he had visited, from the regal manling king Mithras to the greedy Shesha.

Most looked like they wanted to be *anywhere* but *here*.

“Yes,” the gods spoke all at once, with shamed faces, “Your Majesty?”

Friend Victor looked at each of them in silence, most turning their head away in embarrassment. A dark elf among them, the goddess Camilla, blushed in shyness, while a mermaid did her best to avoid the chief of staff’s

gaze. Only a giant squid and a giant dice didn't seem bothered, mostly because they seemed lost in their own little worlds.

"The gods?" Friend Victor asked the Elder Wyrms, his voice devoid of all emotion. "The gods are your servants?"

"What is a god," the Elder Wyrms delivered her wisdom, "but a dragon's minion?"

"But why?" Friend Victor remained deep in denial. "Why did you make the System at all? What is the *meaning of life*?"

"To make dragonz richer and more powerful!" the Elder Wyrms replied proudly.

Friend Victor collapsed on his knees, mentally destroyed.

Vainqueur smiled with pride, vindicated by the irrefutable truth. He would have boasted about being right, but that would have been in poor taste. Instead, the dragon did his best to look smug and pompous.

"All along..." Friend Victor muttered to himself. "All along..."

"I am sorry, Victor," Camilla apologized, putting a hand on her face. "We thought our mortal followers would think less of us if they knew."

"We suppress the memory whenever we can," a white deer said.

"Wait, that's why you can't Claim dragons?" Friend Victor raised his head, many of the gods nodding slowly. "Because a minion can't claim a dragon?"

"Dragonz Claimed are forbidden, until the end of time!" the Elder Wyrms hit the platform with her tail angrily, causing the platform to shake.

"You were the closest thing we got to a loophole," a crowman god with a large scythe told Victor.

“Oh, you have been Claimed?” the Elder Wyrms observing the half-dragon minion with curious attention, like a stupid child with a toy. “You have so many markz!”

“Well, at this point, only Sablar’s is missing,” Friend Victor said, glancing at the worm.

The Elder Wyrms looked between the two with her five heads, before focusing entirely on Sablar. “Minion.”

“... yes?” the worm god asked anxiously, knowing what would come next.

“Give it to him,” the Elder Wyrms nagged him. “Give it to him!”

“No, you can’t make me do this!” the worm minion turned rebellious. “He stole my prophet’s soul!”

The Elder Wyrms glared at him with her ten eyes, like a parent with an unruly child. “Give it to him, minion! Complete the set!”

Unable to resist *‘the stare,’* Sablar turned towards Victor, his many eyes blinking with pure rage. Light shone beneath the chief of staff’s armor, before swiftly vanishing.

“I hate you,” the worm god complained. “I hate you all *so much.*”

“I better get a special Perk out of this,” Friend Victor said, having recovered from his own heretical revelation. “Is... is the world saved? Did we win?”

“Of course we did!” Vainqueur boasted for both of them, raising his fist. “Did you ever doubt it, Friend Victor?”

“Mell Odieuse has been destroyed, her soul torn into the ether, and you successfully sealed Crom Cruach,” the manling god Mithras said. “For this, you have our sincere gratitude.”

“Oh yes!” the Elder Wyrms focused back on serious matters, clearing her five throats. “Vainqueur Knightbane, you have proven yourself worthy of [Apotheosis]!”

The fact that she misspelled his own name annoyed Vainqueur, but the dragon remained regal and self-composed. “Oh Great Elder Wyrms, if godhood means becoming a minion, then I cannot accept it,” the Emperor stated, the scene having made him reconsider.

“No, no, it is fine! They were never meant to become minion godz! The System was made for you...” The divine Zmey marked a short pause, “and the fairies.”

Vainqueur immediately froze. “Great Elder Wyrms, did you not make the System for dragons?”

“Yes, but I made the System with Eldy, my best friend,” the godlike Zmey replied. “He is a fairy, but he is super duper nice!”

“The Eldest?” Friend Victor asked, connecting the dots. “The first of the fomors?”

“Yes! He was always sad and lonely, so I gave him a soul, and he made minionz so I would never feel hungry. We left Outremonde to our kidz, and we created the System so they could grow strong together!”

“Wait, so dragons only created half the world?” Vainqueur asked, his entire worldview crashing down with every new sentence. “The fairies made the other half?”

“Oh yes!” The Elder Wyrms nodded. “But our children never got along and fought, so we spanked them! Eldy took back his fairies’ souls, and I took my dragonz’ magic! Then we left to create new worlds and Systems, but I sneaked in to send souls to other species because it wouldn’t be fair for them.”

“Well, I guess they didn’t learn the lesson,” Friend Victor said, having made a strange theory about this. Now it was his turn to look smug.

“Fomors and dragons were never informed about the System before their falling out through,” Mithras spoke up. “Due to their arrogance and

laziness, they never truly sought to get stronger, and thus never took the steps needed to activate it.”

“Speak for yourself, manling!” Vainqueur replied. “To afford to do nothing is the purest expression of wealth and power!”

“Certainly,” Mithras responded with heavy sarcasm. “In any case, the System slumbered, forgotten and inactive, until Dice accidentally tapped into and reactivated it.”

“Roll me!” a giant dice implored in a corner. “Roll me for DLC!”

“We were asked to keep the secrets of Valhalla to ourselves, and to interfere with both primordial species as little as we could,” a hooded minion goddess added. “For better or worse, they had to find their own path to greatness.”

“There are two choicez for you, my child!” the Elder Wyrn said. “I can either make you ze god administrator of this System or reincarnate you.”

“First, Her Majesty can reincarnate you somewhere else, in a higher difficulty world where you may continue your progression,” Camilla spoke up. “Your level will reset to 1, but you will keep your existing skills and find challenges worthy of your colossal strength.”

“Quite a few [Epic] candidates were adrenaline junkies more interested in adventuring than godhood,” the crowman god said with fondness. “I almost regret not following them, but alas, it wouldn’t have been fun without my rival.”

“I don’t remember getting that offer,” the mermaid minion said.

“Me neither,” a giant squid spoke up.

“Because you were drunk and high, respectively,” Mithras rasped with annoyance.

“Wait, how many worlds and systems are there?” Friend Victor asked.

“Countless, minion of my child,” the Elder Wyrms replied with wisdom and kindness. “I can create Systems, but many otherz can! There’s hundredz of us, and we all have many planets to overzee! It’s so much work, I need to delegate!”

“Higher difficulty worlds are problematic and high-maintenance, but will provide you with a challenge,” a dwarf goddess continued.

“Not as much as Dis though,” the Elder Wyrms said. “Dis is unfair, and its maker is *undragonly*.”

“Alternatively,” Mithras coughed. “You can gain a [Deity] level, and join the pantheon.”

“Zat’s the rules,” the Elder Wyrms said. “And I say you should take divinity.”

“Why so?” Vainqueur asked, still distrustful.

“The System was never made to work with us,” Camilla said, before adding, “Unfortunately.”

“It was originally made for dragons and fomors,” Mithras said. “Even when we ascend, our influence over it is limited. To use Claimed terminology, we are moderators, but not administrators.”

“But if you ascend, then you can update the System!” the Elder Wyrms told Vainqueur. “I never had the time because I manage hundredz of them, some very complex, but you could improve it!”

“You could add racial classes,” the white deer said, “to balance it out!”

“So?” Mithras cleared his throat. “What is your choice, Vainqueur Knightsbane?”

The dragon glanced at the Elder Wyrms and her twelve minions, unsure what to make of it, but pleased by the offer. At long last, he could take his place as the supreme ruler of Outremonde, making the whole world his hoard.

Then, he looked at his chief of staff, who hadn't been mentioned yet, and a doubt forming in his mind. "What about Friend Victor?" the dragon asked.

The sad look on the Elder Wyrms' five faces immediately confirmed Vainqueur's worries.

"I am sorry, my child," the Elder Wyrms said. "He doesn't have the levels needed. I will have to send him back down."

"What?" Friend Victor protested.

"Why?" Vainqueur snarled angrily, before calming himself. To show anger in front of his ancestor, even a Zmey, was beneath him. "He has helped me in all things! We defeated the fairy's armies together!"

"I died for the fourth time already!" Victor added.

"Yes, but you didn't earn as much experience as Vainqueur," Mithras said. "Knightsbane is the one who defeated Odieuse and did most of the work. While you, Dalton... well... you were the sidekick in all of this."

"Okay, maybe that's too much to ask, but why not increase my levels?" Victor offered. "Vainqueur could grant free noble levels, no?"

"No, or your soul will turn into a balloon!" the Elder Wyrms warned.

"What her majesty—"

"Her Majesty!" the Elder Wyrms chastised Mithras, who now Vainqueur suspected to be her chief of staff. "With an M! I can tell the differenz!"

"What Her Majesty means is that levels, stats, and Perks put a strain on the soul, and someone must gain them naturally," Mithras explained with a strained face. "Artificially inflating your levels with exploits and loopholes too much will result in the soul becoming unstable, as you saw with Mell Odieuse."

"Like this guy who tried to gain a free level from every authority class," a giant, squidlike mermaid said. "His soul turned into a balloon and poof."

“That was funny and unexpected,” the crow birdkin among them chuckled.

“Mell Odieuse skyrocketed to level 99 through viciously draining experience from other souls and using devices like [Black Crests], earning none of her levels,” Mithras continued. “In the end, it tore her unstable soul apart. If she had managed to reach this place... her ascension could have crashed the System, if not worse. A few free levels are fine, especially if you gain them early, but more and you risk compromising your very existence.”

“That’s why Crests and hard limits on stat boosters exist,” the greedy Shesha explained. “Crests in particular limit rampant experience inflation; they help assess if a person truly earned the skills needed to level up further.”

“And...” Friend Victor muttered to himself while hanging on his scythe, “I am too high level.”

“You have become so powerful that nothing short of world-shaking feats will grant you enough experience to level up,” Camilla said. “Not even [Exp Dodos] will suffice. I would love to have you among us and at my side, but it cannot be yet.”

“Then I refuse divinity,” Vainqueur declared firmly, having heard enough.

“Your Majesty...” Friend Victor trailed off.

“My manling and I made a promise to ascend together, as two halves of a greater whole,” Vainqueur replied. “If we cannot ascend together, then return us to my empire, so that I may rule it until my manling is ready.”

“I cannot,” the Elder Wyrms said firmly. “The rulez are the rulez for everyone. Even one of my children.”

“I was not yet level 99 when I entered here,” Vainqueur pointed out. “Why can I not be returned to my hoard of minions?”

The Elder Wyrms considered his words, seeing the wisdom in them.

“I can return you both to Outremonde,” the ancestor of dragonkind said, although she sounded saddened by this turn of events. “I will count zis as your reincarnation option, my child. But you won’t be able to come back here. Divinity is not a revolving door.”

“Wait!” Friend Victor spoke up. “Can I have a moment alone with Vainqueur, before he makes a decision?”

The Elder Wyrn nodded, and granted them privacy the dragon way.

By turning her back on the duo.

“Minions, turn around!” she ordered the deities. “Minions!”

“This is ridiculous,” Mithras complained, but obeyed anyway, like everyone else.

“Roll me to the left! Roll me on my angle!”

When at long last, all minions had turned around—Dice kept out of sight within a giant squid’s arms—Victor looked up at his partner. “Are you sure you want to refuse, Your M—”

“Vainqueur,” the dragon reminded his friend. “You have more than earned that privilege, Victor.”

“Vainqueur, are you certain you wish to refuse?” Friend Victor said. “Sure, we won’t be able to adventure together after you ascend, but we can still hang out sometimes. It’s not so bad, I do it all the time. You could do a lot of good up there, and make sure all this mess doesn’t repeat itself. Maybe even patch out the [Dracolich] class before a new Mell Odieuse can emerge.”

“We will have to talk about this, Victor—” Camilla was silenced by another minion, sulking.

“What I mean to say is that this planet needs someone responsible at the wheel, instead of twelve people pulling it in all directions,” Friend Victor continued, some of the other godly minions complaining in the background.

“And... maybe friendship is blind, but I can't think of anyone better suited for this job than you.”

“Friend Victor, what do you make of our promise?” Vainqueur argued.
“That we would ascend together?”

“I can still ascend and join you later,” the [Reaper] replied, although he sounded a bit daunted by the task ahead. “Since we saved the world, I may have to grind a lot to reach Valhalla by myself. But I will.”

Vainqueur observed his partner, trying to understand his reasoning. And he saw it in his eyes, past the helmet.

His manling wanted what was best for Vainqueur... even when he couldn't follow him. Vainqueur had reached the end of his road, as symbolized by his level progression; his minion knew that even if the dragon would enjoy ruling his empire for a time, he would always yearn for greater wealth and heights. Outremonde had become too small for the Great Calamity of this Age, and he would come to resent stopping where he was.

Friend Victor hated leaving his master behind, but he understood that sometimes, a chief of staff's role wasn't to stand at his dragon's side.

Sometimes, their role was to watch them fly away towards new wealth, and manage what was left behind.

“Minion,” Vainqueur said, his heart heavy. “Bend the knee.”

Victor did without complaint, a dark knight bowing before his lord.

“Promise me,” Vainqueur said. “Promise me on your honor, and on mine, that you shall ascend one day. That you shall rejoin me and stand by my side in the heavens, as you did on earth.”

“I swear,” the [Reaper] declared.

“Promise me that you will take care of my hoard,” Vainqueur continued.
“My hoard of minions and lands. Promise me that you will put my niece Jolie on the throne, and guide her with loyalty. Promise me that you will

rule justly, and uphold the same values I lived by. Promise me that you will take care of my family, and protect them as I did.”

“I swear,” the former Vizier repeated, warm liquid flowing through his helmet.

“I’m going to vomit.”

“Shut up, Sablar,” another minion replied, but the dragon didn’t recognize which one.

“Promise me that you will breed,” Vainqueur added, ignoring the background noise. “So that you have the bountiful descendants I will never have. Promise me to breed until the world overflows with your good genes, so that all dragons may one day have a minion of your quality.”

“I... I pinky swear...” that one was more reluctant, but heartfelt still.

“And finally...” Vainqueur lowered his head to whisper as quietly as possible. “Do not tell my kind about...” He glanced at the Elder Zmey’s back and shuddered, “this.”

“I swear.”

Good. Dragonkind was not ready yet.

Satisfied, Vainqueur nodded. “Then, I release you from servitude as my chief of staff. One day, we shall once more meet again here as equals. Until then... make me proud.”

As he always did.

“Is this...” Friend Victor raised his head, to look at his mortal master one last time before ascension, “Is this farewell, Vainqueur?”

“No, Victor,” Vainqueur replied, as the light of Valhalla swallowed them both.

“This is goodbye.”

Congratulations. You earned a level in [**Deity**].

Domains selected: [**Dragons**], [**Leadership**], [**Wealth**], [**Growth**].

Your journey as a mortal has ended.

But your story has only begun.

Vainqueur's final stats

Vainqueur "Best Dragon" Knightsbane (Pre-Ascension)

Level: 99 (Augustus 30/Witchfinder General 19/Kaiser 20/Fisher King 30)

Type: Dragon.

Party: V&V.

Health Points

7,625

Special Points

2200

Strength

184

Vitality

159

Skill

93

Agility

115

Intelligence

77

Charisma

171

Luck

108 (+10)

Personal Perks

Class Perks

Atomic Dragonfire Breath

Born in the Purple

Fire Immunity

For the Emperor

Red Dragon Lifeforce

King of Games

Dragon Honor

Dynasty

Dragonscale

Crowd Favorite

Super Senses

Supercrit

Virgin Princess Radar

Spell Purge

Lesser Poison Resistance

Witch Burning

Deadfriend

Greater Magic Resistance

Taunt

Exorcism II

Epic

Hunter's Resolve

El Presidente

Stipend

Magellan

Dungeon Owner (Castle of Murmurin)

Stat Boosters +10 (all stats)

Victory Fist

Summon Herald (Victor Dalton)

Imperial Authority

Malefic Secrecy

Monster Empathy

Charged Attack (Dragon Breath)

Victory Roar

Mirror Scale

Fire Crown

Immovable

Show-off

Gold Shower

Shining Majesty

Golden Road

Geomancy

Monster Husbandry

Terraform: Non-Magical Terrains

Pontifex Maximus

Malleus Maleficarum

Incinerator

Master of Silence

Glitzy Theater

Improved Hybridization

Rabbit Plague

Alpha Magnetism (Scales)

Miniboss Breeder

Nature Wonder

Sublime Dragonbreath

Wyrn Sovereign

Symbol of Hope

Healing Mantle

Avalon

Fertile Feet

Enclave

Salem Trial

Holy Grail Incarnate

Chapter 151: Left Behind

Victor awoke with his back against the sand, to the sound of saltwater and crashing waves.

He rose up back to his feet, his wounds closed, his armor fully repaired. From a cursory glance at his surroundings, he had been teleported onto a Prydainian beach, perhaps a few miles away from the site of the final battle. The V&V Army had taken over the heavens, chasing away the last remnants of Odieuse's armies.

It took a few minutes for Victor to fully regain his composure, and remember what just happened. He remembered fighting Odieuse in Valhalla, being revived by a giant zmey, and—

Dragons triumphantly roared in the skies, as the heavens turned ablaze. Victor raised his head and saw it.

A new, dragon-shaped constellation had appeared in the heavens; fiery stars forming a familiar crowned design, announcing the birth of a new god for all to see.

The reality finally sank in Victor's heart.

They had won.

The battle was over.

And Vainqueur was gone.

Congratulations! For tricking Mell Odieuse and helping your master defeat her with a fiendish plan, you earned three levels in [**Moriarty**]! You earned the [**True CrimeProfiler**] class perk!

+30 HP, +20 SP, +3 STR, +2 VIT, +3 SKI, +3 AGI, +6 INT, +3 CHA, +3 LCK!

[True CrimeProfiler]: On a successful Intelligence check, you can perfectly profile a victim with whom you are even casually acquainted with. You are always aware when they lie to you, even when they use magic to disguise their intent, and you can predict their actions with a high degree of success. Additionally, you immediately learn a damning fact about your target.

You earned the **[Claimed by Sablar]** personal Perk! For being claimed by the entire pantheon, you also earned the **[Pantheist]** personal Perk!

[Claimed by Sablar]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Strength or Vitality increase. You are immune to all [Time] and [Earth] effects, except those caused by Sablar himself, and you no longer age.

[Pantheist]: You cannot take damage from [Prayer] spells and divine-powered perks, except those used by **[Deities]**.

As if to underline that he hadn't dreamed, Victor felt his left palm itch. He removed his gauntlet, to find a dragon-shaped mark on his skin.

You earned the **[Claimed by Vainqueur]** Perk.

[Claimed by Vainqueur]: When you level up, you have an additional 10 percent chance to gain a Strength, Charisma, or Luck increase. The rate of loot drop and your odds of finding treasure is doubled.

Thanks, buddy.

The sight left a bittersweet taste in Victor's mouth, reminding him that he would be on his own for the future. Three levels put him at level ninety-one, which was still a long way to go to reach godhood. But the Vizier had made a promise, and he would fulfill it.

A great shadow passed over the [Reaper], bringing him back to reality.

“Vic!” Carried by Gorynych, Kia Bekele landed right in front of him and immediately climbed down on the sand. The [Plot Armor] she wore remained unscathed, her power of friendship having shielded her from any wounds. “Vic, finally!”

“Master!” the Zmey rejoiced to see his rider again. “Gorynych was so scared!”

“Kia?” Victor asked, realizing that Akhenapep’s [Time Push]’s duration must have run out.

“I came as fast as I could!” the [Paladin] said, desperate, her sword raised and itching for battle. “Where is Odieuse? Where is she? Where is she?”

Ah, poor gal. Victor tried to mince his words, but there was no way around it. “She’s dead.”

“She’s dead?” Kia sounded both relieved, and terribly scared. “Dead as in, undead, or...”

“We beat her, sealed her apocalyptic castle, and Vainqueur became a god.” Victor pointed his scythe at the heavens and his friend’s miracle. “It’s over.”

Once, a single sentence had utterly destroyed Kia Bekele, pushing her through an abyss of tears and despair. Having sunk as low as she could, the knight had managed to climb up back to normality through blood and tears.

Victor’s words put her right back at the bottom of the well.

“I missed the final battle,” the [Paladin] said, her gaze hollow. “I missed the final battle.”

“Kia, it’s okay,” Victor tried to reassure her, putting a hand on her shoulder. “We’ll find another.”

His words fell on deaf ears, the [Paladin] walking on autopilot on the beach, and muttering to herself as emotions built up inside her. Then, they suddenly exploded without warning.

“BLEEP!” Kia cursed loudly, her armor forcing her to mix family-friendly lines with insults. “Ohana means family! BLEEP this armor! BLEEP IT!”

Before Victor could even do so much as protest, Kia started removing the [Plot Armor] and throwing it on the sand, her fury overtaking her modesty. “Screw that armor!” she shouted, “Screw these lines! BLEEP them!”

“Gorynych can sing a song to cheer her up,” the Zmey suggested. “Can Gorynych sing a song?”

“It is kind, but I don’t think it will help,” Victor stated, as Kia kicked the cursed armor into the sea. As it turned out, she wore black underwear below her magical protections, but the Vizier had a nice view of pretty much everything.

Maybe that was the adrenaline, the exhaustion from all these trials, or just the sight of this perfect amazonian body but... well, his mind wandered off.

Kia and he remained silent a moment until an idea seemed to make its way into the [Paladin]’s mind. “Victor,” she looked at him dead in the eyes, her gaze filled with one last hope at personal fulfillment.

“Kia,” he looked at her, knowing this was now or never.

They said it at the same time.

“Do you want to *fight/breed*?”

The next day, at a camp built amidst the remains of Odieuse’s lands, a great summit was organized between the winners of the Prydain War. Grandrake was chosen as the dragon race’s main representative and arbitrated the debates in the same style as the Dragon Conclave. From Jajambe to the Averagist’s Supreme Leader, every participant earned a voice.

Victor informed Jolie of her new promotion to Empress of Murmurin, and Vainqueur’s niece accepted the charge with grace, and quite a lot of tears; however, having clearly no experience with ‘dragon imperialism,’ she more or less left Victor to do all the work. For hours, the Dragon Empress and the

Grand Vizier sat next to heads of states around a stone table, Vainqueur's constellation shining in the open skies above them.

Well, truth to be told, Victor had already done most of the work while Vainqueur was in power. Now, with his niece being too young to rule, it had become official. The fact their former dragon emperor had become a god and given him a mandate had only enhanced Victor's aura in the eyes of outsiders.

In the end, Jolie officially promoted Victor from Grand Vizier to Grand Regent. Akhenapep would have been proud.

Vainqueur had made his new divinity apparent by Claiming quite a few of his elite minions, although he didn't show up personally. The dragon was probably occupied getting used to his new divinity and System management, leaving Victor to handle things in the mortal world.

Overall, the summit went better than what Victor expected. While Gardemagne's King Roland, his allies, and some violent dragons had hoped to end the fomor threat *permanently*, Victor, Jolie, and Grandrake managed to talk them out of outright genocide by agreeing to ensure a peaceful societal transition. And if necessary, back it up with force.

Prydain would keep its independence, with power granted to the fomors who helped the allies during the war; although the victorious nations would build fortresses and send ambassadors, to make sure there would be no foul play involved. The country would be demilitarized, its arsenal destroyed, and Odieuse's major supporters would be tried on the mainland.

The V&V Empire would provide the surviving fairies with ethical Soulcrests, allowing them to develop souls and compassion. In exchange, the fomors swore a binding oath not to attack their neighbors and pay war indemnities, so long as they were left alone in return.

And so, for the first time since the beginning of civilization, Fomors made peace with everyone else. It may take decades for their culture to change, but like Murmurin, Victor hoped that they would become trading, peaceful neighbors one day.

Cait Sith didn't manage to outlaw cat eating on the whole continent though, although Jolie honored her uncle's promise to ban it in the Empire. You couldn't win every time.

"We should do it more often, Breeder Victor," Grandrake declared, while Jolie ratified the treaty. Kia, having traded the [Plot Armor] for her normal one, stood guard next to the empress, but as far away from Victor as humanly possible; she looked away in embarrassment whenever their eyes met.

"A conclave to settle our issues?" Victor asked Grandrake, still reeling from the [Paladin]'s slap.

"Perhaps one day, the international minion conclave will gain half as much prestige as our own," the old dragon mused. "Under a dragon moderator's rightful direction."

"It is my dream to one day see minions take control of their own destiny," Jolie declared proudly, before handing the document to Jajambe. The sharkman signed with his own blood for dramatic effect. "I swear that one day, dragons and minions will stand as equals!"

"You spoke about soul magic, Lord Grandrake," Victor spoke, the older wyrm more amused by Jolie's revolutionary ideas than anything. "I received confirmation from a higher authority that it once existed."

"If it truly existed, then it can be relearned," the Princess Hunter said. "I understand your trail of thoughts, minion of Vainqueur. You believe this could serve as a foundation towards long-term peace with the fairies."

"Peace through trade." Victor nodded.

Genialissime, who had watched the discussions without truly participating, remained doubtful. "These are truly strange times we live in," he said. "We want to make friends with fairies, and dragons can die like minions."

"You have reconsidered your position, Young Genialissime?" Grandrake asked his younger fellow.

“I admit my convictions have been shaken,” the dragon said. “But what my cousin did, facing death and clawing his way to victory anyway... it is inspiring. Maybe it is not such a bad way to live.”

“If you believe dragons can die, do you also think fomors can change?” Victor asked, curious.

“No,” the dragon replied. “But I am cautiously optimistic. We should try at least.”

“That is what Uncle would have wanted,” Jolie nodded.

“I am certain that he is proud of us all,” Grandrake replied, but immediately pushed for his ecological agenda. “But he would be prouder if you took your breeding duties seriously, Breeder Dalton.”

Victor sighed. Unfortunately, now that he had been recognized as regent and unmarried, the other heads of states had not so subtly approached him about dynastic alliances. King Roland Gardemagne himself lauded his niece’s beauty and intelligence in every conversation he and Victor had so far. “I have my fill of princesses, Lord Grandrake.”

Although, it might help him grind [Fiendish Rake] and rejoin Vainqueur...

...

Maybe when his current kids were old enough to attend Scholomance.

Leaving Jolie in Kia’s care and returning to the camp, Victor found many of his friends waiting for him. Malfy, Jules, Buzz Jelly, the Kobold Rangers, Rolo, Charlene, Allison, Noirceur the Nightmare... quite a motley of allies he had gathered across his travels.

“Hello handsome,” the dryad said, beaming at his arrival. Charlene, meanwhile, carried the teapot where Akhenapep had sealed the Tarasque Emperor; Jajambe must have helped in recovering it. “How did it go?”

“We have world peace,” the [Reaper] declared. In the background, he noticed Junior and his slimes making friends with the Gardemagnians, the

mimic Witch Hut more or less shoving baby slimes in the hands of humans gushing over their cuteness. A bit farther, Averagist Dwarves pitched the value of Averagism to soldiers, encouraging them to cast down the elven bourgeoisie.

Nothing to foster friendly bonds than a shared war.

“Is it true you picked a fight with Kia Bekele?” Charlene asked, raising an eyebrow. “That doesn’t sound like peace.”

“Paladins cannot accept that their monopoly over healing magic is over,” Jules shrugged. The ghoul sounded almost happy to hear of this misadventure.

Victor sighed, still wincing from the wounds. “When a paladin and a necromancer spend too much time close, they start having unprotected Charisma checks. And when the necromancer *fails* the Charisma check, in spite of all his absurd bonuses, it turns into unprotected Strength checks.”

Allison chuckled, clearly amused by the rejection. “It’s not a question of charisma stats, Vic,” she said with wisdom. “It’s with whom you try. Some things are never meant to be.”

Truthfully, while he had made peace with having children—even come to desire it—Victor had enough women in his life. Having multiple dysfunctional families to manage, spending more time with Charlene, and the possibility of dynastic alliances would already be a challenge.

The [Fiendish Rake] never thought he would say this, but he didn’t mind being in the friendzone for once.

“Any news on Furibon?” Victor asked the group, worrying for the cranky lich.

“He hasn’t appeared since the battle at the castle,” Charlene said. “I suspect he survived, but Vainqueur’s ascension scared him off.”

No wonder. With Vainqueur now the supreme deity of Outremonde, the lich would look over his shoulder for the rest of his unlife.

“So what is the plan, handsome?” Allison changed the subject.

“My plan, after we clean up this mess, is to stabilize the Empire and found the Church of Vainqueur.” Without the red dragon’s greedy drive and children on the way, Victor no longer had any reason to keep adventuring. He could focus on kingdom-building, ensure the Empire kept what it had conquered, and settle the New World at his nation’s own pace. “We will build institutions, foster international trade, create alliances, reorganize the peasantry, make school mandatory—”

“That’s good to hear,” Charlene interrupted him. “But I believe she asked your plan for what we do *right now*.”

The vampire looked at the gathered dragon army as she said that, whose ravenous hunger had turned the countryside into an empty pantry. They had had enough fomer warbeasts and cattle to feed them so far, but they ate more in a day than Murmurin’s population in a year.

“Oh,” Victor replied. “Well, we will hold a feast to make our dragon allies happy and convince them to return to sleep afterward. Then we’ll have to figure out a way to survive the ensuing famine.”

Personally, the Vizier believed the dragons’ hunger might cause a higher death toll than the nukes.

Thankfully, his friends paid more attention to the celebration part than the unfortunate, expected aftermath.

“I agree that celebrations are in order,” Allison said with a smile, happier than Victor had ever seen her. Avoiding a nuclear annihilation and achieving world peace had put her in a cheerful mood. “We have won the war, Vainqueur is a god, and you returned to us alive. One would have been a reason enough to party.”

“Perhaps we could organize undead gladiator fights?” Jules suggested. “It would honor Vainqueur, and bring glory to the undead.”

“What about having gladiators fight demon beasts?” Malfy suggested. “Think of the PR.”

“Rolo will take on both!”

“Party!” Buzz Jelly jumped on place. “Hobo fight! Hobo fight!”

“Chief, chief!” Pink Ranger leaped on place. “Can I ask you something? Could you narrate your adventures with His Divine Majesty?”

“You want to make a book about them?” Red Ranger asked her.

“The best and most accurate ever.” The [Bard] nodded. “The Holy Book of his Divine Majesty.”

Maybe Victor hadn’t earned godhood... but life down there wasn’t all that bad.

Before the [Reaper] could open his mouth and invite everyone for a drink, an imp messenger hurriedly rushed in their direction. “Mr. Victor!” the imp shouted. “It’s happening! It’s happening!”

Victor’s eyes widened. “I need to go!”

He opened a portal to Happyland as fast as he could.

When Victor arrived, Isabelle was already breastfeeding their daughter.

The sight immediately froze the adventurer in place, for it was the most beautiful he had ever seen. His mistress was sitting on a king-sized bed, naked, as she provided a pale baby in purple silk with nourishment. His demon concubines were present, having probably helped with the birth, alongside Goblina. The goblin warlord was positively gushing over the new half-demon.

“Darling.” Isabelle smiled at her companion, both exchanging a passionate kiss.

“Vic, I am so happy for you!” Goblina said while showing her friend an advanced, gold-plated gun, “I brought her a gift, so she can shoot peasants from afar!”

“Sweetie,” Isabelle told the tiny babe in her hands, as she looked up at the newcomer with her big blue eyes. “This is your father.”

Your father. Victor had to resist the urge to gush. “Your Daddy,” he said. “I’m your daddy, Braniña.”

“Daddy...” the little half-demon whispered with a soft voice, managing to form words already. He blamed the demon blood in her veins.

Just hearing the word made Victor squeal. “Can I?” he asked the mother, giddy with anticipation.

“Yes.” Isabelle handed him the child. “But be careful, we haven’t conceived a spare yet.”

“I’ll protect her like my life depends on it,” Victor replied, before carrying the soft, tiny babe with the greatest of care.

The creature in his hands was so light, and yet so beautiful. She had skin almost as pale as her mother, although her eyes were those of a human. Besides these adorable features, she already had a patch of dark platinum hair, antennas, and tiny orange wings; no doubt his little princess would grow into a creature as enrapturing as her mother.

Time seemed to freeze while Victor carried his second child, his heir, and his light. He silently swore that he would protect her against all harms, and make sure she grew under better circumstances than he did.

Vainqueur had given him a chance to raise her. It would not go to waste.

“Daddy,” Braniña whispered.

“Yes?” Victor smiled at his daughter, ready to fulfill her every wish.

“I want a pony!” she squealed. “From *Hell!*”

“Everything you want, sweetie,” Victor said, kissing her on the forehead.

“Everything you want.”

He had so much work to do, but the future had never seemed brighter.

Chapter 152: The End

The Second Edition would start at midnight.

In preparation for this moment, Vainqueur Knightsbane, Great Calamity of all Ages, supreme god of the Outremonde Pantheon, King of the World — and the Albain Mountains — gathered his twelve godlike minions in his planar realm.

Also known as [Dracotopia], it was the most beautiful place in the universe, and the dragon would not let anyone tell him otherwise. A world-sized hoard, worthy of his newfound greatness. For since his ascension, Vainqueur had grown larger, being now halfway between his mortal size and the Elder Wyrms, towering over his minions. In time, perhaps he would outgrow even his progenitor.

The floor and walls of his realm were made of gold, the ceiling of gems. Pillars of silver, allowed out of respect for the fallen Icefang, formed a circle around Vainqueur's ostentatious throne; the dragon had moved a large table representing a map of Outremonde before it, so that he may oversee Outremonde Civilization sessions personally.

Each of his minions had answered his summons, gathering around the table; even Wormlike Sablar, who never stopped complaining about anything, had shown up. Certainly, he had tried to shirk his duties; in response, Vainqueur had eaten him once and threatened to do so for all eternity when the insect regenerated in Valhalla the year afterward. The worm learned the meaning of the food chain, his place in it, and never contested the dragon's rule again.

"Your Majesty," Minion Mithras, the most reliable of his godly lackeys, spoke up. "We are ready."

“Your *Divine* Majesty,” Vainqueur insisted, wishing to be exalted above mortal majesty; after all his work, he had earned a self-promotion.

“Minions, I gathered you to present you the fruit of my work, and prepare you for the next campaign that we will start tomorrow.”

Since his ascension, Vainqueur had worked tirelessly to renovate the old System, and guide his minions through the end of their previous Outremonde development campaigns; fusing the two groups of players into one, forcing Wormlike Sablar to attend sessions, and maintaining peace. Now, the wait had ended.

Vainqueur oversaw all his minions until all of them had sat and waited for him to begin. The dragon god cleared his throat, mentally rehearsing his epic speech.

“It has been sixteen years, *sixteen years*,” Vainqueur insisted on the words, “since I, Vainqueur Knightsbane, Great Calamity of this Age, ascended to become the ruler of all creation.”

“More like the solar syst—” Knight Leone started.

“All of creation!” Vainqueur snapped, silencing the foolish knight. “Sixteen years have passed, and the time of small nations has ended. Now, is the era of empires! Greatest of all being the V&V Empire, the most powerful, prosperous nation in the world, which worships me above all else!”

The minions listened religiously, since they knew how proud he was of his country. After all, he constantly reminded them of its greatness every single meeting.

“Leading the armies of my beautiful niece, Empress Jolie, the Whore King Victor has expanded its borders all the way to the New World. Elsewhere, other countries have grown in size and strength; Gardemagne, Barin, Thaoten, Teikoku, and Nagastan. The fairies, now redeemed, have learned their place, and dragon adventurers rule the skies. There has been peace for years, but now, tensions boil beneath the scales!”

Soon, the V&V Empire would crush all its rivals.

And one day, the whole world would be V&V!

“Outremonde is now ready for the update of its System, designed by *me*,” Vainqueur boasted. “It will include revolutionary ideas, like racial levels, new classes, a better experience progression, more opportunities to build wealth, and so much content you can only *dream* of exploring it all! Of course, out of fairness, dragons will start with the highest levels and best abilities, but minion builds will remain perfectly viable.”

Balance shouldn’t get in the way of realism.

Vainqueur would also finally restore the [Dragon Magic] feature which the Elder Wyrms had removed, granting them back their native soulcrafting abilities; while fairies would also start with a soul on birth, putting them on the same starting line as everyone else. The problems that plagued the first System would soon become a thing of the past.

“Now, to inaugurate this Second Edition of the dragon-made Outremonde System, we shall launch the Dalton Dynasty Campaign tomorrow alongside the new rules. While I expect you to keep influencing the world through your portfolios and churches, each of you will also select a chosen to playtest the new System. You will select a *Dalton* child, the beautiful minion spawn of my perfect chief of staff, who will soon join us at this table. You will guide them for...”

Vainqueur hesitated, before settling on the length of a nap. “Fifty years. Fifty years, and the child accumulating the most prestige point at the end wins.”

He glanced at each minion. “Now, have you all chosen your Claimed champion?”

Almost all of them nodded at once, except Sablar, who earned Vainqueur’s glare. “Worm Minion...”

“I don’t want to play this stupid game!” Wormlike Sablar complained, as he always did.

“Minion...” Vainqueur gave him the stare, the giant insect sulking. “You will socialize, whether you like it or not!”

“Victor has one hundred eighty-eight children, if you count all the slimes he adopted,” Greedy Shesha said. “You should find someone matching your peculiar tastes in that pool, Sablar.”

The number of natural children among them had greatly disappointed Vainqueur. The dragon had made his chief of staff swear to reproduce, but the years and family life had tamed his breeding spirit. Still, quality trumped quantity. “Wormlike Sablar, choose or roll.”

“Roll me!” Rolley Dice insisted. “Roll me for your avatar!”

Finally realizing he wouldn’t escape his minion duties, Wormlike Sablar sighed. “Does he have a fomor child? Or one with [Chronomancer] levels?”

“I think one of his natural sons has levels in that class,” Untasty Cybele replied.

“Close enough,” the worm replied, choosing his candidate.

“In my case, I will change my choice to Braniño II,” Dwarf Veran spoke up.

This caused the audience to gasp. “You are no longer playing Braniña?” Crowman Deathjester asked, astonished by the change. The dwarf had showered that child with gifts since her birth.

“She took a level in [Paladin],” Dwarf Veran raged on, infuriated.

“[Paladin]! Her godmother and mother are furious and disappointed, but not as much as I am!”

Knight Leone seemed to take perverse joy in this twist. “Oh, in that case, I will Claim her myself. Maybe there is hope in that family.”

“My protegee isn’t born yet,” the Moon Man said.

“Are you sure?” Cybele asked. “Your spawn will start sixteen years late. This is a wide gap in prestige points to recover.”

“Can’t be worse than Seng’s choice,” Corpseling Camilla said with contempt, glaring at the mermaid.

“I told you, it was an accident!” Mermaid Seng complained while blushing, “We, we were both drunk, and we were watching *Grandrake’s Princess Mating Habits* and, and...”

“I will allow no breed-shaming under this roof!” Vainqueur thundered, although he did admit his favored minion could have shown greater breeding standards.

“My chosen one will be the most powerful,” the Moon Man prophesied, “And with the highest stats.”

“Goddamn metagamer...” Deathjester complained.

“Fine,” Vainqueur told the squid. “But if you are mistaken, you shall play a weredragon.”

The matter settled, Vainqueur reviewed the rules and his minions’ latest actions, making sure they didn’t disobey his ‘*Godlike Minion Deontology Charter*.’ The dragon restricted their influence to their portfolio, churches, or Claimed, ensured they made the universe run on time, and saw to it that dragons and minions would always find adventures worthy of them.

“Second Edition,” Minion Mithras reminisced. “I was worried at first about this divine organization, but I wholeheartedly support the new order.”

“You are just happy someone else disciplines us,” Corpseling Camilla accused her rival while smiling. Only Crowman Deathjester complained about rule-stickers, having been a troublemaker for years. Vainqueur had suspected him of cheating behind his back many times, but the god of criminals was always where the evidence wasn’t.

“It is still hard to believe we spent years playing separately,” Untasty Cybele said. “Things are running more smoothly now, the balance of the world shifting from rampant chaos to neutrality.”

“Who else but a dragon could achieve god-peace?” Vainqueur replied although he was pleased by the positive reception. The dragon had worked hard to make his godly minions get along better and to see them talk around a table warmed his heart.

After reviewing the rules, Vainqueur dismissed the pantheon, expecting them to return at the first hour tomorrow morning to begin the campaign. For now, the dragon emperor had a meeting with destiny.

Tonight was Victor’s last chance to achieve divinity before the update, and Vainqueur had been waiting for sixteen years.

From the balcony of Murmurin’s imperial palace, wielding his scythe and wearing his infernal armor, Victor glanced up at the night skies and blinked in astonishment. A solitary yellow orb glittered in the darkness, surrounded by stars.

The Mooooooooooon had turned into solid gold.

“When did this happen?” Victor asked Jules, who had warned him first.

“Twenty minutes ago,” the necromancer replied. “Croissant sent us a magical message; apparently it happened in the blink of an eye, probably due to a Tier XII spell.”

The highest spellcasting tier recorded... and right before the planned System Update too. Was Furibon trying to quickly accumulate levels at the last moment, as Victor did? The Vizier was glad to hear news from the lich, the undead having vanished for sixteen years, but the timing seemed very odd.

The thought made Victor feel slightly nostalgic, his eyes wandering off to the city which the castle oversaw. Gone was the tiny village he and Vainqueur had once conquered; Murmurin had grown into a Rome for monsters, home to millions. Dragons coexisted with orcs and mimics, as the country did with Gardemagne and Barin; train roads linked the city to other towns, forming the bloodstream of a nation; airships had even started appearing in the skies alongside wyrms, linking the empire’s colonies in the

New World with the mainland. Victor had worked tirelessly to develop and expand this place, until V&V rivaled the Spanish Empire at its height.

“I guess Vainqueur will be rather happy,” said the Grand Vizier. “But otherwise, has the change negatively impacted our colonies?”

“No, neither the moon’s density nor mass changed; I believe Furibon only altered the moon’s surface. It may affect the fauna, but troubles will be minimal.” Jules cleared his throat. “The empress was extremely pleased, but she will continue her annual tour of the golem farms as she planned.”

Good. Jolie had grown into a caring and responsible ruler, almost as well-loved as her uncle. While she spent a lot of time adventuring, the young dragon made sure to check on her subjects’ well-being whenever she returned from her latest quest. “What else is on the agenda?”

“There is a domestic dispute between Isabelle Maure and Chocolatine de Gevaudan about the family planning.”

Again? Victor couldn’t suppress a sigh. This was hopefully his last day on the job, and it would be spent disarming another feud. “I’ll deal with this.”

As the two left the balcony to move to the throne room, Victor thought about his role in the great bureaucracy he created.

The Vizier mostly spent his time either abroad on diplomatic missions or managing his family nowadays, which he took as a good thing. Over the last decade, Murmurin’s institutions had learned to manage the country on their own, without always relying on his direct involvement. Vainqueur’s Empire would survive his and Victor’s absence, something thought impossible sixteen years ago.

The throne room, which had once been Furibon and where Jolie now held court, had a dragon-sized throne shaped within a golden statue of Vainqueur. Victor himself had often seated there when Jolie was busy adventuring abroad, although it never felt comfortable. Slime knights,

Victor's adopted children, stood watch as the Empress' elite guard, their glueness covered by metal helmets and sticky swords.

He found Chocolatine and Isabelle at each other's throat, with Kia in the middle.

Victor would have wished it was metaphorical, but it wasn't; doubly so since they had brought their children to the gathering. Chocolatine had transformed into a giant wolf, backed by two red wyverns and two crimson king slimes. Meanwhile, Isabelle had summoned a blade of wind, the ten years old Braniño II playing with hellfire while his older sister Braniña watched on with her arms crossed.

Kia and slime guards stood between both groups, desperately trying to calm them.

"What is all the racket?" Victor thundered, his presence instantly cowing everyone. It had taken him years to get the 'evil overlord' voice right, even with the help of Akhenapep's sealed soul. Much to his shame though, the would-be heroes trying to slay him had given the Vizier a less than intimidating nickname.

The Whore King of Murmurin.

"Dad!" His kids all smiled at his presence, instantly relaxing. Chocolatine took back her human form, dressing as a peasant with red hood-like clothes; the contrast with Isabelle, who wore expensive silk and jewelry, couldn't be clearer. One represented the common monsters, another the infernal aristocracy. Both had benefited from his Tier X [Idoun] spell though, and the one thousand years of eternal youth it provided; to cover the ravenous black hole they called a national budget, Victor had often sold the spell to foreigners.

Unfortunately, what had started as a mere animosity between the various sides of his extended family had spiraled into political infighting. Since Victor had been a good family man, giving his mistresses and children government offices, factions within his family had entrenched themselves in the empire's political landscape.

Kia tried to counterbalance their influence since the Empress listened to her advice, but she was more often than not adventuring abroad and had few allies in the Empire itself.

In this case, though, the conflict sounded more personal than political.

“Vic, she wants to take my place in the family planning tomorrow!” Chocolatine pointed an accusing finger at Isabelle. “After I already prepared everything with Al!”

“This is an urgent matter!” Isabelle replied icily. “About his heir.”

“You mean his soon to be *former* heir, mother?” Braniño II mused, pinched by his sister. While Braniña looked like the spitting image of her mom, her younger brother had inherited an [Insect/Dragon] typing. He had grown into a humanoid crimson moth with dragon features and already earned a [Demon Prince] level at his age.

It was like watching the second coming of Brandon Maure, except the bashful demon king had never been half as greedy and competent as Victor’s own brood. The half-dragon moth was already planning world domination at ten, which his father blamed on his wyrm heritage.

“It’s our sixteenth anniversary!” Chocolatine complained to Victor. “You promised we would do something special!”

“Yeah, Dad, you said we could go to Dungeonland!” complained his eldest weredragon son, Brioche; unlike their mom, Chocolatine’s children kept their wereforms, being more in tune with their beastly nature.

“I want to try the Tomb of Furibon!” his wereslime son Truffe insisted, hopping on place. “Glunine said they had exploding ducks!”

“And we will visit it,” Victor promised this side of the family, trying to broker peace. “We will go dungeon crawling, I promise.”

“That’s lame,” Braniña complained. She had grown into a beautiful young woman, almost the spitting image of her mother, although their

personalities couldn't be further apart.

“Darling.” Isabelle frowned, her gaze turning jealous. “When you are done cajoling your menagerie, perhaps we can talk about your trueborn daughter.”

Chocolatine and her children glared at the demon queen with murderous fury, Victor raising his scythe to prevent a battle. “All my kids are equal before my eyes,” he warned Isabelle, giving her a stern stare.

“I am sorry,” she said without truly meaning it.

“What is it about?” Victor asked, eager to have the matter done. Why were these two always within an inch of fighting whenever in the same room? He had to move them to opposite regions of the empire to prevent a massacre!

“Mom wants me to change my [Paladin] class to [Dark Knight], that’s why!” Braniña complained.

“What is wrong with that class?” Brioché asked, curious. He himself had become a [Paladin of Isengrim], much to his mom’s delight.

“No daughter of mine will ever become a [Paladin]!” Isabelle replied angrily.

“It would be nice, actually,” Braniño II said. “Only my own sibling would be worthy of becoming my eternal rival, and keep me sharp as I claim my rightful plac—”

“Aunt Kia is one!” the paladin interrupted her brother, the knight in question wisely remaining silent. “And your despotic puppet dragon-empress too!”

“Braniña, I can accept your choice of a class, but I *won't* tolerate talk of democracy under this roof,” Victor warned his daughter. “I spent years turning this country into a nepotistic oligarchy where my children, adopted or otherwise, are all rich and powerful. I will not have it contested from within!”

Victor would never be a good person, but he was a family man, damn it!

Braniña crossed her arms, while Isabelle gave Victor a frustrated stare. “We need to have a talk with her, Victor, as parents. If not tomorrow, then today.”

Victor inwardly winced, tired as all Happyland. “I can’t today, and I gave my word for tomorrow,” he said, turning to Jules while Chocolatine stuck her tongue at Isabelle. “Who am I scheduled to spend time with in two days?”

“It’s your free *alone day* of the year, sir.”

Victor sighed inwardly. “We will have a family talk in two days, Isabelle.”

This didn’t satisfy the demon queen, who clenched her teeth, but that was the best compromise she would get. Braniño II was a lot more enthusiastic though. “Dad, would you mind teaching me [Hasten] after you’re done scolding sis?”

“You learned to cast Tier III spells already?” Victor asked, gushing while his prodigious son nodded pompously. “I am so proud!”

“So am I,” Isabelle added, easing up a bit before grabbing her children by the arms and teleporting away.

“I don’t like her,” Chocolatine told Victor. “Can’t you set her aside? It would make more time for us.”

“Now, now, you already know my answer,” Victor replied, having had this conversation countless times already. Chocolatine pouted in jealousy, causing the Vizier to sigh. Some things never changed.

“I wouldn’t mind showing Braniña the [Paladin] ropes, Mom,” Brioche argued, which made Victor beam a bit. While their mothers didn’t get along at all, his children had learned the value of kinship.

After Chocolatine and their children left, satisfied with the outcome, Victor suddenly noticed Kia giving him a strange gaze. “What?”

“I’m just glad I never got dragged into this public mess you call a private life, Vic.”

“You don’t say,” he deadpanned, Jules saying nothing in the background. The ghoul had grown used to these spat scenes over the years.

Kia shook her head, her hands on her sword. “I could take Braniña under my wing as my squire. We get along better than she does with her mother.”

It would make Isabelle furious, even if Braniño II was turning out to be the prodigious demon lord she always wanted his sister to be.

Intelligence check successful.

On the other hand, the demoness hated Kia, whose ‘goodish’ advice Jolie favored over Isabelle’s own. If Victor presented this as a ploy to get the [Paladin] away to help reinforce her political influence, his mistress might be tempted to make a sacrifice.

“I believe I can convince her,” Victor said, although he would have to use all his charm for it. “But if it works, you will have to leave the Empire for at *least* a year.”

“What?” Kia winced. “For where?”

“You said you itched for another adrenaline rush?” Victor smiled mirthfully. “I heard Outremonde’s Australia is a place full of high-level monsters...”

Kia hesitated to leave Jolie without her good counsel, but Victor had nailed his proposal. She was growing restless, and so jumped at the opportunity to find a challenge.

Another family crisis averted. Truthfully, Victor had the feeling the drama would continue even after he ascended.

“You feel ready?” Victor asked Jules, the necromancer following him as he left the throne room. “If I succeed, you will take over as Grand Vizier.”

The ghoul nodded, having prepared himself for almost a year. “I appreciate the honor, Victor, but I still wonder why you chose me.”

“Frankly, you’re the most reliable person in this whole Empire,” which said a *lot*, “and you’re the only one who isn’t attached to any particular faction. If *anyone* can arbitrate *everyone*, it will be you.”

“I... well, I hope so.” The necromancer gave a sharp nod to his old friend. “The Empire will miss you, Victor. Should you succeed, we will set aside another statue in your honor.”

“Next to Vainqueur’s own, I hope.” The Vizier smiled, before hugging his successor. “Good luck with this mess, Jules.”

With these words, he moved to his apartments, finding Cybele already present. “Victor,” she said, her voice melodious and warm. “I was wondering if you’d leave me dry.”

Victor knew better than scorn the goddess of pleasure, whose precepts he had lived by. “The device is done, milady,” he said. “But are you sure? You could try it with anyone else.”

“For this service, and all those you did to my cause, I would gladly help you achieve divinity,” the deity replied. “You would fit well among us.”

“How is Camilla?” Victor asked anxiously, the goddess having given him the cold shoulder since the *mermaid incident* years ago.

“She is still angry about Seng. You may be able to patch up eventually, but... you should spend a few decades apart.”

Victor knew he had drunk one too many beers that day, but when Seng complained about Camilla having flings with her worshipers while no one wanted to touch her...

The Vizier had always wondered what Ludvic's last advice was. Now he *knew*.

At least it finally forced the mermaid goddess to finally sober up.

The Vizier moved into his chambers, and the magical necklace he had worked on for the last years. His last hope at godhood before the update changed everything.

It took him years due to the experience requirements, but Victor managed to grind all the way to level 98. [Moriarty] had been a pain to level up, needing years-long plans of conquest and political maneuvers to grind; as for [Fiendish Rake], even the *mermaid incident* only granted him one level in it.

Now, with the planned update for tonight, Victor had to move quickly. The Vizier had been warned by his godly patrons that his total level might be adjusted down to fit the new, fairer balance, forcing him to work another decade to ascend. Either he ascended tonight, or he would have to wait for another attempted apocalypse.

With his [Fiendish Rake] level at 9, the Vizier only saw one option to reach Valhalla before the time limit.

“This necklace should debuff your charisma between one hundred fifty and two hundred points, according to my calculations,” Victor said, upon handing it to Cybele, who put it around her neck. “Making it possible to look at and touch you.”

“I must warn you, I have gone centuries without it,” the goddess replied, brimming with anticipation. “If it works, I will make my joy loud.”

Victor breathed deeply, bracing himself for either success or death as the goddess raised her hood.

Half an hour before the update.

Vainqueur waited patiently before the doors of Valhalla, glancing at the marble platform around him with nostalgia. It seemed like today since he had bested the Vile Odieuse there, at a great cost; and to a dragon, sixteen years were but the blink of an eye. Or rather, should have been.

Why had it felt so long though? Because he had been separated from his friend for so long? So much had happened in sixteen years... even the vile Forgotten One had redeemed himself, using his powers to purify the cursed planet Moon.

And now, as the minutes stretched on, Vainqueur wondered if he would have to wait even more.

But then, a flash of light filled him with hope.

“Excalibur!”

Friend Victor teleported before Vainqueur’s eyes, naked below the waist, scythe in one hand and his armored pants in the other. He must have grabbed them at the last second before teleportation.

“It worked,” the Vizier declared, panting in exhaustion. “It worked!.”

“It’s been years, my friend,” Vainqueur spoke up, greatly pleased.

“Welcome back.”

“It has been too long, Vainqueur,” Friend Victor bowed deeply, before hastily putting back his underclothes. “I’m sorry for the delay, but reaching level 99 was *hard*.”

“Minion, you have nothing to apologize for,” Vainqueur said kindly. “You honored your oaths, all of them, and made me proud. You will apologize *only* if you fail to stay at my side.”

“I still have a trial to pass?” Victor asked, having finished dressing. “I’m ready.”

“The old System will generate it soon,” Vainqueur replied calmly, “or maybe not.”

Perhaps the Elder Wurm, in her infinite wisdom, will have recognized that Vainqueur’s struggle for sixteen years without his chief of staff had been the true trial. Or that Victor had earned his place among the dragon’s minions.

“You will enjoy the Second Edition of the Vainqueur System,” the divine emperor said proudly.

“I’ve already noticed the increase in dropped loot,” his chief of staff chuckled.

“One-tenth,” Vainqueur replied.

His old partner marked a short pause, as he registered the dragon’s words. “Wait, you mean we only get one-tenth of the loot drop?”

“Generosity starts with myself,” Vainqueur replied wisely.

Silence stretched between the two. Eventually, Vainqueur’s manling chuckled, while the wyrm emperor smiled in amusement. “Some things never change,” the Vizier mused.

“I understand why time felt so long,” the dragon declared, his heart warmed by their old friendship. “I have many minions, but only one friend. While standing atop of a hoard feels glorious... it is also lonely.”

“It’s never too late,” the Vizier consoled him. “The first time is always the hardest.”

So true. Because he would not be alone for the next time. And with the update done, Vainqueur would finally have time to visit his mortal family, praise Jolie for her work, check on Genialissime’s children... the dragon yearned for a long-needed vacation. And soon, he would have it.

Everything was right in the world.

Until an old, long-forgotten voice shattered the warm atmosphere.

“[Za Warudo]!”

Time paused for five seconds in Valhalla, although neither Vainqueur nor his minion were affected.

The psychological effect, though, devastated the dragon; especially when *he* teleported on the platform, a ghost straight out of a dark, forgotten past.

He was exactly like in the dragon's old nightmare, an undying paragon of evil. But if anything, he had grown worse with time, wearing a lead suit over his dusty bones, powerful ring artifacts on each hand, and a false crown on his head. His empty eyes radiated pauperiness, an evil long buried, but never fully destroyed.

No...

Suddenly, it all made sense. Why the Forgotten One had faked redemption by turning the cursed lead Moon to gold. Why he had remained under the radar for years, luring Vainqueur into a false sense of security, while preparing for this final cruelty.

A dragon's angry roar echoed across Valhalla, shattering the time-stop.

“FUUUUUUUURRRRRRIIIIIIIIIIBBBBOOOOONNNNN!”

“Furi?” Victor reacted with more surprise than anger, even if he winced from his old friend's booming voice. “What are you doing here?”

“How could I not show up?” the lich rasped, his body crackling with magic. “After fulfilling all my ambitions, how could I deny the opportunity to humiliate Knightsbane again?!”

“Don't tell me...”

“You shall not become a god, Victor!” The undead warlock dramatically raised his hands, lightning coming out of his fingers and illuminating the divine realm. “I will!”

“You waited sixteen years, grinding to become a god at the same time I did...” Friend Victor trailed off, astonished by his nemesis' insane persistence, “just to annoy Vainqueur one last time?”

The lich had no lips, but his teeth seemed to morph into a cruel smile.

"I have nothing better to do."

His evil knew no bound; nor did his boredom.

Your minion is challenged by **Final Boss Furibon!**

Now that's an archenemy!

"Minion!" Vainqueur shouted, Victor readying his weapon to fight V&V's ultimate enemy. "Kick his ass!"

"You're getting back in my scythe, Furi!" Victor shouted.

"Or I will seal you in it!" the lich snarled back, spellcasting. "[Meteor Rain]!"

And the dragon god watched, as spells clashed against spells, scythe against staff, sparkles illuminating Valhalla. Explosions shook the platform, reality tearing itself apart as the System prepared to enter its new phase.

So ended Outremonde's First Edition.

In gold and lead.

Victor's final stats

Victor "Whore King" Dalton

Level: 99 (Monster Knight: Red Dragon 20/Reaper 30/Moriarty 19/Chaos Rider 10/Weathermaker 10/Fiendish Rake 10)

Type: Slime/Dragon

Party: V&V

Health Points

2385

Special Points

660

Strength

76 (+6)

Vitality

91 (+6)

Skill

112 (+8)

Agility

98

Intelligence

128

Charisma

126 (+49; +6 when lying)

Luck

107

Personal Perks

Class Perks

Claimed by Dice

Skeleton Key

Observer

Eye for Treasure

Deadfriend

Scythe Lord

Seducer

Monster Kin

Claimed by the Moon Man

Minion Trainer

Black Curse

Monster Student

Noxious Fire

Monster Lifeforce (Red Dragon)

Claimed by Shesha

Monster Rider

Epic

Monster Insight

Vizier Education

Reanimator

Troll Regeneration

Soulmaster VI

Perk Forge

Helheim

Darwinist

Steal Life

Blood Pulse

Mook Promotion

Claimed by Deathjester

Slayer of Men

Claimed by Camilla

Scarlet Study

Exhibitionist

Master's Shield

Slime Totem

Fright Knight

Bloodborn

Lethal

Claimed by Cybele

Hades Blast

Magellan

Final Problem

Miniboss

Black Horseman

Claimed by Seng

Diabolical Mastermind

Claimed by Veran

Envious

Claimed by Mithras

Nightmare Lord

Claimed by Isengrim

Vicious Ankou

Claimed by Leone

Devil Archmage III

Claimed by Sablar

Charon's Grim Harvest

Pantheist

Asteroid Dynamics

Claimed by Vainqueur

Zmey Rider

Godparent

White Rider

Stat Boosters +10 (all stats)

Apocalypse Storm

Planeloved

Curse of Diarmuid

Emotion Magic II

Red Rider

Rally Minion

Hail-bringer

Black Rider

Foul Metamagic

Pale Rider

Hades Rider

Witch Mark

True Crime Profiler

Hounds of Baskerville

Perfect Crime

Sign of the Four

Living Catnip

Chapter 153: [Game Epilogue], [Credits] & [Afterword]

[CHARACTER EPILOGUE]

Jolie Dragon - Dragon Empress

Jolie Dragon, first of her name, spent half her reign adventuring, and the other half ruling justly over the V&V Empire. She especially focused on improving the living conditions of minions, even those living beyond her empire's borders, and never stopped advertising her cattletarian views. While this earned her scorn from other dragons, her subjects adored her; in time, she would become known as *'Jolie the Just.'*

Chocolatine de Gevaudan - Monster Cook

After Victor Dalton's ascension, Chocolatine split her time between raising her children, spreading the faith of Isengrim, and working as an ambassador between the V&V Empire and human nations; a job she proved surprisingly skilled at. While lauded for helping monsters assimilate into civilized societies, she is mostly known today for her pioneer work in the art of cooking. Although ironically banned in the V&V Empire, her Stuffed Garfield recipe remains a delicacy in many countries.

Akhenapep - Immortal Advisor

Akhenapep remained trapped in Victor Dalton's scythe, no matter how many times Sablar argued for his release; when Victor ascended, the artifact was returned to Murmurin and became the official regalia of the Grand Vizier. The specter made the best of his situation by providing ruthless advice to the government and helped shape the structures of the V&V

Empire. Leaving a legacy made the nihilistic maniac feel strangely nostalgic—and quite proud.

Croissant & Savoureuse - Moonlanders

Despite receiving a full pardon, Croissant and Savoureuse never returned to the Empire. They instead lived the rest of their life on the golden Mooonoon, protecting the fledgling colonies from giant spiders, eldritch horrors, the slavers of Leng, and whoever dared to threaten their people. Croissant, in particular, mellowed out and became a beloved uncle to his nephews and nieces, often taking them on alien-hunting trips.

Lynette - Cunning Innkeeper

Lynette used her government connections and business acumen to accumulate a fortune, becoming one of the wealthiest women in Murmurin. She remained a champion of the merchant class, working to open the Empire to international trade. Her eldest son Armand took the most after his father Victor, and became an infamous troublemaker. He eventually found his way to the distant gangland city of Las Vegas, determined to make a name for himself.

Jules Rapace - Ghoul Vizier

Jules the Ghoul replaced Victor Dalton as Murmurin's Grand Vizier after his ascension. He proved to be a moderating influence, never favoring any faction and working to maintain peace, both within the nation and beyond its borders. The only exception was the Undeathstrial Revolution, which he encouraged at all costs, earning no less than five assassination attempts by zealous inquisitors. He always blamed these attacks on a vague [Paladin] conspiracy, although never within earshot of the Empress.

Genialissime, Henry & Barnabas - Dragons Incorporated

Genialissime associated with the troll blacksmith Barnabas to expand his burgeoning dragon enterprise, with the aim to supply all adventurers across the world. Eventually, their association turned into a powerful conglomerate heavily associated with the Church of Shesha. Genialissime never stopped

obsessing over class optimization, and left the minion work to Henry while he pursued his latest fancy; the dragon's magical expertise eventually eclipsed even that of the famed Archmage Nostredame.

Allison - Mother of the Green

Remaining a lifelong ally of Chocolatine, with whom she shared a household, Allison was never interested in imperial politics and instead assumed her rightful place as the high priestess of Cybele in the V&V Empire. She found happiness in developing a hippie-like, eco-friendly community in the empire's countryside, and successfully moved her cult's image away from orgy planners... although her private life was poisoned by persistent rumors about a certain goat incident.

Charlene - Vampire Crime Lord

Charlene slowly turned the Nightblades from a gang of assassins into a *'legitimate business club'*, whose reach even extended to the legendary city of Las Vegas in the New World. It is said that at the height of her power, no crime happened on the Mistral continent without her approval, her name inspiring fear in every scoundrel—this earned her the personal patronage of Deathjester himself. Charlene remained loyal to the V&V Empire, supplying it with information and working in the shadows to sabotage its enemies abroad.

Isabelle Maure - Demon Mastermind

After Victor's ascension, Isabelle Maure remained a major player in both the V&V Empire and Happyland—what her first son had failed to do with force and empty boasts, she did it with diplomacy. Alongside former demon concubines, she formed a league of corporate barons well-entrenched in the V&V Empire. Isabelle always schemed to put her children on the throne of Murmurin and convince her daughter Braniña to abandon her dream of paladinhood; so far, she hasn't succeeded.

Noirceur - Divine Nightmare

Noirceur the Nightmare served her rider with great loyalty and sarcastic devotion, even after divinity. Although the mare always complained about being overworked, Noirceur also boasted that only a god could properly ride her in battle. She worked tirelessly to level up on her own, and eventually achieved her dream of becoming a [Chaos Rider] horse. What creature she rode in battle, well... is a secret best left buried.

Tarasque Emperor & EXP Dodos - Terrifying Hybrids

The Tarasque Emperor was released from confinement in Daltonia, and besides the occasional rampage, remained there. His presence protected the local EXP dodos from poachers, allowing the birds to rebuild their population. The terrifying Taradodo and Dodobear hybrids, however, escaped Daltonia and spread on the mainland; becoming the bane of adventurers everywhere across Outremonde.

Buzz Jelly - Brave Cosmonaut

Buzz Jelly continued to serve its country with patriotic zeal, and when the Empire decided to renew its space program in the search for new lands and resources, the tiny slime was the first onboard. In total, Buzz Jelly survived seven space missions, five crashes, three interstellar conflicts and founded two new colonies. The tiny slime always insisted that its personal rockets had to be sword-shaped, and its slimy bromance with Private Molesty inspired many novels.

Marbré - Averagist Revolutionary

Marbré the dwarf remained an advisor to Murmurin's government, although the presence of hungry dragons forced him to take regular leaves of absence. Obeying the directives of his Supreme Leader, the duergar fostered an imperial alliance with his homeland of Agarthia and worked to 'average out' the surface world. One of his greatest successes was to make Averagist School mandatory in the Empire's colonies, spreading the revolution's ideals across borders.

Jack O'Lantern & Cait Sith - Friendly Neighborhood Fomors

Cait Sith, king of cats, never settled anywhere and defended the rights of cats across Outremonde, especially in countries where they had become delicacies exploited for their nine lives. Jack O'Lantern remained a lifelong tenant of Chocolatine de Gevaudan, his quirky personality and friendly presence slowly easing up people to the idea of pacifist fomors. Both fairies became known as symbols of the fairies' changing ways.

Vainqueur Junior - Jelly Defender

After his master's ascension, Vainqueur Junior became the first [Priest] of Victor Dalton, sharing a message of family, friendship, and love to all slimes. The mimic witch hut expanded its jelly shelters beyond the Empire's frontiers, eating anyone who tried to stop it; but also working hard to provide abandoned slimes with adoring families. Today, slimes rival cats and dogs in popularity as pets, especially among V&V worshipers.

Rolo - Overleveled Farmer

Rolo left the V&V Empire to continue his grand work of making the desert green again, settling near the Tower of Sablar. Over the following decades, the golem managed to turn this evil monument into a thriving oasis and trading hub between Nagastan and the west. When asked if he intended to reach level 99, Rolo famously replied that everything comes in time—but only one sheep at once.

The Kobold Rangers - Shields of the Empire

Fulfilling their dream of greatness, the Kobold Rangers continued to defend the V&V Empire against those who would threaten it, becoming heroes immortalized in songs. They inspired many kobold teams to follow the path of the Sentai, leading to an era of reptilian adventurers almost as eventful as the rise of their dragon overlords. Pink Ranger, however, never stopped writing, and her anonymous works became reviled as heresies by the cults of V&V—who never managed to fully stamp them out.

Goblina - Goblin Godmother

Ruling the Teikoku Empire, Goblina continued to expand her horde in the east and proved that goblins could be ruthless overlords too. Many heroes rose to oppose her rising empire, and although they failed to defeat her, they managed to slow down her expansion—especially when her protegee Braniña started speaking up against her oppressive dictatorship. As a good godmother, Goblina took it in stride, believing this was a mere teenage phase that the half-demon would grow out of.

Malfy & Miel - Planar Salesmen

After much effort and thanks to the miracle cure to Hamelin's plague, Miel managed to restore Heaven's reputation among mortals. She was nominated as General Secretary of Heaven, purging its corruption, and entered a decades-long price war with her Happyland counterpart, Malfaisant. It is said that they grew to respect one another over time, and could exchange pleasantries as easily as assassination attempts.

Grandrake & Gorynych - Princess Savors

After finding his own sister-wife and fathering many inbred children, Gorynych became a princess activist, fighting to protect royal dynasties from rampant democratization. He found a reluctant ally in Grandrake, who eventually warmed up to the Zmey, even learning to hear him. They founded the largest princess refuge in the new world, creating a safe haven for endangered monarchies—a move universally acclaimed by dragons, and criticized by everyone else.

Kia - Shining Knight

Kia and Empress Jolie remained lifelong friends and adventurer buddies. Together, they had many adventures, settled new lands, hunted the legendary Truck-kun, and defeated the reborn Orknoob when he rose to threaten the world again. Many of the Empress' most controversial decisions, such as restrictions on public executions, were said to be inspired by her knightly advisor. Kia eventually took Princess Braniña under her wing, training her to become a [Paladin] in the hope that she might curb the empire's festering evil one day; but she never got over missing the final battle.

Furibon - The Forgotten One

After his legendary final battle with V&V, the evil Furibon completely vanished from historical records. Some said he had been forever sealed inside Victor's old scythe [Harvest]; others said he had left Outremonde to poison other realms with the curse of lead. Whatever the case, he remained a controversial character, being reviled as Vainqueur's greatest enemy, yet celebrated as the savior of the Mooooooon. His dungeon, the Tomb of Furibon, remains a legendary adventurer hotspot to this day.

Victor and Vainqueur - Godlike Pair

Victor Dalton rejoined his best friend Vainqueur in Valhalla as the God of [Minions], [Monsters], [Amorality], and [Souls]. The two were almost never seen apart afterward, Vainqueur leading Outremonde's pantheon atop his world-sized hoard with his loyal minion at his side. The dragon god was never without a new brilliant idea, such as creating a second silver moon when dragons ran out of unexplored places to conquer; and his chief of staff was always happy to make it a reality.

The Dalton children - Spinoff Children

Well...

That part will be for another tale.

THANKS FOR READING VAINQUEUR THE DRAGON!

[GAME CREDITS]

Author, Game Designer, and Internet Dragon - Maxime J. Durand, aka Void Herald.

Beta Tester and chief of staff - Daniel Zogbi.

Regular artist and trusted minion - Gharbi Zouhayer.

And personal thanks to all of **my patrons on Patreon**, for supporting this story all the way to its conclusion!

[AFTERWORD]

Surprise! Didn't expect an RPG-styled slide epilogue and credits?

I mean, I always liked that kind of ending in games like *Fallout*, *Dragon Age* or *Fire Emblem*, where slides showed what each individual character were up to after the main ending. I thought it was fitting to end a LitRPG with that kind of epilogue. One final meta-joke.

In any case, Vainqueur the Dragon has now officially concluded. It's been one hell of a ride, years long; an attempt to blend a One Punch Man-like satire of LitRPGs with a cohesive storyline about a greedy dragon's personal growth. I ended up doing things I never anticipated, like hosting a Vainqueur tabletop-style RPG campaign on Discord.

I thank you all for your kind messages last chapter, and I'm glad you enjoyed this story all the way to the end. While I have kept doors open for a spinoff set in Outremonde (as you can see from the Dalton children's mentions and Furibon's open-ended fate), the adventures of V&V are over. If I revisit that universe, it will be with other protagonists, although V&V and their companions will certainly make cameos. They are gods of Outremonde now after all.

Quite a few people encouraged me to make Vainqueur last longer, but... long story short, I believe that something which stretches on too long will eventually lose what made it special in the first place. Vainqueur's leveling system was meant to bring a character from level 1 to 100, and I always intended for the big V to eventually end his journey as a deity. The story I wanted to tell is finished; I would rather have Vainqueur stay forever good than seeing it lose its luster like the Simpson or burning out midway through an arc like I did with *Magik Online*.

I hope you enjoyed the whole journey and that the ending gave you satisfaction. That was my only wish.

So what next, you may ask?

Well, first I am in early discussions for a webcomic adaptation of Vainqueur, although nothing is signed yet and don't expect anything on that front in 2020. Besides my new story *Never Die Twice* (which will also end this month), I'm currently working on a new project called *The Perfect Run*, a sci-fi/superhero timeloop story - I intend to build a backlog on Patreon before releasing it on RR around mid-October, so stay tuned. Finally, I've also been commissioned to write a Greek Myth/piracy LitRPG, but it won't hit the shelves for a while.

Finally, I'm also going to focus on editing the web serial for Kindle and Audible. After much troubles, I've actually finished editing/publishing the second volume on that platform, with the link available in the author's note below. Every review/rating on Amazon is welcome, as it makes Kindle advertise the work to new people.

And, well, as they say, that's all folks! Thanks for everything, and write you soon!

Best regards,

Voidy Void.